Calculus From the Ground Up

Limits, Insight, and Why It Works — From Functions to Differential Equations

Built for Understanding, Not Just Solving

June 2026

Preface

Understanding before memorizing

Calculus textbooks often focus on procedure: memorize these formulas, practice these templates, and you will pass. Here the goal is different: work through these ideas with pencil in hand, and you will *understand*. You will see why the derivative takes the form it does, where it came from, what a limit actually asserts, why the chain rule holds together geometrically, and why the area under a curve and the slope of a curve turn out to be two sides of a single fact. Beyond calculating answers, you will look at a symbol like $\mathrm{d}x$, or a phrase like "the limit as x approaches a," and see what is actually happening underneath.

That kind of understanding only clicks when you work through concrete examples yourself. We start with what a function truly represents, and we finish, many chapters later, with differential equations – the language in which physics, biology, and economics write down how the world evolves. Every step along the way grows out of a concrete problem, so each new idea feels like something you could have uncovered on your own.

Focus

The single sentence that organizes this entire book: *calculus is the mathematics of change and accumulation, and the bridge between them is the limit.* If you keep that sentence in view, every chapter will find its natural place.

There is a practical reason to insist on understanding, too: memorized recipes fade fast. Within a year of finishing a procedural course, many students cannot integrate by parts or state the Mean Value Theorem, because nothing anchored the rules in place – they were an arbitrary list, and unanchored lists decay. But ideas you have explored visually and conceptually do not vanish in that way, because each one is supported by the geometric intuitions around it. If you forget the quotient rule, you can sketch a small nudge and rederive it in two lines. If you forget the formula for a Taylor polynomial, you can reconstruct the matching-derivative requirement that produced it. Understanding takes more patience up front, but what you build this way stays with you.

How this book is built: intuition, then picture, then proof

Every important idea in this book is introduced in the same three movements, and it will help you to know the rhythm in advance.

First, intuition. Before any symbols, we ask what the idea *is* in plain human terms. What is a

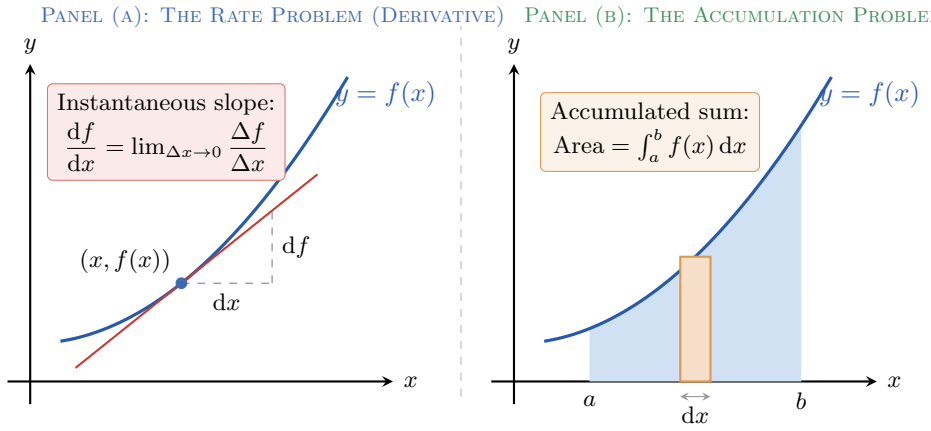


Figure 1: The two central problems of calculus. Left: The rate problem zooms into a single point to find the local steepness $\mathrm{d}f/\mathrm{d}x$. Right: The accumulation problem sums up thin slices of area $f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ across an interval. The central discovery of calculus is that differentiation and integration invert each other.

derivative? It is how fast something is changing right now – the speedometer reading, not the trip average. What is an integral? It is a total accumulated from tiny contributions – the full distance built up from every instant's speed.

Second, the picture. Calculus was discovered with pictures, and it is still understood with pictures. A derivative is the slope of a tangent line. An integral is an area. A limit is a process of closing in. Almost every idea in this book has an exact geometric meaning, and we will draw it. You will see secant lines pivot down into a tangent; you will see rectangles thicken into a smooth region of area; you will see the graphs of Taylor polynomials creep outward to hug a curve. Each figure carries part of the geometric argument rather than serving merely as an illustration.

Pause

Mental check: the secant pivot. Close your eyes and picture the parabola $y = x^2$ with the point $(1, 1)$ held fixed. If you pick a second point far to the right, say $(3, 9)$, the secant line joining them is steep (slope 4). As you slide that second point down the curve toward $(1, 1)$ through $(2, 4)$, then $(1.5, 2.25)$, then $(1.1, 1.21)$, does the secant line become steeper or flatter? What number does its slope approach?

Third, the proof – clear and complete, but never dry. Intuition can mislead, and pictures can hide special cases. So after we see why an idea should be true, we make it precise and we prove it. A proof in this book is not an unmotivated sequence of formulas. We always explain the key idea of the proof first – the core step that makes it work – and then we walk through the steps narrating as we go, the way an instructor talks through a derivation at the board. A proof is a careful explanation of why a statement must hold. Every line should follow with clear reasoning.

Intuition

You can read this book at two depths. On a first pass, read the intuition, study the figures, and follow the overall structure of the proofs to get the main idea. On a second pass, slow down and follow every line of the derivations. Both passes are legitimate. Mathematics is

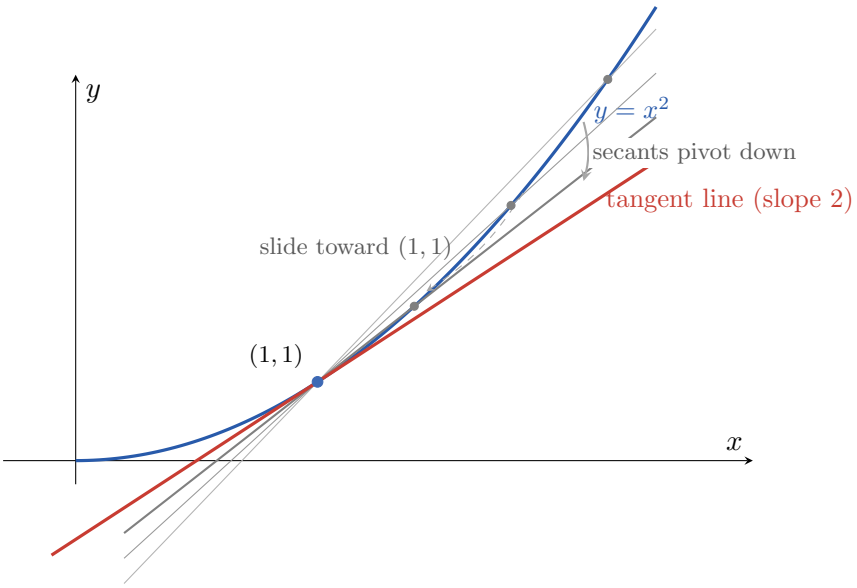


Figure 2: The core geometric intuition of the derivative. Each gray secant line cuts the curve at two points: the fixed point $(1, 1)$ and a second point sliding along the parabola. As that second point slides in, the secants pivot and settle onto a single red line. That limiting line is the tangent, and its slope is the derivative. We will build this picture carefully in the chapters on limits and the derivative.

rarely understood in one sitting, and no one absorbs it linearly. Circling back is simply how understanding is built.

The colored boxes: a visual language

Throughout the book you will meet recurring colored boxes. Each one plays a fixed role, so once you learn the color, you know what kind of thinking is coming. Two of them examine notation and technique directly within the flow of the mathematics:

What is really happening

A **What is really happening** box explains the concrete meaning behind a symbol or a computation. What does the dx in $\int f(x)\,dx$ represent? What does $\lim_{x\to a}$ actually claim, when no input needs to evaluate at a? What does e^x represent, and why does it equal its own derivative? These boxes exist because mathematical notation compresses detailed reasoning, and that compression can obscure the underlying mechanics. We unpack the meaning directly.

Why the technique works

A **Why the technique works** box shows why a method works instead of handing you a list of steps to copy. Every computational rule in calculus grows out of an earlier property of limits or functions: substitution runs the chain rule backward, and integration by parts runs

the product rule backward. Once you see *why* a rule works, you no longer have to memorize it as a separate trick.

The remaining boxes round out the conversation, and you will get to know them by sight:

- An **Intuition** box (green) states an idea in plain language before we make it precise.
- A **History** box (yellow) shows where an idea came from: who invented it, what problem they were trying to solve, and how it was eventually made rigorous. You will meet this chapter's History box in the section on rigor.
- A **Common trap** box (red) flags a mistake almost everyone makes – a place where the intuition lies, or where the notation invites an error. Forewarned is forearmed.
- A **Walking question** box (orange) hands you a question to chew on away from the page, on a walk or in the shower. The best calculus thinking often happens when you are not staring at symbols. These have no answers printed; they are yours to turn over.
- A **Work it yourself** box (purple) asks you to compute one small thing by hand, right then, because some ideas only click when you work them out on paper. Reading about a derivative is not the same as taking one.
- An **Application** box (magenta) shows the idea doing real work in physics, biology, economics, or machine learning – connecting the abstract theory to concrete problems.
- A **Connection** box (teal) links the idea to other parts of mathematics, so the subject feels unified rather than like a list of isolated topics.
- A **Why this matters** box (cyan) steps back to say why an idea is beautiful or central – the aesthetic and structural payoff.
- A **Focus** box (blue) marks the one thing in a section you should not lose.

Reading note

You do not have to read the boxes in any particular order relative to the main text, and you will not break anything by skipping one and coming back. They serve as brief margin notes alongside the main exposition. The main argument always stands on its own in the running prose.

The arc of the book: from functions to differential equations

It helps to see the whole journey before you take the first step, the way you might glance at a trail map before a long hike. Here is the territory, and why it is laid out the way it is.

We begin with functions and the objects calculus acts on. Calculus does not study numbers; it studies *functions* – rules that turn an input into an output, machines for relating one changing quantity to another. So before anything else, we make sure you truly understand functions and the two families that calculus cannot live without. First come the exponential functions and the number e, which we will meet through compound interest, a limit, and the function that equals its own rate of change. Next come the trigonometric functions, which measure rotation and periodic oscillation

alongside static geometry. These early chapters are about *meaning*: what these objects are, before we ever differentiate them.

Then we build the limit. The limit is the foundation that makes the whole subject possible and the idea that took mathematicians the longest to get right. We approach it first through pure intuition and a long historical look at the centuries of productive confusion, and only then through the precise "ε–δ" (read "epsilon-delta") definition that finally made it rigorous. We spend real time here because everything downstream – derivatives, integrals, series, all of it – is built directly on limits.

With limits in hand, we build the derivative. The derivative is the limit of those pivoting secant lines in Figure 2: instantaneous rate of change, the slope of the tangent. We learn what it means, then we earn the rules – the power rule, product and quotient rules, and the chain rule – by deriving each from the definition, so they are never arbitrary. Then we put the derivative to work: linear approximation, the Mean Value Theorem (the central theorem that underpins much of the theory of derivatives and integrals), finding maxima and minima, optimization, and l'Hôpital's rule (the method for resolving indeterminate 0/0 limits by comparing how fast numerator and denominator head to zero).

Next we build the integral, and meet the great theorem. An integral is an accumulation – an area, a total, a sum of infinitely many infinitesimal pieces. We define it carefully as a limit of sums, and then we arrive at the central result of the first half of the book: the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus, which shows that differentiation and integration undo each other. Finding slopes and finding areas look completely unrelated at first, yet each runs the other in reverse. From there we develop the main integration methods – substitution, integration by parts, and partial fractions – pairing each method with a "why the technique works" box so no rule feels pulled out of thin air.

Then we extend the reach: series, and then more than one variable. We learn to add up infinitely many terms (sequences and series), and we discover Taylor series, which let us rebuild familiar functions like e^x, $\sin x$, and $\cos x$ directly from their derivatives at a single point – one of the most beautiful ideas in all of mathematics. Then we step up a dimension to functions of several variables. We study partial derivatives (isolating how an output responds to one variable while holding the others fixed) and the gradient (an arrow pointing in the direction of steepest uphill ascent). From there we build multiple integrals, which sum volume or mass across two- and three-dimensional regions, and conclude with a first taste of vector calculus for fluid flows and force fields.

Finally we arrive at differential equations. This is where calculus models dynamic systems in the physical world. A differential equation relates an unknown function to its derivatives, and its solution describes how the quantity evolves over time. Population growth, radioactive decay, a swinging pendulum, a cooling object, and electrical circuits – all are described by differential equations.

Why this matters

Look at how the chain in Figure 3 funnels through a single bottleneck: limits. Once limits are solid, derivatives, integrals, and infinite series each follow by applying that one idea to a new geometric problem.

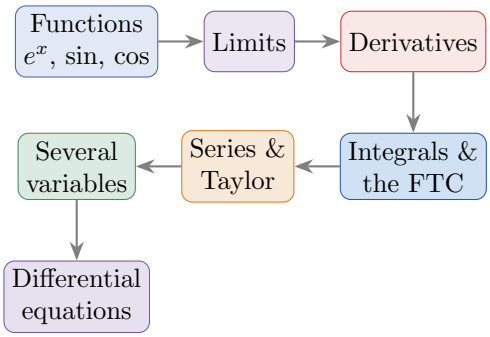


Figure 3: The arc of the book. Each idea rests on the one before it. The limit is the foundation: every concept after it builds directly on limits. The destination – differential equations – is where calculus describes dynamic systems in physics, biology, and engineering.

How to read this book

A few practical suggestions, earned from watching many people learn this subject.

Draw. This is the single most important piece of advice in the preface, and it is why it gets its own paragraph. Keep paper and pencil beside you and redraw the figures yourself – not trace them, draw them. Sketch the secant lines pivoting into the tangent. Shade the area under a curve and chop it into rectangles. Plot a function and guess its derivative before you compute it. The act of drawing forces you to decide what you actually believe about the shape, and it exposes vague understanding instantly. Mathematicians who look like they are "just thinking" are very often drawing in their heads, and they learned to do that by drawing on paper first.

Walking question

Here is a question to consider before moving forward. A car's speedometer reads 60 miles per hour at a single instant – say, exactly at noon. But speed is distance divided by time, and at a single *instant* no time passes and no distance is covered. So what does "60 miles per hour at this exact moment" mean? Resolving this question leads directly to the concept of the derivative, the central idea of the first half of this book.

Ask "why" relentlessly, and refuse to be satisfied too early. When the book states a rule, stop and ask why it should be true before you read on. When it draws a picture, ask what would change if the curve bent the other way. When a proof makes a move, ask why that move and not another. This book is written to reward that interrogation – nearly every "why" you can think to ask is answered somewhere, often in a colored box – but the answer means far more if you have felt the question first. A question you have actually wrestled with is a hook the answer can hang on. An answer to a question you never asked just slides off.

Compute things by hand, especially when you would rather not. Doing the algebra with your own pencil builds an intuition for how terms cancel that reading alone never gives you. When a "Work it yourself" box asks you to take a derivative or evaluate an integral, work it out on paper before reading on.

Work it yourself

Try this one now, before you turn the page, using only arithmetic. Take the function that squares its input, $f(x) = x^2$. Compute the average rate of change between $x = 1$ and a nearby point $x = 1 + h$ for shrinking h: that average rate is

$$\frac{f(1+h) - f(1)}{h} = \frac{(1+h)^2 - 1^2}{h} = \frac{(1 + 2h + h^2) - 1}{h} = \frac{2h + h^2}{h} = \frac{h(2+h)}{h} = 2+h \quad (h \neq 0).$$

Now plug in $h = 0.1$, then $h = 0.01$, then $h = 0.001$. You get 2.1, then 2.01, then 2.001. The numbers are visibly homing in on 2. That 2 is the slope of the red tangent line in Figure 2, and you just computed your first derivative – by watching a quotient close in on a value it never quite reaches. Hold on to the feeling of that "closing in." It is the limit, and the whole book turns on it.

Do the exercises. Every chapter ends with a set of them – some computational, some conceptual, and usually a proof or two. The computational ones build fluency; the conceptual ones build understanding; the proofs build the ability to be *sure*. You do not have to do all of them, but do not do none of them. Mathematics is not a spectator sport, and reading a worked example is not the same as doing one, in the way that watching someone swim is not the same as getting wet.

Common trap

The most common way to fail at calculus is to read it like a novel – smoothly, continuously, never stopping. It cannot be read that way. If you find yourself nodding along for three pages without pausing, you have almost certainly stopped understanding and started skimming. Real reading of mathematics is slow and full of stops: rereading a line, working a tiny case in the margin, drawing the picture. If a sentence does not make sense, do not push past it hoping it will clear up. Stop. Draw a sketch. Test a numerical example to find the exact line where a derivation stops making sense.

Pause

And when you get stuck – you will get stuck, everyone gets stuck – that is not a sign you are bad at this. Getting stuck is what doing mathematics feels like from the inside, for everyone, at every level. The difference between people who learn calculus and people who give up is almost never raw talent. It is whether, on getting stuck, they draw a picture, try a smaller case, reread the definition, and stay with the discomfort for five more minutes.

A word on rigor, and a word of welcome

You may have heard that calculus comes in two flavors: an easy "intuitive" version for engineers and a hard "rigorous" version for mathematicians, and that you must choose between them. This book rejects that choice. Intuition and rigor work together, and each is incomplete without the other. Intuition without rigor led Newton and Leibniz to brilliant results along with occasional nonsense, with no systematic way to distinguish them. Rigor without intuition is how calculus becomes a dry sequence of formal ε and δ manipulations that produce correct proofs of theorems you cannot picture and do not believe. We will develop both side by side. We use intuition to discover and pictures to

see, and we use rigor to be *certain* – to know, not merely to hope, that the geometric insight is sound. The history boxes will show you, again and again, that this is how the subject truly developed: the insight first, followed by the rigorous foundation.

History

The people who invented calculus did not understand its foundations as well as you are about to. In the 1660s and 1670s, Isaac Newton in England and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz in Germany independently confronted two central problems: how to calculate instantaneous speed (the slope of a tangent line) and how to measure curved areas. Their main tools were algebra, Cartesian coordinate geometry, and the intuitive idea of an "infinitesimal"—a quantity imagined to be smaller than any positive real number yet not zero.

Their methods yielded correct answers, but their logical footing was fragile. In 1734, the philosopher Bishop George Berkeley published *The Analyst*, criticizing the foundation of their calculations: in computing a derivative, mathematicians treated a small increment as nonzero in order to divide by it, and then treated the same increment as zero to discard the remaining terms. Meanwhile, a bitter priority dispute broke out over whether Newton or Leibniz deserved credit for the invention. Both had discovered the core ideas independently: Newton approached calculus through physics and motion, while Leibniz crafted the notation (dx and $\int$) that we still use today.

A coherent foundation took another century. In the 1820s, Augustin-Louis Cauchy began rebuilding the subject on the idea of limits, and in the 1860s and 1870s Karl Weierstrass completed the foundation with the precise ε–δ definition, replacing infinitesimals with inequalities. In the 1960s, Abraham Robinson proved that infinitesimal numbers can also be made completely rigorous within an extended number system known as the hyperreals. Knowing this story reminds us that confusion is normal: mathematicians required two centuries to articulate what you are about to master.

Connection

One last orientation. Although this book is about calculus, you will keep glimpsing the rest of mathematics through its windows. The limit connects to the deep structure of the real numbers (an appendix at the end pursues this). The derivative is a linear approximation, which ties calculus to linear algebra. Series connect to the theory of approximation and to complex analysis. Differential equations open onto all of physics. We will not chase every thread, but we will point at them, so you always feel that calculus is one province of a single connected country, not an island.

In Chapter 1, we start with two concrete questions: how fast a falling ball is moving at a single instant, and how much area sits under a curve. Watch how both questions force us toward the same new idea.

Exercises

These are not computational drills – the real exercises begin in Chapter 1. They are meant to fix the habits, mental pictures, and central themes of this preface before you turn the page.

1. **Pause and think: the speedometer.** Suppose a car travels 60 miles along a highway

between 1:00 PM and 2:00 PM. Its average speed is 60 miles per hour. Must the speedometer have read exactly 60 mph at some instant during that hour, or could it have read 50 mph the entire time? What if the car left home at 1:00 PM, drove out, and returned home at 2:00 PM (net distance zero)? (This is a first taste of the Mean Value Theorem, which we will prove in Chapter 15.)

2. **The closing-in feeling from both sides.** Return to the "Work it yourself" box, where the quotient $\dfrac{(1+h)^2 - 1^2}{h}$ simplified to $2 + h$ for $h \neq 0$. Compute it for $h = -0.1$, $h = -0.01$, and $h = -0.001$ – that is, approaching $x = 1$ from *below*. Do the values still close in on 2? What does the simplified form $2 + h$ predict they must do? (A limit requires that approaching a target from the left and from the right arrives at the very same destination.)

3. **Constant rate versus changing rate.** Consider the linear function $f(x) = 3x + 5$. Compute the average rate of change between $x = 1$ and $x = 1 + h$:

$$\frac{f(1+h) - f(1)}{h} = \frac{(3(1+h)+5) - (3(1)+5)}{h}.$$

   Simplify the fraction algebraically. Notice that h cancels completely, leaving the constant 3 with no dependency on h at all. Why does a straight line never need a limiting process ($h \to 0$) to find its slope, whereas a curved parabola like $y = x^2$ does?

4. **Reading the secant picture.** Look carefully at Figure 2. Every gray secant passes through the same point $(1, 1)$, yet each has a different slope. In one or two sentences, say in your own words what is sliding, what is staying fixed, and what the red line is the limit *of*.

5. **The two problems in miniature.** Look at Figure 1. In Panel (a), we zoom into a single point to find a slope $\mathrm{d}f/\mathrm{d}x$. In Panel (b), we add up thin strips across an interval $[a, b]$ to find an area $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. In your own words, why does finding a local rate feel like "cutting," while finding a total area feels like "gluing"?

6. **The structure and the limit.** Without looking back at Figure 3, sketch the chain from functions to differential equations from memory. Which single concept did the preface identify as the foundation, and how do later concepts build on it?

7. **Carry the walking question.** Write down, in one sentence, the speedometer paradox: how can an object have a definite speed at a single instant, when no time elapses and no distance is traversed at that moment? Keep this question in mind as you begin Chapter 1.

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Part I

Foundations: Before the Calculus

Chapter 1

What Calculus Is Really About

In the Preface, we saw that calculus turns on two geometric problems: finding the slope of a curve and finding the area under it. At first glance those two questions look completely unrelated. Let us trace both on a single concrete example – a falling ball – and watch how they turn out to be two sides of the same problem.

1.1 Two questions that built a subject

1.1.1 The first question: how fast, right now?

Imagine a ball dropped from a tall building. You have a stopwatch and a measuring tape, and you record how far the ball has fallen at each instant. After 1 second it has fallen about 4.9 meters; after 2 seconds, about 19.6 meters; after 3 seconds, about 44.1 meters. Galileo found, by rolling balls down ramps to slow time down enough to measure, that the distance fallen grows like the *square* of the time:

$$s(t) = 4.9\,t^2 \quad \text{(meters, with } t \text{ in seconds)},$$

where $s(t)$ denotes the distance fallen as a function of the elapsed time t. Now here is a question a child might ask and a physicist must answer: *how fast is the ball going at the exact instant $t = 2$ seconds?*

Speed is distance divided by time – but at a single *instant* no time passes and no distance is covered. The arithmetic comes out to $0/0$, which means nothing. "Speed at an instant" seems to be a contradiction in terms. Yet your car's speedometer reads something definite at every instant, and the ball really is moving at a definite rate as it passes the second-floor window. Something genuine is being measured. Calculus exists, in large part, to say exactly what.

Intuition

You already know how to dodge the $0/0$ problem in practice: you measure speed over a *short* interval and call it the speed "at" the middle. Drive 60 miles in one hour and your average speed is 60 mph; but to know your speed *now* you would glance at how far you went in the last second, or the last tenth of a second. The shorter the interval, the more the average over it deserves to be called your speed *right now*. Calculus is what happens when you take that

"shorter and shorter" seriously – all the way to the limit.

Let us actually do it. Average speed over an interval is

$$\text{average speed} = \frac{\text{change in distance}}{\text{change in time}}.$$

We want the speed near $t = 2$. Pick a small extra time h and look at the interval from $t = 2$ to $t = 2+h$ (the stretch of time starting at 2 seconds and lasting h seconds, written in standard interval notation as $[2,\, 2+h]$). The distance covered during that interval is $s(2+h) - s(2)$, so

$$\text{average speed over } [2,\, 2+h] = \frac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{h}.$$

With $s(t) = 4.9\,t^2$ this is

$$\frac{4.9(2+h)^2 - 4.9(2)^2}{h} = \frac{4.9\,(4 + 4h + h^2) - 4.9 \cdot 4}{h} = \frac{4.9\,(4h + h^2)}{h} = 4.9\,(4+h) = 19.6 + 4.9\,h.$$

As long as $h \neq 0$ we were allowed to cancel it, and we are left with $19.6 + 4.9\,h$. Now watch what happens as h shrinks:

interval length h (s)	average speed $19.6 + 4.9h$ (m/s)
1	24.5
0.1	20.09
0.01	19.649
0.001	19.6049
0.0001	19.60049

As h shrinks, the average speeds converge steadily toward a single number, 19.6 m/s. We never set $h = 0$ – that would have given the meaningless $0/0$ – but we watched where the answer was *heading* as h approached 0. That destination, 19.6 m/s, is what we will mean by the instantaneous speed at $t = 2$. This act of watching where an expression heads, without ever arriving, is the **limit** (the definite value a varying quantity approaches as its input gets arbitrarily close to some target), and it is the single technical idea on which all of calculus is built.

Pause

Pause and think: Before reading ahead, test the formula $19.6 + 4.9h$. What average speed would you measure over a window of just one microsecond ($h = 0.000001$ s)? You get 19.6000049 m/s. The smaller the window, the more the average speed is indistinguishable from 19.6 m/s. We never have to set $h = 0$ on the clock; we only have to read where the approach is heading.

What is really happening

The fraction $\dfrac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{h}$ is genuinely $\dfrac{0}{0}$ at $h = 0$ – there is no dodging that. What rescues us is that for every *nonzero* h, the fraction simplifies to the perfectly ordinary expression

$19.6 + 4.9h$, which has no trouble at all at $h = 0$. The instantaneous speed is not the value of the bad fraction *at* $h = 0$ (it has none); it is the value the *good* expression is approaching. A limit asserts: "no matter how close you demand the output be to 19.6, I can guarantee it by making h small enough." That is a statement about an entire neighborhood of h's, not about the forbidden point itself. Holding those two things apart – the value at a point versus the value approached near it – is an important distinction.

1.1.2 The second question: how much, in total?

Now flip the situation around. Suppose you do *not* know the distance fallen, but you do know the speed at every instant. From the table above we might guess (correctly) that the falling ball's speed grows linearly with time:

$$v(t) = 9.8\,t \quad \text{(meters per second)}.$$

The new question is the reverse of the first: *given the speed at every instant, how far has the ball travelled in total between* $t = 0$ *and* $t = 2$*?*

If the speed were constant – say a steady 20 m/s – this would be no harder than a grocery bill: distance is speed times time, $20 \times 2 = 40$ meters. But the speed is *changing* every instant, from 0 at the start to 19.6 at the end. There is no single speed to multiply by. So again we are stuck, and again the escape is to chop the problem into small pieces over which things barely change.

Intuition

Over a very short stretch of time the speed hardly changes, so over that short stretch "distance = speed × time" is *almost* exactly right. Slice the two seconds into many short intervals, on each one pretend the speed holds steady, multiply to get the little distance covered, and add up all the little distances. The thinner the slices, the better the pretense, and the closer the sum creeps to the true total distance. Once more it is "finer and finer, then take the limit."

Now look at what those little distances are. Distance over a short interval is (roughly) speed times the width of that interval – but "a height times a width" is the *area of a rectangle*. So adding up all those little distances is the same as adding up the areas of thin rectangles drawn under the speed graph. The total distance travelled *is the area under the speed curve*. A question about accumulated motion has transformed directly into a question about geometric area.

Let us add up the rectangles for $v(t) = 9.8\,t$ from $t = 0$ to $t = 2$, using n equal slices. Each slice has width

$$\Delta t = \frac{2 - 0}{n} = \frac{2}{n}$$

(where the capital Greek letter delta, Δ, is the standard mathematical shorthand for "change in", so Δt represents a small chunk of time). The right edge of the k-th slice occurs at time $t_k = k\,\Delta t = \frac{2k}{n}$. On that slice we evaluate the speed at its right edge:

$$\text{height} = v(t_k) = 9.8 \cdot \frac{2k}{n} = \frac{19.6\,k}{n}.$$

The area of this single k-th rectangle is its height times its width:

$$\text{area of slice } k = \left(9.8 \cdot \frac{2k}{n}\right) \cdot \frac{2}{n} = \frac{39.2\,k}{n^2}.$$

To get the total approximate area, we add all n slices together. Mathematicians write this sum using the capital Greek letter sigma, $\sum$, which stands for "sum": $\sum_{k=1}^{n}$ means "evaluate the expression for each step $k = 1, 2, \ldots, n$ and add up all the results":

$$\sum_{k=1}^{n} \underbrace{9.8 \cdot \frac{2k}{n}}_{\text{height}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{2}{n}}_{\text{width}} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} \frac{39.2\,k}{n^2}.$$

Because the factor $\frac{39.2}{n^2}$ does not depend on the index k, we can pull it out of the summation:

$$\text{Total rectangle area} = \frac{39.2}{n^2} \sum_{k=1}^{n} k.$$

To evaluate this sum, we use the classic identity for the sum of the first n positive integers:

$$\sum_{k=1}^{n} k = 1 + 2 + \cdots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}.$$

(You can see this geometrically: arrange the numbers 1 to n in a staircase of blocks, pair it with an identical upside-down staircase to form an $n \times (n+1)$ rectangle of total area $n(n+1)$, and take half). Substituting this into our total area gives:

$$\text{Total rectangle area} = \frac{39.2}{n^2} \cdot \frac{n(n+1)}{2} = \frac{19.6\,n(n+1)}{n^2} = 19.6 \cdot \frac{n+1}{n} = 19.6\left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right).$$

As the number of slices n grows without bound ($n \to \infty$), the excess fraction $\frac{1}{n}$ shrinks toward 0, so the staircase sum approaches 19.6 meters. And indeed, the area of the triangular region under the straight line $v(t) = 9.8t$ from $t = 0$ to $t = 2$ is $\frac{1}{2} \times$ base $\times$ height $= \frac{1}{2}(2)(19.6) = 19.6$. Notice that $s(2) = 4.9 \cdot 2^2 = 19.6$: the area under the speed graph reproduces precisely the distance we started from in the first question (Figure 1.1).

Pause

Pause and think: In Figure 1.1(a), why did our four rectangles overestimate the true area (24.5 vs. 19.6)? Because the ball is speeding up, so evaluating the speed at the *right* edge of each slice picked its fastest moment during that slice. What would happen if we used the *left* edge instead? The rectangles would sit entirely below the curve, giving an underestimate (14.7 meters for $n = 4$). As $n \to \infty$, the gap between the upper and lower staircase sums shrinks to zero, trapping the exact area 19.6 in between.

1.2 The two big ideas, named

Those two questions are central to calculus. Each has a name, and together they organize the rest of the book.

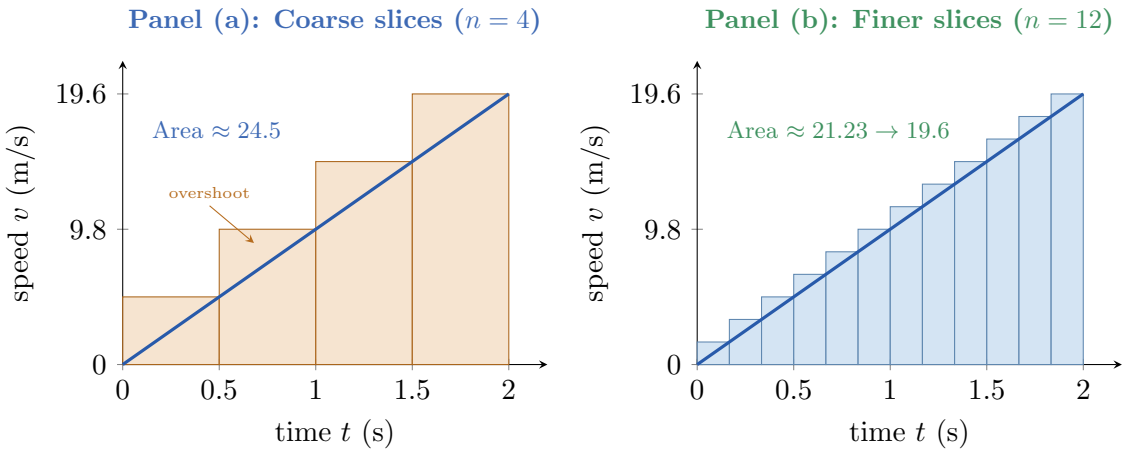


Figure 1.1: The total distance fallen between $t = 0$ and $t = 2$ equals the area under the speed graph $v(t) = 9.8t$. Panel (a) uses 4 coarse right-endpoint rectangles, overestimating the area due to visible stair-step wedges. Panel (b) uses 12 thinner slices, where the staircase clings tightly to the linear curve. As $n \to \infty$, the staircase error vanishes completely, converging to the exact area of 19.6 meters.

Focus

The derivative answers "how fast, right now?" It is the *instantaneous rate of change* of one quantity with respect to another – and, drawn on a graph, it is the *slope of the curve at a point*. The process of finding it is *differentiation*. **The integral** answers "how much, in total?" It is the *accumulation* of a changing quantity – and, drawn on a graph, it is the *area under the curve*. The process of finding it is *integration*.

The same two ideas appear everywhere, and recognizing them is essential. The derivative is velocity (rate of change of position), acceleration (rate of change of velocity), current (rate of flow of charge), marginal cost (rate of change of cost as you make one more), reaction rate, population growth rate, and the slope of any trend you have ever drawn through data. The integral is total distance from a speed, total charge from a current, total cost from a marginal cost, the work done by a varying force, the area of an irregular field, the mass of a rod whose density varies, and the probability piled up under a bell curve. Learn the two ideas once and you have learned them for every subject at once.

1.2.1 The derivative is the slope of a tangent

We computed the falling ball's instantaneous speed by shrinking a time interval. Let us now *see* that computation. Draw the graph of $s(t) = 4.9\,t^2$ with time across and distance up. Pick the point on the curve at $t = 2$. To estimate the speed there we used the interval from 2 to $2 + h$; on the graph, that amounts to drawing the straight line through the two curve points at $t = 2$ and $t = 2 + h$. A line through two points of a curve is called a **secant** line (from the Latin *secare*, "to cut", because it cuts across the curve), and its slope – rise over run – is exactly

$$\text{slope of secant} = \frac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{(2+h) - 2} = \frac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{h},$$

the very same average-speed fraction as before. *Average speed is the slope of a secant line.* Now let $h \to 0$: the second point slides along the curve toward the first, the secant pivots, and in the limit it becomes the line that just grazes the curve at $t = 2$ – the **tangent** line (from the Latin *tangere*, "to touch"). Its slope is the instantaneous speed, 19.6. The derivative *is* the slope of the tangent, and the tangent *is* the limit of secants (Figure 1.2).

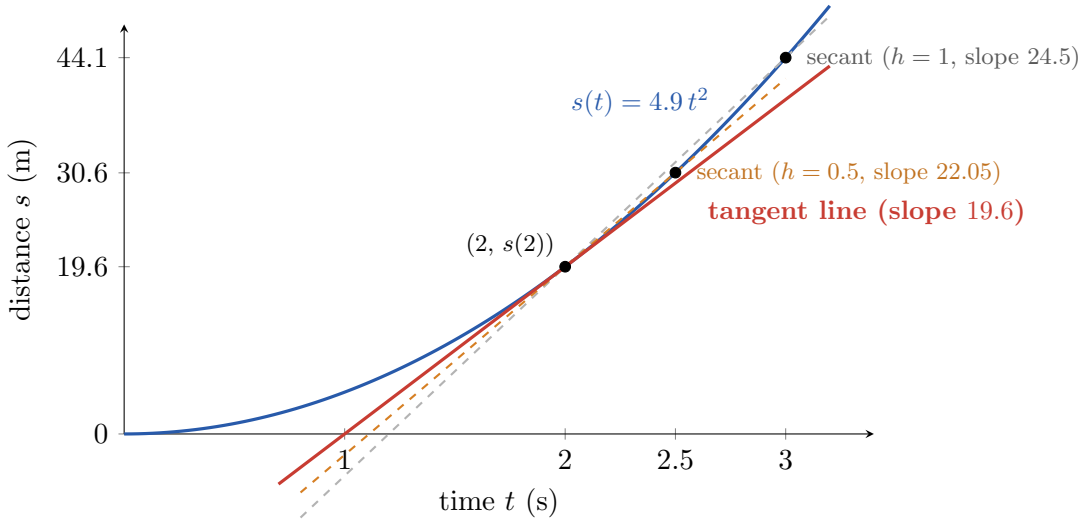


Figure 1.2: Secant to tangent convergence. The dashed lines join $(2, s(2))$ to $(2 + h, s(2 + h))$ for $h = 1$ and $h = 0.5$; their slopes represent the average speed over each shrinking interval. As $h \to 0$, the pivot point slides along the parabola toward $(2, 19.6)$ and the secant line approaches the solid red tangent line, whose slope is the instantaneous speed 19.6 m/s.

Why the technique works

Why should "slope of the tangent" equal "rate of change"? Because slope *is* a rate of change – that is all slope ever was. The slope of a straight line is rise over run: how much the output changes per unit change in the input. A curve is not straight, so it has no single slope; but if you zoom in on one point of a smooth curve, it looks straighter and straighter, until under enough magnification it is indistinguishable from a line. That line is the tangent, and its slope is the rate of change of the curve *at that point*. The limit-of-secants construction is just the precise way to find the slope of a graph that refuses to be a single straight line. Every derivative measures the local slope revealed by zooming in on a curve.

Walking question

Picture a curve that goes up steeply, then levels off, then dips down – say a hill in profile. Walk along it in your mind and watch the tangent line tilt as you go: steep up, then flat at the crest, then tilting down the far side (Figure 1.3). Where is the tangent perfectly horizontal? What is special about that point on the hill? You have just discovered, with no formulas, why setting the derivative to zero finds the tops and bottoms – the peaks and valleys – of a curve.

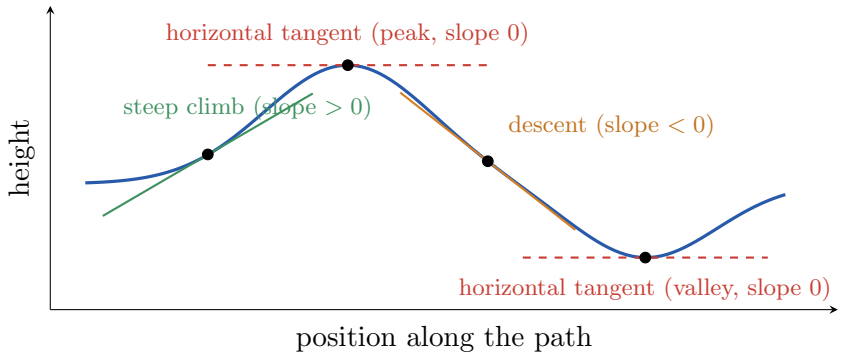


Figure 1.3: Walking the hill. On the climb the tangent tilts steeply upward (positive slope); at the crest and again at the bottom of the valley the tangent is perfectly horizontal (slope zero); on the descent the slope is negative. Those flat-tangent points identify the peaks and valleys – which is why, once we can compute derivatives, solving $f'(x) = 0$ pinpoints the extremes of any smooth curve.

1.2.2 The integral is the area under a curve

The accumulation question turned distance into area, and that picture is exactly the integral. Given any curve $y = f(x)$ sitting above the horizontal axis, the integral of f from $x = a$ to $x = b$ is the area of the region trapped between the curve and the axis over that span. We approximate it, as we did for the falling ball, by filling the region with thin rectangles: slice $[a, b]$ into many narrow strips, on each strip build a rectangle whose height is the value of f somewhere on that strip, sum the rectangle areas, and then let the strips become infinitely thin (Figure 1.4). The sum of rectangle areas is called a **Riemann sum** (named after the German mathematician Bernhard Riemann, who gave this rectangle-slicing method its strict mathematical foundation); the limit it approaches is the integral.

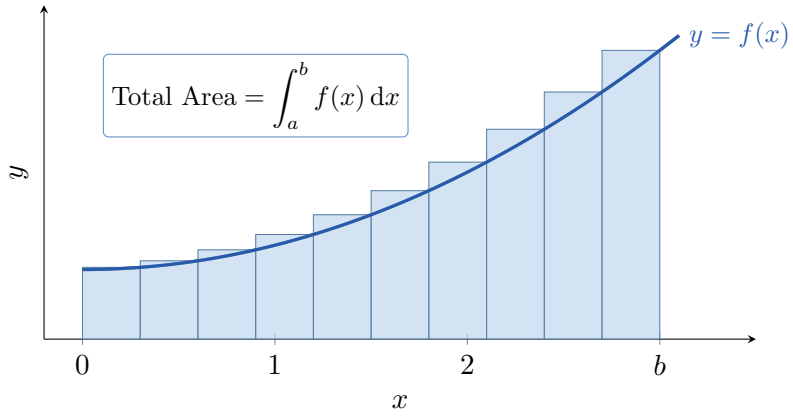


Figure 1.4: The integral as area. The shaded rectangles approximate the area under $y = f(x)$ from $x = a$ to $x = b$; as they get thinner their combined area converges to the exact area, written $\int_a^b f(x)\,dx$. The elongated "S" is Leibniz's sum sign, and dx is the vanishing width of a strip.

What is really happening

The symbol $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ encapsulates this limiting process. Leibniz wrote the integral sign $\int$ as an elongated letter "S" for *summa*, Latin for "sum," because an integral represents the limit of summing rectangle areas. Each approximating rectangle has area $f(x)\,\Delta x$: a height $f(x)$ times a strip width Δx. In $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, the factor $\mathrm{d}x$ recalls the finite strip width Δx before we pass to the limit $\Delta x \to 0$.

1.3 The central difficulty: the infinitely small and the infinitely many

Both the derivative and the integral rest on a limit. For the derivative, we watch a fraction whose numerator and denominator both shrink toward zero as the time step $h \to 0$. For the integral, we add up n thin rectangles whose individual widths shrink toward zero as $n \to \infty$. Neither calculation makes sense if you jump straight to zero, yet both settle onto exact finite numbers. Making that "closing in" completely solid was the hardest foundational problem in calculus.

Intuition

Why do we have to sneak up on the answer instead of plugging in directly? Because at a single frozen instant, $\Delta x = 0$ and $\Delta y = 0$, so rise over run becomes the meaningless ratio $0/0$. Likewise, "rate times time" breaks down when the rate changes at every moment. Calculus sidesteps both obstacles in the same way: compute first with honest, nonzero steps – a secant slope over $h \neq 0$, or the area of n finite rectangles – and then watch what single number those finite answers close in on.

Common trap

Never plug in $h = 0$ too early. Substituting $h = 0$ straight into $\dfrac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{h}$ before simplifying gives $\dfrac{0}{0}$ and tells you nothing; setting the rectangle width to zero up front leaves zero area in every strip. A limit is not evaluation at zero – it is the trend of honest finite answers as the step shrinks toward zero. Early pioneers got into logical trouble whenever they tried to treat an increment as nonzero during division and zero a line later; the limit keeps the step nonzero right up until we read off the destination.

1.3.1 How the pioneers got away with it

History

The two ideas are far older than the name "calculus." Around 250 BCE, *Archimedes* found the area under a parabola and approximated π by trapping a circle between inscribed and circumscribed polygons with up to 96 sides, a technique later called the "method of exhaustion" for how it exhausted the curved gap. He had the integral's core idea without its notation,

proving each result by contradiction to avoid speaking of infinity directly.
In the 1660s and 1670s, *Isaac Newton* in England and *Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz* in Germany independently synthesized rates of change and area into a unified system. Newton viewed curves as paths traced by moving particles, calling his rates "fluxions." Leibniz worked from differences between sequence terms, conceived of instantaneous changes as infinitesimals ($\mathrm{d}x$), and introduced the notation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ and $\int$ that we still use today. A bitter priority dispute broke out over who was first, but both reached the result independently: Newton had the physical insights first, while Leibniz built the superior notation.
What was missing was a coherent foundation. Newton spoke of quantities "ultimately vanishing"; Leibniz of infinitesimals that were nonzero when divided by and zero when discarded. In 1734, Bishop George *Berkeley* exposed this inconsistency in *The Analyst*, arguing that a calculation cannot legitimately treat the same increment as nonzero during division and zero immediately afterward. The formulas gave correct answers, but the logic remained incomplete. The gap stood open for a century. In the 1820s, Augustin-Louis *Cauchy* and later Karl *Weierstrass* replaced infinitesimals with the precise ε–δ (epsilon-delta) definition of a limit, using inequalities to define what "approaches" means without infinitely small numbers. In 1960, Abraham *Robinson* showed using mathematical logic that infinitesimals can also be made completely rigorous (nonstandard analysis).

Why this matters

Notice the order in which calculus grew up: physical and geometric intuition came first, and the formal ε–δ foundation arrived more than a century later once mathematicians knew what they were trying to protect. Your own understanding will grow best in the same order – see the picture first, then pin down why it must be true.

1.4 The central duality: differentiation and integration invert each other

We have two processes. Differentiation takes a quantity and returns its rate of change. Integration takes a rate and accumulates it into a total. Stated like that, they sound like opposites – and they are, in the precise sense that *each undoes the other*. This is the **Fundamental Theorem of Calculus**, the central theorem of the subject, and the reason these two questions belong in one book rather than two.

You have already watched it happen. We started with position $s(t) = 4.9t^2$. Differentiating it (shrinking the time interval) gave the velocity $v(t) = 9.8\,t$. Then, starting from that velocity, integrating it (summing rectangles under its graph from 0 to 2) gave back 19.6 meters $= s(2)$. We went out by the derivative and came home by the integral. Accumulate a rate of change over an interval and you recover the total change of the original quantity. In symbols, with F representing a quantity and $f = F'$ its rate of change (where the prime mark $'$ is Lagrange's notation for the derivative, read "F-prime"):

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F(b) - F(a).$$

Pause

Pause and think: Think of driving on a highway. Your speedometer gives your instantaneous rate of change $v(t)$, while your odometer records your accumulated distance $s(t)$. If you know your speedometer reading at every second of a two-hour trip, you can reconstruct the exact change on the odometer by integrating: $\int_0^2 v(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = s(2) - s(0)$. Differentiation reads the speedometer from the odometer; integration reconstructs the odometer from the speedometer.

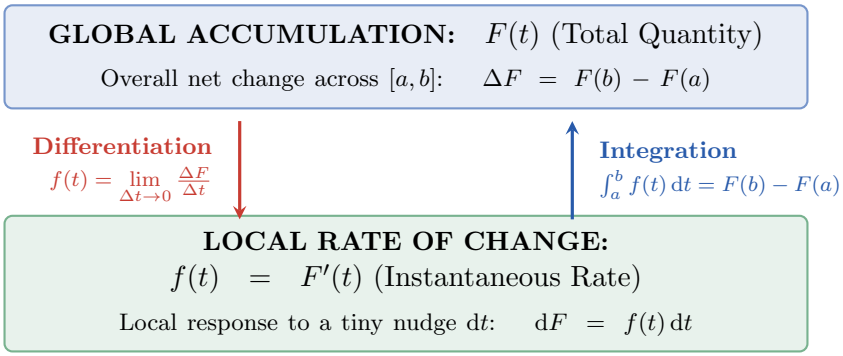


Figure 1.5: The Fundamental Theorem loop. Differentiation evaluates the local instantaneous rate of change $f(t) = F'(t)$ as a limit of difference quotients. Integration reverses the operation, accumulating the contributions $f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ to reconstruct the total net change $F(b) - F(a)$. Differentiation and integration are exact inverse operations.

Why the technique works

Why must accumulating a rate give back the total change? Suppose $F(t)$ is your bank balance and $f(t) = F'(t)$ is the rate money flows in and out at each instant. Over a tiny slice of time $\mathrm{d}t$, the balance changes by (rate)$\times$(time) $= f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$. Add up all those tiny changes from a to b – that is the integral $\int_a^b f\,\mathrm{d}t$ – and of course you get the *net* change in the balance, $F(b) - F(a)$, because the total change is the sum of all the little changes along the way. Differentiation breaks a running total down into its instantaneous rate at each moment; integration adds those local rates back up across an interval to recover the net change.

Why this matters

Tangent slopes and areas under curves look like completely different problems: one zooms in on the steepness at a single point, while the other adds up area across an entire interval. Historically they grew out of separate questions – motion and astronomy on one side, measuring curved shapes on the other. Discovering that each undoes the other is what turned two collections of tricks into a single subject: instead of summing infinitely many rectangles by hand, we can compute areas by running differentiation backward.

Connection

You already know pairs of operations that undo each other: addition and subtraction, multiplication and division, squaring and taking a square root. Calculus adds differentiation and integration to that list, acting not on single numbers but on entire *functions* and linking lo-

cal behavior (slope at a point) with global behavior (area over an interval). Much of higher mathematics, from differential equations to the divergence theorem of vector calculus and differential forms, extends this same local-to-global relationship.

1.5 Overview of the book

We will spend the early chapters making sure we know what a *function* is, and what the special characters of calculus – the number e, the exponential e^x, the trigonometric functions – actually *mean*, beyond merely manipulating formulas. Then we will build the *limit* carefully, because everything rests on it, and see how the ε–δ definition gives a precise mathematical meaning to "heads toward" a target. With limits in hand, we will construct the derivative, learn to compute it, and see *why* each rule (the product rule, the chain rule, and the rest) follows directly from the geometry of slope. We will do the same for the integral, prove the Fundamental Theorem that binds the two, and finally apply these tools to the equations that govern change itself – differential equations.

Focus

First, a picture before a formula, always: if you cannot see it, you do not yet understand it. *Second*, every rule comes with a reason – we will never ask you to memorize a procedure whose mechanism we have not exposed. *Third*, whenever $0/0$ or an infinite sum appears, we resolve it honestly with a limit – watching where finite quantities head rather than dividing by zero.

Work it yourself

Before you turn the page, do the falling-ball computation yourself, but at a different instant. Take $s(t) = 4.9\,t^2$ and find the instantaneous speed at $t = 3$ by forming $\dfrac{s(3+h) - s(3)}{h}$, simplifying until the h in the denominator cancels, and reading off the limit as $h \to 0$. You should get 29.4 m/s. Notice that in each case the speed came out as 9.8 times the time – you have just *derived*, by hand, that the derivative of $4.9\,t^2$ is $9.8\,t$.

To move from falling pebbles to more general curves, we need a precise vocabulary for quantities that change together. In Chapter 2, we build that language: functions.

Exercises

Exercise 1.1 (Mental check: cruise control)**.** If a car travels on cruise control at a steady 60 miles per hour, its position is $s(t) = 60t$ miles after t hours. Without using any algebra, what is its average speed over the interval $[2,\ 2+h]$ for any $h > 0$? What is its instantaneous speed at $t = 2$? Explain why, for a straight line, every secant line is already the tangent line.

Exercise 1.2 (Mental check: zero slope)**.** A parked car sits at position $s(t) = 0$ for all time t. Write down the difference quotient $\dfrac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{h}$. What is its value for any $h \neq 0$? What is the limit as $h \to 0$? What is the slope of the horizontal tangent line?

Exercise 1.3 (Average to instantaneous)**.** A pebble dropped from rest falls $s(t) = 4.9\,t^2$ meters in t seconds. Compute the average speed over each interval $[1,\ 1+h]$ for $h = 1,\ 0.1,\ 0.01,\ 0.001$. Then simplify $\dfrac{s(1+h)-s(1)}{h}$ algebraically and take the limit as $h \to 0$. What is the instantaneous speed at $t = 1$? Confirm it equals $9.8 \cdot 1$.

Exercise 1.4 (A different curve)**.** Let $f(x) = x^2$. Form the secant slope $\dfrac{f(2+h)-f(2)}{h}$, simplify so the denominator's h cancels, and find the limit as $h \to 0$. This is the slope of the tangent to $y = x^2$ at $x = 2$. Repeat at a general point $x = a$ and show the tangent slope is $2a$.

Exercise 1.5 (Area by rectangles)**.** Estimate the area under $y = x$ from $x = 0$ to $x = 1$ by summing n rectangles of equal width $1/n$, using right-endpoint heights. Show the sum equals $\dfrac{1}{n^2} \cdot \dfrac{n(n+1)}{2} = \dfrac{n+1}{2n}$, and take $n \to \infty$. Check your limit against the area of the triangle from elementary geometry ($\frac{1}{2} \times 1 \times 1$).

Exercise 1.6 (Conceptual: instant versus interval)**.** Explain in a few sentences, to a curious friend who has not taken calculus, why "speed at a single instant" is not simply "distance divided by time" at that instant, and how the idea of a limit rescues the notion. Avoid all symbols.

Exercise 1.7 (Reading the notation)**.** In the expression $\displaystyle\int_0^3 f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, identify in words what each piece refers to in the rectangle picture: the sign $\int$, the limits 0 and 3, the height $f(x)$, and the width $\mathrm{d}x$. Why is the integral sign shaped like an "S"?

Exercise 1.8 (The inverse relationship, by hand)**.** The velocity of a cart is $v(t) = 6t$ (meters per second). Using n equal rectangles, show the area under v from 0 to 2 approaches 12 meters as $n \to \infty$. Separately, guess a position function $s(t)$ whose instantaneous rate of change is $6t$ and check that $s(2) - s(0) = 12$. You have just verified one instance of the Fundamental Theorem.

Exercise 1.9 (Where the tangent is flat)**.** Sketch (by hand or in your head) the graph of $y = x^2 - 4x + 3$. Using the result that the tangent slope at $x = a$ for $y = x^2$ is $2a$, argue that the slope of this parabola at $x = a$ is $2a - 4$. At what x is the tangent horizontal? Relate your answer to the lowest point of the parabola, and explain the connection to the "walk along the hill" picture (Figure 1.3) from this chapter.

Exercise 1.10 (Conceptual: taming infinity)**.** In 1734, Bishop George Berkeley published a famous critique of early calculus (*The Analyst*). In your own words, explain what was logically uncomfortable about treating h as nonzero (to divide by it) and then as zero (to finish the calculation), and describe how the limit avoids ever doing both to the same quantity at the same time.

Exercise 1.11 (A proof in miniature)**.** Let $f(x) = c$ be a constant function. Using the secant-slope definition $\dfrac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$, prove carefully that the tangent slope is 0 at every point. Then explain geometrically why this had to be so, and physically why "the rate of change of something that never changes is zero" is the only sensible answer.

Exercise 1.12 (Speed from a table)**.** A runner's position is recorded as 0, 4, 16, 36, 64 meters at times $t = 0, 1, 2, 3, 4$ seconds. Compute the average speed over each one-second interval. Are these average speeds, or instantaneous ones? What extra information (or limiting process) would you need to claim the runner's exact speed at $t = 2$? Discuss why a finite table can never quite pin down an instantaneous rate.

Chapter 2

Functions: The Language of Change

In Chapter 1, we met the two central problems of calculus: finding the slope of a curve at an instant and summing the area beneath it. To tackle either problem beyond a single falling ball, we first need a clean way to describe how one quantity depends on another. That is the job of a *function*.

Every derivative measures how fast a function changes; every integral accumulates a function's values; every differential equation asks you to find an unknown function from its rate of change. Once you see a function clearly as an input-to-output rule, the rest of calculus has a natural language to speak in.

2.1 What a Function Really Is

Start with the everyday experience that functions are trying to capture: one thing depends on another. The cost of filling your tank depends on how many litres you pump. The distance a dropped stone has fallen depends on how long it has been falling. The temperature of your coffee depends on how long it has been sitting. In each case there is an *input* you can dial (litres, seconds) and an *output* that responds (cost, distance, temperature). A function is the exact bookkeeper of that dependence.

Intuition

Picture a machine with a funnel on top and a spout on the bottom. You drop a number in the top; a single number comes out the bottom. The machine is *deterministic*: drop in the same number twice and you get the same answer twice. A function is a reliable rule that assigns, to each allowed input, *exactly one* output.

The phrase "exactly one" is doing quiet but essential work. If a rule could send the input 3 sometimes to 9 and sometimes to 10, it would be useless for prediction — and prediction is the entire point. So we demand single-valuedness: one input, one output, no exceptions.

Definition 2.1 (Function)**.** A *function* f from a set D to a set Y is a rule that assigns to each element $x \in D$ exactly one element $f(x) \in Y$. We write

$$f : D \to Y, \qquad x \mapsto f(x).$$

The set D is the *domain* (the allowed inputs). The set Y is the *codomain* (a set guaranteed to contain all the outputs). The actual set of outputs,

$$\text{range}(f) = \{f(x) : x \in D\} \subseteq Y,$$

is the *range* (or image).

Read the notation out loud so it stops being decoration. "f colon D arrow Y" says f *takes things from* D *and produces things in* Y. The second arrow, the little "$\mapsto$" with a bar, is read "maps to" and tells you the actual rule: x maps to $f(x)$. The first arrow is about *sets*; the second is about a single *element*.

Focus

Three sets travel with every function, and confusing them causes more grief than any other early mistake.

- **Domain** D: where inputs are allowed to live.
- **Codomain** Y: a roomy "target" set we promise the outputs fall inside. It is part of how the function is *declared*.
- **Range**: the outputs that actually occur. Always a subset of the codomain, often a strict subset.

For $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$, $f(x) = x^2$, the codomain is all of $\mathbb{R}$, but the range is only $[0, \infty)$: no real input ever produces a negative output.

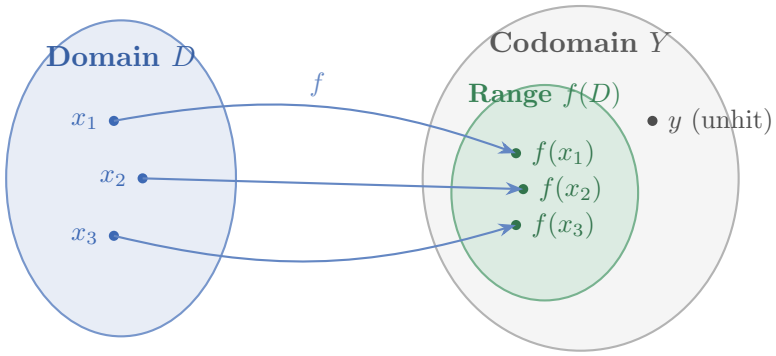


Figure 2.1: The three sets of a function $f : D \to Y$. Every valid input x lives in the domain D (blue). Every output lands inside the codomain Y (gray), but only the subset of outputs that are actually hit forms the range $f(D)$ (green). Unattained target values, like y, sit in the codomain outside the range.

2.1.1 The domain is part of the function

Here is a subtlety beginners routinely miss: *a function is its rule together with its domain.* The two formulas $g(x) = x$ on $\mathbb{R}$ and $h(x) = x^2/x$ are not the same function, even though x^2/x simplifies to x wherever it is defined. The second one cannot accept $x = 0$, because division by zero is undefined, so its domain is $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$. Same rule almost everywhere, different domains, different functions. Calculus cares about this fiercely: the behavior of a function *near* a missing point is exactly the kind of thing a limit is built to examine.

When a function is handed to you as a bare formula with no domain stated, the convention is to use the *natural domain*: every real number for which the formula makes sense (no division by zero, no even roots of negatives, no logs of non-positive numbers, and so on).

Example 2.1 (Finding the natural domain)**.** Find the natural domain of

$$f(x) = \frac{\sqrt{x+2}}{x-3}.$$

Two requirements must both hold. First, the square root needs a non-negative argument: $x+2 \geq 0$, i.e. $x \geq -2$. Second, the denominator must not vanish: $x - 3 \neq 0$, i.e. $x \neq 3$. Intersecting the two conditions gives the natural domain

$$[-2, 3) \cup (3, \infty).$$

Notice how the domain is a *geometric* object on the number line — two intervals with a single point punched out — rather than a mere algebraic footnote.

Common trap

"$f(x) = x$" and "$f(x) = \dfrac{x^2}{x}$" are different functions because they have different domains. More generally, cancelling a factor can silently enlarge the domain. Algebra that "simplifies" $\frac{(x-1)(x+2)}{x-1}$ to $x+2$ has quietly invited $x = 1$ back in — but the original expression was never defined there. Keep track of what you threw away; in calculus those punched-out points are where the interesting things (removable discontinuities, limits) live.

Pause

Pause and think: What is the natural domain of $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{\sqrt{4-x^2}}$? First identify the two restrictions: we cannot take the square root of a negative number, and we cannot divide by zero. So we require $4 - x^2 > 0$ (strictly positive, never zero). That rearranges to $x^2 < 4$, which means x must lie strictly between -2 and 2. The natural domain is the open interval $(-2, 2)$. Had the square root been in the numerator, -2 and 2 would have been included; in the denominator, they must be excluded.

What is really happening

What is a function "really," underneath the machine metaphor? Mathematicians who wanted no metaphors at all settled on this: a function *is* its complete input-output ledger. Formally, f is the set of ordered pairs

$$\{(x, f(x)) : x \in D\},$$

subject to one rule — no two pairs share the same first coordinate (that is single-valuedness restated). So a function is literally a set of points: precisely the set of points you plot to draw its graph. This is why "the function" and "the graph of the function" are, at the deepest level, the same object. The graph is not a picture *of* the function; it *is* the function, drawn.

History

The modern idea of a function developed over two centuries, driven by physics problems.
The word "function" first appeared in print with Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz in 1673. For Leibniz and Isaac Newton, calculus was about geometry and motion: Newton tracked *fluents* (quantities flowing in time) and their *fluxions* (rates of flow), while Leibniz tracked geometric line segments along a curve. Neither founder defined a function as an abstract mapping between sets. To them, a function was a variable quantity attached to a curve.
In 1748, Leonhard Euler defined a function as an "analytic expression"—a formula composed of variables and constants. This formula-bound view was challenged during the vibrating string debate of the 1750s. Jean d'Alembert and Euler believed a physical string could not have a sharp corner because a single formula could not describe it. Daniel Bernoulli argued that any string shape could be expressed as a sum of sine waves (a Fourier series). In 1822, Joseph Fourier showed in his work on heat conduction that infinite sums of sines and cosines could indeed represent piecewise and broken functions.
In 1837, Peter Gustav Lejeune Dirichlet proposed the modern definition: a function does not need a formula. It is simply any rule assigning a unique output to each input. To illustrate this, he introduced the Dirichlet function: $f(x) = 1$ if x is rational, and $f(x) = 0$ if x is irrational. This shift allowed Cauchy and Weierstrass to base limits and derivatives on clear definitions rather than formulas.

2.2 Graphs: Seeing a Function

If a function is a set of input-output pairs, we can *see* it by plotting each pair $(x, f(x))$ as a point in the plane, with the input along the horizontal axis and the output up the vertical axis. Sweep x across the domain and the points trace a curve: the graph. The graph turns an abstract rule into geometry, and geometry is where intuition lives.

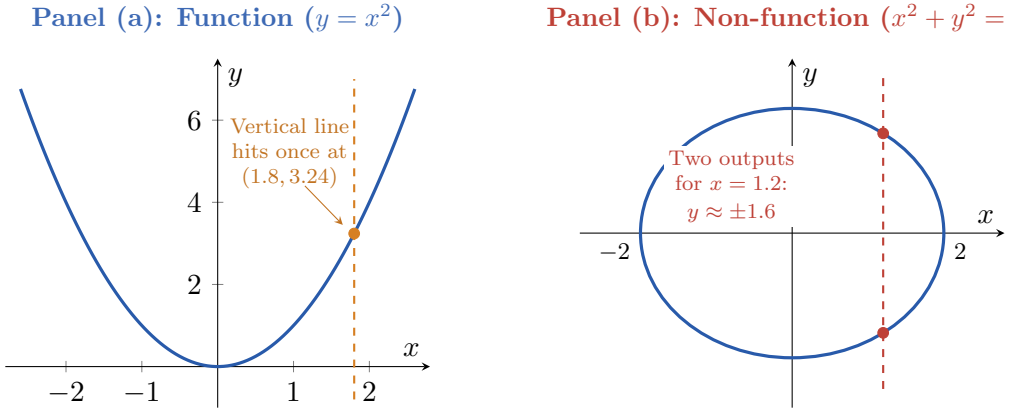


Figure 2.2: The Vertical Line Test in action. Panel (a): On the graph of $f(x) = x^2$, every vertical line crosses the curve at most once, guaranteeing that each input produces exactly one output. Panel (b): On the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 4$, the vertical line at $x = 1.2$ strikes twice (at $y \approx 1.6$ and $y \approx -1.6$), violating single-valuedness and proving the relation is not a single function of x.

Figure 2.2 also makes the single-valuedness rule visible, and gives us a quick diagnostic.

Focus

The Vertical Line Test. A curve in the plane is the graph of a function (of x) if and only if every vertical line crosses it *at most once*. A vertical line is the set of all points with a fixed input x; if it hit the curve twice, that single input would have two outputs, breaking the "exactly one" rule. So the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ is *not* the graph of a function — the vertical line $x = 0$ intersects it at both $(0, 1)$ and $(0, -1)$.

Learning to read a graph pays off constantly, because calculus keeps asking you to read off rates and areas from pictures. A graph shows you at a glance where the function is positive or negative (above or below the x-axis), where it is rising or falling, where it peaks or bottoms out, how fast it climbs (steepness), and what it does far out toward the edges of the domain. Each of those visual features will get a precise calculus name in later chapters — zero, increasing, maximum, derivative, limit at infinity. The graph is the bridge between seeing and computing.

2.3 Four Ways to Represent a Function

You can describe the same function in four complementary ways, and doing calculus well means translating back and forth between them without friction. Each view makes some things obvious and hides others.

1. **A formula (symbolic).** $f(x) = x^2$. Compact, exact, perfect for algebra and for the differentiation rules to come. But a formula can hide behavior — you may not *see* the minimum until you think.

2. **A table (numerical).** A list of input-output pairs. This is what a thermometer log or an experiment actually produces. Exact about the real data; silent about the values *between* the rows.

3. **A graph (visual).** The curve. Reveals shape, trend, symmetry, and speed at a glance; less good for reading off an exact value.

4. **Words (verbal).** "The output is the square of the input." How problems first arrive in the world. Often the hardest step in an applied problem is translating words into one of the other three forms.

Work it yourself

Take $f(x) = x^2$ and build all four views by hand. Words: *square the input.* Formula: $f(x) = x^2$. Table: compute f at $x = -2, -1, 0, 1, 2$ to get $4, 1, 0, 1, 4$. Graph: plot those five points and connect them with a smooth U. Now ask yourself which representation made the symmetry $f(-x) = f(x)$ jump out, which made the minimum at $x = 0$ obvious, and which would let you read off $f(1.5)$ most reliably.

Table 2.1: A function as a table: $f(x) = x^2$ sampled at five inputs. The table is exact at these points and says nothing about what happens between them — that silence is precisely what a graph (or a limit) fills in.

x	-2	-1	0	1	2
$f(x)$	4	1	0	1	4

Application

In data science and machine learning, you almost never meet a function as a clean formula. You meet it as a *table*: rows of measured inputs and outputs (pixels and labels, features and prices). The central act of supervised learning is to *guess a formula or graph* that fits the table and generalizes to inputs you have not seen. The four representations are not academic — choosing which one to trust, and how to interpolate between table rows, is the daily work. Calculus enters the moment you ask "which way should I nudge the formula to fit the table better?" — that nudge is a derivative.

2.4 Composition: Functions in Series

Machines can be plumbed together: send the output of one into the input of the next. If g turns x into $g(x)$, and f then turns *that* into $f(g(x))$, the combined two-stage machine is the *composition* $f \circ g$.

Definition 2.2 (Composition)**.** Given $g : A \to B$ and $f : B \to C$, their composition $f \circ g : A \to C$ is defined by

$$(f \circ g)(x) = f\big(g(x)\big).$$

It is defined exactly at those x in the domain of g for which $g(x)$ lands in the domain of f. You apply g *first*, then f — read the notation from the inside out.

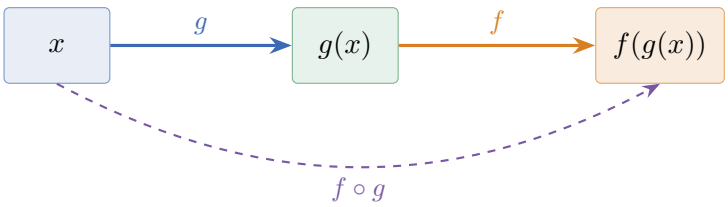


Figure 2.3: Composition is wiring two machines in series. The input x passes through g, and its output is immediately fed to f. The dashed arrow is the combined machine $f \circ g$.

Example 2.2 (Computing a composition)**.** Let $f(u) = \sqrt{u}$ and $g(x) = x^2 + 1$. Then

$$(f \circ g)(x) = f(g(x)) = \sqrt{x^2 + 1},$$

which is defined for *all* real x (since $x^2 + 1 \geq 1 > 0$ always). Reverse the order and you get a genuinely different function:

$$(g \circ f)(x) = g(f(x)) = (\sqrt{x})^2 + 1 = x + 1,$$

but now the domain is only $x \geq 0$, inherited from the inner $\sqrt{x}$. So even where $g \circ f$ and the bare formula $x + 1$ agree, the domain remembers the square root. **Order matters, and so does the inner domain.**

Common trap

$f \circ g$ is almost never the same as $g \circ f$. Composition is not commutative. Above, one branch gave $\sqrt{x^2 + 1}$ and the other gave $x + 1$ — not even close. Always apply the inner function first, and carry its domain restrictions along.

Why this matters

Why fuss over composition this early? Because the single most important rule in all of differential calculus — the *chain rule* — is the rule for differentiating a composition. "Most functions you will ever differentiate are composite functions" is barely an exaggeration: $\sin(x^2)$, e^{3x}, $\sqrt{1 - x^2}$, $\ln(\cos x)$ are all $f(g(x))$ for some inner g. Learning to *see* the inner and outer machine now is learning to use the chain rule later. We will return to this exact picture when the chain rule arrives.

2.5 Inverses: Running the Machine Backwards

Sometimes you know the output and want the input. You measured the cost; how many litres did you pump? You know the area of a square; what was the side length? You want to *undo* the function. The undoing, when it exists, is the *inverse function* f^{-1}.

Intuition

If f is a machine that sends $x \mapsto y$, the inverse f^{-1} is the machine that sends $y \mapsto x$ — it runs the original backwards. Feeding a number through f and then through f^{-1} must return you to where you started: $f^{-1}(f(x)) = x$. The inverse exactly cancels f.

But not every machine can be run backwards. Suppose $f(2) = 4$ and $f(-2) = 4$ (as for $f(x) = x^2$). Hand the inverse the output 4 and ask for the input — it cannot decide between 2 and -2. The inverse would have to be two-valued, which disqualifies it from being a function at all. The fix is to demand that f never sends two different inputs to the same output.

Definition 2.3 (One-to-one and inverse)**.** A function $f : D \to Y$ is *one-to-one* (injective) if distinct inputs give distinct outputs:

$$x_1 \neq x_2 \implies f(x_1) \neq f(x_2).$$

If f is one-to-one, its *inverse* f^{-1} has domain $\text{range}(f)$ and is defined by the rule

$$f^{-1}(y) = x \quad \text{exactly when} \quad f(x) = y.$$

It satisfies $f^{-1}(f(x)) = x$ for all $x \in D$ and $f(f^{-1}(y)) = y$ for all y in the range.

Common trap

The notation f^{-1} means *inverse function*, not reciprocal. So $f^{-1}(x) \neq \dfrac{1}{f(x)}$. The reciprocal of $\sin x$ is $\csc x$; the inverse of $\sin x$ (on a suitable domain) is $\arcsin x$. Same superscript, completely different objects. Blame history for the clash, and read carefully.

There is a beautiful diagnostic for "one-to-one," the mirror image of the vertical line test.

Focus

The Horizontal Line Test. f is one-to-one — and so has an inverse — exactly when every *horizontal* line crosses its graph at most once. A horizontal line is a fixed output value y; if it hit the graph twice, two inputs would share that output, killing invertibility. $f(x) = x^2$ fails this test on all of $\mathbb{R}$ (the line $y = 4$ hits at $x = \pm 2$), which is exactly why $\sqrt{\cdot}$ is only the inverse of x^2 *after* we restrict to $x \geq 0$.

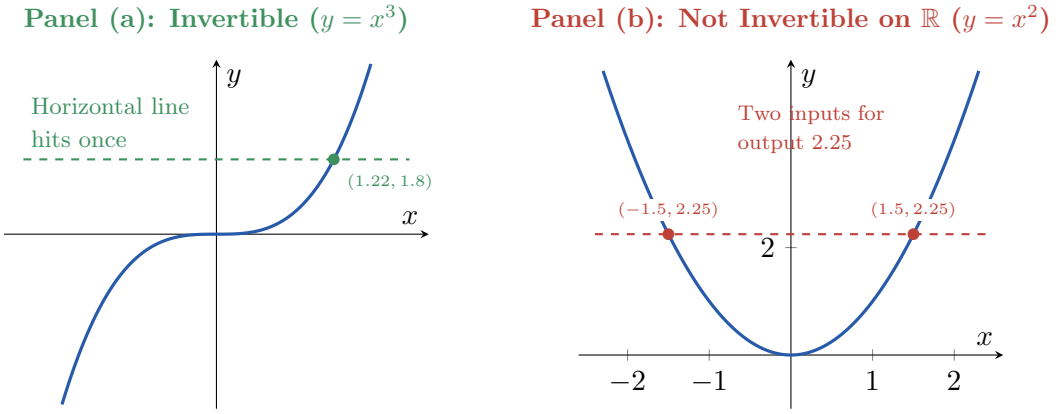


Figure 2.4: The Horizontal Line Test in action. Panel (a): For $f(x) = x^3$, every horizontal line crosses the curve at most once. Each output comes from a single unique input, so the function is one-to-one and can be inverted everywhere. Panel (b): For $f(x) = x^2$ on $\mathbb{R}$, the horizontal line $y = 2.25$ strikes twice (at $x = -1.5$ and $x = 1.5$). The machine cannot decide which input to return, so an inverse function is impossible unless we restrict the domain (for instance, to $x \geq 0$).

2.5.1 The graph of an inverse is a reflection

Geometrically, inverting a function swaps the roles of input and output — it swaps x and y. On a graph, swapping the two coordinates is exactly reflecting across the diagonal line $y = x$. So the graph of f^{-1} is the mirror image of the graph of f in that diagonal.

Why the technique works

Why does inverting a function mean reflecting its graph across $y = x$? Trace it slowly. A point on the graph of f is a pair (a, b) with $b = f(a)$ — "input a, output b." The inverse reverses the roles: it takes input b to output a, so the corresponding point on the graph of f^{-1} is (b, a). The operation $(a, b) \mapsto (b, a)$ that turns one graph into the other is precisely the

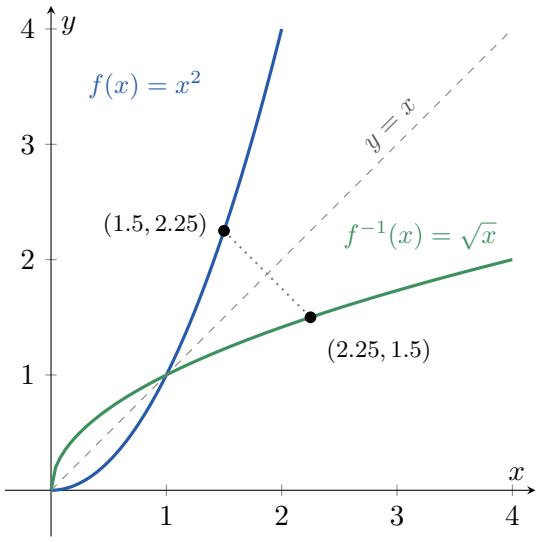


Figure 2.5: An inverse is a reflection across the diagonal line $y = x$. The point $(1.5, 2.25)$ on $f(x) = x^2$ (restricted to $x \geq 0$) is mirrored across $y = x$ to $(2.25, 1.5)$ on $f^{-1}(x) = \sqrt{x}$. Swapping input and output coordinates is geometrically identical to reflecting across the line of equality.

swap of horizontal and vertical coordinates. And swapping coordinates is a reflection across the line where the two coordinates are equal — the line $y = x$.

Example 2.3 (Finding an inverse algebraically)**.** Find the inverse of $f(x) = 2x + 3$. Set $y = 2x + 3$, then *solve for* x (this is the "swap input and output" step made concrete):

$$y = 2x + 3 \implies x = \frac{y - 3}{2}.$$

So $f^{-1}(y) = \dfrac{y - 3}{2}$, or, renaming the input back to x, $f^{-1}(x) = \dfrac{x - 3}{2}$. Sanity check by composing: $f^{-1}(f(x)) = \frac{(2x+3)-3}{2} = \frac{2x}{2} = x$. The machine and its reverse cancel, exactly as required.

2.6 Symmetry and Monotonicity

Two qualitative features of a function come up so often that they earn permanent names. Both are visible at a glance on the graph, and both will matter enormously once we are differentiating and integrating.

2.6.1 Even and odd: the two symmetries

Definition 2.4 (Even and odd functions)**.** A function f is *even* if $f(-x) = f(x)$ for every x in its domain, and *odd* if $f(-x) = -f(x)$ for every x in its domain.

Even means *mirror symmetry across the y-axis*: the left half of the graph is the reflection of the right half. Think $f(x) = x^2$ or $\cos x$. Odd means *point symmetry through the origin*: rotate the graph



Figure 2.6: Even functions are mirror-symmetric across the y-axis ($f(-x) = f(x)$); odd functions are rotationally symmetric through the origin ($f(-x) = -f(x)$).

180° about $(0, 0)$ and it lands on itself. Think $f(x) = x^3$ or $\sin x$. The names come from powers of x: x^{even} is an even function, x^{odd} is an odd function, which is the cleanest possible mnemonic.

Example 2.4 (Testing symmetry algebraically)**.** Classify $f(x) = x^4 - 3x^2$. Replace x by $-x$ and simplify:

$$f(-x) = (-x)^4 - 3(-x)^2 = x^4 - 3x^2 = f(x).$$

It equals the original, so f is *even*. Now try $g(x) = x^3 - x$:

$$g(-x) = (-x)^3 - (-x) = -x^3 + x = -(x^3 - x) = -g(x),$$

so g is *odd*. Most functions are neither: $h(x) = x^2 + x$ gives $h(-x) = x^2 - x$, which is neither $h(x)$ nor $-h(x)$.

Connection

Symmetry is more than visual balance — it saves real calculation. When you integrate an *odd* function over a symmetric interval $[-a, a]$, the left half exactly cancels the right half and the integral is 0, for free, with no antiderivative needed. For an *even* function the two halves are equal, so $\int_{-a}^{a} f = 2\int_{0}^{a} f$, halving the work. We will put both rules to work in the integration chapters. Even and odd are also the building blocks of Fourier analysis, where every function is split into its even (cosine) and odd (sine) parts.

2.6.2 Increasing and decreasing

Definition 2.5 (Increasing and decreasing)**.** A function f is *increasing* on an interval I if larger inputs give larger outputs there:

$$x_1 < x_2 \implies f(x_1) < f(x_2) \quad \text{for all } x_1, x_2 \in I.$$

It is *decreasing* on I if $x_1 < x_2 \implies f(x_1) > f(x_2)$. A function that is one or the other throughout I is called *monotonic* on I.

On the graph, increasing means the curve goes *uphill* as you read left to right; decreasing means *downhill*. Most interesting functions do both, in different stretches: $f(x) = x^2$ falls on $(-\infty, 0]$ and rises on $[0, \infty)$, turning around at the bottom of the U.

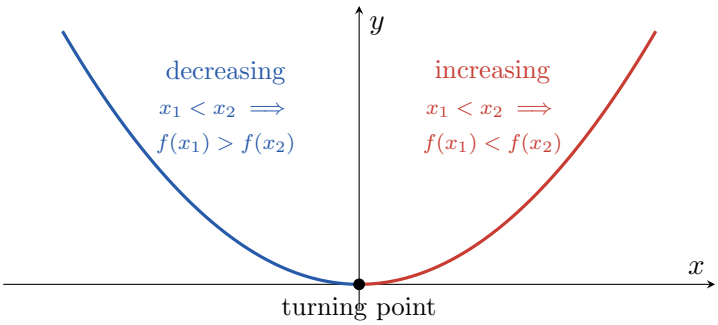


Figure 2.7: The parabola $f(x) = x^2$ decreases (downhill) on $(-\infty, 0]$ and increases (uphill) on $[0, \infty)$, turning around at the bottom of the U. The sign of the slope — and later, of the derivative — is exactly what flips at the turning point.

Connection

Notice the quiet link to invertibility from the previous section: a strictly monotonic function automatically passes the horizontal line test, so *every strictly increasing or strictly decreasing function has an inverse*. Monotonicity is the cleanest guarantee of invertibility we have. And in the chapters ahead, the sign of the *derivative* will be precisely the tool that detects where a function is increasing or decreasing — positive slope means uphill. So this informal idea graduates into a sharp, computable test.

2.7 Families of Functions

Calculus is easier when you recognize the species of function in front of you, because whole families share behavior. We build them up from the simplest.

2.7.1 Polynomials

A *polynomial* is built from x using only addition, subtraction, and multiplication — no division by x, no roots, no exotic operations. Concretely,

$$p(x) = a_n x^n + a_{n-1} x^{n-1} + \cdots + a_1 x + a_0,$$

where the coefficients a_i are constants and n (the highest power with $a_n \neq 0$) is the *degree*. The natural domain of every polynomial is all of $\mathbb{R}$: you can always add and multiply real numbers, so nothing is ever forbidden. Low degrees have familiar shapes — degree 0 is a horizontal line, degree 1 a slanted line, degree 2 a parabola, degree 3 an S-shaped cubic.

Why this matters

Polynomials are the friendliest functions in all of calculus, for three reasons. They are defined everywhere; they are smooth with no breaks or corners; and you can differentiate or integrate them with one trivial rule applied term by term. The deeper payoff comes much later: *Taylor's theorem* will show that a huge class of functions can be approximated, as closely as you like, by polynomials. So when we eventually want to understand $\sin x$ or e^x or $\ln x$ near a point,

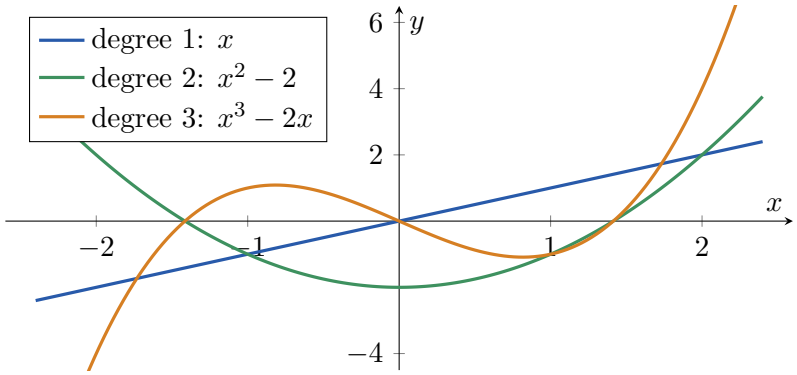


Figure 2.8: Polynomials of degree 1, 2, and 3. Degree controls the maximum number of turns: a degree-n polynomial can change direction at most $n - 1$ times, which is why the line never turns, the parabola turns once, and the cubic turns twice.

our strategy will be to replace them, locally, with a polynomial we already understand. Time spent on polynomials now is repaid then.

2.7.2 Rational functions

Allow division by polynomials and you get the *rational functions*: ratios

$$r(x) = \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}, \qquad p, q \text{ polynomials}, \quad q \not\equiv 0.$$

The name is the same "ratio" as in rational *numbers* (which are ratios of integers); here it is a ratio of polynomials. The new and important feature is that the domain now has holes: $r(x)$ is undefined wherever the denominator vanishes. Those forbidden points are where the most interesting calculus behavior lives — vertical asymptotes, where the function blows up toward $\pm\infty$.

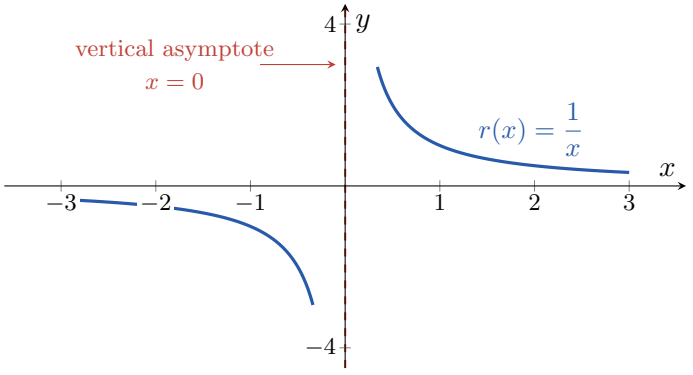


Figure 2.9: The rational function $r(x) = 1/x$. Its natural domain is $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$; as $x \to 0$ the value shoots off to $\pm\infty$, producing a vertical asymptote.

2.7.3 Algebraic functions

Go one step further and allow roots — square roots, cube roots, fractional powers — in addition to the four arithmetic operations. Anything you can build from x with $+, -, \times, \div$ and roots is an *algebraic function*. Examples: $\sqrt{x}$, $\sqrt[3]{x^2+1}$, $\dfrac{x}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}$. The presence of even roots restricts the domain (you cannot take $\sqrt{\text{negative}}$ over the reals), which is why $\sqrt{x}$ lives only on $[0, \infty)$ and $\dfrac{x}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}$ only on $(-1, 1)$.

Focus

A useful hierarchy, each family containing the previous:

$$\text{polynomials} \subset \text{rational} \subset \text{algebraic}.$$

Every polynomial is a rational function (with denominator 1); every rational function is algebraic (no roots needed). Functions that are *not* algebraic at all — that can never be captured by finitely many arithmetic operations and roots — are called *transcendental*. These are the headline acts of the next chapters: e^x, $\ln x$, $\sin x$, $\cos x$. They "transcend" algebra, and calculus is the right tool to tame them.

2.8 Transformations: Reshaping a Graph

Once you know the graph of one function, you can get the graphs of a whole crowd of relatives for free — by shifting, stretching, and reflecting. Understanding transformations means you never start a graph from scratch; you start from a shape you know and *move* it. There are four basic moves, and the key to all of them is a single distinction: changes *outside* the function act on the *output* (y), and changes *inside* act on the *input* (x).

Focus

The four transformations. Start from $y = f(x)$ and let $c > 0$.

- **Vertical shift:** $f(x) + c$ moves the graph *up* by c; $f(x) - c$ moves it *down*. (Outside; behaves as you expect.)
- **Horizontal shift:** $f(x - c)$ moves the graph *right* by c; $f(x + c)$ moves it *left*. (Inside; behaves *opposite* to the sign — the famous surprise.)
- **Vertical stretch/reflect:** $a\, f(x)$ scales the output by $|a|$ (a stretch if $|a| > 1$, a squash if $|a| < 1$) and flips across the x-axis if $a < 0$. (Outside.)
- **Horizontal stretch/reflect:** $f(bx)$ scales the input axis by the factor $1/|b|$, so $|b| > 1$ *compresses* horizontally and $|b| < 1$ stretches it, with a flip across the y-axis if $b < 0$. (Inside; again the counterintuitive direction.)

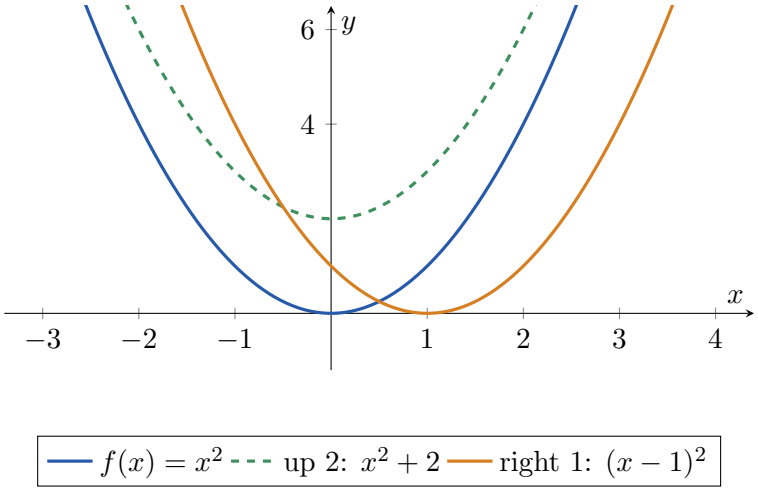


Figure 2.10: The base parabola x^2 (solid blue), shifted *up* by 2 via $x^2 + 2$ (an outside change), and shifted *right* by 1 via $(x-1)^2$ (an inside change). Note that $(x-1)^2$ moves right even though we *subtracted* — the inside surprise.

Why the technique works

Why does $f(x-c)$ shift the graph to the *right* when we *subtract*? It feels backwards, so let us pin down the mechanism instead of memorizing it. Call the new function $h(x) = f(x-c)$ and ask: where does h achieve the value that f achieved at some point x_0? It does so when its *inside* equals x_0, that is when $x - c = x_0$, i.e. at $x = x_0 + c$. So whatever f did at x_0, the new function h does at $x_0 + c$ — a position c units farther right. The graph's features all move right by c. The minus sign is there precisely because the input has to grow by c to "catch up" to the value the inside used to reach. Once you see it as "the input must increase to compensate," the direction stops being a paradox.

Pause

Pause and think: You are looking at the graph of $y = f(x)$. If you replace x by $2x$ to get $y = f(2x)$, does the graph get wider or narrower? Narrower: it compresses horizontally by a factor of 2. To see why concretely, suppose f has a sharp peak at $x = 10$. The new function $f(2x)$ reaches that same peak when its inside equals 10, which happens when $2x = 10$, i.e. $x = 5$. The peak arrives twice as fast, at half the distance from the vertical axis. Inside changes run on compensating logic: to produce the same inside value, the input x needs to be only half as large.

Example 2.5 (Reading a transformed graph)**.** Describe how to build the graph of $g(x) = -2(x+3)^2 + 1$ from the parabola $y = x^2$, taking the operations from the inside out:

1. $(x+3)^2$: inside change, shift *left* 3 units.
2. $2(x+3)^2$: outside multiply, stretch vertically by 2 (taller, thinner).
3. $-2(x+3)^2$: the minus reflects across the x-axis (the U now opens downward).
4. $-2(x+3)^2 + 1$: outside add, shift *up* 1 unit.

Result: a downward parabola with its peak (vertex) at $(-3, 1)$, twice as steep as the original. You read off the whole shape without plotting a single point.

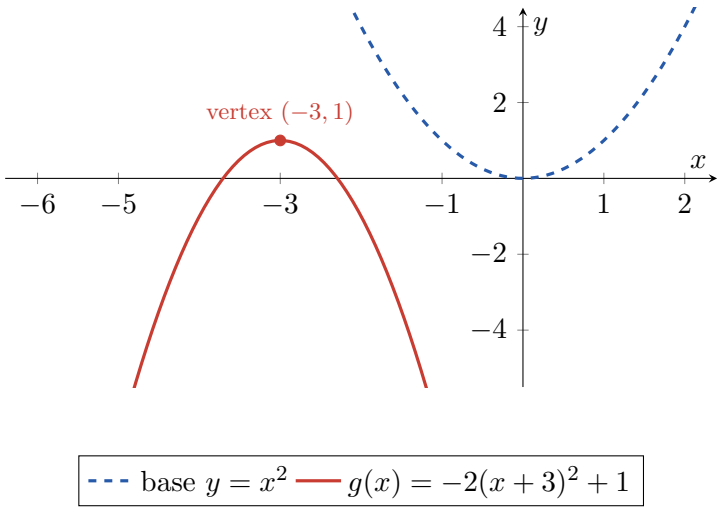


Figure 2.11: Building $g(x) = -2(x+3)^2 + 1$ from $y = x^2$: shift left 3, stretch vertically by 2, reflect across the x-axis, then shift up 1. The vertex lands at $(-3, 1)$ and the parabola opens downward.

Common trap

Order can matter when you stack transformations, because some of them do not commute. "Stretch then shift" generally differs from "shift then stretch." A safe rule: handle everything *inside* the function (affecting x) as one group and everything *outside* (affecting y) as another, and within each group respect the algebraic order of operations. When in doubt, test one point: a single tracked point will tell you immediately whether you applied the moves correctly.

2.9 Why Functions Are the Objects Calculus Acts On

We close by answering the question lurking under the whole chapter. Calculus has two central verbs — *differentiate* and *integrate* — and both take a function as input and return a function as output. Differentiation asks "how fast is this output changing as the input moves?" and hands you back the *rate-of-change function*, the derivative. Integration asks "how much has accumulated?" and hands you back the *accumulation function*, the integral. Neither question even makes sense for a lone number; both are questions about a *relationship* between a varying input and a responding output. That relationship is exactly what a function is.

What is really happening

Why do functions sit underneath everything in calculus? To talk about *change*, you need at least two quantities and a dependence between them: asking "how fast" always means asking "how fast *relative to what*" in context. A function is the cleanest object for packaging how one output depends on an input. Calculus did not pick functions for convenience; functions are the smallest honest description of a varying world, and calculus is what you can *do* with them. Everything ahead — limits, derivatives, integrals, series, differential equations — is a

verb whose noun is a function.

Walking question

On your next walk, pick something changing around you — your shadow's length as the afternoon wears on, your speed as you go up and down a hill, the loudness of traffic as a car passes. For each one, name the input and the output explicitly. Then ask the two calculus questions in plain words: *how fast is the output changing right now?* (that is a derivative) and *how much has accumulated so far?* (that is an integral). You will find that once you have named the function, the calculus questions almost ask themselves. That is the central habit of mind, and you can already practice it.

Connection

The historical rise of the function concept and the birth of calculus were closely intertwined. Isaac Newton thought in terms of *fluents* — physical quantities flowing continuously through time — and *fluxions*, their instantaneous rates of flow (what we now call derivatives). Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, working independently in the 1670s, thought in terms of geometric quantities varying along a curve, giving us the notation $\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}x$ and $\int$. For both founders, the true object under study was already a function in all but the modern formal name: a quantity changing in lockstep with another. The careful set-theoretic definition we gave at the start of this chapter came two centuries later, once mathematicians insisted on making the foundations airtight.

2.10 Looking Ahead: Beyond Polynomials

In this chapter, the functions we built were algebraic: polynomials, rational functions, and roots. For those functions, ordinary algebra is enough to simplify an average rate of change. Take $f(x) = x^2$. Over a step h, the average rate of change is

$$\frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h} = \frac{(x+h)^2 - x^2}{h} = \frac{2xh + h^2}{h} = 2x + h.$$

Factoring h from the numerator cancels the denominator, and letting $h \to 0$ gives $2x$.

Many natural processes do not follow polynomials. Bacterial growth, radioactive decay, and compound interest change at a rate proportional to their current size: they follow exponential functions $f(x) = a^x$. The difference quotient is

$$\frac{a^{x+h} - a^x}{h} = a^x \left(\frac{a^h - 1}{h} \right).$$

Here algebra cannot factor h out of $a^h - 1$. To understand exponential growth, we must find a base a for which $(a^h - 1)/h \to 1$ as $h \to 0$. In Chapter 3, we investigate this question and meet Euler's number e.

2.11 Exercises

Exercise 2.1 (Natural domains)**.** Find the natural domain of each function and express it in interval notation.

1. $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x^2 - 4}$
2. $g(x) = \sqrt{9 - x^2}$
3. $h(x) = \dfrac{\sqrt{x+1}}{x - 2}$
4. $k(x) = \dfrac{1}{\sqrt{x} - 2}$ (watch for *two* forbidden situations)

Exercise 2.2 (Range from the graph)**.** For each function, determine the range, and justify it geometrically (what is the lowest/highest output, and is every value between achieved?).

1. $f(x) = x^2 - 4$ on $\mathbb{R}$.
2. $g(x) = \dfrac{1}{x}$ on $(0, \infty)$.
3. $h(x) = 3 - |x|$ on $\mathbb{R}$.

Exercise 2.3 (Composition and order)**.** Let $f(x) = x + 1$ and $g(x) = x^2$. Compute $(f \circ g)(x)$ and $(g \circ f)(x)$, show they are different functions, and find every x at which the two compositions happen to be *equal*.

Exercise 2.4 (Decomposing a composition)**.** Each of the following is a composition $f(g(x))$. Identify a natural inner function g and outer function f. (This is the skill the chain rule will depend on.)

1. $\sqrt{x^2 + 1}$
2. $(3x - 5)^{10}$
3. $\dfrac{1}{x^2 + 1}$

Exercise 2.5 (Finding inverses)**.** Find the inverse of each function on the indicated domain, state the domain of the inverse, and verify by composition that it undoes the original.

1. $f(x) = 3x - 7$ on $\mathbb{R}$.
2. $g(x) = x^2 + 1$ on $[0, \infty)$.
3. $h(x) = \dfrac{1}{x - 2}$ on $(2, \infty)$.

Exercise 2.6 (Even, odd, or neither)**.** Classify each function as even, odd, or neither, showing the algebra $f(-x) = \ldots$ in each case.

1. $f(x) = x^4 + 5x^2 - 1$
2. $g(x) = x^5 - x$
3. $h(x) = x^3 + x^2$

4. $p(x) = \dfrac{x}{x^2+1}$

Exercise 2.7 (Transformations)**.** Starting from the base graph $y = x^2$, describe in words (inside-out) the sequence of transformations that produces each graph, and state the location of the vertex.

1. $y = (x-2)^2 + 3$
2. $y = -\frac{1}{2}(x+1)^2$
3. $y = 2(x-4)^2 - 5$

Exercise 2.8 (Conceptual: representations)**.** A function is given only by the table

x	0	1	2	3	4
$f(x)$	1	2	4	8	16

Propose a formula that fits all five rows. Explain clearly what the table can and cannot tell you: in particular, name two *different* functions that agree with the table at these five inputs but disagree at $x = 1.5$. What does this say about the limits of the numerical representation?

Exercise 2.9 (Proof: the vertical line test)**.** Prove the vertical line test carefully. That is, prove that a set S of points in the plane is the graph of a function $y = f(x)$ (for x ranging over some domain D) *if and only if* every vertical line meets S in at most one point. (Hint: a function is, by Definition 2.1, a single-valued rule; translate "single-valued" into a statement about the points $(x, y) \in S$.)

Exercise 2.10 (Proof: composition of one-to-one functions)**.** Suppose f and g are both one-to-one, and the composition $f \circ g$ is defined. Prove that $f \circ g$ is also one-to-one. (Hint: assume $(f \circ g)(x_1) = (f \circ g)(x_2)$ and peel off one function at a time, using injectivity of each.) Then explain in one sentence why this guarantees $f \circ g$ has an inverse, and state a formula for $(f \circ g)^{-1}$ in terms of f^{-1} and g^{-1}.

Exercise 2.11 (Proof: even/odd decomposition)**.** Let f be any function whose domain is symmetric about 0 (so $-x$ is in the domain whenever x is). Define

$$f_{\text{even}}(x) = \frac{f(x) + f(-x)}{2}, \qquad f_{\text{odd}}(x) = \frac{f(x) - f(-x)}{2}.$$

Prove that f_{even} is even, that f_{odd} is odd, and that $f = f_{\text{even}} + f_{\text{odd}}$. (This shows *every* such function splits uniquely into an even part plus an odd part — a fact at the heart of Fourier analysis.) As a check, carry out the decomposition for $f(x) = e^x$ and identify the two famous functions you obtain ($\cosh x$ and $\sinh x$).

Exercise 2.12 (Additive versus proportional growth)**.** Compare the linear function $f(x) = 2x$ and the exponential function $g(x) = 2^x$ on the inputs $x = 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5$.

1. For each function, compute the consecutive differences $f(x+1) - f(x)$ and $g(x+1) - g(x)$. Which function changes by a constant *amount* for each step of $\Delta x = 1$?
2. For each function, compute the consecutive ratios $f(x+1)/f(x)$ and $g(x+1)/g(x)$ (for $x \geq 1$). Which function changes by a constant *factor* for each step?
3. In plain words, explain why a bacterial colony that doubles every hour is modeled by $g(x)$ rather than $f(x)$, and why elementary polynomial algebra cannot easily calculate its instantaneous rate of change.

Exercise 2.13 (Restricting domains for invertibility)**.** The quadratic function $f(x) = (x-2)^2 + 1$ fails the horizontal line test on its natural domain $\mathbb{R}$.

1. Sketch or describe the graph, identify its vertex (turning point), and state its range.
2. State the largest interval of the form $[a, \infty)$ on which f is strictly increasing.
3. Restrict f to $[a, \infty)$ and find a formula for the inverse function $f^{-1}(x)$. State the domain and range of f^{-1}.
4. Verify by direct algebraic composition that $f^{-1}(f(x)) = x$ for all x in the restricted domain.

Chapter 3

Exponentials and the Number e

In Chapter 2, we explored algebraic functions where the variable x serves as a base raised to fixed powers, like x^2 or $\sqrt{x}$. But what happens when that relationship is turned inside out – when a fixed base is raised to a variable exponent x, producing curves like 2^x that multiply rather than add?

Among all possible bases, one number stands out across calculus: $e \approx 2.71828$. People often meet e as a button on a calculator and are told it is the "natural" base without seeing why a strange decimal near 2.718 could be more natural than 2 or 10. In this chapter we will see where e comes from – and why compound interest, tangent slopes, and infinite series all lead straight to the same number.

We start with the general family of exponential functions.

3.1 What an Exponential Really Is

3.1.1 From repeated multiplication to a smooth curve

An **exponential function** is a function of the form $f(x) = a^x$, where the base a is a fixed positive number and the input variable x sits in the exponent.

You first met powers as repeated multiplication. If a is a positive number,

$$a^1 = a, \qquad a^2 = a \cdot a, \qquad a^3 = a \cdot a \cdot a, \qquad a^n = \underbrace{a \cdot a \cdots a}_{n \text{ factors}}.$$

This is airtight when n is a positive whole number. You cannot multiply a by itself "$\frac{1}{2}$ times" or "-3 times" or "π times" by counting factors. So if we want a function $f(x) = a^x$ defined for *every* real number x – a smooth curve, rather than merely a discrete scatter of points over the integers – we have to *extend* the idea. The remarkable fact is that there is exactly one consistent way to do it.

The whole extension is forced by a single property we refuse to give up:

$$a^{x+y} = a^x \, a^y. \tag{3.1}$$

This is the law of exponents, and over the integers it is just bookkeeping: $a^{2+3} = a^2 a^3$ because 5 factors is 2 factors followed by 3 factors. We will *insist* that this law keeps holding for all real exponents, and that single insistence pins down everything else.

Intuition

Think of a^x as a machine that turns *addition into multiplication*. Slide the input x along by a fixed step Δx, and the output does not change by a fixed *amount* – it changes by a fixed *factor*. Walk one unit to the right and you multiply by a. Walk another unit and you multiply by a again. Exponentials are the functions for which equal strides cause equal *percentage* changes. That is the whole personality of the thing.

Let us see how (3.1) forces the rest of the definition, step by step.

Zero. Put $y = 0$ in (3.1): $a^{x+0} = a^x a^0$, i.e. $a^x = a^x\, a^0$. Dividing by a^x (which is positive, never zero) gives

$$a^0 = 1.$$

We did not *decree* that $a^0 = 1$ to be tidy; the exponent law leaves us no choice.

Negative exponents. Put $y = -x$: $a^{x+(-x)} = a^0 = 1$, so $a^x a^{-x} = 1$, hence

$$a^{-x} = \frac{1}{a^x}.$$

Again, forced. A negative exponent must mean a reciprocal, because that is the only thing consistent with the law.

Roots and fractions. What could $a^{1/2}$ be? By the law, $a^{1/2} \cdot a^{1/2} = a^{1/2+1/2} = a^1 = a$. So $a^{1/2}$ is a number whose square is a: it is $\sqrt{a}$. More generally $a^{1/n} = \sqrt[n]{a}$, and $a^{m/n} = \left(\sqrt[n]{a}\right)^m$. Every rational exponent is now determined.

Irrational exponents. This is the only delicate step, and it is the place where the integers quietly hand the baton to calculus. What is 2^π? We cannot reach π by counting or by fractions exactly. But we can *sneak up on it*. The number $\pi = 3.14159\ldots$ is the limit of the rational numbers

$$3, \quad 3.1, \quad 3.14, \quad 3.141, \quad 3.1415, \ \ldots$$

and each of those has a perfectly good power: $2^3, 2^{3.1}, 2^{3.14}, \ldots$ These values march steadily toward a single limiting number, and *that* limit is what we define 2^π to be.

What is really happening

When you write 2^π, nothing is being "multiplied π times." What is really happening is a *limit*. We define

$$a^x \;=\; \lim_{\substack{r \to x \\ r \text{ rational}}} a^r,$$

the value the rational powers approach as their exponent closes in on x. The reason this works – the reason the rational powers do not wander off but settle on one number – is that a^r is *monotonic and continuous* in r, a fact guaranteed by the completeness of the real numbers (the property that guarantees the number line has no gaps or missing points). Here, *monotonic* simply means the values head strictly in one direction—always increasing for $a > 1$, never turning around or fluctuating. So the exponential is the first place in this book where the smoothness of the real line is doing real labor under the surface. Calculus is already here, hiding inside an innocent-looking 2^x.

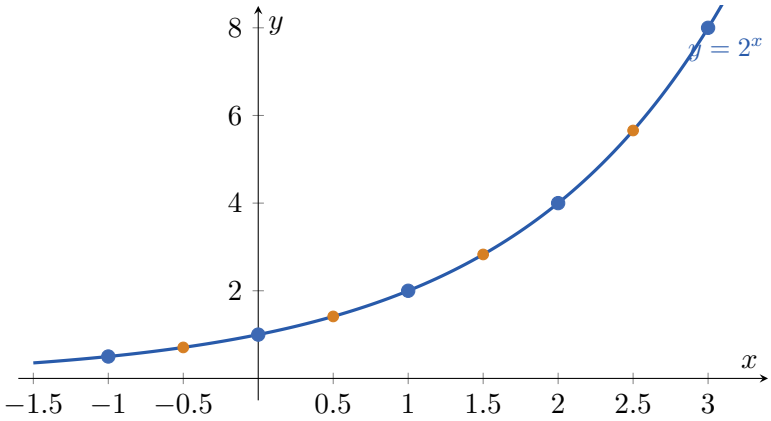


Figure 3.1: From discrete multiplication to a continuous curve. Counting factors defines 2^x only at integer exponents (blue dots). Demanding that the exponent law $2^{x+y} = 2^x 2^y$ hold everywhere forces the values at fractional exponents, like $2^{1/2} = \sqrt{2}$ and $2^{3/2} = \sqrt{8}$ (orange dots). Finally, real completeness fills every intermediate gap, weaving the points into a single unbroken curve.

3.1.2 The shape of the graph

With a^x now defined for all real x, let us look at it. Take $a > 1$, say $a = 2$. The function climbs, gently at first and then ferociously. Take $0 < a < 1$, say $a = \frac{1}{2}$; then $a^x = (1/2)^x = 2^{-x}$ is just the mirror image, decaying instead of growing. And $a = 1$ is the boring flat line $1^x = 1$.

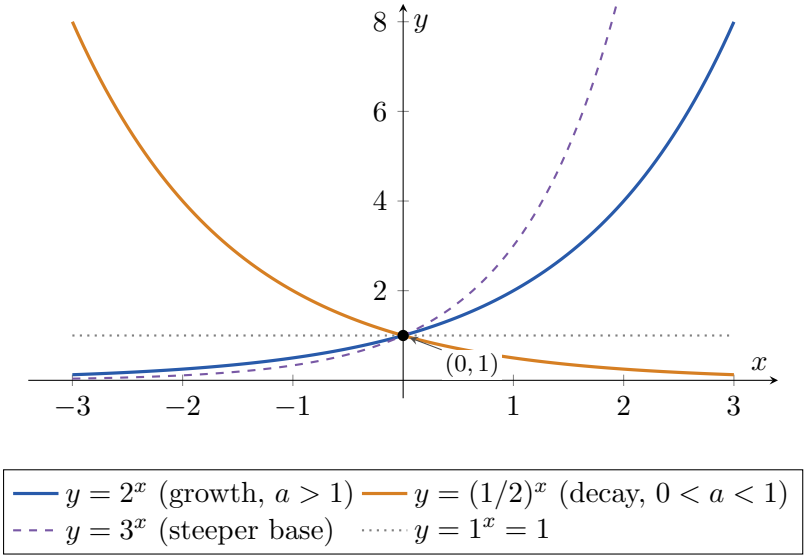


Figure 3.2: Every exponential $y = a^x$ passes through $(0, 1)$, stays strictly positive, and is either increasing ($a > 1$) or decreasing ($0 < a < 1$). Growth and decay are mirror images: $(1/2)^x$ is 2^x reflected across the y-axis.

Three features of Figure 3.2 are worth saying out loud, because they define how every exponential behaves and we will lean on all three.

- **It is always positive.** $a^x > 0$ for every x. The curve hugs the x-axis on one side but never touches or crosses it. (A positive number raised to any power stays positive; the x-axis is

a **horizontal asymptote**—a flat line that the curve gets closer and closer to as $x \to -\infty$, without ever quite touching it.)

- **It always passes through** $(0, 1)$**.** Because $a^0 = 1$ for every base, the whole family pivots through the single point $(0, 1)$.
- **Equal steps multiply.** Step right by 1 and the height multiplies by a. This is constant *proportional* change, and it is what makes exponentials the law of anything that grows or shrinks at a rate set by its own current size: populations, money, radioactive atoms, cooling coffee, viral posts.

Common trap

An exponential function is a^x: the variable is upstairs, in the exponent. A *power* function is x^a: the variable is downstairs, in the base. They are completely different animals. x^2 is a gentle parabola; 2^x eventually leaves every power function in the dust. Confusing 2^x with x^2 – or differentiating one as if it were the other – is one of the most common early mistakes. Say it to yourself: "exponential, variable on top."

Walking question

Here is a famous gut-check. A lily pad doubles its area every day, and on day 30 it covers the whole pond. On which day was the pond *half* covered? Most people instinctively say day 15. Walk with that for a minute and feel why the answer is day 29 – and why "half" happens at the very last step. That surprise – where half of all the growth happens in the single final step – is what makes exponential growth so deceptive.

Pause

Pause and think: the curved midpoint. Since $2^1 = 2$ and $2^2 = 4$, the straight arithmetic average of the two outputs is $\frac{2+4}{2} = 3$. But what is $2^{1.5} = 2^{3/2} = \sqrt{2^3} = \sqrt{8} \approx 2.828$? Why is $2^{1.5}$ strictly smaller than 3?
Look at the curve $y = 2^x$ in Figure 3.1. Because the curve bends upward (it is concave up), any straight chord connecting two points on the graph floats strictly *above* the curve. The midpoint of the straight chord connecting $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 4)$ is at height 3, while the actual point on the exponential curve sits beneath it at $\sqrt{8} \approx 2.828$.

Application

Why nature loves exponentials. Suppose a quantity changes at a rate proportional to how much of it there is right now. Money in an account earns interest in proportion to the balance. A bacterial colony makes new cells in proportion to the cells already present. A lump of uranium loses atoms in proportion to the atoms still intact. In symbols, the rate of change is k times the amount, and – as we will prove once we have derivatives in hand – the only functions obeying that are exponentials, $A(t) = A_0\, a^t$ for a suitable base. The exponential is not one model among many. It is *the* signature of self-proportional change, which is why it shows up everywhere from compound interest to carbon dating to the early phase of an epidemic.

3.2 Logarithms: Running the Exponential Backwards

3.2.1 The question a logarithm answers

Since a^x (for $a > 1$) is strictly increasing, it hits every positive height exactly once. That means it can be *undone*. Given a positive output y, there is exactly one input x with $a^x = y$. We give that input a name.

Definition 3.1 (Logarithm)**.** For a base $a > 0$ with $a \neq 1$, the **logarithm** $\log_a y$ is the exponent you must raise a to in order to get y:

$$\log_a y = x \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad a^x = y, \qquad (y > 0).$$

In words: $\log_a y$ answers the question "a to the *what* gives y?"

So $\log_2 8 = 3$ because $2^3 = 8$, and $\log_{10} 1000 = 3$ because $10^3 = 1000$, and $\log_2 \frac{1}{4} = -2$ because $2^{-2} = \frac{1}{4}$. Fundamentally, a logarithm is simply an exponent. The logarithm and the exponential are **inverse functions**: each undoes the other,

$$a^{\log_a y} = y \quad (y > 0), \qquad \log_a(a^x) = x \quad (\text{all } x).$$

Just as we saw in Chapter 2, these two inverse functions undo each other: if the exponential takes an input x and climbs to $y = a^x$, the logarithm takes that output y and recovers the original x that produced it. Geometrically, their graphs are mirror images across the line $y = x$, because swapping input and output swaps the horizontal and vertical axes.

Pause

Pause and think: comparing logarithms. Without using a calculator, which is larger: $\log_2 10$ or $\log_3 10$?
Translate both expressions into the logarithm's core question: $\log_2 10$ asks what power of 2 reaches 10, whereas $\log_3 10$ asks what power of 3 reaches 10. Because base 2 is smaller than 3, it needs more steps of doubling ($2^3 = 8 < 10 < 16 = 2^4$, giving about 3.32) to reach 10 than base 3 needs of tripling ($3^2 = 9 < 10 < 27 = 3^3$, giving about 2.10). Therefore, $\log_2 10 > \log_3 10$.

3.2.2 Why logs turn multiplication into addition

Every algebraic property of logarithms is just the exponent law (3.1) read backwards. This is worth seeing once, slowly, because it is the reason logarithms were invented and the reason they still matter.

Why the technique works

The mechanism: a logarithm is an exponent, so adding exponents becomes adding logarithms. Take two positive numbers u and v. Write them in terms of the base: $u = a^p$ and $v = a^q$, which is to say $p = \log_a u$ and $q = \log_a v$. Now multiply:

$$u\,v = a^p\,a^q = a^{p+q}$$

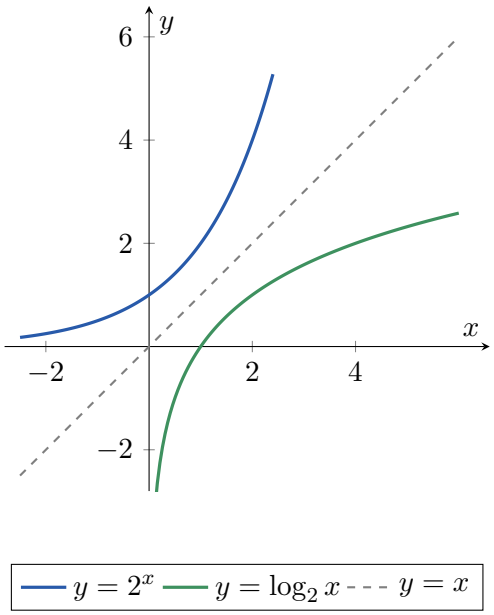


Figure 3.3: The logarithm is the exponential reflected across the dashed line $y = x$. The point $(0, 1)$ on the exponential becomes $(1, 0)$ on the logarithm; the vertical asymptote of the log (at $x = 0$) is the reflected image of the horizontal asymptote of the exponential.

by the exponent law. Read that last equation through the logarithm: the exponent that produces uv is $p + q$. Therefore

$$\boxed{\log_a(uv) = \log_a u + \log_a v.}$$

Multiplication downstairs became addition upstairs. The same one-line trick gives every other rule:

$$\log_a\left(\frac{u}{v}\right) = \log_a u - \log_a v, \qquad \log_a(u^n) = n \log_a u.$$

There is no separate "log algebra" to memorize. There is only the exponent law, seen from the other side.

Application

How logarithms revolutionized astronomy, navigation, and spaceflight. This was not a mere theoretical curiosity – it changed history. In 1614 John Napier published the first table of logarithms, and Henry Briggs soon recast them in base 10. Before computers, multiplying two eight-digit numbers by hand was slow, exhausting, and error-prone. With a log table, an astronomer could *look up* the logs, *add* them (a simple sum), and look the answer back up. Multiplication had been demoted to addition. Kepler used logarithms to grind through the heavy astronomical arithmetic behind his laws of planetary motion. As Laplace later remarked, "by shortening the labours," logarithms "doubled the life of the astronomer" in practice. Meanwhile, the slide rule – the engineer's constant pocket companion until the 1970s – consisted of two logarithmic rulers sliding past each other, *adding physical lengths* to multiply numbers. Every Apollo mission to the Moon was flown with calculations checked on

a device whose whole operating principle was $\log(uv) = \log u + \log v$.

Focus

Changing base. Any one logarithm can be rebuilt from any other by a constant factor. If $a^x = y$, take $\log_b$ of both sides: $x \log_b a = \log_b y$, so

$$\log_a y = \frac{\log_b y}{\log_b a}.$$

The shape of the log curve never really changes with the base – only its vertical scale. That is exactly why, in a moment, we will be free to hunt for the *one* base that makes calculus cleanest, knowing every other base is just a rescaling of it.

3.3 The Central Question: A Base That Grows At Its Own Rate

Now we come to the heart of the chapter. We have a whole family of exponentials a^x, one for each base a. For calculus, the question that matters most is: *how fast does a^x change?* That is, what is the steepness of its graph?

In Chapter 1, we saw that the steepness of a smooth curve at any point can be inspected through a geometric magnifying glass. We pick a nearby point separated by a tiny horizontal step h, draw the straight line connecting them (a **secant line**), and measure the average rate of change: the rise over the run.

We do not yet have the formal machinery of limits (which we will construct with full precision in Chapter 5) or the systematic rules of derivatives (which we will develop in Chapters 10 and 11). But exponential functions possess an algebraic symmetry so clean that we can preview their steepness right now, using only high-school algebra and secant slopes. When we reach Chapter 12, we will return to this exact calculation and establish it as a formal theorem of differential calculus. For now, let us see what the geometry reveals.

3.3.1 Steepness and the starting slope of a^x

Consider the secant slope between (x, a^x) and a nearby point $(x+h, a^{x+h})$ on the curve $y = a^x$. The average rate of change over this tiny interval of width h is the difference quotient:

$$\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x} = \frac{a^{x+h} - a^x}{h}.$$

Using the law of exponents (3.1), $a^{x+h} = a^x a^h$. Factoring out the common term a^x gives:

$$\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x} = \frac{a^x a^h - a^x}{h} = a^x \cdot \frac{a^h - 1}{h}.$$

The average rate of change splits cleanly into two pieces: the height of the curve a^x, and a second factor $\frac{a^h-1}{h}$ that does not depend on the position x at all.

As the step h shrinks toward zero—an operation we denote with the standard limit notation $\lim_{h\to 0}$—the ratio $\frac{a^h-1}{h}$ settles toward a fixed number that depends only on the base a. Let us call this number $M(a)$:

$$M(a) \;=\; \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{a^h - 1}{h}.$$

Because a^x does not change as $h \to 0$, the instantaneous steepness of the curve at position x—traditionally written $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}a^x$ in the notation of Leibniz introduced in Chapter 1—is given by:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\, a^x \;=\; M(a) \cdot a^x. \tag{3.2}$$

Intuition

Read (3.2) out loud: *the slope of an exponential curve is a constant multiple of its current height.* Whatever the base, the rate of growth of a^x is proportional to how high it has already climbed – exactly the "self-proportional" behavior we said exponentials embody. The constant of proportionality $M(a)$ is the only thing that changes from base to base. And $M(a)$ has a beautifully simple meaning: setting $x = 0$ in (3.2) gives the slope at $x = 0$ as $M(a)\cdot a^0 = M(a)$. So $M(a)$ is simply *the slope of a^x as it crosses the y-axis at the point* $(0, 1)$.

So every exponential is its own rate of change *up to a constant factor* $M(a)$, the starting slope. And $M(a)$ is itself a limit of secant slopes through $(0, 1)$: the quotient $(a^h - 1)/h$ is the slope of the line joining $(0, 1)$ to the nearby point (h, a^h) on the curve. As h shrinks, those secants pivot down onto the tangent at $(0, 1)$, and their slopes settle on $M(a)$. Figure 3.4 shows the pivot in action.

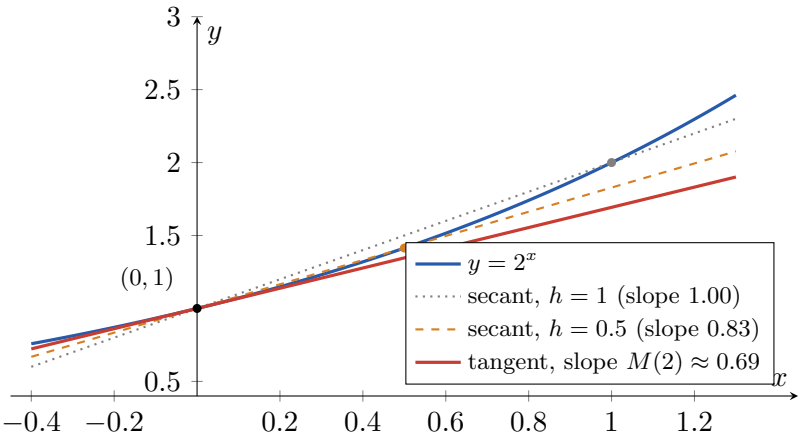


Figure 3.4: The starting slope $M(a)$ as a limit of secants, shown for $a = 2$. Each secant joins $(0, 1)$ to a point $(h, 2^h)$ on the curve; as $h \to 0$ the secants pivot down onto the tangent line at $(0, 1)$, whose slope is $M(2) \approx 0.69$. The number $M(a)$ is the slope this pivoting line lands on.

This raises an irresistible question.

Focus

The central question of this chapter.

Is there a base a for which the fudge factor is exactly 1?

That is, a base whose curve a^x crosses $(0,1)$ at slope exactly 1, so that $M(a) = 1$ and the derivative of a^x is a^x *on the nose*, with no leftover constant? Such a function would be its own rate of change – the purest possible expression of self-proportional growth. *That base, if it exists, is e.*

3.3.2 Cornering the base by measuring starting slopes

Let us actually measure $M(a)$ for a few bases and watch the special base reveal itself. Numerically, with a small h, $M(a) \approx (a^h - 1)/h$. Taking $h = 0.0001$:

base a	2	2.5	2.7	2.718	2.8	3
starting slope $M(a)$	0.693	0.916	0.993	1.0000	1.030	1.099

Look at the trend. At base 2 the curve crosses $(0,1)$ too *shallowly* – slope 0.69, less than 1. At base 3 it crosses too *steeply* – slope 1.10, more than 1. Somewhere in between, the slope passes through exactly 1. The table says it happens right around $a = 2.718$. We have trapped the special base between 2 and 3, and pinned it near 2.718, purely by asking the calculus question "which curve leaves $(0,1)$ at 45°?"

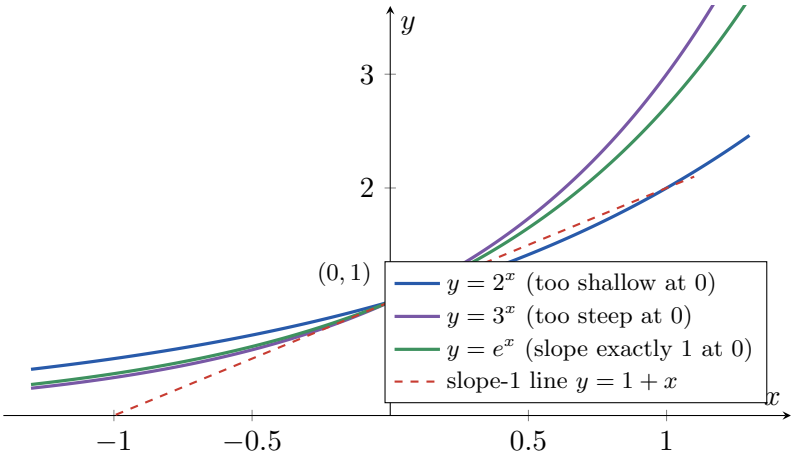


Figure 3.5: The hunt for the natural base. As x leaves 0, the curve 2^x rises too slowly and 3^x too fast. The base e is the one whose tangent at $(0,1)$ is exactly the line $y = 1 + x$ with slope 1.

This is our first sighting of e, and notice how we got it: not by decree, but by *demanding* a clean derivative. The number had to exist, because the starting slope $M(a)$ slides continuously from below 1 (at $a = 2$) to above 1 (at $a = 3$), so by the Intermediate Value Theorem it equals 1 somewhere in between. That "somewhere" is e.

Definition 3.2 (The number e, slope view)**.** e is the unique positive base for which the exponential e^x has slope 1 at $x = 0$; equivalently, the unique base making

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x} e^x = e^x.$$

Up to a constant multiple, the functions that equal their own derivative are precisely Ce^x (with e^x being the unique one with $f(0) = 1$).

Why this matters

Pause on how special Definition 3.2 is. "A function that is its own derivative" sounds almost paradoxical – the curve's height *is* its steepness, everywhere, simultaneously. Picture it: wherever e^x is at height 5, it is climbing at rate 5; at height 100, climbing at rate 100. The function carries its own velocity inside its position. This is why e^x is the natural language of every process whose speed is set by its present state, and why differential equations – the mathematics of change – are written in base e and almost never in base 10.

3.4 Three Faces of e

We now have one definition of e (the slope-1 base). But e is famous precisely because it refuses to be just one thing. The same number arises from money, from slopes, and from a tidy infinite sum, and the fact that these all agree is the real evidence that e is fundamental. We will meet *three faces* of e and show they are the same number.

3.4.1 First face: the compound-interest limit

Forget calculus for a moment and think about money. You invest \$1 at 100% annual interest. If interest is paid once, at year's end, you finish with $\$1 \times (1+1) = \$2$. Fair enough.

But suppose the bank compounds *twice* a year: it pays 50% at the half-year, and then 50% on the new, larger balance. After six months you have $1 \times (1+\frac{1}{2}) = 1.5$; after the full year, $1.5 \times (1+\frac{1}{2}) = (1+\frac{1}{2})^2 = 2.25$. By splitting the year you earned interest *on your interest*, and beat \$2.

Why not compound monthly? Quarterly? Daily? Every second? If we split the year into n equal periods, each period pays interest $1/n$, and the year-end balance is

$$\left(1+\frac{1}{n}\right)^n.$$

Let us tabulate this as n grows.

compounding	n	$\left(1+\frac{1}{n}\right)^n$
yearly	1	2.00000
twice	2	2.25000
quarterly	4	2.44141
monthly	12	2.61304
daily	365	2.71457
hourly	8760	2.71813
each minute	525600	2.71828
$\to$ instant	∞	2.718281828...

Intuition

Look at the tug-of-war inside $(1+1/n)^n$ as n grows: the base $1+1/n$ shrinks toward 1 (which pulls the result toward 1), while the exponent n shoots toward ∞ (which pushes the result upward). Neither side wins outright; they balance at a finite ceiling near 2.718. Going from yearly to monthly compounding makes a real jump, but going from hourly to every second barely moves the fifth decimal place.

Definition 3.3 (The number e, compound-interest view)**.**

$$e = \lim_{n\to\infty} \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n.$$

This limit really does converge – the values are increasing but bounded above (you can check $(1 + 1/n)^n < 3$ for all n), so by the completeness of the reals they close in on a definite limit. That limit is $e \approx 2.71828$.

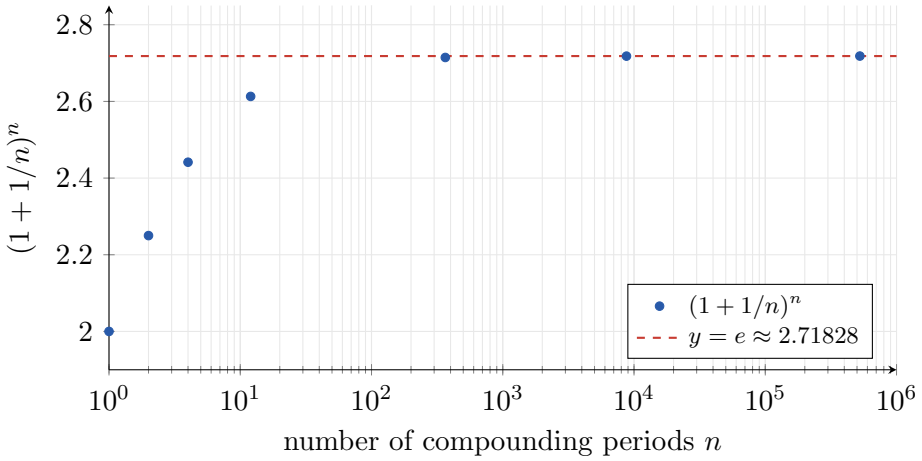


Figure 3.6: Compounding more and more finely. The balance climbs toward a hard ceiling: the horizontal line $y = e$. The horizontal axis is logarithmic, so even multiplying the compounding frequency by a thousand barely moves the dots once n is large.

Application

Continuous growth. Replace "100% for one year" with a rate r over time t, compounded n times. The balance is $\left(1 + \frac{rt}{n}\right)^n$, and as $n \to \infty$ this becomes e^{rt} (substitute $m = n/(rt)$ to recover Definition 3.3). This is the *continuous compounding* formula $A(t) = A_0 e^{rt}$, and it is the same formula that governs bacterial growth, radioactive decay (with $r < 0$), and Newton's law of cooling. The bank's idealized "interest paid every instant" is mathematically identical to a population reproducing continuously. e is what self-reinforcing growth looks like when you stop chopping time into pieces and let it flow.

3.4.2 Second face: the base whose derivative is itself

This is Definition 3.2, the slope-1 base. We have already cornered it numerically near 2.718 in Figure 3.5. The thrilling part is that it gives the *same* 2.718... as the money limit. Let us see why these two definitions give the exact same number.

Why the technique works

Why the slope base equals the compound-interest limit. Suppose a is the base with starting slope 1, so for tiny h,

$$\frac{a^h - 1}{h} \approx 1, \quad \text{i.e.} \quad a^h \approx 1 + h.$$

Now build up $a^1 = a$ by taking $h = 1/n$ and stacking n of these little steps. The slope-1 approximation $a^h \approx 1 + h$ with $h = 1/n$ reads $a^{1/n} \approx 1 + \frac{1}{n}$, and this gets better the larger n is (the smaller the step). Since $a = (a^{1/n})^n$,

$$a \;=\; \left(a^{1/n}\right)^n \;\approx\; \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n.$$

As $n \to \infty$ the approximation tightens to equality, and the right-hand side is exactly Definition 3.3. So the base with slope 1 *is* $\lim_{n\to\infty}(1+1/n)^n$. The "money number" and the "slope number" were never two numbers. The fine-grained compounding $(1 + 1/n)^n$ is literally the process of building self-proportional growth out of tiny equal multiplicative steps – which is the very thing a derivative of 1 at the origin demands.

Work it yourself

Confirm the bridge with your own hands. Take the slope-1 condition $a^h \approx 1 + h$ at $h = 0.001$, which says the special base should satisfy $a \approx (1 + 0.001)^{1000}$. Compute $(1.001)^{1000}$ on a calculator. You should get about 2.7169 – already closing in on 2.71828. Now do it again with $h = 0.0001$, i.e. $(1.0001)^{10000} \approx 2.7181$. Watch the digits of e assemble themselves as h shrinks.

3.4.3 Third face: the infinite sum $\sum 1/n!$

The third face is the one a computer actually uses. It previews the theory of **infinite series** (which we will explore systematically in Chapter 29). For now, think of an infinite sum simply as a sequence of running totals, called **partial sums**, that draw closer and closer to a final destination:

$$e \;=\; 1 + 1 + \frac{1}{2!} + \frac{1}{3!} + \frac{1}{4!} + \cdots \;=\; \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!},$$

where $n! = 1 \cdot 2 \cdot 3 \cdots n$ is the **factorial**—the product of all positive integers from 1 up to n, with $0! = 1$ by convention. The terms decrease rapidly, because each successive term divides by an increasing integer:

$$1,\; 1,\; \tfrac{1}{2} = 0.5,\; \tfrac{1}{6} \approx 0.1667,\; \tfrac{1}{24} \approx 0.0417,\; \tfrac{1}{120} \approx 0.0083,\; \tfrac{1}{720} \approx 0.0014,\; \ldots$$

Add them up cumulatively:

terms used	2	3	4	5	6	7
partial sum	2.0000	2.5000	2.6667	2.7083	2.7167	2.7181

After only seven terms we already have 2.7181, correct to four decimal places. Compare that with the compound-interest limit, which needed over half a million compounding periods to reach the same precision. *This* is why the series is the practical face: it converges quickly.

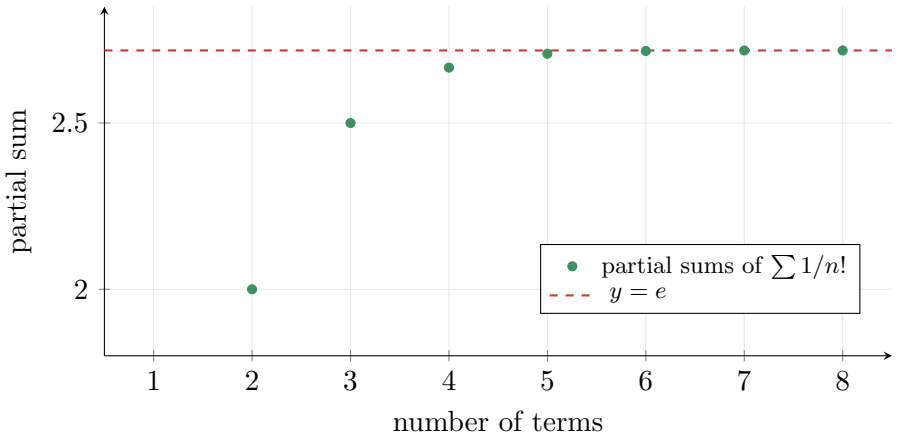


Figure 3.7: The series $\sum 1/n!$ races to e. Each new term is far smaller than the last, so the partial sums lock onto the limit after only a handful of steps – a stark contrast to the crawling convergence of $(1 + 1/n)^n$.

Where does the series come from? It is hiding inside the compound-interest limit. If you expand $(1 + 1/n)^n$ with the binomial theorem and let $n \to \infty$, each binomial term turns into a $1/k!$. Here is the mechanism.

Why the technique works

Why $(1 + 1/n)^n$ unfolds into $\sum 1/k!$. The binomial theorem gives

$$\left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \binom{n}{k} \frac{1}{n^k} = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{n(n-1)(n-2)\cdots(n-k+1)}{k!} \cdot \frac{1}{n^k}.$$

Look at the k-th term. The numerator $n(n-1)\cdots(n-k+1)$ is a product of k factors, each just a hair below n; dividing by n^k pairs them up as

$$\frac{n}{n} \cdot \frac{n-1}{n} \cdot \frac{n-2}{n} \cdots \frac{n-k+1}{n} = 1 \cdot \left(1 - \tfrac{1}{n}\right)\left(1 - \tfrac{2}{n}\right) \cdots \left(1 - \tfrac{k-1}{n}\right).$$

As $n \to \infty$ every one of those factors heads to 1, so for each fixed k the k-th term approaches $\dfrac{1}{k!}$. (Passing to the limit across the growing sum is honest here because each factor $1 - \frac{j}{n}$ lies between 0 and 1, keeping every term bounded above by $\frac{1}{k!}$ so the far tail past any cutoff K stays uniformly tiny.) Summing over all k,

$$e = \lim_{n\to\infty} \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{k!}.$$

Rather than a separate definition, the series is what the compound-interest limit *becomes* when expanded term by term; all three expressions define the same number.

The series view will return with full force in Chapter 30, when we discover that e^x itself has the Taylor

series $\sum x^n/n!$ – and that this is exactly the function that equals its own derivative (differentiate term by term: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n/n!) = x^{n-1}/(n-1)!$, and the sum reproduces itself, shifted). All three faces are then revealed as the same creature seen from three sides.

History

The symbol e and the number's role in analysis are due to Leonhard Euler in the 1720s–1740s. The constant had surfaced earlier when Jacob Bernoulli studied continuous compound interest in 1683, showing that $\lim_{n\to\infty}(1+1/n)^n$ lies between 2 and 3. Euler named the constant e, computed it to 23 decimal places using the series $\sum 1/n!$, proved it is irrational, and linked it to trigonometry through $e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta$. In 1873, Charles Hermite proved that e is transcendental (it is never the root of a polynomial with integer coefficients).

3.5 Why e Is Inevitable, and the Natural Log as Area

3.5.1 The natural logarithm

The logarithm to base e is so central that it gets its own name and symbol: the **natural logarithm**,

$$\ln x \;=\; \log_e x.$$

It is the inverse of e^x: $\ln(e^x) = x$ and $e^{\ln x} = x$ for $x > 0$. Everything we proved about logarithms holds, of course – $\ln(uv) = \ln u + \ln v$, and so on – but the natural log carries an extra gift inherited from its base. Because e^x is its own derivative, its inverse $\ln x$ has the cleanest possible derivative of any logarithm. We will prove later that

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\ln x = \frac{1}{x},$$

with no messy constant out front. (For any other base, $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\log_a x = \frac{1}{x\ln a}$ – the natural log is the one that washes the constant away, precisely because its base is the slope-1 base.)

3.5.2 A preview: the natural log is an area

That clean derivative $1/x$ provides another geometric path to e, one that needs no exponents at all. Here is the idea, as an intuitive preview of the integral chapters to come (specifically Chapter 20).

Consider the curve $y = 1/t$ for $t > 0$ – a simple hyperbola sloping down toward the horizontal axis. Define $L(x)$ to be the accumulated *geometric area* under this curve between $t = 1$ and $t = x$. In standard calculus notation, this accumulation is written with an elongated "S" called an **integral**:

$$L(x) \;=\; \int_1^x \frac{1}{t}\,\mathrm{d}t \;=\; (\text{area beneath } y = 1/t \text{ from } t = 1 \text{ to } t = x).$$

For now, you do not need any formal integration rules; simply picture shading the region on graph paper and counting squares. Yet this innocent area function turns out to *be* the natural logarithm: $L(x) = \ln x$. And it carries the logarithm law right in its geometry: stretching the region horizontally by a factor reproduces $\ln(ab) = \ln a + \ln b$ as a pure statement about areas.

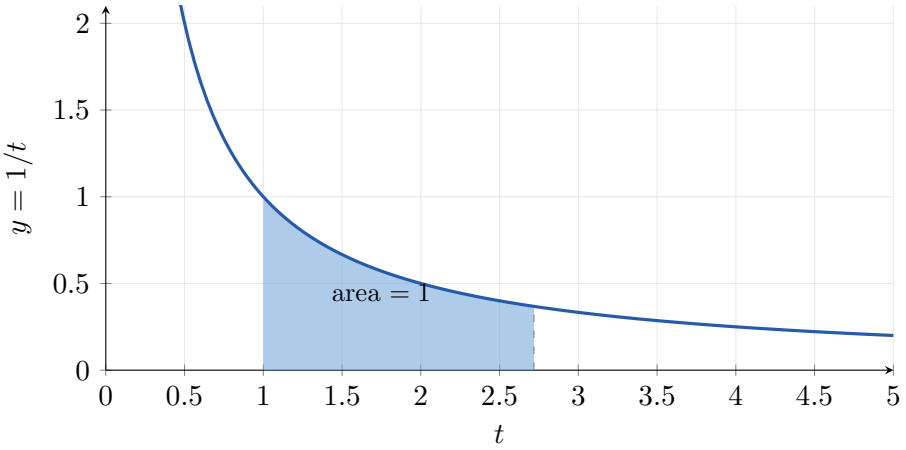


Figure 3.8: The natural logarithm as accumulated area under $y = 1/t$. The shaded region from $t = 1$ to $t = e$ has area exactly 1. This is yet another way to single out e: it is the upper limit at which the running area under $1/t$ first reaches 1, i.e. the x with $\ln x = 1$.

FACE 1 (GROWTH & FINANCE): $e = \lim_{n\to\infty} \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n \approx 2.71828\ldots$

Continuous compounding limit: instantaneous proportional growth at all moments.

FACE 2 (CALCULUS & TANGENTS): $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x} e^x = e^x \iff \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{e^h - 1}{h} = 1$

Self-derivative: curve leaves $(0, 1)$ at 45°; slope equals current height.

FACE 3 (SERIES EXPANSION): $e = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{k!} = 1 + 1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{24} + \ldots$

Rapid factorial convergence: locks onto precision in only a handful of terms.

FACE 4 (GEOMETRIC ACCUMULATION): $\int_1^e \frac{1}{t}\,\mathrm{d}t = 1 \iff \ln(e) = 1$

Hyperbolic area: boundary where accumulated area under $1/t$ reaches unit area.

Figure 3.9: Four distinct doors opening onto the same mathematical constant $e \approx 2.71828\ldots$. Continuous compound interest, the requirement that e^x equal its own derivative, the factorial series $\sum 1/k!$, and the unit-area mark under $y = 1/t$ all single out the exact same number.

Why this matters

Why is e called "natural" while base 10 is not? Base 10 is an accident of human anatomy; base e is forced by calculus itself. Ask for continuous growth, ask for an exponential whose derivative needs no scaling constant, expand that growth into factorials, or measure the area under $1/t$ – in each case, e is the value you find.

Connection

This area-under-$1/t$ picture is more than a curiosity – it is the cleanest *logical* foundation for the whole subject. Notice the awkwardness we waded through in the opening section: to define a^x for irrational x we needed limits, and to differentiate it we needed the mysterious constant $M(a)$. The modern, airtight approach turns the whole story upside down. *First* define $\ln x$ as the area $\int_1^x \frac{1}{t}\,\mathrm{d}t$ – which needs only integration, no irrational exponents at all. *Then* define e^x as its inverse, and *finally* define $a^x = e^{x\ln a}$. Every property we fought for – the exponent law, the derivative rule, the value of e – drops out as a clean theorem. We will walk that road in the chapters on the integral and the Fundamental Theorem. For now, the hyperbola in Figure 3.8 is quietly holding up everything in this chapter.

3.6 Worked Examples

Example 3.1 (Reading the exponent law backward)**.** Simplify $\dfrac{e^3 \cdot e^x}{e^{x-2}}$.

Solution. Combine the numerator with the law $e^a e^b = e^{a+b}$: the top is e^{3+x}. Dividing by e^{x-2} subtracts exponents:

$$\frac{e^{3+x}}{e^{x-2}} = e^{(3+x)-(x-2)} = e^{3+x-x+2} = e^5.$$

The x's cancel entirely. Whenever you see a ratio of exponentials with the same base, do not panic – just add and subtract the exponents.

Example 3.2 (Logs turn an equation inside out)**.** Solve $5 \cdot 2^x = 320$ for x.

Solution. First isolate the exponential: $2^x = 64$. Now ask the logarithm's question, "2 to the what is 64?" Since $64 = 2^6$, we read off $x = 6$. If the right-hand side were not a clean power of 2, we would take ln of both sides:

$$x \ln 2 = \ln 64 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x = \frac{\ln 64}{\ln 2} = \log_2 64 = 6.$$

The logarithm is exactly the tool that brings the unknown *down* from the exponent where you cannot reach it.

Example 3.3 (Continuous vs. annual compounding)**.** You invest \$1000 at 6% per year for 10 years. Compare yearly compounding with continuous compounding.

Solution. Yearly: $A = 1000(1 + 0.06)^{10} = 1000(1.06)^{10} \approx 1000(1.7908) = \$1790.85$. Continuous: $A = 1000\, e^{0.06 \cdot 10} = 1000\, e^{0.6} \approx 1000(1.8221) = \$1822.12$. Compounding "every instant" instead of once a year earns an extra \$31 over the decade – real money, but a far cry from doubling. The gap is the diminishing return we saw in Figure 3.6: most of the benefit of compounding is captured already by compounding a few times a year.

Example 3.4 (How many terms of the series?)**.** Estimate e using the series through the $1/4!$ term, and bound the error.

Solution. The partial sum is

$$1 + 1 + \tfrac{1}{2} + \tfrac{1}{6} + \tfrac{1}{24} = 2 + 0.5 + 0.16667 + 0.04167 = 2.70833.$$

The true value is 2.71828, so the error is about 0.00995. The first omitted term is $1/5! = 1/120 \approx 0.00833$, and indeed the total error is just a touch more than that one term – because every *later* term is far smaller still. This is the hallmark of a fast series: the error is essentially the size of the first thing you dropped.

Example 3.5 (Estimating the starting slope of 3^x)**.** Estimate $M(3) = \lim_{h\to 0}(3^h - 1)/h$ numerically, and say what it means.

Solution. With $h = 0.001$: $3^{0.001} = e^{0.001 \ln 3} \approx 1 + 0.001(1.0986) = 1.0010986$, so $(3^{0.001} - 1)/0.001 \approx 1.0986$. Thus $M(3) \approx 1.099$, matching our table. It means the curve 3^x crosses $(0, 1)$ at slope 1.099 – a bit steeper than 45° – which is why 3 overshoots the natural base e. (And note $1.0986 \approx \ln 3$: the starting slope of a^x is precisely $\ln a$, a fact we will prove once we have the chain rule, since $a^x = e^{x \ln a}$.)

3.7 Looking Ahead: Periodic Change

Exponentials model growth and decay, where quantities multiply and move away from their starting values. Physical quantities also cycle and oscillate: pendulums swing, strings vibrate, and planets orbit. In Chapter 4, we turn to the functions that describe periodic change: sines and cosines.

3.8 Exercises

Exercise 3.1 (Proof: algebraic laws of exponents)**.** Using only the exponent law $a^{x+y} = a^x a^y$ and $a^0 = 1$, prove that $a^{-x} = 1/a^x$ and that $(a^x)^y = a^{xy}$ for integer y. State clearly where you use each law.

Exercise 3.2 (Mental check: evaluating logarithms)**.** Simplify without a calculator: (a) $\log_2 32$; (b) $\log_3 \frac{1}{27}$; (c) $\ln(e^4)$; (d) $e^{\ln 7}$; (e) $\log_5 1$. For each, say in one sentence what question the logarithm is answering.

Exercise 3.3 (Solving exponential and logarithmic equations)**.** Solve for x: (a) $3^x = 81$; (b) $4 \cdot 10^x = 4000$; (c) $e^{2x} = 5$ (leave the answer in terms of ln); (d) $\ln(x - 1) = 2$.

Exercise 3.4 (Application: bacterial growth and continuous rate)**.** A culture of bacteria doubles every 3 hours and starts at 500 cells. (a) Write the population as $N(t) = 500 \cdot 2^{t/3}$ and explain why the exponent is $t/3$. (b) How many cells after 12 hours? (c) Rewrite the model in the form $N(t) = 500\, e^{kt}$ by finding k, and interpret k as a continuous growth rate.

Exercise 3.5 (Mental check: doubling time and half-life)**.** A radioactive sample decays according to $N(t) = N_0 2^{-t/T_{\text{half}}}$, where T_{half} is its half-life.

(a) Explain in words why every tick of T_{half} units of time halves the remaining mass.

(b) What fraction of the original sample remains after 3 half-lives? After 5 half-lives?

(c) Convert this decay formula into continuous base-e form, $N(t) = N_0 e^{-\lambda t}$, and find the decay constant λ in terms of T_{half} and $\ln 2$.

Exercise 3.6 (Squeezing e: compound interest bounds)**.** Compute $(1 + 1/n)^n$ by hand for $n = 1, 2, 3, 4$ and confirm the sequence is increasing. Then compute $(1 + 1/n)^{n+1}$ for the same n and confirm *that* sequence is decreasing. (These two sequences squeeze e from below and above – a clean way to see the limit exists.)

Exercise 3.7 (Series computation and error bound)**.** Using the series $e = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} 1/n!$, compute the partial sum through $1/6!$ and compare with 2.718282. How many decimal places do you get right, and how does the error compare to the first omitted term $1/7!$?

Exercise 3.8 (Conceptual: slope equals height)**.** Explain in a short paragraph, without formulas, why a function whose derivative equals itself must grow exponentially. (Hint: at every height its steepness equals its height, so the bigger it gets, the faster it climbs – describe the runaway feedback.)

Exercise 3.9 (Conceptual: what makes e natural?)**.** Why is base e called "natural" while base 10 is merely convenient for humans? Give two distinct reasons drawn from this chapter – one about derivatives and one about the area under $1/t$.

Exercise 3.10 (Change of base as vertical stretching)**.** Show, using the change-of-base formula, that the graphs of $\log_2 x$, $\ln x$, and $\log_{10} x$ are all vertical rescalings of one another. By what factor must you stretch $\ln x$ to obtain $\log_{10} x$?

Exercise 3.11 (Proof: properties of the starting slope)**.** Prove that the starting slope $M(a) = \lim_{h\to 0}(a^h - 1)/h$ satisfies $M(a^2) = 2M(a)$, and more generally $M(a^k) = k\,M(a)$ for positive integers k. (Hint: $a^{2h} - 1 = (a^h - 1)(a^h + 1)$, and $a^h \to 1$ as $h \to 0$.) Explain why this is consistent with the claim that $M(a) = \ln a$.

Exercise 3.12 (Connection: hyperbolic functions and the circle preview)**.** Recall from Chapter 2 (Exercise 2.11) that any function whose domain is symmetric about 0 can be uniquely split into an even part and an odd part. For the natural exponential $f(x) = e^x$, this decomposition yields the **hyperbolic cosine** and **hyperbolic sine**:

$$\cosh x \;=\; \frac{e^x + e^{-x}}{2}, \qquad \sinh x \;=\; \frac{e^x - e^{-x}}{2}.$$

(a) Expand the squares algebraically and prove the fundamental hyperbolic identity:

$$(\cosh x)^2 - (\sinh x)^2 \;=\; 1.$$

(b) What geometric curve in the (u, v)-plane does the parameterized point $(u, v) = (\cosh x, \sinh x)$ trace out as x varies? (Compare the hyperbolic curve $u^2 - v^2 = 1$ with the unit circle $u^2 + v^2 = 1$ that anchors Chapter 4.)

(c) Confirm that $\cosh 0 = 1$ and $\sinh 0 = 0$.

Exercise 3.13 (Challenge: Fourier's irrationality proof for e)**.** The number e is irrational. Here is Fourier's argument. Suppose for contradiction $e = p/q$ for integers p, q. Multiply the series $e = \sum 1/n!$ by $q!$. Argue that $q!\,e$ would have to be an integer, but that the tail $\sum_{n=q+1}^{\infty} q!/n!$ is a positive number strictly less than 1 (compare it with a geometric series). Conclude that no such p, q exist. Fill in the comparison that bounds the tail below 1.

Chapter 4

Trigonometric and Inverse Functions

In Chapter 3, we studied runaway growth: exponential curves that climb ever faster, and the natural base e whose rate of change matches its height. But the physical world does not only race outward – it also oscillates, cycles, and returns, demanding a mathematics built to describe going around.

The functions in this chapter were not invented by people doing calculus. They were invented thousands of years before, by astronomers tracking the rotation of the heavens and surveyors dividing up land. Sine and cosine are the mathematics of *going around*: of anything that repeats, oscillates, rotates, or vibrates. A swinging pendulum, an alternating current, a sound wave, the seasons, the orbit of a planet, the position of a point on a spinning wheel – all of them, when you measure them carefully, turn out to be made of sines and cosines.

So before we can do calculus *with* these functions – before we can differentiate $\sin x$ or integrate $\cos x$ – we need to really understand what they *are*. Not as buttons on a calculator, and not as ratios in a right triangle (though we will see that picture too), but as something deeper and more useful: the coordinates of a point traveling around a circle. That single picture will explain every identity, every graph, and every symmetry, and it will show why measuring angles in *radians* keeps every derivative formula free of ugly conversion constants.

We will also meet the *inverse* trig functions, the functions that answer the question "what angle has this sine?" Inverses are subtle – a periodic function repeats, so it cannot be undone without care – and sorting out exactly how to undo a sine teaches a lesson about inverse functions in general that will pay off later.

Let us build it all from the circle up.

4.1 Angles: What Are We Really Measuring?

Start with the most basic question. An angle measures *how much you have turned*. Stand facing north, rotate to face east: you have turned through one quarter of a full turn. Rotate to face south: half a turn. The natural, dimensionless way to talk about turning is as a *fraction of a full revolution*.

Everything after that is just choosing a *unit* – a name for "one full turn" – and the choice is pure convention. The Babylonians, working in base 60 and tracking a sky that seemed to cycle once a year through roughly 360 days, declared one full turn to be 360 *degrees*. There is nothing sacred about 360; it is a culturally inherited number that happens to divide nicely ($360 = 2^3 \cdot 3^2 \cdot 5$, so halves,

thirds, quarters, fifths, sixths, eighths, ninths, tenths, twelfths all come out whole). For everyday geometry and navigation, degrees work fine; in calculus, as we will see shortly, they drag an awkward factor of $\pi/180$ into every derivative.

Intuition

An angle is not a length and not an area. It is a *turn* – a fraction of a full rotation. Degrees and radians are just two different rulers laid against that same turn. Degrees call a full turn 360; radians call it 2π. Same turn, different number. The essential step is choosing the ruler that makes the rest of mathematics simplest, and that ruler is radians.

4.1.1 Radians: Measuring an Angle by the Arc It Cuts

Here is a more natural idea, one that uses no arbitrary number at all. Draw a circle of radius r and an angle at its center. That angle opens up onto an *arc* – a curved piece of the circle's outer rim. The bigger the angle, the longer the arc. In fact the arc length is exactly proportional to the angle. So why not let the arc *be* the measure of the angle?

There is one wrinkle: a bigger circle gives a longer arc for the same angle, so raw arc length depends on r. We fix that by dividing out the radius. Define:

$$\theta \;=\; \frac{\text{arc length}}{\text{radius}} \;=\; \frac{s}{r}.$$

This ratio is the same for every circle, because doubling r doubles s. The number you get is the angle measured in **radians**.

Definition 4.1 (Radian)**.** The radian measure of a central angle (an angle whose vertex sits right at the center of the circle) is the length of the arc it subtends (the slice of the rim carved out between the two arms of the angle) divided by the radius: $\theta = s/r$. Equivalently, an angle of one radian subtends an arc whose length equals the radius.

Because $s = r\theta$, an angle of one radian is the angle for which the arc is *exactly as long as the radius*. Wrap one radius-length of string along the rim of the circle, and the angle it spans at the center is one radian – a bit under $60°$ ($57.2958\ldots°$, to be precise).

How many radians in a full turn? The whole circumference has length $2\pi r$, so a full revolution measures $s/r = 2\pi r/r = 2\pi$ radians. That gives us the master conversion:

$$2\pi \text{ radians} \;=\; 360°, \qquad \text{so} \qquad \pi \text{ radians} = 180°, \qquad 1 \text{ rad} = \frac{180°}{\pi}.$$

A handful of values worth knowing cold:

$$30° = \tfrac{\pi}{6}, \quad 45° = \tfrac{\pi}{4}, \quad 60° = \tfrac{\pi}{3}, \quad 90° = \tfrac{\pi}{2}, \quad 180° = \pi, \quad 360° = 2\pi.$$

What is really happening

When you write "$\theta = \pi/3$" you are not really writing an abstract angle – you are writing a *length*. You are saying: on the unit circle (radius 1), walk a distance of $\pi/3 \approx 1.047$ along the rim. The angle and the arc length are literally the same number when $r = 1$. This is why,

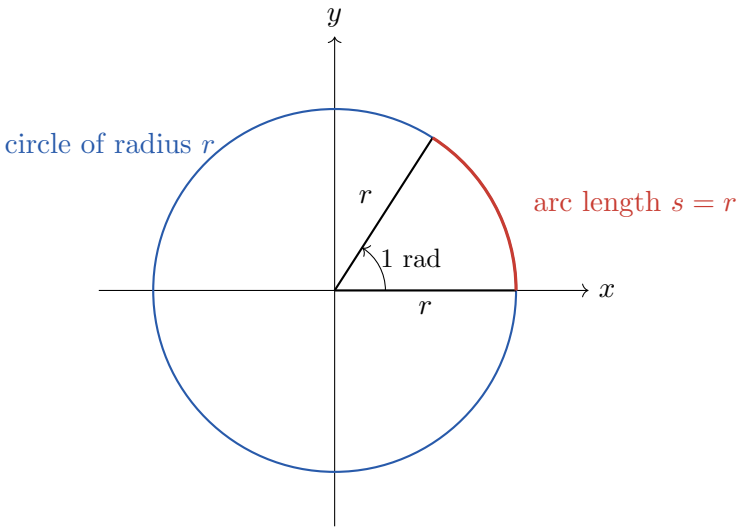


Figure 4.1: One radian: the central angle whose arc length equals the radius ($s = r$). Since the full circumference is $2\pi r$, a full turn is 2π radians.

throughout calculus, the variable inside sin and cos feels like a distance: in radians on the unit circle, it *is* one. Degrees hide this by inserting the arbitrary scaling factor $\pi/180$, which is exactly the factor that will later clutter up every derivative if you let it.

Two immediate payoffs of the $s = r\theta$ definition, both free:

Arc length. The length of an arc of radius r spanning angle θ (in radians) is simply $s = r\theta$. No factor of $\pi/180$, no fuss.

Sector area. A full disk has area πr^2 and spans 2π radians. A sector of angle θ is the fraction $\theta/(2\pi)$ of the disk, so its area is

$$A = \frac{\theta}{2\pi} \cdot \pi r^2 = \tfrac{1}{2} r^2 \theta.$$

Hold onto that formula $A = \frac{1}{2}r^2\theta$; we will use it in a clever sandwich argument later in the book to pin down the most important limit in trigonometry.

Walking question

A bicycle wheel has radius 0.35 m. As you ride, the wheel turns. Convince yourself that the distance the bike travels equals the arc length traced on the rim, and hence that if the wheel turns through θ radians the bike moves $0.35\,\theta$ meters. Now feel why "radians" is the natural rotational unit for anything that rolls: the angle, scaled by the radius, *is* the distance. What ugly conversion factor would appear if you insisted on degrees?

4.2 Sine and Cosine as Coordinates on the Unit Circle

Now the central idea of the whole chapter. Forget triangles for a moment. Draw the **unit circle**: the circle of radius 1 centered at the origin, the set of points with $x^2 + y^2 = 1$.

Start at the point $(1, 0)$ – three o'clock – and walk counterclockwise along the rim. After walking an arc-length t (equivalently, after turning through an angle of t radians, since $r = 1$), you arrive at some point on the circle. *That point's coordinates are the definition of cosine and sine.*

Definition 4.2 (Sine and cosine, circle definition)**.** Let t be a real number. Travel counterclockwise a distance t along the unit circle, starting from $(1, 0)$. The coordinates of the point you reach are denoted $(\cos t,\ \sin t)$. That is, $\cos t$ is the horizontal coordinate and $\sin t$ is the vertical coordinate of the point at arc-length t on the unit circle.

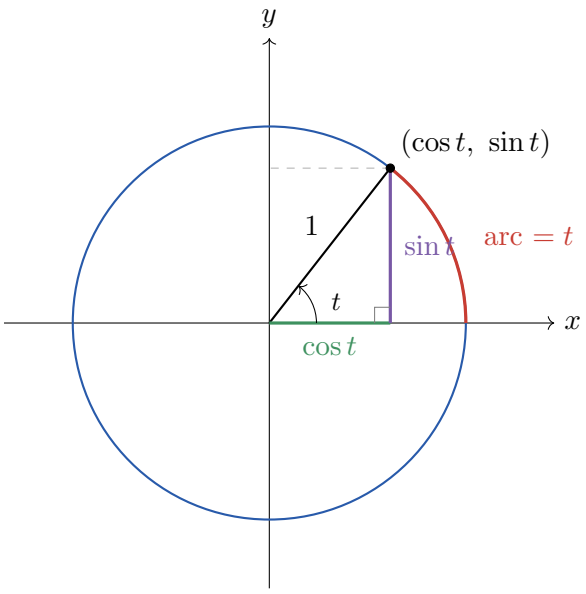


Figure 4.2: Cosine and sine are the coordinates of the point reached by walking arc-length t counterclockwise around the unit circle from $(1, 0)$. The radius, the horizontal segment of length $\cos t$, and the vertical segment of length $\sin t$ form a right triangle with hypotenuse 1.

Defining cosine and sine on the unit circle beats the right-triangle "opposite over hypotenuse" recipe in three ways. It works for *every* real number t, not just acute angles between 0 and 90°: you can keep walking past the top of the circle, past the left side, all the way around and around. It makes the periodic symmetries transparent, as the next section shows. And it ties sin and cos directly to motion along a curve, which is what derivatives measure.

The connection to the right-triangle picture is immediate. Look at Figure 4.2: the radius to the point, the vertical segment, and the segment along the x-axis form a right triangle with hypotenuse 1. The horizontal leg is $\cos t$, and the vertical leg is $\sin t$. The standard right-triangle definitions – often remembered by the mnemonic SOH-CAH-TOA (sin = Opposite/Hypotenuse, cos = Adjacent/Hypotenuse, tan = Opposite/Adjacent) – are just this picture scaled: in any right triangle with hypotenuse h, the leg opposite angle t is $h \sin t$ and the leg adjacent is $h \cos t$. The unit circle is the master reference triangle with hypotenuse normalized to 1.

Intuition

Picture a point riding counterclockwise around the unit circle at steady speed. Its *shadow on the x-axis* – the horizontal coordinate – traces out $\cos t$ as t increases. Its *shadow on the y-axis* traces out $\sin t$. Both shadows slosh back and forth between -1 and 1 forever. Sine

and cosine are the two shadows of uniform circular motion. Every wave you will ever meet is a shadow of something going around.

4.2.1 Everything That Follows Immediately

From this one definition, a cascade of facts falls out with almost no work. This is the sign of a good definition.

The Pythagorean identity. The point $(\cos t, \sin t)$ lies *on* the unit circle, and the unit circle is the set with $x^2 + y^2 = 1$. Therefore, for every real t,

$$\boxed{\cos^2 t + \sin^2 t = 1.}$$

This is not a theorem you prove with effort; it *is* the equation of the circle, with x renamed $\cos t$ and y renamed $\sin t$. (The notation $\cos^2 t$ is shorthand for $(\cos t)^2$, an old convention you simply have to memorize.)

Range. Both coordinates of a point on the unit circle lie between -1 and 1. So $-1 \le \sin t \le 1$ and $-1 \le \cos t \le 1$ for all t. The functions never escape that band.

Periodicity. Walking an extra full lap – an extra 2π of arc – brings you back to the same point. Hence

$$\sin(t + 2\pi) = \sin t, \qquad \cos(t + 2\pi) = \cos t.$$

The functions repeat with **period** 2π. This is why they model anything cyclic.

Special values. Read them straight off the circle. At $t = 0$ you are at $(1, 0)$, so $\cos 0 = 1$, $\sin 0 = 0$. A quarter turn $t = \pi/2$ lands you at the top $(0, 1)$: $\cos(\pi/2) = 0$, $\sin(\pi/2) = 1$. Half a turn $t = \pi$ puts you at $(-1, 0)$. Three-quarters $t = 3\pi/2$ at the bottom $(0, -1)$.

t	0	$\frac{\pi}{6}$	$\frac{\pi}{4}$	$\frac{\pi}{3}$	$\frac{\pi}{2}$
$\sin t$	0	$\frac{1}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$	1
$\cos t$	1	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$	$\frac{1}{2}$	0

Notice the elegant pattern: the sine row reads $\frac{\sqrt{0}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{1}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{4}}{2}$, and the cosine row is the same thing backwards. The values at $\pi/6, \pi/4, \pi/3$ come from the two special triangles – the 30-60-90 and the 45-45-90 – which we can see geometrically in a moment.

Work it yourself

Let us nail down $\sin(\pi/4)$ and $\cos(\pi/4)$ from the circle. At $t = \pi/4$ (a 45° turn) you are exactly on the diagonal line $y = x$, by symmetry: the point is equidistant from the two axes. So $\cos(\pi/4) = \sin(\pi/4)$; call the common value c. Pythagoras says $c^2 + c^2 = 1$, hence $2c^2 = 1$, so $c = 1/\sqrt{2} = \sqrt{2}/2 \approx 0.707$. You just computed a "table value" using the circle and Pythagoras – no calculator, no memorization.

Pause

Pause and think: the 30°–60°–90° triangle. Take an equilateral triangle with side lengths 1, so each corner angle is $60° = \pi/3$ radians. Drop a vertical altitude from the top vertex down to the base. That cuts the triangle in half, creating two identical right triangles with angles $30° = \pi/6$ and $60° = \pi/3$. The base of each half is $\frac{1}{2}$. By the Pythagorean theorem, the vertical height h satisfies $h^2 + (\frac{1}{2})^2 = 1^2$, which gives $h = \sqrt{1 - 1/4} = \sqrt{3}/2$. Look at that half-triangle: opposite the 30° angle is $\frac{1}{2}$ (so $\sin(\pi/6) = \frac{1}{2}$), and adjacent is $\sqrt{3}/2$ (so $\cos(\pi/6) = \sqrt{3}/2$). Looking from the 60° angle reverses their roles. The entire table of special values is simply these two elementary geometric shapes.

4.3 The Other Four: Tangent and Friends

Sine and cosine are the parents; the remaining four trig functions are built from them by division. The most important is the **tangent**:

$$\tan t \;=\; \frac{\sin t}{\cos t}.$$

Geometrically, $\tan t$ is the *slope* of the radius line to the point $(\cos t, \sin t)$ – it is rise over run, $\sin t/\cos t$. But it also has a striking direct geometric interpretation, shown in Figure 4.3. Erect a vertical tangent line to the circle at $(1, 0)$ and extend the ray from the origin through $(\cos t, \sin t)$ until it hits this vertical line at $(1, \tan t)$. Because the horizontal base of that outer right triangle has length 1, the vertical segment cut off along the tangent line is exactly $\tan t$ (since opposite/adjacent $= \tan t/1 = \tan t$). This is where the name *tangent* comes from (Latin *tangere*, to touch).

What about the length along that extended ray from the origin all the way to $(1, \tan t)$? That ray cuts through the circle, making it a *secant* line (Latin *secare*, to cut). By the Pythagorean theorem on the outer triangle with legs 1 and $\tan t$, the hypotenuse has length $\sqrt{1^2 + \tan^2 t} = \sec t$. The remaining three functions are reciprocals, named for historical convenience:

$$\cot t = \frac{\cos t}{\sin t} = \frac{1}{\tan t}, \qquad \sec t = \frac{1}{\cos t}, \qquad \csc t = \frac{1}{\sin t}.$$

Each is undefined wherever its denominator hits zero. Tangent and secant blow up where $\cos t = 0$, i.e. at $t = \pm\pi/2, \pm 3\pi/2, \ldots$; cotangent and cosecant blow up where $\sin t = 0$, i.e. at $t = 0, \pm\pi, \pm 2\pi, \ldots$ Dividing the Pythagorean identity $\cos^2 t + \sin^2 t = 1$ through by $\cos^2 t$ gives a useful cousin:

$$1 + \tan^2 t = \sec^2 t,$$

and dividing instead by $\sin^2 t$ gives $1 + \cot^2 t = \csc^2 t$ – the same Pythagorean identity written in two new outfits.

Common trap

$\tan t$ has period π, *not* 2π. After half a lap the point $(\cos t, \sin t)$ flips to its antipode (the diametrically opposite point on the other side of the circle, $(-\cos t, -\sin t)$), and the two sign flips cancel in the ratio $\sin t/\cos t$. So $\tan(t + \pi) = \tan t$. Students who blindly assume every trig function repeats every 2π get tangent wrong. Always reason from the circle, not from a memorized rule.

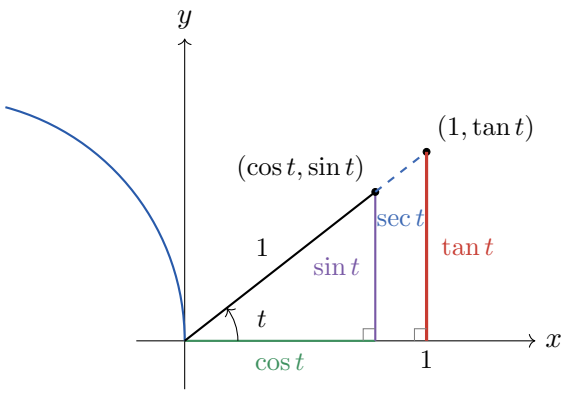


Figure 4.3: The geometric meaning of tangent and secant. The vertical line at $x = 1$ touches the circle at $(1, 0)$ (a tangent line); the ray from the origin cuts off a segment of length $\tan t$ along it. The line cutting through the circle is a secant line, and the total distance along it from the origin to $(1, \tan t)$ is $\sec t$. The inner right triangle embodies $\cos^2 t + \sin^2 t = 1$; the similar outer right triangle embodies $1 + \tan^2 t = \sec^2 t$.

4.4 Symmetries: Reading Identities Off the Circle

Trigonometric identities can seem like a long list to memorize, but almost every identity is a geometric symmetry of the circle, *seen* rather than recalled. Here are the main ones, each as a picture.

Even and odd. Replace t by $-t$: instead of walking counterclockwise you walk clockwise the same distance. You land at the mirror image across the x-axis. Mirroring across the x-axis keeps the horizontal coordinate and flips the vertical one:

$$\cos(-t) = \cos t \quad \text{(even)}, \qquad \sin(-t) = -\sin t \quad \text{(odd)}.$$

Cosine is symmetric, sine is antisymmetric. One picture, two identities.

Supplementary angle ($\pi - t$). The point at angle $\pi - t$ is the mirror image of the point at angle t across the *y-axis*. Mirroring across the y-axis flips x and keeps y:

$$\cos(\pi - t) = -\cos t, \qquad \sin(\pi - t) = \sin t.$$

Co-function / quarter turn ($\frac{\pi}{2} - t$). This is the deep one, and it is the source of the prefix "co-" in cosine. The point at angle $\frac{\pi}{2} - t$ is the reflection of the point at angle t across the diagonal line $y = x$. Reflecting across $y = x$ *swaps* the coordinates. Therefore

$$\sin\left(\tfrac{\pi}{2} - t\right) = \cos t, \qquad \cos\left(\tfrac{\pi}{2} - t\right) = \sin t.$$

Cosine of an angle is the sine of its complement – "cosine" literally means "**co**mplement's **sine**." Rather than a separate rule to memorize, it is the $y = x$ reflection, seen once and never forgotten.

Why the technique works

Why can we get away with *reading* identities off pictures instead of grinding algebra? Because sin and cos were *defined* as coordinates of a point on the circle, and a geometric transformation of the circle (a reflection, a rotation) does a predictable thing to coordinates. Reflect across

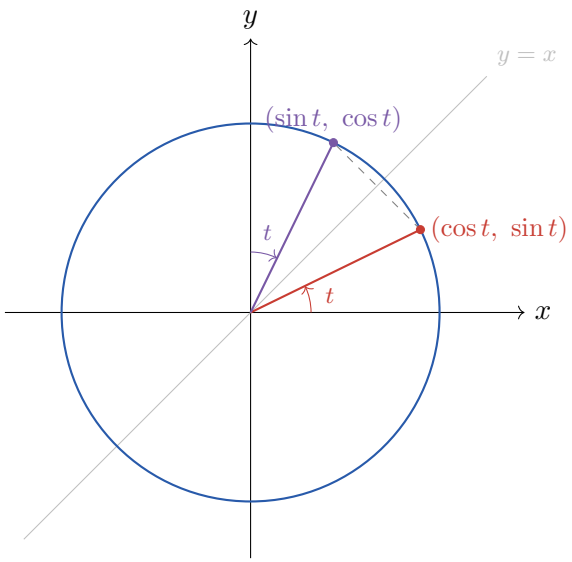


Figure 4.4: The co-function identity as a geometric mirror. Reflecting the point for angle t across the diagonal line $y = x$ yields the point for angle $\frac{\pi}{2} - t$. That reflection swaps the horizontal and vertical coordinates ($x \leftrightarrow y$), so sin and cos trade places: $\cos(\frac{\pi}{2} - t) = \sin t$ and $\sin(\frac{\pi}{2} - t) = \cos t$.

the x-axis: $y \mapsto -y$, so $\sin \mapsto -\sin$. Rotate by a quarter turn, reflect across a diagonal – each motion is a simple coordinate operation. So every symmetry of the circle is automatically an identity, and the "identity" is just the bookkeeping of where the coordinates went. The algebra works because the geometry works; the picture is the proof.

4.4.1 The Addition Formulas

The one family of identities you cannot quite *see* in a single glance, but which everything downstream depends on, is the addition formulas:

$$\cos(a + b) = \cos a \cos b - \sin a \sin b, \qquad \sin(a + b) = \sin a \cos b + \cos a \sin b.$$

These say: if you know where angles a and b land, you can find where angle $a + b$ lands without walking the whole way. They are the engine behind the derivative of sine, so they earn a real derivation. The cleanest one is a rotation argument.

Focus

Deriving the addition formula by rotation. Rotating the entire plane counterclockwise by an angle a sends the reference point $(1, 0)$ to $(\cos a, \sin a)$ and sends $(0, 1)$ to $(-\sin a, \cos a)$ (a quarter turn ahead of the first). A rotation preserves straight lines and proportions (it is a linear transformation), so it is completely determined by what it does to these two standard reference points $(1, 0)$ and $(0, 1)$: any general point (x, y) is carried to

$$(x \cos a - y \sin a, \quad x \sin a + y \cos a).$$

Now take the point on the circle at angle b, namely $(x, y) = (\cos b, \sin b)$, and rotate it further by angle a. Geometrically that lands it at angle $a + b$, meaning its coordinates are $(\cos(a +$

$b), \sin(a+b))$. Algebraically, substituting $x = \cos b$ and $y = \sin b$ into the rotation formula sends it to

$$(\cos b \cos a - \sin b \sin a, \quad \cos b \sin a + \sin b \cos a).$$

Matching the geometric coordinates with the algebraic formulas gives exactly the cosine and sine addition formulas. The single geometric insight – rotating by b and then by a is the same as rotating by $a + b$ – contains both identities at once.

Two consequences we will lean on. Setting $b = a$ gives the **double-angle** formulas:

$$\sin 2a = 2 \sin a \cos a, \qquad \cos 2a = \cos^2 a - \sin^2 a = 1 - 2\sin^2 a = 2\cos^2 a - 1.$$

The last two forms (using $\cos^2 a + \sin^2 a = 1$) rearrange into the **half-angle** formulas, which are used constantly in integration:

$$\sin^2 a = \frac{1 - \cos 2a}{2}, \qquad \cos^2 a = \frac{1 + \cos 2a}{2}.$$

Keep these last two in your pocket; when you later integrate $\sin^2$ or $\cos^2$, these are how you do it.

History

The addition formulas are ancient. In effect they appear in Ptolemy's *Almagest* (c. 150 CE) as "Ptolemy's theorem" about chords of a circle: Greek astronomers worked not with our modern sine but with the *chord* of an angle, the straight-line distance across the arc. In fifth-century India, Aryabhata introduced the half-chord (*jya*), which is our modern sine. The word "sine" itself arose from a mistranslation: the Sanskrit *jya* became Arabic *jiba* (written as the consonants *jb*), which twelfth-century Latin translators misread as *jaib* (a fold or bay) and translated as *sinus*. In 1748, Leonhard Euler defined sine and cosine on the unit circle as functions of a real number, giving trigonometry its modern form.

4.5 The Graphs: Unrolling the Circle

We have been watching a point go around a circle. To graph $\sin t$ and $\cos t$ as functions of t, we *unroll* that circular motion: put t on the horizontal axis (how far around we have walked) and the coordinate on the vertical axis. The circle's repetition becomes a wave that rolls on forever.

Read the structure straight off the graph. The wave oscillates between -1 and 1 (the **amplitude** is 1). It completes one full cycle every 2π (the **period**). Sine starts at 0 climbing; cosine starts at 1 already at its peak. And the two curves are *the same shape shifted*: $\cos t = \sin(t + \frac{\pi}{2})$. Shifting sine to the left by a quarter period lands it exactly on cosine. (This is the co-function identity in motion: using cos even, $\sin(t + \frac{\pi}{2}) = \sin(\frac{\pi}{2} - (-t)) = \cos(-t) = \cos t$.) More simply still: the cosine wave is the sine wave with a head start of a quarter turn, which is precisely what a quarter turn around the circle does.

Connection

A general sinusoid is written $y = A\sin(\omega t + \varphi) + k$. Each parameter is a geometric knob: A is the amplitude (vertical stretch), ω is the angular frequency (horizontal compression – the

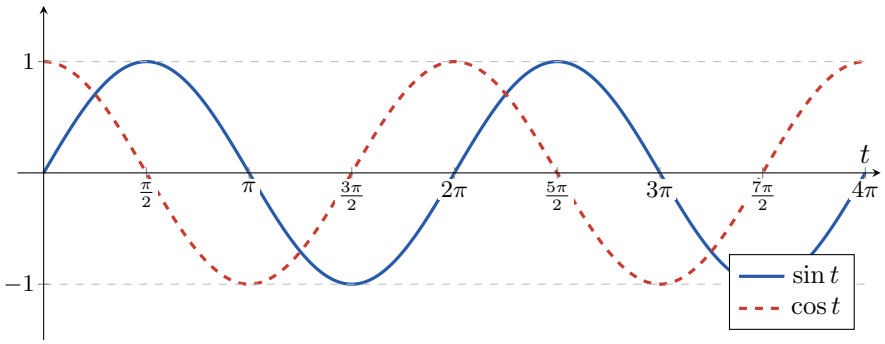


Figure 4.5: Sine and cosine, the unrolled shadows of circular motion. Each is a wave of amplitude 1 and period 2π. Cosine is sine shifted left by $\pi/2$ – the co-function identity, made visual.

period is $2\pi/\omega$), φ is the phase (horizontal shift, the head start), and k is the vertical offset (the midline). Because sine and cosine differ only by a phase, *any* sinusoid can be written with either one. This four-knob family is exactly what describes simple harmonic motion in physics – a mass on a spring, $x(t) = A\cos(\omega t + \varphi)$ – and it is the building block of Fourier analysis, where *every* periodic signal, however jagged, is a sum of these smooth waves.

The tangent graph looks entirely different, and the circle tells us why. As t climbs toward $\pi/2$, the point nears the top of the circle: $\sin t \to 1$ while $\cos t \to 0^+$, so $\tan t = \sin t/\cos t \to +\infty$. Just past $\pi/2$, cosine is negative and tangent leaps to $-\infty$. The result is a curve that races up to a vertical asymptote, vanishes off the top, and reappears from the bottom – repeating every π, not 2π.

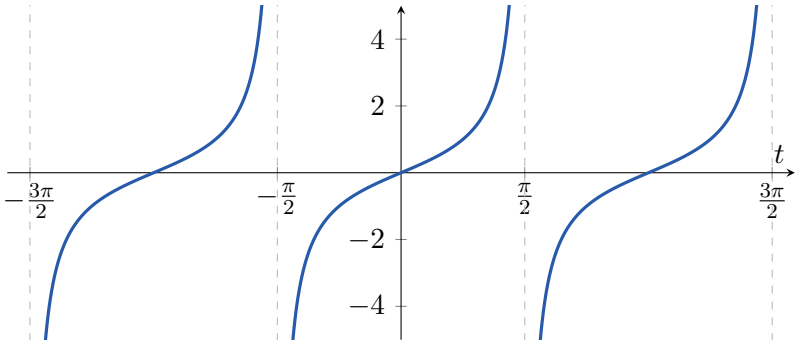


Figure 4.6: The tangent function $\tan t = \sin t/\cos t$. Vertical asymptotes occur where $\cos t = 0$. The function runs from $-\infty$ to $+\infty$ on each interval of width π, then repeats.

4.6 The Small-Angle Behavior: $\sin t \approx t$

This section hands the rest of the book its single most important fact about trig. Look again at the unit circle for a *small* angle t, just above $(1, 0)$.

Three lengths are racing to zero together as $t \to 0$: the vertical drop $\sin t$, the arc t along the rim, and the tangent segment $\tan t$. Geometrically they nest:

$$\sin t \;<\; t \;<\; \tan t \qquad (0 < t < \tfrac{\pi}{2}).$$

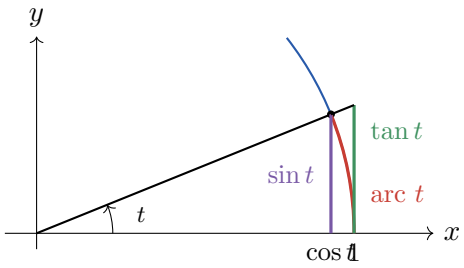


Figure 4.7: For a small angle t, the vertical segment $\sin t$, the arc t, and the tangent segment $\tan t$ are nearly equal, with $\sin t < t < \tan t$. As $t \to 0$ the three become indistinguishable, which forces $\sin t/t \to 1$.

The first inequality says the straight vertical chord is shorter than the curved arc above it; the second compares two triangles against the sector. As the angle shrinks, the arc straightens out and these three lengths become indistinguishable. The most useful way to say this precisely is in terms of the ratio $\sin t/t$.

Focus

The fundamental trig limit.

$$\boxed{\lim_{t\to 0} \frac{\sin t}{t} = 1.}$$

In words: for small t (*in radians*), $\sin t$ and t are almost equal – their ratio rushes to 1. Equivalently, $\sin t \approx t$ when t is small – Figure 4.8 shows the curve and the line clinging together near the origin. This is the seed from which the entire calculus of trig functions grows; the derivative of sine (which we will develop in Chapter 12 once the machinery of limits and differentiation is fully assembled) reduces directly to this limit.

We can already see *why* it must be true, and even sketch the rigorous proof, using only the sector-area formula $A = \frac{1}{2}r^2\theta$ from the start of the chapter.

Focus

Why $\sin t/t \to 1$: the squeeze. Work on the unit circle ($r = 1$) with $0 < t < \pi/2$. Compare three areas in Figure 4.7:

- the inner triangle with vertices $(0,0), (1,0), (\cos t, \sin t)$ has base 1 along the x-axis and vertical height $\sin t$, giving area $\frac{1}{2}\sin t$;
- the circular sector of angle t has area $\frac{1}{2}t$ (using $A = \frac{1}{2}r^2\theta$ with $r = 1$);
- the outer right triangle with vertices $(0,0), (1,0), (1, \tan t)$ has base 1 and vertical height $\tan t$, giving area $\frac{1}{2}\tan t$.

The inner triangle sits inside the sector, which sits inside the outer triangle, so

$$\tfrac{1}{2}\sin t \;<\; \tfrac{1}{2}t \;<\; \tfrac{1}{2}\tan t.$$

Multiply by 2 and divide by $\sin t$ (positive here):

$$1 \;<\; \frac{t}{\sin t} \;<\; \frac{1}{\cos t}.$$

Flip everything (taking reciprocals reverses the inequalities):

$$\cos t \;<\; \frac{\sin t}{t} \;<\; 1.$$

As $t \to 0$, $\cos t \to 1$. The ratio $\sin t/t$ is trapped – *squeezed* – between something heading to 1 and the constant 1. It has no choice: $\lim_{t\to 0} \sin t/t = 1$. (The case $t < 0$ follows because $\sin t/t$ is an even function.)

Common trap

This limit equals 1 **only in radians**. If t is measured in degrees, then walking "t degrees" covers an arc of only $\frac{\pi}{180}t$, so $\sin(t^\circ)/t \to \pi/180 \approx 0.01745$, a needless ugly constant. Every derivative formula for trig functions would be polluted by that factor forever. *This is the real reason calculus uses radians.* Radians are the unit in which arc length equals angle, which is the unit in which $\sin t \approx t$, which is the unit in which the derivatives come out clean.

Pause

Pause and think: the 1° test. A 1° angle is $\pi/180 \approx 0.0174533$ radians. Because $\sin t \approx t$ for small angles in radians, what should $\sin(1^\circ)$ be? It should be approximately 0.0174533. Tap $\sin(1^\circ)$ into a calculator set to degrees: it gives 0.0174524... The two numbers agree to five decimal places. Now try degrees with the raw number: is $\sin(1^\circ)$ close to 1? Not at all. The tangent-line approximation $\sin t \approx t$ works if and only if t is measured in radians.

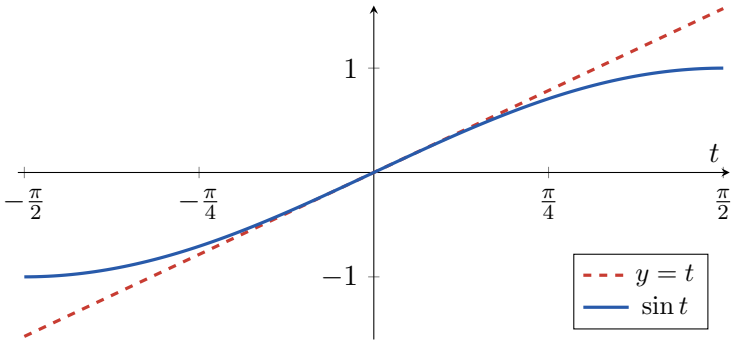


Figure 4.8: Near $t = 0$ the curve $\sin t$ hugs the line $y = t$: they share the same value and the same slope 1 at the origin, and only peel apart slowly. This is the visual content of $\sin t/t \to 1$, equivalently $\sin t \approx t$ for small t.

Why this matters

Pause on how much rides on $\sin t/t \to 1$. It is the statement that, up close, a sine wave and a straight line of slope 1 are the same thing – that the circle, examined under a microscope at $(1, 0)$, looks flat and vertical, rising one unit of height per one unit of arc. From this single "the curve is locally straight" fact will come $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\sin t = \cos t$, the wave equation, the description of light and sound, and the Taylor series $\sin t = t - \frac{t^3}{6} + \cdots$ whose very first term is this approximation $\sin t \approx t$. A great deal of physics is the sentence "for small angles, $\sin t \approx t$" taken seriously.

Application

The pendulum. A pendulum of length L obeys, exactly, $\ddot{\theta} = -\frac{g}{L}\sin\theta$ – a hard, nonlinear equation with no elementary solution. But for small swings, $\sin\theta \approx \theta$, and the equation *linearizes* to $\ddot{\theta} = -\frac{g}{L}\theta$, whose solution is a pure sinusoid with period $T = 2\pi\sqrt{L/g}$. That is why a pendulum clock keeps near-constant time regardless of how far it swings (as long as the swing is small): Galileo's observation, explained in one approximation. The whole of small-oscillation physics – springs, molecules, circuits, bridges – rests on replacing a curve by its tangent line, and $\sin\theta \approx \theta$ is the first and most famous instance.

A companion limit, derived the same way and needed alongside the first, is

$$\lim_{t\to 0}\frac{1-\cos t}{t} = 0.$$

Intuitively: near $t = 0$ the height $\sin t$ falls off the circle like t (first order), but the horizontal gap $1 - \cos t$ falls off like $t^2/2$ (second order, much faster), so dividing it by t still leaves something heading to zero. We prove it with a clean algebraic trick – multiply top and bottom by the algebraic conjugate $1 + \cos t$ (the same two terms with the sign flipped, setting up a difference of squares $(1-\cos t)(1+\cos t) = 1 - \cos^2 t = \sin^2 t$):

$$\frac{1-\cos t}{t} = \frac{(1-\cos t)(1+\cos t)}{t(1+\cos t)} = \frac{1-\cos^2 t}{t(1+\cos t)} = \frac{\sin^2 t}{t(1+\cos t)} = \underbrace{\frac{\sin t}{t}}_{\to 1}\cdot\underbrace{\frac{\sin t}{1+\cos t}}_{\to 0/2\,=\,0}.$$

The first factor tends to 1 by our main limit; the second tends to $0/2 = 0$. Product: 0. Both limits will reappear, fused, the moment we differentiate sine.

4.7 Inverse Trigonometric Functions

We turn now from "given the angle, find the coordinate" to its reverse: "given the coordinate, find the angle." If you know that a point on the unit circle has height $\sin t = 0.5$, which t produced it? This is the job of the inverse trig functions – but to define them properly we must first confront a real obstacle.

4.7.1 The Obstacle: Periodic Functions Are Not One-to-One

A function has an inverse only if it is **one-to-one**: each output comes from exactly one input. Graphically, this is the horizontal line test – no horizontal line may cross the graph more than once, or else that output traces back to several inputs and "the inverse" is ambiguous.

Sine fails this test spectacularly. The horizontal line $y = 0.5$ slices through the sine graph infinitely often: $\sin t = 0.5$ at $t = \pi/6$, at $t = 5\pi/6$, at $t = -7\pi/6$, at $t = -11\pi/6$, and infinitely many other places (Figure 4.9). "The angle whose sine is 0.5" has no single answer. A periodic function repeats, so by its nature it can never be globally invertible.

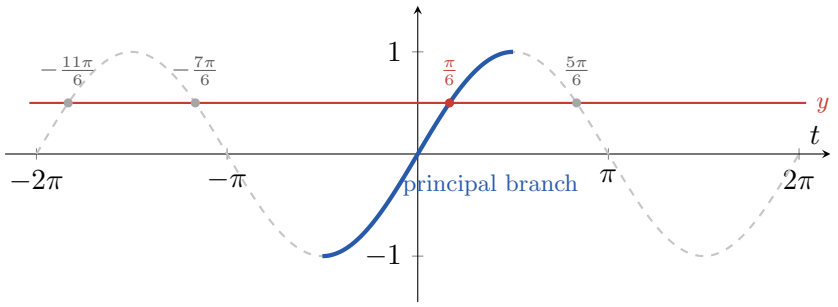


Figure 4.9: The horizontal line test fails on the full sine wave: the horizontal test line $y = 0.5$ intersects the graph at infinitely many inputs (four shown). Restricting sine to the window $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$ (thick blue) isolates a single-valued, strictly increasing branch where every output in $[-1, 1]$ is hit exactly once, defining the principal branch of arcsin.

Intuition

The solution is to restrict sine to a domain interval on which it never repeats a value – a stretch where it is monotonic (moving in only one direction, strictly climbing or strictly falling, never reversing) and sweeps through its full range exactly once. On that restricted piece the inverse exists and is unique. We are not inverting all of sine – that is impossible. We are inverting one carefully chosen, representative slice of it (called a *principal branch*), and keeping track of which slice we chose.

4.7.2 Arcsine: Choosing the Principal Branch

For sine, the agreed-upon slice is the interval $[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$. Why this one? On it, sine climbs monotonically from $\sin(-\frac{\pi}{2}) = -1$ up to $\sin(\frac{\pi}{2}) = 1$, hitting every value in $[-1, 1]$ exactly once. It is the slice straddling the origin, it is symmetric, and it captures sine at its most natural – rising through zero with slope 1. This restricted, invertible sine has an inverse called the **arcsine**.

Definition 4.3 (Arcsine)**.** For $-1 \le x \le 1$, $\arcsin x$ (also written $\sin^{-1} x$) is the unique angle $\theta \in [-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$ with $\sin\theta = x$. Its domain is $[-1, 1]$ (the possible sine values) and its range is $[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$ (the chosen slice of angles). The name *arc*sine reflects exactly what it returns: the *arc* (angle) belonging to a given coordinate.

Common trap

The superscript notation $\sin^{-1} x$ is a genuine menace. It does **not** mean $1/\sin x$ – that is $\csc x$ or $(\sin x)^{-1}$. Here the "-1" marks *functional inverse*, not a reciprocal power. The clash with $\sin^2 x = (\sin x)^2$ is an unfortunate historical inconsistency in the same notation. When in doubt, write $\arcsin x$; it cannot be misread.

Pause

Pause and think: undoing sine. What is $\arcsin(\sin(\pi/6))$? Because $\pi/6$ lies inside the home interval $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$, the two operations cancel cleanly: $\arcsin(\sin(\pi/6)) = \pi/6$. Now what is $\arcsin(\sin(5\pi/6))$? Watch the range carefully: the sine of $5\pi/6$ is 0.5, and arcsine can

only return angles in $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$. Looking at that interval, the unique angle with sine 0.5 is $\pi/6$. So $\arcsin(\sin(5\pi/6)) = \pi/6 \neq 5\pi/6$. The inverse undoes sine only on its home branch.

The graph of an inverse function is the *reflection* of the original across the line $y = x$ – because inverting a function swaps the roles of input and output, which swaps the axes. So arcsin is the restricted sine curve flipped over the diagonal.

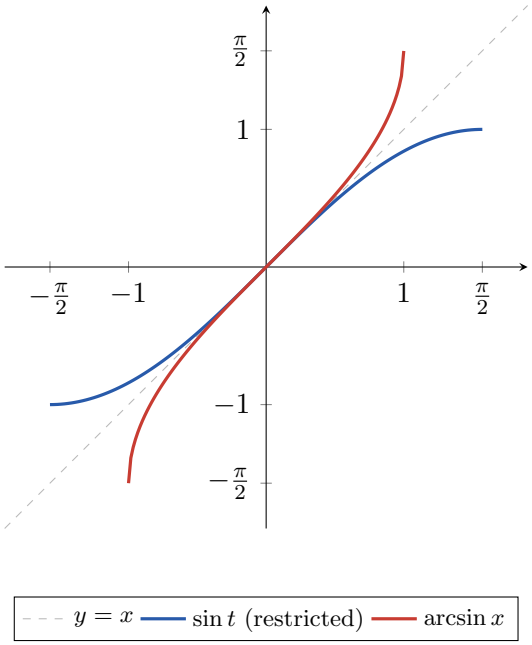


Figure 4.10: Restricted sine (on $[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$) and its mirror image across $y = x$, the arcsine. Reflecting a graph across $y = x$ is what inverting a function does: it swaps input and output.

4.7.3 Arccosine and Arctangent

The same restriction principle defines the other inverses; only the chosen interval differs, each picked to be a monotonic stretch covering the full range once.

Arccosine. Cosine *decreases* from 1 to -1 on $[0, \pi]$, sweeping its whole range once, so that is the slice. Define $\arccos x$ for $x \in [-1, 1]$ as the unique $\theta \in [0, \pi]$ with $\cos\theta = x$. Note its range starts at 0, not $-\frac{\pi}{2}$: a different function needs a different home interval. A clean identity ties the two together: if $\alpha = \arcsin x$, then $\alpha \in [-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$ and $\sin\alpha = x$, so $\frac{\pi}{2} - \alpha$ lies in $[0, \pi]$ and satisfies $\cos(\frac{\pi}{2} - \alpha) = \sin\alpha = x$. By definition of arccosine, $\arccos x = \frac{\pi}{2} - \alpha$, which rearranges to

$$\arcsin x + \arccos x = \frac{\pi}{2} \qquad \text{for all } x \in [-1, 1].$$

The arcsine and arccosine of the same number are complementary angles – again the "co-" relationship, now read backwards through the inverses.

Arctangent. Tangent runs monotonically from $-\infty$ to $+\infty$ on the open interval $(-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2})$, so that is its slice. Define $\arctan x$ for *every* real x as the unique $\theta \in (-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2})$ with $\tan\theta = x$. Because tangent's range is all of $\mathbb{R}$, arctangent accepts every real input – a genuinely useful feature. Its graph

has two horizontal asymptotes, at $y = \pm\frac{\pi}{2}$: feed in an enormous number and the angle approaches, but never reaches, a quarter turn.

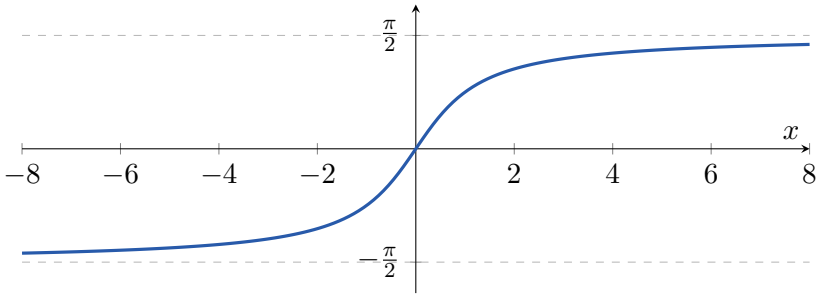


Figure 4.11: Arctangent: defined for all real x, with horizontal asymptotes at $\pm\pi/2$. It is the smooth, bounded "angle-of" function – which is why it appears everywhere a saturating or angle-recovering response is needed.

Inverse	Domain (inputs)	Range (outputs)	Chosen slice of the original
$\arcsin x$	$[-1, 1]$	$[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$	sine increasing through 0
$\arccos x$	$[-1, 1]$	$[0, \pi]$	cosine decreasing from 1
$\arctan x$	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$(-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2})$	tangent increasing through 0

What is really happening

What an inverse trig function "really" returns is a *location on the circle*, reported as the arc length from $(1, 0)$ – but *only the location within the chosen branch.* When your calculator says $\arcsin(0.5) = \pi/6$, it is not lying, but it is silently making a choice: it reports the one answer in $[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$ and quietly discards the equally-valid $5\pi/6$ and all the $+2\pi k$ cousins. This is why solving $\sin t = 0.5$ in full requires you to add back what the inverse threw away: $t = \pi/6 + 2\pi k$ *and* $t = 5\pi/6 + 2\pi k$. The inverse gives you one root; the symmetries of the circle give you the rest.

Why the technique works

Why must we restrict the domain at all, rather than just "allowing" a multivalued inverse? Because in calculus we need a genuine *function* – one output per input – so that we can graph it, differentiate it, and feed it into the chain rule. A function that returns infinitely many answers cannot have a single well-defined derivative at a point. By restricting sine to a single monotonic branch, we obtain a well-defined, differentiable, single-valued inverse. The cost is that the inverse only ever reports angles in one limited window; we accept that cost because differentiability is essential for calculus, and because the discarded solutions are readily recovered from periodicity and symmetry.

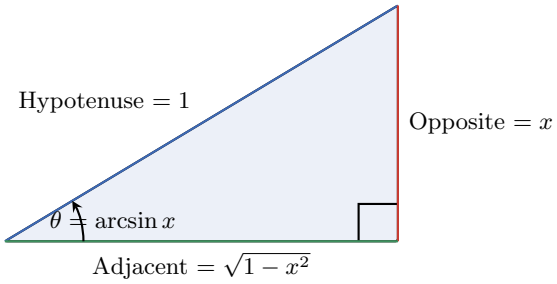
4.7.4 Computing With Inverses: the Triangle Trick

A frequent and initially baffling task is to simplify a composition like $\cos(\arcsin x)$. The expression mixes an angle-finder with a coordinate-finder, but a right-triangle picture untangles it instantly.

Example 4.1 (Simplify $\cos(\arcsin x)$)**.** Let $\theta = \arcsin x$, so $\sin\theta = x$ and, by definition of the arcsine branch, $\theta \in [-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$. We want $\cos\theta$. Build a right triangle in which $\sin\theta = x$: opposite side x, hypotenuse 1 (so that opposite/hypotenuse $= x$). By Pythagoras the adjacent side is $\sqrt{1-x^2}$ (Figure 4.12). Then

$$\cos(\arcsin x) = \cos\theta = \frac{\text{adjacent}}{\text{hypotenuse}} = \sqrt{1-x^2}.$$

We take the *positive* root because θ lies in $[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$, where cosine is never negative. The branch we chose for arcsine is exactly what resolves the sign ambiguity – another reason the restriction matters.



$$\sin\theta = \frac{\text{opp}}{\text{hyp}} = \frac{x}{1} = x$$
$$\cos\theta = \frac{\text{adj}}{\text{hyp}} = \sqrt{1-x^2}$$
$$\tan\theta = \frac{\text{opp}}{\text{adj}} = \frac{x}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}$$

Figure 4.12: The right-triangle method for simplifying inverse trigonometric compositions. Setting $\theta = \arcsin x$ builds a reference right triangle with opposite side x and hypotenuse 1. The Pythagorean theorem supplies the missing adjacent side $\sqrt{1-x^2}$, allowing any trig function of $\arcsin x$ to be read off directly.

This little identity, $\cos(\arcsin x) = \sqrt{1-x^2}$, is not a curiosity: it is precisely what makes the derivative of arcsin come out to the clean $1/\sqrt{1-x^2}$ you will derive later in Chapter 12 when differentiating inverse trigonometric functions, and it is the substitution behind a whole family of integrals.

Work it yourself

Try the same trick on $\tan(\arccos x)$. Set $\theta = \arccos x$, so $\cos\theta = x$ with adjacent $= x$, hypotenuse $= 1$, hence opposite $= \sqrt{1-x^2}$. Then $\tan\theta =$ opposite/adjacent $= \sqrt{1-x^2}/x$. Sketch the triangle yourself and confirm each side; the picture does all the work.

4.8 Why Radians Make Calculus Clean: The Payoff

One thread has run through the whole chapter, and it is the most important practical takeaway. Why radians?

Trace the logic. We *defined* radians so that arc length equals angle ($s = r\theta$, and θ itself on the unit circle). That choice made the arc above $(1, 0)$ have length exactly t. That, in turn, forced the squeeze $\cos t < \frac{\sin t}{t} < 1$, hence $\sin t/t \to 1$, hence $\sin t \approx t$ for small t. And *that* approximation is, almost verbatim, the statement that the derivative of $\sin t$ at $t = 0$ equals 1:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\sin t\Big|_{t=0} = \lim_{t\to 0}\frac{\sin t - \sin 0}{t - 0} = \lim_{t\to 0}\frac{\sin t}{t} = 1.$$

With that, the central differentiation formulas $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\sin t = \cos t$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\cos t = -\sin t$ (which we will prove rigorously in Chapter 12 once limits and derivative rules are established) fall out clean, with no

stray constants. Had we used degrees, every one of these would carry a factor of $\pi/180 \approx 0.01745$, multiplying and compounding through every derivative, every integral, and every Taylor series. Radians are the *unique* angle unit in which the calculus of trigonometry has no extra constant factors.

Why this matters

This is a recurring pattern in mathematics worth naming. The right *units* or the right *definitions* do not merely simplify the bookkeeping – they reveal that two things that looked different are really the same quantity. Radians reveal that angle and arc length are one and the same quantity. In Chapter 3, you saw that Euler's number e is the unique base that makes the starting slope of an exponential curve equal to 1, revealing that the function and its own rate of growth are one. Here, radians are the angle unit that makes the starting slope of $\sin t$ equal to 1. In both cases, choosing the "natural" ruler makes a rate of change equal to 1 exactly where it should, and the whole subject snaps into focus. When formulas suddenly lose their clutter, it is a sure sign you have found the coordinates the problem wanted all along.

4.8.1 Looking Ahead: The Limit

Notice the delicate step we took when computing the fundamental trig limit:

$$\lim_{t \to 0} \frac{\sin t}{t} = 1.$$

If you try to evaluate this expression at the destination itself, setting $t = 0$, you get $\frac{\sin 0}{0} = \frac{0}{0}$, which is undefined. Yet as $t \to 0$, the ratio heads toward 1. How can mathematics make rigorous sense of where a quantity is heading when evaluating at the point is forbidden? In Chapter 5, we explore the idea and history of the *limit*.

4.9 Exercises

Exercise 4.1 (Mental checks: see it before you compute)**.** Test your geometric intuition on the circle before writing down calculations:

(a) Without converting to degrees, in which quadrant does an angle of 4 radians land? (Think: $\pi \approx 3.14$ and $3\pi/2 \approx 4.71$.)

(b) Which is larger: $\sin(1)$ or $\cos(1)$? (Hint: compare 1 radian to $\pi/4 \approx 0.785$.)

(c) What is the sign of $\cos(3)$? Of $\sin(3)$?

(d) Can $\sin t = 1.05$ ever have a real solution? What about $\tan t = 105$?

(e) What is $\arcsin(\sin(0))$? What is $\arcsin(\sin(\pi))$? Explain why the second answer is not π.

Exercise 4.2 (Conversions and arc length)**.** (a) Convert to radians: 135°, 210°, 300°. (b) Convert to degrees: $\frac{5\pi}{6}$, $\frac{7\pi}{4}$, 3 radians (approximate). (c) A circular arc has radius 4 cm and subtends an angle of $\frac{2\pi}{3}$. Find its length and the area of the corresponding sector.

Exercise 4.3 (Reading the circle)**.** Without a calculator, give exact values of sin, cos, and tan at $t = \frac{2\pi}{3}$, $t = \frac{5\pi}{4}$, and $t = \frac{11\pi}{6}$. For each, state which quadrant the point lands in and use that to predict the signs *before* computing.

Exercise 4.4 (Identities from symmetry)**.** Using only the unit-circle picture (reflections and rotations), explain why each holds: (a) $\sin(\pi + t) = -\sin t$; (b) $\cos(\pi + t) = -\cos t$; (c) $\tan(\pi + t) = \tan t$; (d) $\sin(\frac{\pi}{2} + t) = \cos t$. Draw the relevant reflection or rotation for at least two of them.

Exercise 4.5 (Double and half angle)**.** (a) Starting from the addition formula for $\cos(a + b)$, derive $\cos 2a = 1 - 2\sin^2 a$. (b) Use the half-angle formula to find the exact value of $\cos^2(\pi/8)$, and hence $\cos(\pi/8)$.

Exercise 4.6 (The fundamental limit at work)**.** Evaluate each limit, reducing it to $\lim_{t\to 0} \sin t/t = 1$ (and its cousin $\frac{1-\cos t}{t} \to 0$): (a) $\lim\limits_{t\to 0} \dfrac{\sin 5t}{t}$; (b) $\lim\limits_{t\to 0} \dfrac{\sin 3t}{\sin 7t}$; (c) $\lim\limits_{t\to 0} \dfrac{\tan t}{t}$; (d) $\lim\limits_{t\to 0} \dfrac{1-\cos t}{t^2}$. (Hint for (a): write $\frac{\sin 5t}{t} = 5 \cdot \frac{\sin 5t}{5t}$.)

Exercise 4.7 (Inverse compositions)**.** Simplify to an algebraic expression in x (state any restrictions on x): (a) $\sin(\arccos x)$; (b) $\tan(\arcsin x)$; (c) $\cos(\arctan x)$; (d) $\sin(2\arctan x)$.

Exercise 4.8 (Why the branch matters)**.** (a) Is it true that $\arcsin(\sin t) = t$ for *every* real t? Test $t = \frac{3\pi}{4}$ and explain the result using the range of arcsin. (b) For which t *is* $\arcsin(\sin t) = t$ exactly true? (c) Sketch the function $g(t) = \arcsin(\sin t)$ over $[-2\pi, 2\pi]$ and describe its shape.

Exercise 4.9 (Solving trig equations completely)**.** Find *all* real solutions, using an inverse for one solution and the circle's symmetry for the rest: (a) $2\sin t - 1 = 0$; (b) $\cos t = -\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$; (c) $\tan t = 1$. Express each answer as a family $t = (\ldots) + 2\pi k$ or $+\pi k$, $k \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Exercise 4.10 (Prove the squeeze, carefully)**.** Reproduce the proof that $\lim_{t\to 0^+} \sin t/t = 1$ by comparing the areas of the inner triangle, the sector, and the outer triangle on the unit circle. Then explain why the two-sided limit follows, by arguing that $f(t) = \sin t/t$ is an even function.

Exercise 4.11 (A modeling problem)**.** The number of daylight hours at a mid-northern latitude is modeled by

$$D(t) = 12 + 3\sin\left(\frac{2\pi}{365}(t - 80)\right),$$

where t is the day of the year. (a) What are the amplitude, period, and midline, and what do they mean physically? (b) On which day is daylight longest? (c) For roughly how many days per year does $D(t) > 13.5$? (Use an inverse sine and the symmetry of the curve.)

Exercise 4.12 (Conceptual: the missing constant)**.** Suppose a careless textbook *defines* sine using degrees, so that $S(x) = \sin(x^\circ)$ where x is a pure number of degrees. Using $\sin(x^\circ) = \sin\big(\frac{\pi}{180}x \text{ rad}\big)$ and the radian limit, compute $\lim_{x\to 0} S(x)/x$. Explain in one or two sentences why this answer makes degrees a poor choice for calculus, connecting it to the eventual formula for the derivative of S.

Chapter 5

The Idea and History of Limits

In the preceding chapters, we assembled the elementary cast of functions – polynomials, exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric curves – by evaluating them at concrete points. But what happens when the exact instant we care about cannot be evaluated, collapsing into the forbidden ratio $0/0$?

There is a single idea sitting underneath every formula in this book that resolves this riddle. It is not the derivative, and it is not the integral. It is older than both, and both are defined in terms of it. It is the *limit*.

A limit answers a question that sounds almost paradoxical: *what value is a quantity heading toward, even if it never actually gets there?* How can we talk about where something is going if it never arrives? And yet your intuition handles this kind of reasoning every day. When you watch a car decelerate toward a stop sign, you can tell it is heading for a complete stop long before its wheels stop turning. When you pour water into a glass and the level rises more and more slowly, you can see it approaching the brim. The limit is the mathematics of *approach* – of destinations inferred from the journey.

This chapter is about the *idea* of a limit and the long history of how mathematicians fought to understand it. The famous "epsilon–delta" definition can wait for the next chapter. Here we want something harder to get from a formula: we want you to *see* what a limit is, why calculus cannot live without it, and why it took roughly two hundred years and some of the sharpest minds in history to say precisely what it means.

5.1 A quantity that approaches

Start with the most concrete possible picture. Consider the function

$$f(x) = \frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1}.$$

There is something wrong with this function at exactly one point. If you try to evaluate it at $x = 1$, you get

$$f(1) = \frac{1 - 1}{1 - 1} = \frac{0}{0},$$

which is undefined. Division by zero is not allowed, and $0/0$ is not allowed twice over. So the function f has a *hole* at $x = 1$: it is defined everywhere else on the number line, but at $x = 1$ it simply has

no value.

Now here is the question that started calculus. The function is undefined *at* $x = 1$, but what is it doing *near* $x = 1$? What value is it approaching as x creeps toward 1?

Work it yourself

Before reading on, build the table yourself with a calculator. Compute $f(x) = \dfrac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1}$ for $x = 0.9,\ 0.99,\ 0.999$ and then for $x = 1.1,\ 1.01,\ 1.001$. Watch what happens to the output. Do not simplify the formula first – plug the numbers in raw, the way a machine would.

Here is the table you should have produced. The values of x march in toward 1 from below (the left) and from above (the right), and we watch the outputs.

x (from left)	$f(x)$	x (from right)	$f(x)$
0.9	1.9	1.1	2.1
0.99	1.99	1.01	2.01
0.999	1.999	1.001	2.001
0.9999	1.9999	1.0001	2.0001

The pattern is unmistakable. As x approaches 1 from either side, $f(x)$ approaches 2. It never *equals* 2 in this table, and it never can equal anything at $x = 1$, because f is not defined there. But the outputs are clearly homing in on 2. We say:

$$\lim_{x \to 1} \frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1} = 2.$$

Read this aloud as "the limit, as x approaches 1, of $(x^2 - 1)/(x - 1)$, equals 2."

Focus

The notation $\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = L$ is a statement about the *approach*, not about the destination point itself. It says: *as x gets close to a (but not equal to a), the outputs $f(x)$ get close to L.* Whether f is defined at a, and what value it might have there, is a separate question that the limit deliberately ignores.

Why does f approach 2? Algebra reveals the reason. As long as $x \neq 1$, we may factor and cancel:

$$f(x) = \frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1} = \frac{(x - 1)(x + 1)}{x - 1} = x + 1.$$

The cancellation is legal precisely *because* $x \neq 1$, so the factor $x - 1$ in the denominator is not zero and we are allowed to divide it out. Away from $x = 1$, $f(x)$ is indistinguishable from the straight line $x + 1$ – and as x slides toward 1, $x + 1$ plainly slides toward $1 + 1 = 2$. So $f(x)$ approaches 2 as well.

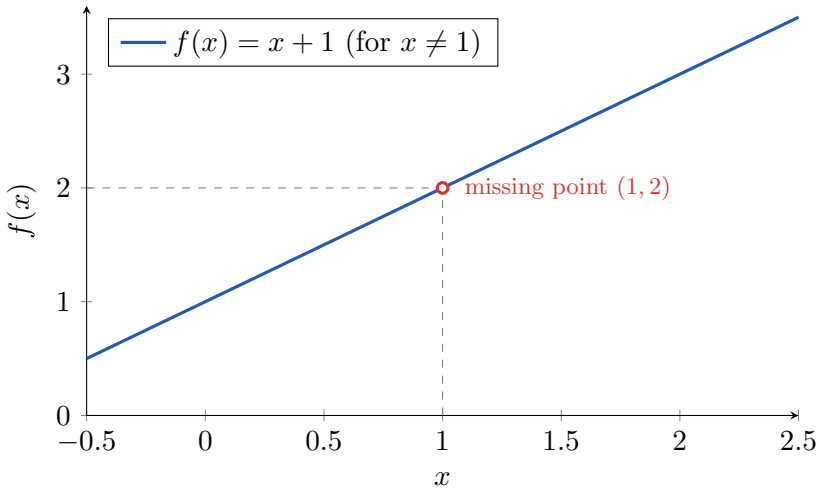


Figure 5.1: The graph of $f(x) = \dfrac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1}$ is the straight line $y = x + 1$ with a single point punched out at $(1, 2)$. The hollow circle marks the missing point. As x slides toward 1 along the line, the height slides toward 2 – regardless of the fact that the point itself is absent.

Intuition

A limit is what your eye does automatically when it follows a curve toward a point. If you trace the line in Figure 5.1 with your finger heading for $x = 1$, your finger arrives at height 2 – and the tiny hole does not stop you, because your finger is reading the *trend* of the curve, not the single missing pixel. The limit is the trend.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose someone argues that $\lim_{x \to 1} \dfrac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1}$ cannot equal 2 because "when you plug in $x = 1$, you get $0/0$, which is undefined." How would you answer in a single sentence? The limit does not ask what happens *at* the point; it asks what value the outputs are marching toward as you get arbitrarily close to the point.

5.1.1 Approaching the undefined point

You might shrug and say: this is a fuss over nothing. Just use the line $x + 1$ and forget the hole. Yet that hole shows why limits are needed in the first place. Consider what happens throughout calculus.

When we measure the steepness of a curve at a point, we will compute the slope of a line through two points on the curve and then let those two points slide together. At the instant they coincide, the slope formula becomes

$$\frac{\text{rise}}{\text{run}} = \frac{0}{0},$$

because the two points are the same point: zero rise over zero run. When we measure the area under a curve, we will add up the areas of thin rectangles and let their width shrink to zero; in the limit each rectangle has zero width, and we are summing infinitely many zeros. Every central computation

in calculus runs straight into a $0/0$ or an "infinity of zeros," an expression that is meaningless if you plug in the forbidden value directly. The limit is the tool that lets us extract a sensible, finite answer from these forbidden expressions by asking not "what is the value *at* the bad point?" but "what is the value *approaching* as we close in on the bad point?"

Why this matters

This is the deep reason the limit is the foundation. Calculus is the study of quantities at an *instant* – instantaneous speed, instantaneous slope, the area swept out at a precise moment. But an instant has no duration, and at an instant the naive formulas collapse to $0/0$. The limit is how we make sense of "at an instant" without ever actually dividing by zero. It is the bridge from the smooth, continuous world we want to describe to the arithmetic of finite numbers we are allowed to do.

5.2 A limit that does not need a hole

It would be a mistake to think limits are only about repairing broken functions. Most of the time the limit of a function at a point is simply its value there, and that is the boring, reassuring case. If $g(x) = x^2 + 3$, then

$$\lim_{x \to 2} g(x) = 2^2 + 3 = 7,$$

and the outputs near $x = 2$ approach 7 for the unremarkable reason that g is a nice smooth function with $g(2) = 7$. There is no hole, no drama. The function approaches the value it actually has (Figure 5.2).

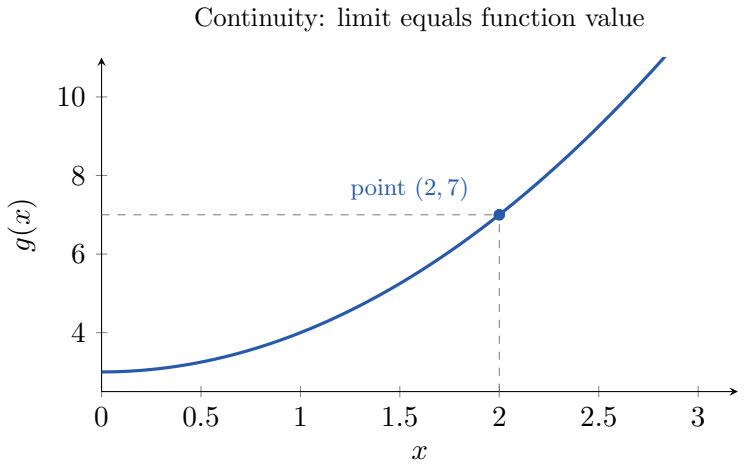


Figure 5.2: The graph of $g(x) = x^2 + 3$ has no hole at $x = 2$. As x slides toward 2 the height slides toward 7 – and the point $(2, 7)$ is genuinely *there* (filled dot), so here the limit and the value agree. Contrast this with the punched-out point of Figure 5.1.

Functions that behave this well – where the limit at a point equals the value at the point – are called *continuous* (informally, curves you can sketch without lifting your pencil from the page), and they get their own chapter. For now, just notice that the limit and the value can either *agree* (the continuous case, g above) or *disagree* (the hole case, f above, where the limit is 2 but the value does not exist). The limit concept earns its place precisely because it does not care which case you are

in. It always asks the same question – where are the outputs heading? – and that question has an answer of 2 for f at $x = 1$ and an answer of 7 for g at $x = 2$, whether or not the function bothers to be defined and equal there.

What is really happening

When you write $\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = L$, you are making a claim about *infinitely many* values of f at once – all the values at points near a. The claim is: *you can force the outputs to be as close to L as you like, just by keeping x close enough to a.* The phrase "as close as you like" is the heart of it. It is not enough that the outputs get *somewhat* close; they must be squeezable arbitrarily close. We deliberately exclude $x = a$ itself from the conversation, which is why the value $f(a)$ – present, absent, or weird – has no vote. The next chapter turns "as close as you like" into the precise ε–δ machinery. Everything there is just this sentence made unambiguous.

5.3 When left and right disagree: one-sided limits

So far our examples approached the same value whether x came in from the left or from the right. That symmetry is not guaranteed, and watching it break is one of the most instructive things you can do.

Consider the *sign-step* function

$$H(x) = \begin{cases} 0 & x < 0, \\ 1 & x \geq 0. \end{cases}$$

This is the Heaviside step (named after electrical engineer Oliver Heaviside, it models an abrupt switch flipped from "off" to "on"). It is flat at height 0 for all negative x, then jumps suddenly to height 1 at $x = 0$ and stays there. Ask the limit question at $x = 0$: what is H approaching?

Jump: one-sided limits disagree

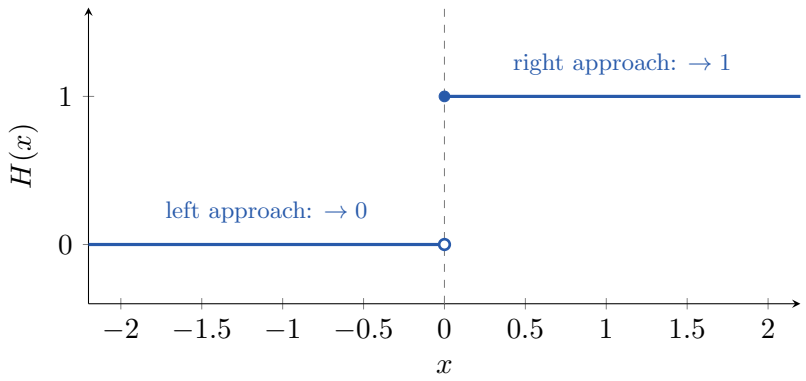


Figure 5.3: The Heaviside step $H(x)$. Approaching $x = 0$ from the left, the outputs sit at 0; approaching from the right, they sit at 1. The two approaches disagree, so there is no single value that H is heading toward.

Figure 5.3 shows the jump. If you walk in toward 0 from the negative side – $x = -0.1, -0.01, -0.001$ – every output is exactly 0. The function is approaching 0. But if you walk in from the positive side

– $x = 0.1, 0.01, 0.001$ – every output is exactly 1. The function is approaching 1. The two sides give different answers. There is no single number that $H(x)$ is "heading toward" as $x \to 0$, because it depends entirely on which direction you came from.

We capture this with *one-sided limits*. The *left-hand limit* watches only x coming from below:

$$\lim_{x \to 0^-} H(x) = 0,$$

where the little minus sign on 0^- means "x approaches 0 through values less than 0." The *right-hand limit* watches only x coming from above:

$$\lim_{x \to 0^+} H(x) = 1,$$

with 0^+ meaning "through values greater than 0." Both one-sided limits exist and are perfectly definite. They simply disagree.

Focus

The ordinary (two-sided) limit $\lim_{x \to a} f(x)$ exists *only when both one-sided limits exist and are equal*. In symbols,

$$\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = L \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \lim_{x \to a^-} f(x) = L \text{ and } \lim_{x \to a^+} f(x) = L.$$

For the Heaviside step, the left limit is 0 and the right limit is 1; they disagree, so the two-sided limit $\lim_{x \to 0} H(x)$ *does not exist*. "Does not exist" is a legitimate, useful answer, not a failure.

Intuition

Think of two hikers approaching a canyon from opposite rims. The left hiker ends at the canyon floor; the right hiker ends on the far rim. If someone asks "where does the trail arrive?" there is no single answer – it depends which hiker you follow. A two-sided limit exists only when both hikers, coming from opposite directions, arrive at the *same* place. One-sided limits let us still describe each hiker's destination separately.

Pause

Pause and think: If you are told that $\lim_{x \to 3^-} f(x) = 5$ and $\lim_{x \to 3^+} f(x) = 5$, can you conclude that $f(3) = 5$? No. The two-sided limit exists and equals 5, but $f(3)$ could be undefined (a hole) or equal to 100 (a displaced point). The limit describes the approach; the function value is whatever sits at the destination itself.

Application

One-sided limits are the natural way to model *sudden events*. Flip a switch and the voltage jumps; the current "before" and "after" have different limits at the instant of the flip. In economics, a tax bracket creates a jump in the marginal rate: the rate just below the threshold and just above it are different one-sided limits. In probability, the cumulative distribution of a discrete variable steps up at each value, exactly like the Heaviside function. Whenever reality has a genuine jump, the two-sided limit fails and the one-sided limits carry the real information.

5.3.1 A more violent disagreement

A jump is a polite failure: each side still settles on a number. Limits can fail more dramatically. Consider $p(x) = 1/x$ near $x = 0$. From the right, as $x = 0.1, 0.01, 0.001$, the outputs are $10, 100, 1000$ – shooting off to $+\infty$. From the left, $x = -0.1, -0.01, -0.001$ give $-10, -100, -1000$ – plunging to $-\infty$. Neither one-sided limit settles on a finite number; the function values grow without bound, as shown in Figure 5.4. We write $\lim_{x\to 0^+} 1/x = +\infty$ and $\lim_{x\to 0^-} 1/x = -\infty$ as shorthand for "grows without bound," but you should hear those as descriptions of *how* the limit fails, not as ordinary numerical answers. We will treat such infinite behavior carefully in the chapter on asymptotes.

Infinite limits: blow-up as $x \to 0$

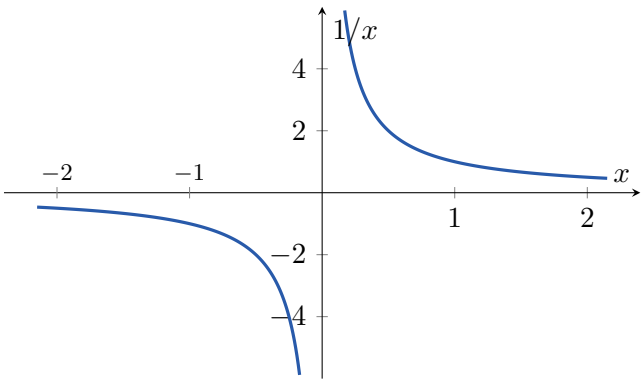


Figure 5.4: $p(x) = 1/x$. The right-hand branch races up toward $+\infty$ as $x \to 0^+$; the left-hand branch dives toward $-\infty$ as $x \to 0^-$. There is no finite value being approached from either side.

5.4 The historical crisis: a triumph built on sand

Now for the history, where the idea of a limit turns dramatic. Calculus was invented – twice, independently – in the late seventeenth century. Isaac Newton in England (working in the 1660s and 1670s, publishing later) and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz in Germany (publishing in the 1680s) each built a calculus of *infinitesimals* (idealized quantities so tiny that they are smaller than any positive fraction, yet still greater than zero). Their methods were powerful. Newton used his "fluxions" (his term for the instantaneous rates of change of flowing quantities, from the Latin for flow) to derive the laws of planetary motion; Leibniz's elegant $\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}x$ and $\int$ notation (an elongated "S" for sum) – which we still use – let problems that had stumped the ancients fall in a few lines. By any practical measure, calculus was a colossal success.

And yet at its logical core sat something nobody could justify.

To see the puzzle, picture how both Newton and Leibniz computed the slope of a curve. Consider $y = x^2$ at an arbitrary point x. You pick a nearby point by letting x change by a tiny amount o (Newton's notation) or $\mathrm{d}x$ (Leibniz's), compute the resulting change in y, and form the ratio of rise to run (Figure 5.5).

For $y = x^2$, the algebra runs:

$$\frac{(x+o)^2 - x^2}{o} = \frac{x^2 + 2xo + o^2 - x^2}{o} = \frac{2xo + o^2}{o} = 2x + o.$$

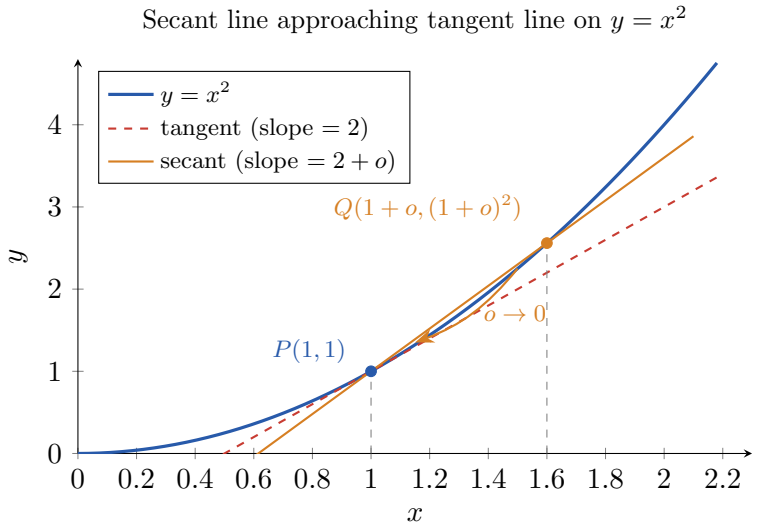


Figure 5.5: The geometric puzzle that troubled early calculus. To find the slope of $y = x^2$ at $P(1, 1)$, we pick a second point $Q(1 + o, (1 + o)^2)$ and connect them with an orange secant line (slope $2 + o$). As o shrinks toward zero, Q slides along the curve toward P, and the secant line swings into the dashed red tangent line (slope 2). For any nonzero o, the points are distinct and the division is valid; the limit is the slope the secant is heading toward.

Then came the suspicious maneuver: you *discard* the leftover o to conclude that the instantaneous slope is $2x$.

Notice the problem in that calculation. In the third equality we *divided* by o, which is only legal if $o \neq 0$. Then in the final step we *threw away* the term o, which is only legal if $o = 0$. The increment o had to be nonzero to allow division, and zero to disappear from the answer. Newton and Leibniz both sensed this tension; neither could explain in clean logical terms why the answer $2x$ was nonetheless indisputably correct.

This was not a minor bookkeeping quirk. It was a contradiction at the very base of the most celebrated mathematics of the Enlightenment, and it did not escape notice. The most famous attack came not from a rival mathematician, but from a philosopher and clergyman: Bishop George Berkeley.

History

In 1734, the philosopher Bishop George Berkeley published *The Analyst*, criticizing the logical foundations of early calculus. He pointed out that in calculating derivatives, the increment o was treated as nonzero in order to divide by it, and then treated as zero to eliminate it from the result. In a famous passage, he challenged mathematicians:

> *"And what are these fluxions? The velocities of evanescent increments? And what are these same evanescent increments? They are neither finite quantities, nor quantities infinitely small, nor yet nothing. May we not call them the ghosts of departed quantities?"*

Berkeley demonstrated that while the results were correct, the methods lacked rigorous justification. This critique motivated nineteenth-century mathematicians to establish limits on

formal foundations without relying on infinitesimals. In the 1960s, Abraham Robinson's non-standard analysis proved that infinitesimals can also be formulated with complete mathematical rigor.

Walking question

Take Berkeley's challenge seriously on your next walk. The computation $\frac{(x+o)^2-x^2}{o} = 2x + o$ is exact and innocent as long as $o \neq 0$. The whole crisis lives in a single move: at the end we replace $2x + o$ by $2x$. Ask yourself: *is that an approximation, or is it exact?* If it is an approximation, calculus is only approximately true – but it is not, the answers are exact. If it is exact, then in what sense is dropping a nonzero o legitimate? Hold that question. The limit is precisely the answer, and feeling the tension first will make the resolution land.

5.4.1 What the early masters got right – and what was missing

Do not read this history as "Newton and Leibniz were sloppy." They were not sloppy; they were *early*. Their physical and geometric intuition was nearly flawless. When Newton spoke of a quantity's "ultimate ratio," he described the ratio $2x + o$ *as* o *vanishes* – not its value at any fixed nonzero o, and not a meaningless ratio at $o = 0$, but the value the ratio is *heading toward*. Read that sentence again: Newton was reaching, in words, for exactly the limit concept. He wrote of "the limit to which they always approach, and to which they approach nearer than by any given difference, but never go beyond." That is almost a definition of a limit – in 1687.

The gap was language, not insight. What Newton and Leibniz lacked was not the geometric picture, but a way to state what "approaching" meant without invoking infinitely small numbers that were somehow both nonzero and zero. Once nineteenth-century mathematicians defined the limit cleanly, every formula Newton and Leibniz had found stayed intact – only the foundation underneath changed.

What is really happening

What is really happening in the $0/0$ derivative computation? *Nothing is ever divided by zero, and nothing nonzero is ever discarded.* The expression $\frac{(x+o)^2-x^2}{o}$ equals $2x+o$ for *every* nonzero o – this is exact algebra, no approximation. The slope is then *defined* as the limit of that exact expression as $o \to 0$, i.e. the number that $2x + o$ is heading toward, which is $2x$. We never set $o = 0$; we ask where $2x + o$ goes as o shrinks. No infinitesimal number is needed: "$o \to 0$" represents a limiting process, not an arithmetic quantity.

5.5 Cauchy and Weierstrass: rebuilding on rock

For over a century after Newton's *Principia*, calculus advanced spectacularly while its logical foundation remained incomplete. Leonhard Euler and his contemporaries computed freely with infinite series and infinitesimals, guided by sharp physical and geometric instinct. As functions grew stranger and infinite series subtler, however, purely intuitive manipulations began producing outright contradictions, forcing mathematicians to spell out exactly when a limiting step is valid.

In the 1820s, Augustin-Louis Cauchy, lecturing at the École Polytechnique in Paris, made a decisive

choice in his *Cours d'analyse* (1821): he made the *limit* the primary concept and defined everything else – continuity, the derivative, the integral, and convergence (the property of an infinite sequence settling on a single destination) – in terms of it. He wrote that a variable's limit is the fixed value it approaches so that it ends up differing from it by "as little as one wishes."

For Cauchy, "infinitesimal" stopped meaning a mysterious fixed number smaller than every positive real; instead, it simply meant an ordinary variable shrinking toward zero.

Cauchy's phrase "as little as one wishes" is the seed of everything. It contains a hidden challenge-and-response: *however* small a gap you want, I can guarantee the difference is smaller, provided the variable is far enough along. But Cauchy still leaned on intuitive verbal phrasing – "approaches indefinitely," "successive values" – and his words occasionally hid subtle errors (for instance, his famous assertion that any convergent sum of continuous functions is continuous is, without extra conditions, false).

The final tightening fell to Berlin. In the 1850s through 1870s, Karl Weierstrass, a former schoolteacher who became the leading figure in mathematical analysis (the branch of mathematics devoted to limits and continuous processes), removed the last trace of motion and mystery from the limit. Where Cauchy still spoke of a variable *approaching* – a word that suggests time and movement – Weierstrass replaced the whole idea with a static inequality between two ordinary positive numbers, ε (output tolerance) and δ (input tolerance): for every $\varepsilon > 0$, there exists $\delta > 0$ such that $0 < |x - a| < \delta \implies |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$. No motion, no infinitesimals – just distances on the number line.

Why this matters

Notice the direction of the centuries-long motion: from *dynamic* to *static*. Newton's quantities *flowed*; Cauchy's variables *approached*; Weierstrass's ε and δ just *sit there* in a logical relationship with no motion at all. This is a recurring pattern in mathematics – we tame a slippery dynamic intuition by reformulating it as a static statement about "for all ... there exists ...." Trading the feeling of motion for a static inequality can feel austere at first, but it gives us a definition sharp enough to prove theorems without guesswork.

Pause

Pause and think: In everyday language, a "limit" is a boundary you cannot cross, like a speed limit on a highway. In calculus, can a function cross its limit? Yes, repeatedly. Consider an oscillating spring settling down, or $f(x) = \frac{\sin x}{x}$ as $x \to \infty$. The graph crosses the limiting height of 0 infinitely many times as it squeezes closer and closer. In calculus, a limit is a destination being approached, not an impassable wall.

5.5.1 Why intuition alone is insufficient

You might reasonably ask: if the intuitive idea – "outputs head toward L" – gets the right answers, why bother with the austere ε–δ machinery at all? Why did this need fixing?

The answer is that intuition, unaided, eventually lies to you. Consider how you would *prove* a basic fact such as "the limit of a sum is the sum of the limits," or decide a genuinely hard case where the function oscillates infinitely fast as it approaches the point. Intuition has no traction on these; it can only gesture. Worse, the nineteenth century discovered functions that violate every naive

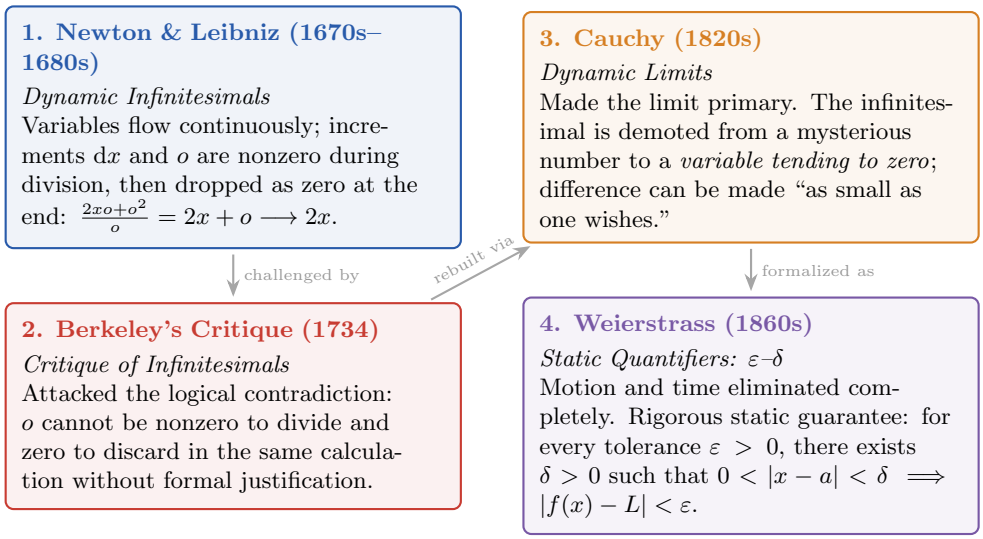


Figure 5.6: The two-century conceptual progression of the limit: from physical intuition of flowing infinitesimals to a completely static arithmetic statement.

expectation – a function continuous at every point yet with a sharp corner at every point, so that "follow the curve with your finger" becomes meaningless. On such monsters, the only way to know what is true is to have a definition precise enough to *compute* with, one that does not quietly assume the function is as tame as the pictures in this chapter.

Common trap

The most common misconception about limits, and the one the whole history is fighting, is the belief that $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)$ means "plug in $x = a$." Sometimes plugging in works (the continuous case), and that lucky coincidence breeds the bad habit. But the limit is fundamentally a statement about values *near* a with a *itself excluded*. Our very first example, $\frac{x^2-1}{x-1}$, has a perfectly good limit of 2 at a point where you *cannot* plug in at all. Train yourself to read $\lim_{x\to a}$ as "as x approaches a," never as "at $x = a$."

Why the technique works

Why does turning "approaches" into a static ε–δ statement actually work – what makes it the definitive formalization? It captures the exact operational content of "as close as you like." The phrase already contains a two-player challenge: a skeptic challenges you with a tolerance ("get within $\varepsilon = 0.001$ of L"), and you must respond with a guarantee ("keep x within δ of a and I promise you will"). If you can meet this challenge for *every* ε – no matter how small – then in every practical and provable sense the outputs are being forced toward L, and there is no wiggle room left for them to be heading anywhere else. The genius of Weierstrass's formulation is that it converts the vague "gets closer and closer" into a finite, checkable promise about two ordinary positive numbers. The next chapter is entirely devoted to playing this game until it is second nature.

5.6 A numerical caution: tables suggest, they do not prove

The table that opened this chapter was persuasive, and tables are a wonderful way to *guess* a limit. But a table can mislead, and seeing how is excellent training for why we eventually need proof rather than evidence.

Work it yourself

Tabulate $f(x) = \sin(\pi/x)$ at the points $x = 1,\ \frac{1}{2},\ \frac{1}{3},\ \frac{1}{4},\ \ldots$, i.e. $x = 1/n$ for $n = 1, 2, 3, \ldots$. At every one of these points $\pi/x = n\pi$, so $\sin(\pi/x) = \sin(n\pi) = 0$. The table reads $0, 0, 0, 0, \ldots$ and screams "the limit as $x \to 0^+$ is 0." Now tabulate instead at $x = 2,\ \frac{2}{5},\ \frac{2}{9},\ \ldots$, i.e. $x = 2/(4k+1)$. There $\pi/x = (4k+1)\pi/2$, an odd multiple of $\pi/2$, so the output is $+1$ every time. A second table, just as correct, screams "the limit is 1."

Both tables are arithmetically correct, and they contradict each other. The truth is that $\sin(\pi/x)$ oscillates between -1 and $+1$ faster and faster as $x \to 0^+$, never settling on anything: the limit *does not exist*, as the crowding oscillations of Figure 5.7 show. No finite table could ever reveal this for certain, because a table only samples finitely many points and the misbehavior hides in between them.

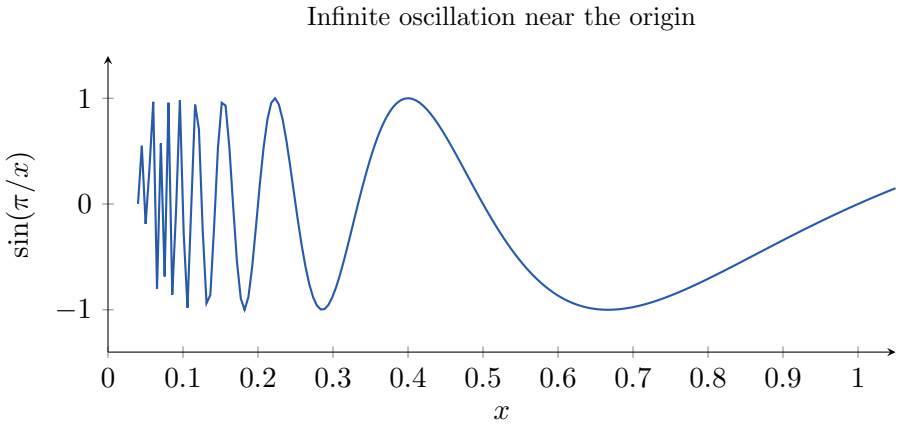


Figure 5.7: $\sin(\pi/x)$ near $x = 0$. The oscillations crowd together without bound as $x \to 0^+$, so the curve never homes in on a single height. A numerical table that happens to land on the zeros (or on the peaks) would falsely suggest a limit. Evidence is not proof.

Focus

The moral is not "never use tables." Tables and graphs are how you *form* the conjecture, and forming the right conjecture is most of the battle. The moral is that a finite amount of evidence cannot *settle* a statement about infinitely many points. That gap – between suggestive evidence and airtight proof – is exactly the gap the ε–δ definition was built to close. This is why the next chapter exists.

5.7 Summary: The Core Concept of a Limit

Here is the whole chapter in a single paragraph, the kind you could recite on a walk.

A limit is the value a function's outputs *head toward* as the input is driven toward some point, deliberately ignoring what – if anything – happens *at* that point. It exists when the approach from the left and the approach from the right agree on a single destination, and it fails to exist when they disagree (a jump), or when the outputs run off to infinity, or when they oscillate forever without settling. Newton and Leibniz used this idea to build calculus on top of "infinitesimals" whose logic Berkeley rightly challenged; Cauchy put the limit at the center of the subject as a variable shrinking toward zero; and Weierstrass finally stripped out all talk of motion, turning "approaches" into a precise challenge-and-response test with ε and δ.

Connection

Every major concept ahead is built on the limit. The *derivative* is the limit of a slope as two points merge (0/0 tamed). The *integral* is the limit of a sum of shrinking rectangles (infinitely many zeros tamed). *Continuity* is the statement that a function's limit equals its value. *Infinite series* are limits of partial sums. *Improper integrals* are limits of ordinary ones. If you truly own the idea in this chapter – a destination inferred from an approach, with the endpoint itself excluded – you own the spine of the entire subject, and each later technique becomes a special way of computing one particular limit.

In Chapter 6, we turn Weierstrass's definition into a practical tool. We will make ε and δ concrete by treating them as an input-output tolerance game.

5.8 Exercises

Exercise 5.1. (*Mental check: limit versus value.*) Answer each question in one or two sentences:

(a) If you know that $\lim_{x\to 4} f(x) = 7$, can you conclude what $f(4)$ is? Could $f(4)$ be undefined? Could $f(4) = 99$?

(b) If you know that $f(4) = 7$, does that guarantee that $\lim_{x\to 4} f(x) = 7$? Sketch or describe a simple counterexample.

Exercise 5.2. (*Mental check: one-sided consistency.*) Suppose f is a function defined near $x = 2$.

(a) If $\lim_{x\to 2^-} f(x) = 3$ and $\lim_{x\to 2^+} f(x) = 3$, must the two-sided limit $\lim_{x\to 2} f(x)$ exist? If so, what is its value?

(b) If instead $\lim_{x\to 2^-} f(x) = 3$ and $\lim_{x\to 2^+} f(x) = 3.0001$, does the two-sided limit exist? Why or why not?

Exercise 5.3. Build a table of values for $g(x) = \dfrac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3}$ at $x = 2.9,\ 2.99,\ 2.999$ and $x = 3.1,\ 3.01,\ 3.001$. Conjecture $\lim_{x\to 3} g(x)$ from the table, then confirm your conjecture algebraically by factoring and cancelling. Explain in one sentence why the cancellation is legitimate even though $g(3)$ is undefined.

Exercise 5.4. For each function, decide from a graph or short table whether the two-sided limit at the given point exists, and if so what it is. If it does not exist, state both one-sided limits (or explain that the behavior is infinite or oscillatory).

(a) $\dfrac{|x|}{x}$ at $x = 0$.

(b) $\dfrac{x^3 - x}{x - 1}$ at $x = 1$.

(c) $\dfrac{1}{(x-2)^2}$ at $x = 2$.

Exercise 5.5. Consider the piecewise function

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x + 1 & x < 2, \\ 5 & x = 2, \\ 3x - 3 & x > 2. \end{cases}$$

Compute $\lim_{x \to 2^-} f(x)$, $\lim_{x \to 2^+} f(x)$, and $\lim_{x \to 2} f(x)$. Then state the value $f(2)$. Which of these four numbers can disagree with the others, and why does that not contradict anything?

Exercise 5.6. (*Berkeley's challenge.*) Carry out the early-calculus computation for $y = x^3$. That is, expand $\dfrac{(x+o)^3 - x^3}{o}$, simplify (dividing by o where $o \neq 0$), and then identify the value the resulting expression heads toward as $o \to 0$. State clearly which step requires $o \neq 0$ and which step requires $o \to 0$, and explain in your own words why no single number o is ever required to be both zero and nonzero.

Exercise 5.7. Explain, in plain prose and to a friend who has not taken calculus, why $\lim\limits_{x \to a} f(x)$ deliberately ignores the value $f(a)$. Give a specific example where the limit exists but the function is undefined at the point, and a second example where the limit exists, the function is defined at the point, but the two *disagree*.

Exercise 5.8. (*Tables can lie.*) Let $h(x) = \cos(\pi/x)$. Evaluate h at $x = 1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{4}, \ldots$ (that is, $x = 1/n$). Show that these values do not all agree, and use this to argue that $\lim_{x \to 0^+} h(x)$ does not exist. Then explain why *no* finite table could ever *prove* that a limit *does* exist, even when one does.

Exercise 5.9. The Heaviside function H has $\lim_{x \to 0^-} H(x) = 0$ and $\lim_{x \to 0^+} H(x) = 1$. Define a new function $S(x) = H(x) + H(-x)$. Work out $S(x)$ explicitly for $x < 0$, $x = 0$, and $x > 0$, then find both one-sided limits of S at 0 and decide whether $\lim_{x \to 0} S(x)$ exists. (This is a nice case where two discontinuous functions combine into something whose two-sided limit *does* exist.)

Exercise 5.10. (*Conceptual / historical.*) In two or three sentences each, describe the distinct contribution of (a) Newton and Leibniz, (b) Berkeley, (c) Cauchy, and (d) Weierstrass to our understanding of limits. Your answer to (a) should make clear what they got *right* intuitively, and your answer to (d) should explain what the shift from "approaches" to "for every ε there exists δ" actually buys us.

Exercise 5.11. (*Toward ε–δ.*) For $f(x) = 3x + 2$, we believe $\lim_{x \to 1} f(x) = 5$. Suppose a skeptic demands that the output be within 0.6 of 5, i.e. $|f(x) - 5| < 0.6$. Find an interval of x-values around 1 (of the form $|x - 1| < \delta$ for some $\delta > 0$) that guarantees this. Then redo it for a tolerance of 0.06. What is the pattern relating the tolerance to your δ? You have just played the ε–δ game by hand.

Part II

Limits and Continuity

Chapter 6

Limits: Intuition and the Epsilon-Delta Definition

In the previous chapter you met the *idea* of a limit. You watched values of a function pile up near a single number L as the input crept toward some point a, and you learned to write

$$\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = L$$

to record that fact. You also saw that the early calculus – Newton's "ultimate ratios," Leibniz's infinitesimals – ran on exactly this kind of intuition, and that for a century and a half nobody could say with full precision what the words actually *meant*. "Approaches." "Tends to." "Becomes infinitely close." These are pictures, not definitions. A picture cannot be argued with; a definition can.

This chapter turns that intuitive idea into an exact definition. We take the everyday phrase "$f(x)$ gets close to L as x gets close to a" and translate it into the *epsilon-delta definition*. With that definition in hand, we can prove specific limits from scratch and show why the standard limit laws – such as the limit of a sum equaling the sum of the limits – have to hold.

Written in symbols, the epsilon-delta definition can look dense because it stacks "for every" ($\forall$) and "there exists" ($\exists$) in a single sentence. Underneath the symbols, though, it is just the game of *challenge and response* we previewed at the end of Chapter 5: a skeptic names an output tolerance, and we find an input window narrow enough to meet it. Let us play that game in plain English first, and let the symbols grow out of it.

6.1 Why intuition alone is not enough

You might reasonably ask: if the intuitive picture works, if everyone *agrees* that $\lim_{x \to 2}(3x + 1) = 7$, why bother making it precise? The answer is that intuition, left to itself, contradicts itself. It gives different answers to different people, and sometimes the wrong answer to everyone.

Intuition

Consider the sloppy slogan "the limit is the value the function gets close to." Now look at

$$f(x) = \frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1}.$$

At $x = 1$ this is $\frac{0}{0}$, undefined. But for every $x \neq 1$ we can cancel: $f(x) = x + 1$. So as x heads toward 1, $f(x)$ heads toward 2. The function never *reaches* 2 at the relevant input – it is not even defined at $x = 1$ – yet 2 is the limit. "Gets close to" has to mean something that does not depend on the value at a at all. The intuitive phrase does not say that out loud, so different readers fill the gap differently. Figure 6.1 shows the situation: a removable discontinuity – a single missing point or hole punched out of an otherwise unbroken line.

Removable discontinuity: approaching the hole

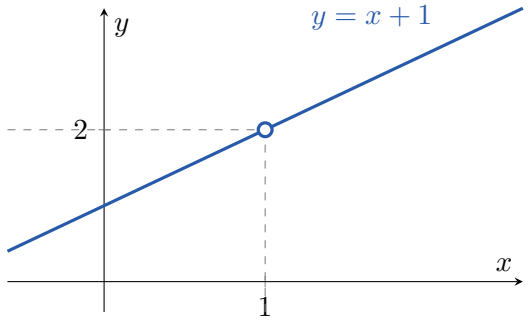


Figure 6.1: The graph of $f(x) = \frac{x^2-1}{x-1}$. For every $x \neq 1$ it agrees exactly with the line $y = x+1$; only at $x = 1$ is it undefined, leaving a removable discontinuity (an isolated hole). The limit asks where the graph is *heading* as $x \to 1$, which is plainly 2 – the very spot the hole sits over. The missing point is exactly what the limit is built to ignore.

Worse, the eighteenth-century notion of an "infinitely small" quantity $\mathrm{d}x$ – a number bigger than zero but smaller than every ordinary positive number – is, taken literally, self-contradictory in the ordinary real numbers. If $\mathrm{d}x > 0$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ is smaller than every positive number, then $\mathrm{d}x$ is smaller than $\mathrm{d}x/2$, which is absurd. The early users got correct answers *despite* this, by a kind of trained instinct for when the infinitesimals were safe to drop. What they lacked was a definition that a skeptic could check mechanically, without instinct.

History

The skeptic arrived. In 1734 Bishop George Berkeley published *The Analyst*, a sharp critique of the foundations of calculus, asking how a quantity $\mathrm{d}x$ could be treated as nonzero (so one can divide by it) and then as zero (so one can discard the remainder) within the same derivation. Berkeley was not being obtuse; he was right that no one could yet answer him. It took until the 1820s for Augustin-Louis Cauchy to base calculus on limits rather than infinitesimals, and until Karl Weierstrass's lectures in the 1850s–1870s for the limit itself to be pinned down in the static, quantifier-based form – epsilon and delta – that we use today. The definition in this chapter is, almost word for word, Weierstrass's answer to Berkeley's critique.

So the goal is a definition with three properties: it must (1) not refer to the value $f(a)$ at all, (2)

capture "arbitrarily close" without infinitesimal numbers, using only ordinary positive real numbers, and (3) be checkable – a finite, rigorous criterion that settles whether a proposed L is the limit. A single definition accomplishes all three.

6.2 The challenge–response game

Let me describe the game first, with no symbols, and then we will name the pieces.

Two players sit across a table. Player One is the *Skeptic*; Player Two is the *Prover*. On the table is a claim: "As $x \to a$, $f(x) \to L$." The Skeptic does not believe it and wants to test it. Here is the single move each player gets, repeated as often as the Skeptic likes.

Focus

The move. The Skeptic names a *tolerance*: a positive number, a margin of error around L that they are willing to accept. Call it ε (epsilon, for "error"). The Skeptic says: "Fine. I want $f(x)$ to land within ε of L. Can you guarantee that?"
The Prover must respond with a *closeness*: a positive number δ (delta, for "distance"), a radius around the input a, and a promise: "Yes. As long as you keep x within δ of a (but not exactly at a), I guarantee $f(x)$ stays within your ε of L."

The Prover *wins a round* if the promise holds: every x in the punctured interval $(a-\delta,\, a+\delta) \setminus \{a\}$ – an open interval around a with the center point a itself removed – really does produce an $f(x)$ inside $(L-\varepsilon,\, L+\varepsilon)$. The Prover *wins the game* – and the limit really is L – if the Prover has a winning response *no matter what tolerance the Skeptic names*, including absurdly tiny ones like $\varepsilon = 10^{-100}$.

The asymmetry between the two sides is important.

Intuition

The Skeptic moves *first*. The Skeptic gets to pick ε as small as they please, and only *then* does the Prover get to choose δ. This is exactly right. "$f(x)$ gets arbitrarily close to L" should mean: name any closeness you want for the *output*, and I can deliver it by squeezing the *input* hard enough. The Prover's δ is allowed to depend on the Skeptic's ε. Usually it must: the smaller the output tolerance, the tighter the Prover has to clamp the input. A winning strategy is a *rule* that turns any ε into a δ that works.

If even one stubborn tolerance defeats the Prover – one ε for which no δ keeps the function inside the band – then the limit is not L. That is how the game lets us *disprove* a wrong claim too, which we will use later.

Walking question

Before reading on, play a round in your head with $f(x) = 3x + 1$ near $a = 2$, claiming $L = 7$. The Skeptic says $\varepsilon = 0.6$: "land within 0.6 of 7, so between 6.4 and 7.6." What inputs x near 2 give outputs in that band? Since $3x + 1$ is between 6.4 and 7.6 exactly when x is between 1.8 and 2.2, the Prover can answer $\delta = 0.2$. Now ask yourself the move that matters: if the Skeptic had said $\varepsilon = 0.06$ instead, what δ would the Prover answer? Notice the pattern in how δ shrinks with ε. That pattern *is* the proof.

6.2.1 Two pictures: a band and an interval

The game lives in a picture, and you should carry the picture with you forever. The Skeptic's ε is a horizontal *band* of height 2ε centered on the line $y = L$. The Prover's δ is a vertical *strip* of width 2δ centered on $x = a$. The Prover wins the round when the graph of f, restricted to that vertical strip, stays trapped inside the horizontal band – with the single point above $x = a$ exempted, since we never ask about $x = a$ itself. See Figure 6.2.

The challenge–response game: horizontal error band vs. vertical input strip

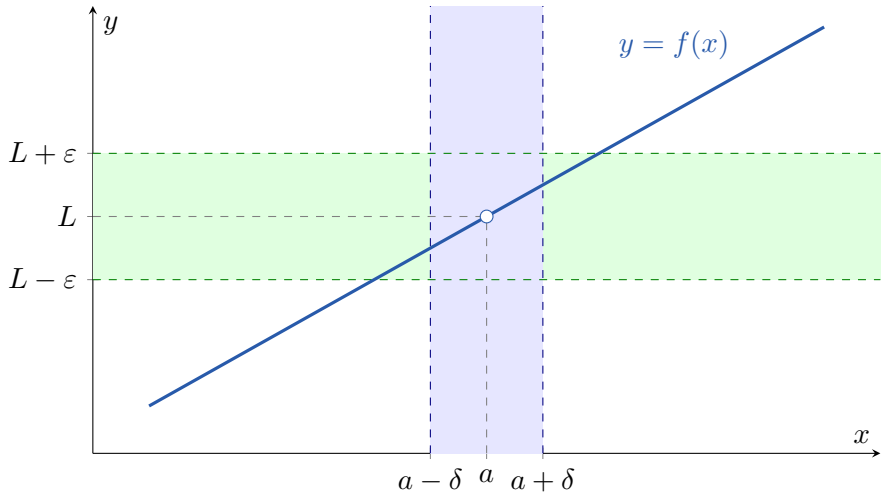


Figure 6.2: The challenge–response game as a picture. The Skeptic paints the horizontal band of half-height ε about $y = L$. The Prover must paint a vertical strip of half-width δ about $x = a$ *narrow enough* that the graph, inside the strip, never escapes the band. The open circle marks that $x = a$ is excluded: we care about the approach, not the value there.

What is really happening

What is the limit definition really asserting? Not that "$f(x)$ moves toward L" – the notion of "moving" suggests time and motion, which the static real numbers do not contain. Instead, the definition asserts a condition on *containment of sets*. For every horizontal band around L, however thin, there exists a vertical strip around a, possibly very thin, such that the part of the graph over the punctured strip lies entirely inside the band. No motion, no infinitely small quantities, and no reference to $f(a)$ are needed. Just: "for every band, there is a strip that fits inside it." Weierstrass's insight was that this containment condition captures the intended meaning of "approaches" in terms that can be verified precisely.

6.3 From the game to the definition

Now we translate, phrase by phrase. This is the moment to go slowly; if you internalize the translation, the definition will never again look foreign.

Game language	$\Longleftrightarrow$	**Symbol language**
"$f(x)$ lands within ε of L"	$\Longleftrightarrow$	$\lvert f(x) - L\rvert < \varepsilon$
"x is within δ of a, but not at a"	$\Longleftrightarrow$	$0 < \lvert x - a\rvert < \delta$
"the Skeptic may name any tolerance"	$\Longleftrightarrow$	for every $\varepsilon > 0$
"the Prover can find a closeness"	$\Longleftrightarrow$	there exists $\delta > 0$
"the promise holds for those x"	$\Longleftrightarrow$	$(0 < \lvert x-a\rvert < \delta)$ implies $(\lvert f(x)-L\rvert < \varepsilon)$

Two of these rows deserve a second look.

First, why $|f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$ and not $\leq \varepsilon$? Because "within ε" is a strict band, and – more importantly – it does not matter. Any tolerance the Skeptic can hit with $\leq$ they can also hit with $<$ by switching to a slightly larger ε, so the two versions of the definition are equivalent. We use strict inequalities throughout for clean algebra.

Second, and this is the subtle one: why the *left* inequality $0 < |x - a|$? The expression $|x - a|$ is zero precisely when $x = a$. Writing $0 < |x - a|$ forbids that single case. This formalizes the rule that "we never ask about $x = a$ itself." It is what makes the limit blind to $f(a)$ – exactly the property we demanded in Section 6.1, the one that let $\frac{x^2-1}{x-1}$ have a limit of 2 at a point where it is undefined.

Stack the rows and you have the definition. Read it now not as a wall of symbols but as the game you just played.

Definition 6.1 (The limit, Weierstrass)**.** Let f be defined on some open interval containing a, except possibly at a itself. We say

$$\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = L$$

if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists a $\delta > 0$ such that, for all x,

$$0 < |x - a| < \delta \quad \Longrightarrow \quad |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon.$$

Formal

Read the quantifiers in order, left to right, as alternating players:

$$\underbrace{\forall\, \varepsilon > 0}_{\text{Skeptic}} \ \underbrace{\exists\, \delta > 0}_{\text{Prover}} \ \underbrace{\forall x \left(0 < |x - a| < \delta \Rightarrow |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon\right)}_{\text{the promise is kept}}.$$

The *order* of quantifiers is essential. Because δ comes after ε, δ can be chosen in terms of ε – and usually must shrink whenever ε shrinks. Reversing the order to "$\exists\delta\, \forall\varepsilon$" would demand a single fixed δ good for every tolerance at once, which no non-constant function can satisfy. Putting $\forall\varepsilon$ before $\exists\delta$ lets the response depend on the challenge.

Common trap

The value at a is irrelevant – truly irrelevant. Three different functions can share the same limit at a: one undefined there, one defined with the "right" value L, and one defined with a deliberately wrong value. Because Definition 6.1 only ever quantifies over x with $|x-a|>0$, none of these differences at the single point a can change the limit. Beginners routinely "simplify" by plugging in $x=a$; that is a *shortcut* that happens to work for nice (continuous) functions, not the definition. We will see in the next chapter exactly when the shortcut is legal.

6.3.1 What it would take to be *false*

A definition you cannot negate is a definition you do not understand. The limit fails to be L when the Skeptic has a winning tolerance. Negating the quantifiers (each $\forall$ becomes $\exists$ and vice versa) gives:

Focus

$\lim_{x\to a} f(x) \neq L$ means: *there exists* some $\varepsilon>0$ such that *for every* $\delta>0$ there is at least one x with $0<|x-a|<\delta$ but $|f(x)-L|\geq\varepsilon$.
In words: there is one bad band the Prover can never fit into, no matter how thin a strip they try – every strip leaks at least one point of the graph out of that band.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose someone claims that $\lim_{x\to 0} f(x)=5$. To disprove their claim using the negated definition, what exactly do you need to produce? You do not need to check every ε. You only need to name *one* stubborn error tolerance $\varepsilon_0>0$ such that every interval around 0, no matter how tiny, contains an input x whose output $f(x)$ stays at least ε_0 away from 5. A single leaky band defeats the Prover forever.

We will put this to work in Section 6.7 to show that $\lim_{x\to 0}\sin(1/x)$ does not exist: there is a fixed band that every strip, however thin, fails to contain because the graph oscillates forever.

6.4 Worked epsilon–delta proofs: linear functions

Time to prove something. The structure of every epsilon-delta proof is the same, and once you see it twice it becomes a template:

1. **Scratch work (find δ).** Start from the goal $|f(x)-L|<\varepsilon$ and work *backwards*, unraveling it into a condition on $|x-a|$. This tells you what δ to pick. This step is exploration; it does not go in the final proof.
2. **The proof (verify δ works).** Announce the δ you found. Then, starting from $0<|x-a|<\delta$, run the algebra *forward* to reach $|f(x)-L|<\varepsilon$.

The scratch work is where the thinking happens; the proof is where you check it. Let me show both

halves out loud the first time, then tighten up.

Example 6.1 (A linear limit)**.** Prove that $\lim_{x\to 2}(3x+1) = 7$.

Scratch work. The output gap is

$$|f(x) - L| = |(3x+1) - 7| = |3x - 6| = 3|x - 2|.$$

There it is: the output distance is exactly 3 times the input distance. We want $3|x-2| < \varepsilon$, i.e. $|x-2| < \varepsilon/3$. So if the Skeptic hands us ε, we should respond $\delta = \varepsilon/3$. (Now we know the answer; the proof below pretends we are seeing it for the first time and just verifies it.)

Proof. Let $\varepsilon > 0$ be given. Choose $\delta = \varepsilon/3$. Suppose $0 < |x-2| < \delta$. Then

$$|(3x+1) - 7| = 3|x-2| < 3\delta = 3 \cdot \frac{\varepsilon}{3} = \varepsilon.$$

Thus $0 < |x-2| < \delta$ implies $|(3x+1)-7| < \varepsilon$. Since $\varepsilon > 0$ was arbitrary, $\lim_{x\to 2}(3x+1) = 7$. ■

Notice how short the actual proof is, and how completely the scratch work did the work. The Skeptic-to-Prover rule here is the function $\delta = \varepsilon/3$: hand it any tolerance and it returns a closeness that provably works.

Why the technique works

Why does $\delta = \varepsilon/3$ work, and why *that* number? Because a line of slope 3 magnifies horizontal distances into vertical ones by exactly the factor 3. If you want the vertical wandering held under ε, you must hold the horizontal wandering under $\varepsilon/3$ – you "pre-divide" by the magnification. For a general line $f(x) = mx + b$ with $m \neq 0$, the same reasoning gives $\delta = \varepsilon/|m|$: the steeper the line, the tighter you must clamp the input. This is your first glimpse of a theme that runs through all of calculus – *the local rate of change controls how output error responds to input error.* The number $|m|$ is, of course, the derivative of the line. We are already computing with derivatives; we just have not named them yet.

Work it yourself

Carry out the whole template yourself for $\lim_{x\to -1}(5 - 2x) = 7$. (Scratch: $|(5-2x) - 7| = |-2x - 2| = 2|x+1|$, so take $\delta = \varepsilon/2$.) Then do $\lim_{x\to 3}(7) = 7$ for the constant function and watch something curious happen: the output gap is $|7 - 7| = 0 < \varepsilon$ *automatically*, so *any* δ works – say $\delta = 1$. The Prover never even has to look at ε. A constant function is the one case where the Prover can answer before the Skeptic finishes speaking.

6.5 Worked epsilon–delta proofs: a quadratic

Lines are easy because the output gap factors cleanly as a constant times the input gap. For a curve, the magnification is not constant – it depends on where you are – and that forces one new idea: *control the wild factor first.*

Example 6.2 (A quadratic limit)**.** Prove that $\lim_{x\to 3} x^2 = 9$.

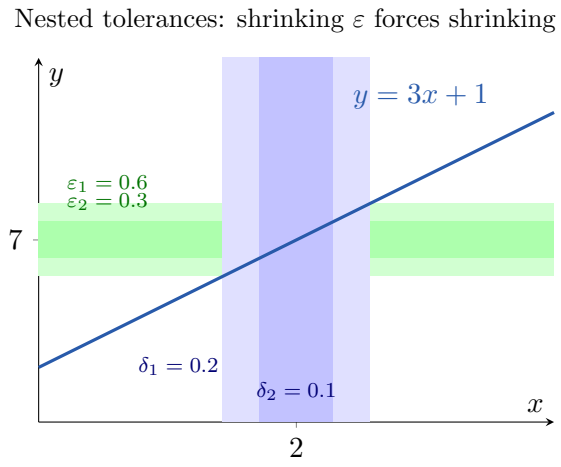


Figure 6.3: For the line $3x + 1$ at $a = 2$: shrink the green band (smaller ε) and the matching blue strip shrinks in lockstep, by the factor $\delta = \varepsilon/3$. The nested bands and strips make the rule $\varepsilon \mapsto \varepsilon/3$ visible.

Scratch work. The output gap is

$$|x^2 - 9| = |(x - 3)(x + 3)| = |x - 3|\,|x + 3|.$$

One factor, $|x - 3|$, is the input gap – the piece we control directly through δ. The other factor, $|x + 3|$, varies with x: near $x = 3$ it sits close to 6, so we first need to put a hard ceiling on it. A simple two-step clamp handles this cleanly.

Step one: bound the variable factor with a preliminary clamp. Decide in advance that δ will be *at most* 1. If $|x - 3| < 1$, then $2 < x < 4$, so

$$5 < x + 3 < 7, \quad \text{hence} \quad |x + 3| < 7.$$

As long as we keep x within 1 of 3, the factor $|x + 3|$ cannot exceed 7. (Any valid upper bound works; 7 is convenient.)

Step two: use the bound to size δ. Now, whenever $|x - 3| < 1$,

$$|x^2 - 9| = |x - 3|\,|x + 3| < 7\,|x - 3|.$$

To force this under ε it suffices to have $|x - 3| < \varepsilon/7$. We need *both* clamps at once – $|x - 3| < 1$ to validate the bound, and $|x - 3| < \varepsilon/7$ to land in the band – so we take the smaller of the two:

$$\delta = \min\left(1,\ \frac{\varepsilon}{7}\right).$$

Proof. Let $\varepsilon > 0$ be given. Choose $\delta = \min(1, \varepsilon/7)$. Suppose $0 < |x - 3| < \delta$. Since $\delta \le 1$, we have $|x - 3| < 1$, so $2 < x < 4$ and therefore $|x + 3| < 7$. Since also $\delta \le \varepsilon/7$, we have $|x - 3| < \varepsilon/7$. Combining,

$$|x^2 - 9| = |x - 3|\,|x + 3| < \frac{\varepsilon}{7} \cdot 7 = \varepsilon.$$

Hence $\lim_{x \to 3} x^2 = 9$. ■

Intuition

Taking a min is simply how we satisfy two upper bounds on δ at once. One part of the requirement ("keep the slope factor bounded") sets a ceiling on δ; the other part ("land inside the ε band") sets another. To satisfy both promises simultaneously you take the tighter one. Whenever you see $\delta = \min(\dots, \dots)$ in an epsilon-delta proof, read it as "I made two promises and I am keeping both." Figure 6.4 illustrates how the two promises divide the work.

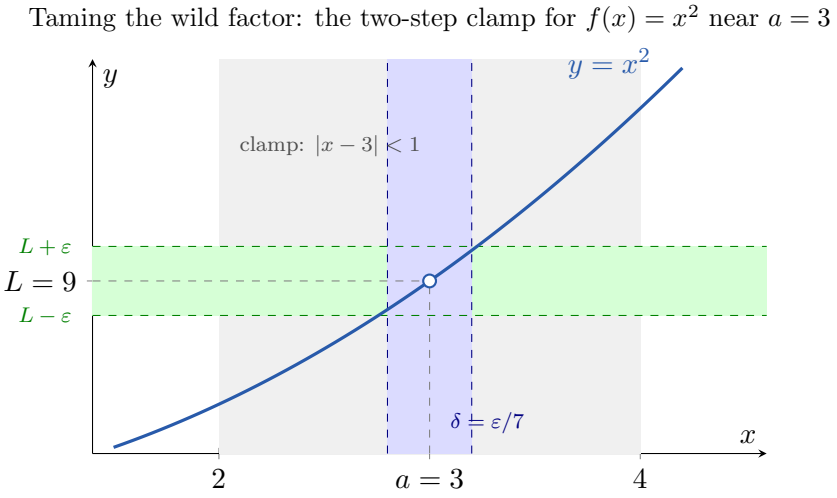


Figure 6.4: The two-step clamp for $f(x) = x^2$ near $a = 3$. Step 1 sets a preliminary ceiling $\delta \leq 1$, confining x to the wide gray region $(2, 4)$ where the slope factor $|x + 3|$ can never exceed 7. Step 2 uses this ceiling to size the input strip $\delta = \varepsilon/7$ (the narrow blue strip). Inside this strip, the curve $y = x^2$ stays trapped between $L - \varepsilon$ and $L + \varepsilon$ (the green band).

Why the technique works

Why does x^2 need a min when a straight line did not? Along a line, the slope is constant, so one ratio $\delta = \varepsilon/|m|$ works everywhere. Along x^2, the steepness changes from point to point. So we first fence x into a window where the varying factor $|x + 3|$ has a fixed ceiling, and then shrink δ inside that window to hit the ε-band. The guiding idea is simple: *a tiny factor times a bounded factor is still tiny.* That single observation drives both this proof and the product limit law ahead.

Common trap

Do not forget to bound the variable factor. A common wrong "proof" of $\lim_{x \to 3} x^2 = 9$ writes $|x^2 - 9| = |x - 3||x + 3|$ and then sets $\delta = \varepsilon/|x + 3|$. But δ is not allowed to depend on x – x is the variable we are quantifying over, not a fixed number you may plug into your choice of δ. The Prover must commit to a single δ depending only on ε (and on the fixed data a), *before* any particular x is examined. The preliminary clamp $|x - 3| < 1$ exists precisely so that we can replace the forbidden, x-dependent $|x + 3|$ by the fixed constant 7.

Work it yourself

Prove $\lim_{x\to 2} x^2 = 4$ on your own. Clamp $|x-2|<1$ so that $1<x<3$ and $|x+2|<5$, then take $\delta = \min(1, \varepsilon/5)$. Compare with the $x=3$ case: the amplifier ceiling changed from 7 to 5 because you are sitting at a less steep part of the parabola. The δ you are allowed to use literally tracks the steepness of the curve at the point – another preview of the derivative.

Pause

Pause and think. What would happen if we used a preliminary clamp of $\delta \le 10$ instead of $\delta \le 1$ when proving $\lim_{x\to 3} x^2 = 9$? If $|x-3|<10$, then $-7<x<13$, so $|x+3|<16$. The proof still goes through: we simply choose $\delta = \min(10, \varepsilon/16)$. The initial clamp of 1 is an arbitrary convenient choice—any positive radius that bounds the variable factor away from infinity serves the same purpose.

Let us record the general lesson as a small lemma, because it is the engine of all the later laws.

Lemma 6.1 (Small times bounded is small)**.** *Suppose that on some punctured interval around a we can write $f(x) - L = g(x)\,h(x)$, where $|g(x)| \le M$ for some constant $M > 0$ on that interval, and $\lim_{x\to a} h(x) = 0$. Then $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$.*

Proof. Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Since $\lim_{x\to a} h(x) = 0$, there is $\delta_1 > 0$ with $0 < |x-a| < \delta_1 \Rightarrow |h(x)| < \varepsilon/M$. Let $\delta_2 > 0$ be a radius small enough that the bound $|g(x)| \le M$ holds for $0 < |x-a| < \delta_2$. Put $\delta = \min(\delta_1, \delta_2)$. Then for $0 < |x-a| < \delta$,

$$|f(x) - L| = |g(x)|\,|h(x)| < M \cdot \frac{\varepsilon}{M} = \varepsilon. \qquad \square$$

The quadratic proof was exactly this lemma with $g(x) = x+3$ (bounded by $M = 7$ near 3) and $h(x) = x-3$ (heading to 0). Hold this pattern; it returns.

6.6 The limit laws, and why they are theorems

In practice nobody computes $\lim_{x\to 3}(x^2+5x)$ from scratch with epsilon and delta. Instead they say: the limit of a sum is the sum of the limits, the limit of a product is the product of the limits, and so on – so the answer is $9 + 15 = 24$. These *limit laws* are what make limits usable. But they are not axioms. Each one is a *theorem* that must be *earned* from Definition 6.1. The intuition (errors add, small times bounded is small) tells you the laws should be true; the epsilon-delta machine is what *makes* them true. Let us prove the two central ones and see the intuition become rigor.

Assume throughout that $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ and $\lim_{x\to a} g(x) = M$.

Theorem 6.1 (Sum law)**.** $\lim_{x\to a} \big(f(x) + g(x)\big) = L + M$.

Intuition

The idea before the proof. The total error of the sum, $|(f+g) - (L+M)|$, is at most the error of f plus the error of g (by the triangle inequality, which states that the direct distance

$|p+q|$ is never greater than the detour $|p|+|q|$). If you want the *combined* error under ε, just demand each piece be under $\varepsilon/2$. Halve the tolerance, hand half to each function, collect their separate δ's, and use the tighter one. "Split the budget" is the entire strategy.

Proof. Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Apply the hypotheses with the tolerance $\varepsilon/2$:

- Since $\lim_{x\to a} f = L$, there is $\delta_1 > 0$ with $0 < |x-a| < \delta_1 \Rightarrow |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon/2$.
- Since $\lim_{x\to a} g = M$, there is $\delta_2 > 0$ with $0 < |x-a| < \delta_2 \Rightarrow |g(x) - M| < \varepsilon/2$.

Let $\delta = \min(\delta_1, \delta_2)$. For $0 < |x-a| < \delta$ *both* bounds hold at once, so by the triangle inequality

$$|\big(f(x)+g(x)\big) - (L+M)| = |\big(f(x)-L\big) + \big(g(x)-M\big)| \le |f(x)-L| + |g(x)-M| < \frac{\varepsilon}{2} + \frac{\varepsilon}{2} = \varepsilon.$$

Therefore $\lim_{x\to a}(f+g) = L+M$. □

Common trap

Why $\varepsilon/2$ and not ε? If you only forced each piece under ε, the triangle inequality would give you $|(f+g)-(L+M)| < \varepsilon+\varepsilon = 2\varepsilon$ – twice the target, a miss. Splitting the budget in half is what makes the two halves *add up* to exactly ε. The choice $\varepsilon/2$ is reverse-engineered from the triangle inequality's "+". This budget-splitting is one of the most reused tactics in all of analysis; it will reappear as "$\varepsilon/3$ tricks" and "ε/n tricks" whenever finitely many errors must be controlled together.

Theorem 6.2 (Product law)**.** $\lim\limits_{x\to a} \big(f(x)\, g(x)\big) = L\, M.$

Intuition

Products are subtler than sums because the errors interact. Write $f = L+u$ and $g = M+v$, where $u = f-L$ and $v = g-M$ are the (small) errors. Then

$$fg = (L+u)(M+v) = LM + Lv + Mu + uv,$$

so the product's error is

$$fg - LM = \underbrace{Lv}_{\text{const}\times\text{small}} + \underbrace{Mu}_{\text{const}\times\text{small}} + \underbrace{uv}_{\text{small}\times\text{small}}.$$

Every one of the three pieces is small: the first two are a fixed constant times something heading to 0, and the third is even smaller, a product of two vanishing errors. Make each of the three under $\varepsilon/3$ and add. That is the proof; the rest is bookkeeping to turn "small" into actual inequalities.

Proof. Let $\varepsilon > 0$. We control the three pieces $|Lv|,\ |Mu|,\ |uv|$, where $u = f(x)-L$ and $v = g(x)-M$, aiming each below $\varepsilon/3$.

The cross term $|uv|$. Pick $\delta_1, \delta_2 > 0$ so that $|u| = |f(x)-L| < \sqrt{\varepsilon/3}$ for $0 < |x-a| < \delta_1$ and $|v| = |g(x)-M| < \sqrt{\varepsilon/3}$ for $0 < |x-a| < \delta_2$. Then $|uv| < \varepsilon/3$.

The term $|Mu|$. Pick $\delta_3 > 0$ so that $|u| < \dfrac{\varepsilon}{3(|M|+1)}$ for $0 < |x-a| < \delta_3$. Then $|Mu| \le |M|\,|u| \le \dfrac{|M|}{|M|+1} \cdot \dfrac{\varepsilon}{3} < \dfrac{\varepsilon}{3}$. (We divide by $|M|+1$ rather than $|M|$ so the bound is safe even when $M = 0$.)

The term $|Lv|$. Symmetrically, pick $\delta_4 > 0$ so that $|v| < \dfrac{\varepsilon}{3(|L|+1)}$ for $0 < |x-a| < \delta_4$, giving $|Lv| < \varepsilon/3$.

Now set $\delta = \min(\delta_1, \delta_2, \delta_3, \delta_4)$. For $0 < |x-a| < \delta$ all four conditions hold simultaneously, so by the triangle inequality

$$|f(x)g(x) - LM| = |Lv + Mu + uv| \le |Lv| + |Mu| + |uv| < \frac{\varepsilon}{3} + \frac{\varepsilon}{3} + \frac{\varepsilon}{3} = \varepsilon.$$

Hence $\lim_{x\to a}(fg) = LM$. □

Remark 6.1. The proof above is the direct, self-contained one, and it shows clearly where each term goes. A slicker route uses Lemma 6.1: since f has a limit it is bounded near a, and $fg - LM = f\,(g-M) + M\,(f-L)$ is then "bounded times small plus constant times small," each piece $\to 0$. Both proofs are really the same observation – *small errors, multiplied by quantities that stay bounded, stay small* – which is why we isolated that lemma earlier.

Why this matters

Look at how little went into proving both the sum law and the product law: the triangle inequality ($|p+q| \le |p| + |q|$), and the fact that a shrinking quantity times a bounded quantity still shrinks to zero. All of limit arithmetic grows out of those two plain facts about distance on the number line.

For completeness, here are the remaining standard laws. The constant-multiple and difference laws are immediate from the two above (take g constant, or replace g by $-g$). The quotient law needs one extra idea – keeping the denominator away from zero – which we state and sketch.

Theorem 6.3 (The limit laws)**.** *If $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ and $\lim_{x\to a} g(x) = M$, then:*

1. *(Constant multiple)* $\lim\limits_{x\to a} c\,f(x) = cL$ *for any constant c.*
2. *(Sum/difference)* $\lim\limits_{x\to a} \big(f(x) \pm g(x)\big) = L \pm M$.
3. *(Product)* $\lim\limits_{x\to a} f(x)g(x) = LM$.
4. *(Quotient)* $\lim\limits_{x\to a} \dfrac{f(x)}{g(x)} = \dfrac{L}{M}$, *provided $M \neq 0$.*

Sketch of the quotient law. It is enough, given the product law, to handle $\lim_{x\to a} \frac{1}{g(x)} = \frac{1}{M}$ when $M \neq 0$; then $\frac{f}{g} = f \cdot \frac{1}{g}$ follows. Compute the error:

$$\left|\frac{1}{g(x)} - \frac{1}{M}\right| = \frac{|M - g(x)|}{|g(x)|\,|M|}.$$

The numerator $|M - g(x)| \to 0$ – that is small. The danger is the $|g(x)|$ in the denominator: if it could be near 0, the fraction could blow up. So we first secure the denominator. Since $M \neq 0$,

apply the limit of g with tolerance $|M|/2$: there is a radius within which $|g(x) - M| < |M|/2$, which implies $|g(x)| \geq |M| - |g(x) - M| > |M|/2 > 0$ by the reverse triangle inequality. On that region the fraction is at most $\frac{2}{|M|^2}\,|M - g(x)|$ – once again "small times bounded" – and shrinking the radius further forces it under any ε. The structure is identical to the quadratic proof: clamp first to control the dangerous factor, then shrink to hit the band. □

Connection

The limit laws say the map "$f \mapsto \lim_{x\to a} f$" respects addition and multiplication: it sends sums to sums and products to products. In the language of later mathematics, taking the limit at a is a *homomorphism* – a structure-preserving dictionary that carries operations in one algebraic system into matching operations in another – from the algebra of functions having a limit at a into $\mathbb{R}$. The same structural fact – "the operation is linear and multiplicative" – recurs for the derivative (linear, with a product rule) and the integral (linear). Spotting which operations preserve which structures is one of the organizing instincts of all higher mathematics, and limits are where it starts.

6.7 When the game cannot be won: limits that do not exist

The definition's real power is that it can also certify *failure*. To show a limit does *not* exist, we play the Skeptic: we exhibit one tolerance ε that defeats every possible δ.

Example 6.3 (A jump)**.** The Heaviside step $H(x)$ – a simple switch function defined by $H(x) = 0$ for $x < 0$ and $H(x) = 1$ for $x \geq 0$ – has no limit at 0.

Argument. Suppose, for contradiction, some L were the limit. Take the Skeptic's tolerance $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{2}$. For *any* $\delta > 0$, the punctured interval $(-\delta, \delta) \setminus \{0\}$ contains both negative points (where $H = 0$) and positive points (where $H = 1$). For the promise to hold we would need both $|0 - L| < \frac{1}{2}$ and $|1 - L| < \frac{1}{2}$, i.e. L within $\frac{1}{2}$ of *both* 0 and 1. But 0 and 1 are a distance 1 apart, and no single point is within $\frac{1}{2}$ of both. So $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{2}$ defeats every δ; the limit cannot exist. ■

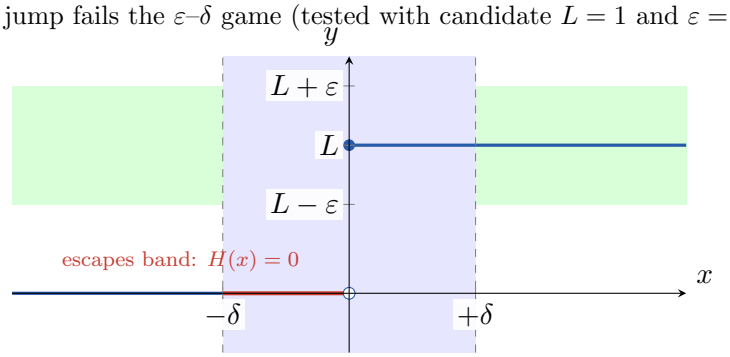


Figure 6.5: Negation of the limit at a jump. Testing candidate $L = 1$ with $\varepsilon = 0.4$ creates a horizontal band $[0.6, 1.4]$. Any proposed vertical strip $(-\delta, \delta)$ inevitably contains negative inputs (red segment) where $H(x) = 0$, lying entirely outside the band. No δ can ever succeed.

Example 6.4 (Infinite oscillation)**.** $\lim_{x\to 0} \sin\dfrac{1}{x}$ does not exist.

As $x \to 0$, the input $1/x$ races off to infinity, so $\sin(1/x)$ runs through its full range $[-1, 1]$ infinitely often – it never settles. No matter how thin a strip $(-\delta, \delta)$ the Prover proposes, that strip still contains inputs where $\sin(1/x) = 1$ and inputs where $\sin(1/x) = -1$ (because $1/x$ sweeps through infinitely many periods). With the Skeptic's tolerance $\varepsilon = 1$, no candidate L can be within 1 of both $+1$ and -1 at once. Every δ leaks; the limit fails to exist. Figure 6.6 shows the graph refusing to settle.

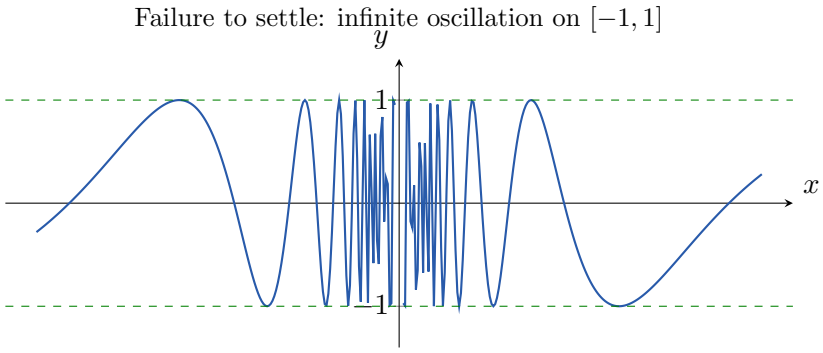


Figure 6.6: $y = \sin(1/x)$ near 0. The oscillations bunch up infinitely as $x \to 0$, forever sweeping the whole band from -1 to 1. No vertical strip around 0, however thin, can trap the graph inside any band thinner than the full height 2, so no limit exists. (Pixels cannot draw the infinitely many wiggles closest to 0; imagine them packed ever tighter.)

Connection

The jump in H fails because the two sides disagree: the left approach heads to 0, the right to 1. Recall the *one-sided limits* we met in Chapter 5 – approaching strictly from the left ($x \to a^-$) or strictly from the right ($x \to a^+$). In the ε–δ language, a one-sided limit simply replaces the symmetric strip $0 < |x - a| < \delta$ by a half-strip: $-\delta < x - a < 0$ on the left, or $0 < x - a < \delta$ on the right. A two-sided limit exists exactly when both half-strips settle on the same L – as we will put to work in Chapters 7 and 8.

6.8 Making the intuition and the formalism agree

We end where the chapter began: with the relationship between the picture and the sentence. They had better agree – a definition that contradicted the clear cases would be a bad definition, not a brave one. Check the handshake from both sides.

Formalism honors intuition. Every limit you would compute "by inspection" – $\lim_{x\to 2}(3x+1) = 7$, $\lim_{x\to 3} x^2 = 9$, $\lim_{x\to a} c = c$ – comes out the expected way under Definition 6.1, as we proved or sketched. The definition does not overturn your instincts for the easy cases; it ratifies them. What it adds is a referee for the *hard* cases, where instinct stalls: removable holes like $\frac{x^2-1}{x-1}$, jumps like H, oscillations like $\sin(1/x)$. There the picture alone gives no confident answer, and the definition decides.

Intuition tames the formalism. Conversely, you should never run the epsilon-delta machine blind. Before writing a single δ, look at the picture and *predict* the answer; the formal proof is then a verification, not a search in the dark. And the scratch-work phase – working backward from

$|f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$ to find δ – is just the picture turned into algebra: "how tight a strip keeps the graph in this band?" The two are one activity in two notations.

What is really happening

Here is the cleanest way to hold the whole chapter in one thought. The intuitive limit and the epsilon-delta limit are not two different limits that happen to agree; they are the *same* statement told at two resolutions. "$f(x)$ approaches L" is the statement at human resolution – fast, visual, occasionally wrong at the edges. "$\forall\varepsilon\,\exists\delta\ldots$" is the identical statement at full resolution – slow, symbolic, never wrong. You learn both because you think in the first and prove in the second, and a working mathematician fluidly translates between them mid-sentence. When that translation becomes automatic, the epsilon-delta definition stops being an obstacle and becomes what it truly is: the exact written form of something you already see.

Walking question

A question to turn over on a walk. We insisted the order of quantifiers is "$\forall\varepsilon\,\exists\delta$." Imagine a stricter notion in which a single δ must work for *all* ε simultaneously: $\exists\delta\,\forall\varepsilon$. Which functions, if any, satisfy *that*? (Hint: it would force $|f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$ for every $\varepsilon > 0$ on a fixed punctured interval, hence $f(x) = L$ there.) You will discover that the strict version describes only locally-constant functions – which is exactly why the ordinary definition uses the looser, correct order. The grammar is doing real work.

6.8.1 From verification to calculation: looking ahead

The epsilon–delta definition is an instrument of verification, not calculation: it checks whether a suspected limit L is correct, but it does not tell you how to find L. Having proved the limit laws, we can now compute limits without building custom ε–δ proofs for each one. In Chapter 7, we turn to algebraic techniques—factoring, conjugates, and the squeeze theorem—for evaluating limits directly.

6.9 Exercises

Exercise 6.1 (Mental checks: reading the quantifiers)**.** Answer these three checks without writing an algebraic proof:

1. If a function satisfies $|f(x) - 3| < 0.05$ whenever $0 < |x - 1| < 0.01$, did the Prover just successfully answer a challenge for $\varepsilon = 0.05$ or $\varepsilon = 0.01$?
2. In an epsilon–delta argument, why is the choice $\delta = \varepsilon/|x - a|$ strictly illegal?
3. If $f(2) = 500$ but $\lim_{x\to 2} f(x) = 7$, does the value 500 prevent the Prover from finding a winning δ for $\varepsilon = 0.1$? Explain in one sentence.

Exercise 6.2 (Linear, by the template)**.** Using the two-step template (scratch work, then proof), prove from Definition 6.1 that $\lim_{x\to 4}(2x - 3) = 5$. Identify the rule $\varepsilon \mapsto \delta$ explicitly and relate the constant in it to the slope of the line.

Exercise 6.3 (Negative slope)**.** Prove that $\lim_{x\to 1}(8-5x)=3$. Be careful that a negative slope does not change the size of the magnification: explain why $\delta=\varepsilon/5$ (not $\varepsilon/(-5)$) is the right response, and where the absolute value enters.

Exercise 6.4 (Quadratic with a clamp)**.** Prove that $\lim_{x\to 4} x^2 = 16$. State your preliminary clamp, derive the resulting ceiling on $|x+4|$, and write $\delta=\min(1,\varepsilon/9)$ (or justify a different constant if you clamp differently).

Exercise 6.5 (A reciprocal)**.** Prove that $\lim_{x\to 2}\dfrac{1}{x}=\dfrac{1}{2}$ directly from the definition. (Compute $|\frac{1}{x}-\frac{1}{2}|=\frac{|x-2|}{2|x|}$, clamp $|x-2|<1$ so that $1<x<3$ and hence $|x|>1$, then choose $\delta=\min(1,2\varepsilon)$.) Point out exactly where you used the clamp to keep the denominator away from 0.

Exercise 6.6 (Negating the definition)**.** Write out, with quantifiers in the correct order, the precise statement "$\lim_{x\to a} f(x)\neq L$." Then use it to prove that $\lim_{x\to 0}\dfrac{|x|}{x}$ does not exist. (Take $\varepsilon=1$ and show every δ contains points where the function is $+1$ and points where it is -1.)

Exercise 6.7 (The $\varepsilon/2$ budget, examined)**.** In the proof of the sum law we chose tolerance $\varepsilon/2$ for each function. **(a)** Redo the final inequality using $\varepsilon/3$ for each piece and confirm it still works (you land at $2\varepsilon/3<\varepsilon$). **(b)** Show that using ε for each piece *fails* to prove the claim, and pinpoint the exact step where the argument breaks. **(c)** Conclude that any split summing to at most ε works, and that $\varepsilon/2$ is simply the tidiest.

Exercise 6.8 (Constant multiple law)**.** Prove from the definition that $\lim_{x\to a} c\,f(x)=cL$ whenever $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)=L$. Treat $c=0$ separately and explain why that case needs no hypothesis on f at all.

Exercise 6.9 (Small times bounded, applied)**.** Use Lemma 6.1 to prove $\lim_{x\to 0} x\sin\dfrac{1}{x}=0$ even though $\sin\frac{1}{x}$ has no limit at 0. Identify g and h in the lemma, and the bound M. (This is a striking case: a wildly oscillating factor, multiplied by something heading to 0, is tamed completely.)

Exercise 6.10 (A removable hole)**.** Let $f(x)=\dfrac{x^2-4}{x-2}$ for $x\neq 2$ and $f(2)=100$. Prove that $\lim_{x\to 2} f(x)=4$ directly from the definition, and explain in one sentence why the absurd value $f(2)=100$ is invisible to the limit. Which inequality in Definition 6.1 is responsible for that invisibility?

Exercise 6.11 (Conceptual: order of quantifiers, proof)**.** Prove that if a single $\delta>0$ satisfied the condition "$0<|x-a|<\delta\Rightarrow|f(x)-L|<\varepsilon$" for *every* $\varepsilon>0$ at once, then $f(x)=L$ for all x in the punctured interval $0<|x-a|<\delta$. Conclude that the order $\forall\varepsilon\,\exists\delta$ in the definition is essential and cannot be reversed without trivializing it.

Exercise 6.12 (Proof: uniqueness of the limit)**.** Prove that a limit, if it exists, is unique: if $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)=L$ and $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)=L'$, then $L=L'$. (Suppose $L\neq L'$ and let $\varepsilon=|L-L'|/2>0$. Use the definition for each limit to trap $f(x)$ within ε of both L and L' simultaneously on a small punctured interval, and derive a contradiction from the triangle inequality.) This is the theorem that licenses the phrase "*the* limit."

Chapter 7

Computing Limits

In the last two chapters you learned what a limit *is*. You met the sharp-edged definition — for every challenge ε there is a response δ — and you saw that this machinery exists to pin down a single idea: *the value a function approaches as the input approaches a point, regardless of what happens at the point itself.* That was the foundation. It was also slow. Nobody wants to run an epsilon-delta argument every time they need a limit, any more than you want to prove the distributive law every time you multiply two numbers.

This chapter is about *fluency*. We will build a small toolbox — substitution, factoring, rationalizing, the squeeze theorem, one-sided limits, absolute values — that lets you compute almost any limit you will meet, quickly and correctly. But this is not a bag of tricks to memorize. Every tool here is *licensed* by something we already proved: the limit laws. Each technique is just a clever, legal rearrangement that turns a hard-looking limit into one you can read off by inspection. The whole art is this:

Focus

Computing a limit means **transforming the expression — using only moves the limit laws permit — until you reach a form where the answer is obvious.** The skill is not in the final step. It is in seeing which legal move clears the obstacle.

We start by recalling the laws, because everything else stands on them.

7.1 The Limit Laws: Our License to Compute

Suppose $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ and $\lim_{x\to a} g(x) = M$, where L and M are finite real numbers. In the epsilon-delta chapter we proved the following facts, which drive everything that follows.

Theorem 7.1 (Limit Laws)**.** *With the hypotheses above, and c a constant:*

1. ***(Constant)*** $\lim_{x\to a} c = c$.
2. ***(Identity)*** $\lim_{x\to a} x = a$.
3. ***(Sum/Difference)*** $\lim_{x\to a} \big(f(x) \pm g(x)\big) = L \pm M$.

4. ***(Constant multiple)*** $\lim_{x\to a} c\,f(x) = c\,L$.
5. ***(Product)*** $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)\,g(x) = L\,M$.
6. ***(Quotient)*** $\lim_{x\to a} \dfrac{f(x)}{g(x)} = \dfrac{L}{M}$, provided $M \neq 0$.
7. ***(Power)*** $\lim_{x\to a} \big(f(x)\big)^n = L^n$ *for any positive integer* n, *and* $\lim_{x\to a} \sqrt[n]{f(x)} = \sqrt[n]{L}$ *when the root is defined.*

Read these slowly. They say something striking: *the limit of a combination is the combination of the limits.* Addition, multiplication, division — the limit passes straight through them. This is exactly why calculus is computable at all. If limits did not respect arithmetic, every single problem would be a fresh epsilon-delta battle.

Why the technique works

Why are we allowed to "pass the limit inside"? The intuition is short. If $f(x)$ is squeezing in on L and $g(x)$ is squeezing in on M, then their sum $f(x)+g(x)$ has no choice but to squeeze in on $L+M$: push f within half your tolerance of L and g within half your tolerance of M, and the sum lands within your full tolerance of $L+M$. That "split the tolerance in two" move is the whole proof of the sum law, and the product and quotient laws are the same spirit with a little more bookkeeping. The laws are not axioms we hope are true; they are theorems we earned with ε and δ. Having earned them, we may now use them freely and never look back.

There is one boundary on this freedom, and it is the single most important caveat in the chapter. **The quotient law requires $M \neq 0$.** The moment a denominator's limit is zero, the law goes silent — it tells you nothing. That silence is exactly where all the interesting work of this chapter lives. Most of our techniques are tricks for handling a $0/0$ that the quotient law refuses to touch.

Common trap

A limit law that does not apply is not a law that gives the answer 0, or ∞, or "undefined." It simply *does not apply.* When you hit $\frac{0}{0}$ you have not found an answer — you have found a question. The expression is called an *indeterminate form* — a symbolic shape where two competing quantities vanish together, leaving the limit laws unable to determine the final balance without algebraic rewriting. You must transform it first.

7.2 Direct Substitution: The First Thing to Try

Here is the happiest fact in limit computation. For the functions you build out of the everyday pieces — polynomials, roots, sines, cosines, exponentials, logs, and any sums, products, quotients, and compositions of these — the limit as $x \to a$ is just the value at a, *whenever that value makes sense.* You plug in. You are done.

Theorem 7.2 (Substitution for continuous functions)**.** *If f is continuous at a, then*

$$\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a).$$

Every polynomial is continuous everywhere. Rational functions, roots, exp, log, sin, cos, *and their compositions are continuous everywhere they are defined.*

We will give continuity its own careful chapter. For now take the working definition: *f is continuous at a when the limit there equals the value there*, with no gap, no jump, and no hole. The theorem then looks almost circular — "the limit is the value when the limit is the value" — but the content is in the second sentence: *the standard building blocks really are continuous*, and that fact is itself a consequence of the limit laws.

Why the technique works

Why does substitution work for a polynomial? Watch the laws assemble it. Take $p(x) = 3x^2 - 5x + 1$ and $a = 2$. By the identity law $\lim x = 2$. By the power law $\lim x^2 = 2^2 = 4$. By the constant-multiple law $\lim 3x^2 = 12$ and $\lim 5x = 10$. By the sum/difference law the whole thing is $12 - 10 + 1 = 3$, which is exactly $p(2)$. Nothing here was a leap of faith — each step cited a law from Theorem 7.1. Substitution is not a shortcut that bypasses the laws; it is the laws, applied so routinely we stopped narrating them.

Example 7.1 (Substitution, straight ahead)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 3} \frac{x^2 + 1}{x - 1} = \frac{3^2 + 1}{3 - 1} = \frac{10}{2} = 5.$$

The denominator's limit is $2 \neq 0$, so the quotient law applies and we simply evaluate.

Example 7.2 (Substitution through a composition)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 0} \cos\big(e^x - 1\big) = \cos\big(e^0 - 1\big) = \cos(0) = 1.$$

The inside $e^x - 1 \to 0$, and cos is continuous at 0, so we evaluate through the composition.

Common trap

Substitution is the *first* thing to try, not the only thing. If plugging in gives a genuine number, you are finished. If it gives $\frac{0}{0}$, $\frac{\text{nonzero}}{0}$, $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, or any other nonsense, **stop** — you have learned that the function is not continuous at a (or not even defined there), and you must reach for a different tool. Substitution failing is a diagnostic clue.

Pause

Mental check: Before setting pencil to paper, always test direct substitution in your head. What happens if you plug $x = 4$ into

$$\frac{x - 4}{\sqrt{x} - 2} \qquad \text{versus} \qquad \frac{x + 4}{\sqrt{x} - 2}?$$

In the first expression, both numerator and denominator vanish to 0 ($\frac{0}{0}$): a shared factor is waiting to cancel, and a finite limit is hiding inside. In the second, the numerator is 8 while the denominator is 0 ($\frac{8}{0}$): the top stays nonzero while the bottom shrinks to zero, signaling an unyielding vertical blow-up toward $\pm\infty$. A single second of mental substitution routes you to the right technique immediately.

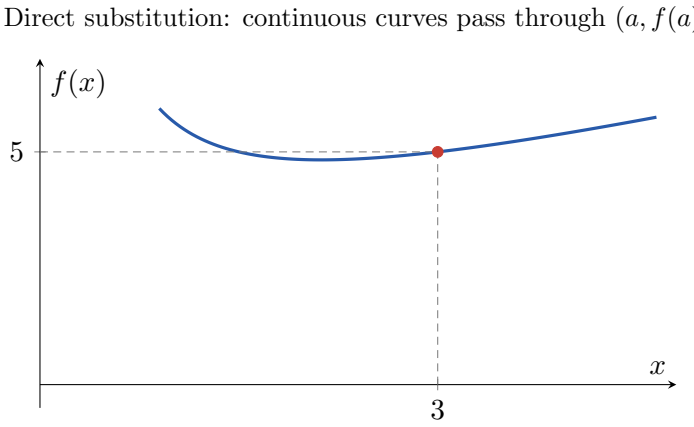


Figure 7.1: For $\dfrac{x^2+1}{x-1}$ near $x = 3$ the curve is smooth and unbroken. The limit is simply the height of the curve there: 5. This is the easy case — substitution and nothing more.

7.3 When Substitution Fails: The 0/0 Form

The interesting limits — the ones calculus actually needs — almost always arrive as $\frac{0}{0}$, for a structural reason. The derivative itself, which we are marching toward, is

$$\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h},$$

and as $h \to 0$ the top goes to $f(x) - f(x) = 0$ while the bottom goes to 0. *Every derivative is a* 0/0 *limit.* So learning to handle 0/0 is not a sideshow; it is the central engine of differential calculus, rehearsed here on simpler functions.

What is really happening

What is really happening in a $\frac{0}{0}$ limit? Both the numerator and the denominator are shrinking to zero, and the limit measures *how fast each shrinks compared to the other.* If the top heads to zero twice as fast as the bottom, the ratio approaches 2. If they vanish at exactly the same rate, you get a nonzero number; if the top wins, you get 0; if the bottom wins, you get a blow-up. The symbol $\frac{0}{0}$ hides all of this — it is "indeterminate" precisely because the bare zeros throw away the rate information. Our algebraic methods are ways to *recover the hidden rate* by canceling the common factor that is causing both to vanish.

The key structural fact is this. When a rational expression gives $\frac{0}{0}$ at $x = a$, it is because $(x - a)$ is a factor of *both* the numerator and the denominator. That shared factor is the culprit: it is what drives both to zero. Cancel it, and the limit becomes visible.

Why the technique works

Why is canceling a factor legitimate when the factor is zero in the limit? Here is the subtle, beautiful point. The functions

$$\frac{x^2-9}{x-3} \qquad \text{and} \qquad x+3$$

are *not the same function*: the first is undefined at $x = 3$, the second is perfectly happy there. But a limit as $x \to 3$ **never looks at** $x = 3$ **itself** — only at the values *near* it. For every $x \neq 3$ the two expressions are identical, because dividing $x^2 - 9 = (x-3)(x+3)$ by $(x-3)$ is legal whenever $x - 3 \neq 0$. Since the limit ignores the single point $x = 3$, the two functions have the same limit there. The cancellation is licensed not by the quotient law (which is silent) but by the very *definition* of a limit: limits care about the neighborhood, not the point. This is the deepest "why" in the chapter, so reread it until it feels obvious.

Canceling the zero-factor: exposing the continuous line

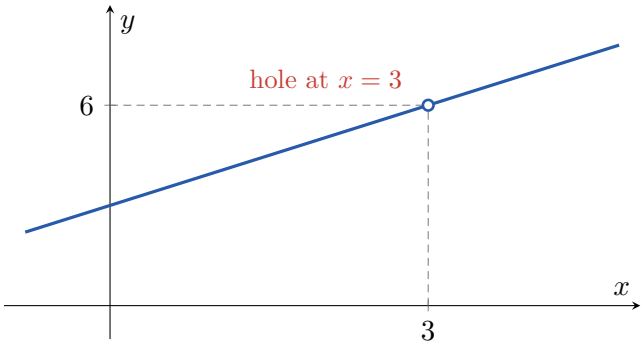


Figure 7.2: The graph of $\dfrac{x^2-9}{x-3}$ is the straight line $y = x + 3$ with a single *puncture* at $x = 3$. The function is undefined there, but the limit reads the height the line is heading for: 6. The missing point is invisible to the limit.

7.3.1 Technique 1: Factor and Cancel

The recipe writes itself: when substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$ in a rational expression, factor top and bottom, cancel the common $(x - a)$, then substitute into what remains.

Example 7.3 (The canonical cancellation)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 3} \frac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3}.$$

Substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$. Factor the numerator:

$$\frac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3} = \frac{(x-3)(x+3)}{x-3} = x + 3 \quad \text{for } x \neq 3.$$

Now substitution into $x + 3$ is legal: $\lim_{x \to 3}(x + 3) = 6$.

Example 7.4 (Factoring a quadratic over a quadratic)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 2} \frac{x^2 - x - 2}{x^2 - 4}.$$

At $x = 2$, numerator and denominator both vanish, so $(x - 2)$ divides each of them. Factor:

$$\frac{x^2 - x - 2}{x^2 - 4} = \frac{(x-2)(x+1)}{(x-2)(x+2)} = \frac{x+1}{x+2} \quad (x \neq 2).$$

Substitute: $\lim_{x\to 2} \dfrac{x+1}{x+2} = \dfrac{3}{4}$.

Example 7.5 (A cube; remember the factoring patterns)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 1} \frac{x^3-1}{x-1}.$$

Use $x^3 - 1 = (x-1)(x^2+x+1)$:

$$\frac{x^3-1}{x-1} = x^2+x+1 \quad (x \neq 1), \qquad \lim_{x\to 1}(x^2+x+1) = 3.$$

Work it yourself

Try this one before reading on:

$$\lim_{x\to -2} \frac{x^2+5x+6}{x+2}.$$

Substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$, so factor: $x^2+5x+6 = (x+2)(x+3)$. Cancel the $(x+2)$ to get $x+3$, then substitute $x = -2$ to find the limit is 1. Did you also notice that the answer is the *slope-like* number you'd get from the rate idea? The numerator and denominator both vanish at $x = -2$, and the ratio of their vanishing rates is exactly 1.

7.3.2 Technique 2: Rationalize

Square roots block factoring. The cure is the *conjugate* — the exact same pair of terms with the connecting sign reversed, so that the conjugate of $\sqrt{A} - \sqrt{B}$ is $\sqrt{A} + \sqrt{B}$. Recall the difference-of-squares identity $(\sqrt{A} - \sqrt{B})(\sqrt{A} + \sqrt{B}) = A - B$: multiplying a root expression by its conjugate turns the roots into ordinary subtraction, which usually exposes the hidden $(x-a)$ factor.

Why the technique works

Why does multiplying by the conjugate help? A subtraction of roots, $\sqrt{x+1}-2$, is opaque — you cannot see what factor is making it vanish. But $(\sqrt{x+1}-2)(\sqrt{x+1}+2) = (x+1)-4 = x-3$ is transparent: the root is gone and the vanishing factor $(x-3)$ stares back at you. We multiply top and bottom by the same conjugate, so we have multiplied by 1 and changed nothing — but we have *relocated* the difficulty from the unreadable numerator to a readable one. It is the conjugate's job to convert "difference of roots" into "difference of the things under the roots."

Example 7.6 (Rationalizing the numerator)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 3} \frac{\sqrt{x+1}-2}{x-3}.$$

Substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$ (the top is $\sqrt{4}-2=0$). Multiply top and bottom by the conjugate $\sqrt{x+1}+2$:

$$\frac{\sqrt{x+1}-2}{x-3} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{x+1}+2}{\sqrt{x+1}+2} = \frac{(x+1)-4}{(x-3)\big(\sqrt{x+1}+2\big)} = \frac{x-3}{(x-3)\big(\sqrt{x+1}+2\big)}.$$

Now the $(x-3)$ cancels:

$$= \frac{1}{\sqrt{x+1}+2} \quad (x \neq 3), \qquad \lim_{x\to 3} \frac{1}{\sqrt{x+1}+2} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{4}+2} = \frac{1}{4}.$$

Example 7.7 (Conjugate on the denominator)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{x}{\sqrt{x+4}-2}.$$

Multiply by the conjugate $\sqrt{x+4}+2$ over itself:

$$\frac{x}{\sqrt{x+4}-2} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{x+4}+2}{\sqrt{x+4}+2} = \frac{x\big(\sqrt{x+4}+2\big)}{(x+4)-4} = \frac{x\big(\sqrt{x+4}+2\big)}{x} = \sqrt{x+4}+2 \quad (x \neq 0).$$

Then $\lim_{x\to 0} \big(\sqrt{x+4}+2\big) = 2+2 = 4$.

7.3.3 Technique 3: Clear Complex Fractions

A fraction buried inside a fraction simplifies using standard algebra: combine the little fractions over a common denominator, then simplify. These appear constantly in derivative computations.

Example 7.8 (A fraction of fractions)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 2} \frac{\dfrac{1}{x} - \dfrac{1}{2}}{x-2}.$$

Combine the numerator over the common denominator $2x$:

$$\frac{1}{x} - \frac{1}{2} = \frac{2-x}{2x}.$$

So the whole expression is

$$\frac{2-x}{2x} \cdot \frac{1}{x-2} = \frac{-(x-2)}{2x(x-2)} = \frac{-1}{2x} \quad (x \neq 2),$$

and $\lim_{x\to 2} \dfrac{-1}{2x} = \dfrac{-1}{4}$. Notice the sign flip from $2-x = -(x-2)$ — a classic place to lose a minus.

Common trap

The recurring danger in all three techniques is **sign errors** during factoring, especially $a-b = -(b-a)$. When you cancel, watch which way the factor points. A single dropped minus sign turns a correct answer into its negative.

7.4 The Squeeze Theorem

Factoring and rationalizing handle algebraic obstructions. But some limits — the ones involving wild oscillation, or transcendental functions like sin near 0 — resist algebra entirely. For these we need a different idea, and it happens to be one of the most intuitive in analysis.

Intuition

Picture a function trapped between a floor curve below it and a ceiling curve above it. If the floor and the ceiling pinch together at the same height L as $x \to a$, the function in the middle has nowhere else to go: it is forced to L too, no matter how wildly it wiggles along the way.

Theorem 7.3 (Squeeze Theorem)**.** *Suppose that for all x near a (except possibly at a itself)*

$$g(x) \le f(x) \le h(x),$$

and that

$$\lim_{x\to a} g(x) = \lim_{x\to a} h(x) = L.$$

Then $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ as well.

Why the technique works

Why is the squeeze theorem true? An epsilon-delta argument makes it airtight, but the idea is the picture. Fix a tolerance ε. Since $g \to L$, eventually $g(x) > L - \varepsilon$. Since $h \to L$, eventually $h(x) < L + \varepsilon$. Once both of these hold (take the smaller of the two δ's), the sandwich $g \le f \le h$ forces

$$L - \varepsilon < g(x) \le f(x) \le h(x) < L + \varepsilon,$$

so $f(x)$ is within ε of L. That is precisely the definition of $\lim f = L$. The two bounding functions do the work; f is constrained to follow them.

Example 7.9 (Taming an oscillation)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 0} x^2 \sin\frac{1}{x}.$$

Substitution is hopeless: $\sin(1/x)$ oscillates infinitely fast as $x \to 0$ and has no limit. But sin of anything lives in $[-1, 1]$, so

$$-1 \le \sin\frac{1}{x} \le 1 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad -x^2 \le x^2 \sin\frac{1}{x} \le x^2.$$

Both ends, $-x^2$ and x^2, go to 0 as $x \to 0$. Squeezed between them, so does our function:

$$\lim_{x\to 0} x^2 \sin\frac{1}{x} = 0.$$

The x^2 factor bounds the oscillation and drives it down to zero.

7.4.1 The Fundamental Trig Limit: $\sin x/x \to 1$

We now use the squeeze theorem to prove the most important single limit in all of calculus:

$$\boxed{\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\sin x}{x} = 1.}$$

This is the limit from which *every* derivative of a trig function flows. When you later learn that $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) = \cos x$, the engine inside that fact is this one limit. It is worth proving carefully.

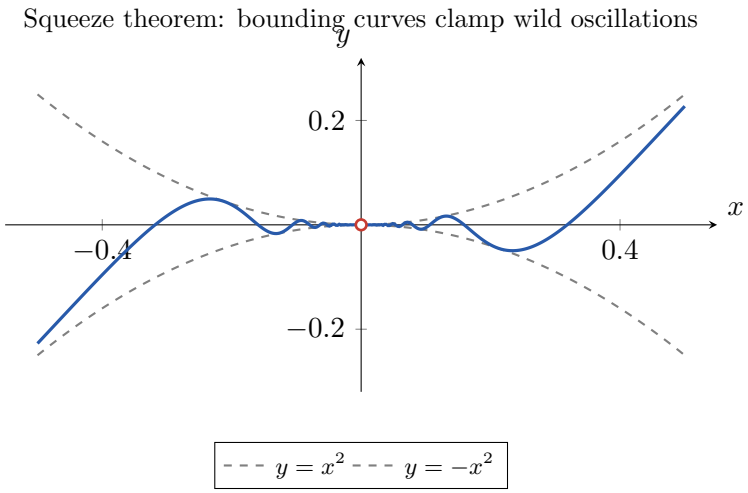


Figure 7.3: $y = x^2 \sin(1/x)$ oscillates faster and faster near 0, but it is pinned between the parabolas $y = \pm x^2$ (dashed). Since both bounding parabolas close on 0, the trapped curve is forced to 0.

Intuition

For a small angle x (measured in radians), the arc of the unit circle and the straight chord beneath it have nearly the same length, and $\sin x$ is almost the arc itself. As the angle shrinks, "nearly" sharpens into equality in the limit. The claim $\sin x/x \to 1$ is the precise statement that, for tiny angles, *the sine of an angle is essentially the angle.* This is why radians matter: only in radians does arc length equal the angle, making the comparison clean.

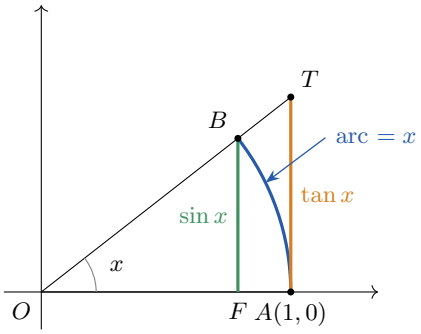


Figure 7.4: The unit circle with central angle x in radians. The vertical green segment FB has height $\sin x$, the blue circular arc AB has length x, and the orange vertical tangent segment AT has height $\tan x$. Comparing the three nested areas (small triangle OAB, circular sector OAB, and large triangle OAT) yields the sandwich $\sin x \le x \le \tan x$.

Focus

The proof, in one sentence: we trap x between $\sin x$ and $\tan x$ using three nested areas in the unit circle, divide through to isolate $\dfrac{\sin x}{x}$, and squeeze.

Setting up the inequality. Work in the unit circle (radius 1) and take a small positive angle x, with $0 < x < \frac{\pi}{2}$. Look at Figure 7.4. We compare three regions:

- the *small triangle* OAB (bounded by the straight chord from A to B, which cuts strictly inside the circular arc AB), of area $\frac{1}{2}\sin x$;
- the *circular sector* OAB, of area $\frac{1}{2}x$;
- the *large triangle* OAT out to the tangent line, of area $\frac{1}{2}\tan x$.

Let us justify each area. The small triangle OAB has horizontal base $OA = 1$ along the x-axis and perpendicular altitude $FB = \sin x$, so its area is $\frac{1}{2} \cdot 1 \cdot \sin x = \frac{1}{2}\sin x$. The sector is the fraction $\frac{x}{2\pi}$ of the full disk of area $\pi(1)^2 = \pi$, giving area $\frac{x}{2\pi} \cdot \pi = \frac{1}{2}x$. The large triangle OAT has base $OA = 1$ and height $AT = \tan x$ (the tangent line meets the vertical at height $\tan x$), so its area is $\frac{1}{2}\tan x$.

Now read off the geometry: the small triangle sits *inside* the sector, which sits *inside* the large triangle. Hence

$$\underbrace{\tfrac{1}{2}\sin x}_{\text{triangle}} \;\le\; \underbrace{\tfrac{1}{2}x}_{\text{sector}} \;\le\; \underbrace{\tfrac{1}{2}\tan x}_{\text{triangle}}.$$

Multiply through by 2:

$$\sin x \;\le\; x \;\le\; \tan x = \frac{\sin x}{\cos x}.$$

Rearranging into a sandwich. Since $0 < x < \frac{\pi}{2}$ we have $\sin x > 0$, so we may divide the whole chain by $\sin x$ without flipping any inequalities:

$$1 \;\le\; \frac{x}{\sin x} \;\le\; \frac{1}{\cos x}.$$

Take reciprocals — which *does* reverse the inequalities, since all quantities are positive:

$$\cos x \;\le\; \frac{\sin x}{x} \;\le\; 1.$$

There it is: $\dfrac{\sin x}{x}$ is sandwiched between $\cos x$ and 1 (Figure 7.5).

Squeezing. As $x \to 0^+$, the lower bound $\cos x \to \cos 0 = 1$, and the upper bound is the constant 1. Both converge to 1, so by the squeeze theorem

$$\lim_{x \to 0^+} \frac{\sin x}{x} = 1.$$

The other side. We assumed $x > 0$. What about $x \to 0^-$? The function $\dfrac{\sin x}{x}$ is *even*: replacing x by $-x$ gives $\dfrac{\sin(-x)}{-x} = \dfrac{-\sin x}{-x} = \dfrac{\sin x}{x}$, unchanged. So the left-hand limit equals the right-hand limit. Both are 1, and therefore the two-sided limit is

$$\lim_{x \to 0} \frac{\sin x}{x} = 1. \qquad \blacksquare$$

History

The fact that $\sin x \approx x$ for small angles was known and *used* long before anyone could prove it with limits. Around 1400 in South India, Madhava of Sangamagrama and his school of astronomy developed infinite polynomial series that already captured this small-angle behav-

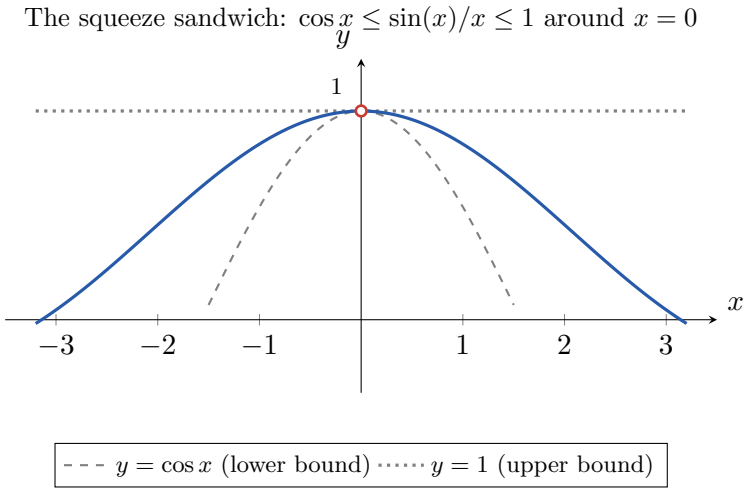


Figure 7.5: The function $y = \dfrac{\sin x}{x}$ (solid) is pinned between $y = \cos x$ (dashed, shown only near 0 where it is the lower bound) and the line $y = 1$ (dotted). As $x \to 0$ both bounds close on 1, forcing the curve up to the punctured value 1. The point $x = 0$ is a removable hole: the formula is undefined there, but the limit is plainly 1.

ior. By the late 1600s and 1700s, Isaac Newton and Leonhard Euler computed fluently with $\sin x/x \to 1$ while treating the angle x as an infinitesimal — a quantity imagined smaller than any positive number, yet not zero.

Their instinct was flawless and their answers correct, but the foundation was shaky: what *is* an infinitesimal? It was Augustin-Louis Cauchy in the 1820s who recast such statements as rigorous limits. The squeeze theorem — the nested-area argument on the unit circle you saw above — is essentially his way of replacing the hand-wavy "$\sin x$ and x become equal" with a watertight bound that anyone can check. The geometry was the ancients'; the rigor is the nineteenth century's.

Example 7.10 (A companion limit)**.** A close relative, proved with the same machinery and a trig identity:

$$\lim_{x \to 0} \frac{1 - \cos x}{x} = 0.$$

Multiply by the conjugate $1 + \cos x$:

$$\frac{1 - \cos x}{x} \cdot \frac{1 + \cos x}{1 + \cos x} = \frac{1 - \cos^2 x}{x(1 + \cos x)} = \frac{\sin^2 x}{x(1 + \cos x)} = \frac{\sin x}{x} \cdot \frac{\sin x}{1 + \cos x}.$$

As $x \to 0$ the first factor $\to 1$ and the second $\to \frac{0}{2} = 0$, so the product $\to 1 \cdot 0 = 0$. Two of our tricks — conjugates and the $\sin x/x$ limit — working together.

Example 7.11 (Using $\sin x/x$ as a building block)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 0} \frac{\sin 5x}{3x}.$$

The trick is to manufacture the form $\frac{\sin(\text{something})}{\text{same something}}$. Multiply and divide to make the argument of sine match its denominator:

$$\frac{\sin 5x}{3x} = \frac{\sin 5x}{5x} \cdot \frac{5x}{3x} = \frac{\sin 5x}{5x} \cdot \frac{5}{3}.$$

As $x \to 0$, $5x \to 0$ too, so $\dfrac{\sin 5x}{5x} \to 1$, and the limit is $1 \cdot \dfrac{5}{3} = \dfrac{5}{3}$.

Pause

Mental check: If $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{\sin x}{x} = 1$, what is $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{x}{\sin x}$? Because the quotient law allows us to invert a nonzero limit ($\frac{1}{1} = 1$), the reciprocal ratio also heads straight to 1. But what about $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{\sin x}{x^2}$? Writing it as $\frac{\sin x}{x} \cdot \frac{1}{x}$ reveals a 1 multiplied by a factor blowing up to $\pm\infty$. The single power of $\sin x$ in the numerator can cancel one factor of x in the denominator, but not two — so the limit does not exist.

7.5 One-Sided Limits

So far in this chapter we have let x approach a from both sides at once. When a function uses different formulas or jumps across a, we split the approach into the *one-sided limits* introduced in Chapter 5 — watching x creep in strictly from the left or strictly from the right.

Definition 7.1 (One-sided limits)**.** The **right-hand limit** $\lim_{x\to a^+} f(x) = L$ means $f(x)$ approaches L as x approaches a through values *greater* than a. The **left-hand limit** $\lim_{x\to a^-} f(x) = L$ uses values *less* than a. The epsilon-delta phrasing is identical to the two-sided one, except we restrict to $0 < x - a < \delta$ (right) or $-\delta < x - a < 0$ (left).

One-sided and two-sided limits are linked by a simple equivalence:

Theorem 7.4 (Two-sided = both one-sided agreeing)**.** $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ if and only if

$$\lim_{x\to a^-} f(x) = L \quad \textit{and} \quad \lim_{x\to a^+} f(x) = L.$$

That is: ***the two-sided limit exists exactly when both one-sided limits exist and are equal.***

Intuition

A two-sided limit is a meeting. For the function to "approach L as $x \to a$" it must approach L whether you sneak up from the left or from the right. If the two approaches head for different heights, there is no single number the function is closing in on — so the two-sided limit *does not exist*. This is the standard way to prove a limit fails to exist: show the two sides disagree.

Example 7.12 (A jump: the limit fails to exist)**.** Recall the Heaviside step function from Chapter 5:

$$H(x) = \begin{cases} 0 & x < 0, \\ 1 & x \geq 0, \end{cases}$$

which models an ideal switch flipping from 0 to 1 at $x = 0$. At the origin,

$$\lim_{x\to 0^-} H(x) = 0, \qquad \lim_{x\to 0^+} H(x) = 1.$$

The two sides disagree, so $\lim_{x\to 0} H(x)$ **does not exist.** The graph jumps; no single height is being approached.

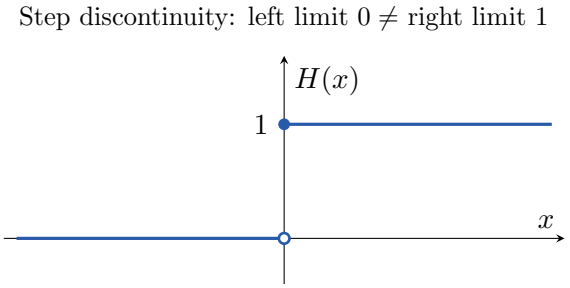


Figure 7.6: The Heaviside step. From the left, $H \to 0$; from the right, $H \to 1$. Because the two one-sided limits disagree, the two-sided limit at 0 does not exist.

Example 7.13 (Different formulas on each side)**.** Let

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2 + 1 & x \le 1, \\ 4 - 2x & x > 1. \end{cases}$$

From the left we use $x^2 + 1$: $\lim_{x \to 1^-} f(x) = 1^2 + 1 = 2$. From the right we use $4 - 2x$: $\lim_{x \to 1^+} f(x) = 4 - 2 = 2$. The sides agree, so $\lim_{x \to 1} f(x) = 2$ *exists*, regardless of the fact that the formula switches at $x = 1$ (Figure 7.7).

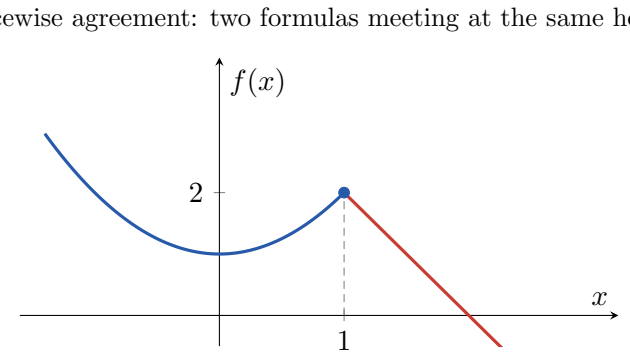


Figure 7.7: The piecewise f: the parabola x^2+1 (blue, for $x \le 1$) and the line $4-2x$ (red, for $x > 1$) meet at the same height 2 when $x = 1$. Both one-sided limits equal 2, so the two-sided limit exists even though the formula changes. Contrast this with the Heaviside jump, where the pieces fail to meet.

Walking question

Take a walk and picture this. A function can have a perfectly good two-sided limit at a point where it is built from *two different formulas*, as long as those formulas meet at the same height. And a function can *fail* to have a limit at a point where it is given by a single tidy formula — if that formula blows up or jumps. The limit cares only about the *heights being approached from each side*, never about how the function is written or what it does at the point itself. Can you sketch a function continuous everywhere except one jump, and one that is defined by two formulas yet perfectly smooth?

7.6 Limits with Absolute Values

The absolute value $|x|$ is defined piecewise:

$$|x| = \begin{cases} x & x \geq 0, \\ -x & x < 0, \end{cases}$$

and this sign change is why one-sided limits are essential here. Whenever an absolute value sits on top of (or inside) an expression, the right move is almost always: **break it at the point where its inside changes sign, and take the limit from each side.**

Example 7.14 (The classic $|x|/x$)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 0} \frac{|x|}{x}.$$

For $x > 0$, $|x| = x$, so $\frac{|x|}{x} = \frac{x}{x} = 1$. For $x < 0$, $|x| = -x$, so $\frac{|x|}{x} = \frac{-x}{x} = -1$. Therefore

$$\lim_{x \to 0^+} \frac{|x|}{x} = 1, \qquad \lim_{x \to 0^-} \frac{|x|}{x} = -1.$$

The two sides disagree, so the two-sided limit **does not exist**. The function is $+1$ on the right and -1 on the left — a jump straight through the origin (Figure 7.8).

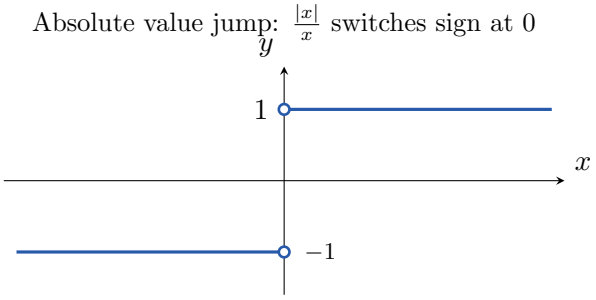


Figure 7.8: The sign function $\dfrac{|x|}{x}$ equals $+1$ to the right of 0 and -1 to the left, with the point $x = 0$ removed (the function is undefined there). The left and right limits, -1 and $+1$, disagree, so the two-sided limit at 0 does not exist.

What is really happening

What is the absolute value really doing to a limit? It *folds the negative side up*, which reverses the direction of approach on the left. So an expression that is heading one way as x increases through 0 from the right may head the opposite way from the left — the fold flips its sign. That is why absolute-value limits so often split into two unequal one-sided limits. The cure is never to fight the absolute value head-on but to *unfold it* into its two cases and treat each side as the plain function it really is.

Example 7.15 (Absolute value not at zero)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 3} \frac{|x-3|}{x-3}.$$

The inside $x-3$ changes sign at $x=3$. For $x>3$, $x-3>0$ so the ratio is $+1$; for $x<3$, $x-3<0$ so the ratio is -1. Right limit $=1$, left limit $=-1$: the two-sided limit does not exist. (It is the previous example shifted three units to the right.)

Example 7.16 (When the absolute value does *not* cause trouble)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 0} x\,|x|.$$

Here splitting is easy and the sides agree. For $x\geq 0$, $x|x| = x^2 \to 0$; for $x<0$, $x|x| = -x^2 \to 0$. Both one-sided limits are 0, so the two-sided limit is 0. An absolute value does not automatically destroy a limit — it only matters when the two folded sides head to different places.

Common trap

Do not "simplify" $|x|$ to x and barge ahead. $|x| = x$ is true only for $x\geq 0$. On the left of the trouble point you must use $|x| = -x$, and forgetting the sign is the single most common error here. When you see an absolute value in a limit, your reflex should be: *find where the inside is zero, then split.*

7.7 One-Sided Limits and Infinite Blow-Ups

One-sided limits also let us describe what happens when a function blows up — the $\frac{\text{nonzero}}{0}$ situation that the quotient law also refuses to touch, but for a different reason than $\frac{0}{0}$.

Example 7.17 (Opposite infinities from each side)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{1}{x}.$$

Substitution gives $\frac{1}{0}$ — not indeterminate, but undefined. Approach from the right ($x>0$, tiny): $\frac{1}{x}$ is a huge positive number, so $\lim\limits_{x\to 0^+} \dfrac{1}{x} = +\infty$. From the left ($x<0$, tiny): $\frac{1}{x}$ is a huge *negative* number, so $\lim\limits_{x\to 0^-} \dfrac{1}{x} = -\infty$. The two sides shoot off in opposite directions, so the two-sided limit does not exist.

Example 7.18 (Same infinity from both sides)**.**

$$\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{1}{x^2} = +\infty.$$

Here $x^2>0$ no matter which side you come from, so $\frac{1}{x^2} \to +\infty$ from *both* sides. We write $+\infty$ to describe the shared behavior, while remembering that "$=\infty$" is shorthand for "grows without bound," not a claim that the limit is a number.

Common trap

$\frac{\text{nonzero}}{0}$ and $\frac{0}{0}$ are completely different diagnoses. A nonzero number over zero *blows up* (vertical asymptote); there is nothing to cancel and no finite limit. A zero over zero is *indeterminate*;

there is a hidden common factor and the limit may be any finite number. When substitution fails, your very first question is: *is the numerator also zero?* The answer routes you to entirely different techniques.

7.8 A Preview of Indeterminate Forms

We have spent this chapter conquering one indeterminate form, $\frac{0}{0}$, with algebra. Its siblings recur throughout calculus, and each demands its own tools, so they are worth naming now. An *indeterminate form* is a symbolic "shape" a limit can take where the limit laws give no answer — the value genuinely depends on the competing rates, not on the shape alone.

Focus

The seven classic indeterminate forms:

$$\frac{0}{0}, \quad \frac{\infty}{\infty}, \quad 0\cdot\infty, \quad \infty-\infty, \quad 1^{\infty}, \quad 0^{0}, \quad \infty^{0}.$$

Each is "indeterminate" because the answer can be *anything* depending on how fast the pieces move. The shape alone does not decide.

Why are these indeterminate while, say, $\frac{2}{0}$ or 0^5 are not? The difference is whether the symbolic form pins down the answer.

Intuition

Consider $0\cdot\infty$: one factor shrinks toward zero while the other shoots off toward infinity, and who wins depends entirely on how fast each one moves. Watch three examples as $x\to 0^+$, each of the form (something $\to 0$) $\cdot$ (something $\to\infty$):

$$x\cdot\frac{1}{x}\to 1, \qquad x\cdot\frac{1}{x^2}\to+\infty, \qquad x^2\cdot\frac{1}{x}\to 0.$$

Same shape $0\cdot\infty$, three different answers. That is the entire meaning of "indeterminate": the form is a question, never an answer. By contrast $\frac{2}{0}$ always blows up and 0^5 is always 0 — those forms *are* determined, so we do not call them indeterminate.

The cleanest power tool for the two leading forms, $\frac{0}{0}$ and $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, is *l'Hôpital's rule*, which turns the limit of a ratio into the limit of the ratio of derivatives. It is wonderfully effective — and it is worthless until you have derivatives, which is why it waits for its own chapter much later. The forms $0\cdot\infty$, $\infty-\infty$, and the three exponential shapes 1^{∞}, 0^0, ∞^0 are all handled by first *algebraically rewriting* them as $\frac{0}{0}$ or $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ (the exponential ones by taking logs), and then applying the same machinery. The algebra you practiced in this chapter — factoring, rationalizing, clearing fractions — handles polynomials, roots, and trig ratios right now; once we build derivatives, l'Hôpital's rule will handle the rest systematically.

Connection

There is a thread running from this chapter all the way to Taylor series near the end of the book. The reason $\frac{\sin x}{x} \to 1$ is that $\sin x = x - \frac{x^3}{6} + \cdots$; divide by x and the leading term is 1 with the rest vanishing. Every indeterminate $\frac{0}{0}$ is, underneath, a competition between the *leading terms* of two series. The algebra tricks of this chapter, l'Hôpital's rule, and Taylor expansion are three faces of the same idea: *a limit is decided by the lowest-order behavior of each piece.*

7.9 A Strategy, Start to Finish

Put the tools in order. Faced with $\lim_{x \to a} f(x)$:

1. **Try substitution.** Plug in a. If you get a finite number and the function is continuous there, you are done.
2. **Diagnose the failure.** If substitution gives $\frac{\text{nonzero}}{0}$, it is a blow-up — use one-sided limits to describe $\pm\infty$ and conclude the two-sided limit (usually) does not exist. If it gives $\frac{0}{0}$, it is indeterminate — proceed.
3. **Remove the common factor.** Factor and cancel; if there are roots, rationalize with the conjugate; if there are nested fractions, clear them. Then substitute into the simplified form.
4. **Squeeze if algebra fails.** For oscillations or trig limits like $\frac{\sin x}{x}$, trap the function between two others with a common limit.
5. **Split at sign changes.** For absolute values or piecewise formulas, take left and right limits separately and check whether they agree.
6. **Recognize the deeper forms.** If you are left with $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, $0 \cdot \infty$, or an exponential shape, name the indeterminate form and remember l'Hôpital is coming.

Example 7.19 (A limit that uses several tools)**.**

$$\lim_{x \to 0} \frac{\sqrt{1+x} - 1}{\sin x}.$$

Substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$. There is a root, so rationalize the numerator, and there is a sine, so plan to use $\frac{\sin x}{x}$. Multiply the numerator by its conjugate:

$$\frac{\sqrt{1+x} - 1}{\sin x} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{1+x} + 1}{\sqrt{1+x} + 1} = \frac{(1+x) - 1}{\sin x \, (\sqrt{1+x} + 1)} = \frac{x}{\sin x \, (\sqrt{1+x} + 1)}.$$

Now split the factors deliberately:

$$= \frac{x}{\sin x} \cdot \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+x} + 1} = \frac{1}{\frac{\sin x}{x}} \cdot \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+x} + 1}.$$

As $x \to 0$, $\frac{\sin x}{x} \to 1$ so its reciprocal $\to 1$, and $\sqrt{1+x} + 1 \to 2$. The limit is

$$1 \cdot \frac{1}{2} = \frac{1}{2}.$$

Rationalizing and the $\sin x / x$ limit, working side by side.

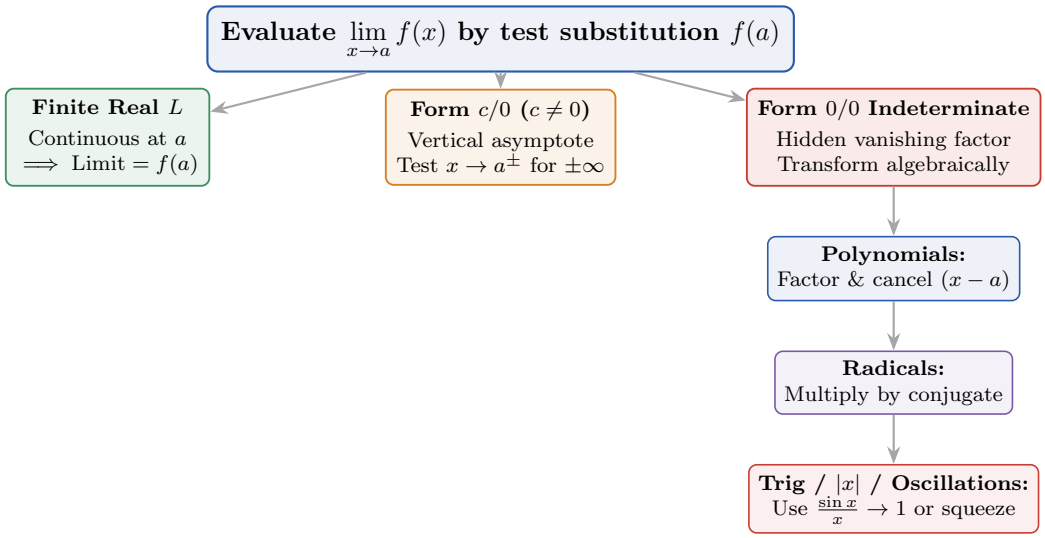


Figure 7.9: The limit computation decision roadmap: diagnose the initial form upon substitution, then deploy the matching algebraic or geometric tool to resolve the obstruction.

Why this matters

Notice the shape of what you have learned. Every technique in this chapter does the same thing: it *changes the appearance of an expression without changing the value it approaches*, until the answer becomes self-evident. Factoring, conjugates, common denominators, the squeeze sandwich, splitting at a sign change — these are not five unrelated tricks, but five ways of using one fact: *a limit lives in the neighborhood of a point, not at the point, so I am free to rewrite the function on that neighborhood however I please.* That freedom, licensed by the limit laws and the definition of a limit itself, is the quiet engine of all of calculus. Once you feel it, computing limits becomes a structured search for the algebraic form that reveals the value.

In the next chapter, we turn this perspective around: when a function can be evaluated by direct substitution without any rewriting — so $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a)$ — it is called *continuous*. We will see how this property guarantees that unbroken curves skip no values, leading directly to the Intermediate Value Theorem.

Exercises

Exercise 7.1 (Substitution)**.** Evaluate by direct substitution, justifying that it is legal:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 2}\big(3x^2 - 4x + 7\big), \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{e^x + \cos x}{x + 2}, \qquad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to \pi}\sin\Big(\frac{x}{2}\Big).$$

Exercise 7.2 (Factor and cancel)**.** Evaluate:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 4}\frac{x^2 - 16}{x - 4}, \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to -1}\frac{x^2 + 3x + 2}{x^2 - 1}, \qquad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to 2}\frac{x^3 - 8}{x - 2}.$$

Exercise 7.3 (Rationalize)**.** Evaluate:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sqrt{9+x}-3}{x}, \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to 1}\frac{\sqrt{x}-1}{x-1}, \qquad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to 7}\frac{\sqrt{x+2}-3}{x-7}.$$

Exercise 7.4 (Complex fractions)**.** Evaluate:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 3}\frac{\frac{1}{x}-\frac{1}{3}}{x-3}, \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{h\to 0}\frac{\frac{1}{(2+h)^2}-\frac{1}{4}}{h}.$$

Exercise 7.5 (Trig limits)**.** Using $\lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sin x}{x}=1$ and $\lim_{x\to 0}\frac{1-\cos x}{x}=0$, evaluate:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sin 7x}{2x}, \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sin 3x}{\sin 5x}, \qquad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\tan x}{x}.$$

Exercise 7.6 (Squeeze)**.** (a) Show $\lim_{x\to 0} x^4\cos\frac{1}{x^2}=0$ by squeezing. (b) Given that $1-\frac{x^2}{6}\le\frac{\sin x}{x}\le 1$ for small x, use the squeeze theorem to re-derive $\lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sin x}{x}=1$.

Exercise 7.7 (One-sided and absolute value)**.** Evaluate each one-sided limit and decide whether the two-sided limit exists:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 5}\frac{|x-5|}{x-5}, \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to 2^+}\frac{x-2}{|x-2|}, \qquad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{x^2}{|x|}.$$

Exercise 7.8 (Piecewise)**.** Let

$$f(x)=\begin{cases}2x+1 & x<1,\\ k & x=1,\\ x^2+2 & x>1.\end{cases}$$

Find $\lim_{x\to 1^-} f(x)$ and $\lim_{x\to 1^+} f(x)$. Does $\lim_{x\to 1} f(x)$ exist? Does the value of k affect your answer? Explain in one sentence why the limit ignores k.

Exercise 7.9 (Blow-ups)**.** Describe the behavior with one-sided limits, and state whether the two-sided limit exists:

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to 2}\frac{1}{x-2}, \qquad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to 2}\frac{1}{(x-2)^2}, \qquad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to 1}\frac{x}{x^2-1}.$$

Exercise 7.10 (Conceptual)**.** Decide whether each statement is true or false, and justify in a sentence. (a) If $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)$ exists then f is defined at a. (b) If $f(a)$ is defined then $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)=f(a)$. (c) The form $\frac{0}{0}$ always has limit 1 because "anything over itself is 1." (d) If both one-sided limits exist, the two-sided limit exists.

Exercise 7.11 (Proof: a squeeze)**.** Prove using the squeeze theorem that if $|f(x)|\le M|x-a|$ for all x near a (with M a fixed constant), then $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)=0$. *Hint:* sandwich f between $-M|x-a|$ and $M|x-a|$.

Exercise 7.12 (Proof: the conjugate, in general)**.** Let $a>0$. Prove that

$$\lim_{x\to a}\frac{\sqrt{x}-\sqrt{a}}{x-a}=\frac{1}{2\sqrt{a}}$$

by rationalizing. Explain in one sentence which limit law licenses the final substitution step, and why it is now legal when it was not before.

Chapter 8

Continuity and the Intermediate Value Theorem

In the previous chapter on computing limits, your very first instinct was direct substitution: plug in $x = a$ to evaluate $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)$. For polynomials and simple fractions away from zero denominators, it yielded the limit immediately. But whenever an expression produced $0/0$ or a piecewise split, substitution broke down, forcing you to factor, rationalize, or test one-sided limits. Why did direct substitution ever work in the first place? When is evaluating a limit as simple as evaluating the function?

Direct substitution works precisely when the curve has no sudden gaps, holes, or jumps at that point – when the function is *continuous*. In everyday speech we say a road runs continuously from one town to the next, or that someone worked continuously for three hours, meaning without interruption. Underneath both uses is the same geometric picture: *no sudden jumps*, moving from one value to the next a little at a time.

Calculus is built on this picture. Almost every major theorem ahead rests on continuity. Continuity guarantees that a function hits every value between two of its outputs and attains both a highest and a lowest point on a closed interval. It also ensures that the area under a curve is well defined, and every differentiable function (one with a tangent line at each point) automatically satisfies it. So before we can differentiate or integrate anything with confidence, we need to say, with total precision, what it means for a function to have "no jumps."

The right definition, oddly enough, does not mention jumps at all. It is phrased entirely in the language of limits you built in the previous chapters. By the end of this chapter, you will see *why* the limit definition captures the no-jump idea and how to classify every way continuity can fail. You will also prove and apply two foundational existence theorems of analysis: the Intermediate Value Theorem and the Extreme Value Theorem.

8.1 From "no jumps" to a definition

Start with the picture, and refuse to leave it until the definition feels forced upon us.

Imagine dragging a pencil along the graph of a function f. Continuity at a point a should mean: as your pencil approaches the vertical line $x = a$ from either side, the height of the curve approaches

the height $f(a)$ of the point actually sitting above a. Nothing jumps; nothing is missing; the point you would *predict* by sliding in is exactly the point that is *there*.

This idea splits into three separate promises, each of which can fail independently.

Intuition

For f to be continuous at a, three things must all hold:

1. $f(a)$ must *exist* — there has to be a point on the graph above a.
2. $\lim_{x\to a} f(x)$ must *exist* — the curve must approach a single definite height as you slide in from both sides.
3. These two numbers must *agree* — the height you slide toward equals the height that is actually there.

The first is about the point. The second is about the approach. The third demands that the approach and the point match. Continuity is precisely the demand that prediction and reality coincide.

Reading note

Mental check: point versus approach. Can you sketch a curve where the point $f(2)$ exists and the approach $\lim_{x\to 2} f(x)$ exists, but they disagree? (Imagine a bead lifted off a wire and glued higher up.) Can you sketch one where the approach exists but the point is missing entirely? (A wire with a missing bead.)

Compressing all three promises into one line gives the definition.

Definition 8.1 (Continuity at a point)**.** A function f is **continuous at** a if

$$\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a).$$

We mean this in the strongest sense: a is in the domain of f (so $f(a)$ is a real number), the limit on the left exists, and the two are equal. If f is continuous at every point of a set S, we say f is **continuous on** S.

This single equation quietly bundles all three promises. If $f(a)$ did not exist, the right side would be meaningless. If the limit did not exist, the left side would be meaningless. And if both existed but disagreed, the equation would simply be false. The equation $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a)$ asserts all three at once. That economy is exactly why mathematicians chose it.

What is really happening

Why does an equation about limits capture a *geometric* idea about jumps? Because a limit *is* the machinery of "sliding in." Recall what $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ really asserts: for every tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$, no matter how small, there is a window of inputs $0 < |x - a| < \delta$ on which f stays within ε of L. Continuity says we may take $L = f(a)$ *and drop the restriction* $x \neq a$. Stated precisely:

$$\text{for every } \varepsilon > 0 \text{ there is } \delta > 0 \text{ such that } |x - a| < \delta \implies |f(x) - f(a)| < \varepsilon.$$

Read that aloud as a promise about jumps: "if you want my output to land within ε of $f(a)$,

just keep your input within δ of a." A jump is exactly a failure of this promise — a height the output refuses to approach no matter how close the input gets. Continuity is the guarantee that small input changes force small output changes. There is no sudden jump across a gap. Figure 8.1 illustrates this contract: center a target window of height 2ε at $f(a)$, and you can always find an input corridor of width 2δ centered at a such that the curve never escapes through the ceiling or floor.

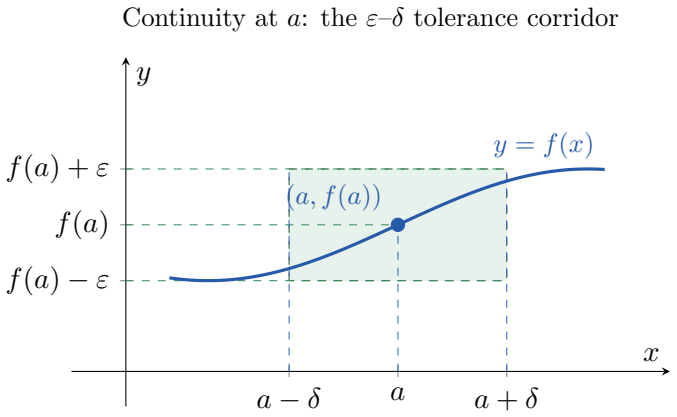


Figure 8.1: The ε–δ definition of continuity at a point a. Given any target window of height 2ε centered at $f(a)$, there exists an input window of width 2δ centered at a such that the curve stays entirely inside the shaded rectangle. Small changes in input force small changes in output, with no jumps or gaps.

Focus

There is an essential difference from the bare limit definition of the previous chapter. There we wrote $0 < |x - a| < \delta$, deliberately *excluding* the point $x = a$, because a limit is about the neighborhood, not the point itself. Continuity is the stronger statement that we may *include* $x = a$: the inequality $|x - a| < \delta$ now allows $x = a$, where it reads $|f(a) - f(a)| = 0 < \varepsilon$ for free. The limit ignores the point; continuity insists the point cooperate with its neighbors.

8.1.1 One-sided continuity and continuity on an interval

Sometimes a function only "slides in" nicely from one side — think of $\sqrt{x}$ at $x = 0$, where there are no inputs to the left at all. We handle this with one-sided limits.

Definition 8.2 (One-sided continuity)**.** f is **continuous from the right** at a if $\lim_{x \to a^+} f(x) = f(a)$, and **continuous from the left** at a if $\lim_{x \to a^-} f(x) = f(a)$. A function is continuous at an **interior point** (a point with room on both sides inside the domain, not an endpoint) exactly when it is continuous from both sides there.

This lets us say cleanly what it means for f to be continuous on a *closed* interval $[a, b]$: continuous at every interior point, continuous from the right at the left endpoint a, and continuous from the left at the right endpoint b. We only ever ask a function to behave with respect to inputs that actually exist. This convention will matter enormously when we state the Extreme Value Theorem, which needs a closed interval.

8.2 A gallery of discontinuities

The fastest way to understand continuity is to see how it breaks. Each of the three promises can fail in its own way, giving four recognizable shapes on a graph.

8.2.1 Removable discontinuity: the patchable hole

Here the limit exists — the curve clearly aims at a single height — but either $f(a)$ is undefined or it is defined "in the wrong place." The graph has a single missing or misplaced point. The defect is *removable*: redefining f at the one point a to equal the limit repairs continuity completely.

Removable discontinuity: limit exists but disagrees with $f(a)$

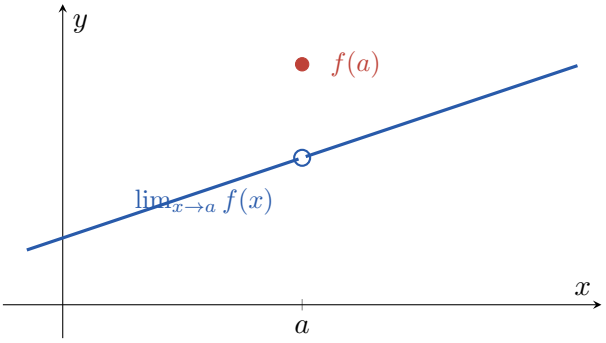


Figure 8.2: A removable discontinuity. The curve aims at the open circle, but the actual value $f(a)$ (filled dot) sits elsewhere. The limit exists; it just disagrees with $f(a)$. Move the dot down into the hole and continuity is restored.

Example 8.1 (The classic hole)**.** Consider

$$g(x) = \frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1}.$$

At $x = 1$ the formula reads $0/0$, undefined, so promise (1) fails: $g(1)$ does not exist. But for every $x \neq 1$ we may cancel:

$$g(x) = \frac{(x-1)(x+1)}{x-1} = x + 1,$$

so $\lim_{x\to 1} g(x) = \lim_{x\to 1}(x+1) = 2$. The limit exists and equals 2; only the point is missing. Defining $g(1) = 2$ plugs the hole and makes g continuous everywhere.

Common trap

A removable discontinuity is still a genuine discontinuity. The function g above is *not* continuous at 1 as originally written — it has no value there, so the equation $\lim_{x\to 1} g(x) = g(1)$ cannot hold. People sometimes say "g is basically $x+1$." It *becomes* $x+1$ only after you supply the missing value. Until you do, there is a hole, and a hole is a discontinuity. Cancellation in a formula does not by itself mend the function; it tells you which value would mend it.

8.2.2 Jump discontinuity: the cliff

Here both one-sided limits exist but *disagree*. The curve approaches one height from the left and a different height from the right. There is a genuine cliff. No single redefinition of $f(a)$ can fix this, because there are two different heights competing and $f(a)$ can only be one number.

Jump discontinuity: one-sided limits exist but disagree

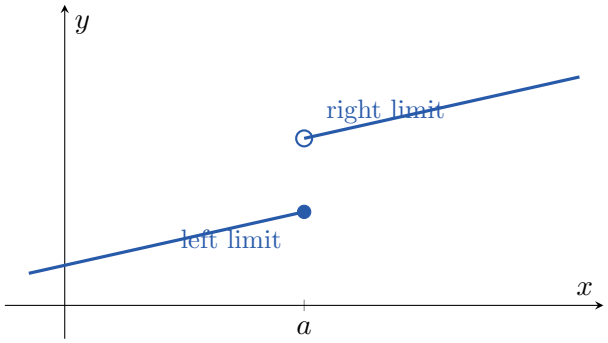


Figure 8.3: A jump discontinuity. The left-hand limit and right-hand limit both exist but are unequal, so the two-sided limit does not exist. The gap between the dots is the size of the jump.

Example 8.2 (A step function)**.** Let $H(x) = 0$ for $x < 0$ and $H(x) = 1$ for $x \geq 0$ (the Heaviside step, the idealized "switch turns on" function). Then $\lim_{x\to 0^-} H(x) = 0$ while $\lim_{x\to 0^+} H(x) = 1$. The one-sided limits disagree, so $\lim_{x\to 0} H(x)$ does not exist, and H is discontinuous at 0. It *is* continuous from the right there, since $\lim_{x\to 0^+} H(x) = 1 = H(0)$.

Application

Jump discontinuities appear constantly in applied modeling. A light switch, a digital signal flipping from 0 to 1, the price of a stock the instant news breaks, the charge on a capacitor the moment a switch closes: all are modeled by jumps. This is exactly why engineers use the Heaviside function and its counterpart, the Dirac delta (an idealized distribution modeling an instantaneous impulse). Calculus copes with such functions by working on the pieces *between* jumps, where everything is continuous, and treating the jumps as boundaries. "Piecewise continuous" is the accurate description of most real-world signals.

8.2.3 Infinite discontinuity: the pole

Here a one-sided limit (or both) is infinite. The curve shoots off to $\pm\infty$ near a. There is a vertical asymptote — a vertical line that the curve hugs ever more closely as its height climbs toward infinity without bound. No finite value of $f(a)$ could possibly match an infinite approach.

8.2.4 Oscillatory discontinuity: the blur

The subtlest failure: the function neither settles down nor blows up; it oscillates forever, infinitely fast, as $x \to a$. The limit fails not because of a jump or a pole but because there is no single height the values approach at all.

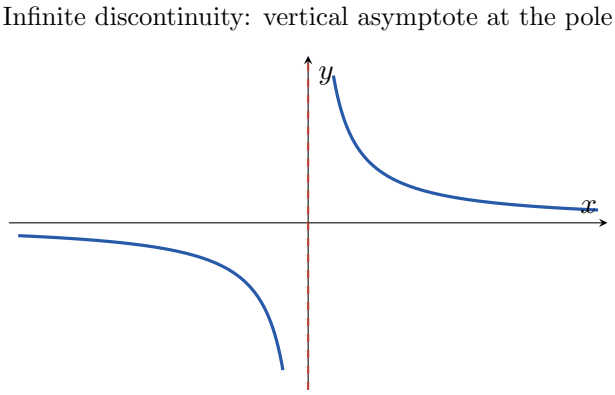


Figure 8.4: An infinite discontinuity: $f(x) = 1/x$ near $x = 0$. The left limit is $-\infty$, the right limit is $+\infty$. The dashed line is the vertical asymptote.

Example 8.3 (Endless wiggling)**.** Let $s(x) = \sin(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. As $x \to 0$, the argument $1/x$ races off to infinity, so $\sin(1/x)$ sweeps through every value in $[-1, 1]$ infinitely many times in any neighborhood of 0. There is no limiting height. No definition of $s(0)$ can rescue continuity, because the values do not approach *anything*.

Contrast its tamer relative $x \sin(1/x)$: the wild oscillation is throttled by the factor $x \to 0$, the wiggles get squeezed to zero amplitude, and $\lim_{x\to 0} x \sin(1/x) = 0$ by the Squeeze Theorem (which traps an oscillating function between two boundaries that pinch together at the same limit). Defining the value at 0 to be 0 makes *that* one continuous. The difference between a curable and an incurable wiggle is whether the amplitude dies out.

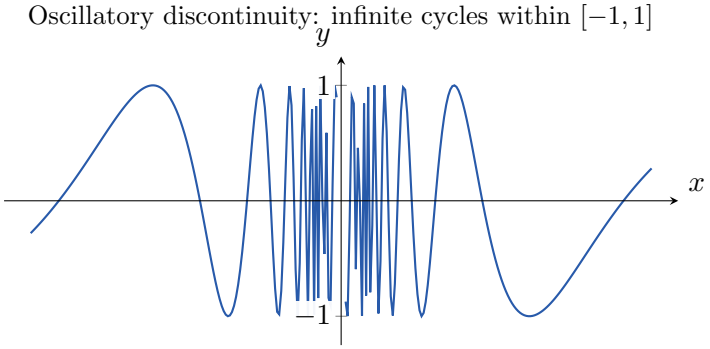


Figure 8.5: $\sin(1/x)$ near the origin. The oscillation never slows; the values fill the band $[-1, 1]$ densely as $x \to 0$, so no limit exists.

Walking question

Take a walk and sort the discontinuities by "how badly broken" they are. The removable hole is barely broken — one point out of place. The jump is broken but tame — two genuine one-sided limits. The pole is broken and unbounded. The oscillation is broken and not even *trying* to have a limit. Now ask yourself: which of these can a computer plotting 200 points possibly miss? (Hint: think about whether your sample points might land on the "wrong" side of the trouble, or skip over a thin spike. This is why we prove things instead of trusting

pictures.)

8.3 Building continuous functions

If we had to check the limit definition by hand for every function, calculus would be unbearable. Fortunately continuity is *hereditary*: continuous functions combine to make more continuous functions. We get to know a few atoms are continuous, then assemble everything else for free.

8.3.1 The atoms

The following are continuous everywhere on their natural domains; each follows directly from the limit laws of the previous chapters.

- Constant functions $f(x) = c$ and the identity $f(x) = x$ (which simply returns whatever input it receives). (For the identity, $\lim_{x\to a} x = a = f(a)$ — this is almost the definition of a limit.)
- Polynomials, everywhere on $\mathbb{R}$.
- Rational functions $p(x)/q(x)$, everywhere $q(x) \neq 0$.
- $\sin x$, $\cos x$, everywhere; $\exp x$ and, on $(0, \infty)$, $\ln x$.
- $\sqrt{x}$ on $[0, \infty)$ (continuous from the right at 0), and more generally x^r on its domain.

8.3.2 The combination laws

Theorem 8.1 (Continuity of combinations)**.** *Suppose f and g are continuous at a. Then so are*

$$f + g, \qquad f - g, \qquad fg, \qquad cf \ (c \in \mathbb{R}),$$

and f/g provided $g(a) \neq 0$.

Why the technique works

Why is this true with no new work at all? Because each statement is just a limit law rephrased. Continuity of f at a means $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a)$, and likewise for g. The sum law for limits says

$$\lim_{x\to a}\big(f(x) + g(x)\big) = \lim_{x\to a} f(x) + \lim_{x\to a} g(x) = f(a) + g(a) = (f + g)(a),$$

which is exactly the statement that $f + g$ is continuous at a. The product, difference, and quotient cases are the corresponding limit laws, read the same way. The proviso $g(a) \neq 0$ in the quotient is precisely the proviso in the limit quotient law: you may not divide by a quantity heading to zero.

This single observation explains the whole list of atoms. A polynomial is built from the identity and constants by multiplication and addition; apply Theorem 8.1 finitely many times and continuity is guaranteed at every point. A rational function is a quotient of polynomials, continuous wherever the denominator is nonzero. You never have to return to ε and δ for these.

8.3.3 Composition: the most important law

The deepest of the combination laws concerns *chaining* functions, g then f. It will reappear as the engine of the chain rule in differentiation, so it is worth seeing clearly now.

Theorem 8.2 (Continuity of compositions)**.** *If g is continuous at a and f is continuous at $g(a)$, then the composition $f \circ g$, defined by $(f \circ g)(x) = f(g(x))$, is continuous at a.*

Intuition

Picture two machines in a row. The first, g, takes x near a and (being continuous) produces output near $g(a)$. The second, f, takes inputs near $g(a)$ and (being continuous there) produces outputs near $f(g(a))$. Feed a small wiggle in x through the pair: g converts it to a small wiggle near $g(a)$, and f converts that to a small wiggle near $f(g(a))$. Small in, small out, all the way through. The chain of two no-jump machines is itself a no-jump machine.

Proof. We use the ε–δ form of continuity. Let $\varepsilon > 0$ be given; we must find $\delta > 0$ so that $|x - a| < \delta$ forces $|f(g(x)) - f(g(a))| < \varepsilon$.

Work from the outside in. Because f is continuous at the point $b := g(a)$, there is an $\eta > 0$ (the tolerance f needs on *its* input) such that

$$|y - b| < \eta \implies |f(y) - f(b)| < \varepsilon.$$

Now hand that η to g. Because g is continuous at a, there is a $\delta > 0$ such that

$$|x - a| < \delta \implies |g(x) - g(a)| < \eta.$$

Chain them: if $|x-a| < \delta$, then $|g(x)-b| < \eta$, and therefore $|f(g(x))-f(b)| < \varepsilon$. Since $f(b) = f(g(a))$, this says exactly $|f(g(x)) - f(g(a))| < \varepsilon$. The required δ exists for every ε, so $f \circ g$ is continuous at a. □

Focus

Watch the direction of the argument. We pick the tolerance ε at the *final* output, pull it back through f to get a tolerance η on f's input, then pull *that* back through g to get a tolerance δ on the original input. Tolerances propagate backward, from the end of the pipeline to the start. This backward flow is the shape of nearly every chain-rule-style argument in calculus. Hold onto it; it returns when we differentiate compositions.

Example 8.4 (Reading off continuity at a glance)**.** The function $h(x) = \sqrt{x^2 + 1}$ is continuous on all of $\mathbb{R}$. Here $g(x) = x^2 + 1$ is a polynomial (continuous, and always $\geq 1 > 0$), and $f(u) = \sqrt{u}$ is continuous on $[0, \infty)$, which safely contains every value of g. By Theorem 8.2 the composition is continuous everywhere. Similarly $\sin(e^x)$, $e^{\cos x}$, and $\dfrac{1}{1 + x^2}$ are continuous on all of $\mathbb{R}$ — each is a finite assembly of continuous atoms by addition, multiplication, division (with nonzero denominator), and composition. After a little practice you simply *see* it.

History

For nearly two centuries calculus thrived on physical intuition without a rigorous definition of continuity. Isaac Newton spoke of quantities "flowing" through time, while Leonhard Euler defined continuous functions as those given by a single algebraic formula, calling piecewise geometric curves "discontinuous" by contrast. Without a formal concept of limits or the real numbers, mathematicians could not prove why a curve crossing a line must intersect it. They also routinely assumed that every continuous curve must have a tangent line almost everywhere.

In 1817, the Bohemian mathematician Bernard Bolzano published a modern limit-based definition of continuity and gave the first rigorous proof of the Intermediate Value Theorem. Yet the mathematical establishment ignored his work for decades, content with geometric self-evidence. In 1821, Augustin-Louis Cauchy popularized a limit-based framework, but ignited fresh debate by publishing a notoriously flawed "proof" that the infinite sum of continuous functions is always continuous. Untangling that error took decades, forcing analysts to distinguish ordinary pointwise convergence from *uniform convergence* (where a family of functions settles down at the same shared speed across an entire interval).

The decisive turning point came in 1872, when Karl Weierstrass constructed a function that is continuous everywhere but differentiable (having a well-defined tangent slope) nowhere — an unbroken curve so jagged that it has a sharp corner at every single point. That shocking discovery proved that continuity is fundamentally distinct from smoothness, and that geometric intuition cannot substitute for rigorous definitions. Together, the ε–δ definition and the completeness of $\mathbb{R}$ gave modern analysis the tools to prove the two theorems that carry the rest of this chapter: the Intermediate Value Theorem and the Extreme Value Theorem.

8.4 The Intermediate Value Theorem

We now reach the first great payoff of continuity. It is an intuitively natural statement, which makes its rigorous proof all the more instructive.

Intuition

Suppose a function is continuous on $[a, b]$, starts below some level N at $x = a$, and ends above N at $x = b$. To get from below N to above N *without jumping*, the graph must cross the line $y = N$ somewhere in between. A continuous pencil stroke that begins below a horizontal line and ends above it has to touch that line. That is the content of the Intermediate Value Theorem. The statement is easy to believe; the work lies in proving that the definition of continuity alone forces the crossing.

Theorem 8.3 (Intermediate Value Theorem, IVT)**.** *Let f be continuous on the closed interval $[a, b]$, and let N be any number strictly between $f(a)$ and $f(b)$. Then there exists at least one $c \in (a, b)$ with $f(c) = N$.*

Intermediate Value Theorem: continuous curve crossing $y = N$

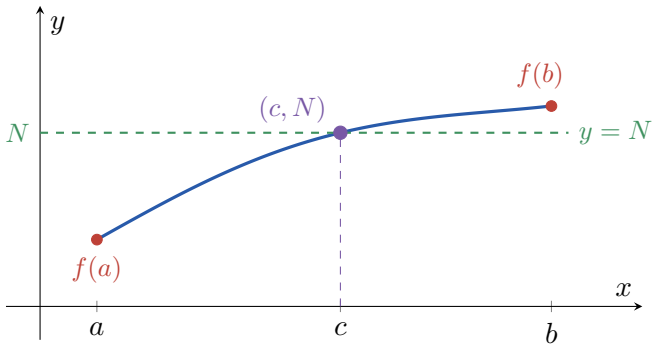


Figure 8.6: The Intermediate Value Theorem. A continuous curve running from height $f(a)$ up to height $f(b)$ must meet every intermediate level N at least once; here it crosses $y = N$ at the point c. For a wigglier curve there could be several crossings, but the theorem guarantees at least one.

8.4.1 The necessity of completeness alongside continuity

Before the proof, a warning that reveals what is really at stake. The IVT is *false* if we work over the rational numbers alone. Consider $f(x) = x^2 - 2$ on $[0, 2]$, restricted to rational inputs. It is "continuous" in the obvious sense, $f(0) = -2 < 0$ and $f(2) = 2 > 0$, yet there is *no rational* c with $f(c) = 0$ — the crossing happens at $\sqrt{2}$, which is not a rational number. The curve sneaks through a gap in the rationals without ever landing on a rational point.

What is really happening

The IVT is not really a theorem about continuity alone. It is a theorem about continuity *plus the absence of gaps in the real line*. That gaplessness has a name: **completeness**, the property that every nonempty set of reals that is bounded above has a least upper bound (a **supremum** — the tightest ceiling above the set, an upper bound smaller than every other upper bound). The rationals fail completeness — the set of rationals whose square is below 2 has no rational least upper bound — and the IVT fails right along with it. The real numbers were, in a sense, *built* to make theorems like the IVT true: $\mathbb{R}$ is the gapless completion of $\mathbb{Q}$. So when we prove the IVT, the decisive step will be the one place we invoke a least upper bound. Watch for it.

8.4.2 Proof by "the last moment it is still below"

There are two standard proofs. One repeatedly bisects the interval, trapping the crossing in shrinking subintervals. The other, which we give, captures the crossing in a single clean stroke using completeness.

Proof. It is enough to handle the case $f(a) < N < f(b)$; the other case ($f(a) > N > f(b)$) follows by applying this one to $-f$ and $-N$. Define

$$S = \{\, x \in [a, b] : f(x) < N \,\}.$$

Think of S as the set of inputs at which the curve is still strictly below the target level. It is nonempty, since $a \in S$ (because $f(a) < N$), and it is bounded above by b. By the **completeness** of $\mathbb{R}$, S has a least upper bound; call it $c = \sup S$. Intuitively, c is *the last moment the curve is still below N* — the exact place where "below" must hand off to "above." We claim $f(c) = N$, and we rule out the only two alternatives.

Suppose $f(c) < N$. Then $c \neq b$ (since $f(b) > N$), so $c < b$. Because f is continuous at c and $f(c)$ is strictly less than N, values of f stay below N on a whole little interval to the right of c: taking $\varepsilon = N - f(c) > 0$, continuity gives a $\delta > 0$ with $f(x) < f(c) + \varepsilon = N$ for all x within δ of c. So some points just to the *right* of c also lie in S. But then c was not an upper bound of S — contradiction. The curve cannot still be below N *and* have room to its right.

Suppose $f(c) > N$. Then $c \neq a$, so $c > a$. By the same continuity argument with $\varepsilon = f(c) - N > 0$, the values of f stay *above* N on a whole little interval around c, including a stretch to the *left* of c. On that stretch no point belongs to S, so $c - \delta$ would already be an upper bound for S — smaller than c, contradicting that c is the *least* upper bound.

Both alternatives are impossible, so the only survivor is $f(c) = N$. And c lies strictly between a and b because $f(a) < N < f(b)$ rules out the endpoints. □

Focus

Notice where each hypothesis is needed in the argument. *Completeness* produced the candidate point $c = \sup S$ — without it, S might have no least upper bound and the proof could not even begin. *Continuity* was used twice, once on each side, to show that the curve cannot be strictly below or strictly above N at c without contradicting how c was chosen. Drop continuity and a jump could leap over N; drop completeness and the crossing could fall into a gap. The theorem lives exactly at the meeting of these two ideas.

8.4.3 Root-finding: using the IVT to locate solutions

The IVT is an *existence* theorem. It does not tell you *where* the crossing is, only that one exists. That modest-sounding guarantee is the foundation of every numerical root-finder.

Corollary 8.1 (Bolzano's sign-change test)**.** *If f is continuous on $[a, b]$ and $f(a)$ and $f(b)$ have opposite signs (one negative, one positive), then f has a root in (a, b): some c with $f(c) = 0$.*

This is just the IVT with $N = 0$: the value 0 lies between a negative number and a positive number, so it is attained.

Reading note

Mental check: the mountain hike. A hiker leaves base camp at 7:00 AM and reaches the summit at noon. The next day, she departs the summit at 7:00 AM along the exact same path and reaches base camp at noon. Must there be a spot along the trail that she passes at the exact same minute on both days? (Hint: consider $D(t) = A(t) - B(t)$, the difference in her positions on the two days, and apply Bolzano's test.)

Example 8.5 (A root of a quintic you cannot solve by formula)**.** Does $p(x) = x^5 + x - 1$ have a real root? There is no algebraic formula for the roots of a general quintic, but we do not need one. p is

a polynomial, hence continuous everywhere. Compute the ends:

$$p(0) = 0 + 0 - 1 = -1 < 0, \qquad p(1) = 1 + 1 - 1 = 1 > 0.$$

Opposite signs across $[0, 1]$, so by Corollary 8.1 there is a root in $(0, 1)$ (Figure 8.7). Existence, established in two arithmetic lines and one theorem, with no formula in sight.

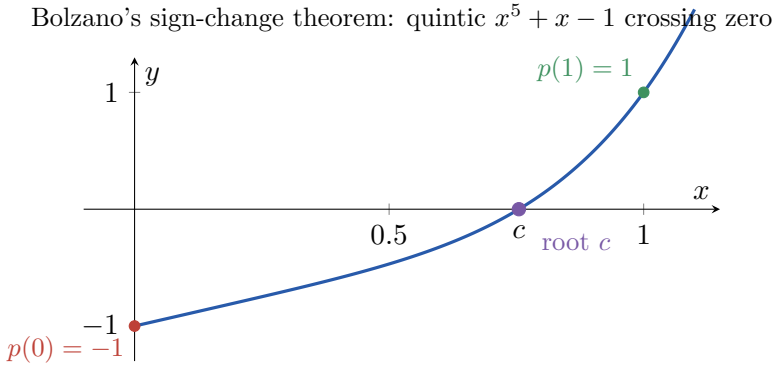


Figure 8.7: The quintic $p(x) = x^5 + x - 1$ on $[0, 1]$. Since $p(0) = -1 < 0$ and $p(1) = 1 > 0$, the continuous curve must cross the axis; the IVT guarantees a root c (here $c \approx 0.755$) even though no algebraic formula produces it.

Work it yourself

Pin that quintic root down by hand using *bisection* — the IVT applied over and over. We know the root lies in $[0, 1]$ since $p(0) < 0 < p(1)$. Test the midpoint:

$$p(0.5) = 0.5^5 + 0.5 - 1 = 0.03125 + 0.5 - 1 = -0.46875 < 0.$$

Same sign as $p(0)$, so the root is in $[0.5, 1]$. Now $p(0.75) = 0.2373 + 0.75 - 1 = -0.0127 < 0$, so the root is in $[0.75, 1]$. Next $p(0.875) \approx 0.5129 + 0.875 - 1 = 0.388 > 0$, so the root is in $[0.75, 0.875]$. Each step halves the interval and the IVT promises the root never escapes. Two more halvings put you near $x \approx 0.755$. You have computed a root of an unsolvable quintic using only arithmetic and a theorem.

Why the technique works

Why is bisection guaranteed to succeed? Each step preserves the property "the endpoints have opposite signs" as an *invariant* (a condition that stays true at every cycle of the algorithm). As long as that invariant holds, the IVT guarantees a root inside the current interval. Halving the interval shrinks its length to $(b-a)/2^n$ after n steps, which tends to 0, so the trapped root is pinned to arbitrary precision. The method cannot fail to converge, because at every stage a root is provably present in a provably shrinking cage. Bisection is the IVT turned into an algorithm.

8.4.4 Fixed points: where a function meets the diagonal

Here is a second use, and a striking one. A **fixed point** of g is an input that g leaves unchanged: $g(c) = c$. Geometrically, it is where the graph of g meets the diagonal line $y = x$.

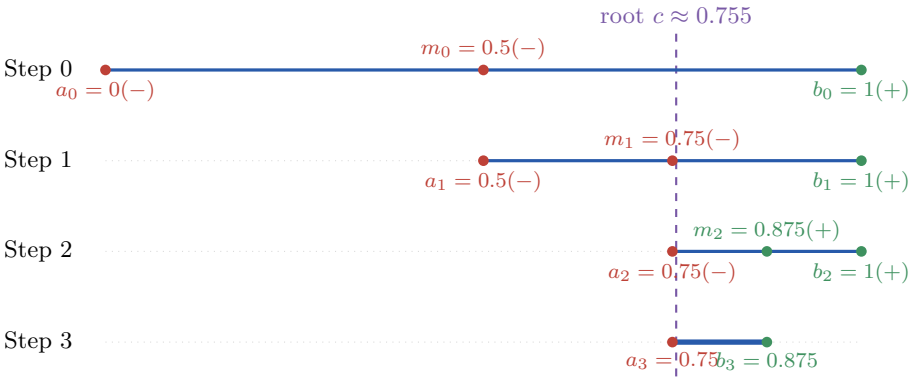


Figure 8.8: The bisection algorithm in action. At each stage the interval is bisected at its midpoint; sign evaluation determines which half preserves opposite signs, halving the cage around the root at every step.

Corollary 8.2 (A fixed-point theorem)**.** *If g is continuous and maps $[a, b]$ into itself — that is, $a \leq g(x) \leq b$ for all $x \in [a, b]$ — then g has a fixed point in $[a, b]$.*

Proof. Consider the auxiliary function $h(x) = g(x) - x$, which is continuous as a difference of continuous functions. At the left end, $g(a) \geq a$ gives $h(a) = g(a) - a \geq 0$. At the right end, $g(b) \leq b$ gives $h(b) = g(b) - b \leq 0$. So h runs from a nonnegative value down to a nonpositive one. If either end is exactly 0 we have our fixed point outright; otherwise $h(a) > 0 > h(b)$, and the IVT hands us a c with $h(c) = 0$, i.e. $g(c) = c$. □

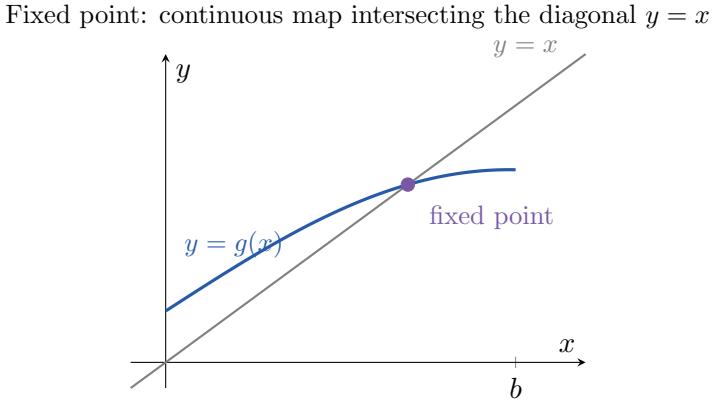


Figure 8.9: A fixed point is a crossing of $y = g(x)$ with the diagonal $y = x$. If a continuous g keeps its outputs inside $[a, b]$, its graph starts on or above the diagonal at a and ends on or below it at b, so it must cross.

Connection

This one-dimensional fixed-point theorem extends to higher dimensions as Brouwer's Fixed-Point Theorem (every continuous map of a closed disk to itself has a fixed point), which underpins the existence of economic equilibria (Nash's equilibrium theorem builds on it) and solutions to differential equations. Picture stirring a cup of coffee gently without splashing:

once it comes to rest, at least one drop sits over the exact spot where it started. Or crumple a paper map of a city and drop it anywhere inside the city limits — one point on the map lies directly above the real-world spot it represents. In one dimension, all of that boils down to a single picture: a continuous curve from $[a, b]$ into $[a, b]$ cannot cross from left to right without meeting the diagonal $y = x$.

8.5 The Extreme Value Theorem

The IVT guarantees a function hits intermediate *values*. Our second great theorem guarantees it hits extreme ones — a genuine highest point and a genuine lowest point — provided we ask on a closed, bounded interval.

Theorem 8.4 (Extreme Value Theorem, EVT)**.** *If f is continuous on a closed bounded interval $[a, b]$, then f attains a maximum and a minimum there: there exist points $p, q \in [a, b]$ with*

$$f(q) \le f(x) \le f(p) \qquad \text{for all } x \in [a, b].$$

The word *attains* is the heart of it. It is not merely that the values stay bounded — it is that the largest value is actually *achieved* by some input p, and the smallest by some input q. The maximum is a value the function truly reaches, and not an unreached ceiling.

8.5.1 Why every hypothesis is necessary

This theorem is fragile: weaken any single condition and it collapses. Studying the failures shows exactly what each word is buying.

- **Drop "closed" (omit an endpoint).** On the *open* interval $(0, 1)$, $f(x) = x$ is continuous but attains neither a max nor a min: it gets arbitrarily close to 1 and to 0 without ever reaching them. The supremum 1 (tightest ceiling) and infimum 0 (tightest floor) exist as bounds but are never *achieved*, because the points that would achieve them were excluded from the domain.
- **Drop "bounded" (let the interval run to infinity).** On $[0, \infty)$, $f(x) = x$ is continuous but has no maximum — it grows without bound. A maximum cannot exist where the values escape to infinity.
- **Drop "continuous."** On $[0, 1]$, let $f(x) = 1/x$ for $x > 0$ and $f(0) = 0$. This is bounded below but shoots to $+\infty$ near 0, so it has no maximum despite living on a perfectly closed bounded interval. A single infinite discontinuity is enough to destroy the conclusion.

Focus

The EVT is the foundation behind all of optimization. Later, when we hunt for maxima and minima by setting derivatives to zero, we will be searching among *candidate* points — critical points and endpoints. But why should a maximum exist among them at all? Because the EVT promises one exists *somewhere*, and a short argument then shows that "somewhere" has to be a critical point or an endpoint. Without the EVT, we would be searching for something that might not exist.

Extreme Value Theorem: global maximum and minimum on $[a, b]$

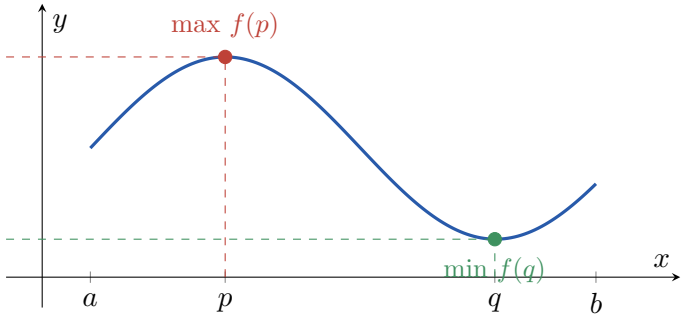


Figure 8.10: The Extreme Value Theorem. A continuous function on a closed bounded interval genuinely reaches a highest value $f(p)$ and a lowest value $f(q)$. The dashed lines mark the ceiling and floor, each *touched* by the curve.

8.5.2 The shape of the argument

A complete proof leans on two facts about continuous functions on $[a, b]$ that are slightly beyond our scope to prove in full, but whose ideas come across clearly enough in outline.

Intuition

Step 1: the function is bounded. First show f cannot run off to $\pm\infty$ on $[a, b]$. The mechanism: if f were unbounded, you could find inputs $x_1, x_2, \ldots$ in $[a, b]$ with $|f(x_n)| \to \infty$. Because $[a, b]$ is closed and bounded, these inputs must *accumulate* somewhere inside it (an infinite subset of them must cluster arbitrarily close to some single point p) — they cannot all spread out to infinity (the interval is finite) and cannot escape out an open end (there is none). Near that accumulation point, continuity forces the f-values to stay close to one finite number, flatly contradicting $|f(x_n)| \to \infty$. So f must be bounded.
Step 2: the bound is achieved. Let M be the least upper bound of the values $f(x)$ — it exists by completeness now that we know the values are bounded. By definition of least upper bound, there are inputs with f-values as close to M as we like; collect such inputs $x_1, x_2, \ldots$ with $f(x_n) \to M$. By the Bolzano–Weierstrass property, we extract a subsequence clustering at some point p in $[a, b]$; continuity at p then forces $f(p) = M$. So the supremum M is actually *attained* at p. Apply the same reasoning to $-f$ to attain the minimum.

What is really happening

Both steps rely on the same key property of $[a, b]$: *any infinite sequence of points in a closed bounded interval has a point it crowds up against, inside the interval.* This is the Bolzano–Weierstrass property, and it is what "closed and bounded" really buys you. "Bounded" keeps the points from escaping to infinity; "closed" keeps the accumulation point from escaping through a missing endpoint. Without both conditions, the accumulation point can vanish — which is precisely why the counterexamples on $(0, 1)$ and $[0, \infty)$ work. Continuity then does the final job: it transfers the accumulation of *inputs* into a statement about *outputs*, letting a limiting value be genuinely reached. The EVT combines compactness (closed and bounded) with continuity.

Connection

The phrase "closed and bounded" is the one-dimensional face of a concept that organizes all of analysis and topology: **compactness**. The grand statement, of which the EVT is a special case, is that *a continuous real-valued function on a compact set attains its maximum and minimum.* Compactness is exactly the abstraction of "no points can escape" that we needed in both steps above. When you later meet compactness in a topology course, you can think back to this chapter: it is the property that makes the Extreme Value Theorem true, distilled to its essence and freed from the real line.

8.6 Why continuity is the right notion of "no jumps"

We close by stepping back. We *defined* continuity by a limit equation, but is that definition the right one — does it really capture "no jumps," nothing more and nothing less? The two big theorems are the evidence.

A function with a jump fails the IVT: the Heaviside step H leaps from 0 to 1 at the origin and skips every value strictly between, like $\frac{1}{2}$. So "jumpy" functions are exactly the ones that can dodge intermediate values, and continuous functions are exactly the ones that cannot. The IVT is, in effect, the theorem that says *our definition of continuity is strong enough to forbid jumps.* Conversely, our gallery showed that every way a function can fail Definition 8.1 — hole, jump, pole, oscillation — is visibly a break in the curve. The definition forbids breaks, and only breaks.

Why this matters

There is a deep economy here worth pausing on. We wanted a geometric idea — an unbroken curve — and we found we could capture it with a single algebraic equation, $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a)$, that mentions no pictures at all. Then that one humble equation, applied with the completeness of $\mathbb{R}$, forced two sweeping existence theorems: every intermediate value is hit (IVT), and extreme values are genuinely attained (EVT). That is a recurring pattern throughout analysis: a clean local rule at each point forces global behavior across an entire interval.

Pause

Before the exercises, a summary of the core ideas: continuity at a means the limit equals the value, which is the precise form of "no jump." Continuity is inherited through sums, products, quotients (away from zeros), and compositions, so almost every function you write down is continuous on its natural domain. On the real line — gapless by completeness — continuity forces the Intermediate Value Theorem (every in-between value is attained, the engine of root-finding and fixed points) and, on closed bounded intervals, the Extreme Value Theorem (max and min are truly reached, the foundation of optimization). Every one of these rests on the same modest equation. If a step ever feels mysterious, return to the picture of a pencil that never leaves the page.

Looking ahead: zooming out to the horizon

Throughout this chapter and the last, our magnifying glass was focused on local behavior at finite points. We asked what happens when x creeps toward a specific number a, and whether the curve knits together without a tear at that single location. The Intermediate Value Theorem and Extreme Value Theorem showed that well-behaved local connections across a bounded stretch $[a, b]$ produce global guarantees: every intermediate height is crossed, and genuine peaks and valleys are reached.

In Chapter 9, we shift from behavior near a single point to behavior in the long run: what happens as $x \to \pm\infty$? Does the graph flatten, follow a slanted line, or blow up without bound? By taking limits at infinity, we will find a function's asymptotes and determine its overall shape.

8.7 Exercises

Exercise 8.1 (Mental checks: continuous or broken?)**.** Answer each with a quick sentence or sketch:

(a) If $f(3) = 7$, must $\lim_{x\to 3} f(x) = 7$?

(b) If $\lim_{x\to 3} f(x) = 7$, must $f(3) = 7$?

(c) If f is continuous on $[0, 1]$ with $f(0) = -2$ and $f(1) = 4$, could $f(x)$ skip 0 and never cross the x-axis?

(d) If f is continuous on the open interval $(0, 1)$, is it guaranteed to attain a maximum value?

(e) Can a function be continuous at every point of its domain if its domain is $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$ and it blows up at $x = 0$?

Exercise 8.2 (Classify the discontinuity)**.** For each function, find every point of discontinuity on $\mathbb{R}$ and classify it as removable, jump, infinite, or oscillatory.

$$\text{(a) } \frac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3}, \quad \text{(b) } \frac{1}{(x-2)^2}, \quad \text{(c) } \frac{|x|}{x}, \quad \text{(d) } \cos\Big(\frac{1}{x}\Big).$$

For any removable case, state the value that repairs it.

Exercise 8.3 (Make it continuous)**.** Find the value of k that makes

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{x^2 - 4}{x - 2}, & x \neq 2, \\ k, & x = 2, \end{cases}$$

continuous at $x = 2$. Then do the same for $g(x) = \dfrac{\sqrt{x+1} - 1}{x}$ at $x = 0$ (rationalize the numerator first).

Exercise 8.4 (Continuity by inheritance)**.** Without using ε and δ, explain why each function is continuous on the stated set, naming which combination or composition laws you use: (a) $\dfrac{\sin x}{x^2 + 1}$ on $\mathbb{R}$; (b) $\sqrt{4 - x^2}$ on $[-2, 2]$; (c) $e^{1/x}$ on $(0, \infty)$.

Exercise 8.5 (A root exists)**.** Show that the equation $\cos x = x$ has a solution in $\big[0, \frac{\pi}{2}\big]$. (Hint: apply the IVT to $h(x) = \cos x - x$ and check the endpoints.) Then use one bisection step to locate the solution in a smaller interval.

Exercise 8.6 (A fixed point in the wild)**.** Let $g(x) = \frac{1}{2}\cos x$. Show g maps the interval $[-1, 1]$ into itself and is continuous, hence has a fixed point there. What equation does the fixed point satisfy?

Exercise 8.7 (An interval always has a midpoint value)**.** Suppose f is continuous on $[a, b]$. Prove there is a point $c \in [a, b]$ with

$$f(c) = \frac{f(a) + f(b)}{2}.$$

(The average of the two endpoint heights lies between them.) Is the same true for $\frac{f(a)+2f(b)}{3}$? Explain.

Exercise 8.8 (Every hypothesis matters)**.** Give an explicit example of a function that is continuous on the half-open interval $(0, 1]$ and is *unbounded* there, showing the EVT genuinely needs the left endpoint. Then give a function continuous and bounded on $(0, 1]$ that nonetheless attains no maximum.

Exercise 8.9 (The temperature on a great circle, a proof)**.** Temperature varies continuously along the equator. Prove there exist two diametrically opposite points on the equator with exactly the same temperature. Model the equator by $[0, 2\pi]$ with $T(0) = T(2\pi)$, and apply the IVT to the function $D(\theta) = T(\theta + \pi) - T(\theta)$ on $[0, \pi]$. (Hint: examine $D(0)$ and $D(\pi)$ and notice they have opposite signs unless one is already zero.)

Exercise 8.10 (A continuous bijection's inverse, conceptual)**.** Argue, using the IVT, that a continuous function on an interval that is one-to-one (meaning different inputs always produce different outputs) must be strictly monotonic (always increasing or always decreasing). (Hint: if it rose then fell, the IVT would force it to repeat a value, contradicting one-to-oneness.) This explains why continuous invertible functions have continuous inverses — a fact we will use when differentiating $\ln x$ and $\arcsin x$.

Exercise 8.11 (Prove a combination law)**.** Using only Definition 8.1 and the limit laws, prove carefully that if f and g are continuous at a then fg is continuous at a. Then explain in one sentence why your proof breaks down for f/g when $g(a) = 0$.

Exercise 8.12 (Dirichlet's nowhere-continuous function, a challenge)**.** Let $D(x) = 1$ if x is rational and $D(x) = 0$ if x is irrational. Show D is discontinuous at *every* real number. (Hint: in any interval, however small, there are both rationals and irrationals, so the values 0 and 1 both occur arbitrarily close to any point, and no single limit can exist.) This function has no points of continuity at all — the opposite extreme from the well-behaved functions of this chapter.

Chapter 9

Limits at Infinity and Asymptotes

In Chapter 8, we harnessed limits to establish *continuity*—the guarantee that a curve flows without sudden tears, jumps, or fractures, enabling the Intermediate Value Theorem to trap roots with certainty. In all those investigations, our limits asked an inherently local question: as x creeps toward some finite landmark a, where does $f(x)$ head?

In this chapter we ask a global question instead. *Where does the function go in the long run?* Does the curve approach a horizontal line? Does it grow without bound? Does it approach a slanted line?

This is the study of **end behavior**—the overall trajectory of a curve as the input heads out toward positive or negative infinity. Its natural language is the **limit at infinity**. It is also the study of **asymptotes**—straight lines that a curve draws arbitrarily close to as you travel far along it or approach a point where the function grows without bound. Asymptotes act like the outer frame of a graph: sketch them first, and you see the curve's long-range shape before plotting a single point. Reading end behavior also lets us compare how fast different families of functions grow — a comparison that shows up everywhere from algorithm runtimes to differential equations and physics.

9.1 What "Limit at Infinity" Really Means

When we wrote $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ for a finite a, the symbol $x \to a$ meant "x gets arbitrarily close to a." But ∞ is not a number, and x cannot get *close* to it — there is nothing to get close to. So we have to say precisely what the new symbol asserts.

What is really happening

The statement $\lim_{x\to\infty} f(x) = L$ does **not** say that x arrives anywhere. It is a promise about the long run:

No matter how tight a tolerance you demand around L, I can name a starting point far enough to the right so that, from there on, $f(x)$ stays inside that tolerance.

There is no last value of x, no destination. There is only the guarantee that *eventually and forever after*, the output is pinned near L. The whole content of "$x \to \infty$" is the word *eventually*.

Here is the precise version, the exact analogue of the ε–δ definition but with the role of "close to a" played by "far to the right."

Definition 9.1 (Limit at infinity)**.** We write $\lim_{x\to\infty} f(x) = L$ if: for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists a real number M such that

$$x > M \quad \Longrightarrow \quad |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon.$$

Likewise $\lim_{x\to-\infty} f(x) = L$ if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is an M with $x < M \implies |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$.

Compare this with the finite-a definition. There, ε bought you a δ and you looked inside the window $0 < |x - a| < \delta$. Here, ε buys you a threshold M and you look at the entire tail $x > M$. The picture is not a shrinking window around a point; it is a horizontal corridor of half-width ε around the height L, and the claim is that the graph enters that corridor and never leaves.

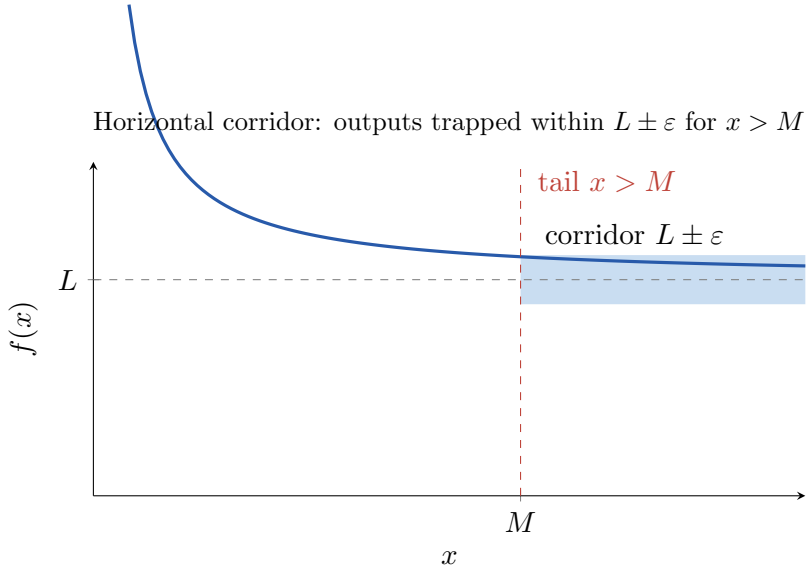


Figure 9.1: A limit at infinity. Once x passes the threshold M, the graph is trapped inside the corridor of half-width ε around the height L. Shrink ε and you may need a larger M, but such an M always exists.

Work it yourself

Show directly from Definition 9.1 that $\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{1}{x} = 0$. Given $\varepsilon > 0$, we need $x > M \implies |1/x - 0| < \varepsilon$, i.e. $1/x < \varepsilon$ (for $x > 0$), i.e. $x > 1/\varepsilon$. So *choose* $M = 1/\varepsilon$. Then any $x > M$ satisfies $1/x < 1/M = \varepsilon$. Done. Notice how M depends on ε: demand a tolerance ten times tighter and your threshold moves ten times farther out. That is the whole mechanism.

9.1.1 Infinite limits: when the output runs away

There is a second, completely different way for a function to behave badly: the *output* can blow up. We already met this near vertical features like $1/x$ at $x = 0$. Let us pin down the language, because "$= \infty$" is another phrase that needs a careful reading.

Definition 9.2 (Infinite limit)**.** We write $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = +\infty$ if for every $N > 0$ there is a $\delta > 0$ such that

$$0 < |x - a| < \delta \quad \Longrightarrow \quad f(x) > N.$$

That is: name any height N, however large, and the graph eventually climbs above it and stays above it as x closes in on a. The case $-\infty$ and the cases $x \to \pm\infty$ are defined by the obvious changes.

Common trap

The notation $\lim f(x) = \infty$ is a **symbolic shorthand**. There is no real number ∞ that the limit equals. Strictly, the limit *does not exist* as a real number — we are describing *how* it fails to exist: not by oscillating, not by jumping, but by growing without bound. Treat "$= \infty$" as a description meaning "increases beyond every bound," never as an arithmetic value you can add or divide.

History

The struggle to make infinite behavior rigorous was the central drama of nineteenth-century analysis. Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz computed with quantities that were "ultimately" vanishing or "infinitely" large, obtaining correct physical results by sure instinct. But the foundation was shaky: nobody could say what an actual infinity or infinitesimal *was*. The repair came in stages. In 1817, Bernard Bolzano in Prague began removing vague notions of motion and time, defining continuity through static bounds. In the 1820s, Augustin-Louis Cauchy advanced this shift, framing limits as values that variable quantities approach. Finally in Berlin during the 1860s, Karl Weierstrass supplied the complete modern grammar — the ε, the δ, and (for our chapter) the threshold M. Under Weierstrass's formulation, the phrase "$x \to \infty$" contains no actual infinite number. It is an ordinary, checkable inequality about finite quantities: given any target window $\varepsilon > 0$, any input $x > M$ keeps $|f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$. Definition 9.1 is Weierstrass's gift: a way to talk about the infinite using only finite numbers.

9.2 Horizontal Asymptotes

A horizontal asymptote is simply a finite limit at infinity, read off the graph.

Definition 9.3 (Horizontal asymptote)**.** The line $y = L$ is a **horizontal asymptote** of f if $\lim_{x\to\infty} f(x) = L$ or $\lim_{x\to-\infty} f(x) = L$ (or both).

A few things worth saying out loud, because each contradicts a common belief.

- A graph **may cross its horizontal asymptote**, even infinitely often. The asymptote describes the *tail*, not a barrier. The function $f(x) = \dfrac{\sin x}{x}$ crosses $y = 0$ at every nonzero multiple of π yet still has $y = 0$ as a horizontal asymptote, because the crossings get ever smaller.
- A function can have **two different** horizontal asymptotes, one to the right and one to the left. We will meet $\arctan x$ and the logistic curve, which level off at different heights in the two directions.
- Having a horizontal asymptote is a statement about ends only. It says nothing about what happens in the middle, where the function may do anything.

Damped oscillation: $\frac{\sin x}{x}$ repeatedly crossing its asymptote $y = 0$

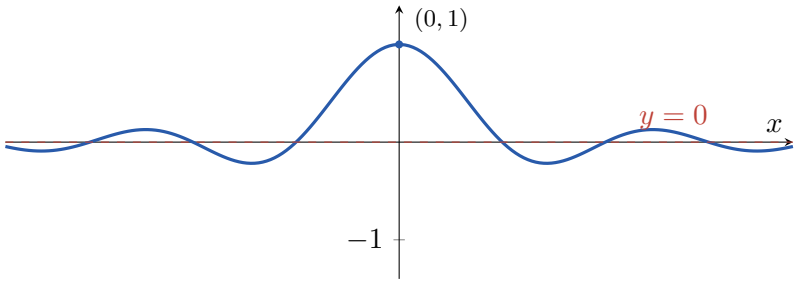


Figure 9.2: $f(x) = \sin(x)/x$ crosses its horizontal asymptote $y = 0$ at every nonzero multiple of π. The asymptote governs the *tail*, not a forbidden line. The wiggles decay because the amplitude $1/|x|$ shrinks.

9.2.1 Two asymptotes, one curve: the inverse tangent and the logistic

Some of the most important curves in science have a floor on one side and a ceiling on the other. The inverse tangent function $\arctan x$—which takes a slope and returns the unique angle between $-\pi/2$ and $\pi/2$ having that slope—levels off at $\pi/2$ as $x \to +\infty$ and at $-\pi/2$ as $x \to -\infty$. The logistic function $\sigma(x) = \dfrac{1}{1+e^{-x}}$—a smooth S-shaped curve that models population growth approaching a carrying capacity and probabilities in machine-learning classifiers—rises from the floor $y = 0$ on the far left to the ceiling $y = 1$ on the far right. In both cases the graph is bounded between two horizontal lines.

Two distinct horizontal asymptotes: logistic sigmoidal saturation

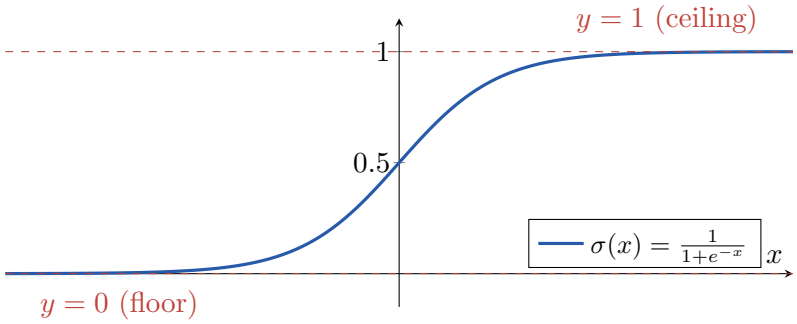


Figure 9.3: The logistic curve $\sigma(x)$ has two horizontal asymptotes: a floor at $y = 0$ (as $x \to -\infty$) and a ceiling at $y = 1$ (as $x \to +\infty$). Most saturating processes in nature look like this.

Application

Why classifiers love the ceiling and floor. A neural network outputs a raw score z that can be any real number, but a probability must live in $[0, 1]$. Passing z through σ squashes it: huge positive z saturates near 1 ("confident yes"), huge negative z saturates near 0 ("confident no"). The two horizontal asymptotes are precisely what make σ a sensible probability. The same shape models a population approaching its carrying capacity, a chemical reaction approaching completion, or a rumor saturating a town — anything that grows fast at first and then runs out of room.

Pause

Pause and think: Settling down versus endless oscillation. Does $f(x) = \cos x$ have a horizontal asymptote as $x \to \infty$? What about $g(x) = \dfrac{\cos x}{x^2}$?
Answer: As $x \to \infty$, $\cos x$ waves endlessly between -1 and $+1$. It never settles into any narrow horizontal corridor of half-width $\varepsilon = 0.1$, so it has **no** horizontal asymptote. But $g(x) = \dfrac{\cos x}{x^2}$ is trapped between $-\dfrac{1}{x^2}$ and $+\dfrac{1}{x^2}$. Since both envelope curves squeeze toward 0, the Squeeze Theorem forces $g(x)$ to flatten onto $y = 0$. Oscillation alone does not prevent an asymptote, provided the amplitude dies out.

9.3 Vertical Asymptotes

A horizontal asymptote happens because x ran off to infinity. A **vertical** asymptote is the opposite: x stays at a finite spot, but the *output* runs to infinity.

Definition 9.4 (Vertical asymptote)**.** The line $x = a$ is a **vertical asymptote** of f if at least one of the one-sided limits $\lim_{x\to a^+} f(x)$ or $\lim_{x\to a^-} f(x)$ is $+\infty$ or $-\infty$.

The usual culprit is a denominator that hits zero while the numerator does not. Near such a point the fraction has a fixed, nonzero amount on top divided by a vanishing amount on the bottom, and "fixed over tiny" is "huge." The sign on each side tells you whether the cliff goes up or down.

Work it yourself

Find the vertical asymptote of $f(x) = \dfrac{x+2}{x-3}$ and its two-sided behavior. The denominator vanishes at $x = 3$, where the numerator is $5 \neq 0$, so $x = 3$ is a vertical asymptote. Now test the signs. Just to the *right* of 3, say $x = 3.01$: top $\approx 5 > 0$, bottom $= 0.01 > 0$, ratio $\approx +500$, so $f \to +\infty$. Just to the *left*, $x = 2.99$: top ≈ 5, bottom $= -0.01 < 0$, ratio ≈ -500, so $f \to -\infty$. The curve dives down on the left of the cliff and rockets up on the right.

Common trap

A zero in the denominator does not guarantee a vertical asymptote. If the numerator vanishes there too, the factor may cancel and leave only a *hole*. Consider $g(x) = \dfrac{x^2-9}{x-3} = \dfrac{(x-3)(x+3)}{x-3}$. For $x \neq 3$ this equals $x + 3$, a perfectly tame line with a single missing point at $(3, 6)$. No cliff — just a puncture. Always factor and cancel *before* declaring an asymptote. Asymptote when the zero survives in the bottom; hole when it cancels.

9.4 Dominant-Term Reasoning for Rational Functions

How did we know the horizontal asymptote in Figure 9.4 was $y = 1$? There is a fast, intuitive method that works for every **rational function**—a fraction formed by dividing one polynomial by another, $p(x)/q(x)$—and, once understood, frees you from memorizing a table of cases.

Duality of asymptotes: vertical ($x = 3$) and horizontal ($y = 1$)

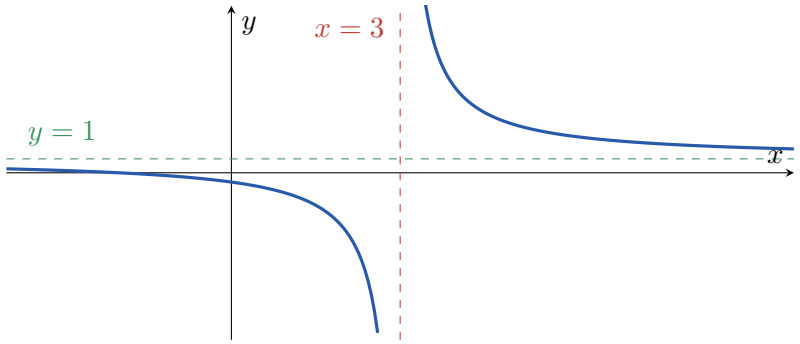


Figure 9.4: $f(x) = \frac{x+2}{x-3}$ has a vertical asymptote at $x = 3$ (output runs off) and a horizontal asymptote at $y = 1$ (input runs off). The two kinds of asymptote are dual: one freezes x and lets y escape, the other freezes the level and lets x escape.

Intuition

When x is large, a polynomial is **dominated by its highest-degree term**. In $3x^2 + 50x + 9000$, plug in $x = 10^6$: the $3x^2$ term is 3×10^{12}, while $50x = 5 \times 10^7$ and the constant 9000 are negligible in comparison. The leading term determines the long-run growth. So for end behavior, *keep only the leading term of the top and the leading term of the bottom, and simplify.*

Why the technique works

Why dominant-term reasoning is exact and rigorous. Take $f(x) = \dfrac{3x^2 + 50x + 9000}{x^2 - 7}$. Divide top and bottom by x^2, the highest power present:

$$f(x) = \frac{3 + \dfrac{50}{x} + \dfrac{9000}{x^2}}{1 - \dfrac{7}{x^2}}.$$

For $x \neq 0$, this is an exact algebraic identity rather than an approximation. Now every term with an x in the denominator $\to 0$ as $x \to \infty$, by the $1/x \to 0$ fact we proved by hand. So the whole thing tends to $\dfrac{3 + 0 + 0}{1 - 0} = 3$. The shortcut of keeping leading terms simply summarizes this division. Dividing by the dominant power is the formal mechanism that justifies it.

The general rule falls out of comparing the **degree** of the numerator p with the degree of the denominator q—the highest power of x appearing in each polynomial. Let $\deg p = n$ with leading coefficient a, and $\deg q = m$ with leading coefficient b.

Focus

End behavior of $\dfrac{p(x)}{q(x)}$ as $x \to \pm\infty$.

- **Bottom wins** ($n < m$): the fraction $\to 0$. Horizontal asymptote $y = 0$. (The numerator grows more slowly than the denominator.)
- **Tie** ($n = m$): the fraction $\to a/b$, the ratio of leading coefficients. Horizontal asymptote $y = a/b$.
- **Top wins** ($n > m$): the fraction $\to \pm\infty$. No horizontal asymptote. If $n = m+1$ exactly, there is instead a *slant* asymptote (next section).

Example 9.1 (All three cases at once)**.**

$$\frac{2x+1}{x^2+5} \to 0 \quad (n=1<m=2), \qquad \frac{4x^2-x}{2x^2+3} \to \frac{4}{2}=2 \quad (n=m=2),$$

$$\frac{x^3}{x^2+1} \to \pm\infty \quad (n=3>m=2).$$

For the middle one, the horizontal asymptote is $y = 2$ in *both* directions, since the leading coefficients do not care about the sign of x when both degrees are even and equal.

Common trap

When degrees *tie*, students sometimes answer "1" by reflex, as if the leading x's simply cancel. They do not: you keep the *coefficients*. In $\frac{4x^2-x}{2x^2+3}$ the limit is $4/2 = 2$, not 1. And the lower-degree terms ($-x$ and $+3$) are genuinely irrelevant to the limit — but only to the *limit*. They still bend the curve before it settles.

Walking question

Without computing, decide the end behavior of each, just by eyeing leading terms: $\dfrac{x^4-100x}{3x^4+1}$, $\dfrac{7x}{x^3-x}$, $\dfrac{x^2-1}{x+1}$. (Answers: $\to \frac{1}{3}$; $\to 0$; the last one cancels to $x-1$ for $x \neq -1$, so it heads to $\pm\infty$ along a line — a slant asymptote.)

9.4.1 Roots and other non-polynomial tops

Dominant-term reasoning extends far beyond polynomials. Whenever you can identify the fastest-growing piece on top and on bottom, the same divide trick works — you just have to be careful about signs under square roots.

Example 9.2 (A square root that needs care)**.** Find $\lim_{x\to\pm\infty} \dfrac{\sqrt{4x^2+1}}{x+3}$. The dominant piece on top is $\sqrt{4x^2} = 2|x|$, and on the bottom it is x. Divide top and bottom by x. The subtlety: $\sqrt{4x^2+1}/x = \pm\sqrt{4+1/x^2}$, where the sign is $+$ if $x > 0$ and $-$ if $x < 0$, because $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$. Hence

$$x \to +\infty: \quad \frac{\sqrt{4+1/x^2}}{1+3/x} \to \frac{\sqrt{4}}{1} = 2, \qquad x \to -\infty: \quad \frac{-\sqrt{4+1/x^2}}{1+3/x} \to -2.$$

Two different horizontal asymptotes, $y = 2$ and $y = -2$, born entirely from the $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$ sign rule.

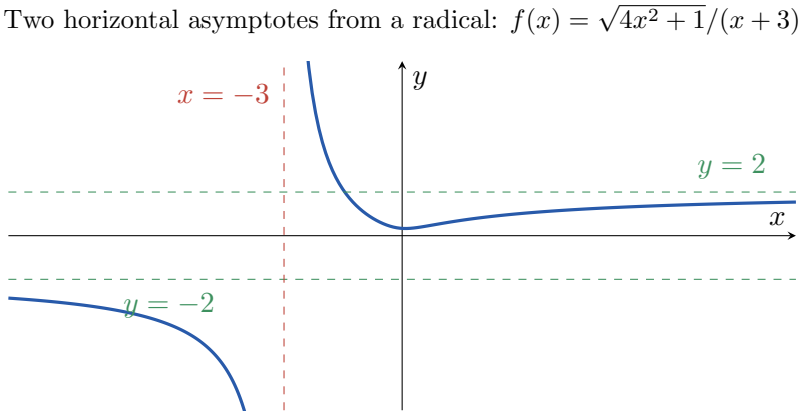


Figure 9.5: The square-root function $f(x) = \frac{\sqrt{4x^2+1}}{x+3}$ of Example 9.2. Because $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$, dividing by x produces $+1$ on the right and -1 on the left, splitting the long-run behavior into two distinct horizontal asymptotes: $y = 2$ as $x \to +\infty$ and $y = -2$ as $x \to -\infty$. The vertical asymptote at $x = -3$ occurs where the denominator vanishes.

Common trap

$\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$, **not** x. For $x \to -\infty$ this single fact flips a sign and gives you the second asymptote. Forgetting it is the most common error in limits-at-infinity with radicals. When dividing by x inside a square root, you are really dividing by $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$, so a minus sign appears on the negative side.

Pause

Pause and think: Spotting signs under a radical. What is $\lim_{x\to-\infty} \dfrac{5x}{\sqrt{x^2+4}}$? Try it mentally before dividing.
Answer: As $x \to -\infty$, the numerator $5x$ is negative, while the square root in the denominator is always non-negative. The ratio of dominant terms is $\dfrac{5x}{\sqrt{x^2}} = \dfrac{5x}{|x|} = \dfrac{5x}{-x} = -5$. Checking the overall sign up front keeps that minus sign from slipping past you.

Example 9.3 (A sneaky difference of roots)**.** Find $\lim_{x\to\infty}\left(\sqrt{x^2+x}-x\right)$. As written this is "$\infty-\infty$," which decides nothing. Multiply by the **conjugate**—the partner expression with the minus sign flipped to a plus sign, $\sqrt{x^2+x}+x$—divided by itself:

$$\sqrt{x^2+x}-x = \frac{(\sqrt{x^2+x}-x)(\sqrt{x^2+x}+x)}{\sqrt{x^2+x}+x} = \frac{x^2+x-x^2}{\sqrt{x^2+x}+x} = \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2+x}+x}.$$

Now divide top and bottom by x (using $\sqrt{x^2+x}/x = \sqrt{1+1/x}$ for $x > 0$):

$$= \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+1/x}+1} \longrightarrow \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+1}} = \frac{1}{2}.$$

The two huge quantities differ by a finite gap of $\frac{1}{2}$ in the limit. The conjugate trick converts a hopeless $\infty - \infty$ into a clean ratio where dominant terms can speak.

9.5 Slant (Oblique) Asymptotes

When the top of a rational function out-grows the bottom by exactly one degree, the curve does not flatten and does not merely blow up vertically. Instead it approaches a *slanted line*. A **slant asymptote** (sometimes called an **oblique asymptote**) is a non-horizontal straight line $y = mx + b$ ($m \neq 0$) that the curve draws arbitrarily close to as x heads out to positive or negative infinity.

Intuition

A slant asymptote is what polynomial *long division* sees. Dividing $p(x)$ by $q(x)$ when $\deg p = \deg q + 1$ gives a linear quotient $mx + b$ plus a proper remainder $r(x)/q(x)$:

$$\frac{p(x)}{q(x)} = \underbrace{mx + b}_{\text{the line}} + \underbrace{\frac{r(x)}{q(x)}}_{\to 0}.$$

The remainder term has a smaller-degree top than bottom, so by the "bottom wins" rule it vanishes at infinity. What is left in the long run is exactly the line $y = mx + b$. **The quotient of long division is the asymptote.**

Example 9.4 (Finding a slant asymptote by division)**.** Consider $f(x) = \dfrac{x^2 + 2x - 1}{x - 1}$. Degree 2 over degree 1: expect a slant. Long-divide:

$$x^2 + 2x - 1 = (x - 1)(x + 3) + 2, \qquad \text{so} \qquad f(x) = x + 3 + \frac{2}{x - 1}.$$

As $x \to \pm\infty$ the remainder $\dfrac{2}{x-1} \to 0$, so $f(x)$ approaches the line $y = x + 3$. The sign of $\dfrac{2}{x-1}$ also tells you *which side* of the line the curve rides: positive (above the line) for $x > 1$, negative (below) for $x < 1$. There is also a vertical asymptote at $x = 1$, where the remainder itself blows up.

Slant asymptote: long-division quotient $y = x + 3$ taming degree-2 rational curve

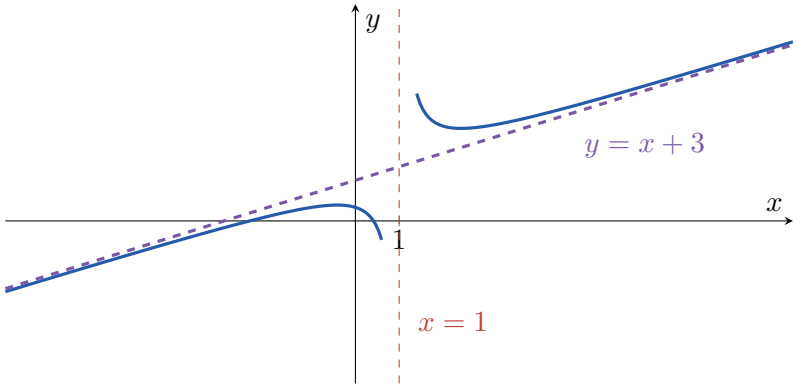


Figure 9.6: $f(x) = \frac{x^2+2x-1}{x-1}$ has a slant asymptote $y = x + 3$ and a vertical asymptote $x = 1$. Far out, the curve is indistinguishable from the tilted line; the gap between them is the remainder $2/(x - 1)$, which melts away.

Why the technique works

Why "the quotient is the asymptote" is an exact theorem. Two functions f and g are *asymptotic* if $f(x) - g(x) \to 0$ as $x \to \infty$ — their graphs become indistinguishable. Long division writes $f = (mx+b) + \text{remainder}$ with remainder $\to 0$, which is *exactly* the statement $f(x) - (mx+b) \to 0$. So the line $mx+b$ is asymptotic to f by definition. The same logic shows the asymptote need not be a line at all: if the top exceeds the bottom by two degrees, the quotient is a *parabola*, and the curve hugs that parabola at infinity. People rarely name these "parabolic asymptotes," but the mechanism is identical — whatever the polynomial quotient is, the curve becomes it.

Common trap

A graph has a slant asymptote **or** a horizontal asymptote, never both in the same direction — a line is either tilted or level. If $\deg p = \deg q$ you get a horizontal asymptote; if $\deg p = \deg q + 1$ you get a slant one; if the gap is 2 or more there is no straight-line asymptote at all. Always compare degrees *first* to know which question you are even asking.

Walking question

Quick degree check: Slant, level, or curved? Before carrying out any division, decide the nature of the asymptote at infinity for each: (1) $f(x) = \dfrac{x^3+1}{x^2-4}$, (2) $g(x) = \dfrac{x^4-2}{x^2+1}$, (3) $h(x) = \dfrac{3x^2+5}{x^2-1}$.

Answer: Compare the degrees $\deg p$ and $\deg q$. In (1), $\deg p - \deg q = 3 - 2 = 1$: the degree gap is exactly 1, so f has a **slant asymptote** (dividing yields $y = x$). In (2), the gap is $4 - 2 = 2$: the quotient is quadratic, so g has a **parabolic asymptote** ($y = x^2 - 1$), not a line. In (3), the degrees tie ($2 = 2$), so h flattens onto a **horizontal asymptote** ($y = 3$). Checking degrees first prevents wasted algebra.

9.6 Growth Rates Revisited: Who Wins the Long Race?

Dominant-term reasoning settled contests *within* the polynomials. But the deepest and most useful comparisons are *across* families: logarithms versus powers versus exponentials. These three grow at wildly different speeds, and the pecking order never changes once x is large enough.

Focus

The growth hierarchy (for large x).

$$\ln x \ll x^p \ (p > 0) \ll a^x \ (a > 1) \ll x! \ll x^x.$$

Here $f \ll g$ means $\dfrac{f(x)}{g(x)} \to 0$ as $x \to \infty$: f is utterly outpaced by g. Logarithmic growth is slower than any polynomial power, polynomial growth is slower than exponential growth, and exponentials are surpassed by factorials. Every exponential, no matter how gentle its base (say 1.000001^x), eventually overtakes every power, no matter how steep (say x^{1000}).

The claim is important enough, and counterintuitive enough, to earn a proof rather than a slogan. Here is *why* the exponential always wins.

Intuition

Why exponentials beat powers: constant percentage versus constant amount. A power like x^2 grows by an ever-smaller *percentage* as x climbs — going from 100 to 101 barely budges x^2 in relative terms. An exponential like 2^x grows by a *fixed percentage* (100% per unit step) forever. Fixed-percentage growth compounds; eventually-shrinking-percentage growth cannot keep up.

Theorem 9.1 (Exponential dominates every power)**.** *For every fixed $p > 0$ and every $a > 1$,*

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{x^p}{a^x} = 0.$$

Proof. The cleanest path is through logarithms, which turn the lopsided ratio into a manageable difference. Take logs of the ratio:

$$\ln\left(\frac{x^p}{a^x}\right) = p\ln x - x\ln a.$$

We will show this $\to -\infty$; then the ratio itself, being e to that power, $\to 0$. Factor out x:

$$p\ln x - x\ln a = x\left(\frac{p\ln x}{x} - \ln a\right).$$

Here $\ln a > 0$ is a fixed positive constant. So everything hinges on the term $\dfrac{\ln x}{x}$. If we can show $\dfrac{\ln x}{x} \to 0$, then the bracket tends to $0 - \ln a = -\ln a < 0$, while the factor $x \to +\infty$; a positive-going x times a negative-bounded bracket gives $-\infty$. So it remains only to prove the central fact: $\ln x/x \to 0$.

Base bound: $\ln x \ll x$. We want an explicit upper bound on $\ln x$ for $x \geq 1$. From Chapter 3 (Figure 3.5), the upward-bending curve e^u sits on or above its slope-1 tangent line $1+u$ for every $u \geq 0$ (a bound we will prove analytically in Chapter 16). Setting $u = \frac{1}{2}\ln x \geq 0$ gives $e^u = e^{(\ln x)/2} = \sqrt{x}$, so

$$\sqrt{x} \;=\; e^u \;\geq\; 1+u \;>\; u \;=\; \frac{1}{2}\ln x, \qquad \text{hence} \qquad \ln x < 2\sqrt{x}.$$

(In the area preview of Chapter 3, where $\ln x = \int_1^x \frac{1}{t}\,\mathrm{d}t$, this is the geometric fact that $\frac{1}{t} \leq \frac{1}{\sqrt{t}}$ on $[1, x]$, whose exact area we will compute in Chapter 21 as $\int_1^x t^{-1/2}\,\mathrm{d}t = 2\sqrt{x} - 2 < 2\sqrt{x}$.) Dividing by $x > 0$ gives $0 \leq \dfrac{\ln x}{x} < \dfrac{2\sqrt{x}}{x} = \dfrac{2}{\sqrt{x}} \to 0$, so $\dfrac{\ln x}{x} \to 0$ by the Squeeze Theorem. That bound — $\ln x < 2\sqrt{x}$ — shows that the logarithm grows slower than even a square root, let alone x itself. Feeding this back, $\dfrac{p\ln x}{x} \to 0$, the bracket $\to -\ln a < 0$, the product $\to -\infty$, and the original ratio $\to 0$. □

What is really happening

What the logarithm trick is really doing. Exponentials and powers live on different scales, and dividing them directly is like comparing a sprinter's position to a walker's — both numbers race off to infinity and the ratio is a ∞/∞ blur. The logarithm *changes the ruler*: it converts multiplicative growth into additive growth, a^x into the straight line $x \ln a$, and x^p into the slow curve $p \ln x$. On this new ruler the contest is between a *line* and a *logarithm*, and the line grows dramatically faster. Taking logs is the standard move whenever you must compare two runaway quantities: it tames both at once.

Connection

Big-O and the speed of algorithms. Computer science lives on this hierarchy. An algorithm that does $\ln n$ work (binary search) is extremely fast; n or $n \ln n$ (a good sort) is fine; n^2 (a naive sort) is sluggish on big inputs; and 2^n (brute-forcing every subset) is hopeless past a few dozen items. The symbol "$f = O(g)$" means f grows *no faster than* a constant times g — a bounded ratio — and "$f = o(g)$" is exactly our $f \ll g$. The same limits that shape a curve's tail decide whether a program finishes before the sun burns out.

Work it yourself

Numerical comparison of growth rates. Compare x^{10} against 2^x at a few points. At $x = 10$: $x^{10} = 10^{10} = 10{,}000{,}000{,}000$ while $2^{10} = 1024$ — the power is ahead by seven orders of magnitude. At $x = 60$: $2^{60} \approx 1.15 \times 10^{18}$ while $60^{10} \approx 6.0 \times 10^{17}$ — the exponential has just pulled even. Beyond that point, 2^x grows much faster than x^{10}. The crossover is late, but it is inevitable. That delay is exactly why the behavior can appear settled for small inputs while the asymptotic truth is the exact opposite.

Example 9.5 (Putting the hierarchy to work)**.** Evaluate each by spotting the dominant family.

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{x^{100}}{e^x} = 0 \quad \text{(exp beats power)}, \qquad \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{\ln x}{x^{0.001}} = 0 \quad \text{(power beats log)},$$

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{3^x + x^5}{3^x - 100} = \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{1 + x^5/3^x}{1 - 100/3^x} = \frac{1+0}{1-0} = 1.$$

In the last one we divided by the dominant term 3^x, then used $x^5/3^x \to 0$ (exp beats power) and $100/3^x \to 0$. Same dominant-term strategy as for rational functions — only now the "leading term" is the fastest-growing *family*, not the highest power.

9.7 Reading a Graph From Its Asymptotes

Put the pieces together. Given a rational function (or any function whose tails you can analyze), a short checklist lets you sketch an accurate silhouette before plotting careful points.

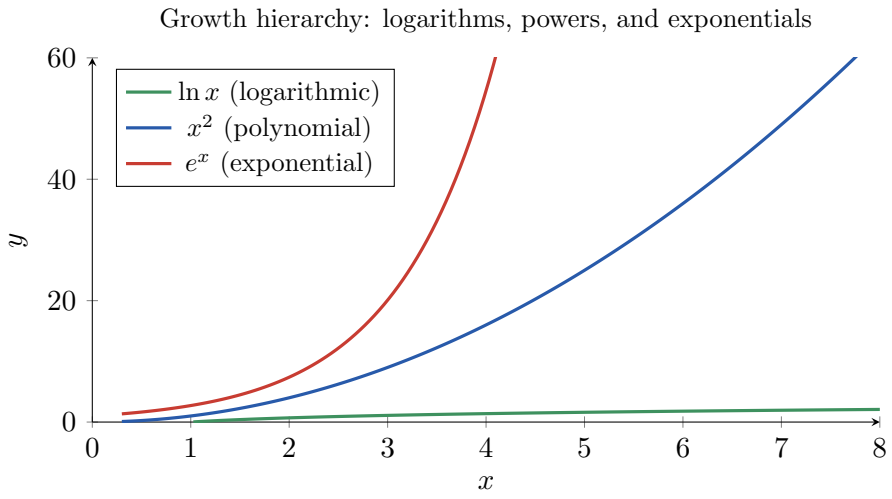


Figure 9.7: The growth hierarchy on one set of axes. For small x the relative order may appear ambiguous, but e^x quickly overtakes x^2, which grows much faster than $\ln x$. As x increases, the gap widens dramatically.

Focus

Asymptote checklist for $f(x) = p(x)/q(x)$.

1. **Factor** top and bottom. Cancel common factors — each cancellation is a *hole*, not an asymptote.
2. **Vertical asymptotes:** the surviving zeros of the denominator. Check the sign on each side to see if the cliff goes up or down.
3. **Horizontal/slant:** compare degrees. $n < m \Rightarrow y = 0$; $n = m \Rightarrow y = a/b$; $n = m+1 \Rightarrow$ slant (do the division); $n > m+1 \Rightarrow$ no line asymptote.
4. **Intercepts:** x-intercepts are the surviving zeros of the *numerator*; the y-intercept is $f(0)$ if defined.
5. **Sketch** the asymptotes as dashed lines first, then thread the curve through the intercepts and into the correct corners.

Example 9.6 (A full reading)**.** Sketch $f(x) = \dfrac{x^2-4}{x^2-1}$. *Factor:* $f(x) = \dfrac{(x-2)(x+2)}{(x-1)(x+1)}$ — no common factors, so no holes. *Vertical asymptotes:* $x = 1$ and $x = -1$. *Horizontal:* degrees tie ($n = m = 2$) with leading coefficients 1 and 1, so $y = 1$. *Intercepts:* zeros of the numerator give $x = \pm 2$; and $f(0) = \dfrac{-4}{-1} = 4$, the y-intercept. With two vertical asymptotes, a horizontal asymptote $y = 1$ at both ends, and the curve pinned through $(\pm 2, 0)$ and $(0, 4)$, the entire shape is determined. The middle branch has a local minimum at $(0, 4)$, staying strictly above the asymptote $y = 1$.

Why this matters

Notice the economy. We never solved $f(x) = k$ for a single generic k, never built a table of twenty points. We asked three structural questions — where does the denominator vanish,

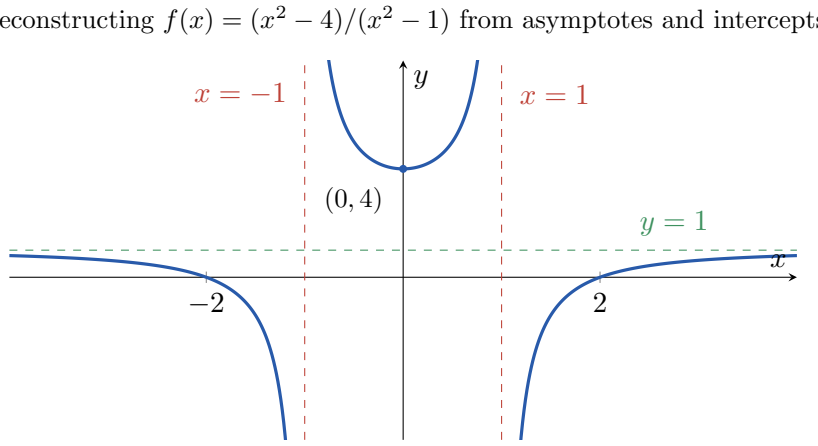


Figure 9.8: $f(x) = \frac{x^2-4}{x^2-1}$, read entirely from its asymptotes: verticals at $x = \pm 1$, a horizontal $y = 1$ at both ends, x-intercepts at ± 2, and the local minimum $(0, 4)$.

how do the degrees compare, where are the zeros — and the graph fell out almost for free. This is the recurring pleasure of calculus: the right *questions* replace mountains of arithmetic. Asymptotes are the first place a beginner feels that leverage, and it is a feeling worth chasing through every later chapter.

Connection

From limits to the derivative. With limits at infinity in hand, our foundation for limits is complete. In Chapter 10, we flip our perspective: instead of stepping infinitely far back to inspect the horizon of a graph, we zoom infinitely far into a single point. The difference quotient $\frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$ produces the indeterminate form $0/0$, and limits resolve it to give the instantaneous rate of change: the *derivative*.
(Much later, in Chapter 25, the growth rates and infinite tails of this chapter return when we evaluate areas under unbounded curves in *improper integrals*.)

9.8 Exercises

Exercise 9.1 (Warm-up limits)**.** Evaluate each limit, naming the dominant terms you used.

$$\text{(a) } \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{5x^3-2x}{2x^3+7}, \quad \text{(b) } \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{x+9}{x^2-4}, \quad \text{(c) } \lim_{x\to-\infty} \frac{6x^4+1}{1-3x^2},$$

$$\text{(d) } \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{\sqrt{9x^2+5}}{2x-1}, \qquad \text{(e) } \lim_{x\to-\infty} \frac{\sqrt{9x^2+5}}{2x-1}.$$

Exercise 9.2 (Two asymptotes from one radical)**.** Find both horizontal asymptotes of $f(x) = \dfrac{\sqrt{9x^2+2}}{4x-1}$, treating $x \to +\infty$ and $x \to -\infty$ separately. Explain, using $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$, why the two answers differ in sign.

Exercise 9.3 (Conjugate trick)**.** Evaluate $\lim_{x\to\infty} \left(\sqrt{x^2+5x} - \sqrt{x^2+x}\right)$ by multiplying by the conjugate. (Answer: 2.) Then explain in one sentence why the naive answer "$\infty - \infty = 0$" is wrong.

Exercise 9.4 (Hole versus asymptote)**.** For each function, state every vertical asymptote and every hole, with coordinates.

$$\text{(a) } \frac{x-2}{x^2-4}, \qquad \text{(b) } \frac{x^2+x-6}{x^2-9}, \qquad \text{(c) } \frac{x^2+1}{x^2-2x}.$$

Exercise 9.5 (Slant asymptote by division)**.** Find the slant asymptote of $f(x) = \dfrac{2x^2+3x-1}{x+2}$ and state on which side of the line the graph lies for large positive x and for large negative x. (Hint: the division leaves $f(x) = 2x - 1 + \frac{1}{x+2}$.)

Exercise 9.6 (Full sketch)**.** Carry out the asymptote checklist for $g(x) = \dfrac{x^2-x-2}{x-3}$: holes, vertical asymptotes, slant asymptote, and all intercepts. Then sketch it, drawing the asymptotes as dashed lines first.

Exercise 9.7 (Growth-rate sorting)**.** Order the following by eventual growth, slowest to fastest, and justify the two closest calls with a limit:

$$x^{50}, \qquad (\ln x)^{1000}, \qquad 1.01^x, \qquad \sqrt{x}, \qquad x \ln x.$$

Exercise 9.8 (A crossing curve)**.** Give an explicit function with horizontal asymptote $y = 2$ that *crosses* the line $y = 2$ infinitely many times as $x \to \infty$. Prove your function does both. (Hint: a decaying oscillation added to 2.)

Exercise 9.9 (Prove a limit from the threshold definition)**.** Using Definition 9.1 directly, prove that $\lim_{x\to\infty} \dfrac{2x-1}{x+4} = 2$. That is, given $\varepsilon > 0$, produce an explicit M (in terms of ε) so that $x > M$ forces $\left|\frac{2x-1}{x+4} - 2\right| < \varepsilon$. (Hint: the difference simplifies to $\frac{-9}{x+4}$.)

Exercise 9.10 (Prove log loses to every power)**.** Adapt the integral bound $\ln x \le 2\sqrt{x}$ from the proof of Theorem 9.1 to show that for every fixed $p > 0$, $\lim_{x\to\infty} \dfrac{\ln x}{x^p} = 0$. (Hint: it suffices to beat x^p with $\sqrt{x}$ when $p \ge \frac{1}{2}$; for small p, bound $\ln x$ by $\frac{1}{q}x^q$ for a suitable $q < p$ using $\int t^{q-1}\,\mathrm{d}t$.)

Exercise 9.11 (Parabolic asymptote)**.** The function $f(x) = \dfrac{x^3+1}{x}$ has a top exceeding the bottom by two degrees, so no straight-line asymptote. By dividing, show that $f(x)$ becomes indistinguishable from a *parabola* for large $|x|$, and state that parabola. Confirm $f(x) - (\text{parabola}) \to 0$.

Exercise 9.12 (Conceptual)**.** True or false, with a one-line reason each. (a) A function can have at most two horizontal asymptotes. (b) A function can have infinitely many vertical asymptotes. (c) If $\lim_{x\to\infty} f(x) = L$ then f never equals L. (d) A rational function whose denominator has higher degree than its numerator always has the horizontal asymptote $y = 0$.

Part III

The Derivative

Chapter 10

The Derivative: Slope, Rate, and the Tangent

In Chapter 9, we stepped far back to study the end behavior of functions as $x \to \pm\infty$. Now we reverse the lens and zoom all the way in on a single point, returning to the question we have been circling since Chapter 1:

Focus

How fast is something changing *right now* – at a single instant, not over a stretch of time? And what does it mean for a quantity to have a rate of change at one instant, when "rate" seems to require two moments to compare?

The answer is the **derivative** – a single number measuring how sensitively a function's output reacts to a tiny nudge in its input. It is, all at once, three things that turn out to be the same thing: the slope of a tangent line, an instantaneous rate of change, and the best straight-line approximation to a curve. By the end of this chapter you will see why those three are one, you will compute a few derivatives from raw first principles using only algebra and a limit, and you will understand exactly what the famous symbol $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is really saying – and what it is *not* saying.

10.1 The problem of the instant

Let us start with the most physical version of the question, the one that drove Newton. Drop a ball. In the absence of air resistance, the distance it has fallen after t seconds is, to good accuracy,

$$s(t) = 16t^2 \quad \text{(feet, with } t \text{ in seconds)}.$$

After 1 second it has fallen 16 feet; after 2 seconds, 64 feet; after 3 seconds, 144 feet. Now I ask: *how fast is the ball moving at the instant $t = 2$?*

You know how to find an *average* speed. Average speed over a time interval is distance covered divided by time elapsed. From $t = 2$ to $t = 3$ the ball falls $144 - 64 = 80$ feet in 1 second, so its average speed over that second is 80 feet per second. But that is the average over a whole second, during which the ball was speeding up the entire time. At the *start* of that second it was slower than

80; at the *end*, faster. The number 80 is not the speed "at $t = 2$." It is a blur of an entire second's worth of speeds.

Intuition

To get the speed *at* an instant, shrink the interval. Don't measure over a whole second – measure over a tenth of a second, then a hundredth, then a millionth. The shorter the interval, the less the speed has a chance to change across it, so the average over that tiny interval gets closer and closer to the "true" instantaneous speed. The instantaneous speed is what those averages are *heading toward*. That is a limit.

Let us actually watch them head somewhere. Take the interval from $t = 2$ to $t = 2 + h$, where h is a small time step. The distance fallen during that interval is $s(2 + h) - s(2)$, and the average speed is

$$\frac{s(2+h) - s(2)}{h} = \frac{16(2+h)^2 - 16(2)^2}{h}.$$

Expand the top:

$$16(2+h)^2 - 16(4) = 16\big(4 + 4h + h^2\big) - 64 = 64 + 64h + 16h^2 - 64 = 64h + 16h^2.$$

Divide by h (we can cancel because h, while small, is not yet zero):

$$\frac{64h + 16h^2}{h} = 64 + 16h.$$

So the average speed over the interval $[2,\ 2 + h]$ is exactly $64 + 16h$ feet per second. Watch what happens as h shrinks.

h (seconds)	average speed $64 + 16h$ (ft/s)
1	80
0.1	65.6
0.01	64.16
0.001	64.016
0.0001	64.0016

The averages are marching toward 64. And we don't have to guess – the algebra told us the average is $64 + 16h$, so as $h \to 0$ the $16h$ term vanishes and the limit is exactly 64. *The ball is moving* 64 *feet per second at the instant* $t = 2$. We never divided by zero. We divided by a small nonzero h, simplified, and only *then* let h go to zero.

Walking question

Pause and think: What happens if you measure the average speed by stepping *backward* in time instead of forward, over the interval $[2 - h, 2]$? Take $h = 0.01$, so the interval is $[1.99, 2]$. Compute:

$$\frac{s(2) - s(1.99)}{0.01} = \frac{64 - 16(1.99)^2}{0.01} = \frac{64 - 63.3616}{0.01} = \frac{0.6384}{0.01} = 63.84 \text{ ft/s}.$$

Notice that $63.84 = 64 - 16(0.01)$. Stepping forward from 2 gave $64 + 16h$ (speeds just above

64); stepping backward gives $64 - 16h$ (speeds just below 64). As $h \to 0$ from either direction, both squeeze onto the identical value: 64 ft/s.

What is really happening

The raw fraction $\dfrac{s(2+h)-s(2)}{h}$ is the indeterminate form $\frac{0}{0}$ when $h = 0$: the ball travels zero distance in zero time, and $\frac{0}{0}$ is meaningless. The instantaneous speed is *not* "$\frac{0}{0}$ evaluated." It is the *number that the fraction approaches* as h shrinks – a number the fraction itself never literally equals at $h = 0$, but circles arbitrarily closely. The limit is precisely the tool that extracts a definite value out of a $\frac{0}{0}$ that would otherwise be nonsense. Without limits, the instant has no speed. With limits, it has exactly one.

10.2 The same picture, drawn: secants closing in on a tangent

That falling-ball calculation has a geometric twin, and once you see the picture you will never lose it. Plot the function – any function $y = f(x)$ – as a curve. Pick a point $P = (a, f(a))$ on it. We want the steepness of the curve *at* P: the slope of the line that just grazes the curve there, touching it at P and matching its direction. That grazing line is the **tangent line** – a straight line that touches the curve at that point without cutting across it locally, matching the curve's exact direction at the contact point.

The trouble is that slope needs *two* points – rise over run – and the tangent touches at only one. So we approximate using two points, exactly as before. Pick a second, nearby point $Q = (a+h,\ f(a+h))$ on the curve, and draw the line through P and Q. A line through two points of a curve is called a **secant** line – a straight chord connecting two separate points on the graph – and its slope we can compute directly from two points:

$$\text{slope of secant } PQ = \frac{\text{rise}}{\text{run}} = \frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{(a+h)-a} = \frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h}.$$

This fraction is so important it has a name: the **difference quotient** – the ratio comparing the vertical change in output to the horizontal step in input over a finite interval. It is the average rate of change of f over the step from a to $a+h$ – the geometric face of the very same average speed we computed for the ball. Figure 10.1 lays out this rise-over-run triangle directly on a curve.

Now slide Q along the curve toward P. As Q approaches P, the secant line pivots about P, and its slope changes. The picture practically begs you to believe that the secants settle down toward one limiting line – the tangent – and that the secant slopes settle toward one limiting number – the slope of the tangent. Figure 10.2 shows three secants for shrinking h, each tilting closer to the dashed tangent.

Walking question

Before reading on, picture the secant pivoting and ask yourself: *why* should the secants approach a single line at all? What could go wrong? Hold a ruler against a smooth bowl and tilt it as the second contact point slides in – you can feel it lock onto one direction. Now imagine the curve has a sharp corner at P (think of the letter "V"). Slide Q in from the right and you

The geometry of the difference quotient: rise over run on a secant chord

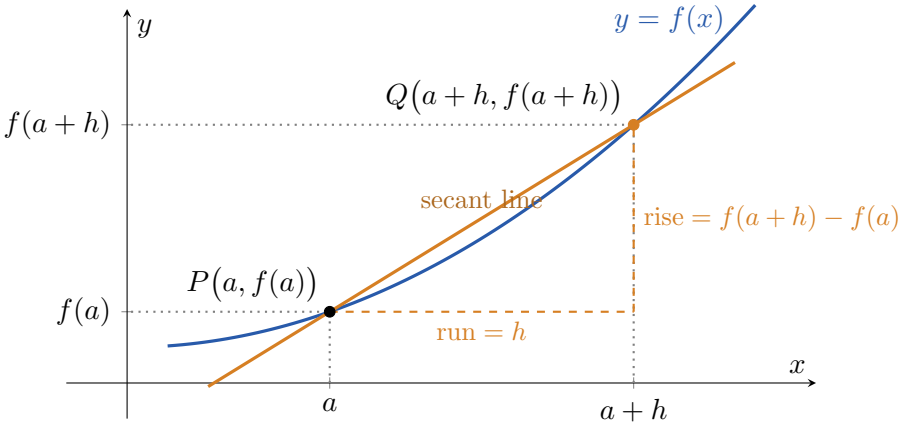


Figure 10.1: The geometric anatomy of the difference quotient. The secant line connects $P = \big(a, f(a)\big)$ and $Q = \big(a+h, f(a+h)\big)$. Its slope is the vertical rise $f(a+h) - f(a)$ divided by the horizontal run h. When h shrinks toward zero, Q slides along the curve toward P, and this secant line pivots toward the tangent.

Secant-to-tangent convergence: chords pivoting as $h \to 0$

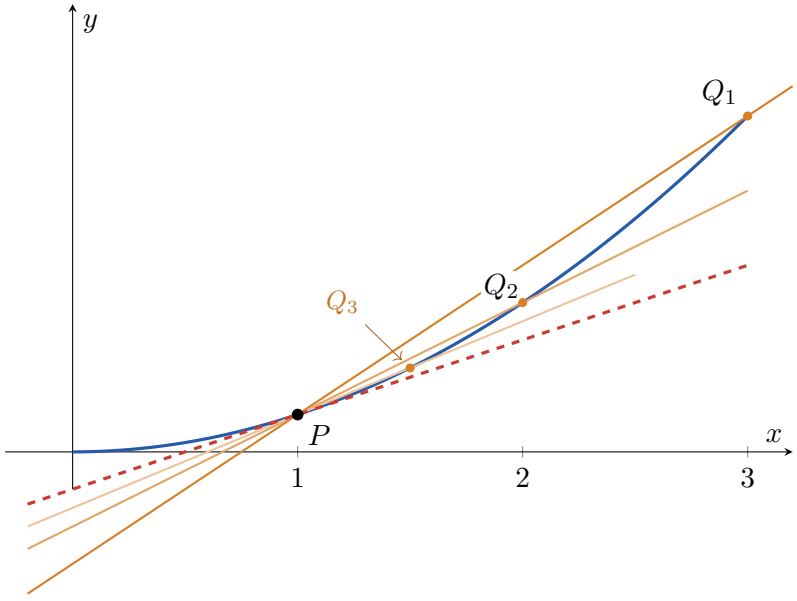


Figure 10.2: Secant lines through $P = (1, \frac{1}{2})$ and points Q_1, Q_2, Q_3 on $y = \frac{1}{2}x^2$, with Q sliding toward P. The secant slopes (2, then 1.5, then 1.25) close in on the slope of the dashed tangent line, which is 1. The tangent is the limit of the secants.

get one limiting slope; slide it in from the left and you get a different one. The secants do *not* agree on a single line. We will meet this failure again – it is exactly where derivatives stop existing.

The two stories – falling ball, grazing line – are not mere analogies. They are mathematically identical calculations. "Instantaneous speed" is the limit of average speeds; "slope of tangent" is the limit of secant slopes; and average speed on a position-time graph is the slope of a secant line.

10.3 The definition of the derivative

We have now done the same thing twice, so let us crystallize it once and name it.

Definition 10.1 (The derivative at a point)**.** Let f be a function defined on an open interval containing the point a (meaning f is defined on both sides of a, with a small buffer of space around it). The **derivative of f at a**, written $f'(a)$, is

$$f'(a) \;=\; \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h},$$

provided this limit exists. When it does, we say f is **differentiable at a**. The number $f'(a)$ is the slope of the tangent line to the graph $y = f(x)$ at the point $(a, f(a))$, and equivalently the instantaneous rate of change of f with respect to x at $x = a$.

Two small but important remarks before we use it.

Remark 10.1. The phrase "provided this limit exists" is doing real work. The derivative is a *limit*, and limits can fail to exist (Chapters 5–7). When the limit does not exist, f has no derivative at a – no well-defined slope, no instantaneous rate. That is not a defect in our definition; the curve genuinely lacks a single tangent direction there (think of a sharp corner), and Section 10.8 shows what those failures look like. (Why must f be defined on an open interval around a? Because taking the limit as $h \to 0$ tests inputs $a + h$ on both the left and right; if f were missing points on either side, the two-sided limit could not even be probed.)

Remark 10.2 (A second, equivalent form)*.* Sometimes it is cleaner to name the moving point directly. Set $x = a + h$, so $h = x - a$, and notice that $h \to 0$ is the same as $x \to a$. Then

$$f'(a) \;=\; \lim_{x\to a} \frac{f(x)-f(a)}{x-a}.$$

This is the identical definition with a change of variable; use whichever is more convenient for the algebra in front of you.

Focus

Read Definition 10.1 as an *instruction*, not a formula to plug into. It says: form the difference quotient (a function of h), simplify it until the offending h in the denominator is gone, and *then* see what it approaches as $h \to 0$. The art of computing derivatives from the definition is entirely the art of making that h in the denominator cancel.

10.4 Computing derivatives from first principles

Let us apply the definition directly, before introducing shortcut rules – just algebra and a limit. (The differentiation rules of the next chapter all get *proved* this way, so this is the foundation the rules stand on.)

Example 10.1 (A parabola)**.** Find the derivative of $f(x) = x^2$ at a general point x.

We build the difference quotient and chase the cancellation:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h} &= \frac{(x+h)^2 - x^2}{h} \\ &= \frac{x^2 + 2xh + h^2 - x^2}{h} = \frac{2xh + h^2}{h} \\ &= \frac{h(2x+h)}{h} = 2x + h \qquad (h \neq 0).\end{aligned}$$

The h cancelled. Now take the limit:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} (2x + h) = 2x.$$

So the derivative of x^2 is $2x$. Sanity check against Figure 10.2, which used $\frac{1}{2}x^2$: at $x = 1$ the slope there should be $\frac{1}{2} \cdot 2 \cdot 1 = 1$, and indeed the tangent we drew had slope 1. The picture and the algebra agree.

Work it yourself

Do this one entirely by hand before reading the solution. Let $f(x) = 3x^2 - 5x + 1$. Form $\dfrac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$, expand, cancel the h, and take the limit.

Solution sketch. The numerator is $3(x+h)^2 - 5(x+h) + 1 - (3x^2 - 5x + 1) = 6xh + 3h^2 - 5h$. Divide by h to get $6x + 3h - 5$, and let $h \to 0$: the derivative is $6x - 5$. Notice the constant $+1$ contributed nothing – a constant has zero rate of change, because shifting the whole graph up and down never tilts it.

Example 10.2 (A reciprocal – cancellation by a common denominator)**.** Find the derivative of $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x}$ for $x \neq 0$.

Here the cancellation comes from combining fractions, not expanding a square:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h} &= \frac{1}{h}\left(\frac{1}{x+h} - \frac{1}{x}\right) = \frac{1}{h} \cdot \frac{x - (x+h)}{(x+h)\,x} \\ &= \frac{1}{h} \cdot \frac{-h}{(x+h)\,x} = \frac{-1}{(x+h)\,x} \qquad (h \neq 0).\end{aligned}$$

Again the h vanished, this time absorbed into the $-h$ on top. Now let $h \to 0$:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{-1}{(x+h)\,x} = \frac{-1}{x \cdot x} = -\frac{1}{x^2}.$$

The minus sign reflects the geometry: $1/x$ slopes *downward* everywhere it is defined, so its rate of change is negative, and the steeper plunge near $x = 0$ shows up as the x^2 blowing up in the denominator.

Example 10.3 (A square root – cancellation by the conjugate)**.** Find the derivative of $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ for $x > 0$.

The trick when a root blocks the cancellation is to multiply top and bottom by the **conjugate**, $\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}$ – the identical pair of terms but with the minus sign flipped to plus. This exploits the difference of squares $(A-B)(A+B) = A^2 - B^2$ to remove the radicals:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\sqrt{x+h}-\sqrt{x}}{h} &= \frac{\sqrt{x+h}-\sqrt{x}}{h}\cdot\frac{\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}}{\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}} \\ &= \frac{(x+h)-x}{h\big(\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}\big)} = \frac{h}{h\big(\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}\big)} \\ &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}} \qquad (h \neq 0).\end{aligned}$$

The lone h on top cancelled the h in the denominator. Now the limit is safe, because $\sqrt{x+h} \to \sqrt{x}$ as $h \to 0$:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{1}{\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}} = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}.$$

Why the technique works

Why does the conjugate trick work, and why do we keep reaching for these maneuvers? Every one of them – expanding $(x+h)^2$, finding a common denominator, multiplying by the conjugate – is a way to expose a hidden factor of h in the numerator so it can cancel the h in the denominator. The difference quotient is $\frac{0}{0}$ at $h = 0$ precisely *because* the numerator $f(x+h) - f(x)$ also vanishes there (it is the difference of a quantity with itself when $h = 0$). A quantity that vanishes at $h = 0$ has h as a factor, at least to first order. The algebra simply drags that factor out into the open where it can be cancelled. Differentiating from first principles is the systematic art of factoring out the h that *must* be there.

Common trap

The single most common error is setting $h = 0$ *too early*. If you write $\dfrac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$ and immediately substitute $h = 0$, you get $\dfrac{0}{0}$ and learn nothing – worse, you may convince yourself the derivative "doesn't exist" when it is perfectly fine. The rule is simple: *simplify until the denominator no longer contains h, and only then evaluate the limit as $h \to 0$.* Cancellation first, limit second. Never the other way.

Example 10.4 (A constant and a line – the easy extremes)**.** If $f(x) = c$ is constant, then $f(x+h) - f(x) = c - c = 0$, so the difference quotient is $0/h = 0$ for every $h \neq 0$, and $f'(x) = 0$. A flat graph has zero slope; a quantity that never changes has zero rate of change. If $f(x) = mx + b$ is a line, then

$$\frac{m(x+h)+b-(mx+b)}{h} = \frac{mh}{h} = m,$$

so $f'(x) = m$ for every x. The derivative of a line is its slope, constant everywhere – which had better be true, since the tangent to a straight line is the line itself.

10.5 The derivative as a function

Look back at the examples. We started out asking for the slope at one point a, but the algebra naturally handed us a *formula in* x: the slope of x^2 is $2x$, valid at every x. This is an essential shift in perspective. The derivative is not just a number attached to one point – it is a *new function* that reports the slope at every point where the original is differentiable.

Definition 10.2 (The derivative function)**.** Given f, its **derivative function** f' is defined by

$$f'(x) \;=\; \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h},$$

on the set of all x for which the limit exists. The process of producing f' from f is called **differentiation**.

There is genuine information in graphing f and f' together. Where f rises, f' is positive; where f falls, f' is negative; where f momentarily levels off at a peak or valley, f' crosses zero. Figure 10.3 shows $f(x) = x^2$ over its derivative $f'(x) = 2x$: the parabola's slope is negative on the left, zero at the bottom, positive on the right, and the straight line $2x$ records exactly that.

Function versus derivative: slope values plotted as heights

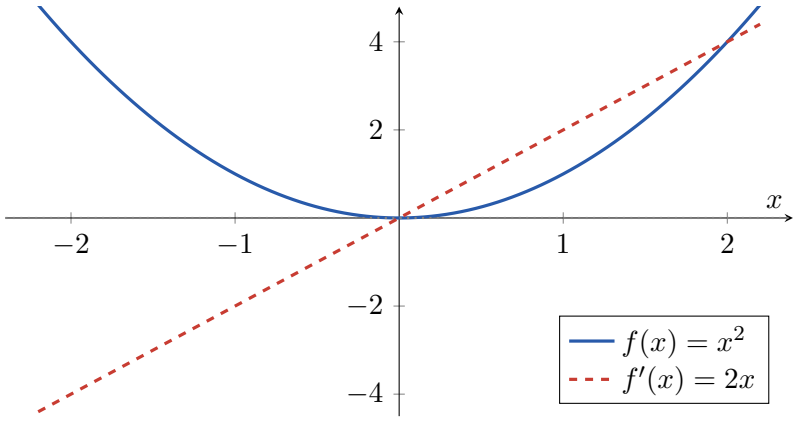


Figure 10.3: A function and its derivative. The slope of $f(x) = x^2$ at each x is read off the line $f'(x) = 2x$: negative for $x < 0$ (the parabola falls), zero at $x = 0$ (the bottom of the bowl), positive for $x > 0$ (the parabola rises). The height of the dashed line *is* the steepness of the solid curve.

Connection

This is the seed of an entire subject – the qualitative analysis of curves (Chapter 16). The sign of f' tells you whether f is increasing or decreasing; the zeros of f' locate the candidate peaks and valleys. We will eventually differentiate f' *again* to get f'', the rate at which the rate is changing – which is acceleration in the falling-ball story and concavity in the geometric one. The derivative being a function, and not merely a single number, is what makes all of that possible.

10.6 The third meaning: best linear approximation

We have met two meanings of the derivative – slope of the tangent and instantaneous rate of change. The third is subtler, and it carries most of the weight in the rest of calculus. It says: *near a, the function f looks like a straight line, and the derivative is the slope of that line.*

Here is the idea. Unwind the definition. To say

$$\lim_{h\to 0}\frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h}=f'(a)$$

is to say that for small h, the difference quotient is approximately $f'(a)$:

$$\frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h}\approx f'(a),\qquad\text{hence}\qquad f(a+h)\approx f(a)+f'(a)\,h.$$

Writing $x=a+h$ (so $h=x-a$), this is the **tangent line approximation**

$$\boxed{f(x)\approx f(a)+f'(a)\,(x-a)}$$

valid for x near a. The right-hand side is precisely the equation of the tangent line at a: it passes through $(a,f(a))$ and has slope $f'(a)$. Thus the tangent line does more than graze the curve: it is the *best linear approximation* to f near a. Among all lines through $(a,f(a))$, the tangent is the one whose error shrinks faster than h itself as $h\to 0$.

Intuition

Zoom in. Take any smooth curve, fix a point on it, and magnify the picture around that point – double the magnification, then double again, and again. The curve flattens. At high enough zoom it is visually indistinguishable from a straight line, and that line is the tangent. This is **local linearity**, and it is the real reason calculus works. Curves are hard; lines are easy. The derivative is the dictionary that translates the hard local behavior of a curve into the slope of a line. Almost every tool ahead – linear approximation, Newton's method, related rates, even Euler's step-by-step method for differential equations – is just this zoom put to work. Figure 10.4 performs the zoom on a genuine curve.

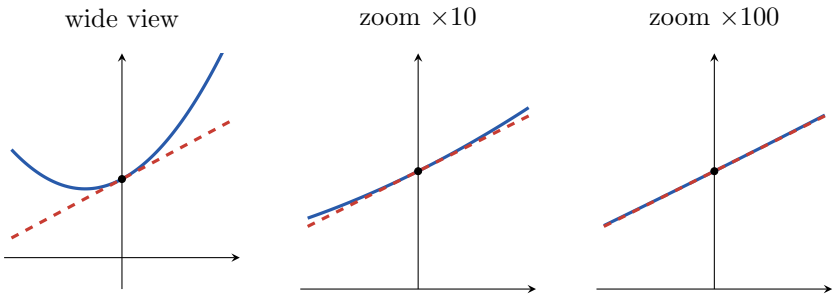


Figure 10.4: Local linearity, made literal. The same curve $f(x)=1+\frac{1}{2}x+\frac{1}{2}x^2$ (solid) and its tangent at $(0,1)$ (dashed), viewed at three magnifications about that point. As we zoom, the curve becomes indistinguishable from its tangent: by $\times 100$ the two are visually one line. The derivative $f'(0)=\frac{1}{2}$ is the slope of the line the curve turns into under the microscope.

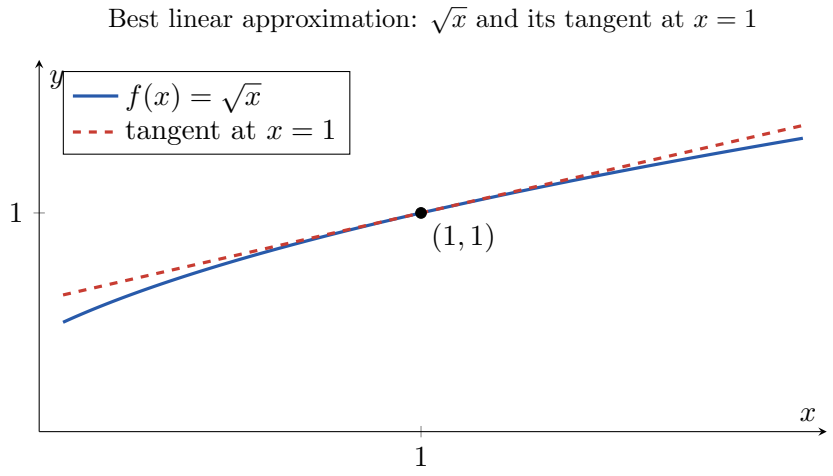


Figure 10.5: The tangent line as best linear approximation. Near $x = 1$ the curve $\sqrt{x}$ and its tangent $y = 1 + \frac{1}{2}(x - 1)$ are nearly on top of each other; they separate only as you move away from the point of contact. The approximation $\sqrt{x} \approx 1 + \frac{1}{2}(x - 1)$ gives, e.g., $\sqrt{1.04} \approx 1.02$.

Example 10.5 (Approximating a square root in your head)**.** From Example 10.3, $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ has $f'(x) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}$. Near $a = 1$ we have $f(1) = 1$ and $f'(1) = \frac{1}{2}$, so

$$\sqrt{x} \approx 1 + \tfrac{1}{2}(x - 1).$$

Then $\sqrt{1.04} \approx 1 + \frac{1}{2}(0.04) = 1.02$. The true value is $1.0198\ldots$, so we are right to three decimal places with mental arithmetic and no calculator – the payoff of replacing a curve by its tangent line. The chapter on linear approximation and differentials develops this systematically.

Formal

Here is the precise statement that justifies calling the tangent the "best" linear approximation. Define the error of the tangent line at a as

$$E(h) = f(a + h) - \big[\, f(a) + f'(a)\, h \,\big].$$

Then differentiability at a is *equivalent* to the statement

$$\lim_{h \to 0} \frac{E(h)}{h} = 0,$$

that is, the error vanishes faster than h itself. Any *other* line through $(a, f(a))$, with slope $m \neq f'(a)$, has error $\big(f'(a) - m\big)h + E(h)$, whose ratio to h tends to the nonzero number $f'(a) - m$. Only the tangent's error is negligible compared to h. This "error smaller than first order" is the rigorous meaning of "best," and it is the doorway to Taylor's theorem later in the book.

10.7 Notation: Leibniz, Lagrange, and what $\frac{dy}{dx}$ really means

Calculus was invented twice, more or less simultaneously, by two people who could hardly have been more different, and we inherited *both* of their notations. It pays to know each, because each makes certain truths obvious and others awkward.

History

Our two main derivative notations grew out of two very different minds – and a century-long fight over both credit and logic.

In the 1660s in England, **Isaac Newton** was driven by physics: how do planets orbit the sun, and how does a falling apple accelerate? He imagined quantities "flowing" through continuous time. He called a changing quantity a **fluent** (a quantity that flows), and its instantaneous rate of change a **fluxion** (its flowing speed), writing $\dot{x}$ for the fluxion of x – a dot notation still prized in physics today. A decade later in Germany, **Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz**, working independently from 1675 to 1684, approached the problem as a philosopher of language. He wanted a notation so transparent that algebraic calculations would automatically mirror geometric truths. He wrote the derivative as $\frac{dy}{dx}$ – a ratio of two **infinitesimals** (idealized quantities smaller than any positive real number, yet strictly not zero).

Both thinkers were stuck on the identical foundational hurdle: calculating an instantaneous rate requires dividing a change in output by an elapsed time step, yet at a single frozen moment both changes are zero, producing the meaningless expression $\frac{0}{0}$. Both relied on Cartesian coordinate geometry and clever algebraic tricks, but neither possessed a rigorous theory of limits. Instead, they divided by tiny infinitesimal increments and then discarded the leftover pieces at the end.

Two major controversies erupted. First was the **priority dispute** – a bitter public battle over who discovered calculus first. Newton had developed his ideas first in private manuscripts, but Leibniz was the first to publish in 1684. The Royal Society of London and Continental mathematicians exchanged sharp accusations of plagiarism. The dispute alienated British mathematicians from the Continent for more than a century; loyalty to Newton's fluxion notation caused British mathematics to lag, while Continental scholars advanced using Leibniz's differential notation.

The second crisis concerned the logical foundations. In 1734, the philosopher Bishop **George Berkeley** published *The Analyst*, identifying the logical weak spot in early derivative calculations. When simplifying a difference quotient, mathematicians assumed the step h was nonzero so they could divide by it, and then treated h as zero to drop the leftover terms – leaning on two contradictory assumptions in one calculation.

Despite Berkeley's critique, calculus provided the mathematical foundation for celestial mechanics, planetary orbits, ocean tides, and differential equations governing heat, wave motion, and fluid flow. The rigorous resolution arrived in the nineteenth century through the work of **Augustin-Louis Cauchy** and **Karl Weierstrass**, who placed calculus on the foundation of limits and the ε–δ definition (Chapters 5–7). In their system, h is never set to zero; we simply evaluate the limit as h approaches zero.

In the 1960s, mathematical logician **Abraham Robinson** developed **nonstandard analysis** – a branch of mathematical logic that uses formal structures to construct the *hyperreal numbers*, a number system containing genuine, logically sound infinitesimals. Robinson proved that infinitesimal arguments can be made completely rigorous and reproduce all results of standard calculus.

Lagrange's prime notation. Joseph-Louis Lagrange later introduced the clean $f'(x)$ we have been using – "f prime of x." It is compact, it clearly emphasizes the derivative-as-a-function (f' is a function just like f), and it is well suited for stating theorems. Its weakness: it hides *what* you are differentiating with respect to. For f' that is fine; for a quantity depending on several variables it is ambiguous.

Leibniz's ratio notation. If we name the output $y = f(x)$, then Leibniz writes

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} \quad \text{or} \quad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}f(x) \quad \text{or} \quad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(f(x))\,,$$

and the value at a specific point a is written $\left.\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\right|_{x=a}$. The symbol $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is an *operator* meaning "take the derivative with respect to x" of whatever follows. Leibniz notation is clear and practical because it *remembers the variables* and makes the chain rule and substitution look like fraction arithmetic. It also makes units visible at a glance: $\frac{\mathrm{d}s}{\mathrm{d}t}$ directly carries units of distance over time, a speed.

What is really happening

Here is the question that trips up nearly every student, so let us answer it squarely. *Is* $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ *a fraction?*

In the way we have built it, **no**. The symbol $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is a single, indivisible name for one number: the limit $\lim_{h\to 0}\dfrac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$. There is no genuine number called $\mathrm{d}y$ sitting on top of a genuine number $\mathrm{d}x$ that you divided. Leibniz himself thought of $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$ as "infinitesimals" – quantities smaller than any positive number yet not zero – and treated $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ as their literal quotient. For two centuries no one could say rigorously what an infinitesimal *was*, and the foundations were, frankly, a mess (see the History box above).

So why does the fraction notation work so flawlessly? Because $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is the *limit* of ordinary fractions $\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x} = \frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$, and many of the algebraic moves you would make on the fraction $\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}$ *survive the limit.* The chain rule $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}u}\cdot\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x}$ looks like cancelling $\mathrm{d}u$, and it is *true* – but it is true because we will *prove* it from the definition, not because $\mathrm{d}u$ literally cancels. The notation is a brilliantly suggestive mnemonic for theorems that are established by limits. Use the fraction intuition to *guess*; lean on the limit definition to *know.*

10.8 Differentiability versus continuity

A function with a derivative at a is rather special, and it helps to know exactly *how* special. There is a clean one-way implication.

Theorem 10.1 (Differentiable ⇒ continuous)**.** *If f is differentiable at a, then f is continuous at a.*

Intuition

Before the proof, the picture. If f has a tangent line at a, then near a the graph hugs that line – and a line has no gaps or jumps. So the graph cannot suddenly leap at a; it must arrive at $f(a)$ smoothly. Having a well-defined slope is a *stronger* demand than merely having no jump. Differentiability implies continuity, but, as we will see, continuity does not imply differentiability.

Proof. We must show $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a)$, equivalently $\lim_{x\to a}\big[f(x) - f(a)\big] = 0$. The trick is to manufacture the difference quotient by multiplying and dividing by $x - a$ (legal for $x \neq a$, which is all the limit ever sees):

$$f(x) - f(a) = \frac{f(x) - f(a)}{x - a} \cdot (x - a).$$

Now take the limit as $x \to a$. The first factor tends to $f'(a)$ by the definition of the derivative (Remark 10.2), which exists by hypothesis; the second factor tends to 0. By the product law for limits,

$$\lim_{x\to a}\big[f(x) - f(a)\big] = f'(a) \cdot 0 = 0.$$

Hence $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = f(a)$, which is exactly continuity at a. □

The converse is false, and its failure is so instructive that we devote the rest of the section to the three classic ways a continuous function can lack a derivative. In every case the function has no jump – it is continuous – yet the limit defining $f'(a)$ does not exist. Watch *why* the limit fails each time; it is always the secant slopes refusing to settle on one number.

Failure 1: a corner – the absolute value

The cleanest example is $f(x) = |x|$ at $a = 0$. It is continuous everywhere (no jump at 0; $|x| \to 0 = |0|$). But form the difference quotient at 0:

$$\frac{f(0+h) - f(0)}{h} = \frac{|h| - 0}{h} = \frac{|h|}{h} = \begin{cases} 1 & h > 0, \\ -1 & h < 0. \end{cases}$$

As $h \to 0^+$ the quotient is $+1$; as $h \to 0^-$ it is -1. The one-sided limits disagree, so the two-sided limit does not exist, and $f'(0)$ is undefined. Geometrically the graph has a sharp **corner** at the origin: the slope is -1 coming from the left and $+1$ going to the right, and there is no single tangent line. The secants from the right insist the slope is 1; the secants from the left insist it is -1; they never agree.

Failure 2: a cusp – the cube root, sharpened

Consider $f(x) = x^{2/3}$ at $a = 0$. It is continuous ($0^{2/3} = 0$), and unlike the corner its two sides do not meet at an angle – they meet at an infinitely sharp **cusp** – a pointed tip where the curve reverses direction and both branches turn vertical. The difference quotient is

$$\frac{(0+h)^{2/3} - 0}{h} = \frac{h^{2/3}}{h} = h^{-1/3} = \frac{1}{h^{1/3}},$$

and as $h \to 0$ this grows without bound (toward $+\infty$ from the right, toward $-\infty$ from the left). The limit does not exist – not even as one-sided finite limits – so $f'(0)$ does not exist. The slope is trying to be vertical on both sides at once.

Failure 3: a vertical tangent – the cube root

Now $f(x) = x^{1/3}$ at $a = 0$, again continuous. The difference quotient is

$$\frac{(0+h)^{1/3} - 0}{h} = \frac{h^{1/3}}{h} = h^{-2/3} = \frac{1}{h^{2/3}} \;\to\; +\infty \quad \text{as } h \to 0.$$

This time both sides agree – the quotient marches to $+\infty$ from either direction – so the curve genuinely has a single limiting tangent direction, but that direction is *vertical*. A vertical line has no (finite) slope, so by our definition $f'(0)$ does not exist as a number. We say the graph has a **vertical tangent** at the origin. It is differentiability's near miss: there is a tangent line, but its slope is infinite.

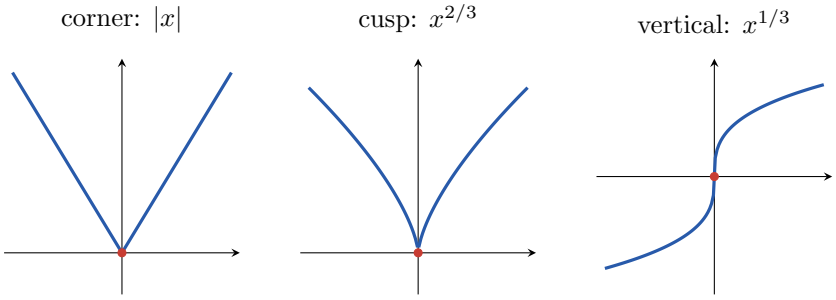


Figure 10.6: Three ways to be continuous but not differentiable at the origin. A *corner* ($|x|$): left and right slopes disagree. A *cusp* ($x^{2/3}$): the secant slopes run off to $+\infty$ on one side and $-\infty$ on the other. A *vertical tangent* ($x^{1/3}$): a genuine tangent exists, but it is vertical, so its slope is infinite.

Walking question

Pause and think: Consider $f(x) = |x - 3|$. At what point does the corner occur, and what are the left-hand and right-hand slopes there? Without writing any algebra, what are $f'(5)$ and $f'(1)$? (The corner is at $x = 3$, where slopes abruptly jump from -1 to $+1$. For $x > 3$, the function is the straight line $y = x - 3$, so $f'(5) = 1$. For $x < 3$, it is the line $y = -(x - 3)$, so $f'(1) = -1$. The derivative exists everywhere except at the single corner point $x = 3$.)

Common trap

Do not over-learn Theorem 10.1. It runs *one way only*: differentiable ⇒ continuous. The reverse is false, as $|x|$ shows – continuous everywhere, not differentiable at 0. So "continuous" is necessary but not sufficient for "differentiable." A handy slogan: *differentiable functions are continuous and smooth; continuous functions are merely unbroken, and may still be jagged.*

Why this matters

How bad can the gap between continuous and differentiable get? In 1872 Weierstrass exhibited a function that is *continuous everywhere yet differentiable nowhere* – an unbroken curve that has a corner at every single point, so jagged that no point on it admits a tangent line. When it was published it surprised many mathematicians; Charles Hermite referred to such functions as an unnatural pathology. Today they are fundamental to fractal geometry and the mathematics of Brownian motion – the erratic path of a microscopic particle suspended

in fluid, which almost surely traces an unbroken path that fails to have a well-defined slope anywhere. Continuity and differentiability are genuinely different properties.

10.9 Rates of change everywhere

We opened with a falling ball because motion makes the derivative tangible, but the derivative is the universal language of *any* quantity changing with respect to *any* other. The pattern is always the same: a small change in the input causes a small change in the output, and the derivative is the limiting ratio.

Application

The derivative goes by a different name in every field, but it is always $\lim_{h\to 0} \dfrac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$.

- **Physics.** If $s(t)$ is position, $s'(t)$ is velocity, and $s''(t)$ is acceleration. Newton's second law $F = ma$ is a statement about the second derivative of position.
- **Biology.** If $P(t)$ is a population, $P'(t)$ is the growth rate (births minus deaths per unit time). The model $P'(t) = kP(t)$ – growth rate proportional to current size – gives exponential growth, and is your first differential equation.
- **Economics.** If $C(q)$ is the cost of producing q items, the derivative $C'(q)$ is the **marginal cost** – the additional expense incurred by producing one single additional item. "Marginal" in economics almost always means "derivative."
- **Chemistry.** If $[A](t)$ is a concentration, the reaction rate is $-\frac{\mathrm{d}[A]}{\mathrm{d}t}$ – the speed at which reactant is consumed.
- **Machine learning.** Training a neural network means minimizing a loss function $L(\mathbf{w})$ over parameters $\mathbf{w}$; gradient descent steps downhill along the negative **gradient** (the multi-dimensional vector pointing along the direction of steepest increase). Modern AI models adjust billions of weights using **backpropagation** – an algorithm that evaluates the chain rule in reverse to compute derivatives of the output error with respect to every internal parameter.

The instantaneous rate of change is not a physics trick. It is the way to talk about change itself, in any domain where one quantity depends on another.

Walking question

Take a walk and find the derivatives hiding around you. The speedometer in a car literally displays $\frac{\mathrm{d}s}{\mathrm{d}t}$. The slope you feel in your legs on a hill is the derivative of elevation with respect to horizontal distance. The rate your coffee cools is the derivative of its temperature with respect to time (and, as Newton noticed, that rate is proportional to how much hotter the coffee is than the room – another differential equation). Ask of each: what is changing, with respect to what, and is the rate positive, negative, or zero right now?

10.10 What to carry forward

Pause

A summary of the chapter's core ideas:

- The **derivative** of f at a is $f'(a) = \lim_{h\to 0} \dfrac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h}$, when this limit exists. It is the limit of difference quotients – of average rates – as the interval shrinks to nothing.
- It has **three faces**, all one number: the *slope of the tangent line*, the *instantaneous rate of change*, and the *slope of the best linear approximation* $f(x) \approx f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)$.
- Compute it from first principles by **cancelling the h first** (expand, common-denominator, or conjugate) and **taking the limit second**. Never set $h = 0$ before the cancellation.
- The derivative is itself a **function**, f', recording the slope at every point.
- **Notation**: Lagrange's $f'(x)$ and Leibniz's $\frac{dy}{dx}$ name the same thing. $\frac{dy}{dx}$ is *not* literally a fraction – it is the limit of ordinary fractions, which is why fraction-style manipulations keep working once we prove them.
- **Differentiable $\Rightarrow$ continuous**, but not conversely: corners ($|x|$), cusps ($x^{2/3}$), and vertical tangents ($x^{1/3}$) are continuous yet have no derivative, because the secant slopes refuse to settle on one finite number.

Next chapter we stop computing every derivative from scratch and build the *rules* – and each rule we prove will rest squarely on the limit definition you now own.

10.11 Exercises

Exercise 10.1 (Mental checks on sight)**.** Answer each of these in your head in ten seconds without pencil or paper:

(a) What is the derivative of the constant function $f(x) = 42$? What is the slope of its graph?

(b) What is the derivative of the straight line $f(x) = -7x + 3$?

(c) If $s(t)$ measures a car's distance in miles and t is in hours, what are the units of $\frac{ds}{dt}$?

(d) If the tangent line to $y = f(x)$ at $x = 5$ is horizontal, what is $f'(5)$?

(e) Given $f(2) = 10$ and $f'(2) = 3$, estimate $f(2.04)$ using linear approximation.

Exercise 10.2 (Warm-ups from the definition)**.** Using only Definition 10.1 (cancel the h, then take the limit), compute $f'(x)$ for each:

(a) $f(x) = 5x - 7$.

(b) $f(x) = x^2 - 3x$.

(c) $f(x) = x^3$. *(Hint:* $(x+h)^3 = x^3 + 3x^2h + 3xh^2 + h^3$*.)*

(d) $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x+1}$.

Exercise 10.3 (A root, by the conjugate)**.** Compute the derivative of $f(x) = \sqrt{2x+1}$ from first principles, using the conjugate trick. At what value of x is the slope equal to 1?

Exercise 10.4 (Instantaneous speed)**.** A particle moves so that its position at time t is $s(t) = t^2 - 4t + 5$ (in meters, t in seconds). (a) Find the average velocity over $[1, 1+h]$ and simplify. (b) Take the limit to find the instantaneous velocity at $t = 1$. (c) At what time is the particle instantaneously at rest (velocity zero)? What is it doing at that instant – where on its path is it?

Exercise 10.5 (Tangent line and approximation)**.** Let $f(x) = x^2$. (a) Write the equation of the tangent line at $a = 3$. (b) Use it to approximate $(3.02)^2$ without squaring, and compare with the exact value. (c) Is your approximation an over- or under-estimate? Explain using the shape (concavity) of the parabola.

Exercise 10.6 (Reading a graph)**.** A function f is increasing for $x < 2$, has a peak at $x = 2$, and decreases for $x > 2$. Sketch a plausible graph of the *derivative* f'. Where is f' positive, where negative, and what happens at $x = 2$? (No formula is needed – reason from signs of slopes.)

Exercise 10.7 (Where the derivative fails)**.** For each function, decide whether it is differentiable at $a = 0$. If not, name the type of failure (corner, cusp, vertical tangent, or discontinuity) and justify with one-sided difference quotients.

(a) $f(x) = |x - 0| = |x|$ – restated for contrast with (b).

(b) $f(x) = x\,|x|$. *(Compute the left and right difference quotients at* 0*; do they agree?)*

(c) $f(x) = x^{1/3}$.

(d) $f(x) = \begin{cases} x & x \geq 0, \\ x - 1 & x < 0. \end{cases}$

Exercise 10.8 (Continuous but not differentiable – by hand)**.** Let $f(x) = |x|$. (a) Show directly from the limit definition that f is *continuous* at 0. (b) Show directly that the two one-sided limits of the difference quotient at 0 are $+1$ and -1, so $f'(0)$ does not exist. (c) In one sentence, explain why this does not contradict Theorem 10.1.

Exercise 10.9 (Prove a special case)**.** Using the binomial expansion of $(x+h)^n$, prove from Definition 10.1 that for any positive integer n,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = nx^{n-1}.$$

Hint: $(x+h)^n = x^n + nx^{n-1}h + (\textit{terms with } h^2 \textit{ or higher})$*. After cancelling* h*, every surviving term except the first still contains at least one factor of* h*.*

Exercise 10.10 (The other definition)**.** Use the equivalent form $f'(a) = \lim_{x \to a} \dfrac{f(x) - f(a)}{x - a}$ (Remark 10.2) to compute $f'(a)$ for $f(x) = x^2$ at a general a, by factoring $x^2 - a^2 = (x-a)(x+a)$. Confirm you get $2a$, matching Example 10.1.

Exercise 10.11 (Conceptual – is the fraction real?)**.** A classmate insists that $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ *is* a fraction because the chain rule "cancels the $\mathrm{d}u$." Write a short paragraph explaining, using the $\frac{0}{0}$-and-limit idea from this chapter, in what precise sense $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is *not* a fraction, and why fraction-style manipulations nonetheless give correct answers.

Exercise 10.12 (A subtle differentiability question)**.** Consider

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2 \sin\left(\dfrac{1}{x}\right) & x \neq 0, \\ 0 & x = 0. \end{cases}$$

(a) Using $|\sin(1/x)| \leq 1$ and the squeeze theorem, show the difference quotient $\dfrac{f(h) - f(0)}{h} = h\sin(1/h)$ tends to 0, so $f'(0) = 0$ exists. (b) This function is differentiable at 0 even though it oscillates infinitely often near 0. What does this tell you about how much "wiggling" is compatible with having a derivative? *(Hint: compare the quadratic envelope $\pm x^2$ here with the linear envelope $\pm|x|$ of $x\sin(1/x)$, whose secants at 0 never settle.)*

Chapter 11

The Rules of Differentiation, and Why They Work

In the previous chapter you met the derivative as a *limit*: the slope of a curve at a point, the instantaneous rate of change, the number that the slopes of shrinking secant lines close in on. But if you had to return to the limit

$$f'(x) \;=\; \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$$

every single time you wanted a derivative, calculus would be unusable. Differentiating $x^7 - 4x^3 + \frac{1}{x}$ from scratch would take a page of algebra and a prayer that no h got left behind.

This chapter is about freedom from that drudgery. We will build a small toolkit of *rules* – the power rule, the constant-multiple and sum rules, the product rule, the quotient rule, and the central tool for compositions, the chain rule – that let you differentiate almost any function you can write down, quickly and mechanically. Rather than merely listing formulas, we will derive each rule from the limit definition and see *why* it takes the shape it does. The product rule expresses how a growing rectangle gains area along two sides at once; the chain rule expresses why rates of change multiply when you link two processes together.

By the end you will not only be able to differentiate fluently – you will be able to *reconstruct* each rule if you ever forget it, because you will know where it comes from.

Focus

The plan: each rule gets (1) a picture or piece of intuition, (2) a careful derivation from the limit definition, (3) a *why* box exposing the mechanism, and (4) worked examples. The order is deliberate: the easy rules (power, constant multiple, sum) first, then product and quotient, then the chain rule, which powers almost everything that comes after it in this book.

11.1 The Building Blocks: Two Derivatives We Already Know

Before any rules, we need raw material. Two derivatives are so simple we can read them straight off the limit definition, and everything else will be assembled from them.

11.1.1 The derivative of a constant is zero

Let $f(x) = c$, a constant – the graph is a flat horizontal line at height c. A flat line has slope 0 everywhere, so we already expect $f'(x) = 0$. The limit confirms it instantly:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{c - c}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{0}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} 0 = 0.$$

The numerator is exactly zero for *every* h, because a constant function does not change. There is nothing accumulating, so there is no rate.

Intuition

A constant function is a thing that never moves. Its rate of change is the rate at which a parked car covers distance: zero. Keep this in mind – it is why additive constants (the "$+C$" you will meet again with integrals) vanish under differentiation.

11.1.2 The derivative of x is one

Let $f(x) = x$. The graph is the 45° line through the origin, slope 1 everywhere. Again the limit agrees:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{(x+h) - x}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{h}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} 1 = 1.$$

When x increases by h, the output $f(x) = x$ increases by exactly h. Output change divided by input change is $h/h = 1$. The identity function passes change through untouched, so its rate is 1.

These two facts – $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(c) = 0$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) = 1$ – are the atoms. Now let us learn how to combine atoms.

Pause

Pause and think. What is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\pi^3)$? And what is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(5x)$? Before turning the page: π^3 is a fixed number (roughly 31.006), not a variable, so its derivative is 0, not $3\pi^2$. For $5x$, the constant factor 5 scales the derivative of x (which is 1), giving $5 \cdot 1 = 5$. Distinguishing fixed numbers from changing variables is the first habit of fluent differentiation.

11.2 Constant Multiples and Sums: Differentiation is Linear

11.2.1 The constant-multiple rule

Suppose you already know f', and you scale the whole function by a constant k, forming $g(x) = k\,f(x)$. What happens to the slope? Stretching a graph vertically by a factor of k stretches all its *rises* by k while leaving the *runs* alone – so every slope is multiplied by k.

Theorem 11.1 (Constant-multiple rule)**.** *If f is differentiable and k is a constant, then kf is differentiable and*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(k\,f(x)) = k\,f'(x).$$

Proof. Go to the definition and watch the constant ride along outside the difference quotient:

$$(kf)'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{kf(x+h) - kf(x)}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} k \cdot \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h} = k \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h} = k\, f'(x).$$

The single nontrivial move is pulling k out of the limit, which is legal because a constant factor always survives a limit unchanged. □

11.2.2 The sum rule

Now add two functions: $g(x) = f(x) + p(x)$. If f is rising at rate f' and p is rising at rate p', then their sum rises at the combined rate $f' + p'$. Rates simply add, the way two streams pouring into one tank add their flows.

Theorem 11.2 (Sum (and difference) rule)**.** *If f and p are differentiable, then so is $f \pm p$, and*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(f(x) \pm p(x)) = f'(x) \pm p'(x).$$

Proof. Form the difference quotient and regroup the four terms so the f's sit together and the p's sit together:

$$(f+p)'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{[f(x+h) + p(x+h)] - [f(x) + p(x)]}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} \left(\frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h} + \frac{p(x+h) - p(x)}{h} \right).$$

The limit of a sum is the sum of the limits (each exists, by assumption), so this is $f'(x) + p'(x)$. The subtraction case is identical with a minus sign. □

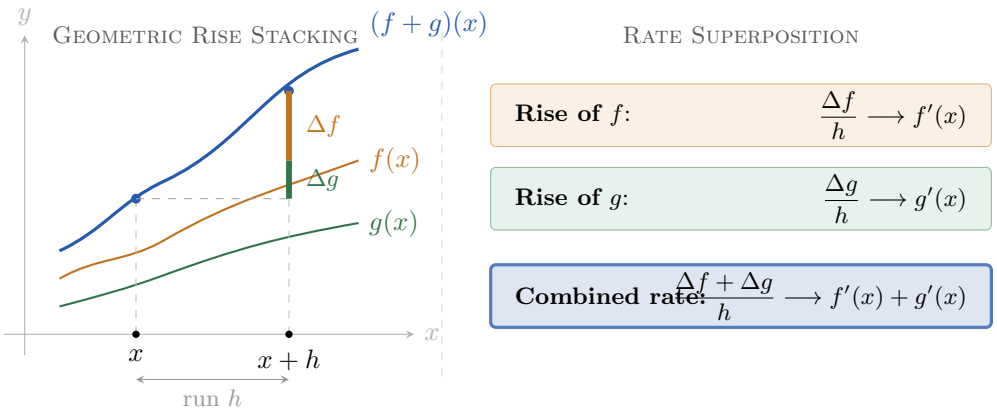


Figure 11.1: Why the sum rule holds: rates add because vertical rises stack over a common run. Left: Over the horizontal step h, curve f rises by Δf and curve g rises by Δg. The sum function $(f + g)$ gains the stacked total rise $\Delta f + \Delta g$. Right: Because both functions share the identical horizontal run h, dividing by h distributes linearity: $\frac{\Delta(f+g)}{h} = \frac{\Delta f}{h} + \frac{\Delta g}{h} \to f'(x) + g'(x)$.

Why the technique works

Together, the constant-multiple and sum rules say the derivative is a *linear operator*—a transformation that respects scaling and addition, meaning the derivative of a combined expression is simply the combination of the separate derivatives: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(af+bg) = af' + bg'$. This is the single most useful structural fact about differentiation. It is what lets you differentiate a long polynomial term-by-term, never having to deal with the whole thing at once. The reason is that the difference quotient itself is built from subtraction and division by h – both linear operations – and the limit preserves linearity. Differentiation inherits its linearity from the linearity of "measuring change" (Figure 11.1).

Common trap

Linearity covers sums and constant multiples *only*. It does *not* extend to products or quotients:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(f\cdot g) \neq f'\cdot g', \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{f}{g}\right) \neq \frac{f'}{g'}.$$

A great many wrong answers in calculus come from wishing products behaved as nicely as sums. They do not – and the next two sections are devoted to what really happens.

11.3 The Power Rule

For any constant exponent n,

$$\boxed{\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = n\,x^{\,n-1}.}$$

"Bring the exponent down in front, then knock the exponent down by one." You will use this thousands of times. But where does it come from? We will prove it three ways, each of which teaches something different: first for small integers by hand, then for all positive integers by the binomial theorem, and finally we will explain why it keeps working for negative and fractional exponents.

11.3.1 Warm-up: x^2 and x^3 by hand

Example 11.1 (The derivative of x^2)**.** Let $f(x) = x^2$. Then

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0}\frac{(x+h)^2 - x^2}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0}\frac{x^2+2xh+h^2-x^2}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0}\frac{2xh+h^2}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0}(2x+h) = 2x.$$

The x^2 cancels; the surviving terms all carry an h, so dividing by h leaves $2x+h$, and the leftover h dies in the limit. Result: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(x^2\big) = 2x = 2x^{2-1}$. The pattern holds.

Example 11.2 (The derivative of x^3)**.** Now $f(x) = x^3$. Using $(x+h)^3 = x^3 + 3x^2h + 3xh^2 + h^3$,

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0}\frac{3x^2h + 3xh^2 + h^3}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0}\big(3x^2 + 3xh + h^2\big) = 3x^2 = 3x^{3-1}.$$

Again the lone x^3 cancels, every surviving term has at least one h, and only the term with a *single* h — namely $3x^2h$ — contributes after we divide by h and take $h \to 0$. That single first-order term sets the instantaneous rate.

What is really happening

Look at what survives. When you expand $(x+h)^n$ you get x^n plus a term with exactly one h, plus higher-order terms in $h^2, h^3, \ldots$ The x^n cancels the $-x^n$. After dividing by h, the single-h term loses its h and becomes a clean constant in h; every other term still carries at least one factor of h and therefore vanishes as $h \to 0$. *The derivative reads off the coefficient of the linear term* — the portion of the change proportional to the nudge h. All higher powers are second-order small, vanishing at the instant. This is the governing mechanism of differential calculus: the derivative isolates the linear response of a function to a microscopic step.

11.3.2 All positive integers at once: the binomial theorem

The hand calculations practically prove themselves once you name the pattern. The binomial theorem expands

$$(x+h)^n = x^n + nx^{n-1}h + \binom{n}{2}x^{n-2}h^2 + \cdots + h^n.$$

The first term is x^n, the second is $nx^{n-1}h$ (this is the one that matters), and every later term carries h^2 or higher.

Theorem 11.3 (Power rule, positive integers)**.** *For every positive integer n, $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = nx^{n-1}$.*

Proof. Subtract x^n, divide by h:

$$\frac{(x+h)^n - x^n}{h} = \frac{nx^{n-1}h + \binom{n}{2}x^{n-2}h^2 + \cdots + h^n}{h} = nx^{n-1} + \underbrace{\binom{n}{2}x^{n-2}h + \cdots + h^{n-1}}_{\text{every term has an } h}.$$

As $h \to 0$ every term in the underbrace contains at least one factor of h and so tends to 0. What remains is nx^{n-1}. □

Pause

Pause and think. What does the power rule give when $n = 1$? The formula yields $1 \cdot x^{1-1} = 1 \cdot x^0 = 1$, instantly recovering our atom $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) = 1$ from Section 11.1. And when $n = 0$ (for $x \neq 0$), $x^0 = 1$ yields $0 \cdot x^{-1} = 0$, matching $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(c) = 0$ (which itself holds even at $x = 0$). The power rule unifies all polynomials under one formula.

11.3.3 Why it survives to negative and fractional exponents

The binomial proof only handles $n = 1, 2, 3, \ldots$ Yet the rule is true far more generally: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(x^{-2}\right) = -2x^{-3}$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(x^{1/2}\right) = \frac{1}{2}x^{-1/2}$ both obey "nx^{n-1}." We are not equipped to prove the full real-exponent case yet – the cleanest proof waits until we have the chain rule and the logarithm (next chapter), where $x^n = e^{n \ln x}$ makes it a one-liner. But two special cases are within reach right now, and they are worth doing because they showcase the algebra.

Example 11.3 (A negative exponent: $1/x$)**.** Let $f(x) = x^{-1} = 1/x$. Then

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{1}{h}\left(\frac{1}{x+h} - \frac{1}{x}\right) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{1}{h}\cdot\frac{x-(x+h)}{x(x+h)} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{-h}{h\,x(x+h)} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{-1}{x(x+h)} = -\frac{1}{x^2}.$$

That is $-x^{-2} = (-1)x^{-1-1}$: the power rule with $n = -1$, exactly as advertised.

Example 11.4 (A fractional exponent: $\sqrt{x}$)**.** Let $f(x) = \sqrt{x} = x^{1/2}$ (for $x > 0$). The trick is to rationalize – multiply by the conjugate to clear the difference of square roots:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\sqrt{x+h} - \sqrt{x}}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{(\sqrt{x+h} - \sqrt{x})(\sqrt{x+h} + \sqrt{x})}{h(\sqrt{x+h} + \sqrt{x})}.$$

The numerator collapses to $(x+h) - x = h$, which cancels the h below:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{1}{\sqrt{x+h} + \sqrt{x}} = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,x^{-1/2}.$$

And $\frac{1}{2}x^{-1/2} = \frac{1}{2}x^{1/2-1}$ – the power rule again, now with $n = \frac{1}{2}$.

Why the technique works

Why does "bring down the exponent" work? Geometrically, think of x^n as the *volume of an n-dimensional cube* of side x. Nudge the side from x to $x + h$. The cube gains a thin slab on each of its n faces, each slab of area x^{n-1} and thickness h, for a leading gain of $n \cdot x^{n-1} \cdot h$. (The edges and corners where slabs overlap involve h^2 and smaller – negligible at an instant.) Divide that gain by h and you get nx^{n-1}. The n in front is literally counting the n faces of the cube that grow. We will see this same "thicken each face" picture again, in two dimensions, when we prove the product rule.

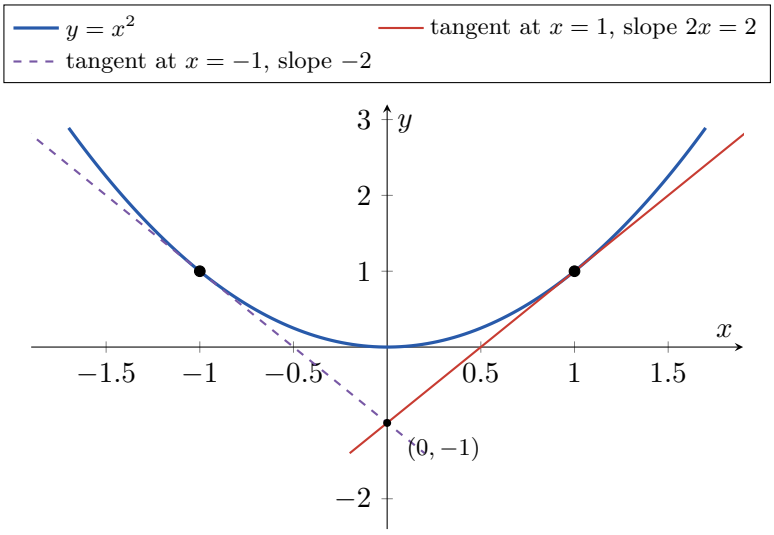


Figure 11.2: The power rule in action for $y = x^2$. At $x = 1$ the predicted slope is $2x = 2$; at $x = -1$ it is -2. The tangent lines have exactly those slopes. Differentiation reads the steepness directly off the formula $2x$.

11.3.4 Polynomials: linearity plus the power rule

The power rule plus linearity (Section 11.2) differentiate *any* polynomial on sight, term by term.

Example 11.5 (A polynomial)**.** Differentiate $p(x) = 4x^5 - 7x^3 + 2x^2 - 9x + 6$.

Work term by term. The exponent comes down, drops by one, and constants multiply through; the lone constant 6 dies:

$$p'(x) = 4 \cdot 5x^4 - 7 \cdot 3x^2 + 2 \cdot 2x - 9 \cdot 1 + 0 = 20x^4 - 21x^2 + 4x - 9.$$

Example 11.6 (Rewrite, then differentiate)**.** Differentiate $g(x) = \dfrac{3}{x^2} + 5\sqrt{x} - \dfrac{x^4}{2}$.

First rewrite every piece as a power of x so the power rule can grip it:

$$g(x) = 3x^{-2} + 5x^{1/2} - \tfrac{1}{2}x^4.$$

Now differentiate each power:

$$g'(x) = 3(-2)x^{-3} + 5 \cdot \tfrac{1}{2}x^{-1/2} - \tfrac{1}{2} \cdot 4x^3 = -6x^{-3} + \tfrac{5}{2}x^{-1/2} - 2x^3 = -\frac{6}{x^3} + \frac{5}{2\sqrt{x}} - 2x^3.$$

The lesson: rewriting roots and fractions as exponents is the essential first step.

Work it yourself

Differentiate $h(x) = x^7 - 3x^4 + \dfrac{1}{x^3} - \sqrt[3]{x}$ by hand. (Hint: rewrite the last two terms as x^{-3} and $x^{1/3}$.) You should get $h'(x) = 7x^6 - 12x^3 - 3x^{-4} - \frac{1}{3}x^{-2/3}$. Then check one value, say $x = 1$, by comparing to a numerical slope $\dfrac{h(1.001) - h(0.999)}{0.002}$.

11.4 The Product Rule

We come to the first rule that genuinely surprises people. The naive guess – "the derivative of a product is the product of the derivatives" – is *wrong*, and a single example demolishes it.

Common trap

Take $f(x) = x$ and $g(x) = x$, so $f(x)g(x) = x^2$. The correct derivative is $2x$. But $f'(x)g'(x) = 1 \cdot 1 = 1 \neq 2x$. The product of the derivatives is not the derivative of the product. Something else is going on.

11.4.1 The picture: a growing rectangle

One picture makes the product rule obvious. Imagine a rectangle whose width is $f(x)$ and whose height is $g(x)$. Its area is the product $A(x) = f(x)g(x)$. Now nudge x forward by a tiny h. The width grows by $\Delta f = f(x+h) - f(x)$ and the height grows by $\Delta g = g(x+h) - g(x)$. How much new area appears?

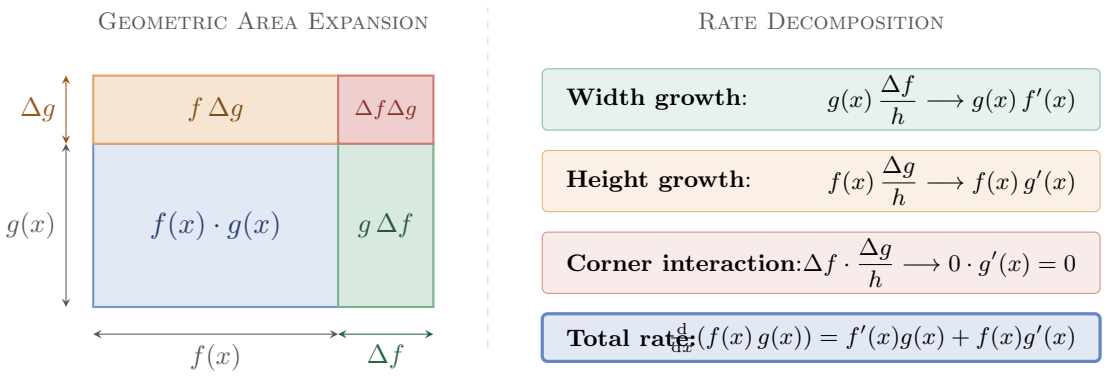


Figure 11.3: Why the product rule has two terms. Left: Growing both dimensions of a rectangle creates a tall strip $g\,\Delta f$, a wide strip $f\,\Delta g$, and a microscopic corner $\Delta f\,\Delta g$. Right: Dividing each piece by h and taking the limit $h \to 0$ reveals that the two edge strips produce finite rates gf' and fg', while the second-order corner vanishes because $\Delta f \to 0$.

The new area comes in three pieces (Figure 11.3):

- a *tall strip* along the right edge, of height g and width Δf: area $g\,\Delta f$;
- a *wide strip* along the top edge, of width f and height Δg: area $f\,\Delta g$;
- a *tiny corner* rectangle of dimensions Δf by Δg: area $\Delta f\,\Delta g$.

So the change in area is

$$\Delta A = g\,\Delta f + f\,\Delta g + \Delta f\,\Delta g.$$

Divide by h to get the rate, and watch the corner term:

$$\frac{\Delta A}{h} = g\,\frac{\Delta f}{h} + f\,\frac{\Delta g}{h} + \Delta f \cdot \frac{\Delta g}{h}.$$

As $h \to 0$, $\Delta f/h \to f'$ and $\Delta g/h \to g'$. The first two terms become gf' and fg'. The corner term is $\Delta f \cdot (\Delta g/h)$; the factor $\Delta g/h$ tends to g' (finite), but $\Delta f \to 0$, so the whole corner vanishes. The geometric insight is straightforward: *the corner is the product of two small quantities, and therefore shrinks at second order.* It contributes nothing to the instantaneous rate of change.

Theorem 11.4 (Product rule)**.** *If f and g are differentiable, then so is fg, and*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(f(x)\,g(x)) = f'(x)\,g(x) + f(x)\,g'(x).$$

Proof. The picture is correct, but let us pin it down with the clean algebraic trick that makes the corner term appear and disappear: *add and subtract the same mixed term.* Start from the difference quotient and insert $-f(x+h)g(x) + f(x+h)g(x)$ (a clever zero):

$$\frac{f(x+h)g(x+h) - f(x)g(x)}{h} = \frac{f(x+h)g(x+h) - f(x+h)g(x) + f(x+h)g(x) - f(x)g(x)}{h}.$$

Group the first two and last two terms, factoring out the common piece in each:

$$= f(x+h)\,\frac{g(x+h) - g(x)}{h} \;+\; g(x)\,\frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h}.$$

Now take $h \to 0$ term by term. In the first term, $f(x+h) \to f(x)$ (because f, being differentiable, is continuous) and $\dfrac{g(x+h)-g(x)}{h} \to g'(x)$. In the second term, $g(x)$ is constant in h and $\dfrac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h} \to f'(x)$. Hence the limit is

$$f(x)\,g'(x) + g(x)\,f'(x),$$

which is the product rule. □

Why the technique works

Why *two* terms? Because a product depends on *both* of its factors, and at any instant both factors are changing at once. The rectangle picture illustrates this directly: area is gained on two sides simultaneously. The term $f'g$ is the contribution from the width growing while the height holds; fg' is the contribution from the height growing while the width holds. You can think of it as "hold one factor still, differentiate the other, then swap and add." The reason you *add* them (rather than, say, multiply) is that to first order the two growths are independent – their interaction, the corner $\Delta f\,\Delta g$, is second-order small and drops out. This "vary one factor at a time and sum" pattern is exactly how the product rule generalizes: for three factors,

$$(fgh)' = f'gh + fg'h + fgh',$$

one term per factor, each differentiating a single factor while freezing the others.

Example 11.7 (A first product)**.** Differentiate $y = (x^2+1)(x^3-4x)$.

Let $f = x^2+1$ and $g = x^3-4x$, so $f' = 2x$ and $g' = 3x^2-4$. Then

$$y' = f'g + fg' = (2x)(x^3-4x) + (x^2+1)(3x^2-4).$$

Expand to simplify:

$$y' = (2x^4 - 8x^2) + (3x^4 - 4x^2 + 3x^2 - 4) = 5x^4 - 9x^2 - 4.$$

Sanity check. We could instead multiply out first: $y = x^5 - 4x^3 + x^3 - 4x = x^5 - 3x^3 - 4x$, whose derivative is $5x^4 - 9x^2 - 4$. Same answer. The product rule and "expand first" must agree – and here expanding was about as fast. The product rule becomes indispensable when expanding is tedious or impossible, as with $x^2 \sin x$ or $e^x \ln x$, which you cannot multiply out.

Example 11.8 (When you cannot expand)**.** Differentiate $y = x^2\sqrt{x+1}$. Write $g(x) = \sqrt{x+1}$: since $\frac{\sqrt{(x+h)+1}-\sqrt{x+1}}{h}$ is the difference quotient of $\sqrt{t}$ evaluated at $t = x+1$, we have $g'(x) = \frac{1}{2}(x+1)^{-1/2}$ directly (as the chain rule in the next section also confirms). With $f = x^2$, $f' = 2x$:

$$y' = 2x\sqrt{x+1} + x^2 \cdot \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x+1}} = 2x\sqrt{x+1} + \frac{x^2}{2\sqrt{x+1}}.$$

There is no way to "expand" a square root away; the product rule is essential here.

11.5 The Quotient Rule

Because division is the inverse of multiplication, we can derive the quotient rule directly from the product rule. Suppose $q(x) = \dfrac{f(x)}{g(x)}$ (with $g(x) \neq 0$). The cleanest derivation clears the denominator first.

11.5.1 Deriving it from the product rule

Write $f = q \cdot g$. Differentiate both sides with the product rule:

$$f' = q'g + qg'.$$

Now solve for the unknown q':

$$q' = \frac{f' - qg'}{g} = \frac{f' - \dfrac{f}{g}\,g'}{g} = \frac{f'g - fg'}{g^2},$$

where in the last step we substituted $q = f/g$ and multiplied top and bottom by g.

Theorem 11.5 (Quotient rule)**.** *If f and g are differentiable and $g(x) \neq 0$, then f/g is differentiable and*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{f(x)}{g(x)}\right) = \frac{f'(x)\,g(x) - f(x)\,g'(x)}{\big(g(x)\big)^2}.$$

Remark 11.1. The derivation above quietly assumed q was differentiable so that we could apply the product rule to $f = qg$. To certify from scratch that q is differentiable whenever $g(x) \neq 0$, put the difference quotient over a common denominator and insert $-f(x)g(x) + f(x)g(x)$:

$$\frac{\frac{f(x+h)}{g(x+h)} - \frac{f(x)}{g(x)}}{h} = \frac{\dfrac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h}\,g(x) - f(x)\,\dfrac{g(x+h) - g(x)}{h}}{g(x+h)\,g(x)} \xrightarrow{h\to 0} \frac{f'(x)g(x) - f(x)g'(x)}{\big(g(x)\big)^2},$$

since $g(x+h) \to g(x) \neq 0$ by continuity of g. The shortcut via $f = qg$ is the easiest way to *remember* the rule; the limit identity is what *certifies* it.

Why the technique works

The quotient rule's strange-looking minus sign and squared denominator are not arbitrary. Think of f/g as f times $1/g$. Increasing f pushes the quotient *up*: that is the $+f'g$ part. Increasing g pushes the quotient *down* – a bigger denominator means a smaller fraction – which is exactly why g' enters with a *minus*. The g^2 in the denominator is the price of the reciprocal: as we computed back in Example 11.3, $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(1/g)$ carries a $1/g^2$, and the quotient rule inherits it. Order matters in the numerator: it is $f'g - fg'$, "derivative of top times bottom, minus top times derivative of bottom." Swapping the two terms flips the sign and gives the wrong answer.

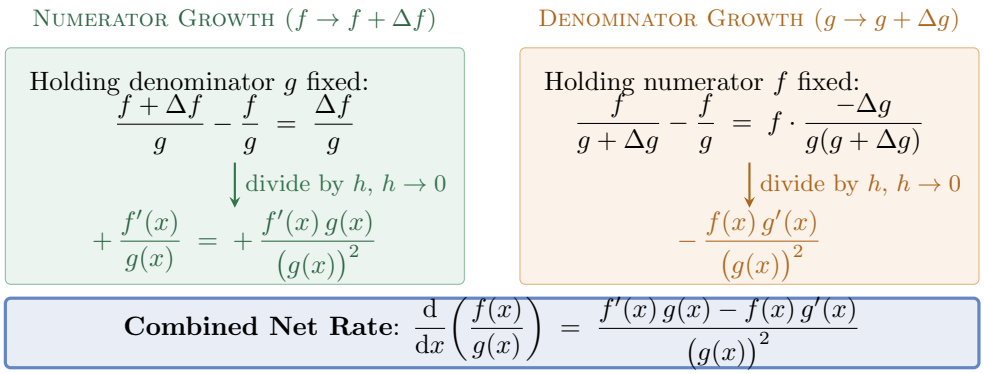


Figure 11.4: The mechanics of the quotient rule. The ratio f/g responds to two competing effects: numerator growth lifts the quotient at rate $+f'/g = +(f'g)/g^2$, while denominator growth pulls the quotient down at rate $-(fg')/g^2$. Superposing both linear responses yields the difference $f'g - fg'$ over the squared denominator g^2.

Common trap

The numerator of the quotient rule is *not* symmetric: $f'g - fg' \neq fg' - f'g$. A mnemonic that prevents the classic sign error: "low dee-high minus high dee-low, over the square of what's below." Here "high" is the numerator f, "low" is the denominator g, and "dee" means "derivative of." So: $\dfrac{\text{low} \cdot \text{high}' - \text{high} \cdot \text{low}'}{\text{low}^2} = \dfrac{gf' - fg'}{g^2}$. Same thing, written to keep the order straight.

Example 11.9 (A rational function)**.** Differentiate $q(x) = \dfrac{x^2 - 1}{x^2 + 1}$.

Top $f = x^2 - 1$, $f' = 2x$. Bottom $g = x^2 + 1$, $g' = 2x$. Then

$$q'(x) = \frac{f'g - fg'}{g^2} = \frac{2x(x^2+1) - (x^2-1)(2x)}{(x^2+1)^2}.$$

Expand the numerator:

$$2x(x^2+1) - 2x(x^2-1) = 2x\big[(x^2+1) - (x^2-1)\big] = 2x \cdot 2 = 4x.$$

So $q'(x) = \dfrac{4x}{(x^2+1)^2}$. Notice the numerator is clean while the denominator stays squared – a typical quotient-rule outcome.

Example 11.10 (Deriving the reciprocal rule)**.** Take $f = 1$ (so $f' = 0$) in the quotient rule:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{1}{g}\right) = \frac{0 \cdot g - 1 \cdot g'}{g^2} = -\frac{g'}{g^2}.$$

This *reciprocal rule* is worth memorizing on its own. As a check, with $g = x$ it gives $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(1/x) = -1/x^2$, matching Example 11.3.

History

The rules of this chapter emerged in the 1670s and 1680s from two very different ways of thinking about change. Both Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz were stuck on the same core problem: how to compute the tangent slopes and instantaneous rates of arbitrary curves without inventing an exhausting, bespoke geometric trick for every single equation.

Newton, working at Cambridge during the plague years of 1665–1666, conceived of calculus *kinematically*—viewing mathematics through the physical experience of time and motion. For Newton, curves were physical trajectories traced out by moving particles, variables were *fluents* (quantities that flow or grow continuously over time, like the altitude of a cannonball), and rates of change were *fluxions* ($\dot{x}, \dot{y}$), his name for their instantaneous velocities. With tools inherited from Euclidean geometry, Cartesian coordinates, and finite difference tables, Newton discovered versions of the product and chain rules early. Yet he viewed them through the mechanics of motion and guarded his manuscripts privately, sharing them only with a small circle of English correspondents.

Leibniz, working independently in Paris and Hanover, approached the problem not from physics, but from *combinatorics and symbolic logic*—treating mathematics as the systematic manipulation of expressive algebraic symbols. In October 1684, Leibniz published the very first paper on the differential calculus in the Leipzig journal *Acta Eruditorum* (the premier scholarly journal of continental Europe): *Nova Methodus pro Maximis et Minimis, itemque Tangentibus...* ("A New Method for Maxima and Minima, as well as Tangents, which is neither impeded by fractional nor irrational quantities..."). At just six pages, Leibniz's paper transformed mathematics through its notation and operational perspective. Leibniz introduced the differential symbols $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$ to denote tiny, localized steps, and treated differentiation rules as principles of *geometric algebra*—using geometric area models to discover symbolic algebraic identities.

To Leibniz, the product $u \cdot v$ was the area of a rectangle with sides u and v. If each side is given an *infinitesimal increment* $\mathrm{d}u$ and $\mathrm{d}v$—infinitely small nudges that were treated as nonzero when setting up ratios, yet small enough to vanish later—the expanded area is $(u + \mathrm{d}u)(v + \mathrm{d}v) = uv + u\,\mathrm{d}v + v\,\mathrm{d}u + \mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$. By discarding the second-order corner $\mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$ as incomparably smaller than the first-order strips, Leibniz deduced $\mathrm{d}(uv) = u\,\mathrm{d}v + v\,\mathrm{d}u$ directly. To find the differential of a quotient $q = u/v$, he inverted the geometry: writing $u = qv$, he applied the product rule to get $\mathrm{d}u = q\,\mathrm{d}v + v\,\mathrm{d}q$, and solved algebraically for $\mathrm{d}q = (\mathrm{d}u - q\,\mathrm{d}v)/v = (v\,\mathrm{d}u - u\,\mathrm{d}v)/v^2$.

This operational success was accompanied by a bitter priority dispute between the Royal Society in London and continental mathematicians over credit for the invention—a feud that divided British and continental mathematics for generations. It also drew sharp philosophical criticism: in his 1734 pamphlet *The Analyst*, Bishop George Berkeley pointed out the logical contradiction of treating increments as nonzero when forming ratios and as zero when discarding higher-order terms like $\mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$.

It took until the 1820s, when Augustin-Louis Cauchy reconstructed calculus on the firm foundation of *limits* (numbers that sequences of finite differences get arbitrarily close to), for Leibniz's geometric algebra to gain its modern rigor. The corner $\Delta u\,\Delta v$ is not discarded by arbitrary fiat; in the limit as $\Delta x \to 0$, its contribution $(\Delta u/\Delta x)\Delta v$ vanishes because $\Delta v \to 0$. Leibniz's geometric intuition was completely vindicated; Cauchy supplied the rigorous backbone.

11.6 The Chain Rule

The chain rule is the most important differentiation rule of all. The power, product, and quotient rules handle functions *built by* arithmetic; the chain rule handles functions built by *composition* – one function fed into another, like $(3x+1)^{10}$, $\sqrt{x^2+1}$, $\sin(x^2)$, or $e^{-t/2}$. Almost every interesting function in science is a composition, so almost every derivative you ever compute will lean on this rule.

11.6.1 The intuition: rates multiply

Forget formulas for a moment and think about *linked rates of change*. Suppose a car's fuel use depends on its speed, and its speed depends on time. Ask: how fast is fuel consumption changing with time?

Suppose that for each 1 km/h of extra speed the car burns 0.2 extra litres per hour (that is $\mathrm{d}(\text{fuel})/\mathrm{d}(\text{speed}) = 0.2$), and that right now the car is accelerating at 3 km/h per second ($\mathrm{d}(\text{speed})/\mathrm{d}t = 3$). Then per second the speed rises by 3 km/h, and each of those raises fuel use by 0.2 litre/h, so fuel use climbs by $0.2 \times 3 = 0.6$ litre/h per second. *The rates multiply.*

Intuition

Gears. Picture two meshed gears. If the first turns 3 times for each turn of the input shaft, and the second turns 2 times for each turn of the first, then the second turns $3 \times 2 = 6$ times per turn of the input. Compose the linkages, multiply the gear ratios. A derivative is precisely a "how-much-output-per-unit-input ratio," and composing functions chains the linkages – so you multiply the derivatives. That is the entire content of the chain rule, before any symbols.

In Leibniz notation the chain rule is almost self-evident. If y depends on u and u depends on x, then

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}u} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x},$$

and it *looks* as if the $\mathrm{d}u$'s simply cancel like fractions. That apparent cancellation is a major reason Leibniz's notation has lasted three centuries: it makes the chain rule easy to remember. (It is not *literally* fraction cancellation, because $\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}x$ is a limit, not a quotient of numbers; but it behaves enough like one that the mnemonic never lies to you here.)

11.6.2 Stating it in function notation

Let $y = f(g(x))$ – the "outer" function f applied to the "inner" function g. Setting $u = g(x)$, we have $y = f(u)$, and the chain rule reads:

Theorem 11.6 (Chain rule)**.** *If g is differentiable at x and f is differentiable at $g(x)$, then the composition $f \circ g$ is differentiable at x, and*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(f\big(g(x)\big)\big) = f'\big(g(x)\big) \cdot g'(x).$$

In words: derivative of the outside (evaluated at the inside) times derivative of the inside.

11.6.3 Why the naive proof almost works – and how to fix it

The natural proof writes the difference quotient and inserts a clever "multiply by 1." Let $u = g(x)$ and let $\Delta u = g(x+h) - g(x)$ be the change in the inner function. Then the change in y is $\Delta y = f(g(x+h)) - f(g(x)) = f(u+\Delta u) - f(u)$, and we write

$$\frac{\Delta y}{h} = \frac{f(u+\Delta u) - f(u)}{h} = \underbrace{\frac{f(u+\Delta u) - f(u)}{\Delta u}}_{\to f'(u)} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\Delta u}{h}}_{\to g'(x)}.$$

As $h \to 0$ we have $\Delta u \to 0$ (because g is continuous), so the first factor tends to $f'(u)$ and the second to $g'(x)$, giving $f'(u)\,g'(x)$. Beautiful – and almost correct.

Common trap

The catch: we divided by Δu, but Δu might be *zero* for some small h (imagine g momentarily flat). Then the fraction $\dfrac{f(u+\Delta u) - f(u)}{\Delta u}$ is $0/0$, undefined, and the slick cancellation is illegal. This is not pedantic fuss; it is a genuine gap that a rigorous proof must close.

11.6.4 A rigorous proof

The standard repair, due in spirit to Carathéodory, replaces the troublesome difference quotient by a single function that is well-behaved *even when* $\Delta u = 0$. Define the "error-corrected slope" of f at u:

$$\phi(t) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{f(t) - f(u)}{t - u}, & t \neq u, \\[2ex] f'(u), & t = u. \end{cases}$$

Because f is differentiable at u, the first branch tends to $f'(u)$ as $t \to u$, which is exactly the value we assigned in the second branch – so ϕ *is continuous at* u. Better still, for *every* t (including $t = u$), multiplying back across gives the clean identity

$$f(t) - f(u) = \phi(t)\,(t - u).$$

When $t \neq u$ this is clearing the fraction; when $t = u$ both sides are 0. Writing the change as a product rather than a fraction avoids dividing by zero altogether.

Proof of the chain rule. Put $t = g(x+h)$ and recall $u = g(x)$, so $t - u = \Delta u = g(x+h) - g(x)$. The identity $f(t) - f(u) = \phi(t)(t-u)$ becomes

$$f\big(g(x+h)\big) - f\big(g(x)\big) = \phi\big(g(x+h)\big) \cdot \big(g(x+h) - g(x)\big).$$

Divide by h (this is now perfectly safe – no division by Δu anywhere):

$$\frac{f(g(x+h)) - f(g(x))}{h} = \phi\big(g(x+h)\big) \cdot \frac{g(x+h) - g(x)}{h}.$$

Now let $h \to 0$. Since g is differentiable, it is continuous, so $g(x+h) \to g(x) = u$; and since ϕ is continuous at u, $\phi(g(x+h)) \to \phi(u) = f'(u)$. The second factor tends to $g'(x)$ by definition. Therefore the product tends to

$$f'(u) \cdot g'(x) = f'\big(g(x)\big)\,g'(x),$$

which is the chain rule. □

Why the technique works

Both proofs reach the same conclusion – "the two rates multiply" – and differ only in how they handle $\Delta u = 0$. The naive version divides by Δu and prays it is nonzero; the Carathéodory version replaces "difference quotient of f" with the genuinely continuous function ϕ, which equals that quotient when $\Delta u \neq 0$ but is also defined (as $f'(u)$) when $\Delta u = 0$. The product $f(t) - f(u) = \phi(t)(t-u)$ holds with no exceptions, so we never divide by something that might vanish. The moral is general: *when a proof stumbles over a possible* $0/0$*, look for a way to write the same quantity as a product instead of a quotient.*

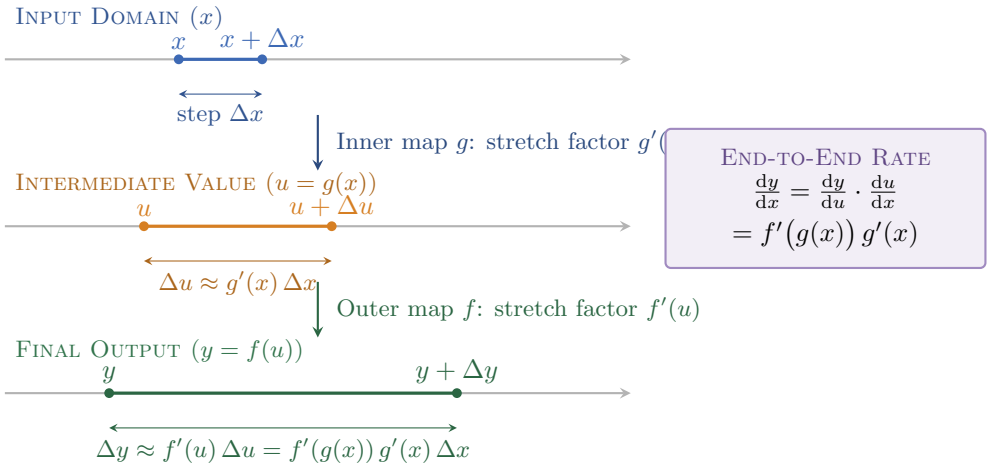


Figure 11.5: The chain rule as consecutive stretch factors across number lines. A small nudge Δx on the input axis is scaled by $g'(x)$ to produce the nudge Δu on the intermediate axis. That intermediate nudge is in turn scaled by $f'(u)$ on the output axis to produce Δy. Because the transformations act in sequence, their local scaling factors multiply.

11.6.5 Using it: differentiating from the outside in

In practice the chain rule is a peeling procedure. Identify the outermost operation, differentiate it while leaving the inside untouched, then multiply by the derivative of the inside – and recurse if the inside is itself a composition.

Example 11.11 (A power of a polynomial)**.** Differentiate $y = (3x+1)^{10}$.

Outer function: "something to the 10th," with derivative $10(\,\cdot\,)^9$. Inner function: $3x+1$, with derivative 3. So

$$y' = 10(3x+1)^9 \cdot 3 = 30(3x+1)^9.$$

Expanding $(3x+1)^{10}$ to differentiate term by term would mean eleven terms and a binomial expansion. The chain rule does it in one line.

Example 11.12 (A square root)**.** Differentiate $y = \sqrt{x^2+1} = (x^2+1)^{1/2}$.

Outer: $(\,\cdot\,)^{1/2}$, derivative $\frac{1}{2}(\,\cdot\,)^{-1/2}$. Inner: x^2+1, derivative $2x$. Thus

$$y' = \tfrac{1}{2}(x^2+1)^{-1/2}\cdot 2x = \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2+1}}.$$

Figure 11.6 shows this slope as an actual tangent line. This finally justifies the square-root step we borrowed in Example 11.8.

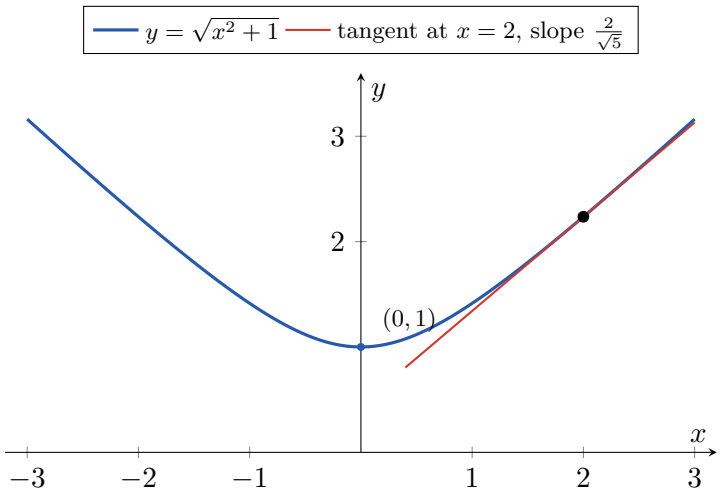


Figure 11.6: The chain rule predicts the slope of a composition. For $y = \sqrt{x^2+1}$ the chain rule gives $y' = x/\sqrt{x^2+1}$; at $x = 2$ this is $2/\sqrt{5} \approx 0.894$, the slope of the tangent line drawn here. The inner derivative $2x$ is exactly what tilts the tangent away from the slope of the bare square root.

Example 11.13 (The general power-chain shortcut)**.** Combining the power rule with the chain rule gives a pattern you will use constantly:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big((g(x))^n\big) = n\big(g(x)\big)^{n-1}\,g'(x).$$

For instance $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big((x^3-2x)^4\big) = 4(x^3-2x)^3(3x^2-2)$.

Example 11.14 (Two layers deep)**.** Differentiate $y = \big(\sqrt{x}+1\big)^3$ – a composition inside a composition.

Work from the outside in. Outermost: $(\,\cdot\,)^3$, derivative $3(\,\cdot\,)^2$. Its inside is $\sqrt{x}+1$, whose derivative is $\frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}$ (the $+1$ contributes nothing). So

$$y' = 3\big(\sqrt{x}+1\big)^2\cdot\frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}} = \frac{3\big(\sqrt{x}+1\big)^2}{2\sqrt{x}}.$$

If there had been a third layer, we would simply have multiplied by one more inner derivative. The chain rule composes as many times as you need: each nested layer contributes one more factor to the product.

Common trap

The single most common chain-rule error is *forgetting the inner derivative*. People write $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big((3x+1)^{10}\big) = 10(3x+1)^9$ and stop – dropping the $\times 3$. The tell-tale check: if the inside is just x, the inner derivative is 1 and you are back to the plain power rule; the moment the inside is anything more interesting, that $\times g'(x)$ factor is doing real work. *Never let go of the inside.*

11.6.6 Combining all the rules

Real problems braid the rules together. The skill is recognizing the *outermost* structure first – is the whole expression a sum, a product, a quotient, or a composition? – and applying the matching rule, then recursing into the pieces.

Example 11.15 (Product and chain together)**.** Differentiate $y = x^2\,(2x+3)^5$.

The outermost structure is a *product*: $f = x^2$ times $g = (2x+3)^5$. Product rule first:

$$y' = f'g + fg' = 2x\,(2x+3)^5 + x^2 \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big((2x+3)^5\big)\,.$$

The remaining derivative $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big((2x+3)^5\big)$ needs the *chain* rule: $5(2x+3)^4 \cdot 2 = 10(2x+3)^4$. Substitute back:

$$y' = 2x(2x+3)^5 + 10x^2(2x+3)^4.$$

You can factor out the common $2x(2x+3)^4$ to tidy up:

$$y' = 2x(2x+3)^4\big[(2x+3) + 5x\big] = 2x(2x+3)^4(7x+3).$$

Example 11.16 (Quotient and chain together)**.** Differentiate $y = \dfrac{(x+1)^3}{x^2+1}$.

Outermost structure: a *quotient*. Top $f = (x+1)^3$ with $f' = 3(x+1)^2$ (chain rule, inner derivative 1); bottom $g = x^2+1$ with $g' = 2x$. Quotient rule:

$$y' = \frac{3(x+1)^2(x^2+1) - (x+1)^3(2x)}{(x^2+1)^2}.$$

Factor $(x+1)^2$ from the numerator:

$$y' = \frac{(x+1)^2\big[3(x^2+1) - 2x(x+1)\big]}{(x^2+1)^2} = \frac{(x+1)^2\,(x^2-2x+3)}{(x^2+1)^2}.$$

(The bracket simplifies as $3x^2+3-2x^2-2x = x^2-2x+3$.)

Walking question

On your next walk, try differentiating $\big((x^2+1)^3\big)$ *two ways* in your head: once by the chain rule directly, and once by first imagining it as the product $(x^2+1)(x^2+1)(x^2+1)$ and using the three-factor product rule. Convince yourself both give $6x(x^2+1)^2$. Then ask: why *must* they agree? (Because they are the same function – and a function has only one derivative.

The rules are different roads to one destination, and the destination cannot move.)

Application

Backpropagation and the chain rule. In machine learning, training a neural network means minimizing a loss that is a deep composition – layer after layer after layer of functions stacked on top of one another. *Backpropagation*, the algorithm that makes modern deep learning possible, is simply the chain rule applied mechanically through that stack, multiplying the local rate of change at each layer to get the overall rate of change of the loss with respect to each weight. When you read that a network "propagates gradients backward," it is computing $f'(g(x)) \cdot g'(x)$ over and over, exactly the rule you just proved.

Connection

The chain rule is the seed of multivariable calculus. When y depends on several intermediate quantities that each depend on x, the single product $f'(g(x))g'(x)$ becomes a *sum* of such products – the multivariable chain rule – and that sum, written compactly, is a dot product of the gradient with a velocity vector. The gradient, directional derivatives, and the backpropagation above are all multivariable generalizations of the chain rule. We will return to this when we reach functions of several variables.

11.7 A Summary You Can Trust

You now hold the complete elementary toolkit. Every entry below was *derived*, not decreed, and each carries a one-line reason you can reconstruct.

Rule	**Formula**	**Why**
Constant	$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(c) = 0$	flat line, no change
Identity	$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) = 1$	change passes through
Power	$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = nx^{n-1}$	linear term of $(x+h)^n$ survives
Constant multiple	$(kf)' = kf'$	vertical stretch scales all slopes
Sum	$(f \pm g)' = f' \pm g'$	rates add
Product	$(fg)' = f'g + fg'$	rectangle grows on two sides
Quotient	$\left(\frac{f}{g}\right)' = \frac{f'g - fg'}{g^2}$	top up, bottom down
Chain	$\big(f(g(x))\big)' = f'(g(x))\, g'(x)$	rates multiply

Why this matters

Consider the structure of these rules. Two basic derivatives ($\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(c) = 0$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) = 1$), one structural principle (linearity), and three combination rules (product, quotient, chain) generate the derivative of *every* function you can build from powers by the four arithmetic operations and composition. That is an enormous reach from a small set of tools, and none of it was arbitrary: each rule is forced by what "rate of change" *means* once you take the limit seriously. A handful of plain ideas, pushed carefully, organize an entire system of computation.

11.7.1 The Scope and Horizon of Differentiation Rules

Connection

Before Leibniz's 1684 paper, finding the slope of a curve required a custom geometric argument for almost every new equation. Mathematicians had to devise bespoke geometric constructions or labor through fresh difference-quotient expansions curve by curve. Leibniz's rules automated differentiation. By recognizing that functions are assembled algebraically from atomic pieces, calculus gained a grammar: any function constructed from powers, sums, products, quotients, and compositions could be differentiated mechanically on paper without returning to the limit definition from scratch.

Yet for all their algebraic power, differentiation rules provide purely *local* information. The derivative $f'(x_0)$ reports the instantaneous velocity or the tilt of the tangent line at one isolated point x_0. It does not, on its own, reveal the global shape of an entire curve or locate the absolute peak and deepest valley on a domain. Nor can a single local derivative guarantee that a function is monotonic or invertible across an interval, or bound how quickly a tangent line deviates as you step away from x_0.

Turning these local rates into global understanding requires the tools ahead: we will add transcendental functions (Chapter 12) and implicit curves (Chapter 13), then use the Mean Value Theorem and critical points (Chapters 15–16) to translate local derivatives into the complete shape of a graph.

11.8 Exercises

Exercise 11.1 (Mental warm-ups)**.** Answer each in your head in ten seconds or less.

1. What is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^3)$? (Careful: is e^3 changing when x changes?)
2. What is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{1}{x^4}\right)$?
3. A student claims that the derivative of $(2x+1)^3$ is $3(2x+1)^2$. What essential factor was dropped?

Exercise 11.2 (Power-rule drill)**.** Differentiate each, rewriting roots and reciprocals as powers first.

1. $f(x) = 6x^4 - 2x^3 + x - 11$.
2. $g(x) = \dfrac{5}{x^3} - \dfrac{2}{\sqrt{x}} + 7$.

3. $h(x) = \sqrt[3]{x^2} + 4x^{-5}$.

Exercise 11.3 (Product rule)**.** Differentiate using the product rule, then (where feasible) check by expanding first.

1. $y = (2x^2 - 1)(x^3 + x)$.
2. $y = x^3\sqrt{x+4}$.
3. $y = (x^2+1)(x^2+2)(x^2+3)$ (use the three-factor product rule).

Exercise 11.4 (Quotient rule)**.** Differentiate and simplify.

1. $y = \dfrac{x}{x^2+1}$.
2. $y = \dfrac{2x-3}{4x+5}$.
3. $y = \dfrac{x^2}{(x-1)^2}$ (quotient rule, with the chain rule on the bottom).

Exercise 11.5 (Chain rule)**.** Differentiate. Work from the outside in, and do not drop the inner derivative.

1. $y = (5x^2 - 3)^7$.
2. $y = \sqrt{4 - x^2}$.
3. $y = \big((x+1)^2 + 1\big)^3$ (two layers).

Exercise 11.6 (All rules braided together)**.** Differentiate. First identify the outermost structure (sum, product, quotient, or composition).

1. $y = x^2\sqrt{x^2+1}$.
2. $y = \dfrac{(3x-1)^4}{x^2+1}$.
3. $y = \big(x + \sqrt{x}\big)^5$.

Exercise 11.7 (Conceptual: spot the error)**.** A student writes $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\dfrac{x^2}{x+1}\right) = \dfrac{2x}{1} = 2x$ by "differentiating top and bottom separately." Explain in one or two sentences why this is wrong, name the rule that should have been used, and give the correct derivative.

Exercise 11.8 (Conceptual: why two terms?)**.** In your own words, explain why $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(fg)$ has *two* terms rather than one, using the growing-rectangle picture. What does the third piece (the corner $\Delta f\,\Delta g$) represent, and why does it not appear in the final formula?

Exercise 11.9 (Reconstruct a rule)**.** Without looking back, derive the quotient rule from the product rule by writing $f = q\,g$ where $q = f/g$, differentiating, and solving for q'. Then check your result by computing $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(1/x)$ two ways: from the quotient rule and from the limit definition.

Exercise 11.10 (Proof: the power rule for negative integers)**.** Assume the power rule holds for positive integers and that the reciprocal rule holds. Let n be a positive integer and set $x^{-n} = 1/x^n$. Use the reciprocal rule $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(1/g) = -g'/g^2$ to prove

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(x^{-n}\big) = -n\,x^{-n-1},$$

thereby extending the power rule to negative integer exponents.

Exercise 11.11 (Proof: a three-factor product rule)**.** Prove that $(fgh)' = f'gh + fg'h + fgh'$ by treating fgh as the product of f with the single function (gh) and applying the two-factor product rule twice. Then state, without proof, the pattern for a product of n factors.

Exercise 11.12 (Proof: the chain rule cannot be skipped)**.** Let $F(x) = f(g(x))$ with $f(u) = u^2$ and $g(x) = x^2 + 1$.

1. Compute $F'(x)$ by the chain rule.
2. Compute $F'(x)$ instead by first expanding $F(x) = (x^2+1)^2 = x^4 + 2x^2 + 1$ and differentiating directly.
3. Verify the answers agree, and explain what would have gone wrong had you mistakenly written $F'(x) = f'(g(x)) = 2(x^2+1)$ without the factor $g'(x)$.

Exercise 11.13 (A limit that hides a derivative)**.** Recognize each limit as a derivative $f'(a)$ for a suitable f and a, and evaluate it using the rules of this chapter rather than the limit directly.

1. $\displaystyle\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{(2+h)^5 - 2^5}{h}$.
2. $\displaystyle\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\sqrt{9+h} - 3}{h}$.

Chapter 12

Derivatives of Exponentials, Logarithms, and Trig

In Chapter 11, we assembled the complete operational rulebook of differential calculus: the power rule, the product rule, the quotient rule, and the chain rule. With those four tools, we can differentiate any algebraic function built from powers and rational combinations of x. But core physical processes – growth, decay, and oscillation – require *transcendental functions*: functions that cannot be constructed from x by any finite sequence of additions, multiplications, divisions, and root extractions. Populations grow like e^{kt}. Radioactive nuclei decay like $e^{-\lambda t}$. A pendulum swings like $\cos(\omega t)$. The human sensations of pitch, loudness, and visual brightness scale logarithmically (measuring relative ratios rather than additive steps). If calculus could not differentiate e^x, $\ln x$, $\sin x$, and their relatives, it would be a beautiful theory with no grip on dynamics.

This chapter computes the derivatives of all of them. But we will not merely memorize a static table. Every single derivative here is *forced* by the underlying geometry of the function. The fact that $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^x) = e^x$ fulfills the central design of Chapter 3: e was chosen specifically so that the curve's rate of growth matches its current height. The formula $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) = \cos x$ comes directly from the velocity vector of a point moving around the unit circle. By the end, you should see that these formulas could not have turned out any other way.

12.1 The Exponential: a Function Equal to Its Own Slope

Back in Chapter 3, when we first explored exponential growth, we caught a glimpse of differential calculus before developing formal differentiation rules. Take any exponential function $f(x) = b^x$ with fixed positive base $b > 0$ and examine its rate of change straight from the difference quotient:

$$\begin{aligned} f'(x) &= \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{b^{x+h} - b^x}{h} \\ &= \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{b^x b^h - b^x}{h} \qquad \text{(law of exponents: } b^{x+h} = b^x b^h\text{)} \\ &= \lim_{h\to 0} b^x \cdot \frac{b^h - 1}{h} \\ &= b^x \cdot \underbrace{\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{b^h - 1}{h}}_{= m(b)}. \end{aligned}$$

Because exponents convert addition in the input into multiplication in the output ($b^{x+h} = b^x b^h$), the term b^x factors cleanly out of the limit since it does not depend on the step size h. What remains is a pure number depending only on the base b, which we named $m(b)$ in Chapter 3:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(b^x) \;=\; m(b) \cdot b^x, \qquad \text{where} \qquad m(b) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{b^h - 1}{h}.$$

Focus

The derivative of *any* exponential function is a constant multiple of *itself*. The curve b^x reproduces its own exact profile when differentiated, rescaled only by the fixed factor $m(b)$. No other family of functions exhibits this self-replicating geometry, and it is the origin of the exponential's dominance in models of physical growth.

Intuition

Why should the slope of b^x be proportional to its height? Picture compound interest or a dividing colony of bacteria. The more money deposited, the more interest earned per second; the more bacteria present, the more new cells divide per hour. Whenever a quantity's rate of change is proportional to its current size, the underlying curve is exponential. The multiplier $m(b)$ is the intrinsic "interest rate" built into base b.

12.1.1 The starting slope and the definition of e

As we established in Chapter 3, setting $x = 0$ in $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(b^x) = m(b)\, b^x$ gives

$$f'(0) = m(b) \cdot b^0 = m(b).$$

So $m(b)$ has an immediate geometric meaning: it is *the slope of b^x at the point $(0, 1)$ where it crosses the y-axis*. Every exponential curve passes through $(0, 1)$; what separates them is how steeply they launch from that point. Knowing the starting slope at the y-axis determines the slope everywhere on the curve: at height y, the slope is simply $m(b) \cdot y$.

In Chapter 3, we explored this starting slope numerically. For base $b = 2$, the curve leaves $(0, 1)$ with slope $m(2) \approx 0.693$, shallower than 45°. For base $b = 3$, it leaves with slope $m(3) \approx 1.099$, steeper than 45°. And we defined the number $e \approx 2.71828\ldots$ precisely as the unique base that launches with slope exactly 1.

Work it yourself

Recall the numerical experiment from Chapter 3 with step $h = 0.001$:

- $b = 2$: $(2^{0.001} - 1)/0.001 \approx 0.6934$.
- $b = 2.5$: $(2.5^{0.001} - 1)/0.001 \approx 0.9167$.
- $b = 2.718$: $(2.718^{0.001} - 1)/0.001 \approx 1.0004$.
- $b = 3$: $(3^{0.001} - 1)/0.001 \approx 1.0992$.

The starting slope $m(b)$ slides smoothly from below 1 to above 1. At the time, those numbers looked like arbitrary decimals produced by a calculator. But now notice: $\ln 2 \approx 0.693147$, and $\ln 3 \approx 1.098612$. The mystery constant $m(b)$ turns out to be the natural logarithm $\ln b$. To prove that link with complete rigor, we first anchor our baseline at e.

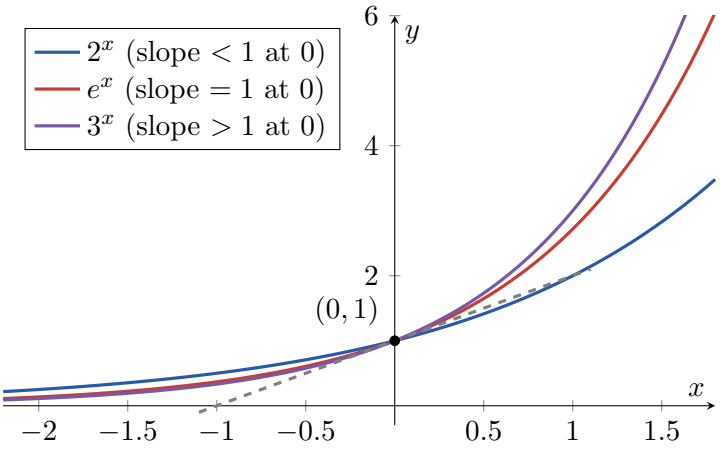


Figure 12.1: Every exponential passes through $(0, 1)$ but leaves at a different slope. The base e is the unique one whose tangent at $(0, 1)$ is the line $y = 1 + x$ (slope exactly 1, dashed).

12.1.2 Defining e as the base that makes $m(b) = 1$

We have found the cleanest possible definition of the number e. How do we know without a calculator that a slope-1 base exists? Because b^x bends upward for every $b > 1$, its tangent slope $m(b)$ at $(0, 1)$ is trapped between the secant slope on $[-1, 0]$ and the secant slope on $[0, 1]$, giving $1 - \frac{1}{b} < m(b) < b - 1$. At $b = 2$ this gives $m(2) < 2 - 1 = 1$, while at $b = 4$ comparing over the half-step $[-\frac{1}{2}, 0]$ gives $m(4) > \frac{1-4^{-1/2}}{1/2} = 1$. Since $m(b)$ increases continuously with b, the Intermediate Value Theorem guarantees a unique base strictly between 2 and 4 whose starting slope is 1. Its base is what we call e.

Definition 12.1 (The number e, via slope)**.** e is the unique base $b > 0$ for which

$$\lim_{h \to 0} \frac{b^h - 1}{h} = 1, \qquad \text{equivalently} \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x} b^x \Big|_{x=0} = 1.$$

With this base the constant $m(e) = 1$, so the leftover limit evaluates to 1 and we obtain the fundamental theorem:

Theorem 12.1 (The exponential is its own derivative)**.**

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^x) = e^x.$$

Proof. From the general formula $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(b^x) = m(b)\,b^x$ with $b = e$, and $m(e) = 1$ by Definition 12.1, we get $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^x) = 1 \cdot e^x = e^x$. □

Pause

Pause and think: What is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(e^4\right)$? Resist the reflex to write $4e^3$ or e^4. The quantity $e^4 \approx 54.598$ is a constant number, with no x in it at all. The derivative of any constant is zero: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(e^4\right) = 0$. The rule $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^u) = e^u \cdot u'$ applies only when the exponent contains a variable.

What is really happening

Look at what "$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^x) = e^x$" really asserts. At every point (x, e^x) on the curve, the steepness of the graph equals its height above the axis. At height 1 the slope is 1; at height 7 the slope is 7; at height 100 the slope is 100. The curve is racing upward exactly as fast as it is tall. That self-referential property – "the rate of growth equals the current size" – is what makes e^x grow rapidly, and it is why the same function appears whenever growth is proportional to current amount: interest, population expansion, and reaction dynamics. The function e^x is uniquely characterized as the function that equals its own rate of change and equals 1 at 0. Everything else about it follows.

History

Exponentials and logarithms entered mathematics long before derivatives did – not as abstract functions, but as practical tools for calculation. In the early seventeenth century, astronomical navigation and planetary calculations (such as Johannes Kepler's calculations of elliptical planetary orbits around the sun) were paralyzed by the sheer drudgery of multiplying and dividing eight-digit numbers by hand. In 1614, John Napier published *Mirifici Logarithmorum Canonis Descriptio*, followed shortly by Henry Briggs's 1624 tables of base-10 logarithms in *Arithmetica Logarithmica*. By converting arduous multiplications into simple additions ($\log(ab) = \log a + \log b$) using precomputed look-up tables of powers, logarithms were celebrated as having "doubled the lives of astronomers."

Yet for more than a century, logarithms were regarded purely as computational tables and geometric areas under hyperbolas (the two-branched curve $y = 1/x$), not as dynamic functions, and certainly not as the inverses of an exponential. The decisive transformation came in 1748 with Leonhard Euler's monumental two-volume treatise *Introductio in analysin infinitorum*. Euler shifted the foundation of mathematics away from geometric curves and onto analytical *functions*. He systematically established the number $e \approx 2.718281828459$, demonstrating that the compound-interest limit $\lim_{n\to\infty}(1 + 1/n)^n$, the infinite power series $\sum_{k=0}^{\infty} 1/k!$, and the unique base whose exponential slope is 1 at the origin are all identical manifestations of the same constant.

This new analytical world was not without fierce controversy. A celebrated dispute erupted between Euler and his former mentor, Johann Bernoulli, over the logarithm of negative numbers. Bernoulli insisted that since $(-x)^2 = x^2$, taking logarithms must yield $2\ln(-x) = 2\ln(x)$,

implying that $\ln(-x) = \ln(x)$ for all real x—so negative numbers would have ordinary, real logarithms. Euler dismantled Bernoulli's argument in 1749 by demonstrating that the logarithm is intrinsically multi-valued in the complex plane. Because completing a full 360° turn in the complex plane returns to the identical geometric point, angles can be shifted by any whole-number multiple of 2π without changing position; Euler showed that $\ln(-1) = (2k+1)\pi i$ for any integer k. The "natural" logarithm was far deeper than either Napier or Bernoulli had dreamed: it tied real rates of change directly to rotational geometry in the complex plane via Euler's formula ($e^{ix} = \cos x + i \sin x$).
What remains open today: In 1873, Charles Hermite proved that e is transcendental—meaning it cannot be the root of any algebraic polynomial equation with integer coefficients (such as $x^2 - 2 = 0$)—and Ferdinand von Lindemann proved the same for π in 1882. Yet simple questions remain open: to this day, no mathematician knows whether $e + \pi$, $e\pi$, or e^e is rational or irrational, or whether they are transcendental numbers. Nor has anyone resolved Schanuel's conjecture on the algebraic independence of exponentials.

Connection

Why does the slope-1 base equal the compound-interest limit? Here is the quick reconciliation. Suppose b is the base with $m(b) = 1$, i.e. $(b^h - 1)/h \to 1$ as $h \to 0$. For small h this says $b^h - 1 \approx h$, so $b^h \approx 1 + h$, hence $b \approx (1+h)^{1/h}$. Letting $h = 1/n$ and $n \to \infty$ turns the right side into $\lim_{n\to\infty}(1 + \frac{1}{n})^n$ – exactly the compound-interest definition of e. The two definitions are the same fact viewed from two heights.

12.2 The Natural Logarithm by Inverse Reasoning

Now that e^x is tamed, its inverse comes almost for free. Recall that $\ln x$ (the natural logarithm) is *defined* as the inverse of e^x:

$$y = \ln x \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad e^y = x, \qquad (x > 0).$$

So ln undoes $e^{(\cdot)}$ and vice versa: $e^{\ln x} = x$ and $\ln(e^x) = x$. We differentiate it two ways – once with a slick implicit argument, and once straight from the limit – because each illuminates the other.

12.2.1 Derivative of $\ln x$ by implicit differentiation

Intuition

A function and its inverse are reflections of each other across the line $y = x$. Reflection swaps the roles of x and y, which means it swaps horizontal "run" with vertical "rise." If the original curve has a steep slope of $m = \Delta y/\Delta x$, its reflection must have a gentle slope equal to the *reciprocal* $1/m = \Delta x/\Delta y$. The slope of the inverse function at any point is therefore the reciprocal of the original slope: $\big(f^{-1}\big)'(x) = 1/f'\big(f^{-1}(x)\big)$.

Because e^y is smooth and strictly increasing with nonzero slope $e^y > 0$ everywhere, its reflection $y = \ln x$ across $y = x$ has no vertical tangents and is differentiable for every $x > 0$. Start from $e^y = x$

and differentiate both sides with respect to x, using the chain rule on the left:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^y) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) \implies e^y \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 1.$$

Solve for $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ and then replace e^y by x (that is what e^y equals):

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{1}{e^y} = \frac{1}{x}.$$

That is the result, clean and complete.

Theorem 12.2 (Derivative of the natural log)**.** *For $x > 0$,*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln x) = \frac{1}{x}.$$

Why the technique works

The inverse-function trick works because differentiating the *identity* $e^{\ln x} = x$ forces the answer. Apply the chain rule to the left side: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(e^{\ln x}\right) = e^{\ln x} \cdot (\ln x)' = x \cdot (\ln x)'$. The right side is just 1. So $x \cdot (\ln x)' = 1$, giving $(\ln x)' = 1/x$ with no guessing at all. Whenever you know a function's derivative and want its inverse's derivative, differentiate the "they cancel" identity and solve. The reciprocal-of-the-slope picture and this one-line computation are the same idea: $\left(f^{-1}\right)'(x) = 1/f'\left(f^{-1}(x)\right)$.

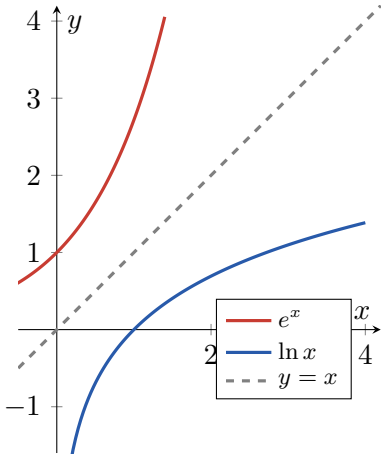


Figure 12.2: $\ln x$ is the mirror image of e^x across $y = x$. Where e^x climbs steeply, $\ln x$ rises gently: the slopes are reciprocals. As $x \to 0^+$, $\ln x$ plunges to $-\infty$ ever more steeply, matching $1/x \to +\infty$.

12.2.2 The same result straight from the limit

The same $1/x$ also drops out of the raw difference quotient, with no inverse machinery – and the derivation reconnects directly to the compound-interest limit for e along the way. We compute:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln x) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\ln(x+h) - \ln x}{h} = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{1}{h} \ln\left(\frac{x+h}{x}\right) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{1}{h} \ln\left(1 + \frac{h}{x}\right).$$

Let $u = h/x$, so $h = ux$ and $u \to 0$ as $h \to 0$. Then $1/h = 1/(ux)$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln x) = \lim_{u\to 0} \frac{1}{ux} \ln(1+u) = \frac{1}{x} \lim_{u\to 0} \frac{\ln(1+u)}{u} = \frac{1}{x} \lim_{u\to 0} \ln\Big[(1+u)^{1/u}\Big].$$

Inside the bracket sits $(1+u)^{1/u}$, which tends to e as $u \to 0$ (the compound-interest limit from Chapter 3 again, setting $u = 1/n$). Since ln is continuous we may pass the limit inside: the bracket becomes $\ln e = 1$. Therefore

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln x) = \frac{1}{x} \cdot \ln e = \frac{1}{x}.$$

Both roads lead to $1/x$, and both quietly rely on the same defining property of e. That is reassuring: the formula is not an artifact of one clever trick.

Why this matters

Notice the algebraic gap that $\ln x$ closes here, a fact we will rely on throughout the integration chapters. The power rule gives $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = nx^{n-1}$ for every exponent n – *except* $n = 0$, where it produces $0 \cdot x^{-1} = 0$ instead of x^{-1}. So in the entire family $\{x^n\}$ of algebraic powers there is no function whose derivative is $x^{-1} = 1/x$. The natural logarithm fills this exact role in calculus (and for $x < 0$, the chain rule gives $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln(-x)) = \frac{1}{-x}(-1) = \frac{1}{x}$ as well). This is why $\int \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \ln|x| + C$ – the logarithm is the antiderivative that the algebraic power rule does not supply.

12.3 General Bases: a^x and $\log_a x$

We deliberately built everything on base e because it is the base with no clutter. Other bases inherit their derivatives from e through one rewrite.

12.3.1 Derivative of a^x

The trick is to express *any* exponential in terms of the natural one. Since $a = e^{\ln a}$, we have $a^x = \left(e^{\ln a}\right)^x = e^{(\ln a)x}$. Now it is just the chain rule with inner function $(\ln a)x$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(a^x) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(e^{(\ln a)x}\right) = e^{(\ln a)x} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}((\ln a)x) = a^x \cdot \ln a.$$

The same rewrite settles the promise we left open in Chapter 11: the power rule for *any real exponent* r (including irrational ones like x^π or $x^{\sqrt{2}}$). For $x > 0$, write $x = e^{\ln x}$ so that $x^r = e^{r \ln x}$, and apply the chain rule:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^r) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(e^{r \ln x}\right) = e^{r \ln x} \cdot \frac{r}{x} = x^r \cdot \frac{r}{x} = r\, x^{r-1}.$$

Focus

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(a^x) = a^x \ln a.$$

Compare with our very first computation, $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(a^x) = m(a)\, a^x$. We have now *identified* the mystery constant: $m(a) = \ln a$. The slope of a^x at the y-axis is the natural log of its base. So

$m(2) = \ln 2 \approx 0.6931$ and $m(3) = \ln 3 \approx 1.0986$ – right where the finite-difference estimates from the lab box (0.6934 and 1.0992) were pointing. The small gap is just the overshoot from using $h = 0.001$ instead of the true limit; shrink h and the estimates march straight onto $\ln 2$ and $\ln 3$.

Work it yourself

Test the formula $m(a) = \ln a$ on a fresh base: take $a = 10$, where $\ln 10 \approx 2.302585$. At step $h = 0.001$, $(10^{0.001} - 1)/0.001 \approx 2.3052$; shrinking the step tenfold to $h = 0.0001$ gives $(10^{0.0001} - 1)/0.0001 \approx 2.3028$, cutting the overshoot tenfold and closing straight in on $\ln 10$.

12.3.2 Derivative of $\log_a x$

The general logarithm reduces to the natural one by the change-of-base formula $\log_a x = \dfrac{\ln x}{\ln a}$. Since $\ln a$ is a constant,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\log_a x) = \frac{1}{\ln a}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln x) = \frac{1}{(\ln a)\,x}.$$

Once more e is the standard base: with $a = e$ the factor $\ln a = 1$ vanishes and we recover $1/x$.

12.4 Logarithmic Differentiation

Here is a technique that turns the logarithm from an object of study into a *tool*. As an algebraic simplifier the natural log does two things: it converts products into sums and exponents into multipliers,

$$\ln(fg) = \ln f + \ln g, \qquad \ln\!\left(f^{\,g}\right) = g\,\ln f.$$

Differentiation distributes directly across sums, whereas products and variable exponents require more complex rules. So the plan is: take ln of both sides *first* to break the expression apart, differentiate the simpler pieces, then multiply back.

Why the technique works

The engine is the chain rule applied to $\ln y$. If $y = y(x)$, then

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln y) = \frac{1}{y}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{y'}{y}.$$

The quantity y'/y is the *logarithmic derivative*, also known as the *relative* or *fractional* rate of change – growth measured as a percentage of current size. So whenever you compute $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln y)$ you are really computing y'/y; multiply by y at the end to recover y' itself. Logarithmic differentiation is just this identity used in reverse: build y'/y out of easy log-pieces, then scale up by y.

Example 12.1 (A product of three factors)**.** Differentiate $y = \dfrac{(x^2+1)^3\sqrt{x-4}}{(x+2)^5}$. Doing this with

the quotient and product rules directly would be a bookkeeping nightmare. Instead take logs:

$$\ln y = 3\ln(x^2+1) + \tfrac{1}{2}\ln(x-4) - 5\ln(x+2).$$

Differentiate term by term (each is an easy chain-rule piece):

$$\frac{y'}{y} = 3\cdot\frac{2x}{x^2+1} + \frac{1}{2}\cdot\frac{1}{x-4} - 5\cdot\frac{1}{x+2} = \frac{6x}{x^2+1} + \frac{1}{2(x-4)} - \frac{5}{x+2}.$$

Finally multiply back by y:

$$y' = \frac{(x^2+1)^3\sqrt{x-4}}{(x+2)^5}\left[\frac{6x}{x^2+1} + \frac{1}{2(x-4)} - \frac{5}{x+2}\right].$$

All the structure of the original function survives out front, with a tidy sum of corrections inside the brackets.

Example 12.2 (A variable base *and* a variable exponent)**.** Differentiate $y = x^x$ for $x > 0$. Notice neither the power rule ($\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = nx^{n-1}$, exponent constant) nor the exponential rule ($\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(a^x) = a^x \ln a$, base constant) applies – here *both* the base and the exponent vary. Logs untangle it. Take ln:

$$\ln y = x\ln x.$$

Differentiate the right side with the product rule:

$$\frac{y'}{y} = 1\cdot\ln x + x\cdot\frac{1}{x} = \ln x + 1.$$

Multiply back: $y' = x^x(\ln x + 1)$. As a sanity check, x^x has its minimum where $y' = 0$, i.e. $\ln x = -1$, i.e. $x = 1/e \approx 0.368$ – which is indeed where the graph of x^x bottoms out (Figure 12.3).

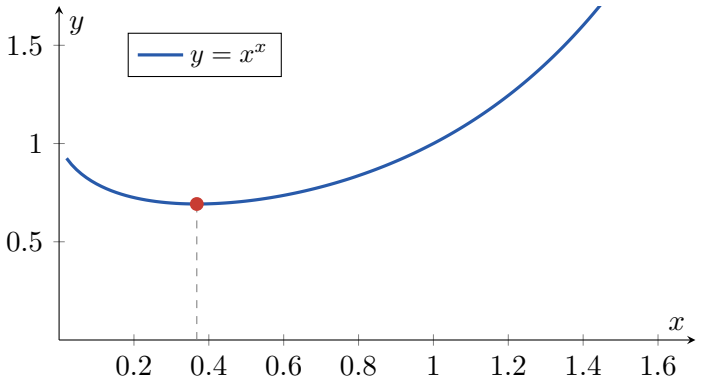


Figure 12.3: The graph of x^x for $x > 0$. Logarithmic differentiation gives $y' = x^x(\ln x + 1)$, which vanishes only at $x = 1/e \approx 0.368$, the marked low point. There $x^x = (1/e)^{1/e} \approx 0.692$.

Common trap

Do not write $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^x) = x\cdot x^{x-1}$ (treating the exponent as constant), and do not write $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^x) = x^x\ln x$ (treating the base as constant). *Both* are wrong because *both* the base and the exponent move. The correct derivative $x^x(\ln x + 1)$ contains a piece from each: the 1 comes from varying

the base, the $\ln x$ from varying the exponent. When in doubt with anything of the form $(\text{stuff})^{(\text{stuff})}$, take logs.

Pause

Pause and think: How do you differentiate x^5, 5^x, x^x, and 5^5? Sort them by their anatomy before putting pencil to paper:

- x^5: Variable base, constant power $\implies$ Power Rule: $5x^4$.
- 5^x: Constant base, variable power $\implies$ Exponential Rule: $5^x \ln 5$.
- x^x: Variable base, variable power $\implies$ Logarithmic Differentiation: $x^x(\ln x + 1)$.
- 5^5: Constant base, constant power $\implies$ Constant Rule: 0.

12.5 Sine and Cosine: the Two Limits That Decide Everything

Now we turn to *periodic functions*—functions whose values repeat at regular intervals, satisfying $f(x+T) = f(x)$ for a fixed period T. Their rates of change rest entirely on two geometric limits, with the angle θ measured in *radians* (the distance traveled along the perimeter of a unit circle of radius 1, where a complete revolution is 2π radians). The two limits are:

$$\lim_{\theta\to 0} \frac{\sin\theta}{\theta} = 1, \qquad \lim_{\theta\to 0} \frac{\cos\theta - 1}{\theta} = 0.$$

The first limit was established in the limits chapters via the squeeze theorem on unit-circle sectors. The second limit follows from the first by an elementary conjugate identity:

$$\frac{\cos\theta - 1}{\theta} = \frac{(\cos\theta - 1)(\cos\theta + 1)}{\theta(\cos\theta + 1)} = \frac{\cos^2\theta - 1}{\theta(\cos\theta + 1)} = \frac{-\sin^2\theta}{\theta(\cos\theta + 1)} = -\left(\frac{\sin\theta}{\theta}\right) \cdot \frac{\sin\theta}{\cos\theta + 1}.$$

As $\theta \to 0$, the first factor $\frac{\sin\theta}{\theta} \to 1$, while the second factor heads to $\frac{0}{1+1} = 0$. Their product is $1 \cdot 0 = 0$.

Intuition

On the unit circle, the *angle* θ (in radians) is the arc length swept out along the circumference, and $\sin\theta$ is the vertical height of the endpoint. For a tiny angle, the curved circular arc and the straight vertical rise are nearly indistinguishable, so $\sin\theta \approx \theta$—their ratio heads to 1. Meanwhile, $\cos\theta$ is the horizontal coordinate. Near $\theta = 0$, it is barely less than the full radius 1, dropping away only to *second* order ($\cos\theta \approx 1 - \theta^2/2$). Height tracks angle to first order; width clings to 1.

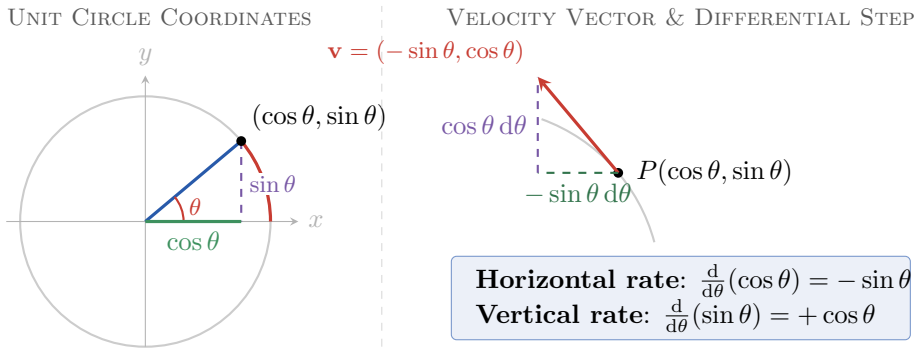


Figure 12.4: The trigonometric derivatives visualized on the unit circle. Left: The coordinates of a point at angle θ are $(\cos\theta, \sin\theta)$. Right: A counterclockwise nudge along the circle of arc length $\mathrm{d}\theta$ moves along the tangent velocity vector $\mathbf{v} = (-\sin\theta, \cos\theta)$, perpendicular to the radius. Resolving this displacement into horizontal and vertical components reveals why $\mathrm{d}(\cos\theta)/\mathrm{d}\theta = -\sin\theta$ and $\mathrm{d}(\sin\theta)/\mathrm{d}\theta = \cos\theta$.

12.5.1 Differentiating sine

Now we run the difference quotient for $\sin x$ and use the angle-addition formula $\sin(x+h) = \sin x\cos h + \cos x \sin h$.

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) &= \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\sin(x+h) - \sin x}{h} \\
&= \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\sin x\cos h + \cos x \sin h - \sin x}{h} \\
&= \lim_{h\to 0} \left[\sin x \cdot \frac{\cos h - 1}{h} + \cos x \cdot \frac{\sin h}{h}\right] \\
&= \sin x \cdot \underbrace{\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\cos h - 1}{h}}_{=0} + \cos x \cdot \underbrace{\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{\sin h}{h}}_{=1} \\
&= \sin x \cdot 0 + \cos x \cdot 1 \;=\; \cos x.
\end{aligned}$$

Theorem 12.3 (Derivatives of sine and cosine)**.**

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) = \cos x, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\cos x) = -\sin x.$$

The cosine derivative falls out the same way, with $\cos(x+h) = \cos x\cos h - \sin x \sin h$. Splitting and taking limits,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\cos x) = \cos x \cdot \left(\lim_{h\to 0} \tfrac{\cos h - 1}{h}\right) - \sin x \cdot \left(\lim_{h\to 0} \tfrac{\sin h}{h}\right) = \cos x \cdot 0 - \sin x \cdot 1 = -\sin x.$$

What is really happening

The two limits did all the work, and each played a clear role. The limit $\sin h/h \to 1$ is what makes the derivative have its full strength – it is the reason $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x)$ is the *whole* cosine and not some shrunken multiple of it. That "1" is the trigonometric analogue of $m(e) = 1$ for the exponential: it is the payoff for measuring angles in radians. The other limit, $(\cos h - 1)/h \to 0$, says cosine is *flat* at its peak – it contributes nothing to first order, which is why no stray $\sin x$ term pollutes the answer. If you measured angles in degrees instead, $\sin h/h$ would tend to $\pi/180$, not 1, and every trig derivative would drag an ugly factor of $\pi/180$ forever. Radians are the natural unit for exactly the same reason e is the natural base: they make the leftover constant equal to 1.

Common trap

The radian warning is not academic. If your calculator is in degree mode, $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) \neq \cos x$ – you would need $\frac{\pi}{180}\cos x$. All of calculus assumes radians. A surprising number of wrong answers in physics and engineering trace back to a calculator left in degree mode.

Pause

Pause and think: What is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin(\pi/3))$? Resist writing $\cos(\pi/3)$. The value $\sin(\pi/3) = \sqrt{3}/2$ is a constant number. Its derivative is zero: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin(\pi/3)) = 0$. The derivative measures how an output responds to a changing input; if the input is fixed, the rate of change is zero.

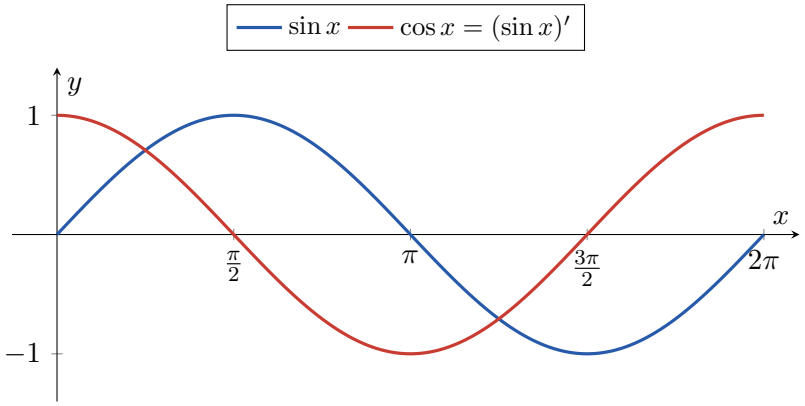


Figure 12.5: Where $\sin x$ rises most steeply (at $x = 0$, slope 1) its derivative $\cos x$ peaks at 1; where $\sin x$ flattens at its crest ($x = \pi/2$) the derivative crosses zero. The slope of sin *is* cos, point by point.

Why this matters

Differentiating sine and cosine sends you around a little cycle of length four:

$$\sin x \xrightarrow{d} \cos x \xrightarrow{d} -\sin x \xrightarrow{d} -\cos x \xrightarrow{d} \sin x.$$

Four derivatives bring you home. This is the seed of oscillation: anything satisfying $y'' = -y$ must be built from sines and cosines, and that equation governs every pendulum, spring, and wave in physics. Contrast the exponential, whose derivative cycle has length *one* ($e^x \to e^x$):

exponentials grow, trig functions circle. Later, Euler's formula $e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta$ will reveal these as the *same* phenomenon viewed along the real and imaginary axes – circling is just exponential growth in an imaginary direction.

12.5.2 The rest of the trig functions

With sin and cos in hand, the other four come from the quotient rule and the Pythagorean identity. Take the tangent:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\tan x) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{\sin x}{\cos x}\right) = \frac{(\cos x)(\cos x) - (\sin x)(-\sin x)}{\cos^2 x} = \frac{\cos^2 x + \sin^2 x}{\cos^2 x} = \frac{1}{\cos^2 x} = \sec^2 x.$$

The numerator simplifies to 1 via the Pythagorean identity $\sin^2 x + \cos^2 x = 1$. For the secant, apply the reciprocal rule to $\sec x = 1/\cos x$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sec x) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{1}{\cos x}\right) = -\frac{-\sin x}{\cos^2 x} = \frac{1}{\cos x}\cdot\frac{\sin x}{\cos x} = \sec x\tan x.$$

Cotangent $(\cos x/\sin x)$ and cosecant $(1/\sin x)$ follow by the exact same steps.

Focus

$$\begin{aligned} \tfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) &= \cos x, & \tfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\cos x) &= -\sin x,\\ \tfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\tan x) &= \sec^2 x, & \tfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\cot x) &= -\csc^2 x,\\ \tfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sec x) &= \sec x\tan x, & \tfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\csc x) &= -\csc x\cot x. \end{aligned}$$

Notice the pattern: every "co-" function $(\cos, \cot, \csc)$ carries a minus sign in its derivative. That bookkeeping minus is a reliable memory aid.

Example 12.3 (Using the chain rule with trig)**.** Differentiate $g(x) = \sin(3x^2+1)$ and $h(x) = \sec(5x)$.

$$g'(x) = \cos(3x^2+1)\cdot\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(3x^2+1\big) = 6x\cos(3x^2+1),$$

$$h'(x) = \sec(5x)\tan(5x)\cdot 5 = 5\sec(5x)\tan(5x).$$

The trig derivative supplies the "outer" factor; the chain rule supplies the derivative of the inside.

12.6 Derivatives of the Inverse Trig Functions

The inverse trig functions arcsin, arccos, arctan answer "which angle has this sine/cosine/tangent?" We differentiate them exactly as we did $\ln x$: implicitly, using the cancellation identity, plus one Pythagorean simplification at the end. The recurring surprise is that these derivatives are *algebraic* – no trig left in the answer at all.

12.6.1 Arcsine

Let $y = \arcsin x$, so $\sin y = x$ with $y \in [-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$. Differentiate $\sin y = x$ implicitly:

$$\cos y \cdot \frac{dy}{dx} = 1 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \frac{dy}{dx} = \frac{1}{\cos y}.$$

Now convert $\cos y$ into something in terms of x. From $\sin^2 y + \cos^2 y = 1$ and $\sin y = x$, we get $\cos y = \sqrt{1 - x^2}$. (We take the $+$ root because on $[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}]$ cosine is nonnegative – the restricted range is doing real work here.) Therefore

$$\frac{d}{dx}(\arcsin x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 - x^2}}, \qquad -1 < x < 1.$$

Why the technique works

Where did the square root come from? The implicit step gives a clean $1/\cos y$, but the answer should be a function of x, not of the hidden angle y. The right triangle with opposite side x and hypotenuse 1 has $\sin y = x$, so by Pythagoras its adjacent side is $\sqrt{1 - x^2}$, and that adjacent-over-hypotenuse is $\cos y$. Drawing the triangle is the direct way to turn "$\cos(\arcsin x)$" into "$\sqrt{1 - x^2}$." Every inverse-trig derivative comes out algebraic for this reason: a trig function of an inverse-trig function is always just a side ratio in a reference triangle.

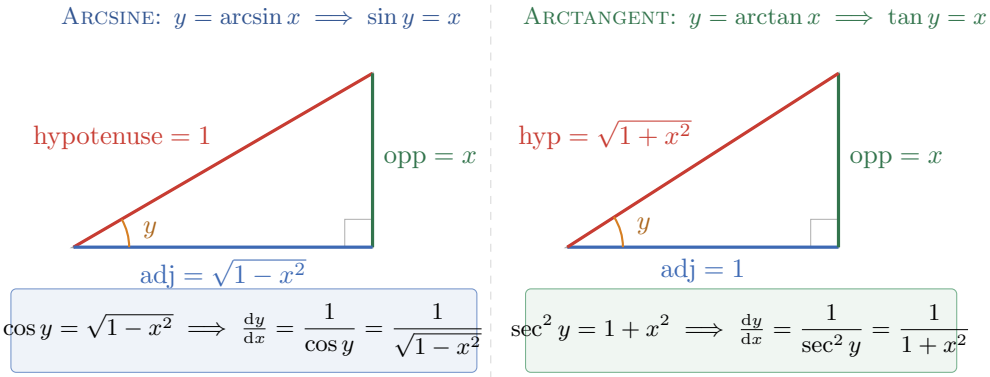


Figure 12.6: The reference triangles converting trig functions of inverse trig functions into pure algebra. Left: For $y = \arcsin x$, a right triangle with hypotenuse 1 and opposite side x forces the adjacent side to be $\sqrt{1 - x^2}$ by the Pythagorean theorem, giving $\cos y = \sqrt{1 - x^2}$. Right: For $y = \arctan x$, adjacent side 1 and opposite side x force the hypotenuse to be $\sqrt{1 + x^2}$, giving $\sec^2 y = 1 + x^2$.

12.6.2 Arctangent

Let $y = \arctan x$, so $\tan y = x$. Differentiate:

$$\sec^2 y \cdot \frac{dy}{dx} = 1 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \frac{dy}{dx} = \frac{1}{\sec^2 y}.$$

Use the identity $\sec^2 y = 1 + \tan^2 y = 1 + x^2$. So

$$\frac{d}{dx}(\arctan x) = \frac{1}{1 + x^2}, \qquad x \in \mathbb{R}.$$

This one is a favorite because it is defined for all x, is beautifully simple, and – as you will see in the integration chapters – it is exactly the antiderivative needed to integrate $1/(1+x^2)$, the function whose area hides π.

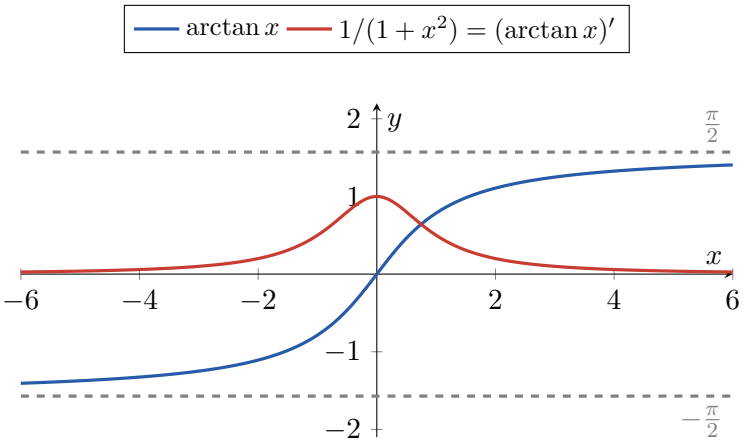


Figure 12.7: $\arctan x$ flattens toward the horizontal asymptotes $\pm\pi/2$, and exactly where it flattens its derivative $1/(1+x^2)$ dies away to 0. The derivative peaks at $x=0$, where arctan is steepest.

Focus

The inverse-trig derivative table (each on its natural domain):

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\arcsin x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\arccos x) = -\frac{1}{\sqrt{1-x^2}},$$
$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\arctan x) = \frac{1}{1+x^2}, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\operatorname{arccot} x) = -\frac{1}{1+x^2},$$
$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\operatorname{arcsec} x) = \frac{1}{|x|\sqrt{x^2-1}}, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\operatorname{arccsc} x) = -\frac{1}{|x|\sqrt{x^2-1}}.$$

Again the "co-" partners differ only by a sign, since $\arccos x = \frac{\pi}{2} - \arcsin x$: complementary angles sum to a constant, so their derivatives are negatives. Note the absolute value in $\operatorname{arcsec} x$ (with standard range $[0,\pi]\setminus\{\frac{\pi}{2}\}$): for $x<-1$, both $\sec y = x$ and $\tan y$ are negative, so their product $\sec y \tan y = |x|\sqrt{x^2-1}$ stays positive across both branches.

Connection

These derivatives matter most read *backwards*, as integration formulas. Differentiating the inverse trig functions is how we discover that

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{1-x^2}} = \arcsin x + C, \qquad \int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{1+x^2} = \arctan x + C.$$

Two perfectly innocent-looking algebraic integrands turn out to have *trigonometric* antiderivatives. That is the deep reason trigonometric substitution works for integrals containing $\sqrt{1-x^2}$ or $1+x^2$ – a topic we reach in the integration part. The angle is hiding inside the algebra.

12.7 A Gallery of Worked Examples

To consolidate, here are the new rules mixed with the product, quotient, and chain rules from the previous chapter.

Example 12.4 (Exponential times trig)**.** Differentiate $f(x) = e^{-2x}\cos(3x)$, the shape of a damped oscillation. Product rule, with each factor needing the chain rule:

$$f'(x) = \underbrace{(-2)e^{-2x}}_{\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^{-2x})}\cos(3x) + e^{-2x}\underbrace{(-3\sin(3x))}_{\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\cos(3x))} = -e^{-2x}\big(2\cos 3x + 3\sin 3x\big).$$

Example 12.5 (Log of a composite)**.** Differentiate $f(x) = \ln\big(\sqrt{x^2+1}\big)$. Simplify with log laws *before* differentiating: $\ln\sqrt{x^2+1} = \frac{1}{2}\ln(x^2+1)$. Then

$$f'(x) = \frac{1}{2}\cdot\frac{2x}{x^2+1} = \frac{x}{x^2+1}.$$

Always check whether a log law can break an expression apart before differentiating; a quick algebraic rewrite often saves a page of quotient-rule work.

Example 12.6 (Putting the base change to work)**.** Differentiate $f(x) = 5^{\sin x}$. Rewrite as $e^{(\ln 5)\sin x}$, or just apply $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(a^u) = a^u \ln a \cdot u'$ directly with $a = 5$, $u = \sin x$:

$$f'(x) = 5^{\sin x}\,(\ln 5)\,\cos x.$$

Example 12.7 (Inverse trig inside a chain)**.** Differentiate $f(x) = \arctan(e^x)$. Outer derivative $1/(1+u^2)$ with $u = e^x$, times $u' = e^x$:

$$f'(x) = \frac{1}{1+(e^x)^2}\cdot e^x = \frac{e^x}{1+e^{2x}}.$$

Example 12.8 (Logarithmic differentiation with a root tower)**.** Differentiate $y = \dfrac{x^3\,e^{2x}}{\sqrt{1+x^2}}$. Take logs:

$$\ln y = 3\ln x + 2x - \tfrac{1}{2}\ln(1+x^2).$$

Differentiate:

$$\frac{y'}{y} = \frac{3}{x} + 2 - \frac{x}{1+x^2}.$$

Multiply back:

$$y' = \frac{x^3 e^{2x}}{\sqrt{1+x^2}}\left(\frac{3}{x} + 2 - \frac{x}{1+x^2}\right).$$

Walking question

Here is something to mull on a walk. We found functions that are, in a sense, "eigenfunctions" of differentiation—where an *eigenfunction* of an operator is a function whose mathematical shape is preserved by the operation, emerging only multiplied by a constant factor. The exponential e^x returns itself under $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}()$, while the pair $\sin x$ and $\cos x$ rotate among themselves in a cycle of four derivatives. Is there a function whose derivative is the function shifted, or

scaled by x, in some equally clean way? What kind of equation would "$y' =$ (something simple involving y)" have to be for its solution to be elementary? You are circling the idea of a *differential equation*, the subject the entire book builds toward. Every function in this chapter is the answer to one: $y' = y$ gives e^x, $y'' = -y$ gives sin and cos, and $y' = 1/x$ gives ln.

Application

These derivatives are the vocabulary of dynamics.

- **Radioactive decay / drug clearance.** If $N(t) = N_0 e^{-\lambda t}$, then $N'(t) = -\lambda N(t)$: the decay rate is proportional to how much is left. The derivative *is* the law of decay.
- **Exponential growth.** $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}(e^{kt}) = ke^{kt}$ is why unchecked populations, viral spread, and compound interest all share the same runaway curve.
- **Oscillation.** A mass on a spring obeys $x'' = -\omega^2 x$, solved by $x(t) = A\cos(\omega t) + B\sin(\omega t)$ precisely because of the derivative cycle of sine and cosine.
- **Machine learning.** The logistic "sigmoid" $\sigma(x) = 1/(1 + e^{-x})$ (an S-shaped curve that smoothly maps the real number line into probability-like values between 0 and 1) has the clean derivative $\sigma'(x) = \sigma(x)\big(1 - \sigma(x)\big)$, as you can verify with the chain rule. That self-contained form makes it computationally cheap in neural networks, since the gradient is assembled from values already computed on the forward pass.

12.8 Summary

Every derivative in this chapter comes from a clear geometric picture paired with a limit:

- $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(b^x) = (\ln b)\, b^x$, and $\ln b = \lim_{h\to 0}(b^h - 1)/h$ is the slope of b^x at the y-axis. The base e is defined as the one making that slope 1, which is exactly why $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^x) = e^x$.
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln x) = 1/x$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\log_a x) = 1/(x \ln a)$, by inverse reasoning or straight from the limit; $\ln x$ fills the gap the power rule leaves at exponent -1.
- Logarithmic differentiation turns products, quotients, and variable-exponent towers into sums via $y'/y = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln y)$.
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) = \cos x$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\cos x) = -\sin x$, driven by $\sin h/h \to 1$ and $(\cos h - 1)/h \to 0$ from the unit circle – and radians are what make those limits clean.
- Inverse trig derivatives are *algebraic*: $(\arcsin x)' = 1/\sqrt{1 - x^2}$, $(\arctan x)' = 1/(1 + x^2)$, found by implicit differentiation plus a Pythagorean triangle.

The recurring theme: e and radians are natural choices because they eliminate extraneous scaling factors from differentiation formulas.

12.8.1 The Scope and Horizon of Transcendental Derivatives

Connection

Adding exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric functions gives differential calculus direct reach across dynamics and geometry:

- *Natural growth and decay*: Any process where rate is proportional to size ($\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}t = ky$) is solved in closed form by $y(t) = y_0 e^{kt}$, modeling radioactive decay, compound capital, and population dynamics.
- *Oscillation and wave mechanics*: The derivative cycle $(\sin x)' = \cos x$ and $(\cos x)' = -\sin x$ explains why simple harmonic motion satisfies the second-order acceleration equation $\mathrm{d}^2y/\mathrm{d}t^2 = -\omega^2 y$.
- *Algebraic antiderivatives from geometry*: Because inverse trigonometric derivatives come out purely algebraic ($(\arctan x)' = 1/(1+x^2)$), we gain a direct way to integrate rational expressions such as $1/(1+x^2)$ that no algebraic antiderivative can match.

The bridge to Chapter 13: Implicit relations and related rates. We repeatedly used a simple idea in this chapter: when an explicit formula for y was unavailable—as with $\ln x$, $\arcsin x$, and $\arctan x$—we inverted the relationship into an equation ($e^y = x$, $\sin y = x$, $\tan y = x$) and differentiated both sides treating y as an implicit function of x.

In Chapter 13, we make this general: curves like the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ cannot be written as $y = f(x)$, yet their tangent slopes are easily found by differentiating the equation directly. Differentiating constraint equations in time then lets us solve related-rates problems where multiple quantities change together.

The algorithmic horizon: Transcendental equations. At the same time, transcendental functions break purely algebraic solvability. In polynomial calculus, finding where a derivative vanishes or locating where two curves intersect requires solving polynomial equations, for which algebraic methods (factoring, the quadratic formula) exist. But the moment exponentials or trig functions enter, optimization and root-finding produce *transcendental equations*:

$$x\,e^x = 1, \qquad x = \cos x, \qquad e^{-x^2} = x.$$

None of these equations can be solved for x using a finite combination of elementary algebraic operations. We can write down the exact derivative formula in seconds, yet algebra cannot tell us the numerical coordinate where that rate equals zero. Because algebra hits a firm wall when solving transcendental equations, calculus must build algorithmic tools. In Chapter 19 (*Newton's Method*), we will transform the derivative itself into an iterative engine that converges quadratically to the roots of transcendental equations, producing twenty decimal digits of accuracy in a handful of mechanical steps.

12.9 Exercises

Exercise 12.1 (Warm-up derivatives)**.** Differentiate each function with respect to x.

(a) $f(x) = 7e^x - 4\ln x$

(b) $g(x) = e^{3x}\sin x$

(c) $h(x) = \dfrac{\cos x}{x^2}$

(d) $p(x) = \tan(2x) + \sec(2x)$

(e) $q(x) = 3^x + x^3$ (mind which rule each term needs)

(f) $r(x) = \ln(\cos x)$

(g) $s(x) = e^4 + \sin(\pi/3)$ (pause and think: is x present?)

(h) $t(x) = x^e + e^x + e^e$

Exercise 12.2 (Chain-rule combinations)**.** Differentiate.

(a) $\sin(e^x)$

(b) $e^{\sin x}$

(c) $\arctan(3x)$

(d) $\arcsin(x^2)$

(e) $\ln\big(\ln x\big)$

(f) $\cos^2(5x)$

Exercise 12.3 (Logarithmic differentiation)**.** Use logarithmic differentiation.

(a) $y = (\sin x)^x$ for $0 < x < \pi$.

(b) $y = x^{\ln x}$.

(c) $y = \dfrac{(x+1)^4(x-2)^3}{(x^2+5)^2}$.

Exercise 12.4 (Find the base)**.** Numerically estimate $m(4) = \lim_{h\to 0}(4^h - 1)/h$ with $h = 0.0001$, then confirm it equals $\ln 4$ to three decimals. Explain in one sentence why the estimate and $\ln 4$ should agree.

Exercise 12.5 (The sigmoid identity)**.** Let $\sigma(x) = \dfrac{1}{1+e^{-x}}$. Show that $\sigma'(x) = \sigma(x)\big(1 - \sigma(x)\big)$. (Hint: write $\sigma = (1+e^{-x})^{-1}$ and use the chain rule, then refactor.)

Exercise 12.6 (Tangent line)**.** Find the equation of the tangent line to $y = \ln x$ at $x = e$. Where does this tangent line cross the x-axis?

Exercise 12.7 (A radian sanity check)**.** Suppose a student insists on degrees and defines $S(x) = \sin(x^\circ)$, i.e. the sine of x degrees. Using $x^\circ = \frac{\pi}{180}x$ radians and the chain rule, show that $S'(x) = \frac{\pi}{180}\cos(x^\circ)$. Explain why this confirms that radians are the natural unit for calculus.

Exercise 12.8 (Conceptual: why proportional growth is exponential)**.** Suppose a function $y(t)$ satisfies $y'(t) = k\,y(t)$ for a constant k, and $y(0) = y_0$. Verify by differentiation that $y(t) = y_0 e^{kt}$ works. Then argue informally why *no* function of the form $y_0 b^t$ with $b \neq e^k$ can satisfy the equation. (This is the precise sense in which "rate proportional to size" means "exponential.")

Exercise 12.9 (Proof: derivative of a^x from scratch)**.** Without quoting $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(a^x) = a^x \ln a$, prove it. Start from the difference quotient, factor out a^x, and identify the leftover limit $m(a)$. Then, using $a = e^{\ln a}$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(e^x) = e^x$ together with the chain rule, show $m(a) = \ln a$. Comment on how the two methods give the same constant.

Exercise 12.10 (Proof: arccosine and the sign)**.** Use the identity $\arccos x = \frac{\pi}{2} - \arcsin x$ to prove that $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\arccos x) = -\dfrac{1}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}$. Then re-derive the same result *independently* by implicit differentiation of $\cos y = x$, being careful about the sign of $\sin y$ on the range $y \in [0, \pi]$. Confirm the two agree.

Exercise 12.11 (Higher derivatives and the cycle)**.** Compute the first four derivatives of $f(x) = \sin x$ and confirm the period-four cycle. Then find a simple formula for the n-th derivative $f^{(n)}(x)$ in terms of $n \bmod 4$. What is $f^{(101)}(x)$?

Exercise 12.12 (Mixed challenge)**.** Differentiate $y = x^{\sin x}$ and find all x in $(0, \pi)$ where the relative rate of change y'/y equals zero. Interpret these points on the graph of $\ln y = (\sin x)(\ln x)$.

Chapter 13

Implicit Differentiation and Related Rates

In earlier chapters, every function arrived in explicit form $y = f(x)$: powers, products, quotients, exponentials, and trig. You feed in a number x, you turn the crank, out comes the output y. The derivative measures how that output responds when you nudge the input.

Many curves in geometry and physics are not so accommodating. Some of the most important shapes refuse to be written as $y = f(x)$. A circle is the cleanest example: the equation

$$x^2 + y^2 = 25$$

describes a perfectly definite curve, and that curve has tangent lines everywhere, with well-defined slopes. Yet there is no single function f with $y = f(x)$ whose graph is the whole circle, because most vertical lines hit the circle *twice*. The circle is a relationship between x and y, not a machine that turns x into y.

This chapter is about two closely linked ideas. The first is *implicit differentiation*: a way to find slopes on curves that are tied together by an equation, without ever solving for y. We will see that it is the chain rule operating directly on an implicit relation. The second is *related rates*: a method for problems where two or more changing quantities are locked together by a *constraint*—a geometric or physical rule (like a rigid ladder length or a fixed volume) that ties the quantities together so they cannot change independently. A ladder slides, a balloon inflates, a shadow lengthens; in each case a single equation ties the pieces together, and differentiating that equation in time tells us how the rates relate. Both ideas spring from the same root: *when quantities are bound by an equation, their rates of change are bound too.*

13.1 Curves That Are Not Functions

Let us look at the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 25$. Pick a point on it, say $(3, 4)$. Geometrically the circle has an unambiguous tangent line there. We can even guess its slope: a radius runs from the center $(0, 0)$ out to $(3, 4)$ with slope $4/3$, and the tangent is perpendicular to the radius, so the tangent slope should be $-3/4$. The geometry leaves no doubt that a slope exists. The only question is how to *compute* it from the equation.

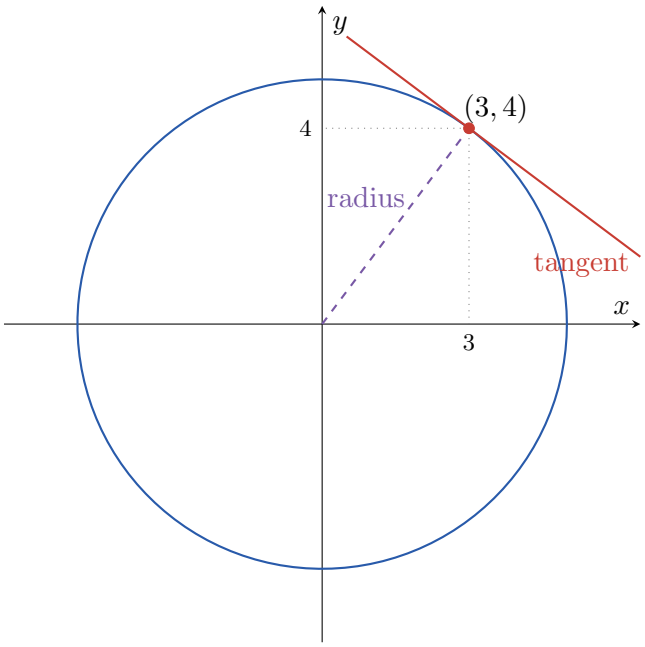


Figure 13.1: The circle $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ is not the graph of any single function of x, yet it has a definite tangent line at each point. At $(3, 4)$ the radius has slope $4/3$, so the perpendicular tangent has slope $-3/4$.

One option is brute force: solve for y. Above the x-axis the upper half of the circle is the genuine function $y = \sqrt{25 - x^2}$, and we could differentiate that. It works here, but it is already a little ugly, and for most equations it is hopeless. Try to solve

$$x^3 + y^3 = 6xy$$

for y – this is the famous *folium of Descartes* – and you will be staring at the cubic formula, producing a monstrous expression with three branches. Nobody wants to differentiate that. We need a method that respects the equation as it stands.

Intuition

The key mental shift: stop thinking of y as "the output of a formula" and start thinking of y as "whatever value (or values) the equation forces, given x." On the upper half of the circle, as x creeps from 3 toward 4, the equation *forces* y to creep downward from 4 toward 3. That forced change in y is what the derivative $\frac{dy}{dx}$ measures.

The phrase mathematicians use is that the equation defines y *implicitly* as a function of x. "Implicit" means *implied but not spelled out*: the dependence of y on x is real and present, hiding inside the equation, even though no explicit formula $y = f(x)$ is written down. Our goal is to extract the slope of that hidden function directly.

Focus

Explicit vs. implicit.

- *Explicit:* $y = \sqrt{25 - x^2}$. The output is isolated; differentiate with the rules you already know.

- *Implicit:* $x^2 + y^2 = 25$. The output is entangled with the input. We will differentiate *both sides of the equation*, treating y as an unknown function of x.

13.2 Implicit Differentiation: the Chain Rule on Level Curves

Here is the underlying logic. We have an equation in x and y that holds along a curve. Along that curve y is some function of x — call it $y(x)$ even if we cannot write its formula. Then *both sides of the equation are functions of* x, and they are equal for every x on the curve. If two functions of x are equal everywhere, their derivatives are equal too. So we may apply $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}$ to both sides and keep a true equation. The key step is that wherever y appears, it is $y(x)$, so differentiating it requires the chain rule.

Let us do the circle.

Pause

Pause and predict. Look back at the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ in Figure 13.1. At the very top point $(0, 5)$, the tangent line is completely flat, so its slope must be 0. At the rightmost point $(5, 0)$, the tangent line is vertical, so its slope must be undefined. Keep those two geometric checkpoints in mind as we compute the slope formula algebraically: our derivative must confirm both without breaking down.

Example 13.1 (The circle, by implicit differentiation)**.** Differentiate both sides of $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ with respect to x:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(x^2\right) + \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(y^2\right) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(25).$$

The first term is $2x$. The right side is 0, since 25 is constant. The middle term is the delicate one. Here y is a function of x, so y^2 is a *composition*: square-of, applied to $y(x)$. The chain rule says differentiate the outside ($u^2 \mapsto 2u$) and multiply by the derivative of the inside (y with respect to x):

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(y^2\right) = 2y \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}.$$

Putting it together,

$$2x + 2y\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{x}{y}.$$

Now read off the slope at $(3, 4)$: $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{3}{4}$. Exactly the geometric prediction. And the answer at $(-3, -4)$? Also $-\frac{3}{4}$ – the formula handles every branch of the curve at once, with no case-splitting.

We never solved for y. The derivative came out in terms of *both* x and y, which is perfectly fine: to use it you supply a point (x, y) that lies on the curve, and out comes the slope there. An implicit derivative is a slope *field along the curve*, expressed using the coordinates of the point.

Why the technique works

Why is differentiating both sides legitimate, and why does $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ pop out? Two facts do all the work.

First, an equation like $x^2+y^2=25$ asserts that two functions of x – the left side and the right side, once we substitute $y=y(x)$ – are equal at every point of the curve. Equal functions have equal derivatives. (This is the same principle that lets you differentiate both sides of $\sin^2 x+\cos^2 x=1$.) So $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\text{LHS})=\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\text{RHS})$ is a valid new equation.
Second, every term containing y is really a composition of some operation with the inner function $y(x)$. The chain rule is precisely the tool for differentiating compositions. So each y-term contributes its outer derivative times the inner derivative $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$. Implicit differentiation is just "differentiate the equation, and remember the chain rule whenever you touch y." That is why $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ always appears *linearly* (to the first power, never squared), which is what lets us solve for it by simple algebra at the end.

What is really happening

When you write $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(y^2\right)=2y\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$, what is really happening is a two-step relay of sensitivities. Nudge x by a tiny $\mathrm{d}x$. The curve forces y to move by $\mathrm{d}y=\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x$. That motion of y then changes y^2 by (rate of y^2 with respect to y) times $\mathrm{d}y$, i.e. $2y\,\mathrm{d}y$. Chaining the two responses gives $2y\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x$. The factor $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is the "exchange rate" converting a change in x into the change in y that the constraint demands. Every appearance of $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ in implicit differentiation is one of these exchange-rate factors, inserted exactly where the chain of dependence passes through y.

13.2.1 A clean recipe

Focus

How to differentiate implicitly.

1. Apply $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}$ to *both* sides of the equation.
2. Differentiate terms in x normally. For any term involving y, use the chain rule: after differentiating with respect to y, multiply by $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$. (Products like xy also need the product rule.)
3. Collect every term containing $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ on one side, everything else on the other.
4. Factor out $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ and divide. The answer will usually involve both x and y.

Common trap

The single most common mistake is forgetting the $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ factor and writing $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(y^2)=2y$. That is wrong: $2y$ is the derivative of y^2 *with respect to* y, not with respect to x. The whole point is that y depends on x, so the chain rule supplies the extra factor $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$. A good habit: every time your pen leaves a y-term, immediately tack on $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ before you forget. By contrast, $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^2)=2x$ needs *no* extra factor, because $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}x}=1$.

Example 13.2 (A term that needs the product rule)**.** Find $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ for $x^2y+y^3=10$.

Differentiate term by term. The term x^2y is a product of x^2 and y, so use the product rule, and remember the chain-rule factor on y:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(x^2y\right) = 2x \cdot y + x^2 \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}.$$

For y^3 the chain rule gives $3y^2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$, and the right side is 0. So

$$2xy + x^2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + 3y^2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 0.$$

Collect the $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ terms:

$$\left(x^2 + 3y^2\right)\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -2xy \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{-2xy}{x^2 + 3y^2}.$$

Work it yourself

Try one with your own pen before reading on: find $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ for $\sin(xy) = x$. You will need the chain rule on sin, then the product rule on xy. (Solution: differentiating, $\cos(xy)\cdot\left(y + x\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\right) = 1$, so $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \dfrac{1 - y\cos(xy)}{x\cos(xy)}$.) The structure is always the same: $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ shows up linearly, and you solve for it.

13.2.2 The folium of Descartes

Now the curve we could not solve. The folium $x^3 + y^3 = 6xy$ is a looping cubic that crosses itself at the origin – a shape that genuinely has no single-formula description, yet implicit differentiation handles it without breaking a sweat.

Example 13.3 (Slope on the folium)**.** Differentiate $x^3 + y^3 = 6xy$ with respect to x. The right side $6xy$ is a product, so it needs the product rule (and the chain factor on y):

$$3x^2 + 3y^2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 6\left(y + x\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\right).$$

Expand and gather $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ terms:

$$3y^2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} - 6x\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 6y - 3x^2, \qquad \left(3y^2 - 6x\right)\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 6y - 3x^2.$$

Divide:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{6y - 3x^2}{3y^2 - 6x} = \frac{2y - x^2}{y^2 - 2x}.$$

The point $(3, 3)$ lies on the curve (check: $27 + 27 = 54 = 6 \cdot 9$). There the slope is

$$\left.\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\right|_{(3,3)} = \frac{6 - 9}{9 - 6} = \frac{-3}{3} = -1.$$

The tangent there is the line $y - 3 = -1(x - 3)$, i.e. $y = -x + 6$.

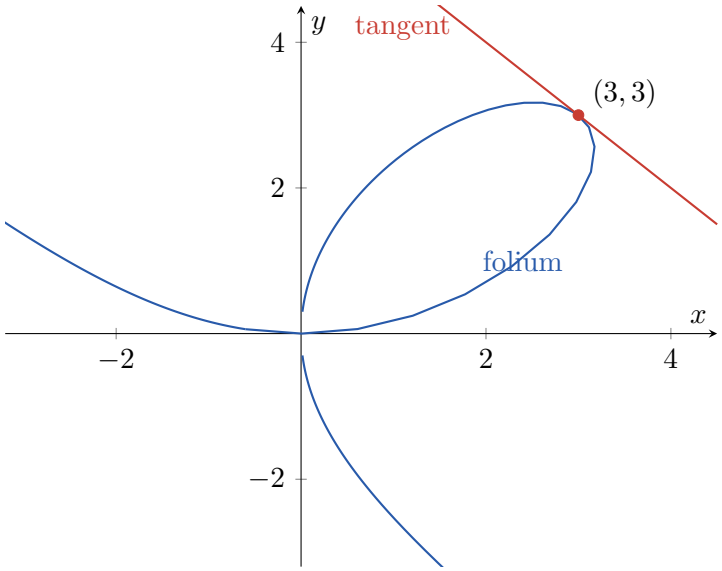


Figure 13.2: The folium of Descartes $x^3 + y^3 = 6xy$. There is no tidy $y = f(x)$ for this looping curve, but implicit differentiation gives the tangent slope at $(3, 3)$ as -1.

History

The folium of Descartes was born in 1638 out of an intellectual duel between René Descartes and Pierre de Fermat. In the 1630s, decades before Newton or Leibniz published, Fermat had devised an ingenious method for finding tangents to algebraic curves known as *adequality* (from Diophantus's Latin *adaequare*, meaning to balance or treat as approximately equal). Fermat's technique was a conceptual ancestor of the differential: he substituted $x + e$ into the polynomial equation of a curve, treated the two sides as approximately equal, cancelled common terms, divided through by the tiny increment e, and then discarded all remaining terms containing e to read off the slope of the tangent line.

Descartes, who championed his own cumbersome *method of normals*—finding tangent lines by constructing auxiliary circles that graze the curve in two coincident points—was deeply skeptical of Fermat's technique, dismissing it as unjustified algebraic manipulation. In 1638, Descartes proposed the looping curve $x^3 + y^3 = 3axy$ (the *folium of Descartes*, with our Example 13.3 taking $3a = 6$) as an aggressive public challenge, taunting Fermat to find its tangent line. Descartes was convinced that the loop and the sheer impossibility of solving for y explicitly would break Fermat's method. To Descartes' frustration, Fermat solved it promptly and correctly.

Around the same era, the physical need for related rates arose directly from mechanics and timekeeping. In his 1673 treatise *Horologium Oscillatorium*, Christiaan Huygens sought to build marine pendulum clocks accurate enough to determine longitude at sea. A standard circular pendulum's period varies slightly with its swing amplitude; to make the period truly constant regardless of swing width (a property called *tautochrone*, from the Greek for "same time"), Huygens had to force the pendulum bob to follow a cycloid—the curve traced by a pebble caught in the tread of a rolling wheel. To design the curved metal guides (the "cycloidal jaws") that constrained the pendulum cord, Huygens had to relate the instantaneous vertical descent rate $\frac{dy}{dt}$ to the horizontal rate $\frac{dx}{dt}$, solving a related-rates problem before differential notation even existed.

In England during the plague years of 1665–1666, Isaac Newton built his own formulation around this very idea: he viewed variables as *fluents* (flowing physical quantities) and their rates as *fluxions* (velocities $\dot{x}$ and $\dot{y}$), casting the core problem of calculus as discovering relations between fluxions from relations between fluents. When Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz independently published his differential notation $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$ in 1684, the chain rule turned these hard-won geometric tangencies and mechanical constraints into fluent algebraic operations.
Yet questions about implicit curves remain open. While the nineteenth-century Implicit Function Theorem proved that an implicit curve is smooth and locally well-behaved anywhere the gradient does not vanish, the *global topology* of implicit curves remains challenging. The second half of David Hilbert's 16th Problem, posed in 1900, asks for the maximum number and possible nested arrangements of separate closed loops (called *ovals*) that a polynomial curve of degree d can form in the plane. Mathematicians settled the case of degree 6 only in the 1970s; for degree $d \geq 8$, the exact possible arrangements of ovals remain unsolved today.

13.3 Tangent Lines and Higher Derivatives

Once you can find $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ at a point on an implicit curve, tangent lines cost nothing extra: the tangent at (x_0, y_0) is

$$y - y_0 = m\,(x - x_0), \qquad m = \left.\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\right|_{(x_0,y_0)}.$$

The only thing to watch is that the point must actually lie on the curve, and that you substitute *both* coordinates into the slope formula.

Example 13.4 (Tangent and a vertical tangent on an ellipse)**.** Consider the ellipse $\dfrac{x^2}{9} + \dfrac{y^2}{4} = 1$. Differentiate implicitly:

$$\frac{2x}{9} + \frac{2y}{4}\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 0 \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{4x}{9y}.$$

At the point $\left(\frac{3}{\sqrt{2}}, \sqrt{2}\right)$ (which lies on the ellipse: $\frac{9/2}{9} + \frac{2}{4} = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2} = 1$), the slope is

$$m = -\frac{4 \cdot \frac{3}{\sqrt{2}}}{9 \cdot \sqrt{2}} = -\frac{12/\sqrt{2}}{9\sqrt{2}} = -\frac{12}{9 \cdot 2} = -\frac{2}{3}.$$

Notice also *where the tangent is vertical*: the slope formula $-\frac{4x}{9y}$ blows up when $y = 0$, i.e. at $(\pm 3, 0)$, the ends of the major axis. There the tangent line is vertical – a slope our $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ correctly reports as "undefined." Implicit differentiation does not hide these features; it flags them (Figure 13.3).

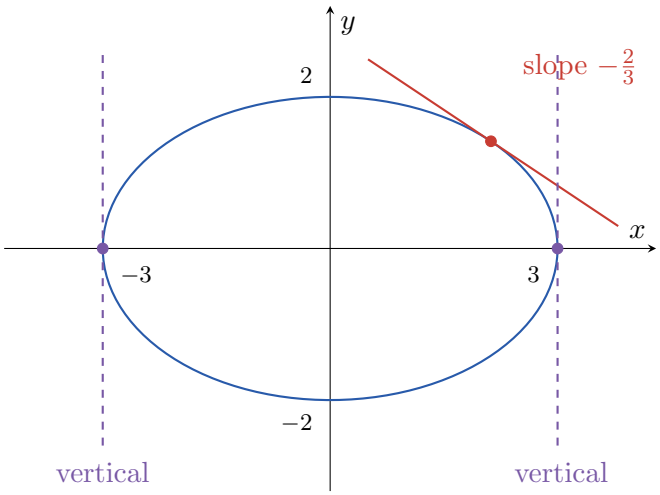


Figure 13.3: The ellipse $\frac{x^2}{9} + \frac{y^2}{4} = 1$. At a typical point the implicit slope $-\frac{4x}{9y}$ gives an ordinary slanted tangent (here $-\frac{2}{3}$). At the ends of the major axis $(\pm 3, 0)$, where $y = 0$, the formula blows up and the tangent is vertical – exactly the feature that "solve for y" handles badly.

Connection

Vertical tangents are where the implicit picture genuinely beats "solve for y." If you split the ellipse into $y = \pm\frac{2}{3}\sqrt{9 - x^2}$, the derivative of each branch becomes infinite and ill-behaved exactly at $x = \pm 3$, the seam where the two branches meet. The implicit form $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{4x}{9y}$ treats the whole curve as one object and simply says: slope undefined when $y = 0$. Later, when we study curves in the plane more generally, this is the seed of the idea that a smooth curve can have a well-defined *tangent direction* even where it has no well-defined *function slope*.

13.3.1 Second derivatives implicitly

You can differentiate a second time to get $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}x^2}$, useful for concavity. The method is the same – differentiate again, remembering the chain rule – but now you also substitute the expression for $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ you already found.

Example 13.5 (Second derivative on the circle)**.** For $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ we found $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\dfrac{x}{y}$. Differentiate this quotient with respect to x, using the quotient rule and remembering that y depends on x:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}x^2} = -\frac{\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x)\cdot y - x\cdot\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(y)}{y^2} = -\frac{y - x\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}}{y^2}.$$

Now substitute $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{x}{y}$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}x^2} = -\frac{y - x\left(-\frac{x}{y}\right)}{y^2} = -\frac{y + \frac{x^2}{y}}{y^2} = -\frac{y^2 + x^2}{y^3}.$$

But on the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 25$, so this simplifies beautifully to

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}x^2} = -\frac{25}{y^3}.$$

On the upper half ($y > 0$) this is negative – the curve is concave down, as a dome should be. On the lower half ($y < 0$) it is positive, concave up. The sign of the second derivative reads off the shape of each half exactly as it should.

Walking question

Take this on a walk. The relation $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ is symmetric in x and y – swapping them leaves the circle unchanged. We found $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{x}{y}$. What should $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}y}$ be, and how is it related? Convince yourself geometrically that $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}y} = -\frac{y}{x}$ and that $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}y} = 1$, then explain in words why "run over rise" is the reciprocal of "rise over run." That is the same reciprocal-slope rule we used to differentiate $\ln x$ and $\arcsin x$ in Chapter 12.

13.4 Related Rates: When One Rate Drives Another

We now turn the same idea toward *time*. In a related-rates problem, several quantities change as time passes, and they are tied together by a geometric or physical relationship. Because the quantities are bound by an equation, their *rates of change* are bound too – and if we know some of the rates we can solve for the others. The mathematics is implicit differentiation again, but now the hidden variable everything depends on is t, time.

Intuition

Picture a constraint as a length of inextensible string connecting two beads. If you know how fast one bead moves, the string *forces* a definite speed on the other; you do not get to choose it. A related-rates problem hands you the constraint (the string) and one or more known rates, and asks for an unknown rate. The constraint, differentiated in time, is the rule that converts the rates you know into the rate you want.

The essential structural fact: every quantity in the problem is a function of time. So when we differentiate the constraint equation with respect to t, *every variable* gets a chain-rule factor – its own rate $\frac{\mathrm{d}(\cdot)}{\mathrm{d}t}$. A length x contributes $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}$, an area A contributes $\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}t}$, an angle θ contributes $\frac{\mathrm{d}\theta}{\mathrm{d}t}$. There is no privileged "independent variable" among x, y, θ; they are all dependent on the one true independent variable, t.

What is really happening

Here is the real mechanism, stripped bare. A constraint $F(x, y) = c$ holds at every instant. As time ticks, the point $(x(t), y(t))$ slides along the curve $F = c$; it is not free to wander off. The condition for staying on the curve is that the *rate* at which F changes must be zero – $\frac{\mathrm{d}F}{\mathrm{d}t} = 0$ – because F is pinned at the constant c. Writing out $\frac{\mathrm{d}F}{\mathrm{d}t} = 0$ by the chain rule produces a single linear equation relating $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}$. That one equation *is* the related-rates relationship. "One rate drives another" is the statement that this equation has only one degree of freedom: fix one rate and the other is determined. Related rates is the time-derivative of a constraint, and nothing more.

13.4.1 A modeling method that always works

Related-rates problems feel hard because they come wrapped in a story. The cure is a fixed procedure that turns the story into algebra in the same way every time.

Focus

The five-step method.

1. **Draw and name.** Sketch the situation. Assign a *variable* to every quantity that changes. Use a letter, not a number, even for quantities you happen to know right now – their numerical value is only true at one instant, and plugging it in too early destroys the relationship.
2. **List knowns and the unknown rate.** Translate every "how fast" into a derivative with respect to t. Watch the signs: a shrinking quantity has a negative rate.
3. **Find the constraint.** Write a single equation connecting your variables, valid at *all* times – usually a geometric fact (Pythagoras, similar triangles, area or volume formula, trig ratio).
4. **Differentiate with respect to t.** Every variable earns its own $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}$ factor (the chain rule, as always). This gives an equation relating the rates.
5. **Substitute and solve.** *Now*, and only now, plug in the instantaneous numbers and solve for the unknown rate. Interpret the sign and units.

Common trap

Do not substitute numbers before differentiating. If you replace a changing length by its current value *before* taking $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}$, you have turned a moving quantity into a constant, and its derivative becomes a wrong 0. The numerical values describe a single frozen instant; the constraint equation and its differentiation describe *all* instants. Differentiate first (in symbols), substitute last (with numbers). This one discipline prevents the majority of related-rates errors.

13.4.2 The sliding ladder

Example 13.6 (The ladder against the wall)**.** A 10-foot ladder leans against a vertical wall. The bottom is pulled away from the wall at $2\,\mathrm{ft/s}$. How fast is the top sliding down the wall when the bottom is $6\,\mathrm{ft}$ from the wall?

Draw and name. Let x be the distance from the wall to the foot of the ladder, and y the height of the top on the wall. The ladder's length is the fixed constraint.

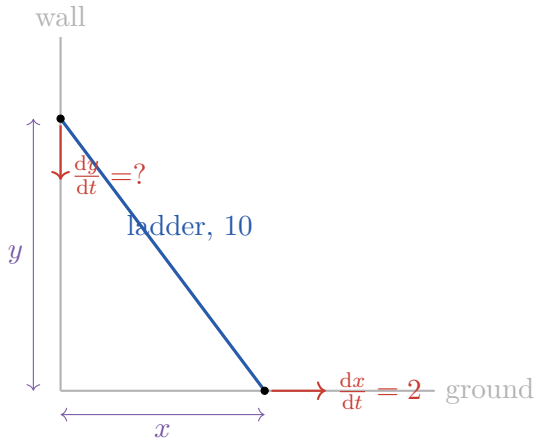


Figure 13.4: The sliding ladder. The fixed length 10 ties x and y together by $x^2 + y^2 = 100$; pulling the foot out forces the top down.

Knowns and unknown. $\frac{dx}{dt} = +2\,\text{ft/s}$ (the foot moves away). We want $\frac{dy}{dt}$ at the instant $x = 6$.

Constraint. The ladder is rigid, so by the Pythagorean theorem, *at every instant*,

$$x^2 + y^2 = 100.$$

Differentiate in t. Each variable gets its rate:

$$2x\,\frac{dx}{dt} + 2y\,\frac{dy}{dt} = 0 \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \frac{dy}{dt} = -\frac{x}{y}\,\frac{dx}{dt}.$$

Substitute. When $x = 6$, the constraint gives $y = \sqrt{100 - 36} = 8$. So

$$\frac{dy}{dt} = -\frac{6}{8}\cdot 2 = -\frac{3}{2} = -1.5\ \text{ft/s}.$$

The top slides *down* at 1.5 ft/s. The negative sign is the model telling us the height is decreasing, exactly as it must.

Why this matters

There is a startling rider to the ladder problem. Keep the foot moving at a steady 2 ft/s and ask what happens as the ladder nears flat against the ground, $y \to 0$. Then $\frac{dy}{dt} = -\frac{x}{y}\cdot 2$ blows up to $-\infty$: the top appears to slam down infinitely fast. Of course no real ladder does this – near the end the top lifts off the wall and the model's assumptions fail. Yet the mathematics flags its own boundary: the equation $x^2 + y^2 = 100$ forces an infinite speed precisely where the physical assumption behind it – that the top stays pinned against the wall – gives way.

13.4.3 The inflating balloon

Example 13.7 (The spherical balloon)**.** Air is pumped into a spherical balloon at $100\,\text{cm}^3/\text{s}$. How fast is the radius growing when the radius is 5 cm? How fast is it growing when the radius is 10 cm?

Name. Let V be the volume and r the radius, both functions of t.

Knowns and unknown. $\frac{dV}{dt} = 100\,\text{cm}^3/\text{s}$. Want $\frac{dr}{dt}$.

Constraint. The geometry of a sphere:

$$V = \frac{4}{3}\pi r^3.$$

Differentiate in t (chain rule on r^3):

$$\frac{dV}{dt} = 4\pi r^2 \frac{dr}{dt} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \frac{dr}{dt} = \frac{1}{4\pi r^2}\frac{dV}{dt}.$$

Substitute. At $r = 5$:

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = \frac{100}{4\pi(25)} = \frac{100}{100\pi} = \frac{1}{\pi} \approx 0.318 \text{ cm/s}.$$

At $r = 10$:

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = \frac{100}{4\pi(100)} = \frac{1}{4\pi} \approx 0.0796 \text{ cm/s}.$$

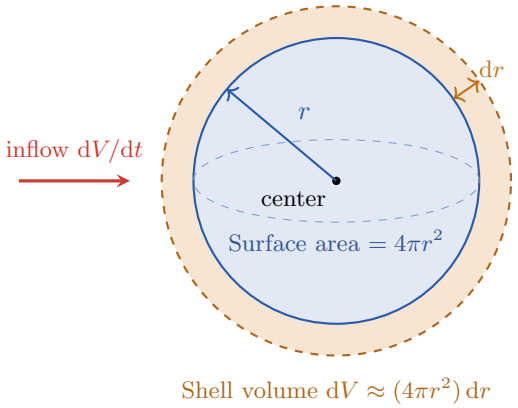


Figure 13.5: The expanding balloon. Air pumped in at rate $\frac{dV}{dt}$ spreads across the sphere's surface of area $4\pi r^2$ as a thin spherical shell of thickness dr. Because $dV \approx 4\pi r^2\,dr$, the radial growth rate is $\frac{dr}{dt} = \frac{1}{4\pi r^2}\frac{dV}{dt}$. As the balloon expands, the same inflow of air must cover four times the surface area at $r = 10$ as at $r = 5$, slowing the radial growth by a factor of four.

Intuition

The factor $4\pi r^2$ in $\frac{dV}{dt} = 4\pi r^2 \frac{dr}{dt}$ is the exact *surface area* of the sphere. The air you pump in spreads itself over the skin of the balloon as a thin shell; a thicker shell over a bigger skin means the same volume of air buys less radius. That is precisely why the radius slows as the balloon grows: at $r = 10$ the surface is four times that at $r = 5$, so the same $100\,\text{cm}^3/\text{s}$ thickens it only a quarter as fast. The derivative $\frac{dV}{dr} = 4\pi r^2 =$ (surface area) is one of the most natural geometric facts in calculus.

13.4.4 The walking shadow

Example 13.8 (The lengthening shadow)**.** A street lamp is 15 ft tall. A person 6 ft tall walks away from the base of the lamp at 5 ft/s. (a) How fast is the tip of the shadow moving? (b) How fast is the shadow's length growing?

Draw and name. Let x be the person's distance from the lamp post, and s the length of the shadow beyond the person. The tip of the shadow is then at distance $x + s$ from the post.

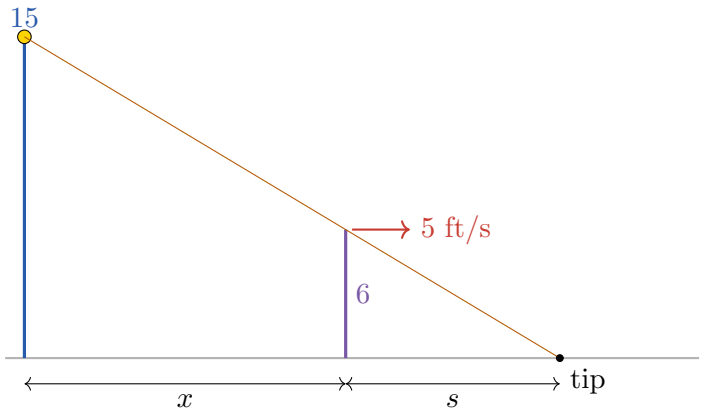


Figure 13.6: The shadow problem. Similar triangles – the big one from lamp top to shadow tip, the small one from the person's head to the tip – give the constraint.

Constraint. The lamp, the person, and the two shadow tips form *similar triangles*: the large triangle (height 15, base $x+s$) and the small triangle (height 6, base s) share the same shape. Equal ratios of height to base:

$$\frac{15}{x+s} = \frac{6}{s}.$$

Cross-multiply: $15s = 6(x+s) = 6x + 6s$, so $9s = 6x$, giving the clean linear relation

$$s = \frac{2}{3}x.$$

Differentiate in t.

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}s}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{2}{3}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{2}{3}(5) = \frac{10}{3} \text{ ft/s}.$$

That answers (b): the shadow lengthens at $\frac{10}{3} \approx 3.33\,\text{ft/s}$.

For (a), the tip is at position $x + s$, so its speed is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}(x+s) = \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} + \frac{\mathrm{d}s}{\mathrm{d}t} = 5 + \frac{10}{3} = \frac{25}{3} \approx 8.33 \text{ ft/s}.$$

Common trap

Part (a) and part (b) ask different questions, and confusing them is the classic shadow trap. The *length of the shadow* (s) and the *position of its tip* ($x + s$) are not the same quantity; the tip moves because *both* the person and the shadow's far end advance. Always decide precisely which point or length the problem is asking about before differentiating. Notice too that neither rate depends on x – the answers are the same whether the person is near or far. That is special to the straight-line, point-source geometry here, and it is a nice surprise worth pausing on.

13.4.5 An angle that changes: the rising balloon

Example 13.9 (Tracking with a camera)**.** A weather balloon rises straight up at 8 m/s. A camera on the ground sits 50 m from the launch point and tilts to keep the balloon in frame. How fast is the camera's angle of elevation increasing when the balloon is 50 m high?

Name. Let h be the balloon's height and θ the camera's angle of elevation above the horizontal. The horizontal distance 50 m is constant.

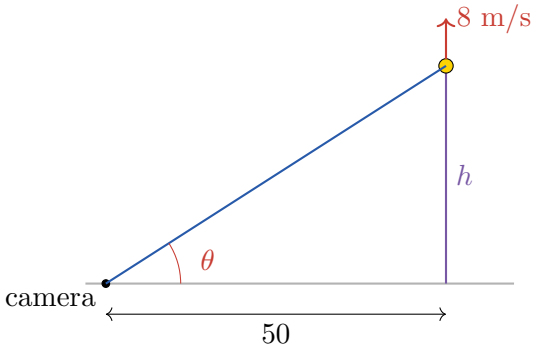


Figure 13.7: Tracking the rising balloon. The camera sits a fixed 50 m from the launch point; the line of sight makes angle θ with the ground, and $\tan\theta = h/50$. As h grows, θ opens.

Constraint. From the right triangle (Figure 13.7),

$$\tan\theta = \frac{h}{50}.$$

Differentiate in t. The left side needs the chain rule on tan:

$$\sec^2\theta\,\frac{d\theta}{dt} = \frac{1}{50}\frac{dh}{dt}.$$

Substitute. When $h = 50$, the triangle is a 50-50 right triangle, so $\theta = 45^\circ$ and the hypotenuse is $50\sqrt{2}$. Then $\sec\theta = \dfrac{50\sqrt{2}}{50} = \sqrt{2}$, so $\sec^2\theta = 2$. With $\frac{dh}{dt} = 8$,

$$2\,\frac{d\theta}{dt} = \frac{8}{50} = \frac{4}{25} \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \frac{d\theta}{dt} = \frac{2}{25} = 0.08 \text{ rad/s}.$$

The angle increases at 0.08 rad/s, about 4.6 degrees per second.

Common trap

The factor $\sec^2\theta$ is easy to drop. Because θ changes with time, $\tan\theta$ is a composition (tangent-of, applied to $\theta(t)$), and the chain rule supplies $\dfrac{d}{dt}\tan\theta = \sec^2\theta\,\frac{d\theta}{dt}$. Forgetting it is the trig version of the $\frac{dy}{dx}$-dropping mistake from earlier. Also: this calculation only works because θ is measured in *radians* – the derivative formula $\dfrac{d}{d\theta}\tan\theta = \sec^2\theta$ is a radian fact. Always work related-rates angles in radians.

13.4.6 Two moving pieces: ships on the sea

So far one rate drove one other. The method is just as happy with several changing lengths at once.

Example 13.10 (Two ships)**.** At noon, ship A is 60 km due east of ship B. Ship A sails west at 20 km/h; ship B sails north at 15 km/h. How fast is the distance between them changing at 1 p.m.?

Name. Put B's noon position at the origin. Let p be the east–west separation between the ships and q the north–south separation, and D the straight-line distance between them.

Set up. Ship A closes the east–west gap at 20 km/h, so $p = 60 - 20t$ and $\frac{dp}{dt} = -20$. Ship B opens a north–south gap at 15 km/h, so $q = 15t$ and $\frac{dq}{dt} = 15$. (Here t is hours after noon.)

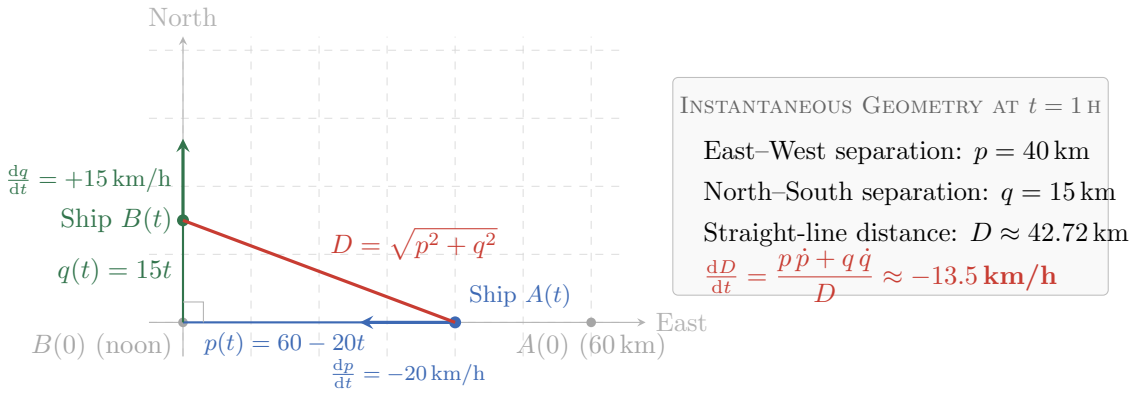


Figure 13.8: The two ships problem. Ship A sails west along the horizontal axis with $\frac{dp}{dt} = -20$ km/h, while ship B sails north with $\frac{dq}{dt} = +15$ km/h. At $t = 1$ hour, the right triangle with legs $p = 40$ and $q = 15$ gives distance $D \approx 42.72$ km; differentiating $D^2 = p^2 + q^2$ shows the distance is decreasing at approximately 13.5 km/h.

Constraint. The two ships and the right angle between their motions give

$$D^2 = p^2 + q^2.$$

Differentiate in t.

$$2D\,\frac{dD}{dt} = 2p\,\frac{dp}{dt} + 2q\,\frac{dq}{dt} \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \frac{dD}{dt} = \frac{p\,\frac{dp}{dt} + q\,\frac{dq}{dt}}{D}.$$

Substitute at $t = 1$. Then $p = 60 - 20 = 40$, $q = 15$, and $D = \sqrt{40^2 + 15^2} = \sqrt{1600 + 225} = \sqrt{1825} \approx 42.72$ km. So

$$\frac{dD}{dt} = \frac{40(-20) + 15(15)}{\sqrt{1825}} = \frac{-800 + 225}{42.72} = \frac{-575}{42.72} \approx -13.5 \text{ km/h}.$$

The ships are still *approaching* at about 13.5 km/h: the negative sign says the distance is shrinking, because A's rapid westward closing outweighs B's slower northward drift – for now.

Walking question

The ships' distance is decreasing at 1 p.m., but A will eventually slide past B's line and the gap must grow again. So somewhere $\frac{\mathrm{d}D}{\mathrm{d}t}$ passes through 0 – the moment of closest approach. Without solving it fully, can you see that the closest approach happens exactly when $p\,\frac{\mathrm{d}p}{\mathrm{d}t} + q\,\frac{\mathrm{d}q}{\mathrm{d}t} = 0$? Geometrically, this sum is a dot product: the rate of D is the component of the relative velocity along the line joining the ships. Related rates connects directly to vector geometry.

13.5 What Ties It All Together

The two halves of this chapter are one idea seen from two angles.

In *implicit differentiation*, a constraint $F(x, y) = c$ binds y to x. Differentiating in x and remembering the chain rule on y yields a relationship between 1 (the rate of x with respect to itself) and $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$, which we solve for the slope.

In *related rates*, a constraint $F(x, y) = c$ binds x and y as both ride along on time. Differentiating in t and remembering the chain rule on every variable yields a relationship between $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}$, which we solve for the unknown rate.

Why this matters

Same equation, same chain rule, same algebra at the end – only the independent variable differs (x in one case, t in the other). In fact you can pass between them: if x and y both depend on t, then by the chain rule

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}.$$

The implicit slope $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is exactly the exchange rate that converts the rate of x into the rate of y. Implicit differentiation finds the exchange rate; related rates uses it. The deep theme of this whole chapter is a single sentence: *when quantities obey an equation, their rates obey the differentiated equation.* Constraints on values become constraints on rates. That principle will return in multivariable calculus when we reach the gradient and the method of Lagrange multipliers – where the same constrained-rate logic governs optimization on surfaces.

Application

Conservation laws and equations of motion. In classical mechanics, differentiating an implicit constraint in time converts a conservation law directly into a force law. Suppose a particle of mass m moves along a line in a potential $V(x)$ with constant total mechanical energy:

$$\tfrac{1}{2}m\dot{x}^2 + V(x) = E,$$

where Newton's dot notation writes $\dot{x} = \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}$ for velocity and $\ddot{x} = \frac{\mathrm{d}[}{\mathrm{d}2}]xt$ for acceleration. Differentiate both sides with respect to t using the chain rule on each term:

$$m\dot{x}\ddot{x} + V'(x)\dot{x} = 0.$$

Whenever the particle is moving ($\dot{x} \neq 0$), dividing by $\dot{x}$ immediately recovers Newton's second law $m\ddot{x} = -V'(x)$: acceleration equals force divided by mass.

13.5.1 The Geometry and Horizons of Implicit Curves

Connection

Implicit differentiation freed calculus from having to isolate $y = f(x)$ before taking a derivative. In geometry, celestial mechanics, and engineering, the relations that govern variables almost never arrive pre-solved for y; they appear as constraint equations $F(x, y) = 0$ or geometric invariants. By differentiating both sides with respect to x or t, we can determine exact tangent slopes and rate couplings directly from the equation.
Yet implicit curves present geometric boundaries where single-variable calculus needs deeper help. When we apply the chain rule to a general constraint $F(x, y) = 0$, we are computing

$$\frac{\partial F}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial F}{\partial y}\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{\frac{\partial F}{\partial x}}{\frac{\partial F}{\partial y}},$$

where $\frac{\partial F}{\partial x}$ and $\frac{\partial F}{\partial y}$ measure the rates of change of F as x or y varies alone while the other is held fixed. This relation encounters two distinct geometric situations:

- Where $\frac{\partial F}{\partial y} = 0$ but $\frac{\partial F}{\partial x} \neq 0$, the denominator vanishes and the tangent line is vertical; single-variable calculus cannot represent y as a function of x locally (though swapping variables to find $\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}y} = 0$ handles it cleanly).
- Where both $\frac{\partial F}{\partial x} = 0$ and $\frac{\partial F}{\partial y} = 0$ simultaneously (as occurs at the origin $(0, 0)$ on the folium of Descartes $x^3 + y^3 - 6xy = 0$), the formula yields an indeterminate $0/0$. Such a point is called a *singular point*—a location where the curve crosses itself in a *node* (an X-shaped crossing with two distinct tangent lines), pinches into a *cusp* (a sharp needle-like point where two branches meet), or isolates a single point. There, single-variable calculus cannot decide which branch to follow.

To systematically classify curves and surfaces defined implicitly, we need the geometry of several variables. In Chapter 32 and Chapter 33, we develop partial derivatives, the gradient vector $\nabla F = \left(\frac{\partial F}{\partial x}, \frac{\partial F}{\partial y}\right)$ (an arrow pointing in the direction of steepest change across the surface $F(x, y)$), and the *Implicit Function Theorem*. That theorem guarantees that near any point (x_0, y_0) on the level set $F(x, y) = c$ (the curve of points where F stays constant, like an elevation contour line on a map) where $\frac{\partial F}{\partial y}(x_0, y_0) \neq 0$, the curve is locally the graph of a unique smooth function $y = f(x)$.

13.5.2 Looking Ahead: The Tangent Line as a Microscope

Throughout this chapter, implicit differentiation showed that even when an equation entangles x and y so completely that we cannot isolate y, we can still determine the exact slope of its tangent line at any point.

Why is that tangent line so useful?

Zoom in close enough to any smooth point on a curve, and the curve becomes indistinguishable from a straight line—its tangent line. If you take a tiny horizontal step $\mathrm{d}x$ along the tangent line, it responds with a vertical step:

$$\mathrm{d}y = \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

On the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ at $(3, 4)$, the slope is $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{3}{4}$. If you step sideways by a small amount $\mathrm{d}x = +0.04$, the tangent line steps down by:

$$\mathrm{d}y = -\frac{3}{4}(0.04) = -0.03.$$

The tangent line predicts that when $x = 3.04$, the circle's vertical coordinate should be approximately:

$$y \approx 4 - 0.03 = 3.97.$$

Check that prediction against the circle's true equation:

$$(3.04)^2 + (3.97)^2 = 9.2416 + 15.7609 = 25.0025 \approx 25.$$

Without evaluating a radical or solving an algebraic equation, the tangent line handed us a close estimate of how the curve behaves.

This is the gateway to our next chapter. When an explicit function is hard to compute by hand, or when we only know a rate of change from instruments, we replace the curve with its tangent line. In **Chapter 14: Linear Approximation and Differentials**, we will turn derivatives into tools of estimation, measure the error of a linear forecast, and use Leibniz's differentials $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$ to track how errors in measurement propagate through formulas.

13.6 Exercises

Exercise 13.1 (Mental checks)**.** Answer each question mentally without writing down scratch work:

(a) For the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 100$, what is the tangent slope $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ at the top point $(0, 10)$? What is it at the rightmost point $(10, 0)$? What does the geometry of the circle say about these two tangents?

(b) A square has side length s. If each side grows at a steady rate of $3\,\mathrm{cm/s}$, what is the rate of change of the square's area when $s = 10\,\mathrm{cm}$? (Differentiate $A = s^2$ in time.)

(c) For the hyperbola $x^2 - y^2 = 1$, where if anywhere is the tangent line horizontal? Where is it vertical?

Exercise 13.2. Find $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ by implicit differentiation for each curve.

(a) $x^2 + xy + y^2 = 7$.

(b) $\sqrt{x} + \sqrt{y} = 4$.

(c) $e^{xy} = x + y$.

(d) $y \sin x = x \cos y$.

Exercise 13.3. The curve $x^2 + y^2 = 25$ passes through $(-4, 3)$. Find the equation of the tangent line there, and confirm with the formula $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = -\frac{x}{y}$ that it is perpendicular to the radius to that point.

Exercise 13.4. For the astroid $x^{2/3}+y^{2/3}=4$, find $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$. At which points is the tangent line horizontal, and at which is it vertical? (Hint: horizontal where $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}=0$, vertical where it is undefined.)

Exercise 13.5 (Linear forecast and error)**.** At the point $(3,4)$ on the circle $x^2+y^2=25$, the tangent line has slope $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}=-\frac{3}{4}$ and equation $y-4=-\frac{3}{4}(x-3)$.

(a) Use the tangent line equation to estimate the value of y on the circle when $x=3.08$.

(b) Calculate the exact value $y=\sqrt{25-(3.08)^2}$. By how much does the tangent line forecast differ from the true circle coordinate?

(c) How does this preview the core theme of Chapter 14 (linear approximation and differentials)?

Exercise 13.6. Find the second derivative $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}x^2}$ for the curve $xy=1$, first by implicit differentiation and then by solving $y=1/x$ explicitly and differentiating twice. Confirm the two answers agree.

Exercise 13.7 (Conceptual)**.** A classmate computes $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(y^3)=3y^2$ while differentiating an implicit equation. Explain in one or two sentences exactly what is wrong, and what the correct expression is. Then state the analogous mistake one might make in a related-rates problem with a term r^3 when differentiating in t.

Exercise 13.8. Water drains from an inverted right-circular cone (point down) of height $12\,\mathrm{m}$ and top radius $3\,\mathrm{m}$. The volume of water at depth h is $V=\frac{1}{3}\pi r^2 h$, where r is the surface radius at that depth. (a) Use similar triangles to express r in terms of h, and show $V=\frac{\pi}{48}h^3$. (b) If the volume decreases at $2\,\mathrm{m}^3/\mathrm{min}$, how fast is the depth dropping when $h=4\,\mathrm{m}$?

Exercise 13.9. A kite $100\,\mathrm{ft}$ above the ground moves horizontally at $8\,\mathrm{ft/s}$ away from the person flying it. The string is taut and runs in a straight line. How fast is the string being let out when $200\,\mathrm{ft}$ of string is out? (Hint: let x be the horizontal distance and L the string length, with $x^2+100^2=L^2$.)

Exercise 13.10. Two roads meet at a right angle. Car A is $0.3\,\mathrm{km}$ from the intersection driving toward it at $60\,\mathrm{km/h}$; car B is $0.4\,\mathrm{km}$ from the intersection driving toward it at $80\,\mathrm{km/h}$. How fast is the distance between the cars changing at this instant? Is it increasing or decreasing, and what does the sign mean physically?

Exercise 13.11. A trough $10\,\mathrm{ft}$ long has a cross-section that is an isosceles triangle, $2\,\mathrm{ft}$ across the top and $1\,\mathrm{ft}$ deep. Water is poured in at $3\,\mathrm{ft}^3/\mathrm{min}$. How fast is the water level rising when the water is 6 inches deep? (Set up similar triangles for the water's surface width in terms of depth, then relate volume to depth.)

Exercise 13.12 (Proof)**.** Suppose x and y both depend on t and satisfy the constraint $F(x,y)=c$ for all t, with y expressible as a differentiable function of x along the curve. Using only the single-variable chain rule, prove that

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}=\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\cdot\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}$$

at any point where these derivatives exist. Explain in one sentence how this identity unifies implicit differentiation and related rates.

Exercise 13.13 (Conceptual)**.** In the sliding-ladder example we found $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}\to-\infty$ as the top approaches the ground. Explain physically why a real ladder does not behave this way, and identify which modeling assumption ($x^2+y^2=100$ holding for all time, the foot moving at constant $2\,\mathrm{ft/s}$, the top staying in contact with the wall) is the first to fail. Argue that the infinite rate is the model reporting its own breakdown rather than a real physical infinity.

Chapter 14

Linear Approximation and Differentials

In the previous chapter, we calculated tangent slopes for implicit curves and related rates. Why spend so much effort finding tangent slopes? Because of a single geometric fact that sits underneath all of differential calculus:

A smooth curve, looked at closely enough, is a straight line.

Geometrically, the derivative $f'(a)$ is the slope of the *tangent line that the curve approaches* under magnification near $x = a$. Once you recognize that smooth means locally linear, the surrounding ideas — tangent lines, error estimates, Newton's method, and the differentials $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ used throughout physics — become straightforward applications of replacing a curve by its tangent line and bounding the remainder.

This chapter makes that replacement precise. We will build the *linearization* of a function, measure the error committed by using it, and pin down what $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ *really mean* (they are neither zero nor "infinitely small"). From there we will track how measurement errors propagate through a formula and take a first look at Newton's method, which applies linear approximation repeatedly.

14.1 Zooming In: Why Smooth Means Straight

Take any function you like that is differentiable at a point – say $f(x) = x^2$ near $x = 1$ – and imagine doing the following experiment. Plot it. Then zoom in on the point $(1, 1)$: cut the viewing window in half, then in half again, then again. What happens to the parabola?

It flattens. The more you zoom, the straighter the visible piece of curve looks, until on a small enough window you genuinely cannot tell it from a straight line drawn with a ruler. Figure 14.1 shows three frames of this experiment.

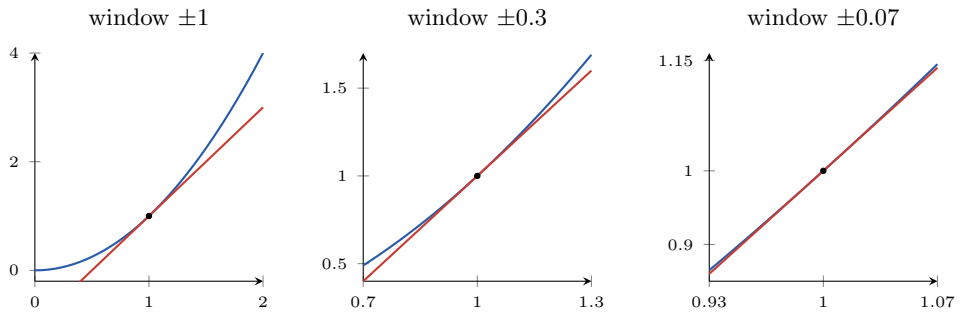


Figure 14.1: Zooming in on $y = x^2$ at $(1, 1)$. The curve (blue) and its tangent line $y = 2x - 1$ (red) become indistinguishable as the window shrinks. "Smooth" literally means "looks straight up close."

Intuition

Differentiability *is* this zoom property. To say f has a derivative at a is to say: there is a single straight line through $(a, f(a))$ that the curve approaches under magnification. A function with a corner (like $|x|$ at 0) fails the test – no matter how far you zoom into the corner, you still see two different slopes meeting, never one line. Smoothness is the condition that the zoom converges to a single line.

Why should you care that the curve becomes straight? Because straight lines are the only functions we can compute with easily. A line is just "start here, go up by the slope times how far you walk." No squaring, no exponentials, no trig tables. If we are willing to accept a small error, we can replace any hard smooth function, *near a point*, by a line and do arithmetic instead of analysis. That trade – a little error in exchange for enormous simplicity – is the engine of applied mathematics.

Walking question

Picture the surface of the Earth. Locally – in your backyard, on a soccer field – it looks flat, and flat-earth geometry (Pythagoras, straight survey lines) works beautifully. The error only shows up over hundreds of miles, where the curvature accumulates. The Earth is the function; the flat backyard is its tangent plane; the error is the curvature. Where else in life do you replace a curved thing by a flat one because the flat version is good enough up close?

14.2 The Tangent Line as the Best Linear Approximation

Let us turn the picture into algebra. We have a function f differentiable at a point a. We want the straight line that best matches f near a. A straight line through the point $(a, f(a))$ has the form

$$L(x) = f(a) + m\,(x - a),$$

and the only freedom we have is the slope m. Which slope makes L hug the curve best?

Geometrically the answer is obvious from the zoom picture: pick the slope of the curve itself at a, namely $m = f'(a)$. That gives the *tangent line*. But "looks best" is not a definition. Let us say precisely what "best" means and then prove the tangent line wins.

Definition 14.1 (Linearization)**.** Let f be differentiable at a. The **linearization** of f at a is the linear function

$$L(x) \;=\; f(a) + f'(a)\,(x - a).$$

The approximation $f(x) \approx L(x)$ for x near a is called the **linear** (or **tangent-line**) **approximation**.

Notice the anatomy of L: it carries the function's *height* $f(a)$ and its *slope* $f'(a)$ at the single point a, and nothing else. It is the most a straight line can know about f. Read it aloud: "Start at the known value $f(a)$. Walk a distance $(x - a)$. For each unit you walk, climb by the rate $f'(a)$."

14.2.1 In what sense is it "best"?

Compare the tangent line to any other line through $(a, f(a))$ with a different slope $m \neq f'(a)$. The error of a line $L_m(x) = f(a) + m(x - a)$ is

$$E_m(x) = f(x) - L_m(x).$$

At $x = a$ every such line is exact: $E_m(a) = 0$, because they all pass through the point. So the contest is about how fast the error grows as you step away. Write $x = a + h$ and divide the error by the step h:

$$\frac{E_m(a+h)}{h} = \frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{h} - m.$$

As $h \to 0$ the difference quotient $\frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h}$ tends to $f'(a)$. Therefore

$$\frac{E_m(a+h)}{h} \;\longrightarrow\; f'(a) - m.$$

Look at what that limit says. If $m \neq f'(a)$, it is a nonzero number; the error is roughly $(f'(a) - m)\cdot h$, growing *in proportion to* h. But if $m = f'(a)$, the limit is 0: the error, divided by h, approaches zero. The error of the tangent line shrinks *faster than* h *itself*. That is the precise sense in which the tangent line is the uniquely best linear approximation.

Focus

The defining property of the tangent line. Among all lines through $(a, f(a))$, the tangent line is the only one whose error is *small compared to the step*: writing $x = a + h$,

$$\lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(a+h) - \big[f(a) + f'(a)\,h\big]}{h} \;=\; 0.$$

Every other line leaves an error proportional to h; the tangent line leaves an error that is negligible next to h. We say the tangent line agrees with f "to first order."

Why the technique works

Why does matching the slope kill the first-order error? Because the derivative *is* the leading-order rate of change. Near a,

$$f(a + h) = f(a) + f'(a)\,h + (\text{error}),$$

and the very definition of $f'(a)$ as a limit forces the error to be small relative to h. Choosing the slope to be anything other than $f'(a)$ leaves a leftover term $(f'(a) - m)h$ that is itself proportional to h – a first-order mistake that swamps the curvature. Matching the slope cancels the leading first-order discrepancy, leaving an error that scales with h^2 as curvature pulls the curve away from the line.

14.2.2 A first worked example

Example 14.1 (Approximating a square root)**.** Estimate $\sqrt{4.1}$ without a calculator.

Let $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$, and choose the *anchor* $a = 4$ because we know $\sqrt{4} = 2$ exactly and 4 is close to 4.1. We need the slope:

$$f'(x) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}, \qquad f'(4) = \frac{1}{2 \cdot 2} = \frac{1}{4}.$$

The linearization is

$$L(x) = f(4) + f'(4)(x - 4) = 2 + \tfrac{1}{4}(x - 4).$$

Plug in $x = 4.1$:

$$\sqrt{4.1} \approx L(4.1) = 2 + \tfrac{1}{4}(0.1) = 2 + 0.025 = 2.025.$$

The true value is $\sqrt{4.1} = 2.024845\ldots$, so our estimate is right to four decimal places. We did it with one division.

Picking a good anchor a means balancing two things: you want a point where f and f' can be computed exactly, and which sits as close to your target as possible. Here $a = 4$ serves both purposes: 4 is a perfect square and lies adjacent to 4.1.

Work it yourself

Estimate $\sqrt{4.4}$ the same way: $L(4.4) = 2 + \frac{1}{4}(0.4) = 2.1$. The true value is $2.0976\ldots$. Notice the error has grown from about 0.00015 (at the step $h = 0.1$) to about 0.0024 (at the step $h = 0.4$): the step grew by a factor of 4, and the error grew by a factor of about $16 = 4^2$. That quadratic growth reflects the curvature, and Section 14.4 explains why the error scales with h^2.

Pause

Pause and think. Look at our estimate $\sqrt{4.1} \approx 2.025$. Before consulting a calculator: is 2.025 slightly too large or slightly too small? Look at the graph of $y = \sqrt{x}$ in Figure 14.2. As x grows, the curve gets flatter – it bends downward (concave down). Any tangent line drawn to a downward-bending curve rides *above* the curve, so without computing a single extra digit we know 2.025 is an overestimate. Check: $2.025^2 = 4.100625 > 4.1$.

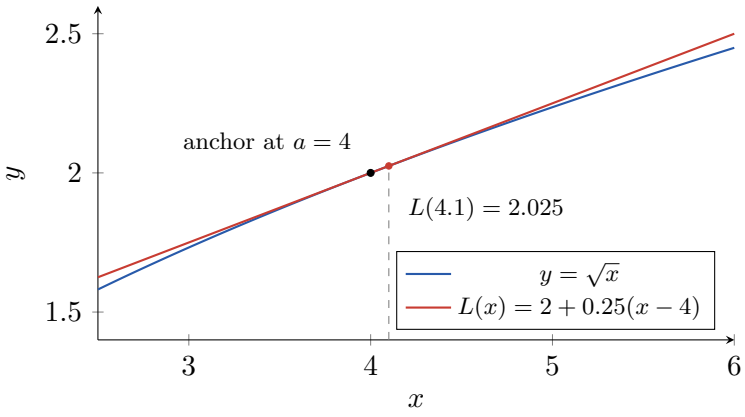


Figure 14.2: The tangent line to $\sqrt{x}$ at $a = 4$. Near the anchor the red line and blue curve are nearly identical; the gap (the error) opens slowly as you move away, and because $\sqrt{x}$ bends downward, the line sits slightly above the curve.

Common trap

Linearization is a *local* tool. It is only trustworthy near the anchor. If you used the line $L(x) = 2 + \frac{1}{4}(x - 4)$ to estimate $\sqrt{100}$ you would get $2 + \frac{1}{4}(96) = 26$, which is absurd (the truth is 10). The approximation does not "know" anything about the curve far from a – it only ever knew the height and slope at one point. Always ask: is my target genuinely close to my anchor?

14.3 What the Differentials $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ Really Mean

You have been writing $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ for chapters now, defined rigorously as the limit of a difference quotient. That care was necessary while constructing the foundations. Now we can clarify the underlying geometric picture: there are two distinct quantities, $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$, whose ratio equals the derivative when defined on the tangent line. Leibniz originally thought of $\mathrm{d}x$ as an infinitesimal change. While intuitive, that notion required two centuries of refinement to place on solid ground. Here is the modern formulation.

Definition 14.2 (The differentials $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$)**.** Let $y = f(x)$ be differentiable at x. We declare $\mathrm{d}x$ to be an **independent real variable** – an ordinary number, which you are free to choose, representing a step in the x-direction. Then we *define* the **differential of** y by

$$\mathrm{d}y \;=\; f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

$\mathrm{d}y$ is the rise of the *tangent line* over a run of $\mathrm{d}x$.

Read that definition slowly, because it dissolves a confusion you may have carried for years.

What is really happening

What $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$ really are. They are not zero. They are not "infinitely small." $\mathrm{d}x$ is just a number you pick – the size of a step. And $\mathrm{d}y$ is the corresponding *rise along the tangent line*,

not along the curve. Look at Figure 14.3. Take a real step $\mathrm{d}x = \Delta x$ from the point $(a, f(a))$. Two things rise:

- the *curve* rises by $\Delta y = f(a + \Delta x) - f(a)$ – the true change;
- the *tangent line* rises by $\mathrm{d}y = f'(a)\,\mathrm{d}x$ – the linear estimate of the change.

The differential $\mathrm{d}y$ is the **approximation**; the increment Δy is the **truth**. The gap between them, $\Delta y - \mathrm{d}y$, is the error of linear approximation – exactly the quantity we studied in the last section. And now the notation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = f'(x)$ is literally a quotient of two numbers $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$, because that is how we defined $\mathrm{d}y$. Leibniz's fraction was real all along; we just had to say which line the rise is measured on.

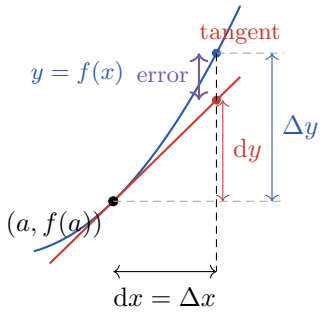


Figure 14.3: The true meaning of differentials. Over a real step $\mathrm{d}x = \Delta x$, the tangent line rises by $\mathrm{d}y = f'(a)\,\mathrm{d}x$ while the curve rises by the true amount Δy. The differential $\mathrm{d}y$ estimates Δy; their difference (purple) is the approximation error, governed by the curvature.

History

Calculus began not with limits, but with the practical struggle to approximate curved motion using straight lines. In the 1660s and 1670s, Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz independently discovered that the slope of a curve could be found by imagining a change so small that the curve was effectively straight. Newton framed this dynamically, speaking of "fluxions" (instantaneous velocities) and "evanescent increments" (quantities caught at the fleeting instant of vanishing). Leibniz developed the enduring notation of differentials: he pictured $\mathrm{d}x$ as an *infinitesimal*—a quantity smaller than any positive real number you can name, yet strictly greater than zero. With $\mathrm{d}y = f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, Leibniz treated derivatives as genuine ratios of geometric lengths, which made the chain rule $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}u}\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x}$ look like simple fraction cancellation.

Their practical results were accurate, but their foundations provoked immediate debate. In 1734, Bishop George Berkeley published his critique *The Analyst*, targeting a clear logical inconsistency: in calculating a derivative, mathematicians treated $\mathrm{d}x$ as nonzero so they could divide by it, and then set $\mathrm{d}x = 0$ to discard the remaining terms. Within the ordinary real numbers, no single quantity can satisfy both conditions.

The response took over a century to mature. In 1768, Leonhard Euler published his *Institutiones calculi differentialis*, demonstrating that stepping along tangent lines ($y_{n+1} = y_n + f'(x_n)\Delta x$) provided a universal numerical tool—now called Euler's method—for solving otherwise intractable differential equations.

The full theoretical resolution arrived in 1823 with Augustin-Louis Cauchy. Cauchy rebuilt

the derivative as the limit of a difference quotient of finite real numbers. Cauchy also showed that linear approximation carries a rigorous quantitative guarantee: using the Mean Value Theorem, he proved that the error $R_1(x) = f(x) - L(x)$ is bounded by the maximum curvature: $|R_1(x)| \leq \frac{1}{2}M(x-a)^2$, where $|f''(t)| \leq M$. Leibniz's $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$ were restored as ordinary, finite numbers: $\mathrm{d}x$ is a chosen horizontal step, and $\mathrm{d}y = f'(a)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the exact vertical rise of the tangent line.
The story held one final surprise. In the 1960s, the logician Abraham Robinson used mathematical logic to prove that Leibniz's dream of true, consistent infinitesimals was logically sound after all, founding *nonstandard analysis*. Today, while the theory of single-variable linear approximation is complete, a vital question remains open in applied mathematics: determining exactly when and where the linearization of massive, complex systems—such as climate dynamics, turbulent fluids, or deep neural networks—breaks down.

14.3.1 Differentials as a notation for approximation

The single most useful sentence about differentials is this:

$$\boxed{\Delta y \;\approx\; \mathrm{d}y \;=\; f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x}$$

"The true change is approximately the linear change." Everything in the rest of this chapter is an application of that boxed line. Let us redo Example 14.1 in this language to see how compact it becomes.

Example 14.2 ($\sqrt{4.1}$ via differentials)**.** We want $\sqrt{4.1}$. Anchor at $x = 4$, take the step $\mathrm{d}x = 0.1$. With $y = \sqrt{x}$ we have $\mathrm{d}y = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}\,\mathrm{d}x$, so

$$\mathrm{d}y = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{4}}(0.1) = \frac{0.1}{4} = 0.025.$$

Then

$$\sqrt{4.1} = \sqrt{4} + \Delta y \approx \sqrt{4} + \mathrm{d}y = 2 + 0.025 = 2.025,$$

matching what we found before. The differential $\mathrm{d}y = 0.025$ *is* the estimated change in $\sqrt{x}$ caused by nudging x from 4 to 4.1.

Connection

The boxed approximation $\Delta y \approx f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the one-variable seed of the *total differential* you will meet in multivariable calculus:

$$\mathrm{d}z = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\,\mathrm{d}x + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\,\mathrm{d}y,$$

where $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}$ and $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ denote the slopes of $f(x, y)$ in the x- and y-directions individually. A small move in the plane changes z by (rate in x)$\times$(step in x) plus (rate in y)$\times$(step in y): the tangent *plane* replaces the tangent line, while the principle – locally, smooth equals linear – stays identical.

14.4 Linearization and Error: How Wrong Are You?

An approximation you cannot bound is a guess. The reason linear approximation is trustworthy – rather than merely convenient – is that we can say precisely how large the error is. Define the error of the linearization at a as

$$E(x) = f(x) - L(x) = f(x) - \big[f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)\big].$$

We already know (Section 14.2) that E vanishes faster than the step: $E(a) = 0$ and $E(x)/(x-a) \to 0$. That tells us the error is small, but not *how* small. The next theorem gives the size exactly: *the error is controlled by the second derivative*—by the curvature that the straight-line approximation omits.

Theorem 14.1 (Error of linear approximation)**.** *Suppose f has a continuous second derivative on an interval containing a and x. Then there is a point c between a and x such that*

$$f(x) - \big[f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)\big] \;=\; \frac{f''(c)}{2}\,(x-a)^2.$$

Before the proof, absorb the shape of the result. Writing $h = x - a$ for the step:

$$E = \tfrac{1}{2}\, f''(c)\, h^2.$$

Three things to notice. First, the error is proportional to h^2, not h – so halving your distance from the anchor quarters the error, exactly the square-law we saw numerically in the lab box. Second, the multiplier is f'', the curvature: a flatter curve (small f'') is approximated better, and a perfectly straight f (with $f'' = 0$) has *zero* error, as it must. Third, the sign of f'' tells you which way you missed: if the curve is concave up ($f'' > 0$) the tangent line lies below it and you underestimate; concave down ($f'' < 0$) and you overestimate. That is why in Figure 14.2 the line for the downward-bending $\sqrt{x}$ sat *above* the curve, and our estimate 2.025 came out slightly high. Figure 14.4 shows this h^2 growth directly: the true error tracks a parabola bounded by the guaranteed bound.

Why the technique works

Where does the $\frac{1}{2}$ come from, and why f''? Think of building f back up from its derivatives, like reconstructing a journey from your speedometer. The value $f(a)$ is where you start. The term $f'(a)h$ is how far you would travel if your speed never changed – the linear estimate. But your speed *does* change, at the rate f'' (that is what the second derivative is: the rate the slope changes). Over a step h, a steadily changing speed contributes an *average* extra displacement. Just as distance under constant acceleration is $\frac{1}{2}at^2$ in physics, the curvature contributes $\frac{1}{2}f''h^2$. The $\frac{1}{2}$ is the same $\frac{1}{2}$ that appears in $\frac{1}{2}at^2$ – it is the average of a quantity ramping linearly from 0 to its full value. The error term is the first correction you would add to make the straight-line estimate curved.

Proof of Theorem 14.1. This proof relies on a fundamental result that we will systematically develop and prove in the very next chapter: the *Mean Value Theorem*, which guarantees that a smooth function's instantaneous rate of change matches its average rate of change across an interval at some intermediate point. Here we use both the standard Mean Value Theorem and its two-function extension, the Cauchy Mean Value Theorem (which asserts that the ratio of overall changes $\frac{g(x)-g(a)}{p(x)-p(a)}$

equals the ratio of instantaneous derivatives $\frac{g'(c_1)}{p'(c_1)}$ at some point c_1). You can follow the core idea without waiting for Chapter 15: we compare the growth of the error to the growth of the quadratic step $(x-a)^2$.

Fix a and let x vary. If $x = a$, both sides of the claimed formula are 0, so assume $x \neq a$. Consider the two functions

$$g(t) = f(t) - \big[f(a) + f'(a)(t-a)\big], \qquad p(t) = (t-a)^2,$$

both on the closed interval between a and x. We want $g(x)/p(x)$. Notice $g(a) = 0$ and $p(a) = 0$, and also

$$g'(t) = f'(t) - f'(a), \qquad p'(t) = 2(t-a).$$

At every interior point t strictly between a and x, we have $p'(t) = 2(t-a) \neq 0$ (even though $p'(a) = 0$ at the endpoint). So the ratio form of the Cauchy mean value theorem applies on the interval between a and x: there is a point c_1 strictly between a and x with

$$\frac{g(x)}{p(x)} = \frac{g(x) - g(a)}{p(x) - p(a)} = \frac{g'(c_1)}{p'(c_1)} = \frac{f'(c_1) - f'(a)}{2(c_1 - a)}.$$

Now apply the ordinary mean value theorem to f' on the interval from a to c_1: there is a point c between a and c_1 (hence between a and x) with

$$\frac{f'(c_1) - f'(a)}{c_1 - a} = f''(c).$$

Substituting,

$$\frac{g(x)}{p(x)} = \frac{f''(c)}{2} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad g(x) = \frac{f''(c)}{2}\,(x-a)^2,$$

which is exactly the claim, since $g(x) = E(x)$. □

Focus

Usable error bound. You rarely know the mystery point c, but you do not need it. If $|f''(t)| \le M$ for all t between a and x, then

$$\big|f(x) - L(x)\big| \;\le\; \frac{M}{2}\,(x-a)^2.$$

Replace the unknown $f''(c)$ by an *upper bound* on the curvature and you get a guaranteed, conservative error bar.

Example 14.3 (Putting a number on the $\sqrt{4.1}$ error)**.** For $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ we have $f''(x) = -\frac{1}{4}x^{-3/2}$. On the interval $[4, 4.1]$ the largest size of f'' occurs at the left end $x = 4$ (where $x^{-3/2}$ is biggest):

$$|f''(x)| \le \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot 4^{-3/2} = \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot \tfrac{1}{8} = \tfrac{1}{32} = M.$$

With $h = 0.1$,

$$\big|\sqrt{4.1} - 2.025\big| \le \frac{M}{2}h^2 = \frac{1}{64}\,(0.1)^2 = \frac{0.01}{64} \approx 0.000156.$$

The actual error was $0.000154\ldots$ – our bound is essentially tight, and we obtained it knowing only that $\sqrt{x}$ does not bend too sharply on $[4, 4.1]$. Because $f'' < 0$ there, we even know the *sign*: the tangent line rides above the curve, confirming that 2.025 is a slight overestimate.

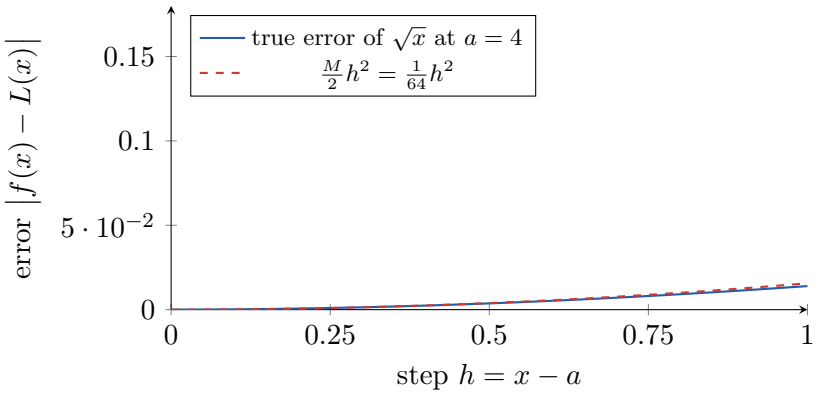


Figure 14.4: The linearization error grows like h^2. The blue curve is the actual error of approximating $\sqrt{x}$ by its tangent line at $a = 4$; the dashed red parabola is the guaranteed bound $\frac{M}{2}h^2$ from Theorem 14.1. The error hugs a parabola, not a line – doubling the step roughly quadruples the error.

Why this matters

Theorem 14.1 is the first step toward *Taylor's theorem*, the general approximation framework developed later. The pattern continues: the linear approximation has error $\sim f''h^2/2$; if you also match the curvature you get the quadratic approximation, with error $\sim f'''h^3/6$; and matching higher derivatives introduces higher powers of h. Linear approximation is Taylor's theorem truncated at degree one.

14.5 Propagation of Error: Differentials in Practice

Differentials provide a direct computational tool for laboratory sciences. You measure something – a radius, a voltage, a time – and your measurement has an uncertainty. You then *compute* something from it – an area, a power, a distance. How does the uncertainty in what you measured affect what you computed? The answer is one application of $\mathrm{d}y = f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, read in a new light: $\mathrm{d}x$ is now the *measurement error*, and $\mathrm{d}y$ is the resulting error in the computed quantity.

Example 14.4 (Error in the area of a circle)**.** You measure the radius of a circular plate as $r = 10\,\mathrm{cm}$, with your ruler good to about $\mathrm{d}r = \pm 0.05\,\mathrm{cm}$. You report the area $A = \pi r^2$. What is the uncertainty in A?

The area's differential is

$$\mathrm{d}A = \frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}r}\,\mathrm{d}r = 2\pi r\,\mathrm{d}r.$$

At $r = 10$, $\mathrm{d}r = 0.05$:

$$\mathrm{d}A = 2\pi(10)(0.05) = \pi \approx 3.14\ \mathrm{cm}^2.$$

So $A = \pi(10)^2 \pm \pi \approx 314.16 \pm 3.14\ \mathrm{cm}^2$. A half-millimeter slip in the radius costs you about $3\,\mathrm{cm}^2$ of area.

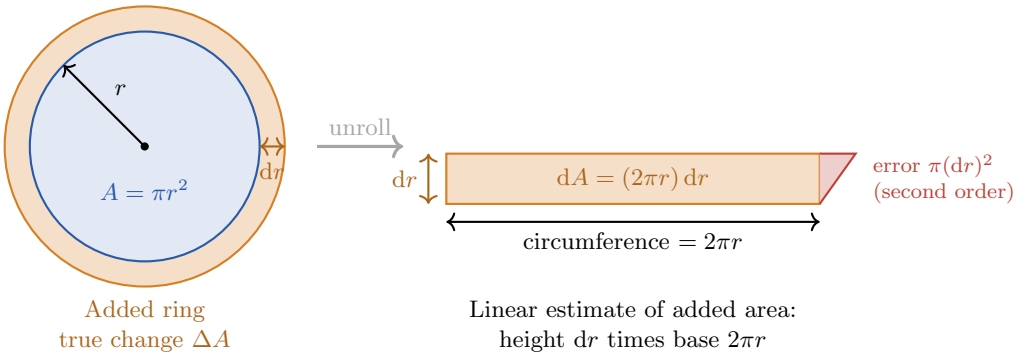


Figure 14.5: The geometry of error propagation for $A = \pi r^2$. A radius uncertainty $\mathrm{d}r$ adds an annular ring of true area $\Delta A = \pi(r + \mathrm{d}r)^2 - \pi r^2$. Unrolling the ring yields a rectangle of length $2\pi r$ and width $\mathrm{d}r$, giving the differential $\mathrm{d}A = 2\pi r\,\mathrm{d}r$. The tiny remaining red wedge has area $\pi(\mathrm{d}r)^2$, which shrinks quadratically and is ignored by the linear approximation.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose you measure the electrical resistance R of a resistor with a 2% uncertainty, and calculate the power dissipated $P = I^2R$ at a known, fixed current I. What is the relative uncertainty in P? Now suppose instead that R is known, while the current I has a 2% uncertainty. What is the relative uncertainty in $P = I^2R$? *Answer:* With fixed I, $\mathrm{d}P = I^2\,\mathrm{d}R$, so $\mathrm{d}P/P = \mathrm{d}R/R = 2\%$ (linear scaling). With fixed R, $\mathrm{d}P = 2IR\,\mathrm{d}I$, so $\mathrm{d}P/P = (2IR\,\mathrm{d}I)/(I^2R) = 2\,\mathrm{d}I/I = 4\%$: squaring the current doubles its relative error, just as squaring the radius doubles the relative error of a circle's area next.

Often the *relative* error – the fractional, or percentage, error – is more illuminating than the absolute error, because it is dimensionless and tells you how many significant figures you can trust. Divide:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{A} = \frac{2\pi r\,\mathrm{d}r}{\pi r^2} = 2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}r}{r}.$$

Focus

Relative error doubles for area, triples for volume. For $A = \pi r^2$,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{A} = 2\,\frac{\mathrm{d}r}{r}.$$

A 1% error in radius becomes a 2% error in area. For a volume $V = \frac{4}{3}\pi r^3$ the same calculation gives $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}V}{V} = 3\,\dfrac{\mathrm{d}r}{r}$ – a 1% radius error becomes a 3% volume error. The exponent in the power law *is* the error-amplification factor.

Why the technique works

Why does the exponent become the multiplier? Because d(power) is just the power rule turned into error language. If $y = x^n$ then $\mathrm{d}y = nx^{n-1}\mathrm{d}x$, and dividing by $y = x^n$ gives

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{y} = n\,\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x}.$$

The logarithm makes it even cleaner: $\ln y = n \ln x$, so $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{y} = n\,\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x}$ is exactly the differential of that identity (since $\mathrm{d}(\ln u) = \mathrm{d}u/u$). Relative error is the *differential of the logarithm*. That is why, for any product or power expression, the relative errors simply add up weighted by the exponents – taking logs turns products into sums, and differentiation turns the sums into added relative errors.

Example 14.5 (Combining several measurements)**.** A pendulum's period is $T = 2\pi\sqrt{L/g}$. Suppose you know L to within 0.5% and g to within 0.2%. How accurately do you know T?

Take logarithms first: $\ln T = \ln(2\pi) + \frac{1}{2}\ln L - \frac{1}{2}\ln g$. Now take the differential of each side, using $\mathrm{d}(\ln u) = \mathrm{d}u/u$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{T} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}L}{L} - \tfrac{1}{2}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}g}{g}.$$

For a *worst-case* bound we add the magnitudes:

$$\left|\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{T}\right| \le \tfrac{1}{2}(0.5\%) + \tfrac{1}{2}(0.2\%) = 0.25\% + 0.1\% = 0.35\%.$$

The logarithmic trick converted a messy square-root-and-quotient formula into a one-line sum of weighted relative errors. This is the everyday error-propagation arithmetic of physics labs.

Application

Error propagation via differentials runs through all of quantitative science. Surveyors turn measured angles into distances, engineers turn measured currents into dissipated power $P = I^2R$ (so $\mathrm{d}P/P = 2\,\mathrm{d}I/I$, doubling any relative current error), and economists turn growth rates into doubling times. Likewise, a machine learning engineer asks how a small perturbation $\mathrm{d}x$ shifts a network's output, and that *sensitivity* $\mathrm{d}y = f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is a single step of backpropagation. In every case the question "how much does the output wobble when the input wobbles?" is answered by the derivative times the input variation.

14.6 The Newton Step: Linear Approximation in Reverse

So far we used the tangent line to estimate a function's *value*. Now turn the question inside out. Suppose we want to *solve* an equation $f(x) = 0$ – to find a root – but the equation is too hard to solve exactly. Examples are everywhere: $\cos x = x$, or $x^5 - x - 1 = 0$, equations with no closed-form solution. The tangent line provides a direct method:

We cannot solve $f(x) = 0$, but we can always solve $L(x) = 0$,
because L is a straight line.

Start with a guess x_0 near the root. Replace the curve by its tangent line at x_0 – the best line we know how to build. Then find where *that line* crosses zero, and call it x_1. Because the line approximates the curve, its crossing is generally much closer to the true root than x_0 was. Repeating this process produces successive approximations that converge rapidly to the root. Figure 14.6 shows the first two steps of this iteration.

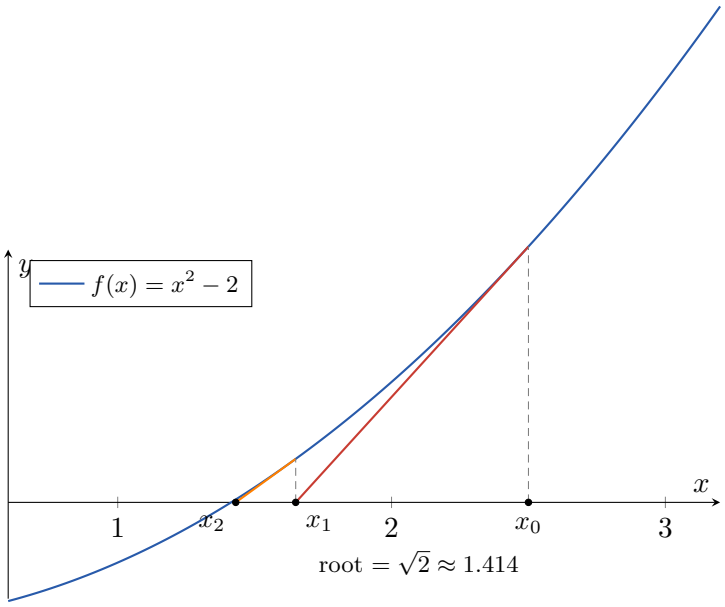


Figure 14.6: Newton's method on $f(x) = x^2 - 2$. From x_0, slide down the tangent (red) to its zero x_1; from x_1, slide down the next tangent (orange) to x_2. Each step lands far closer to the true root $\sqrt{2}$.

Let us derive the step. The tangent line at x_0 is

$$L(x) = f(x_0) + f'(x_0)(x - x_0).$$

Set $L(x_1) = 0$ and solve for x_1:

$$0 = f(x_0) + f'(x_0)(x_1 - x_0) \implies x_1 = x_0 - \frac{f(x_0)}{f'(x_0)}.$$

This single formula drives the iteration.

Focus

Newton's iteration.

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}.$$

In words: from your current guess, step by "minus the value over the slope." The value $f(x_n)$ tells you how far off you are; dividing by the slope $f'(x_n)$ converts that vertical miss into the horizontal correction that a straight line of that slope would need.

Example 14.6 (Computing $\sqrt{2}$ by hand)**.** To find $\sqrt{2}$, solve $f(x) = x^2 - 2 = 0$, with $f'(x) = 2x$. The iteration becomes

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{x_n^2 - 2}{2x_n} = \frac{x_n}{2} + \frac{1}{x_n},$$

the famous "average your guess with 2/guess" rule (known to the Babylonians millennia before Newton). Start at $x_0 = 1.5$:

$$\begin{aligned} x_1 &= \tfrac{1.5}{2} + \tfrac{1}{1.5} = 0.75 + 0.66667 = 1.41667, \\ x_2 &= \tfrac{1.41667}{2} + \tfrac{1}{1.41667} \approx 0.70834 + 0.70588 = 1.41422, \\ x_3 &= 1.414214\ldots \end{aligned}$$

The true value is $\sqrt{2} = 1.4142136\ldots$. After just three steps we are correct to seven digits. Notice the number of correct digits roughly *doubled* each step: 1, then 3, then 6+. That rapid doubling of digits – *quadratic convergence* – is the reward for using the best linear approximation.

Why the technique works

Why does Newton's method converge so rapidly? Because the error it leaves behind is exactly the linear-approximation error of Theorem 14.1, which is of order (current error)^2. Each step uses the tangent line, whose miss is governed by $\frac{1}{2}f''h^2$; so if your current distance to the root is h, your next distance is of size h^2. Square a small number and it becomes tiny: $0.01 \to 0.0001 \to 0.00000001$. The doubling of correct digits per step reflects this $h \mapsto h^2$ scaling. Newton's method is fast for precisely the reason the tangent line is accurate: matching the slope cancels the first-order error, leaving only the squared remainder.

Common trap

Newton's method is powerful but not foolproof. If $f'(x_n) = 0$ the step divides by zero – the tangent is horizontal and never reaches the axis. A bad starting guess can send the iterates flying away from the root, or trap them in a loop. And if the root is one where f' also vanishes (a double root), the fast doubling slows to a crawl. We treat all of this carefully in Chapter 19; here the point is only the *idea* – root-finding is linear approximation run backwards, solving the line instead of the curve.

Intuition

From algebra to geometry: Newton and Raphson. Newton described an early version of this method around 1669 for polynomial equations, manipulating terms algebraically without explicitly picturing tangent slopes. In 1690, Joseph Raphson streamlined the algebra into the iterative algorithm we use today, which is why it is often called the *Newton–Raphson method*. The modern formulation $x_{n+1} = x_n - f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$, framed directly in terms of the derivative and sliding down the tangent line, emerged once differential calculus matured: the same tangent line that estimates a curve's height also drives iterative root-finding across scientific computing.

14.7 The Seed of All of Calculus

Look at what one idea – *locally, smooth is linear* – has already done in this single chapter.

- It *defined* the derivative geometrically: $f'(a)$ is the slope of the line the curve becomes under magnification.
- It gave us *linearization*: replace f by $f(a) + f'(a)(x - a)$ to compute hard values with easy arithmetic.
- It pinned down *differentials*: $\mathrm{d}y = f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the tangent line's rise, and $\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}x$ is a true ratio.
- It powered *error propagation*: the same $\mathrm{d}y = f'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, read as "output wobble equals slope times input wobble."

- It produced *Newton's method*: solve the tangent line instead of the curve, and iterate.

And this is only the beginning of the book. The *integral* is the same idea inverted: chop a curved region into slivers so thin that each is a straight-sided rectangle (smooth = linear on a sliver), then add the slivers up. The *Fundamental Theorem* ties the slope picture to the area picture. A *differential equation* is a recipe that gives you the local slope $\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}x$ at every point and asks you to reassemble the global curve – which you do by stepping along tangent lines (that is literally Euler's method). Taylor series push linear approximation to its limit, matching infinitely many derivatives.

Why this matters

One idea runs underneath all of it: **up close, a smooth function behaves like a straight line.** Differentiation is the act of *finding* that local line; integration is the act of *adding up* local linear pieces into a global total. Almost every tool in calculus – the chain rule, substitution, Euler's method, Taylor series – is another way of turning a curved problem into a locally straight one.

14.7.1 The Power, the Boundaries, and the Bridge to Chapter 15

Connection

Every straight-line model carries an inescapable blind spot: it has zero curvature. A tangent line assumes that the slope at the anchor point a persists unchanged forever. The moment you step away from a, the curvature of the real curve pulls it away from the line, opening a quadratic error gap:

$$E(x) = f(x) - L(x) = \frac{f''(c)}{2}(x-a)^2.$$

If a curve bends sharply (large $|f''|$) or if the step $h = x - a$ is large, the straight line quickly becomes inaccurate. A tangent line cannot turn corners, cannot track waves, and cannot anticipate asymptotes.

Why we need the Mean Value Theorem next. Notice how heavily we leaned on Theorem 14.1 to put guaranteed error bars on our estimates and to explain the quadratic convergence of Newton's method. But pause and ask: *why are we guaranteed that such an intermediate point c exists at all?* How can we be certain that a smooth curve cannot somehow wiggle wildly away from its tangent line between a and x without its second derivative registering that movement?

To turn linear error bounds from an intuitive rule of thumb into rigorous truth, we need a link connecting the local, instantaneous values of a derivative across an interval to the global change of the function over that interval. That link is the **Mean Value Theorem**, the central theorem of calculus that we explore in Chapter 15. Every rigorous error guarantee we used in this chapter is, in truth, a direct consequence of that one foundational theorem.

Looking ahead: allowing approximations to bend. Once the Mean Value Theorem places our error bounds on firm ground, we will eventually generalize the tangent line. In Chapters 30 and 31 (*Power Series and Taylor's Theorem*), we will allow our approximations to bend by matching the second derivative (curvature), third derivative, and beyond:

$$P_n(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x-a) + \frac{f''(a)}{2!}(x-a)^2 + \cdots + \frac{f^{(n)}(a)}{n!}(x-a)^n.$$

By incorporating higher powers of $(x-a)$, Taylor polynomials cling to curves across broad intervals. Linear approximation is the first, essential step on that journey: it is Taylor's theorem stopped at degree one.

14.8 Exercises

Exercise 14.1 (Mental check: linearization at a glance)**.** Without picking up a pen or using paper, consider $f(x) = x^4$ anchored at $a = 1$.

1. What are the value $f(1)$ and the derivative $f'(1)$? Write the linearization $L(x)$ purely in your head.
2. Mentally estimate $(1.002)^4$.
3. Because $f''(x) = 12x^2 > 0$ for all x, does your mental estimate sit slightly above or slightly below the exact value?

Exercise 14.2 (Mental check: relative error scaling)**.** Answer each of the following using only the rule that the exponent is the error-amplification factor:

1. If you measure the side x of a square with a 1.5% uncertainty, what is the resulting percentage uncertainty in the computed area $A = x^2$?
2. If you measure the volume V of a sphere and calculate its radius $r \propto V^{1/3}$, does the percentage error in r grow or shrink compared to the error in V? By what factor?

Exercise 14.3 (Warm-up linearizations)**.** For each function, find the linearization $L(x)$ at the given anchor a, and use it to estimate the requested value. Compare with a calculator.

1. $f(x) = \sqrt[3]{x}$ at $a = 27$; estimate $\sqrt[3]{27.5}$.
2. $f(x) = \sin x$ at $a = 0$; estimate $\sin(0.1)$ (radians).
3. $f(x) = \ln x$ at $a = 1$; estimate $\ln(1.05)$.
4. $f(x) = (1+x)^{10}$ at $a = 0$; estimate $(1.02)^{10}$.

Exercise 14.4 (Differentials directly)**.** A cube has side length measured as $s = 5.00\,\text{cm}$ with possible error $\mathrm{d}s = \pm 0.02\,\text{cm}$. Use the differential of $V = s^3$ to estimate the largest possible error in the computed volume, and the corresponding *relative* error $\mathrm{d}V/V$. State the relative error as a percentage and confirm it equals $3\,(\mathrm{d}s/s)$.

Exercise 14.5 (Sign of the error)**.** Without computing the true value, decide whether the linear approximation of $f(x) = e^x$ at $a = 0$ *over-* or *under*-estimates $e^{0.2}$, and justify your answer using the sign of f''. Then check numerically.

Exercise 14.6 (A guaranteed error bar)**.** Let $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ and anchor at $a = 9$. Use the linearization to estimate $\sqrt{9.3}$, then use the bound $|E| \le \frac{M}{2}h^2$ (with M an upper bound for $|f''|$ on $[9, 9.3]$) to produce a guaranteed interval that contains the true value of $\sqrt{9.3}$. Verify the true value lies inside.

Exercise 14.7 (Relative error in a power law)**.** The kinetic energy of a moving mass is $E = \frac{1}{2}mv^2$. If the speed v is known to within 1.5% and the mass m to within 0.4%, bound the relative error in E. (Hint: take logarithms first, then differentiate.)

Exercise 14.8 (Newton by hand)**.** Apply Newton's method to $f(x) = x^3 - 7$ to estimate $\sqrt[3]{7}$.

1. Write the iteration $x_{n+1} = x_n - f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$ explicitly for this f.
2. Starting from $x_0 = 2$, compute x_1 and x_2 to five decimal places.
3. How many correct digits did each step gain? Relate this to the $h \mapsto h^2$ error law.

Exercise 14.9 (When Newton stumbles)**.** Consider $f(x) = x^3 - 2x + 2$ with starting guess $x_0 = 0$.

1. Compute x_1 and x_2.
2. Show that the iteration falls into a 2-cycle ($0 \to 1 \to 0 \to \cdots$) and never approaches the real root near $x \approx -1.77$. Explain geometrically, in terms of where the tangent lines point, why the method fails to converge here.

Exercise 14.10 (Conceptual: what is dy?)**.** A student writes: "dy is the change in y when x changes by dx." Correct this sentence so that it is precise. In your corrected version, explain the difference between dy and Δy, draw the small picture that distinguishes them, and identify which one the derivative $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is a ratio of.

Exercise 14.11 (Prove the first-order property)**.** Let f be differentiable at a and let $L(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x - a)$ be its linearization. Prove directly from the definition of the derivative that

$$\lim_{x \to a} \frac{f(x) - L(x)}{x - a} = 0,$$

and explain why no line of a *different* slope can satisfy this. (This is the precise statement that the tangent line is the unique best linear approximation.)

Exercise 14.12 (Proof: error formula on a polynomial)**.** Let $f(x) = x^3$ and anchor at $a = 1$.

1. Write the exact error $E(x) = f(x) - L(x)$ as a polynomial in $h = x - 1$ by expanding $(1 + h)^3$.
2. Show directly that $E(x) = \frac{f''(c)}{2}(x - 1)^2$ holds, and solve for the point c as a function of h. Confirm that c lies between 1 and x, as Theorem 14.1 promises.

Exercise 14.13 (Linearization of a product)**.** Suppose u and v are differentiable at a, with values $u(a), v(a)$ and derivatives $u'(a), v'(a)$. Using $\mathrm{d}(uv) = u\,\mathrm{d}v + v\,\mathrm{d}u$, show that the relative error of a product is the sum of the relative errors:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}(uv)}{uv} = \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u} + \frac{\mathrm{d}v}{v}.$$

Interpret this as the differential of the identity $\ln(uv) = \ln u + \ln v$, and state the analogous rule for a quotient u/v.

Chapter 15

The Mean Value Theorem and What It Means

In the last chapter, the tangent line gave us a local linear approximation $f(x) \approx f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)$ near a single point. But what happens across an entire interval? If a derivative stays positive between two points, does that guarantee the curve keeps climbing? If two functions share the same derivative everywhere, must their values stay locked at a fixed vertical separation?

To answer questions that span an interval, we need a bridge from the derivative back to the original function: the *Mean Value Theorem* (MVT). Here "mean" carries its classical mathematical meaning: *average*. The theorem guarantees that somewhere on any smooth journey, your instantaneous rate of change matches your average rate of change over the entire trip.

15.1 The Picture Behind the Theorem

Take a smooth curve and draw the straight line connecting its two endpoints. That straight line cutting across the two endpoints is the *secant* line (from the Latin *secare*, "to cut"). Its slope measures the overall average rate of change across the entire interval:

$$\text{average slope} = \frac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}.$$

Now imagine sliding a straightedge parallel to that secant until it just touches the curve. At that contact point, the instantaneous slope of the tangent line matches the average slope of the secant line.

Intuition

The Mean Value Theorem says that somewhere along a smooth arc, the instantaneous rate of change equals the average rate of change. If you drove 120 miles in 2 hours, your average speed was 60 mph. At some instant during the journey, your speedometer must have pointed to exactly 60 mph. You could speed up to 75, you could slow down to 45, but you cannot transition between speeds without crossing the average. That everyday physical observation is the geometric core of the theorem.

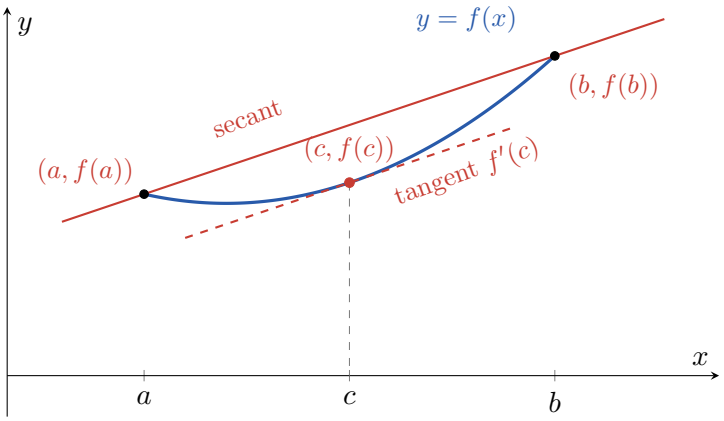


Figure 15.1: The Mean Value Theorem. The red secant line connects the endpoints $(a, f(a))$ and $(b, f(b))$ with average slope $\frac{f(b)-f(a)}{b-a}$. Somewhere in between, at an interior point $x = c$, the dashed tangent line is parallel to the secant: the instantaneous rate $f'(c)$ equals the average rate.

Notice what the picture quietly assumes. The curve has to be unbroken — if it jumped, the ruler could miss it entirely. And it has to be smooth, with a well-defined tangent everywhere inside, or there could be a sharp corner where the slope you want is never achieved. Hold onto those two requirements; they will become the hypotheses of the theorem, and we will see exactly why each one is needed.

15.2 Rolle's theorem: the flat special case

The cleanest way into the MVT is to prove the level special case first, and then *tilt* the whole picture to get the general statement. The special case is the one where the two endpoints sit at the same height.

Intuition

If a smooth curve starts and ends at the same height, then somewhere in between it has a horizontal tangent. Throw a ball; it leaves your hand and returns to the same height; at the top of its arc, for one instant, it is moving neither up nor down. That instant is Rolle's theorem.

Theorem 15.1 (Rolle, 1691)**.** *Let f be continuous on the closed interval $[a, b]$ and differentiable on the open interval (a, b), and suppose $f(a) = f(b)$. Then there exists at least one point $c \in (a, b)$ with*

$$f'(c) = 0.$$

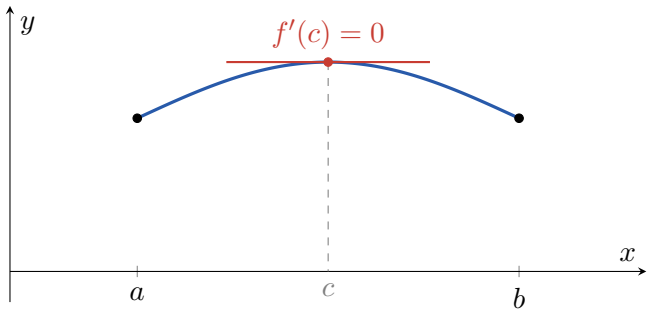


Figure 15.2: Rolle's theorem: equal endpoint heights force a horizontal tangent somewhere inside.

15.2.1 Why it has to be true

Here is the idea before the proof. A continuous function on a closed interval cannot shoot off to infinity or approach an unattainable ceiling without reaching it; there are no missing points in the real number line for the highest or lowest value to hide in. (This is the *Extreme Value Theorem*, which guarantees that every continuous function on a closed interval $[a, b]$ attains an absolute maximum and an absolute minimum.)

Now, in Rolle's theorem, the two endpoints are tied together at the exact same height: $f(a) = f(b)$. If the function climbs above that height anywhere, it must hit a highest peak strictly inside the interval before returning to the baseline. If it dips below, it must hit a lowest trough inside. And if it does neither, the function is completely flat, in which case every interior point has slope zero.

At an interior peak or trough, a smooth function must have derivative zero. Why? Because at a peak the curve has stopped rising and has not yet begun to fall. Its slope can be neither positive nor negative. The only number that is neither positive nor negative is zero.

Why the technique works

The hidden engine of Rolle's theorem is a fundamental observation sometimes called *Fermat's theorem on interior extrema* (where an *extremum* simply means a maximum or minimum): *if f has a local maximum or minimum at an interior point c and $f'(c)$ exists, then $f'(c) = 0$.* Watch the mechanism squeeze the slope to zero. Suppose c is an interior peak (a local maximum). For a small step forward $h > 0$, the value cannot exceed the peak: $f(c + h) \leq f(c)$. The difference quotient is nonpositive:

$$\frac{f(c+h) - f(c)}{h} \leq 0 \implies \lim_{h \to 0^+} \frac{f(c+h) - f(c)}{h} \leq 0.$$

For a small step backward $h < 0$, $f(c + h) \leq f(c)$ still holds, but now we divide by a *negative* denominator h, which flips the direction of the inequality:

$$\frac{f(c+h) - f(c)}{h} \geq 0 \implies \lim_{h \to 0^-} \frac{f(c+h) - f(c)}{h} \geq 0.$$

Because f is differentiable at c, both one-sided limits must agree with the single number $f'(c)$. That number is simultaneously ≤ 0 and ≥ 0. The only number that satisfies both inequalities is 0. The two sides of the peak squeeze the derivative to zero from opposite directions.

Proof of Rolle's theorem. Since f is continuous on the closed, bounded interval $[a, b]$, the Extreme Value Theorem guarantees that f attains an absolute maximum value M and an absolute minimum value m on $[a, b]$.

Case 1: $M = m$. Then the maximum and minimum values coincide, so f is constant on $[a, b]$. Its derivative is zero everywhere: $f'(x) = 0$ for all $x \in (a, b)$, and any interior point serves as c.

Case 2: $M > m$. Because the two endpoints share the same height $f(a) = f(b)$, it is impossible for both the maximum M and the minimum m to occur exclusively at the endpoints. At least one of them must be attained at some interior point $c \in (a, b)$. At that interior point c, f has a local extremum and is differentiable, so by Fermat's interior-extremum fact, $f'(c) = 0$. □

Common trap

Necessity of the hypotheses. Drop any single condition and Rolle's theorem immediately breaks:

- *Continuity on $[a, b]$.* Let $f(x) = x$ on $[0, 1)$ and redefine $f(1) = 0$. Endpoints match ($f(0) = f(1) = 0$), but the derivative is 1 everywhere it exists — no horizontal tangent anywhere. The sudden jump at the boundary let the curve escape without turning around.
- *Differentiability on (a, b).* Let $f(x) = |x|$ on $[-1, 1]$. Endpoints match ($f(-1) = f(1) = 1$), and f is continuous everywhere. But the slope is -1 for $x < 0$ and $+1$ for $x > 0$. The turning point at $x = 0$ is a sharp corner, where the derivative does not exist. The peak is a spike, not a smooth crest.
- *Equal endpoints.* Without $f(a) = f(b)$, a straight ramp $f(x) = x$ has derivative 1 everywhere and never levels off. It is precisely this tilted case that the general Mean Value Theorem handles next.

Pause

Mental check: can a corner cheat Rolle? Consider $f(x) = 1 - x^{2/3}$ on the interval $[-1, 1]$. Check the endpoints: $f(-1) = 1 - (-1)^{2/3} = 0$ and $f(1) = 1 - (1)^{2/3} = 0$. The endpoints match, and the curve climbs to a peak $f(0) = 1$. Does $f'(c) = 0$ anywhere on $(-1, 1)$? Differentiating gives $f'(x) = -\frac{2}{3}x^{-1/3}$. For $x \neq 0$, this is never zero; at $x = 0$, the slope shoots to infinity (a vertical cusp). The function is unbroken, yet never has a horizontal tangent because it lacks differentiability at $x = 0$.

15.3 Tilting Rolle into the Mean Value Theorem

Rolle's theorem handles the level case where the secant line is completely flat. To reach the general Mean Value Theorem, we use a clean algebraic move: we *subtract off the secant line* to turn a tilted problem into a level one.

Intuition

Imagine drawing the general MVT curve on a piece of paper, and then tilting your head until the straight line between the endpoints appears horizontal. In that tilted view, the curve starts and ends at the exact same height — it has become a Rolle problem. Rolle guarantees a horizontal tangent in your tilted frame, which translates to a tangent parallel to the secant in the original frame. Algebraically, tilting the frame means subtracting the secant formula from $f(x)$.

Theorem 15.2 (Mean Value Theorem, Lagrange form)**.** *Let f be continuous on $[a, b]$ and differentiable on (a, b). Then there exists at least one point $c \in (a, b)$ such that*

$$f'(c) = \frac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}.$$

Equivalently, $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)\,(b - a)$ for some c strictly between a and b.

Proof. The secant line through the endpoints $(a, f(a))$ and $(b, f(b))$ is given by the point-slope equation

$$L(x) = f(a) + \frac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}\,(x - a).$$

Because L is a straight line, its derivative is simply its constant slope: $L'(x) = \frac{f(b)-f(a)}{b-a}$ everywhere. Now define the *gap function*

$$g(x) = f(x) - L(x),$$

which measures the vertical signed distance from the curve to its secant line. Notice how neatly g inherits the necessary properties:

- g is continuous on $[a, b]$ and differentiable on (a, b), because it is the difference of the continuous and differentiable functions f and L.
- At the endpoints, the curve meets the secant line: $g(a) = f(a) - L(a) = 0$, and $g(b) = f(b) - L(b) = 0$.

Therefore, g satisfies every condition of Rolle's theorem on $[a, b]$. Rolle guarantees that there is at least one point $c \in (a, b)$ where the gap has a horizontal tangent: $g'(c) = 0$. Differentiating $g(x) = f(x) - L(x)$ gives

$$g'(x) = f'(x) - L'(x) = f'(x) - \frac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}.$$

Setting $g'(c) = 0$ immediately yields

$$f'(c) = \frac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a},$$

completing the proof. □

What is really happening

What is $g(x) = f(x) - L(x)$ really doing? It is the vertical gap between the curve and the straight line joining its endpoints. The proof reveals something fundamental: the place where this gap is widest or narrowest — where $g' = 0$ — is the exact place where the curve is momentarily running *parallel* to the secant. As you move along the curve away from the secant line and return to it at the other end, the gap must reach a maximum or minimum, and at that turning point the curve and the secant are heading in the exact same direction.

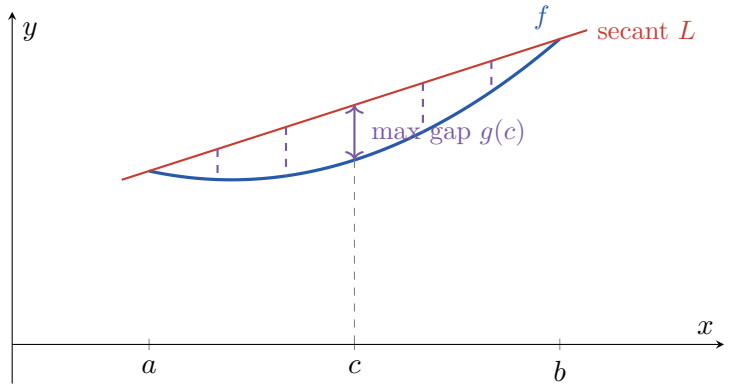


Figure 15.3: The proof in one image: $g(x) = f(x) - L(x)$ is the signed vertical gap between the curve and its secant. It vanishes at both endpoints ($g(a) = g(b) = 0$). By Rolle's theorem, this gap must have a horizontal tangent at some peak or valley $x = c$ ($g'(c) = 0$), which means the curve runs parallel to the secant: $f'(c) = L'(c) = \frac{f(b)-f(a)}{b-a}$.

History

The story of the Mean Value Theorem reflects a century-long struggle to transform calculus from an intuitive art into a rigorous mathematical science.

An early precursor appeared in 12th-century India, where the astronomer-mathematician **Bhāskara II** observed that a planet's instantaneous daily motion must equal its average motion over an interval containing its fastest and slowest points. Five hundred years later, **Michel Rolle** (1652–1719), a conservative French mathematician, published his theorem in 1691 in *Méthode pour résoudre les égalitez*. Rolle was an aggressive critic of the new calculus of Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, denouncing their "infinitesimals"—quantities treated as nonzero when dividing to find a slope, then discarded as zero at the end of a calculation—as logical absurdities. Rolle proved his theorem purely for *polynomials* (expressions with whole-number powers of x): between any two real roots (inputs where a polynomial equals zero), there lies a root of its formal algebraic derivative. He never envisioned his theorem applying to continuous, non-algebraic curves. By historical irony, the critic who sought to dismantle calculus became famous for one of its foundational stones.

In 1797, **Joseph-Louis Lagrange** (1736–1813) recognized that calculus needed an unshakable foundation free of vanishing infinitesimals. In *Théorie des fonctions analytiques*, Lagrange placed the tilted Mean Value Theorem at the very center of differential analysis, calling it the primary tool for connecting derivatives back to functions. Lagrange attempted to define all derivatives using infinite series without limits, a program that was ultimately doomed because

not every smooth function equals its Taylor series.
The modern formulation arrived in 1823 with **Augustin-Louis Cauchy** (1789–1857) at the École Polytechnique in Paris. Cauchy introduced precise limit definitions and recognized that proving Rolle's theorem requires the Extreme Value Theorem, which in turn depends on the *completeness of the real line* (the fact that the real number line has no missing points or gaps). Cauchy also developed a general two-function extension, the Cauchy Mean Value Theorem. Later in the 19th century, **Karl Weierstrass** completed the rigorous framework that made every step of these proofs airtight.
What remains open and active today? In one dimension, the MVT guarantees an exact equality: $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)(b-a)$. But does this exact equality hold for *vector-valued functions* (curves in two or three dimensions, where outputs are arrows or coordinates rather than single numbers)? No. Consider a particle tracing a helical spiral $\mathbf{r}(t) = (\cos t, \sin t, t)$ over $[0, 2\pi]$. The net change is purely vertical: $\mathbf{r}(2\pi) - \mathbf{r}(0) = (0, 0, 2\pi)$. Yet the velocity vector is $\mathbf{r}'(t) = (-\sin t, \cos t, 1)$, which is never parallel to the z-axis for any t. Exact equality fails in higher dimensions: one must settle for the *Mean Value Inequality*, $\|\mathbf{f}(b) - \mathbf{f}(a)\| \leq \sup_{t\in(a,b)} \|\mathbf{f}'(t)\|\,|b-a|$. In modern optimization, nonsmooth analysis, and machine learning, extending mean value theorems to functions with sharp corners (subgradient calculus) and to curved geometric spaces without linear coordinates remains an active frontier of mathematical research.

15.3.1 Reading the theorem carefully

The MVT is an *existence* theorem. It promises that such a point c exists; it does not tell you where, and there may be several. For most purposes this is exactly enough, because we will use it to say "f' at some unknown point equals this average," and then bound or sign that unknown derivative.

Focus

The two faces of the MVT. Keep both forms in mind; you will reach for different ones in different situations.

- *Slope form:* $f'(c) = \dfrac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}$. Read it as "the average rate is hit exactly."
- *Increment form:* $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)(b - a)$. Read it as "the total change equals some interior rate times the elapsed input." This is the primary operational form: it converts a statement about f' into a statement about $f(b) - f(a)$.

Example 15.1. Let $f(x) = x^3$ on $[0, 2]$. The average slope is $\frac{f(2)-f(0)}{2-0} = \frac{8-0}{2} = 4$. The MVT promises a $c \in (0, 2)$ with $f'(c) = 3c^2 = 4$, i.e. $c^2 = \frac{4}{3}$; keeping the positive root inside $(0, 2)$ gives $c = \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} \approx 1.155$, which indeed sits in $(0, 2)$. Notice we *found* c here only because the function is simple; in real applications we almost never solve for c — we just use the fact that some such c exists.

Work it yourself

Take $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ on $[1, 4]$. Compute the average slope $\frac{\sqrt{4}-\sqrt{1}}{4-1} = \frac{2-1}{3} = \frac{1}{3}$. Now set $f'(c) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{c}} = \frac{1}{3}$ and solve: $2\sqrt{c} = 3$, $\sqrt{c} = \frac{3}{2}$, $c = \frac{9}{4} = 2.25$. Check that 2.25 sits in $(1, 4)$. You have just located the exact instant where this curve's slope equals its average climb. Try the same

with $f(x) = 1/x$ on $[1, 2]$ and confirm $c = \sqrt{2}$.

15.4 Consequences of the Mean Value Theorem

Now the payoff. Everything in this section follows from the single increment form $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)(b-a)$. The strategy is always the same: *whatever you know about f' on the interval, you know about that mystery factor $f'(c)$, and the equation passes the knowledge on to $f(b) - f(a)$.* Many intuitively obvious facts are direct consequences of this single theorem.

15.4.1 Zero derivative means constant

You believe that if a function never changes (its rate is always 0) then it stays put. But why, *exactly*? "The derivative is zero" is a statement about slopes; "the function is constant" is a statement about values. The MVT is the only rigorous bridge between them.

Theorem 15.3 (Vanishing derivative)**.** *If f is continuous on $[a, b]$, differentiable on (a, b), and $f'(x) = 0$ for all $x \in (a, b)$, then f is constant on $[a, b]$.*

Proof. Pick any point $x \in (a, b]$. Apply the MVT to f on the subinterval $[a, x]$: there is a c between a and x with

$$f(x) - f(a) = f'(c)\,(x - a).$$

But $f'(c) = 0$ by hypothesis, so $f(x) - f(a) = 0$, i.e. $f(x) = f(a)$. Since $x \in (a, b]$ was arbitrary, $f(x) = f(a)$ for every $x \in [a, b]$. □

Common trap

This is exactly the place where the *interval matters*. On a disconnected domain the conclusion is false. The function

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} 1, & x > 0, \\ -1, & x < 0, \end{cases}$$

has $f'(x) = 0$ everywhere it is defined, yet it is not constant. There is no contradiction: the MVT needs a single interval connecting any two points, and there is no such interval joining a negative x to a positive one inside the domain. The derivative tells you nothing about how f behaves *across a gap*.

Pause

Mental check: why does a gap break the bridge? Suppose $f(x) = 2$ for $x \in (0, 1)$ and $f(x) = 7$ for $x \in (2, 3)$. Differentiating gives $f'(x) = 0$ everywhere the function is defined. Yet $f(2.5) - f(0.5) = 7 - 2 = 5 \neq 0$. Why didn't the Mean Value Theorem force $f(2.5) = f(0.5)$? Because the theorem requires an unbroken interval containing both points. To apply $f(2.5) - f(0.5) = f'(c)(2.5 - 0.5)$, the function must be defined and differentiable at every point between 0.5 and 2.5. The gap on $[1, 2]$ violates that requirement.

15.4.2 Two antiderivatives differ by a constant

This is the fact that makes the "$+C$" in every indefinite integral legitimate. If you have found *one* antiderivative of a function, you have essentially found them all.

Corollary 15.1 (Antiderivatives up to a constant)**.** *If $F'(x) = G'(x)$ for all x in an interval I, then $F(x) = G(x) + C$ on I for some constant C.*

Proof. Let $h = F - G$. Then $h'(x) = F'(x) - G'(x) = 0$ for all $x \in I$. By the previous theorem, h is constant on I: $h(x) = C$. Hence $F(x) = G(x) + C$. □

Why this matters

This corollary is fundamental to integration. It explains why the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus can speak of *the* antiderivative up to an additive constant, why $\int f$ is well posed, and why solving a differential equation $y' = f$ yields a one-parameter family of curves.

15.4.3 The increasing/decreasing test

Here is a central application: determining where functions increase and decrease. We *define* "increasing" by values: f is increasing on I if $x_1 < x_2$ forces $f(x_1) < f(x_2)$. The sign of the derivative is, again, a statement about slopes. The MVT connects the two.

Theorem 15.4 (Monotonicity test)**.** *Let f be continuous on an interval I and differentiable in its interior.*

- *If $f'(x) > 0$ throughout the interior, then f is strictly increasing on I.*
- *If $f'(x) < 0$ throughout, then f is strictly decreasing on I.*
- *If $f'(x) \geq 0$ throughout, then f is nondecreasing; if $f'(x) \leq 0$, nonincreasing.*

Proof. Take any two points $x_1 < x_2$ in I. By the MVT on $[x_1, x_2]$ there is a c between them with

$$f(x_2) - f(x_1) = f'(c)\,(x_2 - x_1).$$

The factor $(x_2 - x_1)$ is positive. So the sign of $f(x_2) - f(x_1)$ is exactly the sign of $f'(c)$. If $f' > 0$ everywhere, then $f'(c) > 0$, so $f(x_2) - f(x_1) > 0$, i.e. $f(x_2) > f(x_1)$: increasing. The other three cases are read off the same equation by changing the sign or allowing equality. □

Why the technique works

Why does the *sign* of the derivative control the *direction* of the function? Because of that single MVT equation. Without it, "$f' > 0$" and "f increasing" are two unrelated sentences — one about tangent lines, one about a table of values. The MVT says the total change $f(x_2) - f(x_1)$ is built out of an actual interior slope times a positive width. You cannot accumulate a net *decrease* out of slopes that are all positive. The local information (slope at points) integrates up into global information (rise across an interval), and the MVT is the gear that meshes the two.

Common trap

A subtle but important converse warning. "Strictly increasing" does *not* require $f' > 0$ at every point. Consider $f(x) = x^3$. It is strictly increasing on all of $\mathbb{R}$, yet $f'(0) = 0$. The theorem's arrow points one way: $f' > 0 \Rightarrow$ increasing, but increasing only gives $f' \geq 0$. A single flat instant is allowed, as long as the function does not actually pause over a whole subinterval. Many students "prove" a function is increasing by checking $f' \geq 0$ and then wrongly assert it must be *strictly* increasing; that needs the extra observation that f' is not zero on any subinterval.

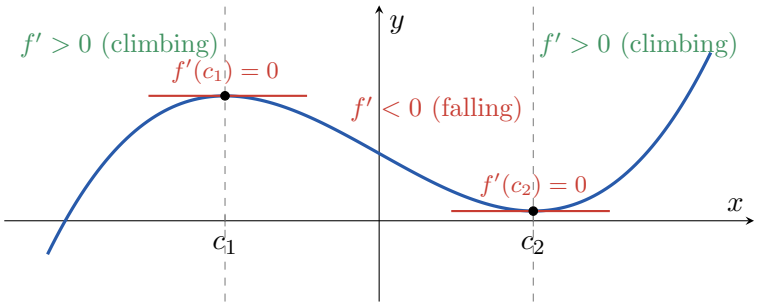


Figure 15.4: The sign of f' controls the shape of f. Where $f' > 0$, the curve climbs; where $f' < 0$, it falls. The turning points c_1 and c_2 where $f' = 0$ mark the crest and the trough. The monotonicity test is simply the Mean Value Theorem applied to any pair of points across each region.

15.4.4 Error bounds: the MVT as a ruler

Perhaps the most practical face of the MVT in applied mathematics is its power to *bound* how much a function can change. If you know a car's speedometer never exceeds 70 mph, you know with absolute certainty that in two hours the car travelled at most 140 miles. That is the MVT expressed as an inequality.

Corollary 15.2 (Change is bounded by the steepest slope)**.** *Suppose f is differentiable on an interval and $|f'(x)| \leq M$ for all x in that interval. Then for any two points a, b in the interval,*

$$|f(b) - f(a)| \leq M\,|b - a|.$$

Proof. By the Mean Value Theorem, there exists some interior point c strictly between a and b such that $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)(b - a)$. Taking absolute values on both sides gives

$$|f(b) - f(a)| = |f'(c)|\,|b - a| \leq M\,|b - a|,$$

because the slope $|f'(c)|$ cannot exceed the bound M anywhere on the interval. □

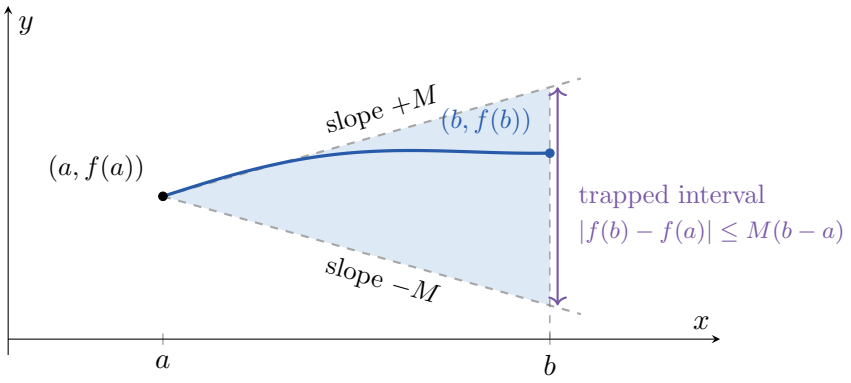


Figure 15.5: The Mean Value Theorem as a geometric cone of possibility. If $|f'(x)| \le M$ everywhere, a curve leaving $(a, f(a))$ cannot rise faster than slope $+M$ or plunge faster than slope $-M$. At any subsequent input $x = b$, the true value $f(b)$ is trapped inside the shaded cone: $|f(b)-f(a)| \le M|b-a|$.

A function whose derivative is bounded by M in this way is called *Lipschitz continuous* with constant M: it cannot change faster than M units of output per unit of input, ever. Geometrically, Figure 15.5 reveals that the curve is trapped within a cone opening from $(a, f(a))$ with slopes $\pm M$. This single inequality is the backbone of error analysis, numerical computation, and the foundational theory that guarantees solutions to differential equations exist and are unique.

Example 15.2 (Bounding a value of sine)**.** How big can $\sin(0.1)$ be, without a calculator? Apply the bound to $f(x) = \sin x$ on the interval $[0, 0.1]$. We have $f'(x) = \cos x$, and $|\cos x| \le 1$ everywhere on the real line, so we can take $M = 1$. Then

$$|\sin(0.1) - \sin(0)| \le 1 \cdot |0.1 - 0| = 0.1.$$

Because $\sin(0) = 0$, this gives $|\sin(0.1)| \le 0.1$. In fact, applying the exact same reasoning on $[0, x]$ proves the inequality $|\sin x| \le |x|$ for all real x in a single stroke, purely from the fact that $|\cos c| \le 1$.

Example 15.3 (A sharper estimate near a known value)**.** Estimate $\sqrt{4.1}$ and place rigorous upper and lower bounds on the error. With $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ on the interval $[4, 4.1]$, the Mean Value Theorem gives

$$\sqrt{4.1} - \sqrt{4} = f'(c)\,(0.1) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{c}}\,(0.1) \quad \text{for some } c \in (4, 4.1).$$

Because c lies strictly between 4 and 4.1, the derivative $\frac{1}{2\sqrt{c}}$ is strictly decreasing with respect to c, so it is squeezed between its endpoint values:

$$\frac{1}{2\sqrt{4.1}} < \frac{1}{2\sqrt{c}} < \frac{1}{2\sqrt{4}} = 0.25.$$

The right-hand inequality immediately gives the upper bound $\sqrt{4.1} < 2 + 0.1(0.25) = 2.025$. Better still, we can get the lower bound *without* knowing $\sqrt{4.1}$ in advance by feeding $\sqrt{4.1} < 2.025$ back into the left-hand denominator:

$$\frac{1}{2\sqrt{c}} > \frac{1}{2\sqrt{4.1}} > \frac{1}{2(2.025)} = \frac{1}{4.05} > 0.2469,$$

since $4.05 \times 0.2469 = 0.999945 < 1$. Multiplying by 0.1 and adding 2 proves $2.02469 < \sqrt{4.1} < 2.025$ purely by hand, trapping the true value inside an interval of width 0.00031.

Application

Where slope bounds govern practice. In numerical analysis, every guarantee of the form "this approximation is accurate to within tolerance ϵ" is ultimately an MVT estimate: the error is expressed as a derivative evaluated at an unknown intermediate point, bounded by the worst-case magnitude of that derivative across the interval.
In machine learning and neural network training, a loss function whose gradient has a derivative bounded by M (an M-Lipschitz gradient) guarantees that gradient descent with a step size smaller than $2/M$ cannot overshoot or diverge — precisely Corollary 15.2 ensuring that a single gradient update cannot produce an uncontrolled jump.
In physics and engineering control, if an actuator has a maximum torque or acceleration M, the change in velocity over a time window Δt is strictly bounded by $M\,\Delta t$. The Mean Value Theorem converts an upper bound on rate into a rigorous bound on displacement.

15.4.5 Proving inequalities without a single graph

The MVT turns many inequalities that look obvious from a graph into short proofs. The recipe: build a function that is the difference of the two sides, show its derivative has a fixed sign, and let monotonicity finish the job.

Example 15.4 ($e^x \geq 1 + x$ for all x)**.** Let $g(x) = e^x - (1 + x)$. Then $g(0) = 0$ and $g'(x) = e^x - 1$. Now $g'(x) > 0$ for $x > 0$ and $g'(x) < 0$ for $x < 0$. By the monotonicity test, g decreases up to 0 and increases after it, so $x = 0$ is a global minimum of g, with value $g(0) = 0$. Hence $g(x) \geq 0$ everywhere, i.e. $e^x \geq 1 + x$. The tangent line $1 + x$ lies below the exponential (Figure 15.6), proved purely from the sign of a derivative.

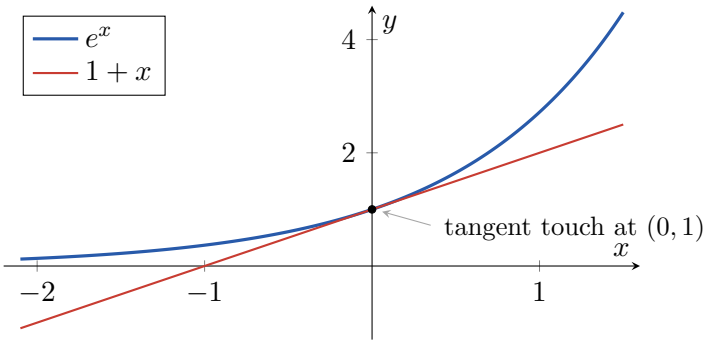


Figure 15.6: The tangent line $y = 1 + x$ at $x = 0$ lies entirely below $y = e^x$, touching only at $(0, 1)$. The single fact $g'(x) = e^x - 1$ changes sign exactly at 0 forces this: $g = e^x - (1 + x)$ falls to its minimum at 0 and climbs away on both sides.

Example 15.5 ($\ln(1 + x) < x$ for $x > 0$)**.** Let $g(x) = x - \ln(1 + x)$ on $[0, \infty)$. Then $g(0) = 0$ and $g'(x) = 1 - \frac{1}{1+x} = \frac{x}{1+x} > 0$ for $x > 0$. So g is strictly increasing on $[0, \infty)$, giving $g(x) > g(0) = 0$, that is $\ln(1 + x) < x$. Same recipe, opposite function.

Walking question

Here is a question to chew on next time you are out walking. The monotonicity test turned "slope is positive" into "function is increasing" using the MVT. But the MVT itself rested on Rolle, which rested on the Extreme Value Theorem, which rested on the *completeness* of the real numbers — the fact that there are no gaps in the number line. When you say "a positive derivative makes a function climb," you are, four layers down, relying on the completeness of $\mathbb{R}$. Ask yourself why these theorems fail if you work only on the rational numbers $\mathbb{Q}$. (Hint: on $\mathbb{Q}$, a continuous function on a closed interval can climb toward a peak located at an irrational input like $\sqrt{2}$ and never actually attain a maximum.)

15.5 The Cauchy Mean Value Theorem

There is a powerful generalization that you will need the moment you reach l'Hôpital's rule, so we prove it here while the machinery is fresh. It compares the changes in *two* functions over the same interval.

Theorem 15.5 (Cauchy's Mean Value Theorem)**.** *Let f and g be continuous on $[a,b]$ and differentiable on (a,b). Then there is a point $c \in (a,b)$ with*

$$\big(f(b)-f(a)\big)\,g'(c) = \big(g(b)-g(a)\big)\,f'(c).$$

If g' is never zero on (a,b) (so $g(b) \neq g(a)$), this rearranges to

$$\frac{f(b)-f(a)}{g(b)-g(a)} = \frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}.$$

Intuition

Think of $\big(g(t), f(t)\big)$ as a point tracing a curve in the plane as t runs from a to b. The ordinary MVT compared a slope to an average slope along the x-axis. Cauchy's version compares the *direction the curve is heading*, $f'(c)/g'(c)$, to the *straight-line direction* from start to end, $\frac{f(b)-f(a)}{g(b)-g(a)}$. It is the MVT for a parametrized path: somewhere the path points the same way as the chord joining its endpoints.

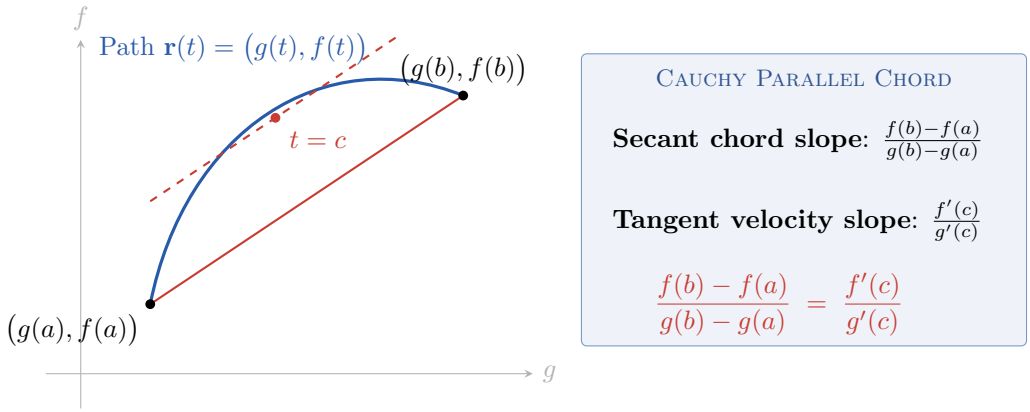


Figure 15.7: Cauchy's Mean Value Theorem viewed in the plane of the two functions (g, f). The point $\mathbf{r}(t) = (g(t), f(t))$ traces a curve from $(g(a), f(a))$ to $(g(b), f(b))$. The secant chord connecting the endpoints has slope $\frac{f(b)-f(a)}{g(b)-g(a)}$. At some interior parameter value $t = c$, the instantaneous velocity vector $(g'(c), f'(c))$ points in the exact same direction, matching the chord's slope: $\frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)} = \frac{f(b)-f(a)}{g(b)-g(a)}$.

Proof. We use the same subtract-a-helper trick that turned Rolle into the MVT, only now the helper is chosen to kill both endpoints at once. Define

$$h(x) = \big(f(b) - f(a)\big)\, g(x) - \big(g(b) - g(a)\big)\, f(x).$$

This h is continuous on $[a, b]$ and differentiable on (a, b). Compute the endpoint values:

$$h(a) = \big(f(b) - f(a)\big)g(a) - \big(g(b) - g(a)\big)f(a) = f(b)g(a) - g(b)f(a),$$
$$h(b) = \big(f(b) - f(a)\big)g(b) - \big(g(b) - g(a)\big)f(b) = f(b)g(a) - g(b)f(a).$$

The cross terms cancel and $h(a) = h(b)$. So Rolle applies: there is $c \in (a, b)$ with $h'(c) = 0$. But

$$h'(x) = \big(f(b) - f(a)\big)g'(x) - \big(g(b) - g(a)\big)f'(x),$$

and $h'(c) = 0$ is precisely the claimed identity. □

Connection

Notice the ordinary MVT is the special case $g(x) = x$: then $g'(c) = 1$ and $g(b) - g(a) = b - a$, and Cauchy's identity collapses to $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)(b - a)$. So Cauchy's theorem genuinely contains the Lagrange MVT, and both descend from Rolle. Three theorems, one idea — "a difference that vanishes at both ends has a flat spot inside" — applied to three cleverly chosen helper functions. When you reach l'Hôpital's rule a couple of chapters from now, that quotient $\frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}$ will be exactly what lets a ratio of functions be replaced by a ratio of their derivatives.

15.6 A glance ahead: the MVT seeds Taylor's theorem

The increment form $f(b) - f(a) = f'(c)(b - a)$ can be read as a *first-order* exact remainder: the change in f is captured exactly by one derivative at one mystery point. Taylor's theorem, which you

will meet in full later, is the same idea pushed to higher order. It says

$$f(b) = f(a) + f'(a)(b-a) + \tfrac{1}{2}f''(c)(b-a)^2$$

for some interior c — a "second-order MVT" whose proof is, once again, build a helper that vanishes at both ends and apply Rolle. The whole tower of polynomial approximation, and every error bound that comes with it, grows from the seed you planted in this chapter.

Why this matters

The simple geometric fact that an average slope across an interval is attained at some interior point yields far-reaching consequences: the $+C$ in antidifferentiation, the monotonicity test relating derivative signs to graphs, the constant function theorem, rigorous error bounds, proofs of inequalities, Cauchy's extension behind l'Hôpital's rule, and the remainder terms in Taylor's theorem. Every time we turn local information about a derivative into a global fact about a function, the Mean Value Theorem is doing the work.

15.6.1 The Scope and Horizons of the Mean Value Theorem

Connection

The Mean Value Theorem guarantees existence without supplying a formula for the location. It proves that your car hit 60 mph at some moment, even though it gives no mechanical formula for the exact mile-marker where that occurred. For simple quadratics we can solve for c directly, whereas for most functions finding c means solving a transcendental equation with no algebraic closed form.

Yet that lack of a specific address is precisely what makes the theorem so powerful. We do not need the exact coordinate of c; we only need to know that c belongs to the interval. If every possible slope in the interval is positive, then $f'(c)$ must be positive, which forces $f(b) > f(a)$. If every possible slope is bounded by M, then $f'(c)$ cannot exceed M, trapping the entire trajectory within our geometric cone. By relinquishing the need to pinpoint c, the Mean Value Theorem transforms local rate bounds into global guarantees that hold across an entire span.

This local-to-global connection underlies the chapters that follow:

- In the next chapter, *Maxima, Minima, and the Shape of a Graph*, the monotonicity and concavity tests become our primary architectural tools. By reading the signs of f' and f'', we will locate peaks, valleys, and inflection points, turning calculus into complete geometric portraits of curves.
- Later, in Chapter 18 (*Indeterminate Forms and L'Hôpital's Rule*), we will harness Cauchy's generalized Mean Value Theorem to resolve indeterminate limits of the form $0/0$ and ∞/∞ by comparing the simultaneous growth rates of two functions.

15.7 Exercises

Exercise 15.1 (Mental warm-up: quick checks)**.** Answer each question in a few words or a single sentence:

(a) If a driver starts from rest (0 mph) and finishes at rest (0 mph) after a 10-mile trip, does Rolle's theorem guarantee an instant during the trip where their acceleration was zero? Explain.

(b) If $f'(x) > 0$ for all $x \in (0, 4)$, could $f(1)$ ever equal $f(3)$?

(c) If $f'(x) = 0$ on the disconnected domain $(0, 1) \cup (2, 3)$, must $f(0.5)$ equal $f(2.5)$?

(d) Can you apply the Mean Value Theorem to $f(x) = 1/x$ on $[-1, 2]$? Which hypothesis fails?

Exercise 15.2 (Finding c)**.** For each function and interval, verify the MVT hypotheses and find every c the theorem promises. (a) $f(x) = x^2 - 3x$ on $[1, 4]$. (b) $f(x) = x + \frac{1}{x}$ on $[1, 3]$. (c) $f(x) = \sin x$ on $[0, \pi]$.

Exercise 15.3 (Rolle by hand)**.** Let $f(x) = x^3 - 3x$. Find two values $a < b$ with $f(a) = f(b)$, then locate the interior point(s) where $f' = 0$ guaranteed by Rolle's theorem. Sketch the graph and mark the horizontal tangents.

Exercise 15.4 (Why a hypothesis is needed)**.** Give an explicit function on $[-1, 1]$ that is continuous, has $f(-1) = f(1)$, but has *no* point where $f' = 0$. Explain precisely which hypothesis of Rolle's theorem your example violates, and where.

Exercise 15.5 (A speed argument)**.** A car travels 90 miles in exactly 90 minutes. Use the MVT to prove that at some instant its instantaneous speed was exactly 60 mph. Then prove the weaker claim that at some instant its speed was *at least* 60 mph, using only the average, without the MVT. Which statement is stronger, and why does the MVT earn the stronger one?

Exercise 15.6 (Bounding with the derivative)**.** Suppose f is differentiable on $\mathbb{R}$ with $f(1) = 5$ and $|f'(x)| \le 2$ for all x. Find the smallest interval that must contain $f(4)$. (Use Corollary 15.2.)

Exercise 15.7 (Inequalities from monotonicity)**.** Prove each inequality by forming a difference g, signing g', and using the monotonicity test. (a) $\tan x > x$ for $0 < x < \frac{\pi}{2}$. (b) $\cos x > 1 - \frac{x^2}{2}$ for $x \neq 0$ *(hint: first show* $\sin x < x$ *for* $x > 0$ *by the same method, then use evenness for* $x < 0$*).* (c) $\frac{x}{1+x} < \ln(1 + x)$ for $x > 0$.

Exercise 15.8 (Uniqueness of a solution)**.** Show that the equation $x^5 + x - 1 = 0$ has exactly one real solution. (Existence: use the Intermediate Value Theorem on $[0, 1]$. Uniqueness: if there were two solutions, Rolle's theorem would force $f' = 0$ somewhere between them — show that is impossible.)

Exercise 15.9 (Constant on an interval)**.** Suppose f is differentiable on $\mathbb{R}$ with $f'(x) = 3$ for all x. Prove, using the MVT and not antidifferentiation rules, that $f(x) = 3x + f(0)$ for every x.

Exercise 15.10 (A fixed-point bound)**.** Let g be differentiable on $\mathbb{R}$ with $|g'(x)| \le \frac{1}{2}$ for all x. Show that for any two numbers p, q, $|g(p) - g(q)| \le \frac{1}{2}|p - q|$. (Such a g is a *contraction*; this inequality is the heart of why iterating g converges to a single fixed point.)

Exercise 15.11 (Proof: a derivative that is always positive)**.** Prove carefully, citing the MVT, that if $f'(x) > 0$ for all x in an open interval I, then f is one-to-one on I. Where exactly do you use that the interval is connected?

Exercise 15.12 (Cauchy MVT in action)**.** Let $f(x) = x^2$ and $g(x) = x^3$ on $[1, 2]$. Find the point c guaranteed by Cauchy's Mean Value Theorem, i.e. solve $\frac{f(2)-f(1)}{g(2)-g(1)} = \frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}$ for $c \in (1, 2)$. Confirm your c lies in the interval.

Exercise 15.13 (Conceptual: the role of the EVT)**.** Explain in a short paragraph why Rolle's theorem genuinely needs the Extreme Value Theorem, and why the Extreme Value Theorem in turn needs the completeness of $\mathbb{R}$. Give an example of a continuous function on the rationals in $[0, 2]$ (with the usual formula) that does *not* attain a maximum, illustrating what breaks without completeness.

Part IV

Using the Derivative

Chapter 16

Maxima, Minima, and the Shape of a Graph

Here is a question so ordinary you may never have thought to ask it carefully: how do you *know* what a graph looks like? You have surely sketched curves before — plotted a few points, connected the dots, trusted that the picture between the dots behaved itself. But that is guessing. A function can do surprising things between two sample points. It can dive down and back up. It can have a sharp bend you would never see at the resolution of your dots. To draw a graph *correctly* — to know where it rises, where it falls, where it turns around, where it bulges up and where it sags down — you need more than a handful of values. You need the derivative, and you need the derivative of the derivative.

Two derivatives are enough to pin the picture down. The first derivative f' tells you the *direction* the curve is heading — uphill or downhill. The second derivative f'' tells you how that direction is *changing* — whether the curve bends upward or downward. Put the two together and you can determine the overall shape of a graph, and find its highest and lowest points. Those highest and lowest points are the payoff. They are what optimization is made of: the cheapest design, the strongest beam, the fastest route, the maximum profit, the least error. All of it begins here, with the simple observation that *at the top of a hill, the ground is momentarily level.*

Everything in this chapter rests on the Mean Value Theorem from the previous chapter. The MVT was the bridge from f' back to f. Now we cross that bridge over and over. When we claim "$f' > 0$ means f is increasing," that is the MVT talking. When we claim a sign change in f' means a genuine peak, that is the MVT again. We will keep pointing back to it, because the real reason these tests *work* — and are not just plausible folklore — is that one theorem.

16.1 The top of the hill is level

Stand at the very top of a smooth hill. Look at the ground right at your feet. It is flat. Not flat far away — the hill falls off on both sides — but flat *right there*, at the summit. Geometry forces this. If the ground at the summit were tilted even slightly uphill in some direction, then you could walk that way and go higher — so you were not at the summit after all. The only way to be at the very top is for every direction to be level or downhill, and for a smooth curve in one variable that means the tangent line is horizontal.

Intuition

At a peak or a valley of a smooth graph, the tangent line is horizontal: the slope is zero. The reason is almost a tautology once you see it. To the left of a peak the function is climbing ($f' > 0$); to the right it is falling ($f' < 0$). A continuous slope cannot jump from positive to negative without passing through zero. So right at the top, $f' = 0$. The summit is where "going up" turns into "going down," and the turning point is level.

Let us make the words precise, because "highest point" hides a real subtlety: highest compared to *what*? Compared to the entire domain, or just compared to nearby points?

Definition 16.1 (Local and global extrema)**.** Let f be defined on a set D and let $c \in D$.

- f has a *local maximum* at c if $f(c) \geq f(x)$ for all x in some open interval around c (a local minimum if $f(c) \leq f(x)$ nearby).
- f has a *global* (or *absolute*) *maximum* at c if $f(c) \geq f(x)$ for *all* $x \in D$ (global minimum if $f(c) \leq f(x)$ for all $x \in D$).

A *local extremum* (plural: *extrema*, from the Latin for outermost) is either a local max or a local min.

A local maximum is a peak relative to its immediate surroundings — the top of *a* hill, even if a taller mountain stands a mile away. A global maximum is the highest point across the entire domain of the function. Every interior global extremum is automatically a local one (being highest overall makes you highest locally), but not the reverse.

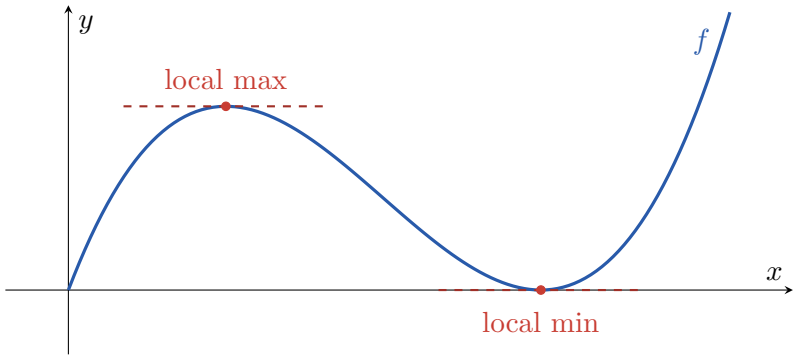


Figure 16.1: At a local maximum and a local minimum of a smooth curve, the tangent line (dashed) is horizontal. The peak is where climbing turns into falling.

16.1.1 Fermat's theorem: where to look

The flatness-at-the-summit idea has a name and a proof. It is one of the oldest results in the subject, found by Pierre de Fermat decades before Newton and Leibniz had a systematic calculus.

Theorem 16.1 (Fermat's theorem on extrema)**.** *If f has a local extremum at c, and f is differentiable at c, then $f'(c) = 0$.*

Intuition

The summit argument translates directly into algebra, exposing why differentiability is the essential hypothesis. The derivative is a single number, the limit of the difference quotients $\dfrac{f(c+h)-f(c)}{h}$ as $h \to 0$. Approaching from the right and from the left, both one-sided limits must converge to that same value. At a local maximum, the numerator $f(c+h)-f(c)$ is ≤ 0 for all sufficiently small h (no nearby point is higher). When $h > 0$, the quotient is nonpositive divided by positive, so ≤ 0. When $h < 0$, the quotient is nonpositive divided by negative, so ≥ 0. The right-hand limit forces $f'(c) \leq 0$, while the left-hand limit forces $f'(c) \geq 0$. The only real number that is simultaneously ≤ 0 and ≥ 0 is 0.

Proof. Suppose f has a local maximum at c (the minimum case is identical with inequalities flipped). Then there is an interval around c on which $f(x) \leq f(c)$, i.e. $f(c+h)-f(c) \leq 0$ for all small h.

For $h > 0$,

$$\frac{f(c+h)-f(c)}{h} \leq 0 \qquad \text{(nonpositive over positive)},$$

so the right-hand limit satisfies $f'(c) = \lim_{h\to 0^+} \dfrac{f(c+h)-f(c)}{h} \leq 0$.

For $h < 0$,

$$\frac{f(c+h)-f(c)}{h} \geq 0 \qquad \text{(nonpositive over negative)},$$

so the left-hand limit satisfies $f'(c) = \lim_{h\to 0^-} \dfrac{f(c+h)-f(c)}{h} \geq 0$.

Because f is differentiable at c, these two one-sided limits are equal and both equal $f'(c)$. The only way to have $f'(c) \leq 0$ and $f'(c) \geq 0$ at once is $f'(c) = 0$. □

History

The discovery that extrema occur where rates of change vanish predates both Newton and Leibniz. In 1636, Pierre de Fermat circulated a short manuscript, *Methodus ad disquirendam maximam et minimam*, presenting his method of *adequality* (from the Latin for "approximate equality"). Fermat was inspired by an observation of the ancient Greek geometer Pappus of Alexandria on dividing a line segment: at a maximum, a slight nudge in the input produces virtually no change in the output. Fermat replaced x with $x+e$, set $f(x+e)$ "adequal" to $f(x)$, divided through by the perturbation e, and then suppressed all terms still containing e. In modern language, Fermat was evaluating $\lim_{e\to 0} \frac{f(x+e)-f(x)}{e} = 0$, identifying peaks and troughs by finding stationary values forty years before the invention of calculus.

This procedure immediately triggered a fierce controversy. In 1638, René Descartes sharply criticized Fermat's method, demanding to know how Fermat could legitimately treat e as a nonzero quantity to justify dividing by it, and then instantly discard it as zero without creating a logical contradiction. Without a rigorous definition of a limit, Fermat could only plead that the method consistently produced the correct geometric answers.

The second half of the story—the geometry of bending and concavity—belongs to Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz. In his 1684 paper and subsequent memoirs in *Acta Eruditorum*, Leibniz analyzed what he called *puncta flexus contrarii*: inflection points where a curve transitions between bending upward and bending downward. Leibniz realized that just as the first differ-

ential $\mathrm{d}y$ determines the slope, the second differential d^2y determines the bending or curvature. At an inflection point, $\mathrm{d}^2y = 0$, and the tangent line actually slices through the curve rather than merely grazing one side.
Fermat and Leibniz understood the geometric intuition perfectly, but lacked the limit concept to justify why vanishing terms could be cancelled. In the nineteenth century, Cauchy and Weierstrass provided the rigorous basis with the ε-δ limit and the Mean Value Theorem, proving that Fermat's stationary points and Leibniz's curvature transitions are exact consequences of real analysis. This foundation supported the calculus of variations, Fermat's principle of least time in optics, and the principle of least action in classical physics. Yet the story is far from closed: while single-variable optimization is completely solved, finding global extrema for non-convex functions of millions of variables—such as the objective surfaces traversed when training deep neural networks—is computationally intractable (NP-hard) in general. Understanding high-dimensional geometry, saddle points, and optimization dynamics remains one of the most vibrant open frontiers of modern mathematics.

Common trap

Fermat's theorem is a one-way street, and reading it backwards is the single most common mistake in this whole subject. $f'(c) = 0$ does *not* guarantee an extremum. The graph of $f(x) = x^3$ has $f'(0) = 0$, yet 0 is neither a max nor a min — the curve flattens for an instant and keeps right on rising. A zero derivative is a *candidate*, a place worth checking, nothing more. The theorem tells you where to look, not what you will find.

16.1.2 Critical points: candidate extrema

Fermat's theorem says smooth extrema hide where $f' = 0$. But there is a second way a function can turn around: at a *corner*, where the derivative does not exist at all. The function $f(x) = |x|$ has its minimum at 0, and $f'(0)$ simply does not exist — the slope is -1 on the left and $+1$ on the right, with no single tangent. Fermat's theorem said nothing here, because its hypothesis ("differentiable at c") failed. So our search must include both kinds of points.

Definition 16.2 (Critical point)**.** A *critical point* of f is a number c in the domain of f at which either $f'(c) = 0$ or $f'(c)$ does not exist. The value $f(c)$ is a *critical value*.

Focus

Combining Fermat's theorem with the corner case gives the rule that organizes the entire hunt for extrema:

$$\boxed{\text{Every local extremum of } f \text{ occurs at a critical point.}}$$

This does not say critical points are extrema — most are not. It says you never have to search the whole real line. The peaks and valleys can *only* sit at the finitely many places where f' is zero or undefined. Find those, and you have narrowed the candidate extrema to a finite set. That is the entire strategy.

Example 16.1 (Listing critical points)**.** Find the critical points of $f(x) = x^3 - 3x^2 - 9x + 5$.

Differentiate: $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 6x - 9 = 3(x^2 - 2x - 3) = 3(x - 3)(x + 1)$. This is a polynomial, defined

everywhere, so the only critical points come from $f' = 0$:

$$3(x-3)(x+1) = 0 \implies x = 3 \text{ or } x = -1.$$

Two suspects: $x = -1$ and $x = 3$. We do not yet know which (if either) is a max or a min — that is the next section's job.

Example 16.2 (A critical point from a missing derivative)**.** Find the critical points of $g(x) = x^{2/3}$.

Here $g'(x) = \frac{2}{3}x^{-1/3} = \frac{2}{3\,x^{1/3}}$. There is no x making this zero (the numerator is a constant $2/3$). But at $x = 0$ the formula blows up: $g'(0)$ does not exist. Yet 0 is in the domain of g, and $g(0) = 0$ while $g(x) > 0$ for every other x. So $x = 0$ is a critical point — in fact a global minimum — found *only* because we remembered to check where the derivative fails to exist. The graph has a sharp *cusp* (a sharp point where two branches meet with a vertical tangent line) pointing down at the origin.

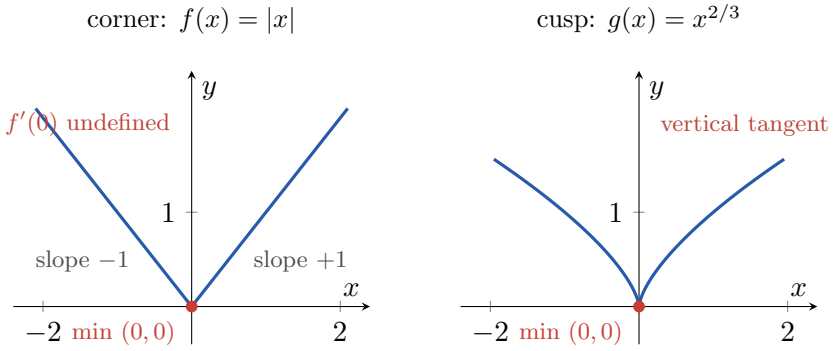


Figure 16.2: Two critical points where the derivative does not exist. Left: a corner, where left- and right-hand slopes disagree (-1 versus $+1$). Right: a cusp, where the tangent line turns vertical and the slope blows up. In both cases, $x = 0$ is a genuine minimum that Fermat's equation $f' = 0$ would overlook.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose a function f is continuous everywhere, climbs steadily on $(-\infty, 2)$, and falls steadily on $(2, \infty)$. Does $x = 2$ have to be a local maximum? Yes: by definition, $f(2) \geq f(x)$ for all nearby x. But does $f'(2)$ have to equal 0? Not at all: the crest could be a sharp corner like $f(x) = 3 - |x-2|$, where the two one-sided slopes disagree and the derivative does not exist. That is why Fermat's equation $f' = 0$ is only half the net: critical points must include every point where f' fails to exist.

16.2 The first-derivative test: reading the sign of the slope

We have a list of candidate points. Now we classify them. The tool is a direct geometric principle: *the sign of f' tells you which way the function is going.* Positive slope, going up. Negative slope, going down. So to decide whether a critical point is a peak, a valley, or neither, we just watch what the slope does as we walk through it.

Why the technique works

Why does the sign of f' control whether f rises or falls? This is the Monotonicity Theorem (Theorem 15.4 in the preceding chapter), resting squarely on the Mean Value Theorem. For any two points $a < b$ in an interval, the MVT guarantees a point $\xi \in (a, b)$ satisfying

$$f(b) - f(a) = f'(\xi)\,(b - a).$$

Because $b > a$, the factor $(b - a)$ is strictly positive. Consequently, the sign of the vertical increment $f(b) - f(a)$ matches the sign of the instantaneous slope $f'(\xi)$. If $f' > 0$ across the entire interval, then $f'(\xi) > 0$ for every pair of sample points, forcing $f(b) > f(a)$ throughout: f is strictly increasing. If $f' < 0$ throughout, $f(b) < f(a)$, and f is strictly decreasing. The first-derivative test is the direct application of this relationship around a critical point.

Theorem 16.2 (First-derivative test)**.** *Suppose f is continuous at a critical point c and differentiable on an open interval around c (except possibly at c itself). Consider the sign of f' just to the left and just to the right of c:*

- *if f' changes from $+$ to $-$ at c, then f has a* local maximum *at c;*
- *if f' changes from $-$ to $+$ at c, then f has a* local minimum *at c;*
- *if f' does* not *change sign at c (stays $+$ or stays $-$), then c is* not *a local extremum.*

Proof. Suppose $f' > 0$ on an interval (a, c) to the left of c and $f' < 0$ on an interval (c, b) to the right. By the Monotonicity Theorem, f is increasing on (a, c) and decreasing on (c, b); by continuity at c these extend to f increasing on $(a, c]$ and decreasing on $[c, b)$. So for any x in (a, c) we have $f(x) < f(c)$, and for any x in (c, b) we have $f(x) < f(c)$. Thus $f(c) \geq f(x)$ for all x in (a, b): a local maximum. The minimum case reverses the inequalities. If f' keeps the same sign on both sides, f is monotone straight through c — still rising (or still falling) — so c cannot be a turning point. □

Intuition

Picture a ball rolling along the graph. Where $f' > 0$ the ground slopes up to the right, so a ball would roll *left*, downhill. Where $f' < 0$ the ground slopes down to the right, so the ball rolls *right*. A local *minimum* is a spot both neighbors roll *toward* (down from the left, down from the right) — a basin, $-$ then $+$. A local *maximum* is a spot both neighbors roll *away* from — a ridge, $+$ then $-$. And if the ball rolls the same direction on both sides, it just passes through; no resting place.

The practical method is a *sign chart*. Mark the critical points on a number line; they cut it into intervals. On each interval, f' has a constant sign (it can only change sign by passing through a zero or a point of nondefinition — a critical point — so between consecutive critical points the sign is locked). Test one convenient point per interval and record $+$ or $-$.

Example 16.3 (First-derivative test in full)**.** Classify the critical points of $f(x) = x^3 - 3x^2 - 9x + 5$ from Example 16.1.

We had $f'(x) = 3(x - 3)(x + 1)$, with critical points $x = -1$ and $x = 3$. These split the line into

three intervals. Pick a test point in each and read the sign of f' from the factored form:

interval	$(-\infty,-1)$	$(-1,3)$	$(3,\infty)$
test x	-2	0	4
$(x-3)$	$-$	$-$	$+$
$(x+1)$	$-$	$+$	$+$
$f'=3(x-3)(x+1)$	$+$	$-$	$+$
f	$\nearrow$	$\searrow$	$\nearrow$

At $x=-1$, f' goes $+\to-$: a **local maximum**, value $f(-1)=-1-3+9+5=10$. At $x=3$, f' goes $-\to+$: a **local minimum**, value $f(3)=27-27-27+5=-22$. The function climbs to a peak at $(-1,10)$, slides down into a valley at $(3,-22)$, then climbs forever.

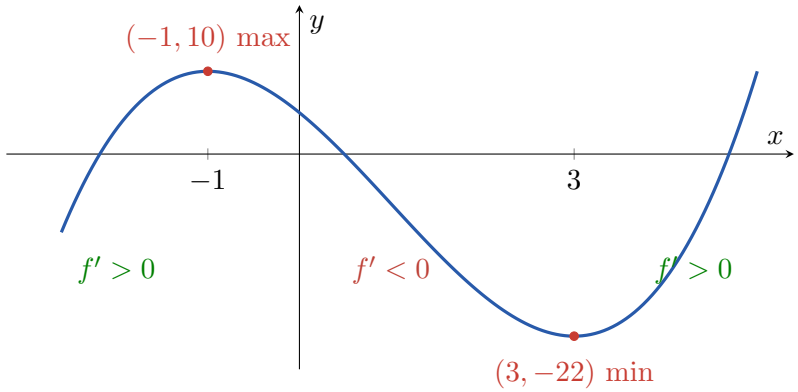


Figure 16.3: $f(x)=x^3-3x^2-9x+5$. The slope is positive, then negative, then positive — so the curve rises, falls, rises, with a peak at $x=-1$ and a valley at $x=3$.

Example 16.4 (A critical point that is not an extremum)**.** Classify the critical point of $f(x)=x^3$.

$f'(x)=3x^2$, zero only at $x=0$. But $3x^2\geq 0$ everywhere: $f'>0$ for $x<0$ *and* $f'>0$ for $x>0$. The slope does not change sign — it dips to zero and bounces back up. By the first-derivative test, $x=0$ is *not* an extremum. The curve flattens for one instant and keeps climbing. This is the trap from earlier made concrete: $f'(0)=0$ did not deliver an extremum.

16.3 Concavity: which way the curve bends

Knowing where a graph rises and falls still leaves its *shape* ambiguous. A curve can climb from A to B in two very different ways: bulging up like the top of a dome, or sagging down like the inside of a bowl. Both go up; they have opposite *curvature*. To capture that, we ask not how f is changing, but how f' is changing — and the rate of change of f' is f''.

Definition 16.3 (Concavity)**.** On an interval where f is differentiable:

- f is *concave up* if f' is increasing on the interval (the slope gets ever larger — more positive or less negative as you move right);
- f is *concave down* if f' is decreasing on the interval.

Apply the Monotonicity Theorem to the function f' itself: f' is increasing exactly where *its* derivative f'' is positive. That gives the working test.

Focus

$f'' > 0 \implies$ concave up (cup-shaped, $\smile$), $\qquad f'' < 0 \implies$ concave down (cap-shaped, $\frown$).

A memory hook: $f'' > 0$ holds *water*, like a cup. $f'' < 0$ spills it, like a frown.

Intuition

There are three ways to picture concavity, and you should hold all three at once.

1. **The slope is turning.** Concave up means the tangent line is rotating counterclockwise as you move right — the slope keeps increasing. Concave down means it rotates clockwise.
2. **The curve vs. its tangent.** A concave-up curve lies *above* each of its tangent lines (the tangent underestimates it). A concave-down curve lies *below* its tangents. This is why the linear approximation from the tangent-line chapter consistently undershoots a convex function and overshoots a concave one.
3. **The chord.** A concave-up curve lies *below* the straight chord joining two of its points (the straight line segment connecting two points on the curve; think of the bottom of a valley); concave down lies above its chords. This is the geometric heart of convexity, and it is what makes inequalities like the AM–GM inequality fall out of a single picture.

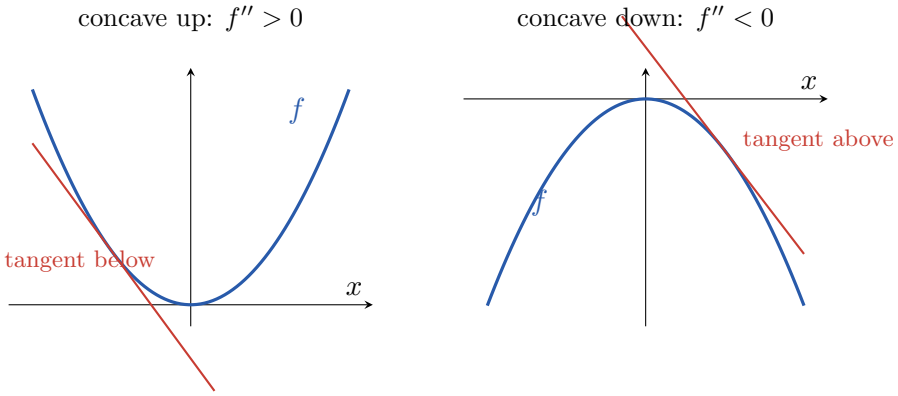


Figure 16.4: Concave up ($\smile$): the curve sits above its tangent lines. Concave down ($\frown$): the curve sits below its tangent lines.

Why the technique works

Why does a concave-up curve ($f'' > 0$) lie above its tangent lines? Fix a point a, and let

$$T(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x - a)$$

be the tangent line at a. Define the gap $g(x) = f(x) - T(x)$, measuring how far the curve sits above the tangent line. Note that $g(a) = 0$ and $g'(x) = f'(x) - f'(a)$, so $g'(a) = 0$.

When $f'' > 0$ on the interval, f' is strictly increasing:

- For $x > a$: $f'(x) > f'(a)$, so $g'(x) > 0$. Since $g(a) = 0$ and g is increasing to the right of a, we have $g(x) > 0$.
- For $x < a$: $f'(x) < f'(a)$, so $g'(x) < 0$. Since g is decreasing toward a where $g(a) = 0$, moving leftward from a means $g(x) > 0$.

On either side of a, $g(x) \geq 0$: the curve sits strictly above its tangent line except at the point of tangency itself. The entire deduction is two successive applications of the Mean Value Theorem: first showing $f'' > 0$ makes f' increase, then showing $g' > 0$ makes g increase.

Pause

Pause and think: Could a curve be concave up everywhere ($f'' > 0$ on all of $\mathbb{R}$) and still possess a local maximum? Picture what that would demand: at a local maximum the tangent line is horizontal, and concave up forces the curve to lie *above* that tangent line on both sides. But lying above a horizontal tangent means climbing even higher, which destroys the peak. Therefore, a function that is strictly concave up everywhere can never have a local maximum.

16.3.1 Inflection points: where the bend reverses

A curve does not have to keep the same concavity forever. Many of the most important shapes in science change their bending partway through. An inflection point is where that switch happens.

Definition 16.4 (Inflection point)**.** A point $\big(c, f(c)\big)$ on the graph of a continuous function is an *inflection point* if the concavity of f *changes* there — from up to down, or down to up.

Since concavity is governed by the sign of f'', an inflection point is a place where f'' changes sign. And just as f' can only change sign at a zero or a gap, f'' can only change sign where $f'' = 0$ or f'' fails to exist. Those are the *candidate* inflection points — and, exactly as with Fermat's theorem, each candidate still has to be tested.

Common trap

$f''(c) = 0$ does *not* by itself make $\big(c, f(c)\big)$ an inflection point. You must check that f'' actually *changes sign*. Classic counterexample: $f(x) = x^4$ has $f''(x) = 12x^2$, which is zero at $x = 0$ but ≥ 0 on both sides — no sign change, no inflection. The curve is concave up throughout; it merely flattens momentarily at the bottom. Always confirm the sign flip, never read it off from $f'' = 0$ alone.

Example 16.5 (The S-curve and its inflection)**.** Consider $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{1 + e^{-x}}$, the logistic curve, widely used in population dynamics, neural networks, and models of saturating growth. Find where it is concave up, concave down, and its inflection point.

Write $s = f(x) = (1 + e^{-x})^{-1}$, noting that $e^{-x} = \frac{1-s}{s}$. By the chain rule,

$$f'(x) = -(1 + e^{-x})^{-2}(-e^{-x}) = \frac{e^{-x}}{(1 + e^{-x})^2} = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-x}} \cdot \frac{e^{-x}}{1 + e^{-x}} = s(1 - s).$$

Differentiating $f'(x) = s - s^2$ with respect to x and substituting $s' = s(1-s)$ once more gives

$$f''(x) = s'(1-2s) = s(1-s)(1-2s).$$

Now s ranges strictly between 0 and 1, so $s > 0$ and $(1-s) > 0$ always; the sign of f'' is determined purely by the factor $(1-2s)$. That is positive when $s < \frac{1}{2}$ and negative when $s > \frac{1}{2}$. And $s = \frac{1}{2}$ happens exactly at $x = 0$. So:

$$f'' > 0 \text{ for } x < 0 \text{ (concave up)}, \qquad f'' < 0 \text{ for } x > 0 \text{ (concave down)}.$$

The concavity flips at $x = 0$: an inflection point at $\left(0, \frac{1}{2}\right)$. This is the famous "tipping point" of the S-curve — the moment of fastest growth, where the curve stops accelerating and begins to level off toward saturation.

Application

In applications, the inflection point is often *the* quantity of interest. In an epidemic modeled by a logistic curve, the inflection point is the day new cases *peak* — after it, growth is still happening but slowing, and the worst is mathematically behind you even though the total is still rising. In a product-adoption curve it is the moment of maximum sales velocity. In both cases f (the cumulative total) is still increasing the whole time; it is f'' changing sign that signals the turn. The first derivative tells you the situation is getting worse; the second derivative tells you how fast it is getting worse, and its sign change is the first good news.

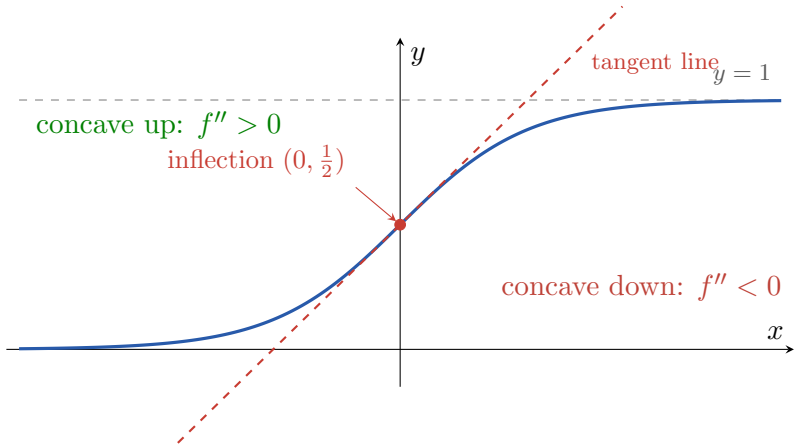


Figure 16.5: The logistic curve $f(x) = 1/(1+e^{-x})$. For $x < 0$, $f'' > 0$ (concave up, curve above tangent); for $x > 0$, $f'' < 0$ (concave down, curve below tangent). At the inflection point $\left(0, \frac{1}{2}\right)$, the tangent line (dashed) slices directly through the curve, marking the transition from acceleration to deceleration.

What is really happening

What is the second derivative *really* measuring at an inflection point? Think of f as position, so f' is velocity and f'' is acceleration. Concave up means accelerating (speeding up in the positive direction); concave down means decelerating. The inflection point is the instant the acceleration passes through zero and reverses — the moment you stop pressing the gas and start pressing the brake. The car is still moving forward (maybe even still gaining ground for

a while, because velocity has not yet hit zero), but the *trend has turned*. That is the deep content of f'' changing sign: not that motion stops, but that the *character* of the motion inverts. A peak in f is where $f' = 0$; an inflection in f is where f' is at its own peak or valley. Inflection points of f are the extrema of f'.

16.4 The second-derivative test: curvature as a shortcut

The first-derivative test always works, but it asks you to examine f' on *both* sides of a critical point. When f'' is easy to compute, there is a faster route that looks at a single point. The idea is geometric and immediate: at a critical point the tangent is horizontal, so the question "peak or valley?" becomes purely a question of *which way the curve bends there*. Bends up ($\smile$) over a horizontal tangent: a valley. Bends down ($\frown$): a peak.

Theorem 16.3 (Second-derivative test)**.** *Suppose $f'(c) = 0$ and $f''(c)$ exists.*

- *If $f''(c) > 0$, then f has a* local minimum *at c.*
- *If $f''(c) < 0$, then f has a* local maximum *at c.*
- *If $f''(c) = 0$, the test is* inconclusive *— c could be a max, a min, or neither.*

Why the technique works

Here is why the test works, first geometrically when f'' is continuous, and then in full generality. If f'' is continuous and $f''(c) > 0$, then $f''(x) > 0$ throughout a small interval around c, so the curve is concave up there and lies *above* its tangent line at c. Because $f'(c) = 0$, that tangent line is the horizontal line $y = f(c)$, giving $f(x) \geq f(c)$ nearby: a local minimum. Likewise $f''(c) < 0$ bends the curve below its horizontal tangent, giving a local maximum.
Even without assuming f'' exists anywhere except right at c, the limit definition proves the theorem directly: for $f''(c) > 0$, $f''(c) = \lim_{x\to c} \frac{f'(x)-f'(c)}{x-c} > 0$, and since $f'(c) = 0$ this forces $\frac{f'(x)}{x-c} > 0$ for all $x \neq c$ sufficiently close to c. Thus $f'(x)$ and $(x - c)$ share the same sign: $f'(x) < 0$ just left of c and $f'(x) > 0$ just right of c. By the first-derivative test on those two half-intervals, c is a local minimum.

Example 16.6 (Second-derivative test, fast)**.** Reclassify the critical points of $f(x) = x^3-3x^2-9x+5$ using f''.

We have $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 6x - 9$, so $f''(x) = 6x - 6 = 6(x - 1)$. Evaluate at the two critical points:

$$f''(-1) = 6(-1 - 1) = -12 < 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \text{local max at } x = -1,$$

$$f''(3) = 6(3 - 1) = 12 > 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \text{local min at } x = 3.$$

Same verdict as the sign chart in Example 16.3, with no intervals to test — two evaluations and done. (Notice in passing that $f'' = 0$ at $x = 1$, with f'' flipping sign there: $x = 1$ is an inflection point, the midpoint between the peak and the valley, as cubics always have.)

Common trap

When $f''(c) = 0$, the second-derivative test tells you *nothing* — do not conclude "not an extremum." Compare three functions at $x = 0$, all with $f'(0) = 0$ and $f''(0) = 0$:

$$x^4 \text{ (min)}, \qquad -x^4 \text{ (max)}, \qquad x^3 \text{ (neither)}.$$

The second derivative cannot tell these apart. When it vanishes, fall back on the first-derivative test (check the sign of f' on both sides) — that one never fails to give an answer.

Why this matters

Why do we have two tests for the same thing? Because they answer different practical questions. The first-derivative test is *robust* — it works at corners and cusps where f'' does not even exist, and it is never inconclusive — but it costs you a study of f' on a whole neighborhood. The second-derivative test is *cheap* — one number per critical point — but it demands a second derivative and shrugs when that derivative is zero. Real problem-solving uses both: reach for f'' first because it is fast, and when it returns zero, retreat to the sign chart, which settles every isolated critical point. Knowing which tool to grab, and why each can fail, is the mark of understanding rather than memorizing.

16.5 Reading f, f', and f'' together: curve sketching

Now everything assembles into a single skill: drawing a graph you have never seen, accurately, from its formula alone. The discipline is to read three layers and let them constrain one another — three independent witnesses to the same shape.

Focus

The three layers of a graph:

Object	What it controls	What you read from it
f	height	intercepts, domain, asymptotes, symmetry
f'	slope	increasing/decreasing, local max/min
f''	bending	concave up/down, inflection points

f' governs whether the curve goes up or down. f'' governs whether it smiles or frowns. Together they pin down the shape between your plotted points, which is exactly the information naive dot-plotting was missing.

A reliable checklist, in order:

1. **Domain and intercepts.** Where is f defined? Where does it cross the axes ($f = 0$, and $f(0)$)?
2. **Symmetry and ends.** Even ($f(-x) = f(x)$, mirror across the y-axis)? Odd ($f(-x) = -f(x)$, rotational)? What happens as $x \to \pm\infty$ — any horizontal or slant asymptotes (straight guide lines the curve approaches ever closer far out)? Any vertical asymptotes where f blows up to

$\pm\infty$ near an excluded point?

3. **First derivative.** Compute f', find critical points, build the sign chart: where increasing, where decreasing, and classify the extrema.

4. **Second derivative.** Compute f'', find where it is zero or undefined, build its sign chart: concavity intervals and inflection points.

5. **Assemble.** Plot the special points (intercepts, extrema, inflections, asymptotes), then connect them *respecting* the slope and concavity you found. There is now exactly one curve that fits all the constraints.

Example 16.7 (A full sketch: a quartic)**.** Sketch $f(x) = x^4 - 4x^3$.

1. Domain, intercepts. Defined for all x. Factor: $f(x) = x^3(x-4)$, so $f = 0$ at $x = 0$ (a triple root — the curve flattens through the axis there) and at $x = 4$. Also $f(0) = 0$.

2. Ends. As $x \to \pm\infty$, the x^4 term dominates and $f \to +\infty$ on both sides. No symmetry ($f(-x) = x^4 + 4x^3 \neq \pm f(x)$). No asymptotes.

3. First derivative. $f'(x) = 4x^3 - 12x^2 = 4x^2(x-3)$. Critical points where $f' = 0$: $x = 0$ (double) and $x = 3$. Sign chart:

	$(-\infty, 0)$	$(0, 3)$	$(3, \infty)$
$4x^2$	$+$	$+$	$+$
$(x-3)$	$-$	$-$	$+$
f'	$-$	$-$	$+$
f	$\searrow$	$\searrow$	$\nearrow$

At $x = 3$, f' goes $- \to +$: **local min**, $f(3) = 81 - 108 = -27$. At $x = 0$, f' does *not* change sign ($-$ to $-$): *not* an extremum, just a momentary flat spot on the way down.

4. Second derivative. $f''(x) = 12x^2 - 24x = 12x(x-2)$. Zero at $x = 0$ and $x = 2$. Sign chart:

	$(-\infty, 0)$	$(0, 2)$	$(2, \infty)$
$12x$	$-$	$+$	$+$
$(x-2)$	$-$	$-$	$+$
f''	$+$	$-$	$+$
shape	$\smile$	$\frown$	$\smile$

Concavity flips at *both* $x = 0$ and $x = 2$ — two inflection points: $\big(0, 0\big)$ and $\big(2, f(2)\big) = \big(2, -16\big)$.

5. Assemble. Coming from the upper left, the curve falls concave up until $x = 0$, where it momentarily flattens (slope 0) and switches to concave down. It keeps falling — now bulging downward — until $x = 2$, where it turns concave up again while still descending, reaches the bottom of the valley at $(3, -27)$, and finally climbs away toward $+\infty$. The flat spot at the origin (slope zero but *not* an extremum) and the deep minimum at $x = 3$ are the two features dot plotting would most likely get wrong.

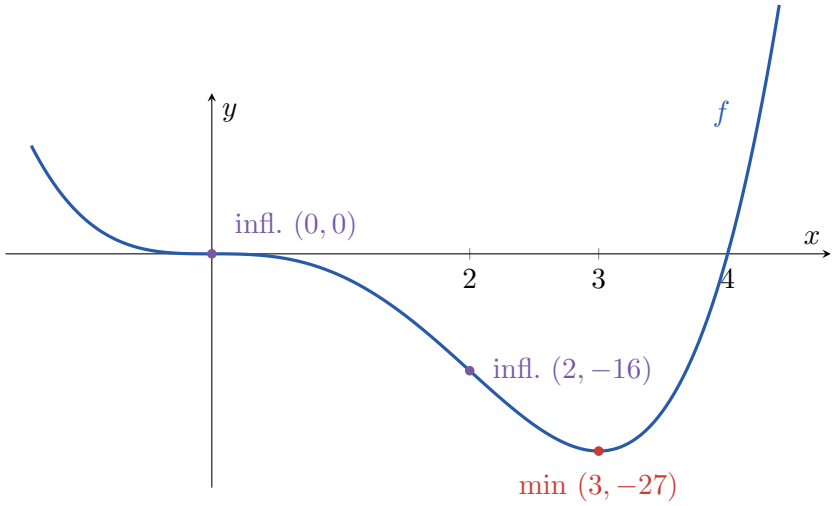


Figure 16.6: $f(x) = x^4 - 4x^3$. A flat-but-not-extreme spot at the origin, a genuine minimum at $(3, -27)$, and two inflection points (purple) at $x = 0$ and $x = 2$ where the bending reverses.

Example 16.8 (A sketch with asymptotes: a rational function)**.** Sketch $f(x) = \dfrac{x^2}{x^2 - 1}$.

1. Domain, intercepts. The denominator $x^2 - 1 = (x - 1)(x + 1)$ vanishes at $x = \pm 1$, so those are excluded: vertical asymptotes there. $f = 0$ only when the numerator $x^2 = 0$, i.e. $x = 0$, where also $f(0) = 0$. So the only intercept is the origin.

2. Symmetry, ends. $f(-x) = \dfrac{x^2}{x^2 - 1} = f(x)$: *even*, symmetric across the y-axis. As $x \to \pm\infty$, $f = \dfrac{x^2}{x^2 - 1} \to 1$: a horizontal asymptote $y = 1$. Near the vertical asymptotes the sign of the denominator tells the story: for $|x|$ slightly less than 1, $x^2 - 1 < 0$ so $f \to -\infty$; for $|x|$ slightly more than 1, $x^2 - 1 > 0$ so $f \to +\infty$.

3. First derivative. By the quotient rule,

$$f'(x) = \frac{(2x)(x^2 - 1) - x^2(2x)}{(x^2 - 1)^2} = \frac{2x^3 - 2x - 2x^3}{(x^2 - 1)^2} = \frac{-2x}{(x^2 - 1)^2}.$$

The denominator is positive wherever defined, so the sign of f' is the sign of $-2x$: positive for $x < 0$, negative for $x > 0$. The only critical point is $x = 0$, and f' goes $+ \to -$ there: a **local maximum** at $(0, 0)$. (It is a maximum of the central branch, even though outer branches take much larger values, illustrating that "local" refers strictly to an open neighborhood.)

4. Second derivative. Differentiating $f'(x) = \dfrac{-2x}{(x^2 - 1)^2}$ with the quotient rule:

$$f''(x) = \frac{-2(x^2 - 1)^2 - (-2x) \cdot 2(x^2 - 1)(2x)}{(x^2 - 1)^4} = \frac{-2(x^2 - 1) + 8x^2}{(x^2 - 1)^3} = \frac{2(3x^2 + 1)}{(x^2 - 1)^3}.$$

The numerator $2(3x^2 + 1)$ is always positive, so the sign of f'' matches the sign of $(x^2 - 1)^3$, which matches the sign of $(x^2 - 1)$:

$$f'' > 0 \text{ when } |x| > 1 \text{ (concave up)}, \qquad f'' < 0 \text{ when } |x| < 1 \text{ (concave down)}.$$

There is no inflection point, because the sign change of f'' happens only at $x = \pm 1$, where f is not even defined.

5. Assemble. Three branches. The middle branch (between the asymptotes) is a downward-bulging arch peaking at the origin and diving to $-\infty$ at both $x = \pm 1$. The two outer branches descend from $+\infty$ (just outside the asymptotes) toward the horizontal line $y = 1$, concave up, mirror images of each other.

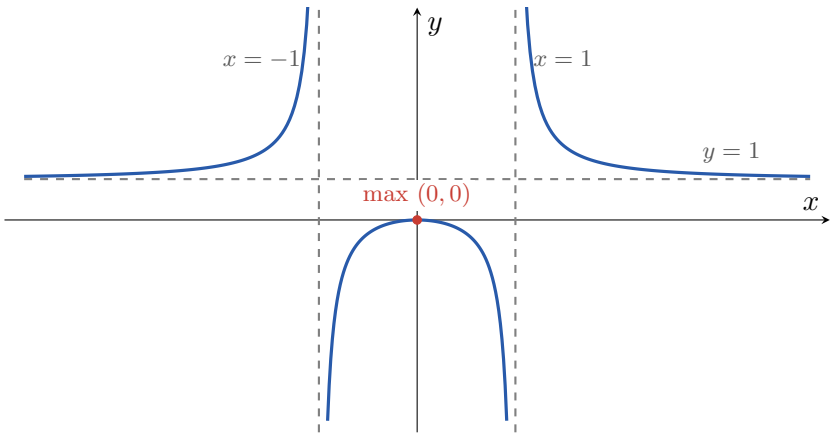


Figure 16.7: $f(x) = x^2/(x^2 - 1)$. Vertical asymptotes at $x = \pm 1$ (dashed) split the graph into three branches; horizontal asymptote $y = 1$. The central arch has a local maximum at the origin.

Walking question

Here is a graph you can build entirely in your head on a walk. Imagine a function whose *derivative* f' looks like a single hump — zero at $x = 0$, rising to a peak at $x = 2$, falling back to zero at $x = 4$, and staying near zero outside. Now ask yourself, without paper: where is f itself increasing? (Wherever $f' > 0$, which is the whole stretch from 0 to 4 — so f climbs the entire time.) Where is f *concave up*? (Wherever f' is *increasing*, i.e. from 0 to 2.) Where is f's inflection point? (At $x = 2$, the peak of f' — the steepest point of the climb.) You have just read the shape of f off the shape of f', which is the single most useful fluency in this chapter (Figure 16.8 shows a worked instance). Practice going both directions: from f to f', and from f' back up to f.

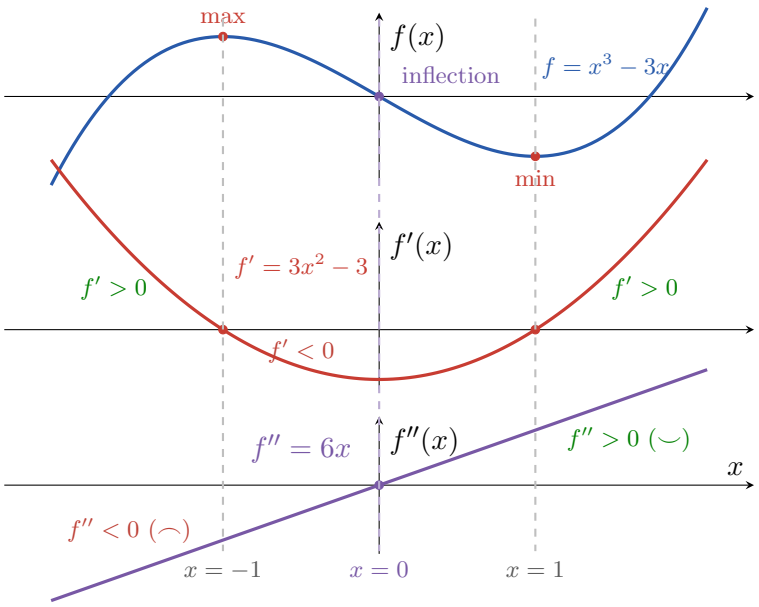


Figure 16.8: The three synchronized layers of curve analysis for $f(x) = x^3 - 3x$. Top lane: the graph of f rises where $f' > 0$ and falls where $f' < 0$. Middle lane: the zeros of f' at $x = \pm 1$ pinpoint the peak and valley of f. Bottom lane: the zero of f'' at $x = 0$ marks the inflection point, where f' attains its global minimum (steepest downhill descent) and the concavity of f flips from down (⌢) to up (⌣).

Work it yourself

Take $f(x) = xe^{-x}$ — a shape that shows up constantly in physics (radioactive decay times a linear rise), pharmacology (drug concentration over time), and probability. Work out the shape entirely by hand, then check your sketch against a plot.

1. Show $f'(x) = e^{-x}(1 - x)$. Find the one critical point and classify it with the first-derivative test. (Answer: max at $x = 1$, value $1/e \approx 0.368$.)
2. Show $f''(x) = e^{-x}(x - 2)$. Find the inflection point. (Answer: at $x = 2$, where the decay's concavity flips from down to up.)
3. As $x \to +\infty$, does $f \to 0$ or $\to \infty$? (The exponential e^{-x} beats the linear x, so $f \to 0^+$ — a horizontal asymptote $y = 0$.) As $x \to -\infty$? ($f \to -\infty$, because e^{-x} explodes.)
4. Assemble: a curve rising from below, crossing the origin, climbing to a single peak at $x = 1$, then decaying back toward zero, with the decay easing off (inflection) at $x = 2$. Sketch it, then plot it and compare.

Connection

Concavity is the one-variable shadow of a much bigger idea: *convexity*, which runs through optimization, economics, and machine learning. A function with $f'' \geq 0$ everywhere is called *convex*; the curve-above-its-chords picture is its defining property. Convex functions have a key property you can already anticipate from this chapter: *any local minimum is automatically a global minimum* — there are no isolated suboptimal valleys, because the curve never turns

back down once it has started up. This is why training a model whose loss function is convex is tractable (gradient descent cannot be trapped) and why non-convex losses with multiple local minima present greater challenges. The second-derivative test is the one-variable origin of that theory. We will meet the multivariable version — where f'' becomes a matrix and "concave up" becomes a statement about that matrix — when we reach functions of several variables.

16.6 Finding the global extremes on an interval

Local extrema are about neighborhoods. But the questions that matter in practice are usually *global*: over this whole range of choices, what is the absolute best? On an unbounded domain a function may have no global max at all (think $f(x) = x$, climbing forever). The clean, decidable case is a function on a *closed, bounded* interval $[a, b]$, and there the Extreme Value Theorem (from the continuity chapter) guarantees both a global max and a global min actually exist. The only question is *where*.

Focus

The closed-interval method. To find the absolute max and min of a continuous f on $[a, b]$:

1. Find all critical points of f *inside* (a, b).
2. Make a list: those critical points, plus the two endpoints a and b.
3. Evaluate f at every point on the list.
4. The largest value is the global max; the smallest is the global min.

No sign charts, no second derivatives — just evaluate and compare. The logic is airtight: a global extremum is in particular a local one *unless* it sits at an endpoint (where "local" has no left or right neighbor to compare with). Local interior extrema live at critical points (Fermat); the only other place is an endpoint. So the global champion is somewhere on the list, guaranteed.

Example 16.9 (Closed-interval optimization)**.** Find the absolute maximum and minimum of $f(x) = x^3 - 3x^2 - 9x + 5$ on $[-2, 4]$.

We already found the critical points $x = -1$ and $x = 3$ (both inside $(-2, 4)$). The list is $\{-2, -1, 3, 4\}$. Evaluate:

$$\begin{aligned} f(-2) &= -8 - 12 + 18 + 5 = 3, \\ f(-1) &= -1 - 3 + 9 + 5 = 10, \\ f(3) &= 27 - 27 - 27 + 5 = -22, \\ f(4) &= 64 - 48 - 36 + 5 = -15. \end{aligned}$$

The largest is $f(-1) = 10$: **global maximum**. The smallest is $f(3) = -22$: **global minimum**. Notice that the endpoint $x = 4$ gives -15, lower than the *other* endpoint and lower than the left critical point — a reminder that endpoints are genuine contenders and must always be on the list. Had we forgotten them, we would still have caught the true extremes here, but on a different interval an endpoint could easily be the winner (Figure 16.9).

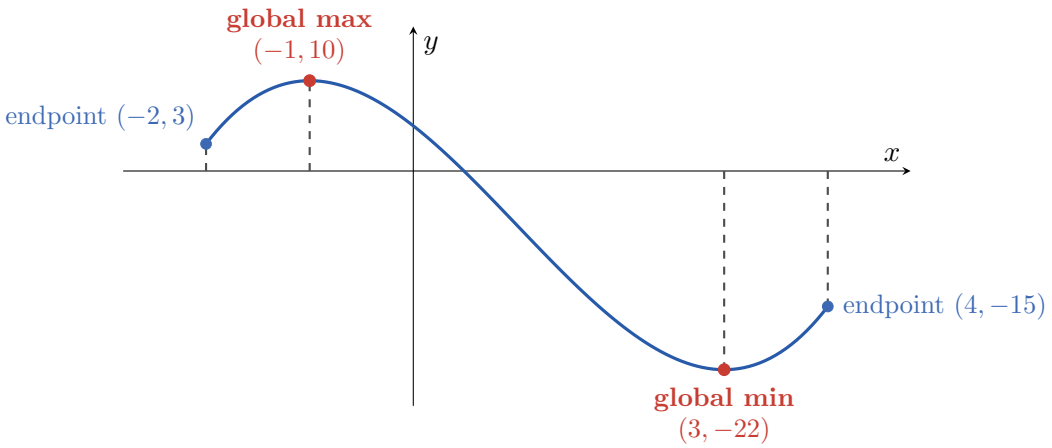


Figure 16.9: The closed-interval method on $[-2, 4]$ for $f(x) = x^3 - 3x^2 - 9x + 5$. Four candidates compete: the two endpoints and the two interior critical points. Evaluating all four reveals the global maximum at $(-1, 10)$ and the global minimum at $(3, -22)$. Notice that the right endpoint $(4, -15)$ sits lower than the left endpoint, confirming that endpoints are genuine contenders.

Common trap

The closed-interval method needs both hypotheses of the Extreme Value Theorem: *continuous* function on a *closed, bounded* interval. Drop either and the guarantee evaporates. On the open interval $(0, 1)$ the function $f(x) = x$ has no maximum — it gets arbitrarily close to 1 but never reaches it, and 1 is not in the domain. On $[0, \infty)$ the function $f(x) = x$ has no maximum either. And a function with a vertical asymptote inside the interval (a discontinuity) can shoot to $+\infty$ with no max at all. When the EVT does not apply, finding global extrema is a genuinely subtler business — you must examine the behavior at the open ends or at infinity by hand.

16.7 What we built

The whole chapter is one idea unfolding: *the derivatives of f encode the shape of f.* The first derivative records direction — its zeros and nondefined points (critical points) trap every local extremum, and its sign on either side (the first-derivative test) classifies them. The second derivative records bending — its sign gives concavity, its sign *changes* give inflection points, and at a flat tangent its sign settles peak-versus-valley in one stroke (the second-derivative test). Reading both at once, you can reconstruct a graph exactly, and on a closed interval you can pin down the absolute best and worst with only a short list of values.

Underneath every one of these tests sits the Mean Value Theorem, quietly converting facts about f' into facts about f. The rule "positive derivative means increasing" is the MVT, and the first-derivative test applies that fact on each side of a critical point. Likewise, concavity applies the same fact to f', and the second-derivative test applies concavity at a horizontal tangent. Those four rules are really one theorem doing four jobs.

In the next chapter we put this machine to work on real questions — the largest box, the cheapest can, the shortest path, the maximum profit — where the art is no longer running the tests but

setting up the right function to optimize. The hard part of optimization was never the calculus. It was deciding what to take the derivative of.

Summary: Curve Shape and Optimization

Connection

With the first and second derivatives, you can systematically determine:

- *Exact critical points and extrema*: Locating every candidate peak, valley, and plateau ($f' = 0$ or undefined) without plotting millions of points.
- *Global monotonicity and concavity*: Partitioning the real line into intervals where the graph rises, falls, bends upward like a cup, or sheds water like a dome.
- *Complete shape and curvature*: Identifying inflections where physical quantities change acceleration, and using the closed-interval method to guarantee global optima.

Yet the critical-point framework relies on isolated critical points and well-behaved, continuous derivatives. It falters on functions with infinite-frequency oscillations. Consider the canonical counterexample:

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2 \sin\left(\frac{1}{x}\right), & x \neq 0, \\ 0, & x = 0. \end{cases}$$

Here $f'(0) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{h^2 \sin(1/h)}{h} = 0$, so $x = 0$ is a critical point. Yet for $x \neq 0$, $f'(x) = 2x\sin(1/x) - \cos(1/x)$, which oscillates between positive and negative infinitely often in every open neighborhood of 0. There are infinitely many local maxima and minima accumulating at the origin! The first derivative test cannot be applied because f' does not have constant sign on either side of 0, and $f''(0)$ does not even exist. Standard calculus tools assume the tame, well-behaved derivatives typical of physical applications.

In Chapter 17 (*Optimization*), we put these classification tools to work on concrete design, geometric, and economic problems — from maximizing container volume and minimizing material cost to shortest-distance geometry, Fermat's least-time principle, and equating marginal revenue to marginal cost.

Exercises

Exercise 16.1 (Mental warm-ups)**.** Answer each question mentally or with a one-line sketch before calculating:

1. If $f'(x) = (x-2)^2(x-5)$, where does f have a local minimum? Does $x = 2$ yield an extremum?
2. Can a cubic polynomial $f(x) = ax^3 + bx^2 + cx + d$ ($a \neq 0$) have two local maxima? Explain using the degree of f'.
3. If a differentiable function on $[1, 5]$ satisfies $f'(x) > 0$ for all $x \in (1, 5)$, where do its global minimum and global maximum occur?

Exercise 16.2. For each function, find all critical points and classify each as a local maximum, local minimum, or neither, using the first-derivative test.

1. $f(x) = 2x^3 - 9x^2 + 12x - 3$
2. $f(x) = x^4 - 8x^2 + 3$
3. $f(x) = x^{2/3}(x - 5)$ (watch for a point where f' does not exist)

Exercise 16.3. Find the intervals of concavity and all inflection points of $f(x) = x^4 - 6x^2 + 5$. Then confirm, using the second-derivative test, the nature of each critical point.

Exercise 16.4. Find the absolute maximum and minimum of $f(x) = 2x^3 - 3x^2 - 12x + 1$ on the closed interval $[-2, 3]$. Identify whether each extreme occurs at an endpoint or at an interior critical point.

Exercise 16.5. Carry out a full curve sketch of $f(x) = \dfrac{x}{x^2 + 1}$: domain, symmetry, intercepts, end behavior and asymptotes, intervals of increase/decrease with extrema, and intervals of concavity with inflection points. Then draw the graph. (Hint: f is odd, $f \to 0$ at both ends, and you will find one max, one min, and three inflection points.)

Exercise 16.6. (Conceptual.) For each description, either sketch a function meeting it or explain briefly why none can exist.

1. $f'(2) = 0$ but f has neither a max nor a min at $x = 2$.
2. $f''(2) = 0$ but f has no inflection point at $x = 2$.
3. f has a local minimum at $x = 2$ but $f'(2)$ does not exist.
4. f has a local maximum at $x = 2$ and $f''(2) > 0$.

Exercise 16.7. (Reading f from f'.) The derivative of a function f is $f'(x) = (x - 1)^2(x - 4)$. Without finding f itself, determine: (a) the intervals where f is increasing and decreasing; (b) the locations and types of all local extrema; (c) whether $x = 1$ is special, and why the squared factor matters.

Exercise 16.8. (Why the test works.) Suppose f'' is continuous and $f''(c) > 0$ at a point where $f'(c) = 0$. Using the definition $f''(c) = \lim_{x \to c} \dfrac{f'(x) - f'(c)}{x - c}$, prove directly that f' is negative just to the left of c and positive just to the right, and conclude that f has a local minimum at c. (This is the second-derivative test, derived from scratch.)

Exercise 16.9. (Proof, tangent line and concavity.) Let f be twice differentiable with $f''(x) > 0$ for all x in an interval I. Prove that for any fixed $a \in I$,

$$f(x) \;\geq\; f(a) + f'(a)(x - a) \qquad \text{for all } x \in I,$$

with equality only at $x = a$. (That is: a strictly convex curve lies strictly above each of its tangent lines. Imitate the gap-function argument from the chapter: let $g(x) = f(x) - f(a) - f'(a)(x - a)$ and study the sign of g'.)

Exercise 16.10. (Inflections are extrema of f'.) Explain carefully why an inflection point of f corresponds to a local maximum or minimum of f'. Use this to find the inflection point of $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{1 + e^{-x}}$ by maximizing f' instead of analyzing f'' directly, and confirm you get $x = 0$.

Exercise 16.11. (Modeling.) A drug's concentration in the bloodstream t hours after a dose is modeled by $C(t) = 12t\, e^{-t/2}$ for $t \geq 0$. (a) When is the concentration highest, and what is that peak concentration? (b) The concentration is "falling fastest" at the inflection point of C; find that time. (c) Sketch C for $t \in [0, 12]$, marking the peak and the inflection.

Chapter 17

Optimization

In the previous chapter, we learned how to read the shape of a graph: we used the first derivative to detect where a curve climbs and falls, the second derivative to feel its curvature, and the Mean Value Theorem to prove that where a smooth peak turns around, the tangent line must be perfectly flat. Every chapter so far has been, in a quiet way, preparation for this one. All of that machinery was built so that we could answer a single, very old, very human question: *what is the best you can do?*

Make the box hold the most. Use the least metal. Build the cheapest fence. Run the shortest distance. Earn the highest profit. These are not artificial textbook puzzles — they are the questions that motivated the invention of calculus in the first place. Fermat was solving max/min problems with a slope-like idea decades before Newton and Leibniz, and the whole subject of the derivative grew partly out of the desire to find peaks and valleys without guessing.

Once a problem is written as a function, the calculus is familiar: find where the derivative is zero and check the candidates. The real work happens *before* you differentiate — turning a geometric or physical setup into a function of one variable on a clear domain.

17.1 What optimization really asks

An optimization problem has exactly three ingredients.

Focus

Every applied max/min problem is built from:

1. an **objective** — the quantity you want to make as large or as small as possible (area, volume, cost, distance, time);
2. one or more **constraints** — the conditions tying your choices together (a fixed amount of fence, a fixed surface area, a point that must lie on a curve);
3. a **domain** — the set of choices that actually make sense (a length cannot be negative; a cut cannot be longer than the cardboard).

Your job is to express the objective as a function of *one* variable, find its extreme value on the domain, and confirm you really found the best.

Why aim for a single variable? We have one tool for finding peaks and valleys: set the derivative to zero. That tool needs a function of one input. So no matter how many quantities a problem mentions — length, width, height, radius, angle — our first task is to collapse them down to one, using the constraint to eliminate the rest. Far from being an obstacle, the constraint *makes the problem solvable* by letting us express the remaining variables in terms of one.

Intuition

Picture the objective as a rolling surface of hills and valleys, and your constraint as a hiking trail cut across it. Without the constraint you could wander across the whole open map, and there might be no single summit at all. The constraint pins you to a single trail. Now "the best you can do" is just the highest point *on that trail* — a one-dimensional question about walking forward or backward along a line, exactly the kind of question a single derivative can answer. Much of optimization is just finding the trail.

17.1.1 A method you can trust

Here is the recipe we will follow on every single example. Write it on an index card. The discipline of doing these steps *in order* is what separates a clean solution from a tangle.

Focus

The modeling method for max/min problems.

1. **Draw a picture** and name the quantities. Introduce letters for the things that can vary.
2. **Write the objective** — the thing to be maximized or minimized — as a formula, even if it still has several variables in it.
3. **Write the constraint(s)** as equations.
4. **Reduce to one variable.** Use the constraint to eliminate every variable but one. Now the objective is a function f of a single variable.
5. **Find the domain** of that variable — the interval of values that correspond to a real, physical configuration. Note the endpoints.
6. **Differentiate and find the critical points**: solve $f'(x) = 0$ and note where f' fails to exist. (A critical point is a candidate location where the slope is zero or undefined — a momentary flat spot or sharp crease where the curve could turn around.)
7. **Test the candidates.** Compare the values of f at the critical points *and* at the endpoints of the domain. Use a first- or second- derivative test, or the closed-interval method, to be sure which candidate wins.
8. **Answer the question that was asked** — with units, and check it is sane.

Notice that steps 1–5 contain no calculus at all. They are modeling. If you get those right, step 6 is mechanical. Most challenging optimization problems turn on setting up the model correctly before calculating derivatives.

Why the technique works

Why does "set the derivative to zero" find the best? Because at an interior point where f is largest or smallest, the curve must, for that instant, be neither rising nor falling — if it were rising, you could nudge a hair to the right and do better; if falling, a hair to the left. So the tangent there is horizontal: $f'(x) = 0$. This is *Fermat's theorem*, proved cleanly in the chapter on maxima and minima: an interior extreme of a differentiable function forces a *stationary point* — a point where the tangent line flattens out and the rate of change is zero ($f'(x) = 0$).

History

The realization that nature and mathematics optimize began in earnest with Pierre de Fermat in 1662. For decades, optics had rested on an empirical rule discovered by Willebrord Snell in 1621: when a ray of light passes from air into a denser medium like water, it bends toward the perpendicular in a fixed ratio of sines (*refraction*). But nobody knew *why*. René Descartes had attempted a mechanical explanation by modeling light as tiny tennis balls bouncing through a permeable membrane, but his model forced light to travel *faster* in dense water than in thin air — a conclusion that seemed physically backwards.

Fermat proposed a bold, unifying hypothesis: light traveling between two points does not choose the path of shortest geometric distance, but the path of *least time* (*Fermat's Principle*). To prove this, Fermat set up the total transit time across an optical boundary as a single-variable function of the crossing point x:

$$T(x) = \frac{\sqrt{a^2 + x^2}}{v_1} + \frac{\sqrt{b^2 + (d - x)^2}}{v_2},$$

where v_1 and v_2 are the speeds of light in the two media. Fermat possessed no modern derivative or limit notation. Instead, he used his algebraic method of *adequality* — an ingenious proto-derivative where he nudged the input x by a tiny fictitious increment e, set the resulting expression approximately equal to the original, canceled like terms, divided through by e, and finally discarded any remaining terms containing e. Setting that rate of change to zero, Fermat derived Snell's law $\frac{\sin\theta_1}{v_1} = \frac{\sin\theta_2}{v_2}$ from pure mathematics. Nature, it appeared, was an optimizer.

Fermat's result sparked furious controversy. Descartes' disciples, led by Claude Clerselier, attacked Fermat bitterly, protesting that nature possesses no consciousness: how could an inanimate ray of light "know" in advance which route takes the least time before setting out? Thirty-four years later, in June 1696, Johann Bernoulli elevated optimization from numbers to geometric shapes by posing the *Brachistochrone problem* (from the Greek *brachistos*, shortest, and *chronos*, time) in *Acta Eruditorum*. Given two points A and B at different heights, he asked: what curve carries a frictionless bead sliding under gravity from A to B in the shortest possible time? A straight ramp gives the shortest distance, but a steeper initial drop builds speed earlier; what path strikes the perfect balance?

Five mathematicians solved it: Johann Bernoulli, his older brother Jakob Bernoulli, Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, Guillaume de l'Hôpital, and Isaac Newton. Newton, returning home exhausted from a grueling day directing the Royal Mint in January 1697, worked through the night and published his solution anonymously the next morning. Johann Bernoulli recognized the author immediately, remarking: "I recognize the lion by his claw." The optimal curve was neither a straight line nor a circular arc, but a *cycloid* — the graceful arch traced by a single point on the rim of a rolling wheel. The contest ignited an acrimonious rivalry between

the Bernoulli brothers over priority and method, but it broke open the boundary of ordinary optimization: it gave birth to the *calculus of variations*, the branch of mathematics where the unknown to be found is not a single number, but an entire optimal path or function.
This led to a central principle of physics: Maupertuis and Hamilton later showed that all of classical mechanics can be derived from the *principle of least action*, asserting that moving particles and orbiting planets follow paths that minimize physical action. In quantum electrodynamics, Richard Feynman showed that light truly does explore every possible path simultaneously; classical rays simply represent the trajectory where neighboring quantum waves interfere constructively, vindicating Fermat's principle at the atomic scale.
What remains open? In single-variable calculus on a closed interval, Fermat's method guarantees finding every extreme. But in modern high-dimensional optimization — such as training deep neural networks with billions of adjustable weights — the loss surface is riddled with non-convex ridges, saddles, and local valleys. Finding a guaranteed global minimum for general high-dimensional non-convex functions is known to be NP-hard. Why simple iterative methods like gradient descent reliably discover exceptionally good solutions without getting hopelessly trapped remains one of the deepest theoretical mysteries in contemporary mathematics and computer science.

17.2 The closed-interval method: making the answer certain

Before the examples, let us nail down the one piece of theory that turns a guess into a guarantee. Setting $f'(x) = 0$ tells you where the function *might* peak. It does not by itself tell you that a peak exists, nor that the candidate you found is the global best. Two things can go wrong: the maximum might sit at an endpoint of the domain rather than at a stationary point, or the function might not have a maximum at all (think of $f(x) = x$ on all of $\mathbb{R}$ — no biggest value).

The clean fix, which we put into checklist form at the end of Chapter 16, rests on the **Extreme Value Theorem** from continuity. In plain terms: on any closed, unbroken stretch of road of finite length, there is guaranteed to be an absolute highest summit and an absolute lowest dip.

Focus

Extreme Value Theorem. If f is continuous on a *closed, bounded* interval $[a, b]$, then f attains both a maximum and a minimum value somewhere on $[a, b]$.

This theorem is the optimizer's safety net. As long as your objective is continuous and your domain is a closed interval $[a, b]$, a best value is *guaranteed to exist*, and it can only live in one of two kinds of places: at a critical point inside, or at an endpoint. That gives a finite checklist.

Focus

The closed-interval method. To find the absolute max and min of a continuous f on $[a, b]$:

1. Find all critical numbers in (a, b) (where $f' = 0$ or f' does not exist).
2. Evaluate f at each critical number.
3. Evaluate f at the two endpoints a and b.

4. The largest of these values is the absolute maximum; the smallest is the absolute minimum.

No derivative tests needed — just compare numbers. The theorem promises the winner is in your list.

Why the technique works

Why is comparing values *enough*? Because the Extreme Value Theorem promises the maximum is attained *somewhere*. Wherever that somewhere is, it is either an interior point or an endpoint. If interior, Fermat's theorem says it is a critical number, so it is in your list. If an endpoint, it is also in your list. There is nowhere else for it to hide. So you do not need to analyze concavity or signs of f' at all; you just need to make sure your list of candidate points is complete and then read off the largest value. The closed-interval method works precisely because the theorem rules out any other possibility.

Common trap

The closed-interval method requires *three* pieces, and beginners drop one:

- **Continuity**: a jump or a vertical asymptote in the domain breaks the guarantee. The function $1/x$ on $[-1, 1]$ has no maximum — it is not continuous there.
- **Closed** (endpoints included): on the open interval $(0, 1)$ the function $f(x) = x$ has no maximum, because it can get arbitrarily close to 1 without reaching it.
- **Bounded**: on $[0, \infty)$ the function $f(x) = x$ runs off to infinity.

If your domain is not a closed bounded interval, you must argue existence another way (often by the shape of the graph or a sign analysis of f').

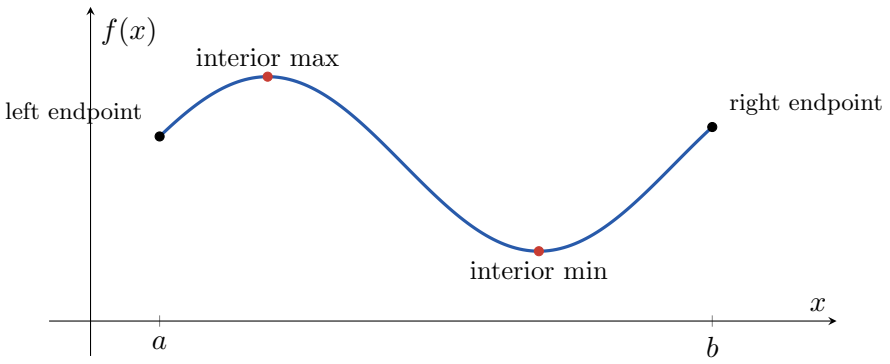


Figure 17.1: On a closed interval $[a, b]$, the absolute max and min of a continuous function can only occur at an interior critical point or at an endpoint. The closed-interval method checks all of them and compares (here both extremes happen to be interior, with the endpoints landing in between).

What is really happening

When you "set $f'(x) = 0$ and solve," what is really happening is a search for *stationary configurations* — arrangements where a tiny change in your choice produces no first-order

change in the objective. Think of balancing a ball on a surface. At a peak, a valley, or a saddle, the ball is momentarily in equilibrium: the slope is zero in every direction you can move along the constraint. The derivative is measuring how sensitive your objective is to a small nudge. Setting it to zero says "find the spot where I am insensitive to nudges." That spot is a candidate for best, but you still have to check whether it is a peak (max), a valley (min), or merely a flat shelf — which is exactly why the second-derivative test and the closed-interval comparison exist. The vanishing derivative locates equilibria; the second-order information classifies them.

17.3 Worked example: the open-top box

Here is the most famous optimization problem in calculus, and deservedly so: it runs every step of the method on something you can hold in your hands.

Example 17.1 (The fold-up box)**.** You have a square sheet of cardboard 30 cm on a side. You cut a small square of side x from each corner, fold up the four flaps, and tape them to make an open-top box. What size cut x gives the box of *largest volume*?

Step 1 — picture and variables. Cutting a square of side x from each corner and folding up leaves a base that is a square of side $30 - 2x$ (you removed x from each end of every side), and the height of the box is exactly the cut x (Figure 17.2).

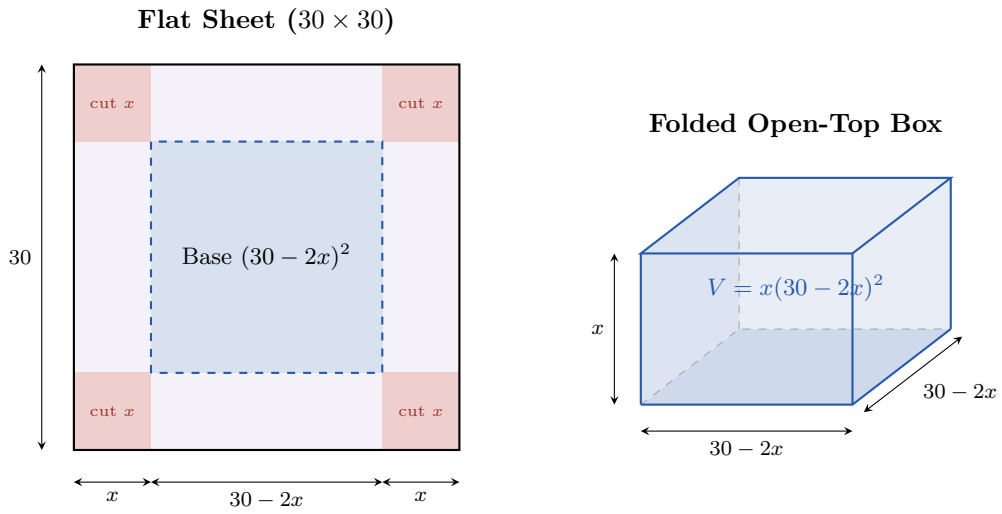


Figure 17.2: The fold-up box. Left: Removing square cutouts of side x from each corner leaves a square base of side $30 - 2x$. Right: Folding along the dashed lines creates an open-top box of height x, square base $(30 - 2x)^2$, and volume $V(x) = x(30 - 2x)^2$.

Step 2 — objective. The volume is base area times height:

$$V = (30 - 2x)^2 \cdot x.$$

This is already a function of the single variable x — the geometry handed us the constraint for free, so there is no separate elimination step here.

Step 3 — domain. What values of x make a real box? We need $x > 0$ (a genuine cut) and we need the base side $30 - 2x > 0$, i.e. $x < 15$. At $x = 0$ there is no height; at $x = 15$ there is no base. Including those degenerate endpoints (where the volume is zero) gives the closed interval

$$0 \le x \le 15.$$

We deliberately include the endpoints: now the domain is closed and bounded, V is continuous, and the Extreme Value Theorem guarantees a maximum exists. That is worth the small fiction of allowing the zero-volume cases.

Step 4 — differentiate. Expand first to make the derivative painless:

$$V = x(30 - 2x)^2 = x(900 - 120x + 4x^2) = 900x - 120x^2 + 4x^3.$$

Then

$$V'(x) = 900 - 240x + 12x^2 = 12\,(x^2 - 20x + 75) = 12\,(x - 5)(x - 15).$$

Step 5 — critical points. $V'(x) = 0$ at $x = 5$ and $x = 15$. The point $x = 15$ is an endpoint (and gives zero volume), so the only interior critical point is

$$x = 5.$$

Step 6 — test. Use the closed-interval method: evaluate V at the critical point and both endpoints.

$$V(0) = 0, \qquad V(5) = 5 \cdot 20^2 = 5 \cdot 400 = 2000, \qquad V(15) = 0.$$

The largest value is $V(5) = 2000$, so the maximum volume is $\boxed{2000\ \text{cm}^3}$, achieved by cutting squares of side $\boxed{x = 5\ \text{cm}}$.

Pause

Pause and think. Look at the two critical numbers $x = 5$ and $x = 15$. Without writing down any algebra, what physical shape does $x = 15$ describe? *Answer*: Cutting 15 cm from each end of a 30 cm side consumes the entire cardboard sheet ($2 \times 15 = 30$). The base collapses to a crease of width zero, leaving a flat folded sheet with zero volume ($V = 0$). The calculus faithfully detected this flat degenerate case as a critical point alongside the genuine peak at $x = 5$.

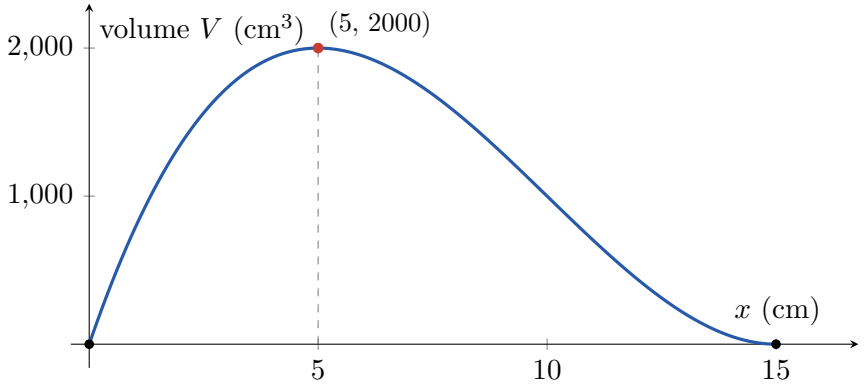


Figure 17.3: Volume of the box as a function of the corner cut x. It rises from zero, peaks at the lone interior critical point $x = 5$, and falls back to zero. The peak is the answer.

Work it yourself

Confirm the peak yourself with the second-derivative test. We have $V'(x) = 12x^2 - 240x + 900$, so $V''(x) = 24x - 240 = 24(x - 10)$. At the critical point, $V''(5) = 24(5 - 10) = -120 < 0$. A negative second derivative means the graph is concave down at $x = 5$, confirming a local maximum — a hilltop, not a valley. This agrees with the closed-interval comparison and gives a second, independent confirmation. Then sketch the graph from $V(0) = 0$, the peak at $(5, 2000)$, and $V(15) = 0$, and watch it match Figure 17.3.

Common trap

A very common slip on the box problem is to use the side of the base, $30 - 2x$, as the height, or to forget that you remove x from *both* ends of each side, writing the base as $30 - x$ instead of $30 - 2x$. Draw the picture every time. The factor of two comes straight from the two corners on each edge, and getting it wrong quietly ruins the whole answer while leaving the algebra looking perfectly healthy.

17.4 Worked example: the cheapest can

Now a problem where the constraint really does extra work, because the objective and the constraint involve different combinations of the variables.

Example 17.2 (The minimal-surface can)**.** A cylindrical can must hold exactly 355 cm^3 (a standard soda can). What radius and height minimize the surface area — that is, use the least metal?

Step 1 — picture and variables. A cylinder has radius r and height h (Figure 17.4).

Step 2 — objective. A closed can has a top disk, a bottom disk, and a wrapped-around side (the lateral surface). The two disks contribute $2\pi r^2$; the side, if you unroll it, is a rectangle of width $2\pi r$ (the circumference) and height h, contributing $2\pi rh$. So the surface area is

$$A = 2\pi r^2 + 2\pi rh.$$

This has *two* variables. We cannot differentiate it yet.

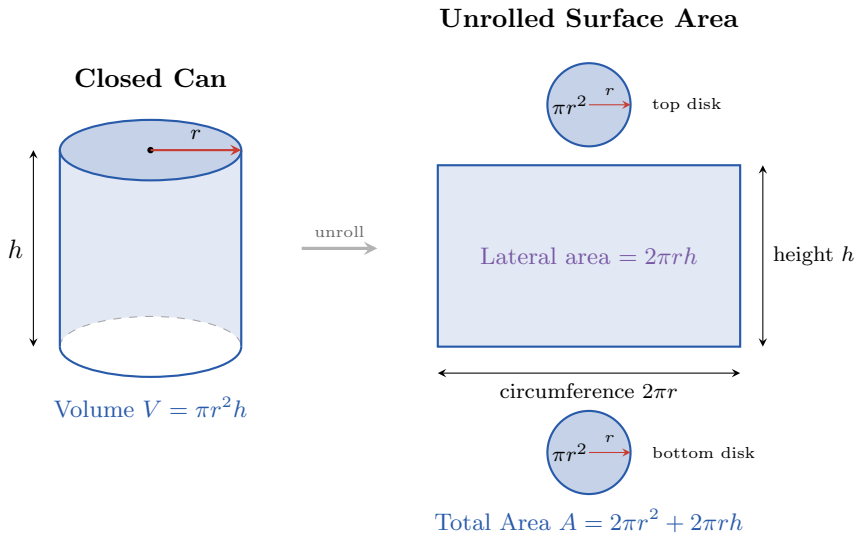


Figure 17.4: Geometry of the cylindrical can. A closed can of radius r and height h unrolls into two circular disks of area πr^2 each, plus a rectangular lateral jacket of width $2\pi r$ (the circumference of the cylinder) and height h. The total surface area to minimize is $A(r, h) = 2\pi r^2 + 2\pi rh$.

Step 3 — constraint. The volume is fixed:

$$\pi r^2 h = 355.$$

Step 4 — reduce to one variable. Solve the constraint for the variable that is easiest to isolate. Here h comes out cleanly:

$$h = \frac{355}{\pi r^2}.$$

Substitute into the objective so that A depends on r alone:

$$A(r) = 2\pi r^2 + 2\pi r \cdot \frac{355}{\pi r^2} = 2\pi r^2 + \frac{710}{r}.$$

Step 5 — domain. Any positive radius gives a valid can (with h adjusting to keep the volume right), so the domain is $r > 0$, the open interval $(0, \infty)$. This is *not* a closed bounded interval, so the closed-interval method does not apply directly — we will instead use the shape of $A(r)$ to confirm the minimum. Notice what happens at the ends: as $r \to 0^+$, the term $710/r \to \infty$ (a tall thin can has a huge side area); as $r \to \infty$, the term $2\pi r^2 \to \infty$ (a wide flat can has huge disks). So $A \to \infty$ at both ends, which already tells us a minimum sits somewhere in the middle.

Step 6 — differentiate.

$$A'(r) = 4\pi r - \frac{710}{r^2}.$$

Set it to zero:

$$4\pi r = \frac{710}{r^2} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad 4\pi r^3 = 710 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad r^3 = \frac{710}{4\pi} = \frac{177.5}{\pi}.$$

So

$$r = \left(\frac{177.5}{\pi}\right)^{1/3} \approx (56.50)^{1/3} \approx 3.837 \text{ cm}.$$

And the height is

$$h = \frac{355}{\pi r^2} \approx \frac{355}{\pi(3.837)^2} \approx \frac{355}{46.25} \approx 7.675 \text{ cm}.$$

Step 7 — confirm it is a minimum. Two independent checks:

- *Second derivative.* $A''(r) = 4\pi + \dfrac{1420}{r^3} > 0$ for every $r > 0$. The function is concave up everywhere, so the single critical point is a minimum — in fact the *global* minimum, since a function that is concave up on all of $(0, \infty)$ can have only one turning point.
- *End behavior.* We saw $A \to \infty$ as $r \to 0^+$ and as $r \to \infty$, with exactly one critical point in between. A continuous function that climbs to infinity at both ends and turns around once must turn at a minimum (Figure 17.5).

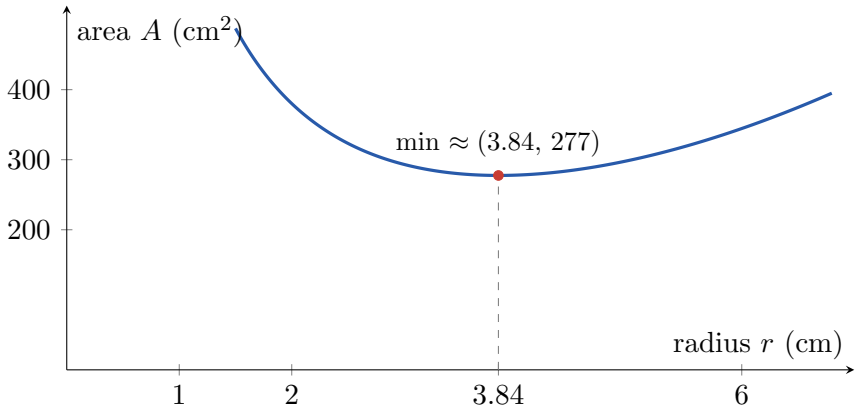


Figure 17.5: Surface area of a 355 cm^3 can as a function of radius. The two terms pull in opposite directions: $710/r$ grows large for thin cans, while $2\pi r^2$ grows large for wide cans. The trade-off yields a unique global minimum.

Why this matters

Look at the answer: $h \approx 7.675$ and $r \approx 3.837$, so $h = 2r$. The most efficient closed can is exactly as *tall* as it is *wide* — its height equals its diameter, so it fits snugly inside a cube. This ratio does not depend on the specific number 355; you get $h = 2r$ for *any* fixed volume. Try it symbolically: minimizing $A = 2\pi r^2 + 2V/r$ gives $4\pi r = 2V/r^2$, i.e. $2\pi r^3 = V = \pi r^2 h$, which simplifies to $h = 2r$ no matter what V is. A clean, scale-free fact sits under the arithmetic. (Real soda cans are taller and thinner than this — because the seams and the thicker top cost extra metal the simple model ignores, and because a hand likes a narrower grip. The math is right; the model is just simpler than a real can.)

Why the technique works

Why does substituting the constraint give the right answer, rather than some distortion? Because the constraint equation $\pi r^2 h = 355$ does not throw any cans away — it simply records that for each radius there is exactly one matching height. The substitution walks along the *curve of all valid cans* in the (r, h) plane, and $A(r)$ is the genuine surface area of the one valid can with that radius. We are not approximating; we are restricting attention to the

feasible set and reading off its true area. Minimizing along the trail gives the minimum over all valid cans, which is exactly what was asked. This is why "reduce to one variable" loses nothing: the eliminated variable was never free — the constraint had already decided it.

17.5 Worked example: the fence with a free side

A constraint can also be the thing in short supply. This is the classic farmer problem, and it teaches a lesson about reading the geometry before reaching for algebra.

Example 17.3 (Maximum field, one free side)**.** A farmer has 200 m of fencing and wants to enclose a rectangular field. One side of the field runs along a straight river and needs no fence. What dimensions enclose the *largest area*?

Step 1 — picture and variables. Call the two sides perpendicular to the river x (there are two of them) and the side parallel to the river y (there is one of it — the opposite, river side, is free); see Figure 17.6.

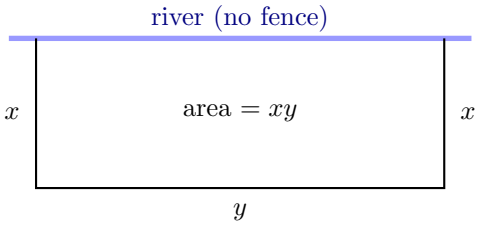


Figure 17.6: Three sides are fenced; the river bounds the fourth for free. Fencing used is $2x + y$.

Step 2 — objective. Maximize the area

$$A = xy.$$

Step 3 — constraint. Only three sides use fence, and there are 200 m of it:

$$2x + y = 200.$$

Step 4 — reduce. Solve the constraint for y: $y = 200 - 2x$. Substitute:

$$A(x) = x(200 - 2x) = 200x - 2x^2.$$

Step 5 — domain. We need $x > 0$ and $y = 200 - 2x > 0$, so $0 < x < 100$; including the degenerate endpoints (zero area) gives the closed interval $[0, 100]$, and again the Extreme Value Theorem guarantees a maximum.

Step 6 — differentiate.

$$A'(x) = 200 - 4x = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x = 50.$$

Then $y = 200 - 2(50) = 100$.

Step 7 — test. Closed-interval comparison:

$$A(0) = 0, \qquad A(50) = 50 \cdot 100 = 5000, \qquad A(100) = 0.$$

The maximum area is $\boxed{5000 \text{ m}^2}$, with the two short sides $x = 50$ m and the long side $y = 100$ m. (The second derivative $A'' = -4 < 0$ confirms concave down, a maximum.)

Intuition

Notice the answer splits the fence in a memorable way: the single parallel side y uses 100 m and the two perpendicular sides together also use $2x = 100$ m. The fence is divided *equally* between the direction along the river and the direction across it. That balance — spend half your resource each way — is the recurring signature of these rectangle problems, and once you have seen it you can often guess the answer before differentiating, then use calculus to confirm.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose the farmer had 300 m of fence instead of 200 m, still bordering a straight river. Using the "split the resource equally between the two directions" rule from the intuition box above, can you find the optimal dimensions in your head? *Answer*: Half the fence (150 m) goes to the single side y parallel to the river. The remaining half (150 m) is split equally between the two perpendicular sides, giving $x = 75$ m. The maximum area is $75 \times 150 = 11{,}250$ m^2. Differentiating $A(x) = x(300 - 2x)$ gives $A'(x) = 300 - 4x = 0$, confirming $x = 75$.

Common trap

The free side changes the constraint, not the area. A frequent error is to fence all four sides out of habit, writing $2x + 2y = 200$, or to optimize the perimeter instead of the area. Always ask: *which* quantity is fixed (the constraint) and *which* am I trying to make extreme (the objective)? Here the fence is fixed and the area is free to grow. Swapping their roles — maximizing the fence — is a question with no answer, and that absurdity is your signal that you mislabeled them.

17.6 Worked example: the closest point

Distance problems hide a small but important computational trick, and they show off the closed-interval reasoning on a domain that is genuinely infinite.

Example 17.4 (Nearest point on a parabola)**.** Find the point on the parabola $y = x^2$ that is closest to the point $(0, 2)$.

Step 1–2 — variables and objective. A point on the parabola is (x, x^2). Its distance to $(0, 2)$ is

$$D(x) = \sqrt{(x - 0)^2 + (x^2 - 2)^2} = \sqrt{x^2 + (x^2 - 2)^2}.$$

We want to minimize this.

The trick. Minimizing the distance D is the same as minimizing the *squared* distance $S = D^2$, because squaring is an increasing function on $[0, \infty)$ — wherever D is smallest, D^2 is smallest too, and at the same x. So we minimize the square-root-free

$$S(x) = x^2 + (x^2 - 2)^2,$$

which is far easier to differentiate. This substitution costs nothing and saves a chain-rule-through-a-square-root mess.

Why the technique works

Why are you allowed to minimize D^2 instead of D? Because the squaring map $t \mapsto t^2$ is strictly increasing for $t \geq 0$, and distances are never negative. A strictly increasing function preserves order: if $D(a) < D(b)$ then $D(a)^2 < D(b)^2$, and vice versa. So D and D^2 rise and fall in lockstep; they have their minimum at the *same* x. The only thing that changes is the messiness of the derivative. This is a general and very useful move: you may replace your objective by any strictly increasing function of it (square it, take its log, etc.) without moving the location of the optimum. Optimizers reach for logs and squares constantly for exactly this reason.

Step 3 — domain. Any real x gives a point on the parabola, so the domain is all of $\mathbb{R} = (-\infty, \infty)$. As $|x| \to \infty$ the point on the parabola shoots off to infinity, so $S \to \infty$ at both ends; a minimum exists in the middle.

Step 4 — differentiate. Expand:

$$S(x) = x^2 + x^4 - 4x^2 + 4 = x^4 - 3x^2 + 4.$$

Then

$$S'(x) = 4x^3 - 6x = 2x(2x^2 - 3).$$

Step 5 — critical points. $S'(x) = 0$ gives $x = 0$ or $2x^2 = 3$, i.e. $x = \pm\sqrt{3/2} = \pm\sqrt{1.5} \approx \pm 1.225$.

Step 6 — test. Compare the squared distances at the three critical points:

$$S(0) = 0 - 0 + 4 = 4,$$

$$S\left(\pm\sqrt{1.5}\right) = (1.5)^2 - 3(1.5) + 4 = 2.25 - 4.5 + 4 = 1.75.$$

The smaller value 1.75 wins, so the closest points are $\left(\pm\sqrt{1.5},\, 1.5\right)$, at distance $D = \sqrt{1.75} \approx 1.323$ (Figure 17.7).

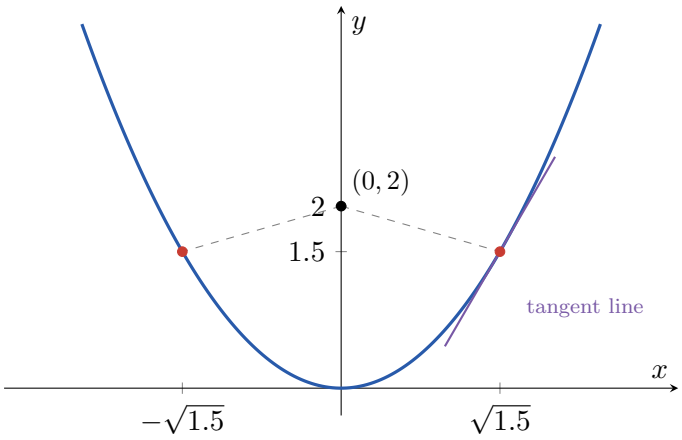


Figure 17.7: The two closest points on $y = x^2$ to the target $(0, 2)$, at $x = \pm\sqrt{1.5}$. At the minimum, the connecting segment (dashed) meets the curve's tangent line perpendicularly. The vertex $x = 0$ is also a critical point, but there the squared distance is locally largest (a local maximum of S, hence locally farthest), so it loses the comparison.

Common trap

The vertex $x = 0$ is a genuine critical point — $S'(0) = 0$ — but it is *not* the answer. In fact S has a local *maximum* there: among the three critical points the vertex is locally the farthest from $(0, 2)$, not the nearest, and the comparison exposes it. This is exactly why you never stop at "I found where $S' = 0$." You must evaluate S at *all* the critical points and compare the resulting values. Had you found only $x = 0$ and quit, you would have reported a local maximum instead of the minimum.

Connection

A pretty piece of geometry sits behind the algebra. At the true closest point, the segment from $(0, 2)$ to the curve is *perpendicular* to the parabola's tangent line. To see why: if the connecting segment met the curve at any other angle, you could slide a little along the curve and get closer, because part of your motion would be "toward" the target. Only when the segment is perpendicular is there no closer direction to slide. This "shortest distance is along the normal" principle reappears throughout physics (light takes the perpendicular-incidence path, a stretched string pulls along the normal) and is the geometric soul of the Lagrange multiplier method you will meet in multivariable calculus. The condition $S'(x) = 0$ and the condition "segment $\perp$ tangent" are the same statement in two languages.

Pause

Pause and think. Why did the vertex $x = 0$ show up as a critical point of the distance function $S(x)$ at all? If you stand at the target $(0, 2)$ and look down at the origin $(0, 0)$, the distance is 2. If you take a tiny step along the parabola to either side, say to $(\pm 0.2, 0.04)$, does the distance to $(0, 2)$ grow or shrink? *Answer*: The squared distance to $(\pm 0.2, 0.04)$ is $(0.2)^2 + (0.04 - 2)^2 = 0.04 + 3.8416 = 3.8816 < 4$. Stepping away from the vertex actually brings the curve *closer* to $(0, 2)$. The vertex is a local peak of distance (locally farthest), which is why the derivative condition $S'(0) = 0$ detected it as a local maximum.

17.7 A profit example: optimization beyond geometry

Optimization is not only about boxes and fences. The same method runs economics, biology, and machine learning. Here is an example from economics.

Example 17.5 (Maximizing profit)**.** A workshop can sell x handmade lamps per week. Market research says that to sell x lamps the price per lamp must be $p(x) = 120 - 2x$ dollars (sell more, charge less). Each lamp costs \$20 to make, plus \$300 in fixed weekly overhead. How many lamps maximize weekly profit?

Objective. Profit is revenue minus cost. Revenue is price times quantity:

$$R(x) = x\,p(x) = x(120 - 2x) = 120x - 2x^2.$$

Cost is overhead plus per-unit cost:

$$C(x) = 300 + 20x.$$

So profit is

$$P(x) = R(x) - C(x) = (120x - 2x^2) - (300 + 20x) = -2x^2 + 100x - 300.$$

Domain. We need $x \geq 0$, and keeping the price nonnegative ($120 - 2x \geq 0$) gives $x \leq 60$. Including the zero-output and zero-price boundaries gives $0 \leq x \leq 60$ (a closed bounded interval — the Extreme Value Theorem applies).

Differentiate.

$$P'(x) = -4x + 100 = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x = 25.$$

Test. Since $P''(x) = -4 < 0$ everywhere (and the endpoints lose money, with $P(0) = -300$ and $P(60) = -1500$), $x = 25$ is the global maximum on $[0, 60]$. The profit is

$$P(25) = -2(625) + 100(25) - 300 = -1250 + 2500 - 300 = 950.$$

Make $\boxed{\text{25 lamps per week for \$950 profit}}$, at a price of $p(25) = 120 - 50 = \$70$ each.

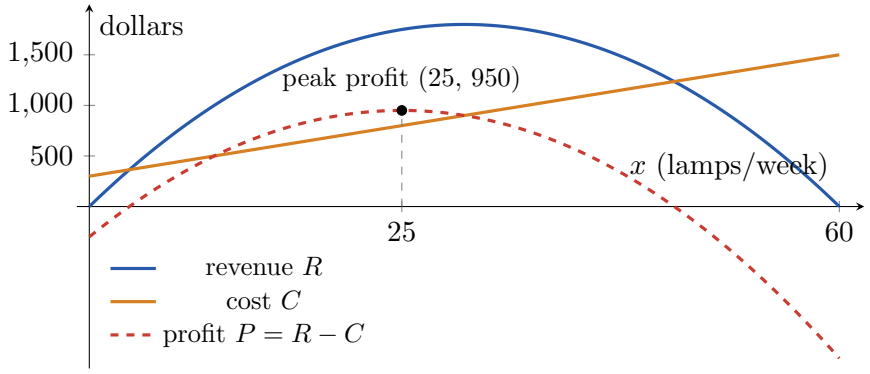


Figure 17.8: Revenue, cost, and profit for the lamp workshop. Profit peaks where its slope is zero — equivalently, where the revenue and cost curves are momentarily climbing at the *same* rate, i.e. marginal revenue equals marginal cost (at $x = 25$).

Application

Economists recognize the condition $P'(x) = 0$ as the famous rule *marginal revenue equals marginal cost*. Watch: $P' = R' - C'$, so $P' = 0$ means $R'(x) = C'(x)$. The derivative R' is the extra revenue from selling one more unit (marginal revenue) and C' is the extra cost of making one more unit (marginal cost). The rule says: keep producing as long as the next unit brings in more than it costs, and stop the instant they balance (Figure 17.8). Past that point each extra lamp costs more than it earns and profit falls. The entire theory of the profit-maximizing firm is this one derivative set to zero — the same Fermat condition as the cardboard box, in the language of money.

Application

The same skeleton drives modern machine learning. Training a model means choosing parameters to *minimize* a loss function — the objective is the error, the variables are the millions of weights, and "learning" is optimization. There is no clean constraint to substitute and no formula for the answer, so instead of solving $\nabla(\text{loss}) = 0$ exactly, the computer rolls downhill: it repeatedly steps in the direction the gradient says decreases the loss fastest (gradient descent). But the target is unchanged from this chapter — a place where the derivative vanishes, a stationary point of the objective. Every example here is a hand-solvable instance of what a neural network does numerically a billion times over.

17.8 When the candidate is not the answer: pitfalls and checks

The single most common way to lose points — and to be flatly wrong in real life — is to find a critical point and *assume* it is the extreme you want. It might be a minimum when you wanted a maximum. It might be a local extreme beaten by an endpoint. It might be a saddle-like inflection that is neither. Here is how to make sure.

Focus

Three ways to confirm you found the right extreme.

1. **Closed-interval method** (best when the domain is a closed bounded interval): evaluate the objective at every critical point and both endpoints, then read off the largest/smallest. The Extreme Value Theorem guarantees the winner is in your list. No further argument needed.

2. **First-derivative test** (works on any interval): check the sign of f' just left and just right of the critical point. Sign change $+ \to -$ means a local max; $- \to +$ means a local min; no change means neither.

3. **Second-derivative test** (quick when f'' is easy): at a critical point, $f'' < 0$ means local max (concave down), $f'' > 0$ means local min (concave up). If $f'' = 0$ the test is silent — fall back to method 1 or 2.

For an *open* or *unbounded* domain, also check the behavior at the open ends (limits as x approaches the boundary or $\pm\infty$) to be sure a max or min exists at all.

Common trap

The endpoint that wins. Suppose you must minimize $f(x) = x^3 - 3x$ on $[0, 3]$. The critical points solve $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 3 = 0$, giving $x = \pm 1$; only $x = 1$ is in the domain, and there $f(1) = 1 - 3 = -2$. If you stopped there you would report the minimum as -2 — and you would be right. But if instead the problem asked for the *maximum* on $[0, 3]$, the critical point $x = 1$ is a local *minimum*, not a maximum at all. The maximum lives at the endpoint: $f(3) = 27 - 9 = 18$ versus $f(0) = 0$. The lesson: the interesting answer is sometimes at the edge of the domain, where the derivative never vanishes (Figure 17.9). *Always check the endpoints.*

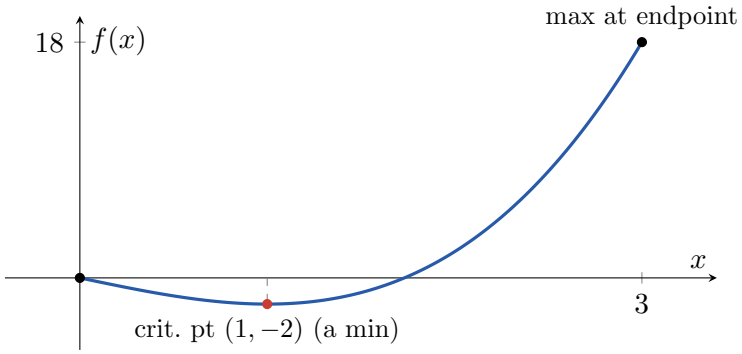


Figure 17.9: $f(x) = x^3 - 3x$ on $[0, 3]$. The only interior critical point is a *minimum*; the maximum occurs at the right endpoint. Find the critical points, and compare objective values across all candidates including endpoints.

Walking question

Take a walk and think about *existence* versus *location*. The derivative is a tool for *location*: it points at where an extreme could be. But it says nothing about whether an extreme *exists*. What guarantees existence? On a closed bounded interval, continuity does (the Extreme Value Theorem). On an open or infinite domain you need something else — the function running off to infinity at both ends, say, or a single turning point. Ask yourself: for each worked example in this chapter, *what* guaranteed the answer existed before I trusted the critical point? You will find the closed-interval cases leaned on the theorem, while the can and the distance problems leaned on $\to \infty$ end-behavior. Existence and location are two separate questions, and a complete solution answers both.

What is really happening

When a problem has no maximum, the symptom is usually that the objective improves forever as you slide toward a boundary the domain does not include. For instance, "find the rectangle of largest area with perimeter at most 100" has an answer, whereas "find the rectangle of largest area" (with no constraint) does not — you can always make a bigger one. The constraint is what bounds the feasible set and lets a best exist. So when a real optimization has no solution, the deepest fix is rarely more calculus; it is finding the missing constraint — the budget, the material limit, the physical wall — that the problem forgot to state. Calculus locates the

optimum; modeling guarantees there is one to locate.

17.9 A fully general template, worked symbolically

To cement that the method is one method, let us do the fence problem's cousin *with letters instead of numbers*, so you can see the structure stand on its own.

Example 17.6 (Largest rectangle inscribed under a parabola)**.** A rectangle sits with its base on the x-axis and its top two corners on the downward parabola $y = c - x^2$ (with $c > 0$), symmetric about the y-axis. What width makes its area largest?

Variables. By symmetry the top corners are at $(\pm x, c - x^2)$ for some $x > 0$. The rectangle then has width $2x$ and height $c - x^2$.

Objective.

$$A(x) = (\text{width})(\text{height}) = 2x\,(c - x^2) = 2cx - 2x^3.$$

Domain. We need the top corners above the axis, $c - x^2 \geq 0$, so $0 \leq x \leq \sqrt{c}$ — a closed bounded interval.

Differentiate.

$$A'(x) = 2c - 6x^2 = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x^2 = \frac{c}{3} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x = \sqrt{c/3}.$$

Test. The endpoints give $A(0) = 0$ and $A(\sqrt{c}) = 0$, while the critical point gives a positive value, so the critical point is the maximum. (Or use $A''(x) = -12x < 0$ for $x > 0$.) The maximal area is

$$A\Big(\sqrt{c/3}\Big) = 2\sqrt{\tfrac{c}{3}}\,\big(c - \tfrac{c}{3}\big) = 2\sqrt{\tfrac{c}{3}} \cdot \tfrac{2c}{3} = \frac{4c}{3}\sqrt{\frac{c}{3}}.$$

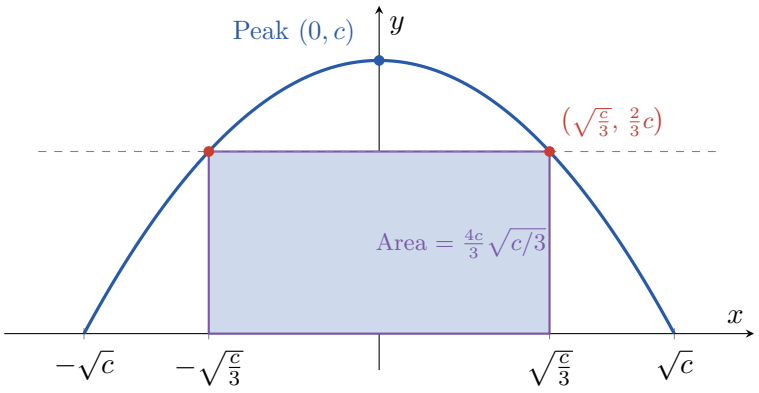


Figure 17.10: The optimal rectangle inscribed under the parabola $y = c - x^2$ (shown for $c = 3$). The upper corners meet the curve at $x = \pm\sqrt{c/3}$, fixing the optimal height at exactly two-thirds of the parabola's maximum height: $y = \frac{2}{3}c$.

Why this matters

The optimal height is $c - x^2 = c - \frac{c}{3} = \frac{2c}{3}$ — exactly *two-thirds* of the parabola's peak height c, no matter what c is. The best rectangle always reaches two-thirds of the way up. Solving the problem once, with a letter, reveals a clean ratio that a hundred numerical versions would only hint at.

17.10 Summary: the shape of every solution

Focus

What to carry away.

- Optimization = objective + constraint + domain. The first and hardest job is *modeling*: turning words and pictures into a one-variable function on a definite domain.
- The constraint is your friend: it is what lets you eliminate variables and reach a single-variable function the derivative can handle.
- Critical points (where $f' = 0$ or f' is undefined) are *candidates*, not answers. Endpoints are candidates too.
- On a closed bounded interval, the Extreme Value Theorem guarantees a best exists, and the closed-interval method finds it by comparing values — no derivative test required.
- On open or infinite domains, you must separately argue that an extreme exists (end behavior, concavity, or a single turning point).
- Confirm with the closed-interval comparison, the first-derivative test, or the second-derivative test — and always sanity-check units and plausibility.
- The very same condition — Fermat's vanishing slope — recurs across geometry, physics, economics, and machine learning.

17.10.1 Optimization and Its Limits

Connection

Optimization gave calculus its primary mandate in the physical and commercial world. Through Fermat's stationarity principle and the closed-interval method:

- *Physical variational principles*: Light rays, gravitational orbits, and hanging chains follow trajectories that make fundamental physical quantities like travel time and action stationary.
- *Engineering design*: Structural arches, beverage containers, and mechanical linkages can be designed to minimize material consumption, minimize aerodynamic drag, or maximize structural rigidity under physical constraints.
- *Economic equilibrium*: Monopolists and competitive firms determine profit-maximizing

production levels by equating marginal revenue to marginal cost ($R'(q) = C'(q)$).

The bridge to Chapter 18: Indeterminate forms at the boundary. When we optimized the soda can and the distance to the parabola, our domain was open or unbounded ($r \in (0, \infty)$ or $x \in (-\infty, \infty)$). To guarantee a minimum, we had to examine what happens at the boundary by taking limits. In those simple examples, individual terms like $710/r$ or $2\pi r^2$ clearly blew up to infinity. But in richer, more realistic models — such as balancing air drag against fuel consumption, or finding the optimal cruising speed of an aircraft — the boundary limits often pit competing effects against each other, yielding ambiguous expressions like $\frac{0}{0}$, $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, or $0 \cdot \infty$. Ordinary arithmetic cannot evaluate these "indeterminate forms." To know whether an objective explodes, collapses to zero, or levels off to an optimal boundary value, we need a rigorous tool that compares the *rates* at which competing factors grow or shrink. That tool is **L'Hôpital's Rule**, the subject of Chapter 18.

Looking further: When algebra stalls and variables multiply. Two further hurdles await in applied optimization:

1. *Nonlinear critical points*: In our examples, $f'(x) = 0$ factored into neat polynomials. In real engineering, setting $f'(x) = 0$ frequently produces transcendental equations (such as $xe^x = 5$ or $x = \tan x$) that cannot be solved by algebraic factoring. In Chapter 19, we build **Newton's Method** — using the tangent line iteratively to zero in on roots of $f'(x) = 0$ with rapid quadratic convergence.

2. *The multivariable frontier*: Real-world systems depend on dozens or billions of coupled variables with nonlinear constraints that cannot be solved for one variable in terms of the others. In Chapter 33, we reach the multivariable tool for constrained optimization: **Lagrange multipliers**. Instead of algebraically eliminating variables, we optimize an objective $f(\mathbf{x})$ subject to $g(\mathbf{x}) = c$ by recognizing that at an optimum, the contour of f must be tangent to the constraint path g, aligning their normal gradient vectors: $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$.

17.11 Exercises

Exercise 17.1 (Mental check: where can the maximum hide?)**.** A continuous function f is defined on the closed interval $[-2, 4]$. If $f'(x) = 0$ only at $x = 1$, what is the complete list of candidate points where the absolute maximum of f could possibly occur? If instead the domain were the open interval $(-2, 4)$, could you still guarantee that an absolute maximum exists?

Exercise 17.2 (Mental check: the square-root shortcut)**.** You are asked to find the point on a curve $y = g(x)$ closest to the point $(3, 1)$. Explain in one sentence why minimizing $(x-3)^2 + (g(x)-1)^2$ produces the exact same optimal x as minimizing $\sqrt{(x-3)^2 + (g(x)-1)^2}$, and why this simplifies your work.

Exercise 17.3 (Open-top box, rectangular sheet)**.** A box with an open top is made from a 16 cm $\times$ 10 cm rectangle of cardboard by cutting equal squares of side x from the corners and folding up the sides. (a) Write the volume $V(x)$. (b) State the domain of x. (c) Find the cut x that maximizes the volume, and give the maximum volume. (d) Confirm with the second-derivative test.

Exercise 17.4 (The cheapest open-top can)**.** An *open-top* cylindrical can (no lid) must hold 1000 cm^3. (a) Write the surface area as a function of the radius r alone. (b) Find the radius and height that

minimize the metal used. (c) Show that for the open-top can the optimal height equals the radius, $h = r$ — contrast this with $h = 2r$ for the closed can, and explain in words why losing the lid makes the optimal can relatively shorter.

Exercise 17.5 (Fence with a divider)**.** A farmer has 240 m of fencing to build a rectangular pen *and* an internal fence parallel to one side that splits the pen into two equal halves. (a) If x is the length of the divided direction (so three segments of length x are needed) and y the other, write the constraint and the area objective. (b) Find the dimensions of maximum total area. (c) How does the answer compare to the no-divider case?

Exercise 17.6 (Closest point on a line)**.** Find the point on the line $y = 2x + 1$ closest to the origin. (a) Minimize the *squared* distance and explain why that is legitimate. (b) Verify that the segment from the origin to your point is perpendicular to the line, and explain geometrically why it must be.

Exercise 17.7 (Norman window)**.** A "Norman window" is a rectangle topped by a semicircle whose diameter equals the rectangle's width. The total perimeter is fixed at P meters. Find the dimensions admitting the most light (i.e. the largest area). Express the optimal rectangle width in terms of P.

Exercise 17.8 (Maximum-area triangle)**.** Among all right triangles with legs summing to a fixed length L (so $\text{leg}_1 + \text{leg}_2 = L$), find the one with the largest area. What is special about its shape? Prove your answer is a maximum, not a minimum.

Exercise 17.9 (An endpoint maximum)**.** Find the absolute maximum and absolute minimum of $f(x) = x^3 - 6x^2 + 9x + 2$ on the closed interval $[0, 5]$ using the closed-interval method. Identify which extreme occurs at a critical point and which (if any) at an endpoint.

Exercise 17.10 (Time, not distance: the lifeguard problem)**.** A lifeguard at point A on a straight beach must reach a swimmer at point B in the water. She runs along the sand at speed v_1 and swims at the slower speed $v_2 < v_1$. Setting up coordinates so the shoreline is the x-axis, $A = (0, a)$ with $a > 0$, and $B = (d, -h)$ with $h > 0$, she enters the water at the point $(x, 0)$. (a) Write the total travel *time* $T(x)$. (b) Show that $T'(x) = 0$ leads to the condition $\dfrac{\sin\theta_1}{\sin\theta_2} = \dfrac{v_1}{v_2}$, where θ_1, θ_2 are the angles the running and swimming paths make with the line perpendicular to the shore. (This is *Snell's law of refraction* — light minimizes travel time the same way.)

Exercise 17.11 (Why $h = 2r$, in general)**.** For a closed cylindrical can of fixed volume V, minimize the surface area *symbolically* (keep V as a letter) and prove that the optimal can always satisfies $h = 2r$, independent of V. Then prove the critical point is a minimum using the second derivative.

Exercise 17.12 (Conceptual: existence)**.** Give an example of a continuous function on an *open* interval that has a critical point which is not its absolute maximum, and explain why the closed-interval method cannot be applied. Then state precisely what additional information would let you conclude that an absolute maximum exists.

Exercise 17.13 (Proof: substitution preserves the optimum)**.** Suppose you minimize $f(x)$ over a domain D, and g is a strictly increasing function defined on the range of f. Prove that f and $g \circ f$ attain their minimum at exactly the same points of D. (This is the theorem that justifies minimizing D^2 instead of D, or minimizing a log-likelihood instead of a likelihood.)

Chapter 18

L'Hopital's Rule and Indeterminate Forms

In the previous chapter, we put derivatives to work solving optimization problems—hunting for peaks and valleys where marginal gains balance marginal costs, and testing boundary behavior as physical parameters stretch toward zero or infinity. But when you push an objective function to a critical boundary, elementary arithmetic frequently grinds to a halt. You plug in the boundary value and get not a number, but a piece of apparent nonsense like $\frac{0}{0}$, $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, or $0 \cdot \infty$.

Some limits answer themselves. If you want $\lim_{x\to 2}(x^2+1)$, you put in 2 and read off 5; continuity does the work and there is nothing to think about. The interesting limits are the ones that *refuse* to answer themselves — the ones where substituting the target value produces an ambiguous ratio like $\frac{0}{0}$ or $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$. These are the *indeterminate forms*, and despite the menacing name they are not rare pathology: they are the most important limits in all of calculus. The derivative that powered our optimization work is built on one: $f'(a) = \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{f(a+h)-f(a)}{h}$ is an indeterminate form of type $\frac{0}{0}$ in every single instance.

This chapter is about *L'Hôpital's rule*, which evaluates a large class of these forms by comparing rates of change: when a ratio approaches $\frac{0}{0}$, the limit is decided not by the values of the two functions (both approaching zero) but by the *rates* at which they approach zero. Replacing the functions by their derivatives yields the limit. We will see why that is true, where it comes from, exactly when it is valid, and common errors to avoid. And along the way we will return to a question from earlier in the book — which functions grow faster than which — and establish a rigorous hierarchy.

18.1 What "indeterminate" really means

Start by getting the word right, because almost everyone misreads it. An indeterminate form is *not* an expression with no value. It is an expression whose value is *not determined by the form alone*. That is a precise and different claim, and the whole subject hinges on it.

Focus

"Indeterminate" is a statement about *information*, not about *impossibility*. The symbol $\frac{0}{0}$ indicates that both the numerator and denominator tend to zero — but it does not specify

how rapidly, which is what determines the limit.

To feel why $\frac{0}{0}$ genuinely carries no answer, watch four limits that all wear that same face as $x \to 0$, yet land in four different places:

$$\frac{2x}{x} \to 2, \qquad \frac{x}{x^2} \to \infty, \qquad \frac{x^2}{x} \to 0, \qquad \frac{x}{x} \to 1.$$

In every one, plugging in $x = 0$ gives $\frac{0}{0}$. If $\frac{0}{0}$ had a fixed value, all four would have to share it. They do not: the answers are 2, ∞, 0, and 1. So $\frac{0}{0}$ cannot be a number. It is a *question*, and the answer depends entirely on the relative speed of the vanishing.

Intuition

Think of two runners both decelerating to a dead stop at the finish line. The ratio of their *remaining distances* as they crawl in is $\frac{0}{0}$ — both gaps go to zero. But whether that ratio approaches 2 or $\frac{1}{2}$ or 1 depends only on their relative *speeds* near the line. The runner who is still moving twice as fast keeps twice the gap. The form $\frac{0}{0}$ hides the speeds; L'Hôpital's rule hands them back to you as derivatives.

Contrast this with a form that is *not* indeterminate. The expression $\frac{1}{0}$ (a nonzero number over something shrinking to zero) is not indeterminate: it blows up, with a sign you can usually pin down. And $\frac{0}{1}$ is not indeterminate either: it is just 0. The trouble appears only when a "smallness" or a "largeness" competes against another of the same kind, so that neither wins automatically.

Focus

The seven indeterminate forms. Up to the tricks of this chapter, all the indeterminacy in elementary calculus comes in seven flavors:

$$\frac{0}{0}, \qquad \frac{\infty}{\infty}, \qquad 0 \cdot \infty, \qquad \infty - \infty, \qquad 1^\infty, \qquad 0^0, \qquad \infty^0.$$

The first two are ratios — L'Hôpital's rule attacks them directly. The middle two, $0 \cdot \infty$ and $\infty - \infty$, are ratios written in another form; we rewrite them as $\frac{0}{0}$ or $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$. The last three are *powers*; we take a logarithm to drag them down into a product, then into a ratio. Everything reduces to the first two.

Common trap

Do not put forms like $\frac{\infty}{0}$, 0^∞, $\infty + \infty$, or $\frac{1}{0}$ on the indeterminate list. They are *determinate*: $\frac{1}{0}$ diverges, $0^\infty = 0$, $\infty + \infty = \infty$, $\frac{\infty}{0}$ diverges. The test is always the same — is there a genuine competition where the answer could come out anywhere depending on the rates? If both forces push in the same direction, the form is not indeterminate and you should just read off the answer.

Pause

Mental check: indeterminate or determinate? Before reading on, test your intuition on

these four candidate limits as $x \to 0^+$:

$$\text{(a) } \frac{0}{x}, \qquad \text{(b) } \frac{1+\cos x}{x}, \qquad \text{(c) } x^{1/x}, \qquad \text{(d) } x^{\sin x}.$$

Which represent a genuine tug-of-war, and which are settled immediately?

(a) *Determinate (0):* The numerator is identically zero for every $x > 0$ before any limit is taken, so the fraction equals 0 at every stage.

(b) *Determinate ($+\infty$):* The numerator approaches $2 > 0$ while the positive denominator shrinks toward 0, so the ratio blows up to $+\infty$.

(c) *Determinate (0):* As $x \to 0^+$, the base sinks toward 0 while the exponent $1/x \to +\infty$; both effects drive $x^{1/x}$ toward 0 (form $0^\infty = 0$). (By contrast, as $x \to \infty$, $x^{1/x}$ has form ∞^0, which *is* indeterminate.)

(d) *Indeterminate (0^0):* The base $x \to 0^+$ pulls the expression toward 0, while the exponent $\sin x \to 0$ pulls it toward 1 — a genuine contest resolved later via logarithms.

18.2 The ratio-of-rates idea

Here is the insight that makes the whole chapter. Slow down for it. Suppose $f(a) = 0$ and $g(a) = 0$, and we want

$$\lim_{x \to a} \frac{f(x)}{g(x)}.$$

Near $x = a$ both functions are small. But "small" is not one number — a smooth function that passes through zero is, very close to that zero, almost exactly a straight line: its tangent line—the best linear approximation to the curve nearby. Concretely, for x near a,

$$f(x) \approx f(a) + f'(a)(x-a) = f'(a)\,(x-a), \qquad g(x) \approx g(a) + g'(a)(x-a) = g'(a)\,(x-a),$$

because $f(a) = g(a) = 0$ kills the constant terms. Now form the ratio and watch the common factor $(x-a)$ cancel:

$$\frac{f(x)}{g(x)} \approx \frac{f'(a)\,(x-a)}{g'(a)\,(x-a)} = \frac{f'(a)}{g'(a)}.$$

The vanishing $(x-a)$ in the numerator and denominator was the entire source of the $\frac{0}{0}$ trouble — and it cancels. What survives is the ratio of the two *slopes* at a. That is L'Hôpital's rule, glimpsed through the linear approximation.

What is really happening

What is really happening in $\frac{0}{0}$. Both functions are diving toward zero, and near their common zero each one is essentially its tangent line — a number (its slope) times the same small quantity $(x-a)$. The ratio of two such lines is the ratio of their slopes; the small quantity $(x-a)$ cancels top and bottom and never gets a chance to be "zero over zero." So the limit is not really $\frac{0}{0}$ at all. It is $\frac{f'(a)}{g'(a)}$ — the ratio of the rates at which the two functions leave zero. L'Hôpital's rule is the act of looking past the values, which are both 0 and tell you nothing, to the slopes, which decide everything.

Look back at the four warm-up limits with this lens. For $\frac{2x}{x}$ the slopes at 0 are 2 and 1, ratio 2. For $\frac{x^2}{x}$ the numerator leaves zero with slope 0 (it is flat there) while the denominator has slope 1, ratio 0. For $\frac{x}{x^2}$ it is $\frac{1}{0}$, which is why that one blew up. The ratio of slopes predicts each answer exactly. The picture below shows the mechanism: near the shared zero, f and g are their tangent lines, and the quotient is the quotient of the lines.

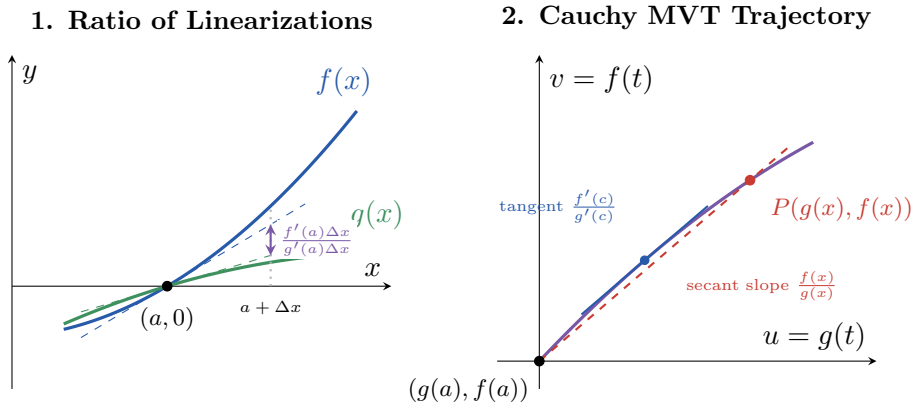


Figure 18.1: Two views of L'Hôpital's ratio of rates. Left: Close to the shared root $x = a$, both curves hug their tangent lines $f(x) \approx f'(a)(x-a)$ and $g(x) \approx g'(a)(x-a)$; the $(x-a)$ factors cancel, leaving the slope ratio $f'(a)/g'(a)$. Right: In Cauchy's parametric plane $(g(t), f(t))$, the secant slope from the origin to $(g(x), f(x))$ equals the tangent slope $f'(c)/g'(c)$ at some intermediate $c \in (a, x)$. As $x \to a$, the secant swings into the initial tangent line at the origin.

Common trap

This tangent-line argument is the right *intuition*, but it is not yet a proof, and it quietly assumes more than L'Hôpital's rule needs. It assumes f and g are differentiable *at* a with $g'(a) \neq 0$, and it hides what happens when both slopes are zero (giving $\frac{0}{0}$ all over again). The actual theorem, proved below with the Mean Value Theorem, is sharper: it only needs the derivatives near a, not the cancellation of tangent lines, and it lets you repeat the trick when the first attempt stalls.

18.3 L'Hopital's rule, stated precisely

Theorem 18.1 (L'Hôpital's rule, the 0/0 case)**.** *Let f and g be differentiable on an open interval I containing a (except possibly at a itself), with $g'(x) \neq 0$ for all $x \neq a$ in I. Suppose*

$$\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = 0 \qquad \text{and} \qquad \lim_{x \to a} g(x) = 0.$$

If $\lim_{x \to a} \dfrac{f'(x)}{g'(x)}$ exists (as a finite number or as $\pm\infty$), then

$$\lim_{x \to a} \frac{f(x)}{g(x)} = \lim_{x \to a} \frac{f'(x)}{g'(x)}.$$

Several features of this statement are doing real work, so read them deliberately. The rule promises only one direction: *if* the limit of the derivative ratio exists, then the original limit exists and equals it. It says nothing if the derivative ratio fails to settle down — in that case the rule is simply silent, and the original limit might still exist for another reason. Notice too that we never need f or g to be defined at a; only their behavior *near* a matters, which is exactly right for a limit. And the very same statement holds verbatim for one-sided limits, for $x \to \pm\infty$, and — with one change we will note — for the $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ case.

Why the technique works

Why the rule works: it is the Mean Value Theorem applied to two functions at once. The clean proof does not lean on tangent lines at all. It leans on *Cauchy's Mean Value Theorem*, the two-function version of the MVT you met in the chapter on the Mean Value Theorem. Cauchy's theorem says that for suitable f, g on an interval $[a, x]$ there is a point c strictly between a and x with

$$\frac{f(x) - f(a)}{g(x) - g(a)} = \frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}.$$

That is the bridge. The left side is built from *values*; the right side is built from *derivatives*. If $f(a) = g(a) = 0$, the left side collapses to exactly $\frac{f(x)}{g(x)}$ — the thing we want — and it has been rewritten as a ratio of derivatives at some in-between point c. As $x \to a$, that point c is squeezed toward a as well (it is trapped between a and x), so the ratio $\frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}$ is forced to the limit of $\frac{f'}{g'}$. The values turn into derivatives by the MVT, and the derivatives carry the answer.

Focus

Proof (the $0/0$ case, finite a). First extend f and g to be continuous at a by *defining* $f(a) = g(a) = 0$; since $f, g \to 0$ as $x \to a$, this loses nothing and makes them continuous on a closed interval with endpoint a. Fix x near a, say $x > a$ (the case $x < a$ is identical). The functions f and g are continuous on $[a, x]$ and differentiable on (a, x), with $g' \neq 0$ there. Cauchy's Mean Value Theorem then supplies a point $c \in (a, x)$ with

$$\frac{f(x) - f(a)}{g(x) - g(a)} = \frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}.$$

(En route, $g(x) \neq g(a)$ because if they were equal the ordinary MVT would force g' to vanish somewhere in (a, x), which we excluded; so the left side is legal.) Using $f(a) = g(a) = 0$, the left side is just $\frac{f(x)}{g(x)}$, hence

$$\frac{f(x)}{g(x)} = \frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)}, \qquad a < c < x.$$

Now let $x \to a^+$. The point c is pinned in (a, x), so $c \to a^+$ too. By hypothesis $\frac{f'(t)}{g'(t)} \to L$ as $t \to a$, so $\frac{f'(c)}{g'(c)} \to L$, and therefore $\frac{f(x)}{g(x)} \to L$. The left-hand limit is the same argument on $[x, a]$. Combining one-sided limits gives the theorem. ■

Remark 18.1. The $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ case is true with the identical conclusion, but its proof is fussier — you cannot simply set $f(a) = g(a) = 0$ because the functions are blowing up, not vanishing. The correct argument splits the interval and controls a tail term; it is a standard but more technical ε estimate. The good news is that you may use it with the same confidence and the same mechanics. We state

it next and move on.

Theorem 18.2 (L'Hôpital's rule, the ∞/∞ case)**.** *Under the same differentiability hypotheses, if* $|f(x)| \to \infty$ *and* $|g(x)| \to \infty$ *as* $x \to a$ *(or as* $x \to \pm\infty$*), and if* $\lim \frac{f'(x)}{g'(x)}$ *exists (finite or* $\pm\infty$*), then* $\lim \frac{f(x)}{g(x)}$ *exists and equals it.*

Pause

Mental check: verifying the hypothesis. Suppose someone evaluates

$$\lim_{x\to 1} \frac{x^2+1}{x+1}$$

by immediately differentiating top and bottom to get $\lim_{x\to 1} \frac{2x}{1} = 2$. What went wrong? *Answer:* Direct substitution gives $\frac{1^2+1}{1+1} = \frac{2}{2} = 1$. The form is completely determinate. Applying L'Hôpital's rule when the ratio does not vanish or blow up produces a confident but totally incorrect number. The rule is a rescue for $\frac{0}{0}$ and $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, never a replacement for simple substitution.

History

The rule carries one of the most famous, bitter, and human stories in mathematics. In 1691, the wealthy French aristocrat **Guillaume-François-Antoine, Marquis de l'Hôpital** (1661–1704), was captivated by the radical new calculus recently invented by Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz. Seeking to master it, l'Hôpital hired the brilliant young Swiss mathematician **Johann Bernoulli** (1667–1748) for private tutoring. In 1694, l'Hôpital made Bernoulli an extraordinary business proposal: a handsome annual retainer of 300 *livres* (the French silver currency of the day, roughly equal to a comfortable university professor's salary) in exchange for Bernoulli sending him his latest mathematical discoveries, with the explicit agreement that l'Hôpital could publish them as his own.

In 1696, l'Hôpital published *Analyse des Infiniment Petits pour l'Intelligence des Lignes Courbes* ("Analysis of the Infinitely Small for the Understanding of Curved Lines")—the first differential calculus textbook ever printed. Embedded in Section IX was the celebrated rule for evaluating fractions that reduce to 0/0. When l'Hôpital died in 1704, Bernoulli went public, claiming full authorship of the rule. For over two centuries, Bernoulli was widely dismissed by historians as an envious claimant trying to rob a deceased nobleman's legacy. It was not until 1922 that Bernoulli's original course notes and letters to l'Hôpital were unearthed in the public library of Basel, completely vindicating Bernoulli: the rule, word for word, was his.

Beyond the priority dispute lay a fierce foundational controversy. In the early eighteenth century, expressions like 0/0 invited mockery. Early calculus relied on *infinitesimals*—quantities imagined to be smaller than any ordinary positive number yet not strictly zero, which were manipulated like numbers during a calculation and then discarded at the end. Critics pointed out the contradiction directly. In *The Analyst* (1734), Bishop George Berkeley argued that treating vanishing increments as nonzero when forming a ratio and as zero afterward—effectively extracting a finite value from 0/0—left calculus without a sound logical foundation.

The definitive vindication came in 1823 from **Augustin-Louis Cauchy**. In his lectures at the École Polytechnique, Cauchy replaced vague infinitesimals with the rigorous machinery of limits: 0/0 is not an impossible division by zero, but the limit of a ratio of two vanishing

continuous functions. Deploying his newly formulated *Cauchy Mean Value Theorem*—which relates the overall changes of two curves to the ratio of their instantaneous slopes at some intermediate point—Cauchy established the rule with deductive certainty, without needing infinitesimals at all.
The rule turned limits that resisted direct algebraic simplification into routine derivative calculations and helped formalize *asymptotic growth rates* (how functions compare as their inputs stretch to infinity). Yet the story remains active today. In multivariable calculus, L'Hôpital's rule has no direct analog: two surfaces that both vanish at the origin can approach zero along infinitely many different curved paths, producing conflicting directional limits. And in modern computer algebra systems, deciding automatically whether a complicated symbolic expression composed of exponentials, logarithms, and powers approaches zero runs straight into the frontiers of algorithmic decidability.

18.4 Worked examples on the two ratio forms

Example 18.1 (The classic sin limit, again)**.** Consider $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{\sin x}{x}$. Substituting gives $\frac{0}{0}$. Differentiate top and bottom *separately* (this is not the quotient rule — more on that trap shortly):

$$\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\sin x}{x} \overset{0/0}{=} \lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\cos x}{1} = \frac{\cos 0}{1} = 1.$$

Common trap

That last example contains a subtle circular argument if used as a foundational proof. We computed $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\sin x) = \cos x$ in the first place by *using* $\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\sin x}{x} = 1$. So "proving" that limit with L'Hopital presupposes the derivative of sine. L'Hopital gives the correct value, but the limit must be established first via geometry and the squeeze theorem.

Example 18.2 (A polynomial-flavored 0/0)**.** $\lim_{x\to 1} \dfrac{x^3-1}{x^2-1}$ is $\frac{0}{0}$. By L'Hopital,

$$\lim_{x\to 1} \frac{x^3-1}{x^2-1} \overset{0/0}{=} \lim_{x\to 1} \frac{3x^2}{2x} = \frac{3}{2}.$$

Sanity check by factoring: $\frac{x^3-1}{x^2-1} = \frac{(x-1)(x^2+x+1)}{(x-1)(x+1)} = \frac{x^2+x+1}{x+1} \to \frac{3}{2}$. The factoring *is* the cancellation of the common $(x-1)$ that L'Hopital performs invisibly — same mechanism, two faces.

Example 18.3 (When once is not enough: applying the rule twice)**.** Take $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{1-\cos x}{x^2}$, which is $\frac{0}{0}$. One application:

$$\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{1-\cos x}{x^2} \overset{0/0}{=} \lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\sin x}{2x}.$$

This new limit is *still* $\frac{0}{0}$ — the rule did not finish the job, but it left us a simpler $\frac{0}{0}$. So apply it again:

$$\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\sin x}{2x} \overset{0/0}{=} \lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\cos x}{2} = \frac{1}{2}.$$

You may iterate L'Hopital as many times as each successive limit stays a legal $\frac{0}{0}$ or $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$. The instant a step yields a determinate form, stop and evaluate — one more differentiation past that point will give a wrong answer.

Common trap

Check the form before *every* application. The single most common L'Hopital error is to differentiate when the form is no longer indeterminate. In the example above, the moment we reached $\frac{\cos x}{2}$ the form became $\frac{1}{2}$, a perfectly ordinary number; differentiating again would give $\frac{-\sin x}{0}$, which is garbage. L'Hopital is a *conditional* rule. Verify $\frac{0}{0}$ or $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ at each step, every time, before you reach for a derivative.

Work it yourself

Compute $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{e^x - 1 - x}{x^2}$ by hand. Confirm it is $\frac{0}{0}$. Apply L'Hopital once and check you again get $\frac{0}{0}$. Apply it a second time and read off the answer. (You should land on $\frac{1}{2}$. Notice how this mirrors the previous example — both are detecting the *quadratic* coefficient in a Taylor expansion, a connection we make explicit at the end of the chapter.)

Example 18.4 (An ∞/∞ at infinity)**.** $\lim_{x\to\infty} \dfrac{\ln x}{x}$ is $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$. By Theorem 18.2,

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{\ln x}{x} \overset{\infty/\infty}{=} \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{1/x}{1} = \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{1}{x} = 0.$$

So $\ln x$, though tending to infinity, grows much more slowly than x. We will build a whole hierarchy out of facts like this in the last section.

18.5 Forcing the other forms into a fraction

L'Hopital only speaks the language of fractions, $\frac{0}{0}$ and $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$. The remaining five indeterminate forms are not fractions on their face. The technique is to *algebraically rewrite* each one as a fraction without changing its value, and then apply L'Hopital's rule. Each rewriting is a direct, learnable step.

18.5.1 The product form $0 \cdot \infty$

A product $f \cdot g$ where $f \to 0$ and $g \to \infty$ is a tug-of-war: the 0 tries to crush the product to nothing, the ∞ tries to blow it up. Who wins is exactly the kind of question L'Hopital answers — once we make it a fraction. And there is a fraction hiding in any product, because dividing is multiplying by a reciprocal:

$$f \cdot g = \frac{f}{1/g} \quad \left(\text{form } \tfrac{0}{0}\right) \qquad \text{or} \qquad f \cdot g = \frac{g}{1/f} \quad \left(\text{form } \tfrac{\infty}{\infty}\right).$$

You get to choose which factor to flip. Flip the one whose reciprocal is friendlier to differentiate.

Example 18.5 ($x \ln x$ at the origin)**.** $\lim_{x\to 0^+} x \ln x$ is $0 \cdot (-\infty)$. Write it as a fraction by flipping the x:

$$x \ln x = \frac{\ln x}{1/x} \quad \left(\tfrac{-\infty}{\infty}\right) \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \lim_{x\to 0^+} \frac{\ln x}{1/x} \overset{\infty/\infty}{=} \lim_{x\to 0^+} \frac{1/x}{-1/x^2} = \lim_{x\to 0^+} (-x) = 0.$$

Had we flipped the other way, $\frac{x}{1/\ln x}$, the derivative of $1/\ln x$ is $-\frac{1}{x(\ln x)^2}$ and the algebra is uglier. *Choosing the right reciprocal* is most of the skill in these problems.

Walking question

Before reading on, decide on a walk: in $\lim_{x\to 0^+} x\ln x$, the function x is pulling the product to 0 and $\ln x$ is pulling it to $-\infty$. The answer came out 0. Which factor dominates, and what does that say about how fast $\ln x$ grows compared to how fast x shrinks? We return to this question in the growth-rates section.

18.5.2 The difference form $\infty - \infty$

Here two quantities both race to infinity and we subtract them; the answer depends on which is bigger and by how much. There is no universal recipe, but there are two reliable moves: *combine into a single fraction* (common denominator), or *factor out the dominant term*. Either one converts the subtraction into a ratio.

Example 18.6 (A common-denominator rescue)**.** $\lim_{x\to 0}\left(\dfrac{1}{\sin x} - \dfrac{1}{x}\right)$ is $\infty - \infty$ (each piece blows up). Put them over a common denominator:

$$\frac{1}{\sin x} - \frac{1}{x} = \frac{x - \sin x}{x\sin x}.$$

Now it is a clean $\frac{0}{0}$. L'Hopital once:

$$\lim_{x\to 0}\frac{x-\sin x}{x\sin x} \overset{0/0}{=} \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{1-\cos x}{\sin x + x\cos x},$$

still $\frac{0}{0}$. Again:

$$\overset{0/0}{=} \lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sin x}{2\cos x - x\sin x} = \frac{0}{2-0} = 0.$$

So the two infinities cancel *exactly* in the limit; their difference settles to 0. Figure 18.2 shows how this looks: the two vertical asymptotes climb in lockstep, and the gap between them narrows to nothing.

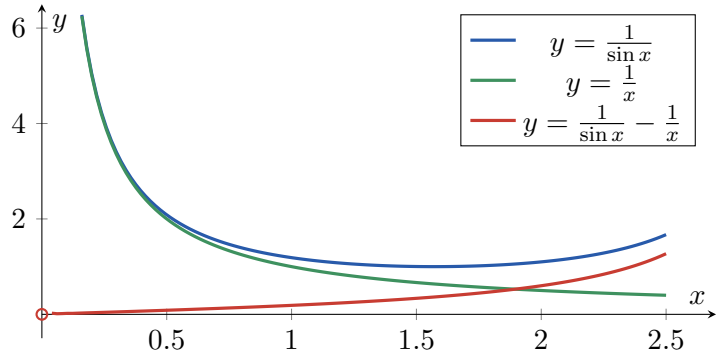


Figure 18.2: Resolving the indeterminate difference $\infty - \infty$ in Example 18.6. As $x \to 0^+$, both $y = 1/\sin x$ (blue) and $y = 1/x$ (green) diverge toward $+\infty$. Yet because $\sin x$ is so close to x near the origin ($\sin x \approx x - x^3/6$), the two curves track each other with increasing precision. Their difference (red curve) does not blow up: it glides gracefully to 0, indicated by the open circle at the origin.

18.5.3 The power forms 1^∞, 0^0, ∞^0

These three look different from each other but yield to one universal trick: a power becomes a product the moment you take a logarithm. If $y = f(x)^{g(x)}$, then

$$\ln y = g(x)\,\ln f(x),$$

and each of the three power forms turns the right-hand side into a $0 \cdot \infty$ product, which we already know how to fractionate. Find $\lim \ln y = L$, then exponentiate: $\lim y = e^L$. The logarithm trades an unmanageable exponent for a manageable product.

Why the technique works

Why the logarithm tames every power form. The trouble in 1^∞ and its cousins is that the *exponent* is doing the limiting, and our tools (derivatives, L'Hopital) are built for sums, products, and ratios — not for moving exponents. Taking ln is precisely the operation that *pulls the exponent down* into a coefficient: $\ln(f^g) = g \ln f$. An impossible-looking power becomes an ordinary product; the product becomes a fraction; the fraction yields to L'Hopital. Because exp is continuous, $\lim \ln y = L$ guarantees $\lim y = e^L$, so nothing is lost in the round trip $y \to \ln y \to L \to e^L$. We are not avoiding the exponent — we are *lowering* it to where our machinery can reach.

Example 18.7 (The most famous 1^∞: compound interest revisited)**.** $\displaystyle\lim_{x\to\infty}\left(1+\frac{1}{x}\right)^x$ is 1^∞ — the base creeps to 1, the exponent runs to ∞, and they fight. Let $y = \left(1+\frac{1}{x}\right)^x$ and take logs:

$$\ln y = x \ln\left(1+\frac{1}{x}\right).$$

This is $\infty \cdot 0$. Make it a fraction by flipping the x:

$$\ln y = \frac{\ln\left(1+\frac{1}{x}\right)}{1/x} \quad \left(\tfrac{0}{0}\right).$$

Differentiate top and bottom. The top differentiates by the chain rule: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\ln(1+1/x)) = \frac{1}{1+1/x} \cdot \left(-\frac{1}{x^2}\right)$, and the bottom gives $-\frac{1}{x^2}$:

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{\dfrac{-1/x^2}{1+1/x}}{-1/x^2} = \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{1}{1+1/x} = 1.$$

So $\lim \ln y = 1$, hence $\lim y = e^1 = e$. This recovers, by L'Hopital, the very limit-definition of e from the early chapters — the compound-interest number falls right out. Figure 18.3 shows the approach.

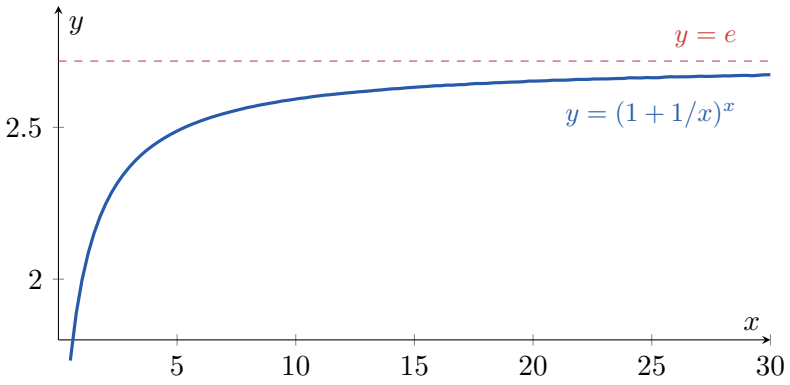


Figure 18.3: The compound-interest sequence $\left(1+\frac{1}{x}\right)^x$ climbing toward $e \approx 2.71828$ as $x \to \infty$. The form is 1^∞ — the base $1+\frac{1}{x}$ sinks to 1 while the exponent x grows — and the two effects balance at exactly e. The dashed line is the limit the curve approaches but never reaches.

Example 18.8 (An ∞^0)**.** $\lim_{x\to\infty} x^{1/x}$ is ∞^0. Logs: $\ln y = \frac{\ln x}{x}$, which we already found in Example 18.4 to be $\frac{\infty}{\infty} \to 0$. Therefore $\lim y = e^0 = 1$. A number raised to a gently vanishing power slides back down to 1.

Example 18.9 (A 0^0)**.** $\lim_{x\to 0^+} x^x$ is 0^0, perhaps the most counterintuitive of the lot. Logs: $\ln y = x \ln x$, which is the $0\cdot(-\infty)$ from Example 18.5, equal to 0. Hence $\lim_{x\to 0^+} x^x = e^0 = 1$ (Figure 18.4).

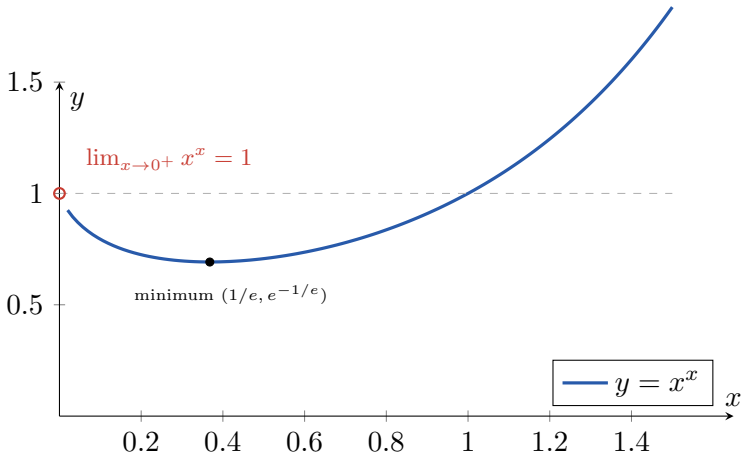


Figure 18.4: The graph of $y = x^x$ for $x > 0$. Although the base x tends to 0, the value x^x does not collapse to 0; it dips to a minimum near $x = 1/e \approx 0.368$ (where $y \approx 0.692$) and approaches 1 as $x \to 0^+$. The form 0^0 is genuinely indeterminate, and here the exponent's vanishing pull wins the tug-of-war.

Common trap

0^0, 1^∞, and ∞^0 are *forms*, not values. People sometimes "know" that $0^0 = 1$ from algebra (where the convention is handy) and conclude that $\lim x^x$ "must" be 1 for that reason. The reasoning is wrong even though the answer is right: change the problem to $\lim_{x\to 0^+} x^{1/\ln x}$, also 0^0, and the answer is e, not 1. The form does not decide; only the logarithm-and-L'Hopital

computation does.

18.6 How the rule gets misused

The rule is convenient enough that students reach for it reflexively, and that reflex causes most of the wrong answers. Here are the failure modes, each worth memorizing as a thing *not* to do.

Common trap

Trap 1: Using it on a determinate form. If the form is not $\frac{0}{0}$ or $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, the rule simply does not apply, and using it gives nonsense. For instance $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{\cos x}{x+1}$ is $\frac{1}{1} = 1$ by direct substitution. "Applying L'Hopital" would give $\lim \frac{-\sin x}{1} = 0$ — flatly wrong. *Always check the form first.*

Common trap

Trap 2: Confusing it with the quotient rule. L'Hopital says differentiate the numerator and the denominator *separately* and form a new quotient $\frac{f'}{g'}$. It does *not* say differentiate the quotient $\frac{f}{g}$ with the quotient rule $\frac{f'g - fg'}{g^2}$. These are completely different expressions. Writing the quotient rule here is one of the most frequent and most fatal slips.

Common trap

Trap 3: Continuing after the form resolves. As stressed in Example 18.3, the instant a step is no longer indeterminate you must stop. One extra differentiation past a determinate form gives a wrong number with total confidence.

Common trap

Trap 4: Treating a non-existent derivative limit as "no answer." The rule is one-directional. If $\lim \frac{f'}{g'}$ fails to exist, you may conclude *nothing* about $\lim \frac{f}{g}$; it might still exist. Take $\lim_{x\to\infty} \dfrac{x + \sin x}{x}$. This is $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, and L'Hopital gives $\lim \frac{1+\cos x}{1} = \lim(1 + \cos x)$, which *oscillates* and has no limit. A beginner concludes "the limit does not exist." But the original limit plainly *does* exist: $\frac{x+\sin x}{x} = 1 + \frac{\sin x}{x} \to 1 + 0 = 1$. L'Hopital was silent here, not authoritative.

Common trap

Trap 5: An endless loop. $\lim_{x\to\infty} \dfrac{e^x}{e^x + 1}$ is $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$; L'Hopital gives $\frac{e^x}{e^x} = 1$ in one clean step, fine. But $\lim_{x\to\infty} \dfrac{\sqrt{x^2+1}}{x}$, attacked by L'Hopital, produces $\frac{x/\sqrt{x^2+1}}{1} = \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2+1}}$, whose own L'Hopital sends you straight back to $\frac{\sqrt{x^2+1}}{x}$. You are chasing your tail. Use algebra: $\frac{\sqrt{x^2+1}}{x} = \sqrt{1 + \frac{1}{x^2}} \to 1$. When L'Hopital cycles, abandon it.

Pause

A healthy habit before reaching for L'Hopital: ask whether a quick algebraic move — factoring, a common denominator, dividing by the dominant power, a known limit — settles the problem first. Algebraic simplification is often faster and less error-prone than repeated differentiation. The examples in Traps 4 and 5 are solved faster, and more safely, by elementary algebra.

18.7 Growth rates, settled once and for all

We have brushed up against a recurring question since the chapter on limits at infinity: among the functions that all run off to infinity — powers of x, exponentials, logarithms — *which outruns which*? L'Hopital lets us answer this cleanly, because "f grows faster than g" is precisely the statement

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{g(x)}{f(x)} = 0,$$

an $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ form tailor-made for the rule.

Theorem 18.3 (The growth hierarchy)**.** *As $x \to \infty$, for any fixed exponents $a > 0$, $p > 0$ and any base $b > 1$,*

$$(\ln x)^a \ll x^p \ll b^x \ll x! \ll x^x,$$

where $u \ll v$ means $\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{u}{v} = 0$ (read: "v dominates u"). When comparing against the factorial, we evaluate along integer values $n \to \infty$ (or the continuous gamma function): $b^n \ll n! \ll n^n$. In words: every power of a logarithm loses to every positive power of x; every positive power of x loses to every exponential with base above 1; the exponential loses to the factorial; and the factorial loses to x^x.

Pause

Mental check: the tortoise and the hare. Consider $f(x) = (\ln x)^{1000}$ and $g(x) = x^{0.0001}$. For $x = 10$, $f(10) \approx (2.30)^{1000} \approx 10^{362}$, an unimaginably immense number, whereas $g(10) \approx 10^{0.0001} \approx 1.0002$, barely larger than 1. Does the logarithm outrun the tiny power? *Answer:* No. As $x \to \infty$, $x^{0.0001}$ eventually completely buries $(\ln x)^{1000}$: the limit $\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{(\ln x)^{1000}}{x^{0.0001}} = 0$. The crossover point happens at an astronomical value of x, but the theorem guarantees that any positive polynomial power, no matter how small the exponent, eventually crushes any power of a logarithm.

Focus

Power beats logarithm. We showed $\frac{\ln x}{x} \to 0$. More generally $\frac{\ln x}{x^p}$ for any $p > 0$ is $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, and L'Hôpital gives $\frac{1/x}{p\,x^{p-1}} = \frac{1}{p\,x^p} \to 0$. So $\ln x \ll x^p$ for every $p > 0$, no matter how tiny — even $x^{0.001}$ eventually buries $\ln x$. Raising the log to any real power $a > 0$ changes nothing: rewrite $\dfrac{(\ln x)^a}{x^p} = \left(\dfrac{\ln x}{x^{p/a}}\right)^a$, where $p/a > 0$, so the inside approaches 0 and its a-th power approaches $0^a = 0$.

Focus

Exponential beats power (and factorial beats exponential). Consider $\frac{x^n}{e^x}$ for a positive integer n — an $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ form. Each L'Hôpital step lowers the power on top by one while e^x on the bottom regenerates unchanged:

$$\frac{x^n}{e^x} \to \frac{nx^{n-1}}{e^x} \to \frac{n(n-1)x^{n-2}}{e^x} \to \cdots \to \frac{n!}{e^x} \to 0.$$

For any real power $p > 0$ and any base $b > 1$, choose an integer $n \geq p$ and substitute $u = x \ln b \to \infty$: then $0 \leq \frac{x^p}{b^x} \leq \frac{x^n}{e^{x \ln b}} = (\ln b)^{-n} \frac{u^n}{e^u} \to 0$. Finally, along integers $n \to \infty$, fix an integer $m \geq 2b$; for $n > m$, $\frac{b^n}{n!} = \frac{b^m}{m!} \prod_{k=m+1}^{n} \frac{b}{k} \leq \frac{b^m}{m!} \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{n-m} \to 0$, while $n!/n^n = \frac{1}{n} \cdot \frac{2}{n} \cdots \frac{n}{n} \leq \frac{1}{n} \to 0$.

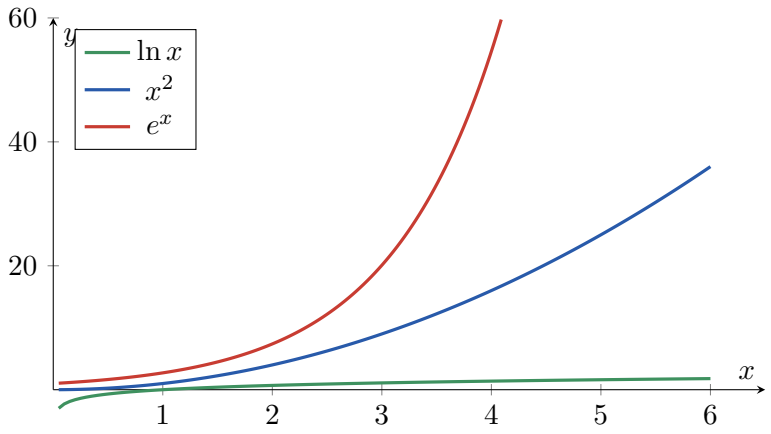


Figure 18.5: The growth hierarchy in one window. $\ln x$ barely lifts off; x^2 climbs steadily; e^x is already running away by $x \approx 4$. Pushed to infinity, the order is permanent: $\ln x \ll x^2 \ll e^x$. L'Hôpital's rule is what proves the order never reverses.

Application

Why your sorting algorithm scales but your brute-force search does not. In computer science, an algorithm's running time as a function of input size n is exactly a growth-rate question. A method costing $n \log n$ steps (good sorting) versus one costing n^2 (naive sorting) versus one costing 2^n (brute-force subset search) are separated by precisely the hierarchy in Theorem 18.3: $n \log n \ll n^2 \ll 2^n$. The L'Hôpital computations above are the rigorous reason a 2^n algorithm becomes hopeless near $n = 60$ while an $n \log n$ algorithm sails through n in the billions. The asymptotic hierarchy is a proved theorem rather than a rule of thumb, and these limits provide the proof.

Connection

The factorial and x^x ends of the hierarchy connect to *Stirling's approximation*, $n! \sim \sqrt{2\pi n}\,(n/e)^n$, which you will meet in probability and combinatorics. Stirling shows $n!$ sits, roughly, like $(n/e)^n$ — slightly below n^n, comfortably above b^n — which is exactly the placement $b^x \ll x! \ll x^x$ in our chain. The elementary ratio ordering and the refined Stirling

estimate tell the same story at two levels of resolution.

18.8 The deeper picture: L'Hopital is Taylor's theorem in miniature

The tangent-line intuition we opened with runs even deeper. When you push it one order further, L'Hôpital's rule is revealed as a first-order case of *Taylor series*, which you will meet in full later. The idea: near a zero, a function looks not just like its tangent line but like its whole power series, and the limit of a ratio is decided by the *first surviving terms* of the top and bottom.

What is really happening

Why repeated L'Hôpital keeps working. Suppose near $x = 0$,

$$f(x) = \frac{f''(0)}{2}x^2 + \cdots, \qquad g(x) = g'(0)\,x + \cdots$$

Then $\frac{f}{g} \sim \frac{(f''(0)/2)x^2}{g'(0)x} = \frac{f''(0)}{2g'(0)}x \to 0$. The function whose series *starts at a higher power* vanishes faster, so it loses. Each L'Hôpital step differentiates away one power of x from both series; you keep going until the surviving lowest-order terms no longer both vanish, and at that moment the ratio of their coefficients is the limit. That is why $\frac{1-\cos x}{x^2} \to \frac{1}{2}$: the series $1-\cos x = \frac{x^2}{2} - \frac{x^4}{24} + \cdots$ starts at $\frac{x^2}{2}$, exactly matching the x^2 below, and the ratio of leading coefficients is $\frac{1/2}{1} = \frac{1}{2}$ — the same $\frac{1}{2}$ two L'Hôpital steps produced. The rule effectively computes the ratio of these first nonzero Taylor coefficients.

Why this matters

Notice how our three views of L'Hôpital's rule fit together. Up close, tangent lines show *why* slopes decide a $\frac{0}{0}$ ratio; Cauchy's Mean Value Theorem turns that picture into an airtight proof even when $f'(a)$ itself is missing; and Taylor series reveal what repeated differentiation is really doing — peeling away matching powers of $(x-a)$ until the first nonzero terms appear.

18.8.1 The Scope, Fragilities, and Horizons of L'Hôpital's Rule

Connection

L'Hôpital's rule provides a direct computational method for indeterminate limits. Ratios like $\frac{e^x-1}{\sin x}$ or $\frac{\ln x}{x-1}$, which resist elementary factoring, can be evaluated once derivatives compare their rates of change. Logarithmic conversion resolves exponential forms like $(1+r/x)^x \to e^r$ and $x^x \to 1$, and iterated derivatives establish the permanent hierarchy that powers modern algorithm analysis: logarithms lose to powers, powers lose to exponentials, and exponentials lose to factorials.

Yet the rule has important limitations:

- *Circular traps:* It cannot establish fundamental derivatives from scratch. Using

L'Hôpital to evaluate $\lim_{x\to 0}\frac{\sin x}{x}=1$ is circular, because finding $(\sin x)'=\cos x$ in the first place requires that very limit.

- *Oscillatory blindness:* On tame limits like $\lim_{x\to\infty}\frac{x+\sin x}{x}=1$, the derivative ratio $\frac{1+\cos x}{1}$ oscillates forever without settling down. The rule reports silence, even though the true limit is obvious from elementary algebra.
- *Algebraic cycling:* On roots like $\lim_{x\to\infty}\frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2+1}}$, differentiation merely flips the radical between numerator and denominator, trapping the calculation in an infinite loop.

The bridge to Chapter 19: when algebra fails, follow the tangent line. When substituting numbers produced the impasse $\frac{0}{0}$, calculus resolved it by replacing $f(x)$ and $g(x)$ near the shared root with their local linear models. In Chapter 19 (*Newton's Method*), we turn that same tangent-line idea on root-finding itself: when $f(x)=0$ has no algebraic formula, we replace the curve at a starting guess with its tangent line, follow the line to the axis, and iterate.

The long horizon: Taylor series. Later, in Chapters 30 and 31 (*Power Series and Taylor's Theorem*), this linear philosophy expands to higher-degree polynomials:

$$f(x)=f(0)+f'(0)\,x+\frac{f''(0)}{2}\,x^2+\frac{f'''(0)}{6}\,x^3+\cdots$$

Comparing the first non-vanishing powers will resolve indeterminate forms in a single inspection, eliminating differentiation loops and laying bare why repeated L'Hôpital steps peel away vanishing terms.

18.9 Exercises

Exercise 18.1 (Warm-up ratios)**.** Evaluate, checking the form before each L'Hopital step: (a) $\lim_{x\to 0}\dfrac{\tan x-x}{x^3}$; (b) $\lim_{x\to 1}\dfrac{\ln x}{x-1}$; (c) $\lim_{x\to\infty}\dfrac{x^2}{e^x}$; (d) $\lim_{x\to 0}\dfrac{e^x-1}{\sin x}$.

Exercise 18.2 (Products and differences)**.** Convert to a fraction first, then evaluate: (a) $\lim_{x\to 0^+} x^2\ln x$; (b) $\lim_{x\to(\pi/2)^-}(\sec x-\tan x)$; (c) $\lim_{x\to 0}\left(\dfrac{1}{x}-\dfrac{1}{e^x-1}\right)$.

Exercise 18.3 (Power forms)**.** Use the logarithm trick: (a) $\lim_{x\to\infty}\left(1+\dfrac{3}{x}\right)^x$; (b) $\lim_{x\to 0^+}(\sin x)^x$; (c) $\lim_{x\to\infty}\left(\dfrac{x+1}{x-1}\right)^x$.

Exercise 18.4 (Spot the misuse)**.** For each, decide whether L'Hopital is legitimately applicable, and if not, find the limit by other means. (a) $\lim_{x\to 0}\dfrac{x+2}{x^2+1}$; (b) $\lim_{x\to\infty}\dfrac{2x-\cos x}{x+1}$; (c) $\lim_{x\to\infty}\dfrac{\sqrt{4x^2+1}}{x+3}$. In (b) and (c), explain in one sentence why blindly differentiating fails or stalls.

Exercise 18.5 (Three steps, then stop)**.** Evaluate $\lim_{x\to 0}\dfrac{x-\sin x}{x^3}$. State the form at each stage and identify the exact moment you must stop applying the rule. Confirm your answer against the series $\sin x=x-\frac{x^3}{6}+\cdots$.

Exercise 18.6 (Growth-rate ordering)**.** Order the following by eventual size as $x \to \infty$, smallest first, and justify each pairwise comparison with a single L'Hopital limit: x^{10}, $(\ln x)^{100}$, $1.0001^{\,x}$, $e^{\sqrt{x}}$. (The last one is subtler than it looks — compare its logarithm.)

Exercise 18.7 (A famous compound limit)**.** Show that $\lim_{x\to\infty}\left(1-\frac{r}{x}\right)^{x} = e^{-r}$ for any constant r, by taking logs and applying L'Hopital. Interpret the result for continuously compounded *decay* (e.g. radioactive material or a depreciating asset losing a fixed fraction per ever-shorter period).

Exercise 18.8 (Conceptual: why the form matters)**.** Construct two functions f, g with $f, g \to 0$ as $x \to 0$ for which $\lim \frac{f}{g} = 7$, and another pair for which the same form $\frac{0}{0}$ gives $\lim \frac{f}{g} = \infty$. Use your examples to explain, in your own words, the precise sense in which $\frac{0}{0}$ "contains no information."

Exercise 18.9 (Proof: the simple case from the definition)**.** Suppose f and g are differentiable *at* a with $f(a) = g(a) = 0$ and $g'(a) \neq 0$. Without invoking the full theorem, prove directly from the definition of the derivative that

$$\lim_{x\to a}\frac{f(x)}{g(x)} = \frac{f'(a)}{g'(a)}.$$

Hint: divide numerator and denominator by $(x-a)$ and recognize two difference quotients. Explain why this short argument needs the stronger hypothesis "differentiable *at* a," whereas Theorem 18.1 gets by with less.

Exercise 18.10 (Proof: L'Hopital can fail without the form)**.** Give an explicit pair f, g with $\lim_{x\to a}\frac{f(x)}{g(x)}$ existing but $\lim_{x\to a}\frac{f'(x)}{g'(x)}$ *not* existing, where the form is genuinely $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$. (Trap 4 contains the seed of such an example.) Explain how this is consistent with the theorem — that is, why no contradiction arises.

Chapter 19

Newton's Method

We have spent many chapters learning to differentiate. We can take a function, find its derivative, read off the slope of its tangent line at any point, and use that tangent line as the best straight-line stand-in for the curve nearby. In the previous chapter, on L'Hôpital's rule, we saw that very principle cut through indeterminate forms: when a ratio collapsed into $\frac{0}{0}$, replacing the curves by their local linear rates revealed the true limit. In this chapter, that same tangent line yields one of the most practical algorithms in mathematics.

Here is the problem. You have an equation. Not a friendly one like $2x - 6 = 0$, where you just rearrange and read off $x = 3$. A genuinely ugly one, like

$$x^5 - 3x + 1 = 0, \qquad \cos x = x, \qquad e^{-x} = x^2.$$

For these there is *no formula*. There is no quadratic-formula analog, no algebraic trick, that will hand you the answer. And yet these equations have real solutions – you can practically see one of them if you sketch the curves. The question is: how do you actually *find* the number, to as many decimal places as you please, when no formula exists?

Focus

Given a function f, find a number r with $f(r) = 0$ – a **root** of f – when there is no formula for r. This single problem is pervasive throughout applied mathematics. Almost every governing equation can be framed as solving $f(x) = 0$: finding an equilibrium state, a break-even point, an orbital intersection, or an interest rate that balances an account. Newton's method is the standard numerical algorithm for solving such equations.

The strategy is short, and it is built entirely out of the tangent line. You guess. Your guess is wrong, but instead of throwing it away you *improve* it: you replace the hard curve with its easy tangent line, solve the easy linear problem exactly, and take that as your next guess. Then you do it again, and again. The guesses converge rapidly toward the true root – often doubling the number of correct digits at every single step. This chapter explains why it works, shows in pictures what it is doing, lays out the handful of ways it can fail, and accounts for its speed.

19.1 The idea: replace the curve with its tangent

Start with a picture and a guess. We want a root of some function f – a place where its graph crosses the horizontal axis. Suppose we have a current guess, call it x_0. Almost certainly x_0 is not the root: the point $(x_0, f(x_0))$ sits above or below the axis, not on it.

Now here is the move. The curve near x_0 is hard to work with, but the *tangent line* at x_0 is trivial – it is a straight line, and finding where a straight line crosses the axis is grade-school algebra. So we make a bargain: we pretend, just for one step, that the function *is* its tangent line. We slide down (or up) that tangent line until it hits the axis, and wherever it lands we call our new, improved guess x_1.

Intuition

The whole method in one sentence: *you cannot easily find where the curve hits the axis, so instead you find where its tangent line hits the axis, and you bet that this is closer.* The tangent line hugs the curve near x_0, so if x_0 is already in the neighborhood of the root, the place the tangent crosses is a much better estimate than x_0 was. Repeat the bargain from the new point and the estimates close in.

Figure 19.1 shows a single step. The guess x_0 is off to the right of the true root r. We climb up to the point on the curve, draw the tangent there, and follow it down to the axis. It lands at x_1, noticeably closer to r than x_0 was.

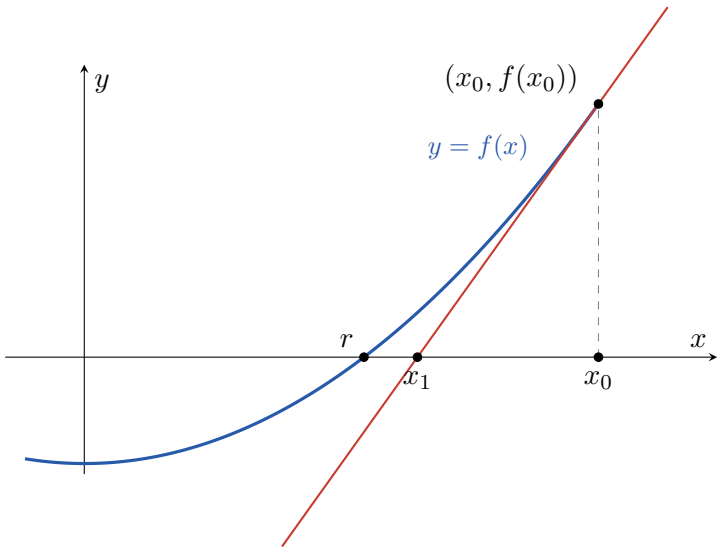


Figure 19.1: One step of Newton's method on $f(x) = x^2 - 2$, whose root is $r = \sqrt{2}$. From the guess x_0 we ride the tangent line (red) down to the axis, landing at x_1, much nearer the root r than x_0 was.

That is the entire idea. Everything else is bookkeeping: turning "follow the tangent to the axis" into a formula, and then turning the formula into a loop.

19.2 Deriving the iteration formula

Do the algebra once, carefully, because the formula is worth understanding rather than memorizing.

We are standing at x_0. The point on the curve is $(x_0, f(x_0))$, and the slope of the tangent there is $f'(x_0)$. The tangent line is therefore

$$y = f(x_0) + f'(x_0)\,(x - x_0).$$

This is the linear approximation of f at x_0 – the very same formula we built in the chapter on differentials. We want the place where this line crosses the horizontal axis, i.e. where $y = 0$. Set the right-hand side to zero and solve for x:

$$0 = f(x_0) + f'(x_0)\,(x - x_0) \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x - x_0 = -\frac{f(x_0)}{f'(x_0)} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad x = x_0 - \frac{f(x_0)}{f'(x_0)}.$$

That landing point is our new guess x_1. Naming the general step, we get the celebrated recurrence.

Focus

Newton's iteration. Starting from a guess x_0, generate a sequence by

$$\boxed{x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}} \qquad n = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$$

Each new estimate is the old one corrected by the amount $f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$. When the x_n stop changing – when $f(x_n)$ has shrunk to essentially zero – you have your root.

Look at what the correction term $f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$ is telling you. The numerator $f(x_n)$ is how far off the axis you are – your "vertical error." The denominator $f'(x_n)$ is the slope, the rate at which the function climbs. Dividing height by slope gives you a *horizontal* distance: "if I am this high up and the ground rises at this rate, I must back up this far to reach ground level." It is exactly the run you get from a given rise and a given slope. The method is just rise over slope equals run, applied over and over.

Pause and think: What happens if your starting guess x_0 happens to be the exact root r? Then $f(x_0) = 0$, the correction term $f(x_0)/f'(x_0)$ vanishes, and $x_1 = x_0$. The iteration immediately stands still; an exact root is a resting point of the method.

What is really happening

What is really happening is that Newton's method *inverts the linear approximation.* Linear approximation answered the forward question: "given a small step Δx, how much does f change?" – the answer being $\Delta f \approx f'(x)\,\Delta x$. Newton's method runs that backwards. It asks: "I want f to change by a specific amount, namely by $-f(x_n)$ so as to land on zero – what step Δx achieves that?" Solving $f'(x_n)\,\Delta x = -f(x_n)$ gives $\Delta x = -f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$, and stepping by that amount is the update. So the iteration is linear approximation solved for the input instead of the output. The reason it is only *approximate* – the reason you must iterate rather than land on the root in one shot – is that the curve is not actually a straight line, so the real f is not yet zero at x_{n+1}. But it is closer, and from the closer point the linear approximation is even better, so the next correction is smaller still.

Why the technique works

Why does following the tangent get you closer to the root at all? Because near a point the tangent line and the curve agree to *first order* – they have the same value and the same slope – so over a short horizontal span they part company only slowly, by an amount governed by the curvature (the second derivative). If your guess is already reasonably near the root, the stretch between guess and root is short, the tangent and curve are nearly indistinguishable across it, and the tangent's crossing is therefore nearly the curve's crossing. The error you make by using the line instead of the curve is small, and – as we will prove shortly – it is small *compared to the error you started with*. Each step's leftover error is roughly the *square* of the previous error. Square a small number and you get a tiny number. That squaring is the engine of the method's speed.

19.3 A first worked example: square roots by hand

Nothing makes the method concrete like computing a number you already know. Take $\sqrt{2}$. It is the positive root of

$$f(x) = x^2 - 2, \qquad f'(x) = 2x.$$

Plug into the iteration:

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{x_n^2 - 2}{2x_n} = x_n - \frac{x_n}{2} + \frac{1}{x_n} = \frac{x_n}{2} + \frac{1}{x_n} = \frac{1}{2}\left(x_n + \frac{2}{x_n}\right).$$

That last form is famous in its own right – it is the *Babylonian method* for square roots, known thousands of years before Newton: "Average your guess with 2 divided by your guess." The ancients arrived at the exact Newton iteration long before the underlying calculus was formulated.

Start, deliberately, with a poor guess: $x_0 = 2$.

Work it yourself

Carry these out yourself with a calculator; watch the digits lock in.

$$\begin{aligned}
x_0 &= 2 \\
x_1 &= \tfrac{1}{2}\left(2 + \tfrac{2}{2}\right) = \tfrac{1}{2}(3) = 1.5 \\
x_2 &= \tfrac{1}{2}\left(1.5 + \tfrac{2}{1.5}\right) = \tfrac{1}{2}(1.5 + 1.3333\ldots) = 1.41666\ldots \\
x_3 &= \tfrac{1}{2}\left(1.416667 + \tfrac{2}{1.416667}\right) = 1.4142156\ldots \\
x_4 &= 1.41421356237\ldots
\end{aligned}$$

The true value is $\sqrt{2} = 1.41421356237\ldots$

Compare the errors – the distance from each iterate to $\sqrt{2}$:

n	error $\lvert x_n - \sqrt{2}\rvert$
0	0.586
1	0.0858
2	0.00245
3	0.0000021
4	0.0000000000016

Read that column from the top down and feel what is happening. The error goes from about half, to about a tenth, to a few thousandths, to a couple millionths, to a *trillionth*. Roughly speaking, the number of correct decimal digits is *doubling* at every step: 0 correct, then 1, then 2–3, then 6, then 12. After four steps from a lazy guess of 2 we have $\sqrt{2}$ to twelve places. That doubling of correct digits is the hallmark of **quadratic convergence**, and we will explain it precisely soon.

Application

This is not a toy. The square-root key on your calculator, and the `sqrt` function buried in every programming language's math library, does not consult a table – it runs an iteration of essentially this kind, typically Newton's method or a close relative, started from a clever first guess and run just enough times to fill the available precision. Division itself, on some processors, is computed by Newton's method applied to $f(x) = 1/x - a$, which finds $1/a$ using only multiplication and subtraction – no division at all. The arithmetic happening inside your machine is shot through with this one idea.

19.4 Watching convergence in pictures

The formula is clean, but the method is geometric, so watch several steps unfold on a graph. Take a cubic equation that does not factor over the rationals:

$$f(x) = x^3 - x - 2 = 0.$$

Cardano's cubic formula expresses the root in nested radicals, which is far too unwieldy for quick numerical work, whereas a sketch shows a single real root a bit past 1.5. Start at $x_0 = 2$.

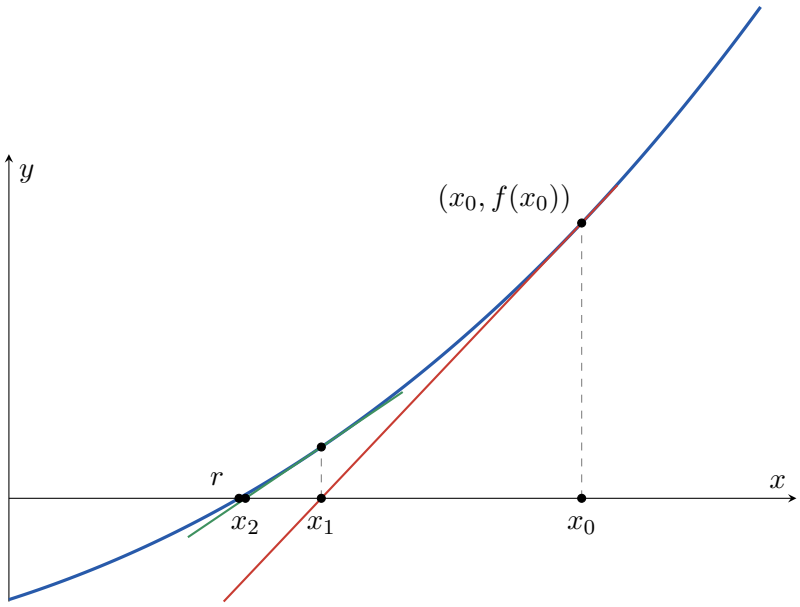


Figure 19.2: Three guesses converging on the root of $f(x) = x^3 - x - 2$. From $x_0 = 2$ the red tangent lands at x_1; from x_1 the green tangent lands at x_2, already nearly on top of the root. Each tangent is taken at a point closer to the crossing – the guesses pile up against the root.

The numbers behind the picture:

$$x_0 = 2, \quad x_1 = 1.63636\ldots, \quad x_2 = 1.53039\ldots, \quad x_3 = 1.52144\ldots, \quad x_4 = 1.52138\ldots$$

By x_4 the digits have stopped moving at the precision shown. The picture and the table tell the same story: each step the new point clings tighter to the root, because each tangent is taken at a point ever closer to the curve's actual crossing, where the line and the curve are ever harder to tell apart.

Walking question

Take this on a walk. In Figure 19.2 the curve is concave up (it bends upward) and the root is approached *from the right*, each guess landing to the left of the last but never overshooting past the root. Picture instead a curve that is concave *down* near its root, approached from the right. Sketch a tangent. Does the iterate stay on the same side of the root, or jump across it? Convince yourself that the curvature and which side you start on together decide whether Newton's method marches in steadily from one side or zig-zags across the root closing in.

19.5 When it works – and when it fails

Newton's method is fast, but it is not foolproof, and a teacher who shows you only the triumphs is doing you a disservice. The method comes with a fine-print contract, and there are four classic ways to violate it. Knowing them is what separates someone who can *use* the method from someone who merely knows the formula.

19.5.1 The happy case: a good start near a simple root

When everything goes right, two conditions hold. First, the starting guess x_0 is *close enough* to a root r. Second, the root is *simple* – meaning $f'(r) \neq 0$, so the curve crosses the axis at a genuine slant rather than grazing it tangentially. Under those conditions convergence is guaranteed to be quadratic: the count of correct digits doubles at every step. That is the regime we have been admiring.

The trouble is the phrase "close enough." Newton's method is a *local* method. It promises wonderful things once you are in the neighborhood of the root, and says almost nothing about how to get into that neighborhood in the first place. Starting far away, anything can happen.

19.5.2 Failure 1: the derivative vanishes – a flat spot

Look again at the formula:

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}.$$

If ever $f'(x_n) = 0$, you are dividing by zero and the method blows up. Geometrically this is obvious: where the derivative is zero the tangent line is *horizontal*, and a horizontal line either never meets the axis or lies along it. There is no "where the tangent crosses" to step to. If your guess lands on or very near a flat spot of f, the tangent is nearly horizontal and it slings your next guess off to some wildly distant place – possibly farther from the root than you began.

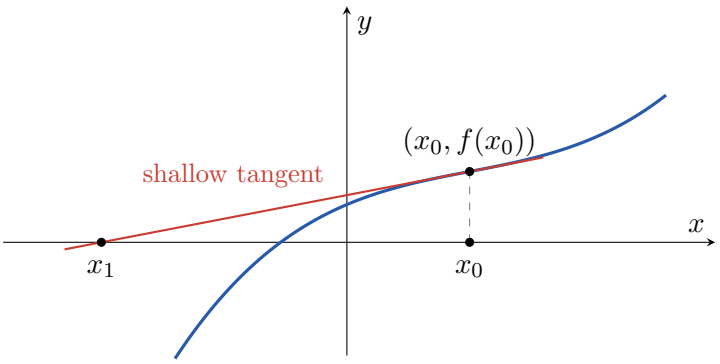


Figure 19.3: A near-horizontal tangent. The shallow slope at $x_0 = 1$ ($f'(x_0) = 0.25$) forces the tangent line to travel a large distance before hitting the axis, slinging the next guess all the way to $x_1 = -2$. If the derivative were exactly zero, the tangent would be horizontal and the next step would be completely undefined.

19.5.3 Failure 2: a bad start – running off to infinity

Even with a perfectly nice function, a careless starting point can send the iterates marching off to infinity instead of inward to the root. The classic demonstration is

$$f(x) = \arctan x,$$

whose only root is $x = 0$. Its graph flattens out toward horizontal asymptotes $\pm\pi/2$ as $|x|$ grows, so far from the origin the slope is tiny. Start with a guess outside the critical threshold $|x_0| = x^\star \approx 1.3917$

(the point where $x_1 = -x_0$ creates a symmetric two-cycle) – say $x_0 = 1.6$, as in Figure 19.4 – and the shallow tangent overshoots the root, landing farther out on the opposite side at $x_1 \approx -2.0$. The next step overshoots further still to $x_2 \approx 3.55$, and the iterates spiral outward with $|x_n| \to \infty$. Inside $|x_0| < x^\star$ Newton's method converges to 0; outside it, the method runs away. "Close enough" is a sharp boundary, not a mere formality.

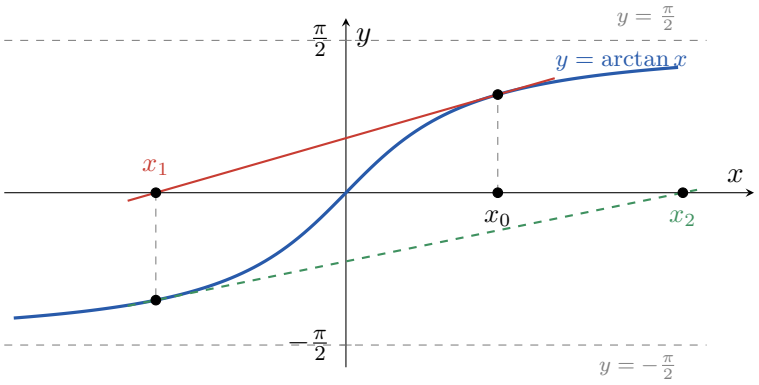


Figure 19.4: Failure through outward overshoot on $f(x) = \arctan x$. Starting from $x_0 = 1.6$, the shallow tangent (red) overshoots the root at $x = 0$, landing farther away at $x_1 \approx -2.0$. The next tangent at x_1 (dashed green) overshoots even farther to $x_2 \approx +3.55$. The iterates diverge to $\pm\infty$ in an expanding spiral.

Common trap

A common and dangerous habit is to run a fixed number of Newton iterations and *trust the result without checking*. If the start was bad, your final x_n may have nothing to do with any root – it might be drifting toward infinity, or oscillating, or have parked itself near a different root than you wanted. Always verify by plugging back in: confirm that $f(x_n)$ is genuinely small. The iteration's internal confidence is no substitute for evaluating the function.

19.5.4 Failure 3: a cycle that never lands

The most surprising failure is that the iterates can fall into a *loop*, bouncing between two values forever, never approaching any root even though one exists. The textbook example is

$$f(x) = x^3 - 2x + 2.$$

Take $x_0 = 0$. Then $f(0) = 2$ and $f'(0) = -2$, so

$$x_1 = 0 - \frac{2}{-2} = 1.$$

Now from $x_1 = 1$: $f(1) = 1 - 2 + 2 = 1$ and $f'(1) = 3 - 2 = 1$, so

$$x_2 = 1 - \frac{1}{1} = 0.$$

We are back to 0. The next step sends us to 1 again, then back to 0, forever: $0 \to 1 \to 0 \to 1 \to \cdots$. The method has entered a two-cycle and will never escape, even though f has a perfectly good real root near -1.77. Starting from the wrong place locked us into a trap with no exit.

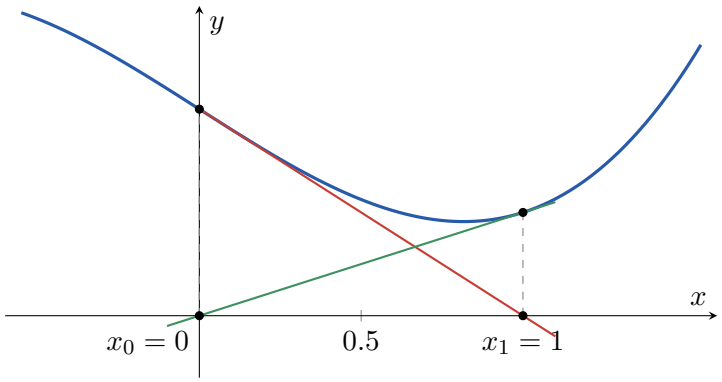


Figure 19.5: A two-cycle for $f(x) = x^3 - 2x + 2$ started at $x_0 = 0$. The red tangent at 0 crosses at 1; the green tangent at 1 crosses back at 0. Newton's method ping-pongs $0 \to 1 \to 0 \to 1 \to \cdots$ and never finds the actual root near -1.77.

19.5.5 Failure 4: a double root slows everything to a crawl

The final "failure" is gentler – the method still converges, but it loses its trademark speed. This happens at a *multiple root*, where $f(r) = 0$ and also $f'(r) = 0$, so the curve does not cross the axis cleanly but kisses it tangentially. Take

$$f(x) = (x-1)^2, \qquad r = 1 \text{ (a double root)}.$$

The iteration becomes

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{(x_n - 1)^2}{2(x_n - 1)} = x_n - \frac{x_n - 1}{2} = \frac{x_n + 1}{2}.$$

Starting at $x_0 = 2$ this gives 1.5, 1.25, 1.125, 1.0625, ... – the error is merely *halving* each step. That is steady but slow **linear** convergence: one extra correct bit per step, not a doubling of digits. The near-flat crossing starves the denominator $f'(x_n)$, which is heading toward zero along with the numerator, and quadratic convergence is lost (Figure 19.6). (There are repaired versions of Newton's method that restore fast convergence at known multiple roots, but the plain method crawls.)

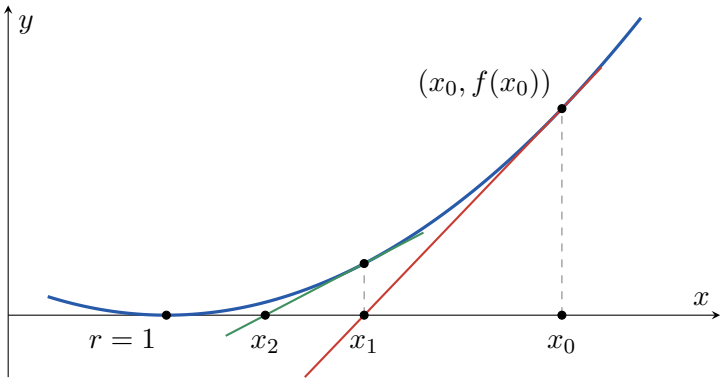


Figure 19.6: Why a double root crawls on $f(x) = (x-1)^2$. Because the parabola kisses the horizontal axis at $r = 1$ rather than crossing it at a slant, the tangent line from any guess x_n lands at the exact midpoint between x_n and the root: $x_{n+1} - 1 = \frac{1}{2}(x_n - 1)$. Instead of squaring the error, each step merely cuts the remaining distance in half (linear convergence).

Intuition

Collect the lesson. Newton's method is a *local* method: near a simple root, with an appropriate initial guess, it converges rapidly; but a flat derivative, a distant start, an unlucky cycle, or a multiple root can stall, mislead, or diverge it. The practical approach is to start from a reasonable guess (often found by a crude, slow, but *reliable* method first), then apply Newton's method to compute the root to full precision, and *always check the answer* by evaluating f.

History

The algorithm bears Isaac Newton's name, but its evolution is a striking example of how modern calculus cleaned up historical algebra. In 1669, Newton wrote a manuscript titled *De analysi per aequationes numero terminorum infinitas* (circulated privately to colleagues and published only in 1711). In it, Newton demonstrated his method on a single cubic polynomial equation:

$$y^3 - 2y - 5 = 0.$$

Newton noted that $y = 2$ is a close guess (giving $8 - 4 - 5 = -1$). Setting $y = 2 + p$, he expanded $(2 + p)^3 - 2(2 + p) - 5 = -1 + 10p + 6p^2 + p^3 = 0$. Neglecting the nonlinear terms $6p^2$ and p^3 as small, he solved $-1 + 10p \approx 0 \implies p = 0.1$. He then set $p = 0.1 + q$, substituted again, and repeated the process. Newton's method was purely algebraic, required expanding polynomials anew at every single stage, and made zero reference to derivatives, slopes, or tangent lines.

In 1690, **Joseph Raphson** published *Analysis aequationum universalis*. Raphson recognized that Newton's tedious chain of changing variables ($y \to p \to q$) could be replaced by a clean, unified algebraic iteration: generating each new numerical approximation directly from the original polynomial coefficients. Because Raphson published this streamlined iteration fifty years before Newton's original text appeared in print, the algorithm is properly called the **Newton–Raphson method**, and priority disputes simmered for decades over historical credit.

The crowning step belongs to **Thomas Simpson**. In 1740, in *Essays on Several Curious and Useful Subjects in Speculative and Mixed Mathematicks*, Simpson broke free of polynomials. He was the first to frame the method using the derivative in the denominator—$x_{n+1} = x_n - f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$—and the first to recognize that the tangent line to *any* smooth geometric curve provides the path to the axis. Simpson also generalized the method to systems of simultaneous non-linear equations. It took seventy years for Newton's polynomial scratchpad to become the geometric, calculus-powered engine we use today.

Yet even with calculus in hand, hard questions remained open. In 1879, the British mathematician **Arthur Cayley** asked a simple question: if you run Newton's method on the complex cubic equation $z^3 - 1 = 0$ (whose three roots form an equilateral triangle in the complex numbers), which initial guesses converge to which root? Cayley was baffled to find that near the boundaries between the three basins of attraction—the regions of initial guesses flowing to each root—the behavior was chaotic. It was only in the 1920s that Pierre Fatou and Gaston Julia proved these boundary zones are *fractals*: geometric sets of infinite, self-similar detail where an infinitesimal nudge in your starting guess changes the destination completely. Today, finding provably fast starting points for general systems of polynomial equations remains an open problem, highlighted in Steve Smale's 17th problem for twenty-first-century mathematics.

19.6 Why it is so fast: quadratic convergence

We have repeatedly claimed that, in the happy case, the number of correct digits *doubles* each step. Time to prove it. The proof is short, and it pinpoints exactly which features of f make the method fly.

The tool is Taylor's theorem to second order, which you can think of for now as linear approximation *with its error term written out exactly*. It says: for a function with a continuous second derivative, expanding f about the point x_n and evaluating at the true root r,

$$f(r) = f(x_n) + f'(x_n)\,(r - x_n) + \tfrac{1}{2} f''(\xi)\,(r - x_n)^2,$$

where ξ is some point between x_n and r. The left side is $f(r) = 0$, because r is the root. So

$$0 = f(x_n) + f'(x_n)\,(r - x_n) + \tfrac{1}{2} f''(\xi)\,(r - x_n)^2.$$

Now divide the whole line by $f'(x_n)$ (legal, since we are assuming a simple root, so f' is not zero nearby):

$$0 = \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)} + (r - x_n) + \frac{f''(\xi)}{2f'(x_n)}\,(r - x_n)^2.$$

Move the first two terms to the left-hand side, noting that $-(r - x_n) = x_n - r$:

$$x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)} - r = \frac{f''(\xi)}{2f'(x_n)}\,(r - x_n)^2.$$

The first two terms are precisely the definition of x_{n+1}:

$$\underbrace{x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}}_{= x_{n+1}} - r = \frac{f''(\xi)}{2f'(x_n)}\,(r - x_n)^2.$$

Define the error at step n as $e_n = x_n - r$. Then $(r - x_n)^2 = e_n^2$, and the left side is exactly $x_{n+1} - r = e_{n+1}$. We have arrived at the master equation of Newton's method:

$$\boxed{e_{n+1} = \frac{f''(\xi)}{2f'(x_n)}\,e_n^2}.$$

Focus

Read this equation slowly, for it contains the whole story. The new error e_{n+1} is proportional to the *square* of the old error e_n. Once e_n is small – say 0.01 – its square is 0.0001, which is a hundred times smaller. The next error is the square of *that*, around 10^{-8}, and the next around 10^{-16}. Each step roughly doubles the count of accurate digits. That squaring is quadratic convergence, and it is built into the geometry: it comes from the fact that the tangent line matches the curve's value *and* slope, so the leftover disagreement is governed by the next term, the curvature f'', multiplying the square of the gap.

Pause and think: Why does squaring the error double the number of correct decimal places? Write the error in scientific notation: an error of 10^{-3} means three digits after the decimal point are verified. When you square that error, $(10^{-3})^2 = 10^{-6}$, yielding six correct places. Square again, and

you reach 10^{-12}, giving twelve correct places. Each step doubles the negative exponent, multiplying your precision at exponential speed.

Figure 19.7 makes the contrast between quadratic and linear convergence visible. We plot the number of correct digits against the step number for our $\sqrt{2}$ run (a simple root, quadratic) and for the double-root crawl $f(x) = (x-1)^2$ from Section 19.5 (linear). The quadratic curve bends sharply upward – each step buys roughly twice the digits of the last – while the linear one climbs at a fixed, plodding pace.

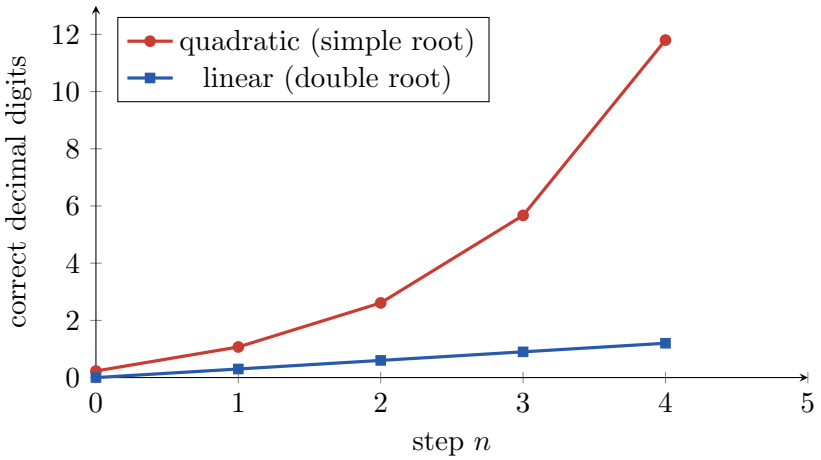


Figure 19.7: Correct digits versus step number. For a simple root (red) Newton's method gains digits at an accelerating rate – the signature of quadratic convergence. For a double root (blue) it gains a fixed amount per step, the slow march of linear convergence. Same algorithm, two radically different speeds, decided entirely by whether $f'(r) = 0$.

The master equation also explains every failure mode at a single glance:

- **The constant out front.** The error is multiplied by $C \approx |f''/2f'|$. If the curve has a clean, steep crossing – f' large, f'' modest – then C is small and convergence is extremely fast. If f' is near zero (the flat-tangent failure), C blows up and a step can hurl you away. The denominator f' is the method's lifeline.
- **Why "close enough" matters.** The relation $e_{n+1} \approx Ce_n^2$ shrinks the error only if $C\,|e_n| < 1$, i.e. only once $|e_n| < 1/C$. Inside that radius each step shrinks the error and the squaring takes over; outside it, squaring a too-large number makes things *worse*. That threshold is the precise meaning of "start close enough."
- **Why double roots crawl.** At a double root $f'(r) = 0$, so the derivation above breaks – you cannot divide by $f'(x_n)$ cleanly, because it too is heading to zero. A more careful analysis (which we leave to the exercises) shows the error then merely *halves* each step: linear, not quadratic. The whole speed advantage came from $f'(r) \neq 0$.

Why this matters

The very same feature that made the tangent line a *good* approximation – that it matches the curve to first order, leaving an error of size $(\Delta x)^2$ – is what makes Newton's method *fast*. The quadratic error of linear approximation turns into the quadratic *convergence* that doubles the

number of accurate digits per step.

19.7 Newton's method as fixed-point iteration

Newton's method belongs to a larger family of root-finding algorithms, the **fixed-point iterations**, and it is a particularly clever member of that family. Placing it there explains *why* Newton converges so much faster than its cousins, and it ties the method to a general theory worth knowing.

A fixed-point iteration is any rule of the shape

$$x_{n+1} = g(x_n),$$

for some function g. You feed in a number, the function spits out the next number, and you keep feeding the output back in. If the sequence settles down to a limit $x^\star$, then taking limits on both sides forces $x^\star = g(x^\star)$: the limit is a point that g leaves *fixed*. That is what a fixed point is – an input g returns unchanged.

Newton's method is exactly such an iteration with the particular choice

$$g(x) = x - \frac{f(x)}{f'(x)}.$$

And notice: at a root r of f we have $f(r) = 0$, so $g(r) = r - 0 = r$. The roots of f are precisely the fixed points of Newton's g. Hunting a root of f has been quietly converted into hunting a fixed point of g.

Connection

Fixed points are everywhere in mathematics, and the picture for finding them is the *cobweb diagram*: plot $y = g(x)$ and the line $y = x$ on the same axes; a fixed point is where the curve meets the diagonal. The iteration is a staircase – go vertically to the curve, horizontally to the diagonal, vertically to the curve – and whether the staircase spirals *into* the fixed point or *away* from it is governed by one number: the slope $g'(x^\star)$ at the fixed point. If $|g'(x^\star)| < 1$ the iteration is a contraction near the fixed point and homes in; if $|g'(x^\star)| > 1$ it is repelled and flies off. This is the contraction-mapping idea, and it reaches far beyond calculus – into differential equations, economics (market equilibria are fixed points), and the convergence proofs that underpin much of numerical analysis.

Here is what sets Newton's method apart from an ordinary fixed-point iteration. For a generic g, convergence is *linear*: the error shrinks by roughly the constant factor $|g'(x^\star)|$ each step – a fixed fraction, like steadily losing half the error every time. That is fine but slow. Newton's iteration function g has a derivative at the root that is not just smaller than 1, but *equal to zero*. Here is the verification. Differentiate $g(x) = x - f(x)/f'(x)$ using the quotient rule on the fraction:

$$g'(x) = 1 - \frac{f'(x)\,f'(x) - f(x)\,f''(x)}{\big(f'(x)\big)^2} = 1 - \frac{\big(f'(x)\big)^2 - f(x)\,f''(x)}{\big(f'(x)\big)^2} = \frac{f(x)\,f''(x)}{\big(f'(x)\big)^2}.$$

Evaluate at the root r, where $f(r) = 0$:

$$g'(r) = \frac{f(r)\,f''(r)}{\big(f'(r)\big)^2} = \frac{0 \cdot f''(r)}{\big(f'(r)\big)^2} = 0.$$

Why the technique works

Why does $g'(r) = 0$ explain the speed? In a fixed-point iteration the error multiplies by about $g'(x^\star)$ each step – so if that slope were, say, 0.5, you would lose half the error per step (linear). Newton arranges $g'(r) = 0$, which kills the linear term entirely. With the first-order term gone, the leading behavior of the error is governed by the *next* term in the Taylor expansion of g, the one carrying $g''(r)$ and a factor of e_n^2. So $e_{n+1} \approx \frac{1}{2} g''(r)\, e_n^2$ – error proportional to the square of the error, which is exactly the quadratic convergence we derived directly. Newton's method succeeds because it is the unique formulation of a fixed-point map that zeroes out the derivative at the root, and zeroing the derivative is precisely what upgrades linear convergence to quadratic.

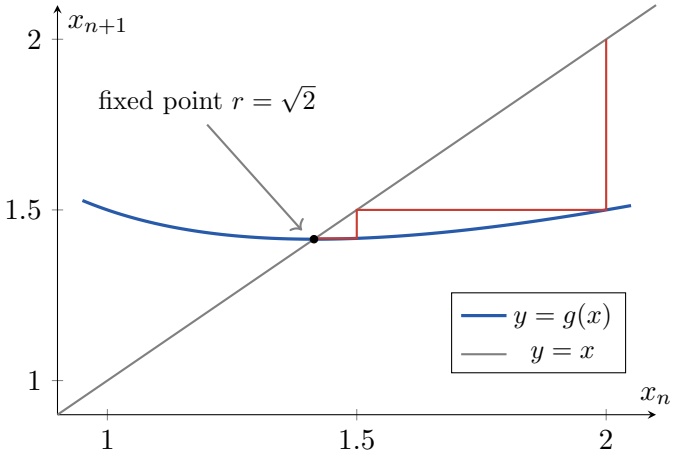


Figure 19.8: Cobweb diagram for Newton's iteration on $\sqrt{2}$, where $g(x) = \frac{x}{2} + \frac{1}{x}$. The staircase (red) descends from $x_0 = 2$ to the fixed point where $y = g(x)$ meets the diagonal $y = x$. Because the curve g is *flat* (slope 0) right at the fixed point, the staircase collapses onto it quadratically.

19.8 Newton's method in real computation

Seeing the method as code is instructive, because the gap between the formula and a robust program is exactly where the failure modes of Section 19.5 demand respect. Here is the method as a small program, written in plain pseudocode that any language would render almost verbatim.

```
def newton(f, fprime, x0, tol=1e-12, max_iter=50):
    x = x0
    for n in range(max_iter):
        fx = f(x)
        if abs(fx) < tol:          # close enough: f(x) is essentially zero
            return x
        dfx = fprime(x)
        if dfx == 0:               # flat tangent: bail out, do not divide by zero
            raise ValueError("zero derivative; Newton stalled")
        x = x - fx / dfx           # the one line that is the whole method
    raise ValueError("did not converge in max_iter steps")
```

Three things in this little program encode the wisdom of the chapter. The `tol` test checks the answer by evaluating f – never trust the iterate blindly. The zero-derivative guard refuses to divide by a vanishing slope. And the `max_iter` cap stops the loop from running forever if the start was bad and the iterates are wandering off or cycling. The mathematics is one line; the engineering is the safety rail around it.

Application

Newton's method drives a great deal of modern computation, far beyond solving single equations.

- **Optimization and machine learning.** To minimize a function F, you look for where its derivative is zero – a root of F'. Applying Newton's method to F' gives the update $x_{n+1} = x_n - F'(x_n)/F''(x_n)$, "Newton's method for optimization," which uses curvature (F'') to take far smarter steps than plain gradient descent. In many variables F'' becomes the Hessian matrix, and training large models leans on quasi-Newton methods (BFGS, L-BFGS) that approximate it.
- **Systems of equations.** Replace f by a vector of functions and f' by the Jacobian matrix; the update becomes "solve a linear system at each step." This multivariable Newton is how engineers solve the giant nonlinear systems behind circuit simulation, fluid dynamics, and structural analysis.
- **Inside the hardware.** As mentioned, reciprocals, square roots, and divisions are computed by Newton iterations chosen so that each step needs only multiplication – the operation silicon does fastest.

The reason it is chosen again and again is the quadratic convergence we proved: when each step doubles your digits, you reach full machine precision (about 16 decimal digits) in a mere handful of iterations.

19.9 A fully worked, non-algebraic example

To close, let us solve a genuine transcendental equation by hand:

$$\cos x = x.$$

This asks for the place where the cosine curve crosses the diagonal line $y = x$ – a number called the *Dottie number*, with no closed form whatsoever. Rewrite it as a root problem:

$$f(x) = \cos x - x = 0, \qquad f'(x) = -\sin x - 1.$$

A quick sketch (or noting $f(0) = 1 > 0$ and $f(1) = \cos 1 - 1 \approx -0.46 < 0$) shows the root lies between 0 and 1. Start at $x_0 = 1$ (radians throughout).

Work it yourself

The iteration is $x_{n+1} = x_n - \dfrac{\cos x_n - x_n}{-\sin x_n - 1}$. Step through it:

$$
\begin{aligned}
x_0 &= 1 \\
x_1 &= 1 - \frac{\cos 1 - 1}{-\sin 1 - 1} = 1 - \frac{0.540302 - 1}{-0.841471 - 1} = 1 - \frac{-0.459698}{-1.841471} = 0.750364 \\
x_2 &= 0.750364 - \frac{\cos(0.750364) - 0.750364}{-\sin(0.750364) - 1} = 0.739113 \\
x_3 &= 0.739085 \\
x_4 &= 0.739085\ldots
\end{aligned}
$$

The root is $0.7390851332\ldots$, and we have it to nine places after four steps.

Notice the digits settling: x_1 is right to one place, x_2 to three, x_3 to six or seven – the familiar doubling. From a single crude guess and four lines of arithmetic we have pinned down, to nine decimal places, a number that no formula can express. This is what Newton's method buys you: it turns calculus – the tangent line, the derivative, the second-order error – into a machine that manufactures the solutions algebra cannot reach.

Pause

If you take one thing from this chapter, take the master equation $e_{n+1} \approx C\,e_n^2$ and the picture behind it: a tangent line, ridden down to the axis, again and again. The formula $x_{n+1} = x_n - f(x_n)/f'(x_n)$ is just that picture written in symbols, and the squaring of the error is just the price the curve charges for not being a straight line – a price that, near a simple root, is wonderfully small.

19.9.1 Convergence, chaos, and algorithmic roots

Connection

Newton's method is our first encounter with a **nonlinear dynamical system**: a rule where the output of one step is fed back in as the input to the next, producing complex evolutionary behavior from a simple formula.

When conditions are favorable, that feedback loop converges rapidly. Within the *basin of attraction* of a simple root – the set of all starting guesses that successfully home in on that particular root – the error squares at every iteration ($e_{n+1} \approx Ce_n^2$). The number of verified decimal digits doubles at each evaluation, solving *transcendental equations* (equations involving sines, cosines, or exponentials that have no algebraic formulas in radicals) to machine precision in four or five quick steps. From celestial mechanics predicting planetary orbits to GPS triangulation and circuit simulation, this quadratic convergence underpins quantitative engineering.

Yet when pushed into its danger zones, that same feedback loop can fail or behave chaotically. A vanishing derivative flings iterates toward infinity. Symmetric hills trap guesses in periodic cycles. An inflection point, as in $\arctan x$ when $|x_0| > 1.3917$, triggers runaway divergence.

And in the complex plane, the boundaries between different basins of attraction form intricate *fractals*—geometric shapes with infinite, self-repeating detail where an infinitesimal nudge to your initial guess can radically alter which root the method ultimately finds.
These breakdowns demonstrate why raw calculus must be paired with numerical safeguards. Modern production libraries rarely run Newton's method in isolation. Instead, they deploy hybrid algorithms such as *Brent's method*: pairing the guaranteed interval-bracketing of the Intermediate Value Theorem with the quadratic acceleration of Newton's method. In high-dimensional optimization, this geometric logic extends to *quasi-Newton algorithms* (such as BFGS), which train modern machine learning models by approximating multivariable curvature without the high cost of computing exact second derivatives.
Looking ahead. For ten chapters we have sliced curves apart into instantaneous slopes. In Chapter 20, we turn calculus around and begin adding things up: the definite integral reconstructs total accumulation from a changing rate.

19.10 Exercises

Exercise 19.1 (Mental check: resting points)**.** What does Newton's formula produce if your starting guess x_0 is already an exact root ($f(x_0) = 0$)? What happens geometrically if the tangent line at your guess is horizontal ($f'(x_0) = 0$)? State in one sentence what each situation tells you about the iteration.

Exercise 19.2 (Mental check: overshooting the domain)**.** Consider $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$, defined for $x \geq 0$, whose only root is $x = 0$. (a) Compute $f'(x)$ and show that Newton's update simplifies to $x_{n+1} = -x_n$. (b) If you start at $x_0 = 4$, where does x_1 land? Why does the method immediately fail on the very next step? Sketch the tangent line at $x_0 = 4$ to see why it overshoots past the boundary of the domain.

Exercise 19.3. Use Newton's method to estimate $\sqrt{5}$ by finding the positive root of $f(x) = x^2 - 5$. Start at $x_0 = 2$ and carry out three iterations by hand, writing each x_n to six decimal places. Compare x_3 to the true value $2.2360679\ldots$ and count how many digits are correct at each step.

Exercise 19.4. Derive, from the general iteration, the formula for computing the cube root of a positive number a by applying Newton's method to $f(x) = x^3 - a$. Simplify your update into the form $x_{n+1} = \frac{1}{3}\left(2x_n + a/x_n^2\right)$, and use it to estimate $\sqrt[3]{2}$ starting from $x_0 = 1$ (two iterations).

Exercise 19.5. Show that applying Newton's method to $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x} - a$ (for a positive constant a) yields the update $x_{n+1} = x_n(2 - ax_n)$, which computes $1/a$ using only multiplication and subtraction – no division. Test it with $a = 4$ and $x_0 = 0.2$, performing two steps, and check that you approach 0.25.

Exercise 19.6. The equation $x^3 - 2x + 2 = 0$ produces the two-cycle $0 \to 1 \to 0 \to \cdots$ from the start $x_0 = 0$, as shown in the chapter. (a) Verify the cycle by direct computation. (b) The equation has a real root near $x = -1.77$. Starting instead from $x_0 = -2$, perform three Newton iterations and confirm the iterates head toward that root. What does this contrast teach about the choice of starting point?

Exercise 19.7. Find the unique real root of $x^3 + x - 1 = 0$ to six decimal places using Newton's method, starting from $x_0 = 1$. Show your work for at least three iterations and verify your answer by plugging it back into the function.

Exercise 19.8 (Conceptual)**.** Explain in your own words, using a sketch, why Newton's method can fail when the starting guess lands near a point where $f'(x) = 0$. Then describe geometrically what happens to the next iterate, and why this is a genuine breakdown of the method rather than a minor inaccuracy.

Exercise 19.9 (Conceptual)**.** The function $g(x) = x - f(x)/f'(x)$ is the fixed-point map behind Newton's method. A general fixed-point iteration $x_{n+1} = g(x_n)$ converges *linearly* when $0 < |g'(x^\star)| < 1$. Using the formula $g'(x) = f(x)f''(x)/(f'(x))^2$ derived in the chapter, explain why Newton's method converges *faster* than a typical fixed-point iteration, and what specifically goes right at a simple root.

Exercise 19.10 (Multiple root)**.** For the double root of $f(x) = (x-3)^2$, show that Newton's iteration simplifies to $x_{n+1} = \frac{1}{2}(x_n + 3)$. Starting from $x_0 = 5$, compute the errors $|x_n - 3|$ for $n = 0, 1, 2, 3, 4$ and confirm that they merely *halve* each step (linear convergence) rather than the digits doubling. Explain, referring to the master equation $e_{n+1} = \frac{f''(\xi)}{2f'(x_n)} e_n^2$, why the quadratic behavior is lost at a double root.

Exercise 19.11 (Proof)**.** Let f have a continuous second derivative and a simple root r (so $f'(r) \neq 0$). Starting from the second-order Taylor expansion of f about x_n evaluated at r, derive the master equation

$$e_{n+1} = \frac{f''(\xi)}{2f'(x_n)}\, e_n^2, \qquad e_n = x_n - r,$$

for some ξ between x_n and r. Then argue that there exist a constant M and a radius $\delta > 0$ such that if $|e_0| < \delta$, the errors satisfy $|e_{n+1}| \leq M|e_n|^2$, and conclude that the convergence is quadratic.

Exercise 19.12 (Application)**.** To minimize a smooth function $F(x)$, one seeks a root of $F'(x) = 0$. Write down the Newton iteration for this root problem (it will involve F' and F''). Apply it to $F(x) = x^4 - 3x^2 + x$ starting from $x_0 = 1$, performing two iterations, and interpret geometrically what the resulting point represents.

Part V

The Integral

Chapter 20

The Integral: Area and Accumulation

In the previous chapter on Newton's method, the tangent line let us pinpoint roots of complicated equations using local slopes. For ten chapters, in fact, we have been obsessed with that one operation: *taking things apart*. The derivative slices a curve into its instantaneous tendencies – the slope here, the slope there, the rate of change at one frozen moment. We zoomed in until the curve became a line and read off how steep that line was. That is calculus run *downhill*: from a whole thing to its local behavior.

This chapter runs calculus the other way. We are going to *add things up*. Given a rate that changes from moment to moment, we will reconstruct the total that accumulated. Given a curve, we will find the area trapped underneath it. And the central discovery of the next chapter is that these two activities, taking apart and adding up, are exact inverses of one another. Differentiation undoes integration and integration undoes differentiation, the way subtraction undoes addition. Before proving that connection, however, we first meet the integral on its own terms, with no derivatives in sight at all.

Focus

Two questions that look unrelated turn out to be the *same* question: (1) What is the area under a curve? (2) If I know the *rate* at which something accumulates at every instant, how much accumulates in total? This chapter builds one object – the **definite integral**, measuring the net total accumulated across an interval as a limit of thin slices – that answers both.

By the end you will know what the symbol $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ really means: not as a rule to apply, but as a limit of a perfectly concrete sum of rectangles. You will see why that elongated S was chosen, what the $\mathrm{d}x$ is doing there, and why "area" sometimes comes out negative. We will compute an integral or two from raw first principles – no shortcuts, no Fundamental Theorem – just so you can feel in your hands what the definition is actually asking for.

20.1 Two ancient problems, one idea

20.1.1 The area problem

How much area is inside a circle? For a rectangle (length times width) or a triangle (half base times height) the answer is immediate, because those shapes are built from straight lines and area for straight-line shapes is elementary. But a circle is bounded by a curve, and there is no finite recipe of multiplications that gives its area. The number π records the fact that the area of a curved region is a genuinely new kind of quantity.

The Greeks found the way through, and it is the same way we will take. Around 250 BCE, Archimedes computed the area of regions bounded by curves – a segment of a parabola, the circle – by trapping the unknown area between shapes he *could* measure. Inscribe a polygon inside the circle and circumscribe another outside it. The true area is squeezed between the two. Now add more sides. The inscribed polygon swells outward, the circumscribed one shrinks inward, and the gap between them closes. The area of the circle is the single number both sequences are converging to.

History

The dream of calculating areas under curves spans over two millennia of struggle against the paradoxes of the infinite. Around 250 BCE, in his treatise *Quadrature of the Parabola* (where "quadrature" was the classical term for finding the area of a curved region by matching it to a square), Archimedes calculated the exact area of a parabolic segment. He inscribed a large triangle and packed the remaining gaps with an infinite cascade of smaller triangles whose areas formed a geometric series—a sum where each term is a fixed fraction ($\frac{1}{4}$) of the previous one:

$$\text{Area} = T + \frac{1}{4}T + \frac{1}{16}T + \cdots = \frac{4}{3}T.$$

Because ancient Greek mathematics rejected actual infinities, Archimedes avoided limits by using the *method of exhaustion*: a double proof by contradiction showing the area could be neither greater nor less than $\frac{4}{3}T$, exhausting any conceivable gap between the polygon and the curve.

Nearly two millennia later, in *Geometria indivisibilibus continuorum* (1635), the Italian mathematician Bonaventura Cavalieri took a daring leap: he imagined a two-dimensional shape as a stack of infinitely many parallel lines of zero thickness, which he called *indivisibles* (like the pages bound in a book, or coins piled in a cylinder). Cavalieri showed that if two regions share equal cross-sections at every height, their total areas must match (*Cavalieri's Principle*). Yet indivisibles sparked a furious controversy. Jesuit mathematicians such as Paul Guldin and the English philosopher Thomas Hobbes attacked them as logically absurd, demanding how lines with zero width could ever accumulate into a finite area, or how an infinity of zeroes could add up to anything at all.

In October 1675, Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz resolved the conceptual knot with one of the most fruitful inventions in the history of science: the integral sign $\int$. Leibniz realized that instead of zero-width indivisibles, one should sum an infinity of thin rectangles of height y and infinitesimal width $\mathrm{d}x$—a width smaller than any positive number yet not zero. He adopted the elongated letter "S" (for the Latin *summa*, or sum) and wrote $\int y\,\mathrm{d}x$, so the notation itself explained that an integral is a sum of tiny rectangular strips.

The modern foundation was completed in the nineteenth century by Augustin-Louis Cauchy

and Bernhard Riemann. In 1854, Riemann proved that the integral is neither an infinite series of metaphysical indivisibles nor a mysterious sum of zeroes, but the precise limit of finite approximating sums as the mesh size (the width of the widest subinterval) shrinks to zero: $\lim_{\|P\|\to 0} \sum f(x_k^*)\Delta x_k$. This established a universal, rigorous definition of area, volume, and continuous accumulation. Yet Riemann's integral had its own boundary: it fails for wildly discontinuous functions (such as a function that equals 1 on rational numbers and 0 on irrationals). In 1902, Henri Lebesgue resolved this by partitioning the function's outputs rather than its inputs, creating modern measure theory. Today, the frontier remains open in mathematical physics: integrating over infinite-dimensional spaces of paths—the Feynman path integrals at the heart of quantum mechanics and quantum field theory—still lacks a universally rigorous mathematical foundation in four spacetime dimensions.

20.1.2 The accumulation problem

Now a problem that seems to have nothing to do with area. A car's speedometer reads $v(t)$ at every instant t. The speed is changing – the driver accelerates, brakes, coasts. *How far did the car travel* between time $t = a$ and time $t = b$?

If the speed were *constant* at 60 miles per hour for 2 hours, distance would be easy: $60 \times 2 = 120$ miles. Rate times time. But the speed is not constant; it changes continuously, and "rate times time" has no obvious meaning when the rate is a moving target.

Here is the method, and notice that it applies the same geometric principle to motion. Chop the trip into tiny time intervals. Over a single hundredth of a second the speed barely changes, so on that sliver the motion is *almost* constant-speed, and distance is *almost* just "speed at that moment times the length of the sliver." Add up the slivers. The finer you chop, the better the approximation, and the true distance is the number these sums converge to.

Intuition

Both problems have the same skeleton. There is a quantity you cannot get directly because something is *curved* or *varying*. So you cut the domain into many small pieces, on each piece pretend the varying thing is constant (which is nearly true when the piece is small), compute the easy straight-line answer on each piece, add them all up, and then let the pieces shrink toward zero width. The integral is the limit of that sum.

Watch what the distance computation produces. On the time-axis, lay out the intervals. Above each one, draw a rectangle whose height is the speed during that interval. The *area* of one rectangle is (height)×(width) = (speed)×(time) = distance covered in that interval. So the total distance is the total *area* of all the rectangles – which is an approximation to the area under the speed curve $v(t)$. The accumulation problem *is* the area problem. Distance traveled is the area under the speed graph.

20.2 Riemann sums: making the idea precise

Let us stop gesturing and pin the construction down. We have a function f on a closed interval $[a, b]$. For now, picture f as continuous and positive, so "area under the graph" is unambiguous – we will lift those assumptions soon.

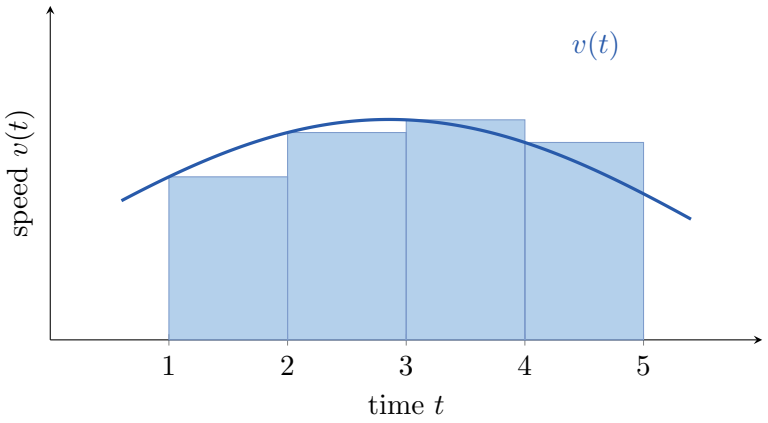


Figure 20.1: Distance traveled is the area under the speed curve. Each rectangle has height equal to the speed on that interval and width equal to the elapsed time, so its area is a distance. The sum of the rectangles approximates the area under $v(t)$; the true distance is the limit as the rectangles get thin.

20.2.1 Partitioning the interval

Cut $[a, b]$ into n subintervals. Choose points

$$a = x_0 < x_1 < x_2 < \cdots < x_{n-1} < x_n = b.$$

This list is called a **partition** P of $[a, b]$. In plain words, a partition is simply a collection of slice marks that cut the interval into smaller segments, like knife cuts dividing a loaf of bread. The k-th subinterval is $[x_{k-1}, x_k]$, and its width is

$$\Delta x_k = x_k - x_{k-1}.$$

The widths need not be equal, though most of the time we will make them equal: if we use n subintervals of the *same* width, then each has width

$$\Delta x = \frac{b-a}{n}, \qquad x_k = a + k\,\Delta x.$$

This even spacing is called a **regular** (or uniform) partition, and it is what you should picture by default.

20.2.2 Sampling a height on each piece

On each subinterval $[x_{k-1}, x_k]$ we are going to approximate the curve by a single horizontal line – a rectangle. But at what height? The curve takes many values across the subinterval; we must pick one. Choose any point $x_k^* \in [x_{k-1}, x_k]$, called a **sample point**, and use the height $f(x_k^*)$. A sample point is our chosen evaluation point inside that slice: we evaluate the function at this single location to fix the height of our approximating rectangle. The rectangle over the k-th subinterval then has

$$\text{area} = f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x_k.$$

Add them up over all n subintervals.

Definition 20.1 (Riemann sum)**.** Given a function f on $[a, b]$, a partition P with subintervals of width Δx_k, and a choice of sample points $x_k^* \in [x_{k-1}, x_k]$, the corresponding **Riemann sum** is

$$S(P, \{x_k^*\}) \;=\; \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x_k.$$

This sum is just a number: a finite pile of rectangle areas, signed by the sign of f. It is named for Bernhard Riemann, who in 1854 gave the first clean general definition of the integral built exactly this way. Each Riemann sum is an *approximation* to the area we are after. To get the true area we will take a limit – but first let us look at the three most common ways to choose the sample points, because their pictures teach you what is going on.

20.2.3 Left, right, and midpoint sums

With a regular partition, three natural choices of x_k^* stand out.

- **Left sum** L_n: take $x_k^* = x_{k-1}$, the left endpoint of each subinterval. The rectangle's height is the value of f at the left edge.
- **Right sum** R_n: take $x_k^* = x_k$, the right endpoint.
- **Midpoint sum** M_n: take $x_k^* = \frac{1}{2}(x_{k-1} + x_k)$, the center of each subinterval.

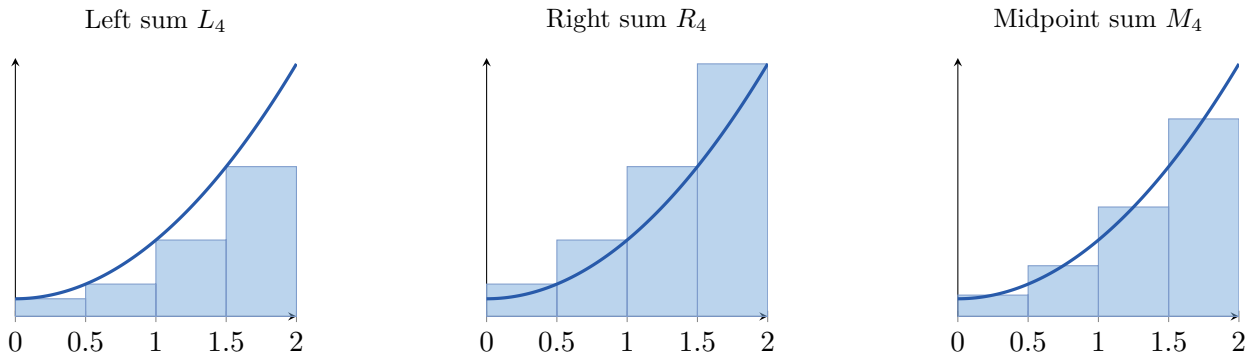


Figure 20.2: Three Riemann sums for $f(x) = x^2+0.3$ on $[0, 2]$ with four subintervals. On a rising curve the left sum *underestimates* (each rectangle ducks below the curve) and the right sum *overestimates*. The midpoint sum splits the difference and is usually closest.

Look at Figure 20.2. On a curve that is *increasing*, the left endpoint is the lowest point of f on each subinterval, so every left rectangle sits below the curve and L_n *undershoots* the true area. Symmetrically, R_n *overshoots*. The true area is sandwiched: $L_n \le$ area $\le R_n$. (On a decreasing curve the roles swap.) That sandwich is Archimedes' inscribed-and-circumscribed idea reborn: the left sum is an inscribed staircase, the right sum a circumscribed one, and the area lives between them.

Pause

Pause and think: What happens if the curve is *decreasing* instead of increasing? Picture it for three seconds before reading on: every left rectangle will now jut above the falling curve,

and every right rectangle will duck below it. The inequalities completely flip to $R_n \le \text{area} \le L_n$, but the true area remains securely trapped between the two staircases.

Work it yourself

Let us do one entirely by hand so the definition stops being abstract. Take $f(x) = x^2$ on $[0, 1]$ with $n = 4$ equal subintervals, so $\Delta x = \frac{1}{4}$ and the partition points are $0, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}, 1$.
Left sum. Heights at $0, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}$:

$$L_4 = \tfrac{1}{4}\big(0^2 + \tfrac{1}{16} + \tfrac{1}{4} + \tfrac{9}{16}\big) = \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot \tfrac{14}{16} = \tfrac{14}{64} = 0.21875.$$

Right sum. Heights at $\frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}, 1$:

$$R_4 = \tfrac{1}{4}\big(\tfrac{1}{16} + \tfrac{1}{4} + \tfrac{9}{16} + 1\big) = \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot \tfrac{30}{16} = \tfrac{30}{64} = 0.46875.$$

Midpoint sum. Heights at $\frac{1}{8}, \frac{3}{8}, \frac{5}{8}, \frac{7}{8}$:

$$M_4 = \tfrac{1}{4}\big(\tfrac{1}{64} + \tfrac{9}{64} + \tfrac{25}{64} + \tfrac{49}{64}\big) = \tfrac{1}{4} \cdot \tfrac{84}{64} = 0.328125.$$

The true area, as we will prove below, is exactly $\frac{1}{3} \approx 0.3333$. Notice $L_4 < \frac{1}{3} < R_4$ as promised, and M_4 is by far the closest – off by less than 0.006. Four rectangles already do well.

Common trap

A Riemann sum is **not** the integral. It is one finite approximation, pinned to a particular partition and a particular set of sample points. Change the sample points and you get a different number. The integral is what all these numbers *converge to* as the rectangles shrink. Students who write "$\int_a^b f = \sum f(x_k)\Delta x$" as if they were equal have skipped the only step that matters – the limit. The sum approximates; the limit *is*.

20.3 The definite integral as a limit

Now we take the limit. As we add more and more subintervals and let their widths shrink toward zero, the staircase of rectangles hugs the curve ever more tightly, and all the different Riemann sums – left, right, midpoint, any sample points at all – get squeezed toward one common value. That value is the integral.

We measure the "fineness" of a partition by its **mesh** (or norm), the width of its widest subinterval:

$$\|P\| = \max_{1 \le k \le n} \Delta x_k.$$

Think of the mesh as measuring the coarseness of your grid: if even the widest subinterval is squeezed down to paper-thinness, then every single subinterval is forced to vanish as well. Driving $\|P\| \to 0$ forces *every* subinterval to shrink, rather than merely the average. With that we can state the definition.

Definition 20.2 (The definite integral)**.** A function f is **integrable** on $[a, b]$ if there is a single number I with the following property: the Riemann sums approach I no matter how the sample

points are chosen, as the mesh goes to zero. In everyday terms, being integrable means the curve is well-behaved enough that our rectangle approximations settle down to one unambiguous total area. Precisely, for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a $\delta > 0$ such that for *any* partition P with $\|P\| < \delta$ and *any* choice of sample points,

$$\left| \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x_k \;-\; I \right| < \varepsilon.$$

When this number I exists we call it the **definite integral** of f from a to b and write

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;=\; \lim_{\|P\|\to 0} \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x_k \;=\; I.$$

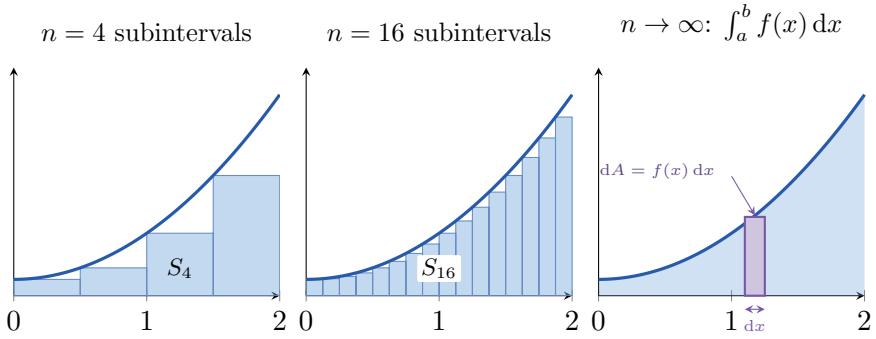


Figure 20.3: The limit of Riemann sums as the partition refines. Left: A coarse partition ($n = 4$) leaves visible staircase gaps and overshoots. Center: A finer partition ($n = 16$) hugs the curve closely as the staircase smooths out. Right: In the continuous limit $n \to \infty$ ($\Delta x \to 0$), the sum becomes the definite integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, accumulating infinitely many infinitesimal strips $\mathrm{d}A = f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$.

That "for any choice of sample points" is the whole strength of the definition. It is demanding that left sums, right sums, midpoint sums, and every other choice all funnel to the *same* limit. For a badly behaved f they might not, and then f is not integrable. The foundational fact of the subject guarantees that most familiar functions qualify:

Theorem 20.1 (Integrability of continuous functions)**.** *If f is continuous on $[a, b]$, then f is integrable on $[a, b]$. More generally, f is integrable if it is bounded and has at most finitely many discontinuities.*

The reason continuity suffices is intuitive: on a narrow subinterval, a continuous function cannot vary much. That property is *uniform* continuity on the closed interval $[a, b]$ – the guarantee that the curve's variation across every slice shrinks uniformly to zero as the slices narrow. Consequently, the gap between the tallest and shortest rectangle on each piece becomes tiny, forcing the left, right, and intermediate sums together. Squeeze the trap shut and the limit exists.

20.3.1 Decoding the notation

The symbol $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is one of the best-designed notations in all of mathematics, and Leibniz designed it in 1675 to be read literally.

What is really happening

Each piece of the integral notation records part of the Riemann sum:

- In the expression $f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, the factor $\mathrm{d}x$ recalls the finite subinterval width Δx_k as we pass to the limit $\Delta x_k \to 0$.
- $f(x)$ is the height of the curve across that slice.
- The product $f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ represents the area of one approximating strip: height times width.
- The sign $\int$ is the seventeenth-century long-*s* initial of the Latin *summa* ("sum") – chosen by Leibniz in 1675 as the continuous counterpart to finite summation (for which Euler later introduced the Greek Σ in 1755).
- The $\int_a^b$ says: accumulate these contributions as x sweeps from a to b.

Read it aloud the way Leibniz meant it: *"sum, from a to b, of height times infinitesimal width."* The integral is, in one symbol, the instruction "add up infinitely many infinitely thin pieces." Everything we did with Riemann sums was the finite, limit-respecting version of exactly that sentence.

A word on the x. It is a **dummy variable**: it ranges over the subintervals and then disappears in the limit. A dummy variable is simply a temporary placeholder whose label never affects the final outcome, exactly like the index k in a summation $\sum_{k=1}^{n} k$. The value of $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is a fixed number that does not depend on what letter you used. So $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_a^b f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = \int_a^b f(u)\,\mathrm{d}u$. The variable is temporary; the number is the actual result.

Why the technique works

Why does letting the rectangle width go to zero give the *exact* area rather than just a better guess? Because of the squeeze. On any subinterval, the true area under the curve lies between the shortest rectangle (height = minimum of f there) and the tallest (height = maximum). Summed up, the true area lies between the lower sum $\underline{S}_n$ and the upper sum $\overline{S}_n$. Each individual gap is at most (oscillation of f on that piece)$\times$(width of that piece). As the mesh shrinks, continuity forces every oscillation toward zero, so the total gap $\overline{S}_n - \underline{S}_n$ collapses to zero. The true area is pinned between two quantities that are coming together, so it must equal their shared limit. No error survives the limit – that is Archimedes' method of exhaustion made rigorous.

20.4 Computing an integral from the definition

Before we have any shortcuts, let us earn one integral the hard way – straight from Definition 20.2 – so you trust that the limit really is there and really is computable. We will compute

$$\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$$

and find it equals $\frac{1}{3}$, the number we sampled in the lab box above.

Example 20.1 ($\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$ by brute force)**.** Use a regular partition into n equal pieces, so $\Delta x = \frac{1}{n}$

and $x_k = \frac{k}{n}$. Choose right endpoints as sample points, $x_k^* = \frac{k}{n}$. The Riemann sum is

$$R_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n} \left(\frac{k}{n}\right)^2 \cdot \frac{1}{n} = \frac{1}{n^3} \sum_{k=1}^{n} k^2.$$

Now we need the sum of the first n squares – a classic closed form, provable by induction:

$$\sum_{k=1}^{n} k^2 = \frac{n(n+1)(2n+1)}{6}.$$

Substitute it in:

$$R_n = \frac{1}{n^3} \cdot \frac{n(n+1)(2n+1)}{6} = \frac{(n+1)(2n+1)}{6n^2} = \frac{2n^2+3n+1}{6n^2}.$$

Divide through by n^2:

$$R_n = \frac{1}{6}\left(2 + \frac{3}{n} + \frac{1}{n^2}\right).$$

Now let $n \to \infty$ (which drives the mesh $\frac{1}{n} \to 0$). The $\frac{3}{n}$ and $\frac{1}{n^2}$ terms vanish, leaving

$$\int_0^1 x^2 \, \mathrm{d}x = \lim_{n\to\infty} R_n = \frac{1}{6} \cdot 2 = \frac{1}{3}.$$

There it is, $\frac{1}{3}$, using no Fundamental Theorem and no antiderivative – nothing beyond a finite sum of squares and a limit. Notice the structure of the computation: a finite-but-growing sum, a closed form for it, then a limit that washes away every term except the one that survives. That is the integral doing precisely what its definition promised.

Work it yourself

Repeat the computation with *left* endpoints, $x_k^* = \frac{k-1}{n}$. Using $\sum_{k=1}^{n}(k-1)^2 = \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} j^2 = \frac{(n-1)n(2n-1)}{6} = \frac{2n^3-3n^2+n}{6}$, you will find $L_n = \frac{1}{6}\left(2 - \frac{3}{n} + \frac{1}{n^2}\right)$. This value is *below* $\frac{1}{3}$ for every finite n (the left sum undershoots a rising curve, as Figure 20.2 showed) – yet it still limits to the same $\frac{1}{3}$. Left and right disagree at every finite stage and agree in the limit. That agreement is integrability in action.

Why this matters

Every finite sum R_n was slightly too big because the rectangles poked above the parabola, yet as $n \to \infty$ the excess $\frac{3}{6n} + \frac{1}{6n^2}$ vanished completely, leaving the exact area $\frac{1}{3}$. Finite approximations plus a limit gave an exact curved area using only algebra.

20.5 Signed area: when the curve dips below the axis

So far f was positive and "area under the curve" meant exactly that. But the definition of the integral never required $f \geq 0$. If $f(x_k^*)$ is *negative*, the term $f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x_k$ is negative – it *subtracts* from the sum. So what does the integral compute when the curve goes below the x-axis?

Focus

The definite integral computes **signed area**: area above the x-axis counts as positive, area below counts as negative. The integral is the area above minus the area below.

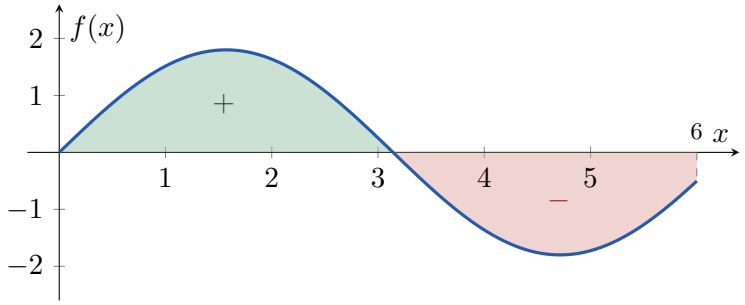


Figure 20.4: Signed area. For $f(x) = 1.8 \sin x$ on $[0, 6]$, the green hump above the axis counts positively and the red dip below counts negatively. The integral $\int_0^6 1.8 \sin x \, dx$ is the green area minus the red area, not the total amount of paint.

This sign convention follows directly from the definition, and it matches physical applications. Recall the car. If $v(t)$ is the car's *velocity* (a signed quantity – positive going forward, negative in reverse), then $\int_a^b v(t) \, dt$ is the *displacement*: net change in position. Time spent in reverse should subtract from how far you have gotten, and the negative integrand makes it do exactly that. If instead you want total distance traveled – odometer mileage, which never decreases – you integrate the *speed* $|v(t)|$, which is never negative. Displacement and distance differ precisely by the sign convention, and both are useful.

Pause

Pause and think: If a car drives east at 50 mph for an hour, then reverses west at 30 mph for an hour, what is its net displacement? The signed integral gives $50(1) + (-30)(1) = 20$ miles east. But what distance did the tires roll? The odometer integrates speed $|v(t)|$: $50(1) + 30(1) = 80$ miles. The definite integral tracks where you ended up; integrating the absolute value tracks the total tire wear.

Common trap

"Find the area between the curve and the axis" and "evaluate the integral" are different requests when the curve crosses the axis. The integral gives signed area and can be zero even when there is plenty of region (a symmetric wiggle cancels itself: $\int_0^{2\pi} \sin x \, dx = 0$). For *geometric* area – total paint – you must split at the crossing points and integrate $|f|$, or equivalently add up the absolute values of the pieces. Read the question carefully.

20.6 Properties of the integral

Working from the definition every time would be unbearable. Fortunately the integral inherits a handful of clean properties straight from the Riemann sum – each one is just a fact about sums that survives the limit. Let f and g be integrable on the relevant intervals and c a constant.

Focus

(1) Linearity (sum). $\displaystyle\int_a^b \big(f(x)+g(x)\big)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x + \int_a^b g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$

(2) Linearity (constant multiple). $\displaystyle\int_a^b c\,f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = c\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$

(3) Additivity over intervals. For $a<c<b$, $\displaystyle\int_a^b f = \int_a^c f + \int_c^b f.$

(4) Orientation (reversing the limits). $\displaystyle\int_b^a f = -\int_a^b f,$ and $\displaystyle\int_a^a f = 0.$

(5) Monotonicity. If $f(x)\le g(x)$ on $[a,b]$, then $\displaystyle\int_a^b f \le \int_a^b g.$

(6) The constant. $\displaystyle\int_a^b c\,\mathrm{d}x = c\,(b-a).$

Each of these is obvious once you see it as a statement about the rectangles.

Why linearity holds. A Riemann sum for $f+g$ is $\sum \big(f(x_k^*)+g(x_k^*)\big)\Delta x_k$. Finite sums split across addition, so this is $\sum f(x_k^*)\Delta x_k + \sum g(x_k^*)\Delta x_k$ – a Riemann sum for f plus a Riemann sum for g, on the *same* partition and *same* sample points. Take the limit of both sides; the limit of a sum is the sum of the limits. Pulling a constant c out is the same story: $\sum c\,f(x_k^*)\Delta x_k = c\sum f(x_k^*)\Delta x_k$. Linearity is simply the distributive law surviving a limit.

Why additivity holds. If the splitting point c is one of your partition points, then the rectangles over $[a,b]$ are literally the rectangles over $[a,c]$ followed by the rectangles over $[c,b]$. The sum over the whole is the sum over the left part plus the sum over the right part. Take the limit. Figure 20.5 illustrates the geometry: dividing the interval at c cuts the total region into two adjacent slices that fit together edge to edge. This is the property that lets us handle a function defined piecewise, or split at a sign change to compute geometric area.

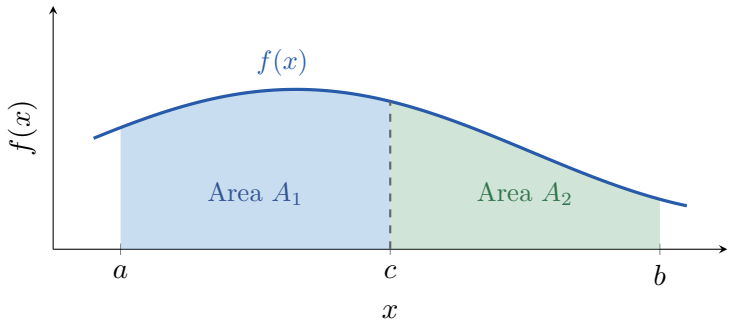


Figure 20.5: Additivity over intervals. Slicing the domain $[a,b]$ at $x=c$ cuts the region into two adjacent pieces of areas $A_1=\int_a^c f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ and $A_2=\int_c^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. The total area is the sum of the parts: $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = A_1+A_2 = \int_a^c f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x + \int_c^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Why orientation flips the sign. We built the integral with a on the left and b on the right, so $\Delta x_k>0$. If we agree to sweep the other way, every Δx_k becomes negative, flipping the sign of the

whole sum. Defining $\int_b^a f = -\int_a^b f$ makes the additivity rule $\int_a^c + \int_c^b = \int_a^b$ hold for *any* arrangement of a, b, c – even when c is outside $[a, b]$. The convention is chosen to keep the algebra consistent without splitting into cases, and you will be grateful for it in the next chapter.

Intuition

Monotonicity is the most intuitive of all: if one curve sits above another everywhere, the area under it is larger. There is simply more region underneath. In rectangle terms, $f \le g$ makes every rectangle for f no taller than the corresponding rectangle for g, so the sums obey the same inequality, and the inequality passes to the limit. From this one fact flow all the comparison and bounding estimates you will ever make for integrals.

Example 20.2 (Properties in action)**.** Suppose someone tells you $\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{3}$ (we proved it) and $\int_0^1 x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}$ (the area of a triangle of base and height 1). Then with no further integration:

$$\int_0^1 \left(6x^2 - 4x + 5\right)\mathrm{d}x = 6\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x - 4\int_0^1 x\,\mathrm{d}x + \int_0^1 5\,\mathrm{d}x = 6\cdot\tfrac{1}{3} - 4\cdot\tfrac{1}{2} + 5\cdot 1 = 2 - 2 + 5 = 5.$$

Linearity and the constant rule did all the work, dissolving a complicated integrand into simple known pieces.

20.7 The average value of a function

Here is a question the integral handles cleanly, and one that previews ideas to come. The average of finitely many numbers is their sum divided by how many there are. But what is the average *height* of a curve over an interval – the average of *infinitely many* values $f(x)$ as x ranges over $[a, b]$? You cannot divide "the sum of infinitely many values" by "infinity." The integral steps in exactly where the naive average breaks down.

Sample the curve at n evenly spaced points and average those:

$$\text{average} \approx \frac{f(x_1) + f(x_2) + \cdots + f(x_n)}{n}.$$

Multiply and divide by $\Delta x = \frac{b-a}{n}$. Since $\frac{1}{n} = \frac{\Delta x}{b-a}$,

$$\frac{1}{n}\sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k) = \frac{1}{b-a}\sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k)\,\Delta x.$$

The sum on the right is a Riemann sum for f. Let $n \to \infty$ and it becomes an integral, giving us the definition.

Definition 20.3 (Average value)**.** The **average value** of an integrable function f over $[a, b]$ is

$$\bar{f} = \frac{1}{b-a}\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Intuition

Rearrange it as $\bar{f} \cdot (b-a) = \int_a^b f(x)\,dx$. The left side is the area of a *rectangle* of width $(b-a)$ and height $\bar{f}$. So the average value is the height of the rectangle that has the *same area* as the region under the curve – the level you would pour the area into to make it flat. If you flooded the area under the graph and let it settle, $\bar{f}$ is the water line.

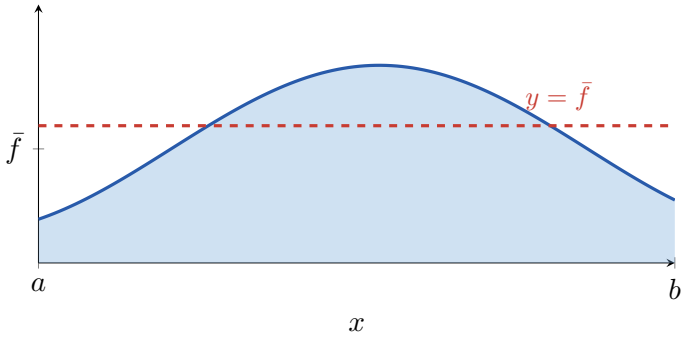


Figure 20.6: Average value as a leveling line. The dashed line $y = \bar{f}$ is set at the height that makes the rectangle over $[a, b]$ have exactly the same area as the shaded region under f. The curve's excess above the line exactly fills its deficits below.

Example 20.3 (Average value of a parabola)**.** The average value of $f(x) = x^2$ on $[0, 1]$ is

$$\bar{f} = \frac{1}{1-0}\int_0^1 x^2\,dx = \frac{1}{1}\cdot\frac{1}{3} = \frac{1}{3}.$$

Sanity check: f runs from 0 up to 1 on this interval, but it spends most of the interval near the bottom (it only climbs steeply near $x = 1$). Its values near the right end, all the way up to 1, pull the average above the midpoint value $f(\frac{1}{2}) = \frac{1}{4}$, landing at $\frac{1}{3}$ – comfortably between the function's low values and its high value of 1, just as an average should be.

Connection

The average value is the bridge to the *Mean Value Theorem for integrals*, which you will meet next chapter: if f is continuous, it actually *attains* its average value at some point $c \in [a, b]$, i.e. $f(c) = \bar{f}$. Geometrically, the curve must cross its own leveling line somewhere. This is the integral's echo of the Mean Value Theorem you proved for derivatives, and it is one of the gears that drives the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus.

Application

Average value is everywhere once you look. The root-mean-square voltage of household AC power is built from the average value of $V(t)^2$ over a cycle – it is why a "120-volt" outlet has a peak voltage near 170. In probability, the *expected value* of a continuous random variable is $\int x\,p(x)\,dx$, an average of outcomes weighted by the density p. In thermodynamics, the average energy of a system is an integral over all its states. Whenever you must summarize a continuously varying quantity by a single representative number, the average value – an integral divided by a length – is the right way to do it.

20.8 Accumulation: the integral as a running total

We close by returning to the theme that names this chapter, because it is the viewpoint that makes the next chapter inevitable. We have treated $\int_a^b f$ as a fixed number – one area. But let the *upper limit* move. Define a new function

$$A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t,$$

the accumulated area from the fixed start a out to a variable endpoint x. (Note the dummy variable is now t, freeing x to be the endpoint.) As x slides right, $A(x)$ grows by sweeping in more area; this A is the **accumulation function**. Think of it as a running meter or odometer: given any chosen endpoint x, it reports the grand total accumulated from the starting point a up to x.

What is really happening

Think of f as a *rate* and A as the *running total* that rate builds up. If $f(t)$ is the rate at which water flows into a tank (liters per second), then $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ is the total liters that have flowed in by time x. If $f(t)$ is a country's birth rate (people per year), A is the cumulative number of births. If f is velocity, A is displacement. The integrand is always a *rate of accumulation*; the integral is always the *amount accumulated*. This single picture – rate in, total out – is the central theme of integral calculus, and it is the exact inverse of the derivative's picture (total in, rate out).

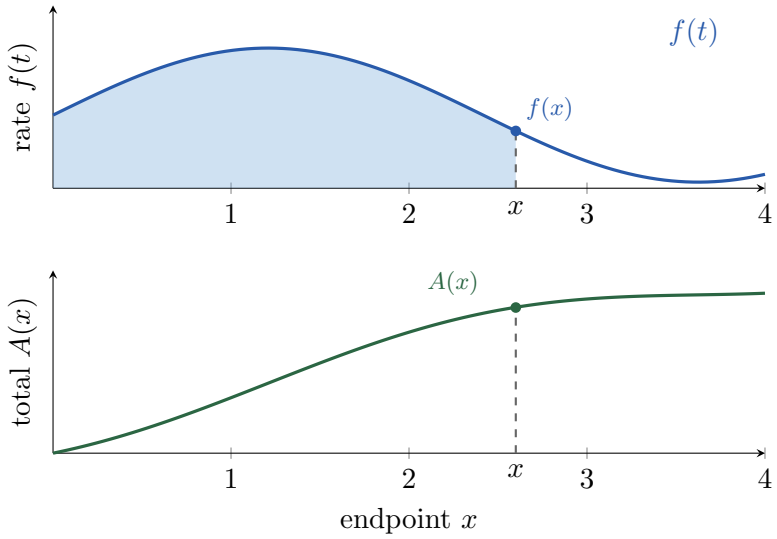


Figure 20.7: The accumulation function $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ (bottom) records the running area swept out under the rate f (top) as the endpoint x moves right. Where f is tall, A climbs steeply; where f is small, A nearly levels off. The *slope* of the lower curve at each x is precisely the *height* of the upper curve at that same x – a picture of $A'(x) = f(x)$ before we prove it.

Now ask the question that ties the whole subject together: *how fast does the running total $A(x)$ grow?* When the endpoint nudges forward by a tiny $\mathrm{d}x$, the area gains a thin sliver of width $\mathrm{d}x$ and height $f(x)$ – so A grows by about $f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, which means

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}x} \approx f(x).$$

The *rate of accumulation of the total is the integrand itself.* The derivative of the area function is the curve. You can see it in Figure 20.7: the running-total curve rises steeply where the rate is large and flattens where the rate is small, so its slope matches the height of f point for point. Differentiation and integration are inverse operations. That relationship, made exact, is the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus – the subject of the next chapter. We built the integral from sums and limits alone; and yet at the end the derivative reappears as the rate of change of accumulated area.

Walking question

Take this on your walk. You have known since childhood that distance is speed times time – when the speed is constant. The integral is the precise meaning of "speed times time" when the speed is *not* constant: chop time fine, on each sliver the speed is nearly constant so distance is nearly speed-times-sliver, add up the slivers, take the limit. Now turn it around: if you only had a record of total distance versus time, how would you recover the speed at an instant? You would differentiate. So the speedometer and the odometer are derivative and integral of one another. Carry that one example with you; the Fundamental Theorem is just this sentence, made airtight, for *every* pair of rate and total.

20.9 Looking back, and looking ahead

We built the definite integral from the ground up. We took two ancient, seemingly separate problems – the area under a curve and the total accumulated from a varying rate – and discovered they are the same problem. We solved it Archimedes' way: cut the domain into thin pieces, approximate the varying thing by a constant on each piece, sum the easy answers, and take a limit as the pieces vanish. That limit, when it exists, is the Riemann integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, and we proved by hand that $\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{3}$ using only a sum of squares.

We saw that the integral computes *signed* area, that it obeys clean linearity, additivity, orientation, and monotonicity rules – each one a fact about finite sums that survives the limit – and that dividing it by the interval length gives the average value of a function. Finally, by letting the upper limit roam, we built the accumulation function and glimpsed the equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}x} = f(x)$ that will, next chapter, unify the two halves of calculus into a single theorem.

Why this matters

The derivative tore a curve down to its instantaneous slopes. The integral rebuilds a total from its instantaneous rates. One is analysis, the other is synthesis; one takes apart, the other puts together. That they are exact inverses is not a convenience but a deep structural truth about change itself – and it is the reason a single subject, calculus, can describe both how things vary and how much accumulates. You have now met both halves separately. Turn the page and watch them fuse.

20.9.1 The Scope of Accumulation and the Bridge Ahead

Connection

The definite integral provides a unified foundation for physical accumulation:

- *Continuous accumulation*: Distance traveled under variable velocity ($s = \int v(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$), total work done by a variable force ($W = \int F(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$), and mass under non-uniform density are all unified under a single operation.
- *Signed net change*: By respecting the algebraic sign of $f(x)$, the integral captures net balances, cancellation between positive inflows and negative outflows, and physical displacements.
- *Rigorous measure of curved geometry*: Regions bounded by non-linear functions have unambiguous, mathematically well-defined areas as the limit of Riemann sums.

Yet Riemann sums are better as a *definition* than as a daily *calculation tool*. To compute $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ directly from the definition:

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{n\to\infty} \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x,$$

one needs closed-form formulas for the finite sums $\sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k^*)$. We know such formulas for low-degree polynomials ($\sum k, \sum k^2, \sum k^3$), but for almost any other function—$\sin x$, e^x, $\sqrt{1-x^2}$, $\ln x$—there are no simple summation formulas.

The practical shortcut arrives in Chapter 21 (*The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus*). Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz recognized that accumulation and differentiation undo each other:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = f(x).$$

Instead of constructing rectangles and taking infinite limits of sums, computing $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ requires only finding an *antiderivative* F with $F'(x) = f(x)$, and evaluating $F(b) - F(a)$.

20.10 Exercises

Exercise 20.1 (Mental checks: signs, symmetry, and constants)**.** Answer each of the following in your head in ten seconds, using geometry and symmetry rather than algebraic calculation:

(a) What is $\int_{-3}^{3} x^5\,\mathrm{d}x$, and why?

(b) What is $\int_2^7 4\,\mathrm{d}x$? (Picture the rectangle.)

(c) If $\int_0^5 f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = 12$ and $\int_0^3 f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = 8$, what is $\int_3^5 f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$?

(d) Without computing, explain why $\int_0^{\pi} \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x > 0$ while $\int_0^{2\pi} \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x = 0$.

Exercise 20.2 (Hand-computed Riemann sums)**.** For $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ on $[0, 4]$ with $n = 4$ equal subintervals ($\Delta x = 1$), compute the left sum L_4, the right sum R_4, and the midpoint sum M_4. The exact value of $\int_0^4 \sqrt{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ is $\frac{16}{3} \approx 5.333$. Which of your three sums is closest, and does $L_4 < \frac{16}{3} < R_4$ hold? Explain in one sentence why, using the fact that $\sqrt{x}$ is increasing.

Exercise 20.3 (An integral from the definition)**.** Following Example 20.1, compute $\int_0^2 x\,\mathrm{d}x$ directly from the definition using a regular partition and right endpoints. You will need $\sum_{k=1}^{n} k = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$. Confirm that your answer equals the area of the triangle you can see in the graph.

Exercise 20.4 (Sum of cubes)**.** Using $\sum_{k=1}^{n} k^3 = \left(\frac{n(n+1)}{2}\right)^2$, evaluate $\int_0^1 x^3\,\mathrm{d}x$ from the definition with right endpoints. Show every step of the limit.

Exercise 20.5 (Using the properties)**.** Given $\int_1^4 f = 7$, $\int_1^4 g = -2$, and $\int_4^6 f = 5$, evaluate each of the following or state that it cannot be determined: (a) $\int_1^4 (3f - 2g)$; (b) $\int_1^6 f$; (c) $\int_6^4 f$; (d) $\int_1^4 f \cdot g$.

Exercise 20.6 (Signed versus geometric area)**.** Consider $f(x) = x^2 - 1$ on $[0, 2]$. (a) Sketch the graph and shade the regions above and below the x-axis. (b) The signed area is $\int_0^2 (x^2 - 1)\,\mathrm{d}x$; using linearity, the known integral of 1, and $\int_0^2 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{8}{3}$ (and $\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{3}$), evaluate it. (c) Now find the *geometric* (total, unsigned) area by splitting at the crossing point $x = 1$ and adding absolute values. Explain why the two answers differ.

Exercise 20.7 (Average value)**.** Find the average value of $f(x) = x^3$ on $[0, 2]$ (you may use $\int_0^2 x^3\,\mathrm{d}x = 4$). Then find a point $c \in [0, 2]$ where $f(c)$ equals that average value, confirming the Mean Value Theorem for integrals in this case.

Exercise 20.8 (Accumulation reasoning)**.** Water flows into a tank at a rate $r(t) = 3 + 2t$ liters per minute, for t from 0 to 5 minutes. (a) Express the total volume that flows in as a definite integral. (b) Without yet knowing antiderivatives, estimate it with a midpoint sum using 5 subintervals of width 1. (c) The integrand is a straight line, so the exact total is the area of a trapezoid – compute it and compare to your estimate.

Exercise 20.9 (A conceptual trap)**.** A student claims: "Since $\int_0^{2\pi} \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x = 0$, the function $\sin x$ encloses no area over $[0, 2\pi]$." Explain precisely what is right and what is wrong with this statement, and write the correct integral expression for the total geometric area enclosed between $\sin x$ and the x-axis on $[0, 2\pi]$.

Exercise 20.10 (Proof: monotonicity)**.** Prove the monotonicity property: if f and g are integrable on $[a, b]$ and $f(x) \le g(x)$ for all $x \in [a, b]$, then $\int_a^b f \le \int_a^b g$. *Hint:* compare the two functions' Riemann sums on a common partition with common sample points, term by term, then pass to the limit. Note where you use $\Delta x_k > 0$.

Exercise 20.11 (Proof: a bound from monotonicity)**.** Suppose $m \le f(x) \le M$ for all $x \in [a, b]$. Prove that

$$m\,(b - a) \;\le\; \int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;\le\; M\,(b - a).$$

Hint: apply the previous exercise twice, comparing f to the constant functions m and M and using $\int_a^b c\,\mathrm{d}x = c(b - a)$. Then interpret the result as a statement about the average value $\bar{f}$.

Exercise 20.12 (Order of magnitude, no computation)**.** Without evaluating any integral, rank these three numbers from smallest to largest and justify each comparison using monotonicity or a sketch: $\int_0^1 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$, $\int_0^1 x^3\,\mathrm{d}x$, $\int_0^1 \sqrt{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$. *Hint:* on $(0, 1)$, how do x^3, x^2, and $\sqrt{x}$ compare in size?

Chapter 21

The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus

On one side of calculus sits the *derivative*: an operation for measuring instantaneous rates of change, slopes of tangent lines, and how fast a quantity changes at a single point. On the other side sits the *integral*: an operation for accumulating quantities over an interval, measuring signed area, total displacement, and swept-out volume. Slope and area, rate and total, look like completely separate questions. One concerns local behavior at an instant; the other concerns global behavior across an interval. One is a tangent line; the other is a region of the plane.

The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus proves that these two operations are inverses of each other. Differentiation and integration undo one another, in the same way that addition undoes subtraction or squaring undoes square-rooting. The slope question and the area question are two directions of a single relationship.

That connection transforms integration from a case-by-case limit calculation into a systematic method. Before the theorem, finding an area meant summing infinitely many rectangles and evaluating the limit directly. After the theorem, finding an area means: find a function whose derivative is the given integrand, then subtract two of its values. Computations that once required custom summation tricks become two-point evaluations, and this chapter explains *why* this connection holds.

21.1 What we are bridging

Let us set the two sides down precisely so we can see how far apart they start.

21.1.1 The integral, briefly recalled

Given a continuous function f on an interval $[a, b]$, the *definite integral*

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$$

is the limit of Riemann sums. Using n equal subintervals of width $\Delta x = (b-a)/n$, you build a thin rectangle on each piece whose height is a sample value $f(x_k^*)$ there, add up the rectangle areas, and

let $n \to \infty$ so the widths shrink to zero:

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;=\; \lim_{n\to\infty} \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k^*)\,\Delta x.$$

When $f \geq 0$ this is the area under the graph. When f dips below the axis it is signed area – area above the axis counts positive, area below counts negative. The key point for us: this is a *global* object. To know it you must, in principle, account for the value of f at *every* point of $[a, b]$.

21.1.2 The derivative, briefly recalled

Given a function F, its *derivative* at a point x is the local rate of change,

$$F'(x) \;=\; \lim_{h\to 0} \frac{F(x+h) - F(x)}{h},$$

the slope of the tangent line to the graph of F at x. This is a *local* object: it cares only about the behavior of F in an infinitesimally small neighborhood of the one point x.

Intuition

Here is the core question. The integral depends on values across an entire interval. The derivative depends only on behavior in the immediate neighborhood of a single point. How can an interval-wide accumulation (accumulated area) and an instantaneous rate of change (slope) determine each other?
The resolution is the central image of this chapter: **watch the area grow**. Don't compute the area once and for all. Instead, let the right-hand edge slide, and ask how fast the accumulated area is increasing at each moment. That *rate* of accumulation is a derivative – and it turns out to equal the height of the curve. Accumulating and rate-measuring are two directions of a single relationship.

21.2 The area-so-far function

Everything hinges on a single new idea: instead of treating the area as a *number*, treat it as a *function*. Fix the left endpoint a and let the right endpoint vary. Define the *area-so-far* function (the standard name is the *accumulation function*):

$$A(x) \;=\; \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

Focus

Read $A(x)$ as "the signed area under f from the starting line a out to the moving wall at x." As you push the wall x to the right, you sweep out more area, so A grows. As you pull the wall back left, A shrinks. $A(x)$ is a running total.
Notice the upper bound of integration is now x, and the variable inside the integral is written t so it does not collide with that bound. Here t is a dummy variable – it is integrated over and disappears, leaving A as a function of the upper bound x alone.

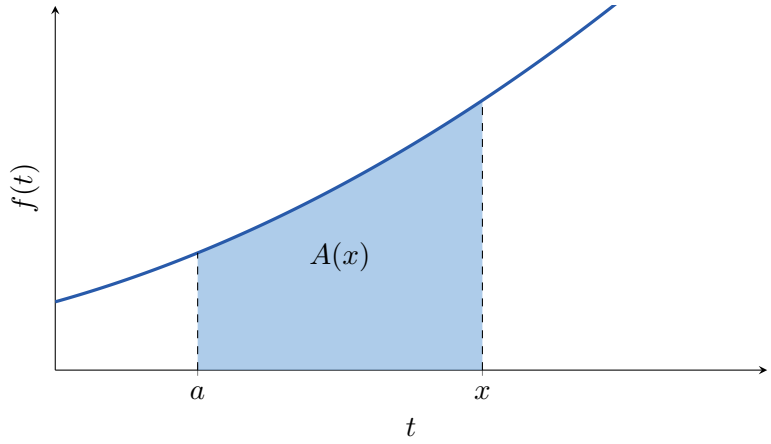


Figure 21.1: The accumulation function $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ is the shaded area from the fixed wall a to the sliding wall x. Sliding x to the right grows the area.

Work it yourself

Take the simplest non-trivial example: $f(t) = t$ on $[0, x]$. The region under f from 0 to x is a right triangle with both legs of length x, so its area is $\frac{1}{2}x^2$. Hence

$$A(x) = \int_0^x t\,\mathrm{d}t = \tfrac{1}{2}x^2.$$

Now do the central calculation of this chapter: differentiate the area.

$$A'(x) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\tfrac{1}{2}x^2\right) = x = f(x).$$

The derivative of the area-so-far is the original height. That is not an isolated property of triangles: it is the Fundamental Theorem in its simplest setting. Hold onto this result; we will explain it in full next.

Pause

Pause and think: If $f(t) > 0$ everywhere on $[a, b]$, can the accumulation function $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ ever decrease as x increases? Picture the sliding wall: whenever you advance x to the right, the newly swept strip sits above the horizontal axis, adding strictly positive area. So $A(x)$ must be strictly increasing. An increasing function has a non-negative derivative: indeed, $A'(x) = f(x) > 0$. The sign of the curve directly controls the slope of the running area.

21.3 Part 1: differentiating the area gives back the curve

21.3.1 The infinitesimal-strip picture

Before any ε appears, let us see *why* $A'(x) = f(x)$ has to be true, using a simple geometric argument.

Push the right wall from x to $x+h$, where h is a tiny positive number. The area grows by a sliver: the strip sitting between x and $x+h$. Call that extra area $A(x+h)-A(x)$. What does the sliver look like? It is a thin vertical strip of width h, sitting under the curve f.

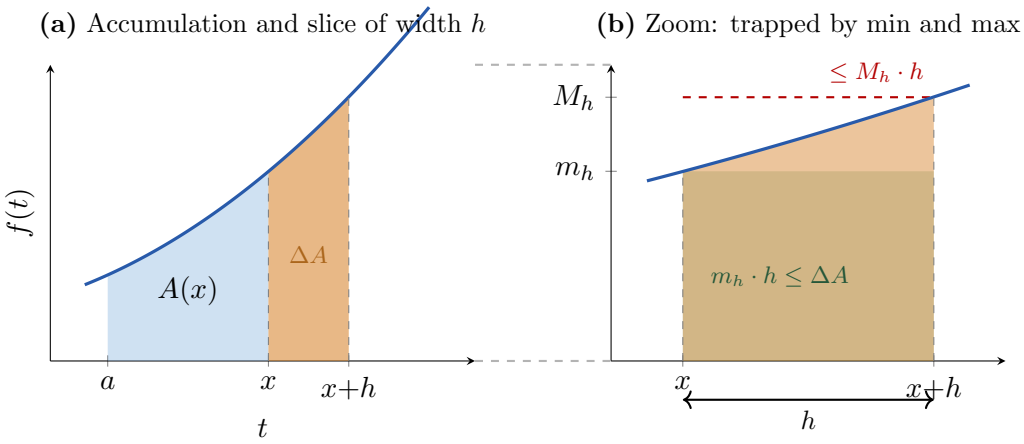


Figure 21.2: The rate of accumulation. **(a)** Growing the wall from x to $x+h$ adds the thin sliver $\Delta A = A(x+h)-A(x)$. **(b)** Zooming in on the sliver reveals it trapped between the lower rectangle of area $m_h \cdot h$ and the upper rectangle of area $M_h \cdot h$. As $h \to 0$, both bounding heights converge to $f(x)$, squeezing the average rate $\Delta A/h$ to $f(x)$.

Here is the key geometric observation: if h is small, the curve barely changes across the strip, so the strip is *almost a rectangle*: width h, height roughly $f(x)$. Its area is approximately

$$A(x+h)-A(x) \;\approx\; f(x)\cdot h.$$

Divide both sides by h:

$$\frac{A(x+h)-A(x)}{h} \;\approx\; f(x).$$

The left side is exactly the difference quotient whose limit defines $A'(x)$. As $h \to 0$ the strip gets thinner, the "almost a rectangle" becomes "a rectangle" in the limit, the approximation tightens to equality, and we land on

$$A'(x) = f(x).$$

What is really happening

What is really happening when you write $A'(x) = f(x)$? You are reading off the **instantaneous rate at which area is piling up.** The height of the curve at x *is* the speed at which the running-area total grows as the wall sweeps past x.
Think of f as a flow rate – liters per second pouring into a tank – and $A(x)$ as the total liters in the tank after time x. "How fast is the tank filling right now?" is answered by the current flow rate. That sentence is the Fundamental Theorem, Part 1, in plain language: *the rate of accumulation is the integrand itself.* A thin strip represents the contribution across a narrow increment; its height is the flow rate, its width $\mathrm{d}x$ is the increment of time, and the product $f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the incremental area added across that step.

21.3.2 Making it a real proof

The strip picture is convincing, but "≈" is a promise, not a proof. The real worry is this: across the strip the height is not exactly $f(x)$; the curve wobbles. We need to control that wobble and show it vanishes in the limit. The clean tool for that is the average-value squeeze, and it works for any continuous f.

Theorem 21.1 (Fundamental Theorem of Calculus, Part 1)**.** *Let f be continuous on $[a, b]$. Define $A : [a, b] \to \mathbb{R}$ by*

$$A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

Then A is differentiable on (a, b) (and one-sidedly at the endpoints), and

$$A'(x) = f(x) \qquad \text{for every } x \in [a, b].$$

In words: the accumulation function is an antiderivative of f.

Intuition

The idea of the proof is to trap the increment $A(x+h)-A(x)$ – the area of the strip – between the area of the shortest rectangle that fits under it and the area of the tallest rectangle that covers it. Both rectangles have width h; their heights are the minimum and maximum of f on the little interval. As $h \to 0$ that little interval collapses onto the point x, so both the minimum and the maximum of f are squeezed toward $f(x)$ (this is where continuity is essential). The strip's average height has nowhere to go but $f(x)$.

Proof. Fix x and take $h > 0$ small enough that $x + h$ stays in $[a, b]$. Using the splitting rule for integrals (area from a to $x + h$ equals area from a to x plus area from x to $x + h$),

$$A(x + h) - A(x) = \int_a^{x+h} f - \int_a^x f = \int_x^{x+h} f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

So the increment of A is exactly the area of the strip – no approximation yet, this is an identity.

Because f is continuous on the closed interval $[x, x + h]$, the Extreme Value Theorem (which guarantees that any continuous curve on a closed interval actually reaches its lowest trough and highest peak) hands us a point where f attains its minimum value m_h and a point where it attains its maximum value M_h on that interval. Every value of f on $[x, x + h]$ lies between m_h and M_h, so the strip's area is trapped between the two rectangles of width h:

$$m_h\, h \;\le\; \int_x^{x+h} f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t \;\le\; M_h\, h.$$

Divide through by $h > 0$:

$$m_h \;\le\; \frac{A(x + h) - A(x)}{h} \;\le\; M_h.$$

Now let $h \to 0^+$. The interval $[x, x + h]$ shrinks to the single point x. By continuity of f, both the minimum value m_h and the maximum value M_h converge to $f(x)$: any point achieving them

is within h of x, and $f(\text{point}) \to f(x)$. The middle term is squeezed between two quantities both heading to $f(x)$, so by the Squeeze Theorem

$$\lim_{h\to 0^+} \frac{A(x+h)-A(x)}{h} = f(x).$$

The case $h<0$ follows the exact same logic with signed directions kept straight. When $h<0$, the interval of integration is $[x+h, x]$ of positive length $-h = |h|$. The change in area is $A(x+h) - A(x) = -\int_{x+h}^{x} f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$. Bounding f between its minimum m_h and maximum M_h on $[x+h, x]$ gives $m_h(-h) \le \int_{x+h}^{x} f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t \le M_h(-h)$. Negating and dividing by the negative quantity h reverses the inequalities right back to $m_h \le \frac{A(x+h)-A(x)}{h} \le M_h$. Letting $h \to 0^-$ squeezes the left-hand limit to $f(x)$ as well. The two one-sided limits agree, so the true two-sided derivative $A'(x)$ exists and equals $f(x)$. □

Why the technique works

Why does the proof go through the *min* and *max* on the little interval rather than just using $f(x)$? Because we are not allowed to assume the strip is a perfect rectangle – that is the very thing we are trying to justify. The min and max rectangles are airtight bounds we can write down with no hand-waving: the true strip area genuinely sits between them. Continuity then guarantees the trap is tight, because over a shrinking interval the highest and lowest values of a continuous function cannot stay apart – they both must collapse to the value at the point. Continuity is exactly the hypothesis that makes "the curve barely changes across a thin strip" a theorem instead of a hope.

Remark 21.1. There is an equivalent and very clean way to package the squeeze, called the *Mean Value Theorem for Integrals*: for continuous f there is a point $c \in [x, x+h]$ with $\int_x^{x+h} f = f(c)\cdot h$. (The average height of the strip is actually achieved somewhere by f.) Then $\frac{A(x+h)-A(x)}{h} = f(c)$, and as $h \to 0$ the point c is trapped at x, so $f(c) \to f(x)$. This expresses the same squeeze argument in concise form.

Common trap

A frequent confusion: students see $\int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ and try to "plug in" or differentiate with respect to t. There is no t to differentiate with respect to – t has been integrated away. The function A depends on its *upper limit* x. The statement $A'(x) = f(x)$ means: differentiate with respect to the upper limit, and you recover the integrand evaluated there.
Also resist writing $A(x) = \int_a^x f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ with x in both places. Using the same letter for the dummy variable and the limit is a recipe for nonsense. Always rename the inside variable.

21.3.3 The chain-rule version (variable in the limits)

Part 1 plus the chain rule lets you differentiate any accumulation whose limits are themselves functions. Suppose

$$G(x) = \int_a^{u(x)} f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

Write $G(x) = A(u(x))$ where A is the accumulation function from before, so $A' = f$. The chain rule gives

$$G'(x) = A'(u(x))\cdot u'(x) = f\big(u(x)\big)\,u'(x).$$

If the variable sits in the lower limit instead, flip the sign (swapping limits negates the integral). The fully general rule, with both limits moving:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\int_{u(x)}^{v(x)} f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t\right) = f\big(v(x)\big)\,v'(x) - f\big(u(x)\big)\,u'(x).$$

Example 21.1. Differentiate $G(x) = \displaystyle\int_2^{x^3} \sin(t^2)\,\mathrm{d}t$.

Solution. Here $f(t) = \sin(t^2)$ and the upper limit is $u(x) = x^3$, so $u'(x) = 3x^2$. By the chain-rule version,

$$G'(x) = \sin\big((x^3)^2\big)\cdot 3x^2 = 3x^2\sin(x^6).$$

Notice we never found a formula for G itself – there isn't an elementary one, since $\sin(t^2)$ has no elementary antiderivative. Yet we differentiated G exactly. This is what Part 1 buys you: the derivative of an integral, with no need to evaluate the integral first.

Example 21.2. Differentiate $H(x) = \displaystyle\int_x^{x^2} \frac{1}{1+\ln t}\,\mathrm{d}t$ for $x > 1$.

Solution. Both limits move: $u(x) = x$, $v(x) = x^2$. With $f(t) = \frac{1}{1+\ln t}$,

$$H'(x) = \frac{1}{1+\ln(x^2)}\cdot 2x \;-\; \frac{1}{1+\ln x}\cdot 1 = \frac{2x}{1+2\ln x} - \frac{1}{1+\ln x}.$$

21.4 Part 1 says: every continuous function has an antiderivative

Tucked inside Theorem 21.1 is a statement of pure existence that is easy to walk past but worth pausing on.

Corollary 21.1 (Existence of antiderivatives)**.** *Every function continuous on an interval has an antiderivative on that interval – namely its own accumulation function* $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$.

Why this matters

This existence statement is stronger than it might appear. In introductory calculus, "find an antiderivative of f" often means "find a familiar formula whose derivative is f," and for many ordinary functions – e^{-x^2}, $\frac{\sin x}{x}$, $\sqrt{1+x^3}$ – *no such formula exists.* The absence of an elementary formula is not a limitation of technique; Liouville proved that these antiderivatives simply cannot be expressed in terms of elementary functions.

Part 1 establishes that the antiderivative still *exists* as a well-defined function; we define it by its accumulation integral rather than by an algebraic formula. The Gaussian integral, $\int_0^x e^{-t^2}\,\mathrm{d}t$, is essential in probability, where (up to a factor of $2/\sqrt{\pi}$) it defines the error function erf. It is a fully legitimate function with a well-defined derivative (e^{-x^2}, by Part 1).

21.5 Part 2: evaluating an integral with any antiderivative

Part 1 tells us *a* particular antiderivative – the area function A – satisfies $A' = f$. Part 2 turns this into an efficient computational method: to find the area, you may use *any* antiderivative you can find, and the answer reduces to a simple subtraction.

Theorem 21.2 (Fundamental Theorem of Calculus, Part 2)**.** *Let f be continuous on $[a, b]$ and let F be* any *antiderivative of f on $[a, b]$, meaning $F' = f$ throughout. Then*

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;=\; F(b) - F(a).$$

The standard shorthand for the right side is $\Big[F(x)\Big]_a^b = F(b) - F(a)$, read "$F$ evaluated from a to b."

Intuition

Why should the area equal $F(b) - F(a)$ for *any* antiderivative, not just the area function? Because antiderivatives of the same function can differ only by a constant (by the Mean Value Theorem, two functions with the same derivative maintain a constant vertical gap everywhere). The area function A and your chosen F differ by a fixed constant C. When you compute the difference $F(b) - F(a)$, the constant cancels: $(A(b) + C) - (A(a) + C) = A(b) - A(a)$. And $A(b) - A(a)$ is the total area from a to b. The constant $+C$ cancels completely in the subtraction.

Proof via Part 1. Let $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ be the area function. By Part 1, $A' = f$. By assumption $F' = f$ as well. Two functions with the same derivative on an interval differ by a constant (vanishing-derivative corollary of the MVT), so there is a constant C with

$$F(x) = A(x) + C \qquad \text{for all } x \in [a, b].$$

Now simply evaluate the difference:

$$F(b) - F(a) = \big(A(b) + C\big) - \big(A(a) + C\big) = A(b) - A(a).$$

But $A(a) = \int_a^a f = 0$ (an interval of zero width sweeps out no area) and $A(b) = \int_a^b f$. Therefore $F(b) - F(a) = \int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. □

There is a second proof that does not lean on Part 1 at all – it grows the total out of tiny MVT-certified increments. It is worth seeing, because it makes the telescoping cancellation that powers Part 2 completely visible.

Proof via telescoping and the Mean Value Theorem. Partition $[a, b]$ into pieces $a = x_0 < x_1 < \cdots < x_n = b$. The total change in F across $[a, b]$ telescopes – each interior value is added once and subtracted once, so all that survives is the endpoints:

$$F(b) - F(a) = \sum_{k=1}^{n} \big(F(x_k) - F(x_{k-1})\big).$$

Apply the Mean Value Theorem to F on each little interval $[x_{k-1}, x_k]$: there is a sample point c_k inside with

$$F(x_k) - F(x_{k-1}) = F'(c_k)\,(x_k - x_{k-1}) = f(c_k)\,\Delta x_k.$$

(We used $F' = f$.) Substituting,

$$F(b) - F(a) = \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(c_k)\,\Delta x_k.$$

The right side is a genuine Riemann sum for f – with the MVT choosing the sample points for us. As the partition is refined and the mesh goes to 0, the left side does not move at all (it is just $F(b)-F(a)$, a fixed number), while the right side converges to $\int_a^b f$ by definition of the integral (which exists and is partition-independent because f is continuous). Therefore $F(b) - F(a) = \int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. □

Why the technique works

The second proof exposes the true mechanism of Part 2: **a total change is a sum of little changes, and a little change in F is, by the MVT, exactly a height of f times a width.** Stacking those little $f(c_k)\,\Delta x_k$ bricks *is* building the area. Telescoping is what guarantees those bricks reassemble into the clean endpoint difference $F(b) - F(a)$ – every interior wall is shared by two bricks and cancels, leaving only the outer walls a and b (Figure 21.3). Integration is addition of infinitesimal increments; an antiderivative is a running total of them; so the net total is the final reading minus the initial reading. Subtraction of two antiderivative values is just the bookkeeping of "ending balance minus starting balance."

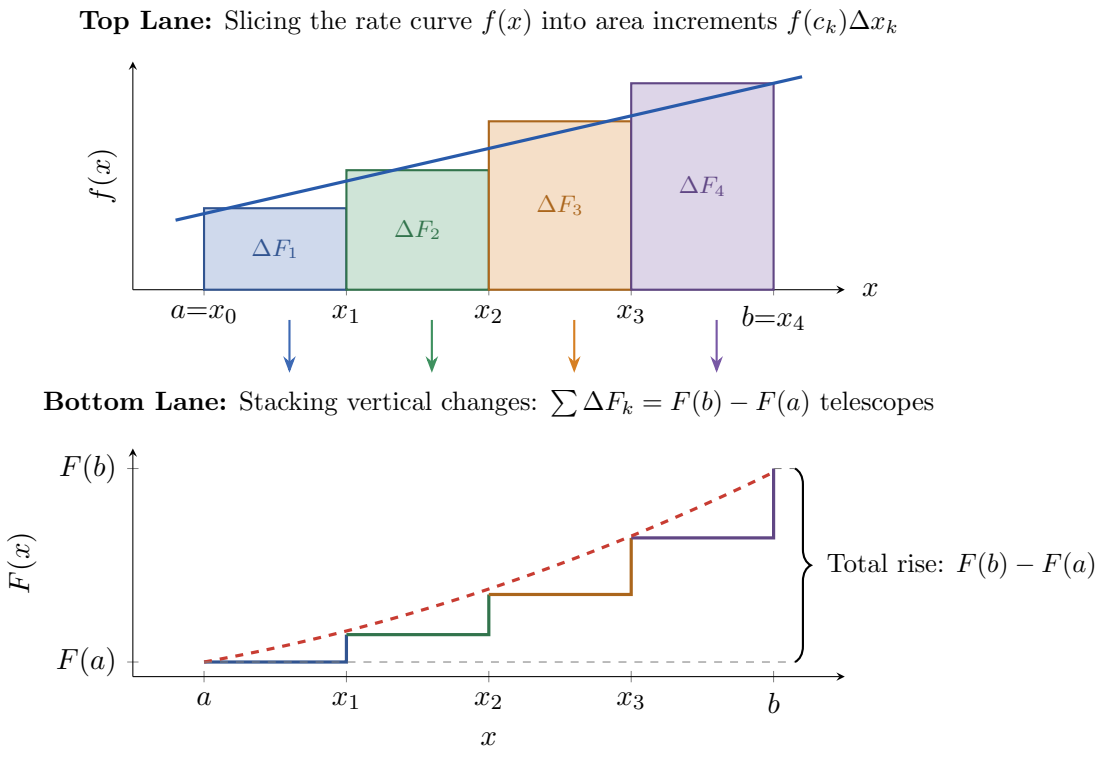


Figure 21.3: The telescoping mechanism of FTC Part 2. **Top lane:** Slices of area under the rate curve $f(x)$ have sizes $f(c_k)\Delta x_k$. **Bottom lane:** By the Mean Value Theorem, each area slice equals an exact vertical rise $\Delta F_k = F(x_k) - F(x_{k-1})$ on the antiderivative curve. Summing the slices stacks the rises, and internal heights cancel, leaving only the net rise $F(b) - F(a)$.

What is really happening

The cleanest way to feel Part 2 is the bank-account reading. Let $F(t)$ be your account balance at time t and $f(t) = F'(t)$ the instantaneous rate money flows in (deposits positive, withdrawals negative). Then $\int_a^b f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ adds up all the little flows over the period – the net amount that moved – and that must equal the change in balance, $F(b) - F(a)$. You did not need to track every transaction; you only needed the balance at the start and the balance at the end. The Fundamental Theorem is the statement that *net accumulated rate equals net change in total*, and it is so intuitive in this form that it feels like it shouldn't need a proof. The work of the chapter is showing that the intuitive banking fact and the geometric area fact are the very same theorem.

21.6 Why differentiation and integration are inverse

We can now say cleanly what "inverse operations" means here. There are two round trips, one for each order.

Focus

Integrate, then differentiate (Part 1): start with f, accumulate it into $A(x) = \int_a^x f$, then differentiate. You get f back.

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t\right) = f(x).$$

Differentiate, then integrate (Part 2): start with F, differentiate into $F' = f$, then accumulate. You recover the net change in F.

$$\int_a^b F'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F(b) - F(a).$$

Each operation undoes the other – with the single wrinkle that going $F \to F' \to \int F'$ recovers F only *up to its value at the starting point* (you get the change $F(b) - F(a)$, not F on the nose). That missing piece is the constant of integration, and it is the only thing the two operations cannot quite cancel.

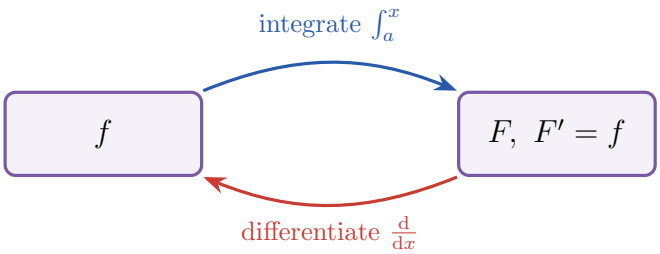


Figure 21.4: The two operations form a loop. Integrating f produces an antiderivative F; differentiating F returns f. The Fundamental Theorem says the loop closes.

Connection

This is the same pattern you meet whenever an operation has an inverse, but here it operates on whole *functions* rather than numbers. Differentiation D and integration are like a matrix and its inverse, or like a group element and its inverse: D followed by $\int$ is (almost) the identity, and $\int$ followed by D is the identity. The "almost" – the loss of the constant – is exactly why D has a one-dimensional kernel (in linear algebra, the kernel is the subspace of inputs crushed to zero): here, the constant functions, whose derivative is zero, are the information differentiation throws away and integration cannot restore. You will meet this kernel-and-inverse bookkeeping again in linear algebra and again in the theory of differential equations, where the $+C$ generalizes to the full family of solutions.

21.7 Antiderivatives and the $+C$

An *antiderivative* of f is any function F with $F' = f$. The *indefinite integral* collects them all:

$$\int f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F(x) + C,$$

where F is one antiderivative and C ranges over all real constants. The notation deliberately drops the limits to signal "a family of functions," as opposed to the definite integral $\int_a^b f$, which is "a single number."

Why the technique works

Why is the family *exactly* $F(x)+C$ – why no other antiderivatives lurking elsewhere? Suppose $G' = f$ too. Then $(G-F)' = f - f = 0$ on the interval. A function with zero derivative on an interval is constant (Mean Value Theorem again: if it ever changed, some secant slope would be nonzero, forcing a nonzero derivative somewhere). So $G - F = C$, i.e. $G = F + C$. The constant $+C$ gives the *complete* description of all antiderivatives on an interval. Geometrically: all antiderivatives are vertical shifts of one another – same shape, same slope at every x, just slid up or down. Shifting a graph vertically never changes any slope, so it never changes the derivative.

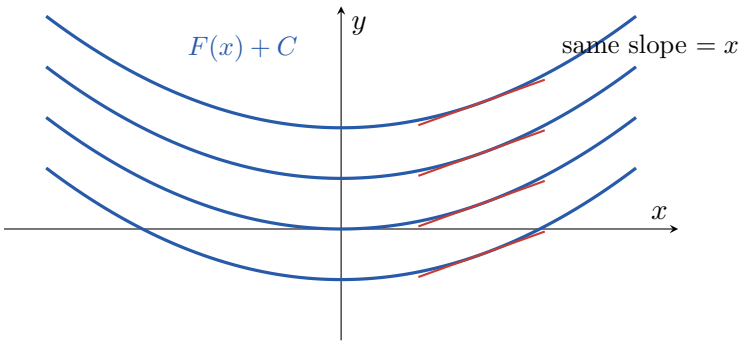


Figure 21.5: Antiderivatives of $f(x) = x$ are $\frac{1}{2}x^2 + C$, a stack of vertical shifts of one parabola. At any fixed x all of them have the identical slope x (short red tangents at $x = 1$), which is why they share the same derivative.

Common trap

Two $+C$ pitfalls.
Forgetting it on an indefinite integral. $\int 2x\,\mathrm{d}x = x^2$ is **incomplete**; the answer is $x^2 + C$. You have named one antiderivative when the question asked for all of them.
Writing it on a definite integral. $\int_0^3 2x\,\mathrm{d}x = 9$, a number – no C. If you carry the constant through, it cancels in $F(3) - F(0)$ anyway, so it is harmless but pointless. The $+C$ belongs to the indefinite world of function-families, not the definite world of numbers.

Walking question

On your walk, picture the family of all antiderivatives as a deck of identical curves stacked vertically. A definite integral asks you to read the *rise* between two x-values – and rises are unaffected by which card of the deck you read, because shifting the whole deck shifts both endpoints equally. Now ask yourself: what *one* extra piece of information would pin down a single card out of the deck? (Answer: the value of F at one point – an "initial condition," the starting point for initial-value problems in differential equations.)

21.8 Worked evaluations

Pause

Pause and think: What happens if we integrate backward, with $b < a$? Part 2 says $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F(b) - F(a)$. Notice this equals $-(F(a) - F(b)) = -\int_b^a f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. The evaluation recipe handles oriented limits automatically: running right to left flips the sign of the rise, mirroring the negative slice widths $\Delta x < 0$ in the underlying Riemann sum.

The procedure for evaluating a definite integral via Part 2 has two steps: (1) find any antiderivative F of the integrand; (2) compute $F(b) - F(a)$. The examples below apply this directly.

Example 21.3. $\displaystyle\int_1^3 (x^2 - 2x + 5)\,\mathrm{d}x.$

Antiderivative. Reverse the power rule term by term: $F(x) = \frac{1}{3}x^3 - x^2 + 5x$. (Check: $F'(x) = x^2 - 2x + 5$. Good.)

Evaluate.

$$\Big[\tfrac{1}{3}x^3 - x^2 + 5x\Big]_1^3 = \Big(9 - 9 + 15\Big) - \Big(\tfrac{1}{3} - 1 + 5\Big) = 15 - \tfrac{13}{3} = \frac{32}{3}.$$

Example 21.4. $\displaystyle\int_0^{\pi} \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x.$

An antiderivative of $\sin x$ is $-\cos x$ (since $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(-\cos x) = \sin x$). Thus

$$\Big[-\cos x\Big]_0^{\pi} = (-\cos\pi) - (-\cos 0) = \big(-(-1)\big) - \big(-(1)\big) = 1 - (-1) = 2.$$

The area under one hump of the sine curve is exactly 2 – a clean number that no amount of staring at Riemann rectangles would have suggested.

Example 21.5. $\displaystyle\int_1^e \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x.$

The antiderivative of $1/x$ (for $x > 0$) is $\ln x$. So

$$\Big[\ln x\Big]_1^e = \ln e - \ln 1 = 1 - 0 = 1.$$

The area under the hyperbola $1/x$ from 1 to e is 1 – an equivalent geometric characterization of e as the unique upper bound where the area under $1/x$ starting at 1 reaches one unit.

Example 21.6. $\displaystyle\int_0^{\ln 2} e^x\,\mathrm{d}x.$

Since e^x is its own antiderivative,

$$\Big[e^x\Big]_0^{\ln 2} = e^{\ln 2} - e^0 = 2 - 1 = 1.$$

Example 21.7. $\displaystyle\int_0^4 \sqrt{x}\,\mathrm{d}x.$

Write $\sqrt{x} = x^{1/2}$. Reverse the power rule: raise the exponent by one to $\frac{3}{2}$ and divide, giving $F(x) = \frac{2}{3}x^{3/2}$. Then

$$\Big[\tfrac{2}{3}x^{3/2}\Big]_0^4 = \tfrac{2}{3}\cdot 4^{3/2} - 0 = \tfrac{2}{3}\cdot 8 = \frac{16}{3}.$$

Example 21.8 (Signed area, and why you sometimes split)**.** $\displaystyle\int_0^{2\pi} \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x$ versus the *geometric* area between $\cos x$ and the axis over the same interval.

The definite integral, using antiderivative $\sin x$:

$$\Big[\sin x\Big]_0^{2\pi} = \sin(2\pi) - \sin(0) = 0.$$

Zero – the positive area of the first hump exactly cancels the negative area of the trough (Figure 21.6). If instead you want the *total geometric area* (everything counted positive), you must split at the sign changes:

$$\int_0^{\pi/2} \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x - \int_{\pi/2}^{3\pi/2} \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x + \int_{3\pi/2}^{2\pi} \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x = 1 + 2 + 1 = 4.$$

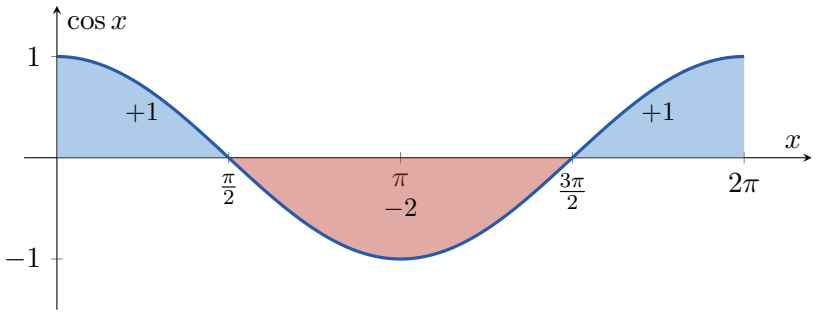


Figure 21.6: Signed area of $\cos x$ over $[0, 2\pi]$. The blue lobes above the axis contribute $+1$ each and the red lobe below contributes -2, so the definite integral is $1 - 2 + 1 = 0$. The total *geometric* area counts every lobe positively: $1 + 2 + 1 = 4$.

Common trap

The single most common Part-2 disaster is integrating across a point where the antiderivative *blows up*. Consider $\int_{-1}^{1} \frac{1}{x^2}\,dx$. Blindly using $F(x) = -\frac{1}{x}$ gives $-1-(1) = -2$, a *negative* answer for the area under a strictly positive function – which contradicts the basic geometric fact that the area under an everywhere-positive curve cannot be negative. The catch: $1/x^2$ is not continuous on $[-1, 1]$; it explodes at 0. Part 2 requires f continuous on the whole interval (and F differentiable throughout). The integral here is actually improper and diverges. **Always confirm the integrand is continuous on $[a, b]$ before applying Part 2.**

Example 21.9 (Using Part 1 and Part 2 together)**.** Find the local maxima and minima of $A(x) = \int_0^x (t^2 - 4)\,dt$ without first computing A.

Solution. By Part 1, $A'(x) = x^2 - 4$. Critical points where $A' = 0$ are $x = \pm 2$. Since $A'(x) = x^2 - 4$ is negative on $(-2, 2)$ and positive outside, A decreases then increases: $x = 2$ is a local minimum and $x = -2$ a local maximum. (If you do want a value, Part 2 gives $A(2) = \left[\frac{1}{3}t^3 - 4t\right]_0^2 = \frac{8}{3} - 8 = -\frac{16}{3}$.) The lesson: Part 1 turns questions about the *shape* of an accumulation function into ordinary derivative questions about the integrand.

21.9 A short history of the bridge

History

Pieces of both halves were known long before anyone saw they fit together. Archimedes (3rd century BCE, Syracuse) computed areas and volumes by his "method of exhaustion" (sandwiching a curved region between inscribed and circumscribed polygons) – essentially Riemann sums evaluated with remarkable geometric skill, one shape at a time, with no general machinery. In the early 1600s, Pierre de Fermat, Bonaventura Cavalieri (using "indivisibles," treating a two-dimensional area as an infinite stack of one-dimensional lines), and John Wallis found area formulas for x^n. On the other side, tangent-line methods (the seeds of differentiation) were developed by Fermat, René Descartes, and especially Isaac Barrow, Newton's teacher and predecessor as Lucasian Professor of Mathematics at Cambridge.

Barrow, in his 1670 *Lectiones Geometricae* (specifically Lecture X, Proposition 11), came strikingly close to the general theorem. Using pure Euclidean geometry without algebraic formulas, Barrow proved that if a curve is constructed by accumulating the ordinates (the vertical heights y of points on a base curve), its tangent at any point is determined directly by the height of the original curve. In modern terms, Barrow proved that differentiation inverts accumulation. Yet Barrow did not develop this into a general computational framework. Working entirely with static geometric diagrams without algebraic equations or functional notation, he treated the proposition as merely one clever geometric theorem among dozens, rather than a universal computational engine.

It took the algebraic and operational leap of *Isaac Newton* (around 1666) and *Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz* (in 1675) to recognize the Fundamental Theorem as the unifying bridge of mathematics. Newton, motivated by physics and celestial orbits, framed the calculus around "fluxions" (his term for the instantaneous rates of change of flowing quantities) and "fluents" (the

flowing quantities themselves, such as accumulated position). Position is the accumulated fluent of velocity. Leibniz, analyzing differential triangles and seeking a universal symbolic language, engineered the supple $\mathrm{d}x$ and elongated-S $\int$ (for Latin *summa*, sum) notation precisely so that d and $\int$ would visibly undo each other on the page: $\int \mathrm{d}F = F$ and $\mathrm{d}(\int f) = f\,\mathrm{d}x$. Together, they transformed scattered geometric triumphs into an algorithmic technology.

Two intense controversies followed. First was the bitter Newton–Leibniz priority dispute: accusations of plagiarism, dueling royal academies, and decades of bad blood that divided British and Continental mathematics for a century, though modern historians confirm they discovered the bridge independently. Second was the foundational crisis: both men computed with "infinitesimals" (quantities treated as smaller than any positive real number yet strictly nonzero when dividing to find slopes, only to be discarded as zero at the end). In 1734, the philosopher Bishop George Berkeley published *The Analyst*, criticizing this shift between $\mathrm{d}x \neq 0$ and $\mathrm{d}x = 0$ as logically inconsistent. The objection was fair: neither Newton nor Leibniz had a rigorous definition of an infinitesimal. It took Augustin-Louis Cauchy (1820s) with limits, Bernhard Riemann (1850s) with partitioned sums, and Karl Weierstrass (1870s) with ε–δ definitions to put the theorem on a rigorous foundation.

The theorem became the foundation for celestial mechanics, differential equations, fluid dynamics, and physics. In geometry, it generalized into Stokes' theorem on differential forms ($\int_{\partial\Omega} \omega = \int_{\Omega} \mathrm{d}\omega$), which unifies the Fundamental Theorem, Green's theorem, the divergence theorem, and classical Stokes' theorem into a single line.

21.10 The two parts, side by side

Focus

A final consolidation. Memorize the *shapes*, not just the symbols.

Part 1 (the area-so-far has slope f):

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = f(x).$$

Differentiating an accumulation returns the integrand. This is the existence half: it builds an antiderivative out of f, and it tells you the rate at which area accumulates.

Part 2 (evaluate by an antiderivative):

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F(b) - F(a), \qquad F' = f.$$

A definite integral is a net change in any antiderivative. This is the computational half: it converts the impossible-looking infinite sum into a two-value subtraction.

They are two readings of one fact – that accumulating and rate-measuring are inverse processes – and together they are the hinge on which all of integral calculus turns. Every technique in the chapters ahead (substitution, parts, partial fractions) is, at bottom, a trick for the *first* step of Part 2: **finding an antiderivative**. Once you have F, the theorem does the rest.

Application

Physics: position from velocity. If $v(t)$ is velocity, then total displacement over $[t_0, t_1]$ is $\int_{t_0}^{t_1} v(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = s(t_1) - s(t_0)$, because position s is an antiderivative of v. The Fundamental Theorem is the statement that "displacement is the accumulation of velocity" – the area under the speedometer trace is the distance traveled. Likewise impulse is the integral of force, and work is the integral of force over distance. The theorem is why a single antiderivative replaces an infinite tally of moment-by-moment contributions.

Probability and ML. A probability density $p(x)$ has a cumulative distribution $F(x) = \int_{-\infty}^{x} p(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$; by Part 1, $F' = p$ – the density is the rate at which probability accumulates. In machine learning, the same identity underlies how a model's loss accumulates from per-example contributions, and why "integrate the rate of change back" recovers a net change.

21.11 Reach of the Fundamental Theorem and the Liouville Barrier

Connection

Before the Fundamental Theorem, computing the area beneath a curve or the volume of a solid required individual summation formulas for each specific curve, partitioning the domain and evaluating limits of algebraic sums directly. The Fundamental Theorem unified these separate calculations into a clear principle: *to integrate, antidifferentiate.* Definite integrals across physics (work, impulse, center of mass), geometry (arc length, surface area), and probability (cumulative distributions) could now be evaluated directly from antiderivatives at boundary points, $F(b) - F(a)$.

Yet differentiation and antidifferentiation possess an asymmetric relationship: while differentiation is an algorithmic mechanical process that always succeeds on elementary formulas, antidifferentiation encounters *Liouville's barrier.* FTC Part 2 requires finding an *elementary antiderivative* F such that $F' = f$. In 1835, Joseph Liouville proved that simple, smooth, elementary functions exist whose antiderivatives *cannot be expressed in terms of any finite combination of elementary functions* (powers, exponentials, logarithms, trigonometric functions, and roots). Canonical examples include:

$$\int e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x \quad \text{(the Gaussian bell curve)}, \qquad \int \frac{\sin x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x \quad \text{(the sine integral)},$$

$$\int \frac{e^x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x \quad \text{(the exponential integral)}, \qquad \int \sqrt{1 - k^2 \sin^2 x}\,\mathrm{d}x \quad \text{(the elliptic integral)}.$$

For all of these functions, FTC Part 1 guarantees that the area accumulation function $A(x) = \int_0^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ exists, is smooth, and satisfies $A'(x) = f(x)$. But FTC Part 2 is powerless to evaluate $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ in closed elementary form, because no algebraic recipe for $A(x)$ can ever be written down.

This tension sets the roadmap for the entire remainder of our study of integration:

- *Expanding the symbolic toolkit (Chapters 22–24):* When an elementary antiderivative exists, how do we systematically find it? Chapter 22 develops *Integration by Substitution* (running the chain rule in reverse to untangle composite coordinates). Chapter 23 introduces *Integration by Parts* (inverting the product rule to disentangle products of

dissimilar families). Chapter 24 builds *Partial Fractions and Trigonometric Integrals* to completely solve all rational functions (ratios of polynomials).

- *When formulas fail: Numerical Quadrature (Chapter 27).* When an integrand hits Liouville's barrier – or when we integrate discrete sensor measurements where no formula exists – we return to Riemann's geometric sums via numerical methods. The Trapezoidal Rule and Simpson's parabolic quadrature approximate areas to high precision without needing an algebraic antiderivative.

21.12 Exercises

Exercise 21.1 (Mental checks)**.** Answer each question in your head or in a single sentence before calculating:

(a) If $f(t) \le 0$ everywhere on $[a, b]$, is the accumulation function $A(x) = \int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ increasing or decreasing?

(b) What is $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\int_3^x \frac{\sin(\sqrt{1+t^5})}{2+\cos(t)}\,\mathrm{d}t$ without doing any integration?

(c) Why does $\int_{-1}^{1} \frac{1}{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ fail to equal $[-\frac{1}{x}]_{-1}^{1} = -1 - (1) = -2$?

(d) If two students pick different antiderivatives of the same integrand, say $F_1(x) = x^2 + 3$ and $F_2(x) = x^2 - 17$, why do both obtain the exact same numerical answer for $\int_1^4 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$?

Exercise 21.2. Evaluate each definite integral with Part 2.

(a) $\displaystyle\int_0^2 (3x^2 - 4x + 1)\,\mathrm{d}x$

(b) $\displaystyle\int_1^4 \frac{1}{\sqrt{x}}\,\mathrm{d}x$

(c) $\displaystyle\int_0^{\pi/4} \sec^2 x\,\mathrm{d}x$

(d) $\displaystyle\int_{-1}^{1} e^{2x}\,\mathrm{d}x$

Exercise 21.3. Differentiate each accumulation function using Part 1 (and the chain rule where needed).

(a) $A(x) = \displaystyle\int_3^x \sqrt{1+t^4}\,\mathrm{d}t$

(b) $B(x) = \displaystyle\int_0^{x^2} \cos(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$

(c) $C(x) = \displaystyle\int_x^5 \frac{\mathrm{d}t}{1+t^2}$ (mind the sign)

(d) $D(x) = \displaystyle\int_{\sin x}^{\cos x} e^{t^2}\,\mathrm{d}t$

Exercise 21.4. Find the total *geometric* area enclosed between the curve $y = x^2 - 1$ and the x-axis on $[0, 2]$. (Hint: the curve crosses the axis inside the interval, so split and count each piece positively. Compare with the plain definite integral $\int_0^2 (x^2 - 1)\,\mathrm{d}x$ and explain the difference.)

Exercise 21.5. Let $G(x) = \int_0^x (t^2 - 3t + 2)\,\mathrm{d}t$. Using Part 1 only (do not first compute G), find all critical points of G and classify each as a local max or min. Then, using Part 2, find the value of G at each critical point.

Exercise 21.6 (Conceptual)**.** A student writes $\displaystyle\int_{-2}^{2} \frac{1}{x^4}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[-\tfrac{1}{3x^3}\Big]_{-2}^{2} = -\tfrac{1}{24} - \tfrac{1}{24} = -\tfrac{1}{12}$. Two things are wrong with this answer at once. Identify both: why is the numerical sign absurd, and which hypothesis of Part 2 fails? What is the correct status of this integral?

Exercise 21.7 (Conceptual)**.** Explain, in your own words and without symbols where possible, why the constant C in $\int f\,\mathrm{d}x = F + C$ cannot be detected by any definite integral $\int_a^b f$. Connect your explanation to the picture of antiderivatives as vertical shifts of one another.

Exercise 21.8. The error function is $\operatorname{erf}(x) = \frac{2}{\sqrt{\pi}} \int_0^x e^{-t^2}\,\mathrm{d}t$. Although erf has no elementary formula, compute $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\operatorname{erf}(x)$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\operatorname{erf}(x^2)$ exactly. Explain why Part 1 lets you do this even though you cannot write down erf in closed form.

Exercise 21.9 (Mean Value Theorem for Integrals)**.** Suppose f is continuous on $[a, b]$. Prove there exists $c \in [a, b]$ with $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = f(c)\,(b - a)$. (Hint: apply Part 1 to get the area function A, then apply the ordinary Mean Value Theorem to A on $[a, b]$. Interpret the result geometrically: a continuous function actually attains its average value somewhere.)

Exercise 21.10 (Proof)**.** Prove that if f is continuous on $[a, b]$ and $\int_a^x f(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = 0$ for *every* $x \in [a, b]$, then f is identically zero on $[a, b]$. (Hint: differentiate the hypothesis using Part 1.) What does this say about the only continuous function whose every accumulation vanishes?

Exercise 21.11 (Synthesis)**.** A particle moves with velocity $v(t) = t^2 - 4t + 3$ (meters per second) for $t \in [0, 4]$.

(a) Compute the net displacement $\int_0^4 v(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$.

(b) Compute the total distance traveled (integrate $|v|$, splitting at the times when $v = 0$).

(c) Explain in one sentence why the two answers differ, in terms of the particle reversing direction. Which computation used signed area, and which used geometric area?

Chapter 22

Integration by Substitution

In the previous chapter, the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus turned area into antidifferentiation: to compute $\int_a^b h(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, we do not need to sum rectangles. We find an antiderivative – a function F whose derivative is h – and evaluate $F(b) - F(a)$.

The catch is finding that F.

We can readily differentiate any standard elementary function: combinations of powers, exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric functions assembled through sums, products, quotients, and compositions. The chain rule, in particular, makes compositions routine: the derivative of $f(g(x))$ is $f'(g(x))\,g'(x)$, where the factor $g'(x)$ accounts for the rate of change of the inner function.

Integration is fundamentally harder, and there is a real reason for it. Differentiation is a *procedure*: follow the rules and the answer falls out mechanically. Integration is a *search*. To integrate an *integrand* $h(x)$ – the function sitting inside the integral waiting to be integrated – is to find some F whose derivative is h, and there is no mechanical rule that always produces it. So we develop a toolkit of techniques, each one a method for *recognizing* an integrand as the derivative of a known function.

This chapter is about the first and most important tool in that box: **substitution**, also called u-substitution. Here is the core idea of the chapter in one sentence:

Focus

Substitution is the chain rule read backwards. The chain rule tells you how the derivative of a composition picks up an extra factor from the inside; substitution teaches your eye to spot that extra factor in an integrand and to undo the composition.

We start from a concrete pattern, prove why substitution works (a one-line consequence of the chain rule and the Fundamental Theorem), and look at what $\mathrm{d}x$ and the limits of integration are doing geometrically when we change variables. Then a graded sequence of examples builds reliable pattern recognition.

22.1 The pattern that starts it all

Suppose we want to integrate

$$\int 2x\cos\big(x^2\big)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Look at the structure of the integrand: it contains a composition $\cos(x^2)$ with inner function x^2. And sitting right next to it is $2x$ – which is the exact derivative of that inside. That matching factor is our signal.

Because you know the chain rule, you can run a quick experiment. What is the derivative of $\sin(x^2)$? The outside function is sin, the inside is x^2, so

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(\sin(x^2)\big) = \cos(x^2)\cdot \underbrace{2x}_{\text{from the inside}} = 2x\cos(x^2).$$

That is exactly our integrand. So

$$\int 2x\cos\big(x^2\big)\,\mathrm{d}x = \sin(x^2) + C,$$

and you can check it by differentiating the answer. The whole trick worked because the integrand had the shape

$$\big(\text{outside}'\text{ of the inside}\big)\times\big(\text{derivative of the inside}\big),$$

which is precisely the shape the chain rule manufactures. Substitution is the discipline of *seeing* this shape even when algebra has partly hidden it, and of having a reliable bookkeeping system to exploit it.

Intuition

Think of the chain rule as a machine that, when it differentiates $F(g(x))$, spits out two pieces multiplied together: the "outer derivative" $F'(g(x))$ and the "inner derivative" $g'(x)$. If you are ever handed an integrand that looks like those two pieces multiplied together, you are looking at the output of that machine – and you can run the machine in reverse to recover $F(g(x))$.

Why the technique works

The mechanism, stated cleanly. The chain rule says

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(F(g(x))\big) = F'(g(x))\,g'(x).$$

Read that equation from right to left. It says: the antiderivative of $F'(g(x))\,g'(x)$ is $F(g(x))$. In integral notation,

$$\int F'(g(x))\,g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F(g(x)) + C.$$

Substitution is a method for *recognizing* an integrand as having the form $F'(g(x))\,g'(x)$ and then writing down $F(g(x))$. Every u-sub you will ever do is an instance of this single equation. The only skill is learning to see the pattern and to manage the bookkeeping when it is partly hidden.

22.1.1 Naming the inside

The mental move that turns this from a lucky guess into a method is to give the inside function a name. Call the inside u. In our example $u = x^2$. Then its derivative is $\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x} = 2x$, which physicists and Leibniz alike happily rearrange into the suggestive form

$$\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Look what that does to the integral. Wherever we see x^2 we write u; wherever we see $2x\,\mathrm{d}x$ we write $\mathrm{d}u$:

$$\int \cos(\underbrace{x^2}_{u})\,\underbrace{2x\,\mathrm{d}x}_{\mathrm{d}u} = \int \cos u\,\mathrm{d}u = \sin u + C = \sin(x^2) + C.$$

The hard integral in x became a trivial integral in u. *That* is the payoff: a good substitution replaces a tangled integrand with a simple one, does the easy integral, and then translates back. We will spend the rest of the chapter making this precise and learning to do it when the pattern is buried.

Pause

Pause and think. Look at $\int 3x^2 e^{x^3}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Before writing anything down, spot the inside function and its derivative. What is u? What is $\mathrm{d}u$? Can you see the antiderivative in your head in five seconds?
Answer: Let $u = x^3$, so $\mathrm{d}u = 3x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$. The integrand is simply $e^u\,\mathrm{d}u$, which integrates immediately to $e^u + C = e^{x^3} + C$.

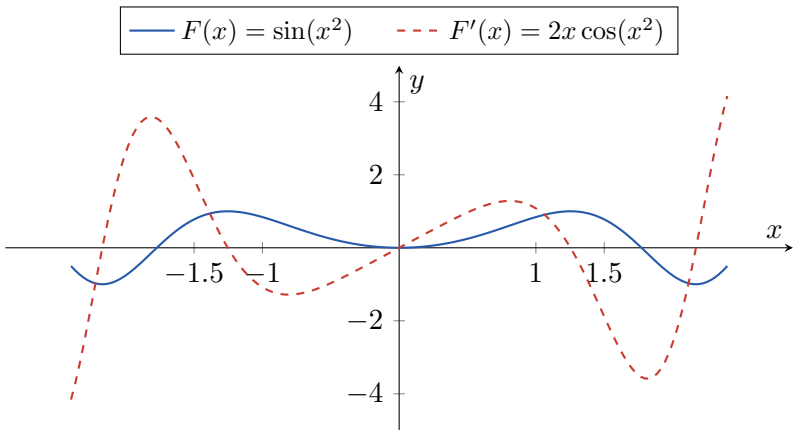


Figure 22.1: The antiderivative $F(x) = \sin(x^2)$ (solid) and its derivative $F'(x) = 2x\cos(x^2)$ (dashed). The dashed curve is the integrand we were handed; the solid curve is what substitution recovers. Notice the dashed curve reaches its peaks and troughs exactly where the solid curve is rising or falling fastest – that is the chain rule made visible.

22.2 The theorem, with proof

Intuition is wonderful, but we promised rigor. Here is substitution stated as a theorem and proved, both for indefinite and definite integrals. The proof is short because all the real work was done when we proved the chain rule and the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus; substitution just bolts them together.

Theorem 22.1 (Substitution, indefinite form)**.** *Let g be differentiable on an interval and let F be an antiderivative of a continuous function f on the range of g, so that $F' = f$. Then*

$$\int f\big(g(x)\big)\, g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = F\big(g(x)\big) + C.$$

Proof. We do not need to integrate anything. We only need to check that the proposed answer, $F(g(x))$, has the right derivative – because an antiderivative is, by definition, any function whose derivative is the integrand. Apply the chain rule to $F(g(x))$:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\big(F\big(g(x)\big)\big) = F'\big(g(x)\big)\, g'(x) = f\big(g(x)\big)\, g'(x).$$

The first equality is the chain rule; the second uses $F' = f$. So $F(g(x))$ is indeed an antiderivative of $f(g(x))\, g'(x)$, and every antiderivative differs from it by a constant. That is exactly the claim. □

This summarizes the procedure. The Leibniz notation $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is a mnemonic device for this theorem – a way of doing the substitution on paper so that the pattern is impossible to miss. But the theorem stands on its own without any talk of "infinitesimals."

Theorem 22.2 (Substitution, definite form)**.** *With the same hypotheses, and assuming g' is continuous on $[a, b]$,*

$$\int_a^b f\big(g(x)\big)\, g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_{g(a)}^{g(b)} f(u)\,\mathrm{d}u.$$

Proof. The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus evaluates the left-hand side using the antiderivative we just found:

$$\int_a^b f\big(g(x)\big)\, g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[F\big(g(x)\big)\Big]_{x=a}^{x=b} = F\big(g(b)\big) - F\big(g(a)\big).$$

Now look at the right-hand side. Since $F' = f$, the Fundamental Theorem also gives

$$\int_{g(a)}^{g(b)} f(u)\,\mathrm{d}u = \Big[F(u)\Big]_{u=g(a)}^{u=g(b)} = F\big(g(b)\big) - F\big(g(a)\big).$$

Both sides equal the same difference $F(g(b)) - F(g(a))$, so they are equal. □

Focus

The definite-form theorem contains an essential instruction hiding in the limits of integration: when you change the variable from x to $u = g(x)$, you must also change the limits. The new lower limit is $u = g(a)$ and the new upper limit is $u = g(b)$. The endpoints travel with the substitution. Forgetting this is the most common mistake in the whole chapter, and we will hammer it later.

History

Newton and Leibniz developed early calculus to solve *quadrature*—finding areas bounded by curves. Newton worked with *fluxions*, viewing changing variables as shifts in time or scale. Leibniz introduced the notation still in use: the elongated sum $\int$ and the differential element $\mathrm{d}x$.

Leibniz's notation makes $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ perform a coordinate change directly, scaling differential widths like ordinary fractions. Euler developed this systematic bookkeeping in his 1768 treatise *Institutiones Calculi Integralis*, interpreting substitution geometrically: $g'(x)$ acts as a local stretch factor scaling the x-axis onto the u-axis so that area is preserved.
For over a century, the foundations remained informal. Early mathematicians manipulated $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}u$ as infinitesimals. In 1734, Bishop George Berkeley objected in *The Analyst* to dividing by small increments as nonzero quantities and then setting those same increments to zero to finish the calculation. Treating $\mathrm{d}u/\mathrm{d}x$ as a fraction gave correct results, but lacked a rigorous foundation until Cauchy (1823) and Weierstrass formalized calculus using limits, confirming that substitution is the Chain Rule integrated over an interval.

22.3 What $\mathrm{d}x$ is really doing

You have been told to "cancel the $\mathrm{d}x$," and it works, and that should bother you a little. What is actually going on when we write $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$ and then treat the d's like algebra?

What is really happening

The $\mathrm{d}x$ inside an integral is not a number being multiplied – it is a *bookkeeping tag* that records which variable you are integrating against, and, more deeply, it records how a tiny step in your variable gets stretched into a tiny step in area.
When you substitute $u = g(x)$, a small change Δx in x produces a small change $\Delta u \approx g'(x)\,\Delta x$ in u. The factor $g'(x)$ is the local *stretch factor*: it says how much the u-axis is being compressed or expanded relative to the x-axis near that point. The integral $\int f(g(x))\,g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is adding up little rectangles of height $f(g(x))$ and width $\mathrm{d}x$. To rewrite this as an integral in u, each width $\mathrm{d}x$ must be re-measured in u-units, and the conversion factor is exactly $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. So the "cancellation" is not a trick: $g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ genuinely *is* the width of the corresponding sliver measured along the u-axis. The equation $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is a statement about how widths transform, and Theorem 22.2 is the rigorous version of that statement.

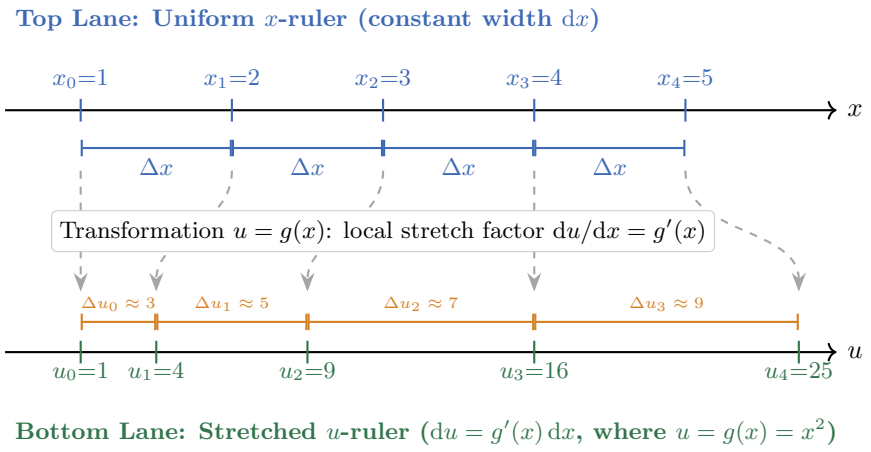


Figure 22.2: Substitution as ruler distortion (the 1D Jacobian). **Top lane:** Slices of equal width Δx along the x-axis. **Bottom lane:** Under the mapping $u = g(x)$ (here $u = x^2$), equal steps in x are non-uniformly stretched along the u-axis into increments $\Delta u \approx g'(x)\Delta x$. Slices stretch out where $g'(x)$ is large and compress where $g'(x)$ is small. The factor $g'(x)$ converts between rulers so total area is preserved.

This is why a substitution can fail or mislead if g' vanishes or changes sign on the interval: in those places the stretch factor degenerates or flips orientation, and the naive picture of "re-measuring widths" needs care. We will see a clean example of the sign issue later. For now, hold onto the geometric meaning: $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the change-of-width law, and substitution is integration performed in a rescaled coordinate.

Connection

This change-of-width factor is your first encounter with something that will return in force later in the book. When you integrate in two or three variables and change coordinates – say to polar coordinates – a similar stretch factor appears, but now it measures how *areas* (not lengths) get rescaled, and it is called the *Jacobian*. The single $g'(x)$ here is the one-dimensional Jacobian. Mastering this one-dimensional stretch factor provides the geometric foundation for the multivariable change-of-variables formula.

22.4 How to choose u

The theorem is easy; the art is picking u. What follows is a practical hierarchy of things to try. None is a guarantee – integration is a search – but in that order they resolve the large majority of substitution problems.

1. **Let u be the inside of a composition.** If the integrand contains something like $\sin(\text{stuff})$, e^{stuff}, $(\text{stuff})^n$, or $\sqrt{\text{stuff}}$, try $u = \text{stuff}$. Then check whether $\mathrm{d}u = (\text{stuff})'\,\mathrm{d}x$ accounts for the rest of the integrand.
2. **Let u be the thing whose derivative is also present.** Scan for a chunk of the integrand that is (up to a constant) the derivative of some other chunk. Name the other chunk u. This is the same rule as above, phrased so your eye hunts for the $g'(x)$ factor.

3. **Let u be an inconvenient denominator or exponent.** A denominator x^2+1 or an exponent in e^{3x} is often the cleanest choice, especially when its derivative is lurking in the numerator.

4. **If a constant is missing, supply it.** You rarely get $\mathrm{d}u$ exactly; usually you get a constant multiple of it. Constants are free to move across the integral sign, so you patch the discrepancy with a constant factor. (Only constants – never a variable.)

Common trap

You may multiply and divide by *constants* to make $\mathrm{d}u$ appear, because $\int c\,h\,\mathrm{d}x = c\int h\,\mathrm{d}x$. You may *not* pull a variable across the integral sign to manufacture $\mathrm{d}u$. Writing $\int x^2 e^x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{?}\int \ldots$ by "factoring out an x" is illegal: $\int x\,h(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \neq x\int h(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. If the leftover factor is not a constant, your chosen u is wrong, or the integral needs a different technique (such as integration by parts, coming in the next chapter).

Walking question

Before you compute anything, train the eye. Take a walk and, for each of these, just decide *what you would call* u and whether its derivative is present: $\int x\,e^{x^2}\mathrm{d}x$; $\int \frac{\ln x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$; $\int \tan x\,\mathrm{d}x$; $\int \frac{x}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}\,\mathrm{d}x$; $\int \cos^3 x\,\mathrm{d}x$. Three of them are clean one-step subs, one needs a clever rewrite of $\tan x$, and one needs a trig identity before the sub appears. Sorting them in your head is the real skill.

22.5 Worked examples, from plain to subtle

The examples below are ordered by how much algebraic preparation is needed before the core pattern $F'(g(x))\,g'(x)$ becomes visible.

22.5.1 The clean cases

Example 22.1 (Inside spotted directly)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int 3x^2\,(x^3+1)^5\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The composition is $(x^3+1)^5$; its inside is x^3+1. Let $u = x^3+1$, so $\mathrm{d}u = 3x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$. The integrand contains exactly $3x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$, which is $\mathrm{d}u$. Substituting,

$$\int (x^3+1)^5\,\underbrace{3x^2\,\mathrm{d}x}_{\mathrm{d}u} = \int u^5\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{u^6}{6} + C = \frac{(x^3+1)^6}{6} + C.$$

Differentiate the answer to check: $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\frac{(x^3+1)^6}{6}\right) = (x^3+1)^5\cdot 3x^2$. It matches.

Example 22.2 (Patching a missing constant)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int x\,e^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Let $u = x^2$, so $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$. But the integrand has only $x\,\mathrm{d}x$, not $2x\,\mathrm{d}x$. No problem: $x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{d}u$. Equivalently, pull the missing $\frac{1}{2}$ outside:

$$\int x\,e^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int e^u\cdot\tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{d}u = \tfrac{1}{2}\int e^u\,\mathrm{d}u = \tfrac{1}{2}e^u + C = \tfrac{1}{2}e^{x^2} + C.$$

The half is not a fudge factor. It is the exact bookkeeping the change-of-width law demands: $\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2x}\,\mathrm{d}u$, and the stray x in the integrand cancels the x in $\frac{1}{2x}$, leaving the clean $\frac{1}{2}$.

Example 22.3 (The logarithmic form)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \frac{2x}{x^2+1}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The denominator x^2+1 has derivative $2x$, which is sitting in the numerator. Let $u = x^2+1$, $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$:

$$\int \frac{2x\,\mathrm{d}x}{x^2+1} = \int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u} = \ln|u| + C = \ln(x^2+1) + C.$$

(We may drop the absolute value because $x^2+1 > 0$ always.) This is a special case of the enormously useful pattern $\int \frac{g'(x)}{g(x)}\,\mathrm{d}x = \ln|g(x)| + C$: *a fraction whose top is the derivative of its bottom integrates to the log of the bottom.* Burn that pattern into memory; it is everywhere.

Example 22.4 (Two layers, one sub)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \frac{\ln x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Here the "inside" is $\ln x$, whose derivative is $\frac{1}{x}$ – and there is a $\frac{1}{x}$ in the integrand. Let $u = \ln x$, $\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$:

$$\int \ln x \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \int u\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{u^2}{2} + C = \frac{(\ln x)^2}{2} + C.$$

22.5.2 When the substitution must be rearranged

Sometimes after choosing u you still have leftover x's that are not part of $\mathrm{d}u$. The fix is to solve $u = g(x)$ for x and substitute those leftover x's too. This is where substitution stops being mere pattern-matching and becomes a genuine change of variable.

Example 22.5 (Solving back for the stray x)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int x\sqrt{x+1}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The natural choice is $u = x+1$, so $\mathrm{d}u = \mathrm{d}x$ and $\sqrt{x+1} = \sqrt{u}$. But there is a stray x out front that is not accounted for. Since $u = x+1$, we have $x = u-1$. Replace it:

$$\int x\sqrt{x+1}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int (u-1)\sqrt{u}\,\mathrm{d}u = \int \left(u^{3/2} - u^{1/2}\right)\mathrm{d}u.$$

Now it is elementary:

$$= \frac{2}{5}u^{5/2} - \frac{2}{3}u^{3/2} + C = \frac{2}{5}(x+1)^{5/2} - \frac{2}{3}(x+1)^{3/2} + C.$$

The lesson: a substitution does not have to consume every x through $\mathrm{d}u$. As long as you can express *all* remaining x's in terms of u, the change of variable is legitimate and complete.

Example 22.6 (A trig identity must come first)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \cos^3 x\,\mathrm{d}x$.

There is no obvious inside-and-its-derivative here. The move is to spend one factor of $\cos x$ as the future $\mathrm{d}u$ and convert the rest using $\cos^2 x = 1 - \sin^2 x$:

$$\int \cos^3 x\,\mathrm{d}x = \int \cos^2 x \cdot \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x = \int (1 - \sin^2 x)\,\cos x\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Now let $u = \sin x$, $\mathrm{d}u = \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x$:

$$= \int (1 - u^2)\,\mathrm{d}u = u - \frac{u^3}{3} + C = \sin x - \frac{\sin^3 x}{3} + C.$$

The identity created the pattern; substitution finished the job. This trick – peel off one factor to be $\mathrm{d}u$, convert the even remainder with a Pythagorean identity – is the backbone of trigonometric integrals, which get a chapter of their own.

Example 22.7 ($\tan x$, the classic rewrite)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \tan x\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Rewrite $\tan x = \dfrac{\sin x}{\cos x}$. Now the bottom is $\cos x$ and the top $\sin x$ is, up to a sign, its derivative. Let $u = \cos x$, $\mathrm{d}u = -\sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$, so $\sin x\,\mathrm{d}x = -\mathrm{d}u$:

$$\int \frac{\sin x}{\cos x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int \frac{-\mathrm{d}u}{u} = -\ln|u| + C = -\ln|\cos x| + C = \ln|\sec x| + C.$$

This is again the $\int \frac{g'}{g}$ pattern, here applied to trigonometric functions.

22.5.3 The genuinely sneaky ones

Example 22.8 (When the obvious sub is not the inside)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \frac{1}{x \ln x}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

You might be tempted by $u = x$ or by the whole denominator. Resist, and notice the structure: $\frac{1}{x}$ is the derivative of $\ln x$. So treat $\ln x$ as the inside. Let $u = \ln x$, $\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$:

$$\int \frac{1}{\ln x} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u} = \ln|u| + C = \ln|\ln x| + C.$$

The result is a logarithm composed with a logarithm: $\ln|\ln x| + C$.

Example 22.9 (Completing the square, then substituting)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \frac{1}{x^2 + 4x + 5}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The denominator does not factor over the reals, but we can complete the square: $x^2 + 4x + 5 = (x + 2)^2 + 1$. Now let $u = x + 2$, $\mathrm{d}u = \mathrm{d}x$:

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{(x+2)^2 + 1} = \int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u^2 + 1} = \arctan u + C = \arctan(x + 2) + C.$$

Here substitution did something subtler than peel off a chain rule: it *recentered* the variable so a standard form ($\int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u^2+1} = \arctan u$) became visible. Shifting and scaling are the humblest and most common substitutions of all.

Example 22.10 (A rationalizing substitution)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int \frac{1}{1 + \sqrt{x}}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The square root is the obstruction, so give it a name: let $u = \sqrt{x}$, which means $x = u^2$ and $\mathrm{d}x = 2u\,\mathrm{d}u$. The integral becomes

$$\int \frac{2u\,\mathrm{d}u}{1 + u}.$$

Now rewrite the numerator to split off a whole copy of the denominator: $\dfrac{2u}{1+u} = \dfrac{2(u+1)-2}{1+u} = 2 - \dfrac{2}{1+u}$. Hence

$$\int \left(2 - \frac{2}{1+u}\right) \mathrm{d}u = 2u - 2\ln|1+u| + C = 2\sqrt{x} - 2\ln\bigl(1+\sqrt{x}\bigr) + C,$$

where the absolute value drops because $1+\sqrt{x} \geq 1 > 0$. Notice this substitution ran "the other way": instead of setting u equal to a part of the integrand and computing $\mathrm{d}u$, we wrote $x = u^2$ and computed $\mathrm{d}x = 2u\,\mathrm{d}u$. Both directions are valid; Theorem 22.1 covers them on any interval where the change of variable is differentiable and one-to-one. (Here $u = \sqrt{x} > 0$ on $x > 0$; $\sqrt{x}$ is not differentiable at $x = 0$, but the resulting antiderivative extends continuously to $x = 0$.)

Why this matters

Look back at how many different-looking integrals collapsed onto the same few shapes: $\int u^n\,\mathrm{d}u$, $\int e^u\,\mathrm{d}u$, $\int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u}$, and $\int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u^2+1}$. Substitution is, in a sense, a *universal translator*: it keeps trying to phrase the integral in one of the handful of languages you already speak fluently. The art of integration is largely the art of recognizing which translation will land you in familiar territory.

22.6 Definite integrals: carry the limits

For a definite integral you have two equally valid styles, and you should be fluent in both.

Style A – change the limits. Use Theorem 22.2 directly: when $u = g(x)$, replace the limits $x = a, x = b$ by $u = g(a), u = g(b)$ and never return to x at all.

Style B – back-substitute. Do the indefinite integral, return to x, then plug in the original limits.

Example 22.11 (The same integral both ways)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int_0^2 x\,e^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Let $u = x^2$, $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$, so $x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{d}u$.

Style A (change the limits). When $x = 0$, $u = 0$; when $x = 2$, $u = 4$. So

$$\int_0^2 x\,e^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\int_0^4 e^u\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{2}\Bigl[e^u\Bigr]_0^4 = \frac{e^4 - 1}{2}.$$

Style B (back-substitute). The antiderivative is $\frac{1}{2}e^{x^2}$, so

$$\int_0^2 x\,e^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\Bigl[e^{x^2}\Bigr]_0^2 = \frac{1}{2}\bigl(e^4 - e^0\bigr) = \frac{e^4 - 1}{2}.$$

Same answer, as it must be. Style A is usually faster and cleaner once you trust it, because you never untangle u back into x.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose you apply the substitution $u = 3x + 1$ to the definite integral $\int_1^5 f(3x+1)\,dx$. What are the new limits of integration in u, before you know anything about f?
Answer: When $x = 1$, $u = 3(1) + 1 = 4$. When $x = 5$, $u = 3(5) + 1 = 16$. The integral becomes $\frac{1}{3}\int_4^{16} f(u)\,du$.

Common trap

The signature blunder: changing the variable to u but leaving the old x-limits on the integral sign. If you write

$$\int_0^2 x\,e^{x^2}\,dx \stackrel{?}{=} \frac{1}{2}\int_0^2 e^u\,du,$$

you have committed it – the "0" and "2" there are x-values, but the integral is now in u. Either change them to the u-values (0 and 4), or drop the limits entirely until you have returned to x. Mixing u-integrand with x-limits gives a wrong number every time. A safe habit: the instant you write a u on the integrand, write the u-limits on the sign, in the same stroke of the pen.

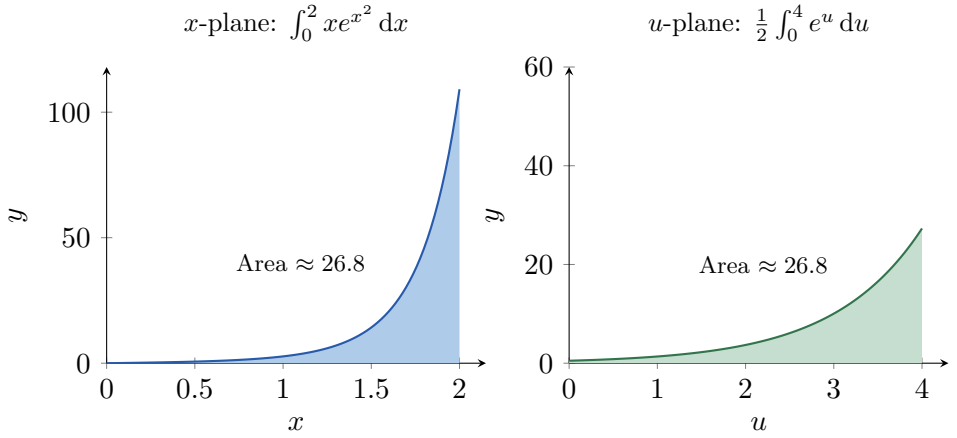


Figure 22.3: Preservation of area under substitution. **Left:** In x-space, the integral $\int_0^2 xe^{x^2}\,dx$ forms a tall, narrow region of width 2 and peak height ≈ 109.2. **Right:** The substitution $u = x^2$ stretches the base onto $[0, 4]$ while the factor $dx = \frac{1}{2x}du$ scales down the height to $\frac{1}{2}e^u$ (peak ≈ 54.6). The transformed region has the exact same area, $\frac{e^4-1}{2} \approx 26.8$. Changing the limits from $x \in [0, 2]$ to $u \in [0, 4]$ is what ensures the re-measured area stays equal.

Work it yourself

Verify the limit-changing rule on a case where you know the answer directly. Take $\int_1^3 (2x)(x^2)\,dx$, which is just $\int_1^3 2x^3\,dx = \frac{1}{2}x^4\big|_1^3 = \frac{1}{2}(81-1) = 40$. Now redo it by substituting $u = x^2$, $du = 2x\,dx$, with limits $u = 1$ to $u = 9$: you get $\int_1^9 u\,du = \frac{1}{2}u^2\big|_1^9 = \frac{1}{2}(81-1) = 40$. The limits change from $\{1, 3\}$ to $\{1, 9\}$, while the evaluated area remains 40, exactly as guaranteed by the definite-form theorem.

22.6.1 A symmetry payoff

Changing limits is not just bookkeeping; sometimes it reveals structure you could not otherwise see.

Example 22.12 (Substitution exposes a symmetry)**.** Show that $\displaystyle\int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\sin x}{\sin x + \cos x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{\pi}{4}$.

There is no friendly antiderivative here. Instead, substitute $u = \frac{\pi}{2} - x$, the reflection that swaps the endpoints. Then $\mathrm{d}u = -\mathrm{d}x$; the limits flip ($x = 0 \to u = \frac{\pi}{2}$ and $x = \frac{\pi}{2} \to u = 0$); and $\sin x = \cos u$, $\cos x = \sin u$. Call the original integral I:

$$I = \int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\sin x}{\sin x + \cos x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_{\pi/2}^{0} \frac{\sin(\pi/2 - u)}{\sin(\pi/2 - u) + \cos(\pi/2 - u)}\,(-\mathrm{d}u) = \int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\cos u}{\cos u + \sin u}\,\mathrm{d}u.$$

The negative sign on $-\mathrm{d}u$ reverses the reversed limits $\int_{\pi/2}^{0}$ back to their standard order $\int_0^{\pi/2}$. The resulting integral has the exact same value as the original, but with sin and cos traded. Now add the two expressions for I:

$$2I = \int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\sin x + \cos x}{\sin x + \cos x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_0^{\pi/2} 1\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{\pi}{2},$$

so $I = \frac{\pi}{4}$. A substitution did what no antiderivative could: it turned an unsolvable-looking integral into a triviality by exploiting symmetry. Figure 22.4 shows why: the integrand and its reflection add to the constant 1, so their two equal areas together fill a rectangle of area $\frac{\pi}{2}$.

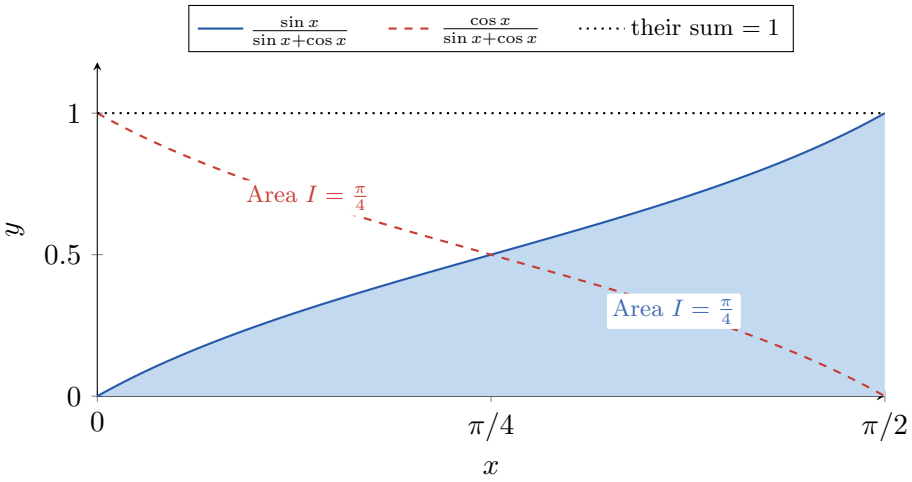


Figure 22.4: The original integrand (solid) and its reflection $x \mapsto \frac{\pi}{2} - x$ (dashed) are mirror images across $x = \pi/4$, and at every point they sum to 1 (dotted). The two shaded regions each have area $I = \pi/4$ and together fill the rectangle $[0, \pi/2] \times [0, 1]$ of area $\pi/2$. Substitution proves their equality without evaluating an antiderivative.

Connection

This reflection identity generalizes to the property that $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_a^b f(a + b - x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ for any integrable f – a direct consequence of the substitution $u = a + b - x$. It is widely used in problem solving and in probability, where it underlies calculations with symmetric

distributions.

22.7 What the symbol-shuffling really means

Time to face head-on the thing that should still nag a careful reader. When we write $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ and then "cancel" $\mathrm{d}x$'s, are we doing real mathematics or just manipulating symbols?

What is really happening

It is rigorous mathematics. Strictly, $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is *defined* to be shorthand for the statement of Theorem 22.2. The $\mathrm{d}x$ standing alone is not a number, so "cancelling" it is not division. What justifies the manipulation is that the shorthand was *designed* to mirror a true theorem: every legal token-move you make with the d's corresponds to a legal step in the proof.
Two things keep you safe. First, the substitution $u = g(x)$ should be *differentiable*, so that $g'(x)$ exists and the change-of-width law makes sense. Second, for definite integrals you want g' to keep a constant sign (or you must track orientation carefully), and for the reverse-direction substitutions $x = h(u)$ of Example 22.10 you want h to be *invertible* on the interval – meaning one-to-one, so every output comes from exactly one input and the trip back to x is unambiguous. When those mild conditions hold, the symbol-shuffling is guaranteed correct, because it is just a compressed transcription of the theorem we proved in three lines.

Common trap

The conditions are not decorative. Consider $\int_{-1}^{1} x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{2}{3}$, and try the substitution $u = x^2$. It is tempting to write $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$, so $x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{d}u$ – but the integrand is $x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$, not $x\,\mathrm{d}x$, and solving $x = \pm\sqrt{u}$ forces a sign *choice* that is positive on $[0,1]$ and negative on $[-1,0]$. The map $x \mapsto x^2$ is not invertible across 0 (it folds the interval in half), so a single substitution over the whole interval is illegal. The fix is to split at $x = 0$ and substitute on each piece separately. Moral: when g' changes sign – here at $x = 0$ – the map folds the domain, so any step that solves $u = g(x)$ back for x needs a separate branch on each side of the fold. (The forward formula of Theorem 22.2 still holds when the integrand is genuinely $f(g(x))\,g'(x)$; the danger is in expressing leftover x's through u.) Split first, then substitute.

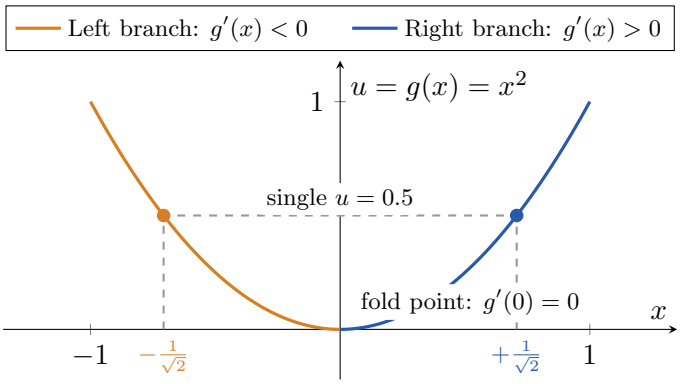


Figure 22.5: Why sign changes in g' break a single substitution. The mapping $u = x^2$ folds the interval $[-1, 1]$ in half at the stationary point $x = 0$. Both the left branch (orange, where $g' < 0$) and the right branch (blue, where $g' > 0$) map onto the same range $u \in [0, 1]$, so a single u-value corresponds to two distinct x-values. To substitute safely, split the integral at $x = 0$ so g is one-to-one on each piece.

Intuition

Whenever you are unsure whether a substitution or domain restriction was valid on an interval, differentiate your candidate antiderivative directly: if $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}((\text{your answer}))$ equals the original integrand at every point of the interval, the answer is a valid antiderivative there, whatever route produced it.

Application

Substitution is a standard step when evaluating integrals in applied models. *Physics:* the work done by a varying force, $\int F \, \mathrm{d}x$, becomes a clean energy integral after substituting the position-dependent variable. *Probability and ML:* normalizing a Gaussian relies on the substitution $u = x/\sigma$ to reduce $\int e^{-x^2/2\sigma^2} \mathrm{d}x$ to the standard bell curve; the same change of variable is the "reparameterization trick" that lets modern generative models backpropagate through random sampling. *Biology and chemistry:* separable differential equations for population growth and reaction rates are solved by substituting to isolate each variable, then integrating. The little factor $g'(x)$ you have been tracking is, in every one of these, a unit conversion between the natural variable of the problem and the variable that makes the integral solvable.

22.8 A compact procedure

Here is the chapter distilled into a checklist you can run on autopilot.

1. **Spot the inside.** Find a composition and let u be its inside (or: find a chunk whose derivative also appears, and call that chunk u).
2. **Differentiate:** compute $\mathrm{d}u = g'(x) \, \mathrm{d}x$.
3. **Rewrite the whole integrand** in terms of u and $\mathrm{d}u$. Patch missing *constants* freely; if a stray *variable* remains, solve $u = g(x)$ for x and substitute it too.

4. **For a definite integral, change the limits** to $u = g(a)$ and $u = g(b)$ at the same moment you change the integrand.
5. **Integrate in** u, landing in one of your known forms.
6. **Translate back to** x (indefinite) or just evaluate at the u-limits (definite).
7. **Differentiate your answer to check.** Always.

Pause

Troubleshooting a stuck substitution. If substituting leaves a stray x that neither cancels against $\mathrm{d}u$ nor rewrites through $u = g(x)$, do not force it. First try a larger inside chunk (for instance, include a constant or a whole denominator in u), or check whether a trigonometric identity or completing the square exposes $g'(x)$. If no composition is present at all, substitution is the wrong tool.

22.9 Limitations and next steps

Connection

Substitution is powerful, but it has a clear limitation: it requires a matching derivative factor $g'(x)$ inside the integrand (up to an adjustable constant).
When that factor is present, as in $\int xe^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$, the method works directly: setting $u = x^2$ gives $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$, turning the integral into $\frac{1}{2}\int e^u\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{2}e^{x^2} + C$.
When that factor is missing, substitution fails. Compare $\int xe^{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ with $\int xe^x\,\mathrm{d}x$. In $\int xe^x\,\mathrm{d}x$, setting $u = x$ changes nothing, while setting $u = e^x$ yields $\int \ln(u)\,\mathrm{d}u$. Neither factor is the derivative of an internal function. Similar difficulties arise with integrals such as $\int \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$, $\int x^2\cos x\,\mathrm{d}x$, and $\int \arctan x\,\mathrm{d}x$.
To handle products of two unrelated functions, we need a method that inverts the Product Rule rather than the Chain Rule. That method is *integration by parts*, developed in Chapter 23:

$$\int u\,\mathrm{d}v = uv - \int v\,\mathrm{d}u.$$

22.10 Exercises

Exercise 22.1 (Mental checks: spot the pair in five seconds)**.** For each integral, identify the inside function u and the derivative factor $g'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ without pencil and paper, and state the antiderivative:

1. $\displaystyle\int 2x\left(x^2+9\right)^4\,\mathrm{d}x$
2. $\displaystyle\int \frac{\cos x}{\sin x}\,\mathrm{d}x$
3. $\displaystyle\int \frac{(\ln x)^3}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$

4. $\displaystyle\int e^{\tan x}\sec^2 x\,\mathrm{d}x$

Exercise 22.2 (Warm-ups)**.** Evaluate each indefinite integral by a single substitution, and check by differentiating.

1. $\displaystyle\int (2x+3)^7\,\mathrm{d}x$
2. $\displaystyle\int x^2\sqrt{x^3+1}\,\mathrm{d}x$
3. $\displaystyle\int \frac{e^{1/x}}{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$
4. $\displaystyle\int \sin x\,\cos^4 x\,\mathrm{d}x$

Exercise 22.3 (The g'/g pattern)**.** Using $\int \frac{g'}{g}\,\mathrm{d}x = \ln|g| + C$, evaluate $\displaystyle\int \frac{3x^2-2}{x^3-2x+7}\,\mathrm{d}x$ and $\displaystyle\int \cot x\,\mathrm{d}x$. For the second, first rewrite $\cot x$ as a quotient.

Exercise 22.4 (Stray variable)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int x(2x-1)^{10}\,\mathrm{d}x$ by letting $u = 2x-1$ and solving for the leftover x.

Exercise 22.5 (Definite, change the limits)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^1 \frac{x}{x^2+1}\,\mathrm{d}x$ two ways: by changing the limits, and by back-substituting. Confirm the answers agree, and state the new limits explicitly.

Exercise 22.6 (Complete the square)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int \frac{1}{x^2-6x+13}\,\mathrm{d}x$ by completing the square and substituting to reach an arctan.

Exercise 22.7 (Rationalize)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int \frac{1}{1+\sqrt[3]{x}}\,\mathrm{d}x$ by setting $u = \sqrt[3]{x}$. (You will need polynomial division.)

Exercise 22.8 (A trig identity first)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int \sin^2 x\,\cos^3 x\,\mathrm{d}x$. (Peel off one $\cos x$ for $\mathrm{d}u$ and convert the rest with $\cos^2 x = 1-\sin^2 x$.)

Exercise 22.9 (Symmetry)**.** Use the reflection substitution $u = \frac{\pi}{2} - x$ to evaluate the definite integral $\displaystyle\int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\cos^2 x}{\sin^2 x + \cos^2 x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ without finding an antiderivative. (It should remind you of Example 22.12.)

Exercise 22.10 (Conceptual: why the constant is allowed)**.** Explain in a sentence or two why you are permitted to pull a constant factor out of an integral to manufacture $\mathrm{d}u$, but *not* a variable factor. Illustrate with a wrong "computation" of $\int x^2 e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$ that mistakenly factors out an x, and point to the exact illegal step.

Exercise 22.11 (Conceptual: the folded interval)**.** Consider $\displaystyle\int_{-1}^{2} x^2\,\mathrm{d}x$ and the substitution $u = x^2$. Explain why a naive single substitution over $[-1,2]$ is invalid, identify where $g'(x)$ changes sign, and describe how you would split the interval to substitute correctly. (You do not need to finish the computation.)

Exercise 22.12 (Proof)**.** Prove the reflection identity $\displaystyle\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_a^b f(a+b-x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ for continuous f, by carrying out the substitution $u = a+b-x$ carefully, including what happens to the limits and the sign of $\mathrm{d}u$. Deduce Example 22.12 as a special case. Then evaluate $\int_0^1 \frac{1}{1+e^{\,x-1/2}}\,\mathrm{d}x$ by adding the integral to its reflected twin (hint: multiplying top and bottom of $\frac{1}{1+e^{1/2-x}}$ by $e^{x-1/2}$ shows the two integrands sum to 1).

Exercise 22.13 (Proof: substitution from the Riemann sum)**.** For a strictly increasing, continuously differentiable g on $[a,b]$, sketch why the change-of-variable formula holds at the level of Riemann sums. Specifically, explain how a partition of the x-axis maps to a partition of the u-axis, why the k-th subinterval width scales by approximately $g'(x_k)$, and how sending the mesh to zero recovers $\int_{g(a)}^{g(b)} f(u)\,\mathrm{d}u$. This is the "change-of-width law" of Section 22.3 made into a proof sketch.

Chapter 23

Integration by Parts

In the previous chapter we ran the chain rule backwards: whenever an integrand has the shape $f(g(x))\,g'(x)$ of a differentiated composition, substitution unwinds it. Yet many simple-looking integrals defeat substitution:

$$\int x\,e^x\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int x\sin x\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int e^x\cos x\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

None of these arises from the chain rule. Direct substitution fails on $\int xe^x\,\mathrm{d}x$: setting $u = x$ reproduces the same integral, while setting $u = e^x$ leaves an unsimplified factor of $x = \ln u$. These integrands are *products* of two unrelated functions – a polynomial times an exponential, a polynomial times a sine – and substitution was designed to invert compositions, not products.

There is exactly one differentiation rule that creates products: the *product rule*. So if we want to integrate products, the move is to run the product rule backwards, exactly as substitution was the chain rule run backwards. The technique that comes out is called *integration by parts*. It will not collapse an integral to nothing the way a lucky substitution sometimes does. Instead it trades the integral you have for a different one, in the hope that the new one is easier. Most of the art is in arranging the trade so that you come out ahead.

23.1 The Product Rule, Run Backwards

Everything in this chapter is squeezed out of one line you already know. If u and v are differentiable functions of x, the product rule says

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(u\,v) = u\,\frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}x} + v\,\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x}.$$

Read it as a statement about how the area of a little rectangle $u \cdot v$ changes: when both sides are growing, the rectangle grows on two fronts at once, one strip of width $\mathrm{d}u$ down the side and one strip of height $\mathrm{d}v$ along the top. The product rule just adds those two strips. (We drew that picture back when we first met the product rule; hold it in mind, because it is about to pay off.)

Now take antiderivatives of both sides with respect to x. Antidifferentiation undoes differentiation (any constant of integration can be absorbed into the indefinite integrals on the right), so the left

side becomes $u\,v$ itself:

$$u\,v = \int u\,\frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x + \int v\,\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

That is already the whole theorem – it just needs to be rearranged. Solve for the first integral on the right:

$$\int u\,\frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x = u\,v - \int v\,\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Finally, abbreviate $\mathrm{d}v = \frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}u = \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ – the differentials of Chapter 14, representing the derivative multiplied by the step $\mathrm{d}x$. We arrive at the standard integration-by-parts formula:

Focus

Integration by parts. If u and v are differentiable, then

$$\boxed{\int u\,\mathrm{d}v \;=\; u\,v \;-\; \int v\,\mathrm{d}u}$$

and, between limits a and b,

$$\int_a^b u\,\mathrm{d}v \;=\; \Big[u\,v\Big]_a^b \;-\; \int_a^b v\,\mathrm{d}u.$$

That is it. Two symbols, u and v, and the rule says: integrating $u\,\mathrm{d}v$ costs you the boundary term uv – the evaluation of the finished product $u \cdot v$ at the endpoints of your interval – minus the price of integrating $v\,\mathrm{d}u$ instead. You have not solved the integral – you have *swapped* it for another. The bet is that $\int v\,\mathrm{d}u$ is friendlier than $\int u\,\mathrm{d}v$.

Why the technique works

Substitution is the chain rule read right to left; integration by parts is the product rule read right to left. That duality organizes the whole structure of integration technique. There are only a handful of ways to *build* a function by differentiation (sums, products, compositions), so there are only a handful of ways to *take one apart* by integration. Sums split term-by-term. Compositions are unwound by substitution. Products are unwound by parts. When you face an unfamiliar integral, the first question is always "which differentiation rule could have produced an integrand shaped like this?" – and the answer tells you which tool to reach for.

What is really happening

Look again at $\int u\,\mathrm{d}v = uv - \int v\,\mathrm{d}u$ and ask what is physically being moved around. The combination $u\,\mathrm{d}v$ is a thin horizontal slab of "stuff": a width u times an increment $\mathrm{d}v$. The formula says the total of all those strips equals the finished rectangle uv *minus* the total of the complementary strips $v\,\mathrm{d}u$. Integration by parts is thus a statement about cutting a rectangle two ways. The product uv is a region in the u–v plane; you can sweep it out in horizontal slabs ($u\,\mathrm{d}v$) or vertical slabs ($v\,\mathrm{d}u$), and the two sweeps must add up to the same rectangle. We will make this picture exact in the next section, and it explains *why* the boundary term uv is there.

23.2 The Picture: Slicing a Rectangle Two Ways

The boundary term uv can feel like it falls out of the algebra by accident. It does not. Here is a proof of integration by parts that uses no symbols at all until the very end – just the area of a rectangle.

Imagine a curve in the u–v plane traced out as x runs from a to b. At $x = a$ the point is (u_a, v_a); at $x = b$ it is (u_b, v_b). As x increases, both u and v change, and the point sweeps a path. Now look at Figure 23.1. The big rectangle reaching out to (u_b, v_b) has area $u_b v_b$. The small rectangle reaching to (u_a, v_a) has area $u_a v_a$. The L-shaped region between them – the big rectangle minus the small one – has area $u_b v_b - u_a v_a$, which is exactly the boundary term $\Big[uv\Big]_a^b$.

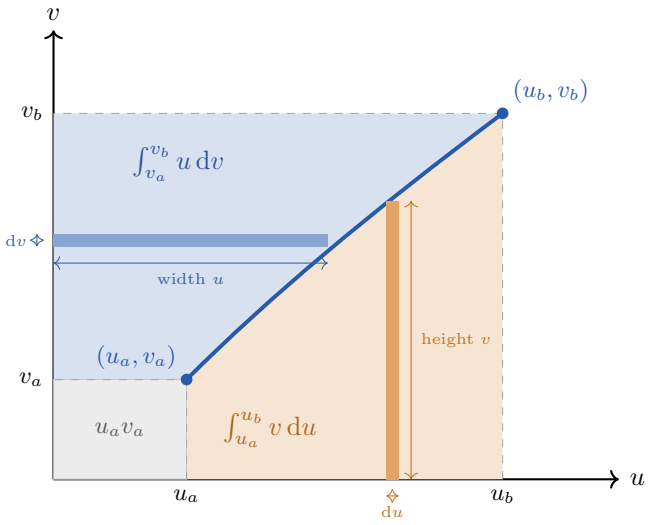


Figure 23.1: Integration by parts as bounding box geometry. The total rectangle out to (u_b, v_b) has area $u_b v_b$. Removing the bottom-left rectangle $u_a v_a$ leaves an L-shaped region of area $u_b v_b - u_a v_a = \Big[uv\Big]_a^b$. The path $(u(x), v(x))$ cuts this L-region into two complementary sweeps: horizontal strips $u\,dv$ (blue) summing to $\int u\,dv$, and vertical strips $v\,du$ (orange) summing to $\int v\,du$. Together they tile the region: $\int u\,dv + \int v\,du = \Big[uv\Big]_a^b$.

Now slice that L-shaped region two different ways. A *vertical* strip has a height v and is built from a change in u; its area is $v\,du$, and summing them gives $\int v\,du$, the orange region below the curve. A *horizontal* strip has a width u and is built from a change in v; its area is $u\,dv$, and summing gives $\int u\,dv$, the blue region to the left of the curve. The path of (u, v) is the boundary between the two regions, and together they tile the entire L. Writing $\int_a^b u\,dv$ for $\int_a^b u(x)\,v'(x)\,dx$ (which sweeps v from v_a to v_b as x runs from a to b, matching the label $\int_{v_a}^{v_b} u\,dv$ in Figure 23.1), we get

$$\int_a^b u\,dv \;+\; \int_a^b v\,du \;=\; u_b v_b - u_a v_a = \Big[uv\Big]_a^b.$$

Move the second integral to the right and you have integration by parts, born purely from cutting a region two ways.

Intuition

This is why the boundary term is uv and not something else: uv is literally the *rectangle* whose two complementary sweeps are the two integrals. Integration by parts is conservation of area. Whatever you "give up" by not integrating $u\,dv$ directly, you get back as the rectangle minus the other sweep. Nothing is created or destroyed; the area is just being cut into different strips.

This geometric proof needs u and v to be monotonic to draw cleanly, but the algebraic derivation in Section 23.1 has no such restriction – it works for any differentiable u, v. Keep the picture for intuition and the algebra for rigor.

23.3 Choosing u and dv

The formula has a built-in decision. Faced with an integral, you must split the integrand into two pieces: one piece you will call u (and *differentiate* to get du), and one piece you will call dv (and *integrate* to get v). Every product can be split two ways, and usually only one split helps. So how do you choose?

Two principles guide every good choice.

1. u **should get simpler when you differentiate it.** The whole point is that $\int v\,du$ is easier than $\int u\,dv$. Differentiating u is your chance to make progress, so pick a u whose derivative is tamer than itself. A polynomial like x^3 is ideal: each derivative knocks the degree down, and after enough rounds it vanishes. The logarithm $\ln x$ is even better – it has no elementary antiderivative of its own, but its *derivative* $1/x$ is beautifully simple, so making $\ln x$ into u converts a hard factor into an easy one.

2. dv **must be something you can actually integrate.** You need $v = \int dv$ to be a function you know. There is no point assigning dv to a factor you cannot antidifferentiate. So $e^x\,dx$, $\sin x\,dx$, $\cos x\,dx$, and powers $x^n\,dx$ all make fine dv's; something like $\ln x\,dx$ does not (you would be stuck integrating it – which is the very problem you started with).

These two principles together produce a famous mnemonic.

Focus

LIATE – a priority order for choosing u. When a product mixes two of these types, let u be whichever appears *earlier* in the list, and let the rest be dv:

L **L**ogarithmic ($\ln x$, $\log x$)
I **I**nverse trig ($\arctan x$, $\arcsin x$)
A **A**lgebraic (powers x^n, polynomials)
T **T**rigonometric ($\sin x$, $\cos x$)
E **E**xponential (e^x, a^x)

Earlier in the list = choose as u.

Why this order? Read the list top to bottom and you are reading functions in order of "how much simpler does differentiating make them, and how easy are they to integrate." Logs and inverse trig

functions are at the top because they are miserable to integrate but pleasant to differentiate, so you always want them as u. Exponentials are at the bottom because they are trivial to integrate and never get simpler when differentiated, so you always want them as $\mathrm{d}v$. Polynomials sit in the middle: they are easy either to differentiate or to integrate, but differentiating lowers their degree, so when paired with a trig or exponential factor they go on the u side.

Common trap

LIATE is a *heuristic, not a law.* It encodes good defaults, but it cannot think for you, and there are integrals where it points the wrong way or where *either* choice works. The genuine criterion is always the two principles above: did $\int v\,\mathrm{d}u$ come out simpler than what you started with? If a choice leads to a worse integral, you have learned something – swap your choice and try the other split. Never defend a bad choice by appeal to a mnemonic.

Pause

Ten-second mental check. Before calculating, look at three test integrands: $\int x^4 \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$, $\int x^3 e^{2x}\,\mathrm{d}x$, and $\int \arcsin x\,\mathrm{d}x$. Which factor should be u, and what is $\mathrm{d}v$?
Pause and decide before reading on. By LIATE:

- In $\int x^4 \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$, the logarithm beats the polynomial (L before A), so $u = \ln x$ and $\mathrm{d}v = x^4\,\mathrm{d}x$.
- In $\int x^3 e^{2x}\,\mathrm{d}x$, the polynomial beats the exponential (A before E), so $u = x^3$ and $\mathrm{d}v = e^{2x}\,\mathrm{d}x$.
- In $\int \arcsin x\,\mathrm{d}x$, there is no second factor, so invent one: $u = \arcsin x$ (I beats everything available) and $\mathrm{d}v = 1\,\mathrm{d}x$.

If your instincts matched all three, you are ready for the worked examples.

History

The mnemonic LIATE is modern—introduced in a 1983 paper by Herbert Kasube to help students choose u and $\mathrm{d}v$. The underlying technique dates to the development of calculus in the late seventeenth century.
In 1694, Johann Bernoulli observed that Leibniz's product rule,

$$\mathrm{d}(uv) = u\,\mathrm{d}v + v\,\mathrm{d}u,$$

could be integrated to yield $\int u\,\mathrm{d}v = uv - \int v\,\mathrm{d}u$, shifting the derivative from one factor to the other. Brook Taylor published the same method independently in his 1715 treatise *Methodus Incrementorum Directa et Inversa* using fluxions.
Continental mathematicians, using Leibniz's differential notation, adopted the technique readily. Euler applied it recursively to obtain reduction formulas such as the one for $\int \sin^n x\,\mathrm{d}x$, which give a modern route to Wallis's 1655 product for $\pi/2$ (Wallis himself found it decades earlier by interpolating tables of integrals). Later mathematicians extended the idea to solve differential equations and to define generalized solutions where functions lack classical derivatives.

23.4 First Worked Examples

The process requires four steps: choose u and $\mathrm{d}v$; differentiate to get $\mathrm{d}u$ and integrate to get v; assemble $uv - \int v\,\mathrm{d}u$; finish the leftover integral.

Example 23.1 (The archetype: $\int xe^x\,\mathrm{d}x$)**.** Here the two factors are algebraic (x) and exponential (e^x). LIATE says: A beats E, so $u = x$ and $\mathrm{d}v = e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$. Then

$$u = x \;\Rightarrow\; \mathrm{d}u = \mathrm{d}x, \qquad \mathrm{d}v = e^x\,\mathrm{d}x \;\Rightarrow\; v = e^x.$$

Assemble:

$$\int xe^x\,\mathrm{d}x = uv - \int v\,\mathrm{d}u = xe^x - \int e^x\,\mathrm{d}x = xe^x - e^x + C = (x-1)e^x + C.$$

Differentiating $u = x$ turned it into 1, leaving the elementary integral $\int e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Work it yourself

Check Example 23.1 by differentiating the answer. By the product rule, $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}((x-1)e^x) = 1\cdot e^x + (x-1)e^x = e^x + xe^x - e^x = xe^x$. It matches the integrand. *Always* verify a by-parts answer this way at first – differentiation is fast and it catches sign errors instantly. Integration by parts is sign-error-prone precisely because of the minus sign in the formula.

Common trap

What if you had chosen the other way, $u = e^x$ and $\mathrm{d}v = x\,\mathrm{d}x$? Then $\mathrm{d}u = e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$ and $v = x^2/2$, and the formula gives

$$\int xe^x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{x^2}{2}e^x - \int \frac{x^2}{2}e^x\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The new integral has x^2 where the old one had x – it got *worse*. The polynomial went up in degree because we integrated it instead of differentiating it. This is the classic wrong turn, and it is exactly what LIATE warns you off: never integrate the polynomial when there is an exponential or trig factor waiting to absorb the $\mathrm{d}v$ role.

Example 23.2 (The clever trick: $\int \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$)**.** This one looks impossible – there is no second factor to play with. The trick is to *invent* one by writing $\ln x = (\ln x)\cdot 1$. Now it is a product, and LIATE is decisive: L beats everything, so $u = \ln x$ and $\mathrm{d}v = 1\,\mathrm{d}x$. Then

$$u = \ln x \;\Rightarrow\; \mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \mathrm{d}v = \mathrm{d}x \;\Rightarrow\; v = x.$$

Assemble:

$$\int \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x = (\ln x)(x) - \int x\cdot\frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x = x\ln x - \int 1\,\mathrm{d}x = x\ln x - x + C.$$

The key simplification is the cancellation $x\cdot\frac{1}{x} = 1$: differentiating $\ln x$ produces $1/x$, which pairs with the factor x from v to leave the basic integral $\int 1\,\mathrm{d}x$. This is the standard approach for integrating functions that are straightforward to differentiate but have no obvious antiderivative – logarithmic and inverse trigonometric functions all yield to $u = f(x)$ and $\mathrm{d}v = \mathrm{d}x$.

Example 23.3 (Inverse trig: $\int \arctan x\,dx$)**.** Same trick. Write $\arctan x = (\arctan x)\cdot 1$, take $u = \arctan x$ and $dv = dx$, so $du = \dfrac{1}{1+x^2}\,dx$ and $v = x$. Then

$$\int \arctan x\,dx = x\arctan x - \int \frac{x}{1+x^2}\,dx.$$

The leftover integral now *is* a substitution problem – set $w = 1+x^2$, $dw = 2x\,dx$, so $\int \frac{x}{1+x^2}\,dx = \frac{1}{2}\ln(1+x^2)$. Hence

$$\int \arctan x\,dx = x\arctan x - \tfrac{1}{2}\ln(1+x^2) + C.$$

Notice how the two big techniques chain together: parts cracked the problem open, and substitution mopped up the remainder. Real integration is almost always a relay race between methods.

Example 23.4 (A polynomial that needs two rounds: $\int x^2 \sin x\,dx$)**.** Here $u = x^2$ (algebraic, beats trig) and $dv = \sin x\,dx$, so $du = 2x\,dx$ and $v = -\cos x$. One round:

$$\int x^2\sin x\,dx = -x^2\cos x - \int(-\cos x)(2x\,dx) = -x^2\cos x + 2\int x\cos x\,dx.$$

We have not finished, but we have made progress: the power dropped from x^2 to x. Attack $\int x\cos x\,dx$ by parts again, with $u = x$, $dv = \cos x\,dx$, $du = dx$, $v = \sin x$:

$$\int x\cos x\,dx = x\sin x - \int \sin x\,dx = x\sin x + \cos x.$$

Substitute back:

$$\int x^2\sin x\,dx = -x^2\cos x + 2\big(x\sin x + \cos x\big) + C = -x^2\cos x + 2x\sin x + 2\cos x + C.$$

Each application of parts lowered the polynomial's degree by one. A degree-n polynomial times $\sin x$ or e^x reduces to a basic integral after exactly n rounds. When you see that coming, there is a shortcut – tabular integration – which we meet in Section 23.7.

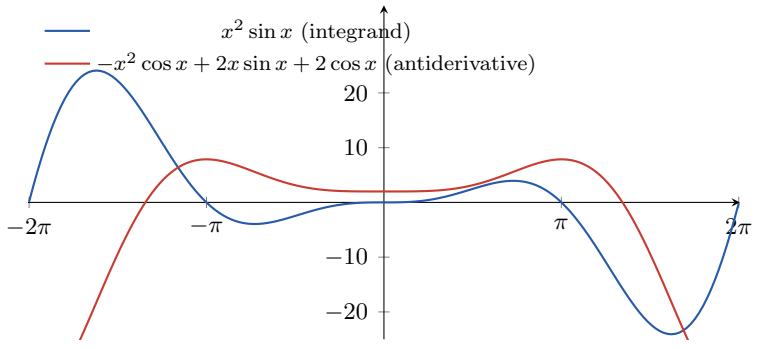


Figure 23.2: The integrand $x^2\sin x$ (blue) and the antiderivative we computed in Example 23.4 (red). Wherever the blue curve is positive the red curve climbs, and where blue is negative red falls – the antiderivative accumulates signed area under the integrand, exactly as the Fundamental Theorem promises.

Example 23.5 (Definite integral: $\int_1^e \ln x \, dx$)**.** We already found the antiderivative $x \ln x - x$ in Example 23.2, so

$$\int_1^e \ln x \, dx = \Big[x \ln x - x\Big]_1^e = (e \ln e - e) - (1 \cdot \ln 1 - 1) = (e - e) - (0 - 1) = 1.$$

Geometrically: the area under the curve $y = \ln x$ from $x = 1$ to $x = e$ is exactly 1 square unit (Figure 23.3). That clean answer reflects how tightly $\ln x$ and e are bound together: e is exactly the point where the area under $\ln x$, starting from 1, reaches one unit.

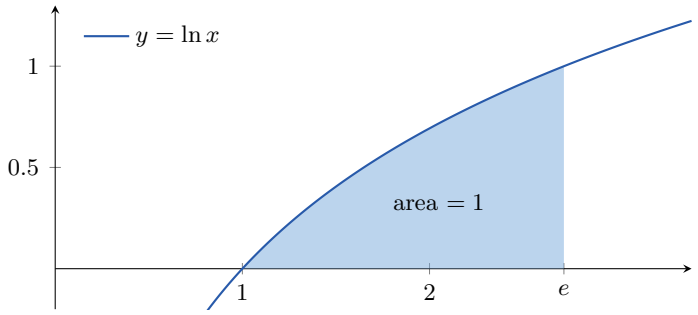


Figure 23.3: The shaded region under $y = \ln x$ from $x = 1$ to $x = e$ has area exactly 1, the value of $\int_1^e \ln x \, dx$ computed in Example 23.5. Integration by parts handed us the antiderivative $x \ln x - x$; the Fundamental Theorem turned it into this clean unit area.

Walking question

Here is a question to chew on while walking. Integration by parts comes from the product rule, yet $\ln x$ is a single function, not a visible product. Why did writing $\ln x = (\ln x) \cdot 1$ make progress instead of going in circles? Because integrating 1 introduces x, while differentiating $\ln x$ produces $1/x$ – and those two factors cancel in $v \, du = x \cdot (1/x) \, dx$. What other single functions have derivatives simple enough to cancel x cleanly?

23.5 Reduction Formulas: Parts as a Machine

When the integrand carries a parameter – a power n, say – a single application of parts can express the integral with parameter n in terms of the *same* integral with a smaller parameter. That recursive relationship is called a *reduction formula*. It is integration by parts at its most powerful: instead of solving one integral, you solve an entire infinite family in one stroke.

Example 23.6 (The reduction formula for $\int x^n e^x \, dx$)**.** Let

$$I_n = \int x^n e^x \, dx.$$

Take $u = x^n$ and $dv = e^x \, dx$, so $du = nx^{n-1} \, dx$ and $v = e^x$. Parts gives

$$I_n = x^n e^x - \int e^x \cdot nx^{n-1} \, dx = x^n e^x - n \int x^{n-1} e^x \, dx = x^n e^x - n \, I_{n-1}.$$

So

$$\boxed{I_n = x^n e^x - n\, I_{n-1}.}$$

Each use of parts lowers the exponent by one. Starting from $I_0 = \int e^x \,\mathrm{d}x = e^x$, we can climb the ladder to any n. For instance,

$$I_1 = xe^x - 1 \cdot I_0 = xe^x - e^x,$$
$$I_2 = x^2e^x - 2I_1 = x^2e^x - 2(xe^x - e^x) = x^2e^x - 2xe^x + 2e^x,$$
$$I_3 = x^3e^x - 3I_2 = x^3e^x - 3x^2e^x + 6xe^x - 6e^x,$$

and the pattern (with its alternating falling-factorial coefficients) is now unmistakable. One reduction formula generated the whole family.

Why the technique works

Why do reduction formulas exist at all? Because parts *trades a hard factor for a smaller version of itself.* When you differentiate x^n you get nx^{n-1} – structurally the same kind of object, one notch simpler. The integral on the right is therefore a clone of the integral on the left with the parameter decremented. Anytime differentiating one factor reproduces a scaled, simpler copy of that factor – powers, $\sin^n$, $\cos^n$, $(\ln x)^n$ – parts will hand you a recursion. Beyond single integrals, integration by parts reduces whole families of integrals by induction on a parameter.

Example 23.7 (A trig reduction: $\int \sin^n x \,\mathrm{d}x$)**.** This is the classic and it is worth seeing in full, because the cleverness is real. Let

$$J_n = \int \sin^n x \,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Split off one factor of sine: write $\sin^n x = \sin^{n-1} x \cdot \sin x$, and take

$$u = \sin^{n-1} x, \qquad \mathrm{d}v = \sin x \,\mathrm{d}x,$$

so that $\mathrm{d}u = (n-1)\sin^{n-2} x \,\cos x \,\mathrm{d}x$ and $v = -\cos x$. Parts:

$$J_n = -\sin^{n-1} x \,\cos x + (n-1)\int \sin^{n-2} x \,\cos^2 x \,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Now use the Pythagorean identity $\cos^2 x = 1 - \sin^2 x$ to turn the leftover integral back into sines:

$$\int \sin^{n-2} x \,\cos^2 x \,\mathrm{d}x = \int \sin^{n-2} x \,\mathrm{d}x - \int \sin^n x \,\mathrm{d}x = J_{n-2} - J_n.$$

Substitute:

$$J_n = -\sin^{n-1} x \,\cos x + (n-1)\big(J_{n-2} - J_n\big).$$

The integral J_n has *reappeared on the right* – this is the recurring integral trick we will name in the next section. Collect the J_n terms:

$$J_n + (n-1)J_n = -\sin^{n-1} x \,\cos x + (n-1)J_{n-2},$$
$$n\, J_n = -\sin^{n-1} x \,\cos x + (n-1)J_{n-2},$$

and finally

$$\boxed{J_n = -\frac{1}{n}\sin^{n-1} x \,\cos x + \frac{n-1}{n} J_{n-2}.}$$

This drops the power by *two* each time – which is exactly right, because the base cases come in two flavors: $J_0 = \int \mathrm{d}x = x$ and $J_1 = \int \sin x \,\mathrm{d}x = -\cos x$. Every even power reduces down to J_0, every odd power down to J_1.

Connection

The reduction formula for $\int_0^{\pi/2} \sin^n x \, dx$ leads to one of the most beautiful formulas in mathematics. Evaluated between 0 and $\pi/2$ the boundary term $-\frac{1}{n}\sin^{n-1} x \cos x$ vanishes at both ends ($\sin 0 = 0$ and $\cos(\pi/2) = 0$), so the recursion becomes purely numerical: $W_n = \frac{n-1}{n} W_{n-2}$, where $W_n = \int_0^{\pi/2} \sin^n x \, dx$ are the *Wallis integrals*. Geometrically, as n increases, each successive power $\sin^n x$ is depressed closer to the x-axis, pinched into an ever-narrower peak near $\pi/2$ (Figure 23.4). Notice the parity split: even powers cascade down to $W_0 = \int_0^{\pi/2} 1 \, dx = \frac{\pi}{2}$ and so carry a factor of $\frac{\pi}{2}$, whereas odd powers cascade down to $W_1 = \int_0^{\pi/2} \sin x \, dx = 1$ and are pure rational numbers. Because $\sin^{2k+1} x \le \sin^{2k} x \le \sin^{2k-1} x$ on $[0, \pi/2]$, the ratio W_{2k}/W_{2k+1} is squeezed to 1 as $k \to \infty$, which yields John Wallis's 1655 product

$$\frac{\pi}{2} = \frac{2}{1} \cdot \frac{2}{3} \cdot \frac{4}{3} \cdot \frac{4}{5} \cdot \frac{6}{5} \cdot \frac{6}{7} \cdots,$$

an infinite product of rational fractions that converges to half of π.

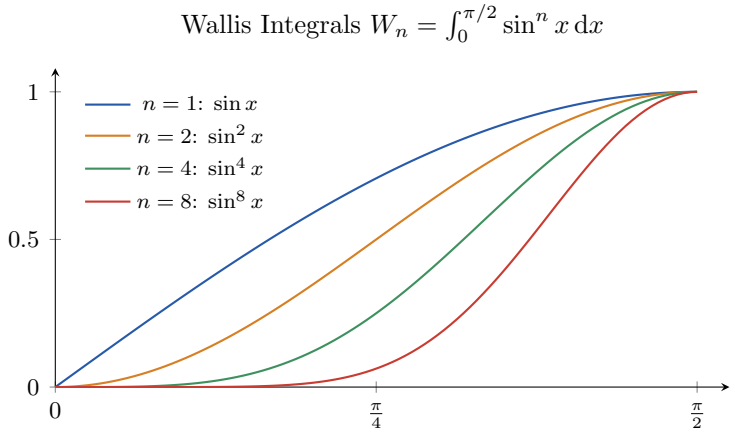


Figure 23.4: The family of powers $\sin^n x$ on $[0, \pi/2]$ whose areas form the Wallis sequence W_n. As the power n increases, the curves are pulled down toward zero across the interval, staying near 1 only in an increasingly narrow shoulder near $x = \pi/2$. The reduction formula $W_n = \frac{n-1}{n} W_{n-2}$ computes this progressive shrinkage, leading directly to Wallis's infinite product for $\pi/2$.

23.6 The Recurring-Integral Trick

Sometimes applying integration by parts twice causes the original integral to *reappear* on the right-hand side. Far from trapping us in a loop, that lets us *solve for the unknown integral algebraically*, just as we solve $K = A - K$ to get $K = A/2$. We saw this in the $\sin^n$ reduction formula. The cleanest example is an integrand combining an exponential and a trigonometric function.

Example 23.8 (Solving for the integral: $\int e^x \cos x \, dx$)**.** Call it $K = \int e^x \cos x \, dx$. Neither factor gets simpler when differentiated – e^x stays e^x, and $\cos x$ cycles to $-\sin x$ to $-\cos x$ – so LIATE has no traction. It does not matter which factor we pick for u; let us take $u = e^x$, $dv = \cos x \, dx$

consistently. Then $\mathrm{d}u = e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$, $v = \sin x$:

$$K = e^x \sin x - \int e^x \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The new integral is no simpler, but it is the same *type*. Apply parts again to $\int e^x \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$, keeping the same choice $u = e^x$, $\mathrm{d}v = \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$, so $v = -\cos x$:

$$\int e^x \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x = -e^x \cos x + \int e^x \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x = -e^x \cos x + K.$$

Substitute this back into the expression for K:

$$K = e^x \sin x - \big(-e^x \cos x + K\big) = e^x \sin x + e^x \cos x - K.$$

There it is – K on both sides. (Treat K here as one fixed antiderivative; the general constant $+C$ is added at the end.) Add K to both sides:

$$2K = e^x \sin x + e^x \cos x,$$

$$\boxed{K = \int e^x \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{e^x(\sin x + \cos x)}{2} + C.}$$

We never "finished" an integral in the usual sense – we trapped the unknown integral in an equation and solved for it.

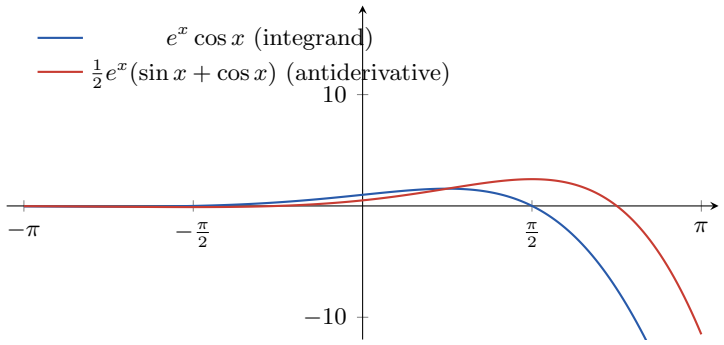


Figure 23.5: The integrand $e^x \cos x$ (blue) and the antiderivative $\frac{1}{2}e^x(\sin x + \cos x)$ (red) we trapped algebraically in Example 23.8. The exponential factor makes both curves swing ever wider, but the antiderivative still rises where the integrand is positive and falls where it is negative – solving for the recurring integral yields the exact antiderivative.

Common trap

A common error in the recurring-integral technique is to *switch the assignment of u midstream.* If you set $u = e^x$ in the first round and then switch roles by setting $u = \sin x$ (with $\mathrm{d}v = e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$) in the second, the second application simply undoes the first: you arrive at $K = K$, or $0 = 0$. To avoid this, keep the same role assignment in both rounds: if you choose the exponential as u in the first step, choose the exponential as u in the second step as well. That consistency is what produces $-K$ rather than $+K$, so you can solve.

What is really happening

Why does the integral come back rather than terminating? Because the pair $\{\sin x, \cos x\}$ is *closed* under differentiation – differentiating either one stays inside the pair – and e^x is its own derivative. So no factor ever simplifies to zero the way a polynomial eventually does; the process can only *rotate* through a finite set of shapes. After two rotations of the trig factor you are back where you started, up to a sign and the boundary terms that piled up along the way. The "recurring integral" is the visible footprint of that rotation. Linear algebra has a name for this: $\sin x$ and $\cos x$ span a two-dimensional space invariant under $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}$, and integration by parts is tracing a loop around it.

23.7 Tabular Integration: Parts on Autopilot

When one factor is a polynomial that differentiates down to zero – like x^3 or x^2 – and the other is something you can integrate over and over without effort – like e^x, $\sin x$, $\cos x$ – repeated integration by parts becomes purely mechanical. There is a bookkeeping shortcut, often called the *tabular method* or the *DI method*, that does all the rounds at once and never makes a sign error.

Here is the recipe. Make two columns. In the D column (for Differentiate) put your polynomial u and keep differentiating down to 0. In the I column (for Integrate) put the $\mathrm{d}v$ function and keep integrating, one row for each row of the D column. Then draw diagonal arrows from each entry in D to the entry one row *down* in I, attach alternating signs $+, -, +, -, \ldots$ starting with $+$, and read off the products.

Example 23.9 (Tabular: $\int x^3 e^x \,\mathrm{d}x$)**.** Differentiate x^3 down to zero; integrate e^x (it never changes):

sign	D (differentiate)		I (integrate)
$+$	x^3	$\searrow$	e^x
$-$	$3x^2$	$\searrow$	e^x
$+$	$6x$	$\searrow$	e^x
$-$	6	$\searrow$	e^x
	0		e^x

Multiply each D entry by the I entry one row down, with the sign on its left:

$$\int x^3 e^x \,\mathrm{d}x = +x^3 e^x - 3x^2 e^x + 6x e^x - 6e^x + C = (x^3 - 3x^2 + 6x - 6)e^x + C.$$

Compare this to the laborious three rounds of integration by parts we would otherwise do, and to the reduction formula's I_3 in Example 23.6 – same answer, a fraction of the writing. Figure 23.6 diagrams the complete flow.

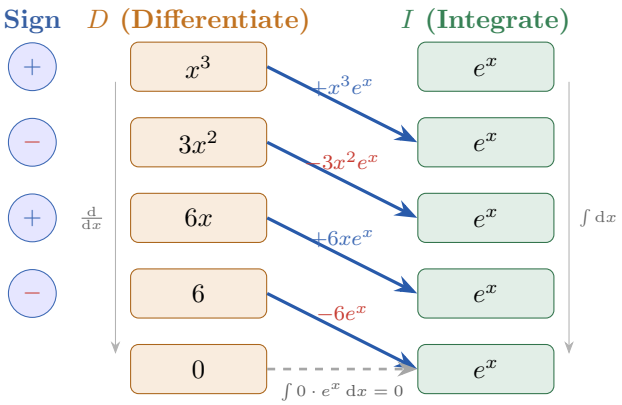


Figure 23.6: The tabular (DI) method visualized as a computational flow for $\int x^3 e^x \, dx$. The left column differentiates the polynomial x^3 down to zero; the right column repeatedly integrates e^x. Diagonal arrows link each derivative to the antiderivative one row down with alternating signs. The method terminates cleanly at zero because the horizontal product $\int 0 \cdot e^x \, dx = 0$ leaves no remainder integral.

Why the technique works

Tabular integration is simply repeated integration by parts organized in a table. Watch the columns line up with the formula. The first diagonal $+x^3 \cdot e^x$ is the boundary term uv. The next row down is exactly the $-\int v \, du$ that parts hands you, but instead of writing the integral sign you immediately apply parts to *it*, producing the next uv term and the next leftover – and so on. The alternating signs are the chain of minus signs from each application of the formula. The table terminates precisely because differentiating the polynomial eventually gives 0, killing the final leftover integral. So the table is a flip-book of the recursion in Example 23.6, all frames drawn at once.

Example 23.10 (Tabular with a trig factor: $\int x^2 \cos x \, dx$)**.** Differentiate x^2 to zero; integrate $\cos x \to \sin x \to -\cos x \to -\sin x$:

sign	D		I
$+$	x^2	$\searrow$	$\cos x$
$-$	$2x$	$\searrow$	$\sin x$
$+$	2	$\searrow$	$-\cos x$
	0		$-\sin x$

Read the diagonals with signs:

$$\int x^2 \cos x \, dx = +x^2 \sin x - 2x(-\cos x) + 2(-\sin x) + C = x^2 \sin x + 2x \cos x - 2 \sin x + C.$$

The signs in the answer come from *two* sources – the alternating $\pm$ of the table and the minus signs that appear inside the I column as cos integrates to sin to $-\cos$. Write out both signs explicitly before simplifying so neither one gets dropped.

Common trap

Tabular integration in its simplest form requires the D column to terminate at 0 – that is, u must be a polynomial. If *neither* factor differentiates to zero (as with $\int e^x \cos x \, dx$, where both columns cycle indefinitely), the table does not terminate. An extended tabular method can be applied by stopping when a row reproduces the original integrand and solving algebraically, mirroring the recurring-integral method of Section 23.6.

23.8 Putting It All Together: A Harder Example

We conclude with an example that combines multiple integration techniques.

Example 23.11 ($\int x \arctan x \, dx$)**.** Two factors: algebraic x and inverse-trig $\arctan x$. LIATE places I above A, so $u = \arctan x$ and $dv = x \, dx$. Then

$$du = \frac{1}{1+x^2}\,dx, \qquad v = \frac{x^2}{2}.$$

Parts:

$$\int x \arctan x \, dx = \frac{x^2}{2}\arctan x - \frac{1}{2}\int \frac{x^2}{1+x^2}\,dx.$$

The leftover is a rational function. Do the polynomial-division trick: $\dfrac{x^2}{1+x^2} = 1 - \dfrac{1}{1+x^2}$. Hence

$$\int \frac{x^2}{1+x^2}\,dx = \int 1\,dx - \int \frac{1}{1+x^2}\,dx = x - \arctan x.$$

Assemble the final answer:

$$\int x \arctan x \, dx = \frac{x^2}{2}\arctan x - \frac{1}{2}\big(x - \arctan x\big) + C = \frac{x^2+1}{2}\arctan x - \frac{x}{2} + C.$$

Three techniques in one problem: parts to break it open, polynomial division to simplify the rational leftover, and the known antiderivative of $1/(1+x^2)$. This is what real integration looks like – a sequence of recognitions, each one turning the problem into a slightly easier problem until nothing is left.

Why this matters

Look at what happened to $\arctan x$ in Example 23.11: differentiating it traded a transcendental inverse-trig function for the purely algebraic fraction $\frac{1}{1+x^2}$, turning the remaining integral into elementary rational algebra. Whenever a function has an algebraic derivative – $\ln x$, $\arcsin x$, $\arctan x$ – integration by parts converts a transcendental integral into a rational or algebraic one.

Application

Integration by parts is used throughout mathematics, physics, and probability. In **probability**, the expected value of a nonnegative random variable can be rewritten as $E[X] =$

$\int_0^\infty (1-F(x))\,\mathrm{d}x$ by integrating $\int_0^\infty x f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ by parts – the boundary term and the survival function $1-F$ appear precisely because of the uv term. In **physics**, the entire framework of Lagrangian mechanics and field theory rests on "integrating by parts to move a derivative off the variation": the Euler–Lagrange equations come from doing exactly that to $\int \frac{\partial L}{\partial \dot{q}}\,\delta\dot{q}\,\mathrm{d}t$. In **signal processing**, every integration-by-parts shifts a derivative from one factor onto another, which is the seed of the theory of *distributions* (the "derivative" of a non-differentiable signal is *defined* by where parts would have moved it). In **numerical analysis**, repeated parts produces asymptotic expansions for integrals that are otherwise intractable. Learn the move well; you will meet it for the rest of your mathematical life.

23.9 Why It Works, One More Time

Here is the core idea plainly, stripped of all examples. Once you hold it you will never be confused about when to reach for parts.

Intuition

The one-sentence summary. Integration by parts moves a derivative from one factor of a product to the other, paying a boundary term uv for the move.

To see that, rewrite the formula with the differentials spelled out. Starting from $\int u\,v'\,\mathrm{d}x = uv - \int u'\,v\,\mathrm{d}x$, notice that on the left the prime (the derivative) sits on v, and on the right it sits on u. The two integrals

$$\int u\,v'\,\mathrm{d}x \quad\longleftrightarrow\quad \int u'\,v\,\mathrm{d}x$$

are the same product with the derivative *relocated* from one factor to the other, and the cost of relocation is the rectangle uv evaluated at the endpoints. You apply integration by parts whenever moving the derivative makes the integrand simpler:

- Move the derivative *onto* a polynomial repeatedly and it dies ($x^n \to \cdots \to 0$); the integral terminates. (This is tabular integration.)
- Move the derivative *off* a log or inverse-trig function and its ugly "no antiderivative" problem dissolves into a simple rational factor. (This is the $\int \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$ trick.)
- Move the derivative around a closed family like $\{e^x, \sin x, \cos x\}$ and it cycles back, letting you solve for the integral algebraically. (This is the recurring trick.)

Every example in this chapter is one of these three motions. The formula is one line; the judgment is in seeing which direction to push the derivative so the problem gets smaller.

Formal

Statement and proof, for the record. Let $u, v : [a,b] \to \mathbb{R}$ be continuous with continuous derivatives u', v' on $[a,b]$. Then uv is differentiable and, by the product rule, $(uv)' = u'v + uv'$, which is continuous. By the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus,

$$\Big[u(x)v(x)\Big]_a^b = \int_a^b (uv)'\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_a^b u'v\,\mathrm{d}x + \int_a^b uv'\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Rearranging gives the definite form $\int_a^b uv'\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[uv\Big]_a^b - \int_a^b u'v\,\mathrm{d}x$; dropping the limits and writing $\mathrm{d}v = v'\,\mathrm{d}x$, $\mathrm{d}u = u'\,\mathrm{d}x$ gives the indefinite form. The only hypothesis is that u' and v' are continuous so that the Fundamental Theorem applies – everything else is algebra. □

23.10 Limitations and next steps

Connection

Integration by parts succeeds when shifting the derivative produces a simpler integrand. For products like xe^x or $x\sin x$, differentiating the polynomial factor eventually reduces it to a constant. For solitary functions like $\ln x$ and $\arctan x$, choosing $\mathrm{d}v = \mathrm{d}x$ trades a transcendental function for an algebraic rational function.

However, parts has clear limitations:

1. *Non-simplifying products:* For integrals such as $\int \frac{e^x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$, differentiating $1/x$ produces higher negative powers ($-\int \frac{e^x}{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$), while integrating $1/x$ produces $\int e^x \ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$. Neither choice leads to an elementary antiderivative.
2. *Rational functions:* Integrands consisting of polynomial fractions, such as $\int \frac{x^3+5x-2}{x^4-16}\,\mathrm{d}x$, cannot be simplified effectively by parts.

To integrate rational functions systematically, Chapter 24 develops the method of *partial fractions*. By factoring the denominator, any rational function can be decomposed into simpler terms whose antiderivatives involve only logarithms and arctangents.

Exercises

Exercise 23.1 (Warm-ups)**.** Before putting pencil to paper, do a mental check on each part: identify which factor should be u, which should be $\mathrm{d}v$, and whether a single round will suffice. Then evaluate each indefinite integral, stating your choices clearly.

(a) $\displaystyle\int x\cos x\,\mathrm{d}x$

(b) $\displaystyle\int xe^{-x}\,\mathrm{d}x$

(c) $\displaystyle\int x\,\ln x\,\mathrm{d}x$

(d) $\displaystyle\int \arcsin x\,\mathrm{d}x$

Exercise 23.2 (Two rounds and tabular)**.** (a) Evaluate $\displaystyle\int x^2e^x\,\mathrm{d}x$ by applying parts twice.

(b) Now redo it with the tabular method and confirm you get the same answer.

(c) Use the tabular method to evaluate $\displaystyle\int x^3\sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Exercise 23.3 (Definite integrals)**.** Evaluate, simplifying fully:

(a) $\displaystyle\int_0^1 xe^x \,\mathrm{d}x$

(b) $\displaystyle\int_1^e x^2 \ln x \,\mathrm{d}x$

(c) $\displaystyle\int_0^\pi x \sin x \,\mathrm{d}x$

Exercise 23.4 (The recurring trick)**.** (a) Evaluate $\displaystyle\int e^x \sin x \,\mathrm{d}x$ by applying parts twice and solving for the integral. (Be consistent in your choice of u.)

(b) Evaluate $\displaystyle\int e^{2x} \cos(3x) \,\mathrm{d}x$ the same way.

(c) Explain in one or two sentences why choosing u inconsistently makes the method collapse to $0 = 0$.

Exercise 23.5 (Reduction formulas)**.** (a) Derive the reduction formula $\displaystyle\int (\ln x)^n \,\mathrm{d}x = x(\ln x)^n - n\int (\ln x)^{n-1} \,\mathrm{d}x$.

(b) Use it to evaluate $\displaystyle\int (\ln x)^2 \,\mathrm{d}x$.

(c) Derive the reduction formula $\displaystyle\int \cos^n x \,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{n}\cos^{n-1} x \,\sin x + \frac{n-1}{n}\int \cos^{n-2} x \,\mathrm{d}x$, mirroring the $\sin^n$ derivation in Example 23.7.

Exercise 23.6 (Combining with substitution)**.** Each of these needs a substitution *first*, then parts. Find them.

(a) $\displaystyle\int \cos(\sqrt{x}) \,\mathrm{d}x$ (try $w = \sqrt{x}$).

(b) $\displaystyle\int x^3 e^{x^2} \,\mathrm{d}x$ (try $w = x^2$, then parts).

(c) $\displaystyle\int \sin(\ln x) \,\mathrm{d}x$ (try $w = \ln x$, then the recurring trick).

Exercise 23.7 (Conceptual)**.** (a) A student integrates $\int xe^x \,\mathrm{d}x$ by choosing $u = e^x$, $\mathrm{d}v = x\,\mathrm{d}x$ and gets a *worse* integral. Explain, in terms of the two principles in Section 23.3, exactly what went wrong.

(b) Explain why $\int \sec x \,\mathrm{d}x$ cannot be cracked by the "$u = \sec x$, $\mathrm{d}v = \mathrm{d}x$" trick that worked for $\ln x$ and $\arctan x$. What is different about $\sec x$? (You do not have to evaluate it.)

(c) Why does the geometric "two ways of slicing a rectangle" proof in Section 23.2 require u and v to be monotonic, while the algebraic derivation does not?

Exercise 23.8 (A proof)**.** Prove the **Wallis recursion** for the definite integrals $W_n = \displaystyle\int_0^{\pi/2} \sin^n x \,\mathrm{d}x$: show that $W_n = \dfrac{n-1}{n} W_{n-2}$ for $n \geq 2$. Begin from the reduction formula in Example 23.7 and ex-

plain carefully why the boundary term $-\frac{1}{n}\sin^{n-1}x\cos x$ vanishes at *both* endpoints $x = 0$ and $x = \pi/2$. Then compute W_0 and W_1, and use the recursion to find W_4 and W_5.

Exercise 23.9 (Going further)**.** Use integration by parts to establish the reduction formula for powers of sec:

$$\int \sec^n x\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{\sec^{n-2}x\,\tan x}{n-1} + \frac{n-2}{n-1}\int \sec^{n-2}x\,\mathrm{d}x \qquad (n \geq 2).$$

Hint: write $\sec^n x = \sec^{n-2}x \cdot \sec^2 x$, let $\mathrm{d}v = \sec^2 x\,\mathrm{d}x$ (so $v = \tan x$), and use $\tan^2 x = \sec^2 x - 1$. You will need to solve for the recurring integral, just as in Section 23.6.

Chapter 24

Partial Fractions and Trigonometric Integrals

In the previous chapter, integration by parts showed us how to trade a stubborn product for a friendlier one by shifting derivatives across factors. Together with substitution, which runs the chain rule in reverse, it gave us two powerful ways to undo differentiation. And underneath both sits a single quiet idea that this chapter turns into an explicit strategy: *we almost never integrate the integrand we are handed.* We reshape it. We push and pull on it with algebra and trigonometry until it turns into something we already recognize – a power, a logarithm, an arctangent – and then we read off the answer.

That reshaping is the real subject here. We will meet two families of integrands that look hopeless at first and become routine once you know the trick. The first is *rational functions*, ratios of polynomials like $\dfrac{3x+5}{x^2-x-2}$. The cure is *partial fractions*: a way of breaking one ugly fraction into a sum of simple ones, each of which integrates to a logarithm or an arctangent. The second is integrals built from *powers and products of sines and cosines*, and then a beautiful move called *trigonometric substitution* that turns a stubborn algebraic expression like $\sqrt{a^2-x^2}$ into a clean trig expression by drawing a right triangle and reading off its sides.

Nothing in this chapter is new calculus: every integral we evaluate reduces to standard integrals you already know, using algebra and trigonometry to bridge the gap. One principle runs through all of it: **every method in this chapter reshapes the integrand into a known form.** Partial fractions reshapes a ratio into a sum of standard pieces. Trig identities reshape a product into a sum. Trig substitution reshapes a square root into a triangle. Completing the square reshapes a quadratic into a shifted square. Keep asking: *what known form am I steering toward?*

24.1 The Unifying Idea: Reshaping Into Known Forms

Let us name the small set of integrals we are allowed to treat as "known." Everything in this chapter lands on one of these.

Focus

The standard forms we steer toward (omitting $+C$ for brevity):

$$\int x^n\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{x^{n+1}}{n+1}\ (n \neq -1), \qquad \int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \ln|x|,$$

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2+a^2} = \frac{1}{a}\arctan\frac{x}{a}, \qquad \int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{a^2-x^2}} = \arcsin\frac{x}{a},$$

together with $\int e^x\,\mathrm{d}x = e^x$, $\int \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x = -\cos x$, $\int \cos x\,\mathrm{d}x = \sin x$, and whatever a single u-substitution can reach from these. *That is the entire target vocabulary.* Each technique below rewrites an unfamiliar integrand in terms of these few forms.

Why these particular forms? Because each is a derivative you have already computed and reversed. $\ln|x|$ is there because its derivative is $1/x$; the absolute value is there because ln is defined only for positive inputs, and $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\ln|x| = 1/x$ on both sides of zero. The arctangent is there because $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\arctan x = \dfrac{1}{1+x^2}$, and the a-flavored version is just that rule run through a substitution. The arcsine is there for the same reason with $\dfrac{1}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}$.

Intuition

Notice how small that target list is: powers, $1/x$, $1/(x^2+a^2)$, $1/\sqrt{a^2-x^2}$, exponentials, and basic sines and cosines. Faced with a complicated rational function or radical, we do not invent a new rule. We apply algebraic and trigonometric identities to break the integrand into a sum of those familiar pieces, then integrate term by term.

24.2 Rational Functions and the Promise of Partial Fractions

A *rational function* is a quotient of polynomials, $R(x) = P(x)/Q(x)$. We would like to integrate any such thing. Two of them are already easy:

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x-3} = \ln|x-3| + C, \qquad \int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{(x-3)^2} = -\frac{1}{x-3} + C.$$

Both are one substitution ($u = x-3$) away from a standard form. The trouble starts when the denominator factors into *several* different roots, all tangled together, as in

$$\int \frac{3x+5}{x^2-x-2}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The integrand as written is not any standard form. But watch what happens if we are clever. The denominator factors: $x^2 - x - 2 = (x-2)(x+1)$. Suppose, for a moment, that we could write

$$\frac{3x+5}{(x-2)(x+1)} = \frac{A}{x-2} + \frac{B}{x+1}$$

for some constants A and B. Then the integral would split into two pieces we *can* do:

$$\int \frac{A}{x-2}\,\mathrm{d}x + \int \frac{B}{x+1}\,\mathrm{d}x = A\ln|x-2| + B\ln|x+1| + C.$$

If every rational function can be decomposed into a sum of pieces like $\dfrac{A}{x-r}$ (and a couple of cousins we will meet), then integrating rational functions is finished: each piece is a logarithm or an arctangent, and we are done.

Focus

Partial fraction decomposition applies to any proper rational function $P(x)/Q(x)$, where the degree of the numerator is strictly smaller than the degree of the denominator (just like $3/5$, whose top is smaller than its bottom). It states that $P(x)/Q(x)$ can be written as a sum of "simple" fractions, one group for each factor of $Q(x)$. It converts an integral you cannot see into a sum of integrals you can.

Two things must be checked before we trust this. Can we always *find* the constants A, B? And, deeper, does the decomposition always *exist*? We find the constants first – it is satisfying and quick – and then come back and prove the decomposition is guaranteed, because understanding *why it exists* is more illuminating than any single computation.

24.2.1 Finding the constants

Start from the proposed identity and clear the denominator by multiplying both sides by $(x-2)(x+1)$:

$$3x+5 \;=\; A(x+1)+B(x-2).$$

This must hold for *every* x. That gives us freedom: we can plug in any x we like and squeeze out the constants. The smart choices are the values that kill a factor.

Set $x=2$: the B term dies, leaving $3(2)+5=A(2+1)$, so $11=3A$ and $A=\frac{11}{3}$.

Set $x=-1$: the A term dies, leaving $3(-1)+5=B(-1-2)$, so $2=-3B$ and $B=-\frac{2}{3}$.

Intuition

This trick of plugging in the root is sometimes called the "cover-up" method, and it has a clean meaning. To find the coefficient sitting over $(x-2)$, you cover up that factor in the original denominator and evaluate what is left at $x=2$:

$$A=\left.\frac{3x+5}{x+1}\right|_{x=2}=\frac{11}{3},\qquad B=\left.\frac{3x+5}{x-2}\right|_{x=-1}=\frac{2}{-3}=-\frac{2}{3}.$$

Why does covering up work? Multiplying by $(x-2)$ removes that factor from the denominator, and then setting $x=2$ makes every *other* term vanish, because each of them still carries a factor of $(x-2)$. You are isolating one coefficient by evaluating at the precise point where its neighbors disappear.

So the decomposition is

$$\frac{3x+5}{(x-2)(x+1)}=\frac{11/3}{x-2}-\frac{2/3}{x+1},$$

and the integral falls out:

$$\int\frac{3x+5}{x^2-x-2}\,\mathrm{d}x=\frac{11}{3}\ln|x-2|-\frac{2}{3}\ln|x+1|+C.$$

Work it yourself

Check the decomposition without integrating. Put $\dfrac{11/3}{x-2} - \dfrac{2/3}{x+1}$ over the common denominator $(x-2)(x+1)$. The numerator is $\frac{11}{3}(x+1) - \frac{2}{3}(x-2) = \frac{11}{3}x + \frac{11}{3} - \frac{2}{3}x + \frac{4}{3} = 3x+5$. It matches. The algebra of putting fractions over a common denominator is exactly what partial fractions *undoes*; that is why a check is just running the machine forward.

24.2.2 Why the decomposition must exist

It is one thing to find A and B when they are promised to be there. It is another to know they are *always* there, for any denominator. Proving that this decomposition always works is short, concrete, and explains why the cover-up method succeeds.

Why the technique works

Here is the mechanism, in the cleanest case where the denominator $Q(x) = (x-r_1)(x-r_2)\cdots(x-r_n)$ has n *distinct* real roots and the numerator P has degree less than n. We claim

$$\frac{P(x)}{Q(x)} = \frac{A_1}{x-r_1} + \frac{A_2}{x-r_2} + \cdots + \frac{A_n}{x-r_n}$$

for some constants. Why *must* such constants exist?
It comes down to counting. Clearing denominators turns the claim into

$$P(x) = A_1\,\frac{Q(x)}{x-r_1} + A_2\,\frac{Q(x)}{x-r_2} + \cdots + A_n\,\frac{Q(x)}{x-r_n}.$$

Each $\dfrac{Q(x)}{x-r_k}$ is a polynomial of degree $n-1$. The right side is a combination of n such polynomials, and as we vary the A_k it ranges over some subspace of the polynomials of degree $\le n-1$. That space has dimension n (the coefficients of $1, x, \ldots, x^{n-1}$). We have n knobs A_k and n coefficients to match – a square system. So the question is only whether those n building blocks $\dfrac{Q(x)}{x-r_k}$ are *linearly independent* – meaning no block can be formed as a combination of the others, so each provides a genuinely new direction of freedom; if they are, they span everything of degree $\le n-1$, and *every* valid P can be hit.

They are independent, and the cover-up trick proves it. Suppose a combination $\sum_k c_k \dfrac{Q(x)}{x-r_k}$ is the zero polynomial. Evaluate at $x = r_j$. Every term with $k \neq j$ still contains the factor $(x-r_j)$ and so vanishes there; the surviving $k=j$ term equals $c_j \prod_{m\neq j}(r_j - r_m)$, a product of nonzero numbers (the roots are distinct). For the whole thing to be zero we need $c_j = 0$. This holds for every j, so all coefficients are zero: the building blocks are independent. A square system with independent columns has exactly one solution for any right-hand side. **The decomposition exists, and it is unique.**

Notice that this proof also explains why the cover-up method works: the root evaluation $x = r_j$ that isolates A_j is the same evaluation that shows the building blocks cannot cancel each other.

Connection

This is a direct application of finite-dimensional linear algebra: n linearly independent vectors in an n-dimensional vector space form a basis and span the entire space. Partial fractions is one of many places in calculus where a dimension-counting argument guarantees that a desired representation exists before computing its coefficients – just as matching $n+1$ derivative conditions determines a unique Taylor polynomial of degree n, or $n+1$ data points determine a unique interpolating polynomial of degree at most n.

History

In 1702, writing in *Acta Eruditorum*, Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz considered whether every rational function could be integrated into logarithms and arctangents. He believed he had found a counterexample in the fraction

$$\frac{1}{x^4+1}.$$

Factoring over the complex numbers gives $(x^2+i)(x^2-i)$. Because $\pm i$ are imaginary, Leibniz argued that these factors could not be combined into real quadratic polynomials, concluding that x^4+1 could not be factored over the reals and that its integral could not be expressed with real logarithms or arctangents.

The flaw in Leibniz's reasoning is that complex roots of real polynomials occur in conjugate pairs, which multiply together to form real quadratics. In 1719 Nicolaus Bernoulli exhibited the real factorization explicitly:

$$x^4+1 = (x^2+1)^2 - 2x^2 = (x^2+\sqrt{2}x+1)(x^2-\sqrt{2}x+1),$$

and Leonhard Euler's 1748 *Introductio* developed the conjugate-pairing principle in general. Both quadratic factors are real, and $\int \frac{dx}{x^4+1}$ splits into standard partial fractions. The general principle was established in 1799, when Carl Friedrich Gauss proved the Fundamental Theorem of Algebra: every real polynomial factors completely into real linear and real irreducible quadratic factors.

24.3 The Four Cases of Partial Fractions

To decompose *any* proper rational function you handle the denominator's factors one type at a time. Real-coefficient polynomials factor completely into linear factors $(x-r)$ and irreducible quadratics (x^2+px+q) (those with no real root), each possibly repeated. That gives exactly four kinds of pieces.

Focus

The setup rules. First make the fraction *proper* (numerator degree $<$ denominator degree) by long division if needed. Then for each factor of $Q(x)$, add terms:

- Distinct linear factor $(x-r)$: one term $\dfrac{A}{x-r}$.

- Repeated linear factor $(x-r)^m$: a full tower $\dfrac{A_1}{x-r}+\dfrac{A_2}{(x-r)^2}+\cdots+\dfrac{A_m}{(x-r)^m}$.
- Distinct irreducible quadratic (x^2+px+q): one term $\dfrac{Bx+C}{x^2+px+q}$ (a linear numerator, because the denominator is degree two).
- Repeated irreducible quadratic $(x^2+px+q)^m$: a tower $\dfrac{B_1x+C_1}{x^2+px+q}+\cdots+\dfrac{B_mx+C_m}{(x^2+px+q)^m}$.

The rule about repeated factors deserves a word of intuition, because students forget the lower powers.

Intuition

Why must $(x-r)^3$ contribute three terms, $\dfrac{A_1}{x-r}+\dfrac{A_2}{(x-r)^2}+\dfrac{A_3}{(x-r)^3}$, and not just the top one? Because you need enough freedom. A general numerator over $(x-r)^3$ can be *any* quadratic $a+b(x-r)+c(x-r)^2$ near $x=r$. Dividing that by $(x-r)^3$ gives exactly $\dfrac{a}{(x-r)^3}+\dfrac{b}{(x-r)^2}+\dfrac{c}{x-r}$. The three terms are the three coefficients of that local quadratic. Drop any one and you lose a degree of freedom you might need to match the original numerator.

24.3.1 Why a quadratic factor gets a linear numerator

Over an irreducible quadratic the numerator is $Bx+C$, not just a constant. The reason is the same counting principle: a piece $\dfrac{N(x)}{x^2+px+q}$ is "proper" as long as $\deg N<2$, so the most general allowed numerator has *two* free constants, B and C. Using only a constant would throw away half the freedom and the system would have no solution in general.

Common trap

The three classic errors:

1. Forgetting to do long division first when the fraction is *improper*. $\dfrac{x^3}{x^2-1}$ is not proper; you must divide to get $x+\dfrac{x}{x^2-1}$ before decomposing.
2. Writing only $\dfrac{A}{(x-r)^m}$ for a repeated factor and omitting the lower powers. The tower must be complete.
3. Putting a constant A over an irreducible quadratic instead of $Bx+C$.

Each of these makes the linear system unsolvable – a useful early warning: if your constants come out inconsistent, suspect a malformed setup.

Pause

Pause and predict. Look at $\dfrac{2x+5}{(x-3)(x^2+1)}$. Before touching any algebra: how many unknown constants will you need to solve for, and what species of functions will appear in the final antiderivative? The denominator degree is $1+2=3$, so you need three constants (A over $x-3$, and $Bx+C$ over x^2+1). The linear factor will produce a logarithm $\ln|x-3|$; the irreducible quadratic will split into a logarithm $\ln(x^2+1)$ and an arctangent $\arctan x$. Predicting the final shape before starting keeps you oriented throughout the algebra.

24.3.2 Worked example: a repeated linear factor

Example 24.1 (Repeated root)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{x+4}{(x-1)^2(x+2)}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The denominator has a repeated factor $(x-1)^2$ and a single factor $(x+2)$, so the setup is

$$\frac{x+4}{(x-1)^2(x+2)} = \frac{A}{x-1} + \frac{B}{(x-1)^2} + \frac{D}{x+2}.$$

Clear denominators:

$$x+4 = A(x-1)(x+2) + B(x+2) + D(x-1)^2.$$

Use the cover-up values for the easy constants. Set $x=1$: $1+4=B(3)$, so $B=\frac{5}{3}$. Set $x=-2$: $-2+4=D(-3)^2$, so $2=9D$ and $D=\frac{2}{9}$. The constant A has no root to cover up (it sits over the *first* power of a repeated factor), so match one more coefficient. The x^2 coefficient on the left is 0; on the right it is $A+D$. Hence $A=-D=-\frac{2}{9}$.

So

$$\frac{x+4}{(x-1)^2(x+2)} = \frac{-2/9}{x-1} + \frac{5/3}{(x-1)^2} + \frac{2/9}{x+2},$$

and integrating term by term,

$$\int \frac{x+4}{(x-1)^2(x+2)}\,\mathrm{d}x = -\frac{2}{9}\ln|x-1| - \frac{5}{3(x-1)} + \frac{2}{9}\ln|x+2| + C.$$

Notice the middle term: the integral of $1/(x-1)^2$ is $-1/(x-1)$, a power, not a logarithm. Repeated factors produce these non-log pieces, which is exactly why their tower matters.

24.3.3 Worked example: an irreducible quadratic

Example 24.2 (Quadratic factor)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{2x^2-x+4}{x(x^2+4)}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Set up with a linear numerator over the quadratic:

$$\frac{2x^2-x+4}{x(x^2+4)} = \frac{A}{x} + \frac{Bx+C}{x^2+4}.$$

Clear denominators: $2x^2 - x + 4 = A(x^2+4) + (Bx + C)x$. Set $x = 0$: $4 = 4A$, so $A = 1$. Match x^2: $2 = A + B$, so $B = 1$. Match x^1: $-1 = C$. Thus

$$\frac{2x^2 - x + 4}{x(x^2+4)} = \frac{1}{x} + \frac{x-1}{x^2+4}.$$

Now integrate. The first piece is a logarithm. The second piece we *split* into a part whose numerator is the derivative of the denominator and a leftover:

$$\int \frac{x-1}{x^2+4}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int \frac{x}{x^2+4}\,\mathrm{d}x - \int \frac{1}{x^2+4}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

For the first, $u = x^2 + 4$, $\mathrm{d}u = 2x\,\mathrm{d}x$, giving $\frac{1}{2}\ln(x^2+4)$. The second is a standard arctangent with $a = 2$: $\frac{1}{2}\arctan(x/2)$. Altogether,

$$\int \frac{2x^2 - x + 4}{x(x^2+4)}\,\mathrm{d}x = \ln|x| + \frac{1}{2}\ln(x^2+4) - \frac{1}{2}\arctan\frac{x}{2} + C.$$

What is really happening

Look at what the quadratic piece actually became: *a logarithm plus an arctangent.* This is the universal fate of an irreducible-quadratic term, and there is a reason. The Bx part of the numerator, after you arrange it to be a multiple of the denominator's derivative $2x$, integrates to $\ln(x^2+4)$ – that is substitution. The leftover constant part has no x on top, so it has nothing to substitute and instead lands on the arctangent form. Every irreducible quadratic splits its numerator into a "derivative-of-denominator" half (a log) and a "pure constant" half (an arctangent). Once you see this split you can integrate any quadratic term on autopilot.

24.3.4 Worked example: improper, needing division first

Example 24.3 (Improper fraction)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{x^3}{x^2-1}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

The numerator degree (3) exceeds the denominator degree (2), so do polynomial long division first: $x^3 = x(x^2-1) + x$, hence

$$\frac{x^3}{x^2-1} = x + \frac{x}{x^2-1}.$$

The leftover $\dfrac{x}{x^2-1} = \dfrac{x}{(x-1)(x+1)}$ decomposes as $\dfrac{1/2}{x-1} + \dfrac{1/2}{x+1}$ (cover-up: at $x = 1$, $\frac{1}{2}$; at $x = -1$, $\frac{-1}{-2} = \frac{1}{2}$). So

$$\int \frac{x^3}{x^2-1}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{1}{2}\ln|x-1| + \frac{1}{2}\ln|x+1| + C = \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{1}{2}\ln|x^2-1| + C.$$

Walking question

On your walk, picture why long division is unavoidable. A proper fraction P/Q with $\deg P < \deg Q$ shrinks toward 0 as $x \to \infty$. But $x^3/(x^2-1) \approx x$ for large x – it grows without bound. No sum of pieces like $\dfrac{A}{x-r}$ (each shrinking to zero) could ever reproduce that growth. The division peels off the polynomial part x that carries the growth, leaving a genuinely proper remainder for the fractions to handle. The methods only work on the part of the function that actually decays.

24.3.5 The shape of the picture

It helps to *see* a decomposition. Below, the rational function $\dfrac{3x+5}{(x-2)(x+1)}$ from earlier is drawn together with its two simple pieces. Near each vertical asymptote, one piece dominates and the other is nearly flat: near $x = 2$ the curve behaves like $\frac{11/3}{x-2}$, and near $x = -1$ it behaves like $-\frac{2/3}{x+1}$.

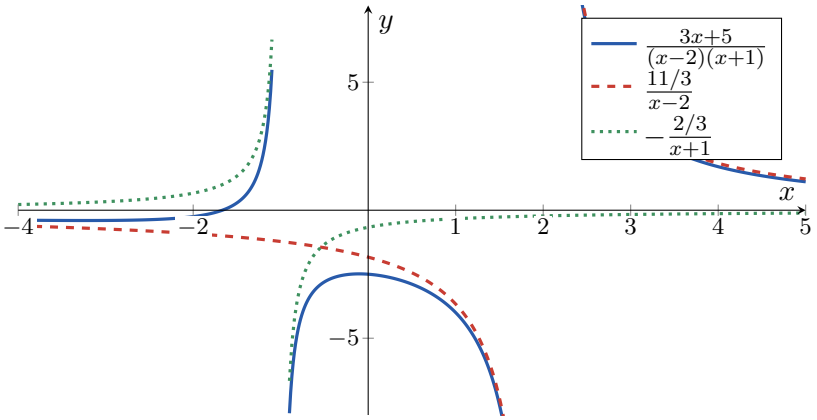


Figure 24.1: A rational function (solid) and its two partial-fraction pieces (dashed, dotted). Each piece controls the behavior near its own asymptote; the sum reproduces the original everywhere.

24.4 Trigonometric Integrals: Powers and Products

We turn now to integrals built from powers and products of sines and cosines, such as $\int \sin^5 x\,dx$, $\int \sin^2 x \cos^2 x\,dx$, or $\int \sin 3x \cos 5x\,dx$. None is a standard form as written. But every one yields to the same move: *use a trig identity to reshape the integrand into something a substitution can finish.* There is no new calculus, only the Pythagorean identity, the double-angle formulas, and the product-to-sum formulas, deployed cleverly.

24.4.1 Odd powers: peel off one factor

Example 24.4 (Odd power of sine)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \sin^5 x\,dx$.

There is an *odd* number of sines, so peel one off and convert the rest to cosines using $\sin^2 x = 1-\cos^2 x$. The lone sine becomes the $\mathrm{d}u$ for $u = \cos x$.

$$\int \sin^5 x\,\mathrm{d}x = \int (\sin^2 x)^2 \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x = \int (1-\cos^2 x)^2 \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Substitute $u = \cos x$, $\mathrm{d}u = -\sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$:

$$= -\int (1-u^2)^2\,\mathrm{d}u = -\int (1-2u^2+u^4)\,\mathrm{d}u = -\left(u - \tfrac{2}{3}u^3 + \tfrac{1}{5}u^5\right) + C.$$

Back-substitute $u = \cos x$:

$$\int \sin^5 x\,\mathrm{d}x = -\cos x + \frac{2}{3}\cos^3 x - \frac{1}{5}\cos^5 x + C.$$

Why the technique works

Why does peeling one factor work, and why does it need an *odd* power? Substitution $u = \cos x$ needs $\mathrm{d}u = -\sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$ – it consumes exactly *one* sine. After spending that one, the remaining sines must be expressible in $u = \cos x$, and $\sin^2 x = 1 - \cos^2 x$ does that perfectly because it only ever uses sine in *even* amounts. So you need one sine to spend on $\mathrm{d}u$ and an even number left over to convert: total odd. If the power were even, you would have a leftover lone sine with nothing to pair it with, and the substitution stalls. Odd powers are easy precisely because they split as "one for $\mathrm{d}u$, the rest even."

The same trick handles odd powers of cosine (peel one cosine, set $u = \sin x$) and mixed products $\int \sin^m x \cos^n x\,\mathrm{d}x$ *whenever at least one of* m, n *is odd*: peel one factor off the odd one, convert the rest, substitute for the other function.

Example 24.5 (Mixed product, one odd power)**.** $\int \sin^2 x \cos^3 x\,\mathrm{d}x$. The cosine power is odd. Peel one cosine, convert the rest with $\cos^2 x = 1 - \sin^2 x$, set $u = \sin x$:

$$\int \sin^2 x(1-\sin^2 x)\cos x\,\mathrm{d}x = \int u^2(1-u^2)\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{u^3}{3} - \frac{u^5}{5} = \frac{\sin^3 x}{3} - \frac{\sin^5 x}{5} + C.$$

Pause

Pause and predict. What is the definite integral $\int_0^{2\pi} \sin^7 x\,\mathrm{d}x$? Before reaching for pencil and paper: sine oscillates symmetrically above and below zero. Every positive peak on $[0, \pi]$ is matched by an identical negative trough on $[\pi, 2\pi]$. Raising sine to an odd power preserves this sign reversal ($(-y)^7 = -y^7$), so the two halves cancel completely: the integral is 0 by pure symmetry.

24.4.2 Even powers: the half-angle slowdown

When *both* powers are even, the peel-one trick fails – there is no spare factor to serve as $\mathrm{d}u$. Instead we step the exponent down with the power-reduction (or half-angle) identities – so named because x is half of the doubled angle $2x$:

$$\sin^2 x = \frac{1-\cos 2x}{2}, \qquad \cos^2 x = \frac{1+\cos 2x}{2}.$$

Each application trades a squared sine or cosine for a first-power cosine of double the angle: the exponent drops, in exchange for a doubled frequency. Repeat until nothing is squared.

Example 24.6 (Even power)**.** Integrate $\int \sin^2 x \, dx$.

$$\int \sin^2 x \, dx = \int \frac{1 - \cos 2x}{2} \, dx = \frac{1}{2}\Big(x - \frac{\sin 2x}{2}\Big) + C = \frac{x}{2} - \frac{\sin 2x}{4} + C.$$

Intuition

There is a sanity check hiding here. The average value of $\sin^2 x$ over a full period is $\frac{1}{2}$ – because $\sin^2 + \cos^2 = 1$ and, by symmetry, $\sin^2$ and $\cos^2$ have the same average, so each must average $\frac{1}{2}$. Our antiderivative $\frac{x}{2} - \frac{\sin 2x}{4}$ grows like $\frac{x}{2}$ with a small wobble on top, so over a period it accumulates exactly $\frac{1}{2} \cdot (\text{length})$. The formula encodes the average. This "$\sin^2$ averages to a half" fact is the reason the RMS of an alternating current is the peak over $\sqrt{2}$.

Example 24.7 (Both even)**.** Integrate $\int \sin^2 x \cos^2 x \, dx$. The slick route uses the double-angle identity $\sin x \cos x = \frac{1}{2} \sin 2x$, so $\sin^2 x \cos^2 x = \frac{1}{4} \sin^2 2x$. Then half-angle again on $\sin^2 2x$:

$$\int \tfrac{1}{4} \sin^2 2x \, dx = \frac{1}{4} \int \frac{1 - \cos 4x}{2} \, dx = \frac{x}{8} - \frac{\sin 4x}{32} + C.$$

24.4.3 Products of different frequencies

For $\int \sin(mx) \cos(nx) \, dx$ with $m \neq n$ there are no powers at all, just a product of two waves at different frequencies. The reshaping tool is the *product-to-sum* identities:

$$\sin A \cos B = \tfrac{1}{2}\big[\sin(A + B) + \sin(A - B)\big],$$

and its siblings for $\cos A \cos B$ and $\sin A \sin B$. A product of two waves becomes a *sum* of two waves, and a sum is trivial to integrate.

Example 24.8. $\displaystyle\int \sin 3x \cos 5x \, dx = \frac{1}{2} \int \big[\sin 8x + \sin(-2x)\big] \, dx = -\frac{\cos 8x}{16} + \frac{\cos 2x}{4} + C.$

Connection

These product-to-sum integrals are the computational core of **Fourier series** – the decomposition of an arbitrary wave into a sum of pure harmonic sines and cosines. The reason you can extract the "amount of frequency n" inside a signal is that $\int_0^{2\pi} \sin(mx) \sin(nx) \, dx = 0$ whenever $m \neq n$ and equals π when $m = n$. Two functions are called *orthogonal* when their product integrates to zero over a full period, just as two perpendicular vectors have dot product zero. That orthogonality follows directly from the product-to-sum identities above: distinct frequencies multiply into oscillating waves that average to zero over a cycle, whereas identical frequencies multiply into a squared wave with average $\frac{1}{2}$. Every time you stream music, compress audio, or filter signals, this integral is doing the work.

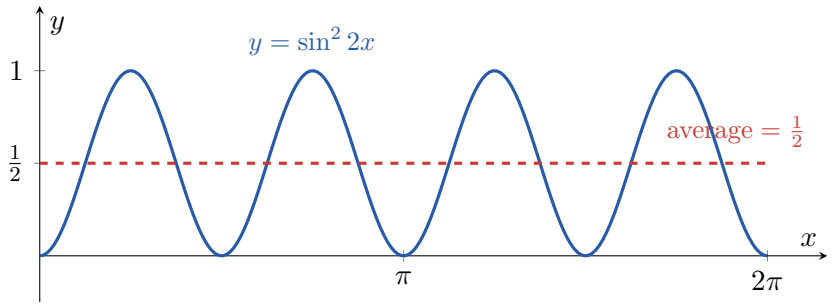


Figure 24.2: A squared sine oscillates between 0 and 1 but spends its time symmetrically, averaging $\frac{1}{2}$. The half-angle identity $\sin^2 2x = \frac{1-\cos 4x}{2}$ makes this visible: a constant $\frac{1}{2}$ plus a zero-average wobble.

24.5 Completing the Square: Taming Any Quadratic

Before trig substitution we need one small, powerful algebraic move. Many integrals hide a quadratic in the denominator or under a root that is not quite a standard form, like

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2 + 4x + 13}.$$

The denominator is not $x^2 + a^2$, so the arctangent form does not apply directly. But *completing the square* reshapes any quadratic into a perfect square plus (or minus) a constant:

$$x^2 + 4x + 13 = (x^2 + 4x + 4) + 9 = (x + 2)^2 + 9 = (x + 2)^2 + 3^2.$$

Now substitute $u = x + 2$ (a pure shift, $\mathrm{d}u = \mathrm{d}x$) and it *is* the arctangent form with $a = 3$:

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{(x + 2)^2 + 3^2} = \frac{1}{3} \arctan \frac{x + 2}{3} + C.$$

What is really happening

Completing the square amounts geometrically to a *horizontal shift*. The graph of $y = x^2 + 4x + 13$ is the parabola $y = x^2 + 9$ shifted two units to the left (Figure 24.3). The substitution $u = x + 2$ slides our coordinate system to sit at the bottom of the parabola, where the quadratic is symmetric: $u^2 + 9$. Every quadratic is a standard parabola shifted horizontally and vertically; completing the square determines the shift, and the substitution undoes it. Once centered, the integrand matches the standard arctangent form.

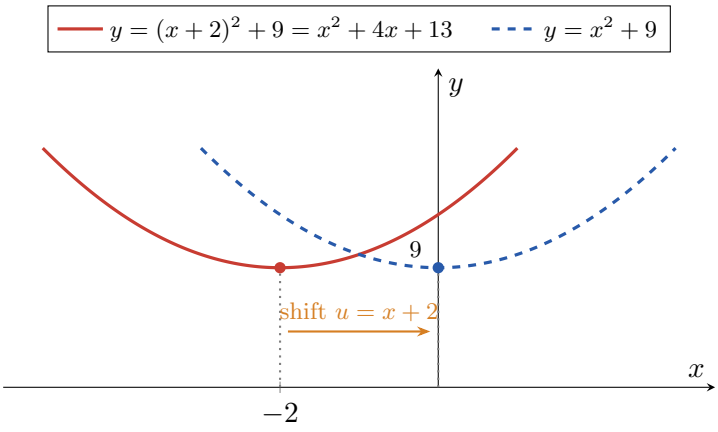


Figure 24.3: Completing the square reveals the hidden symmetry of a quadratic. The parabola $y = x^2 + 4x + 13$ (solid) is identical to the centered parabola $y = x^2 + 9$ (dashed), shifted two units to the left. The linear substitution $u = x + 2$ recenters the origin at the vertex, turning the un-factored quadratic into the standard sum of squares $u^2 + 3^2$.

Example 24.9 (Linear numerator over a completed square)**.** $\displaystyle\int \frac{x+1}{x^2+4x+13}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Split the numerator into a multiple of the denominator's derivative $2x+4$ plus a leftover constant: $x+1 = \frac{1}{2}(2x+4) - 1$. Then

$$\int \frac{x+1}{x^2+4x+13}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\int \frac{2x+4}{x^2+4x+13}\,\mathrm{d}x - \int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2+4x+13}.$$

The first integral is $\frac{1}{2}\ln(x^2+4x+13)$ by substitution; the second is the arctangent we just did. So the answer is

$$\frac{1}{2}\ln(x^2+4x+13) - \frac{1}{3}\arctan\frac{x+2}{3} + C.$$

This "log half plus arctangent half" split is the same one from the partial fractions section – another sign that all these techniques are one idea.

24.6 Trigonometric Substitution: Algebra Becomes Geometry

The last technique is the most geometric one in the chapter. Integrals containing $\sqrt{a^2 - x^2}$, $\sqrt{a^2 + x^2}$, or $\sqrt{x^2 - a^2}$ resist ordinary substitution because the square root has no convenient derivative hiding in the integrand. The escape is to *change variables so that the expression under the root becomes a perfect square*, using the Pythagorean identities. And the cleanest way to see which substitution to use, and how to get back, is to *draw a right triangle*.

24.6.1 The idea on a triangle

Consider $\sqrt{a^2 - x^2}$. The relation $a^2 = x^2 + (\sqrt{a^2 - x^2})^2$ is the Pythagorean theorem: a is a hypotenuse, x and $\sqrt{a^2 - x^2}$ are the two legs. So *draw* that triangle and let θ be the angle whose *opposite leg* is x:

$$\sin\theta = \frac{x}{a} \implies x = a\sin\theta, \qquad \sqrt{a^2 - x^2} = a\cos\theta.$$

To make the substitution reversible, we restrict θ to the principal interval $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$. On this interval, cosine is always nonnegative, so $\sqrt{\cos^2\theta} = |\cos\theta| = \cos\theta$ – no absolute-value sign needed.

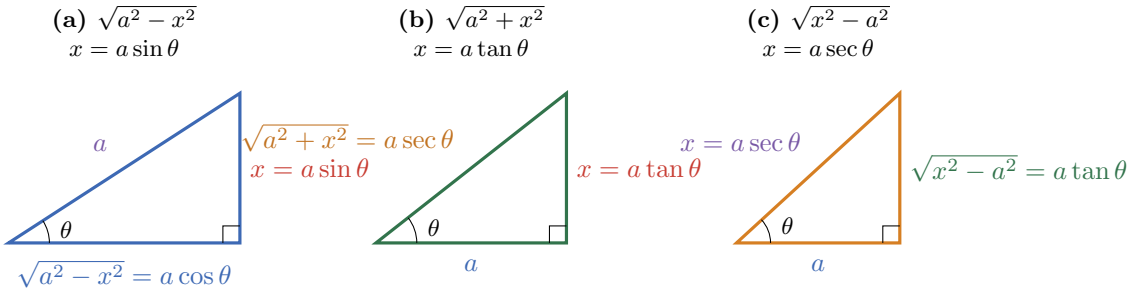


Figure 24.4: The three canonical right-triangle substitutions. Each substitution is engineered so the Pythagorean theorem collapses the square root to a single trigonometric function: **(a)** $x = a\sin\theta$ yields $a^2 - x^2 = a^2\cos^2\theta$; **(b)** $x = a\tan\theta$ yields $a^2 + x^2 = a^2\sec^2\theta$; **(c)** $x = a\sec\theta$ yields $x^2 - a^2 = a^2\tan^2\theta$. Reading the triangle's ratios translates any trig expression of θ back to x.

The reference triangle tracks the relationships among the sides. It tells you the substitution ($x = a\sin\theta$), it tells you $\mathrm{d}x = a\cos\theta\,\mathrm{d}\theta$, it converts the root to $a\cos\theta$, and most importantly, it tells you how to convert the *answer* back to x at the end, because every trig function of θ is just a ratio of the triangle's sides.

Focus

The three triangles.

- $\sqrt{a^2 - x^2}$: set $x = a\sin\theta$, so the root becomes $a\cos\theta$ (using $\sin^2\theta + \cos^2\theta = 1$).
- $\sqrt{a^2 + x^2}$: set $x = a\tan\theta$ with $\theta \in (-\pi/2, \pi/2)$, so $\sec\theta > 0$ and the root becomes $a\sec\theta$ (using $1 + \tan^2\theta = \sec^2\theta$).
- $\sqrt{x^2 - a^2}$: for $x \geq a$, set $x = a\sec\theta$ with $\theta \in [0, \pi/2)$, so $\tan\theta \geq 0$ and the root becomes $a\tan\theta$ (using $\sec^2\theta - 1 = \tan^2\theta$; for $x \leq -a$, check the sign of $\tan\theta$).

In each case the substitution is the one that makes a Pythagorean identity collapse the root into a single trig function. Draw the triangle and you never have to memorize which is which.

Why the technique works

Why does turning x into a trig function help at all? Because the obstacle is the square root, and a square root vanishes only when its inside is a perfect square. The Pythagorean identities are precisely the algebraic statements that $a^2 - (a\sin\theta)^2$, $a^2 + (a\tan\theta)^2$, and $(a\sec\theta)^2 - a^2$ are each a perfect square ($a^2\cos^2\theta$, $a^2\sec^2\theta$, $a^2\tan^2\theta$). Trig substitution is the deliberate choice of a new variable engineered so that the thing under the root becomes a square and the root opens up cleanly. It is substitution aimed by geometry.

24.6.2 Worked example: the area of a circle, recovered

Example 24.10 (Root of $a^2 - x^2$)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \sqrt{a^2 - x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

This integrand is the height of a circle of radius a, so the integral is a circular area (Figure 24.5); watch the geometry fall out of the algebra. Use the triangle: $x = a\sin\theta$, $\mathrm{d}x = a\cos\theta\,\mathrm{d}\theta$, and $\sqrt{a^2 - x^2} = a\cos\theta$. The integral becomes pure trig:

$$\int a\cos\theta \cdot a\cos\theta\,\mathrm{d}\theta = a^2\int \cos^2\theta\,\mathrm{d}\theta = a^2\Big(\frac{\theta}{2} + \frac{\sin 2\theta}{4}\Big) + C,$$

using the even-power technique from before. Now convert back via the triangle. From $\sin\theta = x/a$ we get $\theta = \arcsin(x/a)$, and $\sin 2\theta = 2\sin\theta\cos\theta = 2\cdot\dfrac{x}{a}\cdot\dfrac{\sqrt{a^2-x^2}}{a} = \dfrac{2x\sqrt{a^2-x^2}}{a^2}$. Therefore

$$\int \sqrt{a^2 - x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{a^2}{2}\arcsin\frac{x}{a} + \frac{x}{2}\sqrt{a^2 - x^2} + C.$$

Why this matters

Test this on a whole circle. The area inside $x^2 + y^2 = a^2$ is four times the area under $y = \sqrt{a^2 - x^2}$ from 0 to a:

$$4\int_0^a \sqrt{a^2 - x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = 4\left[\frac{a^2}{2}\arcsin\frac{x}{a} + \frac{x}{2}\sqrt{a^2 - x^2}\right]_0^a.$$

At $x = a$: $\arcsin 1 = \frac{\pi}{2}$ and the square-root term is 0. At $x = 0$: everything is 0. So the area is $4\cdot\dfrac{a^2}{2}\cdot\dfrac{\pi}{2} = \pi a^2$. The most famous formula in geometry falls out of a triangle substitution. The arcsin that appears is *the angle*, and integrating around the circle is literally accumulating that angle.

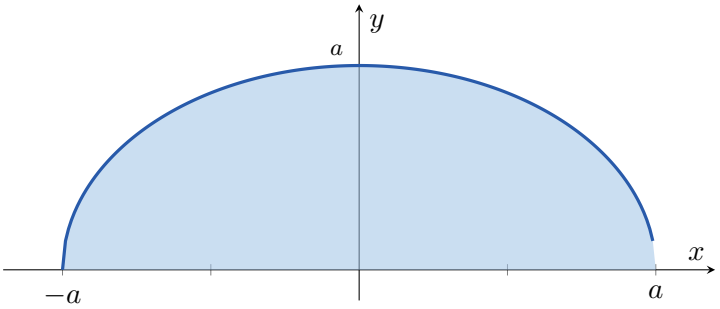


Figure 24.5: The integral $\int_{-a}^{a}\sqrt{a^2 - x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the shaded area under the upper semicircle of radius a (here $a = 2$). The trig-substitution antiderivative evaluates it to $\frac{\pi a^2}{2}$, the half-disc area; double it (or take four quarters, as in the box above) and the full πa^2 appears.

24.6.3 Worked example: a secant integral via the tangent triangle

Example 24.11 (Root of $a^2 + x^2$)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x^2 + 9}}$.

Here $a = 3$ and the root is $\sqrt{a^2 + x^2}$, so we use the tangent triangle with $\theta \in (-\pi/2, \pi/2)$: $x = 3\tan\theta$,

$dx = 3\sec^2\theta\,d\theta$, and $\sqrt{x^2+9} = 3\sec\theta$. The integral simplifies to

$$\int \frac{3\sec^2\theta}{3\sec\theta}\,d\theta = \int \sec\theta\,d\theta.$$

To evaluate $\int \sec\theta\,d\theta$, multiply top and bottom by $\sec\theta+\tan\theta$. The new numerator $\sec^2\theta+\sec\theta\tan\theta$ is exactly the derivative of the new denominator $w = \sec\theta+\tan\theta$, so the $\int \frac{dw}{w}$ pattern finishes it:

$$\int \sec\theta\,d\theta = \int \frac{\sec^2\theta+\sec\theta\tan\theta}{\sec\theta+\tan\theta}\,d\theta = \ln|\sec\theta+\tan\theta| + C.$$

Convert back with the triangle. With opposite $= x$, adjacent $= 3$, hypotenuse $= \sqrt{x^2+9}$, we have $\tan\theta = x/3$ and $\sec\theta = \sqrt{x^2+9}/3$. So

$$\int \frac{dx}{\sqrt{x^2+9}} = \ln\left|\frac{\sqrt{x^2+9}}{3} + \frac{x}{3}\right| + C = \ln\left|x+\sqrt{x^2+9}\right| + C',$$

absorbing the constant $-\ln 3$ into C'. (This is also $\operatorname{arcsinh}(x/3)$ up to a constant – the inverse hyperbolic sine – which is no coincidence: hyperbolic functions parametrize $\sqrt{x^2+a^2}$ the way circular ones parametrize $\sqrt{a^2-x^2}$.)

Common trap

The single most forgotten step in trig substitution is **converting back to** x. Your answer must be a function of the original variable; an answer left in θ is unfinished. Always draw the triangle, label its three sides from the substitution, and read off whatever trig functions appear in your antiderivative as ratios of those sides. The triangle is your dictionary back to x.

A second trap: when the integral is *definite*, you may instead change the limits to θ-values and never convert back – often cleaner. Pick one discipline and follow it through.

24.6.4 When the root hides inside a shifted quadratic

Completing the square and trig substitution combine to handle the general quadratic-under-a-root. For $\int \frac{dx}{\sqrt{x^2+4x+13}}$, first complete the square: $x^2+4x+13 = (x+2)^2+9$. Substitute $u = x+2$ to center it, giving $\int \frac{du}{\sqrt{u^2+9}}$, which is exactly the tangent-triangle integral above. Reshape (complete the square), then reshape again (trig substitution): the chapter's whole theme in one problem.

Work it yourself

Do this one by hand to feel the pipeline. Integrate $\int \frac{dx}{\sqrt{5-4x-x^2}}$.

1. Complete the square inside the root. Write $5-4x-x^2 = -(x^2+4x)+5 = -\big((x+2)^2-4\big)+5 = 9-(x+2)^2$.
2. Substitute $u = x+2$: the integral is $\int \frac{du}{\sqrt{9-u^2}}$, a standard arcsine with $a = 3$.

3. Read off $\arcsin(u/3) = \arcsin\dfrac{x+2}{3} + C$.

Notice you did not even need the triangle here – once centered, it was a named standard form. Recognizing the standard form is always the fastest path; the triangle is the fallback when no name fits.

24.7 One Worldview, Several Tools

All of the techniques in this chapter share a single strategy.

Focus

Every technique reshapes the integrand into a known form.

- *Partial fractions*: a ratio of polynomials → a sum of $\dfrac{A}{(x-r)^k}$ and $\dfrac{Bx+C}{(x^2+px+q)^k}$, each a log, a power, or an arctangent.
- *Trig powers (odd)*: peel a factor → a polynomial in sin or cos, finished by substitution.
- *Trig powers (even)*: half-angle identities → lower powers and doubled angles, repeated to the end.
- *Products of waves*: product-to-sum → a sum of single waves.
- *Completing the square*: a general quadratic → a centered $u^2 \pm a^2$, matching the arctangent or arcsine form.
- *Trig substitution*: a square root → a triangle, where the Pythagorean identity makes the root a perfect square.

The calculus underneath never changes. What changes is your fluency at recognizing which rewrite exposes a known form.

Connection

By the middle of the eighteenth century, Leonhard Euler had organized essentially all of these techniques into a coherent program. His *Institutiones Calculi Integralis* (1768) treats rational functions by partial fractions, trig integrals by the identities, and irrational integrands by substitutions that rationalize them – including the trigonometric substitutions for roots of quadratics. The central idea Euler systematized is the one we have pursued: a wide variety of integrals can be evaluated not by inventing new operations, but by *transforming integrands into a small canon of solvable standard forms*. The skill of integration consists largely in recognizing which algebraic transformation exposes the standard form.

Why this matters

Notice how small a set of functions suffices here: integrating rational functions never requires anything beyond rational terms, logarithms, and arctangents, while integrating square roots of quadratics adds at most square roots, arcsines, and logarithms such as $\ln|x+\sqrt{x^2+9}|$. In every case, the antiderivative stays within the class of elementary functions (combinations of powers,

exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric functions under arithmetic and composition). By contrast, Liouville proved in 1835 that simple integrands such as $\int e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ have no elementary antiderivative at all, whereas every rational function and every square root of a quadratic integrates systematically within this compact family.

24.8 Limitations and next steps

Connection

Partial fractions provides an algorithmic method for integrating any rational function $P(x)/Q(x)$, provided the denominator $Q(x)$ can be factored into linear and quadratic terms. Coupled with trigonometric substitution, it also handles many integrands containing square roots of quadratics.

The method has two main limitations:

1. *Factoring high-degree denominators:* By the Abel–Ruffini theorem, general polynomials of degree 5 or higher have no root formula in radicals. Unless we know the linear and quadratic factors of $Q(x)$ explicitly, we cannot write down the decomposition in closed form.

2. *Non-elementary antiderivatives:* Simple-looking integrands such as e^{-x^2} or $\sqrt{1+x^4}$ have no antiderivative expressible as a finite combination of powers, roots, exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric functions.

When no closed-form antiderivative exists – or when we know the integrand only from measured data – *numerical integration* (Chapter 27) computes definite integrals directly from sample values. Before that, Chapter 25 extends integration to unbounded intervals and vertical asymptotes (*improper integrals*), and Chapter 26 applies integration to geometric and physical quantities.

24.9 Exercises

Exercise 24.1 (Mental check: Partial fraction setup and counting)**.** Without solving for any constants, write down the partial fraction decomposition template for $\dfrac{3x^2+5}{(x-2)^2(x^2+9)}$. State how many total constants you must determine, and predict which pieces will yield logarithms, which will yield powers, and which will yield arctangents.

Exercise 24.2 (Mental check: Symmetry and parity in trig integrals)**.** Without computing any antiderivatives, determine the exact value of $\displaystyle\int_{-\pi/2}^{\pi/2} \sin^5 x \cos^4 x\,\mathrm{d}x$, and explain why using the concept of odd functions. Then predict the exact value of $\displaystyle\int_{0}^{\pi/2} \sin^2 x\,\mathrm{d}x$ using the average value of $\sin^2 x$.

Exercise 24.3 (Distinct linear factors)**.** Decompose and integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{5x-4}{(x-1)(x+3)}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Use the

cover-up method to find both constants, and verify your decomposition by recombining over a common denominator.

Exercise 24.4 (Repeated factor)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{2x^2+3}{(x+1)^3}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Set up the full tower of three terms, find the constants (try the substitution $u = x+1$ as an alternative to matching coefficients), and identify which pieces become logarithms and which become powers.

Exercise 24.5 (Irreducible quadratic)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{x^2+x+1}{x(x^2+1)}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Decompose with a linear numerator over the quadratic, then split that piece into its "log half" and "arctangent half" as in Example 24.2.

Exercise 24.6 (Improper fraction)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{x^2}{x^2-4}\,\mathrm{d}x$. First explain, in one sentence, why long division is required before any decomposition, then carry it out.

Exercise 24.7 (Odd trig power)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \cos^3 x\,\mathrm{d}x$ and $\displaystyle\int \sin^3 x\cos^4 x\,\mathrm{d}x$. State which factor you peel and why the substitution then closes.

Exercise 24.8 (Even trig powers)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \cos^4 x\,\mathrm{d}x$ by applying the half-angle identity twice. Then, without computing, predict the average value of $\cos^4 x$ over a full period and check that your antiderivative's linear part agrees with it.

Exercise 24.9 (Product of waves)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \cos 2x\cos 6x\,\mathrm{d}x$ using a product-to-sum identity. Then explain, using your answer, why $\int_0^{2\pi} \cos 2x\cos 6x\,\mathrm{d}x = 0$, and connect this to the orthogonality of distinct frequencies.

Exercise 24.10 (Completing the square)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2-6x+25}$ and $\displaystyle\int \frac{2x-1}{x^2-6x+25}\,\mathrm{d}x$. For the second, split the numerator into a multiple of the denominator's derivative plus a constant.

Exercise 24.11 (Trig substitution)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{x^2}{\sqrt{4-x^2}}\,\mathrm{d}x$ using the sine triangle. Draw the triangle, convert every quantity, integrate the resulting trig expression, and convert your answer back to x explicitly.

Exercise 24.12 (Trig substitution, the other two triangles)**.** Integrate $\displaystyle\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2\sqrt{x^2-9}}$ using the secant triangle, and $\displaystyle\int \sqrt{x^2+1}\,\mathrm{d}x$ using the tangent triangle. The second will need $\int \sec^3\theta\,\mathrm{d}\theta$; derive it with one integration by parts.

Exercise 24.13 (Conceptual / proof)**.** Prove that the partial-fraction building blocks $\dfrac{Q(x)}{x-r_k}$, where $Q(x) = \prod_{i=1}^{n}(x-r_i)$ has n distinct roots, are linearly independent as polynomials. (Mimic the cover-up argument of Section 24.2.2.) Explain in a sentence why this independence is exactly what guarantees the partial-fraction decomposition exists for every proper numerator.

Exercise 24.14 (Synthesis)**.** The single integral $\displaystyle\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x^2+2x+2}}$ uses two techniques from this chapter in sequence. Name them in order, carry the computation through to a function of x, and write one sentence explaining how this problem embodies the chapter's slogan that every method reshapes the integrand into a known form.

Chapter 25

Improper Integrals

Over the last three chapters we built a toolkit for finding antiderivatives – substitution, integration by parts, partial fractions, and trigonometric rewrites. Whenever those tools produce an antiderivative F, the Fundamental Theorem turns $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ into the two-point evaluation $F(b) - F(a)$.

Yet every integral we have computed so far has quietly relied on two finiteness assumptions: the interval $[a, b]$ has two concrete endpoints, and the integrand f stays bounded on it. Under those conditions the area under the curve is a single finite number, the Riemann sums close in on it, and the Fundamental Theorem applies.

This chapter is about what happens when we break one or both of those conditions on purpose. What is the area under a curve that runs off to the right *forever*? What is the area under a curve that shoots up to infinity as you approach an endpoint? At first these questions sound either meaningless or unavoidably infinite – how could an infinitely wide region, or an infinitely tall spike, enclose any finite amount of area?

Focus

The surprise – and it genuinely surprised the people who first met it – is that sometimes an infinitely long or infinitely tall region has a perfectly finite area, and sometimes it doesn't. Whether it does depends on *how fast* the curve shrinks or grows, in a way we can make completely precise. Learning to tell the finite cases from the infinite ones is the central objective of this chapter.

The device that lets us ask these questions rigorously is the same one that made the derivative rigorous: the **limit**. We will never actually "integrate to infinity" or "integrate up to a vertical asymptote." Instead we will integrate over an ordinary, finite, well-behaved region, and then *watch what happens* as we let the edge of that region march off to infinity or creep up to the bad point. The integral over the infinite or unbounded region will be *defined* to be the limit of those ordinary integrals – if the limit exists. That single idea, applied carefully, organizes the entire chapter.

25.1 Two ways an integral can be improper

Two things can go wrong, and naming them cleanly pays off because the cures differ slightly.

Definition 25.1 (Improper integral, informally)**.** An integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is called **improper** if either

1. the interval of integration is infinite – one or both limits are $\pm\infty$ (an improper integral *of the first kind*); or
2. the integrand f is unbounded somewhere on the interval – it has a vertical asymptote at an endpoint or at an interior point (an improper integral *of the second kind*).

In plain terms, either the interval of integration extends without bound, or the integrand blows up somewhere along the interval. An integral can be improper for both reasons at once.

The ordinary Riemann integral simply has nothing to say about either case. Its whole construction – chop $[a, b]$ into finitely many pieces, build rectangles, take a limit of the sums – assumes a finite interval and a bounded function. If the interval is $[1, \infty)$ there is no finite chopping to do; if f blows up at $x = 0$, no finite collection of rectangles can pin down the area near the spike. So we are not "computing a Riemann integral" in these cases. We are *defining a new kind of object* and choosing, deliberately, to define it as a limit of ordinary integrals.

Intuition

Think of it as photographing an open road or an endless coastline that extends past the horizon. You cannot fit the whole stretch in one frame. So you take a frame that stops at distance t, measure the area it contains, then slide the right edge of the frame out – $t = 10$, $t = 100$, $t = 10\,000$ – and ask whether the measured area is settling down toward a fixed number or growing without bound. The improper integral is the number it settles toward.

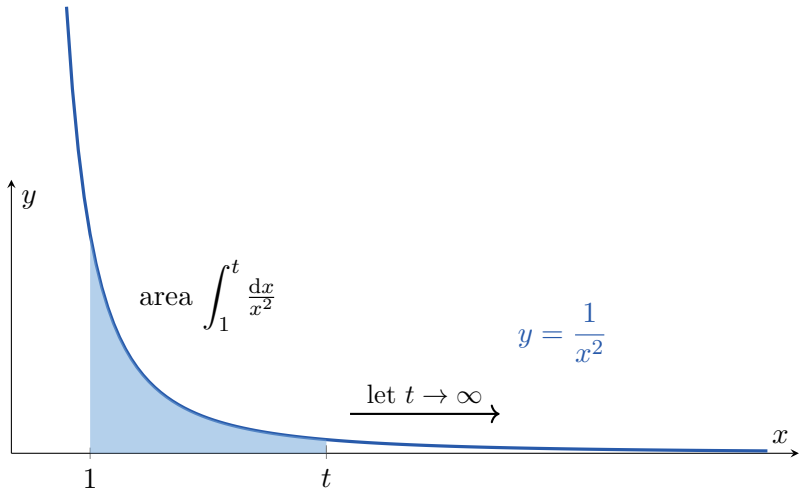


Figure 25.1: The frame that stops at $x = t$. We measure a finite area, then slide the right edge t outward and ask what number the area approaches.

25.2 Infinite intervals: the first kind

Here is the definition, stated for the most common case of a single infinite endpoint on the right.

Definition 25.2 (Improper integral over $[a,\infty)$)**.** Let f be defined on $[a,\infty)$ and integrable on every finite subinterval $[a,t]$. We define

$$\int_a^{\infty} f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;=\; \lim_{t\to\infty}\int_a^{t} f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x,$$

provided this limit exists as a finite number. In that case we say the improper integral **converges** (the accumulated area settles down to a single finite number), and its value is that limit. If the limit is $\pm\infty$ or fails to exist, we say the integral **diverges** (the area climbs without bound or oscillates without settling).

Symmetrically, $\displaystyle\int_{-\infty}^{b} f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{s\to-\infty}\int_s^{b} f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. The doubly-infinite case needs a little care, and we will get to it.

What is really happening

The symbol $\int_1^{\infty}$ looks like it has an endpoint called "∞" that you evaluate at an antiderivative. But ∞ is not a real number that can be plugged in, and the Riemann machinery never runs over an infinite interval. What is *really* happening is a two-step process hidden inside one piece of notation: first do an ordinary integral up to a movable finite wall t, getting a *function of* t; then take the limit of that function as $t\to\infty$. The "∞" in the upper limit is shorthand for "take the limit." Every correct calculation with these objects re-separates those two steps.

25.2.1 The canonical example: two curves that look almost identical

Run the definition on the cleanest possible pair. Consider

$$\int_1^{\infty}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2} \qquad\text{and}\qquad \int_1^{\infty}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x}.$$

Both integrands are positive, both decrease toward zero as $x\to\infty$, and if you sketch them they look like nearly the same gently-falling curve. Yet one encloses a finite area and the other does not. Watch.

For the first, work to the finite wall t:

$$\int_1^{t}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2} = \int_1^{t} x^{-2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[-\frac{1}{x}\Big]_1^{t} = -\frac{1}{t}+1 = 1-\frac{1}{t}.$$

Now slide the wall out. As $t\to\infty$, the term $1/t$ collapses to 0, so

$$\int_1^{\infty}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2} = \lim_{t\to\infty}\Big(1-\tfrac{1}{t}\Big) = 1.$$

The area under $1/x^2$ from 1 all the way out to infinity is exactly 1. A region of *infinite width* has area 1.

Now the second, the same way:

$$\int_1^{t}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \Big[\ln x\Big]_1^{t} = \ln t - \ln 1 = \ln t.$$

And $\ln t \to \infty$ as $t \to \infty$ – slowly, but it never stops climbing. So

$$\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \lim_{t\to\infty} \ln t = \infty \quad \text{(diverges)}.$$

Intuition

What is the real difference? Both curves fall to zero, but $1/x^2$ falls *fast enough* that the leftover area out past $x = t$ shrinks to nothing, while $1/x$ falls *too slowly* – it leaves behind a thin but stubbornly non-negligible sliver of area at every stage, and those slivers add up to infinity. The whole subject is the contest between "the tail is getting thin" and "but there is infinitely much of it." Convergence means thinness wins.

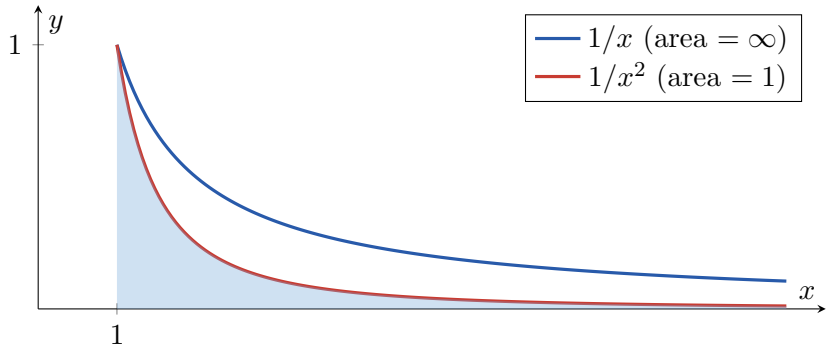


Figure 25.2: Two curves that look nearly the same near the start. The faster-falling $1/x^2$ (red, shaded) encloses finite area; the slower-falling $1/x$ (blue) encloses infinite area. The eye cannot tell them apart out in the tail – only the arithmetic of the limit can.

Work it yourself

Before reading on, compute $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^3}$ by hand. Integrate to t, then let $t \to \infty$. (You should get the finite value $\frac{1}{2}$.) Then try $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}}$ and watch it diverge. The point is to feel, in your fingers, exactly where the $1/t^{\text{something}}$ either dies or survives in the limit.

25.2.2 The p-test: the master pattern

The two examples above are the $p = 2$ and $p = 1$ cases of one general family. Settle the whole family at once, since it becomes the yardstick against which we measure everything else.

Theorem 25.1 (p-test at infinity)**.** *For a fixed real number p,*

$$\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^p} \quad \textit{converges if and only if} \quad p > 1,$$

and in the convergent case its value is $\dfrac{1}{p-1}$.

Proof. The only delicate part is that the antiderivative of x^{-p} has a different form when $p = 1$, so we split the argument.

Case $p \neq 1$. Then

$$\int_1^t x^{-p}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[\frac{x^{1-p}}{1-p}\Big]_1^t = \frac{t^{1-p}-1}{1-p}.$$

Everything now rides on the exponent $1-p$ of t. If $p > 1$ then $1-p < 0$, so $t^{1-p} = 1/t^{p-1} \to 0$ as $t \to \infty$, leaving

$$\lim_{t\to\infty} \frac{t^{1-p}-1}{1-p} = \frac{0-1}{1-p} = \frac{1}{p-1},$$

a finite number: *convergence*. If instead $p < 1$ then $1-p > 0$, so $t^{1-p} \to \infty$ and the integral diverges.

Case $p = 1$. Here the antiderivative is the logarithm, not a power:

$$\int_1^t \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \ln t \to \infty,$$

so the integral diverges. Collecting the cases: convergence happens exactly when $p > 1$, with value $1/(p-1)$. □

Why the technique works

Why is $p = 1$ the exact threshold between finite and infinite area? Because $1/x$ is the unique power whose antiderivative is logarithmic rather than a power. A logarithm grows slower than *any* positive power of t, yet it still grows without bound. So $1/x$ sits precisely on the border: its tail is just barely too fat to enclose finite area. Push the exponent up to 1.0000001 and the antiderivative becomes a (negative) power that converges; drop it to 0.9999999 and you still diverge. The logarithm is the borderline case, and it falls on the side of divergence. The threshold $p = 1$ serves as the benchmark: convergence questions over $[1, \infty)$ fundamentally reduce to whether the integrand decays faster or slower than $1/x$.

Common trap

"The integrand goes to zero, so the area must be finite." This is the single most common mistake, and $\int_1^\infty \mathrm{d}x/x$ is the clearest counterexample. The integrand *does* go to zero, and the integral still diverges. For decreasing integrands, going to zero is *necessary* for convergence over an infinite interval (narrow spikes can evade even that; see Exercise 25.12), but it is never sufficient on its own – the tail has to go to zero *fast enough*. Never conclude convergence just from $f(x) \to 0$.

25.2.3 Exponential tails and rapid decay

While power functions like $1/x^2$ decay at a polynomial rate, exponential functions decay far more rapidly and converge with room to spare. They appear frequently in probability and physics, beginning with the standard decaying exponential.

Example 25.1 (The decaying exponential)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^\infty e^{-x}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

$$\int_0^t e^{-x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[-e^{-x}\Big]_0^t = -e^{-t} + e^0 = 1 - e^{-t}.$$

As $t \to \infty$, $e^{-t} \to 0$, so the integral converges to 1. More generally, for any rate $k > 0$,

$$\int_0^\infty e^{-kx}\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{t\to\infty}\Big[-\tfrac{1}{k}e^{-kx}\Big]_0^t = \frac{1}{k}.$$

Application

This is the backbone of the *exponential distribution* in probability, the model for waiting times – how long until a radioactive atom decays, until the next customer arrives, until a component fails. The density is $f(x) = ke^{-kx}$ for $x \geq 0$, and the calculation above says $\int_0^\infty ke^{-kx}\,\mathrm{d}x = 1$: total probability is one, exactly as a probability density must give. The whole edifice of continuous probability rests on improper integrals converging to 1. The mean waiting time, $\int_0^\infty x\,ke^{-kx}\,\mathrm{d}x = 1/k$, is another improper integral – you can do it with integration by parts and the same $t \to \infty$ limit.

25.2.4 Both ends infinite: split, don't straddle

What about $\int_{-\infty}^\infty f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, infinite at *both* ends? The correct definition splits the line at any convenient finite point c and demands that *each half* converge on its own.

Definition 25.3 (Doubly infinite integral)**.**

$$\int_{-\infty}^\infty f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_{-\infty}^c f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x + \int_c^\infty f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x,$$

and the left side converges if and only if *both* integrals on the right converge (the value is then independent of the split point c).

Common trap

You must *not* compute $\int_{-\infty}^\infty f$ as a single symmetric limit $\lim_{t\to\infty}\int_{-t}^t f$. That symmetric quantity is a different, weaker object called the *(Cauchy) principal value*, in which both boundaries are forced to march outward in lockstep at the same rate. The principal value can give a finite answer even when the true integral diverges. Example: $\int_{-t}^t x\,\mathrm{d}x = 0$ for every t, so the symmetric limit is 0. But $\int_0^\infty x\,\mathrm{d}x = \infty$, so the genuine improper integral $\int_{-\infty}^\infty x\,\mathrm{d}x$ *diverges*. The symmetric limit was letting $+\infty$ and $-\infty$ cancel each other in lockstep, which is cheating – convergence is not allowed to depend on marching the two ends out at the same speed. Always split into two independent halves.

Example 25.2 (A doubly-infinite winner)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_{-\infty}^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{1+x^2}$. Split at $c = 0$. The antiderivative is $\arctan x$, so

$$\int_0^t \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{1+x^2} = \arctan t - \arctan 0 \to \frac{\pi}{2},$$

and by the symmetry of the integrand the left half contributes another $\pi/2$. Both halves converge, so the whole integral converges to

$$\int_{-\infty}^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{1+x^2} = \frac{\pi}{2} + \frac{\pi}{2} = \pi.$$

A bell-shaped curve stretching to infinity in both directions, total area exactly π. The appearance of π here is a cousin of why π shows up in the Gaussian and throughout probability.

25.3 Unbounded integrands: the second kind

Now the other way an integral can be improper: the interval is finite, but the *function* runs off to infinity. Consider $\int_0^1 \mathrm{d}x/\sqrt{x}$. The interval $[0,1]$ is as tame as can be, but the integrand $1/\sqrt{x} \to \infty$ as $x \to 0^+$. There is an infinitely tall spike pinned against the left edge. Does it enclose finite area?

The cure is the same in spirit as before. We never integrate *at* the bad point. We back off to a wall a tiny distance ε away from it, integrate over the safe region, and then let the wall creep in toward the singularity—a **singularity** being any point where a function blows up to infinity or ceases to be defined.

Definition 25.4 (Singularity at an endpoint)**.** Suppose f is integrable on $[a+\varepsilon, b]$ for every small $\varepsilon > 0$ but is unbounded as $x \to a^+$. Then

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{\varepsilon \to 0^+} \int_{a+\varepsilon}^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x,$$

provided the limit exists (finite). Symmetrically, if the singularity is at the *right* endpoint b, back off from there: $\displaystyle\int_a^b f = \lim_{\varepsilon\to 0^+} \int_a^{b-\varepsilon} f$.

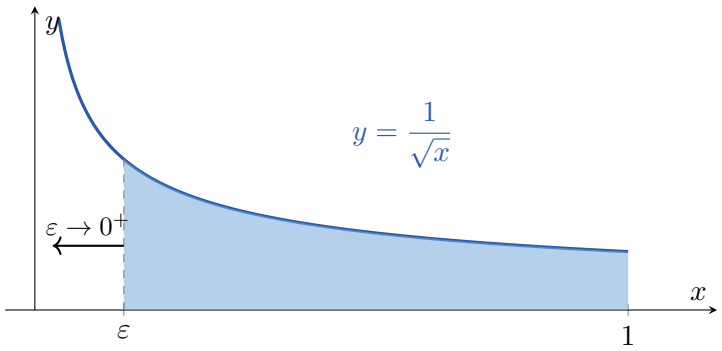


Figure 25.3: An unbounded integrand. The spike at $x = 0$ is infinitely tall, so we cut the area off at $x = \varepsilon$, measure it, and slide the wall ε toward 0. If the measured area settles, the spike has finite area despite its infinite height.

Example 25.3 (A tall spike with finite area)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}}$. Back off to ε:

$$\int_\varepsilon^1 x^{-1/2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[2\sqrt{x}\Big]_\varepsilon^1 = 2\sqrt{1} - 2\sqrt{\varepsilon} = 2 - 2\sqrt{\varepsilon}.$$

As $\varepsilon \to 0^+$, $\sqrt{\varepsilon} \to 0$, so the integral converges to 2. The spike is infinitely tall, and it encloses area 2.

Example 25.4 (A tall spike with infinite area)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x}$. The same procedure:

$$\int_\varepsilon^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \Big[\ln x\Big]_\varepsilon^1 = \ln 1 - \ln\varepsilon = -\ln\varepsilon.$$

As $\varepsilon \to 0^+$, $\ln\varepsilon \to -\infty$, so $-\ln\varepsilon \to +\infty$: *diverges*. Again the logarithm sits on the knife-edge, again it falls on the side of divergence.

25.3.1 A p-test for spikes – and a beautiful inversion

There is a p-test here too, and comparing it to the one at infinity reveals one of the prettiest little symmetries in calculus.

Theorem 25.2 (p-test at a singularity)**.** *For a fixed real p,*

$$\int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^p} \quad \textit{converges if and only if} \quad p < 1,$$

with value $\dfrac{1}{1-p}$ *in the convergent case.*

Proof. For $p \neq 1$,

$$\int_\varepsilon^1 x^{-p}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[\frac{x^{1-p}}{1-p}\Big]_\varepsilon^1 = \frac{1-\varepsilon^{\,1-p}}{1-p}.$$

If $p < 1$ then $1-p > 0$ and $\varepsilon^{\,1-p} \to 0$, giving the finite limit $1/(1-p)$. If $p > 1$ then $1-p < 0$ and $\varepsilon^{\,1-p} = 1/\varepsilon^{\,p-1} \to \infty$, so it diverges. For $p = 1$ we got $-\ln\varepsilon \to \infty$ above. Hence convergence exactly when $p < 1$. □

Why this matters

Lay the two p-tests side by side and admire the reversal:

$$\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^p} \text{ converges } \iff p > 1, \qquad \int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^p} \text{ converges } \iff p < 1.$$

The inequality literally flips. And it *must*, because the two integrals ask opposite questions about the same exponent. Far out at infinity, you want the curve to fall *quickly* (large p) so the long tail is thin. Near zero, you want the curve to rise *slowly* (small p) so the tall spike is narrow. A large p makes a thin tail but a fat spike; a small p makes a thin spike but a fat tail. You cannot have both – which is exactly why $\int_0^\infty \mathrm{d}x/x^p$ *diverges for every* p: whatever value of p tames one end ruins the other. The borderline curve $1/x$ ($p = 1$) diverges at both ends at once.

Pause

Mental check: Without writing anything down, which of these two integrals converges: $\displaystyle\int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^{0.99}}$ or $\displaystyle\int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^{1.01}}$? And which one converges if the interval is flipped to $[1,\infty)$?
Answer: Near zero, the smaller power $p = 0.99 < 1$ climbs slowly enough that the vertical spike is thin, so $\int_0^1 \mathrm{d}x/x^{0.99}$ converges ($= 1/(1-0.99) = 100$). The power $p = 1.01 > 1$ blows up too aggressively and diverges. Out on the infinite tail $[1,\infty)$, the roles reverse: $p = 1.01 > 1$ falls fast enough to enclose finite area ($= 1/(1.01-1) = 100$), while $p = 0.99$ diverges. The boundary $p = 1$ is the logarithm, which diverges in both directions.

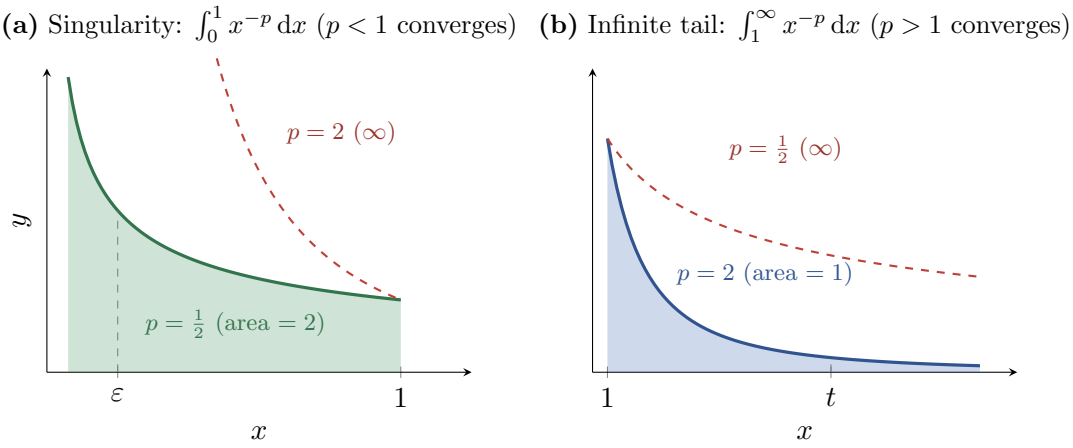


Figure 25.4: The trade-off behind the flipped p-tests. **(a)** Near a vertical singularity on $(0,1]$, small exponents $p<1$ converge (green shaded, area $=2$) because the spike is narrow, whereas large exponents $p\geq 1$ diverge (dashed red). **(b)** Out on the infinite tail $[1,\infty)$, large exponents $p>1$ converge (blue shaded, area $=1$) because the tail decays rapidly, whereas small exponents $p\leq 1$ diverge (dashed red). No single p can win at both ends – which is why $\int_0^\infty dx/x^p$ diverges for every p.

25.4 When you cannot find an antiderivative: comparison

So far every example handed us a clean antiderivative. But the questions we most want to answer often involve integrands like e^{-x^2} or $\dfrac{1}{\sqrt{x^3+1}}$ that have *no elementary antiderivative* at all. We cannot evaluate $\int_1^\infty e^{-x^2}\,dx$ by finding F and taking a limit – there is no F to find. Yet we can still answer the only question that matters for many purposes: does it *converge*?

The idea is the oldest trick in analysis: if you cannot measure a quantity, trap it between two quantities you *can* measure.

Intuition

If your messy curve sits *underneath* a curve whose area you know to be finite, then your curve – having even less area – must also have finite area. And if your messy curve sits *above* a curve whose area is infinite, then yours, having even more, must be infinite too. You never compute your own area; you sandwich it. This is the same move as the Squeeze Theorem for limits, now applied to whole accumulated areas.

Theorem 25.3 (Comparison Test for integrals)**.** *Suppose $0\leq f(x)\leq g(x)$ for all $x\geq a$, and both are integrable on every $[a,t]$. Then:*

1. *If $\displaystyle\int_a^\infty g$ converges, so does $\displaystyle\int_a^\infty f$ (the smaller one is also finite).*
2. *If $\displaystyle\int_a^\infty f$ diverges, so does $\displaystyle\int_a^\infty g$ (the bigger one is also infinite).*

The same statements hold for second-kind (unbounded-integrand) integrals.

Proof. The assumption $f \geq 0$ is essential for monotonicity. Define the accumulated area function

$$A(t) = \int_a^t f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Because $f \geq 0$, adding more interval only adds (non-negative) area, so A is a *nondecreasing* function of t. A nondecreasing function as $t \to \infty$ has only two possible fates: it climbs to a finite limit, or it runs off to $+\infty$. (There is no oscillation to worry about – it cannot come back down.) This is the Monotone Convergence principle (the guarantee that any quantity that only ever grows and cannot cross a fixed ceiling must settle into a finite limit), and it is the engine of the whole proof.

For part (1): since $f \leq g$, comparing areas over the same interval gives

$$A(t) = \int_a^t f \;\leq\; \int_a^t g \;\leq\; \int_a^\infty g =: M,$$

where M is finite by hypothesis. So A is nondecreasing *and bounded above* by M. A nondecreasing function bounded above must converge to a finite limit (it cannot escape past its ceiling). Hence $\int_a^\infty f$ converges.

Part (2) is the contrapositive of part (1): if $\int_a^\infty f$ diverged to $+\infty$ while $\int_a^\infty g$ converged, part (1) would force $\int_a^\infty f$ to converge – a contradiction. So if $\int f$ diverges, $\int g$ must diverge too. □

Why the technique works

Why does the comparison test *need* f and g to be non-negative? Because the whole argument rests on $A(t)$ being monotone – on the fact that the area "so far" can only grow as we extend the interval. If f were allowed to dip negative, $A(t)$ could rise and fall, and "bounded above" would no longer force convergence (a bounded oscillation need not settle anywhere). Sign-control is what converts "bounded" into "convergent." For integrands that change sign you need the stronger notion of *absolute convergence*, coming up at the end of the chapter.

Example 25.5 (Trapping a curve with no antiderivative)**.** Show $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ converges. There is no elementary antiderivative, so we cannot evaluate it – but for $x \geq 1$ we have $x^2 \geq x$, hence $e^{-x^2} \leq e^{-x}$. And we computed $\int_1^\infty e^{-x}\,\mathrm{d}x = e^{-1}$, which is finite. By part (1) of the Comparison Test, our integral is squeezed under a finite area and therefore converges. We have proven it is finite without ever finding its value.

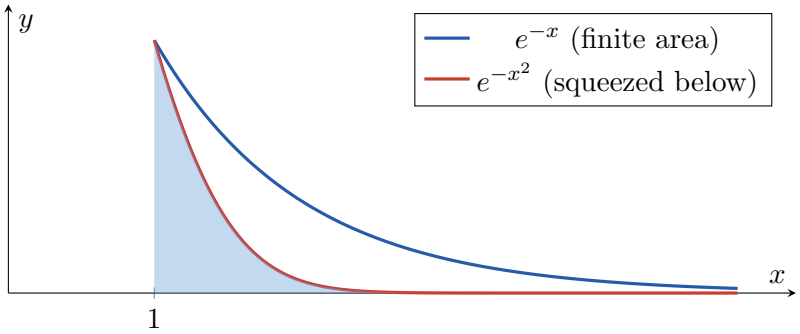


Figure 25.5: The comparison test in one picture. For $x \geq 1$ the curve e^{-x^2} (red, shaded) lies entirely under e^{-x} (blue), whose tail area is finite. A curve trapped beneath a finite area must itself have finite area – so $\int_1^\infty e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ converges, even though we never compute it.

Example 25.6 (Using divergence to prove divergence)**.** Show $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x^2+x}}$ diverges. For $x \geq 1$ we have $x^2 + x \leq x^2 + x^2 = 2x^2$, so

$$\frac{1}{\sqrt{x^2+x}} \;\geq\; \frac{1}{\sqrt{2x^2}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}\,x}.$$

But $\int_1^\infty \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}\,x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x}$ diverges (it is the $p = 1$ borderline). Our integrand sits *above* a divergent one, so by part (2) it diverges too.

Common trap

Comparison only works in the helpful direction. Bounding f *above* by a *divergent* g tells you nothing – a small thing under a big infinite thing can be finite or infinite. Likewise bounding f *below* by a *convergent* g tells you nothing. The useful pairings are: "smaller than convergent $\Rightarrow$ convergent" and "bigger than divergent $\Rightarrow$ divergent." Get the direction backwards and you have proven nothing. When in doubt, ask: is my known curve acting as a finite ceiling, or an infinite floor?

25.4.1 Limit comparison: comparing by behavior, not by inequality

Building an explicit inequality $f \leq g$ can be fiddly – you have to nudge the algebra into the right direction. Often you can *see* that two integrands behave the same way far out (both "act like" $1/x^2$, say) even though neither is cleanly below the other. The limit-comparison test makes that intuition rigorous.

Theorem 25.4 (Limit Comparison Test)**.** *Let $f, g > 0$ on $[a, \infty)$ and suppose*

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{f(x)}{g(x)} = L \quad \textit{with } 0 < L < \infty.$$

Then $\int_a^\infty f$ and $\int_a^\infty g$ either both converge or both diverge: they share the same fate.

The hypothesis $0 < L < \infty$ says f and g are, far out, the same size up to a bounded constant factor – and a bounded constant factor cannot turn a finite area infinite or vice versa. (We sketch the proof in an exercise; it is a clean application of the plain comparison test, bounding f between $\frac{L}{2}g$ and $2L\,g$ for large x.)

Example 25.7 (Limit comparison in action)**.** Does $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{3x^2 - x + 5}{2x^4 + 7}\,\mathrm{d}x$ converge? Forget the constants and look at the dominant powers: for large x the integrand behaves like $\dfrac{3x^2}{2x^4} = \dfrac{3}{2x^2}$. So compare against $g(x) = 1/x^2$:

$$\lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{(3x^2 - x + 5)/(2x^4 + 7)}{1/x^2} = \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{(3x^2 - x + 5)\,x^2}{2x^4 + 7} = \lim_{x\to\infty} \frac{3x^4 - x^3 + 5x^2}{2x^4 + 7} = \frac{3}{2}.$$

The limit is finite and positive, so our integral shares the fate of $\int_1^\infty \mathrm{d}x/x^2$, which *converges* ($p = 2 > 1$). And we never had to integrate the ugly rational function.

Focus

This provides a direct criterion for rational functions. For an integrand $P(x)/Q(x)$, compare degrees: if the denominator degree exceeds the numerator degree by more than one ($\deg Q - \deg P > 1$), the integrand decays faster than $1/x$ and the integral over $[1, \infty)$ converges. If $\deg Q - \deg P \leq 1$, the integral diverges. The difference $\deg Q - \deg P$ plays the role of the exponent p in the p-test.

Pause

Mental check: Suppose $0 \leq f(x) \leq \dfrac{1}{x^3}$ for all $x \geq 1$. Does $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ converge? What if you only knew $f(x) \geq \dfrac{1}{x^3}$?

Answer: In the first case, f is trapped under $1/x^3$, whose integral converges ($p = 3 > 1$). Having a finite ceiling forces $\int_1^\infty f$ to converge. In the second case, knowing f sits above a convergent curve tells you nothing: $f(x)$ could be $1/x^4$ (convergent) or $1/x$ (divergent). A finite floor cannot stop a curve from escaping to infinity.

25.5 The famous surprises

We have already met one mild surprise – finite area under an infinitely long curve. The historical excitement around improper integrals came from a few results that genuinely offended common sense. They are worth meeting both for the delight and because they sharpen what "finite area" really does and does not promise.

25.5.1 Finite area, infinite length

Intuition

Take the region under $y = 1/x^2$ from 1 to ∞: area = 1, finite. Now ask about the *arc length* of a curve that runs to infinity horizontally – how long is the wiggly line, not the area under it. The arc length formula gives $\int_1^\infty \sqrt{1 + (y')^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Since $\sqrt{1 + (y')^2} \geq 1$ for *every* curve, the arc length is at least $\int_1^\infty 1\,\mathrm{d}x = \infty$. *Any* curve that runs to infinity horizontally has infinite length, no matter how flat it gets. So length and area are genuinely different beasts: one can be infinite while the other is finite, on the very same picture.

25.5.2 Gabriel's Horn: finite volume, infinite surface

A classic geometric demonstration discovered by Evangelista Torricelli around 1641 – before calculus had its modern notation – illustrates this distinction directly. Rotate the curve $y = 1/x$ for $x \geq 1$ about the x-axis to produce the surface of revolution known as *Gabriel's Horn* (also called Torricelli's trumpet).

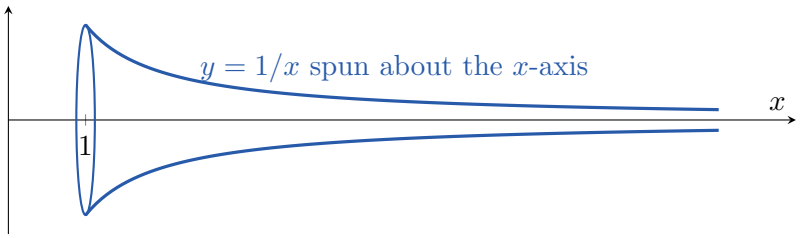


Figure 25.6: Gabriel's Horn: the curve $y = 1/x$ revolved about the x-axis, narrowing forever as $x \to \infty$. Finite volume, infinite surface area.

Two improper integrals describe the horn. Using the disk and surface-of-revolution formulas (which you will derive in the applications chapter; we just use them here):

Volume (stacking up thin disks of radius $1/x$):

$$V = \int_1^\infty \pi \left(\frac{1}{x}\right)^2 \mathrm{d}x = \pi \int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^2} = \pi \cdot 1 = \pi.$$

A finite volume. You could fill the entire infinitely-long horn with exactly π cubic units of paint.

Surface area (wrapping a thin band of circumference $2\pi/x$ around each slice):

$$S = \int_1^\infty 2\pi \frac{1}{x}\sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{-1}{x^2}\right)^2}\,\mathrm{d}x > \int_1^\infty \frac{2\pi}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x = 2\pi \int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x} = \infty.$$

Here the surface integrand is at least $2\pi/x$ (because the square root is at least 1), and $\int_1^\infty \mathrm{d}x/x$ diverges – our old friend the $p = 1$ borderline. So the surface area is *infinite*.

Why this matters

The apparent paradox arises from contrasting volume with surface area. Gabriel's horn encloses a finite volume of π, yet has infinite surface area. In physical terms, filling the interior requires a finite volume of paint, whereas coating the surface with a layer of uniform thickness $\delta > 0$ requires infinite volume (since the volume of a coating of thickness δ is at least $\delta \cdot S = \infty$). The geometric resolution is that volume and surface area are independent dimensional quantities: *a finite three-dimensional volume can be bounded by an infinite two-dimensional surface*, just as a finite area can be bounded by a curve of infinite length.

History

Evangelista Torricelli, a student of Galileo Galilei, analyzed this solid in 1641. He calculated the volume and surface area of the infinitely long horn obtained by rotating the hyperbola $y = 1/x$ about its asymptote.
Torricelli worked before the development of calculus, using Cavalieri's *method of indivisibles*—comparing the solid to concentric cylindrical shells of known volume. The result surprised contemporary scholars. Classical geometry, following Aristotle, avoided completed infinities, and the idea that a solid of infinite length could enclose a finite volume seemed counterintuitive. Thomas Hobbes argued against the result, while René Descartes and Marin Mersenne debated its implications in correspondence – one of the first times mathematicians accepted a rigorous calculation over an infinite domain.

Connection

Gabriel's horn is the continuous geometric counterpart of a fundamental fact about infinite series: $\sum 1/n^2$ converges, whereas the harmonic series $\sum 1/n$ diverges. The Integral Test, developed in the series chapters, establishes that an improper integral $\int_1^\infty f(x)\,dx$ and the corresponding infinite series $\sum f(n)$ for a positive decreasing function f share the exact same convergence behavior. Improper integrals and infinite series both address the accumulation of infinitely many shrinking terms. The p-test for improper integrals directly anticipates the p-series test.

25.6 Hidden singularities and other traps

The most dangerous improper integrals are the ones that do not announce themselves. A finite interval and a formula that looks bounded can still hide a singularity in the middle, and if you integrate straight through it with the Fundamental Theorem you can get a confident, plausible, and completely wrong answer.

Common trap

Consider the innocent-looking

$$\int_{-1}^{1} \frac{dx}{x^2}.$$

A careless application of the Fundamental Theorem gives $\Big[-1/x\Big]_{-1}^{1} = (-1) - (1) = -2$. This is *nonsense*: the integrand $1/x^2$ is positive everywhere it is defined, so any genuine "area" must be positive, never -2. What went wrong? The integrand blows up at $x = 0$, an *interior* point of $[-1, 1]$, so the integral is improper and the Fundamental Theorem – which assumes a continuous integrand – does not apply. The formula $-1/x$ is not a valid antiderivative *across* the discontinuity. Doing it correctly, you split at 0 and find each half is $\int_0^1 dx/x^2 = \infty$, so the integral diverges. Always scan the *whole* interval, interior included, for points where the integrand is undefined before you reach for an antiderivative.

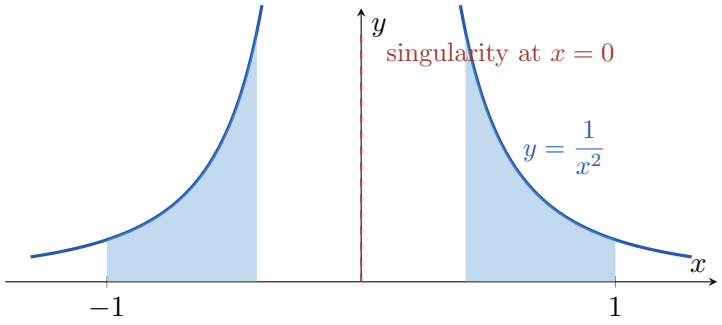


Figure 25.7: The hidden interior singularity trap: $\int_{-1}^{1} dx/x^2$. The curve $y = 1/x^2$ is strictly positive everywhere, shooting up to $+\infty$ on both sides of $x = 0$. Applying the Fundamental Theorem blindly across the tear yields -2—an absurd negative area for a curve that never drops below the x-axis. The correct value is $\infty + \infty = \infty$ (diverges).

Definition 25.5 (Interior singularity)**.** If f is unbounded near an interior point c of $[a,b]$, define

$$\int_a^b f = \int_a^c f + \int_c^b f,$$

and the whole integral converges only if *both* pieces converge as improper integrals in their own right. As with two-sided infinity, you may not let the two sides cancel across the singularity.

Example 25.8 (Careful handling of a spike)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^8 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^{1/3}}$. The integrand blows up at $x=0$ (an endpoint here, but the moral is the same). Back off and take the limit:

$$\int_\varepsilon^8 x^{-1/3}\,\mathrm{d}x = \Big[\tfrac{3}{2}x^{2/3}\Big]_\varepsilon^8 = \tfrac{3}{2}\big(8^{2/3}-\varepsilon^{2/3}\big) = \tfrac{3}{2}\big(4-\varepsilon^{2/3}\big).$$

As $\varepsilon \to 0^+$, $\varepsilon^{2/3}\to 0$, so the value is $\frac{3}{2}\cdot 4 = 6$. Here $p = 1/3 < 1$, so the p-test for singularities promised convergence, and indeed it converges to 6.

Walking question

Take a walk and turn this over: the integrand $1/x$ diverges at the singularity $x=0$ (over $[0,1]$) *and* diverges at infinity (over $[1,\infty)$). The exponent that would fix one end (p large near ∞, p small near 0) is exactly the wrong fix for the other. Convince yourself, without writing anything, that there is *no* power $1/x^p$ whose integral over the whole ray $(0,\infty)$ is finite. What does that tell you about trying to assign a finite "total area under $1/x^p$"? And what happens when you apply the substitution $u = 1/x$ to $\int_0^1 \mathrm{d}x/x^p$ – why does $p=1$ map onto itself at both ends?

25.7 When the sign keeps changing: absolute convergence

Everything in the comparison section assumed $f \ge 0$, so that the area-so-far $A(t)$ could only climb. What about an integrand that oscillates – positive, then negative, then positive – like $\dfrac{\sin x}{x}$ out to infinity? Now $A(t)$ rises and falls, and "does the area settle down?" becomes a subtler question of *cancellation*, not just of size.

Definition 25.6 (Absolute convergence)**.** The integral $\int_a^\infty f$ **converges absolutely** if $\int_a^\infty |f|$ converges. A basic theorem of analysis says: *if $\int_a^\infty |f|$ converges, then $\int_a^\infty f$ converges too.* Absolute convergence is the safe, robust kind – and what makes it so useful in practice is that it is checkable by the comparison test, because $|f| \ge 0$.

Intuition

Why does absolute convergence force ordinary convergence, ruling out even endless oscillation? Shift f upward by $|f|$: since $f(x)+|f(x)|$ is either 0 or $2|f(x)|$, we have $0 \le f+|f| \le 2|f|$. The comparison test then makes $\int_a^\infty (f+|f|)$ converge, and subtracting the convergent integral $\int_a^\infty |f|$ recovers $\int_a^\infty f$. The converse fails: an integral can converge *only* through cancellation while its absolute version diverges. That fragile kind is called *conditional* convergence, and $\int_1^\infty \frac{\sin x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ is the classic example. Integrating by parts ($u = 1/x$, $\mathrm{d}v = \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$) turns it

into a vanishing-at-infinity boundary term plus $-\int_1^\infty \frac{\cos x}{x^2}\,dx$, which converges absolutely; yet $\int_1^\infty \frac{|\sin x|}{x}\,dx$ diverges, because the bumps of $|\sin x|/x$ are, on average, a constant times $1/x$.

Example 25.9 (Absolute convergence via comparison)**.** Show $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{\sin x}{x^2}\,dx$ converges. We cannot sign-control $\sin x$, but we can bound its size: $|\sin x| \le 1$, so

$$\left|\frac{\sin x}{x^2}\right| \le \frac{1}{x^2}.$$

Since $\int_1^\infty dx/x^2$ converges, the comparison test makes $\int_1^\infty |\sin x/x^2|$ converge – that is, our integral converges *absolutely*, and hence converges. The oscillation never even had a chance to cause trouble, because the envelope $1/x^2$ already had finite area.

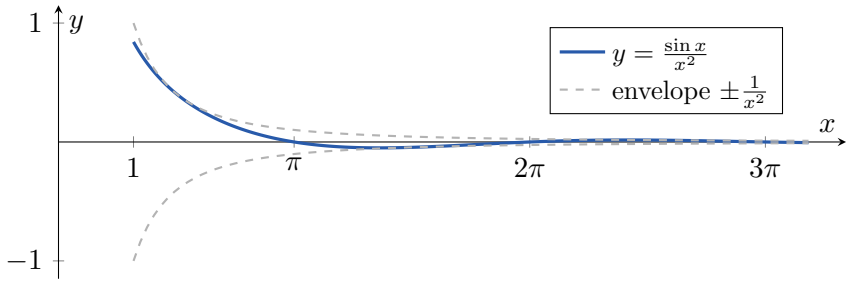


Figure 25.8: Absolute convergence via an envelope. The oscillating curve $y = \frac{\sin x}{x^2}$ (blue) is squeezed between the symmetric boundaries $\pm\frac{1}{x^2}$ (dashed gray). Because the envelope encloses a finite total area ($\int_1^\infty dx/x^2 = 1$), the oscillations have no room to accumulate an infinite sum, guaranteeing that $\int_1^\infty \frac{\sin x}{x^2}\,dx$ converges absolutely.

25.8 A gallery of fully worked examples

Here are a handful of complete computations, each touching a different technique.

Example 25.10 (Integration by parts to infinity)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^\infty x\,e^{-x}\,dx$. Go to the wall t and integrate by parts ($u = x$, $dv = e^{-x}dx$, so $du = dx$, $v = -e^{-x}$):

$$\int_0^t xe^{-x}\,dx = \Big[-xe^{-x}\Big]_0^t + \int_0^t e^{-x}\,dx = -te^{-t} + \big(1 - e^{-t}\big).$$

As $t \to \infty$, the term $te^{-t} \to 0$ (exponential decay beats the linear growth of t – you proved this in the L'Hôpital chapter), and $e^{-t} \to 0$. So the value is $0 + (1 - 0) = 1$. This is the mean of the exponential distribution with rate $k = 1$.

Example 25.11 (A logarithmic spike)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^1 \ln x\,dx$. The integrand blows up at $x = 0^+$ (since $\ln x \to -\infty$), so this is second-kind. Back off and use parts ($u = \ln x$, $dv = dx$):

$$\int_\varepsilon^1 \ln x\,dx = \Big[x\ln x\Big]_\varepsilon^1 - \int_\varepsilon^1 1\,dx = \big(1\cdot 0 - \varepsilon\ln\varepsilon\big) - (1 - \varepsilon) = -\varepsilon\ln\varepsilon - 1 + \varepsilon.$$

As $\varepsilon \to 0^+$, the product $\varepsilon \ln \varepsilon \to 0$ (again the L'Hôpital fact: a power kills a logarithm), and $\varepsilon \to 0$, leaving

$$\int_0^1 \ln x \, \mathrm{d}x = 0 - 1 + 0 = -1.$$

A finite, negative area – negative because $\ln x < 0$ on $(0, 1)$ – under a curve that plunges to $-\infty$ at the left edge.

Example 25.12 (Doubly improper: both kinds at once)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}\,(1+x)}$. This is improper *twice*: the integrand blows up at $x = 0$ *and* the interval runs to ∞. The rule is to split off each bad place. Split at $x = 1$:

$$\int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}\,(1+x)} = \int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}\,(1+x)} + \int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}\,(1+x)},$$

and demand both converge. Substitute $x = u^2$, $\mathrm{d}x = 2u\,\mathrm{d}u$, so $\sqrt{x} = u$:

$$\int \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}\,(1+x)} = \int \frac{2u\,\mathrm{d}u}{u\,(1+u^2)} = 2\int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{1+u^2} = 2\arctan u = 2\arctan\sqrt{x}.$$

Now evaluate each piece through its limit. On $[0, 1]$: $2\arctan 1 - \lim_{\varepsilon\to 0^+} 2\arctan\sqrt{\varepsilon} = \frac{\pi}{2} - 0 = \frac{\pi}{2}$. On $[1, \infty)$: $\lim_{t\to\infty} 2\arctan\sqrt{t} - 2\arctan 1 = \pi - \frac{\pi}{2} = \frac{\pi}{2}$. Both pieces converge, so

$$\int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}\,(1+x)} = \frac{\pi}{2} + \frac{\pi}{2} = \pi.$$

The substitution *absorbed* both singularities at once, turning a doubly improper integral into a single tidy arctangent.

Why the technique works

Why was it legitimate to use the antiderivative $2\arctan\sqrt{x}$ and just plug in the endpoints 0 and ∞, instead of writing the ε and t limits explicitly? Because once you have a single antiderivative that is *continuous all the way down to (and out to) the bad points* – and $2\arctan\sqrt{x}$ is, it has finite one-sided limits 0 and π – the limit operations reduce to evaluating those limits of the antiderivative. The ε and t are still there; you have just done them in your head. The danger, as the $\int_{-1}^1 \mathrm{d}x/x^2$ trap showed, is using an antiderivative that is *not* continuous across the singularity. When the antiderivative behaves nicely at the boundary, the shortcut is safe; when it blows up there, you must keep the limits explicit and check convergence.

25.9 What we built

We extended the integral past its original home – bounded functions on bounded intervals – by the single device of *taking a limit of ordinary integrals.*

- **First kind** (infinite interval): $\int_a^\infty f = \lim_{t\to\infty} \int_a^t f$. Split doubly-infinite integrals into independent halves; never use a symmetric straddling limit.
- **Second kind** (unbounded integrand): back off from the singularity by ε and let $\varepsilon \to 0^+$. Watch for *interior* singularities that hide inside an innocent-looking interval.

- **The p-tests**, the two yardsticks: $\int_1^\infty dx/x^p$ converges iff $p > 1$; $\int_0^1 dx/x^p$ converges iff $p < 1$. The inequality flips because the two ends reward opposite behavior.
- **Comparison and limit comparison** settle convergence even with no antiderivative: trap your curve under a finite ceiling or over an infinite floor; or match its leading behavior to a known p-integral.
- **Absolute convergence** handles sign-changing integrands: if $\int|f|$ converges (checkable by comparison), so does $\int f$.
- **The surprises** – finite area under an infinite curve, finite volume inside Gabriel's Horn's infinite surface – are not paradoxes but lessons: area, length, volume, and surface are genuinely independent measurements, and the infinite must be *computed*, never guessed.

The deepest takeaway is a habit of mind: an improper integral is never evaluated "at infinity" or "at the spike." It is always an ordinary finite integral with a limit wrapped around it. Keep the two steps separate, ask whether the tail is thinner or fatter than $1/x$, and the entire subject organizes itself around that one borderline curve.

25.10 Applications and next steps

Connection

Improper integrals extend integration to unbounded intervals and unbounded functions, making them essential across physics, probability, and analysis:

- *Probability:* Continuous probability distributions over unbounded domains, such as the normal distribution $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}\sigma} e^{-(x-\mu)^2/(2\sigma^2)}\,dx = 1$, are defined by improper integrals.
- *Physics:* Gravitational potential energy $U(r) = -\int_r^\infty \frac{GMm}{s^2}\,ds = -\frac{GMm}{r}$, electrostatic potentials, and escape velocity calculations integrate force over infinite paths.
- *Integral transforms:* The Laplace and Fourier transforms integrate functions against decaying exponentials or sinusoids over unbounded domains.

In the next chapter, we apply integration to geometry and physics—computing volumes, arc lengths, surface areas, and work. Later chapters develop numerical integration for integrands without elementary antiderivatives (Chapter 27), build the theory of sequences (Chapter 28), and study the discrete analogue of improper integrals in infinite series (Chapter 29).

25.11 Exercises

Exercise 25.1 (Direct evaluation, first kind)**.** Evaluate each by integrating to a finite wall and taking the limit, or show it diverges:

$$\text{(a)} \int_2^\infty \frac{dx}{x^3}, \qquad \text{(b)} \int_0^\infty e^{-3x}\,dx, \qquad \text{(c)} \int_1^\infty \frac{dx}{x^{4/5}}.$$

Exercise 25.2 (Direct evaluation, second kind)**.** Evaluate or show divergence, being explicit about where the integrand blows up:

$$\text{(a)}\ \int_0^4 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x}}, \qquad \text{(b)}\ \int_0^1 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^{3/2}}, \qquad \text{(c)}\ \int_0^2 \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{(x-2)^{2/3}}.$$

Exercise 25.3 (The hidden interior singularity)**.** A student computes $\int_{-2}^{2} \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^4}$ by writing $\left[-\frac{1}{3x^3}\right]_{-2}^{2}$ and reports a finite number. Explain in one or two sentences why the answer is wrong, identify the singularity, and determine the correct status (converge to what, or diverge?).

Exercise 25.4 (Comparison test)**.** Use the (plain) comparison test to decide convergence. State clearly which known integral you compare to and in which direction.

$$\text{(a)}\ \int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^3+5}, \qquad \text{(b)}\ \int_1^\infty \frac{2+\cos x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \text{(c)}\ \int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x^4+1}}.$$

Exercise 25.5 (Limit comparison)**.** Use limit comparison against a suitable $1/x^p$ to decide convergence:

$$\text{(a)}\ \int_1^\infty \frac{x+1}{x^3-x+2}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \text{(b)}\ \int_1^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\sqrt{x^2+3x}}.$$

Exercise 25.6 (Absolute convergence)**.** Show that $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{\cos x}{x^2+x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ converges by proving it converges absolutely. (Bound $|\cos x|$ and compare.)

Exercise 25.7 (The p-spectrum at both ends)**.** Explain, using both p-tests, why $\displaystyle\int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x^p}$ diverges for *every* real p. (Split at $x=1$ and analyze each piece; show no single p saves both.)

Exercise 25.8 (Gabriel's Horn, your turn)**.** Repeat the Gabriel's-Horn computation for the curve $y = 1/x^2$, $x \geq 1$, revolved about the x-axis. (a) Show the volume $\int_1^\infty \pi(1/x^2)^2\,\mathrm{d}x$ is finite and find it. (b) Explain why the lower bound $\sqrt{1+(y')^2} \geq 1$ fails to decide convergence, and decide whether the surface area $\int_1^\infty 2\pi\,\frac{1}{x^2}\sqrt{1+(y')^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ converges or diverges this time. (Hint: the square root $\sqrt{1+(2/x^3)^2}$ is bounded for $x \geq 1$, so compare to $\int_1^\infty 2\pi/x^2$.) Contrast with the $y = 1/x$ horn: why does this one *not* give the paradox?

Exercise 25.9 (Proving the Limit Comparison Test)**.** Suppose $f, g > 0$ on the interval $[a, \infty)$ and $\lim_{x\to\infty} f(x)/g(x) = L$ with $0 < L < \infty$. Using the definition of the limit, show that there is some X beyond which $\frac{L}{2}\,g(x) \leq f(x) \leq 2L\,g(x)$. Then invoke the plain comparison test (twice) to conclude $\int f$ and $\int g$ share the same fate. (This is a clean, complete proof – write out both directions.)

Exercise 25.10 (A convergence that needs L'Hôpital)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\int_1^\infty \frac{\ln x}{x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$. Integrate by parts to the wall t, then take $t \to \infty$, using $\lim_{t\to\infty} \frac{\ln t}{t} = 0$. (Answer: 1.)

Exercise 25.11 (Conceptual: why split?)**.** In two or three sentences, explain why $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x\,\mathrm{d}x$ is said to diverge even though $\lim_{t\to\infty} \int_{-t}^{t} x\,\mathrm{d}x = 0$. What is the difference between the principal value and genuine convergence, and why do we insist on the stricter notion?

Exercise 25.12 (A surprise of your own making)**.** Find a continuous function f on $[1, \infty)$ that does *not* tend to zero as $x \to \infty$, yet has $\int_1^\infty f\,\mathrm{d}x$ convergent. (Hint: tall thin spikes. Put a triangular spike of height 1 and base width $1/2^n$ centered at $x = n$. The integrand keeps hitting 1 – so it fails to go to zero pointwise everywhere – yet the total area is a convergent geometric series. This shows the "$f \to 0$" folklore is not even necessary in the strict pointwise sense; only the *tail area* must vanish.)

Chapter 26

Applications of Integration

So far we have focused on what an integral means and how to evaluate one – from Riemann sums and the Fundamental Theorem through substitution, parts, partial fractions, and improper limits. Now we turn the question around: given a geometric shape or a physical process, how do we recognize it as an integral in the first place?

Areas between curves, volumes of solids, lengths of curved paths, surface areas, mechanical work, and continuous probabilities all yield to the same method.

Underlying each application is a single idea:

To integrate something is to add up infinitely many infinitely thin slices.

Every problem here is solved the same way. You ask one question: *what am I accumulating?* You cut the thing you want into thin slices, you write down the amount in one representative slice – always of the form (something) $\mathrm{d}x$ – and then you let the integral sign add them all up. The whole art is in finding the slice. The integral does the rest.

So this is not really a chapter of formulas. It is a chapter of *one* formula, $\int(\text{slice}) = \text{total}$, applied over and over until the move becomes second nature. We begin where the integral itself began: with area.

26.1 The One Move: Slice, Measure, Sum

Here is the three-step procedure we will use throughout the chapter.

Focus

The slicing recipe. To compute a total quantity Q by integration:

1. **Slice.** Cut the region (or solid, or curve, or process) into thin pieces indexed by a variable, say x, with thickness $\mathrm{d}x$.
2. **Measure.** Find the amount $\mathrm{d}Q$ contributed by one slice. It will look like $\mathrm{d}Q =$ (some function of x) $\mathrm{d}x$. This is the only creative step.

3. **Sum.** Add the slices: $Q = \int_a^b \mathrm{d}Q$, where a and b are the smallest and largest values of the slicing variable.

Why does this work at all? Because that is the foundational meaning of the definite integral:

$$\int_a^b g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;=\; \lim_{n\to\infty} \sum_{k=1}^{n} g(x_k^*)\,\Delta x,$$

a limit of Riemann sums – approximations formed by chopping an interval into n subintervals of width $\Delta x = (b-a)/n$ and evaluating the height at a sample point x_k^*. Each term $g(x_k^*)\,\Delta x$ is the contribution of one thin strip of width Δx. When we write "$\mathrm{d}Q = g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$" we are naming a single term of that sum, and "$\int \mathrm{d}Q$" is the instruction to take the limit of the sum. So the slicing recipe is not a trick layered on top of integration; it is integration, told as a story about pieces.

What is really happening

When a physicist writes $\mathrm{d}Q = g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ and then "integrates both sides," what is really happening is *not* that $\mathrm{d}x$ is a tiny number being multiplied. The precise statement is: the total Q is the limit of sums of slice-contributions, and each slice-contribution is approximately $g(x_k)\,\Delta x$, with the approximation getting perfect as $\Delta x \to 0$. The differential notation $\mathrm{d}Q = g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ is just shorthand for "the rate at which Q accumulates per unit of x is $g(x)$." The error you make in one slice by treating it as a perfect rectangle is of *higher order* – it shrinks faster than Δx itself – so it washes out completely in the limit. That higher-order vanishing is the entire reason the recipe is exact rather than merely approximate.

Keep that picture in mind. Now we make a slice, eight different ways.

26.2 Area Between Curves

The integral was born to measure the area under a single curve. The first generalization is almost too easy – the area *between* two curves.

Suppose $f(x) \geq g(x)$ on $[a, b]$, so the graph of f sits above the graph of g. What is the area of the region trapped between them? Slice it vertically.

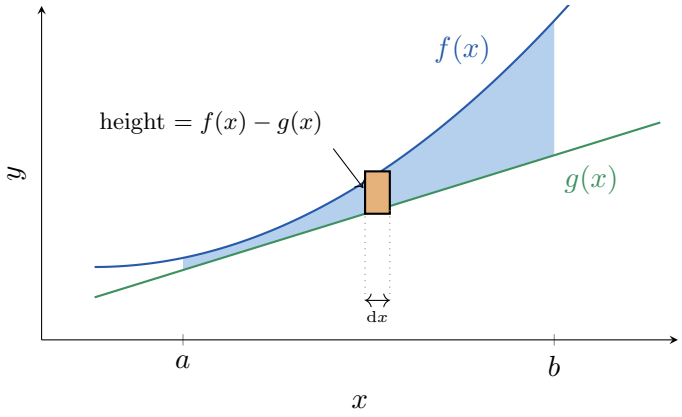


Figure 26.1: A vertical slice of the region between f (top) and g (bottom). One slice is a thin rectangle of width $\mathrm{d}x$ and height $f(x) - g(x)$.

Slice. A vertical strip at position x, thickness $\mathrm{d}x$.

Measure. The strip is (almost) a rectangle. Its width is $\mathrm{d}x$ and its height is the vertical gap between the curves, $f(x) - g(x)$. So

$$\mathrm{d}A = \big(f(x) - g(x)\big)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Sum.

$$\boxed{A = \int_a^b \big(f(x) - g(x)\big)\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

That is the entire theory. We did not memorize a new formula so much as read it off the picture. The integrand is always (top minus bottom).

Common trap

Top minus bottom, not left limit minus right. The single most common error is forgetting which curve is on top, and getting a negative area. Area is positive. If you are not sure which function is larger on the interval, test one point: plug in a value of x between a and b and see which output is bigger. A second classic trap: if the curves *cross* inside $[a, b]$, the top and bottom switch. Then you must split the integral at the crossing points and use $|f - g|$ on each piece. Sketch first, always.

Example 26.1 (Area between a parabola and a line)**.** Find the area enclosed between $y = x^2$ and $y = x + 2$.

First, where do they meet? Set $x^2 = x + 2$, i.e. $x^2 - x - 2 = 0$, i.e. $(x - 2)(x + 1) = 0$. The curves cross at $x = -1$ and $x = 2$. Between those points, which is on top? Test $x = 0$: the parabola gives 0, the line gives 2. The line is on top. So

$$A = \int_{-1}^{2} \big[(x + 2) - x^2\big]\,\mathrm{d}x = \left[\frac{x^2}{2} + 2x - \frac{x^3}{3}\right]_{-1}^{2}.$$

At $x = 2$: $2 + 4 - \frac{8}{3} = 6 - \frac{8}{3} = \frac{10}{3}$. At $x = -1$: $\frac{1}{2} - 2 + \frac{1}{3} = \frac{3}{6} - \frac{12}{6} + \frac{2}{6} = -\frac{7}{6}$. Subtracting,

$$A = \frac{10}{3} - \left(-\frac{7}{6}\right) = \frac{20}{6} + \frac{7}{6} = \frac{27}{6} = \frac{9}{2}.$$

The enclosed area is $\frac{9}{2}$.

26.2.1 Slicing the other way

Sometimes a region is easier to describe by horizontal strips – when the boundaries are naturally functions of y rather than x. Then you slice horizontally: a strip at height y has thickness $\mathrm{d}y$ and width (right curve) minus (left curve) (Figure 26.2), both expressed as functions of y. The area is

$$A = \int_c^d \big(x_{\text{right}}(y) - x_{\text{left}}(y)\big)\,\mathrm{d}y.$$

It is the same recipe with the roles of x and y swapped. Choose whichever direction makes the slices simple.

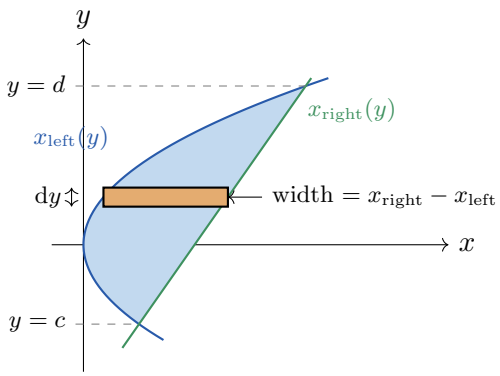


Figure 26.2: A horizontal slice of a region bounded by curves $x = x_{\text{left}}(y)$ and $x = x_{\text{right}}(y)$. One slice is a thin horizontal rectangle of height $\mathrm{d}y$ and width $x_{\text{right}}(y) - x_{\text{left}}(y)$.

Example 26.2 (Same region, horizontal slices)**.** Find the area enclosed by $x = y^2$ and $x = y + 2$.

Solving $y^2 = y + 2$ gives $y^2 - y - 2 = (y - 2)(y + 1) = 0$, so y runs from -1 to 2. For these y, the line $x = y + 2$ is to the right of the parabola $x = y^2$ (check $y = 0$: line gives 2, parabola gives 0). So

$$A = \int_{-1}^{2} \big[(y + 2) - y^2\big]\,\mathrm{d}y = \frac{9}{2},$$

identical to before – it is literally the same algebra. The lesson: pick the slicing direction that makes "right minus left" (or "top minus bottom") a single clean expression, so you never have to split the integral.

Walking question

Picture a region shaped like a sideways parabola, opening to the right, capped by a vertical line. If you slice it vertically, a single vertical strip can hit the parabola *twice* (top and bottom branches), forcing you to split the integral. Slice it horizontally and each strip hits one left edge and one right edge cleanly. Which way would you cut, and why does the geometry of the region – not any rule – decide for you?

26.3 Volumes by Slicing

Now lift the idea into three dimensions. The recipe does not change at all: cut the solid into thin slices, find the volume of one slice, integrate.

The cleanest case is slicing a solid by parallel planes. Imagine a loaf of bread. Cut it into thin slices perpendicular to the x-axis. A slice at position x is a flat slab of thickness $\mathrm{d}x$ whose flat face has some area $A(x)$. Its volume is (face area)$\times$(thickness):

$$\mathrm{d}V = A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \text{so} \qquad \boxed{V = \int_a^b A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

This is the general principle of volume by slicing, and *everything* that follows – disks, washers, even shells – is a special case of it. You only ever need to know the cross-sectional area $A(x)$ as a function of where you cut.

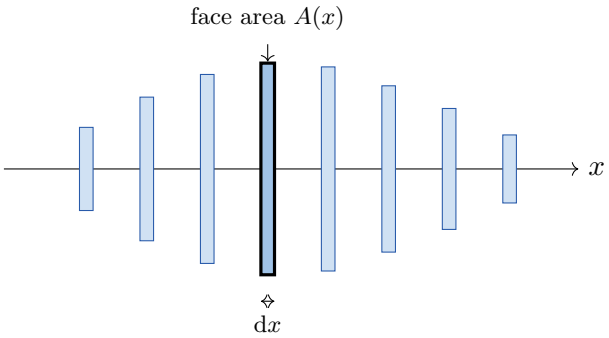


Figure 26.3: A solid cut into slabs perpendicular to the x-axis. One slab has volume $A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, where $A(x)$ is the area of its face.

Example 26.3 (A pyramid, derived from scratch)**.** A pyramid has a square base of side s and height h, apex directly above the center. Find its volume.

Put the apex at the origin and let x measure distance *down* from the apex, $0 \le x \le h$. At depth x the cross-section is a square. By similar triangles, the square's side grows linearly from 0 at the apex to s at the base: side $= s\,(x/h)$. So the cross-sectional area is

$$A(x) = \left(\frac{sx}{h}\right)^2 = \frac{s^2}{h^2}\,x^2.$$

Therefore

$$V = \int_0^h \frac{s^2}{h^2}\,x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{s^2}{h^2}\cdot\frac{x^3}{3}\Big|_0^h = \frac{s^2}{h^2}\cdot\frac{h^3}{3} = \frac{1}{3}s^2h.$$

This recovers the familiar formula: the volume of a pyramid is one-third base times height. The factor $\frac{1}{3}$ from elementary geometry arises directly from $\int_0^h x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{h^3}{3}$; because the cross-sectional area scales quadratically with depth, integrating x^2 produces the factor of $\frac{1}{3}$.

History

The factor of $\frac{1}{3}$ in the volume of a pyramid has a long history. In the 5th century BCE, Democritus conjectured that a pyramid has one-third the volume of a prism with the same base and height. Eudoxus (c. 370 BCE) and Archimedes (c. 250 BCE) proved this using the *method of exhaustion*: trapping the solid between inner and outer approximations of prisms and showing the difference vanishes in the limit. Archimedes also determined the volume of a sphere by balancing slices against a cone and cylinder.

In 1615, Johannes Kepler estimated the capacity of wine barrels by slicing them into thin circular disks. In 1635, Bonaventura Cavalieri generalized this into *Cavalieri's principle*: two solids have the same volume if all horizontal cross-sections at equal heights have equal areas. Cavalieri viewed a solid as a stack of two-dimensional planes. Critics questioned how zero-thickness planes could form a nonzero volume, but the method gave consistent results.

Calculus resolved this by replacing indivisible planes with differential slices: $\mathrm{d}V = A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ represents a rate of volume accumulation, integrated via an antiderivative.

26.3.1 Solids of revolution: the disk method

Now a very common special case: spin a region around an axis to sweep out a solid. If you revolve the region under $y = f(x)$ (above the x-axis, from a to b) about the x-axis, each vertical strip sweeps out a thin *disk* – a coin – of radius $f(x)$ and thickness $\mathrm{d}x$. A disk is just a cylinder, so its area is $\pi(\text{radius})^2$:

$$A(x) = \pi\,[f(x)]^2, \qquad \boxed{V = \pi \int_a^b [f(x)]^2\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

The disk method is simply volume by slicing when every cross-section is a circle.

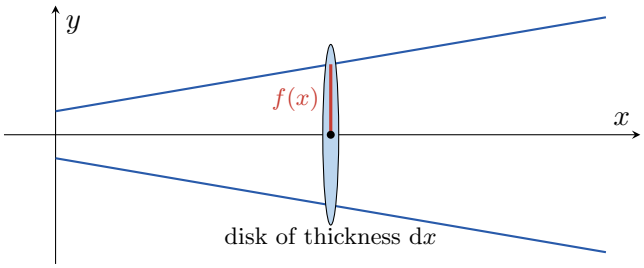


Figure 26.4: Revolving $y = f(x)$ about the x-axis. A vertical strip sweeps out a disk of radius $f(x)$; its volume is $\pi[f(x)]^2\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Example 26.4 (Volume of a sphere – Archimedes' tombstone)**.** Revolve the upper half of the circle $y = \sqrt{r^2 - x^2}$, from $x = -r$ to $x = r$, about the x-axis. You sweep out a solid ball of radius r. The disk at x has radius $\sqrt{r^2 - x^2}$, so

$$V = \pi \int_{-r}^{r} \left(\sqrt{r^2 - x^2}\right)^2 \mathrm{d}x = \pi \int_{-r}^{r} (r^2 - x^2)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The integrand is even, so integrate from 0 to r and double:

$$V = 2\pi \left[r^2 x - \frac{x^3}{3}\right]_0^r = 2\pi \left(r^3 - \frac{r^3}{3}\right) = 2\pi \cdot \frac{2r^3}{3} = \frac{4}{3}\pi r^3.$$

This derives the classical sphere volume $\frac{4}{3}\pi r^3$ directly.

26.3.2 Hollow solids: the washer method

What if the region you revolve does not touch the axis – if there is a gap? Then each slice is not a solid disk but a *washer*: a disk with a hole punched out. Revolve the region between $y = f(x)$ (outer) and $y = g(x)$ (inner), with $f \geq g \geq 0$, about the x-axis. The slice at x is an *annulus* – a flat ring, like a metal washer or a DVD, bounded by two concentric circles – with outer radius $f(x)$ and inner radius $g(x)$ (Figure 26.5). Its area is the big circle minus the little one:

$$A(x) = \pi[f(x)]^2 - \pi[g(x)]^2, \qquad \boxed{V = \pi \int_a^b \Big([f(x)]^2 - [g(x)]^2 \Big)\, \mathrm{d}x.}$$

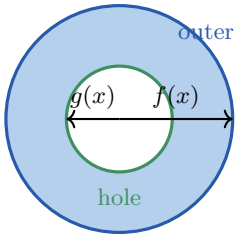


Figure 26.5: A washer cross-section: a disk of outer radius $f(x)$ with a concentric hole of inner radius $g(x)$ punched out. Its area is $\pi[f(x)]^2 - \pi[g(x)]^2$.

Common trap

Square first, then subtract – never the other way. The washer area is $\pi(R^2 - r^2)$, *not* $\pi(R - r)^2$. The annulus is the difference of two *areas*, so you square each radius and then subtract. Writing $\pi \int (f - g)^2$ is a wrong answer that looks plausible; it computes a solid of a completely different shape. Always: outer radius squared minus inner radius squared.

Example 26.5 (A washer volume)**.** Revolve the region between $y = x$ and $y = x^2$ (for $0 \leq x \leq 1$) about the x-axis. On this interval $x \geq x^2$, so the outer radius is $f(x) = x$ and the inner radius is $g(x) = x^2$. Then

$$V = \pi \int_0^1 (x^2 - x^4)\, \mathrm{d}x = \pi \left[\frac{x^3}{3} - \frac{x^5}{5} \right]_0^1 = \pi \left(\frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{5} \right) = \pi \cdot \frac{2}{15} = \frac{2\pi}{15}.$$

26.3.3 The shell method: slicing parallel to the axis

There is a second way to slice a solid of revolution, and it is worth seeing because it pushes the slicing idea a level deeper. Instead of cutting *across* the axis into disks, cut *around* the axis into nested cylindrical shells – think of the rings of a tree, or a set of nesting tin cans.

Revolve the region under $y = f(x)$, from $x = a$ to $x = b$, about the *y-axis*. Take a thin vertical strip at position x, width $\mathrm{d}x$, height $f(x)$. When this strip revolves around the y-axis it sweeps out a thin cylindrical shell of radius x and height $f(x)$.

Now, what is the volume of a thin shell? *Unroll it.* A thin cylindrical shell of radius x, height $f(x)$, and thickness $\mathrm{d}x$, slit open and flattened, is a thin rectangular slab. Its dimensions are:

- length = circumference of the shell = $2\pi x$,
- height = $f(x)$,
- thickness = $\mathrm{d}x$.

So its volume is

$$\mathrm{d}V = \underbrace{2\pi x}_{\text{circumference}} \cdot \underbrace{f(x)}_{\text{height}} \cdot \underbrace{\mathrm{d}x}_{\text{thickness}},$$

and summing the shells,

$$\boxed{V = \int_a^b 2\pi x\, f(x)\, \mathrm{d}x.}$$

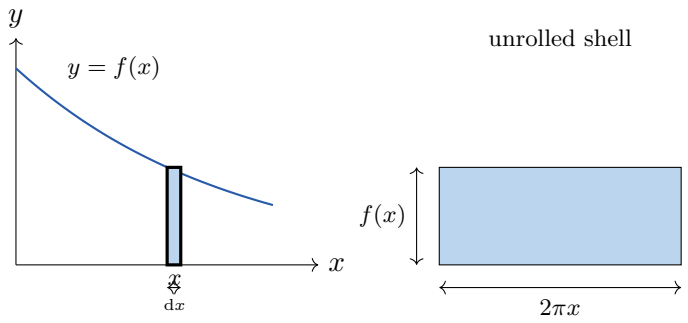


Figure 26.6: The shell method. A vertical strip at x revolves into a cylindrical shell; unrolled, the shell is a slab of dimensions $2\pi x$ by $f(x)$ by $\mathrm{d}x$.

Why the technique works

Why "unrolling" is legitimate. A real cylindrical shell is not a flat slab – its outer face ($2\pi(x+\mathrm{d}x)$ around) is slightly longer than its inner face ($2\pi x$ around). So why may we use the single circumference $2\pi x$? Write the exact shell volume as the difference of two cylinders:

$$\mathrm{d}V = \pi(x+\mathrm{d}x)^2 f(x) - \pi x^2 f(x) = \pi f(x)\big(2x\,\mathrm{d}x + (\mathrm{d}x)^2\big) = 2\pi x\, f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x + \pi f(x)(\mathrm{d}x)^2.$$

The leading term is exactly $2\pi x\, f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. The correction $\pi f(x)(\mathrm{d}x)^2$ involves $(\mathrm{d}x)^2$ – it is *higher order*, shrinking faster than $\mathrm{d}x$ – so when we sum and take the limit it contributes nothing. This is the same higher-order-vanishing that justified treating an area strip as a perfect rectangle. Unrolling is legitimate because the discrepancy between the inner and outer circumferences is a second-order effect.

Example 26.6 (Same solid, two methods)**.** Revolve the region under $y = x^2$, from $x = 0$ to $x = 2$, about the y-axis.

By shells (slicing parallel to the y-axis):

$$V = \int_0^2 2\pi x \cdot x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = 2\pi \int_0^2 x^3\,\mathrm{d}x = 2\pi \cdot \frac{x^4}{4}\Big|_0^2 = 2\pi \cdot 4 = 8\pi.$$

By washers, to check, we slice perpendicular to the y-axis. Here y runs from 0 to 4; at height y the solid is the region between the curve $x = \sqrt{y}$ and the line $x = 2$, revolved, giving outer radius 2 and inner radius $\sqrt{y}$:

$$V = \pi \int_0^4 \left(2^2 - (\sqrt{y})^2\right) \mathrm{d}y = \pi \int_0^4 (4 - y)\, \mathrm{d}y = \pi \left[4y - \frac{y^2}{2}\right]_0^4 = \pi(16 - 8) = 8\pi.$$

The two methods agree, as they must. Notice how shells here avoided having to solve for x in terms of y. *That* is when you reach for shells: choose the method whose slices are easy to describe.

Intuition

A pocket rule for choosing. Ask: in which direction are my slices parallel to the axis of rotation? Slices *perpendicular* to the axis are disks/washers; slices *parallel* to the axis are shells. Then ask which description of the boundary is simpler. Revolving around the y-axis a region given as $y = f(x)$? Vertical strips are parallel to the axis, so shells let you keep the natural variable x – no algebraic gymnastics. The methods never disagree; one is just less work.

26.3.4 The Pappus–Guldin Theorems: Revolution via Centroids

Connection

Before calculus gave us disks and shells, the ancient Greek geometer *Pappus of Alexandria* (c. 320 CE, in Book VII of his *Collection*) discovered a shortcut for solids of revolution, later rediscovered and popularized by the Swiss mathematician *Paul Guldin* in 1640.
Suppose a plane region of area A is revolved about an external axis in the same plane (touching at most the boundary, never cutting through the interior). Its geometric center of mass – the *centroid* $(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$, where the flat shape would balance on a pin – sits at some perpendicular distance d from that axis. The **Pappus–Guldin Centroid Theorems** state that the swept volume equals the area A times the circumference $2\pi d$ traveled by the centroid:

$$V = (2\pi d)\, A.$$

Similarly, revolving a curve of arc length L about an external axis sweeps out surface area

$$S = (2\pi d_{\text{curve}})\, L,$$

where d_{curve} is the distance from the curve's centroid to the axis. Why does this work? For a region under $y = f(x)$ revolved about the y-axis, the centroid's distance to the axis is $d = \bar{x} = \frac{1}{A}\int_a^b x f(x)\, \mathrm{d}x$. The shell integral is $\int_a^b 2\pi x f(x)\, \mathrm{d}x = 2\pi \int_a^b x f(x)\, \mathrm{d}x = 2\pi \bar{x} A = (2\pi d)A$: the shell method *is* Pappus's theorem, written slice by slice.

26.4 Arc Length: Accumulating Distance

So far we have accumulated area and volume. Now accumulate *length*. How long is a curve $y = f(x)$ from $x = a$ to $x = b$?

Slice. Cut the curve into tiny pieces. Over a sliver of horizontal width $\mathrm{d}x$, the curve rises by $\mathrm{d}y$. The piece of curve is so short that it is essentially straight – a tiny line segment (smooth means locally straight, the refrain of this whole book).

Measure. That little segment is the hypotenuse of a right triangle with legs $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$. Pythagoras gives its length:

$$\mathrm{d}s = \sqrt{(\mathrm{d}x)^2 + (\mathrm{d}y)^2}.$$

Factor out $\mathrm{d}x$ to express everything in terms of the slope:

$$\mathrm{d}s = \sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}\right)^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Sum.

$$\boxed{L = \int_a^b \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2}\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

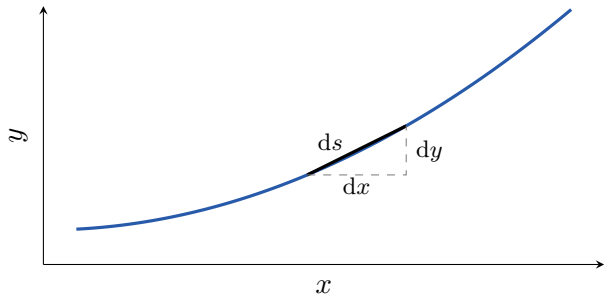


Figure 26.7: A short piece of curve is the hypotenuse of a triangle with legs $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$. Its length is $\mathrm{d}s = \sqrt{(\mathrm{d}x)^2 + (\mathrm{d}y)^2}$.

What is really happening

The symbol $\mathrm{d}s = \sqrt{(\mathrm{d}x)^2 + (\mathrm{d}y)^2}$ is the infinitesimal version of the distance formula. What is really happening: we replace the curve by an inscribed polygon – a chain of straight chords – and add up the chord lengths. Each chord has length $\sqrt{(\Delta x)^2 + (\Delta y)^2}$. As the chords get shorter the polygon hugs the curve, and the sum of chord lengths approaches the arc length. The formula is just that limit written compactly. Arc length is the total "ground covered," integrating the local stretch factor $\sqrt{1 + (f')^2}$ that tells you how much real distance you travel per unit of horizontal travel.

Common trap

The square root usually fights back. Arc-length integrands are notoriously ugly: $\sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2}$ rarely has an elementary antiderivative. Even for $y = x^2$ you get $\int \sqrt{1 + 4x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$, which needs a trig or hyperbolic substitution. Authors of textbook problems rig f so the radical collapses to a perfect square. In real life you reach for numerical integration. Do not be alarmed when an arc-length integral looks intractable – that is the normal state of affairs, not a sign you set it up wrong.

Example 26.7 (A length that actually works out)**.** Find the arc length of $y = \frac{2}{3}x^{3/2}$ from $x = 0$ to $x = 3$. Then $f'(x) = x^{1/2}$, so $[f'(x)]^2 = x$, and

$$L = \int_0^3 \sqrt{1+x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{2}{3}(1+x)^{3/2}\Big|_0^3 = \frac{2}{3}\big(4^{3/2}-1\big) = \frac{2}{3}(8-1) = \frac{14}{3}.$$

The radical simplified because $1+[f'(x)]^2 = 1+x$ is linear in x, which allows a direct u-substitution.

Pause

Pause and think: does the formula work for a straight line? Consider a line $y = mx+c$ on $[a, b]$. The derivative is constant: $f'(x) = m$. Plugging this into the arc length formula gives

$$L = \int_a^b \sqrt{1+m^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \sqrt{1+m^2}\,(b-a).$$

Now look at the right triangle under the segment: its horizontal run is $\Delta x = b-a$ and its vertical rise is $\Delta y = m(b-a)$. The Pythagorean theorem gives the hypotenuse as $\sqrt{(\Delta x)^2+(\Delta y)^2} = \sqrt{(b-a)^2+m^2(b-a)^2} = \sqrt{1+m^2}\,(b-a)$. The calculus formula gives the exact Pythagorean length. The integral does not replace geometry; it applies ordinary Pythagoras slice-by-slice where the slope $f'(x)$ is constantly bending.

Connection

The little relation $\mathrm{d}s = \sqrt{(\mathrm{d}x)^2+(\mathrm{d}y)^2}$ is the seed of an enormous subject. In physics, dividing by $\mathrm{d}t$ gives speed $\frac{\mathrm{d}s}{\mathrm{d}t} = \sqrt{\dot{x}^2+\dot{y}^2}$ – the magnitude of the velocity vector. In differential geometry, the rule for measuring $\mathrm{d}s$ at each point is called the *metric*, and replacing the flat Pythagorean $\mathrm{d}s^2 = \mathrm{d}x^2+\mathrm{d}y^2$ with a position-dependent rule is precisely how Einstein's general relativity encodes curved spacetime. Arc length is your first encounter with a metric.

26.5 Surface Area of Revolution

Combine the last two ideas. Revolve the curve $y = f(x)$ about the x-axis and ask for the *area of the surface* it sweeps out – the skin of the solid, not its volume.

Slice. A tiny arc of the curve, of length $\mathrm{d}s$, at horizontal position x and height $f(x)$.

Measure. When that little arc revolves around the x-axis it traces a thin *band* – a ribbon (Figure 26.8). The ribbon is a tiny strip wrapped in a circle of radius $f(x)$ (the distance from the curve to the axis). Its circumference is $2\pi f(x)$ and its width is the arc length $\mathrm{d}s$. So its area is

$$\mathrm{d}S = 2\pi\, f(x)\,\mathrm{d}s = 2\pi f(x)\sqrt{1+[f'(x)]^2}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Sum.

$$\boxed{S = \int_a^b 2\pi\, f(x)\sqrt{1+[f'(x)]^2}\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

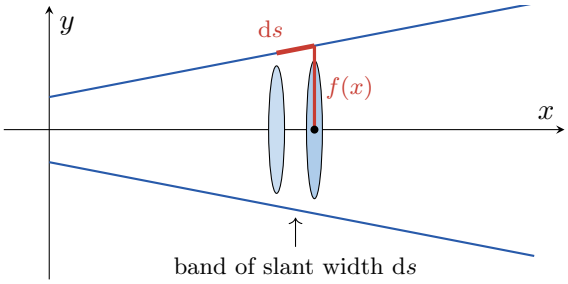


Figure 26.8: Revolving $y = f(x)$ about the x-axis. A short arc of length $\mathrm{d}s$ sweeps out a band of radius $f(x)$; its area is $2\pi f(x)\,\mathrm{d}s$.

Why the technique works

Why $2\pi f(x)\,\mathrm{d}s$ and not $2\pi f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$? A natural instinct is to multiply the circumference $2\pi f(x)$ by the horizontal width $\mathrm{d}x$. That is wrong, and the reason is geometric. The little band is not a vertical cylinder; it is a slanted *frustum* of a cone – the shape of a lampshade or a drinking cup with the bottom cut open – because the curve is rising. Its slant width is the *arc length* $\mathrm{d}s$, which is longer than $\mathrm{d}x$ whenever the curve has any slope. Using $\mathrm{d}x$ would systematically undercount the surface – it ignores the tilt. A conical frustum with end radii r_1, r_2 and slant width ℓ has exact lateral area $2\pi\frac{r_1+r_2}{2}\,\ell$. Over a thin slice $[x, x+\Delta x]$, the average radius $\frac{f(x)+f(x+\Delta x)}{2}$ approaches $f(x)$ (the discrepancy vanishes in the limit), whereas the slant width $\Delta s \approx \sqrt{1+[f'(x)]^2}\,\Delta x$ differs from Δx by the factor $\sqrt{1+[f'(x)]^2}$, which does *not* approach 1. That is why the circumference $2\pi f(x)$ must multiply $\mathrm{d}s$, never $\mathrm{d}x$.

Example 26.8 (Surface area of a sphere)**.** Revolve $y = \sqrt{r^2 - x^2}$, from $x = -r$ to $x = r$, about the x-axis. We have $f(x) = \sqrt{r^2 - x^2}$ and

$$f'(x) = \frac{-x}{\sqrt{r^2 - x^2}}, \qquad 1 + [f'(x)]^2 = 1 + \frac{x^2}{r^2 - x^2} = \frac{r^2}{r^2 - x^2}.$$

The radical is therefore $\sqrt{1+[f']^2} = \dfrac{r}{\sqrt{r^2 - x^2}}$, giving

$$\mathrm{d}S = 2\pi\sqrt{r^2 - x^2} \cdot \frac{r}{\sqrt{r^2 - x^2}}\,\mathrm{d}x = 2\pi r\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The square roots cancel cleanly, leaving a constant. Then

$$S = \int_{-r}^{r} 2\pi r\,\mathrm{d}x = 2\pi r \cdot (2r) = 4\pi r^2.$$

The surface area of a sphere is $4\pi r^2$.

Why this matters

The cancellation in that calculation reflects an exact geometric theorem known to Archimedes. Because $\mathrm{d}S = 2\pi r\,\mathrm{d}x$ is constant with respect to x, slices of a sphere between parallel planes have surface area proportional strictly to the axial thickness Δx, regardless of where along the axis the slice is taken. A spherical cap near a pole and a band near the equator have equal

surface areas provided they span the same axial height. This is *Archimedes' hat-box theorem*: a sphere and its circumscribed cylinder, cut by two planes perpendicular to the cylinder's axis, have equal lateral surface areas between those planes. This property provides the foundation for the Lambert cylindrical equal-area projection in cartography.

26.6 Work: Accumulating Force Over Distance

We leave geometry and integrate a physical process. In physics, *work* is force times distance – but only when the force is constant. What if the force changes as the object moves? Slice the motion.

Slice. Break the path into tiny displacements $\mathrm{d}x$.

Measure. Over a displacement so small that the force $F(x)$ barely changes, the work done is $(\text{force}) \times (\text{distance}) = F(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$.

Sum.

$$\boxed{W = \int_a^b F(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

Work is the accumulation of force over distance. This is the prototype of every "integrate a varying rate" problem in science.

Example 26.9 (Stretching a spring – Hooke's law)**.** A spring resists stretching with a force proportional to how far it is stretched: $F(x) = kx$ (Hooke's law), where k is the spring constant. How much work does it take to stretch the spring from its natural length to a displacement $x = d$?

The force is not constant – it grows as you pull – so you must integrate:

$$W = \int_0^d kx\,\mathrm{d}x = k \cdot \frac{x^2}{2}\Big|_0^d = \frac{1}{2}kd^2.$$

The $\frac{1}{2}$ appears for the same reason it always does: you are summing a linearly growing quantity, and the average of a quantity that ramps from 0 to kd is $\frac{1}{2}kd$. Work = average force times distance = $\frac{1}{2}kd \cdot d$. The integral and the averaging picture agree.

Connection

Work across an infinite horizon. What if the force extends outward indefinitely? In Chapter 25 you learned how to evaluate improper integrals over unbounded intervals. Consider Newton's law of universal gravitation: the attractive force on a spacecraft of mass m at distance r from the center of a planet of mass M is $F(r) = \frac{GMm}{r^2}$. How much work is required to haul the spacecraft from the planet's surface at radius R completely free of its gravitational field? The displacement stretches to infinity, so the work is an improper integral:

$$W = \int_R^\infty \frac{GMm}{r^2}\,\mathrm{d}r = \lim_{b\to\infty}\left[-\frac{GMm}{r}\right]_R^b = 0 - \left(-\frac{GMm}{R}\right) = \frac{GMm}{R}.$$

Because the $1/r^2$ force drops off quickly enough, the infinite stretch of space costs only a finite expenditure of energy. Setting this work equal to the spacecraft's initial kinetic energy $\frac{1}{2}mv_{\text{esc}}^2$ yields the famous escape velocity formula $v_{\text{esc}} = \sqrt{2GM/R}$. Because gravity falls off as $1/r^2$

($p = 2 > 1$), the improper integral converges and a finite launch speed suffices to escape.

26.6.1 Pumping problems: when the slices are layers of fluid

The richest work problems involve pumping liquid out of a tank. Here the slicing is subtle and worth dwelling on, because *each slice is a different amount of stuff that has to move a different distance.*

The setup: a tank holds water; you must pump it all up and out over the top rim. Slice the water into thin horizontal layers. Consider one layer at height y, thickness $\mathrm{d}y$.

How much does this layer weigh? Its volume is (cross-sectional area at height y) times thickness, $A(y)\,\mathrm{d}y$. Multiply by the weight density of the fluid ρg (for water, about 9800 $\mathrm{N/m^3}$, or in US units the weight density is about 62.4 $\mathrm{lb/ft^3}$). So the layer's weight is $\rho g\, A(y)\,\mathrm{d}y$.

How far must this layer move? If the water exits at height H, this layer must rise a distance $(H - y)$.

Work to lift this one layer = weight × distance:

$$\mathrm{d}W = \rho g\, A(y)\,(H - y)\,\mathrm{d}y.$$

Sum over all layers:

$$\boxed{W = \rho g \int_{y_{\min}}^{y_{\max}} A(y)\,(H - y)\,\mathrm{d}y.}$$

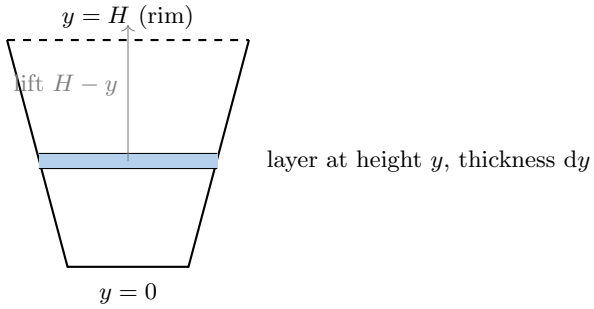


Figure 26.9: Pumping a tank. A horizontal layer at height y weighs $\rho g A(y)\,\mathrm{d}y$ and must be lifted a distance $H - y$ to clear the rim.

Common trap

The two quantities that vary are easy to confuse. In a pumping problem *two* things depend on the slice: how much water is in the layer (through $A(y)$) and how far it travels (through $H - y$). Beginners get one and forget the other – using a constant cross-section for a cone, or forgetting that lower layers must travel farther. Always write both factors explicitly and ask, for a test layer, "is this the weight? is this the distance?" Also: the lift distance is measured to the *exit point*, which may be above the tank's rim if there is a spout. Read the geometry carefully.

Example 26.10 (Pumping a cylindrical tank)**.** A cylindrical tank, radius 2 m and height 5 m, is full of water. Find the work to pump all the water out over the top rim. Use $\rho g = 9800\ \text{N/m}^3$.

Put $y = 0$ at the bottom, $y = 5$ at the rim, so $H = 5$. The cross-section is a constant disk of area $A(y) = \pi(2)^2 = 4\pi$. A layer at height y must rise $(5 - y)$. So

$$W = 9800 \int_0^5 4\pi\,(5 - y)\,\mathrm{d}y = 9800 \cdot 4\pi \left[5y - \frac{y^2}{2}\right]_0^5.$$

The bracket is $25 - \frac{25}{2} = \frac{25}{2}$. Hence

$$W = 9800 \cdot 4\pi \cdot \frac{25}{2} = 9800 \cdot 50\pi = 490{,}000\,\pi \approx 1.54 \times 10^6\ \text{J}.$$

About 1.5 million joules. Notice that even though every layer weighs the same (constant cross-section), they do *not* all do the same work, because the lower layers must be lifted farther – the $(5 - y)$ factor does the bookkeeping.

Work it yourself

Redo Example 26.10 but pump the water to a spout 1 m above the rim, so $H = 6$. You should only need to change one number and re-evaluate $\int_0^5 (6-y)\,\mathrm{d}y = [6y - y^2/2]_0^5 = 30 - 12.5 = 17.5$. Confirm $W = 9800 \cdot 4\pi \cdot 17.5 = 686{,}000\,\pi \approx 2.16 \times 10^6$ J. Notice how much extra work that one meter of extra lift costs – and why: every single layer pays the surcharge.

26.7 Average Value of a Function

How do you average infinitely many numbers – all the values $f(x)$ takes as x ranges over $[a, b]$? The average of finitely many numbers is their sum divided by their count. For a continuous spread of values, the sum becomes an integral and the count becomes the length of the interval:

$$\boxed{\bar{f} = \frac{1}{b - a} \int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

Where does this come from? Sample f at n evenly spaced points and average:

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k) = \frac{1}{b - a} \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k)\,\frac{b - a}{n} = \frac{1}{b - a} \sum_{k=1}^{n} f(x_k)\,\Delta x.$$

We slipped $\Delta x = (b - a)/n$ in and out. As $n \to \infty$ the sum becomes the integral, giving the boxed formula. So the average value is the integral spread evenly over the interval.

Intuition

The average value $\bar{f}$ is the height of the rectangle, sitting on $[a, b]$, that has the *same area* as the region under f. You are flattening the bumpy graph into a level one without changing the total area underneath. Rearranged, $\bar{f}\,(b - a) = \int_a^b f$: average times width equals area. That is the cleanest way to remember it.

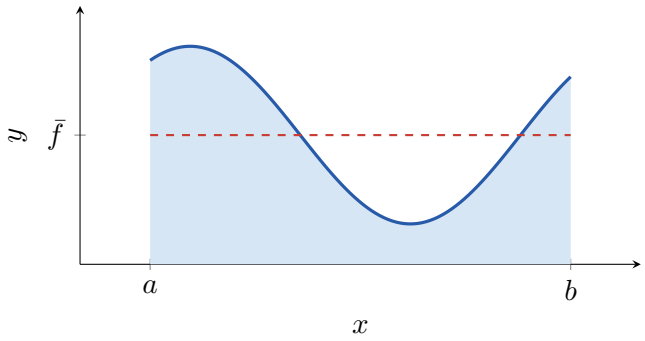


Figure 26.10: The average value $\bar{f}$ is the height of the level rectangle over $[a, b]$ whose area equals the area under f. The wiggles above the dashed line exactly fill the gaps below it.

Example 26.11 (Average value)**.** Find the average value of $f(x) = x^2$ on $[0, 3]$.

$$\bar{f} = \frac{1}{3-0}\int_0^3 x^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{3}\cdot\frac{x^3}{3}\Big|_0^3 = \frac{1}{3}\cdot 9 = 3.$$

The function climbs from 0 to 9, but because it spends most of the interval at smaller values, its average is only 3, well below $9/2$, the naive average of the two endpoint values 0 and 9. Averages of nonlinear functions are not the average of the endpoints – the shape matters.

Connection

The *Mean Value Theorem for Integrals* says that a continuous f actually *attains* its average value: there is some $c \in [a, b]$ with $f(c) = \bar{f}$. Geometrically, the curve must cross the level $\bar{f}$ line somewhere – it cannot be entirely above its own average. This is the integral cousin of the Mean Value Theorem for derivatives you met earlier; both say a continuous quantity must, somewhere, equal its average behavior.

26.8 A Preview of Probability Density

We finish with the application that integration was, in a sense, reinvented for in the twentieth century: *continuous probability*. The slicing idea here is so natural that probability almost forces it on you.

How do you describe the probability of a quantity that can take any real value – a person's exact height, the precise time a bus arrives, the energy of a molecule? You cannot assign positive probability to each single value, because there are uncountably many and they would sum to more than 1. The probability of the height being *exactly* $1.8000\ldots$ meters is zero. So instead you describe probability as something *spread out*, a density, and you accumulate it by integrating.

A **probability density function** (pdf) is a function $p(x) \geq 0$ with total integral 1:

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = 1.$$

Because the real line is unbounded, this total probability is itself an improper integral of the exact kind you explored in Chapter 25: the probability of all possibilities combined must converge to certainty.

The meaning of p is exactly the slicing meaning: the probability that the quantity lands in a tiny window $[x, x + \mathrm{d}x]$ is

$$\mathrm{d}(\text{prob}) = p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x,$$

and the probability of landing in any range $[a, b]$ is the accumulation of those slices (Figure 26.11):

$$\boxed{P(a \le X \le b) = \int_a^b p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.}$$

Probability corresponds directly to the area under the density curve.

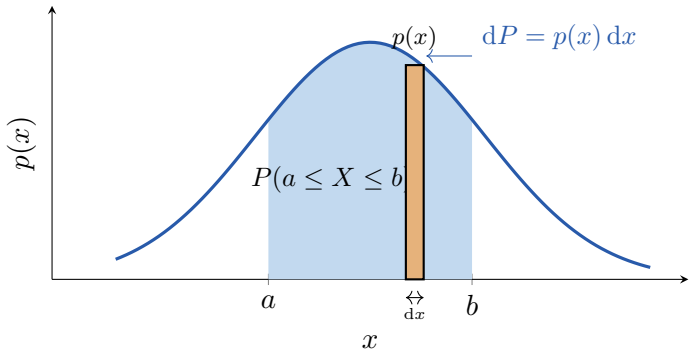


Figure 26.11: A continuous probability density $p(x)$. The probability of landing in the window $[a, b]$ is the accumulated area under the curve. A single infinitesimal slice carries probability $\mathrm{d}P = p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$.

What is really happening

A probability density measures probability *per unit length* rather than probability itself, just as mass density is mass per unit volume. By itself $p(x)$ can even exceed 1; what must stay ≤ 1 is the *area* $p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ accumulated over a region. This is why the units work and why "the probability of exactly x" is zero: a single point has width $\mathrm{d}x = 0$, so it carries area zero. Probability lives in the *accumulation*, never in the point. To get a real probability you must integrate the density across a window of nonzero width – you must collect a band of slices.

Example 26.12 (The uniform and exponential densities)**. Uniform on** $[0, L]$**.** A bus is equally likely to arrive at any time in $[0, L]$. The density is constant, $p(x) = 1/L$ on $[0, L]$ and 0 outside. Check: $\int_0^L \frac{1}{L}\,\mathrm{d}x = 1$. The probability the bus comes in the first third is $\int_0^{L/3} \frac{1}{L}\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{3}$ – area of a rectangle, exactly as intuition demands.

Exponential. The waiting time for a random event (a radioactive decay, a phone call) often follows $p(x) = \lambda e^{-\lambda x}$ for $x \ge 0$. First check it is a valid density. Because the domain $[0, \infty)$ is unbounded, this is an improper integral of the first kind (Chapter 25):

$$\int_0^\infty \lambda e^{-\lambda x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{b\to\infty}\Big[-e^{-\lambda x}\Big]_0^b = \lim_{b\to\infty}\big(-e^{-\lambda b} - (-1)\big) = 0 + 1 = 1.$$

The probability the event happens before time t is

$$P(X \le t) = \int_0^t \lambda e^{-\lambda x}\,\mathrm{d}x = 1 - e^{-\lambda t}.$$

At $t = 0$ this is 0; as $t \to \infty$ it climbs to 1. The accumulation of density sweeps from impossible to certain.

Application

The **expected value** (mean) of a continuous random variable is, once again, a slicing problem. To average x over the density, weight each value x by the probability $p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ sitting on it, and sum:

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x\,p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

This is the continuous analogue of $\sum(\text{value}) \times (\text{probability})$, and it is also exactly the formula for the *center of mass* of a rod whose mass density is p – the balance point. Probability theory and mechanics share the integral because they share the slice: in both, you accumulate a quantity weighted by how much "stuff" (probability, or mass) sits at each location.
For the exponential density on $[0, \infty)$, we evaluate this improper integral using integration by parts (Chapter 23) with $u = x$ and $\mathrm{d}v = \lambda e^{-\lambda x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ (so $\mathrm{d}u = \mathrm{d}x$ and $v = -e^{-\lambda x}$):

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \int_0^{\infty} x \cdot \lambda e^{-\lambda x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{b\to\infty}\left(\Big[-xe^{-\lambda x}\Big]_0^b + \int_0^b e^{-\lambda x}\,\mathrm{d}x\right) = 0 + \lim_{b\to\infty}\left[-\frac{1}{\lambda}e^{-\lambda x}\right]_0^b = \frac{1}{\lambda}.$$

The famous mean waiting time $1/\lambda$ unites improper integrals, integration by parts, and physical accumulation in a single calculation.

26.9 The Common Thread

Look back at everything we built. We solved eight very different problems – area, volume several ways, arc length, surface area, work, pumping, average value, probability – and we never once invented a genuinely new idea. Every single result came from the same three-step move:

Quantity	**One slice** $\mathrm{d}Q$	**Accumulated**
Area between curves	$(f-g)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b (f-g)\,\mathrm{d}x$
Volume (slicing)	$A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$
Volume (disks)	$\pi[f]^2\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\pi\int_a^b [f]^2\,\mathrm{d}x$
Volume (washers)	$\pi([f]^2-[g]^2)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\pi\int_a^b ([f]^2-[g]^2)\,\mathrm{d}x$
Volume (shells)	$2\pi x\,f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b 2\pi x f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$
Arc length	$\sqrt{1+[f']^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b \sqrt{1+[f']^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$
Surface area	$2\pi f\sqrt{1+[f']^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b 2\pi f\sqrt{1+[f']^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$
Work	$F(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b F(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$
Pumping	$\rho g A(y)(H-y)\,\mathrm{d}y$	$\rho g\int A(y)(H-y)\,\mathrm{d}y$
Average value	—	$\frac{1}{b-a}\int_a^b f\,\mathrm{d}x$
Probability	$p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$\int_a^b p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$

The middle column is the only one that ever required thought, and it always came straight from a picture: a rectangle, a coin, a shell, a triangle, a layer of water. *Find the slice, and the integral writes itself.* That is the entire craft of applied integration, and it will carry you through multiple integrals, center of mass, fluid pressure, and far beyond. Whenever you meet a new quantity to compute, do not hunt for a formula. Ask the one question this chapter is built on: *what am I accumulating, and what does one slice contribute?*

Why this matters

In classical geometry, Archimedes and Eudoxus had to invent a separate exhaustion argument for each shape – one construction for a parabolic segment, another for a sphere, another for a spiral. Writing $\mathrm{d}Q$ for a single thin slice and integrating replaces all of those separate geometric arguments with one uniform calculation.

26.10 Limitations and next steps

Connection

The slicing method expresses many geometric and physical quantities as integrals: areas, volumes of revolution, arc lengths, surface areas, work, and probability densities.
However, setting up an integral does not guarantee that its antiderivative is elementary. Many natural geometry and physics problems lead to integrals that cannot be evaluated in closed form:

- *Arc length of an ellipse:* Slicing the ellipse $\frac{x^2}{a^2} + \frac{y^2}{b^2} = 1$ yields the perimeter

$$L = 4a \int_0^{\pi/2} \sqrt{1 - e^2 \sin^2 \theta}\, \mathrm{d}\theta,$$

  where $e = \sqrt{1 - b^2/a^2}$ is the eccentricity. This is a *complete elliptic integral of the second kind*, which has no elementary antiderivative.

- *Pendulum period:* Computing the exact period of a pendulum swinging from an initial angle θ_0 yields a *complete elliptic integral of the first kind*:

$$T = 4\sqrt{\frac{L_p}{g}} \int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\mathrm{d}\phi}{\sqrt{1 - \sin^2(\theta_0/2) \sin^2 \phi}}.$$

When closed-form formulas are unavailable, we evaluate integrals using *numerical integration* (Chapter 27) or approximate them with series expansions (Chapter 30). In Chapter 27, we develop algorithms that approximate definite integrals directly from sample values to high accuracy.

26.11 Exercises

Exercise 26.1 (Mental check: round-trip work)**.** A worker lifts a crate of mass m vertically from the floor to a shelf at height h, and later lowers it back to the floor. Gravity exerts a constant downward force of magnitude mg. (a) How much work is done by gravity as the crate is lifted? (b) How much work is done by gravity as the crate is lowered? (c) What is the total work done by gravity over the round trip? Explain why the signs must differ.

Exercise 26.2 (Mental check: disk vs. shell selection)**.** Consider the region bounded by $y = e^{-x^2}$, $y = 0$, $x = 0$, and $x = 1$, revolved about the y-axis. Would you choose the disk/washer method

or the shell method to set up the volume? Explain your choice in one sentence without computing either integral. (Hint: consider the antiderivatives of xe^{-x^2} versus $\sqrt{-\ln y}$.)

Exercise 26.3 (Area, both directions)**.** Find the area of the region bounded by $y = \sqrt{x}$ and $y = x^2$. First by vertical slices, then by horizontal slices, and confirm the answers agree.

Exercise 26.4 (Crossing curves)**.** Find the total area enclosed between $y = \sin x$ and $y = \cos x$ from $x = 0$ to $x = \pi/2$. (The curves cross at $x = \pi/4$; remember to use top-minus-bottom on each piece, so the answer is positive.)

Exercise 26.5 (Volume by slicing, non-circular cross sections)**.** A solid has as its base the region between $y = 0$ and $y = 1 - x^2$ for $-1 \le x \le 1$. Every cross-section perpendicular to the x-axis is a square sitting on the base. Set up and evaluate $\int A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ to find the volume. (Here the side of the square at position x is $1 - x^2$, so $A(x) = (1 - x^2)^2$.)

Exercise 26.6 (Disk vs. shell)**.** Let R be the region under $y = x^2$ from $x = 0$ to $x = 1$. Find the volume when R is revolved (a) about the x-axis, and (b) about the y-axis. For each, decide whether disks/washers or shells gives the easier integral, and explain your choice in one sentence.

Exercise 26.7 (Arc length)**.** Find the arc length of $y = \frac{1}{3}\big(x^2+2\big)^{3/2}$ from $x = 0$ to $x = 2$. (Compute f', simplify $1 + [f']^2$ to a perfect square, and watch the radical disappear.)

Exercise 26.8 (Surface area)**.** The curve $y = \sqrt{x}$ from $x = 0$ to $x = 1$ is revolved about the x-axis. Set up the surface-area integral $\int 2\pi f\sqrt{1 + [f']^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$, simplify the integrand, and evaluate it.

Exercise 26.9 (Work, varying force)**.** A chain 10 m long weighs 5 N/m and hangs from the top of a building. How much work is required to haul the entire chain to the top? (Hint: slice the chain by length; a piece at depth x weighs $5\,\mathrm{d}x$ and must rise a distance x, so $\mathrm{d}W = 5x\,\mathrm{d}x$.)

Exercise 26.10 (Pumping a cone)**.** A tank in the shape of an inverted cone (point down) has height 4 m and top radius 2 m, and is full of water. Set up and evaluate the work to pump all the water to the top rim. (By similar triangles the radius at height y is $y/2$, so $A(y) = \pi(y/2)^2$; the lift is $4 - y$. Use $\rho g = 9800$ N/m^3.)

Exercise 26.11 (Average value, and where it is attained)**.** Find the average value of $f(x) = \sin x$ on $[0, \pi]$. Then find the value(s) of $c \in [0, \pi]$ where $f(c)$ equals that average, illustrating the Mean Value Theorem for Integrals.

Exercise 26.12 (Probability density)**.** A continuous random variable has density $p(x) = c\,x(1 - x)$ on $[0, 1]$ and zero elsewhere. (a) Find c so that $\int_0^1 p = 1$. (b) Compute $P(X \le 1/2)$. (c) Compute the mean $\mathbb{E}[X] = \int_0^1 x\,p(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, and explain why symmetry could have told you the answer in advance.

Exercise 26.13 (Conceptual: the slice is everything)**.** In one short paragraph each, state "what one slice contributes" ($\mathrm{d}Q$) for: the area between two curves, a washer, a cylindrical shell, and the work to pump a fluid. You should be able to do this from the pictures alone, without looking up a formula – that is the point of the chapter.

Exercise 26.14 (Proof: shells and washers must agree)**.** Consider the region under $y = f(x)$ from $x = 0$ to $x = b$ (with f decreasing, $f(b) = 0$) revolved about the y-axis. Write the shell-method volume $V = \int_0^b 2\pi x f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. Using integration by parts with $u = f(x)$ and $\mathrm{d}v = 2\pi x\,\mathrm{d}x$, transform this into an integral over y and identify the result as the washer/disk volume. Conclude that the two methods are not two facts but one, related by integration by parts. (This is a satisfying capstone: the algebra of parts is exactly the geometry of re-slicing.)

Chapter 27

Numerical Integration

In the previous chapter, we applied integration across geometry and physics: volumes of solids, arc lengths, work, and probability distributions. In each case, the application led to a definite integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$.

We usually expect to evaluate such integrals using the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus by finding an antiderivative F with $F' = f$. But that requires being able to express F in closed form.

For many functions, no such antiderivative exists. For example,

$$\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$$

has no antiderivative in terms of elementary functions – no finite formula built from polynomials, roots, exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric functions differentiates to e^{-x^2}. Yet the integral represents a well-defined area (approximately 0.7468), and it appears throughout probability and statistics as the normal distribution.

When an antiderivative cannot be found, we return to the definition of the integral as an accumulated sum. By evaluating the integrand at selected sample points, we can estimate the area to any desired accuracy with certified error bounds. That is the goal of numerical integration.

Focus

The integral $\int_a^b f\,\mathrm{d}x$ is a number: the signed area under f. The Fundamental Theorem is one road to that number, available only when an antiderivative exists in usable form. Numerical integration is a different road, always open, that returns to the original meaning of the integral as accumulated area and computes that area directly from samples of f. Our goal: get an accurate number *and* a reliable bound on how wrong it might be.

27.1 When the Antiderivative Will Not Come

Numerical methods are necessary for two distinct reasons: functions with no elementary antiderivative, and functions known only through discrete data points.

Here are integrals that arise constantly and have no elementary antiderivative:

$$\int e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int \frac{\sin x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int \frac{1}{\ln x}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int \sqrt{1+\tfrac{1}{4}\cos^2 x}\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \int \frac{e^x}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The first is the Gaussian in probability. The second, $\sin(x)/x$, arises in optics and signal processing. The third, $1/\ln x$, relates to the distribution of prime numbers. The fourth gives the arc length of an ellipse. None of them yields to substitution, parts, or partial fractions, because no elementary antiderivative exists to be found.

Why the technique works

Why an impossible antiderivative is not your fault. Joseph Liouville (1833–1841) proved which functions can have elementary antiderivatives, establishing that e^{-x^2}, $\sin(x)/x$, and many others provably cannot. The absence of an elementary antiderivative is an intrinsic property of these functions, not a lack of technique. In such cases, numerical integration is the standard path to a quantitative answer.

And even when an antiderivative *does* exist, you may not have a formula for f at all. A bridge engineer measuring the deflection of a beam, a physiologist tracking cardiac output, a data scientist with a column of numbers – they have f only as a *table of values*, sampled at points. There is no symbolic f to integrate. There is only data, and the area under it. Numerical integration is the language for turning samples into accumulated quantities.

Application

A car's speedometer reads its speed $v(t)$ each second. How far did the car travel between $t = 0$ and $t = 60$? Distance is $\int_0^{60} v(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$. You have no formula for $v(t)$ – you have sixty-one numbers. The only way to recover distance is to estimate the area under the speed curve from those samples. Every fitness tracker, every flight data recorder, every digital oscilloscope integrates this way thousands of times a second.

27.2 The Crudest Defensible Estimate: Rectangles

We already met the idea in the chapter on the integral. Chop $[a, b]$ into n equal slices of width

$$h = \frac{b-a}{n},$$

with cut points $x_0 = a,\ x_1 = a + h,\ \ldots,\ x_n = b$. On each slice approximate the area by a rectangle. If we use the left endpoint's height $f(x_{i-1})$ on each slice we get the *left Riemann sum*; the right endpoints give the right sum.

The trouble with rectangles is visible to the eye. A rectangle has a flat top, but f usually slopes. On a rising function, left rectangles sit entirely below the curve and lose area; right rectangles poke above and gain it (Figure 27.1). The error on each slice is roughly the little triangular sliver between the flat top and the sloping curve. Halve the slice width and you halve roughly each sliver's base *and* its height – but there are twice as many of them, so the total error only halves. This is the painful arithmetic of rectangles: error $\propto h$. To get one more correct decimal digit you need ten times as many slices.

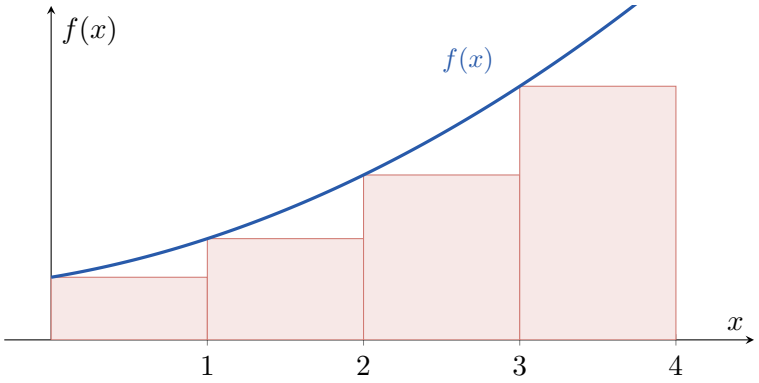


Figure 27.1: Left rectangles under a rising curve. Each rectangle's flat top falls short of the sloping curve, leaving a triangular sliver of lost area. The total error shrinks only in proportion to the slice width h. We can do much better by letting the tops slope.

Intuition

The guiding principle of numerical quadrature is to improve the local approximation of the curve. A rectangle's top is a constant (degree 0). A line segment (degree 1) accounts for the local slope, yielding the trapezoidal rule. A parabola (degree 2) accounts for local curvature as well, yielding Simpson's rule. Each higher-degree polynomial interpolation eliminates a leading error term, increasing the order of convergence.

27.3 The Trapezoidal Rule: Let the Tops Slope

The natural remedy for the rectangle error becomes clear once you inspect the missing sliver. Instead of a flat top, connect the two endpoints of each slice with a straight line. The flat-topped rectangle becomes a *trapezoid* whose slanted top hugs the curve far better (Figure 27.2).

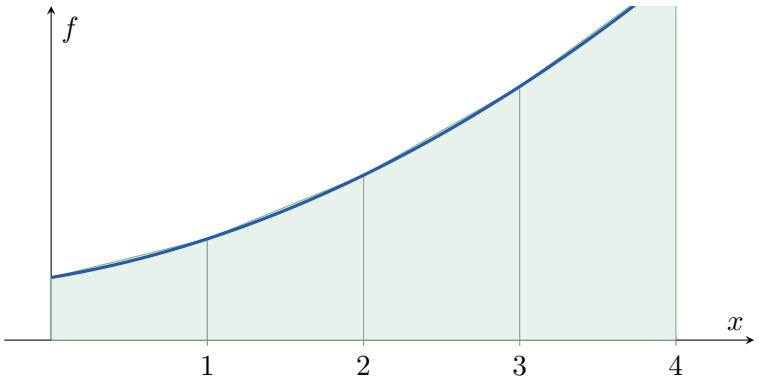


Figure 27.2: The trapezoidal rule: connect consecutive sample points with straight chords. Each trapezoid hugs the curve much more closely than a flat rectangle. The leftover error per slice now comes only from the curve's *bending*, not its sloping.

The area of a single trapezoid is its average height times its width. On the slice $[x_{i-1}, x_i]$ the two

heights are $f(x_{i-1})$ and $f(x_i)$, and the width is h, so

$$\text{slice area} \approx h \cdot \frac{f(x_{i-1}) + f(x_i)}{2}.$$

Add up all n slices. Watch what happens: every interior point $x_1, \ldots, x_{n-1}$ is the right endpoint of one trapezoid and the left endpoint of the next, so its height gets counted twice. The two outer endpoints x_0 and x_n are counted once. The total telescopes into a clean formula.

Focus

Trapezoidal Rule. With $h = (b-a)/n$ and $x_i = a + ih$,

$$T_n = \frac{h}{2}\Big[\, f(x_0) + 2f(x_1) + 2f(x_2) + \cdots + 2f(x_{n-1}) + f(x_n) \,\Big].$$

The pattern of weights is $1, 2, 2, \ldots, 2, 1$. Ends count once, interiors count twice, and the whole thing is scaled by $h/2$.

Why the technique works

Why is the weight pattern $1, 2, 2, \ldots, 2, 1$ and not something fancier? Because each interior sample is shared between two neighboring trapezoids – it is the right wall of one and the left wall of the next – so its height contributes to two pieces of area, hence weight 2. The two boundary samples belong to only one trapezoid each, hence weight 1. The trapezoidal rule simply says to "replace the curve with the connect-the-dots polygon through your samples, and take the area under the polygon." That polygon is the unique piecewise-linear function agreeing with f at every node (the sample points x_i where we evaluate the function). Integrating it exactly gives T_n. So the trapezoidal rule is exact for any function that already *is* a straight line on each slice – and approximately right to the extent that f is nearly straight at the scale of h.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose you use the trapezoidal rule to integrate $f(x) = 5x - 3$ from $x = 0$ to $x = 10$, using just a single slice ($n = 1$). What is the error?
Mental check: The function is a straight line, so its second derivative is zero everywhere ($f'' = 0$). The top edge of the trapezoid is not an approximation of the line – it *is* the line. The error is identically zero, even with just one slice.

Work it yourself

Estimate $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,dx$ with the trapezoidal rule using $n = 4$. Then $h = 0.25$ and the nodes are $0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1$. Compute the heights $f(x) = e^{-x^2}$:

x	e^{-x^2}
0	1.000000
0.25	0.939413
0.5	0.778801
0.75	0.569783
1.0	0.367879

Now apply the weights $1, 2, 2, 2, 1$:

$$T_4 = \frac{0.25}{2}\Big[1.000000 + 2(0.939413) + 2(0.778801) + 2(0.569783) + 0.367879\Big].$$

The bracket is $1.000000 + 1.878826 + 1.557602 + 1.139566 + 0.367879 = 5.943873$. Multiply by $h/2 = 0.125$: $T_4 = 0.742984$. The true value is 0.746824. We are off by about 0.0038 – already under one percent with only five function evaluations, and we never found an antiderivative because none exists.

27.3.1 How Wrong Is the Trapezoidal Rule? The Error Comes From Curvature

Look again at Figure 27.2. Where the curve bulges *up* (concave down), the chord cuts underneath and the trapezoid undershoots. Where the curve bulges *down* (concave up), the chord rides above and the trapezoid overshoots. Either way, the error is governed by how much the curve bends – by the second derivative f''. A straight line has $f'' = 0$ and the trapezoidal rule nails it exactly. The more f curves, the more the chord misses.

We can make this precise by analyzing a single slice. Take a single interval of width h and ask how far the area under the chord differs from the area under f. A careful accounting (a short Taylor expansion – approximating f near the midpoint by its local value, slope, and bending – done in the box below) gives, for one slice,

$$(\text{true area}) - (\text{trapezoid area}) = -\frac{h^3}{12} f''(\xi)$$

for some point ξ inside the slice. The error on one slice is proportional to h^3 and to the curvature there.

What is really happening

Why h^3 per slice but h^2 overall. Each slice carries error of size $\sim h^3$. But to cover a fixed interval $[a, b]$ you need $n = (b - a)/h$ slices, so the errors stack up:

$$\text{total error} \sim n \cdot h^3 = \frac{b-a}{h} \cdot h^3 = (b - a)\, h^2.$$

One power of h is eaten by needing more slices as h shrinks. What survives is h^2. This is the deep pattern of the whole subject: a method with per-slice error h^{p+1} delivers *global* error h^p. The trapezoidal rule has $p = 2$. Halve h (double the work) and the error drops by a factor of 4, not 2. That is already a world better than rectangles, where halving h only halves the error.

Why the technique works

Where the $-h^3 f''/12$ comes from. Put the slice symmetrically as $[-h/2, h/2]$ to keep the algebra clean. Taylor-expand f about the midpoint:

$$f(x) = f(0) + f'(0)\, x + \tfrac{1}{2} f''(0)\, x^2 + \cdots$$

Integrate across the slice. The odd term $f'(0)x$ integrates to zero by symmetry, leaving

$$\int_{-h/2}^{h/2} f\,\mathrm{d}x = f(0)\,h + \tfrac{1}{2}f''(0)\cdot\frac{2}{3}\Big(\tfrac{h}{2}\Big)^3 + \cdots = f(0)\,h + \frac{f''(0)\,h^3}{24} + \cdots$$

The trapezoid uses the two endpoint heights $f(\pm h/2)$. Their average is

$$\frac{f(h/2)+f(-h/2)}{2} = f(0) + \tfrac{1}{2}f''(0)\Big(\tfrac{h}{2}\Big)^2 + \cdots = f(0) + \frac{f''(0)h^2}{8} + \cdots,$$

so the trapezoid area is $h\big(f(0)+\frac{f''(0)h^2}{8}\big) = f(0)h + \frac{f''(0)h^3}{8}$. Subtract:

$$\text{true} - \text{trap} = \frac{f''(0)h^3}{24} - \frac{f''(0)h^3}{8} = f''(0)h^3\Big(\tfrac{1}{24}-\tfrac{3}{24}\Big) = -\frac{f''(0)h^3}{12}.$$

There it is. The midpoint rule (rectangle of height $f(0)$, area $f(0)\,h$) misses the truth by $+\frac{1}{24}f''(0)h^3$, while the trapezoid misses by $-\frac{1}{12}f''(0)h^3$. Both errors are governed by $f''h^3$, but the trapezoid's error is exactly *twice as large, in the opposite direction.* This relationship is the foundation for Simpson's rule.

Summing the per-slice errors $-\frac{h^3}{12}f''(\xi_i)$ over all n slices and bounding each $|f''(\xi_i)| \le M_2$ by the triangle inequality gives at most $n\cdot\frac{h^3}{12}M_2 = \frac{(b-a)h^2}{12}M_2$, since $nh = b-a$: adding up n slices costs one power of h. (When f'' is continuous, the discrete average $\frac{1}{n}\sum f''(\xi_i)$ lies between the minimum and maximum of f'', so the Intermediate Value Theorem even pins the exact global error to $-\frac{(b-a)h^2}{12}f''(\xi)$ for some $\xi \in [a,b]$.)

Focus

Trapezoidal error bound. If $|f''(x)| \le M_2$ for all x in $[a,b]$, then

$$\Big|\int_a^b f\,\mathrm{d}x - T_n\Big| \le \frac{(b-a)\,h^2}{12}\,M_2 = \frac{(b-a)^3}{12\,n^2}\,M_2.$$

The error is controlled by the largest curvature on the interval and falls like $1/n^2$.

Work it yourself

Bound the error of our T_4 estimate of $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$. We need a bound M_2 on $|f''|$ over $[0,1]$. With $f = e^{-x^2}$, $f' = -2xe^{-x^2}$ and $f'' = (4x^2-2)e^{-x^2}$. On $[0,1]$ this ranges between -2 (at $x=0$) and about 0.74 (at $x=1$), so $|f''| \le 2$; take $M_2 = 2$. With $b-a=1$, $n=4$, $h=0.25$:

$$|\text{error}| \le \frac{1\cdot(0.25)^2}{12}\cdot 2 = \frac{0.0625}{12}\cdot 2 = 0.0104.$$

Our actual error was 0.0038, comfortably inside the guaranteed bound of 0.0104. The bound is valid but conservative – it uses the worst-case curvature everywhere, while the real curvature is smaller over most of the interval. This is the typical relationship: the bound certifies, the true error beats it.

27.4 Simpson's Rule: Let the Tops Be Parabolas

The trapezoidal rule replaced the curve by straight chords and was left with an error driven by curvature, f''. The obvious next move: replace the curve not by lines but by *parabolas*, which can themselves curve. A parabola is determined by three points, so we take the samples two slices at a time – x_0, x_1, x_2 – fit the unique parabola through those three heights, and use the exact area under that parabola as our estimate for the area over $[x_0, x_2]$ (Figure 27.3).

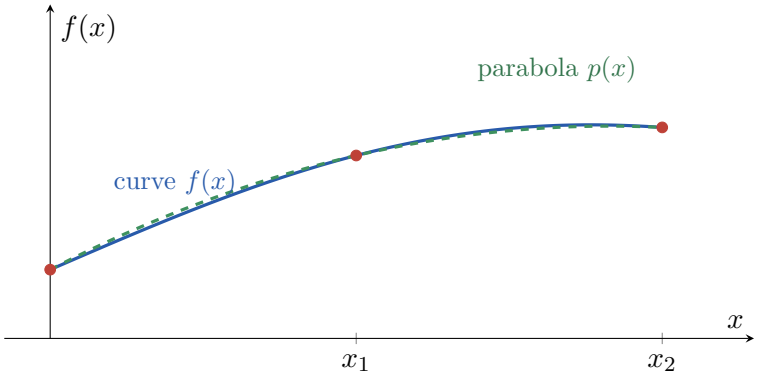


Figure 27.3: Simpson's rule fits a parabola (dashed green) through three consecutive samples and integrates the parabola exactly. A parabola can bend, so it tracks a curving function far better than a straight chord. The fit need not pass under or over the curve everywhere – it weaves through it, and the over- and under-estimates largely cancel.

The arithmetic of "integrate the parabola through three points" produces a startlingly tidy weight pattern. Over a double-slice $[x_0, x_2]$ of total width $2h$, the exact area under the interpolating parabola (the unique quadratic passing through the three points) works out to

$$\int_{x_0}^{x_2} (\text{parabola})\, \mathrm{d}x = \frac{h}{3}\Big[\, f(x_0) + 4f(x_1) + f(x_2) \,\Big].$$

The middle point gets weight 4, the two ends weight 1, scaled by $h/3$. (The derivation is in the box below – it is just integrating a quadratic.) Now stitch these double-slices together along $[a, b]$. This requires n to be *even* so the slices pair up cleanly. Each interior odd-indexed node $x_1, x_3, x_5, \ldots$ is the apex of its own parabola and gets weight 4. Each interior even-indexed node $x_2, x_4, \ldots$ is shared as the right end of one parabola and the left end of the next, so its two weight-1 contributions add to 2. The outer ends keep weight 1.

Focus

Simpson's Rule (requires n even). With $h = (b-a)/n$,

$$S_n = \frac{h}{3}\Big[\, f(x_0) + 4f(x_1) + 2f(x_2) + 4f(x_3) + 2f(x_4) + \cdots + 4f(x_{n-1}) + f(x_n) \,\Big].$$

The weight pattern is $1, 4, 2, 4, 2, \ldots, 4, 1$: ends are 1, odd interior nodes are 4, even interior nodes are 2, all scaled by $h/3$.

Why the technique works

Deriving the $\frac{h}{3}[1,4,1]$ formula. Center the double-slice at the origin: nodes at $-h, 0, +h$ with heights y_{-1}, y_0, y_1. Any parabola is $p(x) = A + Bx + Cx^2$. Integrate it across $[-h, h]$:

$$\int_{-h}^{h} (A + Bx + Cx^2)\,\mathrm{d}x = 2Ah + \frac{2Ch^3}{3},$$

since the odd term Bx integrates to zero. Now express A and C through the sampled heights. Plugging in the nodes: $y_0 = A$, and $y_1 + y_{-1} = 2A + 2Ch^2$, so $C = (y_1 - 2y_0 + y_{-1})/(2h^2)$. Substitute:

$$2Ah + \frac{2Ch^3}{3} = 2y_0h + \frac{h}{3}(y_1 - 2y_0 + y_{-1}) = \frac{h}{3}\big(y_{-1} + 4y_0 + y_1\big).$$

This yields the $1, 4, 1$ coefficient pattern. Notice that the linear term Bx dropped out by odd symmetry across $[-h, h]$ – and, as we are about to see, the same symmetry kills any cubic term Dx^3 for free.

Work it yourself

Estimate $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ with Simpson's rule, $n = 4$, reusing the exact same five heights from the trapezoidal lab. Apply the weights $1, 4, 2, 4, 1$:

$$S_4 = \frac{0.25}{3}\Big[1.000000 + 4(0.939413) + 2(0.778801) + 4(0.569783) + 0.367879\Big].$$

The bracket: $1.000000 + 3.757652 + 1.557602 + 2.279132 + 0.367879 = 8.962265$. Multiply by $h/3 = 0.083333$: $S_4 = 0.746855$. The true value is 0.746824. The error is 0.000031 – about 31 *millionths*. Trapezoid with the very same data missed by 0.0038. Simpson, using not a single extra function evaluation, is more than a hundred times more accurate. Let us see why that simple change in weights buys so much accuracy.

27.5 Cubic Exactness and Fourth-Order Convergence

Simpson's rule is derived by fitting parabolas, which guarantees exact integration for quadratic polynomials. However, it is also mathematically exact for all *cubic* polynomials. That additional degree of polynomial exactness accounts for its fourth-order convergence rate.

Intuition

Cubic exactness via symmetry. Consider $f(x) = x^3$ on the symmetric double-slice $[-h, h]$ with midpoint at 0. Its true integral is zero, because x^3 is an odd function: the positive area on $[0, h]$ exactly cancels the negative area on $[-h, 0]$. Now evaluate Simpson's rule on this interval: the weights $1, 4, 1$ act on the sample values $(-h)^3 = -h^3$, $0^3 = 0$, and h^3, giving $1 \cdot (-h^3) + 4 \cdot 0 + 1 \cdot h^3 = 0$. Simpson's rule yields zero with zero error. The symmetric evaluation cancels the cubic contribution just as the true integral does. Consequently, a method constructed to interpolate quadratics integrates all cubics exactly as well.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose you apply Simpson's rule to $f(x) = 2x^3 - 5x^2 + 4x - 1$ on $[-2, 2]$ using $n = 2$. How far will your numerical estimate be from the exact integral?
Mental check: The error is exactly zero. Simpson's rule fits a degree-2 parabola, but because the weighting is symmetric, the cubic and linear terms cancel out completely. Any polynomial up to degree 3 is integrated with zero error by Simpson's rule.

To understand this error cancellation, we examine the *midpoint rule*. Instead of sampling at the ends of a slice (trapezoid) it samples at the *center* and uses a rectangle of that single height. Evaluating at the midpoint changes the error behavior significantly: because the rectangle's flat top crosses the curve in the middle of the slice, it overshoots on one side and undershoots on the other, and those two errors largely balance each other (Figure 27.4). That cancellation is why the midpoint rule, despite using only *one* sample per slice, achieves h^2 accuracy – and its leading error term has the *opposite sign* of the trapezoidal error, which Simpson's rule exploits directly.

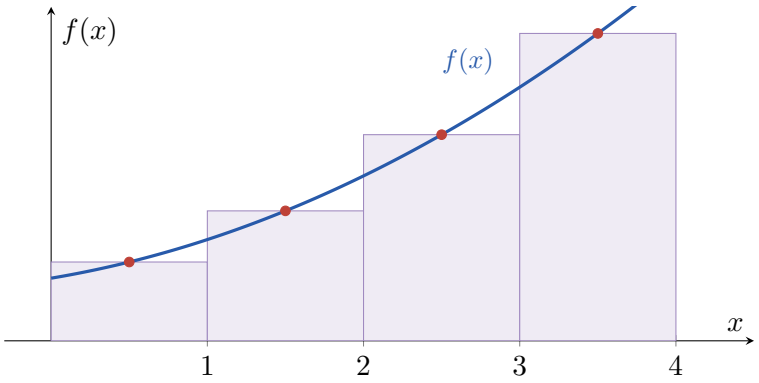


Figure 27.4: The midpoint rule: each rectangle's height is sampled at the *center* of its slice (red dots). The flat top now slices through the curve, overshooting on the low side and undershooting on the high side, so the two errors largely cancel. One sample per slice, yet accuracy $\sim h^2$ – and its leftover error tilts opposite to the trapezoid's, the fact Simpson exploits.

Why the technique works

Simpson is the trapezoid's error, cancelled. Recall the two facts we proved earlier on a single slice: the *midpoint rule* (rectangle of height f at the center) has error $+\frac{1}{24}f''h^3$ per slice, while the *trapezoid* has error $-\frac{1}{12}f''h^3$ – the trapezoid's leading error is exactly -2 times the midpoint's. So if we take a weighted blend that kills the f'' term,

$$\frac{2\,(\text{Midpoint}) + 1\,(\text{Trapezoid})}{3},$$

the leading curvature errors cancel: $2 \cdot (+\frac{1}{24}) + 1 \cdot (-\frac{1}{12}) = \frac{1}{12} - \frac{1}{12} = 0$. And this blend *is* Simpson's rule. On a double-slice $[-h, h]$ of width $2h$, the single-panel midpoint area is $2h\,f(0)$ and the single-panel trapezoid area is $h\big(f(-h) + f(h)\big)$; blending them 2:1 gives $\frac{1}{3}\big[4h\,f(0) + h\big(f(-h) + f(h)\big)\big] = \frac{h}{3}\big[f(-h) + 4f(0) + f(h)\big]$, exactly the $1, 4, 1$ pattern. So Simpson is not an unrelated trick: it is precisely the linear combination of the two simple rules engineered to cancel their common f'' error term.

With the curvature error gone, what is the leading remainder? Expand f to fourth order about 0. Odd powers cancel both in the integral and in the sum $f(-h)+f(h) = 2f(0) + f''(0)h^2 + \frac{1}{12}f^{(4)}(0)h^4 + \cdots$. The true integral is $2f(0)h + \frac{1}{3}f''(0)h^3 + \frac{1}{60}f^{(4)}(0)h^5 + \cdots$, while $\frac{h}{3}\big[f(-h) + 4f(0) + f(h)\big]$ evaluates to $2f(0)h + \frac{1}{3}f''(0)h^3 + \frac{1}{36}f^{(4)}(0)h^5 + \cdots$. The difference is $(\frac{1}{60} - \frac{1}{36})f^{(4)}(0)h^5 = -\frac{1}{90}f^{(4)}(0)h^5$ per double-slice of width $2h$. Summing over all $n/2$ double-slices (with $(n/2)\cdot 2h = b - a$) yields a global error of $-\frac{(b-a)h^4}{180}f^{(4)}(\xi)$: every lower order of error has vanished.

Because the f'' error is gone, Simpson's per-slice error is $\sim h^5 f^{(4)}$, and summed over the $n/2$ double-slices the global error is $\sim h^4 f^{(4)}$. Compare:

Rule	Exact for	Global error	Halving h divides error by
Rectangles	constants (deg 0)	$\sim h$	2
Trapezoid	lines (deg 1)	$\sim h^2$	4
Simpson	cubics (deg 3)	$\sim h^4$	16

These three growth laws are not abstractions; you can *watch* them. Figure 27.5 plots the true error of each rule against the number of slices n for our running integral $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$, on log–log axes (where each major grid line marks a power of ten in slices or error). On such axes a power law error $\sim n^{-p}$ becomes a straight line of slope $-p$, and the three rules sort themselves into three visibly different slopes.

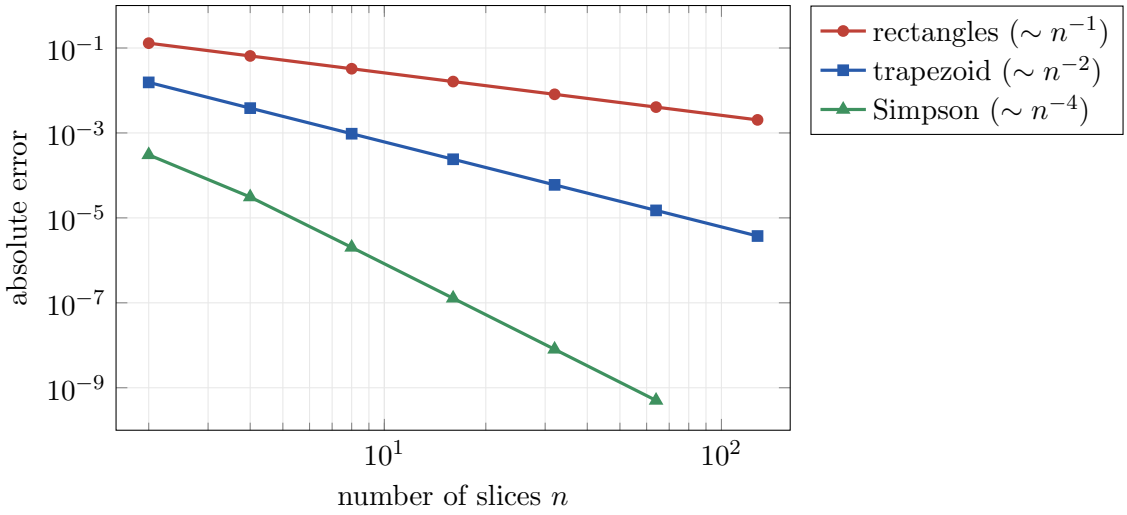


Figure 27.5: Error of each rule versus the number of slices n for $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$, on log–log axes, where a power law appears as a straight line of slope $-p$. Rectangles fall one decade per decade ($p = 1$), the trapezoid two ($p = 2$), Simpson four ($p = 4$). This vertical gap illustrates the primary advantage of higher-order methods: at $n = 32$, Simpson's error is about 10^{-8}, while the trapezoid's is near 10^{-4} and the rectangles' near 10^{-2}.

Focus

Simpson error bound. If $|f^{(4)}(x)| \le M_4$ on $[a,b]$, then

$$\left| \int_a^b f\,\mathrm{d}x - S_n \right| \le \frac{(b-a)\,h^4}{180}\,M_4 = \frac{(b-a)^5}{180\,n^4}\,M_4.$$

The error falls like $1/n^4$. Doubling the number of slices divides the error by 16.

Work it yourself

Bound the error of S_4 for $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$. We need $M_4 = \max|f^{(4)}|$ on $[0,1]$. For $f = e^{-x^2}$, $f^{(4)} = (16x^4 - 48x^2 + 12)e^{-x^2}$. At $x = 0$ this is 12; it decreases over $[0,1]$, so $|f^{(4)}| \le 12$; take $M_4 = 12$. With $b - a = 1$, $h = 0.25$:

$$|\text{error}| \le \frac{1 \cdot (0.25)^4}{180} \cdot 12 = \frac{0.00390625}{180} \cdot 12 = 0.00026.$$

Our actual error was 0.000031, well inside the certified 0.00026. Even the conservative bound promises four good digits from five function values; the truth delivers five.

Why this matters

Moving from straight chords to parabolas – with symmetry cancelling the cubic term – improves the global error from h^2 to h^4. In practice, that difference in scaling is dramatic: to achieve an accuracy of 10^{-8}, the trapezoidal rule requires on the order of 10^4 subintervals, whereas Simpson's rule requires only on the order of 10^2. Using identical function evaluations, adjusting the quadrature weights from $1, 2, 2, \ldots, 2, 1$ to $1, 4, 2, 4, \ldots, 4, 1$ increases accuracy by orders of magnitude. In scientific computing, choosing a higher-order approximation method generally yields greater gains than simply increasing the number of grid points.

27.6 A Fuller Worked Example with Both Rules

Let us integrate something with a known answer so we can check ourselves against the truth. Take

$$\int_1^2 \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \ln 2 = 0.693147\ldots$$

This one *does* have an antiderivative, $\ln x$, but that makes it a perfect test bench: we can compare our estimates against the exact value to the last digit.

Use $n = 4$, so $h = 0.25$ and the nodes are $1, 1.25, 1.5, 1.75, 2$. The heights $f(x) = 1/x$:

x	$1/x$
1.00	1.000000
1.25	0.800000
1.50	0.666667
1.75	0.571429
2.00	0.500000

Trapezoidal. Weights $1, 2, 2, 2, 1$:

$$T_4 = \frac{0.25}{2}\big[1.000000 + 2(0.800000) + 2(0.666667) + 2(0.571429) + 0.500000\big].$$

Bracket: $1.000000 + 1.600000 + 1.333334 + 1.142858 + 0.500000 = 5.576192$. Times 0.125: $T_4 = 0.697024$. Error: 0.003877.

Simpson. Weights $1, 4, 2, 4, 1$:

$$S_4 = \frac{0.25}{3}\big[1.000000 + 4(0.800000) + 2(0.666667) + 4(0.571429) + 0.500000\big].$$

Bracket: $1.000000 + 3.200000 + 1.333334 + 2.285716 + 0.500000 = 8.319050$. Times 0.083333: $S_4 = 0.693254$. Error: 0.000107.

Simpson beats the trapezoidal rule by a factor of about 36 here, on identical data. Now let us check the error bounds. For $f = 1/x$ on $[1, 2]$: $f'' = 2/x^3$, maximized at $x = 1$ giving $M_2 = 2$; and $f^{(4)} = 24/x^5$, maximized at $x = 1$ giving $M_4 = 24$.

$$\text{Trap bound} = \frac{1 \cdot (0.25)^2}{12} \cdot 2 = 0.01042, \qquad \text{Simpson bound} = \frac{1 \cdot (0.25)^4}{180} \cdot 24 = 0.00052.$$

Both actual errors (0.0039 and 0.0001) sit safely below their bounds. The numbers tell a consistent story across two completely different integrands.

Work it yourself

Use the bound to choose n in advance. Suppose you want $\int_1^2 \frac{1}{x}\,dx$ to within 10^{-6} using Simpson. Solve the bound for n:

$$\frac{(b-a)^5}{180\,n^4} M_4 \le 10^{-6} \implies \frac{1 \cdot 24}{180\,n^4} \le 10^{-6} \implies n^4 \ge \frac{24}{180 \cdot 10^{-6}} = 133{,}333 \implies n \ge 19.1.$$

Round up to the next even integer: $n = 20$. With just twenty-one function values, Simpson guarantees six correct digits of $\ln 2$. The same calculation for the trapezoidal rule demands $n \ge 409$ – twenty times the work for the same accuracy. This is how production code actually decides its step size: not by trial and error, but by inverting the error bound.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose your simulation needs to improve an integral's accuracy by a factor of 10,000. How many times more slices must the trapezoidal rule use? How many times more for Simpson?
Mental check: The trapezoid error falls like $1/n^2$, so cutting error by 10,000 requires $\sqrt{10{,}000} = 100$ times as many slices. Simpson's error falls like $1/n^4$, so it requires only $(10{,}000)^{1/4} = 10$ times as many slices. A ten-fold increase in evaluation points buys a ten-thousand-fold gain in precision.

Common trap

Three common numerical integration pitfalls:

- **Odd n in Simpson.** Simpson pairs slices into parabolas, so n must be even. With

odd n the weight pattern $1, 4, 2, \ldots$ does not close properly and your answer is silently wrong. Always check n is even before applying $h/3\,[1, 4, 2, \ldots, 4, 1]$.

- **Forgetting the rules assume smoothness.** The error bounds rely on f'' (trapezoid) or $f^{(4)}$ (Simpson) being bounded. If f has a kink, a spike, or a vertical tangent in the interval – think $\sqrt{x}$ near 0, whose derivatives blow up – the bound is infinite and the promised convergence rate evaporates. Subdivide at the bad point or change variables first.
- **Mixing up $h/2$ and $h/3$.** Trapezoid is $h/2$, Simpson is $h/3$. Swap them and every digit is off. The mnemonic: trapezoid *averages* two heights ($\div 2$); Simpson's weights $1{+}4{+}1 = 6 = 3 \times 2$ live naturally over $\div 3$.

27.7 How Computers Actually Integrate

When you type `quad(f, a, b)` in a scientific library, what runs underneath is a refined descendant of exactly what we have built. The core ideas survive; engineering wraps them.

Adaptive subdivision. A fixed, uniform h is wasteful. Where f is nearly straight, big slices suffice; where f swings violently, you want tiny slices. So real integrators are *adaptive*: they apply Simpson's rule on a region, then split the region in half and apply Simpson to each half. If the two-half estimate agrees with the whole-region estimate to within tolerance, the region is declared done; otherwise each half is recursively subdivided. Effort flows automatically to wherever the function is hardest, which is the only sensible place to spend it (Figure 27.6).

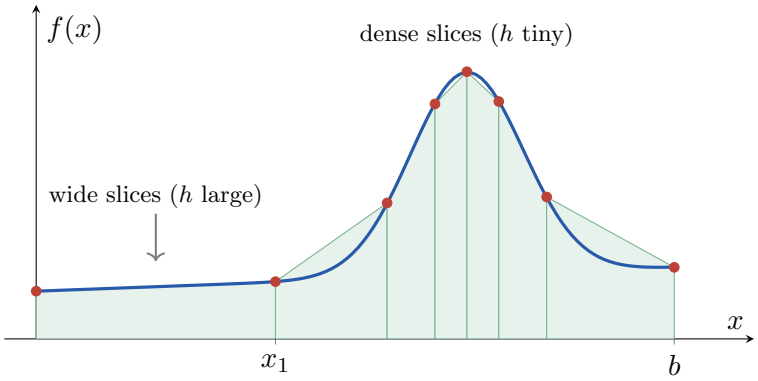


Figure 27.6: Adaptive quadrature in action. Where the curve is gentle and nearly straight (left), a wide interval suffices. Where the curve surges into a sharp peak (center-right), the algorithm recursively bisects the region into narrow slices to capture the high curvature. Computation is saved in the flats and concentrated at the peak.

Why the technique works

How the computer estimates its own error without knowing the answer. This is the cleverest practical idea in the chapter. Run Simpson once on $[a, b]$ with step h to get $S(h)$, then again with step $h/2$ to get $S(h/2)$. We know the error scales like h^4, so $S(h)$ is off by

about Ch^4 and $S(h/2)$ by about $C(h/2)^4 = Ch^4/16$. Subtract the two estimates:

$$S(h/2) - S(h) \approx \left(I - \tfrac{Ch^4}{16}\right) - \left(I - Ch^4\right) = Ch^4 - \frac{Ch^4}{16} = \frac{15}{16}\,Ch^4.$$

The thing we cannot see directly – the error $Ch^4/16$ of the better estimate – is therefore about $\frac{1}{15}$ of the *difference between the two estimates*, which we *can* see. So the computer gauges its own error by comparing two grids, with no oracle for the true value. When that estimated error drops below your tolerance, it stops. This is the engine inside every adaptive quadrature routine.

Connection

That same comparison-of-two-grids trick can be turned into *Richardson extrapolation*: form the combination $\big(16\,S(h/2) - S(h)\big)/15$, which cancels the leading h^4 error entirely and leaves an error of order h^6. Applied systematically to the trapezoidal rule, this idea generates the *Romberg integration* table – a triangular scheme that raises the accuracy order at each column. Romberg's first column is trapezoidal estimates on ever-finer grids; its second column is exactly Simpson's rule; later columns are higher-order rules nobody had to derive by hand. It is the same Taylor-cancellation logic used to construct Simpson's rule, carried to higher orders. We meet this extrapolation principle again when studying Taylor series.

Gaussian quadrature. We assumed the sample points were *equally spaced*, because that is natural and because it is forced on you when f is a table of measurements. But if you are free to choose *where* to sample f, you can do dramatically better. Gauss asked: with a fixed budget of n sample points, placed wherever we like and weighted however we like, what is the most accurate rule possible? The answer – sampling at special points called the roots of Legendre polynomials, clustered toward the ends of the interval – yields a rule exact for polynomials up to degree $2n - 1$. With the same n evaluations that give Simpson degree-3 exactness, Gaussian quadrature reaches degree $2n - 1$. For smooth functions this is the method of choice, and it is what high-precision libraries reach for first.

History

Around 250 BCE, Archimedes approximated the area of a circle using inscribed and circumscribed polygons, establishing the principle of bounding areas by simpler shapes. Surveys in Egypt and Rome similarly estimated irregular land areas using trapezoidal slices.

The systematic theory began around 1676–1711, when Isaac Newton and Roger Cotes developed what is now called **Newton–Cotes quadrature**. Working on planetary orbits where no algebraic antiderivatives were available, they interpolated functions with polynomials over equally spaced points.

Thomas Simpson published the three-point parabolic rule bearing his name in his 1743 treatise *Mathematical Dissertations*, though the formula had been derived earlier by James Gregory in 1668 and used by Newton and Cavalieri.

Newton and Cotes assumed that increasing polynomial degree on equally spaced nodes would yield arbitrary accuracy. However, for degree 8 and higher, the interpolation weights oscillate in sign and grow large, making the formulas sensitive to rounding errors (a manifestation of Runge's phenomenon). In 1814, Carl Friedrich Gauss showed that by choosing both the sample locations and their weights optimally, an n-point rule could integrate polynomials up

to degree $2n-1$ exactly, with all weights positive. Modern scientific software commonly uses adaptive extensions such as Gauss–Kronrod quadrature.

What is really happening

What a computer evaluates during numerical quadrature is a concrete weighted sum. It samples f at a set of designated points, multiplies those function values by precomputed quadrature weights, and sums the results. Every definite integral evaluated computationally – a probability, a Fourier coefficient, the energy of an orbit, or a machine learning loss – reduces to a weighted sum of function values: $\sum_i w_i f(x_i)$. The trapezoidal weights are $1, 2, 2, \ldots, 2, 1$; Simpson's are $1, 4, 2, 4, \ldots, 1$; Gaussian quadrature weights are derived from orthogonal polynomials. In each case, numerical integration selects nodes x_i and weights w_i so that the finite sum approximates continuous accumulation as accurately as the smoothness of f allows.

Walking question

On your walk, picture the speedometer-and-distance problem. You glance at the speedometer once a minute on a winding drive. The trapezoidal rule says: average each consecutive pair of readings and multiply by a minute. Simpson says: take readings three at a time and trust that the speed varied parabolically between them. Now ask yourself: on a stretch where your acceleration was steadily increasing (constant f'' but $f''' = 0$), which rule is exactly right, and why does Simpson nail it while the trapezoid does not? Then ask the harder one: if you got to choose *when* to glance, would you space your glances evenly – or look more often through the twists and less often on the straightaways?

27.8 Summary: The Logic of the Whole Subject

We began stranded – handed integrals like $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,dx$ that provably have no elementary antiderivative, so the Fundamental Theorem cannot help. We returned to the integral's true meaning as area and learned to estimate that area from samples.

- **Rectangles** approximate f by constants on each slice. Global error $\sim h$. Crude.
- **Trapezoidal rule**, weights $\frac{h}{2}[1, 2, \ldots, 2, 1]$, approximates f by straight chords. Exact for lines; error driven by curvature f''; global error $\sim h^2$. Built from connect-the-dots.
- **Simpson's rule**, weights $\frac{h}{3}[1, 4, 2, 4, \ldots, 4, 1]$ with n even, approximates f by parabolas. Exact for cubics (one bonus degree, by symmetry); error driven by $f^{(4)}$; global error $\sim h^4$. Built as the curvature-cancelling blend $\frac{2\,\text{Mid}+\text{Trap}}{3}$.
- **Error bounds** let you certify accuracy and choose n in advance: trapezoid $\leq \frac{(b-a)^3}{12n^2}M_2$, Simpson $\leq \frac{(b-a)^5}{180n^4}M_4$.
- **Real software** uses these as building blocks inside adaptive subdivision (spend effort where f is wild), self-error-estimation by comparing grids, Richardson extrapolation and Romberg tables, and Gaussian quadrature (optimal sample placement). It is always, in the end, a weighted sum $\sum w_i f(x_i)$.

The throughline is a single idea, applied with increasing refinement: *replace the curve, locally, by something you can integrate exactly, and the better the local fit, the faster the error dies.* Constant, line, parabola – and the error exponent climbs h, h^2, h^4. That is calculus turning its own definition into an algorithm.

27.9 Limitations and next steps

Connection

Numerical quadrature evaluates definite integrals directly from samples, bypassing the need for elementary antiderivatives. When formulas like Simpson's rule or Gauss–Kronrod quadrature are applied to smooth functions in one dimension, accurate approximations require only a modest number of function evaluations.

However, standard grid-based quadrature faces a major limitation in higher dimensions. When integrating over a d-dimensional domain, a grid of N points per axis requires N^d total function evaluations:

- In 1 dimension: $100^1 = 100$ evaluations;
- In 3 dimensions: $100^3 = 10^6$ evaluations;
- In 10 dimensions: $100^{10} = 10^{20}$ evaluations.

This exponential growth in computation is known as the *curse of dimensionality.* Deterministic grids quickly become impractical as dimension grows.

In high-dimensional problems, two alternative approaches are standard:

- *Analytic reductions:* When symmetry exists, coordinate transformations and Fubini's theorem can reduce multidimensional integrals to simpler nested forms (Chapter 34).
- *Monte Carlo integration:* In high dimensions, random sampling estimates integrals with an error of $O(1/\sqrt{N})$ independent of the dimension d.

27.9.1 From Continuous Integrals to Discrete Lists: The Bridge to Chapter 28

Evaluating $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ by repeatedly halving the step size $h = 1/n$ generated a succession of trapezoidal estimates:

$$T_2,\ T_4,\ T_8,\ T_{16},\ T_{32},\ \ldots,\ T_{2^k},\ \ldots$$

Writing out their numerical values reveals an orderly approach toward the true area:

$$0.731370,\quad 0.742984,\quad 0.745866,\quad 0.746584,\quad 0.746764,\quad \ldots$$

This highlights a conceptual transition. The first twenty-seven chapters focused on the continuum, where variables vary continuously. Numerical approximations generate an ordered list of discrete numbers:

$$a_1,\ a_2,\ a_3,\ a_4,\ \ldots,\ a_k,\ \ldots$$

where each entry $a_k = T_{2^k}$ is indexed by a positive integer $k \in \mathbb{N}$. As the grid is refined, this list approaches a definite limit:

$$\lim_{k\to\infty} a_k = \int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Such an infinite ordered list is a *sequence*.

Having studied continuous rates of change and continuous accumulation, we now turn to discrete lists and infinite sums. In Chapter 28, we begin with *Sequences and Their Limits*.

27.10 Exercises

Exercise 27.1 (Mental checks)**.** Answer each of the following without pencil or paper:

(a) If $f(x)$ is strictly concave down ($f'' < 0$) on $[a, b]$, will the trapezoidal estimate T_n be strictly greater than or strictly less than the true integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$?

(b) You evaluate an integral using the trapezoidal rule with $n = 10$ and obtain an error of 0.04. If you increase to $n = 20$, approximately what error do you expect?

(c) You evaluate the same integral with Simpson's rule and find an error of 0.0016 with $n = 10$. If you increase to $n = 20$, approximately what error do you expect?

(d) For which of the following functions is Simpson's rule with $n = 2$ mathematically exact: $f(x) = 4x^3 - 2x + 7$, $g(x) = x^4$, $h(x) = \sin x$?

Exercise 27.2. Estimate $\int_0^2 \sqrt{1 + x^3}\,\mathrm{d}x$ using the trapezoidal rule with $n = 4$. (Nodes $0, 0.5, 1, 1.5, 2$; compute each $\sqrt{1 + x^3}$ to four decimals, then apply weights $1, 2, 2, 2, 1$ and multiply by $h/2$.)

Exercise 27.3. Estimate the same integral $\int_0^2 \sqrt{1 + x^3}\,\mathrm{d}x$ with Simpson's rule, $n = 4$, reusing your five heights from the preceding exercise but with weights $1, 4, 2, 4, 1$ and factor $h/3$. By how much do the two estimates differ?

Exercise 27.4. Compute $\int_0^\pi \sin x\,\mathrm{d}x$ exactly (you know the antiderivative), then estimate it with Simpson's rule using $n = 2$ (nodes $0, \pi/2, \pi$). Find the actual error. Why is it not zero even though sin is smooth?

Exercise 27.5. For $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$, how large must n be to guarantee the trapezoidal rule is within 10^{-4} of the truth? Use $M_2 = 2$. Then find the n needed for Simpson to reach the same tolerance using $M_4 = 12$. Comment on the ratio.

Exercise 27.6. A car's speed (in m/s) is recorded every 2 seconds: at $t = 0, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10, 12$ the readings are $0, 8, 17, 22, 24, 25, 25$. This gives $n = 6$ intervals – an even number, so Simpson applies. Estimate the distance travelled, $\int_0^{12} v\,\mathrm{d}t$, with (a) the trapezoidal rule and (b) Simpson's rule. Which would you trust more, and why?

Exercise 27.7. (Conceptual.) Explain in your own words why the trapezoidal rule *overestimates* the integral of a function that is concave up (like e^x) on the whole interval, and underestimates a concave-down function. Tie your answer to the sign of f'' in the error term $-\frac{h^3}{12}f''(\xi)$ per slice.

Exercise 27.8. (Proof.) Show directly that Simpson's rule is exact for every cubic $f(x) = ax^3 + bx^2 + cx + d$ on a single double-slice $[-h, h]$. That is, compute $\int_{-h}^{h} f\,\mathrm{d}x$ exactly and compare it to $\frac{h}{3}[f(-h) + 4f(0) + f(h)]$, and verify they are equal. Identify which term of f would have to be present (degree 4) for Simpson to start being wrong.

Exercise 27.9. (Proof / derivation.) Show that for the trapezoidal rule applied to a single slice $[x_0, x_1]$ of width h, the leading error term is $-\frac{h^3}{12}f''(\xi)$ by Taylor-expanding f about the midpoint and integrating, mirroring the symmetric derivation in the chapter.

Exercise 27.10. (Self-error estimation.) Using $\int_1^2 \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x$ with Simpson, compute S_2 (i.e. $h = 0.5$) and S_4 ($h = 0.25$). Form the estimated error of S_4 as $\frac{1}{15}(S_4 - S_2)$ and compare it to the actual error $\ln 2 - S_4$. How close is the estimate? This is exactly what adaptive software does.

Exercise 27.11. (Richardson extrapolation.) Continue the previous exercise: form the combination $S^\star = \frac{16S_4 - S_2}{15}$, which cancels the leading h^4 error. Compute $S^\star$ and its error against $\ln 2 = 0.693147$. You should find it dramatically more accurate than either S_2 or S_4 alone – this is the first step of Romberg integration.

Exercise 27.12 (The sequence of approximations)**.** Let $f(x) = e^{-x^2}$ on $[0, 1]$. For each positive integer $k \in \mathbb{N}$, let $s_k = S_{2^k}$ denote the Simpson's rule approximation with $n = 2^k$ slices.

(a) Write down the first three terms of this list: $s_1 = S_2$, $s_2 = S_4$, $s_3 = S_8$.

(b) Explain why the collection $(s_k)_{k=1}^{\infty}$ is a *sequence* of real numbers, and what it means to write $\lim_{k\to\infty} s_k = \int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$.

(c) Using the error bound $\left|\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x - S_n\right| \le \frac{M_4}{180n^4}$ with $M_4 = 12$, find a power $n = 2^k$ that mathematically guarantees $\left|\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x - s_k\right| < 10^{-10}$. (This challenge-and-response behavior on discrete indices is the foundation of Chapter 28.)

Part VI

Sequences and Series

Chapter 28

Sequences and Their Limits

In the previous chapter on numerical integration, we encountered integrals like $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ that possess no elementary antiderivative. To find the area, we chopped the interval into n slices and calculated trapezoid estimates: $T_2, T_4, T_8, T_{16}, \ldots$. Each entry was a concrete, finite approximation; none was the exact answer. Yet as we doubled the number of slices, the numbers settled down, marching closer and closer to a single fixed destination.

For most of this book, a limit has been a process *along a continuum*. You let x slide smoothly toward some point a and you watched what $f(x)$ did. The input could come from the left, from the right, through rationals, through irrationals – any way at all, as long as it crept up on a. That freedom was the whole content of the epsilon-delta definition.

Now we change the shape of the approach. Instead of a continuous variable gliding toward a point, picture a discrete *list* of numbers, one after another, marching out forever:

$$a_1,\ a_2,\ a_3,\ a_4,\ \ldots,\ a_n,\ \ldots$$

There is a first term, a second term, a thousandth term, but never a last term. The question is no longer "what happens as $x \to a$?" but "where is this list *headed* as we walk down it?" Does it settle on a single number? Does it wander forever? Does it blow up?

This is the idea of a *sequence* and its *limit*, and it is the gateway to the second half of calculus. Every infinite series – every Taylor expansion, every $\pi = 4(1 - \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{5} - \cdots)$, every decimal that never terminates – is defined through a sequence: the sequence of its partial sums (the running totals of the terms added so far). Newton's method produces a sequence of root guesses. The trapezoid rule produces a sequence of area approximations. Even a real number like $\sqrt{2}$ is, at bottom, the destination of a sequence of rational approximations. Understand how a list of numbers can *converge* and all of these come within reach at once.

The chapter proceeds in three stages. We begin by pinning down what a sequence is and what it means for one to have a limit – the same challenge-and-response game you already know, re-tuned for the integers. From there we assemble the working tools: the squeeze theorem for sequences, a short table of limits you will use constantly, and the deep fact that a sequence which climbs but stays bounded *must* converge. Last comes recursion – sequences in which each term is built from the one before – together with the idea of a *fixed point*, which is where such sequences come to rest.

28.1 What a sequence really is

A sequence can be formalized as a function. The only twist is its domain.

Definition 28.1 (Sequence)**.** A *sequence* of real numbers is a function $a\colon \mathbb{N} \to \mathbb{R}$ whose domain is the natural numbers $\mathbb{N} = \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$. Instead of writing $a(n)$ we write a_n and call it the *nth term*. We denote the whole sequence by $(a_n)_{n=1}^{\infty}$, or just (a_n).

History

The study of sequences began around 450 BCE with the Greek philosopher *Zeno of Elea*. In his famous paradoxes of motion – the *Dichotomy* and *Achilles and the Tortoise* – Zeno argued that motion across a room is impossible. Before you can reach the opposite wall, you must first cover half the distance ($a_1 = 1/2$). Before you can cover the remaining half, you must cover half of that ($a_2 = 1/2 + 1/4 = 3/4$). Then half again ($a_3 = 7/8$). You are trapped facing an infinite sequence of discrete milestones:

$$a_n = 1 - \frac{1}{2^n}.$$

Zeno argued that because an infinite number of discrete acts cannot be completed in finite time, you can never reach the wall – in fact, you can never even take your first step. Ancient Greek geometry was deductive and precise, but its thinkers avoided "actual infinity," insisting that an infinite process could never conclude.

For two millennia, mathematicians skirted this dilemma with intuitive metaphors of "vanishing increments" and Newtonian "fluxions" (quantities thought of as flowing smoothly through time). By the eighteenth century, Leonhard Euler and his contemporaries manipulated infinite sequences and infinite sums with formal algebra, but without a rigorous foundation. This lack of guardrails sparked debate: did the alternating sequence of partial sums $1 - 1 + 1 - 1 + \cdots$ equal $1/2$, 0, or nothing sensible at all?

The crisis came to a head when *Augustin-Louis Cauchy* published his 1821 textbook *Cours d'Analyse*. Cauchy sought to replace vague intuitions with inequalities, asserting that a sequence (a_n) converges to L if the error $|a_n - L|$ can be made smaller than any pre-assigned tolerance. Yet even Cauchy stumbled: he published a false "proof" that a convergent series of continuous functions always has a continuous sum. In 1826 *Niels Henrik Abel* pointed out that Fourier's sine series – sums of perfectly smooth waves – converge to a square wave with jump discontinuities.

The modern resolution arrived between 1817 and the 1860s through *Bernard Bolzano* and *Karl Weierstrass*. Weierstrass introduced the quantifier discipline used today ($\forall \varepsilon > 0, \exists N \in \mathbb{N}, \forall n \geq N$), distinguishing pointwise from uniform convergence. This resolved Cauchy's error and proved the **Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem**: every bounded sequence of real numbers contains a convergent subsequence (a sub-list chosen by skipping terms without reordering). Zeno's runner arrives at $L = 1$ because an infinite sequence of shrinking distances has a finite limit.

Open questions about sequence limits remain today. While we can prove that a sequence converges, discovering the algebraic nature of its limit can be difficult. For example, the sequence defining the Euler–Mascheroni constant,

$$\gamma_n = \left(\sum_{k=1}^{n} \frac{1}{k}\right) - \ln n,$$

is proven to decrease monotonically to $\gamma \approx 0.57721566\ldots$. But after nearly three centuries, no one knows whether γ is rational or irrational. Likewise, the Collatz sequence (halve if even, $3n+1$ if odd) is conjectured to reach the cycle $4, 2, 1$ from every positive integer, but a general proof remains unsolved.

That is the entire definition. A sequence is a function whose inputs are $1, 2, 3, \ldots$ rather than a continuous interval. Where an ordinary function f has a smooth graph you can trace with a pencil, a sequence has a graph made of *isolated dots*, one above each integer on the horizontal axis.

Intuition

Three ways to read the same object, all useful:

- **As a list.** $\frac{1}{1}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{4}, \ldots$ – the thing you write down term by term.
- **As a function.** $a_n = \frac{1}{n}$, the rule that turns an input n into an output. Plug in $n = 7$, read off $\frac{1}{7}$.
- **As a picture.** A scatter of dots at heights $1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \ldots$ above the integers $1, 2, 3, \ldots$, sinking toward the horizontal axis but never touching it.

Keep all three in mind. The list view is how you compute, the function view is how you reason, and the picture view is how you *see* where the sequence is going (Figure 28.1).

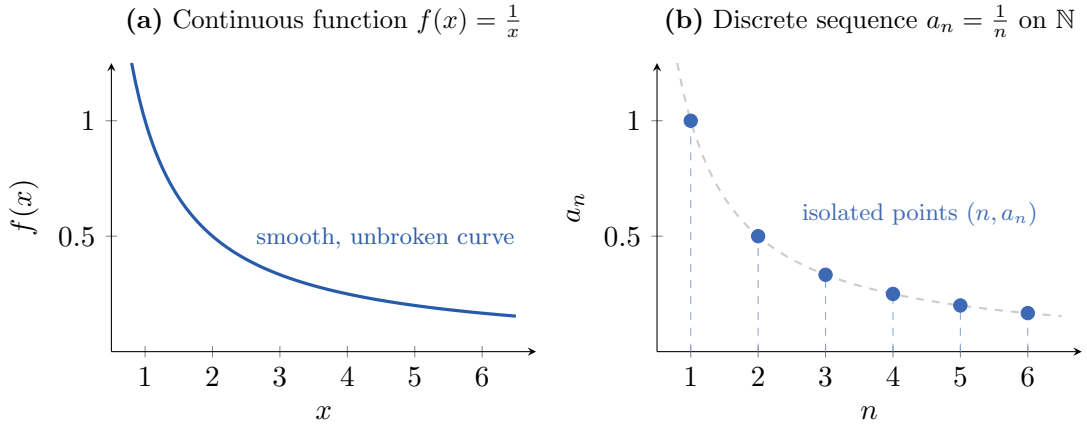


Figure 28.1: Continuous function versus discrete sequence. **(a)** A continuous function $f(x) = 1/x$ has a continuous real domain $[1, \infty)$ and a smooth, unbroken graph. **(b)** A sequence $a_n = 1/n$ restricts the domain to the positive integers $\mathbb{N} = \{1, 2, 3, \ldots\}$. Its graph consists of isolated dots sampling the underlying curve at discrete integer stations.

There are three common ways to hand someone a sequence.

By a closed formula. You give a_n as an explicit expression in n. For example $a_n = \dfrac{n}{n+1}$ produces $\frac{1}{2}, \frac{2}{3}, \frac{3}{4}, \frac{4}{5}, \ldots$. To find the thousandth term you just substitute: $a_{1000} = \frac{1000}{1001}$. No bookkeeping required.

By recursion. You give the first term (or first few) and a rule that builds each new term from earlier ones. The classic is the Fibonacci sequence, $F_1 = F_2 = 1$ and $F_n = F_{n-1} + F_{n-2}$, which

marches out as $1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, \ldots$. Recursion is powerful but slippery: to know a_{1000} you must, in principle, walk through all 999 terms before it. Section 28.7 is devoted to taming such sequences.

By description. Sometimes the rule is verbal: "let p_n be the nth prime," giving $2, 3, 5, 7, 11, \ldots$. There is no tidy formula, but it is a perfectly good function $\mathbb{N} \to \mathbb{R}$.

Walking question

Write out the first five terms of $a_n = \dfrac{(-1)^n}{n}$. What is the sign doing, and what are the magnitudes doing? Where do you think this list is headed?

The terms are -1, $\frac{1}{2}$, $-\frac{1}{3}$, $\frac{1}{4}$, $-\frac{1}{5}$. The sign alternates; the magnitudes $1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{5}$ shrink toward zero. So the dots bounce above and below the axis but the bounces get ever smaller. The list is being squeezed toward 0 from both sides. Hold that image – it is exactly the case the squeeze theorem (Section 28.4) will handle.

Reading note

A word on indexing. Some sequences naturally start at $n = 0$ (powers, $2^0, 2^1, 2^2, \ldots$) and some at $n = 1$. Nothing about a limit depends on where the list starts – changing or deleting the first million terms cannot change where the *tail* is headed. We will start at $n = 1$ unless a formula begs to start at 0, and we will be relaxed about it, because the mathematics is relaxed about it.

28.2 Convergence: the destination of a list

Look again at $a_n = \frac{1}{n}$. The terms are $1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{4}, \ldots$. Nobody hesitates to say this sequence "goes to 0." But what, *precisely*, does that claim assert? Not that any term equals zero – none does. Not merely that the terms decrease – the sequence $1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \ldots$ also decreases (weakly) but goes to $\frac{1}{2}$, not 0. The real content is this:

> *No matter how small a margin of error you name, eventually – from some term onward – every term of the sequence lands inside that margin of* 0.

This is the challenge-and-response game again, the same one that defined $\lim_{x \to a} f(x)$, but cleaner, because there is no δ to find. The input does not slide toward a point; it just *increases*. So the response to a challenge is not "get within δ of a" but simply "go far enough out in the list."

Intuition

The game. A skeptic challenges you with a tiny positive number ε – a tolerance band of half-width ε drawn around the candidate limit L. Your job is to answer with a cutoff N: a place in the list beyond which *all* terms lie inside the band. If you can meet *every* challenge, no matter how small the ε, then L is the limit. If there is even one ε you cannot answer, L is not the limit.

The skeptic moves first and can make ε as close to zero as desired. You move second, so you may choose N *after* seeing ε – and N is allowed to be enormous. Small ε usually forces large

N; that is fine. The only thing that matters is that for each ε *some* workable N exists.

Definition 28.2 (Limit of a sequence)**.** A sequence (a_n) *converges* to the number L, written

$$\lim_{n\to\infty} a_n = L \qquad \text{or} \qquad a_n \to L,$$

if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists a natural number N such that

$$n \geq N \quad \Longrightarrow \quad |a_n - L| < \varepsilon.$$

If no such L exists, the sequence *diverges*.

Read that implication out loud as a sentence in the game: "once you go past the cutoff N, every term is within ε of L." The quantity $|a_n - L|$ is the distance from the nth term to the candidate limit; demanding it be less than ε is demanding the term sit inside the tolerance band.

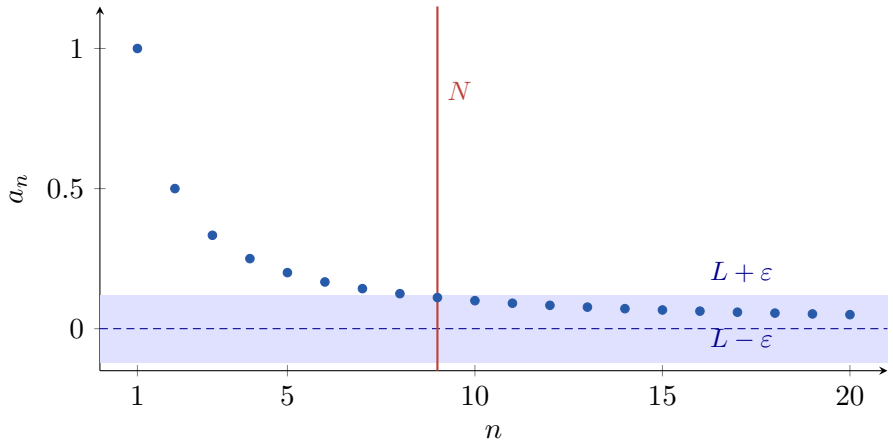


Figure 28.2: The sequence $a_n = 1/n$ converging to $L = 0$. The shaded strip is the tolerance band $|a_n - 0| < \varepsilon$ for $\varepsilon = 0.12$. To the right of the red cutoff N (here $N = 9$) every dot lies inside the band. Shrink ε and the band narrows, pushing the cutoff N rightward – but a workable N always exists.

Example 28.1 (Proving $1/n \to 0$ from the definition)**.** We claim $\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{1}{n} = 0$. Let $\varepsilon > 0$ be given by the skeptic. We must produce N so that $n \geq N$ forces $|\frac{1}{n} - 0| = \frac{1}{n} < \varepsilon$.

Solve the target inequality for n: $\frac{1}{n} < \varepsilon$ exactly when $n > \frac{1}{\varepsilon}$. So *any* integer N larger than $\frac{1}{\varepsilon}$ will do; the existence of such an integer is guaranteed by the Archimedean property of the real numbers (no real number is larger than every integer). Concretely, take $N = \lfloor 1/\varepsilon \rfloor + 1$.

Now verify. If $n \geq N > \frac{1}{\varepsilon}$, then $n > \frac{1}{\varepsilon}$, hence $\frac{1}{n} < \varepsilon$, hence $|\frac{1}{n} - 0| < \varepsilon$. The challenge is met, and since ε was arbitrary, $\frac{1}{n} \to 0$. $\square$

Why the technique works

Notice the *shape* of that proof, because every epsilon-N proof has it.

1. **Let $\varepsilon > 0$ be given.** You do not get to choose it; you must handle all of them at once by handling a typical one.

2. **Work backwards.** Start from the goal $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$ and solve for what n must satisfy. This is scratch work – it tells you how big N has to be.
3. **Declare N.** Announce the cutoff your scratch work revealed.
4. **Verify forwards.** Assume $n \geq N$ and chain the inequalities to reach $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$. This is the actual proof; steps 2–3 were the search.

The search and the proof run in opposite directions. Beginners blur them together and get confused about which inequality they are allowed to assume. Keep them separate: solve backward in the margin, then write forward on the page.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose someone challenges you with tolerance $\varepsilon = 0.005$ for the sequence $a_n = 1/n$. What is the smallest integer cutoff N that satisfies the contract? *Check:* We need $1/n < 0.005 = 1/200$, which requires $n > 200$. The smallest integer cutoff is $N = 201$. From term 201 onward, every single dot sits strictly inside the tolerance strip.

Divergence, and a sequence with no limit

A sequence diverges if no L works. There are two flavors worth naming.

Divergence to infinity. The terms $a_n = n$ grow without bound. They cannot converge to any finite L, because once the terms exceed $L + 1$ they can never return to within $\varepsilon = 1$ of L. We write $a_n \to \infty$ to record this behavior; here ∞ is not a number that the sequence reaches, only notation for growth past every finite bound.

Oscillation. The terms $a_n = (-1)^n$ cycle $-1, 1, -1, 1, \ldots$ forever. This sequence is bounded – it never escapes $[-1, 1]$ – yet it has no limit. If we proposed $L = 1$, the term -1 keeps appearing arbitrarily far out, so the choice $\varepsilon = 1$ is never met from any cutoff on. The same defeat befalls $L = -1$, or any L in between. No single destination; no limit.

Common trap

Bounded does not mean convergent. The sequence $(-1)^n$ stays trapped in $[-1, 1]$ but never settles. Convergence requires the terms to *pile up* near one number, not merely to stay in a finite range. We will see in Section 28.6 the extra ingredient – *monotonicity* – that upgrades "bounded" into "convergent."

Connection

The Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem: convergent subsequences. Even when a sequence diverges, boundedness constrains its behavior. Consider our oscillating example $a_n = (-1)^n$. The entire sequence cycles between -1 and 1, never settling on a single limit. But if you select every *even* term $(a_2, a_4, a_6, \ldots)$, that sub-list is constant at 1 and converges to 1. If you select every *odd* term, it converges to -1.
In the 1860s, Karl Weierstrass formalized this into one of the foundational theorems of analysis: the **Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem**. It states that *every bounded sequence of real numbers*

contains a convergent subsequence (a sub-list formed by choosing infinitely many terms in their original order). Geometrically, infinitely many points confined to a closed bounded interval $[a, b]$ cannot remain spaced apart without clustering around at least one accumulation point. Boundedness alone does not force a sequence to converge, but it guarantees that some subsequence does.

28.3 The limit laws, and why they transfer

You spent a chapter proving that limits of functions respect addition, multiplication, and division. The good news: sequence limits inherit every one of those laws, with proofs that are if anything simpler, because there is no δ to juggle.

Theorem 28.1 (Algebra of sequence limits)**.** *Suppose $a_n \to A$ and $b_n \to B$. Then*

$$a_n + b_n \to A + B, \qquad a_n\, b_n \to A\, B, \qquad c\, a_n \to c\, A \quad (\textit{constant } c),$$

and, provided $B \neq 0$ and $b_n \neq 0$ for all n,

$$\frac{a_n}{b_n} \to \frac{A}{B}.$$

The limit, when it exists, is also unique.

We will not grind out all of these – they mirror the function case – but the sum law is short and shows the flavor, and uniqueness is worth a glance because it justifies the very phrase "the limit."

Why the technique works

Why the sum law holds. Suppose $a_n \to A$ and $b_n \to B$. We want $(a_n + b_n) \to A + B$. The distance to beat is

$$|(a_n + b_n) - (A + B)| = |(a_n - A) + (b_n - B)| \leq |a_n - A| + |b_n - B|,$$

where the last step is the triangle inequality ($|x + y| \leq |x| + |y|$: the direct route is never longer than the detour). Each piece on the right can be made small. Given $\varepsilon > 0$, use $a_n \to A$ with tolerance $\varepsilon/2$ to get a cutoff N_1 past which $|a_n - A| < \varepsilon/2$; use $b_n \to B$ with the same tolerance to get a cutoff N_2 past which $|b_n - B| < \varepsilon/2$. Let $N = \max(N_1, N_2)$. For $n \geq N$ both bounds hold at once, so

$$|(a_n + b_n) - (A + B)| \leq |a_n - A| + |b_n - B| < \tfrac{\varepsilon}{2} + \tfrac{\varepsilon}{2} = \varepsilon.$$

Two moves drive this proof: splitting the error with the triangle inequality, and demanding $\varepsilon/2$ from each piece so the halves add back up to ε. This budget-splitting argument recurs throughout analysis.

Why the technique works

Why the limit is unique. Suppose, for contradiction, that $a_n \to L$ and also $a_n \to L'$ with $L \neq L'$. Let $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{2}|L - L'| > 0$, which is the half-gap between the two candidates. Far enough out, the terms are within ε of L; far enough out, they are also within ε of L'. Past both cutoffs a single term a_n would sit within ε of *both* L and L' – but the two ε-bands do not overlap, since the gap between L and L' is 2ε. A point cannot be inside both. Contradiction. So $L = L'$: a convergent sequence has exactly one limit.

Example 28.2 (Limit laws in action)**.** Find $\displaystyle\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{3n^2 - n + 5}{2n^2 + 7n}$.

As $n \to \infty$ both top and bottom blow up; the expression is an $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$ form and we cannot read off the answer. The standard move is to divide top and bottom by the highest power present, here n^2:

$$\frac{3n^2 - n + 5}{2n^2 + 7n} = \frac{3 - \dfrac{1}{n} + \dfrac{5}{n^2}}{2 + \dfrac{7}{n}}.$$

Now each little piece is something we know. By Example 28.1, $\frac{1}{n} \to 0$; multiplying that limit by itself (the product law) gives $\frac{1}{n^2} \to 0$; scaling by constants and adding (the sum and constant-multiple laws) lets us evaluate numerator and denominator separately:

$$\text{numerator} \to 3 - 0 + 0 = 3, \qquad \text{denominator} \to 2 + 0 = 2.$$

Since the denominator's limit 2 is nonzero, the quotient law applies and

$$\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{3n^2 - n + 5}{2n^2 + 7n} = \frac{3}{2}.$$

The leading coefficients won; everything else washed out. That is the typical fate of a ratio of polynomials of equal degree.

Connection

There is a clean bridge between sequence limits and the function limits of Chapter 9. If f is a function with $\lim_{x\to\infty} f(x) = L$, and $a_n = f(n)$, then $a_n \to L$ as well – a sequence is just the function sampled at the integers, so if the whole continuous tail heads to L, the sampled dots do too. This is what lets you import L'Hôpital's rule: to find $\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{\ln n}{n}$, study the function $\frac{\ln x}{x}$, apply L'Hôpital to get $\frac{1/x}{1} \to 0$, and conclude $\frac{\ln n}{n} \to 0$.

The bridge runs only one way, though. The continuous limit existing forces the sampled limit to exist, but *not* conversely: $a_n = \sin(\pi n) = 0$ for every integer n, so $a_n \to 0$, while $\sin(\pi x)$ oscillates forever and has no limit as $x \to \infty$. Sampling can be calmer than the function it samples.

28.4 The squeeze theorem for sequences

Some sequences resist the limit laws because they are tangled with something that oscillates or otherwise misbehaves – think $\dfrac{\sin n}{n}$, where the numerator lurches between -1 and 1 with no pattern

you can pin down. You cannot "take the limit of $\sin n$" because it has none. But you do not need to. You only need to trap the sequence between two others that you *can* handle.

Theorem 28.2 (Squeeze theorem for sequences)**.** *Suppose that, from some index onward,*

$$\ell_n \le a_n \le u_n,$$

and that both bounding sequences converge to the same limit, $\ell_n \to L$ and $u_n \to L$. Then $a_n \to L$ as well.

Intuition

The picture is exactly what the name says. Two sequences – a lower fence ℓ_n and an upper fence u_n – close in on the same height L. The sequence a_n is caught between the fences. As the gap between the fences crushes down to nothing, the trapped sequence has nowhere to go but L. Even if a_n oscillates back and forth inside the gap, the shrinking fences force it to L.

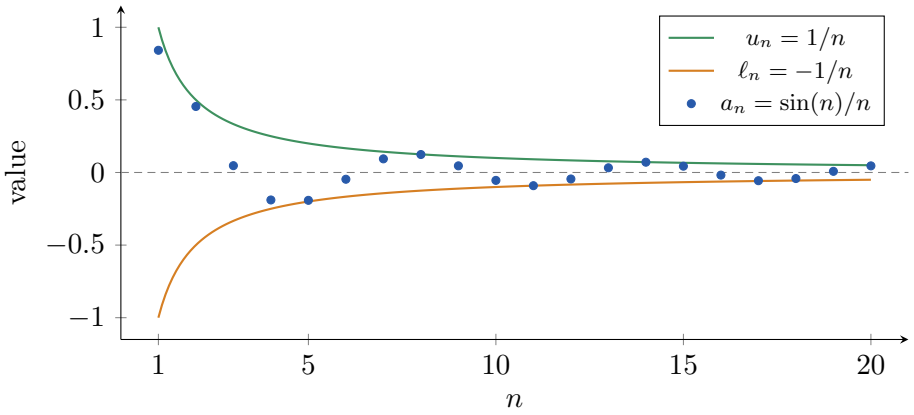


Figure 28.3: The sequence $a_n = \sin(n)/n$ trapped between the fences $\ell_n = -1/n$ and $u_n = 1/n$. Both fences converge to 0, so the pinned sequence is forced to 0 – no matter how erratically $\sin n$ jumps. The outer fences funnel the terms from the full $[-1, 1]$ span down toward zero.

Why the technique works

Why squeezing works. Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Since $\ell_n \to L$ there is a cutoff N_1 past which $L - \varepsilon < \ell_n$. Since $u_n \to L$ there is a cutoff N_2 past which $u_n < L + \varepsilon$. Take N to be the larger of N_1, N_2 (and also large enough that the sandwich $\ell_n \le a_n \le u_n$ has kicked in). Then for $n \ge N$,

$$L - \varepsilon < \ell_n \le a_n \le u_n < L + \varepsilon,$$

so $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$. The trapped sequence inherits the common limit of its two bounds. Notice we never needed a formula for a_n – only the two inequalities and the two known limits.

Example 28.3 ($\sin n/n \to 0$)**.** For every n we have $-1 \le \sin n \le 1$, and dividing by the positive number n preserves the inequalities:

$$-\frac{1}{n} \le \frac{\sin n}{n} \le \frac{1}{n}.$$

Both outer sequences $\pm\frac{1}{n}$ converge to 0. By the squeeze theorem, $\dfrac{\sin n}{n} \to 0$. We handled the oscillating numerator by bounding it between -1 and 1. $\square$

Example 28.4 (A factorial beats an exponential)**.** Show that $a_n = \dfrac{2^n}{n!} \to 0$. The factorial in the denominator eventually overwhelms the exponential on top, but let us prove it. Write out the factors for $n \geq 2$:

$$\frac{2^n}{n!} = \frac{2}{1} \cdot \frac{2}{2} \cdot \frac{2}{3} \cdot \frac{2}{4} \cdots \frac{2}{n}.$$

The first two factors multiply to 2. Every remaining factor $\frac{2}{k}$ (for $k \geq 3$) is below 1, so the product of all of them is at most the single last factor $\frac{2}{n}$ – dropping factors that are below 1 only raises the bound. Hence

$$0 \leq \frac{2^n}{n!} \leq 2 \cdot \frac{2}{n} = \frac{4}{n}.$$

Now $0 \to 0$ and $\frac{4}{n} \to 0$, so the squeeze pins $\frac{2^n}{n!}$ to 0. □

Pause

Pause and think. Consider $a_n = \dfrac{(-1)^n}{n^2}$. The numerator oscillates between -1 and 1 forever, yet the squeeze theorem handles it instantly. What are the two bounding fences ℓ_n and u_n? *Check:* Since $-1 \leq (-1)^n \leq 1$ for every n, dividing by $n^2 > 0$ gives $-\frac{1}{n^2} \leq a_n \leq \frac{1}{n^2}$. Both outer fences head straight to 0, so the trapped sequence is forced to 0.

28.5 A short table of limits worth memorizing

A handful of sequence limits come up so often that you should know them cold and know *why* each is true. Treat the following as a toolkit; the reasons matter more than the entries.

Limit	**Condition**	**Why**
$\dfrac{1}{n^p} \to 0$	$p > 0$	denominator grows without bound
$r^n \to 0$	$\lvert r\rvert < 1$	repeated shrinking factor
r^n diverges	$\lvert r\rvert > 1$	repeated growing factor
$n^{1/n} \to 1$	—	the root tames the growth
$r^{1/n} \to 1$	$r > 0$	ditto, for any positive base
$\left(1 + \dfrac{x}{n}\right)^n \to e^x$	$x \in \mathbb{R}$	the definition of e^x
$\dfrac{\ln n}{n^p} \to 0$	$p > 0$	powers beat logarithms
$\dfrac{n^p}{r^n} \to 0$	$r > 1$	exponentials beat powers
$\dfrac{r^n}{n!} \to 0$	any r	factorials beat exponentials

What is really happening

There is one organizing principle behind most of this table: a *hierarchy of growth*. Step up the ladder and each rung eventually outgrows the one below it by any constant factor:

$$\ln n \ll n^p \ll r^n \ll n! \ll n^n \qquad (p > 0,\ r > 1).$$

"$\ll$" here means the ratio of the smaller to the larger goes to 0. A logarithm is slower than any positive power; any positive power is slower than any exponential with base above 1; the factorial outruns every fixed exponential; and n^n outruns even the factorial. Whenever you face a ratio of two such terms, the dominant term determines the limit: the ratio tends to 0 or to ∞ depending on which term grows faster. Figure 28.4 shows the lower rungs racing apart on a logarithmic scale. The table is just this ladder, read off rung by rung. Internalize the ladder and you can predict most sequence limits at a glance, then confirm with the squeeze theorem or L'Hôpital.

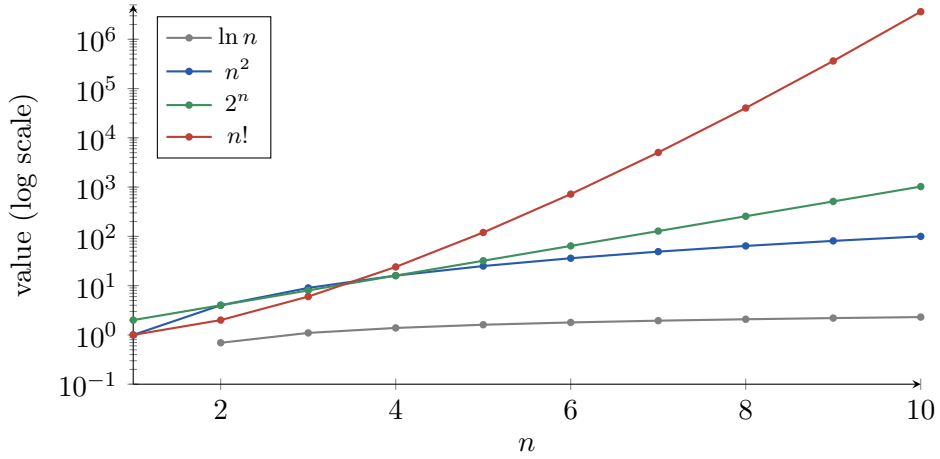


Figure 28.4: The hierarchy of growth on a logarithmic vertical scale, where each curve's height is its value and a higher curve grows faster. The logarithm $\ln n$ grows slowly along the bottom; the power n^2 climbs steadily; the exponential 2^n pulls ahead (note 2^n overtakes n^2 once $n \geq 5$); and the factorial $n!$ grows much faster than either. This is the ladder $\ln n \ll n^p \ll r^n \ll n!$ made visible – illustrating why the limit of a ratio of such terms is determined by their relative growth rates.

Example 28.5 (The root that tames growth: $n^{1/n} \to 1$)**.** Here the base $n \to \infty$ while the exponent $\frac{1}{n} \to 0$, giving an indeterminate form of type ∞^0 with limit 1. Here is a clean argument. For $n \geq 2$, write $n^{1/n} = 1 + h_n$ where $h_n \geq 0$ (since $n^{1/n} \geq 1$, the excess h_n is nonnegative). Raise both sides to the nth power:

$$n = (1 + h_n)^n \geq \binom{n}{2} h_n^2 = \frac{n(n-1)}{2}\, h_n^2,$$

where we kept just the single quadratic term from the binomial expansion – every other term is nonnegative, so dropping them only weakens the right side. Solve for h_n:

$$h_n^2 \leq \frac{2}{n-1} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad 0 \leq h_n \leq \sqrt{\frac{2}{n-1}}.$$

The right side goes to 0, so by the squeeze $h_n \to 0$, hence $n^{1/n} = 1 + h_n \to 1$. The trick – keep *one* well-chosen term of a binomial expansion to get a usable inequality – is worth filing away. $\square$

Example 28.6 (The compound-interest limit: $(1+1/n)^n \to e$)**.** You met e in this guise long ago: invest a dollar at 100% annual interest, compound it n times a year, and your year-end balance is $(1+\frac{1}{n})^n$. As the compounding gets finer, the balance climbs toward a ceiling. That ceiling is Euler's number,

$$\lim_{n\to\infty}\left(1+\frac{1}{n}\right)^n = e \approx 2.71828.$$

A few values make the climb visible: $n=1$ gives 2; $n=2$ gives 2.25; $n=12$ (monthly) gives about 2.613; $n=365$ (daily) gives about 2.7146. Expanding $(1+\frac{1}{n})^n$ by the binomial theorem shows that the sequence increases and stays below $1+1+\frac{1}{2}+\frac{1}{4}+\cdots = 3$ (the kth binomial term is at most $\frac{1}{k!} \le \frac{1}{2^{k-1}}$) – which, by the monotone convergence theorem of the next section, is already enough to *guarantee* a limit exists, even before we name it e. This is one of the cleanest examples of a limit that defines a number rather than merely computing one.

28.6 Monotone bounded sequences converge

Here is one of the central theorems about the real numbers. It says that a sequence can be guaranteed to converge *without your ever knowing what it converges to* – purely from two qualitative facts about its shape.

First, two pieces of vocabulary.

Definition 28.3 (Monotone and bounded)**.** A sequence (a_n) is *increasing* if $a_n \le a_{n+1}$ for all n, and *decreasing* if $a_n \ge a_{n+1}$ for all n; it is *monotone* if it is one or the other. It is *bounded above* if there is a number M with $a_n \le M$ for all n, *bounded below* if some m has $a_n \ge m$ for all n, and *bounded* if both.

Theorem 28.3 (Monotone Convergence Theorem)**.** *An increasing sequence that is bounded above converges – and its limit is the* least upper bound *(supremum) of its terms. Symmetrically, a decreasing sequence that is bounded below converges, to the greatest lower bound of its terms.*

Intuition

Picture an increasing sequence as a runner who only ever moves forward (or stands still), but who can never cross a wall at height M. The runner's positions keep rising; they are pinned below the wall. Intuitively the runner must *pile up* against some ceiling – maybe the wall itself, maybe somewhere short of it, but *some* definite height. They cannot keep advancing forever without either crossing the wall (forbidden) or accumulating at a limit. The limit is the lowest height that the runner never exceeds: the least upper bound.

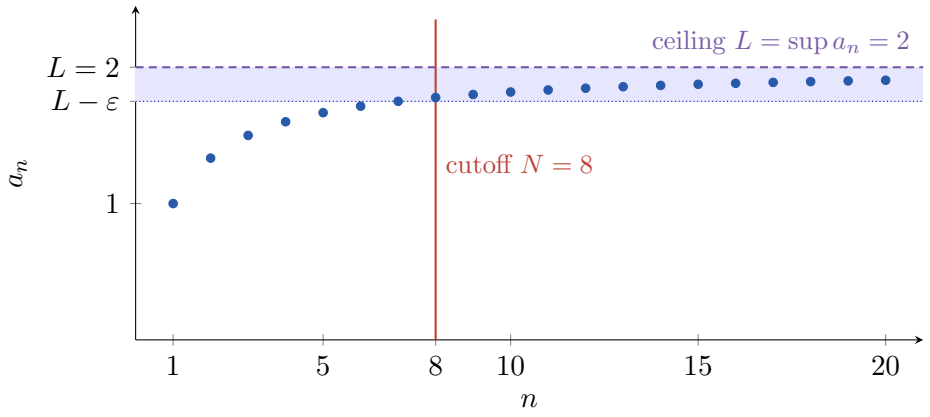


Figure 28.5: An increasing sequence ($a_n = 2 - \frac{2}{n+1}$) bounded above by $L = 2 = \sup a_n$. The shaded strip $[L - \varepsilon, L]$ is the tolerance band below the supremum. Because the terms increase, once term a_8 penetrates the strip (past the red cutoff $N = 8$), every subsequent term is permanently trapped inside. Monotone plus bounded guarantees convergence.

Why the technique works

Why monotone + bounded forces convergence. The decisive property of the real numbers here is *completeness*: every nonempty set of reals that is bounded above has a *least* upper bound, a supremum, denoted sup. There are no "gaps" for a least upper bound to fall into. (The rationals lack this: the rationals less than $\sqrt{2}$ are bounded above but have no rational least upper bound, because $\sqrt{2}$ is missing from $\mathbb{Q}$.)

Now take an increasing sequence (a_n) bounded above. Let $L = \sup\{a_n\}$, the least upper bound of the set of its terms; completeness guarantees this number exists. We claim $a_n \to L$. Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Because L is the *least* upper bound, $L - \varepsilon$ is *not* an upper bound – something smaller than L fails to bound the terms – so some term a_N exceeds $L - \varepsilon$. But the sequence is increasing, so for every $n \geq N$ we have $a_n \geq a_N > L - \varepsilon$. And every term is $\leq L$ since L bounds them all. Therefore, for $n \geq N$,

$$L - \varepsilon < a_n \leq L, \qquad \text{so} \qquad |a_n - L| < \varepsilon.$$

That is convergence to L. The engine is completeness; monotonicity is what lets a single term a_N vouch for all that follow it. □

Why this matters

This theorem separates the question of *existence* from the task of *computation*. To prove convergence directly from Definition 28.2, one must already know the limit L to test the inequality $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$. In many settings, however, a sequence is defined without an explicit formula for its limit: the partial sums of an unfamiliar series, the iterates of a numerical algorithm, or the successive decimal approximations of a real number. The Monotone Convergence Theorem establishes that a limit exists solely from two structural properties: that the terms move in one direction and remain bounded. Once existence is guaranteed, numerical approximations or algebraic techniques can be used to estimate or identify the limit. This is why so many existence proofs in analysis conclude with "monotone and bounded, hence convergent."

Connection

This theorem is the precise reason an infinite decimal means anything. The string $0.333\ldots$ is the sequence of truncations $0.3,\ 0.33,\ 0.333,\ \ldots$. Each truncation is bigger than the last (increasing), and every one is below 0.4 (bounded above). Monotone plus bounded: the sequence converges, to a genuine real number – which equals $\frac{1}{3}$. Without the Monotone Convergence Theorem, "the number $0.333\ldots$" would be a string of digits with no guaranteed value. The same logic certifies *every* infinite decimal as a real number. Chapter 29 builds infinite series on exactly this foundation: a series converges precisely when its sequence of partial sums does.

28.7 Recursive sequences and fixed points

Many of the most important sequences are not given by a formula in n but by a *rule for getting the next term from the current one*:

$$a_{n+1} = f(a_n),$$

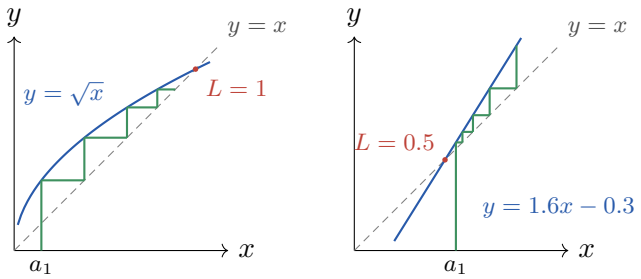
starting from some seed a_1. Each term is the previous term fed through the same function f. Newton's method is of this form; so is every numerical scheme that "iterates to a solution." The natural questions are: does the sequence settle down, and if so, where?

What is really happening

What is really happening: iteration and fixed points. Suppose the sequence $a_{n+1} = f(a_n)$ *does* converge, to some limit L. Then both $a_n \to L$ and $a_{n+1} \to L$ (a sequence and its own shifted copy share a limit – shifting by one place cannot change where a list is headed). If f is continuous, taking the limit of both sides of $a_{n+1} = f(a_n)$ gives

$$L = f(L).$$

A point satisfying $L = f(L)$ is called a *fixed point* of f: feeding it through f returns it unchanged. So *the only possible limits of the iteration are the fixed points of* f. Because the sequence can only settle where $f(L) = L$, finding candidate limits reduces to solving the equation $L = f(L)$.



(a) Attracting: $|f'(L)| < 1$ **(b) Repelling:** $|f'(L)| > 1$

Figure 28.6: Cobweb diagrams for the iteration $a_{n+1} = f(a_n)$. Starting at a_1, move vertically to the curve (apply f), then horizontally to the mirror line $y = x$ (copy output to input), and repeat. **(a)** When $|f'(L)| < 1$ (the curve is shallower than the diagonal), each step contracts toward $L = 1$: the fixed point attracts. **(b)** When $|f'(L)| > 1$ (the curve is steeper than the diagonal), each step magnifies the error away from $L = 0.5$: the fixed point repels.

Intuition

Reading a cobweb. The line $y = x$ is the "mirror" that copies an output back into an input. A fixed point is where the curve $y = f(x)$ crosses this mirror – there, output equals input, so the iteration stops moving. Whether the staircase is drawn *toward* a fixed point (it attracts) or *away* from it (it repels) is governed by how steep f is there: a shallow curve (slope of magnitude below 1) pulls nearby points in; a steep one (slope above 1) pushes them away. The next box makes that precise.

Example 28.7 (A recursion that converges: $a_{n+1} = \sqrt{2 + a_n}$)**.** Define $a_1 = \sqrt{2}$ and $a_{n+1} = \sqrt{2 + a_n}$. The terms are the nested radicals

$$\sqrt{2}, \quad \sqrt{2+\sqrt{2}}, \quad \sqrt{2+\sqrt{2+\sqrt{2}}}, \quad \dots$$

numerically 1.414, 1.848, 1.962, 1.990, 1.998, ..., visibly climbing toward 2. Let us prove they converge and find the limit, the right way.

Step 1: find the candidate limit. If $a_n \to L$, then L is a fixed point of $f(x) = \sqrt{2 + x}$, so $L = \sqrt{2 + L}$. Square: $L^2 = 2 + L$, i.e. $L^2 - L - 2 = 0$, i.e. $(L - 2)(L + 1) = 0$. The roots are $L = 2$ and $L = -1$. Since every term is positive, the only viable candidate is $L = 2$.

Step 2: show it is bounded above (by 2). Use induction. $a_1 = \sqrt{2} < 2$. If $a_n < 2$, then $a_{n+1} = \sqrt{2 + a_n} < \sqrt{2 + 2} = \sqrt{4} = 2$. So $a_n < 2$ for all n.

Step 3: show it is increasing. We check $a_{n+1} > a_n$, i.e. $\sqrt{2 + a_n} > a_n$. Squaring (both sides positive), this is $2 + a_n > a_n^2$, i.e. $a_n^2 - a_n - 2 < 0$, i.e. $(a_n - 2)(a_n + 1) < 0$. Since $0 < a_n < 2$ from Step 2, the first factor is negative and the second positive, so the product is negative. The inequality holds; the sequence increases.

Step 4: conclude. The sequence is increasing and bounded above, so by the Monotone Convergence Theorem (28.3) it converges. By Step 1 the limit can only be 2. Therefore

$$\sqrt{2+\sqrt{2+\sqrt{2+\cdots}}} = 2. \qquad \square$$

Notice the division of labor: Step 1 (fixed point) tells us *where* the limit must be; Steps 2–3 (monotone, bounded) tell us a limit *exists at all*. Neither alone is enough – the fixed-point equation also offered -1, an extraneous root that the positivity of the terms rules out.

Why the technique works

Why slope decides attraction. Suppose L is a fixed point, f is differentiable, and $|f'(L)| < 1$. Near L the map moves a point at distance d from L to a point at distance roughly $|f'(L)|\,d$ – closer, because the multiplier is below 1. Each step shrinks the distance by a factor under 1, so the errors form a sequence dominated by a geometric one tending to 0: the iteration is drawn in, and we call L *attracting* (stable). If instead $|f'(L)| > 1$, each step *enlarges* the distance and the iteration is flung away (L is *repelling*). At the borderline $|f'(L)| = 1$ the linear term decides nothing and you must look closer.
In Example 28.7, $f(x) = \sqrt{2+x}$ has $f'(x) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{2+x}}$, so $f'(2) = \frac{1}{2\cdot 2} = \frac{1}{4} < 1$: the fixed point 2 attracts, consistent with the staircase marching in. The phantom root -1 is not even in the domain we care about, so it never competes.

Example 28.8 (A recursion that does *not* settle)**.** Not every recursion converges. Take $a_{n+1} = 2a_n - 1$ with seed $a_1 = 2$. The fixed-point equation $L = 2L - 1$ gives $L = 1$. But $f(x) = 2x - 1$ has $f'(x) = 2 > 1$ everywhere, so the fixed point 1 repels. Starting at $a_1 = 2$ (distance 1 above the fixed point) the terms are

$$2,\ 3,\ 5,\ 9,\ 17,\ 33,\ \ldots,$$

each step doubling the distance from 1. The sequence diverges to $+\infty$. The fixed point exists, but the iteration moves away from it rather than toward it. This illustrates the distinction: solving $L = f(L)$ identifies the candidate limits, but does not guarantee convergence. Convergence must be earned separately – by monotone-bounded, by the slope test, or by direct estimate.

Connection

Connection: From fixed points to Banach and Picard. The fixed-point idea is one of the great unifying threads of modern mathematics. In 1922 Stefan Banach proved his *contraction mapping theorem*: if a map f shrinks distances by a fixed factor below 1 – $|f(x) - f(y)| \le k\,|x - y|$ with $k < 1$ – then iterating from *any* starting point produces a sequence converging to the one and only fixed point. The slope condition $|f'(L)| < 1$ you met above is the local, calculus-flavored shadow of Banach's global statement.
This is not abstraction for its own sake. Banach's theorem is the engine behind the existence-and-uniqueness proof for differential equations (Picard iteration, Chapter 37), behind Newton's method, behind Google's PageRank, and behind countless numerical solvers. In each case a hard problem is rephrased as "find the fixed point of this map," and a sequence of approximations is generated to converge to it. The iterative scheme $a_{n+1} = f(a_n)$ studied here provides the underlying framework.

Application

Babylonian square roots. To compute $\sqrt{S}$, iterate

$$a_{n+1} = \frac{1}{2}\left(a_n + \frac{S}{a_n}\right),$$

which is exactly Newton's method applied to $x^2 - S = 0$. Its fixed points solve $L = \frac{1}{2}(L + S/L)$, i.e. $2L = L + S/L$, i.e. $L^2 = S$, i.e. $L = \sqrt{S}$. For $S = 2$ starting at $a_1 = 1$:

$$1, \quad 1.5, \quad 1.41667, \quad 1.41422, \quad 1.41421356\ldots,$$

and the correct figures roughly *double* each step – a hallmark of Newton's method near a simple root. The Babylonians ran this recursion on clay tablets nearly four thousand years ago. They had no theory of limits, no ε, no N – only the observation that the iteration "stopped changing." What this chapter supplies is the why: $\frac{1}{2}(x + S/x)$ has an attracting fixed point at $\sqrt{S}$, so the clay tablets were converging all along.

Work it yourself

Pick a recursion and run it by hand for five steps, then explain its fate.

1. $a_1 = 0$, $a_{n+1} = \cos(a_n)$ (radians). Compute $a_2, \ldots, a_6$ on a calculator. The terms hover around a single number – the *Dottie number*. What equation does that number satisfy? (Answer: the fixed point $L = \cos L \approx 0.739$.) Is $|f'(L)| < 1$?
2. $a_1 = 1$, $a_{n+1} = 1 + \frac{1}{a_n}$. Compute several terms. They approach the golden ratio φ. Find the fixed-point equation $L = 1 + \frac{1}{L}$ and solve it. Which root do the terms choose, and why?

28.8 From sequences to series: a preview

Everything in this chapter was built to support one move, the move that occupies the next several chapters: making sense of an *infinite sum*.

You cannot literally add infinitely many numbers – addition is an operation on two inputs, repeated finitely. So what could

$$\tfrac{1}{2} + \tfrac{1}{4} + \tfrac{1}{8} + \tfrac{1}{16} + \cdots$$

possibly *mean*? The precise mathematical meaning is defined via a sequence. Form the *partial sums*, the running totals:

$$s_1 = \tfrac{1}{2}, \quad s_2 = \tfrac{1}{2} + \tfrac{1}{4} = \tfrac{3}{4}, \quad s_3 = \tfrac{7}{8}, \quad s_4 = \tfrac{15}{16}, \quad \ldots, \quad s_n = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2^n}.$$

This is a perfectly ordinary sequence (s_n). It is increasing (each new term adds a positive amount) and bounded above (by 1). By the Monotone Convergence Theorem it converges – and its limit is explicitly 1, since $1/2^n \to 0$. *That* is what we mean when we write the infinite sum and declare it equal to 1: the sequence of partial sums converges to 1.

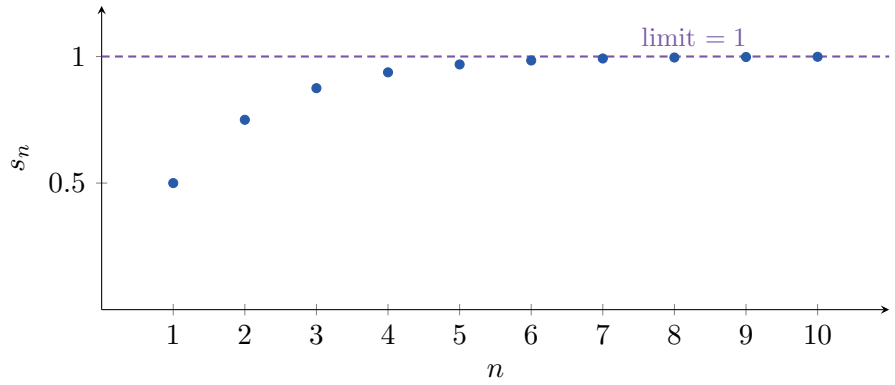


Figure 28.7: Partial sums $s_n = 1 - 2^{-n}$ of the series $\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{8} + \cdots$. The running totals climb, halving the remaining gap to 1 at each step: increasing and bounded above, hence convergent. The infinite sum is *defined* to be this limit, 1.

Why this matters

The central principle is: **an infinite process is defined to be the limit of its finite stages.** An infinite sum is the limit of partial sums. An infinite product is the limit of partial products. A real number is the limit of its decimal truncations. A definite integral is the limit of Riemann sums. In every case the actual infinity is never performed – it is replaced by a sequence of finite, computable approximations, and the "answer" is wherever that sequence is *headed*. The theory of sequences you have just built is therefore not a side topic. It is the foundation on which the entire calculus of the infinite stands.

28.9 Summary and Non-Constructive Limits

Connection

Sequences connect discrete step-by-step arithmetic to continuous limits.
Sequence theory resolved Zeno's paradoxes of motion. By defining limits through the rigorous (ε, N) framework of Cauchy and Weierstrass, mathematics established the algebra of limits, the Squeeze Theorem, and the Monotone Convergence Theorem. This delivered two fundamental breakthroughs:

- *Certification of convergence without knowing the limit:* Through the Monotone Convergence Theorem (and, for subsequences, the Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem), we can prove that a sequence converges from monotonicity and boundedness alone, with no prior formula for the limit.
- *Universal fixed-point iteration:* Recursive sequences $a_{n+1} = f(a_n)$ and contraction mappings gave a rigorous foundation to Newton's method for root-finding, Picard's existence proof for differential equations, and modern algorithmic optimization (such as gradient descent and PageRank).

Yet while the Monotone Convergence Theorem guarantees that a bounded monotone sequence must have a limit $L \in \mathbb{R}$, it is fundamentally non-constructive: *proving that a limit exists gives*

no formula to evaluate it in closed form.
Recall the Euler–Mascheroni sequence $\gamma_n = \left(\sum_{k=1}^{n} \frac{1}{k}\right) - \ln n$ from Section 28.1: comparing the sum to $\int_1^n \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{x}$ shows quickly that γ_n decreases and stays positive, so the Monotone Convergence Theorem guarantees a limit $\gamma \approx 0.5772$ even though no closed-form expression in standard constants is known and its rationality (centuries after Euler introduced it in 1734) remains open. Existence does not mean closed-form evaluation.
In Chapter 29 (*Infinite Series and Convergence*), we put sequence theory to work to make sense of infinite sums. By defining an infinite series $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k$ strictly as the limit of its sequence of partial sums $S_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n} a_k$, every theorem of this chapter becomes an operational convergence test for series (the Integral Test, Comparison Test, Ratio Test, and Root Test).

Exercises

Exercise 28.1. Write out the first five terms of each sequence and predict, with a one-line reason, where it is headed.

(a) $a_n = \dfrac{2n-1}{n+3}$

(b) $a_n = \dfrac{(-1)^{n+1}}{2^n}$

(c) $a_n = \dfrac{n!}{n^n}$

(d) $a_n = \cos(\pi n)$

Exercise 28.2. Use the epsilon-N definition (28.2) directly to prove each limit. In each case, given $\varepsilon > 0$, exhibit an explicit N and verify the implication.

(a) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{1}{n^2} = 0.$

(b) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{n}{n+1} = 1.$ *Hint: simplify* $\left|\frac{n}{n+1} - 1\right|$ *first.*

(c) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{3n+2}{n} = 3.$

Exercise 28.3. Evaluate each limit, naming the limit laws or table entries (Section 28.5) you use.

(a) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{4n^3 - 2n + 1}{5n^3 + n^2}$

(b) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{\sqrt{n^2+1}}{n}$

(c) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \left(\sqrt{n+1} - \sqrt{n}\right)$ *Hint: multiply by the conjugate.*

(d) $\lim\limits_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{2^n + 3^n}{3^n}$

Exercise 28.4. Use the squeeze theorem (28.2) to evaluate each limit. State your two bounding sequences explicitly.

(a) $\lim_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{\cos(n^2)}{n}$

(b) $\lim_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{n+\sin n}{n^2}$

(c) $\lim_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{3^n}{n!}$ *(adapt Example 28.4)*

(d) $\lim_{n\to\infty} \sqrt[n]{2^n+3^n}$ *Hint: bound below by* 3 *and above by* $3\sqrt[n]{2}$.

Exercise 28.5. Explain carefully, using the definition of a limit, why the sequence $a_n = (-1)^n \cdot \dfrac{n}{n+1}$ diverges. (What two values do the even and odd terms approach, and why does that forbid a single limit?)

Exercise 28.6. Let $a_1 = 1$ and $a_{n+1} = \sqrt{6 + a_n}$.

(a) Find the candidate limit by solving the fixed-point equation $L = \sqrt{6+L}$; discard the inadmissible root.

(b) Prove by induction that $a_n < 3$ for all n (bounded above).

(c) Prove the sequence is increasing.

(d) Conclude that it converges, and state the limit.

Exercise 28.7. Let $a_1 = 6$ and $a_{n+1} = \dfrac{a_n + 4}{2}$.

(a) Compute the first four terms. Is the sequence increasing or decreasing?

(b) Find the fixed point of $f(x) = \frac{x+4}{2}$ and compute f'; is the fixed point attracting or repelling?

(c) Show the sequence is bounded below by the fixed point, then conclude it converges (which form of the Monotone Convergence Theorem applies here?).

Exercise 28.8. Consider the logistic-style map $a_{n+1} = \frac{3}{2}\, a_n(1 - a_n)$ with seed $a_1 = 0.2$.

(a) Find the two fixed points of $f(x) = \frac{3}{2}x(1-x)$.

(b) Compute f' at each fixed point and classify each as attracting or repelling.

(c) Compute the first five terms numerically and say which fixed point the iteration is approaching, consistent with part (b).

Exercise 28.9. Apply the Babylonian iteration $a_{n+1} = \frac{1}{2}(a_n + \frac{5}{a_n})$ with $a_1 = 2$ to approximate $\sqrt{5}$.

(a) Compute a_2, a_3, a_4 to six decimal places.

(b) How many correct digits does each step produce? Comment on the doubling you observe and connect it to the discussion in the application box.

Exercise 28.10. (a) Using a calculator, tabulate $(1 + \frac{1}{n})^n$ for $n = 1, 10, 100, 1000, 10{,}000$ and watch it climb toward e.

(b) The sequence is increasing and bounded above. Which theorem of this chapter guarantees, before any numerical evidence, that the limit *exists*? Explain in one or two sentences what role completeness of the real numbers plays.

Exercise 28.11. Without computing exact values, use the growth hierarchy $\ln n \ll n^p \ll r^n \ll n! \ll n^n$ (Section 28.5) to decide whether each limit is 0 or $+\infty$, and justify in one line.

(a) $\displaystyle\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{n^{10}}{2^n}$

(b) $\displaystyle\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{n!}{100^n}$

(c) $\displaystyle\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{(\ln n)^3}{\sqrt{n}}$

(d) $\displaystyle\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{n^n}{n!}$

Exercise 28.12. A real number is the limit of its decimal truncations. Let a_n be π truncated to n decimal places: $a_1 = 3.1,\ a_2 = 3.14,\ a_3 = 3.141, \ldots$.

(a) Argue that (a_n) is increasing and bounded above (by 3.2, say).

(b) Which theorem certifies that this sequence has a limit – so that "the number π" is a well-defined real number rather than just an endless string of digits? Relate your answer to the connection box on infinite decimals.

Chapter 29

Infinite Series and Convergence

In Chapter 28, we studied sequences: infinite lists of numbers $a_1, a_2, a_3, \ldots$ marching along a line, asking whether their terms eventually settle on a single destination. Now we take the next natural step: instead of watching those numbers one at a time, what happens when we try to *add them all together*?

At first sight, adding infinitely many numbers sounds like a category mistake. Addition, as you first learned it, is a finite act: you line up two numbers, or ten, or a million, and you combine them. The process *stops*. But what could it possibly mean to write

$$1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{8} + \frac{1}{16} + \cdots$$

and ask for "the sum"? You can never reach the end. There is no last term to add. Yet many such infinite sums settle onto a definite finite number, while others grow without bound or oscillate indefinitely. This chapter develops the tools to tell which infinite sums settle down and which ones diverge.

These questions have practical weight. Every time you evaluate $e^{0.3}$ on a calculator, or your computer reports $\sin(1)$, or a physicist models the gravitational pull of a ring of mass, an infinite series is doing the work underneath. Key transcendental functions – such as e^x, $\sin x$, and $\ln(1+x)$ – can be represented as infinite series, as we will explore in the next chapter. But none of it makes sense until we are clear about what it means for an infinite sum to have a value at all. So we begin where we must: with the partial sums.

29.1 What It Means to Add Infinitely Many Things

The trick – and it is the single most important idea in the chapter, the seed from which everything else grows – is that we never actually perform an infinite addition. We *can't*. Instead we perform a sequence of perfectly ordinary finite additions and watch where they are heading.

Intuition

Imagine walking toward a wall. First you cover half the remaining distance, then half of what's left, then half again. After each step you have walked a finite, knowable distance. You will never literally arrive, but it is intuitively clear *where* you are arriving: at the wall. The infinite

sum is not the act of taking infinitely many steps. It is the *destination* those steps approach.

Let us make this precise. Given an infinite list of numbers $a_1, a_2, a_3, \ldots$ – which we call the *terms* – we build a brand-new list out of them, the list of **partial sums**:

$$S_1 = a_1, \qquad S_2 = a_1 + a_2, \qquad S_3 = a_1 + a_2 + a_3, \qquad \ldots, \qquad S_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n} a_k.$$

Each S_n is a finite sum – no mystery, no infinity, just arithmetic. The infinite series is then *defined* to be the limit of this sequence of partial sums, if that limit exists.

Definition 29.1 (Convergence of a series)**.** Let $a_1, a_2, a_3, \ldots$ be a sequence of real numbers and let $S_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n} a_k$ be its nth partial sum. We say the series $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k$ **converges** to the number S if

$$\lim_{n\to\infty} S_n = S,$$

and we then write $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k = S$. If the sequence (S_n) has no finite limit, we say the series **diverges**.

What is really happening

The symbol $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k$ does not instruct you to perform infinitely many additions. It is shorthand for a *limit of a sequence*: the sequence of finite partial sums. When we write $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{2^k} = 1$, we mean that the sequence of finite sums $\frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}, \frac{7}{8}, \frac{15}{16}, \ldots$ approaches 1. An infinite sum is a statement about limits.

History

Why was this definition of partial sums so desperately needed? Because without it, the greatest mathematicians fell into outright contradictions.

In the eighteenth century, mathematicians lacked a formal definition of what an infinite sum actually meant. Armed with powerful algebraic methods, they treated infinite series like ordinary finite polynomials, rearranging and grouping terms at will. In 1703, the Italian monk and mathematician Guido Grandi analyzed the alternating series:

$$1 - 1 + 1 - 1 + 1 - 1 + \cdots$$

Grouping adjacent pairs as $(1 - 1) + (1 - 1) + \cdots$ gave $0 + 0 + \cdots = 0$, while shifting the grouping by one term as $1 - (1 - 1) - (1 - 1) - \cdots$ gave $1 - 0 - 0 - \cdots = 1$. Grandi argued that since the sum was poised between 0 and 1, its true value must be the average, $1/2$, and claimed this proved God created the universe out of nothing ($0 = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{2}$). Even Leonhard Euler, whose computational intuition was peerless, accepted that $1 - 1 + 1 - \cdots = 1/2$ by evaluating $\frac{1}{1+x} = 1 - x + x^2 - \cdots$ at $x = 1$. But Euler's bold formal algebra led to troubling paradoxes, such as asserting $1 + 2 + 4 + 8 + \cdots = -1$ by evaluating $\frac{1}{1-x}$ at $x = 2$. Critics attacked the emerging calculus as logically suspect.

Order was restored in 1821 when Augustin-Louis Cauchy published his *Cours d'Analyse*. Cauchy established Definition 29.1: an infinite sum has a value if and only if the sequence of its finite partial sums S_n approaches a single, finite limit. Because the partial sums of Grandi's series bounce endlessly between 1 and 0 $(1, 0, 1, 0, \ldots)$, no limit exists, and the series simply diverges. Cauchy's partial-sum definition replaced metaphysical speculation with the

solid ground of sequence limits.
Cauchy's framework made possible the rigorous development of mathematical physics and Fourier series. Yet infinite series still present difficult open questions. While Euler famously discovered that $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2} = \frac{\pi^2}{6}$, closed-form formulas for odd-exponent sums like $\zeta(5) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^5}$ remain unknown (Roger Apéry proved that $\zeta(3)$ is irrational in 1978, but no formula in terms of standard constants is known). Even more elementary, the gap between the harmonic sum and the natural logarithm approaches the Euler–Mascheroni constant $\gamma = \lim_{n\to\infty} \left(\sum_{k=1}^{n} \frac{1}{k} - \ln n \right) \approx 0.5772$. Despite centuries of study, whether γ is rational or irrational remains unsolved.

So "convergence" and "divergence" are not really new ideas. They are the limit concept from earlier in the book, applied to the particular sequence (S_n). Every theorem about series is ultimately a statement about the convergence of the sequence of partial sums (S_n). Keeping this connection in mind clarifies why each convergence test works.

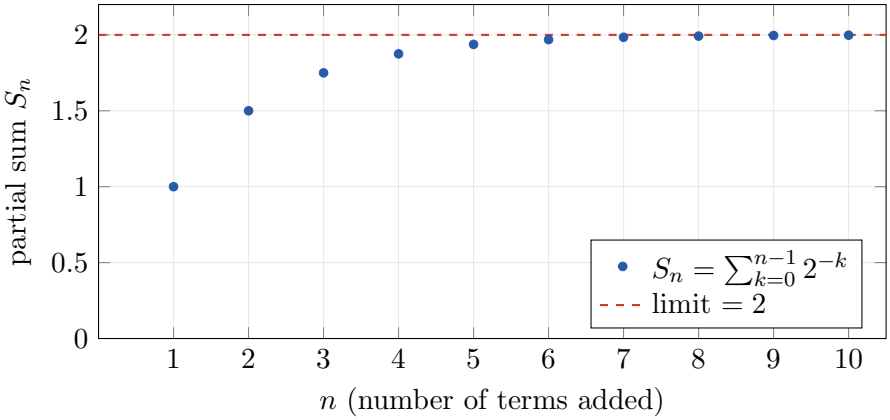


Figure 29.1: The partial sums of $1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4} + \cdots$ climb toward 2, halving the gap each step but never crossing. The infinite sum *is* that ceiling.

Walking question

Before reading on, settle a question in your head on a walk: the terms $\frac{1}{2^k}$ get smaller and smaller and eventually become negligibly tiny. Is "the terms shrink to zero" enough, all by itself, to guarantee the sum is finite? Hold your answer. By the end of Section 29.5 it may surprise you.

29.2 The Geometric Series: The One You Can Sum Exactly

Most convergent series have no simple closed-form sum – we can often prove a series converges without being able to write its exact total in elementary terms. A major exception that can be evaluated exactly is the **geometric series**, in which each term is a constant multiple r of the preceding term.

$$a + ar + ar^2 + ar^3 + \cdots = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} a\, r^k.$$

The number r is the *ratio*. Our walk-toward-the-wall example was the case $a = 1$, $r = \frac{1}{2}$. Let us find the total properly, by computing the partial sums and taking their limit – never by waving hands at infinity.

Focus

The summing trick. Let $S_n = a + ar + ar^2 + \cdots + ar^{n-1}$ (that's n terms). Multiply the whole thing by r:

$$rS_n = ar + ar^2 + \cdots + ar^{n-1} + ar^n.$$

Now subtract. Look at what happens: almost everything cancels, because rS_n is just S_n shifted over by one slot.

$$S_n - rS_n = a - ar^n \quad \Longrightarrow \quad (1-r)S_n = a\,(1-r^n).$$

Provided $r \neq 1$, divide:

$$\boxed{S_n = a\,\frac{1-r^n}{1-r}}.$$

This is an *exact* formula for the finite partial sum – valuable on its own. Now we take the limit. Everything hinges on what r^n does as $n \to \infty$. If $|r| < 1$, then $r^n \to 0$ (repeatedly multiplying by something smaller than 1 in size drives you to zero). If $|r| > 1$, then $|r^n| \to \infty$ and the partial sums blow up. The boundary cases $r = 1$ and $r = -1$ misbehave in their own ways.

Theorem 29.1 (The geometric series)**.** *The geometric series $\sum_{k=0}^{\infty} a\,r^k$ converges if and only if $|r| < 1$, and in that case*

$$\sum_{k=0}^{\infty} a\,r^k = \frac{a}{1-r}.$$

If $|r| \geq 1$ (and $a \neq 0$) the series diverges.

Proof. From the boxed formula, $S_n = a\dfrac{1-r^n}{1-r}$ for $r \neq 1$. If $|r| < 1$ then $r^n \to 0$, so $S_n \to \dfrac{a(1-0)}{1-r} = \dfrac{a}{1-r}$. If $|r| > 1$ then $|r^n| \to \infty$, so S_n has no finite limit. If $r = 1$, the series is $a + a + a + \cdots$ and $S_n = na \to \pm\infty$. If $r = -1$, the partial sums bounce $a, 0, a, 0, \ldots$ and never settle. In every case with $|r| \geq 1$ the series diverges. □

Why the technique works

Why does the $|r| < 1$ condition do *all* the work? Because the geometric series carries its own fate in its terms. The "tail" that remains after n terms is itself a geometric series, $ar^n + ar^{n+1} + \cdots = r^n \cdot \frac{a}{1-r}$, a shrunken copy of the original scaled by r^n. When $|r| < 1$ that scaling factor crushes the leftover tail to nothing; the destination is in sight and the remaining journey shrinks geometrically. When $|r| \geq 1$ the tail is as big as – or bigger than – the whole, so there is never any "settling down." The self-similarity of the geometric series is exactly why it is the one we can pin down precisely, and it is why $|r|$ versus 1 is the only thing that matters.

Example 29.1 (The walk to the wall, finished)**.** With $a = 1$, $r = \frac{1}{2}$: the sum is $\dfrac{1}{1-\frac{1}{2}} = 2$. Note our list started at $k = 0$, so this is $1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4} + \cdots = 2$, matching Figure 29.1.

Example 29.2 (A repeating decimal is a geometric series)**.** What is $0.7777\ldots$ really? It is

$$\frac{7}{10} + \frac{7}{100} + \frac{7}{1000} + \cdots = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \frac{7}{10}\left(\frac{1}{10}\right)^{k-1},$$

a geometric series with first term $a = \frac{7}{10}$ and ratio $r = \frac{1}{10}$. So its value is

$$\frac{a}{1-r} = \frac{7/10}{1-1/10} = \frac{7/10}{9/10} = \frac{7}{9}.$$

Every repeating decimal can be written as a geometric series, showing why repeating decimals represent rational numbers. For instance, $0.999\ldots = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \frac{9}{10^k} = \frac{9/10}{1-1/10} = 1$.

Connection

The geometric series is ancient. Around 250 BCE, Archimedes summed $1 + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{16} + \cdots = \frac{4}{3}$ to find the area of a parabolic segment – a genuine infinite sum, handled with total rigor, two thousand years before "limit" had a formal definition. He did not say "let $n \to \infty$"; instead he proved by his *method of exhaustion* that the area could be neither more nor less than $\frac{4}{3}$, squeezing it from both sides. The intuition of convergence was available to the very best mathematicians long before the machinery. The formalization of limits and partial sums in the nineteenth century provided a general, systematic framework to evaluate and verify such series.

Pause

Mental check. What is $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty}(1/3)^k$? Notice the index begins at $k = 1$, so the first term is $a = 1/3$ and the common ratio is $r = 1/3$. By Theorem 29.1, the sum is $\frac{1/3}{1-1/3} = \frac{1/3}{2/3} = \frac{1}{2}$.

29.3 Telescoping Series: When the Middle Cancels

Besides the geometric series, there is one more family we can sum exactly, and it relies on the same essential move: arrange for the partial sum S_n to collapse to just a few surviving terms. These are the **telescoping series**, named for the way an old collapsible spyglass folds down to almost nothing.

The idea: suppose each term can be written as a *difference* of consecutive values of some sequence, $a_k = b_k - b_{k+1}$. Then

$$S_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n}(b_k - b_{k+1}) = (b_1 - b_2) + (b_2 - b_3) + (b_3 - b_4) + \cdots + (b_n - b_{n+1}).$$

Every interior term appears twice with opposite signs and cancels. Only the very first and very last survive:

$$S_n = b_1 - b_{n+1}.$$

The infinite sum is then $\lim_{n\to\infty} S_n = b_1 - \lim_{n\to\infty} b_{n+1}$, easy as soon as you know where b_k heads.

Example 29.3 (A classic telescoping sum)**.** Consider $\displaystyle\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{k(k+1)}$. The terms shrink fast, but is there a sum? Use partial fractions – the algebraic decomposition that reveals the difference structure:

$$\frac{1}{k(k+1)} = \frac{1}{k} - \frac{1}{k+1}.$$

So with $b_k = \frac{1}{k}$ we have $a_k = b_k - b_{k+1}$, and

$$S_n = \left(1 - \tfrac{1}{2}\right) + \left(\tfrac{1}{2} - \tfrac{1}{3}\right) + \cdots + \left(\tfrac{1}{n} - \tfrac{1}{n+1}\right) = 1 - \frac{1}{n+1}.$$

As $n \to \infty$, $\frac{1}{n+1} \to 0$, so the series sums to exactly 1. Clean and complete.

Common trap

A common error in telescoping series is assuming that every term cancels except the first. To avoid this, write out the partial sum S_n in full and identify which terms remain at *both* ends. Some telescopes leave two survivors on each side (when the difference skips a step, like $b_k - b_{k+2}$), giving $S_n = b_1 + b_2 - b_{n+1} - b_{n+2}$. And the sum exists only if the trailing survivors have a limit. If b_k does not converge, the telescope diverges no matter how much cancels in the middle.

Pause

Mental check. If $a_k = \frac{1}{k} - \frac{1}{k+2}$, which terms survive in S_n? Expanding $S_n = (1 - \frac{1}{3}) + (\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{4}) + (\frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{5}) + (\frac{1}{4} - \frac{1}{6}) + \cdots$ reveals that 1 and $\frac{1}{2}$ have no subtracted partners, leaving $S_n = 1 + \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{n+1} - \frac{1}{n+2} \to \frac{3}{2}$.

29.4 The First Thing to Check: The nth-Term Test

Before reaching for any heavy machinery, there is a one-second sanity check that can kill a series outright. It comes from a simple observation about *convergent* series and their terms.

Intuition

If the partial sums S_n are settling down to a fixed number S, then consecutive partial sums must be getting closer and closer to each other. But the gap between consecutive partial sums is exactly one term: $S_n - S_{n-1} = a_n$. So the terms must be shrinking to zero. A convergent sum *cannot* keep adding non-negligible chunks forever – if it did, it would never settle.

Theorem 29.2 (The nth-term test for divergence)**.** *If $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k$ converges, then $\lim_{n\to\infty} a_n = 0$. Equivalently (contrapositive): if a_n does* not *tend to 0, the series diverges.*

Proof. Suppose the series converges to S, so $S_n \to S$ and also $S_{n-1} \to S$ (same sequence, shifted). Then

$$a_n = S_n - S_{n-1} \longrightarrow S - S = 0. \qquad \square$$

Common trap

This is the single most misused fact in the chapter, so read carefully. The theorem says one thing and one thing only: *if the terms don't go to zero, the series diverges.* It does **not** say the converse. "The terms go to zero" does **not** imply the series converges. That converse is false, and the harmonic series in Section 29.5 is the famous counterexample. The nth-term test is a *divergence detector only.* When the terms shrink to zero, the test is silent – it tells you nothing, and you must reach for a real test.

Example 29.4. $\sum \dfrac{n}{2n+1}$ diverges, because $\dfrac{n}{2n+1} \to \frac{1}{2} \neq 0$. We are adding chunks that stay near $\frac{1}{2}$ forever; no settling is possible. Likewise $\sum(-1)^n$ diverges since the terms don't approach 0 (they bounce between 1 and -1). One glance, done.

29.5 The Harmonic Series: A Genuine Surprise

Here is the series that should unsettle you, the one the walking question pointed toward:

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n} = 1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{5} + \cdots$$

Why is it called the *harmonic* series? The name comes from musical acoustics: the overtones or harmonics of a vibrating string of length L are produced by dividing the string into fractions of its length: $L/2, L/3, L/4, \ldots$. The terms shrink to zero. The nth-term test says nothing against it. Yet the harmonic series **diverges** – its partial sums crawl off to infinity, slowly but inexorably. This is one of the classic surprises of mathematics, and the proof is so clean that it is worth knowing by heart.

Focus

Oresme's grouping (c. 1350). Group the terms in blocks whose lengths double, and bound each block from below:

$$1 + \frac{1}{2} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{4}}_{>\frac{1}{4}+\frac{1}{4}=\frac{1}{2}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{5} + \frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{7} + \frac{1}{8}}_{>\frac{1}{8}\cdot 4=\frac{1}{2}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{9} + \cdots + \frac{1}{16}}_{>\frac{1}{16}\cdot 8=\frac{1}{2}} + \cdots$$

In each block, replace every term by the *smallest* term in that block; the block still beats $\frac{1}{2}$. So the sum contains infinitely many chunks each exceeding $\frac{1}{2}$. Add enough blocks and you pass any number you like. The partial sums are unbounded; the series diverges.

Connection

Nicole Oresme, a French scholar of the fourteenth century, produced exactly this argument around 1350 – centuries before calculus existed. It is one of the earliest truly rigorous results about an infinite process. The divergence is agonizingly slow: to push the partial sum past 10 you need over twelve thousand terms; to reach 100 you need more terms than there are atoms in your body. This sluggishness is precisely why the result is shocking. Everything *looks* like it should converge. It is the slowest, gentlest possible march to infinity – but it gets there.

Why this matters

The harmonic series teaches the deepest lesson of the whole subject: *the rate at which terms shrink is everything.* The terms $\frac{1}{n}$ go to zero, but not fast enough; the terms $\frac{1}{2^n}$ go to zero fast enough. The entire theory of convergence – every test that follows – is really one question asked in many forms: *do the terms shrink fast enough?* Geometric decay (r^n) is fast enough. Decay like $\frac{1}{n}$ is not. The borderline lies somewhere in between, and mapping that borderline precisely is what the rest of the chapter is about.

29.6 The Integral Test: Series as Areas

The harmonic series begs a follow-up: where, exactly, is the borderline? We know $\sum \frac{1}{n}$ diverges. What about $\sum \frac{1}{n^2}$, or $\sum \frac{1}{n^{1.5}}$, or $\sum \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}}$? To settle a whole family at once we connect sums to integrals – two ways of measuring the same underlying quantity, area under a decreasing curve.

Intuition

Picture the terms $a_n = f(n)$ of a positive, decreasing sequence as the heights of rectangles, each of width 1. The sum $\sum f(n)$ is the total area of an infinite staircase of rectangles. The integral $\int_1^\infty f(x)\,dx$ is the area under the smooth curve $y = f(x)$. Because the curve is decreasing, the rectangles and the curve trap each other: the staircase is never far from the smooth area. So the sum is finite exactly when the integral is finite. We've traded a hard sum for an integral we may know how to do.

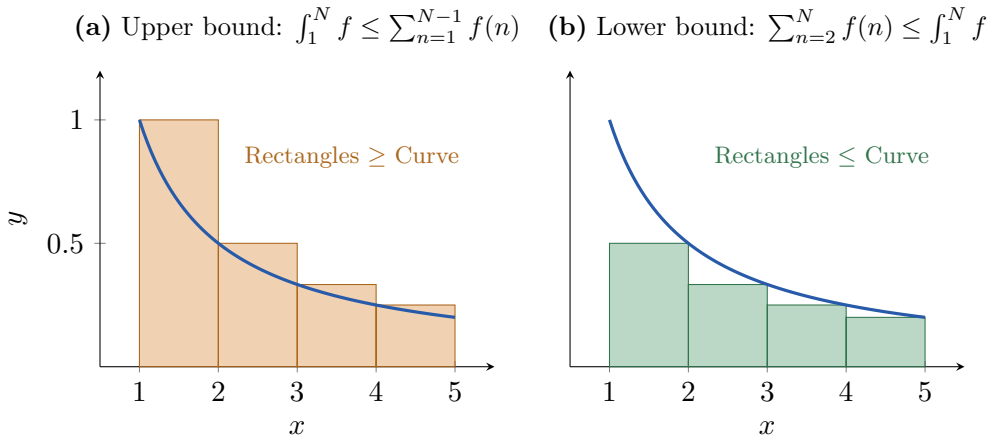


Figure 29.2: The Integral Test sandwich. **(a)** Left-endpoint rectangles sit *above* the decreasing curve $f(x)$, showing $\int_1^N f(x)\,dx \le \sum_{n=1}^{N-1} a_n$. If the integral diverges, it forces the series to diverge. **(b)** Right-endpoint rectangles sit *below* the curve on $[n-1, n]$, showing $\sum_{n=2}^{N} a_n \le \int_1^N f(x)\,dx$. If the improper integral converges, it caps the series from above, guaranteeing convergence.

Theorem 29.3 (The integral test)**.** *Let f be positive, continuous, and decreasing on $[1, \infty)$, and set $a_n = f(n)$. Then the series $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} a_n$ and the improper integral $\int_1^\infty f(x)\,dx$ either both converge or both diverge.*

Proof. Because f decreases, on the interval $[n, n+1]$ we have $f(n+1) \le f(x) \le f(n)$. Integrating across that unit interval (width 1) gives the rectangle-vs-curve sandwich:

$$f(n+1) \;\le\; \int_n^{n+1} f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;\le\; f(n).$$

Sum the right inequality for $n = 1$ to $N-1$: $\int_1^N f \le \sum_{n=1}^{N-1} f(n)$. Sum the left inequality for $n = 1$ to $N-1$: $\sum_{n=2}^{N} f(n) \le \int_1^N f$. Together,

$$\sum_{n=2}^{N} a_n \;\le\; \int_1^N f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \;\le\; \sum_{n=1}^{N-1} a_n.$$

If the integral converges (finite as $N \to \infty$), the left inequality bounds the partial sums above; a bounded increasing sequence converges, so the series converges. If the integral diverges, the right inequality forces the partial sums to infinity, so the series diverges. The integral and the series are locked together. □

Why the technique works

The integral test works because the sum and the improper integral both represent accumulated area under or along the curve $y = f(x)$. When f is decreasing, the difference between the staircase of rectangles and the smooth curve on each unit interval $[n, n+1]$ is bounded by $f(n) - f(n+1)$. Summing these differences produces a telescoping sum bounded by $f(1)$, ensuring that the total discrepancy remains finite. This explains why the decreasing hypothesis is necessary: it ensures that the discrete sum and continuous integral remain within a bounded distance of each other.

The payoff is an entire family of series settled at once, and it is the convergence fact worth memorizing above all others.

Theorem 29.4 (The p-series)**.** *The series* $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^p}$ *converges if and only if* $p > 1$.

Proof. Apply the integral test to $f(x) = x^{-p}$ (positive, decreasing for $x \ge 1$ when $p > 0$; and for $p \le 0$ the terms don't even go to zero, so it diverges by the nth-term test). For $p \ne 1$,

$$\int_1^{\infty} x^{-p}\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{b\to\infty} \frac{x^{1-p}}{1-p}\Big|_1^b = \lim_{b\to\infty} \frac{b^{1-p}-1}{1-p}.$$

When $p > 1$, the exponent $1-p$ is negative, so $b^{1-p} \to 0$ and the integral equals $\frac{1}{p-1}$, finite: convergence. When $p < 1$, $b^{1-p} \to \infty$: divergence. When $p = 1$, $\int_1^{\infty} \frac{1}{x}\,\mathrm{d}x = \lim_{b\to\infty} \ln b = \infty$: divergence (the harmonic series, again). □

Focus

Memorize this. $\sum \frac{1}{n^p}$ converges $\iff$ $p > 1$. So $\sum \frac{1}{n^2}, \sum \frac{1}{n^3}, \sum \frac{1}{n^{1.01}}$ converge; $\sum \frac{1}{n}, \sum \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}} = \sum n^{-1/2}, \sum \frac{1}{n^{0.99}}$ diverge. The borderline sits exactly at $p = 1$, and the harmonic series sits exactly on the borderline – on the *divergent* side. The borderline you have

been hunting since Section 29.5 is now located: it is $p = 1$, and among pure powers $1/n^p$, the term $1/n$ is the smallest that still diverges. Figure 29.3 shows the three regimes side by side.

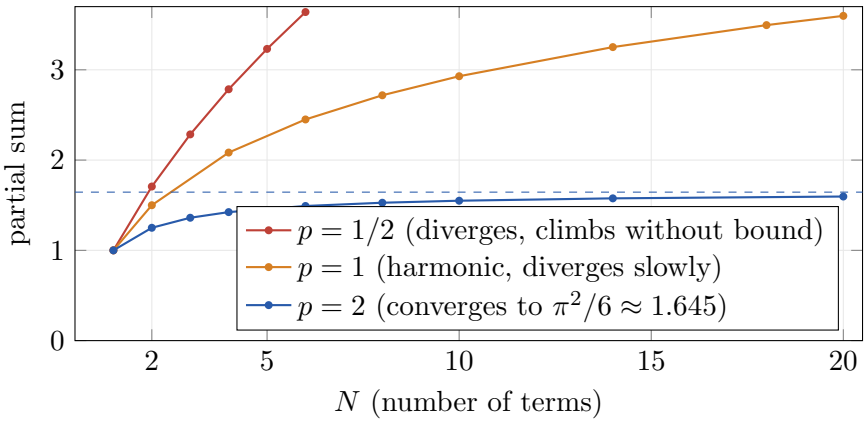


Figure 29.3: Partial sums of three p-series. For $p = 2$ they flatten toward a ceiling; for $p = 1$ and $p = \frac{1}{2}$ they keep rising, the half-power case visibly faster. Convergence is decided entirely by whether p clears 1.

Connection

Even-integer p-series evaluate to exact powers of π. Euler surprised Europe in 1735 by proving $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2} = \frac{\pi^2}{6}$ – a fact the integral test alone cannot deliver (it tells you *that* the sum is finite, not *what* it equals). As a function of p, this object is the Riemann zeta function $\zeta(p) = \sum n^{-p}$, whose behavior encodes the distribution of the prime numbers.

29.7 Comparison Tests: Lean on a Series You Already Understand

We now have two reliable yardsticks – geometric series and p-series. The comparison tests let us measure unfamiliar series against these known ones, and the logic runs just as intuition would suggest.

Intuition

If your terms are smaller (term by term) than the terms of a series you already know converges, your sum is trapped underneath a finite total – it has nowhere to go but to a finite value. And if your terms are bigger than those of a series you know diverges, your sum is pushed up past every bound. Smaller than finite is finite; bigger than infinite is infinite. That's the whole idea.

Theorem 29.5 (Direct comparison test)**.** *Suppose $0 \le a_n \le b_n$ for all n (beyond some starting point).*

- *If $\sum b_n$ converges, then $\sum a_n$ converges.*
- *If $\sum a_n$ diverges, then $\sum b_n$ diverges.*

Proof. All terms are nonnegative, so both sequences of partial sums are increasing. Let $A_n = \sum_{k\le n} a_k$ and $B_n = \sum_{k\le n} b_k$; then $A_n \le B_n$. If $\sum b_n$ converges to B, then $A_n \le B_n \le B$, so (A_n) is increasing and bounded above, hence convergent. The second bullet is the contrapositive of the first. □

Example 29.5. Does $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2+3n+1}$ converge? The denominator is bigger than n^2, so each term is *smaller* than $\frac{1}{n^2}$:

$$0 < \frac{1}{n^2+3n+1} < \frac{1}{n^2}.$$

Since $\sum \frac{1}{n^2}$ converges ($p = 2 > 1$), our smaller series converges too. We never needed its value – only that it's trapped under something finite.

The direct comparison demands a clean term-by-term inequality, which can be fiddly to arrange (you may have to make the smaller series smaller, or the bigger one bigger, in just the right direction). Often it is easier to compare asymptotic growth rates rather than the terms themselves. That is the limit comparison test, and it is widely applicable.

Theorem 29.6 (Limit comparison test)**.** *Let $a_n > 0$ and $b_n > 0$, and suppose*

$$\lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{a_n}{b_n} = L, \qquad 0 < L < \infty.$$

Then $\sum a_n$ and $\sum b_n$ either both converge or both diverge.

Why the technique works

Why does a finite, nonzero limit force the two series to share a fate? Because $\frac{a_n}{b_n} \to L$ means that eventually a_n is sandwiched between $\frac{L}{2} b_n$ and $2L\, b_n$ – the two series are, in the long run, just constant multiples of each other. And multiplying every term of a series by a fixed positive constant cannot change whether it converges (it only scales the total). Convergence is decided by the *tail*, by how fast terms shrink, and a constant factor does not change a shrink rate. So $\sum a_n$ and $\sum b_n$ have the same convergence behavior. You don't have to win a delicate inequality; you only have to identify which known series your terms *grow like*.

Focus

How to pick b_n in practice. Strip your term down to its dominant behavior for large n – keep only the fastest-growing parts of numerator and denominator. That skeleton is your comparison series. Example: $a_n = \dfrac{3n^2-n}{4n^4+5}$ behaves like $\dfrac{3n^2}{4n^4} = \dfrac{3}{4n^2}$, so compare with $b_n = \frac{1}{n^2}$.

Example 29.6. Test $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{3n^2-n}{4n^4+5}$. The dominant behavior is $\frac{1}{n^2}$, so take $b_n = \frac{1}{n^2}$:

$$\frac{a_n}{b_n} = \frac{3n^2-n}{4n^4+5} \cdot n^2 = \frac{3n^4-n^3}{4n^4+5} \longrightarrow \frac{3}{4}.$$

The limit $\frac{3}{4}$ is finite and nonzero, and $\sum \frac{1}{n^2}$ converges, so our series converges. Notice how much cleaner this is than fighting for a direct inequality.

Example 29.7 (A divergence by limit comparison)**.** Test $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{\sqrt{n^2+1}}$. For large n, $\sqrt{n^2+1} \approx n$, so compare with $b_n = \frac{1}{n}$:

$$\frac{a_n}{b_n} = \frac{n}{\sqrt{n^2+1}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+1/n^2}} \longrightarrow 1.$$

Finite, nonzero. Since $\sum \frac{1}{n}$ diverges (harmonic), so does our series. The square root barely changed anything; the term still shrinks "like $1/n$," and that is fatal.

29.8 The Ratio and Root Tests: Asymptotically Geometric Series

The geometric series converges precisely because the ratio of consecutive terms is a constant r with $|r| < 1$. The **ratio test** takes this idea and applies it to series that are only *eventually*, *approximately* geometric – which, it turns out, is an enormous and important class, including every series built from factorials and exponentials.

Intuition

Look at the magnitude ratio $|a_{n+1}/a_n|$ of each term to the previous one. For a geometric series $\sum ar^n$ this ratio is constantly $|r|$. For a general series it varies, but if it *settles* toward some limit L, then far out in the tail the series behaves like a geometric series with ratio L. So if $L < 1$, the tail decays geometrically and the series converges; if $L > 1$, the terms eventually *grow*, dooming the sum.

Theorem 29.7 (Ratio test)**.** *For a series $\sum a_n$ with $a_n \neq 0$, suppose* $\displaystyle\lim_{n\to\infty} \left|\frac{a_{n+1}}{a_n}\right| = L.$

- *If $L < 1$, the series converges (absolutely).*
- *If $L > 1$ (or $L = \infty$), the series diverges.*
- *If $L = 1$, the test is inconclusive – it tells you nothing.*

Why it works. Suppose $L < 1$. Pick a number r strictly between L and 1 (for instance $r = \frac{L+1}{2}$). Applying the limit definition with tolerance $\varepsilon = r - L > 0$ gives a cutoff N with $|a_{n+1}/a_n| < L + \varepsilon = r$, that is $|a_{n+1}| < r\,|a_n|$, for all $n \geq N$. By induction $|a_{N+k}| < r^k |a_N|$, so the tail of the series is dominated, term by term, by the geometric series $|a_N| \sum r^k$, which converges because $r < 1$. By direct comparison the tail converges, hence the whole series converges absolutely. If instead $L > 1$, then past some cutoff $|a_{n+1}| > |a_n|$, so the magnitudes keep growing, $a_n \not\to 0$, and the nth-term test kills it. When $L = 1$, the comparison geometric series sits exactly on its own boundary and tells us nothing. □

Example 29.8 (Factorials are the ratio test's home turf)**.** Test $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{2^n}{n!}$. Form the ratio and watch the factorial demolish the exponential:

$$\left|\frac{a_{n+1}}{a_n}\right| = \frac{2^{n+1}}{(n+1)!} \cdot \frac{n!}{2^n} = \frac{2}{n+1} \longrightarrow 0.$$

$L = 0 < 1$, so the series converges – and fast. (Its sum, foreshadowing the next chapter, is $e^2 - 1$.) Whenever you see factorials, reach for the ratio test first; the cancellation is almost always this clean. Figure 29.4 shows the terms diving under a geometric envelope, which illustrates why the test works.

Example 29.9 (Why $L = 1$ is genuinely useless)**.** Apply the ratio test to $\sum \frac{1}{n}$ (diverges) and to $\sum \frac{1}{n^2}$ (converges). Both give

$$\sum \tfrac{1}{n}: \ \frac{1/(n+1)}{1/n} = \frac{n}{n+1} \to 1, \qquad \sum \tfrac{1}{n^2}: \ \frac{n^2}{(n+1)^2} \to 1.$$

The ratio test returns $L = 1$ for both, yet one converges and one does not. This is concrete proof that $L = 1$ carries no information – you must switch to another test (here, the p-series rule). The ratio test is blind precisely at the borderline of polynomial decay.

The **root test** is the ratio test's close cousin, better suited when the nth term is an nth power. Instead of comparing neighbors, it extracts the "geometric ratio" directly by taking an nth root.

Theorem 29.8 (Root test)**.** *For $\sum a_n$, suppose $\lim_{n\to\infty} \sqrt[n]{|a_n|} = L$. If $L < 1$ the series converges absolutely; if $L > 1$ (or ∞) it diverges; if $L = 1$ it is inconclusive.*

Why the technique works

The root test works for the same reason as the ratio test, even more directly. If $\sqrt[n]{|a_n|} \to L$ then for large n, $|a_n| \approx L^n$ – the term *is* essentially the nth term of a geometric series with ratio L. So $L < 1$ means geometric decay and convergence; $L > 1$ means geometric growth and divergence. The root test estimates the effective geometric ratio directly from a_n itself, rather than from consecutive terms. Use it whenever a_n involves an nth power, such as $a_n = \left(\frac{n}{2n+1}\right)^n$.

Example 29.10. Test $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \left(\frac{n}{2n+1}\right)^n$. Because the general term is an nth power, we apply the root test:

$$\sqrt[n]{|a_n|} = \frac{n}{2n+1} \longrightarrow \frac{1}{2} < 1,$$

so the series converges. A ratio-test attack here would be a mess; the root test reads the answer off in one line.

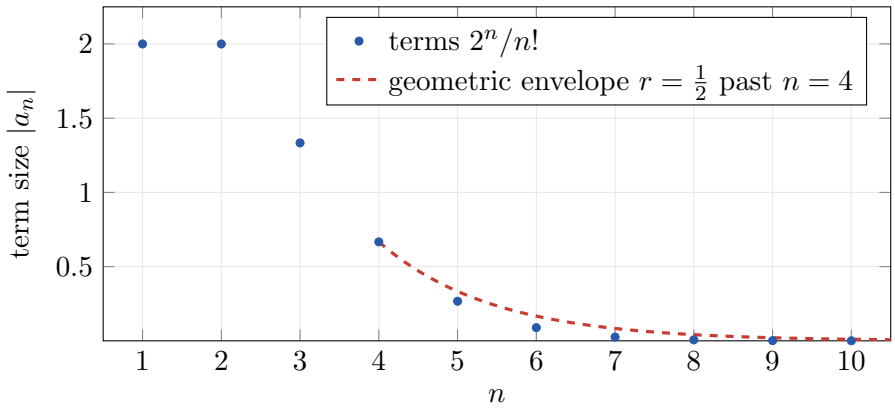


Figure 29.4: The ratio test in action on $\sum 2^n/n!$. The ratio $2/(n+1)$ drops below $\frac{1}{2}$ once $n \geq 4$, so from there on every term is bounded by a decaying geometric series (dashed). Being trapped under a convergent geometric tail is exactly what forces convergence.

29.9 Alternating Series and the Sign That Saves You

So far our terms have mostly been positive. Something remarkable happens when the signs alternate $+, -, +, -, \ldots$: the back-and-forth lets partial cancellation rescue a series that would diverge if all its terms were positive. The exemplar is the **alternating harmonic series**:

$$1 - \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{5} - \cdots = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1}}{n}.$$

The positive version (the plain harmonic series) diverges to infinity. But with alternating signs, this one *converges* – to $\ln 2$, in fact. The alternating signs provide cancellation that prevents the partial sums from growing without bound.

Intuition

Watch the partial sums of an alternating series whose terms shrink. You go up by 1, down by $\frac{1}{2}$, up by $\frac{1}{3}$, down by $\frac{1}{4}$. Each step overshoots the eventual limit, but by less than the last step (because the steps are shrinking). The partial sums zig-zag with ever-tightening swings – like a pendulum losing energy, homing in on a single value squeezed between every up-step and every down-step.

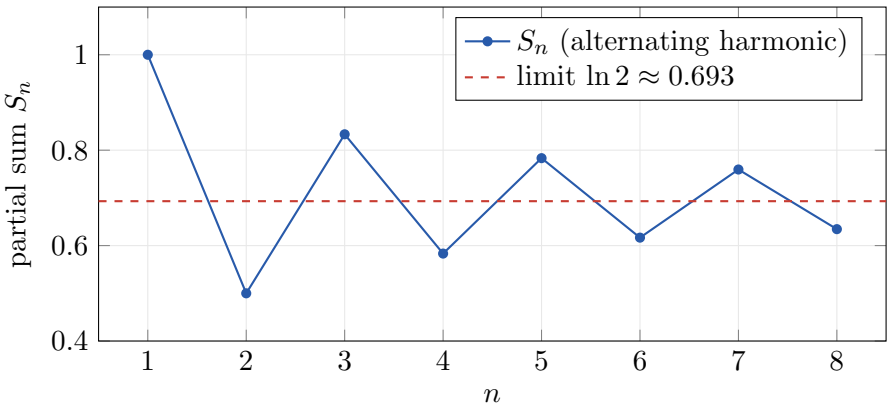


Figure 29.5: Partial sums of $1 - \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} - \cdots$ oscillate with shrinking amplitude around $\ln 2$. The odd partial sums approach from above, the even ones from below, and they trap the limit between them.

Theorem 29.9 (Alternating series test, Leibniz)**.** *If the positive numbers b_n satisfy (i) $b_{n+1} \le b_n$ (decreasing) and (ii) $b_n \to 0$, then the alternating series $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} (-1)^{n-1} b_n$ converges. In addition, the error from stopping at the nth term is bounded by the very next term: $|S - S_n| \le b_{n+1}$.*

Proof. Consider the even partial sums. Grouping in pairs, $S_{2n} = (b_1 - b_2) + (b_3 - b_4) + \cdots + (b_{2n-1} - b_{2n})$; each pair is ≥ 0 since b_k decreases, so (S_{2n}) is increasing. Regroup shifting by one slot: $S_{2n} = b_1 - (b_2 - b_3) - \cdots - (b_{2n-2} - b_{2n-1}) - b_{2n}$; every parenthesized difference is ≥ 0 and $b_{2n} > 0$, so $S_{2n} \le b_1$. Being increasing and bounded above, (S_{2n}) converges to a limit S. Meanwhile $S_{2n+1} = S_{2n} + b_{2n+1} \to S + 0 = S$, and (S_{2n+1}) decreases, since $S_{2n+1} - S_{2n-1} = -(b_{2n} - b_{2n+1}) \le 0$. So all partial sums converge to S, and $S_{2k} \le S \le S_{2k+1}$ for every k: the true sum always sits between two consecutive partial sums S_n and S_{n+1}, which differ by exactly b_{n+1}. Hence $|S - S_n| \le b_{n+1}$. $\square$

Why this matters

The alternating series error bound is computationally direct. To approximate the sum to within 0.001, you simply add terms until they drop below 0.001; the truncation error is smaller than the first omitted term. Because this error estimate requires no additional calculations, alternating series are useful in numerical work.

29.10 Absolute vs. Conditional Convergence: A Subtle Hierarchy

The alternating harmonic series converges, but only thanks to its signs – strip them away and it diverges. Contrast that with $\sum \frac{(-1)^{n-1}}{n^2}$, which converges even with all signs made positive (it's the p-series $p = 2$). These two convergences are not the same *kind*, and the difference matters enormously.

Definition 29.2 (Absolute and conditional convergence)**.** A series $\sum a_n$ **converges absolutely** if $\sum |a_n|$ converges. It **converges conditionally** if $\sum a_n$ converges but $\sum |a_n|$ diverges – that is, the convergence depends on cancellation among the signs.

Theorem 29.10 (Absolute convergence implies convergence)**.** *If $\sum |a_n|$ converges, then $\sum a_n$ converges.*

Proof. The clean trick: $0 \le a_n + |a_n| \le 2|a_n|$ (the middle is either 0 or $2|a_n|$). Since $\sum 2|a_n|$ converges, by direct comparison $\sum (a_n + |a_n|)$ converges. Then $\sum a_n = \sum (a_n + |a_n|) - \sum |a_n|$ is a difference of two convergent series, hence converges. □

Focus

This theorem is what makes the ratio and root tests legitimate. When they report "$L < 1$," they are really proving $\sum |a_n|$ converges – absolute convergence – which by the theorem guarantees ordinary convergence. So those tests handle signs for free: you can throw a sign-changing series at them and they just work, because absolute convergence is the stronger, sign-blind notion.

What is really happening

What is the structural difference between the two kinds? When $\sum |a_n|$ converges, the positive terms alone have some finite total P and the negative terms alone have some finite total $-Q$, so every rearrangement still adds up to $P - Q$: the sum is robust, exactly as with a finite sum. When a series converges only *conditionally*, its positive terms alone sum to $+\infty$ and its negative terms alone sum to $-\infty$ (if either total were finite, convergence of the series would force the other to be finite too, making the convergence absolute). That hands you two inexhaustible supplies of ever-shrinking steps. Pick *any* target T – say $T = 100$. Add positive terms in order until the running total first passes 100 (it must, since that supply is infinite); then add negative terms until it first dips below 100; then positive again, back and forth forever. Because the individual terms shrink to 0, the overshoots on either side of 100 shrink to 0 too, and the rearranged series converges to 100. This is the Riemann Rearrangement Theorem: absolute convergence makes a sum independent of order, while conditional convergence is a delicate balance between two infinite reservoirs.

Connection

In 1837, *Peter Gustav Lejeune Dirichlet* showed that infinite sums do not always commute. While $a+b=b+a$ holds for finite sums, Dirichlet noticed that the alternating harmonic series $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}\frac{(-1)^{n+1}}{n}=\ln 2$ could be rearranged to sum to half its original value:

$$1-\frac{1}{2}+\frac{1}{3}-\frac{1}{4}+\cdots=\ln 2, \qquad \text{but} \qquad \left(1-\frac{1}{2}-\frac{1}{4}\right)+\left(\frac{1}{3}-\frac{1}{6}-\frac{1}{8}\right)+\cdots=\frac{1}{2}\ln 2.$$

Mathematicians had long assumed that an infinite sum would obey the commutative law; Dirichlet proved that commutativity fails for conditionally convergent series.
In 1854, *Bernhard Riemann* generalized this in the **Riemann Rearrangement Theorem**: if a series converges conditionally, its terms can be reordered to converge to any chosen real number, or diverge to $\pm\infty$. Conditional convergence depends on the specific order of summation; only *absolute convergence* guarantees an invariant sum.

29.11 Choosing a Test: A Systematic Strategy

With seven or eight tests in hand, the real skill is knowing which to reach for. The choice is not arbitrary – the *form* of the term usually tells you. Here is the decision flow an experienced eye runs, almost unconsciously.

Focus

A practical order of attack.

1. **Glance at the terms.** Do they fail to go to 0? Then it diverges by the nth-term test (Sec. 29.4). One look – always do this first.
2. **Recognize the species.** Is it geometric (ar^n) or telescoping (a difference $b_k - b_{k+1}$)? Then sum it *exactly* (Secs. 29.2, 29.3).
3. **Spot factorials or nth powers.** Factorials or exponentials $\Rightarrow$ ratio test. A whole term raised to the nth power $\Rightarrow$ root test (Sec. 29.8).
4. **See a rational / algebraic term** (powers of n, roots): find its dominant p-power and use limit comparison against a p-series (Secs. 29.7, 29.6).
5. **Notice alternating signs** $(-1)^n$: check absolute convergence first (it's stronger and easier); if that fails, try the alternating series test (Secs. 29.9, 29.10).
6. **If $f(n)$ has a clean antiderivative** ($\frac{1}{n\ln n}$, ne^{-n^2}): the integral test may be the most direct route (Sec. 29.6).

Common trap

The classic blunders, collected so you can avoid them:

- Concluding *convergence* from $a_n \to 0$. The nth-term test only proves divergence; it is silent on convergence. (Harmonic series.)
- Declaring victory when the ratio or root test returns $L = 1$. That is the *inconclusive*

verdict – switch tests, do not guess.

- Using the integral test when f is not eventually decreasing. The hypothesis is essential; without it the rectangle-curve sandwich falls apart.
- Using limit comparison with $L = 0$ or $L = \infty$ carelessly. The clean "share a fate" conclusion needs $0 < L < \infty$; the boundary cases give only one-directional information.
- Reordering a conditionally convergent series as if order didn't matter. It does (Riemann).

Work it yourself

Classify each by hand, naming the test and the reasoning before you compute. (a) $\sum \dfrac{n}{n^2+1}$. (b) $\sum \dfrac{n!}{n^n}$. (c) $\sum \dfrac{(-1)^n}{\ln n}$ (from $n = 2$). (d) $\sum \dfrac{\cos n}{n^2}$.
Hints to check yourself: (a) limit-compare with $\frac{1}{n}$, diverges. (b) ratio test, $\left(\frac{n}{n+1}\right)^n \to \frac{1}{e} < 1$, converges. (c) terms decrease to 0, alternating series test, converges – but $\sum \frac{1}{\ln n}$ diverges (since $\ln n < n$ gives $\frac{1}{\ln n} > \frac{1}{n}$), so only *conditionally*. (d) $\left|\frac{\cos n}{n^2}\right| \le \frac{1}{n^2}$, comparison gives *absolute* convergence.

Application

Series arise throughout applied mathematics and scientific computing. In physics, the potential energy of a crystal lattice is an infinite (often conditionally convergent) sum over ions, and specifying the order of summation is essential. In probability, the expected value of a random variable is a series $\sum x_k p_k$, and whether it converges *absolutely* decides whether the expectation is well-defined. In machine learning, a discounted reward $\sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t r_t$ is a geometric-type series whose convergence (requiring $|\gamma| < 1$) ensures that reinforcement learning value functions are finite. And special functions – Bessel functions, the error function, $\zeta(s)$ – are evaluated numerically as series whose convergence rate determines how many terms are needed for target precision. The tests in this chapter provide the theoretical guarantees that make these computations valid.

29.12 Scope and Limits of Convergence Tests

Connection

The convergence tests of this chapter replace ad-hoc manipulations with a systematic protocol. Before Cauchy's 1821 formulation of partial sums and convergence tests, infinite series frequently produced contradictory sums (as Grandi and Euler did with $1 - 1 + 1 - \cdots$). The tests in this chapter achieved two main purposes:

- *Certifying convergence of non-elementary quantities:* Proving that mathematical constants (like the Euler–Mascheroni constant γ or $\zeta(3)$) and special functions (Bessel, Airy, Fresnel, and Riemann zeta functions) represent well-defined finite values;
- *High-precision scientific computing:* Establishing error bounds (via the alternating series

bound $|S - S_n| \le b_{n+1}$ and the geometric tail bound) that allow numerical calculation with guaranteed accuracy.

Yet the convergence tests of this chapter face two practical limits:

1. *The sum-value limitation:* Most tests (integral test, comparison, ratio, root) are qualitative: they determine whether a series converges, but not its exact sum. Proving that $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2}$ converges takes half a minute using the integral test. Finding its exact sum ($\frac{\pi^2}{6}$, Euler's solution to the Basel Problem in 1735) required techniques far beyond single-variable convergence tests.

2. *The sensitivity of conditional convergence:* When a series converges only conditionally ($\sum |a_n| = \infty$), its value depends on the order of terms. By Riemann's Rearrangement Theorem, reordering the terms of $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n+1}}{n}$ can change the sum from $\ln 2$ to any chosen real number.

In Chapter 30 (*Power Series and Taylor Series*), we let the terms of a series depend on a variable x:

$$f(x) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} c_n (x-a)^n.$$

Treating an infinite series as an infinite polynomial lets us differentiate and integrate term by term, express functions like e^x, $\sin x$, and $\arctan x$ as explicit power series, evaluate exact sums of numerical series, and solve differential equations across physics.

29.13 Exercises

Exercise 29.1 (Sum it exactly)**.** Evaluate each convergent series in closed form. (a) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{3}{4^n}$. (b) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \left(\frac{2}{3}\right)^n$. (c) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{(2n-1)(2n+1)}$ (telescope via $\frac{1}{2}\big(\frac{1}{2n-1} - \frac{1}{2n+1}\big)$). (d) Express $0.1\overline{6}$ (that is, $0.16666\ldots$) as a fraction using a geometric series.

Exercise 29.2 (The nth-term test, used correctly)**.** Determine which of these diverge by the nth-term test, and explain why the test is *silent* on the others. (a) $\sum \frac{n^2}{n^2+5}$. (b) $\sum \frac{1}{n^2+5}$. (c) $\sum \cos\big(\frac{1}{n}\big)$. (d) $\sum (-1)^n \frac{n}{n+1}$.

Exercise 29.3 (p-series and comparison)**.** Decide convergence, naming your comparison series each time. (a) $\sum \frac{1}{n^{3/2}}$. (b) $\sum \frac{1}{\sqrt[3]{n}}$. (c) $\sum \frac{n+4}{n^3 - 2n + 7}$. (d) $\sum \frac{1}{\sqrt{n^3+1}}$.

Exercise 29.4 (Ratio and root)**.** Apply the ratio or root test, whichever is cleaner, and say what L is. (a) $\sum \frac{5^n}{n!}$. (b) $\sum \frac{n!}{10^n}$. (c) $\sum \frac{n^2}{2^n}$. (d) $\sum \left(\frac{3n+1}{4n+5}\right)^n$.

Exercise 29.5 (Integral test)**.** Use the integral test to settle each, and verify the hypotheses (positive, decreasing) hold. (a) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=2}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n \ln n}$. (b) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=2}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n(\ln n)^2}$. (c) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n\, e^{-n^2}$. Comment on how (a) and (b) differ despite looking nearly identical – where is the borderline now?

Exercise 29.6 (Alternating, absolute, conditional)**.** For each, decide whether it converges absolutely, converges conditionally, or diverges. Justify all three possibilities you rule out or confirm. (a) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1}}{\sqrt{n}}$. (b) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1}}{n^2}$. (c) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1}\, n}{n+1}$. (d) $\displaystyle\sum_{n=2}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n}}{n \ln n}$.

Exercise 29.7 (Error estimate)**.** For the alternating series $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1}}{n^3}$, how many terms must you add to guarantee the partial sum is within 10^{-3} of the true value? Use the alternating-series error bound, and explain why that bound applies here.

Exercise 29.8 (Conceptual)**.** Answer in a sentence or two each, with reasons. (a) True or false: if $a_n \to 0$ then $\sum a_n$ converges. Give the canonical counterexample. (b) True or false: if $\sum a_n$ converges then $a_n \to 0$. Which theorem is this? (c) Can a series of positive terms converge conditionally? Why or why not? (d) If $\sum a_n$ and $\sum b_n$ both diverge, must $\sum(a_n + b_n)$ diverge? Find an example or prove it.

Exercise 29.9 (Prove it)**.** Prove that if $\sum a_n$ converges and $\sum b_n$ diverges, then $\sum(a_n+b_n)$ diverges. (Hint: argue by contradiction using the fact that the difference of two convergent series converges.)

Exercise 29.10 (Prove it – the heart of the matter)**.** Prove the nth-term test from scratch: if $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k = S$ (converges), then $a_n \to 0$. Your proof should use only the definition of convergence via partial sums (Definition 29.1) and the fact that if $S_n \to S$ then $S_{n-1} \to S$. Then explain in one paragraph, in your own words, why the converse fails, citing a specific series.

Exercise 29.11 (Drug Accumulation as a Geometric Series)**.** A patient takes a 100 mg dose of a drug each day. Each day, the body eliminates 25% of whatever drug is present, so 75% carries over to the next day. Model the long-run amount of drug in the body just after a dose as an infinite series, identify it as geometric, and find the steady-state amount. (This shares the discounted-sum structure discussed in the application box.)

Exercise 29.12 (Build the borderline)**.** We saw $\sum \frac{1}{n}$ diverges and $\sum \frac{1}{n^2}$ converges. Investigate the finer scale between them: (a) Argue that $\sum \frac{1}{n^{1.0001}}$ converges and $\sum \frac{1}{n^{0.9999}}$ diverges – the borderline at $p = 1$ is sharp. (b) Using the integral test, show $\sum \frac{1}{n \ln n}$ still diverges, so $\frac{1}{n}$ is not even the "last" divergent term – there is a whole ladder of ever-slower divergences below it. Reflect briefly on what this says about the idea of a single "boundary" between convergence and divergence.

Chapter 30

Power Series and Taylor Series

In the previous chapter, we asked whether an infinite sum of numbers, $a_0 + a_1 + a_2 + \cdots$, settles to a finite total. Now we take the next step: what happens if the terms in the sum depend on a variable x? Then an infinite series of numbers becomes a function of x.

Polynomials are straightforward to compute with: you can add, multiply, differentiate, integrate, and evaluate them using basic arithmetic. By contrast, transcendental functions – functions like e^x, $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and $\ln(1+x)$ – cannot be written as any finite combination of powers of x, so evaluating $\sin(0.3)$ requires an approximation method.

This chapter dissolves that barrier. *Many familiar functions can be represented as polynomials of infinite degree.* The function e^x, the function $\sin x$, the function $\ln(1+x)$ – each is equal, on some interval, to a genuine sum of powers of x,

$$c_0 + c_1 x + c_2 x^2 + c_3 x^3 + \cdots,$$

where the coefficients c_n are specific, computable numbers scaling each power. Once you know those coefficients, the transcendental function becomes something you can compute by hand, differentiate term by term, integrate term by term, and analyze using the algebra of polynomials.

These infinite polynomials are called *power series*, and the recipe that produces the coefficients is the *Taylor series*. By the end of this chapter you will see not only *how* to build them but *why* the recipe must give the coefficients it does – it is forced, with no freedom at all, by demanding that the polynomial match the function's value, slope, curvature, and every higher rate of change at a single point.

30.1 What a Power Series Is

Intuition

A power series is a polynomial that never stops. Think of it as a recipe for a function written entirely in powers of x: pick a list of numbers $c_0, c_1, c_2, \ldots$, and the series is

$$c_0 + c_1 x + c_2 x^2 + c_3 x^3 + \cdots$$

For most coefficient lists this sum converges only for x close to 0, where it defines a function.

Many standard functions can be represented this way.

Definition 30.1 (Power series)**.** A *power series centered at a* is an expression of the form

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} c_n(x-a)^n \;=\; c_0 + c_1(x-a) + c_2(x-a)^2 + c_3(x-a)^3 + \cdots,$$

where the numbers c_n are the *coefficients* and the fixed number a is the *center*. For each fixed value of x this is an infinite series of real numbers in the sense of the previous chapter, and we ask the same question we always ask of an infinite sum: does it converge?

When $a = 0$ the series simplifies to $\sum c_n x^n$, and that is the case we will live in most of the time. A series centered at a simply shifts the domain so that expansions occur around $x = a$ instead of $x = 0$. Everything we prove about $\sum c_n x^n$ near 0 transfers, by the substitution $x \mapsto x - a$, to $\sum c_n(x-a)^n$ near a.

A power series is a *function of* x, but only on the set of x where the series actually converges. At $x = a$ every term past the first vanishes, so the series collapses to c_0 – it always converges at its center. The interesting question is how far away from the center the convergence survives.

Example 30.1 (The geometric series is a power series)**.** The most important power series in all of mathematics is one you have already met:

$$1 + x + x^2 + x^3 + \cdots = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n.$$

Here every coefficient is $c_n = 1$. From the previous chapter you know this geometric series converges precisely when $|x| < 1$, and when it does, it sums to $\dfrac{1}{1-x}$. So we may write the exact equation

$$\frac{1}{1-x} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n, \qquad |x| < 1.$$

This is our first function-as-infinite-polynomial. The rational function $1/(1-x)$, defined everywhere except $x = 1$, agrees with the infinite polynomial on the open interval $(-1, 1)$ and disagrees (the series diverges) everywhere else. Hold onto this example: almost every other series in this chapter is built from it by differentiating, integrating, or substituting.

30.1.1 Where does a power series live? Radius of convergence

For the geometric series the set of good x was the symmetric interval $(-1, 1)$. That symmetry holds in general: the set of points where a power series converges is *always* an interval centered at a – there is a single radius R such that the series converges inside and diverges outside.

Theorem 30.1 (Radius of convergence)**.** *For any power series $\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} c_n(x-a)^n$, exactly one of the following holds:*

1. *The series converges only at $x = a$ (we say $R = 0$).*
2. *The series converges for all real x (we say $R = \infty$).*

3. *There is a positive number R, the* radius of convergence*, such that the series converges absolutely whenever $|x-a|<R$ (meaning the sum of absolute values $\sum|c_n(x-a)^n|$ converges, guaranteeing the strongest form of stability) and diverges whenever $|x-a|>R$.*

Intuition

Picture a circle of influence around the center a. Inside the circle the powers $(x-a)^n$ shrink fast enough that the series adds up to something finite. Outside, the powers grow and overwhelm any coefficients, so the sum explodes. The boundary – the two endpoints $a\pm R$ – is a delicate place that must be checked by hand each time, because the series can go either way there.

The engine behind this theorem is a single comparison idea, resting on one lemma: if a power series converges *anywhere* away from the center, it converges *everywhere closer in.*

Lemma 30.1 (Abel's comparison)**.** *Suppose $\sum c_n b^n$ converges for some particular $b\neq 0$. Then $\sum c_n x^n$ converges absolutely for every x with $|x|<|b|$.*

Proof. If $\sum c_n b^n$ converges, then its terms must march to zero (the term test, from the previous chapter). A sequence that tends to zero is in particular bounded, so there is a constant M with

$$|c_n b^n|\le M \qquad \text{for every } n.$$

Now take any x closer to the origin than b, and let $r=|x|/|b|$, a number strictly less than 1. Watch how the terms of $\sum c_n x^n$ get controlled:

$$|c_n x^n| = |c_n b^n|\cdot\left|\frac{x}{b}\right|^n \le M\,r^n.$$

We have bounded our terms by the terms of a convergent geometric series $\sum Mr^n$ (convergent because $r<1$). By the comparison test, $\sum|c_n x^n|$ converges. That is exactly absolute convergence for $\sum c_n x^n$. □

Why the technique works

Why does the convergence set have to be an *interval* – why couldn't a power series converge at $x=3$ and $x=7$ but diverge at $x=5$ in between? Abel's lemma forbids it. Convergence at the far point $x=7$ would force convergence at every point closer to the center than 7, including $x=5$. So the "good" set has no holes: if it contains a point, it contains everything between that point and the center. A subset of the line that contains the whole segment from the center out to each of its points, and is symmetric about the center, can only be a single interval centered at a. That is the entire content of Theorem 30.1: the radius R is simply the supremum (the least upper bound, or furthest reach) of the distances $|b-a|$ at which convergence happens.

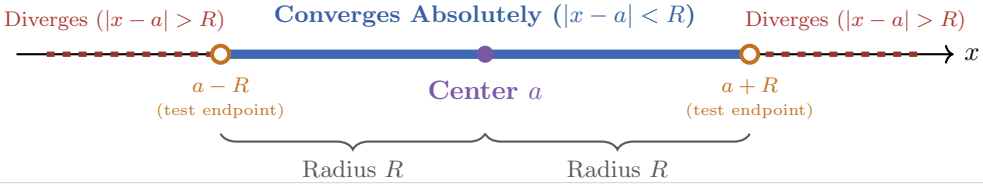
Connection

Abel at the boundary: connecting the interior to the edge. What happens right on the boundary circle $|x-a|=R$? In 1826, the Norwegian mathematician *Niels Henrik Abel* investigated this delicate boundary and proved the celebrated **Abel's Theorem**: if a power series converges at an endpoint $x=a+R$, then the function defined by the series is continuous

from the inside up to that boundary point:

$$\lim_{x\to(a+R)^-}\sum_{n=0}^{\infty}c_n(x-a)^n=\sum_{n=0}^{\infty}c_nR^n.$$

This gave mathematicians the rigorous right to evaluate series at their boundary – for example, allowing us to plug $x=1$ into the $\ln(1+x)$ Maclaurin series to prove that $1-\frac{1}{2}+\frac{1}{3}-\frac{1}{4}+\cdots=\ln 2$, or setting $x=1$ in the arctangent series to prove Gregory and Leibniz's formula $\frac{\pi}{4}=1-\frac{1}{3}+\frac{1}{5}-\cdots$. Without Abel's theorem, jumping from the open interval $|x|<1$ to the boundary point $x=1$ was an unproven leap of faith.



The 4 Possible Intervals of Convergence:

$(a-R,\,a+R)$ $\quad[a-R,\,a+R)$ $\quad(a-R,\,a+R]$ $\quad[a-R,\,a+R]$

Interior behavior is guaranteed; each endpoint must be checked independently with series tests.

Figure 30.1: The geometry of power series convergence. Inside the radius of convergence $|x-a|<R$, the series converges absolutely. Outside ($|x-a|>R$), the terms fail to go to zero and the series diverges. At the two boundary points $x=a\pm R$, the ratio test is inconclusive and the series may converge or diverge independently, leading to four possible interval types.

30.1.2 Finding the radius with the ratio test

In practice you almost always find R by feeding the series to the ratio test from the previous chapter. The ratio test asks for the limit of the absolute ratio of consecutive terms; convergence happens when that limit is below 1. For a power series the variable x rides along in that ratio, and the condition "ratio <1" becomes a condition on $|x|$ – which is exactly the radius.

Focus

The ratio-test recipe for the radius. Apply the ratio test to $\sum c_n(x-a)^n$:

$$L(x)=\lim_{n\to\infty}\left|\frac{c_{n+1}(x-a)^{n+1}}{c_n(x-a)^n}\right|=|x-a|\cdot\lim_{n\to\infty}\left|\frac{c_{n+1}}{c_n}\right|.$$

If $\lim|c_{n+1}/c_n|=\ell$, then convergence ($L<1$) means $|x-a|<1/\ell$, so

$$\boxed{R=\frac{1}{\ell}=\lim_{n\to\infty}\left|\frac{c_n}{c_{n+1}}\right|}$$

(with $R=\infty$ if $\ell=0$ and $R=0$ if $\ell=\infty$). Always remember to test the endpoints $a\pm R$ separately.

Example 30.2 (Radius of the exponential series)**.** Consider $\displaystyle\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n!}$, so $c_n = 1/n!$. The ratio of consecutive coefficients is

$$\left|\frac{c_{n+1}}{c_n}\right| = \frac{1/(n+1)!}{1/n!} = \frac{n!}{(n+1)!} = \frac{1}{n+1} \to 0.$$

So $\ell = 0$ and $R = 1/\ell = \infty$. This series converges for *every* real x. The factorials in the denominator grow so fast that they eventually outrun any fixed power x^n in the numerator, no matter how large x is. (We will soon see this series is e^x.)

Example 30.3 (A series with a finite radius and interesting endpoints)**.** Consider $\displaystyle\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n}$, so $c_n = 1/n$. Then

$$\left|\frac{c_n}{c_{n+1}}\right| = \frac{1/n}{1/(n+1)} = \frac{n+1}{n} \to 1,$$

so $R = 1$. The series converges on $(-1, 1)$ and diverges outside $[-1, 1]$. Now the endpoints:

- At $x = 1$ the series is $\sum 1/n$, the harmonic series – diverges.
- At $x = -1$ the series is $\sum (-1)^n/n$, the alternating harmonic series – converges.

So the true interval of convergence is $[-1, 1)$: closed on the left, open on the right. This lopsidedness is exactly why the endpoints cannot be guessed and must be checked. (We will soon see this series is $-\ln(1 - x)$.)

Work it yourself

Find the radius of convergence of $\displaystyle\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} n!\, x^n$ by hand. Compute $|c_n/c_{n+1}| = n!/(n+1)! = 1/(n+1) \to 0$, so $R = 0$: this series converges *only* at $x = 0$. The coefficients grow so fast that no nonzero x can tame them. A power series really can have a vanishing radius.

Common trap

The radius is determined by the coefficients, *not* by where the function you are representing happens to misbehave – but the two are often related. Be careful, though, with two classic confusions:

- "R large means the terms are large." No: large R means the coefficients c_n *shrink* fast, so the powers can grow far before overwhelming them.
- "Convergence at one endpoint guarantees the other." No, as Example 30.3 shows. Each endpoint is its own separate question.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose you are told that a power series $\sum c_n x^n$ centered at 0 has radius of convergence $R = 4$.

(a) Does the series converge at $x = 3.9$? Does it converge at $x = -4.1$?

(b) Can you tell without further testing whether it converges at $x = 4$ or at $x = -4$?

Answers: (a) It converges absolutely at $x = 3.9$ because $|3.9| < 4$. It diverges at $x = -4.1$ because $|-4.1| > 4$. (b) No; the boundary $|x| = 4$ is the exact border where the ratio of terms approaches 1, leaving the ratio test inconclusive. One endpoint might converge while the other diverges, both might converge, or both might diverge. Each endpoint must be plugged in and tested as a standalone series of numbers.

30.2 Building Functions from the Geometric Series

Before we develop the general Taylor machinery, let us see how much mileage we get from the single equation

$$\frac{1}{1-x} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n, \qquad |x| < 1,$$

together with two tools we are about to justify: *you may differentiate and integrate a power series term by term inside its radius of convergence*, and *you may substitute one power series into a simple expression*. These two moves let us derive a wide family of series from the geometric series alone.

Theorem 30.2 (Term-by-term differentiation and integration)**.** *Suppose $f(x) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} c_n (x-a)^n$ has radius of convergence $R > 0$. Then on the open interval $(a-R, a+R)$ the function f is differentiable (indeed infinitely differentiable), and its derivative and antiderivative are obtained term by term:*

$$f'(x) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n\, c_n (x-a)^{n-1}, \qquad \int f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = C + \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{c_n}{n+1}(x-a)^{n+1}.$$

Both new series have the same radius of convergence R. (If integrating as a definite integral from the center a to x, the constant is simply $C = 0$.)

We will not prove this in full – the careful proof belongs to the theory of uniform convergence – but the next box explains why it ought to be true, and why the radius is preserved.

Why the technique works

A finite polynomial can of course be differentiated term by term; that is just the power rule applied to each piece. The only thing in doubt for an *infinite* sum is whether the infinitely many error contributions, when you swap "differentiate" and "add up", stay under control. They do, and the reason is the absolute convergence guaranteed *strictly inside* the radius (Lemma 30.1). Inside the radius there is room to spare – the terms decay geometrically – and that slack is exactly what lets the limit defining the derivative pass through the infinite sum. As for the radius being unchanged: differentiating multiplies the coefficient c_n by n, and $\lim |n c_n/((n+1)c_{n+1})| = \lim(n/(n+1)) \cdot |c_n/c_{n+1}| = R$, since $n/(n+1) \to 1$. The factor of n is too mild to change where the series lives.

Example 30.4 (A series for $\dfrac{1}{(1-x)^2}$ by differentiating)**.** Differentiate both sides of $\dfrac{1}{1-x} =$

$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n$. The left side differentiates to $\dfrac{1}{(1-x)^2}$. The right side differentiates term by term:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\left(\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n\right) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n x^{n-1} = 1 + 2x + 3x^2 + 4x^3 + \cdots .$$

Reindexing with $k = n-1$ (so that when n starts at 1, k starts at 0), we may write, for $|x| < 1$:

$$\frac{1}{(1-x)^2} = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n\, x^{n-1} = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} (k+1) x^k.$$

We obtained a brand-new, nontrivial series for free, just by differentiating the one series we knew.

Example 30.5 (The series for $\ln(1+x)$ by integrating)**.** Start from the geometric series with x replaced by $-t$:

$$\frac{1}{1+t} = \frac{1}{1-(-t)} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (-t)^n = 1 - t + t^2 - t^3 + \cdots , \qquad |t| < 1.$$

Now integrate both sides from 0 to x. On the left,

$$\int_0^x \frac{\mathrm{d}t}{1+t} = \ln(1+x).$$

On the right, integrate term by term:

$$\int_0^x \left(1 - t + t^2 - t^3 + \cdots\right) \mathrm{d}t = x - \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{x^3}{3} - \frac{x^4}{4} + \cdots .$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{\ln(1+x) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1}}{n} x^n = x - \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{x^3}{3} - \frac{x^4}{4} + \cdots}, \qquad -1 < x \le 1.$$

Notice the bonus at the endpoint: although Theorem 30.2 guarantees equality only on $(-1, 1)$, at $x = 1$ the right side becomes the convergent alternating harmonic series, so Abel's Theorem (Section 30.1) extends the equality to the endpoint. So

$$\ln 2 = 1 - \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{5} - \cdots ,$$

a strange and beautiful identity: an alternating sum of unit fractions equals the natural logarithm of 2.

Example 30.6 (The series for $\arctan x$, and a formula for π)**.** The same trick produces one of the most famous series in history. Replace x by $-t^2$ in the geometric series:

$$\frac{1}{1+t^2} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (-t^2)^n = 1 - t^2 + t^4 - t^6 + \cdots , \qquad |t| < 1.$$

Integrate from 0 to x, using $\int_0^x \dfrac{\mathrm{d}t}{1+t^2} = \arctan x$:

$$\boxed{\arctan x = x - \frac{x^3}{3} + \frac{x^5}{5} - \frac{x^7}{7} + \cdots = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{2n+1} x^{2n+1}}, \qquad -1 \le x \le 1.$$

At $x = 1$ the alternating series still converges, so Abel's Theorem again extends the equality to the endpoint, yielding the Madhava–Leibniz formula:

$$\frac{\pi}{4} = 1 - \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{5} - \frac{1}{7} + \frac{1}{9} - \cdots .$$

Reading note

Why $x = 1$ is slow – and how Madhava sped it up. By the alternating series error bound, stopping $1 - \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{5} - \cdots$ after n terms leaves an error of roughly $\frac{1}{2n+1}$, so six correct decimal places at the boundary $x = 1$ would take on the order of a million terms. When **Madhava of Sangamagrama** computed π to eleven decimal places in fourteenth-century India, he evaluated the arctangent series *inside* its interval of convergence instead, at $x = 1/\sqrt{3}$, where $\arctan(1/\sqrt{3}) = \pi/6$:

$$\pi = \sqrt{12} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{(2n+1)\,3^n}.$$

Moving inside the radius brings in the geometric factor $(1/3)^n$, and about 21 terms already give eleven correct digits.

Pause

Pause and think. Knowing that $\frac{1}{1-u} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} u^n$ for $|u| < 1$, what is the power series for $\frac{1}{1+4x^2}$, and on what interval does it converge?

Answer: Substitute $u = -4x^2$ to obtain $\sum_{n=0}^{\infty}(-4x^2)^n = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty}(-1)^n 4^n x^{2n} = 1 - 4x^2 + 16x^4 - \cdots$. The condition $|u| < 1$ becomes $|-4x^2| < 1$, which means $x^2 < 1/4$, so $|x| < 1/2$. The radius shrunk from 1 to $1/2$ because the input variable was scaled by 2.

30.3 Taylor and Maclaurin Series: the Universal Recipe

So far we have manufactured series by clever manipulation of the geometric series. That is wonderful when it works, but it does not work for e^x, $\sin x$, or $\cos x$ – those are not built from $1/(1-x)$ by any obvious substitution. We need a *universal* method that takes *any* sufficiently smooth function and produces its power series directly. That method is Taylor's, and the idea behind it is one of the cleanest in all of calculus.

History

The dream of representing arbitrary curves as infinite polynomials began long before modern calculus had a name. In fourteenth-century India, **Madhava of Sangamagrama** and his Kerala school of astronomy and mathematics derived infinite series for $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and $\arctan x$ three centuries before Newton and Leibniz. Stuck on the practical problem of computing precise astronomical tables and celestial positions using only finite arithmetic, Madhava used geometric dissections of circular arcs and step-by-step differences to generate series for π accurate to eleven decimal places.

In Europe, the Scottish mathematician **James Gregory** glimpsed the universal method in 1671, discovering expansions for $\tan x$, $\sec x$, and $\arcsin x$ by calculating successive geometric

differences. In 1715, the English mathematician **Brook Taylor** published the universal formulation in his treatise *Methodus Incrementorum Directa et Inversa*. Taylor realized that the derivatives of a function at a single basepoint $x = a$ determine the coefficients of a polynomial matching the curve's height, slope, curvature, and higher-order rates of change. In 1742, the Scottish mathematician **Colin Maclaurin** popularized the special case centered at the origin $a = 0$ in his *Treatise of Fluxions*.

Yet for over a century, mathematicians manipulated these series without a rigorous framework for convergence. **Leonhard Euler** computed with formal power series, obtaining results such as the Basel sum $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} 1/n^2 = \pi^2/6$, but also encountering paradoxes like $1-1+1-1+\cdots = 1/2$ or $1+2+4+8+\cdots = -1$. The foundation was settled in the 1820s when **Augustin-Louis Cauchy** and **Niels Henrik Abel** established the modern definitions of limits and convergence. Cauchy also demonstrated that an infinitely differentiable function could have all derivatives vanish at a point without being identically zero (meaning its Taylor series fails to represent the function away from that point).

Taylor series made non-elementary functions computable: functions whose antiderivatives cannot be written in finite formulas (such as the Gaussian e^{-x^2} in statistics) could now be integrated term by term to any desired precision. They provided series solutions to the differential equations of mathematical physics (the Bessel, Legendre, and Airy equations describing waves and orbits), and connected exponential growth with oscillation via Euler's formula $e^{ix} = \cos x + i \sin x$.

What remains open? In modern quantum field theory, the perturbative power series physicists use to calculate particle interactions are known to be divergent asymptotic expansions (as Freeman Dyson argued in 1952); developing rigorous mathematical frameworks to "resum" these divergent series into exact non-perturbative physical quantities remains an active research area. In pure mathematics, describing the subtle fractal behavior of power series on the exact boundary circle of convergence remains an active frontier of complex analysis and dynamical systems.

Intuition

Suppose a function f really is equal to some power series near a point a:

$$f(x) = c_0 + c_1(x-a) + c_2(x-a)^2 + c_3(x-a)^3 + \cdots .$$

We do not yet know the coefficients. But we have a tool that extracts them one at a time: *differentiation*. Each derivative, evaluated at the center a, reaches in and pulls out exactly one coefficient, leaving the others either already gone or not yet arrived. Thus the coefficients cannot be chosen freely: each c_n is determined by $f^{(n)}(a)$.

Let us watch the extraction happen. Assume $f(x) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} c_n(x-a)^n$ and that we may differentiate term by term.

First, just plug in $x = a$. Every term with a factor of $(x-a)$ dies, leaving only the constant:

$$f(a) = c_0.$$

Next, differentiate once: $f'(x) = c_1 + 2c_2(x-a) + 3c_3(x-a)^2 + \cdots$, then plug in $x = a$ again. Once more all the $(x-a)$ factors vanish:

$$f'(a) = c_1.$$

Differentiate again: $f''(x) = 2c_2 + 6c_3(x-a) + 12c_4(x-a)^2 + \cdots$, and set $x = a$:

$$f''(a) = 2c_2 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad c_2 = \frac{f''(a)}{2}.$$

Once more: $f'''(x) = 6c_3 + 24c_4(x-a) + \cdots$, so $f'''(a) = 6c_3$, giving $c_3 = f'''(a)/6$.

The general pattern is unmistakable. Suppose we differentiate n times:

- Every lower-power term $(x-a)^k$ with $k < n$ has been differentiated to zero.
- Every higher-power term $(x-a)^k$ with $k > n$ still contains at least one remaining factor of $(x-a)$, which vanishes when we set $x = a$.
- Only the $k = n$ term survives: differentiating $(x-a)^n$ a total of n times pulls down the falling product $n \cdot (n-1) \cdot (n-2) \cdots 2 \cdot 1 = n!$ into the coefficient, leaving $n!\, c_n$.

Evaluating the nth derivative at $x = a$ therefore yields:

$$f^{(n)}(a) = n!\, c_n \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad c_n = \frac{f^{(n)}(a)}{n!}.$$

Definition 30.2 (Taylor and Maclaurin series)**.** Let f be infinitely differentiable at a. The *Taylor series of f centered at a* is

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(n)}(a)}{n!}\,(x-a)^n = f(a) + f'(a)(x-a) + \frac{f''(a)}{2!}(x-a)^2 + \frac{f'''(a)}{3!}(x-a)^3 + \cdots.$$

When the center is $a = 0$ this is also called the *Maclaurin series*:

$$f(0) + f'(0)\,x + \frac{f''(0)}{2!}x^2 + \frac{f'''(0)}{3!}x^3 + \cdots.$$

The polynomial obtained by stopping at the term of degree N is the *Taylor polynomial* $P_N(x)$ of order N.

Why the technique works

Why this exact recipe and no other? Because a power series matching f has *no freedom*. Each coefficient is pinned down by one derivative: c_n controls (and is the only coefficient controlling) the nth derivative at the center. The factor $n!$ appears because differentiating $(x-a)^n$ a total of n times produces the falling product $n(n-1)\cdots 1 = n!$. The Taylor recipe is simply the unique answer to the question: *which polynomial has the same value, the same slope, the same curvature, the same third derivative, and so on, all the way up, as f at the point a?* You are not approximating by guesswork; you are matching f to infinite order at a single point.

What is really happening

Here is what a Taylor polynomial *really* is, stripped of symbols. The order-0 polynomial $P_0 = f(a)$ is the horizontal line through the point – it gets the height right. The order-1 polynomial $P_1 = f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)$ is the tangent line – it gets the height *and* the slope right; this is exactly the linear approximation from the chapter on differentials. The order-2 polynomial adds $\frac{1}{2}f''(a)(x-a)^2$, a parabola that also matches the *curvature*. Each new term

fixes the next derivative without disturbing the ones already matched, because $(x-a)^n$ and all its first $n-1$ derivatives vanish at a. So the Taylor series is a tower: each floor corrects a finer feature of the function's shape at the center, and "infinitely many floors" means matching the function's local shape to infinite precision. Whether that local matching extends to a global equality is the subtle question we take up in the next chapter.

30.3.1 The three great Maclaurin series

We now compute, from the definition, the three series that every scientist carries in their head: e^x, $\sin x$, $\cos x$. Each is centered at 0, and in each case the derivatives at 0 fall into a simple repeating pattern.

Example 30.7 (The series for e^x)**.** Let $f(x) = e^x$. The defining property of the exponential function is that it equals its own derivative: $f'(x) = e^x$, $f''(x) = e^x$, and in general $f^{(n)}(x) = e^x$ for all n. Evaluated at 0, every derivative is $e^0 = 1$:

$$f^{(n)}(0) = 1 \qquad \text{for all } n.$$

So the coefficients are $c_n = f^{(n)}(0)/n! = 1/n!$, and

$$\boxed{e^x = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n!} = 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2!} + \frac{x^3}{3!} + \frac{x^4}{4!} + \cdots}, \qquad \text{all } x.$$

We computed the radius of this series back in Example 30.2: it is infinite. The same factorial growth that gave $R = \infty$ now reveals itself as the engine of e^x.

What is really happening

This series is arguably the *true definition* of e^x. In the chapter on the exponential we met e^x three ways: as a limit of compound interest, as the function equal to its own derivative, and as the inverse of ln. The series $\sum x^n/n!$ unifies them. It is its own derivative by term-by-term differentiation: differentiating $x^n/n!$ gives $x^{n-1}/(n-1)!$, which is just the previous term, so the whole series reproduces itself. It equals 1 at $x = 0$. Those two facts – self-derivative and value 1 at 0 – determine e^x completely. Setting $x = 1$ even gives the number e itself as a rapidly converging sum: $e = 1 + 1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{24} + \cdots = 2.71828\ldots$, far faster than the compound-interest limit ever did.

Example 30.8 (The series for $\sin x$ and $\cos x$)**.** Let $f(x) = \sin x$. Its derivatives cycle with period four:

$$f = \sin x, \quad f' = \cos x, \quad f'' = -\sin x, \quad f''' = -\cos x, \quad f'''' = \sin x, \ \ldots$$

Evaluating at 0, where $\sin 0 = 0$ and $\cos 0 = 1$, we get the pattern $0, 1, 0, -1, 0, 1, 0, -1, \ldots$. The even-order derivatives vanish; the odd ones alternate $+1, -1$. So only odd powers survive:

$$\boxed{\sin x = x - \frac{x^3}{3!} + \frac{x^5}{5!} - \frac{x^7}{7!} + \cdots = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{(2n+1)!}\, x^{2n+1}}, \qquad \text{all } x.$$

The same computation for $\cos x$ (whose derivatives at 0 run $1, 0, -1, 0, 1, \dots$) keeps only even powers:

$$\boxed{\cos x = 1 - \frac{x^2}{2!} + \frac{x^4}{4!} - \frac{x^6}{6!} + \cdots = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{(2n)!}\, x^{2n}}, \qquad \text{all } x.$$

Both have infinite radius. Notice that sin uses only odd powers (it is an odd function) and cos only even powers (it is even): the series reflects the symmetry of the function. And differentiating the sin series term by term gives the cos series exactly, just as it must.

Pause

Pause and think. Look at the Maclaurin series for $\cos x = 1 - \frac{x^2}{2!} + \frac{x^4}{4!} - \cdots$. Without computing derivatives the standard way, what does the series tell you about the slope $f'(0)$ and the curvature (second derivative $f''(0)$) of $\cos x$ at the origin?

Answer: The linear term x^1 is missing, which means its coefficient is $0 = f'(0)/1!$, so $f'(0) = 0$ (the graph has a horizontal tangent at its peak). The coefficient of x^2 is $-1/2 = f''(0)/2!$, which gives $f''(0) = -1$, confirming the downward curvature at $x = 0$. A Taylor series lets you read off every derivative of a function by inspection.

Connection

Comparing the three series reveals a direct connection:

$$e^x = 1 + x + \tfrac{x^2}{2!} + \tfrac{x^3}{3!} + \cdots, \quad \cos x = 1 - \tfrac{x^2}{2!} + \tfrac{x^4}{4!} - \cdots, \quad \sin x = x - \tfrac{x^3}{3!} + \tfrac{x^5}{5!} - \cdots.$$

The terms of e^x are precisely the terms of $\cos x$ and $\sin x$ interleaved – if only we could supply the alternating signs. Feed an imaginary argument ix into the exponential series and the powers i^n cycle $1, i, -1, -i, \dots$, producing exactly those signs. The even powers reconstruct $\cos x$, the odd powers reconstruct $i \sin x$, and you land on **Euler's formula**

$$e^{ix} = \cos x + i \sin x,$$

the deepest identity connecting exponential growth and circular motion. At $x = \pi$ it collapses to $e^{i\pi} + 1 = 0$. The power series is what makes this rigorous: it is the common language in which e^x, $\cos x$, and $\sin x$ are visibly the same kind of object.

30.4 Watching the Polynomials Close In

Definitions are one thing; *seeing* a polynomial chase down a transcendental function is another. The Taylor polynomials $P_N(x)$ are ordinary finite polynomials – you can graph them. As N grows, they hug the true function over a wider and wider stretch. Let us look.

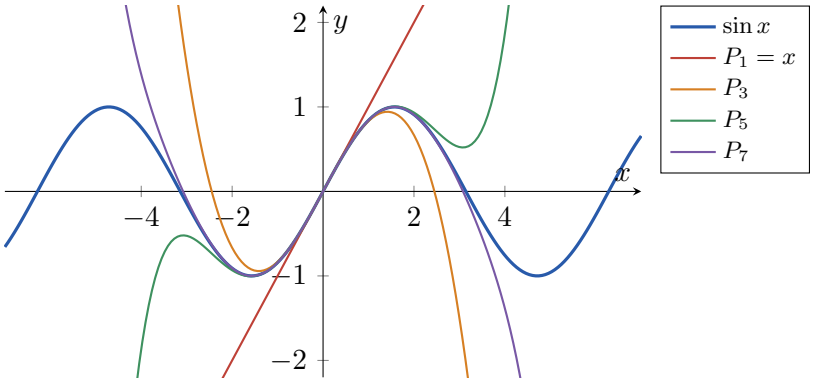


Figure 30.2: Taylor polynomials of $\sin x$ at 0. P_1 (the tangent line) is good only very near the origin; each higher-order polynomial clings to the sine curve over a longer interval before peeling away. By P_7 the match is excellent across a full period.

The picture tells the whole story. Near the center every polynomial is a good fit – that is guaranteed, because they match $\sin x$ to high order *at the origin*. Away from the origin, a low-order polynomial eventually grows like its leading power $\pm x^{2n+1}$, departing from the bounded sine wave. But it remains accurate longer than its predecessor, and the interval where it approximates well widens steadily as N increases. In the limit $N \to \infty$, the full series equals $\sin x$ everywhere on $\mathbb{R}$.

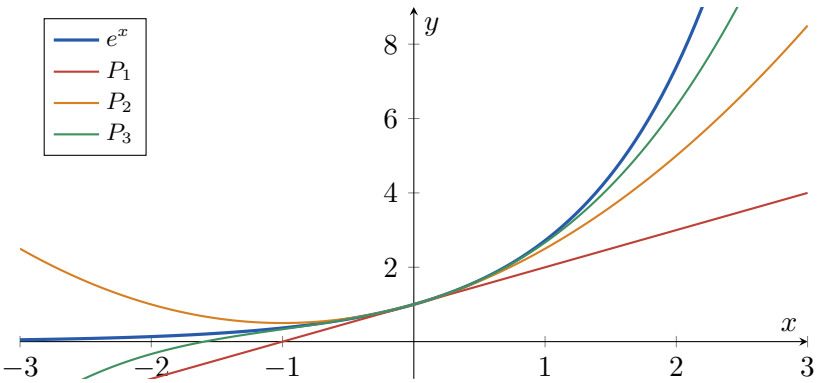


Figure 30.3: Taylor polynomials of e^x at 0. The tangent line $P_1 = 1 + x$ falls below the curve immediately; the parabola P_2 matches the upward curvature; P_3 improves the fit further. Each polynomial sits underneath e^x for $x > 0$ and creeps closer as the order rises.

Walking question

Consider the contrast between local and global behavior. The Taylor polynomial matches the function value and derivatives at the expansion point to order N. Yet a polynomial of odd degree must eventually diverge to $\pm\infty$, whereas $\sin x$ remains bounded in $[-1, 1]$. How do these two behaviors reconcile? Matching to high order at a single basepoint controls the function's values in a neighborhood of that point, but does not prevent growth far away for any fixed N. For a fixed degree, the approximation error grows as you move away from the center. The central question of approximation theory is quantifying this trade-off: for a given distance from the center, how high must the degree be to achieve a specified accuracy? Chapter 31

addresses this question via Taylor's Theorem with Remainder.

Work it yourself

Compute $\sin(0.5)$ by hand from the series, keeping three terms:

$$\sin(0.5) \approx 0.5 - \frac{0.5^3}{6} + \frac{0.5^5}{120} = 0.5 - \frac{0.125}{6} + \frac{0.03125}{120}.$$

That is $0.5 - 0.0208333 + 0.0002604 = 0.4794271$. The true value is $\sin(0.5) = 0.4794255\ldots$, so three terms already give six-digit accuracy. Calculators and math libraries work the same way: reduce the angle to a small interval near zero, then evaluate a short polynomial using only multiplication and addition.

30.5 Manipulating Series: an Algebra of Infinite Polynomials

Inside their radius of convergence, power series obey the same algebra as ordinary polynomials, and that is what makes them so useful. You may add them, subtract them, multiply them, substitute one into another, and (with care) divide them. This means you rarely have to grind out high derivatives from the Taylor definition – you start from the known series for e^x, $\sin x$, $\cos x$, $\ln(1+x)$, $1/(1-x)$ and *build*.

Focus

The toolbox of legal moves (valid wherever the series involved converge):

- **Add / subtract:** combine coefficients of like powers.
- **Multiply by a constant or a power of x:** scale or shift every term.
- **Substitute** a simple expression (like x^2 or $-x$ or $3x$) for the variable.
- **Multiply two series:** collect terms of each total degree (the Cauchy product).
- **Differentiate / integrate** term by term (Theorem 30.2).

The uniqueness of power series (each function has *one* series at a given center) is what makes this legal: whatever route you take, you must arrive at the same coefficients, so you may take the easiest route.

Example 30.9 (Substitution: the series for e^{-x^2})**.** The function e^{-x^2} – the unnormalized Gaussian bell curve – has no elementary antiderivative, so the integral $\int e^{-x^2}\mathrm{d}x$ defies the usual techniques. But its series is effortless. Start from $e^u = \sum u^n/n!$ and substitute $u = -x^2$:

$$e^{-x^2} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-x^2)^n}{n!} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n}}{n!} = 1 - x^2 + \frac{x^4}{2!} - \frac{x^6}{3!} + \cdots.$$

Now integrate term by term – something we could never do to the closed form:

$$\int_0^x e^{-t^2}\,\mathrm{d}t = x - \frac{x^3}{3} + \frac{x^5}{5\cdot 2!} - \frac{x^7}{7\cdot 3!} + \cdots = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n+1}}{(2n+1)\,n!}.$$

This is, up to a constant, the error function erf that governs the normal distribution in statistics. A function with no elementary antiderivative becomes completely computable through its series.

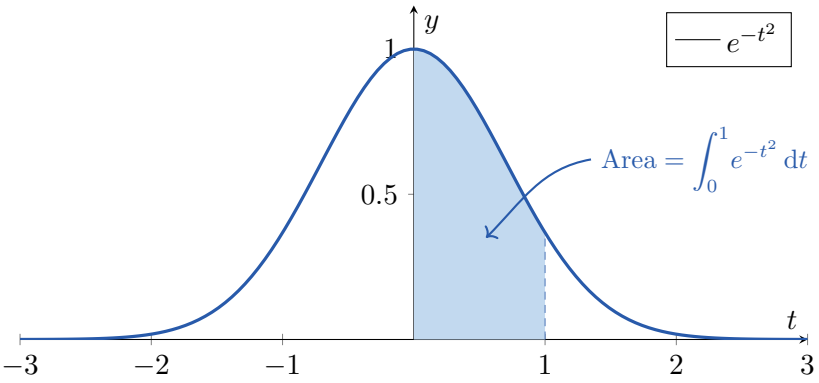


Figure 30.4: The Gaussian bell curve e^{-t^2}. The shaded area from 0 to 1 has no elementary formula, yet the term-by-term integration of Example 30.9 turns it into the convergent sum $1 - \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{5\cdot 2!} - \frac{1}{7\cdot 3!} + \cdots$, which any calculator can add up.

Application

The integral above is the backbone of probability and statistics. The area under the bell curve e^{-x^2} (Figure 30.4) between two points is what every "what fraction of outcomes fall within so many standard deviations" question reduces to, and no elementary formula for it exists. Statistical tables and software evaluate it by summing exactly the series of Example 30.9 (or a cleverer variant). The same situation arises in physics – Fresnel integrals for light diffraction, the integral of $\sin(x)/x$ in optics – where the only real way to get numbers is the power series. Series are not a curiosity; for a huge swath of applied mathematics they are the *only* bridge from a non-elementary function to an actual decimal.

Example 30.10 (Multiplication: the first terms of $e^x \sin x$)**.** To find the series of $e^x \sin x$ up to x^3, multiply the two series and collect by total degree:

$$e^x = 1 + x + \tfrac{x^2}{2} + \tfrac{x^3}{6} + \cdots, \qquad \sin x = x - \tfrac{x^3}{6} + \cdots.$$

Collect powers:

$$\begin{aligned} x^1 &: \quad 1 \cdot x = x, \\ x^2 &: \quad x \cdot x = x^2, \\ x^3 &: \quad \tfrac{x^2}{2} \cdot x + 1 \cdot \left(-\tfrac{x^3}{6}\right) = \tfrac{x^3}{2} - \tfrac{x^3}{6} = \tfrac{x^3}{3}. \end{aligned}$$

So $e^x \sin x = x + x^2 + \frac{1}{3}x^3 + \cdots$. To get the same three terms from the Taylor definition you would differentiate $e^x \sin x$ three times with the product rule – much more painful. Multiplying known series is the smart route.

Example 30.11 (Building a Taylor series at a shifted center)**.** To expand $\ln x$ around $a = 1$ (you cannot center at 0, since $\ln 0$ is undefined), write $x = 1 + (x-1)$ and reuse the known $\ln(1+u)$ series with $u = x - 1$:

$$\ln x = \ln\bigl(1 + (x-1)\bigr) = (x-1) - \frac{(x-1)^2}{2} + \frac{(x-1)^3}{3} - \cdots, \qquad 0 < x \le 2.$$

This is the Taylor series of $\ln x$ centered at 1. The substitution did all the work the derivative computation would have done – and the radius of convergence $R = 1$ tells us the series is valid only out to $x = 0$ and $x = 2$, exactly up to the wall at $\ln 0$.

Common trap

Series manipulation is forgiving, but three mistakes recur:

- **Forgetting the new radius after substitution.** Substituting $u = -x^2$ into a series valid for $|u| < 1$ gives one valid for $|x^2| < 1$, i.e. $|x| < 1$ – you must translate the condition.
- **Mismatched starting indices when adding.** Before combining $\sum$ and $\sum$, line up the powers; a series starting at $n = 0$ and one starting at $n = 1$ cannot be merged coefficient-by-coefficient until you peel off the stray term.
- **Assuming $\ln x$ has a Maclaurin series.** It does not – $\ln 0$ is undefined, so you must shift the center, as in Example 30.11.

30.6 The Catch: When Does the Series Equal the Function?

We have been a little cavalier. The Taylor recipe produces a series from any infinitely differentiable function – but does that series actually *sum to* the function? For e^x, $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and all our examples, yes. But it is not automatic, and we should not paper over the gap.

For a century after Newton and Leibniz, mathematicians manipulated power series with great algebraic flexibility, often without formal definitions of convergence. The assumption that "any smooth function equals its Taylor series wherever it converges" was widely accepted. It took **Augustin-Louis Cauchy** in the 1820s to insist on a rigorous definition of convergence and to confront the underlying question: does matching all derivatives at a single basepoint guarantee that the series reproduces the curve everywhere else? Cauchy showed that the answer is no, constructing the famous cautionary counterexample below.

Common trap

[Cauchy's cautionary function] Consider

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} e^{-1/x^2}, & x \neq 0, \\ 0, & x = 0. \end{cases}$$

This function is infinitely differentiable everywhere, and *every one* of its derivatives at 0 equals zero: $f(0) = f'(0) = f''(0) = \cdots = 0$. So its Maclaurin series is

$$0 + 0 \cdot x + 0 \cdot x^2 + \cdots = 0,$$

the zero series. But $f(x)$ is plainly *not* zero for $x \neq 0$. Here is a perfectly smooth function whose Taylor series converges everywhere – to the wrong answer. The series sees only what happens at the single point $x = 0$, and because e^{-1/x^2} approaches 0 faster than every power x^n as $x \to 0$, all derivatives at the origin are blind to its growth away from 0.

Intuition

The moral: a Taylor series is built from purely *local* data – the derivatives at one point. Sometimes (most happy times) that local fingerprint determines the function globally, and the series reproduces it perfectly; such functions are called *analytic* (meaning they are locally equal to their own convergent power series at every point). Sometimes, as with Cauchy's example, the fingerprint is misleading. The tool that decides which case you are in is the *remainder*: the difference $f(x) - P_N(x)$ between the function and its Taylor polynomial. The series equals the function exactly when this remainder shrinks to 0 as $N \to \infty$. Proving the remainder vanishes – for e^x, $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and the rest – is the precise, satisfying business of the next chapter.

Why this matters

The core transcendental functions – exponential growth, oscillation, the logarithm, and inverse trigonometric functions – share a unified representation as power series. Within their respective intervals of convergence, each is given by an infinite series with patterned coefficients. Differentiation, integration, multiplication, and substitution apply to them as systematically as to ordinary polynomials. The factorials, alternating signs, and symmetries reflect how higher derivatives behave at the expansion point. Writing these functions in a single polynomial language lets us compute their values, derivatives, and integrals with ordinary algebra.

30.7 A Table to Carry With You

These are the series worth memorizing. Everything else is built from them.

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{1}{1-x} &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n &&= 1 + x + x^2 + x^3 + \cdots && |x| < 1 \\
e^x &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n!} &&= 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2!} + \frac{x^3}{3!} + \cdots && \text{all } x \\
\sin x &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n+1}}{(2n+1)!} &&= x - \frac{x^3}{3!} + \frac{x^5}{5!} - \cdots && \text{all } x \\
\cos x &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n}}{(2n)!} &&= 1 - \frac{x^2}{2!} + \frac{x^4}{4!} - \cdots && \text{all } x \\
\ln(1+x) &= \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{n-1} x^n}{n} &&= x - \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{x^3}{3} - \cdots && -1 < x \le 1 \\
\arctan x &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n+1}}{2n+1} &&= x - \frac{x^3}{3} + \frac{x^5}{5} - \cdots && -1 \le x \le 1
\end{aligned}$$

30.8 Scope of Power Series and the Complex Plane

Connection

Power series express smooth transcendental functions as infinite polynomials, allowing us to manipulate them with ordinary algebra.
Before power series, evaluating functions like $\sin x$ or $\ln x$ required painstaking geometric approximations and precomputed tables. Taylor series gave them explicit polynomial expansions, making possible:

- *Term-by-term calculus of non-elementary functions:* Functions whose antiderivatives cannot be written in closed form (by Liouville's 1835 theorem proving that functions like e^{-x^2} have no antiderivatives built from standard elementary functions) are integrated term by term. The Gaussian error function, central to probability and statistics, is integrated directly:
$$\int e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = C + \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n+1}}{n!(2n+1)},$$
yielding an alternating series that converges for *every real number* x.
- *Solving differential equations:* In mathematical physics, the fundamental equations of quantum mechanics, electromagnetism, and gravitation (the Legendre, Bessel, Hermite, and Airy equations) cannot be solved by elementary formulas. Power series expansions (the Frobenius method) provide the exact wavefunctions and fields that govern atoms, vibrating drums, and planetary orbits.
- *Euler's identity:* Comparing the series for e^x, $\cos x$, and $\sin x$ revealed Euler's formula $e^{ix} = \cos x + i \sin x$, uniting trigonometry and exponentials into a single entity.

Yet why does a power series have a finite radius of convergence R? When a function blows up on the real line – such as $f(x) = \frac{1}{1-x}$ having a vertical asymptote at $x = 1$ – it is natural that its Maclaurin series cannot reach past $x = 1$. The radius $R = 1$ is enforced by a visible obstacle.

Now consider the innocent-looking function:

$$f(x) = \frac{1}{1+x^2}.$$

Its graph is a smooth, bell-shaped curve defined for *all* real numbers $x \in (-\infty, \infty)$, with no vertical asymptotes, corners, or jumps. It is infinitely differentiable everywhere. Yet its Maclaurin series is:

$$\frac{1}{1+x^2} = 1 - x^2 + x^4 - x^6 + \cdots,$$

and its radius of convergence is strictly $R = 1$. If you plug in $x = 1.1$, the series diverges ($1 - 1.21 + 1.4641 - \cdots$), even though $f(1.1) = \frac{1}{1+1.21} \approx 0.45$ is completely well behaved.

Why does a completely smooth function on the real line halt its Taylor series at $R = 1$? Confined to the real line, nothing in the graph explains why $x = \pm 1$ is a barrier. The explanation appears only when you step off the real line into the *complex plane* $\mathbb{C}$.

In the complex plane, the denominator $1+z^2$ factors as $(z-i)(z+i)$, which vanishes at the imaginary points $z = \pm i$. A point where a function blows up or its denominator vanishes is called a *singularity*

(and when caused by an isolated zero of the denominator, a *pole*). The distance from the origin $z = 0$ to these poles is:

$$|0 - (\pm i)| = \sqrt{0^2 + (\pm 1)^2} = 1.$$

Power series do not really live on a 1D line; they live in a two-dimensional disk in the complex plane. A power series' circle of convergence expands outward from the center until it strikes the *nearest singularity in the entire complex plane*. The poles at $\pm i$ are completely invisible to an observer confined to the real line, yet they cast a shadow that halts convergence at $x = \pm 1$ (Figure 30.5). To see why a real power series stops converging, we have to look off the real line into the complex plane.

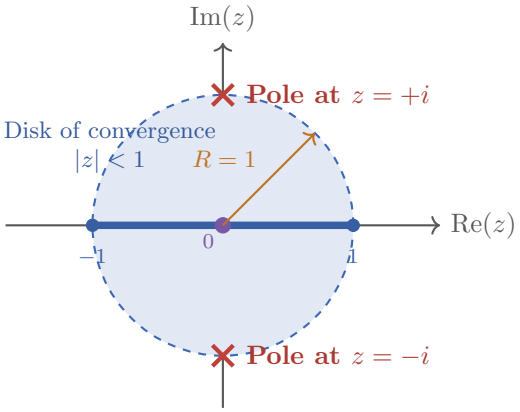


Figure 30.5: Why $1/(1+x^2)$ has radius of convergence $R = 1$. On the real line (the horizontal axis), the curve is completely smooth with no vertical asymptotes anywhere. But in the complex plane, the denominator factors as $(z - i)(z + i)$ and vanishes at the imaginary points $z = \pm i$. The disk of convergence expands outward from the center 0 until it strikes these hidden poles, limiting the real interval of convergence to $(-1, 1)$.

In Chapter 31, we turn to error analysis: Taylor's Theorem with Remainder gives exact bounds on the error when approximating a function by a finite Taylor polynomial.

30.9 Exercises

Exercise 30.1 (Warm-up: rapid mental checks)**.** Without writing down long calculations, answer the following in your head:

(a) What is the center and the radius of convergence of $\displaystyle\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(x-5)^n}{3^n}$?

(b) If a power series centered at 0 converges at $x = -4$ and diverges at $x = 6$, can it converge at $x = 3$? Can it converge at $x = -7$? What are the possible values for its radius of convergence R?

(c) If $f(x) = \displaystyle\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n^2+1}$, what is the exact value of the fourth derivative $f^{(4)}(0)$?

(d) Why must the Maclaurin series of an odd function (satisfying $f(-x) = -f(x)$) contain only odd powers of x?

Exercise 30.2 (Radius and interval of convergence)**.** For each series, find the radius of convergence, then test the endpoints to determine the full interval of convergence.

$$\text{(a) } \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n^2}, \qquad \text{(b) } \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{2^n}, \qquad \text{(c) } \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{(x-3)^n}{n\,5^n}, \qquad \text{(d) } \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (2n)!\,x^n.$$

Exercise 30.3 (Series by manipulation)**.** Without computing a single derivative, find the Maclaurin series (and its radius of convergence) for:

$$\text{(a) } \frac{1}{1+3x}, \qquad \text{(b) } x^2 e^{-x}, \qquad \text{(c) } \cos(2x), \qquad \text{(d) } \frac{x}{1-x^2}.$$

Exercise 30.4 (Differentiate a known series)**.** Starting from $\dfrac{1}{1-x} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} x^n$, differentiate twice to find a closed-form sum for $\sum_{n=2}^{\infty} n(n-1)x^{n-2}$, valid for $|x| < 1$. Then evaluate $\sum_{n=2}^{\infty} n(n-1)(1/2)^{n-2}$ as an exact number.

Exercise 30.5 (Integrate a known series)**.** Use the series for $\dfrac{1}{1+x^2}$ to write $\displaystyle\int_0^{1/2} \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{1+x^2}$ as an infinite series, and use the first three terms to estimate $\arctan(1/2)$. Compare with the true value.

Exercise 30.6 (Computing a transcendental number)**.** Use the Maclaurin series for e^x at $x = 1$ to estimate e using the terms up to $1/5!$. How many decimal places do you trust, and why does the alternating-series-style reasoning *not* directly apply here (the terms do not alternate)? Bound the tail $\sum_{n\geq 6} 1/n!$ by comparison with a geometric series.

Exercise 30.7 (A limit by series)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{\sin x - x}{x^3}$ by replacing $\sin x$ with the first few terms of its series, simplifying, and taking the limit. Then confirm with L'Hôpital's rule, and reflect on which method exposed *why* the answer is what it is.

Exercise 30.8 (Product of series)**.** Find the Maclaurin series of $\dfrac{e^x}{1-x}$ up to and including the x^3 term, by multiplying the series for e^x and $\dfrac{1}{1-x}$. (You should find the coefficient of x^n is $\sum_{k=0}^{n} 1/k!$.)

Exercise 30.9 (Shifted center)**.** Find the Taylor series of $f(x) = 1/x$ centered at $a = 2$. (Hint: write $\dfrac{1}{x} = \dfrac{1}{2+(x-2)} = \dfrac{1}{2}\cdot\dfrac{1}{1+(x-2)/2}$ and use the geometric series.) State the radius of convergence and explain geometrically why it is what it is.

Exercise 30.10 (Conceptual: uniqueness)**.** Explain in your own words why a function can have only one power series at a given center. If $\sum a_n x^n = \sum b_n x^n$ for all x in some interval around 0, prove that $a_n = b_n$ for every n. (Hint: differentiate n times and set $x = 0$.)

Exercise 30.11 (Proof: term-by-term and the derivative)**.** Let $f(x) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} c_n x^n$ have radius $R > 0$, and let $g(x) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n c_n x^{n-1}$ be the formally differentiated series. Prove that g has the same radius of convergence R as f. (You do not need to prove $g = f'$; just the radius. Use the ratio-test characterization and the fact that $\sqrt[n]{n} \to 1$ or that $n/(n+1) \to 1$.)

Exercise 30.12 (Cauchy's function, conceptual)**.** For $f(x) = e^{-1/x^2}$ (with $f(0) = 0$), explain why every derivative at 0 is zero, at least intuitively, by arguing that e^{-1/x^2} goes to 0 as $x \to 0$ faster than any power of x. What does this example tell you about the difference between "the Taylor series converges" and "the Taylor series converges *to the function*"?

Exercise 30.13 (Euler's formula by series)**.** Substitute $x = i\theta$ into the series for e^x, group the real and imaginary terms separately, and recognize the series for $\cos\theta$ and $\sin\theta$. Conclude $e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta$, and deduce the value of $e^{i\pi}$.

Chapter 31

Taylor's Theorem and Approximation

In the previous chapter, we built Taylor series $\sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}(x-a)^k$ from a striking local-to-global idea: if you know everything about a smooth function — meaning a function whose derivatives of all orders exist without kinks or sudden breaks — at a *single anchor point* a, you can often reconstruct the function far away. Starting from the tangent line $f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)$, which matches height and slope, adding a second derivative produces an *osculating parabola* — from the Latin *osculari*, "to kiss" — that bends with the exact same curvature (how sharply the curve turns away from its tangent line). A third derivative buys a cubic matching the rate at which curvature changes, and each further derivative lets the *Taylor polynomial* $P_n(x)$ hug the curve across a wider window before peeling away.

In practice, any concrete calculation stops after finitely many terms, and even when we let the degree grow toward the full *Taylor series*, we saw at the end of Chapter 30 that matching all derivatives at a does not automatically force the series to equal $f(x)$ away from a. That leaves two central questions:

1. *How large is the truncation error?* When approximating $f(x)$ by a Taylor polynomial $P_n(x)$ of degree n, how big can the remainder $R_n(x) = f(x) - P_n(x)$ be?
2. *When does the full series equal $f(x)$?* Under what conditions does $R_n(x) \to 0$ as $n \to \infty$, proving that the Taylor series converges to $f(x)$ rather than drifting away?

Answering both questions requires an explicit formula for the gap $R_n(x)$ at any finite step — *Taylor's theorem with remainder*. In this chapter we examine how these polynomial approximations behave, why the factorial denominators arise inevitably from differentiation, how to bound the remainder with certainty, and why infinite reconstruction succeeds for functions like e^x and $\cos x$ yet encounters genuine barriers for others.

31.1 From a line to a polynomial: matching derivatives

Start with the linear approximation and recall why it works near $x = a$. Near a point a, the line

$$L(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x-a)$$

agrees with f in two respects: $L(a) = f(a)$ (same height) and $L'(a) = f'(a)$ (same slope). Those two matched conditions are the whole reason the line clings to the curve near a. It is the unique line that gets both right.

Intuition

Approximation by matching is a recurring technique in mathematics: to model a complicated function near a point, construct a simple polynomial that agrees with it in as many *derivatives* as possible. A line matches two pieces of data (value and slope). A parabola can match three (value, slope, and curvature). A degree-n polynomial has $n+1$ free coefficients, so it can match $n+1$ pieces of data: the value and the first n derivatives. The more derivatives you match at a, the closer the polynomial approximates the function as you move away from a.

To construct higher-order approximations, we specify a polynomial P_n of degree n satisfying

$$P_n(a) = f(a), \quad P_n'(a) = f'(a), \quad P_n''(a) = f''(a), \quad \ldots, \quad P_n^{(n)}(a) = f^{(n)}(a).$$

Match the function and its first n derivatives at the single point a. The question is what coefficients make this happen.

In Chapter 30 we extracted these coefficients under the optimistic assumption that f already equaled an infinite power series. The same algebra works for a *finite* polynomial of degree n, with no convergence assumption at all. Write P_n in powers of $(x-a)$, because we only care about behavior near a:

$$P_n(x) = c_0 + c_1(x-a) + c_2(x-a)^2 + c_3(x-a)^3 + \cdots + c_n(x-a)^n.$$

Now extract the coefficients one at a time by differentiating and then plugging in $x = a$, which kills every term that still has a factor of $(x-a)$ in it.

Plug in $x = a$ directly: every term but the first dies, leaving $P_n(a) = c_0$. So $c_0 = f(a)$.

Differentiate once: $P_n'(x) = c_1 + 2c_2(x-a) + 3c_3(x-a)^2 + \cdots$. Plug in $x = a$: everything but the first term dies, $P_n'(a) = c_1$. So $c_1 = f'(a)$.

Differentiate again: $P_n''(x) = 2c_2 + 3\cdot 2\, c_3(x-a) + \cdots$. Plug in $x = a$: $P_n''(a) = 2c_2$. So $c_2 = f''(a)/2$.

Once more: $P_n'''(x) = 3\cdot 2\, c_3 + 4\cdot 3\cdot 2\, c_4(x-a) + \cdots$, so $P_n'''(a) = 6c_3$, giving $c_3 = f'''(a)/6$.

The numbers $1, 2, 6, 24, \ldots$ marching down the denominators are the factorials, because differentiating $(x-a)^k$ exactly k times brings down $k\cdot(k-1)\cdots 2\cdot 1 = k!$ and turns the term into a constant, while all lower terms have already vanished and all higher terms still carry a factor of $(x-a)$. So in general

$$P_n^{(k)}(a) = k!\, c_k \quad \Longrightarrow \quad c_k = \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}.$$

Focus

The Taylor polynomial. The unique degree-n polynomial matching f and its first n derivatives at a is

$$P_n(x) = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}(x-a)^k = f(a) + f'(a)(x-a) + \frac{f''(a)}{2!}(x-a)^2 + \cdots + \frac{f^{(n)}(a)}{n!}(x-a)^n.$$

The factorials are exactly what is needed to undo the factorials that differentiation k times produces. When $a = 0$ this is sometimes called the *Maclaurin* polynomial, but it is the same idea centered at the origin.

Why the technique works

Why factorials, really? Differentiation and the monomial $(x-a)^k$ are made for each other. Each derivative peels one factor off the front: $(x-a)^k \to k(x-a)^{k-1} \to k(k-1)(x-a)^{k-2} \to \cdots$. After exactly k steps the variable is gone and a bare $k!$ stands where the term used to be. Dividing the coefficient by $k!$ in advance is the antidote: it guarantees that when you differentiate k times and set $x=a$, the k-th term contributes precisely $f^{(k)}(a)$ and nothing else contributes at all. Dividing by the factorial is the adjustment that makes the k-th coefficient control the k-th derivative cleanly and independently of all the others.

Pause

Pause and think. Before moving on, test the formula on a polynomial: what is the degree-3 Taylor polynomial of $f(x) = 2x^3 - 4x + 7$ centered at $a = 0$? What is its degree-4 Taylor polynomial? If you expand a degree-n polynomial to degree n (or higher) about any center, what must the remainder be?
Reflection: Differentiating a degree-n polynomial $n+1$ times yields zero, so all derivatives beyond the n-th vanish identically. The Taylor polynomial P_n of a degree-n polynomial is the polynomial itself, just re-expressed in powers of $(x-a)$. There is no remainder at all.

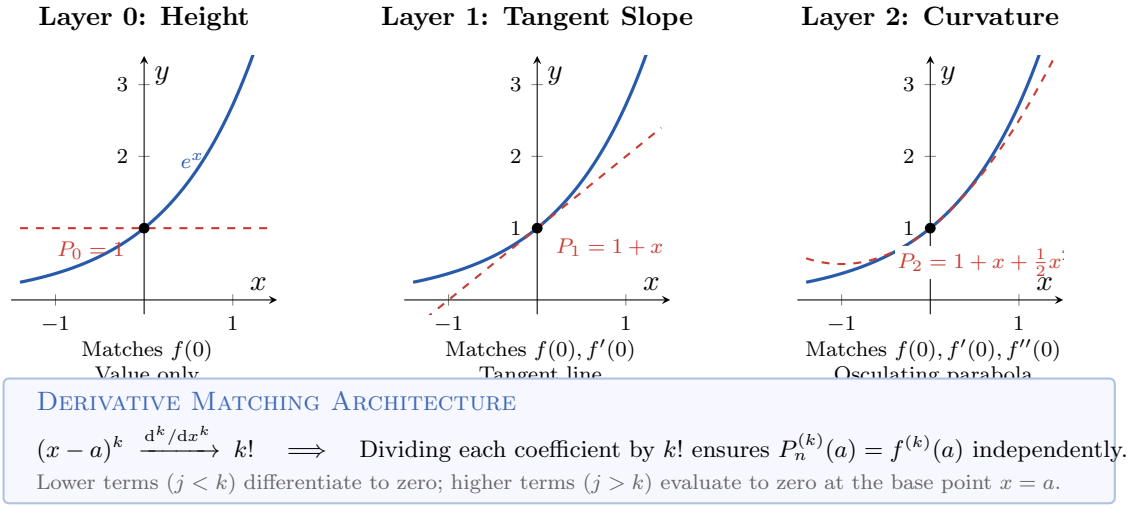


Figure 31.1: Building Taylor polynomials layer by layer at $a = 0$ for $f(x) = e^x$. Layer 0 pins the height, Layer 1 adds the tangent slope, and Layer 2 bends the polynomial to match the exact curvature. The lower lane illustrates the cascade of differentiation: each term $(x-a)^k/k!$ controls its own derivative at a without disturbing any of the previously calibrated layers.

31.1.1 A first picture: parabola beats line

Take $f(x) = \cos x$ at $a = 0$. We know $f(0) = 1$, $f'(0) = -\sin 0 = 0$, $f''(0) = -\cos 0 = -1$. So

$$P_1(x) = 1, \qquad P_2(x) = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2}x^2.$$

The linear approximation of cosine at the top of its hump is just the flat line $y = 1$ — correct in value and slope but blind to the fact that cosine curves *downward*. The quadratic $1 - \frac{1}{2}x^2$ knows

about that downward bend, and you can see it follow the cosine far better.

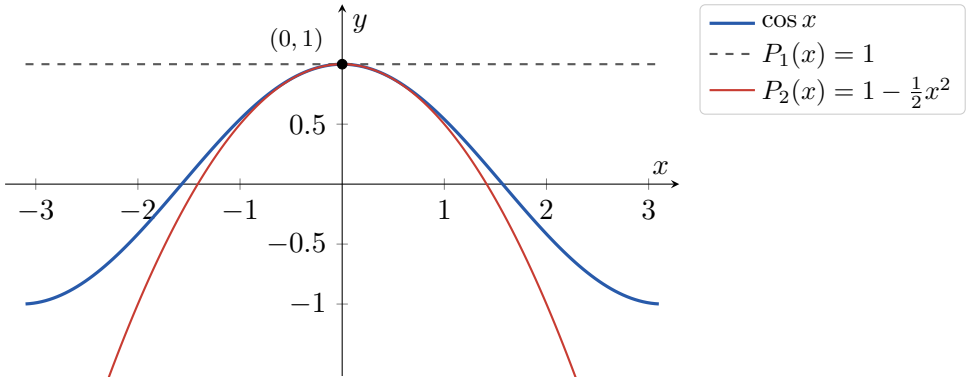


Figure 31.2: At $a = 0$, the linear approximation to $\cos x$ is the horizontal tangent line $y = 1$, which matches height and slope but ignores curvature. The quadratic $P_2(x) = 1 - \frac{1}{2}x^2$ incorporates the downward bending $f''(0) = -1$ and embraces the cosine wave over a substantial interval.

Each extra term tightens the grip. The degree-4 Taylor polynomial of cosine, $1 - \frac{1}{2}x^2 + \frac{1}{24}x^4$, tracks the true cosine accurately well past $x = 2$. We will quantify "accurately" soon; for now, notice the qualitative law: *higher degree buys a wider window of trust.*

31.2 The remainder: naming the gap exactly

A picture that "hugs" a curve is suggestive but not yet mathematics. The exact object is the *remainder*, the difference between the function and its polynomial:

$$R_n(x) = f(x) - P_n(x).$$

This is an exact identity rather than an approximation: $f(x) = P_n(x) + R_n(x)$ for every x, with $R_n(x)$ collecting the entire approximation error. Analyzing the approximation now reduces to bounding R_n: if we can show $R_n(x)$ is small, then $P_n(x)$ is a good approximation, with a guarantee, not a hope.

What is really happening

When you write $\cos x \approx 1 - \frac{1}{2}x^2$, the "$\approx$" is hiding a precise statement. What is really there is an equation with a correction term:

$$\cos x = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2}x^2 + R_2(x),$$

and Taylor's theorem is going to hand us a *formula* for $R_2(x)$ — not its exact value (that would be asking too much), but a clean expression that lets us *bound* it. The difference between an engineer who trusts a small-angle approximation and a gambler who hopes it works is exactly this remainder term.

So what should we expect of R_n? Two things, immediately. First, since P_n matches f and its first n derivatives at a, the remainder and *its* first n derivatives must all vanish at a:

$$R_n(a) = R_n'(a) = R_n''(a) = \cdots = R_n^{(n)}(a) = 0.$$

A function whose first n derivatives die at a point is extremely flat there — flatter than $(x-a)^n$. So $R_n(x)$ ought to behave like $(x-a)^{n+1}$ near a: small, and getting small *fast* as $x \to a$. That is the heart of why more terms help. Let us turn this intuition into a theorem.

31.3 Taylor's theorem with the Lagrange remainder

Here is the destination, stated cleanly, before we earn it.

Focus

Taylor's Theorem (Lagrange form of the remainder). Suppose f is $n+1$ times differentiable on an open interval containing a and x. Then there is a point c strictly between a and x such that

$$f(x) = \underbrace{\sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}(x-a)^k}_{P_n(x)} + \underbrace{\frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{(n+1)!}(x-a)^{n+1}}_{R_n(x)}.$$

The remainder $R_n(x)$ looks exactly like the *next* Taylor term — the degree-$(n+1)$ term you would have written next — except that the $(n+1)$-st derivative is evaluated not at a but at some mystery point c in between.

Notice how this generalizes the Mean Value Theorem. Set $n = 0$. The theorem says $f(x) = f(a) + f'(c)(x-a)$ for some c between a and x — which, rearranged, is $\frac{f(x)-f(a)}{x-a} = f'(c)$, precisely the MVT. So Taylor's theorem is the MVT with more derivatives. The single mysterious point c where "the average is achieved" in the MVT reappears here as the point where the $(n+1)$-st derivative takes the value that makes the equation exactly balance.

Intuition

A natural first guess is that the truncation error after n terms should look like the first omitted term, $\frac{f^{(n+1)}(a)}{(n+1)!}(x-a)^{n+1}$. Taylor's theorem says: it does behave exactly like that next term — you just have to evaluate the derivative at a slightly shifted point c instead of at a. And since you usually do not need c exactly, only a *bound* on $f^{(n+1)}$ over the interval, this shifted point costs you almost nothing in practice. You trade "the exact error" (impossible to know) for "the error has this exact *form*" (immediately useful).

History

Between the fourteenth and nineteenth centuries, mathematics underwent a transformation: turning calculus from geometric intuition into numerical calculation with guaranteed precision. The earliest origins trace to Madhava of Sangamagrama and the Kerala school in fourteenth-century India, who discovered the infinite series expansions for $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and $\arctan x$ to construct accurate astronomical tables. Centuries later in Europe, James Gregory (in 1671) and Isaac Newton independently rediscovered several of these expansions. In 1715, the English mathematician Brook Taylor published the general recipe matching derivatives to polynomial coefficients in his *Methodus Incrementorum Directa et Inversa*.

Yet for all this brilliance, an essential piece was missing: *none of them had the remainder*. They

had no formula for the error committed by truncating a series after a finite number of terms. The early calculus of Newton, Leibniz, and Euler treated infinite series as formal algebraic identities. Mathematicians calculated with them boldly and often correctly by instinct, but they were working without safety nets. When Leonhard Euler manipulated divergent series — infinite sums whose running totals oscillate or blow up toward infinity rather than settling to a fixed number — to deduce spectacular mathematical identities, other mathematicians grew uneasy, unable to draw a clear line between sound approximation and mathematical illusion. Controversy simmered on two fronts. A priority dispute flared between Taylor and Johann Bernoulli over who first discovered the polynomial expansion, while Colin Maclaurin's 1742 treatise popularized the expansion centered at zero so widely that history attached Maclaurin's name to Taylor's special case. More fundamentally, mathematicians debated whether infinite sums could ever be trusted without an error term.

The breakthrough arrived in 1797, when Joseph-Louis Lagrange published *Théorie des fonctions analytiques*. Lagrange realized that an approximation is only scientific if accompanied by an error bound: he isolated the exact, finite remainder term that bears his name. In the 1820s, Augustin-Louis Cauchy and later Karl Weierstrass placed Lagrange's remainder on rigorous footing by linking it directly to the Mean Value Theorem.

What this made possible was far-reaching: it turned calculus into an engineering tool. With a computable remainder bound, navigators could rely on printed tables of logarithms, astronomers could compute celestial orbits with certified precision, and today computer chips evaluate trigonometric functions knowing the exact number of terms needed to make every displayed digit correct. While the one-dimensional Taylor remainder is fully settled today, finding sharp, computable remainder bounds for nonlinear partial differential equations and high-dimensional optimization surfaces in machine learning remains an active area of modern research.

31.3.1 Why it is true: the idea before the proof

There are several routes to this theorem (an exercise develops one through repeated integration by parts). Here we take a direct route: apply the Cauchy Mean Value Theorem to a sliding-center helper function whose derivative telescopes to a single term. Before the formalism, here is the core idea.

We want to compare $f(x)$ with $P_n(x)$. Fix the target point $x = b$ and the center a. Build a helper function $g(t)$ of a new variable t that measures, at each t, how far f is from *its own Taylor polynomial centered at* t (evaluated at b), and arrange it so that g equals 0 at the end $t = b$. Then a single mean-value step on g causes the sum to telescope, leaving precisely the remainder formula. The telescoping is not luck; the helper is designed to telescope.

Why the technique works

Why a helper function? Because the quantity we care about, $f(b) - P_n(b)$, is a single number with no t in it — there is nothing to apply a mean-value argument to. The trick, which runs through all of analysis, is to *introduce a variable*: turn the static number into the endpoint value of a moving quantity, so that the machinery of derivatives (Rolle, MVT) has something to bite on. We promote the fixed center a to a sliding center t, watch the discrepancy change as t slides from a to b, and let the Mean Value Theorem catch the instant where the change

reveals the remainder. Constructing the right auxiliary function is the key step; verifying it is then mechanical.

31.3.2 The proof

Theorem 31.1 (Taylor with Lagrange remainder)**.** *Let f be a function such that $f, f', \dots, f^{(n)}$ are continuous on the closed interval between a and b, and $f^{(n+1)}$ exists on the open interval between them. Then there is a point c strictly between a and b with*

$$f(b) = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}(b-a)^k + \frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{(n+1)!}(b-a)^{n+1}.$$

Proof. Treat a, b, n as fixed. Define a function of a sliding center t, living on the interval between a and b:

$$g(t) = f(b) - \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{f^{(k)}(t)}{k!}\,(b-t)^k.$$

Read $g(t)$ out loud: it is the gap between the true value $f(b)$ and the Taylor polynomial of f *centered at* t, evaluated at b. Two endpoint values are immediate.

At $t = b$: every factor $(b-t)^k$ with $k \geq 1$ vanishes, and the $k = 0$ term is $f(b)$, so

$$g(b) = f(b) - f(b) = 0.$$

At $t = a$: the sum is exactly the Taylor polynomial $P_n(b)$, so

$$g(a) = f(b) - P_n(b) = R_n(b),$$

which is the remainder $R_n(b)$ we wish to evaluate. Thus g evaluates to $R_n(b)$ at $t = a$ and to 0 at $t = b$.

Now differentiate g with respect to t. This is the step where the design pays off. Each term of the sum is a product $\frac{f^{(k)}(t)}{k!}(b-t)^k$, so we use the product rule:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\left[\frac{f^{(k)}(t)}{k!}(b-t)^k\right] = \frac{f^{(k+1)}(t)}{k!}(b-t)^k \;-\; \frac{f^{(k)}(t)}{k!}\,k\,(b-t)^{k-1}.$$

The first piece is the derivative landing on $f^{(k)}$; the second is the derivative landing on $(b-t)^k$, which brings down k and lowers the power (the minus sign comes from the chain rule on $b-t$). Now sum over $k = 0$ to n and watch the second pieces cancel the first pieces of the neighboring term. For $k = 0$ the term is just $f(t)$, whose derivative is $A_0 = f'(t)$, with no second piece at all. For each $k \geq 1$, write the first piece as $A_k = \frac{f^{(k+1)}(t)}{k!}(b-t)^k$ and simplify $\frac{k}{k!} = \frac{1}{(k-1)!}$ in the second piece, which becomes $\frac{f^{(k)}(t)}{(k-1)!}(b-t)^{k-1} = A_{k-1}$. So

$$g'(t) = -A_0 - \sum_{k=1}^{n}\big(A_k - A_{k-1}\big) = -\sum_{k=0}^{n} A_k + \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} A_k = -A_n,$$

because every neighboring pair cancels, leaving only the very last first-type term. Therefore

$$g'(t) = -\frac{f^{(n+1)}(t)}{n!}\,(b-t)^n.$$

Everything collapsed to a single clean term: this is exactly the telescoping the helper was engineered to produce.

Now we apply a mean-value argument — but cleverly, using a second helper so that we get the strong $(n+1)!$ form rather than a weaker estimate. Introduce

$$h(t) = (b-t)^{n+1}.$$

Both g and h are continuous on the closed interval and differentiable on the open one, and $h'(t) = -(n+1)(b-t)^n$ never vanishes inside. The Cauchy (generalized) Mean Value Theorem then guarantees a point c strictly between a and b with

$$\frac{g(a)-g(b)}{h(a)-h(b)} = \frac{g'(c)}{h'(c)}.$$

We computed $g(b) = 0$, $g(a) = R_n(b)$, $h(b) = 0$, and $h(a) = (b-a)^{n+1}$. The right side is

$$\frac{g'(c)}{h'(c)} = \frac{-\frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{n!}(b-c)^n}{-(n+1)(b-c)^n} = \frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{(n+1)!}.$$

The $(b-c)^n$ factors cancel — another piece of the design — and the $n!$ becomes $(n+1)!$. Setting the two sides equal,

$$\frac{R_n(b)}{(b-a)^{n+1}} = \frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{(n+1)!},$$

which rearranges to exactly

$$R_n(b) = \frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{(n+1)!}(b-a)^{n+1}.$$

That is the claim. □

Remark 31.1. The case $n = 0$ recovers the Mean Value Theorem itself, and the proof above, stripped to $n = 0$, *is* the standard proof of the MVT via the Cauchy form. Taylor's theorem is a direct generalization of the Mean Value Theorem to higher derivatives.

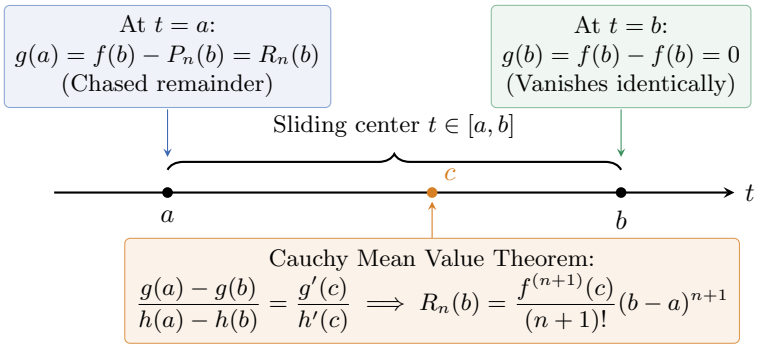


Figure 31.3: The sliding-center strategy in the proof of Taylor's theorem. The helper function $g(t)$ measures the discrepancy at b when the expansion is centered at t. Moving t from a to b connects the unknown remainder $R_n(b)$ at one boundary to zero at the other. The Cauchy Mean Value Theorem catches the intermediate point c where telescoping yields the exact Lagrange remainder.

31.4 Using the remainder to bound error

The point c is unknown, and that is fine, because we almost never want c itself. We want a guarantee. And a guarantee follows the instant we can say how big $f^{(n+1)}$ can possibly be on the interval. This is the primary operational corollary of the remainder theorem.

Focus

The error bound. If $|f^{(n+1)}(t)| \le M$ for all t between a and x, then

$$|R_n(x)| \;\le\; \frac{M}{(n+1)!}\,|x-a|^{n+1}.$$

You do not need to find c. You only need a ceiling M on the next derivative.

This is the form you actually use. To approximate $f(x)$ by $P_n(x)$ and *know* how wrong you might be, you ask one question: how large can the $(n+1)$-st derivative get on the way from a to x? Whatever that ceiling M is, the error cannot exceed $\frac{M}{(n+1)!}|x-a|^{n+1}$. Two competing factors appear in that bound: $|x-a|^{n+1}$ increases with distance from a, while $(n+1)!$ in the denominator grows rapidly with n. For functions whose derivatives stay bounded (like sin, cos, e^x on any fixed interval), the factorial wins decisively, and the error collapses to zero as you take more terms.

Pause

Pause and think. Look at the balance of power in the error bound $\frac{M}{(n+1)!}|x-a|^{n+1}$. If you double your distance from the base point a (say from $|x-a| = 0.1$ to 0.2), by what factor does the worst-case error bound grow for a tangent line ($n=1$)? What about for a degree-4 approximation ($n=4$)?
Reflection: For $n=1$, the bound scales as $2^{1+1} = 2^2 = 4$. For $n=4$, it scales as $2^{4+1} = 2^5 = 32$. Higher-degree polynomials provide much tighter bounds near the center, but the error bound grows more rapidly with distance.

Work it yourself

Approximate $\cos(0.5)$ using $P_2(x) = 1 - \frac{1}{2}x^2$ and bound the error *before* comparing to a calculator.
The estimate: $P_2(0.5) = 1 - \frac{1}{2}(0.25) = 1 - 0.125 = 0.875$.
The bound: here $n=2$, so we need a ceiling on $|f^{(3)}|$. For $f = \cos$, $f'''(x) = \sin x$, and $|\sin t| \le 1$ everywhere, so $M = 1$. Then

$$|R_2(0.5)| \le \frac{1}{3!}\,(0.5)^3 = \frac{0.125}{6} \approx 0.0208.$$

So we may assert, with certainty, that the true $\cos(0.5)$ lies in $[0.875 - 0.021,\ 0.875 + 0.021] = [0.854,\ 0.896]$.
The check: a calculator gives $\cos(0.5) = 0.87758\ldots$, and indeed $|0.87758 - 0.875| = 0.0026$, comfortably under our promised ceiling of 0.0208. The bound held and, as usual, came out a bit pessimistic — which is exactly what you want from a guarantee.

Common trap

A bound is an upper limit, not a prediction. Beginners sometimes report "the error is 0.0208" when the theorem only promises "the error is *at most* 0.0208." The actual error here was 0.0026, almost ten times smaller. The Lagrange bound is deliberately conservative: it assumes the next derivative sits at its worst-case value M over the whole interval, which it usually does not. Never quote the bound as the error; quote it as the worst case.

There is an even deeper reason the actual error was so small: for cosine, the third derivative at the origin is $-\sin(0) = 0$. That means the quadratic polynomial $P_2(x) = 1 - \frac{1}{2}x^2$ is *also* the cubic Taylor polynomial $P_3(x)$. If we apply Taylor's theorem at degree $n = 3$, the remainder is bounded by $\frac{M_4}{4!}(0.5)^4 = \frac{1}{24}(0.0625) \approx 0.00260$, matching the true error almost to the last decimal place. Whenever the next coefficient happens to be zero, your polynomial automatically gains an extra degree of accuracy.

Work it yourself

A harder, more satisfying one: how many terms of the Maclaurin series for e^x do we need to compute $e = e^1$ to within 10^{-6}?

For $f(x) = e^x$ centered at $a = 0$, every derivative is e^x again, and on $[0, 1]$ we have $e^t \le e < 3$, so we may take $M = 3$. With $x = 1$,

$$|R_n(1)| \le \frac{3}{(n+1)!} \cdot 1^{n+1} = \frac{3}{(n+1)!}.$$

We need $\frac{3}{(n+1)!} \le 10^{-6}$, i.e. $(n+1)! \ge 3 \times 10^6$. Now just march up the factorials: $9! = 362880$ (too small), $10! = 3628800 \ge 3 \times 10^6$. So $(n+1) = 10$, meaning $n = 9$: the polynomial through the $x^9/9!$ term suffices. Computing $\sum_{k=0}^{9} \frac{1}{k!}$ gives $2.7182815\ldots$ against the true $e = 2.7182818\ldots$, an error of about 3×10^{-7} — under our budget, as promised. The factorial in the denominator does the heavy lifting: ten terms and we already have six digits.

Application

This is precisely how scientific computing libraries evaluate e^x, $\sin x$, and related functions. Rather than evaluating transcendental expressions symbolically, the algorithm computes a finite Taylor polynomial (after reducing the argument to a standard interval where convergence is rapid, such as using periodic symmetries or range reduction), and the Lagrange remainder guarantees that the computed value is accurate to machine precision.

31.5 When does the series converge to the function?

Now the bigger dream. Suppose f has *all* derivatives. We can keep building Taylor polynomials of every degree, and we may ask whether the infinite series

$$\sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}(x-a)^k$$

adds up to $f(x)$. The series equals $f(x)$ at a given point x exactly when the remainder vanishes in the limit:

$$\boxed{\lim_{n\to\infty} R_n(x) = 0}$$

This equation is the exact criterion for a Taylor series to represent its function. The Taylor series converges *to* f at x if and only if the leftover $R_n(x)$ shrinks to zero as you include more terms. Not "if the series converges" — the series can converge to the *wrong* thing, as we will see — but if and only if the gap between f and the polynomial closes.

Why the technique works

Why is $R_n \to 0$ the exact condition, and not something about the series "converging"? Because $f(x) = P_n(x) + R_n(x)$ is an identity for every n. Rearranged, $R_n(x) = f(x) - P_n(x)$. As $n \to \infty$, $P_n(x)$ is the partial sum of the Taylor series. So $P_n(x) \to f(x)$ — the series summing to the function — is literally the same statement as $R_n(x) \to 0$. There is no daylight between them. This is why all the labor went into the remainder: it is the only thing standing between the polynomial and the function.

For the friendly functions, the Lagrange bound closes the case in one line. Take $\sin x$ centered at 0. Every derivative is one of $\pm\sin x, \pm\cos x$, so $|f^{(n+1)}(t)| \le 1$ for all t, giving

$$|R_n(x)| \le \frac{1}{(n+1)!}\,|x|^{n+1}.$$

For any fixed x, no matter how large, $\frac{|x|^{n+1}}{(n+1)!} \to 0$ as $n \to \infty$ — the factorial outruns any fixed power. Therefore the Maclaurin series for $\sin x$ converges to $\sin x$ for *every* real x. The same argument works for e^x at any fixed x: every derivative is e^t, which between 0 and x is at most e^x when $x \ge 0$ and at most $e^0 = 1$ when $x < 0$. Either way $M = e^{|x|}$ bounds $|f^{(n+1)}(t)|$ independently of n, so $|R_n(x)| \le e^{|x|}\frac{|x|^{n+1}}{(n+1)!} \to 0$. These functions are reconstructed everywhere from their derivatives at the single point $x = 0$.

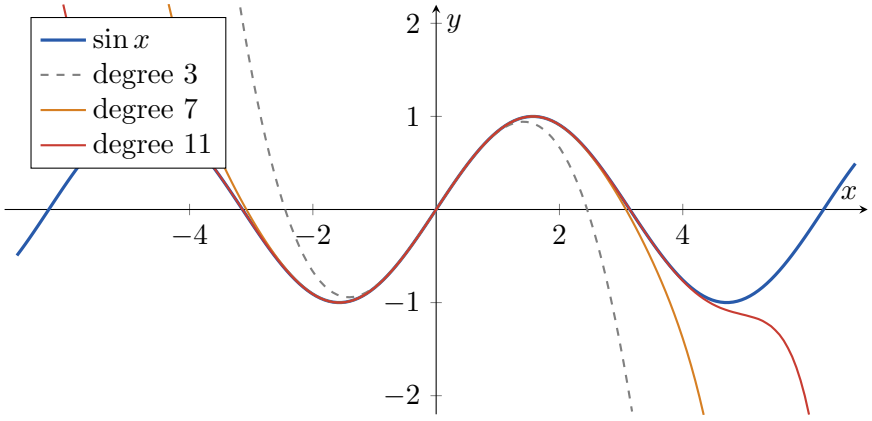


Figure 31.4: Taylor polynomials of $\sin x$ at 0 closing in on the curve. Each higher degree extends the interval over which the polynomial tracks $\sin x$ before it finally shoots off to infinity. In the limit, the series captures $\sin x$ on the entire real line.

31.5.1 Where convergence stops: the geometric warning

Not every smooth function is captured on the whole line. Recall from the end of Chapter 30 the bell-shaped curve

$$f(x) = \frac{1}{1+x^2}.$$

This function is perfectly smooth everywhere on $\mathbb{R}$ — no breaks, no corners, no vertical asymptotes, infinitely differentiable. Now look at it through the remainder. The finite geometric sum gives $\frac{1}{1+x^2} = 1 - x^2 + x^4 - \cdots + (-1)^n x^{2n} + \frac{(-1)^{n+1}x^{2n+2}}{1+x^2}$, so the exact remainder after degree $2n$ is $R_{2n}(x) = \frac{(-1)^{n+1}x^{2n+2}}{1+x^2}$. For $|x| < 1$ it shrinks to 0; for $|x| > 1$ it grows without bound. So the series

$$1 - x^2 + x^4 - x^6 + \cdots$$

converges to f only for $|x| < 1$. Why 1? There is nothing visibly wrong with the function at $x = 1$. The graph sails smoothly through $(1, \frac{1}{2})$ without a hint of trouble.

Pause

Pause and think. The bell-shaped curve $f(x) = \frac{1}{1+x^2}$ is bounded, completely smooth, and shows no break or corner anywhere on the real line. If you were confined to the real axis with no knowledge of complex numbers, could you find any clue in the real graph explaining why its Taylor series at $a = 0$ refuses to converge when $|x| > 1$?
Reflection: Nothing in the real graph gives it away. The curve stays bounded and smooth on $\mathbb{R}$, yet for $|x| > 1$ the partial sums oscillate with growing amplitude. The obstruction is invisible until you look off the real axis into the imaginary direction.

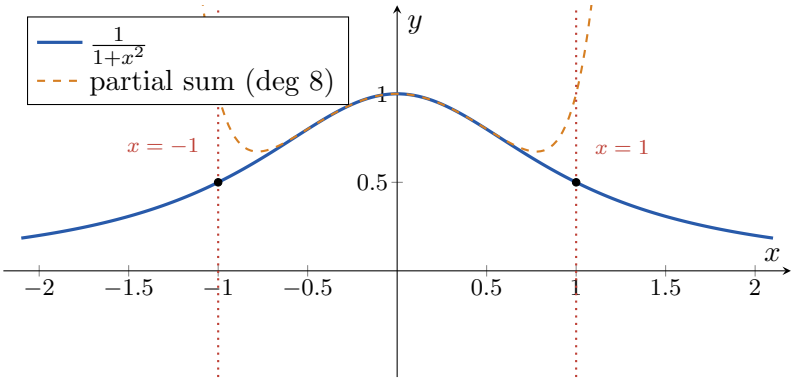


Figure 31.5: The function $\frac{1}{1+x^2}$ is smooth everywhere, yet its Maclaurin series $1-x^2+x^4-\cdots$ tracks it only on $(-1, 1)$ (dotted lines). Inside that interval the partial sums close in; just outside, they fly apart, even though the function itself is perfectly well behaved there. The wall at $|x| = 1$ is set by a singularity hiding off the real axis.

Intuition

The mystery dissolves the moment you allow complex numbers, and this was one of the great clarifying insights of nineteenth-century analysis (Cauchy, then Weierstrass and Riemann). The function $\frac{1}{1+x^2}$, viewed over the complex plane, *blows up* at $x = \pm i$, where $1 + x^2 = 0$. Those poles sit at distance 1 from the origin. A power series centered at 0 converges inside the

largest disk around 0 that reaches no singularity — and the nearest singularities, invisible on the real line, are exactly one unit away in the imaginary direction. The radius of convergence 1 was being dictated by points you could not see. The early calculus of Newton and Euler used such series freely and often correctly by instinct; it took the complex viewpoint to explain *why* the instinct sometimes failed.

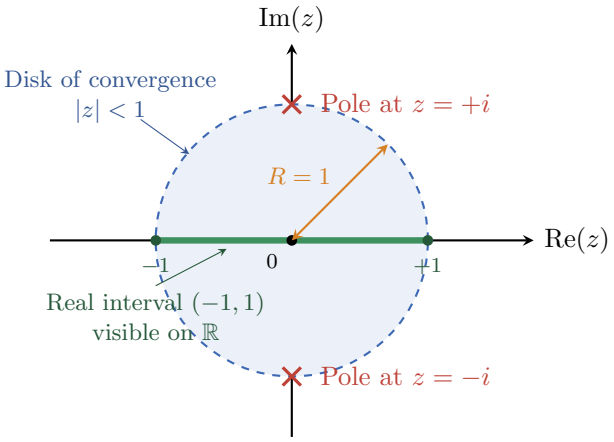


Figure 31.6: Why the Maclaurin series of $\frac{1}{1+x^2}$ halts at $|x| = 1$. Viewed over the complex plane, the function blows up at $z = \pm i$ (red crosses), where the denominator $1 + z^2$ vanishes. A power series expands outward from its center in an open circular disk until it touches the nearest singularity. That collision occurs at radius $R = 1$. The convergence interval $(-1, 1)$ on the real line is simply the one-dimensional slice where this disk intersects the real axis.

Connection

This is the bridge to complex analysis. A real power series centered at a converges on an interval $(a-R, a+R)$ (the green slice in Figure 31.6); the number R is the *radius of convergence*, and it equals the distance from a to the nearest point — real *or complex* — where the function misbehaves. The interval on the real line is just the diameter of a hidden disk in the complex plane. Once you know this, "why does this series stop converging at $x = 1$ when the function looks fine?" is never mysterious again: look for the nearest singularity off the real axis.

31.5.2 The shocking counterexample: smooth but not analytic

Recall Cauchy's flat function from Chapter 30. It draws the sharp line between "has a Taylor series" and "equals its Taylor series":

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} e^{-1/x^2}, & x \neq 0, \\ 0, & x = 0. \end{cases}$$

This function is infinitely differentiable everywhere, including at 0. But it is so flat at the origin that (as you will verify for $f'(0)$ in the exercises)

$$f(0) = f'(0) = f''(0) = \cdots = f^{(n)}(0) = \cdots = 0$$

— *every* derivative at 0 is zero. The exponential e^{-1/x^2} decays to zero faster than any power of x can detect, so the difference quotients defining each derivative all collapse to 0.

Now build the Maclaurin series. Every coefficient $\frac{f^{(k)}(0)}{k!}$ is 0, so the Taylor series is

$$0 + 0 \cdot x + 0 \cdot x^2 + \cdots = 0.$$

The series converges beautifully — to the zero function. But $f(x)$ is *not* zero for $x \neq 0$. The Taylor series converges everywhere and yet equals f only at the single point $x = 0$. Here $R_n(x) = f(x) - 0 = f(x)$ does *not* go to zero; it just sits there equal to the whole function. The remainder never shrinks because there is nothing in the polynomial to shrink toward f.

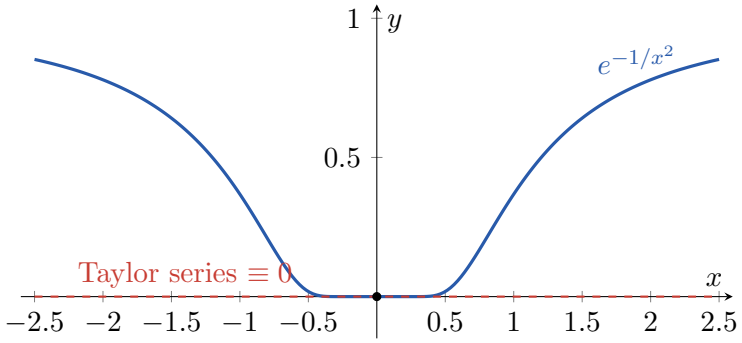


Figure 31.7: The function e^{-1/x^2} (extended by 0 at the origin) is infinitely flat at $x = 0$: every derivative there is zero. Its Taylor series is identically zero (red), and matches the function only at the single point $x = 0$. Smoothness does not guarantee that a function equals its Taylor series.

Focus

Analytic functions. A function is *analytic* at a if its Taylor series centered at a converges to the function on some interval around a — that is, if $R_n(x) \to 0$ there. Most familiar functions (e^x, sin, cos, polynomials, ln, $1/(1-x)$ away from their singularities) are analytic. The example e^{-1/x^2} shows that *infinitely differentiable is strictly weaker than analytic*: being smooth is necessary but not sufficient. Equality with the Taylor series is an additional property, and $R_n \to 0$ is the exact condition that certifies it.

Why this matters

Functions that equal their Taylor series on a neighborhood of every point in their domain are called **analytic**. Notice how rigid analytic functions are compared with merely smooth (C^∞) ones. You can smoothly splice e^{-1/x^2} onto the zero function at $x = 0$ without breaking a single derivative, so smooth functions can be modified locally without disturbing the rest of the line. Analytic functions cannot be patched this way: knowing all derivatives at a single point fixes the Taylor series — and therefore the function itself — across the entire interval of convergence.

31.6 Physics lives in the first two terms

Many classic models in physics come down to a single move: keep the first nonvanishing Taylor term, drop the higher-order terms, and solve the resulting equation. Controlled truncation is often what makes the underlying physical behavior clear.

31.6.1 The small-angle approximation

The pendulum equation, the bending of light, the behavior of a vibrating string — all of them simplify enormously the moment you replace $\sin\theta$ by its first Taylor term. From the series

$$\sin\theta = \theta - \frac{\theta^3}{6} + \frac{\theta^5}{120} - \cdots,$$

for small θ we keep just the leading term:

$$\sin\theta \approx \theta \qquad (\theta \text{ in radians}).$$

The remainder bound tells you exactly when this is safe. The first dropped term is $\theta^3/6$, and (using $|f^{(3)}| \le 1$) the Lagrange remainder for the degree-1 approximation is at most $\frac{|\theta|^3}{6}$. At $\theta = 0.1$ rad (about $5.7°$), the error is below $\frac{(0.1)^3}{6} \approx 1.7 \times 10^{-4}$ — a relative error well under two tenths of a percent. This single approximation is why the pendulum has a period $T = 2\pi\sqrt{L/g}$ *independent of amplitude*: replacing $\sin\theta$ by θ turns the true (hard) pendulum equation into the simple harmonic oscillator, whose period does not depend on how far it swings. The famous result is an artifact of truncating a Taylor series at the first term.

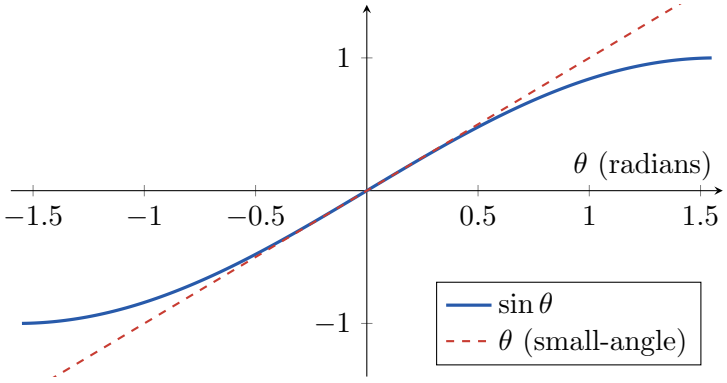


Figure 31.8: The small-angle approximation $\sin\theta \approx \theta$. Near the origin the line $y = \theta$ and the curve $y = \sin\theta$ are nearly indistinguishable; the gap grows like $\theta^3/6$, so it stays tiny while θ is small.

Application

The same "first nonvanishing term" logic runs through physics:

- **Relativistic energy.** The exact kinetic energy is $E = mc^2\big(\frac{1}{\sqrt{1-v^2/c^2}} - 1\big)$. Expanding the square root for small v/c gives $E \approx \frac{1}{2}mv^2 + \frac{3}{8}\frac{mv^4}{c^2} + \cdots$. The first term is Newton's $\frac{1}{2}mv^2$ — so classical kinetic energy is just the leading Taylor term of the relativistic one. The next term is the first relativistic correction.
- **Potential wells.** Near a stable equilibrium x_0, any smooth potential $V(x)$ has $V'(x_0) = 0$, so its Taylor expansion begins $V(x) \approx V(x_0) + \frac{1}{2}V''(x_0)(x - x_0)^2$. The quadratic term is an osculating parabola: *every* smooth potential well behaves locally like a harmonic oscillator.

In each case the Taylor remainder is the auditor that tells you when the approximation may be trusted and when the next term must be restored.

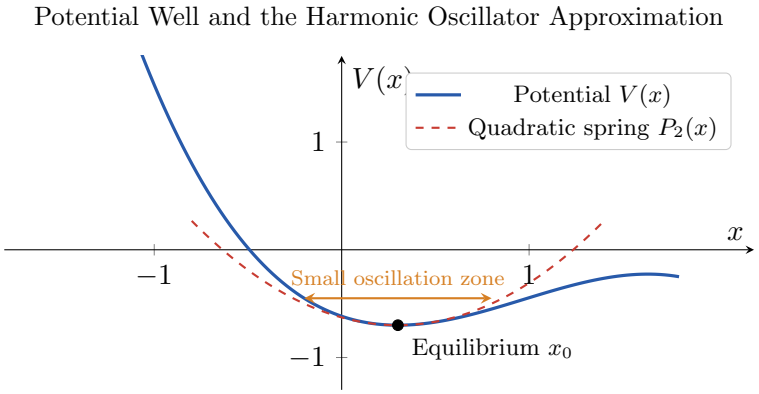


Figure 31.9: Why springs rule classical physics. Near any stable equilibrium x_0, the potential $V(x)$ has $V'(x_0) = 0$. The leading non-constant Taylor term is quadratic: $V(x) \approx V(x_0) + \frac{1}{2}V''(x_0)(x-x_0)^2$. To a particle confined to small oscillations around the trough, the true potential is indistinguishable from a parabola — an effective Hooke's-law spring with constant $k = V''(x_0)$.

Walking question

Walk and turn this over: why is it the *second* derivative that governs the behavior of a system near equilibrium, never the first? (Hint: equilibrium means the first derivative of the potential is zero, so the first surviving Taylor term is the quadratic one — and a quadratic potential is exactly a spring. Stability is $V'' > 0$; instability is $V'' < 0$.) What would a system look like if V'' also vanished and the leading term were quartic?

31.7 Worked examples, start to finish

Example 31.1 (Estimating $\sqrt{e}$ with a guarantee)**.** Approximate $\sqrt{e} = e^{0.5}$ using the degree-3 Maclaurin polynomial of e^x and bound the error.

The polynomial is $P_3(x) = 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2} + \frac{x^3}{6}$. At $x = 0.5$,

$$P_3(0.5) = 1 + 0.5 + \frac{0.25}{2} + \frac{0.125}{6} = 1 + 0.5 + 0.125 + 0.020\overline{83} = 1.645\overline{83}.$$

For the error, $f^{(4)}(x) = e^x$ and on $[0, 0.5]$ we have $e^t \le e^{0.5} < 1.65$, so take $M = 1.65$. Then

$$|R_3(0.5)| \le \frac{1.65}{4!}(0.5)^4 = \frac{1.65}{24} \cdot 0.0625 \approx 0.0043.$$

So $\sqrt{e} \in [1.6458 - 0.0043,\ 1.6458 + 0.0043] = [1.6415,\ 1.6501]$. The true value is $\sqrt{e} = 1.64872\ldots$, inside the interval, with actual error ≈ 0.0029 — under the promised 0.0043.

Example 31.2 (A Taylor expansion not centered at 0)**.** Approximate $\ln(1.2)$ by expanding $\ln x$ about $a = 1$.

The derivatives of $f(x) = \ln x$ are $f'(x) = x^{-1}$, $f''(x) = -x^{-2}$, $f'''(x) = 2x^{-3}$, so at $a = 1$: $f(1) = 0$, $f'(1) = 1$, $f''(1) = -1$, $f'''(1) = 2$. The degree-2 polynomial is

$$P_2(x) = 0 + 1 \cdot (x-1) + \frac{-1}{2}(x-1)^2 = (x-1) - \tfrac{1}{2}(x-1)^2.$$

At $x = 1.2$, with $(x-1) = 0.2$:

$$P_2(1.2) = 0.2 - \tfrac{1}{2}(0.04) = 0.2 - 0.02 = 0.18.$$

For the error, $f'''(x) = 2x^{-3}$ and on $[1, 1.2]$ this is largest at $x = 1$, where it equals 2, so $M = 2$. Then

$$|R_2(1.2)| \le \frac{2}{3!}(0.2)^3 = \frac{2}{6}(0.008) \approx 0.00267.$$

The true value $\ln(1.2) = 0.18232\ldots$ differs from 0.18 by 0.00232, inside the bound. Notice we expanded about 1, not 0, because ln is undefined at 0 — you center where the function is friendly and where you know the derivatives.

Example 31.3 (Reading off a limit from the first surviving term)**.** Evaluate $\lim_{x\to 0} \dfrac{x - \sin x}{x^3}$ using Taylor expansion.

Expand the numerator: $\sin x = x - \frac{x^3}{6} + \frac{x^5}{120} - \cdots$, so

$$x - \sin x = \frac{x^3}{6} - \frac{x^5}{120} + \cdots.$$

Divide by x^3:

$$\frac{x - \sin x}{x^3} = \frac{1}{6} - \frac{x^2}{120} + \cdots \xrightarrow[x\to 0]{} \frac{1}{6}.$$

The limit is $\frac{1}{6}$. This is the same answer L'Hôpital's rule gives after three differentiations, but Taylor expansion makes the mechanism transparent: the numerator's first nonzero term is $x^3/6$, and dividing by x^3 exposes its coefficient. Taylor series turn many delicate limits into bookkeeping of leading terms.

Connection

Example 31.3 reflects a universal computational principle. Whenever you face a 0/0 limit, expanding numerator and denominator in Taylor series and comparing their lowest surviving powers resolves it cleanly — and reveals exactly *why* L'Hôpital's rule works at all. L'Hôpital differentiates to peel away vanishing orders one at a time; Taylor expansion exposes all orders at once. Near a zero, every smooth function behaves like its lowest nonvanishing Taylor term.

31.8 What to carry away

Taylor's theorem turns polynomial approximation from a qualitative picture into a quantitative tool with explicit error bounds.

First, **matching derivatives is the universal blueprint**. The degree-n Taylor polynomial $P_n(x) = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \frac{f^{(k)}(a)}{k!}(x-a)^k$ is the unique polynomial of degree n matching the value and the first n derivatives of f at the anchor point a. The factorials in the denominators are the exact antidotes to the cascade of powers pulled down by repeated differentiation.

Second, **Taylor's theorem makes the gap exact**. By writing $f(x) = P_n(x) + R_n(x)$, we convert approximation into an exact identity. The Lagrange form of the remainder,

$$R_n(x) = \frac{f^{(n+1)}(c)}{(n+1)!}\,(x-a)^{n+1},$$

shows that the error is simply the very next Taylor term, evaluated at an intermediate point c between a and x. This generalizes the Mean Value Theorem: where the MVT balances average slope with instantaneous slope through one point, Taylor's theorem balances a polynomial approximation with the curve through the $(n+1)$-st derivative.

Third, **practical bounds require only a ceiling, not the mystery point** c. The error bound $|R_n(x)| \le \frac{M}{(n+1)!}|x-a|^{n+1}$ demands only an upper bound M on the next derivative over the interval. When the derivatives stay uniformly bounded, as for e^x, $\sin x$, and $\cos x$ on any fixed interval, the factorial in the denominator outgrows the power $|x-a|^{n+1}$ and additional terms drive the error to zero. This simple bound certifies calculator digits and guarantees numerical stability.

Fourth, **smoothness does not guarantee infinite reconstruction**. An infinite Taylor series equals its generating function if and only if the remainder vanishes: $\lim_{n\to\infty} R_n(x) = 0$. For rational functions like $\frac{1}{1+x^2}$, convergence halts at a finite radius because of singularities hiding off the real axis in the complex plane. And for Cauchy's flat function e^{-1/x^2}, every derivative at the origin is zero, so the series is identically zero and tells us nothing about the function away from the origin. Only *analytic* functions are locally determined by their Taylor series.

31.8.1 Looking forward: multivariable calculus

Up to this point, calculus has operated in one dimension: functions $y = f(x)$ took a single input and returned a single output. In Chapter 32, we move to functions of several variables, where inputs are points in the plane or in space, graphs become surfaces, and derivatives measure rates of change along multiple directions.

31.9 Exercises

Exercise 31.1. Find the degree-3 Maclaurin polynomial of $f(x) = e^x \cos x$ by computing $f(0)$, $f'(0)$, $f''(0)$, and $f'''(0)$ directly. Confirm that the result matches $1 + x - \frac{x^3}{3}$.

Exercise 31.2. Use the degree-2 Taylor polynomial of $\sqrt{x}$ centered at $a = 4$ to estimate $\sqrt{4.2}$. Then use the Lagrange remainder to bound the error, and compare with a calculator value.

Exercise 31.3. The small-angle approximation $\sin\theta \approx \theta$ is used for $\theta = 10°$. Convert to radians, and use the remainder bound $|R_1(\theta)| \le |\theta|^3/6$ to find the maximum possible error. Is the approximation good to three decimal places?

Exercise 31.4. How many terms of the Maclaurin series for $\cos x$ are needed to compute $\cos(1)$ with error less than 10^{-8}? Justify with the Lagrange bound, then state the polynomial you would use.

Exercise 31.5. Use Taylor expansions to evaluate $\displaystyle\lim_{x\to 0} \frac{e^x - 1 - x}{x^2}$. Identify the first surviving term of the numerator and read off the answer.

Exercise 31.6 (Conceptual)**.** A classmate says, "If a function is infinitely differentiable, its Taylor series must converge to it." Give the counterexample from this chapter and explain in one or two sentences exactly which step of that reasoning fails.

Exercise 31.7 (Conceptual)**.** The Maclaurin series of $\frac{1}{1-x}$ is $1 + x + x^2 + \cdots$, with radius of convergence 1. Explain why 1 is the radius, both from the real-line behavior of the function and from the location of its singularity. Then predict the radius of convergence of the Maclaurin series of $\frac{1}{4+x^2}$ without computing the series, and justify your prediction.

Exercise 31.8 (Proof)**.** Prove the integral form of the remainder: if $f^{(n+1)}$ is continuous on the interval between a and x, then

$$R_n(x) = \frac{1}{n!}\int_a^x f^{(n+1)}(t)\,(x-t)^n\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

(Hint: start from $f(x)-f(a) = \int_a^x f'(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$ and integrate by parts repeatedly, choosing the antiderivative of 1 to be $-(x-t)$ so the powers build up. This is the cleanest remainder of all, and the Lagrange form follows from it by the weighted Mean Value Theorem for integrals, since $(x-t)^n$ keeps one sign.)

Exercise 31.9 (Proof)**.** Show that for $f(x) = e^{-1/x^2}$ (with $f(0) = 0$), the first derivative at 0 is $f'(0) = 0$. (Compute $\lim_{h\to 0} \frac{e^{-1/h^2}}{h}$ by substituting $u = 1/h^2 \to \infty$ and comparing the growth of e^u against $\sqrt{u}$.) Explain in words why the same kind of argument forces *every* derivative at 0 to vanish.

Exercise 31.10. Expand $f(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+x}}$ to degree 2 about $a = 0$ to derive the approximation $\frac{1}{\sqrt{1+x}} \approx 1 - \frac{1}{2}x + \frac{3}{8}x^2$. Use it to estimate $\frac{1}{\sqrt{1.1}}$, bound the error, and explain how this is the Taylor origin of the relativistic correction term mentioned in the chapter.

Part VII

Multivariable Calculus

Chapter 32

Functions of Several Variables and Partial Derivatives

Up through Chapter 31, where we approximated curves with Taylor polynomials, every function we studied was one-dimensional: it took a single number x and returned a single number y, and its graph was a curve in the plane with a tangent line. Most quantities in science and engineering, however, depend on several inputs at once: temperature in a room depends on three spatial coordinates and time, aircraft costs depend on hundreds of parameters, and the loss function of a neural network depends on millions of weights.

Here we step from the line onto the plane, and eventually into space. A function will now take *several* numbers as input and return one. Its graph will no longer be a curve but a *surface*. The single derivative will split into several *partial derivatives*, one for each input direction. And the simple intuition "a limit just means you can get as close as you like" will turn out to hide a genuine new subtlety, because in the plane there are infinitely many directions from which to approach a point. Almost everything you already know carries over – except that approach from two sides along a line becomes approach from every direction in the plane, and that is where the new geometry lives.

32.1 Functions of Two and Three Variables

A function of two variables is a rule that assigns to each ordered pair (x, y) a single real number $z = f(x, y)$. The set of pairs we are allowed to feed in is the *domain* (now a region in the plane $\mathbb{R}^2$, not an interval on the line), and the set of outputs is the *range*. Nothing about the *idea* of a function has changed: it is still a machine, still single-valued, still "one output per input." What changed is that the input slot is wider. It now takes a point of the plane.

Focus

A real-valued function of two variables is a map $f : D \to \mathbb{R}$ where $D \subseteq \mathbb{R}^2$. We write $z = f(x, y)$. For three variables, $f : D \to \mathbb{R}$ with $D \subseteq \mathbb{R}^3$, written $w = f(x, y, z)$. The output is always a *single number*; only the input has grown.

Here are functions you should hold in your head for the rest of the chapter.

Example 32.1 (A handful of surfaces)**.**

- $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$. The height above (x, y) is its squared distance from the origin. This is a bowl (a *paraboloid*) opening upward.
- $f(x, y) = \sqrt{1 - x^2 - y^2}$, with domain the disk $x^2 + y^2 \leq 1$. This is the upper half of the unit sphere: at the origin the height is 1, and it falls to 0 at the rim.
- $f(x, y) = x^2 - y^2$. A *saddle*: it curves up as you walk along the x-axis and down as you walk along the y-axis.
- $T(x, y, z) = \dfrac{1}{x^2 + y^2 + z^2}$, a function of three variables – think of it as the temperature near a hot point source at the origin, blazing at the center and cooling with distance.

Notice the domain is now a genuinely two-dimensional object. For $\sqrt{1 - x^2 - y^2}$ we must have $x^2 + y^2 \leq 1$, so the domain is a filled disk. For $\ln(x + y)$ we need $x + y > 0$, the open half-plane above the line $y = -x$. Sketching the domain is the first thing to do with any new multivariable function, because it tells you *where the surface lives*.

Intuition

Think of $z = f(x, y)$ as the elevation of rolling terrain. The pair (x, y) is your position on a map – east and north – and $f(x, y)$ is the *altitude* at that spot. The graph is the mountain topography itself: hills, valleys, ridges, passes. Every concept in this chapter – level curve, partial derivative, tangent plane – translates directly into what a hiker sees and feels on that terrain.

Three variables and why you cannot draw them

A function $w = f(x, y, z)$ of three variables has a graph in four-dimensional space (three coordinates for input, one for output), which cannot be drawn on a flat page. The remedy is to study three-variable functions through their *level sets* (below) and through slices, holding some inputs fixed. We will lean on two-variable functions for pictures and let the three-variable case ride along on the same algebra, because every definition we give extends to n variables by simply writing more commas.

32.2 Graphs, Level Curves, and Surfaces

There are two complementary ways to see a function of two variables. The first is the *graph*: lift each domain point (x, y) to the height $z = f(x, y)$ and look at the surface that results. The second is the *contour map*: stay flat on the domain and draw the curves where the height is constant, exactly as a topographic map encodes a mountain on a flat sheet. Cartographers solved the "draw a 3D surface on 2D paper" problem centuries before calculus needed it, and their solution – contour lines – is one of the most useful pictures in all of multivariable calculus.

Definition 32.1 (Level curve, level surface)**.** For a function $f(x, y)$ and a constant c, the *level curve* (or contour) at level c is the set of domain points where the function equals c:

$$\{(x, y) : f(x, y) = c\}.$$

For $f(x, y, z)$, the analogous set $\{(x, y, z) : f(x, y, z) = c\}$ is a *level surface*.

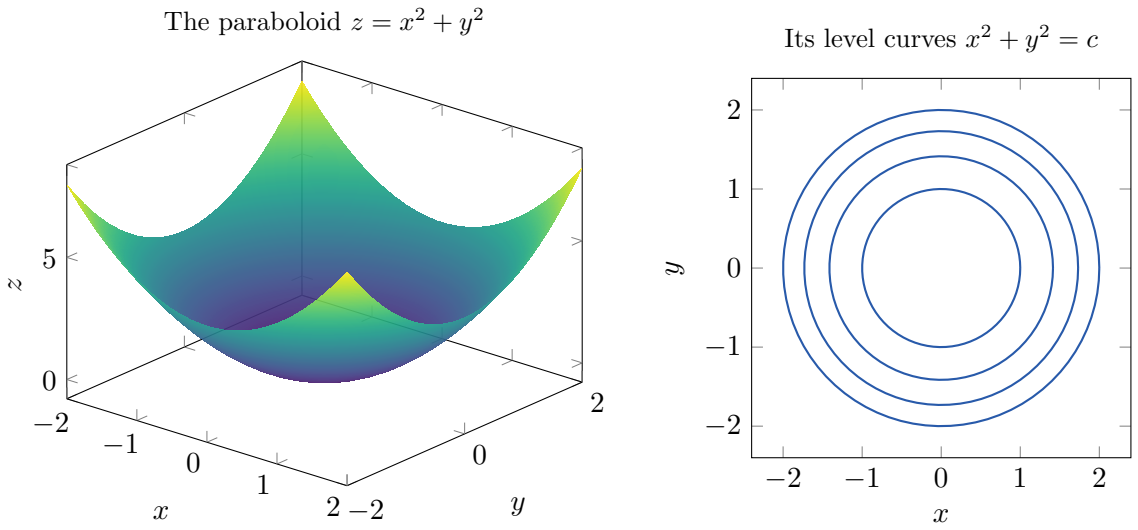


Figure 32.1: Left: the bowl $z = x^2 + y^2$ as a surface. Right: its contour map. Each circle is a level curve $x^2 + y^2 = c$; the circles are evenly spaced in height but get *closer together* as you move outward, because the bowl gets steeper. Crowded contours mean steep terrain.

Read Figure 32.1 the way a hiker reads a trail map. Each circle is a fixed altitude. Where the circles bunch up, the ground is steep; where they spread apart, it is gentle. For the bowl $x^2 + y^2 = c$, the level curve at height c is a circle of radius $\sqrt{c}$. The radii $\sqrt{1}, \sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}, \ldots$ grow more and more slowly, so equal steps in height correspond to ever-smaller steps outward – which is precisely the contours crowding together. The contour spacing *is* the steepness, encoded in flatland.

What is really happening

A level curve is a *horizontal slice* of the graph, dropped straight down onto the domain. Slice the surface $z = f(x, y)$ with the plane $z = c$; the intersection is a curve sitting at height c in space; its shadow on the floor is the level curve. So the contour map is the collection of all these shadows, one per height. Nothing is lost: from a dense enough family of contours you can reconstruct the whole surface. This is why a topographic map, though flat, tells you everything about the mountain.

Example 32.2 (Reading a saddle from its contours)**.** Take $f(x, y) = x^2 - y^2$. The level curve at c is $x^2 - y^2 = c$. For $c > 0$ these are hyperbolas opening left-right; for $c < 0$ they open up-down; and for $c = 0$ we get $x^2 = y^2$, i.e. the two lines $y = \pm x$ crossing at the origin. Whereas the contours around a peak or a valley shrink concentrically to a single point, contours that cross themselves at a critical point like this one are the signature of a saddle, where the surface rises along one direction and falls along another at the very same spot.

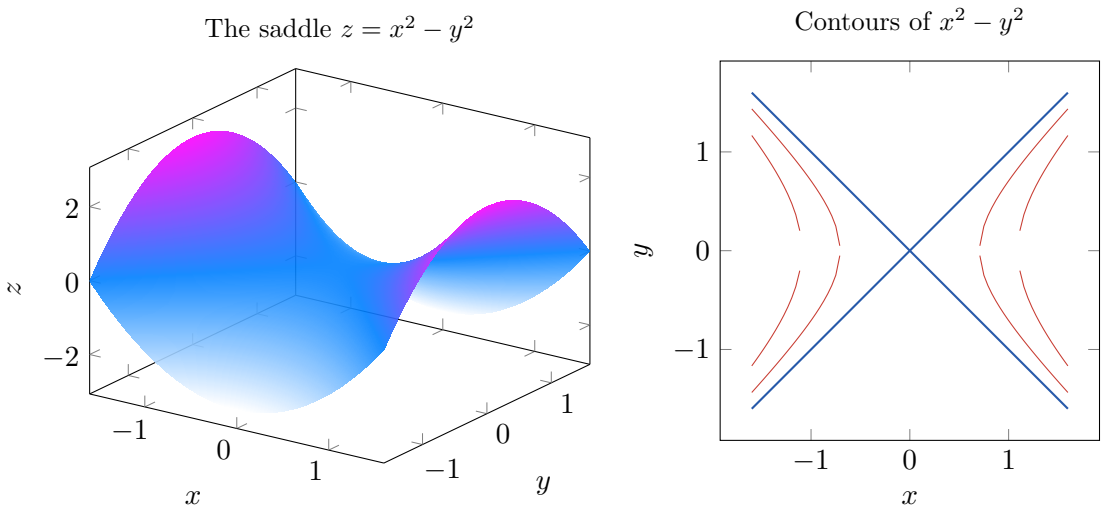


Figure 32.2: The saddle and its contours. The blue lines $y = \pm x$ are the level set $z = 0$ and cross at the saddle point; the red hyperbolas are levels $c = 0.5, 1.2$. Self-crossing contours are how a saddle announces itself on a flat map.

Walking question

On your next walk, find a mountain pass – a saddle – in your mind: the low point of a ridge between two peaks. Stand on it. Forward and backward (toward the peaks) the ground rises; left and right (down into the valleys) it falls. You are at a point that is simultaneously a *minimum* along one path and a *maximum* along another. Hold that feeling; it is the geometric heart of why finding maxima and minima in several variables is harder than in one.

Application

Level sets are everywhere once you look. Weather maps draw *isobars* (level curves of pressure) and *isotherms* (level curves of temperature). Economists draw *indifference curves*: level curves of a utility function $U(x, y)$, the combinations of two goods that leave a consumer equally happy. In machine learning, the *decision boundary* of a classifier is a level set $f(\mathbf{x}) = 0$ of the score function, separating one predicted class from another. Whenever someone says "the set of points that are equally good/hot/likely," they are naming a level set.

32.3 Limits and Continuity in Several Variables

Now we need a limit: what it means for $f(x, y)$ to approach a value L as (x, y) approaches a point (a, b). The algebraic definition looks almost identical to the one-variable version, but the geometry in the plane is much subtler.

On the line, "$x \to a$" has exactly two avenues of approach: from the left and from the right. We made peace with that using one-sided limits, and a two-sided limit existed precisely when both sides agreed. In the plane, "$(x, y) \to (a, b)$" allows approach from *every direction at once* – straight in along the x-axis, in along the y-axis, in along any line, in along a spiral, along a parabola. For the

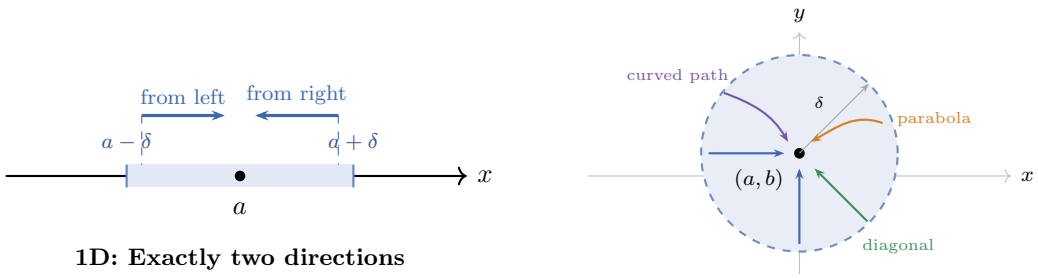
limit to exist, *all* of these infinitely many approaches must agree on the same value L. That is a far stronger demand.

Definition 32.2 (Limit of a function of two variables)**.** We say $\lim_{(x,y)\to(a,b)} f(x,y) = L$ if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a $\delta > 0$ such that

$$0 < \sqrt{(x-a)^2 + (y-b)^2} < \delta \quad \Longrightarrow \quad |f(x,y) - L| < \varepsilon.$$

In words: once (x, y) is within distance δ of (a, b) – inside a small disk around (a, b), in any direction – the output is within ε of L.

Compare this letter for letter with the one-variable ε–δ definition. The only change is that $|x-a| < \delta$, the length of an interval, has become $\sqrt{(x-a)^2 + (y-b)^2} < \delta$, the radius of a *disk*. The interval became a disk because the domain became two-dimensional. That single substitution carries all the new subtlety with it, as shown in Figure 32.3.



1D: Exactly two directions **2D: Infinitely many paths**

Figure 32.3: The leap from one variable to several. Left: On the real line, approaching a allows only two avenues – from the left and from the right – so a two-sided limit exists as soon as those two agree. Right: In the plane, approaching (a, b) requires entering a circular disk of radius δ from every conceivable direction: along horizontal or vertical axes, along diagonals, or along curved paths like parabolas. For the multivariable limit to exist, *all* of these infinitely many approaches must arrive at the exact same destination L.

Focus

The quantity $\sqrt{(x-a)^2 + (y-b)^2}$ is just the distance from (x, y) to (a, b). The definition says: small distance forces small error, *regardless of direction*. The δ-disk has no preferred direction, which is exactly why the limit must come out the same no matter how you approach.

The two-path test: how multivariable limits fail

Here is the practical consequence, and it is the single most important computational fact in this section. If you can find *two* paths into (a, b) that give two *different* limiting values, then the limit does not exist. One disagreement among the infinitely many directions is enough to destroy the limit. Agreement along finitely many paths *never* proves a limit exists — it only fails to disprove it.

Example 32.3 (The classic non-limit)**.** Consider

$$f(x,y) = \frac{xy}{x^2+y^2}, \qquad (x,y) \neq (0,0),$$

and ask whether the limit exists as $(x, y) \to (0, 0)$.

Approach along the x-axis ($y = 0$): then $f(x, 0) = \dfrac{x \cdot 0}{x^2 + 0} = 0$ for all $x \neq 0$. So along this path $f \to 0$.

Approach along the y-axis ($x = 0$): then $f(0, y) = 0$ likewise. Still 0. So far so innocent – if these were the only two paths, we might be fooled.

Approach along the diagonal $y = x$: then

$$f(x, x) = \frac{x \cdot x}{x^2 + x^2} = \frac{x^2}{2x^2} = \frac{1}{2} \quad \text{for all } x \neq 0.$$

Along the diagonal the function is *constantly* $\frac{1}{2}$, no matter how close we get to the origin. The axes say 0; the diagonal says $\frac{1}{2}$. They disagree. Therefore

$$\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} \frac{xy}{x^2 + y^2} \quad \text{does not exist.}$$

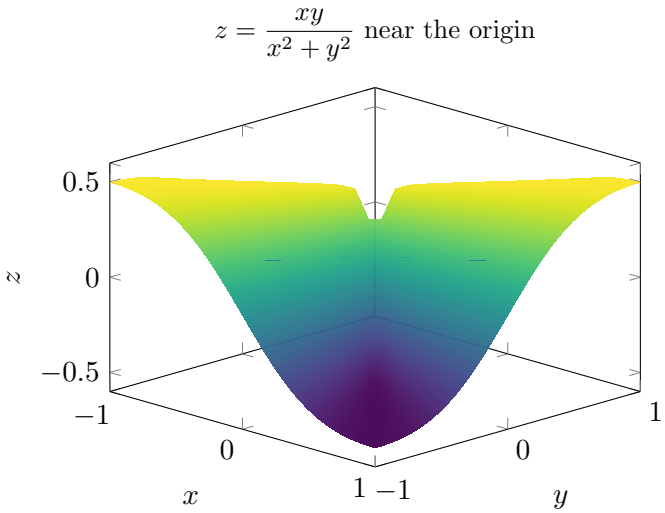


Figure 32.4: The surface $z = xy/(x^2 + y^2)$. Along the axes it sits at height 0; along the diagonals it rides at $\pm\frac{1}{2}$. The surface is pleated right at the origin – there is no single height the function settles toward, so the limit fails.

There is an even cleaner way to see the failure, straight from the contour map. Along the ray at angle θ from the origin the function $xy/(x^2 + y^2)$ is *constant*: in polar form it equals $\frac{1}{2}\sin 2\theta$, which depends on θ but not on r. So every ray into the origin carries its own fixed value, and the values disagree from one ray to the next. A function whose level sets are rays through the point you are approaching cannot have a limit there – you can read its non-existence right off Figure 32.5.

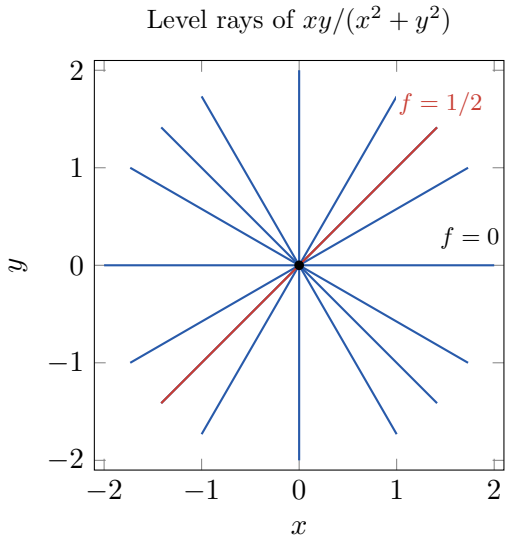


Figure 32.5: The level sets of $xy/(x^2+y^2)$ are straight rays through the origin, because the value $\frac{1}{2}\sin 2\theta$ depends only on the direction θ. The diagonal $y = x$ (red) carries the constant value $\frac{1}{2}$; the axes (horizontal/vertical) carry 0. Different rays, different values – so no single limit can exist at the origin.

Common trap

Checking a few lines does not prove a limit exists. Worse: there are functions whose limit is the same along *every straight line* through the origin and yet still fails, because some *curved* path disagrees. The standard cautionary tale is $g(x,y) = \dfrac{x^2 y}{x^4+y^2}$. Along every line $y = mx$ you get $g \to 0$. But along the parabola $y = x^2$,

$$g(x, x^2) = \frac{x^2 \cdot x^2}{x^4 + x^4} = \frac{x^4}{2x^4} = \frac{1}{2}.$$

So the line-limits all agree on 0, the parabola says $\frac{1}{2}$, and the limit does not exist. Moral: matching paths can only *disprove* a limit. To *prove* one exists you need an estimate that controls *all* directions at once, like the squeeze below.

Why the technique works

Why is the two-path test legitimate? Because the limit in Definition 32.2 demands a single L that works inside the *whole* disk. Any particular path of approach lives inside that disk, so if the full limit is L, the limit *restricted to any path* must also be L – the path inherits the bound. Contrapositive: if two paths produce two different restricted limits, no single L can serve both, so the full limit cannot exist. The test works because a path is a special case of "approaching," and the general statement, if true, forces every special case.

When the limit *does* exist: the squeeze

To prove a limit exists you must bound the error in a way that does not care about direction. Polar coordinates are the natural tool, because they package "distance from the center" into a single variable r.

Example 32.4 (A limit that exists)**.** Show that $\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} \dfrac{x^2y}{x^2+y^2} = 0$.

Write $x = r\cos\theta$, $y = r\sin\theta$, so $x^2+y^2 = r^2$ and $r \to 0$ *means* the same as $(x,y) \to (0,0)$, regardless of the angle θ. Then

$$\left|\frac{x^2y}{x^2+y^2}\right| = \left|\frac{r^2\cos^2\theta \cdot r\sin\theta}{r^2}\right| = r\,|\cos^2\theta\,\sin\theta| \le r.$$

The angle dropped out of the bound: whatever direction θ you came in along, the size is at most r. As $r \to 0$ this is squeezed to 0. So the limit is 0, and now we mean it for *all* approaches at once. (Concretely, given $\varepsilon > 0$, take $\delta = \varepsilon$; then distance $r < \delta$ forces the value within ε of 0.)

The contrast between Examples 32.3 and 32.4 illustrates the main lesson. In the bad case the angle θ survived ($f = \frac{1}{2}\sin 2\theta$ in polar form, genuinely depending on direction); in the good case the angle was crushed under a factor of r that goes to zero no matter what.

Definition 32.3 (Continuity)**.** A function f is *continuous* at (a,b) if (a,b) is in the domain, the limit there exists, and

$$\lim_{(x,y)\to(a,b)} f(x,y) = f(a,b).$$

From here on, we will rely on the fact that every function built from x, y, constants, and the familiar one-variable functions by adding, multiplying, dividing (where the denominator is nonzero), and composing is continuous wherever it is defined. Polynomials in x and y are continuous everywhere; $\sin(xy)$, e^{x-y}, and $\sqrt{1+x^2+y^2}$ are continuous everywhere; rational functions are continuous off their zero denominators. The pathologies above all came from a $0/0$ at a single point. Away from such points, life is calm.

Reading note

The leap to several variables happened early and informally. Leonhard Euler, in the mid-1700s, computed with functions of several variables and "partial differences" fluently, long before anyone had formulated a rigorous ε–δ definition of a limit even in *one* variable. The direction-dependent subtlety we just encountered was simply not on the eighteenth-century radar; mathematicians computed slopes along coordinate lines and produced successful models for fluid flow and vibrating sound. The disquieting counterexamples – such as functions continuous along every straight line yet failing to be continuous at a point – were discovered in the late nineteenth century by analysts seeking rock-solid foundations. Such counterexamples show why continuity must be defined on full δ-disks rather than along individual lines.

32.4 Partial Derivatives: Slopes in the Coordinate Directions

Now we differentiate. In one variable the derivative measured one slope: how fast y changes as x changes. On a surface there is no single slope, because the answer depends on which way you walk.

Walk east and the ground may rise; walk north and it may fall. So we measure slope *one direction at a time*, starting with the two coordinate directions. That is the partial derivative, and it reduces directly to ordinary one-variable differentiation.

Intuition

To find how the surface tilts in the x-direction at a point, *freeze* y. Holding y constant turns $f(x, y)$ back into an ordinary one-variable function of x alone – a single curve carved out of the surface by the vertical plane $y = \text{const}$. Differentiate that curve the old way. The result is the partial derivative with respect to x. To get the y-direction, freeze x instead. The partial derivative is simply the one-variable derivative, applied along one axis with the other coordinate held still.

Definition 32.4 (Partial derivatives)**.** The *partial derivative of f with respect to x* at (a, b) is

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}(a, b) \;=\; \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(a + h,\, b) - f(a, b)}{h},$$

and with respect to y,

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(a, b) \;=\; \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(a,\, b + h) - f(a, b)}{h},$$

whenever the limits exist. We also write f_x and f_y for these.

In the first formula, only the *first* coordinate varies: $a + h$ in the x-place, the y-place glued at b. It is exactly the one-variable difference quotient, run on the function $x \mapsto f(x, b)$. The curly ∂ (d's rounder cousin) is the only new symbol, and it means precisely "derivative while the other variables are held fixed."

What is really happening

The notation ∂ is doing real work. The plain d in $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ promised that y depended on *only* x. Here f depends on both x and y, so we cannot ask for "the" rate of change of f – there isn't one. The rounded ∂ is a flag: it says *"rate of change of f as x varies, with every other variable held constant."* The symbol $\partial f/\partial x$ is a single indivisible object; the "∂f" and "∂x" on their own are not quantities you may cancel. The notation was introduced by Legendre in 1786 and made standard by Jacobi in the 1840s, exactly so that nobody would mistake a partial rate for a total one.

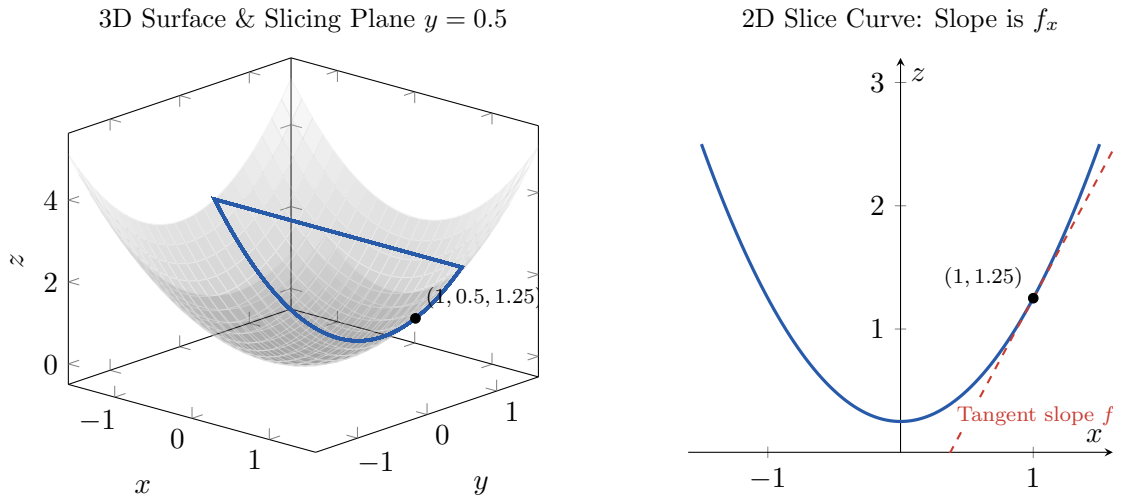


Figure 32.6: The geometric essence of a partial derivative: slicing a surface with a coordinate plane. Left: The vertical plane $y = 0.5$ slices through the paraboloid $z = x^2 + y^2$, holding y fixed and carving out a curve in space. Right: Viewed straight on in the slice plane, that curve is the ordinary single-variable parabola $z(x) = x^2 + 0.25$. The partial derivative $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}(1, 0.5) = 2$ is simply the slope of the tangent line to this cross-sectional curve.

Work it yourself

Compute f_x and f_y for $f(x, y) = x^2+y^2$ at $(1, 0.5)$ by hand, from the definition, before reading on.
For f_x: hold $y = 0.5$, so $f(x, 0.5) = x^2 + 0.25$, whose derivative is $2x$; at $x = 1$ that is **2**.
For f_y: hold $x = 1$, so $f(1, y) = 1 + y^2$, derivative $2y$; at $y = 0.5$ that is **1**. So the bowl tilts upward twice as steeply in the x-direction (slope 2) as in the y-direction (slope 1) at that point – precisely the slope of 2 captured by the tangent line on the $y = 0.5$ cross-section in Figure 32.6.

Computing partials in practice

You almost never go back to the limit definition. The trick is the one your intuition already gave you: **to differentiate with respect to x, treat y as a constant** and apply all your one-variable rules. Then swap roles for y.

Example 32.5 (Treat the other variable as a number)**.** Let $f(x, y) = x^3y^2 + \sin(xy) + 4y$.

With respect to x (so y is a constant):

$$f_x = 3x^2y^2 + \cos(xy) \cdot y + 0 = 3x^2y^2 + y\cos(xy).$$

The x^3 differentiated to $3x^2$ while y^2 rode along as a constant multiplier; the chain rule on $\sin(xy)$ produced $\cos(xy)$ times the x-derivative of the inside, $\partial(xy)/\partial x = y$; and the lone $4y$, constant with respect to x, differentiated to 0.

With respect to y (so x is a constant):

$$f_y = x^3 \cdot 2y + \cos(xy) \cdot x + 4 = 2x^3y + x\cos(xy) + 4.$$

Now x^3 was the constant multiplier, $y^2 \mapsto 2y$, the inside derivative is $\partial(xy)/\partial y = x$, and $4y \mapsto 4$. Notice how each variable's computation is a completely ordinary single-variable problem.

Example 32.6 (Three variables, same idea)**.** Let $g(x, y, z) = x^2 e^{yz}$. Then, freezing the other two each time,

$$g_x = 2x\, e^{yz}, \qquad g_y = x^2 z\, e^{yz}, \qquad g_z = x^2 y\, e^{yz}.$$

For g_y we held x and z fixed, so e^{yz} has z as the constant multiplying y in the exponent, giving the factor z; symmetrically for g_z. Three variables, three partials, each a one-liner.

Common trap

Two slips to guard against. First, do not forget the chain-rule factor when the other variable sits *inside* a composite. In $\sin(xy)$, differentiating with respect to x gives $y\cos(xy)$, not $\cos(xy)$ – the inside xy has x-derivative y. Second, do not kill a term too eagerly: in f_x, a term like $4y$ vanishes (it is constant in x), but a term like $4xy$ does *not* – it becomes $4y$. "Constant in x" means *no x appears at all*, not merely that a y appears.

Application

Partial derivatives are the language of sensitivity. In thermodynamics, pressure, volume, and temperature are tangled together, and physicists write $(\partial P/\partial V)_T$ – "how pressure responds to volume *at fixed temperature*" – with the held variable in a subscript precisely because the answer changes if you hold something else fixed instead. In economics, $\partial(\text{output})/\partial(\text{labor})$ at fixed capital is the *marginal product of labor*. In training a neural network, every weight w_i gets its own partial $\partial(\text{loss})/\partial w_i$; the list of all of them is the gradient, and backpropagation computes all of these millions of partials in a single backward pass, at roughly the cost of evaluating the network once.

32.5 Higher Partial Derivatives and Clairaut's Theorem

A partial derivative f_x is itself a function of x and y, so we can differentiate it again. This gives *second-order partial derivatives*, and now there is a genuine choice: we can differentiate first by x then by y, or first by y then by x. The notation, read inner-to-outer in the operator form, is

$$f_{xx} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\right) = \frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x^2}, \qquad f_{yy} = \frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial y^2},$$

$$f_{xy} = \frac{\partial}{\partial y}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\right) = \frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial y\,\partial x}, \qquad f_{yx} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\right) = \frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x\,\partial y}.$$

Common trap

The order conventions are maddening but standard. In the *subscript* form f_{xy} you read left to right: first x, then y. In the *fraction* form $\partial^2 f/\partial y\,\partial x$ you read right to left, inside out: the ∂x next to f acts first. So f_{xy} and $\partial^2 f/(\partial y\,\partial x)$ are the *same* object. Pick one convention and translate carefully.

The two "mixed" partials f_{xy} and f_{yx} ask different-looking questions: how does the eastward slope change as you move north, versus how does the northward slope change as you move east? A priori, these rates of change need not agree. Yet under standard continuity conditions, they are always equal.

Pause

Pause and think. Before calculating mixed derivatives, ask yourself what f_{xy} and f_{yx} physically measure. If you stand on a hillside facing north and take a step east, your northward slope may change. If instead you face east and step north, does your eastward slope change by the exact same amount? It feels as though the two numbers could easily disagree on an uneven hill. Why should two perpendicular directions always report identical twists?

Example 32.7 (The mixed partials match)**.** Take $f(x,y) = x^3y^2$. Then

$$f_x = 3x^2y^2, \qquad f_{xy} = \frac{\partial}{\partial y}\left(3x^2y^2\right) = 6x^2y,$$

$$f_y = 2x^3y, \qquad f_{yx} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(2x^3y\right) = 6x^2y.$$

Both routes land on $6x^2y$. Differentiating in the order x-then-y gave the same thing as y-then-x. Try it on $\sin(xy)$ or $e^x \cos y$ and the mixed partials match there too, for a general reason.

Theorem 32.1 (Clairaut / Schwarz)**.** *If f_{xy} and f_{yx} are both continuous on an open region containing (a,b), then*

$$f_{xy}(a,b) = f_{yx}(a,b).$$

The order of mixed partial differentiation does not matter.

Intuition

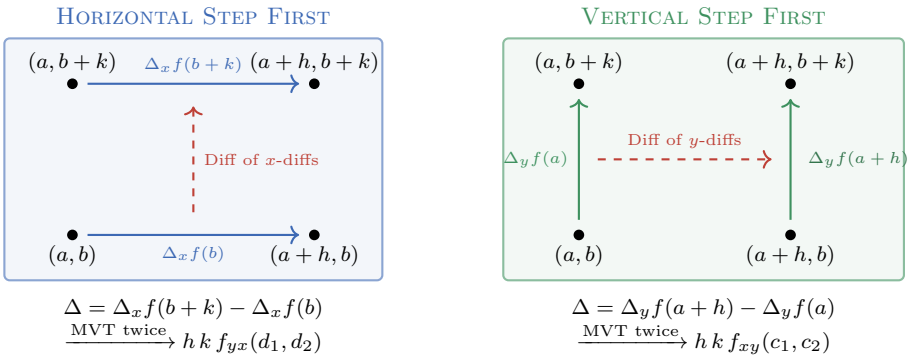
Why *should* order not matter? Picture a tiny rectangle with corners (a,b), $(a+h,b)$, $(a,b+k)$, $(a+h,b+k)$. Form the "second difference" of f around the rectangle: take the change across the top minus the change across the bottom,

$$\Delta = \big[f(a+h,b+k) - f(a,b+k)\big] - \big[f(a+h,b) - f(a,b)\big].$$

Group it the other way – change up the right side minus change up the left side – and you get *exactly the same four terms*, just reassociated:

$$\Delta = \big[f(a+h,b+k) - f(a+h,b)\big] - \big[f(a,b+k) - f(a,b)\big].$$

Divide the first grouping by h and let $h \to 0$: each bracket becomes an x-slope, so the difference measures how the x-slope changes from b to $b+k$; dividing by k then gives f_{xy}. The second grouping, read the same way, gives f_{yx}. But both were always the same number $\Delta/(hk)$. The symmetry of the mixed partials is just the symmetry of a rectangle – top-then-side equals side-then-top – pushed to the limit.



$$\Delta = f(a+h, b+k) - f(a+h, b) - f(a, b+k) + f(a, b) \text{ in both groupings} \implies \lim_{h,k\to 0} f_{xy} = f_{yx}.$$

Figure 32.7: Why mixed partials commute: the second difference on a coordinate rectangle. Left: writing Δ as a y-difference of horizontal x-steps and applying the Mean Value Theorem from the outside in (first in y, then in x) yields $hk\,f_{yx}(d_1, d_2)$. Right: writing it as an x-difference of vertical y-steps and applying the Mean Value Theorem first in x, then in y, yields $hk\,f_{xy}(c_1, c_2)$. Because both corner sums are identical, continuity forces $f_{xy} = f_{yx}$ as the rectangle shrinks.

Why the technique works

Here is the idea of the proof made rigorous. Define the second difference $\Delta(h, k)$ above. Apply the one-variable Mean Value Theorem twice. Group Δ as a difference in x of the y-difference: the function $\phi(x) = f(x, b+k) - f(x, b)$ satisfies $\Delta = \phi(a+h) - \phi(a) = h\,\phi'(c_1)$ for some c_1 between a and $a+h$, and $\phi'(x) = f_x(x, b+k) - f_x(x, b)$. Apply the MVT again in the y-direction to this difference: it equals $k\,f_{xy}(c_1, c_2)$ for some c_2 between b and $b+k$. So $\Delta = h\,k\,f_{xy}(c_1, c_2)$. Run the *same* argument grouping in the other order and you get $\Delta = h\,k\,f_{yx}(d_1, d_2)$. Therefore $f_{xy}(c_1, c_2) = f_{yx}(d_1, d_2)$. Now let $h, k \to 0$: all four interior points are squeezed toward (a, b), and by *continuity* of the mixed partials both sides converge to their values at (a, b), giving $f_{xy}(a, b) = f_{yx}(a, b)$. The continuity hypothesis is exactly what lets the squeeze land on a single value – without it the theorem can fail.

History

Alexis Clairaut stated the symmetry of mixed derivatives around 1740 while investigating the equilibrium shape of the spinning Earth – a problem in celestial mechanics where gravitational and centrifugal forces interact across several dimensions. Leonhard Euler and Jean le Rond d'Alembert used mixed partials freely throughout the 1740s and 1750s to model vibrating musical strings and fluid motion. At the time, mathematicians possessed only single-variable differential calculus (Leibniz's infinitesimals) and mechanical intuition. They lacked a formal ε–δ definition of a limit, had no precise notion of two-dimensional open regions, and blithely assumed that if partial derivatives existed along coordinate lines, they behaved like one-variable derivatives in every respect.

That confidence led to decades of controversy. Euler and d'Alembert clashed sharply over what curves could physically describe a plucked string: d'Alembert insisted solutions required smooth formulas, while Euler argued that a string plucked into a triangular kink with a sharp corner was physically real even if its derivatives were undefined at the peak. Simultaneously,

mathematicians treated the equation $\partial^2 f/\partial x \partial y = \partial^2 f/\partial y \partial x$ as an inviolable algebraic identity, believing that the order of limits could always be interchanged. It was not until the 1870s that Hermann Schwarz, followed by Karl Weierstrass and Giuseppe Peano, proved that symmetry can fail when the second partials are not continuous. Counterexamples such as $f(x,y) = xy(x^2 - y^2)/(x^2 + y^2)$ (with $f(0,0) = 0$) give $f_{xy}(0,0) = -1$ while $f_{yx}(0,0) = +1$, showing that equality of mixed partials is an analytic theorem about continuity rather than an automatic rule of algebra.

Clarifying these foundations put classical field theory, thermodynamics, and fluid dynamics on firm ground. In thermodynamics, physical properties like internal energy and entropy are *state functions* – quantities that depend solely on the current state of a gas, not on how it got there. That path-independence holds mathematically if and only if the mixed partials of the thermodynamic potential agree. Today, multivariable calculus has scaled from two or three spatial dimensions to millions or billions of parameters in modern deep learning. In these high-dimensional loss functions, non-smooth activations – such as the rectified linear unit, or ReLU, which has a sharp hinge like an absolute-value function – mean that second derivatives often fail to exist or commute. Understanding optimization dynamics around saddles in non-convex multi-million-dimensional spaces remains a vibrant, open frontier of modern mathematical research.

Connection

Clairaut's theorem is the seed of a deep idea. It says the mixed partials of a smooth function agree – equivalently, that a gradient vector field (f_x, f_y) (an assignment of a little arrow of slopes to every point in the plane) has a special symmetry: $\partial_y f_x = \partial_x f_y$. In vector calculus this becomes the statement "the curl of a gradient is zero," where *curl* measures the tendency of a fluid flow to spin a tiny paddle wheel placed at that point. A vector field whose curl vanishes is *conservative* – meaning it represents a force field (like gravity) where moving a particle around any closed loop costs zero net energy, precisely because the force derives from an underlying potential energy function. That equality $f_{xy} = f_{yx}$ returns in Chapter 35 as the test for whether a planar force field comes from a potential function.

32.6 Tangent Planes

In one variable, the tangent line was the best straight-line approximation to a curve: zoom in on a smooth graph and it looks linear. Zooming in on a smooth surface works the same way, except that the flat approximation to a surface is a *plane* rather than a line. The tangent plane is the best flat approximation to the surface at a point, and the partial derivatives are precisely the two slopes that pin it down.

Intuition

Stand on the surface at the point above (a,b). You found two slopes there: $f_x(a,b)$, the tilt as you face east, and $f_y(a,b)$, the tilt as you face north. A flat plane through that point is completely determined by how steeply it rises eastward and how steeply it rises northward. Match those two slopes to the surface's two slopes and you have the unique plane that approximates the surface – the tangent plane. East-slope and north-slope are exactly

enough data to fix a plane, which is why *two* partials suffice.

A plane through the point $(a, b, f(a, b))$ has the form

$$z = f(a, b) + A\,(x - a) + B\,(y - b),$$

where A is its slope in the x-direction and B its slope in the y-direction. To be tangent, those slopes must equal the surface's slopes: $A = f_x(a, b)$ and $B = f_y(a, b)$. That gives the formula.

Focus

Tangent plane. If f has continuous partials near (a, b), the tangent plane to $z = f(x, y)$ at the point $\big(a, b, f(a, b)\big)$ is

$$\boxed{z = f(a, b) + f_x(a, b)\,(x - a) + f_y(a, b)\,(y - b)}.$$

The right-hand side is the *linearization* $L(x, y)$ of f at (a, b): the best linear approximation, just as the tangent line was in one variable.

What is really happening

Compare this with the one-variable tangent line $y = f(a) + f'(a)(x - a)$ – which we saw in Chapter 31 as the first-order Taylor approximation $P_1(x)$. The structure is identical: value at the base point, plus slope times displacement. We simply have *two* displacement terms now, one per input direction, each weighted by its own partial derivative. The tangent plane is two tangent lines – the slice-curves of Figure 32.6 – spanned into a flat sheet. "Differentiable at (a, b)" means that this plane really is an excellent approximation: the surface peels away from the plane faster than you walk, so the error shrinks faster than the distance $\sqrt{(x - a)^2 + (y - b)^2}$. (Beware: in several variables the mere *existence* of f_x and f_y is not enough to guarantee this – continuity of the partials is the clean condition that does.)

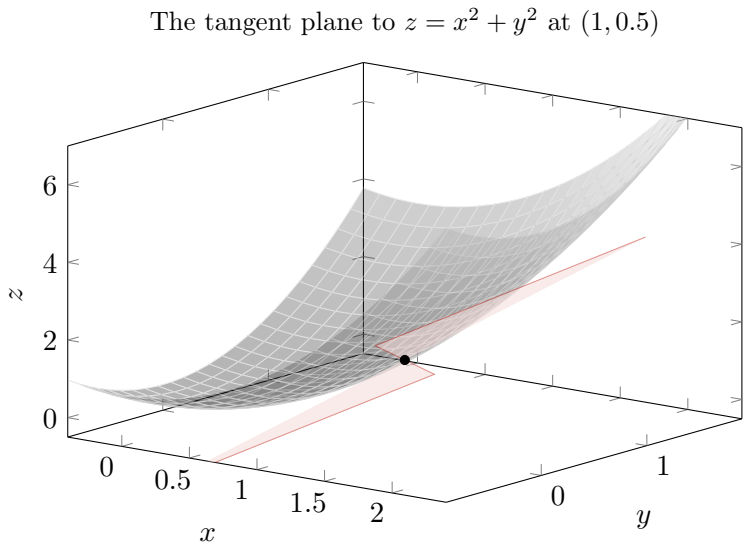


Figure 32.8: The bowl and its tangent plane at $(1, 0.5, 1.25)$. The plane has x-slope $f_x = 2$ and y-slope $f_y = 1$, matching the two slice-slopes from Figure 32.6. It touches the surface at one point and is the surface's best linear approximation nearby.

Example 32.8 (Building a tangent plane)**.** Find the tangent plane to $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$ at $(1, 0.5)$.

We already have $f(1, 0.5) = 1 + 0.25 = 1.25$, and from the lab box $f_x(1, 0.5) = 2$, $f_y(1, 0.5) = 1$. Plug in:

$$z = 1.25 + 2(x - 1) + 1\,(y - 0.5) = 2x + y - 1.25.$$

That is the plane in Figure 32.8.

Example 32.9 (Linear approximation in action)**.** Use the tangent plane to estimate $f(1.1, 0.45)$ for $f = x^2 + y^2$ without squaring anything. The linearization is $L(x, y) = 2x + y - 1.25$, so

$$L(1.1, 0.45) = 2(1.1) + 0.45 - 1.25 = 2.2 + 0.45 - 1.25 = 1.40.$$

The true value is $1.1^2 + 0.45^2 = 1.21 + 0.2025 = 1.4125$. The linear estimate 1.40 is off by only 0.0125 – excellent for a step of about a tenth, and a perfect echo of how tangent lines estimated $\sqrt{4.1}$ back in the one-variable chapter. The whole machinery of differentials and linear approximation survives the jump to several variables; it just acquires a second slope term.

Why this matters

The linear approximation generalizes directly across dimensions. In Chapter 31, Taylor's theorem began with the degree-one linear polynomial: $P_1(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x - a)$. In two variables, that linear approximation is the tangent plane: $L(x, y) = f(a, b) + f_x(a, b)\,(x - a) + f_y(a, b)\,(y - b)$. In three variables, it is a tangent hyperplane: $f(a, b, c) + f_x(x - a) + f_y(y - b) + f_z(z - c)$. The pattern continues consistently, adding one linear slope term per dimension. Knowing rates of change due east (f_x) and due north (f_y) raises a natural question: what about arbitrary directions? In Chapter 33, these separate partial derivatives assemble into the *gradient vector* $\nabla f = (f_x, f_y, f_z)$. With the gradient, directional derivatives become simple dot products, the chain rule extends to paths, and linearization takes the vector form $f(\mathbf{a}) + \nabla f(\mathbf{a}) \cdot (\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{a})$.

32.7 Exercises

Exercise 32.1 (Warm-up mental checks)**.** Test your immediate geometric and algebraic intuition with these quick mental checks (no scratch paper required):

(a) At the point $(x, y) = (1, 2)$, what is $\frac{\partial}{\partial x}(x^3y^4)$? (Hold $y = 2$ fixed as a constant number; differentiate $16x^3$ with respect to x).

(b) A hiker on a pass discovers that moving due east has zero slope ($\frac{\partial z}{\partial x} = 0$) and moving due north has zero slope ($\frac{\partial z}{\partial y} = 0$). Is the hiker guaranteed to be standing at a mountain peak or valley? (Think of the saddle $z = x^2 - y^2$).

(c) Suppose a classmate verifies that $\lim_{x\to 0} f(x, mx) = 0$ along every straight line of slope m. Can they conclude that $\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} f(x, y) = 0$? Which counterexample curve from this chapter refutes it?

(d) If $f(x, y) = \sin(x)e^y$, why must $\frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x\,\partial y} = \frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial y\,\partial x}$ without writing down any derivatives? Which theorem guarantees this?

Exercise 32.2 (Domains and contours)**.** For each function, describe the domain as a region in the plane and sketch three level curves.

(a) $f(x, y) = \sqrt{9 - x^2 - y^2}$.

(b) $f(x, y) = \ln(x - y)$.

(c) $f(x, y) = \dfrac{1}{x^2 + y^2}$ (what happens to the contours near the origin?).

Exercise 32.3 (Reading a saddle)**.** For $f(x, y) = y^2 - x^2$, identify the level curve at $c = 0$, at $c = 1$, and at $c = -1$. Which way does the surface rise from the origin, and which way does it fall? Sketch the contour map and mark the saddle point.

Exercise 32.4 (The two-path test)**.** Show that each limit fails to exist by finding two paths giving different values.

(a) $\displaystyle\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} \frac{x^2 - y^2}{x^2 + y^2}$.

(b) $\displaystyle\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} \frac{x^2y}{x^4 + y^2}$ (try lines, then the parabola $y = x^2$).

Exercise 32.5 (A limit that exists)**.** Using polar coordinates or a squeeze, prove that

$$\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} \frac{x^3 - y^3}{x^2 + y^2} = 0.$$

Then explain in one sentence why the angle θ disappearing from your bound is exactly what ensures the limit exists.

Exercise 32.6 (Computing partials)**.** Find f_x and f_y.

(a) $f(x, y) = x^4y - 3xy^3 + 7$.

(b) $f(x, y) = e^{xy}\sin x$.

(c) $f(x,y) = \dfrac{x}{x^2+y^2}$.

(d) $f(x,y) = \ln\bigl(x^2+y^2\bigr)$.

Exercise 32.7 (Three variables)**.** For $g(x,y,z) = x\,y^2\,z^3 + \dfrac{x}{y} - \cos(yz)$, compute all three first partials g_x, g_y, g_z.

Exercise 32.8 (Verifying Clairaut)**.** For $f(x,y) = x^2e^y + \sin(xy)$, compute f_{xy} and f_{yx} separately and confirm they agree. State explicitly where in your work you used the fact that the function is built from continuous pieces.

Exercise 32.9 (Tangent plane and estimate)**.** Let $f(x,y) = \sqrt{x^2+y^2}$ (the cone).

(a) Find the tangent plane at $(3,4)$, where $f = 5$.

(b) Use it to estimate $f(3.1, 3.9)$, and compare with the exact value.

(c) Explain why no tangent plane exists at the origin. (Hint: walk toward $(0,0)$ from two directions and look at the slopes – this is the cone's sharp tip.)

Exercise 32.10 (Conceptual: lines are not enough)**.** A student claims: "I checked that

$$\lim_{(x,y)\to(0,0)} \frac{x^2y}{x^4+y^2} = 0$$

along every straight line $y = mx$, so the multivariable limit must be 0." In a short paragraph, explain what is wrong with this conclusion, and state the curved path that refutes it.

Exercise 32.11 (Proof: Clairaut by the second difference)**.** Let $\Delta(h,k) = f(a+h,b+k) - f(a+h,b) - f(a,b+k) + f(a,b)$. Assuming f, f_x, f_y, f_{xy}, and f_{yx} are all continuous near (a,b), apply the Mean Value Theorem twice in each of the two groupings of Δ to show $f_{xy}(a,b) = f_{yx}(a,b)$. Identify the precise step where continuity of the mixed partials is needed.

Exercise 32.12 (A function continuous along every line but not at the origin)**.** Let $g(x,y) = \dfrac{x^2y}{x^4+y^2}$ for $(x,y) \neq (0,0)$ and $g(0,0) = 0$.

(a) Show g restricted to any line through the origin is continuous at the origin.

(b) Show g is nonetheless *not* continuous at the origin.

(c) In one sentence, say what this example teaches about Definition 32.3.

Chapter 33

The Gradient, Directional Derivatives, and the Chain Rule

In the last chapter we learned to take a function of several variables, freeze all but one of its inputs, and differentiate the survivor. That gave us the partial derivatives $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}$ and $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$: the slopes you feel if you walk due east or due north across rolling terrain. They are exact answers, but to only two questions. Real hills are not made of north-south and east-west walks. A river runs diagonally. A ball rolls downhill in whatever direction is steepest, which is almost never one of the axis directions. If all we can ever ask is "how steep is it if I head exactly east?" we have not yet learned to read the surface beneath our feet.

This chapter fixes that. We will learn to ask: *how fast does f change if I walk in any direction I choose?* The answer to that question, for *every* direction at once, turns out to be packaged inside a single vector – the **gradient** ∇f. It points in the direction of steepest ascent. Its length tells you how steep that steepest climb is. And it sits perpendicular to the level curves – the contour lines – of f, for a reason you will be able to see with your eyes by the end of Section 33.3. From there, the multivariable chain rule reduces to a single dot product, and linear approximation upgrades the tangent line to a tangent *plane*. Finally, *gradient descent* – the algorithm that trains nearly every modern neural network – becomes plain geometry: keep stepping in the direction of $-\nabla f$ and you walk downhill.

33.1 Walking in an Arbitrary Direction

Stand on a hillside whose height above sea level is $f(x, y)$. You are at the point (a, b). The two partial derivatives answer only two of the infinitely many walks you could take: $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\big|_{(a,b)}$ is your rate of climb heading east, $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\big|_{(a,b)}$ heading north. Now suppose you want to set off in some other direction – say northeast, or exactly 30° north of east. How steep is the ground *that* way?

Let us name the direction with a unit vector $\mathbf{u} = (u_1, u_2)$, $\|\mathbf{u}\| = 1$. Walking "in direction $\mathbf{u}$" starting from (a, b) means tracing the straight path

$$(a, b) + t\,\mathbf{u} = (a + tu_1,\ b + tu_2), \qquad t \geq 0,$$

where t is the distance you have walked (because $\mathbf{u}$ has length one, t *is* arc length). Your height

along this path is a function of the single variable t:

$$g(t) = f(a + tu_1,\ b + tu_2).$$

The slope of the ground in direction $\mathbf{u}$ is just how fast your height is changing per step taken – that is, $g'(0)$. This is exactly the rate we want.

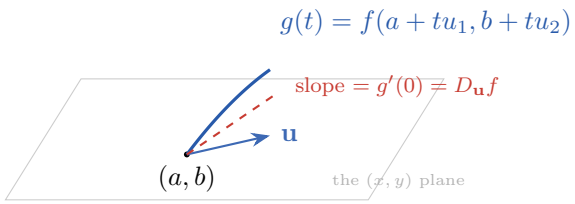


Figure 33.1: Walking from (a, b) in the unit direction $\mathbf{u}$ traces a straight line in the floor plane; the height f above that line is the single-variable function $g(t)$. Its slope at the start, $g'(0)$, is the directional derivative $D_{\mathbf{u}} f(a, b)$ – the steepness of the hillside as you set off that way.

Definition 33.1 (Directional derivative)**.** Let f be defined near (a, b) and let $\mathbf{u} = (u_1, u_2)$ be a unit vector. The **directional derivative** of f at (a, b) in the direction $\mathbf{u}$ is

$$D_{\mathbf{u}} f(a, b) \ = \ \lim_{t \to 0} \frac{f(a + tu_1,\ b + tu_2) - f(a, b)}{t},$$

provided the limit exists. It is the instantaneous rate of change of f per unit distance traveled in the direction $\mathbf{u}$.

Figure 33.1 shows the picture behind this definition: the walk in the plane, the height curve $g(t)$ above it, and the tangent slope $g'(0)$ that the limit computes. Notice the family resemblance to the ordinary derivative: numerator is "new height minus old height," denominator is "distance moved," and we let the step shrink to zero. The only new feature is that "distance moved" is now measured along a chosen compass heading.

Intuition

The partial derivatives are special directional derivatives. Take $\mathbf{u} = (1, 0)$ – walk due east – and the definition collapses to exactly the limit defining $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}$. Take $\mathbf{u} = (0, 1)$ and you get $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$. Thus $D_{\mathbf{u}} f$ collects the slopes of f in *every* unit direction $\mathbf{u}$, and the two partials are the two members of that family pointing along the axes.

Common trap

The direction vector *must* be a unit vector, $\|\mathbf{u}\| = 1$. If you feed in a vector of length 3, the limit measures change per "unit of that vector," which is change over 3 actual steps – inflating your answer by a factor of 3. Whenever someone hands you a direction like $(3, 4)$, normalize it first: $\mathbf{u} = \frac{1}{5}(3, 4)$. We will see in a moment that the clean formula $D_{\mathbf{u}} f = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}$ only measures a true slope when $\mathbf{u}$ has length one.

33.1.1 A formula instead of a limit

Computing that limit by hand for every direction would be miserable. Happily we never have to. The function $g(t) = f(a + tu_1,\ b + tu_2)$ is a composition: an outer function f of two variables, fed

by two inner functions $x(t) = a + tu_1$ and $y(t) = b + tu_2$ of the single variable t. We are about to prove a chain rule for exactly this situation, but it is worth seeing where it leads first.

If f is nice enough (Section 33.4 states the condition, and Section 33.5 explains what it means), the rate $g'(0)$ turns out to be

$$g'(0) \;=\; \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\Big|_{(a,b)} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t}\Big|_0 + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\Big|_{(a,b)} \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}\Big|_0 \;=\; f_x(a,b)\,u_1 + f_y(a,b)\,u_2.$$

Read that result slowly. The slope in direction $\mathbf{u}$ is a *weighted combination* of the two axis-slopes, weighted by how much of your step points east (u_1) and how much points north (u_2). If you head straight east, $u_1 = 1$, $u_2 = 0$, and you recover f_x. If you head northeast, you get a half-and-half blend (after normalizing). This is the linearity we have been promised all along: near a point, f behaves like a flat plane, and the slope of a plane in a diagonal direction is just the mix of its slopes along the two axes.

Focus

The directional derivative formula. For a differentiable f and a unit vector $\mathbf{u} = (u_1, u_2)$,

$$\boxed{D_{\mathbf{u}} f(a,b) = f_x(a,b)\,u_1 + f_y(a,b)\,u_2.}$$

The right-hand side is a dot product of two vectors: (f_x, f_y) and (u_1, u_2). The first of those vectors is so important it earns a name of its own – the gradient – which is the subject of the next section.

Pause and think: What happens to the directional derivative if you reverse direction and walk along $-\mathbf{u}$? Because $-\mathbf{u} = (-u_1, -u_2)$, the formula gives $D_{-\mathbf{u}} f = f_x(-u_1) + f_y(-u_2) = -D_{\mathbf{u}} f$. Walking backward downhill gives the exact negative of walking forward uphill.

Example 33.1 (A first directional derivative)**.** Let $f(x,y) = x^2 + xy$ and find the rate of change at $(1,2)$ in the direction toward $(4,6)$.

First the partials: $f_x = 2x + y$ and $f_y = x$. At $(1,2)$ these are $f_x(1,2) = 2(1)+2 = 4$ and $f_y(1,2) = 1$.

Next the direction. The displacement from $(1,2)$ to $(4,6)$ is $(3,4)$, of length $\sqrt{3^2+4^2} = 5$, so the unit direction is $\mathbf{u} = \left(\frac{3}{5}, \frac{4}{5}\right)$.

Now the formula:

$$D_{\mathbf{u}} f(1,2) = f_x\,u_1 + f_y\,u_2 = 4 \cdot \tfrac{3}{5} + 1 \cdot \tfrac{4}{5} = \tfrac{12}{5} + \tfrac{4}{5} = \tfrac{16}{5} = 3.2.$$

So if you stand at $(1,2)$ and walk toward $(4,6)$, the value of f climbs at 3.2 units per unit distance. Had we forgotten to normalize and used $(3,4)$ directly, we would have gotten $4 \cdot 3 + 1 \cdot 4 = 16$ – exactly 5 times too big, the length of the vector we failed to divide out.

Work it yourself

Take $f(x,y) = x^2 + xy$ from Example 33.1 and compute $D_{\mathbf{u}} f(1,2)$ *from the raw limit*, using $\mathbf{u} = \left(\frac{3}{5}, \frac{4}{5}\right)$ and a tiny step $t = 0.001$:

$$\frac{f(1 + 0.001 \cdot 0.6,\; 2 + 0.001 \cdot 0.8) - f(1,2)}{0.001}.$$

Work out $f(1.0006,\, 2.0008)$ and $f(1,2) = 3$ on paper, subtract, divide by 0.001. You should land very close to 3.2. Watching the limit and the formula agree – once – is worth more than ten formula-only exercises.

33.2 The Gradient Vector

We just discovered that every directional derivative is a dot product of $\mathbf{u}$ with the same fixed vector (f_x, f_y). That vector deserves its own name.

Definition 33.2 (The gradient)**.** For a function $f(x, y)$ with partial derivatives at (a, b), the **gradient** of f at (a, b) is the vector

$$\nabla f(a,b) \;=\; \Big(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\Big|_{(a,b)},\; \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\Big|_{(a,b)}\Big) \;=\; \big(f_x(a,b),\; f_y(a,b)\big).$$

The symbol ∇ is read "del" or "nabla." For a function of n variables the gradient is the n-vector of all the first partials, $\nabla f = (f_{x_1}, f_{x_2}, \ldots, f_{x_n})$.

With this name in hand the directional-derivative formula becomes a one-liner:

$$\boxed{D_{\mathbf{u}} f = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}.}$$

Every slope on the compass is obtained by dotting the single vector ∇f against the direction you choose to walk. The gradient is a complete summary of the local steepness of f in *all* directions at once – a remarkable compression. Two numbers, f_x and f_y, encode infinitely many slopes.

What is really happening

The gradient is a vector from which every directional slope is computed. A beginner often thinks "the gradient is how steep the function is." Not quite. Steepness is a single number and it depends on which way you face. The gradient is a *vector* that acts as a linear map: give it a unit direction, and it returns the slope in that direction. That is the deep meaning of the dot product $\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}$: the gradient is the row of coefficients of the best linear approximation to f, and dotting it with $\mathbf{u}$ evaluates that linear map in the direction $\mathbf{u}$. When in later study you meet "the derivative of a multivariable function is a linear map," the gradient is that map, written as a vector.

33.2.1 The direction of steepest ascent

Now comes the payoff that makes the gradient famous. We have $D_{\mathbf{u}} f = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}$, and we want to know: *of all the directions* $\mathbf{u}$ *I could walk, which one makes* f *increase fastest?* That is, which unit vector $\mathbf{u}$ maximizes the dot product $\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}$?

Recall the geometric meaning of the dot product. For any two vectors,

$$\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u} = \|\nabla f\|\, \|\mathbf{u}\| \cos\theta = \|\nabla f\| \cos\theta,$$

since $\|\mathbf{u}\| = 1$, where θ is the angle between ∇f and your direction $\mathbf{u}$. The only thing you control here is θ, and the expression is largest exactly when $\cos\theta = 1$, i.e. when $\theta = 0$ – when $\mathbf{u}$ points the *same way* as ∇f. At that choice the climb rate is $\|\nabla f\|$.

Pause and think: What is your rate of climb if you head off at an angle $\theta = 60°$ relative to the gradient? Since $\cos 60° = \frac{1}{2}$, you climb at exactly half the steepest possible rate: $D_{\mathbf{u}}f = \frac{1}{2}\|\nabla f\|$.

This leads to the following conclusion:

Focus

Steepest ascent. At any point where $\nabla f \neq \mathbf{0}$:

- The direction of *steepest ascent* is $\mathbf{u} = \nabla f/\|\nabla f\|$ – straight along the gradient.
- The maximum rate of increase is $\|\nabla f\|$ – the length of the gradient.
- The direction of *steepest descent* is the opposite, $-\nabla f$, with rate $-\|\nabla f\|$.
- In any direction *perpendicular* to ∇f ($\theta = 90°$, $\cos\theta = 0$), the rate of change is *zero*: you are walking along a level curve, neither climbing nor descending.

Intuition

Why should one special direction be steepest? Because slope in direction $\mathbf{u}$ is the *projection* of the gradient onto $\mathbf{u}$. Imagine the gradient as an arrow lying on your tabletop. As you swing your walking direction $\mathbf{u}$ around the compass, the slope you feel is the shadow that the gradient arrow casts onto your line of travel. The shadow is longest when you face straight along the arrow, shrinks as you turn away, and vanishes when you face perpendicular to it. There is nothing mysterious here once you see it as a shadow: a fixed arrow has its longest shadow along its own direction.

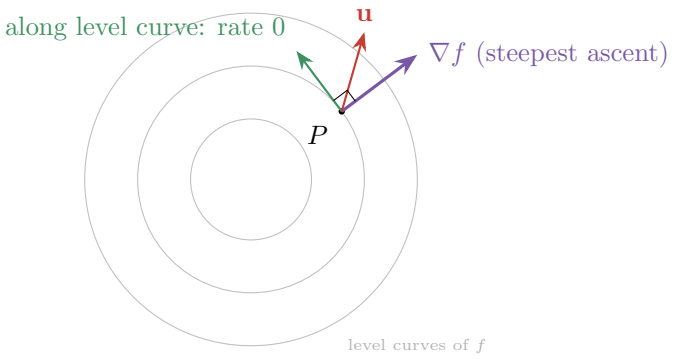


Figure 33.2: At a point P, the gradient (purple) points perpendicular to the level curve through P and aims along the steepest uphill direction. Walking along the level curve (green) keeps you at the same height: rate of change zero. Any other direction $\mathbf{u}$ (red) gives a slope between 0 and $\|\nabla f\|$.

Example 33.2 (Finding the steepest direction)**.** Let $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$, a round bowl, and consider the point $(3, 1)$.

The gradient is $\nabla f = (2x, 2y)$, so $\nabla f(3, 1) = (6, 2)$. The steepest uphill direction is along $(6, 2)$; normalized that is $\frac{1}{\sqrt{40}}(6, 2) = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{10}}(6, 2)$. The steepest climb rate is $\|(6, 2)\| = \sqrt{40} = 2\sqrt{10} \approx 6.32$

units per unit distance. To descend fastest – to roll the ball downhill – head in the direction $(-6, -2)$, straight back toward the bottom of the bowl at the origin. That matches intuition exactly: on a round bowl the steepest way down points at the center.

Walking question

You are hiking and the fog rolls in; you can see only the patch of ground at your feet. You want to reach the summit as fast as possible. You cannot see the peak, but you *can* feel, with each tentative step, which way the ground rises most steeply – that is the gradient at your feet. If you always step in the locally steepest uphill direction, are you guaranteed to reach the true summit? Think about terrain with several separate hills. (This is exactly the promise and the peril of gradient ascent, which we revisit in Section 33.6.)

33.3 Why the Gradient Is Perpendicular to Level Curves

The single most useful geometric fact about the gradient is that it stands at a right angle to the level curves of f. We stated it above; now let us *see* why it must be true, two ways: first with a picture and a one-line argument, then with the chain rule for full rigor.

A **level curve** of f is the set of points where f takes one fixed value: $f(x, y) = c$. On a topographic map these are the contour lines; on a weather map, the isobars; on the round bowl $f = x^2 + y^2$, they are circles. Walking along a level curve, by definition, keeps f constant – your height never changes.

Why the technique works

Why $\nabla f \perp$ level curves. Walking along a level curve keeps f constant, so the rate of change of f in the direction $\mathbf{u}$ *tangent to the level curve* is zero:

$$D_{\mathbf{u}} f = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0.$$

But a dot product is zero precisely when the two vectors are perpendicular. Therefore ∇f is perpendicular to the tangent of the level curve – that is, perpendicular to the level curve itself. The mechanism is exactly the steepest ascent picture run sideways: the directions of *zero* change are perpendicular to the gradient, and those are exactly the directions that keep you on a contour. Steepest ascent is therefore perpendicular to "no change," which is why the gradient crosses every contour at a right angle.

Let us make the "rate is zero along a level curve" step airtight using the chain rule, which also previews the next section. Parametrize the level curve as a path $\mathbf{r}(t) = (x(t), y(t))$ that stays on it, so $f(x(t), y(t)) = c$ for all t. Differentiate both sides with respect to t. The left side is a composition; its derivative (by the chain rule we prove in Section 33.4) is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} f\big(x(t), y(t)\big) = f_x\, x'(t) + f_y\, y'(t) = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{r}\,'(t).$$

The right side is the constant c, whose derivative is 0. Hence

$$\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{r}\,'(t) = 0.$$

But $\mathbf{r}\,'(t)$ is the velocity vector – it points *along* the level curve, tangent to it. A zero dot product with the tangent means ∇f is perpendicular to the curve at every point. Done.

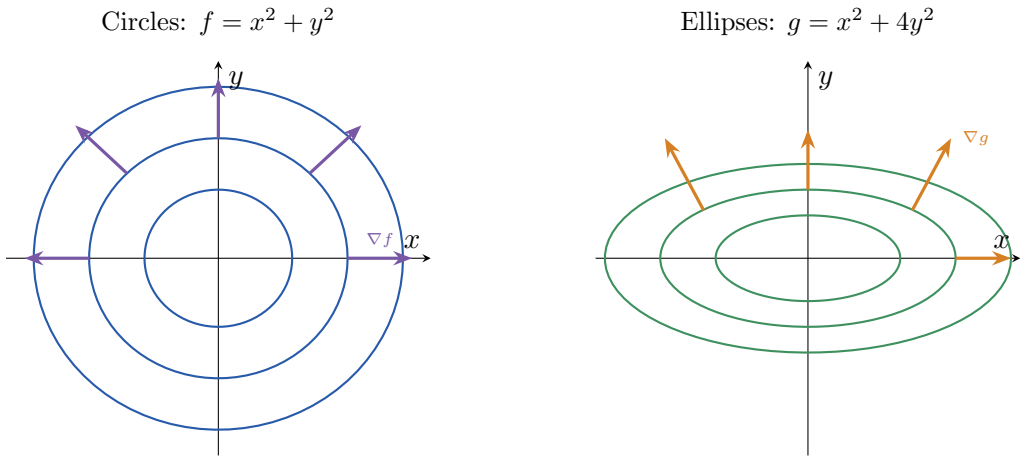


Figure 33.3: The gradient vector is strictly orthogonal to level curves everywhere. Left: For the round bowl $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$, level sets are circles and the gradient $\nabla f = (2x, 2y)$ radiates perpendicularly outward. Right: For the elongated elliptic paraboloid $g(x, y) = x^2 + 4y^2$, the contours are ellipses; the gradient $\nabla g = (2x, 8y)$ tilts more steeply toward the narrow y-axis, crossing the tangent to each ellipse at a precise 90° angle.

Why this matters

This perpendicularity explains why the gradient plays a central role in applied mathematics. In physics, force is (minus) the gradient of potential energy, and so forces point "straight downhill" against the potential energy surface, perpendicular to the surfaces of constant energy. In image processing, the gradient of brightness points across edges, perpendicular to them – which is exactly how an algorithm *finds* edges. In optimization, the gradient tells you the one direction that changes your objective fastest. One geometric fact – steepest change is perpendicular to no-change – underlies all of these applications.

Connection

In three variables the same story holds with "curve" upgraded to "surface." The level *sets* of $g(x, y, z)$ are surfaces $g = c$, and ∇g is perpendicular to the surface – it is the surface's *normal vector*. That is the quickest way to find the tangent plane to a surface like a sphere $x^2 + y^2 + z^2 = R^2$: its gradient $(2x, 2y, 2z)$ at a point is the radial direction, so the tangent plane is perpendicular to the radius. You may have proved that in geometry the hard way; the gradient hands it to you for free.

33.4 The Multivariable Chain Rule

We have leaned on a chain rule twice now without proving it. Time to pay the debt – and the payoff is large, because the multivariable chain rule is the single computational engine behind directional derivatives, the perpendicularity proof, implicit differentiation in several variables, and (as we will see) backpropagation in neural networks.

33.4.1 One inner parameter: a path through a surface

Start with the simplest case, the one we keep using. Suppose $z = f(x, y)$, but x and y are themselves functions of a single parameter t – think of t as time, and $(x(t), y(t))$ as the position of a bug crawling across the floor while f measures the temperature of the floor. The bug's temperature over time is $F(t) = f(x(t), y(t))$. How fast is the bug heating up?

Theorem 33.1 (Chain rule, single parameter)**.** *If f is differentiable at $(x(t_0), y(t_0))$ and x, y are differentiable at t_0, then $F(t) = f(x(t), y(t))$ is differentiable at t_0 and*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}F}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} \;=\; \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{r}\,'(t),$$

where $\mathbf{r}(t) = (x(t), y(t))$.

Intuition

The formula is just bookkeeping of two contributions. The temperature changes for two reasons at once: the bug is moving east at rate $x'(t)$ into ground whose temperature rises eastward at rate f_x, contributing $f_x\, x'$; and it is moving north at rate $y'(t)$ into ground rising northward at rate f_y, contributing $f_y\, y'$. Total rate of warming = sum of the two. The single-variable chain rule was "outer slope times inner slope"; the multivariable one is "add up outer slope times inner slope over every input channel."

Why the technique works

Why the chain rule looks like this: local flatness. Near (x_0, y_0) the surface f is, to first order, a flat plane:

$$f(x_0 + \Delta x,\, y_0 + \Delta y) \approx f(x_0, y_0) + f_x\, \Delta x + f_y\, \Delta y.$$

That is the entire content of differentiability: the change in f is *linear* in the change of the inputs, with coefficients f_x and f_y. Now let the inputs change because t changed by Δt. To first order $\Delta x \approx x'(t)\, \Delta t$ and $\Delta y \approx y'(t)\, \Delta t$. Substitute:

$$\Delta f \approx f_x\, x'(t)\, \Delta t + f_y\, y'(t)\, \Delta t.$$

Divide by Δt and let $\Delta t \to 0$: the approximations become exact and you get the chain rule. The whole proof is "f is locally a plane, and the slope of a plane responds linearly to a moving input." Every chain rule in mathematics is this same idea: compose two linear approximations and the linear parts multiply (here, dot) together.

Proof of Theorem 33.1. Differentiability of f at $(x_0, y_0) = (x(t_0), y(t_0))$ (defined formally in Section 33.5) means that the increment equals its linear part plus a remainder r that shrinks faster than the step length:

$$f(x_0 + \Delta x, y_0 + \Delta y) - f(x_0, y_0) = f_x\, \Delta x + f_y\, \Delta y + r(\Delta x, \Delta y),$$

where $r(0,0) = 0$ and $r(\Delta x, \Delta y)/\sqrt{\Delta x^2 + \Delta y^2} \to 0$ as $(\Delta x, \Delta y) \to (0,0)$. Now take $\Delta x = x(t_0 + h) - x(t_0)$ and $\Delta y = y(t_0 + h) - y(t_0)$, the actual changes caused by bumping t_0 to $t_0 + h$. Divide

the whole equation by h:

$$\frac{F(t_0+h)-F(t_0)}{h} = f_x\,\frac{\Delta x}{h} + f_y\,\frac{\Delta y}{h} + \frac{r(\Delta x,\Delta y)}{h}.$$

As $h \to 0$, differentiability of x and y gives $\Delta x/h \to x'(t_0)$ and $\Delta y/h \to y'(t_0)$, so the first two terms tend to $f_x\,x'(t_0) + f_y\,y'(t_0)$. For the last term, multiply and divide by the step length (when $\Delta x = \Delta y = 0$ the term is simply 0):

$$\frac{|r(\Delta x,\Delta y)|}{|h|} = \frac{|r(\Delta x,\Delta y)|}{\sqrt{\Delta x^2+\Delta y^2}} \cdot \sqrt{\left(\frac{\Delta x}{h}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\Delta y}{h}\right)^2}.$$

The second factor tends to the finite number $\sqrt{x'(t_0)^2 + y'(t_0)^2}$. The first factor tends to 0, because x and y are continuous (being differentiable), so $(\Delta x, \Delta y) \to (0,0)$. A quantity tending to 0 times a bounded one tends to 0, so the remainder term vanishes. The survivors give

$$F'(t_0) = f_x\,x'(t_0) + f_y\,y'(t_0).$$ □

Common trap

The hypothesis "f is *differentiable*," not merely "f has partial derivatives," is essential and is a genuine pitfall in several variables. A function can have both partials existing at a point and yet not be well approximated by any plane there – in which case the chain rule formula can *fail*. (The standard cautionary example is $f(x,y) = \frac{xy}{x^2+y^2}$ at the origin, extended by $f(0,0)=0$: both partials exist and equal 0, but f is not even continuous there.) In one variable, "derivative exists" and "differentiable" are the same thing, so this trap has no analogue; it is one of the first real surprises of higher-dimensional calculus.

Example 33.3 (Warming bug)**.** Let the floor temperature be $f(x,y) = x^2 + 3xy$ and let a bug move along $x(t) = t$, $y(t) = t^2$. Find $\frac{\mathrm{d}F}{\mathrm{d}t}$ at $t = 1$.

Partials: $f_x = 2x + 3y$, $f_y = 3x$. Inner derivatives: $x'(t) = 1$, $y'(t) = 2t$. So

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}F}{\mathrm{d}t} = (2x+3y)(1) + (3x)(2t).$$

At $t = 1$ we have $x = 1$, $y = 1$, giving $(2+3)(1) + (3)(2) = 5 + 6 = 11$.

Sanity check by direct substitution. Along the path, $F(t) = f(t,t^2) = t^2 + 3t\cdot t^2 = t^2 + 3t^3$, so $F'(t) = 2t + 9t^2$, and $F'(1) = 2 + 9 = 11$. The chain rule and brute force agree – as they must.

33.4.2 Several inner variables: the general chain rule

Often the inner variables depend on *several* parameters. Suppose $z = f(x,y)$ but $x = x(s,t)$ and $y = y(s,t)$ depend on two parameters s and t. Then z is ultimately a function of s and t, and we want its partial derivatives. The principle is identical – add up outer-slope times inner-slope over every channel – applied one parameter at a time (hold the other fixed):

$$\frac{\partial z}{\partial s} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\frac{\partial x}{\partial s} + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\frac{\partial y}{\partial s}, \qquad \frac{\partial z}{\partial t} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\frac{\partial x}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\frac{\partial y}{\partial t}.$$

Intuition

A *dependency tree* keeps this organized. Draw z at the top with two branches down to x and y; from each of those draw two more branches down to s and t. To find $\frac{\partial z}{\partial s}$, trace *every* path from z down to s, multiply the partial derivatives you cross along each path, and add the paths together. Two paths reach s ($z \to x \to s$ and $z \to y \to s$), giving the two terms above. "Multiply along paths, add across paths" is the chain rule for any dependency diagram, no matter how tangled – and it is exactly how automatic differentiation libraries organize backpropagation.

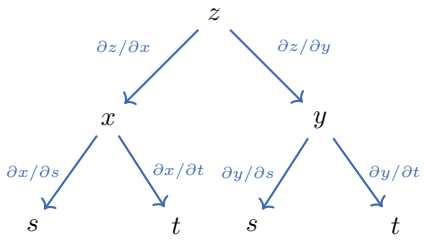


Figure 33.4: The dependency tree for $z = f(x, y)$ with x, y depending on s, t. To get $\frac{\partial z}{\partial s}$, follow each downward path that ends at s (the two leftish ones), multiply the labels along the path, and add the results.

Example 33.4 (Polar coordinates)**.** A frequent use: $f(x, y)$ with $x = r\cos\theta$, $y = r\sin\theta$. Find $\frac{\partial f}{\partial r}$.

Here the parameters are r, θ. The inner partials are $\frac{\partial x}{\partial r} = \cos\theta$ and $\frac{\partial y}{\partial r} = \sin\theta$. So

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial r} = f_x \cos\theta + f_y \sin\theta.$$

Look closely: $(\cos\theta, \sin\theta)$ is the outward radial *unit* vector. So $\frac{\partial f}{\partial r} = \nabla f \cdot \hat{\mathbf{r}}$ is just the directional derivative of f in the radial direction – which is exactly what "rate of change as r increases" should mean. The chain rule has computed a directional derivative for us.

33.5 Linear Approximation in Several Variables: the Tangent Plane

In one variable, the derivative gave us the tangent *line*, the best straight approximation to a curve near a point. In two variables the gradient gives us the tangent *plane*, the best flat approximation to a surface near a point. The gradient is precisely the recipe for that plane.

Near (a, b), differentiability says the change in f is approximately linear in the changes of the inputs:

$$f(x, y) \approx f(a, b) + f_x(a, b)\,(x - a) + f_y(a, b)\,(y - b).$$

The right-hand side, viewed as a function of (x, y), is the equation of a plane – the **tangent plane** to the graph $z = f(x, y)$ at the point $(a, b, f(a, b))$. Using the gradient we can write it as a single dot product:

$$\boxed{L(x, y) = f(a, b) + \nabla f(a, b) \cdot \big((x, y) - (a, b)\big).}$$

What is really happening

What "differentiable" really means in several variables. It is tempting to define differentiability as "all partial derivatives exist," but that definition is too weak, as the trap above showed. The right definition is the one that matches the picture: f is differentiable at (a, b) if there is a plane L through $(a, b, f(a, b))$ such that the error $f - L$ shrinks *faster than the distance* to (a, b):

$$\lim_{(x,y)\to(a,b)} \frac{f(x, y) - L(x, y)}{\|(x, y) - (a, b)\|} = 0.$$

This is the exact two-variable echo of "smooth means locally straight": smooth now means *locally flat*, well approximated by a plane, with the error negligible compared to how far you have stepped. When that holds, the coefficients of L are forced to be the partial derivatives, and the gradient is born. The gradient exists as a meaningful object precisely because the surface has a tangent plane.

A surface and its tangent plane at the origin

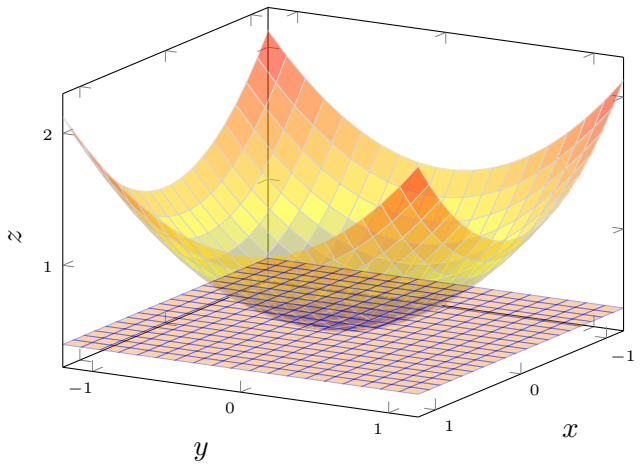


Figure 33.5: The bowl $z = 0.6x^2 + 0.6y^2 + 0.4$ and its tangent plane at the bottom point $(0, 0, 0.4)$. Because $\nabla f(0, 0) = (0, 0)$, the tangent plane is horizontal – the flat "floor" that the bowl melts into when you zoom in on its lowest point. At a slanted point the plane would tilt to match.

Example 33.5 (Estimating a value without a calculator)**.** Estimate $\sqrt{(3.02)^2 + (3.97)^2}$ using a tangent plane.

Let $f(x, y) = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2}$ and anchor at the friendly point $(a, b) = (3, 4)$, where $f(3, 4) = \sqrt{9 + 16} = 5$ exactly. The partials are

$$f_x = \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + y^2}}, \qquad f_y = \frac{y}{\sqrt{x^2 + y^2}},$$

so $f_x(3, 4) = \frac{3}{5}$ and $f_y(3, 4) = \frac{4}{5}$; thus $\nabla f(3, 4) = (\frac{3}{5}, \frac{4}{5})$. The steps are $\Delta x = 3.02 - 3 = 0.02$ and $\Delta y = 3.97 - 4 = -0.03$. The linear approximation gives

$$f(3.02, 3.97) \approx 5 + \tfrac{3}{5}(0.02) + \tfrac{4}{5}(-0.03) = 5 + 0.012 - 0.024 = 4.988.$$

A calculator gives $\sqrt{3.02^2 + 3.97^2} = \sqrt{9.1204 + 15.7609} = \sqrt{24.8813} \approx 4.98812$. Our tangent-plane estimate 4.988 is correct to four significant figures (three decimal places), from arithmetic you can do in your head – because near $(3, 4)$ the surface is practically its tangent plane.

Connection

This is the engine of *error propagation* in the lab. If a quantity $f(x, y)$ is computed from two measurements x, y with small uncertainties $\Delta x, \Delta y$, then to first order the uncertainty in f is $\Delta f \approx f_x\,\Delta x + f_y\,\Delta y$. The partial derivatives are the *sensitivities*: they say how strongly each input's error feeds through to the output. The gradient is the vector of sensitivities. Scientists who have never heard the word "gradient" use this formula every time they write "±" after a result.

33.6 Gradient Descent: How Machines Learn

We have all the ingredients for one of the most consequential algorithms of our century. The core idea is straightforward: *to minimize a function, step iteratively in the direction of steepest descent* – that is, in the direction of $-\nabla f$ – and you will walk downhill toward a valley.

Application

Gradient descent in machine learning. A machine-learning model has a pile of adjustable numbers called *parameters* (or weights), which we collect into a vector $\mathbf{w} = (w_1, \ldots, w_n)$ – a modern network has millions or billions of them. A *loss function* $L(\mathbf{w})$ measures how badly the model does on the training data: big loss means bad predictions, small loss means good ones. Training the model means *minimizing* L over the weights.
We cannot see this n-dimensional loss surface, and we certainly cannot solve $\nabla L = \mathbf{0}$ by hand for a billion variables. But we can do what the foggy hiker in our earlier hiking example does. At our current weights, we compute the gradient $\nabla L(\mathbf{w})$ – the direction in weight-space that would increase the loss fastest – and we step the *opposite* way:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{w}_{\text{new}} = \mathbf{w}_{\text{old}} - \eta\,\nabla L(\mathbf{w}_{\text{old}}).}$$

The number $\eta > 0$ is the **learning rate**, the size of the step. Repeat millions of times and the weights slide downhill into a valley of low loss – the model has *learned*. The gradient here is computed by the multivariable chain rule applied layer by layer through the network; that organized application of the chain rule is exactly what *backpropagation* is. Everything in this chapter – gradient as steepest direction, chain rule as the way to compute it – is precisely the mathematics that trains modern AI.

Intuition

Why step *against* the gradient? Because $-\nabla L$ is the direction of steepest *descent* (Section 33.2): of all directions you could step, it lowers the loss the fastest. And why multiply by a small η? Because the gradient is only the slope *at your current point*; trust it only for a short step. The linear approximation $L(\mathbf{w} - \eta\,\nabla L) \approx L(\mathbf{w}) - \eta\,\|\nabla L\|^2$ shows that as long as η is small and $\nabla L \neq \mathbf{0}$, the loss strictly decreases: the term $-\eta\|\nabla L\|^2$ is negative. That single inequality is the mathematical guarantee that a small gradient step makes progress.

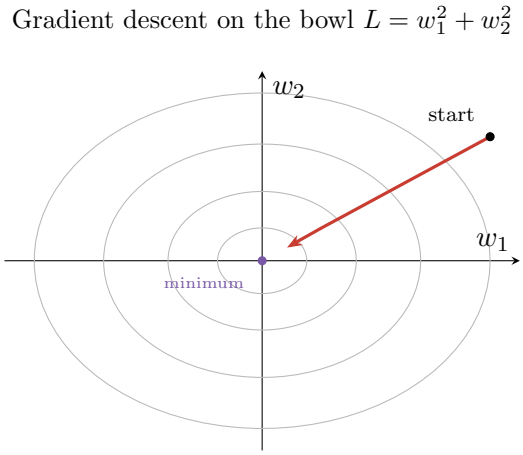


Figure 33.6: Gradient descent on $L = w_1^2 + w_2^2$. Each red step points opposite the gradient (perpendicular to the contour, straight toward the center) and is scaled by the learning rate. The iterates march into the minimum at the origin.

Example 33.6 (One descent step by hand)**.** Minimize $L(w_1, w_2) = w_1^2 + w_2^2$ starting at $\mathbf{w}_0 = (2, 3)$ with learning rate $\eta = 0.1$.

The gradient is $\nabla L = (2w_1, 2w_2)$, so $\nabla L(2, 3) = (4, 6)$. One step:

$$\mathbf{w}_1 = (2, 3) - 0.1\,(4, 6) = (2 - 0.4,\ 3 - 0.6) = (1.6,\ 2.4).$$

The loss dropped from $L(2, 3) = 4 + 9 = 13$ to $L(1.6, 2.4) = 2.56 + 5.76 = 8.32$. We moved toward the origin – the true minimum – as expected. Notice each coordinate got multiplied by $1 - 2\eta = 0.8$; iterating, the weights shrink geometrically to zero, which is gradient descent solving this bowl exactly.

Common trap

The learning rate is a genuine knife-edge. Too *small* and progress is glacial – thousands of tiny steps. Too *large* and you overshoot the valley and bounce up the far wall; the loss can *increase* and even diverge. In Example 33.6 the update multiplied each weight by $1 - 2\eta$. That factor has magnitude below 1 (so the steps converge) only when $0 < \eta < 1$; at $\eta = 1$ the weights flip sign and never shrink, and for $\eta > 1$ they blow up. Choosing η well is one of the central practical arts of training models, and it comes down to our earlier warning against trusting a linear approximation too far.

Walking question

Gradient descent only ever steps downhill, so it can get *stuck* in a valley that is not the lowest valley – a *local* minimum. Picture a surface with two basins of different depths (Figure 33.7); depending on where you start, you slide into one or the other and stop. Why, then, does gradient descent work so well for training large neural networks, whose loss surfaces have vast numbers of critical points? Part of the answer from modern research: in very high dimensions, most flat spots are saddle points (Section 33.7), which a slightly noisy step escapes along a downhill direction, and the valleys gradient descent does reach tend to have nearly equal loss.

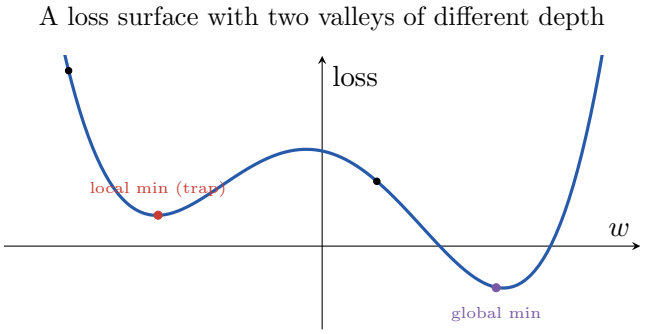


Figure 33.7: Gradient descent only steps downhill, so where you start decides where you stop. A ball released on the far left slides into the shallow left valley (a *local* minimum) and halts; one released just right of center rolls into the deeper right valley (the *global* minimum). Both are critical points where the slope is zero, but only one is the true bottom.

33.7 Finding and Classifying Critical Points: the Hessian

To find the peaks and valleys of a surface, we look for the places where it is momentarily flat – where the tangent plane is horizontal. In one variable we set $f'(x) = 0$; in several variables we set the entire gradient to zero.

Definition 33.3 (Critical point)**.** A point (a, b) is a **critical point** of f if $\nabla f(a, b) = \mathbf{0}$, that is $f_x(a, b) = 0$ and $f_y(a, b) = 0$ (or if the gradient fails to exist). Where the gradient is zero, the tangent plane is horizontal.

Pause and think: Suppose you stand at a point where $f_x(a, b) = 0$ but $f_y(a, b) = 4$. Is (a, b) a critical point? No. The ground is flat if you walk east-west, but slopes steeply if you step north. A critical point requires the ground to be flat in *every* direction, which means both partial derivatives must vanish at once.

A horizontal tangent plane is necessary for a local max or min – if the ground sloped at all, you could go uphill one way and downhill the other, so it would be neither a top nor a bottom. But "flat" alone does not tell you *which*. There are three flavors of critical point, and the new one has no analogue in a single variable.

- **Local minimum:** the surface curves *up* in every direction – a bowl. You are at the bottom of a valley.
- **Local maximum:** the surface curves *down* in every direction – a dome. You are at a summit.
- **Saddle point:** the surface curves up in some directions and down in others – like a mountain pass, or the seat of a horse saddle. Up along the horse's spine, down toward the stirrups. This is genuinely new: a point can be flat yet be neither a max nor a min.

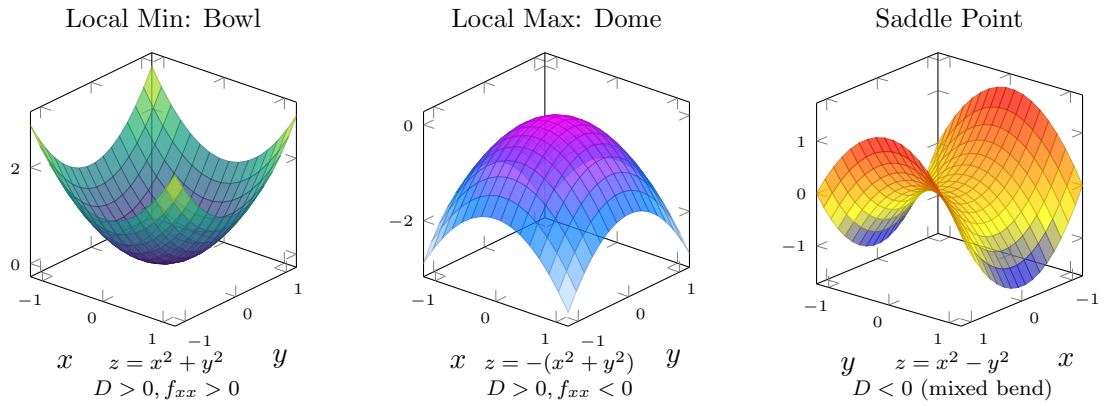


Figure 33.8: The three geometric archetypes of critical points in two variables. Left: A local minimum ($z = x^2 + y^2$) where curvature is positive in every direction ($D > 0, f_{xx} > 0$). Center: A local maximum ($z = -(x^2 + y^2)$) where curvature is negative in every direction ($D > 0, f_{xx} < 0$). Right: A saddle point ($z = x^2 - y^2$) curving upward along the x-axis and downward along the y-axis ($D < 0$), producing a horizontal tangent plane at $(0, 0)$ that is neither a peak nor a valley.

33.7.1 The second-derivative test, intuitively

How do we tell the three apart without plotting? By looking at *curvature* – the second derivatives. In one variable, after $f'(a) = 0$, the sign of $f''(a)$ decided max ($f'' < 0$, concave down) versus min ($f'' > 0$, concave up). In two variables there are *three* second partials to track,

$$f_{xx} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\right), \qquad f_{yy} = \frac{\partial}{\partial y}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}\right), \qquad f_{xy} = \frac{\partial}{\partial y}\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x}\right),$$

(and for the functions we meet, $f_{xy} = f_{yx}$, the mixed partials agree). We arrange them in a 2×2 grid called the **Hessian matrix**:

$$H = \begin{pmatrix} f_{xx} & f_{xy} \\ f_{xy} & f_{yy} \end{pmatrix}.$$

The Hessian is the multivariable second derivative: it records the curvature of the surface in every direction, just as the gradient recorded the slope in every direction. The quantity that decides the verdict is its **determinant**,

$$D = f_{xx} f_{yy} - (f_{xy})^2.$$

Focus

The second-derivative (Hessian) test. At a critical point (a, b), let $D = f_{xx} f_{yy} - f_{xy}^2$, all evaluated at (a, b).

- If $D > 0$ and $f_{xx} > 0$: **local minimum** (a bowl, curving up).
- If $D > 0$ and $f_{xx} < 0$: **local maximum** (a dome, curving down).
- If $D < 0$: **saddle point** (curving up one way, down another).
- If $D = 0$: the test is **inconclusive** – the curvature is too gentle to decide; look closer.

Intuition

Where does $D = f_{xx}f_{yy} - f_{xy}^2$ come from, intuitively? Two things must be true for a genuine bowl. First, it must curve up along the x-direction *and* along the y-direction: $f_{xx} > 0$ and $f_{yy} > 0$. But that is not enough – a strong mixed term f_{xy} can twist the surface so that even though both axis-directions curve up, some diagonal direction curves *down*, producing a saddle surface. The determinant D is exactly the bookkeeping that catches this twist: requiring $f_{xx}f_{yy} > f_{xy}^2$ says the genuine upward curvature beats the twisting. When the twist wins ($D < 0$), you have a saddle: up some ways, down others. The sign of f_{xx} then just picks bowl (+) from dome (−). This is the two-dimensional cousin of "concave up vs concave down," with D guarding against mixed diagonal curvature.

Why the technique works

Why the determinant decides it (the deeper reason). Near a critical point the gradient is zero, so the linear part of f vanishes and the *quadratic* part takes over:

$$f(a+h, b+k) \approx f(a,b) + \tfrac{1}{2}\big(f_{xx}h^2 + 2f_{xy}hk + f_{yy}k^2\big).$$

The fate of the critical point hangs entirely on the sign of the quadratic form $Q(h,k) = f_{xx}h^2 + 2f_{xy}hk + f_{yy}k^2$. If $Q > 0$ for every direction (h,k), the surface rises every way – a min. If $Q < 0$ always – a max. If Q is positive some ways and negative others – a saddle. Completing the square (assuming $f_{xx} \neq 0$),

$$Q = f_{xx}\Big(h + \tfrac{f_{xy}}{f_{xx}}k\Big)^2 + \frac{f_{xx}f_{yy} - f_{xy}^2}{f_{xx}}\,k^2,$$

and you can read off everything: the leftover coefficient on k^2 is D/f_{xx}. For Q to keep one sign, both pieces need matching signs, which forces $D > 0$; then f_{xx} sets that sign (min if +, max if −). If $D < 0$ the two squared pieces fight, so Q takes both signs – a saddle. Up to a factor of -4, the determinant is the discriminant $4f_{xy}^2 - 4f_{xx}f_{yy}$ of the quadratic form $Q(h,k)$, and it is the exact higher-dimensional heir of the f'' sign test.

Example 33.7 (Classifying every critical point)**.** Classify the critical points of $f(x,y) = x^3 - 3x + y^2$.

Step 1: find them. $f_x = 3x^2 - 3 = 3(x^2-1)$ and $f_y = 2y$. Setting both to zero: $f_y = 0$ gives $y = 0$, and $f_x = 0$ gives $x^2 = 1$, so $x = \pm 1$. Two critical points: $(1,0)$ and $(-1,0)$.

Step 2: second partials. $f_{xx} = 6x$, $f_{yy} = 2$, $f_{xy} = 0$. So $D = f_{xx}f_{yy} - f_{xy}^2 = (6x)(2) - 0 = 12x$.

Step 3: apply the test.

- At $(1,0)$: $D = 12(1) = 12 > 0$ and $f_{xx} = 6(1) = 6 > 0$. *Local minimum.*
- At $(-1,0)$: $D = 12(-1) = -12 < 0$. *Saddle point.*

This fits the shape of f: in x it is a cubic (one local min at $x = 1$, one local max at $x = -1$), and in y it is the upward parabola y^2. At $x = 1$ both directions curve up – a true bowl. At $x = -1$ the x-cubic curves down while the y-parabola curves up – up one way, down the other, a saddle. The Hessian test read all of this off three derivatives.

Example 33.8 (A clean maximum)**.** Classify the critical point of $f(x,y) = 4 - x^2 - y^2 + 2x$.

$f_x = -2x + 2 = 0 \Rightarrow x = 1$; $f_y = -2y = 0 \Rightarrow y = 0$. One critical point $(1, 0)$. Second partials: $f_{xx} = -2$, $f_{yy} = -2$, $f_{xy} = 0$, so $D = (-2)(-2) - 0 = 4 > 0$ with $f_{xx} = -2 < 0$: a *local maximum*. Indeed $f = 5 - (x-1)^2 - y^2$ after completing the square, an upside-down bowl with summit 5 at $(1, 0)$ – exactly what the test reported.

33.8 Constrained Optimization and Lagrange Multipliers

Up to this point, our search for extreme values has operated without boundaries: we roamed across the entire xy-plane seeking summits, pits, or saddles where the gradient vanished, $\nabla f(x, y) = \mathbf{0}$. In physical, statistical, and engineering applications, however, variables are rarely free to wander without restriction. A structural engineer must maximize load-bearing capacity subject to a strict weight budget; an economist seeks to maximize utility under a fixed financial ceiling; a machine learning algorithm minimizes empirical risk subject to a spherical parameter constraint $\|\mathbf{w}\|^2 = 1$.

In single-variable calculus (Chapters 13 and 17), we attacked constrained problems through algebraic substitution: given an objective function $f(x, y)$ and a constraint equation $g(x, y) = c$, we attempted to solve the constraint explicitly for one variable in terms of the other—say, $y = h(x)$—and substitute it directly into $f(x, h(x))$, reducing the problem to single-variable critical points where $\frac{\mathrm{d}f}{\mathrm{d}x} = 0$.

Both Chapters 13 and 17 pointed out that algebraic elimination is a fragile bottleneck. If the constraint is nonlinear or implicit – such as $x^5 + x + y^3 + y = 1$ or a multivariable quadratic form – solving for one coordinate in closed form is impossible. Eliminating variables also breaks the natural geometric symmetry of the problem. As promised in Chapter 17, multivariable calculus provides a geometric alternative: the method of *Lagrange multipliers*.

33.8.1 The Geometry of Tangent Contours

To see the geometric core of constrained optimization, step away from formulas and picture a physical mountainside.

Imagine hiking on a mountainous terrain where your elevation above sea level is described by the height function $f(x, y)$. You wish to climb as high as possible. If you were free to walk in any direction across the terrain, you would follow the gradient ∇f until you reached a mountain peak where $\nabla f = \mathbf{0}$.

Now introduce the constraint: you are confined to a narrow fenced trail painted across the mountain, defined by the equation $g(x, y) = c$. You cannot step off the path; you can only walk forward or backward along it. Which point on this fenced trail attains the highest elevation?

Picture the elevation contours (level curves) $f(x, y) = k$ on the mountain slope. As you hike along the trail $g(x, y) = c$, you cross from one elevation contour to another:

- Suppose that at your current position, the trail cuts *across* a contour line $f(x, y) = k$ at an angle. Because the trail penetrates the contour line rather than running along it, stepping forward along the trail takes you uphill toward contours of higher elevation ($f > k$), while stepping backward takes you downhill toward contours of lower elevation ($f < k$).
- Consequently, any point where the trail crosses an elevation contour at a nonzero angle cannot be an extremum on the trail. The directional derivative of f along the path's unit tangent

vector $\mathbf{T}$ is nonzero:

$$D_{\mathbf{T}} f = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{T} \neq 0.$$

Stepping in the direction of this projection takes you higher.

Where can your climb along the trail terminate? Only when moving along the trail produces zero instantaneous change in elevation. This occurs at the exact instant where the trail no longer cuts through the contours of f, but instead runs momentarily parallel to them.

At the constrained maximum (or minimum) point (x^*, y^*), the contour line $f(x, y) = k^*$ must be **tangent to the constraint curve** $g(x, y) = c$.

Pause and think: If the objective is $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$ (a bowl) and the constraint is the line $x + y = 2$, what does the tangency condition look like? The level curves of f are concentric circles centered at the origin. The constraint is a straight diagonal line. The lowest point on the line corresponds to the smallest circle that touches the line – touching it tangentially at $(1, 1)$.

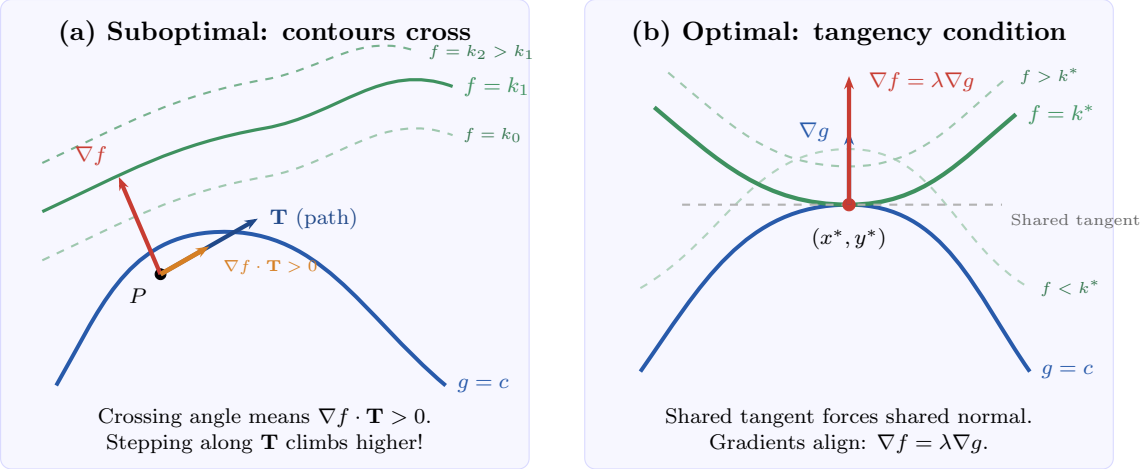


Figure 33.9: The geometric genesis of Lagrange multipliers. (a) At a suboptimal point, the elevation contour $f = k_1$ cuts across the constraint path $g(x, y) = c$; the gradient ∇f has a nonzero projection along the path, which means you can climb higher by walking along the trail. (b) At the constrained optimum (x^*, y^*), the level curve $f = k^*$ is tangent to the constraint path without crossing it. Because tangent lines match, their perpendicular normal vectors align along the exact same line, forcing $\nabla f(x^*, y^*) = \lambda \nabla g(x^*, y^*)$.

Now connect this geometric tangency to the property established earlier in this chapter: *wherever the gradient of a differentiable function is nonzero, it is perpendicular to the level curve through that point* (Section 33.3).

1. The contour curve of elevation $f(x, y) = k^*$ has normal vector $\nabla f(x^*, y^*)$.
2. The constraint path $g(x, y) = c$ is itself a level curve of g, so its normal vector is $\nabla g(x^*, y^*)$.
3. Because the two curves are tangent at (x^*, y^*), they share the exact same tangent line.
4. Two curves in the plane that share the same tangent line must share the same perpendicular normal line.

Therefore, the normal vectors $\nabla f(x^*, y^*)$ and $\nabla g(x^*, y^*)$ must point along the exact same line. Two

vectors lie along the same line if and only if one is a scalar multiple of the other:

$$\nabla f(x^*, y^*) = \lambda \nabla g(x^*, y^*), \tag{33.1}$$

for some scalar $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, known as the **Lagrange multiplier** (provided $\nabla g(x^*, y^*) \neq \mathbf{0}$).

In two dimensions, expanding Equation (33.1) into components yields two scalar equations:

$$f_x(x, y) = \lambda g_x(x, y), \qquad f_y(x, y) = \lambda g_y(x, y).$$

Pairing these with the original constraint equation $g(x, y) = c$ produces a closed system of three equations in three unknowns (x, y, λ). Every candidate for a local constrained maximum or minimum must satisfy this system.

33.8.2 The Physical Meaning of λ: Shadow Price and Sensitivity

What is the physical meaning of this scalar λ? It is far more than an algebraic parameter.

Suppose the constraint budget c changes by a small amount $\mathrm{d}c$ – for instance, you are granted one additional unit of budget, fuel, or material. The constraint curve shifts slightly, and so does the best elevation you can reach on it. How much does the optimal value f^* change per unit change in c?

Let $\mathbf{r}^*(c) = (x^*(c), y^*(c))$ denote the position of the constrained optimum as a function of the parameter c, and let $f^*(c) = f(\mathbf{r}^*(c))$ be the optimal value achieved. By the multivariable chain rule:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = \nabla f(\mathbf{r}^*(c)) \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}^*}{\mathrm{d}c}.$$

At the optimum, the gradient condition holds: $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$. Substituting this into the chain rule gives:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = \lambda \nabla g(\mathbf{r}^*(c)) \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = \lambda \left(\nabla g(\mathbf{r}^*(c)) \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}^*}{\mathrm{d}c} \right).$$

Now differentiate the constraint identity $g(\mathbf{r}^*(c)) = c$ with respect to c, again applying the multivariable chain rule:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}c}\big[g(\mathbf{r}^*(c))\big] = \nabla g(\mathbf{r}^*(c)) \cdot \frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}c}[c] = 1.$$

The dot product inside the parenthesis is identically 1. Substituting this back into our expression for $\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c}$ yields:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = \lambda. \tag{33.2}$$

The Lagrange multiplier λ is the **marginal sensitivity** or **shadow price** of the constraint:

- If $\lambda = 5$, relaxing your budget c by 0.01 will increase your optimal return by approximately $5 \times 0.01 = 0.05$.
- If $\lambda = 0$, then $\nabla f(x^*, y^*) = \mathbf{0}$: the optimum on the curve happens to be a critical point of f itself, so nudging c changes f^* by zero to first order ($\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = 0$).
- If λ is negative, increasing the budget parameter c decreases the optimal value of f.

In economics, resource allocation, and operations research, λ is often the most important quantity in the problem: it measures the marginal return of an additional unit of constrained resource.

33.8.3 Two Complete Worked Examples

Example 33.9 (Maximizing a product under a linear budget)**.** Maximize $f(x, y) = xy$ subject to the linear constraint $g(x, y) = 2x + y = 100$, where $x, y > 0$.

Step 1: Compute gradients.

$$\nabla f = \begin{pmatrix} f_x \\ f_y \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} y \\ x \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \nabla g = \begin{pmatrix} g_x \\ g_y \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Step 2: Set up the Lagrange system $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$.

$$y = 2\lambda, \tag{33.3}$$
$$x = \lambda, \tag{33.4}$$
$$2x + y = 100. \tag{33.5}$$

Step 3: Eliminate λ to find the optimal ratio. From Equation (33.4), $\lambda = x$. Substituting this into Equation (33.3) gives:

$$y = 2x.$$

At the optimum, the ratio of marginal benefits equals the ratio of marginal costs ($y/x = 2/1$).

Step 4: Substitute into the constraint. Substitute $y = 2x$ into Equation (33.5):

$$2x + (2x) = 100 \implies 4x = 100 \implies x^* = 25.$$

Then $y^* = 2(25) = 50$, and the multiplier is $\lambda = x^* = 25$.

Step 5: Compute the optimal value and verify the shadow price. The maximum product is:

$$f^* = f(25, 50) = (25)(50) = 1250.$$

To verify the physical meaning of $\lambda = 25$, consider a general budget c so that $2x + y = c$. The condition $y = 2x$ remains unchanged, so $4x = c \implies x^*(c) = c/4$ and $y^*(c) = c/2$. The optimal product as a function of budget c is:

$$f^*(c) = x^*(c)\, y^*(c) = \left(\frac{c}{4}\right)\left(\frac{c}{2}\right) = \frac{c^2}{8}.$$

Differentiating with respect to the budget c:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c} = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}c}\left[\frac{c^2}{8}\right] = \frac{2c}{8} = \frac{c}{4}.$$

Evaluating at our specific budget $c = 100$:

$$\left[\frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c}\right]_{c=100} = \frac{100}{4} = 25 = \lambda.$$

The rate at which the optimal value increases with respect to the budget is precisely the Lagrange multiplier λ.

Example 33.10 (Quadratic forms on the unit circle: The bridge to eigenvalues)**.** Let A be a real symmetric 2×2 matrix, $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b & c \end{pmatrix}$. Maximize the quadratic form (a pure degree-two polynomial in x and y):

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{x}^T A\mathbf{x} = ax^2 + 2bxy + cy^2$$

subject to the unit circle constraint:

$$g(\mathbf{x}) = \|\mathbf{x}\|^2 = \mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{x} = x^2 + y^2 = 1.$$

Step 1: Compute gradients in vector notation. Using the multivariable derivative of a quadratic form (or by computing partials directly):

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{pmatrix} 2ax + 2by \\ 2bx + 2cy \end{pmatrix} = 2A\mathbf{x}.$$

For the constraint $g(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{x} = x^2 + y^2$, the gradient is:

$$\nabla g(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{pmatrix} 2x \\ 2y \end{pmatrix} = 2\mathbf{x}.$$

Step 2: Apply the Lagrange condition $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$.

$$2A\mathbf{x} = \lambda(2\mathbf{x}) \iff A\mathbf{x} = \lambda\mathbf{x}.$$

The Lagrange multiplier condition for a quadratic form on the unit sphere is the eigenvalue equation of linear algebra:

- The critical points $\mathbf{x}^*$ of the quadratic form on the unit circle are precisely the **unit eigenvectors** of A – directions where matrix multiplication simply stretches the vector without rotating it.
- The Lagrange multipliers λ are precisely the **eigenvalues** of A – the stretch factors along those special directions.

Step 3: What value does the objective attain at an eigenvector? Multiply $A\mathbf{x} = \lambda\mathbf{x}$ on the left by $\mathbf{x}^T$:

$$\mathbf{x}^T A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}^T(\lambda\mathbf{x}) = \lambda(\mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{x}).$$

Because $\mathbf{x}$ lies on the unit sphere ($\mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{x} = 1$), this simplifies to:

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = \lambda.$$

The value of the quadratic form at any critical point is the corresponding eigenvalue. Therefore:

- The **maximum** of $\mathbf{x}^T A\mathbf{x}$ on the unit sphere is the largest eigenvalue $\lambda_{\max}$.
- The **minimum** of $\mathbf{x}^T A\mathbf{x}$ on the unit sphere is the smallest eigenvalue $\lambda_{\min}$.

Step 4: A concrete numerical calculation. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 5 & 2 \\ 2 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$, so $f(x, y) = 5x^2 + 4xy + 2y^2$ subject to $x^2 + y^2 = 1$. The Lagrange system $A\mathbf{x} = \lambda\mathbf{x}$ becomes:

$$(5 - \lambda)x + 2y = 0,$$
$$2x + (2 - \lambda)y = 0.$$

For a nonzero solution vector $\mathbf{x}$ to exist on the unit circle, the determinant of the system must vanish:

$$\det\begin{pmatrix} 5-\lambda & 2 \\ 2 & 2-\lambda \end{pmatrix} = (5-\lambda)(2-\lambda) - 4 = \lambda^2 - 7\lambda + 6 = 0.$$

Factoring gives $(\lambda - 6)(\lambda - 1) = 0$, yielding two eigenvalues: $\lambda_1 = 6$ and $\lambda_2 = 1$.

- For $\lambda_1 = 6$: $(5-6)x + 2y = 0 \implies -x + 2y = 0 \implies x = 2y$. Substituting into $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ gives $(2y)^2 + y^2 = 5y^2 = 1$, so $y = \pm 1/\sqrt{5}$ and $x = \pm 2/\sqrt{5}$. The maximum value of $f(x, y)$ on the circle is $f^* = \lambda_1 = 6$.
- For $\lambda_2 = 1$: $(5-1)x + 2y = 0 \implies 4x + 2y = 0 \implies y = -2x$. Substituting into $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ gives $x^2 + (-2x)^2 = 5x^2 = 1$, so $x = \pm 1/\sqrt{5}$ and $y = \mp 2/\sqrt{5}$. The minimum value of $f(x, y)$ on the circle is $f^* = \lambda_2 = 1$.

This establishes a direct bridge between multivariable calculus and Book 3 (*Linear Algebra From the Ground Up*): the spectral decomposition and principal axis theorem (which guarantee that every symmetric matrix simply stretches along perpendicular axes) are constrained optimization in geometric form.

History

The tools in this chapter arose from physics and astronomy. In 1788, Joseph-Louis Lagrange sought a way to calculate the motion of pendulums and planets constrained along curved tracks without having to compute internal reaction forces. His method of multipliers relied on a geometric observation: because constraint forces act normal to the constraint surface, the objective gradient and constraint gradient must align along a shared normal line, $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$.
In 1847, two key developments appeared. In Paris, Augustin-Louis Cauchy computed planetary orbits by taking iterative steps downhill in the direction of steepest descent, introducing gradient descent. In Dublin, around the same time, William Rowan Hamilton introduced an early form of the symbol ∇ while developing quaternions. The name *nabla* was suggested to Peter Guthrie Tait because the symbol resembled an ancient Hebrew harp.
In the 1890s, Gibbs and Heaviside simplified quaternions by extracting the dot product, cross product, and gradient to formulate modern vector calculus, which simplified Maxwell's equations of electromagnetism. Earlier, in the 1840s, Otto Hesse had organized second partial derivatives into the Hessian matrix to classify local curvature.
Open questions remain in optimization. In high-dimensional non-convex optimization (such as neural networks with millions of weights), understanding when and why gradient descent avoids saddle points and converges to good local minima remains an active research area.

Pause

The chapter in six statements. (1) The *directional derivative* $D_{\mathbf{u}} f$ is the slope of f as you walk in the unit direction $\mathbf{u}$, and it equals $\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}$. (2) The *gradient* $\nabla f = (f_x, f_y)$ points in the direction of steepest ascent, its length is the steepest slope, and it is perpendicular to level curves. (3) The *chain rule* "multiply along paths, add across paths" computes derivatives through any chain of dependencies and is the engine of backpropagation. (4) Linear approximation upgrades the tangent line to a tangent *plane*, $L = f(a, b) + \nabla f \cdot ((x, y) - (a, b))$. (5) Unconstrained critical points are where $\nabla f = \mathbf{0}$, classified by the *Hessian* determinant $D = f_{xx} f_{yy} - f_{xy}^2$. (6) Constrained extrema occur where the objective contour is tangent to the

constraint path, aligning their perpendicular gradients: $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$, where $\lambda = \frac{\mathrm{d}f^*}{\mathrm{d}c}$ measures the shadow price of the budget. Every item on this list is one geometric idea – local flatness and normal orthogonality – seen from a different angle.

Connection

Looking ahead: from local slopes to global volume. Chapters 32 and 33 built the differential half of multivariable calculus: zoom in on a point until the surface looks like a flat plane, and read off its slopes from ∇f. Chapter 34 builds the other half: chop a region or solid into tiny cells, add up a function over all of them, and recover volume, mass, and probability – the two-dimensional version of the Riemann sum.

33.9 Exercises

Exercise 33.1 (Directional derivative, by formula)**.** Let $f(x, y) = x^2y + y^3$. Compute the directional derivative of f at the point $(2, 1)$ in the direction toward $(5, 5)$. (Remember to normalize the direction vector first.)

Exercise 33.2 (Steepest ascent)**.** For $f(x, y) = e^x \sin y$, find at the point $(0, \frac{\pi}{2})$: (a) the gradient, (b) the unit direction of steepest ascent, and (c) the maximum rate of increase. In what direction(s) is the directional derivative zero?

Exercise 33.3 (Chain rule, one parameter)**.** Let $z = x^2 - y^2$ with $x(t) = \cos t$ and $y(t) = \sin t$. Use the chain rule to find $\frac{\mathrm{d}z}{\mathrm{d}t}$, then verify your answer by first substituting to get z as an explicit function of t and differentiating directly. (You should find a clean trigonometric expression.)

Exercise 33.4 (Chain rule, two parameters)**.** Let $z = xy$ where $x = s + t$ and $y = s - t$. Compute $\frac{\partial z}{\partial s}$ and $\frac{\partial z}{\partial t}$ using the multivariable chain rule. Then compute z directly in terms of s, t and confirm.

Exercise 33.5 (Tangent plane and estimation)**.** Let $f(x, y) = \ln(x^2 + y^2)$. (a) Write the equation of the tangent plane to the graph at $(1, 0)$. (b) Use it to estimate $f(1.1,\, 0.05)$, and compare with the true value.

Exercise 33.6 (A gradient descent run)**.** Consider $L(w_1, w_2) = w_1^2 + 4w_2^2$ with learning rate $\eta = 0.1$, starting at $(w_1, w_2) = (1, 1)$. (a) Carry out two steps of gradient descent by hand, reporting the iterates and the loss at each. (b) Each coordinate is multiplied by a constant factor every step – find the two factors. Why does w_2 converge faster than w_1, and what does that say about choosing η when the bowl is stretched?

Exercise 33.7 (Classify the critical points)**.** Find and classify all critical points of $f(x, y) = x^3 + y^3 - 3xy$ using the Hessian test. (You should find one saddle and one local extremum.)

Exercise 33.8 (The perpendicularity, concretely)**.** Let $f(x, y) = x^2 + 4y^2$, whose level curves are ellipses. At the point $(2, 1)$ (which lies on the level curve $f = 8$): (a) compute $\nabla f(2, 1)$; (b) find a vector tangent to the ellipse $f = 8$ at $(2, 1)$ (hint: parametrize, or use implicit differentiation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ on $x^2 + 4y^2 = 8$); (c) verify by a dot product that the gradient and the tangent are perpendicular.

Exercise 33.9 (Conceptual: partials exist but no plane)**.** Explain in your own words, using the caution in Section 33.4, why "all partial derivatives exist at a point" is *not* enough to guarantee that the chain rule formula holds there. What stronger condition (stated in Section 33.5) is the right one, and what does it say geometrically?

Exercise 33.10 (Proof: steepest ascent)**.** Prove that among all unit vectors $\mathbf{u}$, the directional derivative $D_{\mathbf{u}}f = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u}$ is maximized when $\mathbf{u}$ points along ∇f, and that the maximum value is $\|\nabla f\|$. (Use the identity $\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{u} = \|\nabla f\| \cos\theta$ and explain why $\cos\theta = 1$ is forced. State clearly where you use $\|\mathbf{u}\| = 1$.)

Exercise 33.11 (Proof: gradient perpendicular to level sets)**.** Suppose a differentiable path $\mathbf{r}(t) = (x(t), y(t))$ lies entirely on the level curve $f(x, y) = c$. Differentiate the identity $f(x(t), y(t)) = c$ with respect to t and use the chain rule to conclude that $\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{r}\,'(t) = 0$. Explain in one sentence why this proves ∇f is perpendicular to the level curve.

Exercise 33.12 (Lagrange multipliers on a circle)**.** Find the maximum and minimum values of the linear objective $f(x, y) = x + 2y$ subject to the circular constraint $x^2 + y^2 = 5$.

(a) Set up the Lagrange system $\nabla f = \lambda \nabla g$ and solve for the critical points (x, y) and multipliers λ.

(b) Calculate the maximum and minimum values f^*.

(c) Describe the geometric picture: what do the level lines $x + 2y = c$ look like, and where are they tangent to the circle?

Exercise 33.13 (Mental check: shadow price in production)**.** A factory produces output $P(x, y)$ from labor x and capital y subject to a total budget constraint $20x + 50y = B$. At the current budget $B = \$10{,}000$, the manager optimizes production using Lagrange multipliers and finds $\lambda = 1.4$.

(a) Using the identity $\frac{\mathrm{d}P^*}{\mathrm{d}B} = \lambda$, estimate the increase in maximum production if the company increases its budget by $\Delta B = \$500$.

(b) What would $\lambda = 0$ have implied about the budget constraint?

Chapter 34

Multiple Integrals

Chapters 32 and 33 zoomed in on functions of several variables to read off local slopes and tangent planes. This chapter zooms out and adds such a function up across a whole region of the plane or a solid in space.

Back in Chapter 20 we built the single integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ out of one stubbornly simple idea: chop the interval $[a, b]$ into tiny pieces, build a thin rectangle over each piece, add up their areas, and watch the sum settle onto a number as the pieces shrink. The picture was a curve over a line, and the answer was the area trapped between them.

Now the domain grows a dimension. Instead of integrating over an interval on the x-axis, we integrate over a *region* in the xy-plane – a disk, a triangle, a blob bounded by two curves. The graph of our function $f(x, y)$ is no longer a curve but a *surface* floating above that region, and the thing we add up is no longer area but *volume*: the volume of the solid trapped between the region on the floor and the surface overhead.

The underlying idea has not changed at all: chop the region into tiny pieces, estimate the contribution on each piece, add them up, and take the limit. What is new is how we actually compute that sum: how to break a two-dimensional integral into two ordinary integrals done one variable at a time (**iteration**, via Fubini's theorem), and how to switch to curved coordinates when the region calls for them (**change of variables**, via the Jacobian determinant). Those two tools are the heart of this chapter.

Focus

A single integral adds a function over an *interval* and measures *area*. A double integral adds a function over a *planar region* and measures *volume*. The definition is the same Riemann sum (an approximating sum of tiny column volumes), just with little patches of area ΔA instead of little widths Δx. Everything hard is bookkeeping: how to organize the sum (Fubini) and how to bend the coordinate grid without losing track of area (the Jacobian).

34.1 The double integral as volume and as accumulation

34.1.1 Two readings of the same sum

When you met $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ you learned to read it two ways at once, and both readings will carry over. The *geometric* reading: it is the signed area under the graph of f. The *accumulation* reading: if $f(x)$ is a density-per-unit-length, then the integral is the total stuff. A double integral has exactly these same two faces.

Geometric reading. Let R be a region in the xy-plane and let $f(x,y) \geq 0$ be a function defined on it. The graph $z = f(x,y)$ is a surface hovering above the plane. The double integral

$$\iint_R f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}A$$

is the *volume* of the solid that sits over R and reaches up to the surface. When f dips below zero the contribution is negative, exactly as area went negative for the single integral when the curve dipped below the axis.

Accumulation reading. Suppose a flat metal plate occupies the region R, and $f(x,y)$ is its *density* – grams per square centimeter – which may vary from point to point. Then $\iint_R f\,\mathrm{d}A$ is the total *mass* of the plate. Here there is no surface and no volume in sight; we are simply adding up a quantity that is spread out over an area, weighting each tiny patch by how much stuff sits on it. Population over a county, rainfall over a watershed, charge over a sheet – all the same integral.

Intuition

Think of $\mathrm{d}A$ as an *infinitesimal tile* of the floor, and $f(x,y)$ as "how tall the building is" (volume reading) or "how heavy this tile is" (mass reading) at that spot. The integral lays down infinitely many infinitely small tiles over the whole region, multiplies each by its height-or-weight, and sums. The $\iint$ – a double S – is just two nested "sum" signs, one for each direction you have to sweep across the floor.

34.1.2 The Riemann sum, from scratch

Let us build the thing so the definition is not a mystery. To keep the picture clean, start with a region that is a rectangle, $R = [a,b] \times [c,d]$ – all points (x,y) with $a \leq x \leq b$ and $c \leq y \leq d$.

Cut $[a,b]$ into m equal sub-intervals of width $\Delta x = (b-a)/m$, and cut $[c,d]$ into n equal sub-intervals of height $\Delta y = (d-c)/n$. The grid lines slice R into $m \cdot n$ little rectangles, each of area

$$\Delta A = \Delta x\,\Delta y.$$

In the (i,j)-th little rectangle pick any sample point $(x_i^*,\, y_j^*)$. Over that rectangle, build a thin rectangular *box* whose base is the little rectangle and whose height is the value of the function there, $f(x_i^*, y_j^*)$. The volume of that one box is height times base area,

$$f(x_i^*, y_j^*)\,\Delta A.$$

Now add up all $m \cdot n$ boxes to obtain an approximation to the total volume under the surface:

$$S_{m,n} = \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{j=1}^{n} f(x_i^*, y_j^*)\,\Delta A.$$

This double sum is the two-dimensional Riemann sum.

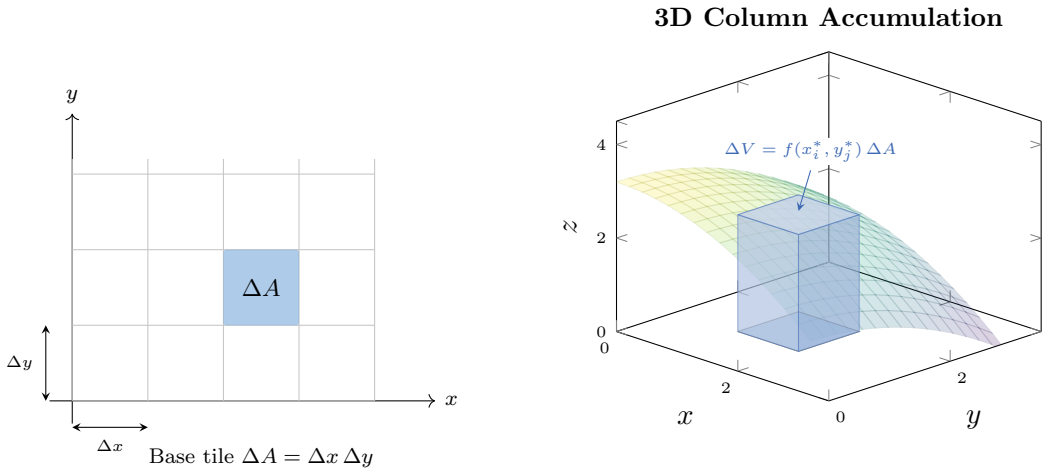


Figure 34.1: The double Riemann sum approximating the volume under a surface. Left: The domain rectangle R is partitioned into small tiles of area $\Delta A = \Delta x\,\Delta y$. Right: Over each tile, we erect a rectangular column of height $f(x_i^*, y_j^*)$. The volume of the column is $\Delta V = f(x_i^*, y_j^*)\,\Delta A$. As the grid is refined, the sum of column volumes converges to the total volume under the surface $z = f(x, y)$.

If, as we make the grid finer and finer ($m, n \to \infty$, so $\Delta x, \Delta y \to 0$), this sum approaches one and the same number no matter how we chose the sample points, we call that number the **double integral**.

Definition 34.1 (Double integral over a rectangle)**.** Let f be defined on $R = [a, b] \times [c, d]$. If the Riemann sums $S_{m,n}$ above converge to a single limit L as $m, n \to \infty$, independent of the choice of sample points, then f is *integrable* on R and we write

$$\iint_R f(x, y)\,\mathrm{d}A = L.$$

As in the single-variable setting, every continuous function on a closed rectangle is integrable: continuity forces the Riemann sums to settle on a single limit as the grid is refined. The same holds on any closed bounded region with a reasonably tame boundary, as the next subsection explains.

What is really happening

What does the differential $\mathrm{d}A$ represent geometrically? In the finite Riemann sum, we multiply width Δx by height Δy to get the tile area $\Delta A = \Delta x\,\Delta y$, and weight f by that area. In the limit, $\mathrm{d}A$ denotes the infinitesimal area element. The symbol $\mathrm{d}A$ takes different forms depending on the coordinate system: $\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y$ in Cartesian coordinates, $r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$ in polar coordinates, and $|\det J|\,\mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$ under a general transformation. Each expression reflects the area of an infinitesimal coordinate cell under that choice of coordinates.

34.1.3 Regions that are not rectangles

Real regions are rarely rectangles. To integrate over a triangle or a disk, do the obvious thing: pretend f is zero outside the region. Enclose the region R inside a big rectangle, define a new

function that equals f on R and equals 0 everywhere else in the rectangle, and integrate *that* over the rectangle. Tiles that fall outside R contribute nothing; tiles inside contribute $f\,\Delta A$ as before. The boundary tiles, the ones the curve slices through, are a vanishing fraction of the total as the grid shrinks, so they do not corrupt the limit. This little trick lets Definition 34.1 cover any reasonable region without new ideas.

Focus

Useful sanity checks you will use constantly:

- $\iint_R 1\,\mathrm{d}A =$ area of R. (Height 1 everywhere, so the "volume" is just area times height = area.)
- $\iint_R c\,f\,\mathrm{d}A = c\iint_R f\,\mathrm{d}A$ and the integral of a sum is the sum of the integrals – linearity, inherited straight from the sums.
- If R splits into two non-overlapping pieces R_1 and R_2, then $\iint_R = \iint_{R_1} + \iint_{R_2}$. Cut the region, add the volumes.

Pause

Pause and think. Before calculating anything by formulas, evaluate $\iint_R (x^3 + \sin y)\,\mathrm{d}A$ over the square $R = [-1, 1] \times [-1, 1]$.
Answer: Exactly 0. The surface overhead has two components: x^3 is odd across the y-axis (meaning for every positive value at (x, y) there is a matching negative value over $(-x, y)$), and $\sin y$ is odd across the x-axis. By symmetry, the positive and negative volumes cancel out completely. Spotting symmetry before computing integrals is one of the most useful habits in multivariable calculus.

34.2 Iterated integrals and Fubini's theorem

A double sum $\sum_i \sum_j$ is intimidating only until you remember you are allowed to do the two sums *one at a time*. Fix a column, add up that column, then add up the column-totals. The continuous analogue of that regrouping is the foundational computational tool of this chapter: **Fubini's theorem**, which states that a double integral can be evaluated as two nested single integrals.

34.2.1 The idea: volume by slices

Here is the picture that makes Fubini obvious. You already know one way to find a volume from Chapter 26: slice the solid into thin slabs and add the slab volumes.

Take our solid under $z = f(x, y)$ over the rectangle $[a, b] \times [c, d]$. Slice it with a plane $x =$ const, perpendicular to the x-axis. The slice is a thin slab. Its *cross-sectional area* is the area under the curve $z = f(x, y)$ as y runs from c to d – with x held fixed – which is just a single integral,

$$A(x) = \int_c^d f(x, y)\,\mathrm{d}y.$$

The slab has thickness $\mathrm{d}x$, so its volume is $A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$. Add up the slabs from $x = a$ to $x = b$:

$$\text{Volume} = \int_a^b A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_a^b \left(\int_c^d f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}y \right) \mathrm{d}x.$$

That nested expression is an *iterated integral*. We just sliced the solid the long way and added the slices.

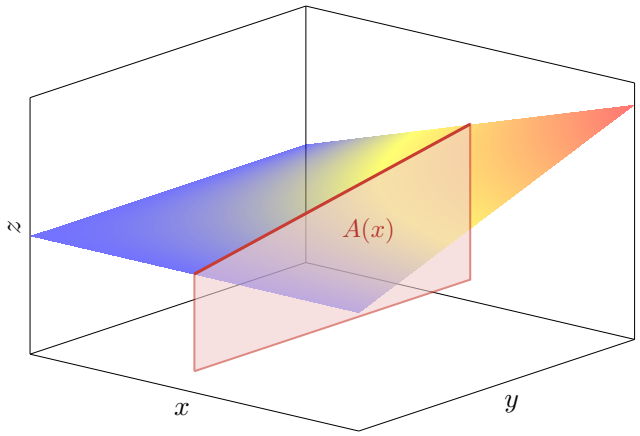


Figure 34.2: Slicing the solid at a fixed x gives a slab whose face area is $A(x) = \int_c^d f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}y$ (the red profile). Adding the slabs $A(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ from a to b rebuilds the volume. That is Fubini.

But we could just as well have sliced the *other* way, with planes $y = \text{const}$, giving

$$\text{Volume} = \int_c^d \left(\int_a^b f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}x \right) \mathrm{d}y.$$

The solid does not care which way you slice it. Both iterated integrals equal the same volume, hence equal each other. That equality – and the fact that either equals the genuine double integral $\iint_R f\,\mathrm{d}A$ – is the content of Fubini.

Theorem 34.1 (Fubini, for nice functions)**.** *If f is continuous on the rectangle $R = [a,b] \times [c,d]$, then*

$$\iint_R f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}A = \int_a^b \int_c^d f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}y\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_c^d \int_a^b f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y.$$

In particular both orders of integration give the same answer, and both equal the double integral.

Why the technique works

Why is the iterated integral allowed to replace the double sum at all? Because addition does not care how you group it. In the Riemann sum $\sum_i \sum_j f(x_i^*, y_j^*)\,\Delta x\,\Delta y$, factor the constant Δx out of the inner sum:

$$\sum_i \Bigg(\underbrace{\sum_j f(x_i^*, y_j^*)\,\Delta y}_{\approx A(x_i^*)} \Bigg) \Delta x.$$

The inner sum is a Riemann sum in y alone; as the grid refines it becomes $\int_c^d f(x_i^*, y)\,\mathrm{d}y =$

$A(x_i^*)$. The outer sum is then a Riemann sum of $A(x)$ in x, becoming $\int_a^b A(x)\,dx$. So Fubini's theorem represents "do the y-sum first, then the x-sum," the freedom to regroup a sum, carried through the limit. The one piece of fine print – which is why Fubini is a *theorem* and not a triviality – is checking that the limits can be taken in this nested order; continuity (more generally, $\iint |f|\,dA < \infty$) is what licenses it.

Connection

Fine print: when is order-swapping safe? Iterating integrals by slicing was standard practice for Newton, Euler, and the Bernoullis in the 1600s and 1700s, who sliced solids and added slices without worrying about order. But swapping integrals is not always legal: if a function oscillates wildly toward infinity, the two orders can yield genuinely different numbers. In 1907, Guido Fubini proved the exact condition: swapping the order is guaranteed safe whenever the function is *absolutely integrable* ($\iint_R |f|\,dA < \infty$). Every continuous function on a closed, bounded region satisfies this, and a nonnegative integrand can always be swapped (as in the Gaussian integral below), so every swap in this chapter is legitimate.

34.2.2 A first computation

Example 34.1 (A double integral over a rectangle)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\iint_R (x+2y)\,dA$ over $R = [0,2]\times[0,3]$.

Integrate in y first, treating x as a constant:

$$\int_0^3 (x+2y)\,dy = \Big[xy + y^2\Big]_0^3 = 3x + 9.$$

Now integrate that in x:

$$\int_0^2 (3x+9)\,dx = \Big[\tfrac{3}{2}x^2 + 9x\Big]_0^2 = 6 + 18 = 24.$$

As a check, slice the other way – x first:

$$\int_0^2 (x+2y)\,dx = \Big[\tfrac{1}{2}x^2 + 2xy\Big]_0^2 = 2 + 4y, \qquad \int_0^3 (2+4y)\,dy = \Big[2y + 2y^2\Big]_0^3 = 6 + 18 = 24.$$

Same number, as Fubini promised.

Common trap

The bounds and the differentials must match up *from the inside out*. In $\int_a^b\int_c^d f\,dy\,dx$, the inner differential dy pairs with the inner limits c, d, and the outer dx pairs with a, b. A frequent disaster is writing the limits in the wrong order, so that x ends up "integrated" over y's interval. Read the integral inside-out, like nested parentheses, and keep each variable with its own bounds.

34.2.3 Non-rectangular regions: variable bounds

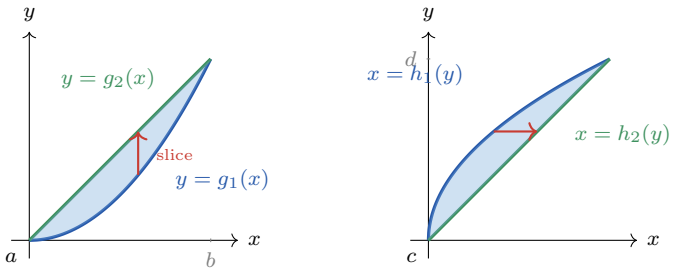
For a rectangle the inner limits are constants. For a curvy region they are *functions*, because the cross-section changes length as you sweep across. There are two standard shapes.

A region is *y-simple* (vertically simple) if it sits between two curves $y = g_1(x)$ below and $y = g_2(x)$ above, for x in some interval $[a, b]$. Slice it vertically: at each fixed x, y runs from the bottom curve to the top curve.

$$\iint_R f \, \mathrm{d}A = \int_a^b \int_{g_1(x)}^{g_2(x)} f(x, y) \, \mathrm{d}y \, \mathrm{d}x.$$

A region is *x-simple* (horizontally simple) if it lies between $x = h_1(y)$ on the left and $x = h_2(y)$ on the right, for y in $[c, d]$:

$$\iint_R f \, \mathrm{d}A = \int_c^d \int_{h_1(y)}^{h_2(y)} f(x, y) \, \mathrm{d}x \, \mathrm{d}y.$$



y-simple: vertical slices x-simple: horizontal slices

Figure 34.3: Comparing slice directions for non-rectangular regions. Left: A y-simple region sliced vertically. For each fixed $x \in [a, b]$, the inner variable y runs from the lower boundary $y = g_1(x)$ to the upper boundary $y = g_2(x)$. Right: An x-simple region sliced horizontally. For each fixed $y \in [c, d]$, the inner variable x runs from the left boundary $x = h_1(y)$ to the right boundary $x = h_2(y)$.

Example 34.2 (A triangular region)**.** Integrate $f(x, y) = x$ over the triangle R with vertices $(0, 0)$, $(1, 0)$, $(1, 1)$. The hypotenuse is the line $y = x$; the bottom is $y = 0$; the right edge is $x = 1$. Treating R as y-simple: for each $x \in [0, 1]$, y runs from 0 up to x.

$$\iint_R x \, \mathrm{d}A = \int_0^1 \int_0^x x \, \mathrm{d}y \, \mathrm{d}x = \int_0^1 x \cdot \Big[y \Big]_0^x \mathrm{d}x = \int_0^1 x \cdot x \, \mathrm{d}x = \int_0^1 x^2 \, \mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{3}.$$

34.2.4 Changing the order of integration

Changing the order of integration is one of the most effective tools in multivariable calculus. Frequently one order involves an inner integral with no elementary antiderivative, while reversing the order introduces a factor that makes integration straightforward. The procedure is systematic: **draw the region**, determine the limits in the reverse order, and evaluate.

Example 34.3 (An integral you cannot do in the given order)**.** Evaluate

$$I = \int_0^1 \int_x^1 e^{y^2} \, \mathrm{d}y \, \mathrm{d}x.$$

The inner integral $\int e^{y^2}\,dy$ has *no* elementary antiderivative – you are stuck cold. So change the order.

First decode the region from the bounds as written: x goes from 0 to 1, and for each x, y goes from $y = x$ up to $y = 1$. That is the triangle bounded by $y = x$, $y = 1$, and $x = 0$ – the triangle with vertices $(0, 0)$, $(0, 1)$, $(1, 1)$.

Now describe the *same* triangle as x-simple. Let y run from 0 to 1; for each y, x runs from the left edge $x = 0$ to the right edge $x = y$ (the line $y = x$ solved for x). So

$$I = \int_0^1 \int_0^y e^{y^2}\,dx\,dy.$$

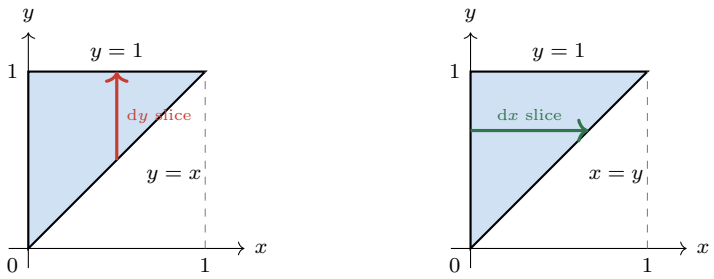
Now the inner integral is trivial – e^{y^2} is constant in x:

$$\int_0^y e^{y^2}\,dx = y\,e^{y^2}, \qquad I = \int_0^1 y\,e^{y^2}\,dy.$$

And *that* we can do, with the substitution $u = y^2$, $du = 2y\,dy$:

$$I = \frac{1}{2}\int_0^1 e^u\,du = \frac{1}{2}(e - 1).$$

The same region, swept the other direction, turned an impossible integral into a one-line substitution.



Given: vertical slice (y from x to 1) Reversed: horizontal slice (x from 0 to y)

Figure 34.4: Reversing the order of integration for Example 34.3. The triangular region is identical in both panels. Left: Slicing vertically requires an inner integral $\int_x^1 e^{y^2}\,dy$, which has no elementary antiderivative. Right: Slicing horizontally swaps the inner variable to x, where e^{y^2} is constant across the slice. The inner integral trivially produces $y\,e^{y^2}$, setting up an easy u-substitution.

Walking question

Take Example 34.3 on your walk. The number $\frac{1}{2}(e-1)$ never needed the antiderivative of e^{y^2} – yet the inner integral as first written *was* that forbidden antiderivative. How can a quantity be perfectly computable while one route to it is blocked? (Hint: the blocked route asks for the antiderivative as a *function of* x; the open route only ever needs a *definite* integral, a single number. The double integral is a number; only our bookkeeping made it look like it needed a forbidden function.)

Common trap

When you flip the order, you must re-derive the limits from the *geometry*, not by mechanically swapping the symbols. Swapping $\int_0^1 \int_x^1 \, dy\, dx$ into $\int_0^1 \int_x^1 \, dx\, dy$ is nonsense – you cannot have x in the limits of an x-integral. Sketch the region every single time; let the picture tell you the new bounds.

34.3 Polar coordinates and the Gaussian integral

Many regions are awkward to describe in rectangular coordinates. For domains with circular symmetry – disks, annuli, and circular sectors – the natural geometric parameters are radial distance and angle: **polar coordinates**

$$x = r\cos\theta, \qquad y = r\sin\theta,$$

where $r \geq 0$ is the distance from the origin and θ is the angle. A disk of radius a is simply $0 \leq r \leq a$, $0 \leq \theta \leq 2\pi$ – a rectangle in the (r, θ) world.

34.3.1 Why the polar area element carries an extra factor of r

Here is the subtlety that trips up everyone the first time. In rectangular coordinates, $dA = dx\, dy$, because a little grid cell is a tiny rectangle of width dx and height dy. In polar coordinates, dA is

$$\boxed{dA = r\, dr\, d\theta}$$

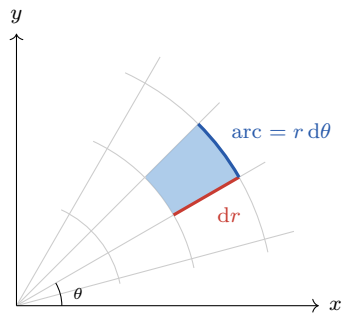
not $dr\, d\theta$. Seeing where that extra factor of r comes from is our first glimpse of the general change-of-variables rule that closes the chapter.

What is really happening

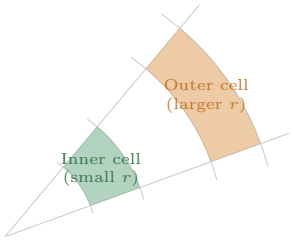
Picture the polar grid: circles of constant r and rays of constant θ. The little cell between radius r and $r + dr$, and between angle θ and $\theta + d\theta$, is *not* a rectangle of sides dr and $d\theta$. Its two "radial" sides do have length dr. But its two "arc" sides are pieces of circles, and the length of a circular arc is radius times angle: $r\, d\theta$. So the cell is (very nearly) a rectangle of sides dr and $r\, d\theta$, with area

$$dA = (dr)(r\, d\theta) = r\, dr\, d\theta.$$

Out at a larger radius r, the same angular wedge $d\theta$ sweeps out a wider arc, so the tiles grow larger as you move away from the origin – and the factor r tracks that growth.



$\mathrm{d}A \approx (\mathrm{d}r)(r\,\mathrm{d}\theta) = r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$



Same Δr and $\Delta\theta$, but different area!
Area scales linearly with radius r.

Figure 34.5: Why the polar area element carries an extra factor of r. Left: A polar tile is bounded by two rays separated by $\mathrm{d}\theta$ and two circular arcs separated by $\mathrm{d}r$. Its circumferential width is the arc length $r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$, yielding area $\mathrm{d}A = r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$. Right: Comparing two cells of identical Δr and $\Delta\theta$ at different radii demonstrates that tiles naturally widen as you move outward. The factor r accounts for this geometric expansion.

So the conversion rule is: replace $x \to r\cos\theta$, $y \to r\sin\theta$, and $\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y \to r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$, then set the limits as r- and θ-ranges.

$$\iint_R f(x,y)\,\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y = \iint_{R'} f(r\cos\theta,\, r\sin\theta)\; r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta.$$

Example 34.4 (Area of a disk)**.** Take $f = 1$ over the disk of radius a. In polar:

$$\iint_R 1\,\mathrm{d}A = \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{a} 1\cdot r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta = \int_0^{2\pi}\left[\tfrac{1}{2}r^2\right]_0^{a}\mathrm{d}\theta = \int_0^{2\pi}\frac{a^2}{2}\,\mathrm{d}\theta = \pi a^2.$$

The factor r is exactly what produces the familiar πa^2; Exercise 34.12 asks what goes wrong without it.

Pause

Pause and think. Suppose you need the area of the upper half-disk $R = \{(x,y) : x^2 + y^2 \le a^2,\ y \ge 0\}$. What are the integration limits in polar coordinates, and what does the integral compute?

Answer: Radius r sweeps from 0 to a, but angle θ only sweeps from 0 to π (the upper half-plane). The integral is $\int_0^{\pi}\int_0^{a} r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta = \pi\cdot\frac{1}{2}a^2 = \frac{1}{2}\pi a^2$, exactly half the area of the full disk. The geometry sets the angle limits instantly.

34.3.2 The Gaussian integral: evaluating $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$

We can now evaluate one of the most important integrals in analysis, probability, and physics:

$$I = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

The function e^{-x^2} has no elementary antiderivative, so standard single-variable techniques cannot evaluate it directly. Yet the value is exactly $\sqrt{\pi}$. The classical trick, usually credited to Poisson,

proceeds by squaring the integral, viewing I^2 as a double integral over $\mathbb{R}^2$, and converting to polar coordinates.

Example 34.5 ($\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x = \sqrt{\pi}$)**.** We cannot find I directly, so consider I^2. Because the integral is just a number, we may name the dummy variable of the second copy differently – call it y:

$$I^2 = \left(\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x\right)\left(\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-y^2}\,\mathrm{d}y\right) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty}\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}e^{-y^2}\,\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y.$$

The key algebraic property is the radial factorization $e^{-x^2}e^{-y^2} = e^{-(x^2+y^2)}$. The integrand depends on (x, y) only through $x^2 + y^2 = r^2$, exhibiting radial symmetry. Converting to polar coordinates turns this into an elementary integral. The region is the whole plane, so r runs 0 to ∞ and θ runs 0 to 2π. (Is it fair to fill the plane with growing disks instead of growing squares? Yes: the square $[-R, R]^2$ contains the disk of radius R and sits inside the disk of radius $\sqrt{2}R$, and the integrand is positive, so the square integral is trapped between two disk integrals with the same limit.) With $x^2 + y^2 = r^2$ and the mandatory $\mathrm{d}A = r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$:

$$I^2 = \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty} e^{-r^2}\,r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta.$$

Here the area factor r in $\mathrm{d}A = r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$ provides the exact factor needed for substitution. Setting $u = r^2$, $\mathrm{d}u = 2r\,\mathrm{d}r$:

$$\int_0^{\infty} e^{-r^2}\,r\,\mathrm{d}r = \frac{1}{2}\int_0^{\infty} e^{-u}\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{2}\Big[-e^{-u}\Big]_0^{\infty} = \frac{1}{2}.$$

Therefore

$$I^2 = \int_0^{2\pi}\frac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{d}\theta = \frac{1}{2}\cdot 2\pi = \pi, \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad I = \sqrt{\pi}.$$

Why this matters

A one-dimensional integral with no elementary antiderivative was evaluated by passing to two dimensions, where radial symmetry could be exploited. The polar factor r in the area element supplied precisely the factor needed to evaluate the radial antiderivative. Lifting a problem to a higher-dimensional setting where new geometric symmetries become available is a recurring and powerful technique in mathematics.

Application

The bell curve of statistics is $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}\,\sigma}e^{-(x-\mu)^2/2\sigma^2}$. The strange-looking constant $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}}$ is there for exactly one reason: so the total probability integrates to 1. Substituting $x = \mu + \sqrt{2}\,\sigma t$ turns $\int e^{-(x-\mu)^2/2\sigma^2}\,\mathrm{d}x$ into $\sqrt{2}\,\sigma\int e^{-t^2}\,\mathrm{d}t = \sqrt{2}\,\sigma\sqrt{\pi} = \sqrt{2\pi}\,\sigma$, and dividing by that total forces the normalizing constant. Every time a statistician, physicist, or machine-learning engineer writes down a Gaussian, the $\sqrt{2\pi}$ they carry around is a direct descendant of the polar computation you just did.

34.4 Triple integrals

Add one more dimension and nothing conceptually changes. A **triple integral**

$$\iiint_E f(x, y, z)\,\mathrm{d}V$$

chops a solid region $E \subset \mathbb{R}^3$ into tiny boxes of volume $\mathrm{d}V = \mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y\,\mathrm{d}z$, weights each by f, and sums. Fubini still holds: evaluate it as three nested single integrals, in any of the six orders, with the inner limits possibly functions of the outer variables.

34.4.1 What it measures

If $f = 1$, the triple integral is the *volume* of E: $\iiint_E 1\,\mathrm{d}V = \mathrm{Vol}(E)$. (Just as $\iint 1\,\mathrm{d}A$ was area.) If f is a density – mass per unit volume – the integral is the total *mass* of a solid body. There is no "graph" picture this time, because the graph $w = f(x, y, z)$ would live in four dimensions; the accumulation reading is the one to hold onto. We are summing a quantity spread through a three-dimensional body.

Example 34.6 (Volume of a tetrahedron)**.** Find the volume of the solid E bounded by the coordinate planes and the plane $x+y+z = 1$ (the corner of the unit cube cut by a slanted plane). Sweep z first: for fixed (x, y) in the base triangle, z runs from the floor $z = 0$ up to the slanted roof $z = 1 - x - y$. The base triangle (where the roof is still above the floor, i.e. $1-x-y \geq 0$) is $0 \leq y \leq 1-x$, $0 \leq x \leq 1$. So

$$\mathrm{Vol}(E) = \int_0^1 \int_0^{1-x} \int_0^{1-x-y} 1\,\mathrm{d}z\,\mathrm{d}y\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

Innermost: $\int_0^{1-x-y} \mathrm{d}z = 1 - x - y$. Middle:

$$\int_0^{1-x} (1 - x - y)\,\mathrm{d}y = \Big[(1-x)y - \tfrac{1}{2}y^2\Big]_0^{1-x} = (1-x)^2 - \tfrac{1}{2}(1-x)^2 = \tfrac{1}{2}(1-x)^2.$$

Outermost, with $u = 1 - x$:

$$\int_0^1 \tfrac{1}{2}(1-x)^2\,\mathrm{d}x = \frac{1}{2}\int_0^1 u^2\,\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{2}\cdot\frac{1}{3} = \frac{1}{6}.$$

The volume is $\frac{1}{6}$, the familiar volume of that corner tetrahedron.

Work it yourself

Confirm $\frac{1}{6}$ a second way. Treat the tetrahedron as a stack of horizontal triangular slices at height z. At height z, the cross-section is the triangle $x + y \leq 1 - z$, $x, y \geq 0$, a right triangle of legs $1 - z$, so of area $\frac{1}{2}(1-z)^2$. Then Vol $= \int_0^1 \frac{1}{2}(1-z)^2\,\mathrm{d}z = \frac{1}{6}$. Two slicing orders, one answer – Fubini in three dimensions, by hand.

34.4.2 Cylindrical and spherical coordinates

Just as planar circular regions motivate polar coordinates, solids with axial or spherical symmetry are most naturally evaluated in *cylindrical* or *spherical* coordinates, where the geometry of coordinate cells determines the volume element.

Cylindrical coordinates are just polar in the xy-plane with z left alone: $x = r\cos\theta$, $y = r\sin\theta$, $z = z$. A cell is a polar cell ($r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$ of floor area) times a height $\mathrm{d}z$, so

$$\mathrm{d}V = r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta\,\mathrm{d}z.$$

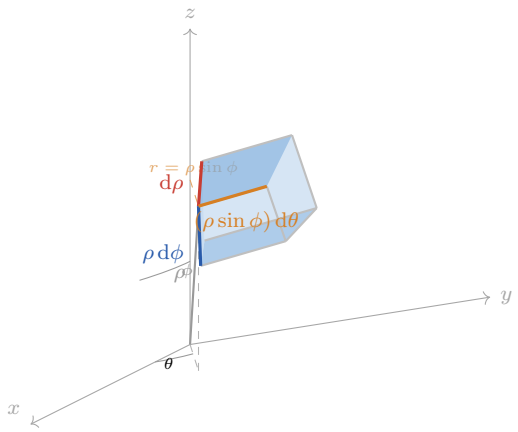
The same factor r as before, for the same arc-length reason.

Spherical coordinates measure a point by its distance ρ from the origin, the angle ϕ down from the positive z-axis (the "polar angle" or colatitude, measuring how far you tip from the vertical pole), and the angle θ around the z-axis (the "azimuth", the horizontal compass direction):

$$x = \rho \sin\phi \cos\theta, \quad y = \rho \sin\phi \sin\theta, \quad z = \rho \cos\phi.$$

A spherical cell has three mutually perpendicular edges. The radial edge has length $\mathrm{d}\rho$, and the ϕ-edge is an arc of radius ρ with length $\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi$. Finally, the θ-edge is a horizontal arc of radius $\rho\sin\phi$ (the distance from the z-axis), giving length $\rho\sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta$. Multiply the three edge lengths:

$$\boxed{\mathrm{d}V = \rho^2 \sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta}$$



$$\mathrm{d}V = (\mathrm{d}\rho)\,(\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi)\,(\rho\sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta) = \rho^2 \sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta$$

Figure 34.6: Geometry of the spherical volume element $\mathrm{d}V$. A tiny spherical cell is bounded by surfaces of constant ρ, ϕ, and θ. Because these coordinate curves intersect at right angles, the cell forms an infinitesimal box with radial thickness $\mathrm{d}\rho$, meridional height $\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi$, and circumferential width $(\rho\sin\phi)\,\mathrm{d}\theta$ (along a circle of latitude with radius $r = \rho\sin\phi$). Multiplying the three perpendicular dimensions yields $\mathrm{d}V = \rho^2\sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta$.

What is really happening

Do not memorize $\rho^2\sin\phi$ – *rebuild* it. The cell is nearly a little box with three perpendicular edges of lengths $\mathrm{d}\rho$, $\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi$, and $\rho\sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta$. Multiplying: $\rho\cdot\rho\sin\phi = \rho^2\sin\phi$ out front, then $\mathrm{d}\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta$. Each factor is just an arc length, "radius times angle," for the circle that that coordinate sweeps along. The $\sin\phi$ appears because circles of constant latitude shrink toward the poles: near the north pole ($\phi \approx 0$) a full lap in θ covers almost no distance, and $\sin\phi \to 0$ records it.

Example 34.7 (Volume of a ball, finally)**.** The ball of radius a is $0 \le \rho \le a$, $0 \le \phi \le \pi$, $0 \le \theta \le 2\pi$ – a box in spherical coordinates. With $f = 1$:

$$\mathrm{Vol} = \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\pi}\int_0^{a} \rho^2 \sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta.$$

The three integrals separate because each factor depends on a single variable:

$$\int_0^a \rho^2 \, \mathrm{d}\rho = \frac{a^3}{3}, \qquad \int_0^\pi \sin\phi \, \mathrm{d}\phi = \Big[-\cos\phi \Big]_0^\pi = 2, \qquad \int_0^{2\pi} \mathrm{d}\theta = 2\pi.$$

Multiply: $\mathrm{Vol} = \dfrac{a^3}{3} \cdot 2 \cdot 2\pi = \dfrac{4}{3}\pi a^3$. The famous formula, derived rather than recited.

34.5 The Jacobian: change of variables as area scaling

We have derived coordinate scale factors geometrically: r for polar coordinates and $\rho^2 \sin\phi$ for spherical coordinates. In each case the factor arose from the geometry of an infinitesimal coordinate cell. We now establish the general principle governing coordinate transformations in multivariable integrals, connecting it directly to a foundational tool from linear algebra: the **determinant**.

34.5.1 The one-variable rehearsal

The one-dimensional analogue of this principle is integration by substitution (u-substitution). When you substitute $x = g(u)$ in $\int f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$, you replace $\mathrm{d}x$ by $g'(u)\,\mathrm{d}u$:

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_{u_a}^{u_b} f(g(u))\, g'(u)\,\mathrm{d}u.$$

The factor $g'(u)$ is a *stretch factor*: near u, the map g stretches a little interval $\mathrm{d}u$ into an interval of length $|g'(u)|\,\mathrm{d}u$. (We carry an absolute value when we ignore orientation and only care about length.) The substitution rule *is* the statement "account for how much the transformation stretches length."

Why the technique works

The Jacobian is this same idea promoted to two and three dimensions. In one dimension a smooth map stretches lengths by $|g'(u)|$. In two dimensions, a smooth map $(u, v) \mapsto (x, y)$ stretches *areas*, so the local stretch factor is a determinant of partial derivatives rather than a single derivative. Near any point, a smooth map behaves like a *linear* map, and linear algebra tells us that a linear map scales area by the absolute value of its determinant (the intuition box below shows why). Change of variables in a multiple integral is u-substitution with the word "derivative" replaced by the word "determinant," for the simple reason that area-scaling in many dimensions is measured by a determinant.

34.5.2 Why a determinant: linearization

Let a transformation T carry the uv-plane to the xy-plane:

$$x = x(u, v), \qquad y = y(u, v).$$

Take a tiny rectangle in the uv-plane with corner at (u, v) and sides $\mathrm{d}u$ (along the u-axis) and $\mathrm{d}v$ (along the v-axis). Where does T send it? Each corner moves, and because the rectangle is tiny,

T acts on it almost *linearly*: the image is (very nearly) a parallelogram. The side that was $\mathrm{d}u\,\mathbf{e}_u$ becomes the vector

$$\mathbf{a} = \left(\frac{\partial x}{\partial u}, \frac{\partial y}{\partial u}\right) \mathrm{d}u,$$

because moving by $\mathrm{d}u$ in the u-direction changes x by $\frac{\partial x}{\partial u}\mathrm{d}u$ and y by $\frac{\partial y}{\partial u}\mathrm{d}u$. Likewise the $\mathrm{d}v$ side becomes

$$\mathbf{b} = \left(\frac{\partial x}{\partial v}, \frac{\partial y}{\partial v}\right) \mathrm{d}v.$$

The image cell is the parallelogram spanned by $\mathbf{a}$ and $\mathbf{b}$, and the area of a parallelogram spanned by two vectors is the absolute value of the 2×2 determinant of their components:

$$\mathrm{d}A_{xy} = \left|\det \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial x}{\partial u} & \frac{\partial x}{\partial v} \\ \frac{\partial y}{\partial u} & \frac{\partial y}{\partial v} \end{pmatrix}\right| \mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v.$$

Intuition

Why the determinant measures area. Take two vectors $\mathbf{a} = (a_1, a_2)$ and $\mathbf{b} = (b_1, b_2)$ with all four components nonnegative and $\mathbf{b}$ steeper than $\mathbf{a}$, as in Figure 34.7. Why does the parallelogram they span have area $a_1b_2 - a_2b_1$? Enclose it in the bounding box from $(0, 0)$ to $(a_1 + b_1,\ a_2 + b_2)$, whose area is $(a_1 + b_1)(a_2 + b_2) = a_1a_2 + a_1b_2 + a_2b_1 + b_1b_2$. Six pieces of the box lie outside the parallelogram. Two $b_1 \times a_2$ rectangles sit in the top-left and bottom-right corners (combined area $2a_2b_1$). Alongside them sit two right triangles with legs a_1, a_2 along $\mathbf{a}$ and its opposite side (combined area a_1a_2), plus two right triangles with legs b_1, b_2 along $\mathbf{b}$ and its opposite side (combined area b_1b_2). Subtracting them leaves

$$(a_1 + b_1)(a_2 + b_2) - 2a_2b_1 - a_1a_2 - b_1b_2 = a_1b_2 - a_2b_1.$$

Swapping the roles of $\mathbf{a}$ and $\mathbf{b}$ flips the sign, and rotating or reflecting the picture changes neither the area nor $|a_1b_2 - a_2b_1|$. (If the angle between the vectors exceeds a right angle, first replace $\mathbf{b}$ by $-\mathbf{b}$, which spans a congruent parallelogram.) Every pair can be moved into the pictured position this way, so $|a_1b_2 - a_2b_1|$ is the area for every pair of vectors. The sign records orientation: whether $\mathbf{b}$ lies counterclockwise or clockwise from $\mathbf{a}$.

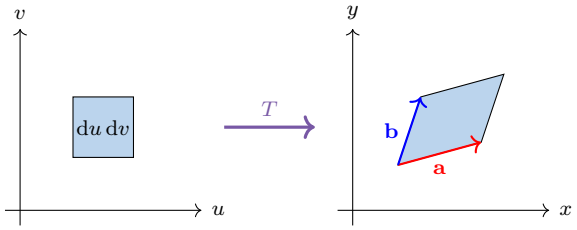


Figure 34.7: Under a smooth map T, a tiny rectangle becomes a tiny parallelogram. Its area is $|\det|\ \mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$, where the determinant is built from the partial derivatives. That determinant is the Jacobian.

That determinant has a name.

Definition 34.2 (Jacobian)**.** For a transformation $x = x(u, v)$, $y = y(u, v)$, the *Jacobian determinant* is

$$\frac{\partial(x, y)}{\partial(u, v)} = \det\begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial x}{\partial u} & \frac{\partial x}{\partial v} \\ \frac{\partial y}{\partial u} & \frac{\partial y}{\partial v} \end{pmatrix} = \frac{\partial x}{\partial u}\frac{\partial y}{\partial v} - \frac{\partial x}{\partial v}\frac{\partial y}{\partial u}.$$

Theorem 34.2 (Change of variables)**.** *If $T : (u, v) \mapsto (x, y)$ is a smooth, invertible map carrying a region S in the uv-plane onto a region R in the xy-plane, then*

$$\iint_R f(x, y)\,\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y = \iint_S f\big(x(u, v), y(u, v)\big)\left|\frac{\partial(x, y)}{\partial(u, v)}\right| \mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v.$$

To change variables in a double integral: substitute the expressions for $x(u, v)$ and $y(u, v)$ into f, replace $\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y$ by the absolute Jacobian determinant times $\mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$, and re-express the limits of integration in the new variables (u, v). This generalizes single-variable u-substitution to multiple dimensions.

Connection

In linear algebra, composing two linear maps multiplies their matrices, and the determinant of a product is the product of the determinants: $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$. Because smooth maps behave locally like linear maps, their area-scaling factors multiply in the exact same way when you chain two coordinate changes together – the multivariable echo of $(f \circ g)' = f' \cdot g'$ in single-variable substitution.

34.5.3 Polar coordinates, re-derived without pictures

We can verify this formula on polar coordinates. For polar coordinates the "new variables" are (r, θ) and $x = r\cos\theta$, $y = r\sin\theta$. The partials:

$$\frac{\partial x}{\partial r} = \cos\theta, \quad \frac{\partial x}{\partial \theta} = -r\sin\theta, \quad \frac{\partial y}{\partial r} = \sin\theta, \quad \frac{\partial y}{\partial \theta} = r\cos\theta.$$

The Jacobian:

$$\frac{\partial(x, y)}{\partial(r, \theta)} = \det\begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta & -r\sin\theta \\ \sin\theta & r\cos\theta \end{pmatrix} = r\cos^2\theta + r\sin^2\theta = r.$$

So $\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y = |r|\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta = r\,\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$ (since $r \geq 0$), exactly the factor we found by staring at one fanned-out cell. The formula and the picture agree, as they must. The spherical factor $\rho^2\sin\phi$ comes out of the analogous 3×3 Jacobian determinant in the same way; computing it is a useful exercise, and the Jacobian formula applies directly even when geometric visualization is difficult.

Example 34.8 (A change of variables that is not polar)**.** Evaluate $\iint_R (x + y)\,\mathrm{d}A$ where R is the parallelogram with vertices $(0, 0)$, $(1, 1)$, $(2, 1)$, $(1, 0)$ – ugly bounds in x, y. Its edges follow the lines $x - y = \text{const}$ and $y = \text{const}$, so set

$$u = x - y, \qquad v = y.$$

Then $x = u + v$, $y = v$. In the new variables R becomes the clean rectangle $0 \leq u \leq 1$, $0 \leq v \leq 1$. The Jacobian:

$$\frac{\partial(x, y)}{\partial(u, v)} = \det\begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial x}{\partial u} & \frac{\partial x}{\partial v} \\ \frac{\partial y}{\partial u} & \frac{\partial y}{\partial v} \end{pmatrix} = \det\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = 1.$$

The map is a shear, and shears preserve area – determinant 1 – so $\mathrm{d}A$ is unchanged. With $x + y = (u + v) + v = u + 2v$:

$$\iint_R (x + y)\,\mathrm{d}A = \int_0^1 \int_0^1 (u + 2v) \cdot 1\,\mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v.$$

Inner: $\int_0^1 (u + 2v)\mathrm{d}u = \frac{1}{2} + 2v$. Outer: $\int_0^1 (\frac{1}{2} + 2v)\mathrm{d}v = \frac{1}{2} + 1 = \frac{3}{2}$. The shear turned a parallelogram into a unit square at no cost, because its Jacobian was 1.

Pause

Pause and think. What is the Jacobian determinant of a pure diagonal scaling transformation $x = 3u, y = 5v$?

Answer: The matrix of partial derivatives is $\begin{pmatrix} 3 & 0 \\ 0 & 5 \end{pmatrix}$, whose determinant is $3 \cdot 5 = 15$. Geometrically, the transformation stretches every horizontal increment $\mathrm{d}u$ by a factor of 3 and every vertical increment $\mathrm{d}v$ by a factor of 5. The area of every tiny tile scales by $3 \times 5 = 15$, so $\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y = 15\,\mathrm{d}u\,\mathrm{d}v$. The Jacobian measures this local area-stretching factor everywhere.

Common trap

Common pitfalls when applying a change of variables:

- Omitting the Jacobian determinant factor entirely.
- Forgetting the absolute value. Area is non-negative; a negative determinant indicates that the mapping reverses orientation, so the local scaling factor is $|\det|$.
- Forgetting to transform the region of integration: substituting expressions into f and inserting the Jacobian while retaining the old Cartesian limits. Changing variables requires re-describing the region in terms of the new coordinates (u, v).

History

The idea of calculating volumes by slicing began in antiquity, but its modern form began with Bonaventura Cavalieri in 1635. Cavalieri proposed that two solids have identical volumes if their cross-sectional slices by parallel planes have equal areas at every height – treating a solid as a stack of flat layers. Cavalieri's "method of indivisibles" drew criticism: critics asked how adding infinitely many slices of zero thickness could produce a solid volume, and the technique worked only when slicing along parallel planes.

In the eighteenth century, Leonhard Euler and Joseph-Louis Lagrange extended slicing to iterated integrals, $\iint \mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y$. But physical problems in gravitation and fluid flow required curved coordinates (polar, spherical, and elliptical). For each new coordinate system, Euler and Lagrange had to re-derive the volume factor by ad-hoc geometric sketches. Mathematicians also routinely swapped the order of integration assuming it was always valid, until Cauchy and others found counterexamples where switching orders gave different values.

The breakthrough unifying coordinate transformations came in 1841 from Carl Gustav Jacob Jacobi. Jacobi showed that near any point, every smooth map $(u, v) \mapsto (x, y)$ behaves like a linear transformation – its derivative matrix – and that the local area-scaling factor is the absolute value of the determinant of that matrix. Six decades later, in 1907, Guido Fubini used Lebesgue integration to prove the definitive condition for swapping integrals: the two iterated orders agree whenever $\iint |f|\,\mathrm{d}A < \infty$.

In two and three dimensions, integration is well understood. But modern applications in statistics, machine learning, and statistical physics require integrating over hundreds or thousands of variables. Standard grid sums fail because dividing a 100-dimensional cube into just 10 slices along each axis yields 10^{100} cells. High-dimensional integration relies instead on randomized Monte Carlo methods and Markov chain sampling.

Why this matters

The whole chapter fits in one sentence: *An integral adds up a quantity over little cells; to compute it you slice (Fubini), and to bend the coordinate grid you scale each cell by a determinant (the Jacobian).* The single integral, the double, the triple; polar, cylindrical, spherical; the $\sqrt{\pi}$ of the Gaussian – all of it is that one sentence, applied with different cells and different determinants. Calculus in many variables is not a pile of new formulas. It is the same Riemann sum you have known since Chapter 20, asked the same two questions: how shall I organize the sum, and how big is one cell?

In the physical world, quantities often carry direction: wind has a velocity at each point, and forces act along trajectories. How do you compute the work done by a force along a curved path, or the net fluid pouring through a surface? In Chapter 35, integration extends to vector fields, leading to line integrals, surface flux, and Green's and Stokes' theorems relating regions to their boundaries.

34.6 Exercises

Exercise 34.1 (Mental check: zero by symmetry)**.** Without evaluating any antiderivative, explain why

$$\iint_R (x^5 \cos y + y^3)\,\mathrm{d}A = 0$$

where R is the rectangle $[-2,2] \times [-1,1]$. (Identify the symmetry of each term in its respective variable.)

Exercise 34.2 (Mental check: predict the scaling)**.** A linear transformation from the uv-plane to the xy-plane is defined by $x = 4u - v$ and $y = u + 2v$. What is its Jacobian determinant? If a region S in the uv-plane has area 3, what is the area of its image R in the xy-plane?

Exercise 34.3 (Warm-up over a rectangle)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\iint_R (4 - x - y)\,\mathrm{d}A$ over $R = [0,1] \times [0,2]$ by iterating in both orders, and confirm the two answers agree.

Exercise 34.4 (A region between curves)**.** Let R be the region bounded by $y = x^2$ and $y = 2x$. Sketch it, decide which order is convenient, and evaluate $\displaystyle\iint_R x\,\mathrm{d}A$. (First find where the two curves meet.)

Exercise 34.5 (Change the order)**.** Rewrite $\displaystyle\int_0^4 \int_{\sqrt{y}}^2 \frac{1}{x^3+1}\,\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y$ with the order of integration reversed, then evaluate it. (As written the inner integral is unpleasant; reversed it is a clean substitution.)

Exercise 34.6 (Integration in polar coordinates)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\iint_R \frac{1}{1+x^2+y^2}\,\mathrm{d}A$, where R is the disk $x^2+y^2\le 1$, by converting to polar coordinates. Where did the factor of r make the radial integral elementary?

Exercise 34.7 (A radial Gaussian)**.** Using polar coordinates, find $\displaystyle\iint_{\mathbb{R}^2} e^{-(x^2+y^2)}\,\mathrm{d}A$. Then explain in one sentence why this equals $\left(\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}\mathrm{d}x\right)^2$, and use it to recover $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-x^2}\,\mathrm{d}x=\sqrt{\pi}$.

Exercise 34.8 (Triple integral over a box and a wedge)**.** (a) Compute $\displaystyle\iiint_E xyz\,\mathrm{d}V$ over the box $[0,1]^3$. (b) Compute the volume of the solid below $z=1-x$ and above the unit square $[0,1]\times[0,1]$ in the xy-plane (assume $1-x\ge 0$ throughout).

Exercise 34.9 (Spherical coordinates)**.** Find the mass of a ball of radius a whose density at a point is proportional to its distance from the center, $f=k\rho$. Use spherical coordinates and the volume element $\rho^2\sin\phi\,\mathrm{d}\rho\,\mathrm{d}\phi\,\mathrm{d}\theta$. (You should find the mass is $k\pi a^4$.)

Exercise 34.10 (Compute a Jacobian)**.** For the transformation $x=u^2-v^2$, $y=2uv$, compute the Jacobian $\dfrac{\partial(x,y)}{\partial(u,v)}$ and simplify. (You should get $4(u^2+v^2)$. This is the squaring map of complex numbers, $z\mapsto z^2$; the area-scaling at a point grows with distance from the origin – interpret why.)

Exercise 34.11 (Change of variables, designed)**.** Evaluate $\displaystyle\iint_R e^{(x-y)/(x+y)}\,\mathrm{d}A$ over the triangle with vertices $(0,0)$, $(1,0)$, $(0,1)$ using the substitution $u=x-y$, $v=x+y$. Find the Jacobian, convert the region, and reduce to a one-variable integral.

Exercise 34.12 (Conceptual: why the r?)**.** Without computing any integral, explain in your own words why the polar area element carries a factor of r but the Cartesian element $\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}y$ does not. Then explain why $\iint_R 1\cdot\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$ (with the r wrongly omitted) does *not* give the area of a disk, and what quantity it gives instead.

Exercise 34.13 (Proof: linearity from the sum)**.** Prove that $\iint_R\big(f+g\big)\,\mathrm{d}A=\iint_R f\,\mathrm{d}A+\iint_R g\,\mathrm{d}A$ directly from the Riemann-sum definition, by writing out the sum for $f+g$ and splitting it. Identify the single property of finite sums that makes the argument work, and note that the limit step requires both integrals to exist.

Exercise 34.14 (Proof: a determinant is an area scaler)**.** Let T be the linear map sending (u,v) to $(au+bv,\ cu+dv)$. Show directly that the unit square $[0,1]^2$ maps to a parallelogram of area $|ad-bc|$, and conclude that T scales every area by the factor $|ad-bc|$. Explain how this is the constant-coefficient special case of the Jacobian theorem (Theorem 34.2).

Chapter 35

Vector Calculus: Green, Stokes, and Divergence

In Chapter 34 we computed double integrals $\iint_D f \, \mathrm{d}A$ over flat regions and triple integrals $\iiint_V f \, \mathrm{d}V$ over solids. In every case, we chopped the region into a fine grid of cells and summed a scalar quantity – density, height, or charge – throughout the entire interior. Every cell contributed its own share to the total.

What happens when the quantity we add up across the interior is not an arbitrary function, but the *derivative* of some underlying field?

Back in Chapter 21, the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus revealed a remarkable simplification in one dimension: to add up a rate of change over an interval, you do not actually have to add up anything in the interior at all – you just look at the two endpoints:

$$\int_a^b F'(x) \, \mathrm{d}x \;=\; F(b) - F(a).$$

The whole interior of $[a, b]$ – the infinitely many places where F is wiggling and changing – collapses into two numbers at the boundary. The accumulated change inside is completely determined by the values at the edge.

That principle – *the boundary records what happens inside* – is the central theme of vector calculus. The great theorems of this chapter (Green's theorem, the divergence theorem, Stokes' theorem) all say the same thing in higher dimensions: to learn what is happening throughout a multi-dimensional region, you only have to walk around its *boundary*. An integral over a solid blob equals an integral over the skin that wraps it. An integral over a flat patch equals an integral around the loop that fences it. In each case, integrating a derivative over a d-dimensional region equals evaluating the field along its $(d-1)$-dimensional boundary. The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus is the one-dimensional version, where the boundary of an interval consists of its two endpoints.

To formulate these theorems we use *vector fields*. Up to this point our functions have assigned numbers to points. A vector field assigns a *vector* to each point: a velocity at every point of a flowing fluid, a gravitational or electrostatic force, or the flow of heat. Once we can integrate vector fields along curves and across surfaces, the integral theorems take a clean, unified form.

Focus

One idea, four faces:

$$\begin{aligned}
&\text{FTC:} && \int_a^b F' = F(b) - F(a) && \text{(1D: endpoints)}\\
&\text{Gradient theorem:} && \int_C \nabla f \cdot d\mathbf{r} = f(\text{end}) - f(\text{start}) && \text{(curve: endpoints)}\\
&\text{Green / Stokes:} && \iint_S (\text{curl}) = \oint_{\partial S} (\text{field}) && \text{(patch: boundary loop)}\\
&\text{Divergence:} && \iiint_V (\text{div}) = \oiint_{\partial V} (\text{flux}) && \text{(solid: boundary skin)}
\end{aligned}$$

Read every line as: *accumulate a derivative inside = read the field on the boundary.*

35.1 Vector fields: assigning vectors to points

A *scalar field* assigns a number to each point: temperature in a room, altitude on a map, pressure in the ocean. We have been studying these for two chapters under the name $f(x, y)$ or $f(x, y, z)$. A *vector field* assigns an *arrow* – a vector – to each point instead.

Definition 35.1 (Vector field)**.** A vector field on a region of the plane is a function

$$\mathbf{F}(x, y) = \big(P(x, y),\, Q(x, y)\big) = P(x, y)\,\mathbf{i} + Q(x, y)\,\mathbf{j},$$

that assigns to each point (x, y) the vector $\mathbf{F}(x, y)$. In three dimensions, $\mathbf{F}(x, y, z) = (P, Q, R)$, with three component functions. We draw it by planting the arrow $\mathbf{F}(x, y)$ with its *tail* at the point (x, y).

The geometric picture is direct. Below is the field $\mathbf{F}(x, y) = (-y, x)$. At each point we draw the arrow $(-y, x)$. Notice it always points ninety degrees counterclockwise from the position vector (x, y) – so the whole field swirls around the origin like water circling a drain, or a spinning turntable.

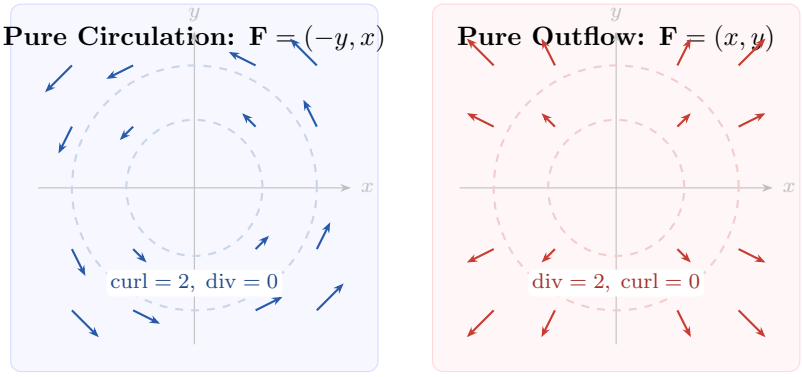


Figure 35.1: The two fundamental motions of a vector field. Left: The rotational field $\mathbf{F}(x, y) = (-y, x)$ circulates around the origin with constant scalar curl 2 and zero divergence. Right: The source field $\mathbf{F}(x, y) = (x, y)$ radiates outward from the origin with constant divergence 2 and zero curl.

Intuition

Two motions live inside every vector field, and the rest of the chapter is about measuring them. **Circulation**: does the field tend to *spin* you around a loop? (The swirl in Figure 35.1, left, does.) **Flux**: does the field tend to *carry stuff out through* a boundary? (The source in Figure 35.1, right, does.) Curl will measure local spin; divergence will measure local spreading. The integral theorems make this relationship quantitative.

Pause

Pause and think: Compare the arrows in Figure 35.1. If you drop a tiny floating twig into the swirl $\mathbf{F} = (-y, x)$, it spins around its own center of mass as it circles the origin. But if you drop the same twig into the radial outflow $\mathbf{F} = (x, y)$, it is pushed straight outward along a ray, never turning. Spin versus spread: this chapter is entirely about how these two simple local tendencies add up across curves, surfaces, and solids.

Application

Vector fields model physical quantities distributed through space. The wind on a weather map is $\mathbf{F}(x, y) =$ (velocity of air). The gravitational pull near a planet is a field of arrows pointing inward. The electric field around a charge, the magnetic field around a wire, the flow of heat through a wall, the current in the ocean – each is a vector field, and each obeys laws written in the language of this chapter. Maxwell's four equations of electromagnetism are statements about the divergence and curl of electric and magnetic fields.

35.2 Line integrals: adding a field along a path

35.2.1 Work, and why we multiply force by displacement

Drag a box across a floor. The work you do is force times distance – but only the *part of the force that lies along the motion* counts. Push straight down on a box and slide it sideways and you have done no work on it at all; your downward force is perpendicular to the sideways motion. The right measure of work for a constant force $\mathbf{F}$ over a straight displacement $\mathbf{d}$ is the dot product

$$W = \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{d} = |\mathbf{F}|\,|\mathbf{d}| \cos\theta,$$

which keeps exactly the component of $\mathbf{F}$ pointing along $\mathbf{d}$ and throws away the perpendicular part.

Now let the force vary from point to point – a vector field $\mathbf{F}$ – and let the path curve. We do what we always do in calculus: chop the path into tiny nearly-straight pieces, on each piece treat the force as roughly constant, compute the little bit of work $\mathbf{F} \cdot \Delta\mathbf{r}$, add them all up, and take the limit as the pieces shrink. That limit is the *line integral*.

Definition 35.2 (Line integral of a vector field)**.** Let C be a curve traced by $\mathbf{r}(t) = (x(t), y(t))$ for $t \in [a, b]$, and let $\mathbf{F}$ be a vector field along it. The line integral of $\mathbf{F}$ along C is

$$\int_C \mathbf{F} \cdot d\mathbf{r} \;=\; \int_a^b \mathbf{F}\big(\mathbf{r}(t)\big) \cdot \mathbf{r}\,'(t)\, dt.$$

Writing $\mathbf{F} = (P, Q)$ and $\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} = (\mathrm{d}x, \mathrm{d}y)$, this is also written $\displaystyle\int_C P\,\mathrm{d}x + Q\,\mathrm{d}y$.

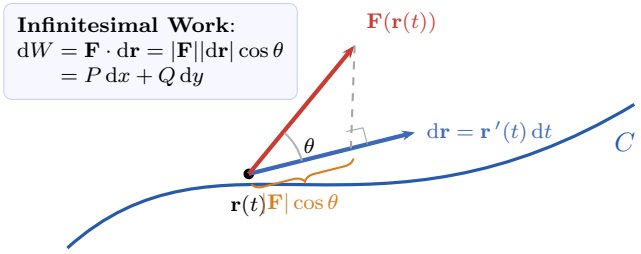


Figure 35.2: The infinitesimal work element $\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ along a curve C. At each point $\mathbf{r}(t)$, the path advances along the tangent displacement $\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}'(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$. The dot product projects $\mathbf{F}$ onto the motion: only the component $|\mathbf{F}|\cos\theta$ parallel to the curve does work. The perpendicular component produces zero motion along C.

Why the technique works

Why does $\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ become $\mathbf{r}'(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$? Because $\mathbf{r}'(t)$ is the velocity vector – it points along the curve and its length is the speed. Over a tiny time $\mathrm{d}t$ the path advances by the little displacement vector $\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}'(t)\,\mathrm{d}t$. Dotting the force against this displacement gives the infinitesimal work $\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$, and integrating in t adds them along the curve. The parameter t traces the path; the value of the integral does not depend on the parametrization speed.

Walking question

Why doesn't the speed of traversal change the answer? If you re-parametrize and move twice as fast, then $\mathbf{r}'$ doubles but the time interval $\mathrm{d}t$ halves, and the product $\mathbf{r}'(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ is unchanged – it is a geometric displacement, independent of the rate of traversal. (Reversing direction, however, flips every $\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$, so it flips the sign of the integral. Orientation matters; speed does not.)

35.2.2 A worked line integral, step by step

Example 35.1 (Work along a parabola)**.** Compute $\displaystyle\int_C \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ for $\mathbf{F}(x, y) = (y,\, x^2)$ along the parabola $y = x^2$ from $(0, 0)$ to $(2, 4)$.

Step 1 – parametrize. Let $x = t$, $y = t^2$, so $\mathbf{r}(t) = (t, t^2)$ for $t \in [0, 2]$. Then $\mathbf{r}'(t) = (1, 2t)$.

Step 2 – evaluate the field on the path. $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t)) = (y,\, x^2)\big|_{x=t,\,y=t^2} = (t^2,\, t^2)$.

Step 3 – dot. $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t))\cdot\mathbf{r}'(t) = (t^2)(1) + (t^2)(2t) = t^2 + 2t^3$.

Step 4 – integrate.

$$\int_0^2 (t^2 + 2t^3)\,\mathrm{d}t = \left[\frac{t^3}{3} + \frac{t^4}{2}\right]_0^2 = \frac{8}{3} + 8 = \frac{32}{3}.$$

The total work is $\frac{32}{3}$. The recipe never changes: parametrize, plug in, dot, integrate a single ordinary integral in t.

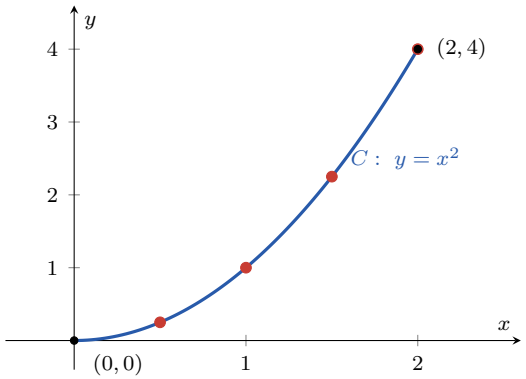


Figure 35.3: The work integral of Example 35.1: we walk the parabola C (blue) from $(0,0)$ to $(2,4)$. The line integral adds up, at each point of the path, the component of the field $\mathbf{F} = (y, x^2)$ that lies along the blue curve. The along-path total works out to $\frac{32}{3}$.

Common trap

A line integral $\int_C \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ is *not* the same as the arc-length integral $\int_C f \, \mathrm{d}s$ you may have seen (mass of a wire). The dot product version measures the field's component *along* the curve and is sensitive to direction; reversing the path negates it. The arc-length version uses $\mathrm{d}s = |\mathbf{r}'(t)| \, \mathrm{d}t$ (a length, always positive) and does not care about direction. They answer different questions. This chapter is almost entirely about the dot-product kind.

35.3 Conservative fields: when the path does not matter

In Example 35.1 the answer depended on the curve we chose. For some special fields it does *not*: the work depends only on where you start and where you stop, never on the route between. These are the *conservative* fields, and they are exactly the fields that are gradients.

Theorem 35.1 (Fundamental Theorem for line integrals / Gradient theorem)**.** *If $\mathbf{F} = \nabla f$ for some scalar function f (a* potential*), then for any curve C from point A to point B,*

$$\int_C \nabla f \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} = f(B) - f(A).$$

The integral depends only on the endpoints. In particular, around any closed loop ($A = B$), $\oint_C \nabla f \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} = 0$.

Why the technique works

This is the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus applied along a curve. Parametrize C by $\mathbf{r}(t)$, $t \in [a, b]$, and watch the chain rule do the entire job:

$$\int_C \nabla f \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} = \int_a^b \nabla f(\mathbf{r}(t)) \cdot \mathbf{r}\,'(t)\,\mathrm{d}t = \int_a^b \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\Big[f(\mathbf{r}(t))\Big]\,\mathrm{d}t = f(\mathbf{r}(b)) - f(\mathbf{r}(a)).$$

The middle equality is the multivariable chain rule (Chapter 33): $\nabla f \cdot \mathbf{r}\,' = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} f(\mathbf{r}(t))$. So the integrand was an exact derivative, and the ordinary FTC finishes it. Here, the value of the integral depends only on the potential at the two endpoints.

Intuition

A potential f is an *altitude*. The field ∇f points straight uphill, and its work is the height you gain. Walk any trail from the trailhead to the summit – switchbacks, scenic detours, whatever – and the elevation gained is the same, because it is just (summit altitude) minus (trailhead altitude). Walk a loop back to where you started and you gain zero net altitude. That is the core idea of conservativeness. A field is conservative precisely when it has an altitude function.

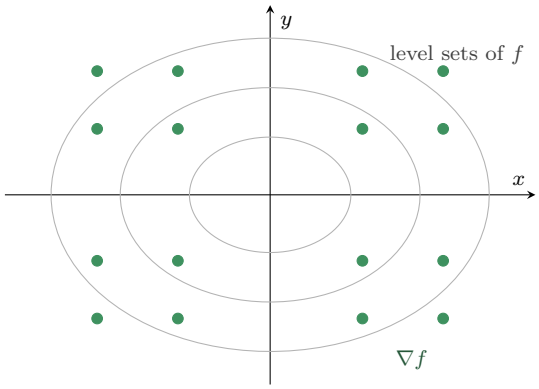


Figure 35.4: A conservative field is a gradient. Here $f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$ is the "altitude." Its level sets (gray circles) are the contour lines, and the field $\nabla f = (2x, 2y)$ (green arrows) crosses them at right angles, always pointing uphill. Work done along any path is just the change in altitude between its endpoints; around a closed loop it is zero.

35.3.1 How to test for, and find, a potential

In the plane, write $\mathbf{F} = (P, Q)$. If $\mathbf{F} = \nabla f = (f_x, f_y)$ then $P = f_x$ and $Q = f_y$. By Clairaut's theorem (mixed partials commute, Chapter 32),

$$\frac{\partial P}{\partial y} = f_{xy} = f_{yx} = \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x}.$$

So a *necessary* condition is $P_y = Q_x$. On a region with no holes (a "simply connected" region – one where every loop can be shrunk to a point) this condition is also *sufficient*: it guarantees a potential exists.

Example 35.2 (Finding a potential)**.** Is $\mathbf{F} = (2xy + 3,\ x^2 - 1)$ conservative? Here $P = 2xy + 3$, $Q = x^2 - 1$.

Test. $P_y = 2x$ and $Q_x = 2x$. They agree, and the plane has no holes, so a potential exists.

Build it. We need f with $f_x = 2xy + 3$. Integrate in x (treating y as constant):

$$f(x, y) = x^2 y + 3x + g(y),$$

where the "constant" of integration is allowed to depend on y. Now demand $f_y = Q$:

$$f_y = x^2 + g'(y) \overset{!}{=} x^2 - 1 \ \Rightarrow\ g'(y) = -1 \ \Rightarrow\ g(y) = -y + C.$$

So $f(x, y) = x^2 y + 3x - y + C$. As a check, $\nabla f = (2xy + 3,\ x^2 - 1) = \mathbf{F}$. Now any line integral of $\mathbf{F}$ is trivial: from $(0, 0)$ to $(1, 2)$ it is $f(1, 2) - f(0, 0) = (2 + 3 - 2) - 0 = 3$, no matter the path.

Common trap

The hole matters. The famous swirl $\mathbf{F} = \left(\frac{-y}{x^2+y^2}, \frac{x}{x^2+y^2}\right)$ satisfies $P_y = Q_x$ *everywhere it is defined*, yet $\oint \mathbf{F} \cdot d\mathbf{r} = 2\pi \neq 0$ around the unit circle. It is *not* conservative. The catch: it is undefined at the origin, so its domain has a hole, and the loop around that hole cannot be shrunk to a point. The test $P_y = Q_x$ only promises a potential on a *simply connected* domain. Here topology enters multivariable calculus.

Connection

The word "conservative" comes from physics, not bookkeeping. If $\mathbf{F}$ is a force with potential energy U (so $\mathbf{F} = -\nabla U$), then the work done equals the drop in U, and the total mechanical energy (kinetic plus potential) stays strictly constant along any trajectory – energy is *conserved*. Gravity and electrostatics are conservative; friction is not (it bleeds energy away as heat, and its closed-loop integral is nonzero, which is why every real machine eventually runs down). The nineteenth-century drive to understand which physical forces conserve mechanical energy, spearheaded by Hermann von Helmholtz and Lord Kelvin, is precisely what led mathematicians to clarify when a vector field is the gradient of an altitude function.

35.4 Green's theorem: interior curl equals boundary circulation

The first of the three great theorems is also the one easiest to picture. Green's theorem relates a line integral *around* a closed loop C to a double integral *over* the flat region D that the loop encloses.

Theorem 35.2 (Green's theorem, circulation form)**.** *Let D be a region in the plane bounded by a simple closed curve C, traversed counterclockwise. If $\mathbf{F} = (P, Q)$ has continuous partials on D, then*

$$\oint_C P\,dx + Q\,dy \;=\; \iint_D \left(\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y}\right) dA.$$

The quantity $\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y}$ is the *microscopic circulation* – the "curl" of the field, which we meet properly in the next section. Green's theorem says: the total swirl around the boundary equals the sum of all the little swirls inside.

What is really happening

The underlying mechanism is a telescoping cancellation. Tile the region D with tiny rectangles. For each tiny rectangle, run the line integral around its own little boundary, counterclockwise. Now add up all these little loop integrals. Look at any internal edge shared by two adjacent tiles: one tile traverses it left-to-right, its neighbor traverses the *same* edge right-to-left. The two contributions are equal and opposite – they **cancel**. Every interior edge cancels against its neighbor. The only edges that survive this cancellation are those on the outer boundary of D, where there is no adjacent tile to cancel with. So

$$\sum_{\text{tiles}} (\text{tiny loop integral}) = (\text{big boundary integral}).$$

Meanwhile each tiny loop integral, by a short computation, equals $\big(Q_x - P_y\big) \times (\text{area of tile})$. Summing those is the double integral. The interior cancellation is *exactly* the same telescoping that made the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus work, where the inner endpoints of adjacent subintervals cancelled and only a and b survived.

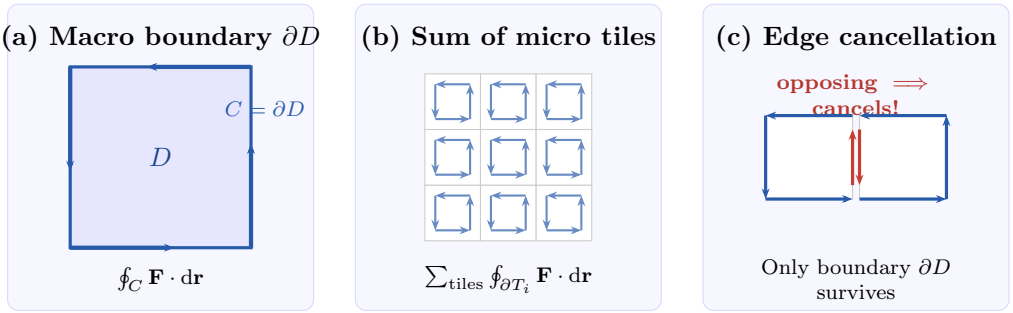


Figure 35.5: Green's theorem via microscopic edge cancellation. (a) The macro circulation $\oint_{\partial D} \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ around the outer boundary loop. (b) The region D tiled into tiny sub-rectangles, each evaluated counterclockwise. (c) On every internal boundary shared by two adjacent cells, one cell traverses the segment forward while the other traverses it backward; the two opposing contributions cancel out identically. Every interior edge cancels, leaving only the outer perimeter ∂D to account for the sum of all microscopic curls.

35.4.1 Computing area with Green's theorem

As an immediate application, choose $\mathbf{F}$ so that $Q_x - P_y = 1$. Then the double integral is just the *area* of D, and Green's theorem computes area from a trip around the boundary. Taking $\mathbf{F} = (-y/2,\, x/2)$ gives $Q_x - P_y = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2} = 1$, so

$$\text{Area}(D) = \frac{1}{2} \oint_C x\,\mathrm{d}y - y\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

This is the principle behind the *planimeter*, a mechanical instrument that measures the area of any shape by tracing its outline: guide its pointer once around the boundary and a dial reads off the enclosed area.

Example 35.3 (Area of an ellipse by its boundary)**.** Let C be the ellipse $x = a\cos t$, $y = b\sin t$,

$t \in [0, 2\pi]$. Then $\mathrm{d}x = -a\sin t\,\mathrm{d}t$, $\mathrm{d}y = b\cos t\,\mathrm{d}t$, and

$$x\,\mathrm{d}y - y\,\mathrm{d}x = (a\cos t)(b\cos t)\,\mathrm{d}t - (b\sin t)(-a\sin t)\,\mathrm{d}t = ab(\cos^2 t + \sin^2 t)\,\mathrm{d}t = ab\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

Therefore

$$\text{Area} = \frac{1}{2}\int_0^{2\pi} ab\,\mathrm{d}t = \frac{1}{2}\,(ab)(2\pi) = \pi ab.$$

This yields the familiar πab using only the boundary curve.

Example 35.4 (Verifying Green's theorem directly)**.** Let $\mathbf{F} = (-y,\, x)$ (the swirl) and let D be the unit disk, C its boundary circle counterclockwise.

Right side (double integral). Here $P = -y$, $Q = x$, so $Q_x - P_y = 1 - (-1) = 2$. Thus $\iint_D 2\,\mathrm{d}A = 2 \cdot (\text{area of disk}) = 2\pi$.

Left side (line integral). Parametrize $x = \cos t$, $y = \sin t$:

$$\oint_C -y\,\mathrm{d}x + x\,\mathrm{d}y = \int_0^{2\pi} \big[(-\sin t)(-\sin t) + (\cos t)(\cos t)\big]\,\mathrm{d}t = \int_0^{2\pi} 1\,\mathrm{d}t = 2\pi.$$

Both sides give 2π. The constant microscopic swirl of 2 at every point, summed over the disk, equals the circulation you feel going once around the rim.

35.5 Curl and divergence: spin and spread, made local

Green's theorem has already handed us two local quantities worth naming. They are the derivatives the great theorems integrate, so it pays to know what each one measures physically.

35.5.1 Divergence: how much a point is a source

Definition 35.3 (Divergence)**.** For $\mathbf{F} = (P, Q, R)$, the divergence is the scalar

$$\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = \nabla \cdot \mathbf{F} = \frac{\partial P}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial R}{\partial z}.$$

(In the plane, drop the last term.)

Intuition

Divergence measures *spreading*. Imagine $\mathbf{F}$ is the velocity of a fluid. Surround a point with a tiny balloon. If more fluid flows *out* of the balloon than in, the point is a *source* and $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} > 0$. If fluid piles *in*, it is a *sink* and $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} < 0$. If as much leaves as enters, $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 0$ and the fluid is *incompressible* there. For the source field $\mathbf{F} = (x, y)$ of Figure 35.1 (right), $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 1 + 1 = 2 > 0$ everywhere: every point is gushing. For the swirl $(-y, x)$, $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 0$: swirling moves fluid around but never makes it pile up or thin out.

35.5.2 Curl: how much a point is a whirlpool

Definition 35.4 (Curl)**.** In three dimensions, $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F} = \nabla \times \mathbf{F}$, the vector

$$\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F} = \left(\frac{\partial R}{\partial y} - \frac{\partial Q}{\partial z},\ \frac{\partial P}{\partial z} - \frac{\partial R}{\partial x},\ \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y}\right).$$

In the plane, only the last component survives; the *scalar curl* of (P, Q) is $\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y}$ – exactly the integrand of Green's theorem.

Intuition

Curl measures *spin*. Drop a tiny paddlewheel into the fluid at a point. If the flow makes it rotate, the curl is nonzero, and it points along the axle (by the right-hand rule), with magnitude twice the angular speed of the spin. The swirl $(-y, x)$ has scalar curl $1 - (-1) = 2$ everywhere – a paddlewheel anywhere in it spins counterclockwise. The source (x, y) has curl $0 - 0 = 0$: gas rushing radially outward never spins a paddlewheel, it just carries it straight out.

Common trap

A field can *circle the origin* and still have zero curl everywhere it is defined – "curls around" (global) and "has curl" (local) are different. The hole field $\left(\frac{-y}{x^2+y^2}, \frac{x}{x^2+y^2}\right)$ has scalar curl 0 at every point of its domain, yet its loop integral around the origin is 2π. Curl is a local paddlewheel test; circulation around a big loop is a global sum. Green's theorem links them only when the field is smooth *everywhere inside* the loop – and this field is not (it blows up at the origin).

35.5.3 The microscopic geometry: where the formulas come from

Why is divergence $\frac{\partial P}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial y}$? Why is curl $\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y}$, with a minus sign? Neither formula is arbitrary. Both come from doing the bookkeeping around one tiny rectangle $[x, x + \Delta x] \times [y, y + \Delta y]$ of area $\Delta A = \Delta x\, \Delta y$ (Figure 35.6).

Flux out through the four walls. Fluid leaves through the right wall at rate about $P(x + \Delta x, y)\, \Delta y$ and enters through the left wall at rate about $P(x, y)\, \Delta y$. The net horizontal outflow is $[P(x + \Delta x, y) - P(x, y)]\, \Delta y \approx P_x\, \Delta x\, \Delta y$, by the definition of the partial derivative. The top and bottom walls give, in the same way, $[Q(x, y + \Delta y) - Q(x, y)]\, \Delta x \approx Q_y\, \Delta x\, \Delta y$. The total outward flux is about $(P_x + Q_y)\, \Delta A$; per unit area, that is $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = P_x + Q_y$.

Circulation around the four edges. Walk counterclockwise: east along the bottom $(+P(x, y)\, \Delta x)$, north up the right side $(+Q(x + \Delta x, y)\, \Delta y)$, *west* along the top $(-P(x, y + \Delta y)\, \Delta x)$, and *south* down the left side $(-Q(x, y)\, \Delta y)$. Pair opposite sides:

$$\big[Q(x + \Delta x, y) - Q(x, y)\big]\Delta y - \big[P(x, y + \Delta y) - P(x, y)\big]\Delta x \ \approx\ (Q_x - P_y)\, \Delta x\, \Delta y.$$

The minus sign in $Q_x - P_y$ is just the fact that a counterclockwise loop walks east along the bottom but west along the top.

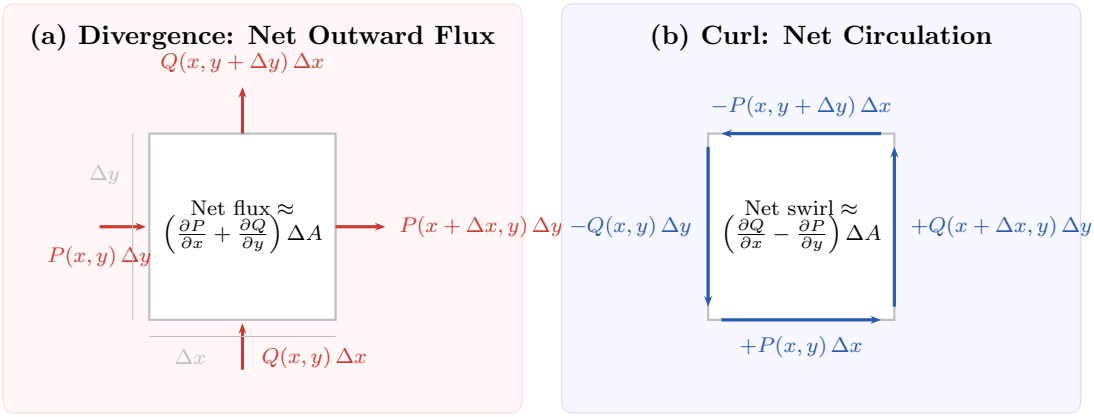


Figure 35.6: The microscopic origin of divergence and curl. (a) Divergence counts the net outward flux per unit area across the four walls of a cell: the difference in horizontal flow across Δx gives $\frac{\partial P}{\partial x}$, plus the difference in vertical flow across Δy gives $\frac{\partial Q}{\partial y}$. (b) Curl counts the net counterclockwise circulation around the four edges: the difference between the right and left edges gives $+\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x}\,\Delta x\Delta y$, while the difference between the top and bottom edges (running backward on top) gives $-\frac{\partial P}{\partial y}\,\Delta x\Delta y$.

Why this matters

Notice the symmetry. Green's theorem in *circulation form* ($\oint P\,\mathrm{d}x + Q\,\mathrm{d}y = \iint(Q_x - P_y)$) integrates the *curl*. There is a twin, the *flux form*, that integrates the *divergence*:

$$\oint_C \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}s = \iint_D \left(\frac{\partial P}{\partial x}+\frac{\partial Q}{\partial y}\right)\mathrm{d}A = \iint_D \operatorname{div}\mathbf{F}\,\mathrm{d}A,$$

where $\mathbf{n}$ is the outward unit normal. The same Green's theorem, read two ways, is the seed of *both* theorems to come: extending its circulation form into 3D gives Stokes' theorem; extending its flux form into 3D gives the divergence theorem. Both theorems generalize this single planar relationship.

35.6 Flux and the divergence theorem: the boundary skin

35.6.1 Flux across a surface

In 3D the analog of "how much field crosses the boundary loop" becomes "how much field crosses the boundary *surface*." That quantity is the *flux*.

Definition 35.5 (Flux integral)**.** Let S be a surface with a chosen unit normal direction $\mathbf{n}$. The flux of $\mathbf{F}$ through S is

$$\iint_S \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S.$$

Only the component of $\mathbf{F}$ *piercing* the surface (along $\mathbf{n}$) contributes; field sliding *along* the surface carries nothing through.

Here $\mathrm{d}S$ is the area of a tiny patch of the surface. In particular, if $\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}$ has the same value c everywhere on S, the flux is simply $c\cdot\text{Area}(S)$.

Intuition

Hold a hoop in a river. The flux is the volume of water passing through the hoop per second. Hold it face-on to the current and the flux is large; turn it edge-on and the flux drops to zero, because now the water slides past the rim instead of through the hoop. That "how much is going through" – counting only the piercing component $\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{n}$ – is flux.

35.6.2 The divergence theorem

Theorem 35.3 (Divergence theorem / Gauss's theorem)**.** *Let V be a solid region in space bounded by a closed surface $S = \partial V$ with outward unit normal $\mathbf{n}$. If $\mathbf{F}$ has continuous partials on V, then*

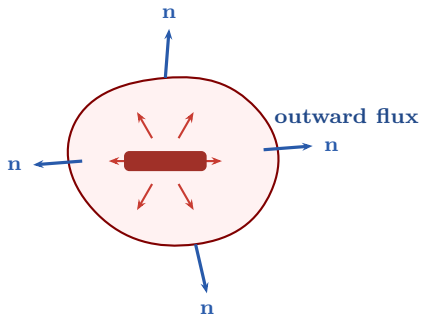
$$\iiint_V \operatorname{div} \mathbf{F} \, dV \;=\; \oiint_S \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{n} \, dS.$$

What is really happening

The proof is the same cancellation story, one dimension up. Chop the solid V into tiny boxes. Compute the net flux out of each tiny box – its outward push minus its inward pull on all six faces. Now sum over all the boxes. Every *internal* face is shared by two adjacent boxes: what flows *out* of one box through that face flows *into* its neighbor, so the two flux contributions are equal and opposite and **cancel**. Only the faces on the *outer skin* of V survive, with no neighbor to cancel them – and their total is the flux through $S = \partial V$. Meanwhile the net flux out of one tiny box equals $\operatorname{div} \mathbf{F} \times$ (box volume) – that is literally what divergence *is*, the outflow per unit volume. Summing gives $\iiint_V \operatorname{div} \mathbf{F} \, dV$. Interior fluxes cancel; the boundary records the net source inside.

Why this matters

The divergence theorem expresses a conservation law in geometric form. All the sources scattered throughout a solid – every point where fluid is generated – must account exactly for the net flux passing through its surface. In a steady state, whatever is generated inside must pass through the enclosing surface. This single identity underlies Gauss's law of electrostatics (charge inside equals field flux out), the continuity equation of fluid flow, and the heat equation's energy balance.



$$\iiint_V \operatorname{div}\mathbf{F}\,\mathrm{d}V = \iint_{\partial V} \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S$$

Figure 35.7: The divergence theorem. Sources generating fluid in the interior (red) must balance exactly against the net flux escaping through the enclosing skin (blue outward normals $\mathbf{n}$). Internal flows cancel between adjoining cells; only the outer boundary ∂V records the net generation inside.

Example 35.5 (Divergence theorem on a ball)**.** Let $\mathbf{F} = (x, y, z)$ and let V be the ball of radius a, with S its sphere.

Left side. $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 1 + 1 + 1 = 3$, so

$$\iiint_V 3\,\mathrm{d}V = 3 \cdot \mathrm{Vol}(V) = 3 \cdot \frac{4}{3}\pi a^3 = 4\pi a^3.$$

Right side. On the sphere of radius a the outward normal is $\mathbf{n} = \frac{1}{a}(x, y, z)$, so $\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n} = \frac{1}{a}(x^2 + y^2 + z^2) = \frac{a^2}{a} = a$, a constant. Then

$$\oiint_S \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S = a \cdot \mathrm{Area}(S) = a \cdot 4\pi a^2 = 4\pi a^3.$$

The two agree. The uniform source density 3 filling the ball is paid off exactly by the outward flux through the sphere.

35.7 Stokes' theorem: the boundary loop of a surface

Now the last of the three. Green's theorem lived in the flat plane; Stokes' theorem lifts it into 3D, where the surface S may be any curved membrane in space, like a soap film, with the line integral run around its rim ∂S.

Theorem 35.4 (Stokes' theorem)**.** *Let S be an oriented surface in space bounded by a simple closed curve $C = \partial S$, oriented compatibly (right-hand rule). If $\mathbf{F}$ has continuous partials, then*

$$\oint_C \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r} \;=\; \iint_S (\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F})\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S.$$

Intuition

The total circulation you feel marching once around the rim of a membrane equals the sum of all the little paddlewheel spins (the curl) spread across the membrane. And here is the

wonder: *any* surface with the same rim gives the same answer. A flat disk, a tall dome, a curved sheet – if they share a boundary loop, the curl-flux through each is identical, because only the boundary values determine the integral. (Since $\operatorname{div}(\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F}) = 0$ always, the divergence theorem guarantees this independence: curl has no sources, so its flux depends only on the boundary.) Green's theorem is Stokes' theorem for the special case where S is a flat region lying in the plane.

What is really happening

The same cancellation mechanism applies on a curved surface. Tile the membrane S with tiny patches. Around each patch run the local circulation; by Green's theorem in miniature, that circulation equals $(\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n})\times$ (patch area). Sum over all patches. The shared edges between neighboring patches are traversed in opposite directions and **cancel**; only the outer rim $C = \partial S$ survives. Result: rim circulation = total curl-flux.

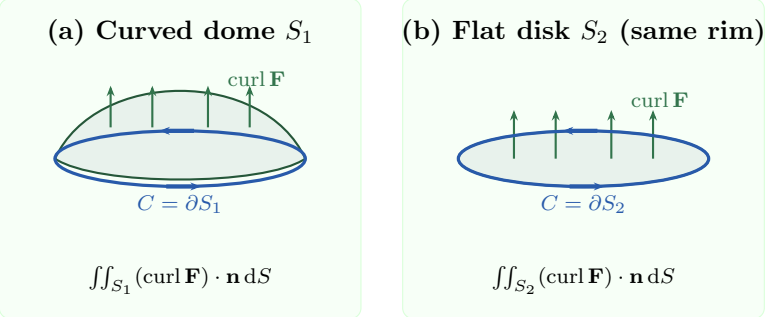


Figure 35.8: Stokes' theorem and surface independence. The circulation $\oint_C \mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r}$ around the boundary rim C equals the total flux of $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F}$ through *any* surface that caps C. (a) A curved dome S_1 and (b) a flat disk S_2 sharing the same rim $C = \partial S$ capture the exact same total curl flux, because any two such surfaces together form a closed container through which the divergence-free curl field has zero net flux.

Example 35.6 (Stokes on a hemisphere)**.** Let $\mathbf{F} = (-y, x, 0)$ (the swirl, lifted into 3D) and let S be the upper unit hemisphere $x^2 + y^2 + z^2 = 1$, $z \geq 0$, oriented upward. Its boundary C is the unit circle in the xy-plane.

Surface side. $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F} = (0, 0, Q_x - P_y) = (0, 0, 1 - (-1)) = (0, 0, 2)$. The simplest membrane with the same rim is the flat disk $z = 0$, where $\mathbf{n} = (0, 0, 1)$, so $(\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F})\cdot\mathbf{n} = 2$ and

$$\iint_S (\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F})\cdot\mathbf{n}\,dS = 2\cdot(\text{area of unit disk}) = 2\pi.$$

(We are allowed to swap the hemisphere for the flat disk precisely because Stokes says only the shared rim matters.)

Rim side. Parametrize C by $x = \cos t$, $y = \sin t$, $z = 0$:

$$\oint_C \mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r} = \int_0^{2\pi} \big[(-\sin t)(-\sin t) + (\cos t)(\cos t)\big]\,dt = 2\pi.$$

Both give 2π. The curl pointing up through the cap is precisely the swirl you feel walking the equator.

History

The story of vector calculus begins not in a university lecture hall, but in a grain windmill in Nottingham. In 1828, George Green, a self-taught miller who had only one year of formal schooling as a child, published a private essay on electricity and magnetism. Green was trying to solve a concrete puzzle: if electrical charges or heat sources are buried invisibly inside a solid body, how can you deduce what they are doing using only measurements taken by meters placed on the outside skin?

At the time, mathematicians worked in coordinate components. They wrote out separate formulas for the x, y, and z directions. Modern vector notation did not exist: neither dot products nor cross products, nor the operational symbols ∇, div, and curl, had been invented yet. Green realized that the sum of microscopic changes inside an enclosure must cancel along every interior boundary, leaving only a reckoning at the outer edge.

Because Green was an unknown outsider, his self-funded booklet was sold to only 51 subscribers, mostly local friends, and was completely ignored by the scientific world. It was almost lost forever. In 1845, a young Scottish physicist named William Thomson (later Lord Kelvin) stumbled upon a surviving copy, immediately saw its importance, and circulated it across Europe. Five years later, in 1850, Thomson wrote a letter to his friend George Gabriel Stokes containing the three-dimensional version of the boundary principle on a curved surface. Stokes never published a proof; instead, he set it as Question 8 on the 1854 Cambridge Smith's Prize examination, an advanced mathematics competition. Sitting that very exam was an undergraduate named James Clerk Maxwell.

Maxwell seized the theorem and made curl and divergence central to his equations of electromagnetism, showing for the first time that light is an electromagnetic wave. A lively debate soon followed over how to formulate these ideas. Peter Guthrie Tait championed four-dimensional numbers called quaternions, debating with Josiah Willard Gibbs and Oliver Heaviside, who argued for the three-dimensional vectors used today. In the early twentieth century, Henri Poincaré and Élie Cartan unified these results into the generalized Stokes theorem $\int_{\partial M} \omega = \int_M \mathrm{d}\omega$, where ω is a differential form (a tidy geometric package ready to be integrated) and ∂M is the boundary of a smooth region M.

Yet even with this beautiful boundary geometry in hand, the fundamental physics of fluid flow remains an open frontier. The Navier–Stokes existence and smoothness problem – one of the million-dollar Millennium Prize Problems – asks whether the three-dimensional vector equations governing flowing water and air always have smooth, predictable solutions for all time, or whether the curl of the velocity field (its local whirlpool spin) can spontaneously concentrate and blow up to infinity in finite time.

35.8 One theorem, four faces

These theorems share a common structure. In each statement, an integral of a *derivative* over a region equals an integral of the original *field* over the region's *boundary*:

Theorem	**Inside (a derivative)**	**Boundary (the field)**
FTC	$\displaystyle\int_a^b F'(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$	$F(b)-F(a)$
Gradient thm	$\displaystyle\int_C \nabla f\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$	$f(B)-f(A)$
Green	$\displaystyle\iint_D (Q_x-P_y)\,\mathrm{d}A$	$\displaystyle\oint_{\partial D}\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$
Stokes	$\displaystyle\iint_S \operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S$	$\displaystyle\oint_{\partial S}\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$
Divergence	$\displaystyle\iiint_V \operatorname{div}\mathbf{F}\,\mathrm{d}V$	$\displaystyle\oiint_{\partial V}\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S$

Why this matters

The boundary operator ∂ lowers dimension by one: the boundary of a solid is a surface, of a surface a curve, of a curve two endpoints. The derivative operator (∇, curl, div) is the perfect partner: applied inside, it produces exactly what, when summed, the boundary can account for. The two are *adjoint* – that is the one-sentence content of the generalized Stokes theorem, $\int_M \mathrm{d}\omega = \int_{\partial M}\omega$. Every row of the table above, from $\int F' = F(b)-F(a)$ onward, is a special case of that single formula.

Connection

This unification provides a compact mathematical language for physical field theories. Maxwell's equations say $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{E} = \rho/\varepsilon_0$ (charges are sources of the electric field) and $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{B} = \mu_0\mathbf{J} + \cdots$ (currents swirl the magnetic field). Feed these into the divergence and Stokes theorems and out come Gauss's law and Ampère's law in their boundary form – the form you can actually measure with a wire and a meter. The local differential law and the global integral law are the same statement seen from inside and from the boundary.

Work it yourself

Verify the unification on a concrete example. Take $\mathbf{F} = (-y, x)$. (1) Compute its scalar curl. (2) Compute its divergence. (3) Use Green's theorem to find its circulation around the boundary of the square $[0,1]\times[0,1]$, then check it by integrating around the four edges directly. (4) Now compute its *flux* out of that same square using the flux form of Green's theorem – and explain, before you compute, why you expect 0. (The swirl spins but does not spread.)

35.9 The Bridge to Complex Analysis: Analytic Functions, Cauchy–Riemann, and Contour Integrals

Throughout this chapter, Green's theorem, Stokes' theorem, and the divergence theorem established a single unifying principle: an integral of a derivative over an interior region is completely recorded by the field along the boundary. While historically developed to describe fluid vortices and electromagnetic fields, Green's theorem produces an even more striking payoff in two dimensions when the coordinate plane $\mathbb{R}^2$ is identified with the complex plane $\mathbb{C}$ via $z = x + iy$.

Here, Green's theorem becomes the foundation of *complex analysis* – a subject where a function with one complex derivative on an open region automatically has infinitely many, and where difficult definite integrals are evaluated by counting how paths wind around isolated singularities. A *singularity* is a point where the function fails to be differentiable, typically because a denominator vanishes there.

35.9.1 Complex Differentiability and the Amplitwist

A complex function $f : \mathbb{C} \to \mathbb{C}$ maps an input point $z = x + iy$ to an output $w = u(x, y) + iv(x, y)$, where $u, v : \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}$ are its real and imaginary parts.

Just as in single-variable calculus, the complex derivative of f at a point z_0 is defined as the limit of a difference quotient:

$$f'(z_0) = \lim_{\Delta z \to 0} \frac{f(z_0 + \Delta z) - f(z_0)}{\Delta z}. \tag{35.1}$$

In single-variable real calculus, the increment Δx can approach zero from only two directions: left or right. In the complex plane, however, $\Delta z = \Delta x + i\Delta y$ can approach zero along an infinite family of two-dimensional trajectories. For the complex derivative $f'(z_0)$ to exist, the quotient must converge to the exact same complex number regardless of the trajectory of approach.

Compare two perpendicular directions of approach:

1. **Horizontal approach** ($\Delta z = \Delta x \in \mathbb{R}$, so $\Delta y = 0$):

$$f'(z) = \lim_{\Delta x \to 0} \frac{u(x + \Delta x, y) - u(x, y)}{\Delta x} + i \lim_{\Delta x \to 0} \frac{v(x + \Delta x, y) - v(x, y)}{\Delta x} = u_x + iv_x.$$

2. **Vertical approach** ($\Delta z = i\Delta y$ with $\Delta y \in \mathbb{R}$, so $\Delta x = 0$):

$$f'(z) = \lim_{\Delta y \to 0} \frac{u(x, y + \Delta y) - u(x, y)}{i\Delta y} + i \lim_{\Delta y \to 0} \frac{v(x, y + \Delta y) - v(x, y)}{i\Delta y} = \frac{u_y + iv_y}{i}.$$

   Multiplying numerator and denominator by $-i$ (recalling that $1/i = -i$):

$$\frac{u_y + iv_y}{i} = -i(u_y + iv_y) = v_y - iu_y.$$

For $f'(z)$ to exist, these two directional limits must be identical:

$$u_x + iv_x = v_y - iu_y.$$

Equating real and imaginary components yields the celebrated **Cauchy–Riemann equations**:

$$u_x = v_y \qquad \text{and} \qquad u_y = -v_x. \tag{35.2}$$

35.9.2 The Geometric View: Pure Rotation and Scaling

What do the Cauchy–Riemann equations mean geometrically?

View f as a mapping from $\mathbb{R}^2$ to $\mathbb{R}^2$, sending (x, y) to $(u(x, y), v(x, y))$. When u and v are differentiable in the sense of Chapter 33 (for instance, when their first partials are continuous), the local linear approximation of f is governed by the 2×2 Jacobian matrix:

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} u_x & u_y \\ v_x & v_y \end{pmatrix}.$$

Imposing the Cauchy–Riemann equations $v_y = u_x$ and $u_y = -v_x$, the Jacobian specializes to:

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} u_x & -v_x \\ v_x & u_x \end{pmatrix}.$$

Let $r = \sqrt{u_x^2 + v_x^2} = |f'(z)|$, and let $\theta = \operatorname{Arg}(u_x + iv_x) = \operatorname{Arg}(f'(z))$. Then this matrix factors into:

$$J = r \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta & -\sin\theta \\ \sin\theta & \cos\theta \end{pmatrix}.$$

The Jacobian is not an arbitrary linear transformation: it is a pure counterclockwise rotation by angle θ accompanied by an isotropic scaling by factor r.

As Tristan Needham termed it in *Visual Complex Analysis*, a complex derivative acts locally as an **amplitwist**: it *amplifies* lengths by $r = |f'(z)|$ and *twists* directions by angle $\theta = \operatorname{Arg}(f'(z))$. Because all directions are scaled equally and angles between vectors are preserved, every complex-differentiable (or *holomorphic*) map is *conformal* wherever $f'(z) \neq 0$: tiny squares in the domain map to tiny, rotated squares in the range, free of any shear or directional stretching.

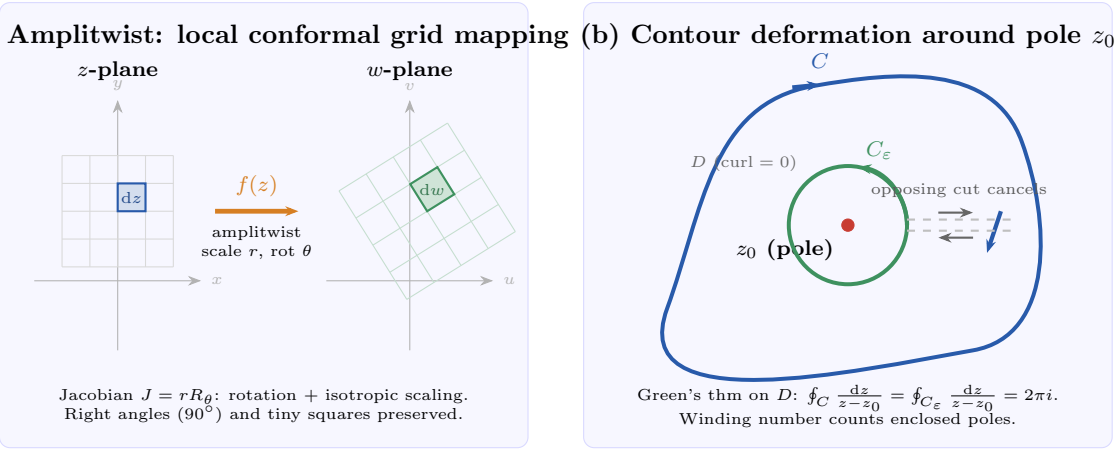


Figure 35.9: The bridge from Green's theorem to complex analysis. (a) A complex function $f(z)$ satisfies the Cauchy–Riemann equations if and only if its derivative acts locally as an amplitwist: rotating by $\theta = \operatorname{Arg}(f')$ and scaling isotropically by $r = |f'|$, preserving infinitesimal squares. (b) Green's theorem implies Cauchy's integral theorem ($\oint_C f(z)\,dz = 0$ on holomorphic domains). When an isolated pole z_0 is enclosed, Green's theorem on the annular region between C and a small circle C_ε proves the contour can be deformed onto C_ε, evaluating to $2\pi i$.

35.9.3 Cauchy's Integral Theorem in Three Lines via Green's Theorem

Now consider the contour integral of a complex function $f(z)$ around a closed curve $C = \partial D$ bounding a simply connected region $D \subset \mathbb{C}$.

Expand the complex integrand and differential displacement into real and imaginary components:

$$f(z) = u + iv, \qquad \mathrm{d}z = \mathrm{d}x + i\,\mathrm{d}y.$$

Multiplying these expressions:

$$f(z)\,\mathrm{d}z = (u + iv)(\mathrm{d}x + i\,\mathrm{d}y) = (u\,\mathrm{d}x - v\,\mathrm{d}y) + i\,(v\,\mathrm{d}x + u\,\mathrm{d}y).$$

Integrating around the closed boundary loop C splits the complex contour integral into two ordinary real line integrals:

$$\oint_C f(z)\,\mathrm{d}z = \oint_C (u\,\mathrm{d}x - v\,\mathrm{d}y) + i \oint_C (v\,\mathrm{d}x + u\,\mathrm{d}y). \tag{35.3}$$

Now apply Green's Theorem, $\oint_C (P\,\mathrm{d}x + Q\,\mathrm{d}y) = \iint_D (Q_x - P_y)\,\mathrm{d}A$, directly to both integrals:

1. **Real part** ($P = u$, $Q = -v$):

$$\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y} = \frac{\partial(-v)}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial u}{\partial y} = -v_x - u_y.$$

   By the second Cauchy–Riemann equation, $u_y = -v_x$. Substituting this gives:

$$-v_x - (-v_x) = 0.$$

2. **Imaginary part** ($P = v$, $Q = u$):

$$\frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial P}{\partial y} = \frac{\partial u}{\partial x} - \frac{\partial v}{\partial y} = u_x - v_y.$$

   By the first Cauchy–Riemann equation, $u_x = v_y$. Substituting this gives:

$$v_y - v_y = 0.$$

Both interior curl integrands vanish identically throughout the domain D:

$$\oint_C f(z)\,\mathrm{d}z = \iint_D 0\,\mathrm{d}A + i \iint_D 0\,\mathrm{d}A = 0. \tag{35.4}$$

This is **Cauchy's Integral Theorem**:

Theorem 35.5 (Cauchy's Integral Theorem)**.** *If $f(z)$ is complex-differentiable (holomorphic) on and inside a simple closed contour C, then:*

$$\oint_C f(z)\,\mathrm{d}z = 0.$$

Cauchy's integral theorem is Green's theorem applied to complex functions: the Cauchy–Riemann equations ensure that the vector fields $(u, -v)$ and (v, u) are identically curl-free. (Green's theorem needs continuous partial derivatives of u and v; Goursat later showed that the theorem holds without that extra assumption.)

35.9.4 The Single Punctured Exception: $\oint_{|z|=R} \frac{1}{z}\,\mathrm{d}z = 2\pi i$

What occurs when $f(z)$ fails to be differentiable at an isolated singularity inside C?

The standard test case is $f(z) = 1/z$, which is holomorphic everywhere except at the origin $z = 0$, where it is undefined. An isolated singularity where $|f(z)| \to \infty$ is called a *pole*.

Let C be the circle $|z| = R$ traversed counterclockwise. Parametrize C in polar form:

$$z(\theta) = Re^{i\theta}, \qquad \mathrm{d}z = iRe^{i\theta}\,\mathrm{d}\theta, \qquad \theta \in [0, 2\pi].$$

Substitute this parametrization into the contour integral:

$$\oint_{|z|=R} \frac{1}{z}\,\mathrm{d}z = \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{1}{Re^{i\theta}} \left(iRe^{i\theta}\,\mathrm{d}\theta\right) = \int_0^{2\pi} i\,\mathrm{d}\theta = 2\pi i. \tag{35.5}$$

Observe the cancellation: the radius R cancels completely from the calculation. Whether the circular path has radius $R = 10^5$ or $R = 10^{-5}$, the line integral is invariantly $2\pi i$.

Now take any smooth loop C around the origin and a small circle C_ε of radius ε inside it. In the region between them, $1/z$ is holomorphic, so the two curl integrands vanish there. Cut a narrow corridor joining the two curves; its two sides are traversed in opposite directions and cancel (Figure 35.9b). Green's theorem on the cut region then shows that C can be shrunk onto C_ε without changing the integral:

$$\oint_C \frac{1}{z}\,\mathrm{d}z = \oint_{C_\varepsilon} \frac{1}{z}\,\mathrm{d}z = 2\pi i.$$

The integral $\oint_C \frac{1}{z}\,\mathrm{d}z$ acts as an integer winding counter: it evaluates to $2\pi i$ times the number of times the path C winds around the singularity.

In contrast, for every other integer power z^n with $n \neq -1$, the number $n+1$ is a nonzero integer, so $e^{i(n+1)\theta}$ has an antiderivative that returns to its starting value after a full turn:

$$\oint_{|z|=R} z^n\,\mathrm{d}z = \int_0^{2\pi} R^n e^{in\theta} \left(iRe^{i\theta}\,\mathrm{d}\theta\right) = iR^{n+1} \int_0^{2\pi} e^{i(n+1)\theta}\,\mathrm{d}\theta = iR^{n+1} \left[\frac{e^{i(n+1)\theta}}{i(n+1)}\right]_0^{2\pi} = 0.$$

Only for $n = -1$ does the division by $n+1$ break down, which is why z^{-1} is the unique survivor.

35.9.5 Cauchy's Residue Theorem and Signal Processing

A function that is holomorphic on a punctured disk around an isolated singularity z_0 can be expanded there in a Laurent series:

$$f(z) = \sum_{n=-\infty}^{\infty} a_n (z - z_0)^n = \cdots + \frac{a_{-2}}{(z - z_0)^2} + \frac{a_{-1}}{z - z_0} + a_0 + a_1(z - z_0) + \ldots$$

A *Laurent series* is a power series that permits negative integer powers, capturing the blow-up near z_0 (called a *pole* when only finitely many negative powers appear). To integrate $f(z)$ around a small loop enclosing z_0, deform the loop onto a circle $|z - z_0| = R$ and integrate the series term by term (legitimate because the series converges uniformly on the circle). By the calculation above, every power with $n \neq -1$ contributes zero. Only the term $a_{-1}(z - z_0)^{-1}$ survives, yielding $2\pi i a_{-1}$. The

coefficient a_{-1} is called the **residue** of f at z_0, written $\operatorname{Res}(f, z_0)$ – it is the only nonvanishing term in the loop integral.

Deforming a general contour around multiple enclosed isolated poles $z_1, z_2, \ldots, z_k$ yields **Cauchy's Residue Theorem**:

$$\oint_C f(z)\,\mathrm{d}z = 2\pi i \sum_k \operatorname{Res}(f, z_k). \tag{35.6}$$

In modern engineering and physics, this residue calculation is a standard tool for solving linear differential equations:

- **Continuous-time systems and the Laplace transform**: When modeling an electrical circuit or a vibrating spring, physical laws yield differential equations relating a function to its time derivatives. The Laplace transform turns these differential equations into ordinary algebraic equations in terms of a complex frequency variable s. Solving for the system yields an algebraic transfer function $F(s)$. To convert the solution back into real-world time $f(t)$, we compute a contour integral in the complex plane (the Bromwich integral). Cauchy's Residue Theorem evaluates this integral directly: the sum of the residues at the poles of $F(s)$ reveals the system's natural frequencies and exponential decay rates.
- **Discrete-time systems and digital filters**: In digital signal processing (DSP), where signals are sampled sequences of numbers $x[n]$ rather than continuous curves, the Z-transform plays the same role. A closed contour integral in the complex plane extracts the digital filter's time response directly from the residues of its transfer function $X(z)$.

Green's theorem, originally designed to tally fluid circulation and boundary flux, provides the foundation for evaluating these contour integrals.

35.10 Looking forward: from static vector fields to differential equations

Throughout this chapter, we have treated vector fields from a *global, spatial* standpoint. We stood outside the plane or solid, viewing $\mathbf{F}(x, y)$ as a fixed pattern of arrows painted across space, and asked accounting questions over regions:

- How much does the field circulate around a boundary fence C? ($\oint_C \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$)
- How much fluid leaks out across the enclosing skin of a solid? ($\iint_S \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{n}\,\mathrm{d}S$)

Green's, Stokes', and the divergence theorems revealed that all microscopic curls and sources inside cancel in pairs, leaving only a reckoning at the outer perimeter. Even in our excursion into complex analysis, Cauchy's theorem and the Residue Theorem operated by evaluating closed loops around singularities to decode the vibrations of physical systems.

Now consider the trajectory of an individual point. Instead of computing flux across an entire surface, place a particle in the flow at an initial point $\mathbf{r}_0 = (x_0, y_0)$ and track its motion over time.

At every location (x, y), the vector field plants a velocity arrow:

$$\mathbf{F}(x, y) = \big(P(x, y),\, Q(x, y)\big).$$

If the vector field represents a fluid current, the speck must move in the direction the local arrow points, with speed equal to the arrow's length. Its instantaneous velocity $\frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}}{\mathrm{d}t}$ is dictated at every moment by its current position:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \mathbf{F}\big(\mathbf{r}(t)\big) \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \begin{cases} \dfrac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} = P(x,y), \\ \dfrac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = Q(x,y). \end{cases} \tag{35.7}$$

This is our first encounter with an **ordinary differential equation** (ODE): a rule of change relating a quantity's rate of change to its current state.

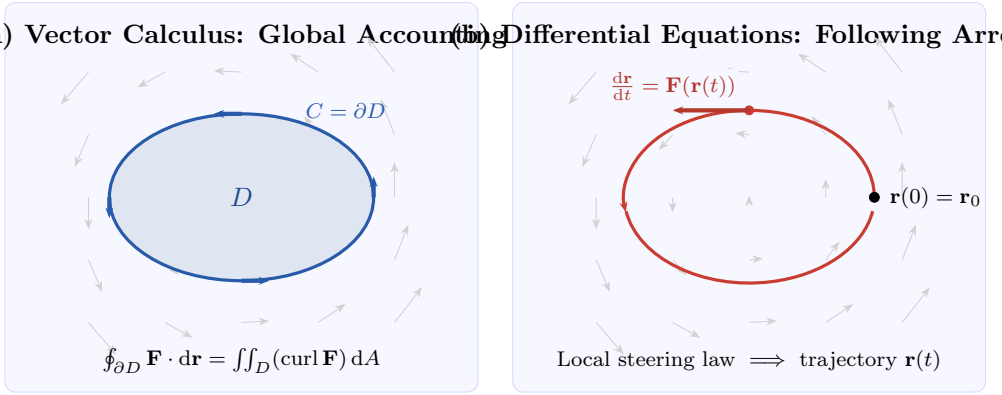


Figure 35.10: From vector calculus to differential equations. (a) Vector calculus takes a global, spatial view: given a static vector field $\mathbf{F}$, it evaluates macroscopic circulation $\oint_{\partial D} \mathbf{F} \cdot \mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}$ or outward flux by summing local derivatives across the interior region D. (b) The theory of differential equations takes a dynamical, temporal view: place a particle at an initial state $\mathbf{r}_0$, and the local field arrow dictates its instantaneous velocity $\frac{\mathrm{d}\mathbf{r}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t))$ at every moment. The resulting solution curve $\mathbf{r}(t)$ (streamline) traces the future of the system. Chapter 36 begins the study of these local laws of change.

Notice the shift in perspective between the two panels of Figure 35.10:

- In **vector calculus**, the vector field is a static canvas. We ask what happens when we integrate across it or around closed boundary loops.
- In **differential equations**, the vector field is a *dynamical rule of motion*. It acts as a compass and speedometer at every point in the plane. An initial point $\mathbf{r}(0) = \mathbf{r}_0$ launches a traveler along a path $\mathbf{r}(t)$ called a *streamline* or *solution trajectory*.

The geometric properties of the vector field determine the behavior of these trajectories. If the field is conservative ($\mathbf{F} = -\nabla U$), every trajectory moves downhill along lines of steepest descent, typically settling toward a local minimum of the potential U. If the field is divergence-free ($\operatorname{div} \mathbf{F} = 0$), any cloud of initial points flowing along the trajectories preserves its area for all t (a fundamental principle known as Liouville's theorem in statistical mechanics).

In Chapter 36, we begin the study of differential equations from the ground up. We temporarily return from multivariable fields to the simplest dynamic case: a single quantity $y(t)$ whose rate of change $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}$ is linked directly to its own value. We will explore what a differential equation actually is, how to visualize direction fields without solving anything, and why these local rules of change govern phenomena ranging from radioactive decay and cooling coffee to the orbits of planets.

35.11 Exercises

Exercise 35.1 (Mental check: curl and loops)**.** Suppose a vector field $\mathbf{F}$ satisfies $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F} = \mathbf{0}$ everywhere in $\mathbb{R}^3$. Without doing any calculation, what is the line integral $\oint_C \mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r}$ around any simple closed loop C? State your reasoning in one sentence using Stokes' theorem.

Exercise 35.2 (Mental check: divergence and closed containers)**.** If a solid watermelon contains no fluid sources or sinks ($\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 0$ everywhere inside), can more fluid flow out through its rind than flows in? What does the divergence theorem say about the net outward flux $\oiint_S \mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}\,dS$?

Exercise 35.3 (Mental check: constant wind)**.** A steady wind blows horizontally across the plains with constant velocity $\mathbf{F}(x,y) = (4,7)$ meters per second. What is its scalar curl? What is its divergence? If you walk once around a circular running track in this wind, what is the net work done on you by the air?

Exercise 35.4. Compute $\displaystyle\int_C \mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r}$ for $\mathbf{F} = (x+y,\, y)$ along the straight segment from $(0,0)$ to $(3,1)$. Parametrize by $\mathbf{r}(t) = (3t, t)$, $t \in [0,1]$, and reduce to a single integral in t.

Exercise 35.5. Show that $\mathbf{F} = (3x^2y + e^y,\; x^3 + xe^y + 2)$ is conservative by checking $P_y = Q_x$, then find a potential f. Use it to evaluate $\int_C \mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r}$ from $(0,0)$ to $(1,1)$ along *any* path.

Exercise 35.6. For $\mathbf{F} = (y,\, -x)$, compute $\oint_C \mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r}$ around the unit circle counterclockwise two ways: directly by parametrization, and via Green's theorem. Confirm they agree, and explain why the nonzero answer proves $\mathbf{F}$ is not conservative.

Exercise 35.7. Use the area formula $\text{Area} = \frac{1}{2}\oint_C x\,dy - y\,dx$ to find the area enclosed by the astroid $x = \cos^3 t$, $y = \sin^3 t$, $t \in [0, 2\pi]$. (You should get $\frac{3}{8}\pi$.)

Exercise 35.8. For $\mathbf{F} = (x^2y,\; -xy^2,\; z)$ compute $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F}$ and $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F}$ as functions of (x,y,z). Is there any point where the field is locally incompressible ($\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 0$)? Explain.

Exercise 35.9. Verify Green's theorem for $\mathbf{F} = (xy,\, x^2)$ over the triangle with vertices $(0,0)$, $(1,0)$, $(1,1)$, by computing both the boundary line integral (three edges) and the double integral of $Q_x - P_y$ over the triangle.

Exercise 35.10. Use the divergence theorem to compute the flux of $\mathbf{F} = (x^3,\, y^3,\, z^3)$ out of the unit sphere. (Hint: $\operatorname{div}\mathbf{F} = 3(x^2+y^2+z^2)$; convert the resulting triple integral to spherical coordinates.)

Exercise 35.11. Let $\mathbf{F} = (z,\, x,\, y)$ and let S be the part of the paraboloid $z = 1 - x^2 - y^2$ above the xy-plane, oriented upward, with boundary the unit circle. Use Stokes' theorem to compute $\oint_{\partial S}\mathbf{F}\cdot d\mathbf{r}$ by integrating $\operatorname{curl}\mathbf{F}\cdot\mathbf{n}$ over the flat unit disk instead (legal because only the rim matters).

Exercise 35.12. Consider $\mathbf{F} = \left(\frac{-y}{x^2+y^2},\, \frac{x}{x^2+y^2}\right)$. (a) Verify that its scalar curl is 0 wherever it is defined. (b) Compute its circulation around the unit circle and get 2π. (c) Explain why parts (a) and (b) do not contradict Green's theorem. (What goes wrong at the origin?)

Exercise 35.13. In your own words, state the single sentence that contains the FTC, the gradient theorem, Green's, Stokes', and the divergence theorem at once. Identify, for each of the five, what plays the role of "the inside," "the derivative taken inside," and "the boundary."

Exercise 35.14 (From field to trajectory)**.** For the swirl field $\mathbf{F}(x,y) = (-y, x)$, write down the corresponding system of differential equations for a moving particle: $\frac{dx}{dt} = P(x,y)$ and $\frac{dy}{dt} = Q(x,y)$. Show by direct differentiation that $\mathbf{r}(t) = \big(R\cos(t - t_0),\, R\sin(t - t_0)\big)$ solves this system for any choice of radius R and initial phase t_0. How does this family of solution curves relate to the concentric circles of Figure 35.1?

Part VIII

Differential Equations

Chapter 36

What a Differential Equation Is

In Chapters 32 through 35, we explored the rich geometry of several variables: partial derivatives, gradients, multiple integrals, and the integral theorems of Green, Stokes, and Gauss. Those theorems dealt with static vector fields defined across curves, surfaces, and volumes in space.

Now we pivot from the static geometry of space to the dynamic geometry of time. Why return from multivariable vector fields to functions of a single variable? Because before we can understand how an entire spatial field evolves in time – the domain of partial differential equations like the heat, wave, and Navier–Stokes equations – we must first master how a single quantity moves forward under a dynamic law. And as you will discover in this chapter, vector fields have not been left behind: a differential equation in the plane assigns a direction to every coordinate, and its solution curves are streamlines flowing through that field.

Every chapter until now has handed you a function and asked questions about it. Here is a curve; what is its slope? Here is a region; what is its flux or volume? The function came first, fully formed, and calculus was the lens through which we studied it. In this chapter, we consider the reverse perspective, which reflects the original motivation for inventing calculus.

For in the real world the function almost never comes first. What comes first is a *law* – a statement about how a quantity is changing right now, expressed in terms of how much of that quantity there is right now. A population grows faster when there are more individuals to reproduce. A hot cup of coffee cools faster when it is further above room temperature. A falling stone speeds up at a rate fixed by gravity. In each case nature does not tell you the function $y(t)$ directly. Nature tells you something about y and its rate of change $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}$, tangled together in a single equation, and leaves you the job of untangling it – of finding the actual function that obeys the law.

An equation that ties a function to its own derivatives is called a *differential equation* (in plain terms: a rule relating what a quantity is doing right now to how fast it is changing). Solving one means finding the functions that satisfy the law. This is the central problem of mathematical physics, of population biology, of engineering, of economics – of nearly every quantitative science. It is, in a real sense, the question calculus was built to answer. Newton developed the derivative in large part to formulate and solve the differential equations of motion governing celestial bodies.

Here we clarify *what these equations are*, what it means to solve one, and why a single law produces a whole family of solutions until an initial condition selects one. We will also see how to visualize solutions as curves threading through a field of slope marks before doing any algebra.

36.1 A law about change

Start with the simplest possible example, built from a sentence rather than from symbols.

Intuition

A quantity grows at a rate equal to its current size. That sentence states a differential equation in words. Piece by piece: "A quantity" is some function $y(t)$ – maybe a population, maybe a bank balance. "Grows at a rate" is its derivative $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}$. "Equal to its current size" means that rate equals y itself. Put the three pieces together and the sentence becomes

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y.$$

That is it. That is a differential equation. It does not tell you what y is. It tells you a *relationship* that the true y – whatever it turns out to be – must satisfy at every instant.

Notice what kind of object an equation like $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y$ is. An ordinary algebraic equation, like $x^2 = y$, relates *numbers*: plug in a number for x, get a number for y. A differential equation relates a *function* to its own derivative. Its unknown is not a number but an entire function. When we ask for a solution, we are asking: *which function, when you differentiate it, gives back a result that fits this equation?*

For $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y$, we need a function that is its own derivative, and we already know one: the exponential, since $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}e^t = e^t$. So $y = e^t$ solves the equation. And it is not the only one: $y = 3e^t$ works too, because its derivative is $3e^t$, which equals the function itself. So does $y = -\frac{1}{2}e^t$, and $y = Ce^t$ for *any* constant C. This infinite collection $y = Ce^t$ is called the *general solution* (the full family of formulas that satisfy the differential equation, indexed by an arbitrary constant). When a specific constant is chosen, such as $y = 3e^t$, we call it a *particular solution* (a single concrete trajectory). We will return to this whole family shortly; for now just register the pattern: one law, many solutions.

Definition 36.1 (Differential equation; ordinary and partial)**.** A *differential equation* is an equation relating an unknown function to one or more of its derivatives. If the unknown function depends on a single independent variable – so that only ordinary derivatives appear – the equation is called an *ordinary differential equation*, abbreviated **ODE**. (An ordinary derivative tracks how a quantity changes along a single parameter, like time.) If the unknown depends on several variables and partial derivatives appear, it is a *partial differential equation*, abbreviated **PDE**. (A partial derivative measures the slope of a surface in one chosen direction while all other coordinates remain constant.) This chapter, and the three that follow, are about ODEs.

The distinction in the definition matters. A PDE like the heat equation $\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2}$ involves a function $u(x,t)$ of two variables – here the temperature u at position x and time t – and is genuinely harder; PDEs are a subject of their own. By restricting to a single independent variable – usually time t or position x – we keep the unknown a curve in the plane, something we can draw. That restriction is exactly what makes the geometric picture in this chapter possible.

History

The phrase "differential equation" goes back to Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, who in a 1676 manuscript was already manipulating equations relating a variable quantity to its differential

dy (his notation for an infinitesimal change). But the subject truly ignited with Isaac Newton. In the *Principia* (1687) and his earlier work on fluxions (Newton's term for rates of change, imagining quantities flowing smoothly through time), Newton's deepest insight was that the laws of nature are most naturally stated as equations of *rates*. His second law of motion, $F = m\,\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2}$ where $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2}$ is the second derivative (acceleration), is a differential equation for position. Newton solved this equation for a planet orbiting the Sun under an inverse-square gravitational pull and mathematically *derived* Kepler's elliptical orbits – proving that a local law of change reproduces the orbital motions of celestial bodies.

In the decades that followed, the Swiss brothers Jakob and Johann Bernoulli turned differential equations into an active field of investigation. They wrestled with physical curve puzzles, notably the *catenary* (the U-shaped curve naturally assumed by a heavy hanging chain supported at both ends) and the celebrated 1696 *brachistochrone* problem (from the Greek for "shortest time," asking what curve allows a frictionless bead to slide between two points in the least possible time). Armed with early infinitesimal methods and ingenious substitutions, the Bernoullis, Leibniz, Huygens, and Newton solved these problems (the brachistochrone turned out to be an inverted cycloid), and in the next generation Leonhard Euler turned such tricks into a systematic theory.

Yet the era was plagued by controversy. A bitter priority feud raged between Newton and Leibniz over who first discovered calculus. A second, deeper debate arose over what actually counted as a "solution." When an equation could not be solved in terms of elementary functions (familiar algebraic combinations of polynomials, roots, sines, and logarithms), was it truly solved? Euler recognized that differential equations themselves define brand-new transcendental functions that expand mathematics beyond elementary algebra.

These methods formed the mathematical basis of classical physics: celestial navigation, wave propagation, acoustics, and the engineering of the Industrial Revolution (steam engines, bridges, and fluid pumps). What remains open today? Most nonlinear differential equations cannot be solved by explicit formulas. Even the simple-looking gravitational motion of three bodies (the classical *three-body problem*) was shown by Henri Poincaré in the 1880s to be non-integrable and prone to deterministic chaos – extreme sensitivity where tiny shifts in starting positions cause wildly diverging futures. And in partial differential equations, proving whether smooth solutions to the three-dimensional Navier–Stokes equations (which govern fluid flow like air turbulence and ocean currents) always exist for all time or can develop infinite singularities remains a famous million-dollar open problem.

36.1.1 The general shape

Most of the equations we meet can be written so that the highest derivative sits alone on the left:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = f(t, y).$$

Read aloud, this says that the rate of change of y is a specified function of the current time t and the current value y. The right-hand side $f(t, y)$ is the *law*: hand it where you are (t) and what you have (y), and it returns how fast y is changing. Our first example $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y$ is the case $f(t, y) = y$ – the rate depends on y but not directly on t. The slightly different equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = t$ has $f(t, y) = t$ – the rate depends on the clock but not on the current value. Both are legitimate, and they behave very differently, as we will see.

What is really happening

A differential equation $\frac{dy}{dt} = f(t, y)$ is a *rule for the slope of a curve, given the curve's location.* It requires that at any point (t, y) in the plane, a solution curve must have slope $f(t, y)$. A solution is a curve that satisfies this slope condition everywhere. Solving the equation means finding a function whose graph matches these local slopes at every point. This geometric interpretation is formalized by the slope field in Section 36.5.

36.2 What it means to solve one

Solving a differential equation is unlike solving the equations you are used to. When you solve $x^2 - 5x + 6 = 0$ you are hunting for *numbers* – here $x = 2$ and $x = 3$. When you solve a differential equation you are hunting for *functions*. The answer is not a value but a formula, a whole curve.

Definition 36.2 (Solution of an ODE)**.** A *solution* of the differential equation $\frac{dy}{dt} = f(t, y)$ on an interval I is a function $y = \varphi(t)$, differentiable on I, such that substituting φ for y makes the equation true for every t in I. That is, $\varphi'(t) = f\big(t, \varphi(t)\big)$ holds identically on I. Verifying a proposed solution is therefore a purely mechanical act: differentiate it, substitute, and check that the two sides agree.

The last sentence of the definition is important: *checking* a proposed solution is always straightforward, even when *finding* it was difficult. You differentiate, you substitute, you see whether the equation holds. Here is that check on our running example.

Example 36.1 (Verifying a solution)**.** Claim: $y = Ce^t$ solves $\frac{dy}{dt} = y$ for every constant C. To check, differentiate the candidate:

$$\frac{dy}{dt} = \frac{d}{dt}(Ce^t) = Ce^t.$$

And the right-hand side of the equation is just $y = Ce^t$. The two agree – $Ce^t = Ce^t$ – for every t and every C. So the claim is verified. We have not *derived* this solution; we have only confirmed it. But confirmation is genuine knowledge: we now know with certainty that every function of the form Ce^t obeys the law.

Example 36.2 (A solution by direct integration)**.** Consider another simple equation, $\frac{dy}{dt} = t$. Here the right-hand side depends only on t. An equation of this form, $\frac{dy}{dt} = g(t)$, is solved by integration, because it asks for a function whose derivative is $g(t)$—the standard antiderivative problem. So

$$y = \int t \, dt = \tfrac{1}{2}t^2 + C.$$

Again a constant of integration appears, and again it is a *family* of solutions, one for each value of C. Every parabola $\frac{1}{2}t^2 + C$ is a vertical shift of every other, and each one has slope exactly t at every point, as the equation demands.

These two examples reveal something structural that you must internalize: **a first-order differential equation does not have one solution; it has a one-parameter family of solutions.** The arbitrary constant C is inherent to the problem rather than an artifact of our solution method.

Why the technique works

A free constant appears because the differential equation specifies only the *slope* of the solution curve, not its *height*. For $\frac{dy}{dt} = t$, the curve must have slope t at position t, but this condition does not determine the vertical placement. Any solution can be shifted vertically by a constant without changing its slope. This vertical freedom corresponds to the integration constant C. In general, a first-order equation determines the solution up to an arbitrary constant, reflecting the initial value.

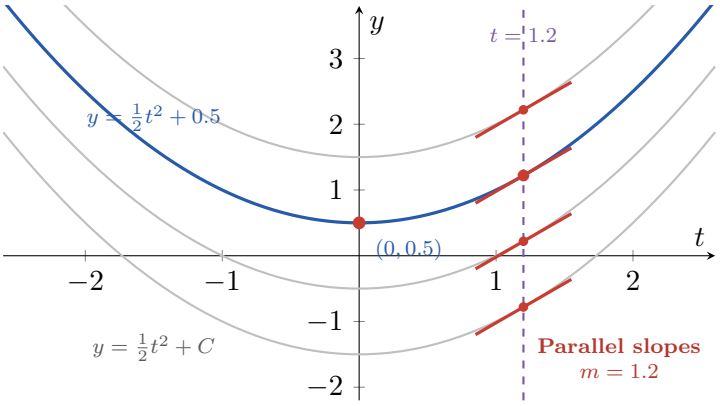


Figure 36.1: The vertical freedom in a differential equation. For $\frac{dy}{dt} = t$, every solution is a parabola $y = \frac{1}{2}t^2 + C$. Along any vertical slice (such as $t = 1.2$, purple dashed line), every parabola has the exact same slope ($m = 1.2$, red tangents), because the rate depends only on t. Sliding a curve vertically leaves its slopes unchanged. An initial condition, like $(0, 0.5)$, acts as a peg: it eliminates the vertical freedom and selects a single particular solution (blue).

This is the cleanest way to see why a single law yields a family (Figure 36.1). The law fixes the *shape* of motion – the slopes everywhere – but not the starting point. To select one solution from the family, we need exactly one more piece of data: an *initial condition*.

36.3 Initial conditions: pinning down one curve

An *initial condition* is a single anchoring fact of the form "at this time, the quantity had this value," written

$$y(t_0) = y_0.$$

It is the missing piece. The differential equation supplies the slopes; the initial condition supplies one point the curve must pass through. Together they typically determine exactly one solution. A differential equation packaged with an initial condition is called an *initial value problem*, or IVP.

Example 36.3 (An initial value problem)**.** Solve

$$\frac{dy}{dt} = y, \qquad y(0) = 5.$$

We already know the general solution is $y = Ce^t$. Now impose the initial condition: at $t = 0$, we need $y = 5$. Substitute:

$$y(0) = Ce^0 = C \cdot 1 = C = 5.$$

So $C = 5$, and the unique solution to the initial value problem is

$$y = 5e^t.$$

The family Ce^t collapsed to a single curve the instant we said where it started. Geometrically, of all the exponential curves obeying the law, exactly one passes through the point $(0, 5)$ – and that is our answer.

Focus

The two-step rhythm of solving an initial value problem is worth committing to memory, because it recurs in every chapter to come:

1. **Find the general solution** – the whole family, with its free constant(s). This is the hard, creative step, the one that needs the techniques of later chapters.
2. **Apply the initial condition(s)** to solve for the constant(s). This is the easy, mechanical step – plug in the known point and do algebra.

Mixing these up – trying to satisfy the initial condition before you have the general family – is the single most common source of confusion for beginners.

Common trap

A tempting error: thinking the initial condition has to be given "at the beginning," at $t = 0$. Not so. The condition $y(t_0) = y_0$ can anchor the curve at *any* time t_0. "Initial" is a name, not a requirement. If a problem tells you $y(3) = 7$, you use that point exactly the same way – substitute $t = 3$, set the result equal to 7, solve for the constant. The word "initial" is a historical leftover from physics, where the natural anchor is the state of a system when you start the clock.

Pause

Pause and think: If you are told that $\frac{dy}{dt} = y$ and $y(2) = 10$, what is the unique solution? *Mental check:* The general solution is $y(t) = Ce^t$. Setting $t = 2$ yields $Ce^2 = 10$, so $C = 10e^{-2}$. The particular solution is therefore $y(t) = 10e^{-2}e^t = 10e^{t-2}$. Notice how cleanly the exponent shifts: when $t = 2$, $e^{2-2} = 1$, instantly verifying $y(2) = 10$.

36.3.1 Why we expect exactly one

Pause on *why* a single initial condition should select a single curve, because the picture here is so persuasive. Imagine you are a tiny walker dropped onto the plane at the starting point (t_0, y_0). The differential equation is a compass: at your current location it tells you which direction to face – it gives you a slope. You take an infinitesimal step in that direction. Now you are at a slightly new point; consult the compass again; it gives a new slope; step again. Marching forward (and backward) this way, you trace out a curve, and at every point of it your heading is exactly the slope the law prescribes – so the curve is a solution. And the curve is *forced*: at each instant you had no choice about which way to step. Start at the same point and you trace the same curve. *One starting point, one path.*

That heuristic is essentially correct, and it is the seed of both a numerical method (Euler's method, which literally takes those small steps) and a theorem (the existence and uniqueness theorem of

Section 36.6). But the heuristic also quietly assumes the compass is well-behaved – that the slope does not do anything pathological. We will see in a moment that when the law misbehaves, uniqueness can genuinely fail, and the picture of the forced walker breaks down in an instructive way.

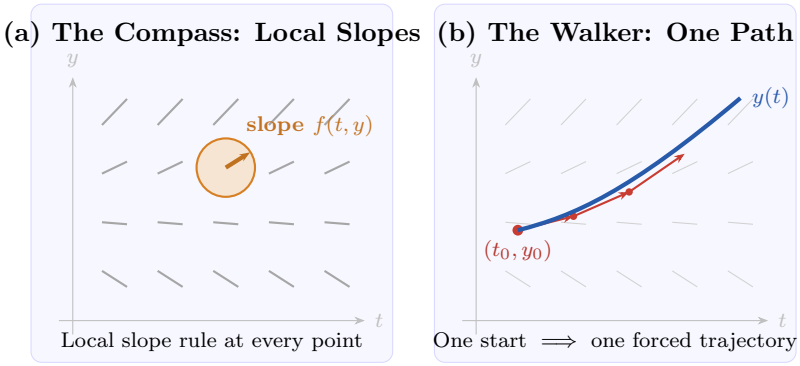


Figure 36.2: The walker and the compass. (a) A differential equation $\frac{dy}{dt} = f(t, y)$ acts as a local compass, assigning a prescribed heading to every coordinate in the plane. (b) Dropping a walker at an initial point (t_0, y_0) fixes the entire journey: stepping along the compass directions forces out a single, unique solution curve $y(t)$.

36.4 Order and linearity: classifying equations

Differential equations take many forms. Two primary ways of classifying them are by *order* and by *linearity*. These two properties indicate the structure of an equation and the appropriate methods for solving it.

Definition 36.3 (Order)**.** The *order* of a differential equation is the order of the highest derivative that appears in it.

Thus $\frac{dy}{dt} = y$ is *first order* – only the first derivative shows up. Newton's law of motion $m\frac{d^2x}{dt^2} = F$, involving the second derivative (acceleration), is *second order*. The order matters enormously: a first-order equation needs one initial condition to pin down a solution, a second-order equation needs *two* (typically an initial position *and* an initial velocity), and in general an nth-order equation carries n free constants in its general solution and needs n conditions to fix them.

Connection

The rule "order n means n free constants" is the differential-equation echo of a fact you already know from integration. Each time you integrate, you collect one constant of integration. A second-order equation is, very loosely, "two integrations deep," so it accumulates two constants; an nth-order equation, n of them. This is exactly why pinning down a thrown ball's motion ($\frac{d^2x}{dt^2} = -g$, second order) requires two facts – where you threw it from and how fast – not one. Integrating $-g$ once gives velocity with a constant; integrating again gives position with a second constant. Two integrations, two constants, two initial conditions.

The second classifier, linearity, is subtler but matters even more, because the entire theory splits along this line. Linear equations are the ones we can largely *solve*; nonlinear ones are, in general, beyond closed-form reach and must be studied qualitatively or numerically.

Definition 36.4 (Linear ODE)**.** A differential equation is *linear* if the unknown function y and *all* of its derivatives appear only to the first power, never multiplied together, and never inside any nonlinear function. A first-order linear ODE can always be written in the standard form

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} + p(t)\, y = q(t),$$

where p and q are given functions of t alone. If the unknown appears in any other way – squared, as y^2; multiplied by its own derivative, as $y\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t}$; or inside a function, as $\sin y$ or e^y – the equation is *nonlinear*.

In a linear equation, the unknown and its derivatives appear only to the first power, scaled by coefficients that may depend on t but not on y. Linearity is a condition on how the dependent variable y enters, not on how t enters.

Example 36.4 (Sorting a handful of equations)**.** Classify a few equations to make the definitions concrete.

- $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y$ – first order, linear ($p(t) = -1$, $q(t) = 0$).
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = t^2 y + \cos t$ – first order, linear; rewrite as $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} - t^2 y = \cos t$, so $p = -t^2$, $q = \cos t$. The coefficient functions $p(t)$ and $q(t)$ may be nonlinear in t.
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y^2$ – first order, *nonlinear*: y appears squared.
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = \sin y$ – first order, *nonlinear*: y sits inside sin.
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} + 3\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} + 2x = 0$ – second order, linear.
- $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\theta}{\mathrm{d}t^2} + \sin\theta = 0$ – second order, *nonlinear* (the pendulum equation; $\sin\theta$ is the culprit).

Pause

Pause and think: Why is $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = t^4 y$ a linear equation, whereas $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = t y^4$ is nonlinear? The power 4 appears in both. *Mental check:* Linearity cares strictly about the *unknown function* y and its derivatives, never about the independent variable t. In $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = t^4 y$, the unknown y appears purely to the first power; the factor t^4 is merely a time-dependent coefficient $p(t) = -t^4$. In $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = t y^4$, the unknown itself is raised to the fourth power, which immediately breaks linearity.

Why this matters

The central role of linearity stems from the *superposition principle*: if y_1 and y_2 both solve a linear *homogeneous* equation (where $q(t) = 0$), then so does every linear combination $c_1 y_1 + c_2 y_2$. This algebraic fact – that the solution set forms a vector space – is the foundation for the theory of linear ODEs and enables systematic solution formulas. Nonlinear equations have no such principle; their solutions cannot be combined by addition. Superposition makes linearity the primary dividing line of the subject.

36.5 The slope field: seeing solutions before solving

Here is the idea that turns an abstract equation into a picture you can read with your eyes. It rests entirely on the mechanism exposed earlier: a first-order equation $\frac{dy}{dt} = f(t, y)$ assigns a *slope to every point* of the plane. So *draw* those slopes.

At a grid of points (t, y), compute the number $f(t, y)$ and draw a short line segment through the point with that slope. Do this at many points and you fill the plane with a texture of tiny tilted dashes – a *slope field* (also called a direction field). Each dash is a local instruction: "a solution passing through here must be heading this way." A solution curve is then any curve that flows along the dashes, tangent to the field at every point it touches, like a leaf carried by a current.

Connection

The geometric turn of Poincaré. The idea of reading an equation through its field of directions is older than it looks. The eighteenth-century analysts already thought of $\frac{dy}{dt} = f(t, y)$ as prescribing a direction at each point, but it was the qualitative theory of differential equations – pioneered by Henri Poincaré in the 1880s in his memoirs on curves defined by differential equations – that made the geometric viewpoint a discipline in its own right. Faced with equations that no algebraic formula could ever solve, Poincaré shifted the question from "can we write down an exact formula for the solution?" to "what does the family of solutions *look like*?" – where the curves go, which ones are stable, and what happens in the long run. The slope field is the gateway to that whole way of thinking, and it is the seed of the phase-plane analysis you will meet in Chapter 39.

Intuition

The slope field is the differential equation made *visible*. You never solve anything; you just plot the law's slope at a mesh of points. And yet, once the field is drawn, the solutions reveal themselves to the eye: trace any curve that stays tangent to the little dashes, and you are tracing a solution. Different starting heights give different curves – the family of solutions appears as a family of streamlines combing through the field.

Take the slope field for our very first equation, $\frac{dy}{dt} = y$. Here $f(t, y) = y$: the prescribed slope at a point is simply its height. Above the t-axis (where $y > 0$) slopes are positive and steepen as you rise; below it (where $y < 0$) slopes are negative and steepen as you fall; right on the axis ($y = 0$) the slope is 0, flat. Figure 36.3 shows the result, with three solution curves $y = Ce^t$ threaded through it.

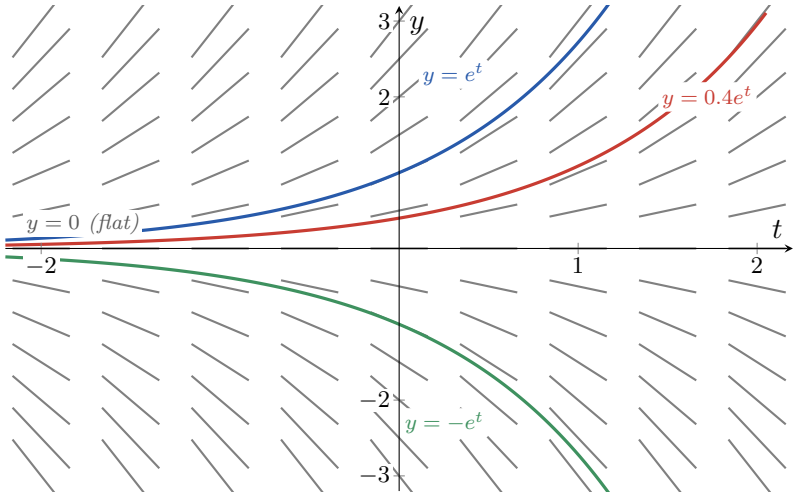


Figure 36.3: The slope field for $\frac{dy}{dt} = y$. Each gray dash has slope equal to its own height y. Three solution curves $y = Ce^t$ flow tangent to the field: $C = 1$ (blue), $C = 0.4$ (red), and $C = -1$ (green). Notice how every curve hugs the dashes everywhere it passes.

Spend a moment really looking at Figure 36.3. The dashes are flat along the t-axis and tilt ever more steeply as you move away from it – exactly because the slope equals the height. The blue curve, $y = e^t$, rises through the steepening forest of positive slopes, always tangent. The green curve, $y = -e^t$, plunges through the negative slopes below. And the t-axis itself, $y = 0$, is a perfectly flat solution – the constant zero function, with slope 0 everywhere, matching the flat dashes that lie along it. You are reading the entire solution family off a picture, having solved nothing.

Walking question

Look again at Figure 36.3 and ask yourself: through the single point $(0, 0.4)$, how many solution curves pass? Trace the dashes by eye starting there. You should find that the curve is forced – there is exactly one streamline through that point (the red one, $y = 0.4e^t$), because at every step the field dictates your heading. This is the geometric face of uniqueness: a well-behaved slope field carries exactly one solution curve through each point. Now ask the harder question: can two *different* solution curves ever cross each other? If they did, they would share a point – and at that shared point the field prescribes a single slope, so both curves would have to leave it in the same direction. Solution curves of a nice first-order equation never cross. That is uniqueness, seen.

36.5.1 Reading a field with a t-dependent slope

The previous field had slopes depending only on y, so the pattern looked the same at every horizontal position. Now take one where the clock matters too:

$$\frac{dy}{dt} = t - y.$$

Now the prescribed slope at (t, y) is $t - y$, which changes as you move both horizontally and vertically. Where $t = y$ – along the diagonal line $y = t$ – the slope is zero, so the dashes lie flat there. Above

that diagonal ($y > t$) slopes are negative; below it ($y < t$) slopes are positive. Everything is gently herded toward a special straight solution. Figure 36.4 shows the field with two solution curves.

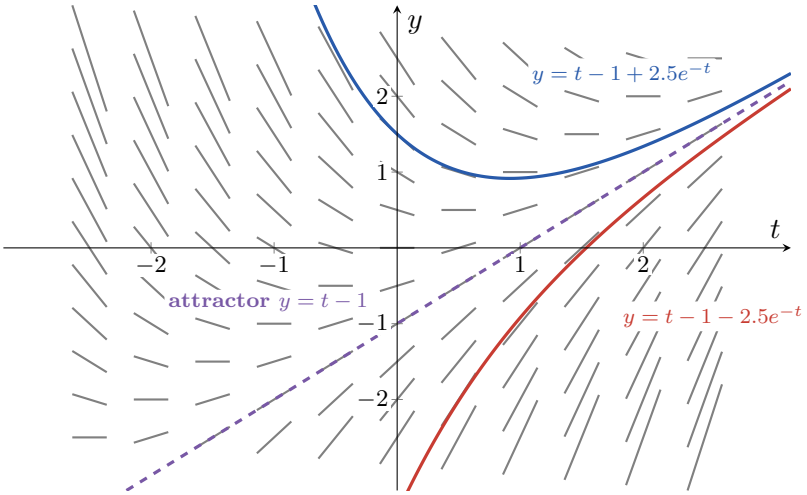


Figure 36.4: The slope field for $\frac{dy}{dt} = t - y$. Dashes are flat along the diagonal $y = t$ and tilt away from it. The purple dashed line $y = t - 1$ is itself a solution – an *attractor* every other solution curls toward. The blue and red curves, $y = t - 1 \pm 2.5e^{-t}$, both rush in to merge with it as t grows.

There is a striking feature in Figure 36.4 that you could not have guessed from the bare equation but that the picture announces immediately: the line $y = t - 1$ is itself a solution, and it acts as an *attractor*. Check that it solves the equation: if $y = t - 1$ then $\frac{dy}{dt} = 1$, while the right side is $t - y = t - (t - 1) = 1$. They match. And every other solution, no matter where it starts, bends toward this line as t increases – you can watch the blue and red curves swoop in and shadow it. This long-run behavior is exactly the kind of qualitative insight slope fields hand you for free, long before you can write the general solution $y = t - 1 + Ce^{-t}$ (substitute it to check that it works).

What is really happening

What is really happening when you "read a slope field" is that you are performing, by eye, the same construction the existence theorem performs by logic and Euler's method performs by arithmetic. All three reconstruct a global solution from purely local slope data. Your eye integrates the field into a smooth streamline; Euler's method integrates it into a polygonal approximation by taking literal small steps; the theorem proves that this integration always succeeds (under mild hypotheses) and yields exactly one curve per starting point. The slope field is therefore not a mere illustration – it is the geometric content of the equation itself. An equation you cannot solve in formulas, you can very often *understand completely* from its field.

36.5.2 A field we cannot solve, but can read: the logistic law

For the first two fields we could spot or check a formula almost by inspection, so the slope field only confirmed what algebra already knew. The picture earns its place when we do not yet have the algebra. The cleanest example in elementary modeling is the *logistic equation*, the corrected law of

population growth that we will meet again in Section 36.7:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = k\,P\left(1 - \frac{P}{M}\right).$$

The right-hand side is nonlinear (expanding it gives a $-kP^2/M$ term), and its explicit formula will have to wait until Chapter 37 develops separation of variables. We cannot solve it yet, but we can draw its slope field right now and read off how its solutions behave.

Read the law as a rule for slope. Two heights make the right side vanish: $P = 0$ and $P = M$. At those two heights the prescribed slope is zero, so the dashes lie perfectly flat – they mark two *equilibrium* (constant) solutions, two horizontal lines where the slope is zero. Between them, for $0 < P < M$, both factors P and $1 - P/M$ are positive, so the slope is positive and every solution climbs. Above the carrying capacity, $P > M$, the factor $1 - P/M$ turns negative, the slope turns negative, and solutions fall. Both regions drain toward the line $P = M$: it is an attractor, just like the line $y = t - 1$ was for the earlier field. Figure 36.5 draws it, taking $k = 1$ and $M = 3$.

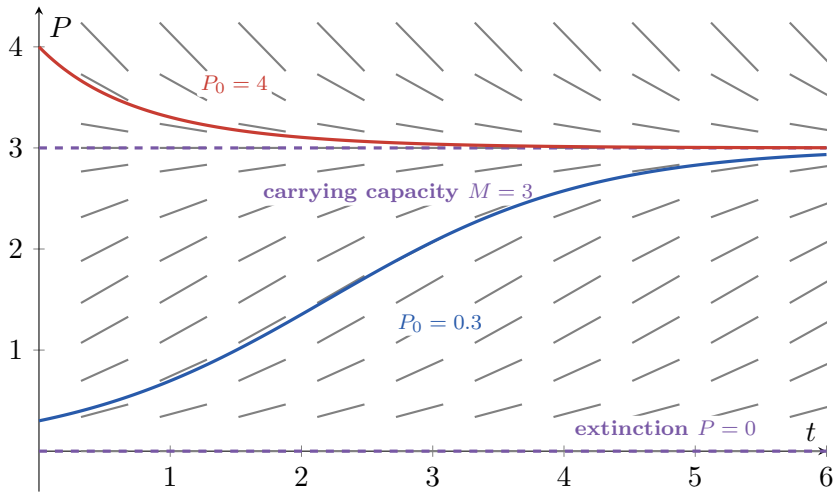


Figure 36.5: The slope field for the logistic law $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = P(1 - P/3)$ (so $k = 1$, $M = 3$). The dashes lie flat along the two equilibria $P = 0$ and $P = M = 3$ (purple dashed). The blue curve starts small ($P_0 = 0.3$) and traces the famous "S" shape – slow, then fast, then leveling off at the carrying capacity. The red curve starts above capacity ($P_0 = 4$) and sinks toward the same line. Every solution is herded toward $P = M$.

Walking question

Follow the blue curve in Figure 36.5 across three stages of growth. Near the bottom the dashes are nearly flat (small P makes the slope small), so the curve creeps – a young population grows slowly because there are few to reproduce. Through the middle, around $P = M/2 = 1.5$, the slope is steepest (the product $P(1 - P/M)$ is maximal there), and the curve shoots up – this is the rapid growth phase. Near the top the dashes flatten again as P nears M, and the curve eases into a plateau – growth slows as the population approaches capacity. Slow, fast, slow: that produces the characteristic sigmoid curve. We have determined the qualitative behavior of a self-limiting population without solving the nonlinear equation analytically. The red curve from above similarly approaches the attractor $P = M$ from higher initial values.

This illustrates the utility of slope fields. The logistic equation is a nonlinear law that can be solved analytically by separation of variables (as shown in the next chapter) – but even before doing so, the direction field displays the equilibria, their stability, and the characteristic shape of every solution. For equations that resist closed-form solution entirely, this geometric approach is essential.

36.6 Existence and uniqueness, intuitively

We have been assuming, on the strength of the walker picture, that an initial value problem has exactly one solution. It is time to say carefully when that is true – and, just as instructively, when it fails. The governing result is one of the cornerstones of the subject.

Theorem 36.1 (Existence and Uniqueness, informal)**.** *Consider the initial value problem*

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = f(t, y), \qquad y(t_0) = y_0.$$

*If f is continuous in a rectangle around the point (t_0, y_0), then at least one solution exists through that point (*existence*). If, in addition, the partial derivative $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ is continuous there, then the solution is* unique *– exactly one solution curve passes through (t_0, y_0).*

The theorem has two halves, and they require different amounts of niceness from the law f. Mere continuity of f buys you *existence*: some solution gets going. To also guarantee *uniqueness* – that the walker's path is forced, with no branching – you need the extra smoothness that $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ be continuous (a slightly weaker "Lipschitz" condition is what the full proof really uses, but continuity of $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ is the clean sufficient version). Intuitively, $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ controls how fast the prescribed slope changes as you move up and down; keeping it under control prevents nearby curves from being able to split apart or merge.

Intuition

Read the theorem as a guarantee about the walker. *Existence* says: if the compass (the law f) points somewhere sensible at and near your starting spot, you can always start walking – a path exists. *Uniqueness* says: if the compass also turns *smoothly* as you move (no sudden infinite swings in the prescribed slope), then your path is completely determined – there is no fork in the road, no moment where the law leaves you a choice. Together they justify the whole enterprise: a sensible law plus a starting point yields one and only one future.

Pause

Pause and think: Does Theorem 36.1 guarantee that a unique solution passes through $(0, 2)$ for the equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 3y + \cos t$? *Mental check:* Here $f(t, y) = 3y + \cos t$, which is continuous everywhere. Its partial derivative with respect to y is $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y} = 3$, which is a constant and therefore continuous across the entire plane. Both hypotheses hold everywhere, so exactly one solution curve passes through $(0, 2)$ – and through any other point you choose.

Without this theorem, deterministic modeling lacks a formal guarantee. If a physical process is modeled by a differential equation and an initial condition, we expect exactly one determined outcome. The existence and uniqueness theorem confirms this mathematically, ensuring that a well-posed initial value problem yields exactly one solution.

36.6.1 When uniqueness fails – and why that is not a paradox

The following example illustrates why the hypotheses of Theorem 36.1 are necessary. Consider the problem

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = \sqrt{|y|}, \qquad y(0) = 0.$$

Here $f(t, y) = \sqrt{|y|}$ is continuous everywhere, so existence is satisfied – a solution exists. But watch what $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ does near $y = 0$. For $y > 0$, $f = \sqrt{y}$ and $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y} = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{y}}$, which blows up to infinity as $y \to 0$. The uniqueness hypothesis fails at the starting point, and uniqueness itself fails with it:

Example 36.5 (Two solutions from one start)**.** The constant function $y(t) = 0$ solves the problem: its derivative is 0, and $\sqrt{|0|} = 0$, so the equation holds, and $y(0) = 0$. But the function

$$y(t) = \tfrac{1}{4}t^2 \quad (t \geq 0)$$

also solves it. Check: $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{2}t$, while $\sqrt{|y|} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{4}t^2} = \frac{1}{2}t$ for $t \geq 0$. The two sides match, and $y(0) = 0$. So *two different* solution curves emerge from the single point $(0, 0)$ – the flat one that stays put, and the rising parabola. In fact there are infinitely many: the curve can linger at zero for any length of time $a \geq 0$ and then peel up into the shifted parabola $y = \frac{1}{4}(t - a)^2$. Figure 36.6 shows a few of them fanning out of the origin. Uniqueness does not hold here.

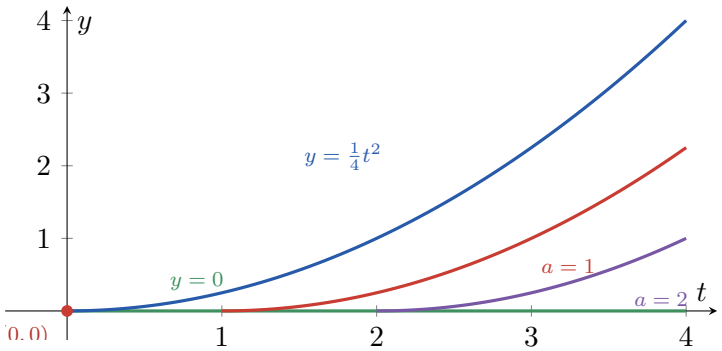


Figure 36.6: Non-uniqueness for $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = \sqrt{|y|}$, $y(0) = 0$. Infinitely many solution curves leave the single starting point $(0, 0)$: the flat solution $y = 0$ (green), and a whole fan of parabolas $y = \frac{1}{4}(t - a)^2$ that linger at zero until an arbitrary time a and then rise. The uniqueness hypothesis $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ continuous fails at $y = 0$, and this is what failure looks like.

Common trap

The lesson is that the hypotheses of the theorem are essential. When $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ is continuous, uniqueness is guaranteed; when that condition fails (here, an infinite partial derivative at $y = 0$), solutions can branch. Never assume uniqueness for a nonlinear equation without checking the hypothesis. The square-root law above is not an artificial curiosity: up to constants, it governs how fast a leaking tank drains (Torricelli's law). Its non-uniqueness has a concrete physical reading: staring at an empty tank, you cannot run the clock backward to tell when it finished draining, because tanks that emptied at different times all look identical afterward.

36.7 Why differential equations exist: modeling

We have treated differential equations as mathematical objects, but they earn their central place because they are the language of *change in the physical world*. A modeling problem almost always arrives as a statement about rates, and translating that statement into symbols produces a differential equation. We construct three classical models from basic physical principles.

36.7.1 Population growth

Application

The sentence: *A population grows at a rate proportional to its current size.* The reasoning is straightforward – twice as many individuals means twice as many births per year. Let $P(t)$ be the population. "Grows at a rate" is $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t}$; "proportional to its current size" means that rate is some constant k times P. So

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = kP.$$

This is the differential equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = kP$ applied to population dynamics. Its solution is $P(t) = P_0 e^{kt}$, where $P_0 = P(0)$ is the starting population: *exponential growth*, the same model that describes unchecked populations, continuously compounded interest, and chain reactions. The constant k is the per-capita growth rate; a larger k means faster growth.

Exponential growth is, of course, too optimistic forever – no real population grows without bound. The fix is itself a lesson in modeling: add a term that brakes the growth as P approaches a carrying capacity M. That gives the *logistic equation* $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = kP(1 - P/M)$, a nonlinear model whose slope field shows every solution leveling off at M. We will not solve it here, but notice how naturally a refined sentence ("growth slows as the population fills its niche") produces a refined equation.

36.7.2 Newton's law of cooling

Application

The sentence: *An object cools at a rate proportional to the gap between its temperature and the surrounding temperature.* Let $T(t)$ be the object's temperature and A the ambient temperature. The "gap" is $T - A$. The rate of cooling is $\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t}$, and "proportional to the gap" (with cooling, so the constant is negative) gives

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t} = -k\,(T - A), \qquad k > 0.$$

When $T > A$ the right side is negative and the object cools; when $T < A$ it is positive and the object warms; when $T = A$ the rate is zero and the temperature holds. The solution is $T(t) = A + (T_0 - A)e^{-kt}$ – the temperature decays exponentially toward the ambient A, exactly the attractor behavior we saw in Figure 36.4. This is the equation forensic scientists use to estimate time of death from body temperature.

36.7.3 Motion under a force

Application

The sentence: *Force equals mass times acceleration.* Acceleration is the second derivative of position, $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2}$, so Newton's second law is already a second-order differential equation:

$$m\,\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = F.$$

For a stone in free fall the force is constant, $F = -mg$, and the equation collapses to $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = -g$. Integrate once for velocity, again for position, collecting two constants – which the two initial conditions (starting height and starting velocity) fix. For a mass on a spring the force is $F = -kx$ (Hooke's law, pulling back toward rest), giving $m\,\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = -kx$, whose solutions oscillate sinusoidally forever. The same skeleton, $F = ma$, with a different force law, produces falling, orbiting, oscillating, and swinging – the entire repertoire of classical motion.

Why this matters

Notice the unity here. Three completely different phenomena – a breeding population, a cooling cup, a falling stone – led to differential equations, and two of them led to the *same* equation, $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = ky$, up to a shift ($y = T - A$ for cooling) and the sign of the constant. This is what gives the subject its reach: a handful of equation-shapes recur across all of science, so that mastering them addresses problems across biology, physics, chemistry, and finance. The differential equation is the level of abstraction at which a population, a bank account, and a radioactive sample share the same mathematical structure.

Work it yourself

Before reading on, try translating each sentence into a differential equation yourself – do not solve, just write the equation.

1. A radioactive sample decays at a rate proportional to the amount remaining.
2. A skydiver's downward speed v increases due to gravity but is opposed by air resistance proportional to the speed.
3. A savings account grows by continuous interest at rate r, and money is also withdrawn at a steady w dollars per year.

Answers: (1) $\frac{\mathrm{d}N}{\mathrm{d}t} = -kN$; (2) $m\,\frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}t} = mg - bv$; (3) $\frac{\mathrm{d}B}{\mathrm{d}t} = rB - w$. Notice that each is just a sentence about rates, set equal to symbols. That translation – prose to equation – is the real modeling skill, and it is almost entirely a matter of identifying "rate of change of ___" with a derivative.

36.8 Looking ahead

You now know what a differential equation is, what it means to solve one, how an initial condition selects one solution from a family, and how to classify equations by order and linearity. You also

know how to *see* solutions in a slope field, when existence and uniqueness are guaranteed, and why the sciences write their laws in this language. What remains is technique – the actual machinery for producing the general solutions we have so far only verified or read off pictures.

The next three chapters supply that machinery. Chapter 37, *First-Order Differential Equations*, immediately develops systematic methods for first-order equations – separation of variables, which solves $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = ky$ and the logistic equation, and the integrating factor, which solves first-order linear equations $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} + p(t)y = q(t)$. The chapter after that tackles second-order linear equations, where superposition gives a complete and elegant theory – this is the home of springs, circuits, and resonance. And the final chapter pushes onward to systems of equations and the qualitative, geometric viewpoint, where the slope-field thinking of this chapter blossoms into the full phase-plane analysis of how coupled quantities evolve together. The pictures you have learned to read here are the ones you will be reading for the rest of the subject.

Exercises

Exercise 36.1 (Mental check: equations and their unknowns)**.** For each equation, identify what kind of mathematical object a solution must be (a number, a coordinate point, or an entire function): (a) $x^2 - 4x + 3 = 0$; (b) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 3y - t$; (c) $x^2 + y^2 = 25$; (d) $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}t^2} + 9y = 0$. Which of these are ordinary differential equations?

Exercise 36.2 (Mental check: reading slope from the law)**.** Without solving or finding an antiderivative, determine the slope of the solution curve to $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 2t - y$ as it passes through the point $(t, y) = (1, 3)$. Is the solution curve rising, falling, or flat at that exact instant? Where in the (t, y) plane would solution curves have horizontal tangents?

Exercise 36.3. Verify by substitution that $y = \sin(2t)$ is a solution of the second-order equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}t^2} + 4y = 0$. Then verify that $y = \cos(2t)$ is also a solution, and that $y = 3\sin(2t) - 5\cos(2t)$ is too. What property of the equation makes this last combination work?

Exercise 36.4. For each equation state its order, and say whether it is linear or nonlinear (give the reason for any nonlinearity): (a) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 3y - 7$; (b) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y\cos t$; (c) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = \cos(y)$; (d) $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} + x\,\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} + x = 0$; (e) $t^2\frac{\mathrm{d}^2y}{\mathrm{d}t^2} - t\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} + y = e^t$.

Exercise 36.5. The general solution of $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = -2y$ is $y = Ce^{-2t}$. Find the particular solution satisfying $y(0) = 7$. Then find the one satisfying $y(1) = 7$ instead, and explain why the constant C comes out differently in the two cases.

Exercise 36.6. Solve the initial value problem $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 6t^2 - 4$, $y(0) = 3$, by direct integration. (This equation's right-hand side depends only on t, so a single antiderivative does the job.)

Exercise 36.7. Consider $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = -y/t$ for $t > 0$. (a) Along which curves in the plane is the prescribed slope equal to zero? Where is it undefined? (b) Verify that $y = C/t$ is a solution for every constant C. (c) Sketch, by hand, the slope field at a few points and confirm that the curves $y = C/t$ (hyperbolas) flow tangent to it.

Exercise 36.8. For Newton's law of cooling $\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t} = -k(T - A)$ with $k > 0$: (a) What constant function $T(t)$ is a solution? (This is the *equilibrium* temperature.) (b) Using the slope-field reasoning of Section 36.5, argue without solving that every solution approaches A as $t \to \infty$. (c) Verify that $T(t) = A + (T_0 - A)e^{-kt}$ solves the equation and satisfies $T(0) = T_0$.

Exercise 36.9. Explain, in your own words, why the general solution of an nth-order differential equation should contain n arbitrary constants. Then state how many initial conditions are needed to determine a unique solution of (a) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y^2$, and (b) $m\frac{\mathrm{d}^2x}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = -kx$, and say physically what those conditions represent in case (b).

Exercise 36.10. Consider $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 3y^{2/3}$ with $y(0) = 0$. (a) Verify that $y(t) = 0$ is a solution. (b) Verify that $y(t) = t^3$ is also a solution. (c) Compute $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ for $f(t, y) = 3y^{2/3}$ and explain, by reference to Theorem 36.1, why the existence of two solutions does not contradict the uniqueness theorem.

Exercise 36.11. Translate each sentence into a differential equation (do not solve): (a) A tank holds V liters of water; salt water flows in carrying salt at a constant r grams per minute, and well-mixed water flows out carrying salt at a rate proportional to the current amount S of salt. (b) The velocity v of a parachutist changes under gravity minus an air-resistance force proportional to v^2. (c) A rumor spreads through a town of N people at a rate proportional to the product of those who know it, y, and those who do not, $N - y$.

Exercise 36.12. The logistic equation is $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = kP\left(1 - \dfrac{P}{M}\right)$ with $k, M > 0$. (a) Find the two constant (equilibrium) solutions by setting the right-hand side to zero. (b) For $0 < P < M$, is $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t}$ positive or negative? What does this say about a population that starts below carrying capacity? (c) Without solving, sketch the qualitative shape of a solution that starts at $P(0)$ slightly above zero, and explain why it has the famous "S" shape.

Exercise 36.13. The equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y^2$ is nonlinear. Show that $y_1 = -1/t$ is a solution (for $t > 0$), but that $2y_1 = -2/t$ is *not* a solution. Why does this not violate any principle? Contrast with what would happen for a linear homogeneous equation, and connect your answer to the discussion of superposition in Section 36.4.

Chapter 37

First-Order Differential Equations

Chapter 36 introduced differential equations from the outside: how to read them as local laws of change, how an initial condition selects one solution out of a family, and how to see solutions in a slope field. This chapter builds the methods that actually *solve* them, starting with first-order equations, where a single derivative ties the slope of an unknown curve to its current position.

Differential equations are the standard way physical and biological laws are stated. Newton did not hand us a closed-form formula for the position of a planet; he handed us a law dictating how its velocity changes under force. A biologist modeling an epidemic does not start with a predetermined infected-count curve; she starts with a relationship stating that the rate of new infections is proportional to the encounters between sick and susceptible individuals. A bank does not define your balance in twenty years by decree; it quotes an annual interest rate, which is an assertion about $\frac{\mathrm{d}B}{\mathrm{d}t}$. The laws governing the natural world are overwhelmingly local rules of change. Solving a differential equation is the art of knitting those local, instantaneous rules into a global, long-term picture of behavior.

A **first-order** differential equation is one in which only the first derivative appears: no y'', no y''', just y' and y and the independent variable. The general shape is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = f(x, y).$$

Geometrically, at every point (x, y) in the plane, the right-hand side $f(x, y)$ hands you a *number* — a slope. So a first-order ODE is really a field of little slope-marks blanketing the plane, and a solution is a curve that is everywhere tangent to those marks. That picture, the *slope field*, is the single most important image in this chapter. Hold onto it.

37.1 The Picture First: Slope Fields

Keep the slope-field picture from Chapter 36 in view through every algebraic step in this chapter. The equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = f(x, y)$ plants a short segment of slope $f(x, y)$ at each point, and a solution curve is a path that flows tangent to those segments, like a leaf carried on a current.

Intuition

Think of the slope field as a current in a river and the solution curves as the paths leaves take when dropped in. Drop a leaf at a point — that is choosing an initial condition — and the current carries it along a unique path. Different starting points give different paths, but they all obey the same current. Solving the ODE means *finding the shape of those paths.* You can often sketch their shape by eye, long before you can write a formula, just by following the arrows.

Consider the simplest interesting example, $\frac{dy}{dx} = y$. At a point with height $y = 2$ the slope is 2; at height $y = -1$ the slope is -1; along the x-axis the slope is 0. The slope depends only on height, not on x, so the field looks the same as you slide left or right. Figure 37.1 shows it.

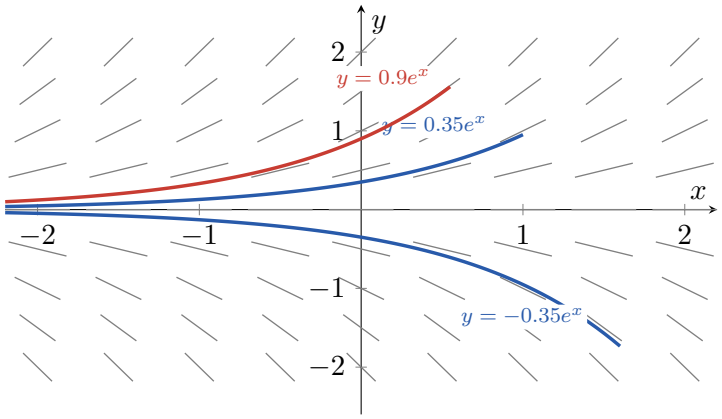


Figure 37.1: The slope field of $\frac{dy}{dx} = y$. Each gray segment has slope equal to its own height (so the marks are flat along the x-axis and steepen away from it). Three solution curves $y = Ce^x$ (blue and red) thread through the field, everywhere tangent to it. Notice how the curves never cross — one leaf, one path.

The blue and red curves are the solutions $y = Ce^x$. We have not derived that yet, but you can *believe* it from the picture: a curve hugging arrows whose slope equals their height is exactly a curve whose own slope equals its own height, and the exponential is the function that is its own derivative.

Pause

Pause and think: reading a slope field by eye. Consider the differential equation $\frac{dy}{dx} = -\frac{x}{y}$. What do the slopes do along the coordinate axes? On the y-axis (where $x = 0$), the slope is 0, giving horizontal slope marks. On the x-axis (where $y = 0$), the slope is undefined (division by zero), giving vertical slope marks. In the first quadrant ($x > 0, y > 0$), every slope is negative. What familiar family of geometric curves is flat at the top and bottom, vertical at the far left and right, and tilts downward in between? Concentric circles, $x^2+y^2 = C$. Without computing a single antiderivative, your visual intuition has already solved the equation.

What is really happening

A first-order ODE is a *local* law: it only ever talks about one point at a time, telling you the slope there. Solving it means *integrating that local law into a global shape*. The remarkable thing — guaranteed by the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus and the existence–uniqueness theorems — is that an infinitesimal rule, repeated, knits itself into a single coherent curve. Every solution method in this chapter is a different way of doing that knitting.

Focus

Three words you must keep straight:

- A **general solution** is a whole *family* of curves, carrying one arbitrary constant C (because a first-order equation involves one integration, and integration always leaves a $+C$).
- An **initial condition** like $y(x_0) = y_0$ picks *one* curve out of the family by naming a point it must pass through. This nails down C.
- A **particular solution** is that single chosen curve.

The general solution is the river; the initial condition is where you drop the leaf; the particular solution is the leaf's path.

37.2 Separable Equations

The friendliest equations are those in which the slope $f(x, y)$ factors into a part that depends only on x times a part that depends only on y:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = g(x)\,h(y).$$

We call these **separable**, because we can herd all the y's to one side and all the x's to the other. The standard procedure treats $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ formally as a differential quotient, multiplying both sides by $\mathrm{d}x$, dividing by $h(y)$, and integrating:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{h(y)} = g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \int \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{h(y)} = \int g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x.$$

This works. But notice what we just did: we chopped the derivative $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ in half and treated $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ as separate movable objects, as if the derivative were a genuine ratio of two numbers. However, $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$ is formally a *limit* of ratios, a single indivisible symbol. So why is this allowed?

Why the technique works

Separation of variables is the chain rule run backwards. Here is the rigorous derivation, with no division of $\mathrm{d}y$ by $\mathrm{d}x$.
Start from $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = g(x)\,h(y)$. Assume $h(y) \neq 0$, and divide both sides (legitimately, these are real numbers) by $h(y)$:

$$\frac{1}{h(y)}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = g(x).$$

Now introduce $H(y)$, an antiderivative of $1/h(y)$, so that $H'(y) = 1/h(y)$. By the *chain rule*, the left-hand side is exactly the derivative of $H(y(x))$ with respect to x:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(H(y(x))) = H'(y)\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{1}{h(y)}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}.$$

So our equation says

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(H(y(x))) = g(x).$$

Two functions of x with the same derivative differ by a constant, so integrating both sides in x gives

$$H(y) = \int g(x)\,\mathrm{d}x + C.$$

That is *precisely* the answer the casual "multiply by $\mathrm{d}x$" recipe produces, because $\int \mathrm{d}y/h(y)$ is just $H(y)$. The fraction-juggling is a mnemonic; the chain rule is the mechanism. The $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ are not really being separated — they are bookkeeping symbols that happen to track the substitution $u = y(x)$ correctly. This is the same reason u-substitution in integration works: separation of variables is mathematically equivalent to u-substitution.

Common trap

When we divided by $h(y)$ we assumed $h(y) \neq 0$. But any value $y = c$ with $h(c) = 0$ gives the *constant* solution $y \equiv c$ (its derivative is zero, and $g(x)\,h(c) = 0$ too). These constant "equilibrium" solutions are real solutions that the separation recipe can quietly lose, because dividing by $h(y)$ silently excludes them. Always check the roots of h separately. We will meet these again as equilibria in the section on autonomous equations.

37.2.1 A First Worked Example

Solve $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = xy$ with $y(0) = 3$.

Walking question

Is it separable? The right side is $x \cdot y$, a function of x times a function of y. Yes, with $g(x) = x$ and $h(y) = y$. So we expect to find $\int \mathrm{d}y/y$ on the left and $\int x\,\mathrm{d}x$ on the right.

Step 1. Separate. Divide by y (noting $y = 0$ as a possible lost solution):

$$\frac{1}{y}\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = x.$$

Step 2. Integrate both sides in x. The left integrates to $\ln|y|$ (chain rule in reverse), the right to $\frac{1}{2}x^2$:

$$\ln|y| = \tfrac{1}{2}x^2 + C.$$

Step 3. Solve for y. Exponentiate:

$$|y| = e^{C}\,e^{x^2/2}, \qquad \text{so} \qquad y = A\,e^{x^2/2},$$

where $A = \pm e^{C}$ is a new constant absorbing the sign and the e^{C}. (Letting $A = 0$ even recovers the lost solution $y \equiv 0$, so the single formula $y = Ae^{x^2/2}$ captures everything.)

Step 4. Apply the initial condition. $y(0) = 3$ means $3 = A\,e^{0} = A$, so $A = 3$. The particular solution is

$$\boxed{y = 3\,e^{x^2/2}}.$$

Check: $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 3\,e^{x^2/2} \cdot x = x \cdot y$. It satisfies the equation, and $y(0) = 3$. Done.

Work it yourself

Solve $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{x}{y}$ with $y(0) = 2$ before reading on. Separate as $y\,\mathrm{d}y = x\,\mathrm{d}x$, integrate to $\frac{1}{2}y^2 = \frac{1}{2}x^2 + C$, so $y^2 - x^2 = \text{const}$. The solution curves are *hyperbolas*. The initial condition $y(0) = 2$ gives $4 - 0 = 4$, so $y = \sqrt{x^2 + 4}$. Notice the answer is an implicit relation $y^2 - x^2 = 4$ that we then solved for y; many separable problems leave you with an implicit equation, and that is a perfectly good answer.

37.2.2 Why an Initial Condition Pins Down One Curve

Connection

The general solution $y = Ae^{x^2/2}$ is a one-parameter family — an entire stack of curves, one for each value of A. They fill the plane without crossing, just like the leaves' paths in the river picture. The existence and uniqueness theorem (which holds whenever $f(x, y)$ and $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ are continuous near the starting point) guarantees that through each point passes *exactly one* solution curve. That is why naming one point, the initial condition, selects one and only one member of the family. No two distinct solution curves of a well-behaved first-order ODE ever touch.

37.3 Exponential Growth and Decay

The most important separable equation in all of science is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = k\,y,$$

which says *the rate of change is proportional to the amount present.* Read it as a sentence: "the more there is, the faster it grows" (if $k > 0$), or "the more there is, the faster it shrinks" (if $k < 0$). Money in a continuously compounded account, a colony of bacteria with unlimited food, a lump of radioactive uranium, the cooling-off of a difference in temperature — all obey this.

Separating, $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{y} = k\,\mathrm{d}t$, so $\ln|y| = kt + C$, and

$$\boxed{y(t) = y_0\,e^{kt}},$$

where $y_0 = y(0)$ is the starting amount. If $k > 0$ the amount explodes; if $k < 0$ it decays toward zero. Figure 37.2 shows both.

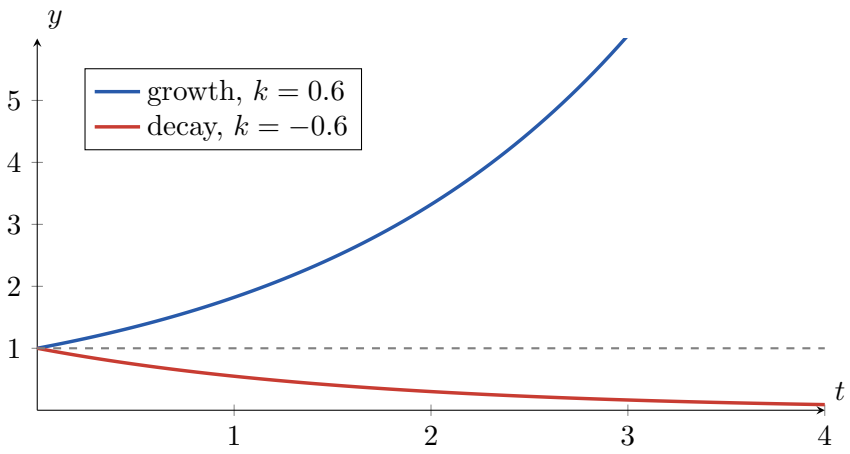


Figure 37.2: Exponential growth ($k > 0$) and decay ($k < 0$). Both start at the dashed reference and obey $y' = ky$. Growth curves upward without bound; decay falls toward the t-axis but never reaches it.

Connection

Radiocarbon dating. The radioactive decay law $N' = -\lambda N$ was pieced together by Ernest Rutherford and Frederick Soddy around 1902 from careful laboratory measurements of how thorium emanation faded over time. They discovered that a fixed *fraction* of atoms decayed per unit time, regardless of the total amount present — the unmistakable signature of the proportionality law $N' \propto N$. From this came the concept of *half-life*, the time $t_{1/2}$ required for half of any given sample to vanish. Setting $\frac{1}{2} = e^{-\lambda t_{1/2}}$ gives the celebrated relation $t_{1/2} = \dfrac{\ln 2}{\lambda}$. Half a century later, this exact differential equation, run backward in time, allowed Willard Libby to calculate the age of ancient biological remains from the residual carbon-14 left in their bones, an invention that earned the 1960 Nobel Prize in Chemistry.

Application

Carbon dating, worked. Living tissue holds a steady ratio of carbon-14; when it dies, the ^{14}C decays with half-life $t_{1/2} = 5730$ years, so $\lambda = \dfrac{\ln 2}{5730} \approx 1.21 \times 10^{-4}$ yr^{-1}. A bone is found with 62% of the living ^{14}C level. How old is it? Solve $0.62 = e^{-\lambda t}$ for t:

$$t = -\frac{\ln 0.62}{\lambda} = -\frac{\ln 0.62}{1.21 \times 10^{-4}} \approx \frac{0.478}{1.21 \times 10^{-4}} \approx 3950 \text{ years.}$$

The bone is roughly four thousand years old. The whole calculation is one separable ODE, solved once and reused forever.

37.3.1 Newton's Law of Cooling

A hot cup of coffee in a cool room cools fast at first, then slowly, leveling off at room temperature. Newton's law of cooling captures this: the rate of cooling is proportional to the temperature *difference* between the object and its surroundings. If $T(t)$ is the object's temperature and T_a the (constant)

ambient temperature,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t} = -k\,(T - T_a), \qquad k > 0.$$

The minus sign is the physics: if $T > T_a$ the object is hotter than the room, so $\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t} < 0$ and it cools; if $T < T_a$ it warms. Either way it heads toward T_a.

Why the technique works

This has the same structure as $y' = ky$ under a shift of coordinates. Let $u = T - T_a$ be the temperature *difference*. Since T_a is constant, $\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t}$, and the equation becomes

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}u}{\mathrm{d}t} = -k\,u,$$

plain exponential decay. The difference from ambient decays exponentially: $u(t) = u_0 e^{-kt}$. Translating back,

$$T(t) = T_a + (T_0 - T_a)\,e^{-kt}.$$

The substitution $u = T - T_a$ *slid the whole problem down* so that the equilibrium sat at zero, where we already know the answer, then slid it back up. A huge amount of differential-equations technique is exactly this: find the change of variable that turns your problem into one you have already solved.

Application

The coffee, worked. Coffee at $T_0 = 90°\text{C}$ sits in a $20°\text{C}$ room. After 5 minutes it has cooled to $70°\text{C}$. When will it reach a drinkable $50°\text{C}$?
First find k. With $T_a = 20$ and $T_0 = 90$, the difference starts at 70 and at $t = 5$ has fallen to $70 - 20 = 50$:

$$50 = 70\,e^{-5k} \;\Rightarrow\; e^{-5k} = \tfrac{5}{7} \;\Rightarrow\; k = \tfrac{1}{5}\ln\tfrac{7}{5} \approx 0.0673 \text{ min}^{-1}.$$

Now solve for the time when $T = 50$, i.e. the difference is 30:

$$30 = 70\,e^{-kt} \;\Rightarrow\; e^{-kt} = \tfrac{3}{7} \;\Rightarrow\; t = \frac{\ln(7/3)}{k} \approx \frac{0.847}{0.0673} \approx 12.6 \text{ min}.$$

So about 12.6 minutes after pouring. Notice the curve in Figure 37.3 flattening toward the room line — that flattening is the $e^{-kt} \to 0$ tail.

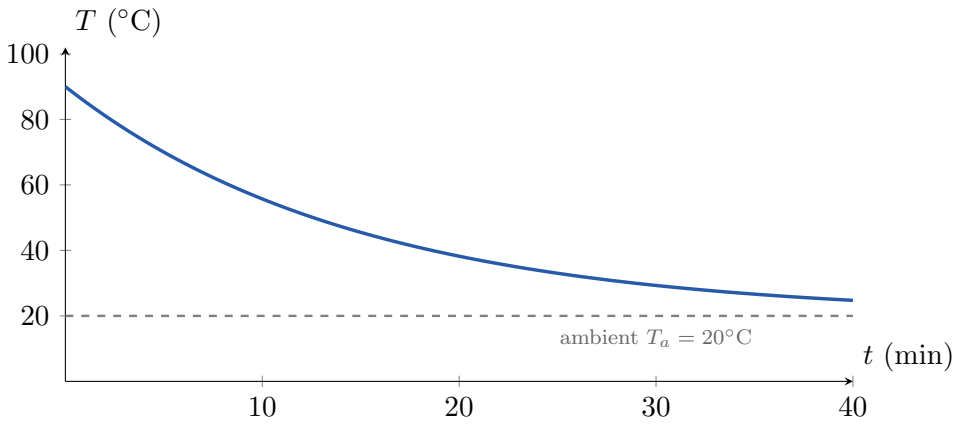


Figure 37.3: Newton cooling: the coffee's temperature decays toward the ambient line $T_a = 20°\text{C}$. Steep at first (big difference), then ever gentler. The temperature *difference* is what decays exponentially.

37.4 First-Order Linear Equations and the Integrating Factor

Not every equation separates. Consider

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + 2y = x.$$

Try to separate it: $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = x - 2y$. The right side is $x - 2y$, which does *not* factor as (function of x)(function of y). Stuck. We need a new idea.

The class of equations we can solve systematically is the **first-order linear** equations:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + P(x)\,y = Q(x).$$

"Linear" means y and y' appear only to the first power, never multiplied together, never inside a sine or a square. The coefficients P and Q may be any functions of x. This single template covers an enormous range of models.

37.4.1 The Idea: Make the Left Side a Single Derivative

The central idea is as follows. The left side $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + P(x)\,y$ is *almost* the derivative of a product. Recall the product rule:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\mu y) = \mu\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + \mu' y.$$

If only we could multiply our whole equation by some cleverly chosen function $\mu(x)$ so that the left side became exactly $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\mu y)$, then the equation would collapse to

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\mu y) = \mu\,Q,$$

and we could just *integrate both sides* and be done. The function μ that achieves this is called the **integrating factor**.

Why the technique works

Deriving the integrating factor. Multiply the equation by an unknown positive function $\mu(x)$:

$$\mu \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + \mu P\, y = \mu Q.$$

We *want* the left side to equal $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\mu y) = \mu \frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + \mu' y$. Comparing the two expressions term by term, the $\mu\, y'$ pieces already match. The remaining pieces match precisely when

$$\mu' = \mu P.$$

That is a *separable* equation for μ. Separate it: $\dfrac{\mathrm{d}\mu}{\mu} = P\,\mathrm{d}x$, integrate to $\ln \mu = \int P\,\mathrm{d}x$, and exponentiate:

$$\boxed{\mu(x) = e^{\int P(x)\,\mathrm{d}x}}.$$

That is where the famous formula comes from. The formula is directly determined by demanding that the product rule applies. The integrating factor is exactly the function whose logarithmic derivative is P, because that is what it takes to make $\mu y' + \mu P y$ collapse into one clean derivative.

What is really happening

What is really happening is a *change of viewpoint.* The combination $y' + Py$ does not look like a derivative of anything tidy. But multiply by μ and it becomes the derivative of the single quantity μy. We have re-expressed an awkward two-term expression as the rate of change of one product. Once something is written as $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\text{stuff})$, the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus lets us undo it by integration.

37.4.2 The Full Recipe, Derived

Putting it together: to solve $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + P(x)\, y = Q(x)$,

1. Compute the integrating factor $\mu = e^{\int P\,\mathrm{d}x}$.
2. Multiply the equation by μ. The left side is now $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(\mu y)$ by construction.
3. Integrate both sides: $\mu y = \int \mu Q\,\mathrm{d}x + C$.
4. Divide by μ to get $y = \dfrac{1}{\mu}\left(\int \mu Q\,\mathrm{d}x + C\right)$.

37.4.3 Worked Example with the Integrating Factor

Solve $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + 2y = x$ with $y(0) = 1$.

Walking question

Here $P(x) = 2$ (a constant) and $Q(x) = x$. The integrating factor will be $e^{\int 2\,dx} = e^{2x}$. We expect to multiply through by e^{2x} and watch the left side fold into $\frac{d}{dx}\big(e^{2x}y\big)$.

Step 1. Integrating factor. $\mu = e^{\int 2\,dx} = e^{2x}$.

Step 2. Multiply through.

$$e^{2x}\frac{dy}{dx} + 2e^{2x}y = x\,e^{2x}.$$

The left side is exactly $\frac{d}{dx}\big(e^{2x}y\big)$ — check it with the product rule: $\frac{d}{dx}\big(e^{2x}y\big) = e^{2x}y' + 2e^{2x}y$.

Step 3. Integrate both sides.

$$e^{2x}y = \int x\,e^{2x}\,dx.$$

The integral on the right needs integration by parts (let $u = x$, $dv = e^{2x}dx$):

$$\int x\,e^{2x}\,dx = \frac{x}{2}e^{2x} - \frac{1}{2}\int e^{2x}\,dx = \frac{x}{2}e^{2x} - \frac{1}{4}e^{2x} + C.$$

So

$$e^{2x}y = \frac{x}{2}e^{2x} - \frac{1}{4}e^{2x} + C.$$

Step 4. Solve for y. Divide by e^{2x}:

$$y = \frac{x}{2} - \frac{1}{4} + C\,e^{-2x}.$$

Step 5. Initial condition. $y(0) = 1$:

$$1 = 0 - \tfrac{1}{4} + C \;\Rightarrow\; C = \tfrac{5}{4}.$$

The particular solution is

$$\boxed{y = \frac{x}{2} - \frac{1}{4} + \frac{5}{4}\,e^{-2x}}.$$

Notice the structure: a part $\frac{x}{2} - \frac{1}{4}$ that tracks the forcing $Q = x$ (the "steady" response), plus a transient $\frac{5}{4}e^{-2x}$ that fades away. This split into a lingering particular response and a dying homogeneous transient recurs everywhere in applied mathematics.

Figure 37.4 makes this geometry visible.

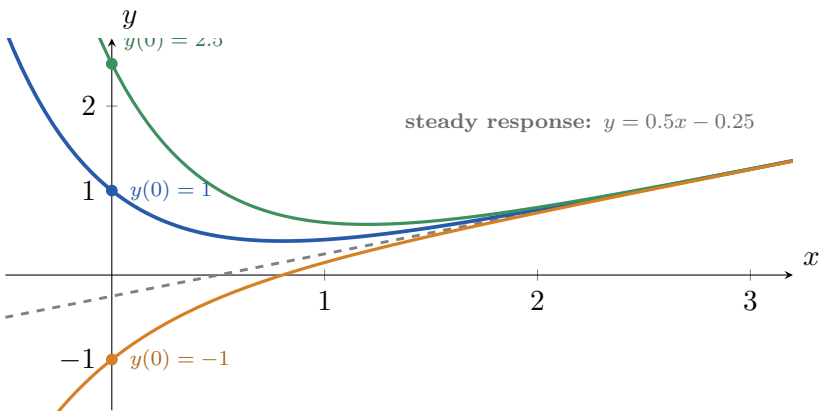


Figure 37.4: Solutions to $\frac{dy}{dx} + 2y = x$ for different initial values $y(0)$. Each solution is the sum of the steady-state line $y = \frac{x}{2} - \frac{1}{4}$ (dashed line) and a transient Ce^{-2x} that decays exponentially fast. Regardless of where a trajectory starts at $x = 0$, the transient rapidly dissolves, funneling all solutions onto the exact same steady asymptote.

Pause

Pause and think: transient versus steady response. Examine the formula $y(x) = \frac{x}{2} - \frac{1}{4} + Ce^{-2x}$. By the time $x = 3$, the transient exponential factor is $e^{-6} \approx 0.0025$. How much does the initial starting point $y(0)$ matter once $x > 3$? Virtually not at all: the system has effectively "forgotten" where it started. The forcing input $Q(x) = x$ has taken complete command of the trajectory. In electronics, heat transfer, and acoustics, the initial state is merely an opening transient; the long-term behavior is dictated by the input.

Common trap

Two common pitfalls to avoid:

1. Forgetting to put the equation in *standard form* first. The coefficient of y' must be 1 before you read off P. If you start from $x\,y' + y = x^2$, divide by x to get $y' + \frac{1}{x}y = x$, so $P = 1/x$, not something else.

2. Dragging the $+C$ from the integrating-factor integral $\int P\,dx$ into μ. You do not need it: any one antiderivative works, because an extra constant in the exponent just multiplies μ by a constant, and that constant cancels when you divide by μ at the end. Use the simplest μ. The $+C$ that *does* matter is the one from Step 3, integrating μQ.

Connection

The integrating-factor method is analogous to completing the square: you massage an expression by a deliberate multiplication (or addition) until it becomes a recognizable, invertible shape. There, you force a perfect square; here, you force a perfect derivative. Recognizing the shape of a known operation, and bending your problem until it fits, is one of the great recurring moves in all of mathematics.

History

Differential equations arose alongside calculus itself, as mathematicians sought to model physical laws relating rates of change to state variables. The earliest challenges in the 1690s grew directly out of physics and geometry. Mathematicians sought the shape of a drooping hanging chain (the *catenary*, from the Latin for chain), the fastest frictionless ramp between two points under gravity (the *brachistochrone*, from the Greek for shortest time), and cannonball trajectories through air resistance.

The pioneers had very few tools. Isaac Newton in England and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz in Germany had developed the initial rules of fluxions and differentials in the 1670s and 1680s, but there was no general theory of differential equations, no systematic integration tables, and not even a standard concept of a function as an abstract mapping. Instead, mathematicians worked with geometric sketches, ingenious coordinate substitutions, and power series. Above all, they relied on differentials $\mathrm{d}x$ and $\mathrm{d}y$, which they manipulated as literal, vanishingly small pieces of curves.

Between 1691 and 1695, the Swiss brothers Jakob and Johann Bernoulli turned the new calculus into an arena of fierce public competition. Working in Basel, the brothers challenged each other and the mathematical world through the pages of the journal *Acta Eruditorum*. When Jakob posed what is now known as the Bernoulli equation ($y' + P(x)y = Q(x)y^n$, where y is raised to a power), Leibniz and Johann solved it promptly. Leibniz discovered the integrating-factor technique in 1694, realizing that multiplying by an auxiliary exponential could force an unruly sum of terms into the derivative of a single product. Leibniz and Johann also worked out separation of variables (Johann gave the method its name), herding the variables to opposite sides of the equals sign so that each side could be integrated on its own. Leonhard Euler, a student of Johann Bernoulli, later generalized integrating factors in the 1730s and 1740s into a systematic technique.

These developments occurred alongside two major debates. First was the priority dispute between Newton and Leibniz and their respective disciples, which soured relations between British and Continental mathematicians for decades and delayed Britain's adoption of the far more flexible Leibnizian notation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x}$. Second was a question of rigor: critics, notably Bishop George Berkeley in his 1734 treatise *The Analyst*, objected to treating $\mathrm{d}y$ and $\mathrm{d}x$ as nonzero quantities when separating and dividing them, yet as vanishing increments without a clear logical definition. As we saw in Section 37.2, it took the modern understanding of the chain rule and the limit concept to validate the infinitesimal bookkeeping that the Bernoullis had intuitively mastered.

First-order methods made it possible to analyze classical celestial mechanics, ballistics, fluid flow, population biology, and the foundations of thermodynamics. Yet deep barriers quickly emerged. In 1841 the French mathematician Joseph Liouville proved that even simple-looking Riccati equations such as $y' = x^2 + y^2$ cannot be solved in terms of *elementary functions* (finite combinations of polynomials, roots, exponentials, logarithms, and trigonometric functions) and their integrals. The same holds for $y' = y^2 + x$, and for most differential equations one writes down at random.

That boundary shifted the entire field from formula-hunting toward the modern geometric and qualitative viewpoint pioneered by Henri Poincaré in the late nineteenth century. Today, open frontiers in first-order theory thrive in *dynamical systems* (the study of how systems evolve over time in geometric space). A central open challenge is the second part of *Hilbert's sixteenth problem*, posed by David Hilbert in 1900: what is the maximum number and relative

configuration of *limit cycles* (isolated closed loops in the plane representing self-sustaining, periodic rhythms) that can arise in planar polynomial differential equations $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \frac{Q(x,y)}{P(x,y)}$? Even for quadratic polynomials (P and Q of degree two), Hilbert's question remains unsolved to this day.

37.5 Autonomous Equations, Equilibria, and Stability

A first-order equation is **autonomous** when the right side does not mention the independent variable explicitly:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = f(y).$$

The slope depends only on *where* you are (y), never on *when* (t). Newton cooling, exponential growth, and the logistic equation we are about to meet are all autonomous. Autonomy buys us a lot: it lets us read off the long-term fate of solutions *without solving the equation at all*, just by looking at the sign of f.

37.5.1 Equilibria: Where Nothing Changes

An **equilibrium** (or steady state, or fixed point) is a value y^* where $f(y^*) = 0$. There, $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = 0$: the system is frozen. If you start exactly at y^* you stay there forever, giving the constant solution $y \equiv y^*$. These are the constant solutions from the separable section, now considered systematically.

An important question is *stability*: if the system is slightly displaced from an equilibrium, does it return toward the equilibrium (stable) or move away (unstable)?

Intuition

Picture a marble resting on a curved track of hills and valleys. A **stable** equilibrium is the bottom of a bowl: push the marble a little in either direction and gravity rolls it right back to the bottom. An **unstable** equilibrium is the very crest of a hill: perfectly balanced while undisturbed, but the slightest nudge sends it rolling away, never to return. A **phase line** is the one-dimensional version of this picture, and the sign of $f(y)$ tells you which way the marble rolls.

37.5.2 The Phase Line

Because the equation is autonomous, we can draw everything on a single vertical y-axis, the *phase line*. Mark the equilibria (roots of f). Between them, f has a constant sign. Where $f(y) > 0$, the solution increases (draw an upward arrow); where $f(y) < 0$, it decreases (downward arrow). An equilibrium with arrows pointing *toward* it from both sides is stable; arrows pointing *away* is unstable.

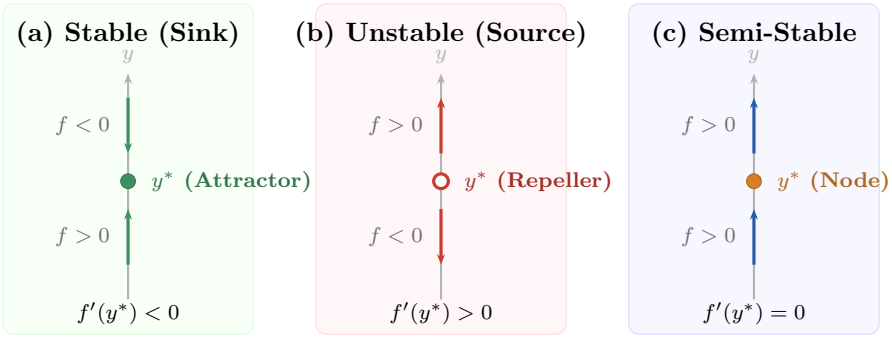


Figure 37.5: The three stability archetypes on a phase line for $\frac{dy}{dt} = f(y)$. (a) Stable Attractor (Sink): slopes point inward from both sides; small perturbations decay back to y^*. (b) Unstable Repeller (Source): slopes point outward; any perturbation drives the solution away. (c) Semi-Stable Node: slopes point in the same direction on both sides; perturbations from one side return, while perturbations to the other side run away.

Focus

The derivative test for stability. Near an equilibrium y^*, linearize: $f(y) \approx f'(y^*)(y - y^*)$ since $f(y^*) = 0$. So a small displacement $u = y - y^*$ obeys $\frac{du}{dt} \approx f'(y^*)\, u$, plain exponential behavior. Therefore:

$$f'(y^*) < 0 \implies \text{stable (perturbations decay)},$$
$$f'(y^*) > 0 \implies \text{unstable (perturbations grow)}.$$

The sign of the derivative of f at the equilibrium determines its stability. This is the one-dimensional case of linear stability analysis.

Pause

Pause and think: stability from the slope of f. Suppose an autonomous rate law has an equilibrium at $y^* = 4$. If you sketch the graph of $f(y)$ against y, and the curve crosses the horizontal axis from positive to negative as y increases past 4, is $y^* = 4$ stable or unstable? Below 4, $f(y) > 0$, so y increases toward 4. Above 4, $f(y) < 0$, so y decreases toward 4. The flow squeezes toward 4 from both sides: it is a stable sink. Notice that crossing from positive to negative means the slope of the curve is downward: $f'(4) < 0$. The derivative test is simply the geometry of crossing downward.

37.6 Logistic Growth

Exponential growth $y' = ky$ holds only while resources are unlimited. No real population grows forever; resource limits and competition eventually constrain growth. The simplest fix, proposed by the Belgian mathematician Pierre François Verhulst in 1838, is to let the per-capita growth rate *decline* as the population approaches a ceiling M, the **carrying capacity**:

$$\frac{dP}{dt} = r\,P\left(1 - \frac{P}{M}\right).$$

Intuition

Read the two factors. When P is tiny, $1-P/M \approx 1$, and growth is nearly exponential, $P' \approx rP$ — plenty of room, breed freely. As P climbs toward M, the factor $1 - P/M$ shrinks toward 0, throttling the growth. At $P = M$ growth stops entirely. The population is self-limiting: its own size applies the brakes.

37.6.1 The Phase Line of the Logistic

This is autonomous with $f(P) = rP(1 - P/M)$, a downward parabola in P crossing zero at $P = 0$ and $P = M$. Between them $f > 0$ (growth); below 0 and above M, $f < 0$. So:

- $P^* = 0$ is **unstable**: $f'(0) = r > 0$. A tiny population grows away from extinction.

- $P^* = M$ is **stable**: $f'(M) = -r < 0$. Populations above or below M are drawn back to it.

Every positive starting population, no matter how small or how large, ends up at the carrying capacity M. Figure 37.6 draws this verdict as a phase line, and Figure 37.7 shows the family of solution curves all funneling toward $P = M$.

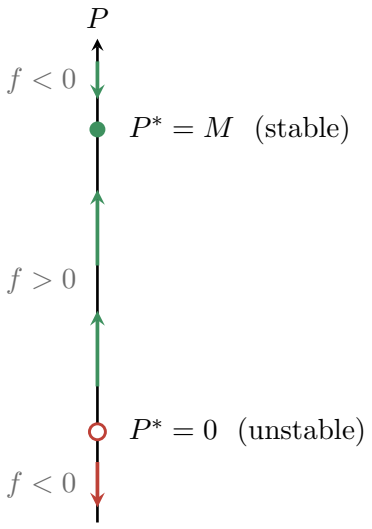


Figure 37.6: The phase line of the logistic equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = rP(1 - P/M)$. Arrows show the direction of motion: away from the open circle at $P = 0$ (unstable) and toward the filled circle at $P = M$ (stable). Reading a one-dimensional picture like this tells us the long-term fate of every solution without solving anything.

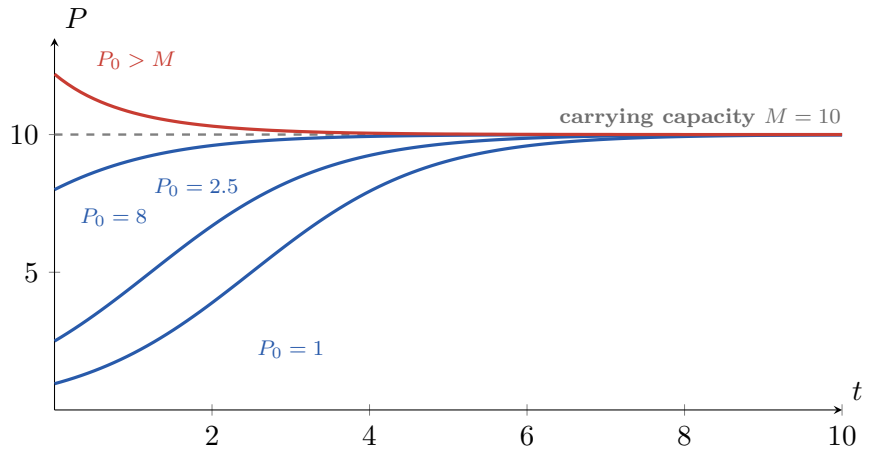


Figure 37.7: Logistic solutions for several initial populations. Small starts show the S-shaped (sigmoid) rise: nearly exponential, then bending over at the inflection near $P = M/2$, then leveling at the carrying capacity $M = 10$. A start *above* M (red) decays toward M. All solutions with $P_0 > 0$ approach M.

37.6.2 Solving the Logistic Equation

The logistic equation is separable, though evaluating the integral calls on partial fractions. Separate variables:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{P\,(1 - P/M)} = r\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

Split the fraction on the left into two simpler pieces by partial fractions, $\dfrac{1}{P(1-P/M)} = \dfrac{1}{P} + \dfrac{1/M}{1-P/M}$ (you can verify this by recombining over a common denominator). Now integrate both sides:

$$\int \left(\frac{1}{P} + \frac{1/M}{1 - P/M} \right) \mathrm{d}P = \int r\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

For a population, $P > 0$, so the first term integrates to $\ln P$. For the second term, substituting $u = 1 - P/M$ gives $\mathrm{d}u = -\frac{1}{M}\mathrm{d}P$, introducing a minus sign. We keep an absolute value, because u is negative when the population starts above capacity ($P > M$):

$$\int \frac{1/M}{1 - P/M}\,\mathrm{d}P = -\int \frac{\mathrm{d}u}{u} = -\ln|1 - \frac{P}{M}|.$$

Combining the logarithms gives

$$\ln P - \ln|1 - \frac{P}{M}| = \ln|\frac{P}{1 - P/M}| = rt + C.$$

Exponentiate both sides, and absorb the sign hidden in the absolute value into the constant:

$$\frac{P}{1 - P/M} = C_0\, e^{rt}, \qquad \text{where} \quad C_0 = \pm e^{C}.$$

To isolate $P(t)$, take the reciprocal of both sides:

$$\frac{1 - P/M}{P} = \frac{1}{P} - \frac{1}{M} = \frac{1}{C_0}\, e^{-rt}.$$

Add $\frac{1}{M}$ and place the right-hand side over a common denominator M:

$$\frac{1}{P} = \frac{1}{M} + \frac{1}{C_0}\,e^{-rt} = \frac{1 + (M/C_0)\,e^{-rt}}{M}.$$

Inverting gives the celebrated **logistic function**:

$$\boxed{P(t) = \frac{M}{1 + A\,e^{-rt}}}, \qquad A = \frac{M}{C_0} = \frac{M - P_0}{P_0},$$

where $P_0 = P(0)$ is the initial population at $t = 0$.

As $t \to \infty$, $e^{-rt} \to 0$ and $P \to M$, confirming the phase-line verdict. (A start above capacity gives $A < 0$, and the same formula describes the red curve in Figure 37.7.) A solution that starts below $M/2$ has a single inflection point, where it switches from concave-up to concave-down, located exactly at $P = M/2$, the moment of fastest growth.

Walking question

Why is the fastest growth at $P = M/2$? The growth *rate* is $f(P) = rP(1 - P/M)$, a downward parabola in P. Its maximum is at the vertex, halfway between its roots 0 and M, namely $P = M/2$. So the population adds members fastest when it is at half capacity, $P = M/2$.

Application

A yeast culture, worked. A flask of yeast follows the logistic law with carrying capacity $M = 1000$ cells and intrinsic rate $r = 0.7$ hr^{-1}, starting from $P_0 = 50$ cells. Then $A = (1000 - 50)/50 = 19$, so

$$P(t) = \frac{1000}{1 + 19\,e^{-0.7t}}.$$

How long until the culture is half full ($P = 500$)? Half-full happens when the denominator is 2, i.e. $19e^{-0.7t} = 1$:

$$t = \frac{\ln 19}{0.7} \approx \frac{2.944}{0.7} \approx 4.2 \text{ hours}.$$

That is also the moment of fastest growth. Verhulst's 1845 fit of this curve to Belgian census data was one of the first genuinely predictive uses of a differential-equation model in the social sciences.

Why this matters

Verhulst and population modeling. Verhulst introduced the logistic curve in 1838 and named it *logistique* in 1845, but his work was largely forgotten for eighty years. It was rediscovered independently in the 1920s by Raymond Pearl and Lowell Reed, who fit it to the United States population and projected a ceiling of approximately 197 million. Later census counts exceeded that estimate, illustrating that the logistic model is an idealization that clarifies self-limiting dynamics rather than providing exact demographic forecasts.

37.7 Existence, Uniqueness, and the Limits of Formulas

We have leaned on the comforting belief that an initial condition picks out exactly one solution. When is that guaranteed?

Formal

Existence and Uniqueness (Picard–Lindelöf, stated plainly). Consider the initial value problem $\frac{dy}{dx} = f(x, y)$, $y(x_0) = y_0$. If f and its partial derivative $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ are continuous on some rectangle containing (x_0, y_0), then on some interval around x_0 there exists *one and only one* solution passing through (x_0, y_0).

Here the partial derivative $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ simply measures how rapidly the prescribed slope changes as you move straight up or down across the plane. This theorem is the result that justifies the slope-field picture: continuous, non-crossing solution curves filling the plane, exactly one through each point. When the hypotheses fail, strange things can happen — solutions can branch or blow up in finite time.

Common trap

The equation $\frac{dy}{dx} = \sqrt{|y|}$ with $y(0) = 0$ has *two* solutions through the origin: the constant $y \equiv 0$, and the curve $y = \frac{1}{4}x^2$ (for $x \geq 0$). Uniqueness fails because $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y} = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{y}}$ blows up at $y = 0$ — the smoothness hypothesis is violated exactly there. Two distinct solution trajectories diverge from the origin. If a physical particle obeyed this rate law starting from rest at the origin, it could sit motionless for an arbitrary length of time and then start moving, with nothing in the law to say when. Uniqueness is the mathematical condition that keeps a physical model deterministic.

Why this matters

Most first-order ODEs that arise in practice cannot be solved with a clean formula at all — $\frac{dy}{dx} = x^2 + y^2$ has no elementary solution. Yet the slope field still exists, the phase line still tells us about equilibria, and numerical methods (Euler and its descendants) can trace any particular solution to whatever accuracy we like. Qualitative geometry and numerical stepping tell you how solutions behave even when no closed-form formula exists.

37.8 Looking Ahead: The Leap to Second Order

Every differential equation in this chapter had one feature in common: it tied the rate of change $\frac{dy}{dt}$ directly to the state y and the time t. A single integration, accompanied by one initial condition $y(t_0) = y_0$, was always enough to pin down a unique trajectory. The geometry lived entirely on a one-dimensional line or in a planar slope field where curves could never cross or oscillate.

Yet the foundational laws of the physical world are rarely first-order. When Isaac Newton formulated his second law of motion, $F = ma$, he did not declare that force dictates velocity. He discovered that force dictates *acceleration* — the second derivative $\frac{d^2y}{dt^2}$.

The moment acceleration enters, the entire nature of the mathematics transforms. A moving particle

does not merely occupy a location; it possesses momentum and inertia that resist abrupt redirection. Because the governing equation involves y'', finding the position function requires *two* successive integrations, spawning two arbitrary constants instead of one. Consequently, pinning down a single physical trajectory demands two initial measurements: not just where the object starts ($y(0)$), but also how fast it is launched ($y'(0)$).

In addition, second derivatives introduce a physical behavior that no single first-order autonomous equation can ever exhibit: *oscillation*. A first-order system on a line is monotonic: it can only drift toward an equilibrium or flee from it; it can never overshoot, double back, and ring back and forth like a mass on a spring, a pendulum, or a plucked violin string.

In Chapter 38, we turn to **second-order linear differential equations**. We will see how inertia and restoring forces give rise to the mathematics of mechanical vibrations, electrical circuits, and resonance — the phenomenon where periodic driving at a natural frequency produces large-amplitude responses.

37.9 Exercises

Exercise 37.1. Mental check: equilibrium and cooling without formulas. Inspect Newton's cooling equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t} = -2(T - 25)$ without integrating or solving.

(a) What is the equilibrium temperature T^*?

(b) If hot tea starts at $T(0) = 85°\mathrm{C}$, what is the initial sign of $\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t}$? Does the tea warm or cool?

(c) If chilled lemonade starts at $T(0) = 5°\mathrm{C}$, what is the initial sign of $\frac{\mathrm{d}T}{\mathrm{d}t}$? Does it warm or cool?

(d) What value does $T(t)$ approach as $t \to \infty$, regardless of $T(0)$?

Exercise 37.2. Mental check: classifying by eye. For each differential equation, state whether it is separable, first-order linear, autonomous, or none of these (an equation may fit multiple categories):

(a) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = x^2 y$

(b) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + xy = x^3$

(c) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y(3 - y)$

(d) $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = x + y$

Exercise 37.3. Solve the separable equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = 3x^2 y$ with $y(0) = 5$. Identify the lost constant solution and check whether your general formula recovers it.

Exercise 37.4. Solve $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = \dfrac{1 + y^2}{1 + x^2}$. (Hint: both sides integrate to arctangents.) Express the answer as an implicit relation, then solve for y when $y(0) = 1$.

Exercise 37.5. A sample of a radioactive isotope decays to 80% of its initial mass in 3 days. Find its half-life, and determine how long until only 10% remains.

Exercise 37.6. A turkey at 5°C is placed in a 175°C oven. After 30 minutes its internal temperature is 40°C. Using Newton's law of heating, find the constant k and predict when the turkey reaches 75°C.

Exercise 37.7. Solve the linear equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} + \dfrac{1}{x}\,y = \cos x$ for $x > 0$ by the integrating-factor method. (Hint: $\mu = x$, and $\int x\cos x\,\mathrm{d}x$ needs parts.)

Exercise 37.8. Solve $x\,\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} - 2y = x^3 e^x$. First put it in standard form, then find the integrating factor. Show that $\mu = x^{-2}$ and finish the problem.

Exercise 37.9. For the autonomous equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = y^3 - y$, find all equilibria, draw the phase line, and classify each equilibrium as stable or unstable using the sign of f' at each.

Exercise 37.10. For the autonomous equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}t} = (y-1)(y-3)^2$, find the equilibria and classify them. One of them is *semi-stable* (attracting on one side, repelling on the other) because f touches zero without changing sign there. Identify which, and explain using the phase-line arrows.

Exercise 37.11. A lake with carrying capacity $M = 20{,}000$ fish currently holds 4,000 fish and grows logistically with $r = 0.4\ \mathrm{yr}^{-1}$. Write $P(t)$ explicitly, find when the population reaches 10,000, and find when it is growing fastest.

Exercise 37.12. Mixing problem. A tank holds 100 liters of pure water. Brine containing 0.5 kg of salt per liter flows in at 4 L/min, and the well-stirred mixture flows out at the same rate. Let $S(t)$ be the kilograms of salt in the tank. Argue that $\frac{\mathrm{d}S}{\mathrm{d}t} = 2 - \dfrac{4}{100}S$, solve this first-order linear equation with $S(0) = 0$, and find the long-run amount of salt. (Hint: the equilibrium is where $S' = 0$.)

Exercise 37.13. Show by direct substitution that the logistic function $P(t) = \dfrac{M}{1 + Ae^{-rt}}$ satisfies $\frac{\mathrm{d}P}{\mathrm{d}t} = rP(1 - P/M)$. (This verifies the solution without re-deriving it, a good habit: solving is hard, checking is easy.)

Exercise 37.14. The equation $\frac{\mathrm{d}y}{\mathrm{d}x} = x^2 + y^2$ has no elementary closed-form solution. Without solving it, sketch its slope field for $-2 \le x, y \le 2$ by computing the slope at a handful of points, and describe qualitatively how a solution starting at $(0, 0)$ behaves as x increases. (This is the spirit of the final box: geometry without formulas.)

Chapter 38

Second-Order Linear Differential Equations

In Chapter 37, we explored first-order differential equations: laws that tie the rate of change of a quantity directly to the quantity itself, like cooling coffee, radioactive decay, or a draining tank. A first-order equation takes your current state and sets your velocity at that instant. But the physical world is governed by a deeper kind of law. Newton did not write "velocity is proportional to force." He wrote "*acceleration* is proportional to force." Acceleration is the second derivative. The moment you write down $F = ma$ for almost any real mechanical or electrical system – a mass on a spring, a pendulum, a swinging bridge, a tuned radio circuit, a vibrating molecule – you get a *second-order* differential equation.

This chapter is about the most important and most tractable family of them: the *linear* ones with constant coefficients,

$$a\,y'' + b\,y' + c\,y \;=\; f(t).$$

The entire theory hangs on one observation – differentiating $y = e^{rt}$ just multiplies it by r – and this single guess, pushed all the way through, unfolds into oscillation, damping, resonance, and the whole vocabulary of vibration. Throughout, our running example is a mass on a spring (the *harmonic oscillator*), the prototype of every vibrating linear system.

38.1 What a Second-Order Linear Equation Is

A second-order ordinary differential equation (ODE) is an equation involving an unknown function $y(t)$, its first derivative y', and its second derivative y''. In physical terms, it ties together an object's position, velocity, and acceleration at each instant of time. It is *linear* if y, y', and y'' each appear to the first power only, never multiplied together, never inside a sine or a square root. The general second-order linear ODE with constant coefficients is

$$a\,y'' + b\,y' + c\,y = f(t), \qquad a \neq 0, \tag{38.1}$$

where a, b, c are fixed numbers and $f(t)$ is a given function, the *forcing term* or *input* – an external push or driving signal applied from the outside world. When $f(t) = 0$ the equation is called *homogeneous* (the system is left alone to move under its own internal forces); otherwise it is *inhomogeneous* (or *forced*, driven by outside intervention).

Focus

The plan of the chapter is direct: first solve the homogeneous equation $ay'' + by' + cy = 0$ completely (that is the "free" motion of the system, what it does when nobody pushes it), then handle the forcing $f(t)$ by adding one particular solution on top. The structure

$$y_{\text{general}} = \underbrace{y_h}_{\text{free motion}} + \underbrace{y_p}_{\text{response to forcing}}$$

is the spine of everything that follows.

Why second order means two constants

A first-order equation comes with one arbitrary constant in its general solution; you pin it down with one initial condition, usually $y(t_0)$. A second-order equation comes with *two* arbitrary constants, and you need *two* initial conditions to determine a specific solution. The natural pair is

$$y(t_0) = y_0 \quad \text{(initial position)}, \qquad y'(t_0) = v_0 \quad \text{(initial velocity)}.$$

Intuition

This matches physical reality exactly. To predict where a thrown ball will be, knowing the law of gravity is not enough – you must know where you released it *and* how fast and in what direction. Position and velocity together form the complete "state" of a Newtonian system. Two numbers in, a unique future out. The two arbitrary constants of the general solution are precisely the slots where that initial state gets plugged in.

Walking question

Before doing any algebra, pause and test the physical idea: why could a single initial condition, such as knowing the pendulum passes through the bottom $y(0) = 0$, never be enough to predict where it will be three seconds later? Picture two grandfather clocks. In both clocks, the pendulum swings through the bottom dead center ($y = 0$) at $t = 0$. But one pendulum was pulled far back and is flying through the center at maximum speed, while the other was barely nudged and is creeping past. Their positions match, but their velocities are completely different – and three seconds later, one is swinging through a wide arc while the other barely strays from the center. Without velocity, the future remains undetermined.

History

The leap from first to second order is the leap from Aristotle to Newton, but the mathematical conquest of these equations belongs to Leonhard Euler. Aristotle's physics was, in modern notation, *first order*: he believed a force produces a velocity ($b\,y' = f$), so remove the force and motion ceases. Isaac Newton's revolution in the *Principia* (1687) insisted that force produces *acceleration* ($m\,y'' = f$), giving birth to the second derivative as the mathematical fingerprint of inertia – the tendency of moving matter to keep moving on its own.

Yet for fifty years after Newton, mathematicians were stuck. They had the calculus of Newton and Leibniz, but every vibrating system – a swinging pendulum, an oscillating spring, a mu-

sical string – was tackled through individual geometric diagrams and ad-hoc approximations. Nobody possessed a universal method to solve even the basic constant-coefficient equation $ay'' + by' + cy = 0$.

In 1739, in an exchange of letters with Johann Bernoulli, Euler found the key. He proposed an *ansatz* – an educated guess for the algebraic shape of a solution – testing the exponential $y = e^{rt}$. Because differentiating an exponential merely scales it by r, the differential equation collapsed into the elementary quadratic $ar^2 + br + c = 0$.

This stroke sparked controversy. When the discriminant $b^2 - 4ac$ was negative, the roots $r = \alpha \pm i\beta$ involved $\sqrt{-1}$. Contemporaries distrusted imaginary numbers as physical nonsense: how could an imaginary exponent predict the real, tangible oscillation of a spring? Euler settled the dispute by unveiling his formula $e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta$, showing that complex exponentials trace rotations in the complex plane and combine into ordinary real sines and cosines. Euler also resolved the puzzle of repeated roots ($b^2 - 4ac = 0$), showing that the missing second independent solution is te^{rt}. A fierce debate followed between Euler, d'Alembert, and Daniel Bernoulli over whether superpositions – sums of pure sine and cosine waves – could describe an arbitrary plucked string with sharp corners, a question that Joseph Fourier took up decisively in the early 1800s.

Euler's exponential ansatz became basic to acoustics, structural vibration in ships and bridges, and later the entire theory of alternating-current (AC) circuits and quantum wave mechanics. Yet the frontier did not close: equations with time-dependent coefficients (like Bessel and Airy equations) rarely yield elementary closed-form solutions, and nonlinear second-order equations (such as the large-angle pendulum $y'' + \frac{g}{L}\sin y = 0$ and the gravitational three-body problem) lead directly into deterministic chaos – where exact formulas fail and the long-term stability of orbits remains an active mathematical quest.

38.2 The Harmonic Oscillator: Our Running Example

Picture a block of mass m on a frictionless table, attached to a wall by a spring (Figure 38.1). Let $y(t)$ be the displacement of the block from its rest position, positive to the right. Hooke's law says the spring pulls back with a force proportional to how far you have stretched it, and always toward rest: $F_{\text{spring}} = -k\,y$, where $k > 0$ is the spring constant. Newton's second law $F = ma$ then reads

$$m\,y'' = -k\,y, \qquad \text{i.e.} \qquad m\,y'' + k\,y = 0.$$

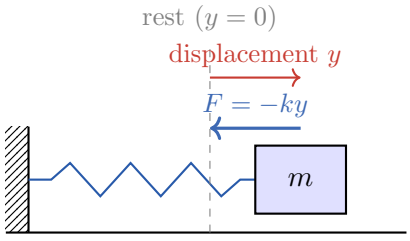


Figure 38.1: A mass on a spring. When pulled to the right ($y > 0$), Hooke's law generates a restoring force $F = -ky$ pulling back to the left toward rest. The combination of this restoring pull and the mass's inertia creates the oscillation.

Divide by m and write $\omega_0^2 = k/m$. The equation becomes the cleanest second-order ODE in all of science:

$$y'' + \omega_0^2\, y = 0. \tag{38.2}$$

The constant $\omega_0 = \sqrt{k/m}$ is the *natural frequency* – the rate in radians per second at which the spring wants to bounce when left entirely to itself. Before we solve it formally, read the equation as a sentence: *the second derivative of y is $-\omega_0^2$ times y itself.* What function is proportional to its own second derivative, with a *minus* sign? Sine and cosine. Differentiate $\cos(\omega_0 t)$ twice and you get $-\omega_0^2 \cos(\omega_0 t)$. The form of the equation suggests its trigonometric solutions directly.

Intuition

Why *must* a spring oscillate, intuitively? When the block is displaced right, the spring pulls it left. It accelerates left, races back through the rest point with maximum speed, overshoots because of inertia, stretches the spring on the left, gets pulled back right, and so on forever. The continuous interchange between restoring force and inertia produces sinusoidal motion.

If we add friction proportional to velocity (a dashpot, air resistance, the block dragging on the table), the force law gains a damping resistance $-b\,y'$, where $b > 0$ is the *damping coefficient* measuring the strength of the drag, and we get the *damped* harmonic oscillator

$$m\,y'' + b\,y' + k\,y = 0. \tag{38.3}$$

If we also push the block with an external force $F(t)$ – shaking the wall, say – we get the *forced* oscillator $my'' + by' + ky = F(t)$. These three equations, free, damped, and forced, will carry us through the entire chapter. They are special cases of the general form (38.1), and everything we prove about that form is best pictured as something happening to this block.

38.3 Superposition: Why Linearity Is Everything

The property of linearity is the key feature that makes these equations solvable, and it deserves to be stated as a theorem.

Theorem 38.1 (Superposition for the homogeneous equation)**.** *Suppose $y_1(t)$ and $y_2(t)$ are both solutions of the homogeneous equation $ay'' + by' + cy = 0$. Then for any constants C_1, C_2, the combination $y = C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2$ is also a solution.*

Proof. Write $L[y] := ay'' + by' + cy$ for the operation the equation performs on a function. Differentiation is linear: the derivative of a sum is the sum of the derivatives, and constants pull out. So

$$L[C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2] = a(C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2)'' + b(C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2)' + c(C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2).$$

Distribute the derivatives and regroup by y_1 and y_2:

$$= C_1 \underbrace{(ay_1'' + by_1' + cy_1)}_{L[y_1]=0} + C_2 \underbrace{(ay_2'' + by_2' + cy_2)}_{L[y_2]=0} = C_1 \cdot 0 + C_2 \cdot 0 = 0. \qquad \square$$

What is really happening

The operator $L[y] = ay'' + by' + cy$ is a *linear machine* – a rule that accepts an entire function as input and outputs a new function assembled from its derivatives. Feed it a scaled sum, and out comes the scaled sum of the outputs: $L[C_1y_1 + C_2y_2] = C_1L[y_1] + C_2L[y_2]$. This is the same abstract property that makes matrices, integrals, and the derivative itself behave so well. The set of all solutions of $L[y] = 0$ is therefore a *vector space* – a collection of functions where adding any two solutions or scaling by a number produces another valid solution. For a second-order equation this space is two-dimensional, which is the deep reason there are exactly two arbitrary constants. Finding the general solution means finding a *basis*: two independent solutions y_1, y_2 that act as coordinate axes, spanning every possible free motion.

Why the technique works

Superposition is why our strategy works at all. Finding two linearly independent solutions of the homogeneous equation is sufficient; linearity guarantees that every solution is of the form $C_1y_1 + C_2y_2$. We make "genuinely different" precise (linear independence, tested by the Wronskian) right after we have found some candidate solutions.

38.4 Solving the Homogeneous Equation: Why e^{rt}?

We now want two solutions of

$$ay'' + by' + cy = 0. \tag{38.4}$$

Where do we even start? The central idea of the chapter is worth a slow read.

What is really happening

Look at what equation (38.4) asks for: a function whose second derivative, first derivative, and self can be *added up with constant weights to cancel to zero*. For that cancellation to happen at every instant t, the three functions y'', y', y had better all be the *same shape* as each other – otherwise their sum could not vanish identically. We need a function that reproduces itself under differentiation, up to a constant multiple. There is essentially only one such function in all of mathematics:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\, e^{rt} = r\, e^{rt}.$$

The exponential is the unique shape that differentiation cannot change, only rescale. This is why e^{rt} is directly suggested by the structure of the equation. Every other method in this chapter is downstream of this one observation.

So we *try* $y = e^{rt}$, with r an unknown constant, and let the equation tell us which r works. Differentiating, $y' = re^{rt}$ and $y'' = r^2e^{rt}$. Substitute into (38.4):

$$ar^2e^{rt} + bre^{rt} + ce^{rt} = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad e^{rt}\,(ar^2 + br + c) = 0.$$

Now e^{rt} is never zero, so we may divide it away. What survives is purely algebraic – the differential equation has collapsed into a quadratic:

$$\boxed{ar^2 + br + c = 0.} \tag{38.5}$$

This is the *characteristic equation* (or *auxiliary equation*) of the ODE. We have traded a calculus problem for a high-school algebra problem. Its roots r are exactly the exponents that make e^{rt} solve the differential equation.

Why the technique works

Why is collapsing a differential equation into a polynomial legitimate – and so powerful? Because differentiating e^{rt} multiplies by r, the operator $a\frac{\mathrm{d}^2}{\mathrm{d}t^2} + b\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} + c$ acts on e^{rt} exactly the way the polynomial ar^2+br+c acts on the number r. Differentiation "becomes" multiplication by r. The hard analytic object (an operator on functions) and the easy algebraic object (a quadratic in r) are two faces of the same thing. This correspondence – calculus turning into algebra on exponentials – is the seed of the Laplace transform and of huge parts of engineering mathematics.

The quadratic (38.5) has roots given by the familiar formula

$$r = \frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a}.$$

Everything now hinges on the *discriminant* $\Delta = b^2 - 4ac$ – the quantity inside the square root that decides whether the roots are two real numbers, a single repeated real number, or a pair of complex numbers. Each case yields a distinct physical behavior, and we examine them in turn.

Walking question

Pause and test the intuition: if you face the equation $y'' - 9y = 0$, what two exponential shapes does differentiation preserve? Before writing down formulas, think: what number squared gives $+9$? It must be $r = 3$ and $r = -3$. So the solutions are e^{3t} and e^{-3t}. Notice the stark contrast: with $y'' = +9y$, the curve accelerates away from zero instead of oscillating back toward it. A mere plus sign in the equation turned an oscillator into an exponential runaway.

38.5 Case 1: Two Distinct Real Roots ($\Delta > 0$)

When $b^2 - 4ac > 0$, the characteristic equation has two different real roots $r_1 \neq r_2$. Then $e^{r_1 t}$ and $e^{r_2 t}$ are both solutions, and – as we will confirm in §38.8 – they are independent. Superposition hands us the general solution

$$y(t) = C_1 e^{r_1 t} + C_2 e^{r_2 t}. \tag{38.6}$$

Physically, this case is *overdamping*: so much friction that the system oozes back to rest without ever oscillating. Both roots are typically negative (for a stable system), so both exponentials decay, just at different rates.

Example 38.1 (Overdamped motion)**.** Solve $y'' + 5y' + 6y = 0$ with $y(0) = 1$, $y'(0) = 0$.

Step 1. Characteristic equation. Replace $y'' \to r^2$, $y' \to r$, $y \to 1$:

$$r^2 + 5r + 6 = 0 \implies (r+2)(r+3) = 0 \implies r = -2,\ -3.$$

Step 2. General solution. Two distinct real roots, so

$$y(t) = C_1 e^{-2t} + C_2 e^{-3t}.$$

Step 3. Apply initial conditions. First, $y(0) = C_1 + C_2 = 1$. Differentiate: $y'(t) = -2C_1 e^{-2t} - 3C_2 e^{-3t}$, so $y'(0) = -2C_1 - 3C_2 = 0$. Solve the pair:

$$C_1 + C_2 = 1, \qquad -2C_1 - 3C_2 = 0.$$

From the first, $C_1 = 1 - C_2$; substitute: $-2(1 - C_2) - 3C_2 = 0 \Rightarrow -2 - C_2 = 0 \Rightarrow C_2 = -2$, hence $C_1 = 3$.

Step 4. Answer.

$$y(t) = 3e^{-2t} - 2e^{-3t}.$$

At $t = 0$ this is $3 - 2 = 1$ with zero slope, as required. As $t \to \infty$ both terms vanish: the block creeps back to rest and never crosses zero. That is the signature of overdamping.

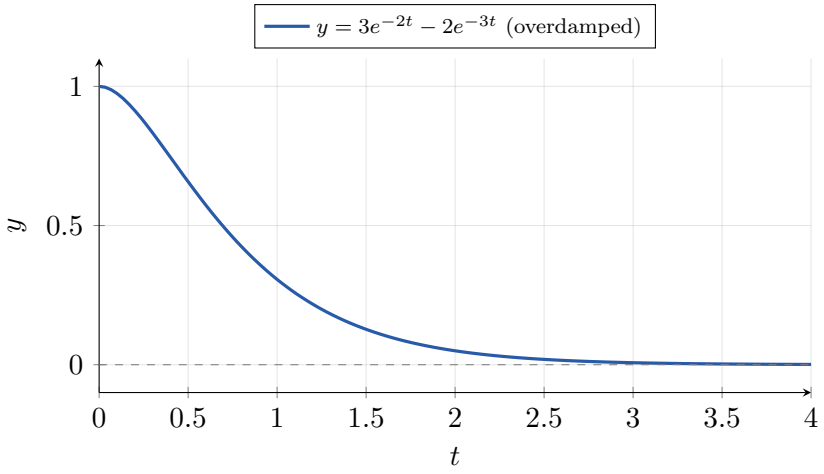


Figure 38.2: The overdamped solution of Example 38.1. It returns monotonically to rest – too much friction to overshoot, so no oscillation.

38.6 Case 3: Complex Roots ($\Delta < 0$) – Oscillation

We jump to the complex case next, out of numerical order, because it is the heart of the chapter: it is where oscillation lives. When $b^2 - 4ac < 0$, the square root of a negative number forces the roots to be a *complex-conjugate pair*

$$r = \alpha \pm i\beta, \qquad \alpha = \frac{-b}{2a}, \qquad \beta = \frac{\sqrt{4ac - b^2}}{2a} > 0.$$

Formally, superposition still applies and the general solution is $y = C_1 e^{(\alpha + i\beta)t} + C_2 e^{(\alpha - i\beta)t}$. But $y(t)$ describes the position of a real block; we want a *real* answer, with no i in sight. Euler's formula is what gets us there.

What is really happening

Recall Euler's formula, $e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta$: as θ increases, $e^{i\theta}$ traces the unit circle in the complex plane, projecting onto real cosines and sines. For a complex root $r = \alpha + i\beta$, the real part α sets the growing or decaying amplitude envelope $e^{\alpha t}$, while the imaginary part β sets the oscillation frequency.

To extract the real solutions, factor out the common envelope:

$$e^{(\alpha\pm i\beta)t} = e^{\alpha t}\, e^{\pm i\beta t} = e^{\alpha t}\big(\cos\beta t \pm i\sin\beta t\big).$$

Two particular real combinations come straight out by adding and subtracting. Their average is the real part and (dividing by $2i$) their difference is the imaginary part:

$$\tfrac{1}{2}\big(e^{(\alpha+i\beta)t} + e^{(\alpha-i\beta)t}\big) = e^{\alpha t}\cos\beta t, \qquad \tfrac{1}{2i}\big(e^{(\alpha+i\beta)t} - e^{(\alpha-i\beta)t}\big) = e^{\alpha t}\sin\beta t.$$

By superposition (Theorem 38.1), each of these is itself a real solution. They are independent, so the real general solution is

$$\boxed{y(t) = e^{\alpha t}\big(C_1\cos\beta t + C_2\sin\beta t\big).} \tag{38.7}$$

Why the technique works

Why are we allowed to take real and imaginary parts and call them solutions? Because the coefficients a, b, c are real, the operator L maps real functions to real functions and complex to complex *without mixing*: if $L[u + iv] = 0$ with u, v real, then $L[u] + i\,L[v] = 0$, and a complex number is zero only when both its real and imaginary parts vanish. So $L[u] = 0$ and $L[v] = 0$ separately. The real and imaginary parts of a complex solution are each, on their own, real solutions.

The undamped oscillator, finally solved

Return to the pure spring (38.2), $y'' + \omega_0^2 y = 0$. The characteristic equation is $r^2 + \omega_0^2 = 0$, giving $r = \pm i\omega_0$: pure imaginary, $\alpha = 0$ and $\beta = \omega_0$. By (38.7),

$$y(t) = C_1\cos\omega_0 t + C_2\sin\omega_0 t.$$

There is no envelope ($e^0 = 1$), so the block oscillates forever with constant amplitude – exactly the perpetual duel between spring and inertia we pictured earlier. The motion is often rewritten in *amplitude-phase form*

$$y(t) = A\cos(\omega_0 t - \varphi), \qquad A = \sqrt{C_1^2 + C_2^2}, \quad \tan\varphi = \frac{C_2}{C_1},$$

with φ chosen in the quadrant of the point (C_1, C_2). (Expand $A\cos(\omega_0 t - \varphi) = A\cos\varphi\cos\omega_0 t + A\sin\varphi\sin\omega_0 t$ and match: $C_1 = A\cos\varphi$, $C_2 = A\sin\varphi$.) This form makes the amplitude A and the natural frequency ω_0 stand out at a glance.

Example 38.2 (Undamped oscillation)**.** Solve $y'' + 9y = 0$ with $y(0) = 2$, $y'(0) = -3$.

Characteristic equation $r^2 + 9 = 0 \Rightarrow r = \pm 3i$, so $\omega_0 = 3$ and

$$y(t) = C_1\cos 3t + C_2\sin 3t.$$

Now $y(0) = C_1 = 2$. Differentiate: $y'(t) = -3C_1 \sin 3t + 3C_2 \cos 3t$, so $y'(0) = 3C_2 = -3 \Rightarrow C_2 = -1$. Hence

$$y(t) = 2\cos 3t - \sin 3t.$$

The amplitude is $A = \sqrt{2^2 + (-1)^2} = \sqrt{5} \approx 2.24$, and the motion repeats with period $2\pi/3$ (Figure 38.3).

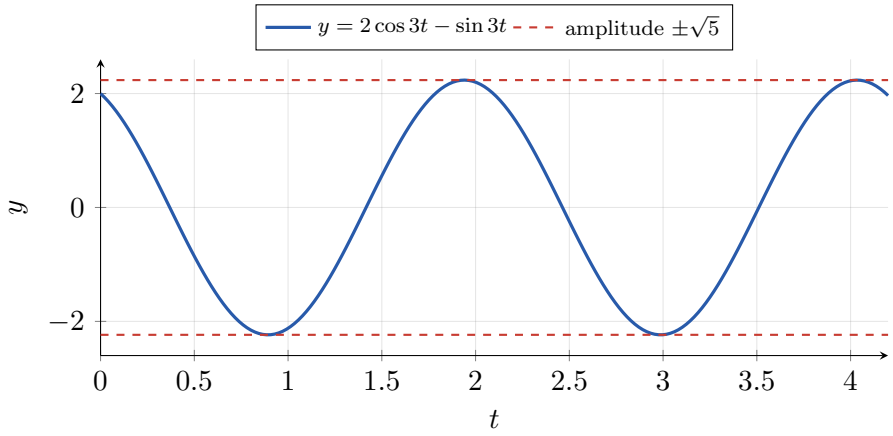


Figure 38.3: The undamped oscillation of Example 38.2: a pure sine wave of constant amplitude $\sqrt{5}$ and period $2\pi/3$, riding forever between the fixed lines $\pm\sqrt{5}$ because there is no friction to drain its energy.

Underdamping: oscillation inside a shrinking envelope

Now reinstate a *little* friction in the damped oscillator (38.3), $my'' + by' + ky = 0$, just enough that the discriminant stays negative. Then $\alpha = -b/(2m) < 0$ and the solution is

$$y(t) = e^{-(b/2m)\,t}\big(C_1 \cos \beta t + C_2 \sin \beta t\big).$$

The block still oscillates, but each swing is smaller than the last: the oscillation rides inside a decaying envelope $\pm Ae^{\alpha t}$. This is *underdamping* – a plucked guitar string, a struck tuning fork, a car on good shock absorbers nudged once. The oscillation frequency is

$$\beta = \frac{\sqrt{4mk - b^2}}{2m} = \sqrt{\omega_0^2 - \left(\frac{b}{2m}\right)^2} < \omega_0,$$

slightly lower than the undamped ω_0: friction makes each cycle a hair slower.

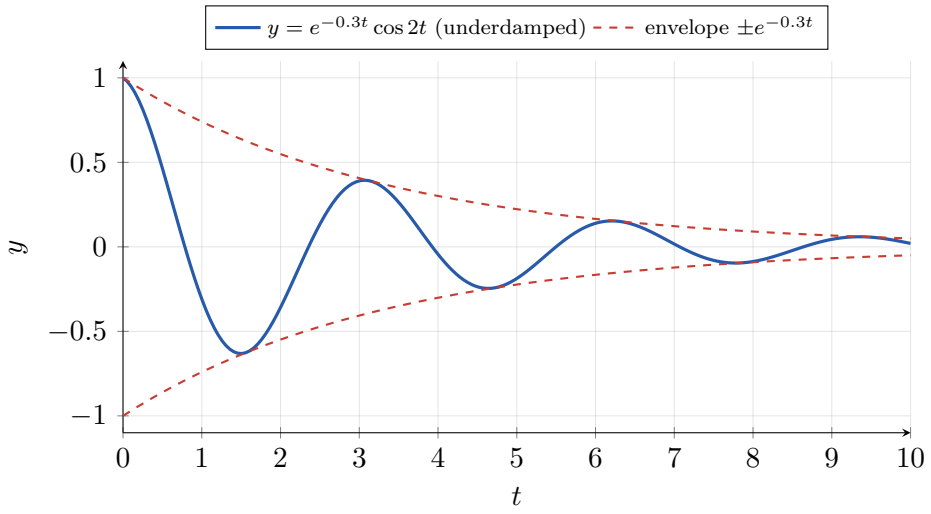


Figure 38.4: Underdamped motion: a sine wave squeezed inside the decaying envelope $\pm e^{-0.3t}$. The system oscillates but loses amplitude every cycle. This is the most common behavior of real vibrating systems.

Why this matters

Watch how three utterly different pictures – a slow monotone crawl back to rest (overdamping), an eternal pure sine wave (no damping), and a ringing wave fading inside an envelope (underdamping) – all fall out of *one* quadratic, depending only on the sign of $b^2 - 4ac$ and whether b is zero. Few places in mathematics show so clearly how a single algebraic quantity governs qualitative behavior. The boundary case $\Delta = 0$ is the repeated-root case we treat next.

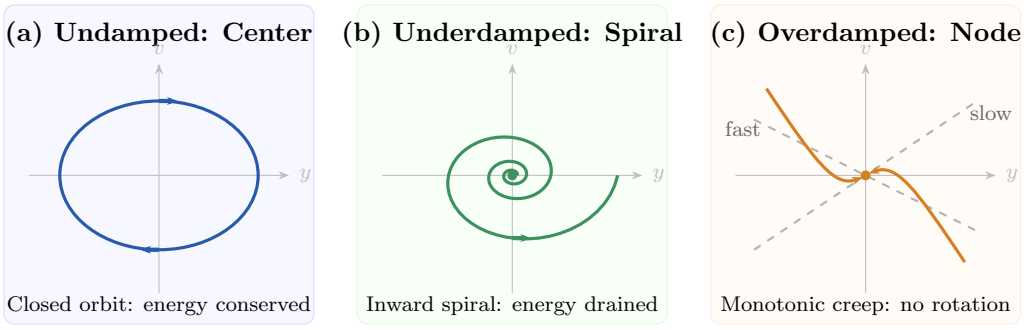


Figure 38.5: The three vibrational regimes viewed in displacement–velocity phase space (y, v) where $v = y'$. (a) Undamped motion is a closed periodic orbit (Center) cycling forever between potential and kinetic energy. (b) Underdamped motion is an inward spiral (Spiral Sink), losing amplitude on each cycle as friction extracts energy. (c) Overdamped motion is a direct approach (Nodal Sink), collapsing along the slow eigenspace into rest without a single oscillation.

38.7 Case 2: A Repeated Real Root ($\Delta = 0$)

The borderline case $b^2 - 4ac = 0$ is the strangest and most instructive. The quadratic has a single (double) root

$$r = -\frac{b}{2a},$$

and the recipe e^{rt} gives us only *one* solution, $y_1 = e^{rt}$. But a second-order equation needs *two* independent solutions to span its two-dimensional solution space. We are one solution short. Where does the second one come from?

Common trap

A tempting wrong move is to write $y = C_1 e^{rt} + C_2 e^{rt} = (C_1 + C_2)e^{rt}$. That is *not* a two-parameter family at all – it collapses to a single constant times e^{rt}. You have one solution masquerading as two. The two pieces are not independent, so the initial-value problem has no hope of matching arbitrary $y(0)$ *and* $y'(0)$. A genuinely new solution is required.

What is really happening

Here is the real reason the missing solution is $t\,e^{rt}$. Think of the repeated root as the limit of two distinct roots r and $r + \varepsilon$ that are sliding together as $\varepsilon \to 0$. For distinct roots we have the two solutions e^{rt} and $e^{(r+\varepsilon)t}$. Their difference, divided by ε, is also a solution by superposition:

$$\frac{e^{(r+\varepsilon)t} - e^{rt}}{\varepsilon}.$$

But this is exactly a difference quotient – in the limit $\varepsilon \to 0$ it becomes the *derivative of* e^{rt} *with respect to* r:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\, e^{rt} = t\, e^{rt}.$$

The second solution is the rate at which e^{rt} changes as you nudge the exponent. When two exponential solutions collide, the slot the second one vacated is filled by "t times the first."

Let us verify directly that $y_2 = t\,e^{rt}$ works when $r = -b/(2a)$ is a double root, so that $ar^2 + br + c = 0$ *and* (since r is the vertex of the parabola) $2ar + b = 0$. Compute the derivatives of $y_2 = te^{rt}$:

$$y_2' = e^{rt} + rt\,e^{rt} = (1 + rt)e^{rt}, \qquad y_2'' = re^{rt} + r(1 + rt)e^{rt} = (2r + r^2 t)e^{rt}.$$

Substitute into $ay_2'' + by_2' + cy_2$ and collect by powers of t:

$$e^{rt}\Big[\underbrace{(ar^2 + br + c)}_{=0}\, t + \underbrace{(2ar + b)}_{=0}\Big] = 0.$$

Both bracketed quantities vanish precisely because r is a *repeated* root. So te^{rt} is a bona fide second solution. The general solution in the repeated-root case is therefore

$$\boxed{y(t) = (C_1 + C_2 t)\, e^{rt}.} \tag{38.8}$$

Physically this is *critical damping*: the exact knife's-edge amount of friction that brings the system back to rest as fast as possible *without* overshooting. A screen door closer, a sensitive galvanometer,

and a well-tuned car suspension are all designed to sit at or near this critical value – any less and they would bounce, any more and they would respond sluggishly.

Example 38.3 (Critical damping)**.** Solve $y'' + 4y' + 4y = 0$ with $y(0) = 1$, $y'(0) = 1$.

Characteristic equation $r^2 + 4r + 4 = (r + 2)^2 = 0$, a double root $r = -2$. So

$$y(t) = (C_1 + C_2 t)e^{-2t}.$$

Then $y(0) = C_1 = 1$. Differentiate with the product rule:

$$y'(t) = C_2 e^{-2t} - 2(C_1 + C_2 t)e^{-2t} = \big(C_2 - 2C_1 - 2C_2 t\big)e^{-2t}.$$

So $y'(0) = C_2 - 2C_1 = 1$, giving $C_2 = 1 + 2 = 3$. The solution is

$$y(t) = (1 + 3t)e^{-2t}.$$

Notice it rises briefly (the $3t$ wins early) before the exponential drags it down to rest – a single gentle bump, no oscillation. That is critical damping in one picture.

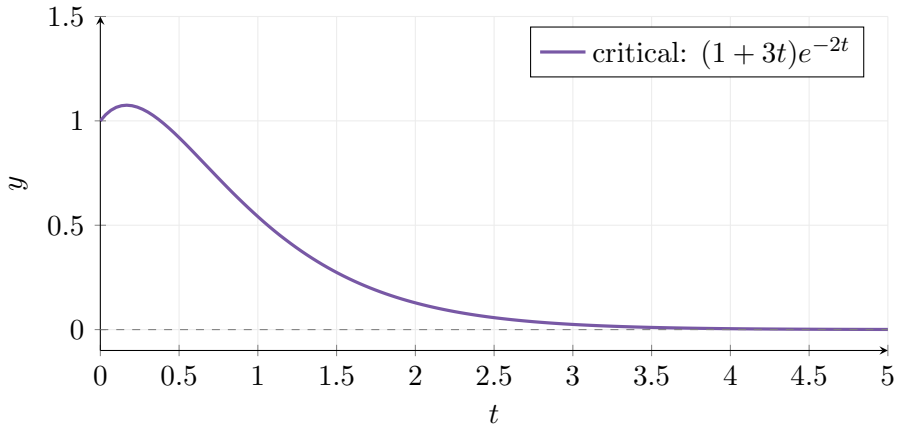


Figure 38.6: Critically damped motion from Example 38.3: one bump, then a clean return to rest with no overshoot. This is the fastest non-oscillating decay possible.

38.8 When Are Two Solutions Really Independent? The Wronskian

We have repeatedly claimed that pairs like $\{e^{r_1 t}, e^{r_2 t}\}$ or $\{e^{rt}, te^{rt}\}$ are "independent," so that $C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2$ captures *all* solutions. Let us pin down what "independent" means, since that is exactly what guarantees we have not missed any solutions.

Two solutions y_1, y_2 are *linearly independent* if neither is a constant multiple of the other – equivalently, if $C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2 = 0$ for all t forces $C_1 = C_2 = 0$. The clean test is the *Wronskian* determinant

$$W(y_1, y_2)(t) = \det \begin{pmatrix} y_1 & y_2 \\ y_1' & y_2' \end{pmatrix} = y_1 y_2' - y_2 y_1'.$$

Why the technique works

Why does this determinant detect independence? Suppose we want constants with $C_1y_1 + C_2y_2 = 0$ for all t. Differentiating gives a second equation $C_1y_1' + C_2y_2' = 0$. Together they are a 2×2 linear system for (C_1, C_2):

$$\begin{pmatrix} y_1 & y_2 \\ y_1' & y_2' \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} C_1 \\ C_2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

If the determinant W is nonzero at even one point, the only solution is $C_1 = C_2 = 0$ – so y_1, y_2 are independent. The Wronskian is precisely the determinant that decides whether the "cancel to zero" system has a nontrivial solution. A nonzero Wronskian is the certificate that our two solutions genuinely span a two-dimensional space, with no overlap.

Example 38.4 (The exponential pair is independent)**.** For $y_1 = e^{r_1 t}$, $y_2 = e^{r_2 t}$ with $r_1 \neq r_2$,

$$W = e^{r_1 t} \cdot r_2 e^{r_2 t} - e^{r_2 t} \cdot r_1 e^{r_1 t} = (r_2 - r_1)\, e^{(r_1 + r_2)t}.$$

Since $r_1 \neq r_2$ and the exponential never vanishes, $W \neq 0$ everywhere. The two solutions are independent, confirming (38.6). For the repeated-root pair $\{e^{rt}, te^{rt}\}$, $W = e^{rt}(1+rt)e^{rt} - te^{rt} \cdot re^{rt} = e^{2rt} \neq 0$. For the complex-root pair $\{e^{\alpha t}\cos\beta t,\ e^{\alpha t}\sin\beta t\}$ with $\beta \neq 0$, the same kind of computation gives $W = \beta e^{2\alpha t}(\cos^2\beta t + \sin^2\beta t) = \beta e^{2\alpha t} \neq 0$. All three cases produce independent pairs.

Formal

The payoff is the *Existence and Uniqueness Theorem* for constant-coefficient linear ODEs: given any initial data $y(t_0) = y_0$, $y'(t_0) = v_0$, there is one and only one solution. Because the Wronskian of our basis $\{y_1, y_2\}$ is nonzero, the system

$$C_1y_1(t_0) + C_2y_2(t_0) = y_0, \qquad C_1y_1'(t_0) + C_2y_2'(t_0) = v_0$$

always has a unique solution (C_1, C_2). So every initial-value problem is solved exactly once by our two-parameter family – nothing is missed, nothing is double-counted. This is the rigorous backbone under all the case work above.

38.9 Forcing the System: Inhomogeneous Equations

Now switch the forcing back on:

$$ay'' + by' + cy = f(t). \tag{38.9}$$

Physically, $f(t)$ is an external push: a periodic shove on the spring, a voltage applied to a circuit, gravity loading a beam. The structure theorem that organizes everything is this.

Theorem 38.2 (Structure of the general solution)**.** *Let y_p be* any one *particular solution of the inhomogeneous equation (38.9), and let $y_h = C_1y_1 + C_2y_2$ be the general solution of the associated homogeneous equation $ay'' + by' + cy = 0$. Then the general solution of (38.9) is*

$$y = y_h + y_p = C_1y_1 + C_2y_2 + y_p.$$

Proof. First, $y_h + y_p$ solves (38.9): applying the linear operator L, $L[y_h + y_p] = L[y_h] + L[y_p] = 0 + f = f$. Conversely, let Y be *any* solution. Then $L[Y - y_p] = L[Y] - L[y_p] = f - f = 0$, so $Y - y_p$ solves the homogeneous equation and must equal some $C_1 y_1 + C_2 y_2$. Hence $Y = y_h + y_p$. Every solution has this form, and every function of this form is a solution. □

Intuition

Read the structure physically. The homogeneous part y_h is the system's own free vibration – whatever it would do if you set it going and walked away. The particular part y_p is its forced response – the steady motion the external push drives it into. The true motion is the *sum*: the driven response, plus whatever leftover free vibration the initial conditions demand. In a damped system y_h decays away (it is called the *transient*), and after a while only the forced y_p survives (the *steady state*). This is why, long after you start shaking a damped spring, it settles into the rhythm of your hand and forgets how it started.

38.10 Undetermined Coefficients: Guessing y_p Intelligently

To finish the inhomogeneous problem we need just one particular solution y_p. For the common forcing functions – polynomials, exponentials, sines and cosines – there is a beautifully direct method: *guess a y_p of the same shape as f, with unknown coefficients, and let the equation solve for them.*

Why the technique works

Why should a same-shape guess work? Because differentiation keeps these special functions inside their own families. Differentiate a polynomial and you get a polynomial; differentiate e^{kt} and you get a multiple of e^{kt}; differentiate $\cos \omega t$ and you stay within $\{\cos \omega t, \sin \omega t\}$. Since $L[y]$ only differentiates and scales, if y_p is built from such a family, then $L[y_p]$ lands in the same family. To match a forcing f from that family, we only need to tune the coefficients. The method is not luck; it exploits the fact that these forcings live in finite-dimensional spaces that L maps into themselves.

The table of first guesses:

Forcing $f(t)$	Trial y_p
constant k	A
polynomial degree n	$A_n t^n + \cdots + A_1 t + A_0$
e^{kt}	Ae^{kt}
$\cos \omega t$ or $\sin \omega t$	$A \cos \omega t + B \sin \omega t$
$e^{kt} \cos \omega t$	$e^{kt}(A \cos \omega t + B \sin \omega t)$

Always include *both* a sine and a cosine when the forcing has either, because differentiation turns one into the other.

Example 38.5 (Polynomial forcing)**.** Solve $y'' - y' - 2y = 4t^2$.

Homogeneous part. $r^2 - r - 2 = (r - 2)(r + 1) = 0$, so $r = 2, -1$ and $y_h = C_1 e^{2t} + C_2 e^{-t}$.

Guess. The forcing is a degree-2 polynomial, so try $y_p = At^2 + Bt + C$. Then $y_p' = 2At + B$ and $y_p'' = 2A$. Substitute:

$$\underbrace{2A}_{y_p''} - \underbrace{(2At + B)}_{y_p'} - 2\underbrace{(At^2 + Bt + C)}_{y_p} = 4t^2.$$

Collect by powers of t:

$$-2A\,t^2 + (-2A - 2B)\,t + (2A - B - 2C) = 4t^2 + 0t + 0.$$

Match coefficients.

$$t^2:\ -2A = 4 \Rightarrow A = -2; \qquad t^1:\ -2A - 2B = 0 \Rightarrow B = 2; \qquad t^0:\ 2A - B - 2C = 0 \Rightarrow C = -3.$$

So $y_p = -2t^2 + 2t - 3$, and the general solution is

$$y = C_1 e^{2t} + C_2 e^{-t} - 2t^2 + 2t - 3.$$

Example 38.6 (Sinusoidal forcing – a driven oscillator)**.** Solve $y'' + 4y = 5\cos t$ (an undamped spring with $\omega_0 = 2$, pushed at frequency 1).

Homogeneous part. $r^2 + 4 = 0 \Rightarrow r = \pm 2i$, so $y_h = C_1 \cos 2t + C_2 \sin 2t$.

Guess. Forcing $5\cos t$; try $y_p = A\cos t + B\sin t$. Then $y_p'' = -A\cos t - B\sin t$, and

$$y_p'' + 4y_p = (-A + 4A)\cos t + (-B + 4B)\sin t = 3A\cos t + 3B\sin t.$$

Match to $5\cos t + 0\sin t$: $3A = 5 \Rightarrow A = 5/3$, and $3B = 0 \Rightarrow B = 0$. So $y_p = \frac{5}{3}\cos t$, and

$$y = C_1 \cos 2t + C_2 \sin 2t + \tfrac{5}{3}\cos t.$$

The driving frequency 1 differs from the natural frequency 2, so the response stays bounded – the system simply hums along at the driving frequency with a modest amplitude. Watch what happens in the next section when those two frequencies coincide.

The resonance snag, and how to fix the guess

There is one trap, and it is the most physically important phenomenon in the chapter. *What if the trial y_p is already a solution of the homogeneous equation?* Then substituting it gives $L[y_p] = 0 \neq f$, and the guess cannot possibly match a nonzero forcing.

Common trap

If your trial solution duplicates a homogeneous solution, do *not* just give up – and do not try strange new shapes. The fix mirrors the repeated-root cure: multiply the trial by t (or by t^2 if the homogeneous root is doubled). For forcing e^{kt} when k is already a characteristic root, use $y_p = Ate^{kt}$. For forcing $\cos\omega_0 t$ at the natural frequency, use $y_p = t(A\cos\omega_0 t + B\sin\omega_0 t)$. The extra factor of t plays the same role as in the repeated-root case: it generates an independent solution when the trial form is already an element of the homogeneous solution space.

38.11 Resonance: When Forcing Hits the Natural Frequency

Take the undamped oscillator and push it at *exactly* its own natural frequency:

$$y'' + \omega_0^2 y = F_0 \cos \omega_0 t. \tag{38.10}$$

The naive guess $A\cos\omega_0 t + B\sin\omega_0 t$ is a homogeneous solution, so by the rule above we multiply by t and try

$$y_p = t\,(A\cos\omega_0 t + B\sin\omega_0 t).$$

Write $c = \cos\omega_0 t$ and $s = \sin\omega_0 t$ for short. The product rule gives

$$\begin{aligned} y_p' &= (Ac + Bs) + \omega_0 t\,(-As + Bc), \\ y_p'' &= 2\omega_0(-As + Bc) - \omega_0^2 t\,(Ac + Bs). \end{aligned}$$

In $y_p'' + \omega_0^2 y_p$ the terms carrying a factor t cancel exactly (they are t times a homogeneous solution, which the operator kills), leaving

$$y_p'' + \omega_0^2 y_p = -2\omega_0 A\, s + 2\omega_0 B\, c = F_0\, c.$$

Matching coefficients gives $A = 0$ and $B = F_0/(2\omega_0)$, so

$$y_p = \frac{F_0}{2\omega_0}\, t \sin\omega_0 t.$$

The defining feature is the factor of t *outside* the sine. The amplitude of the oscillation is $\dfrac{F_0}{2\omega_0}\,t$ – it grows without bound, linearly in time. This is *resonance*.

What is really happening

Why does pushing at the natural frequency make the amplitude explode? Timing. When you drive at ω_0, every push is perfectly synchronized with the oscillator's own motion – you always shove in the direction it is already moving, like pumping a swing exactly in rhythm. Each cycle you add a little energy and *none* is wasted fighting the motion. Energy accumulates cycle after cycle, so the amplitude climbs and climbs. The factor of t in $t\sin\omega_0 t$ is the mathematical signature of energy piling up with no escape. Off resonance, your pushes sometimes help and sometimes oppose, the books roughly balance, and the amplitude stays bounded – as we saw in Example 38.6.

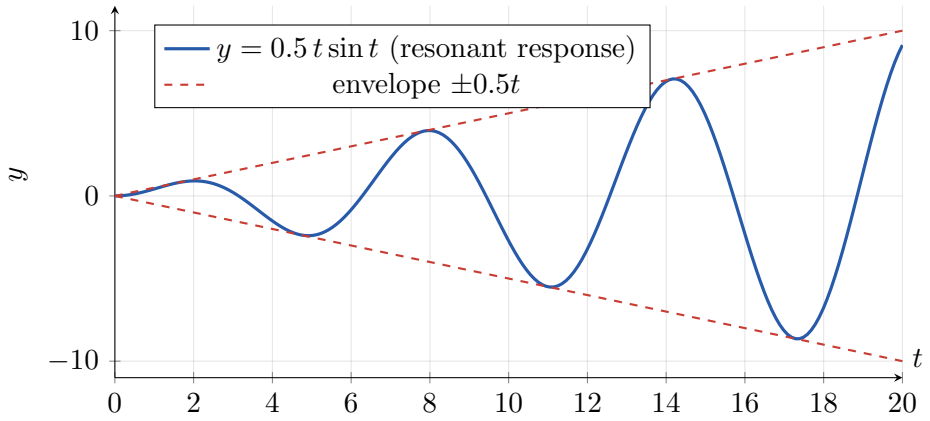


Figure 38.7: Resonance: driving at the natural frequency produces oscillations whose amplitude grows linearly in t, bounded only by the widening envelope $\pm\frac{1}{2}t$. No matter how small the push, given enough time the response becomes arbitrarily large.

Why this matters

Resonance is a central concern in structural and electrical engineering. A file of soldiers is told to break step when crossing a bridge, lest their cadence happen to match the bridge's natural frequency and pump it to destruction. The Tacoma Narrows Bridge tearing itself apart in 1940 is the textbook (if technically more subtle) cautionary image. On the constructive side, resonance is how a radio works: a tunable circuit is built to resonate at one broadcast frequency, amplifying that station hugely while ignoring all the others. A microwave oven drives water molecules near their resonance; an MRI machine resonates atomic nuclei. That factor of t marks the exact frequency at which energy builds up cycle after cycle.

Application

Real systems always have a little damping, so the amplitude does not literally go to infinity – the decaying transient and the energy lost to friction eventually balance the energy you pump in, and the response levels off at a large but finite amplitude. The closer the driving frequency is to ω_0, and the smaller the damping b, the taller that resonant peak. Engineers plot the steady-state amplitude against driving frequency and get a sharp spike at ω_0 – the *resonance curve*. Designing a structure means either keeping its natural frequencies far from any expected driving frequency, or adding enough damping to tame the peak. The undamped, infinitely growing solution above is the idealized limit that warns you where the danger lies.

Example 38.7 (Pure resonance, worked)**.** Solve $y'' + y = 2\cos t$ with $y(0) = 0$, $y'(0) = 0$.

Here $\omega_0 = 1$ and the forcing frequency is also 1: resonance. The homogeneous solution is $y_h = C_1\cos t + C_2\sin t$. Since $\cos t$ solves the homogeneous equation, multiply the trial by t:

$$y_p = t(A\cos t + B\sin t).$$

Differentiate twice:

$$y_p' = A\cos t + B\sin t + t(-A\sin t + B\cos t),$$

$$y_p'' = 2(-A\sin t + B\cos t) + t(-A\cos t - B\sin t).$$

Then $y_p'' + y_p = 2(-A\sin t + B\cos t)$ (the t-terms cancel because $\cos t, \sin t$ solve the homogeneous equation). Match to $2\cos t$: $2B = 2 \Rightarrow B = 1$ and $-2A = 0 \Rightarrow A = 0$. So $y_p = t\sin t$, and

$$y = C_1\cos t + C_2\sin t + t\sin t.$$

Apply $y(0) = 0 \Rightarrow C_1 = 0$. Then $y' = C_2\cos t + \sin t + t\cos t$, so $y'(0) = C_2 = 0$. The clean answer is

$$y(t) = t\sin t,$$

an oscillation whose swings grow without bound – the picture of Figure 38.7 with envelope $\pm t$.

38.12 A Unified Worked Lab

Work it yourself

Take the damped, forced oscillator

$$y'' + 2y' + 5y = 10\cos t, \qquad y(0) = 0,\ y'(0) = 0,$$

and carry it through end to end. The skeleton:

1. **Homogeneous solution.** Characteristic equation $r^2+2r+5 = 0$. Discriminant $4-20 = -16 < 0$, so $r = -1 \pm 2i$. Underdamped:

$$y_h = e^{-t}(C_1\cos 2t + C_2\sin 2t).$$

2. **Particular solution.** Forcing $10\cos t$; the frequency 1 is not a homogeneous frequency, so no resonance, no extra t. Try $y_p = A\cos t + B\sin t$ and show

$$y_p'' + 2y_p' + 5y_p = (4A + 2B)\cos t + (4B - 2A)\sin t.$$

   Match to $10\cos t + 0\sin t$: solve $4A + 2B = 10$, $-2A + 4B = 0$. Confirm $A = 2$, $B = 1$, so $y_p = 2\cos t + \sin t$.

3. **Combine.** $y = e^{-t}(C_1\cos 2t + C_2\sin 2t) + 2\cos t + \sin t$.

4. **Initial conditions.** Use $y(0) = 0$ to get $C_1 + 2 = 0$, so $C_1 = -2$. Now differentiate the full y and set $y'(0) = 0$. Since

$$y'(0) = -C_1 + 2C_2 + 1 = 0,$$

   substituting $C_1 = -2$ gives $2 + 2C_2 + 1 = 0$, so $C_2 = -\frac{3}{2}$. Final answer:

$$y(t) = -e^{-t}\left(2\cos 2t + \tfrac{3}{2}\sin 2t\right) + 2\cos t + \sin t.$$

5. **Interpret.** Identify the transient $-e^{-t}\left(2\cos 2t + \frac{3}{2}\sin 2t\right)$ (gone within a few seconds) and the steady state $2\cos t + \sin t$ (the lasting response, oscillating at the *driving* frequency 1, not the damped frequency 2). Sketch both and watch the transient fade.

Do every step with pencil before reading on; the differentiation in step 2 is the only fiddly part, and getting it by hand cements the method.

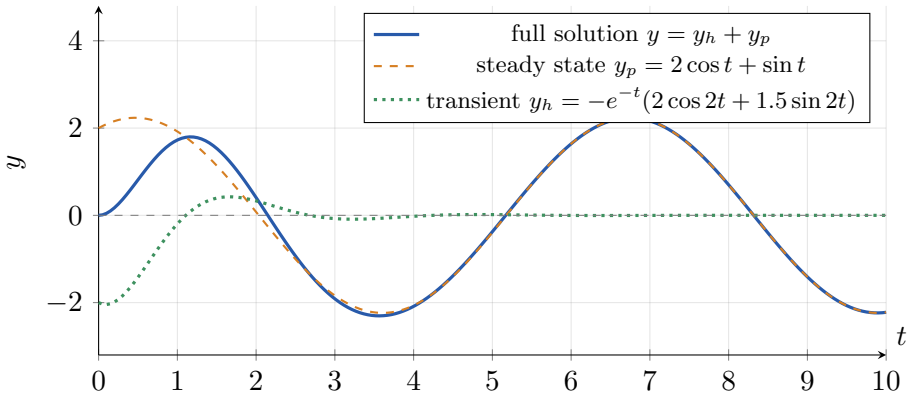


Figure 38.8: Decomposition of the worked lab solution into its transient and steady-state components. The transient free response $y_h(t)$ (dotted green) decays exponentially within a few cycles as damping drains initial energy. The steady-state forced response $y_p(t)$ (dashed orange) oscillates indefinitely at the driving frequency. The actual motion $y(t) = y_h + y_p$ (solid blue) starts from rest at the origin ($y(0) = 0, y'(0) = 0$) and rapidly synchronizes with the driving force.

Connection

Everything here generalizes upward and sideways. *Upward in order:* an nth-order constant-coefficient linear ODE has a degree-n characteristic polynomial, and its n roots (real, repeated, or complex) build the solution by exactly the rules of this chapter – e^{rt} for each root, an extra t for each repetition, $e^{\alpha t}\cos\beta t$ pairs for complex roots. *Sideways into systems:* a single second-order equation is equivalent to a 2×2 *system* of first-order equations (set $v = y'$), and there the characteristic equation reappears as the eigenvalue equation of a matrix. The roots r become eigenvalues; oscillation becomes complex eigenvalues; damping becomes negative real parts.

In engineering applications, structures rarely consist of an isolated oscillator. When multiple masses or electrical loops interact, coupled physical components require simultaneous differential equations. The displacement of each mass exerts a force on the next, meaning no single equation can be solved in isolation. In Chapter 39, we step into that world, discovering how matrix algebra and eigenvectors unravel systems of simultaneous ODEs into independent modes of vibration.

38.13 Summary

Focus

The whole method, on one card.

To solve $ay'' + by' + cy = f(t)$:

1. Solve the homogeneous equation. Write the characteristic equation $ar^2 + br + c = 0$ and find its roots.
   - Distinct real r_1, r_2: $y_h = C_1 e^{r_1 t} + C_2 e^{r_2 t}$ (overdamped).
   - Repeated real r: $y_h = (C_1 + C_2 t)e^{rt}$ (critically damped).

- Complex $\alpha \pm i\beta$: $y_h = e^{\alpha t}(C_1 \cos \beta t + C_2 \sin \beta t)$ (oscillation; underdamped if $\alpha < 0$).

2. If $f \neq 0$, find one particular y_p by undetermined coefficients – guess the shape of f, multiplying by t if the guess collides with a homogeneous solution (resonance).
3. General solution $y = y_h + y_p$. Apply the two initial conditions $y(t_0), y'(t_0)$ last, to fix C_1, C_2.

The central idea throughout: e^{rt} converts the linear differential equation into an algebraic quadratic equation, whose discriminant classifies the unforced motion as overdamped, critically damped, or underdamped, while forcing at the natural frequency produces resonance.

With single second-order equations in hand, Chapter 39 extends the exponential guess to coupled **systems of differential equations** $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$.

38.14 Exercises

Exercise 38.1. Classify each by its discriminant as overdamped, critically damped, or underdamped, then write the general solution. (a) $y''+7y'+12y = 0$. (b) $y''+6y'+9y = 0$. (c) $y''+2y'+10y = 0$.

Exercise 38.2. Solve the initial-value problem $y'' + \omega_0^2 y = 0$, $y(0) = y_0$, $y'(0) = v_0$, for general ω_0, y_0, v_0. Then show the amplitude of the resulting oscillation is $A = \sqrt{y_0^2 + v_0^2/\omega_0^2}$. Interpret each term physically.

Exercise 38.3. For the equation $y'' + 4y' + 4y = 0$ (a double root at $r = -2$), verify by direct substitution that $y_2 = te^{-2t}$ is a solution, and compute the Wronskian $W(e^{-2t}, te^{-2t})$ to confirm the two solutions are independent.

Exercise 38.4. Solve $y'' - 3y' + 2y = 0$ with $y(0) = 0$, $y'(0) = 1$. Then describe, in one sentence each, how the solution behaves as $t \to \infty$ and as $t \to -\infty$.

Exercise 38.5. Use undetermined coefficients to find a particular solution of $y'' - y = 3e^{2t}$. Why does the plain guess Ae^{2t} work here without an extra factor of t?

Exercise 38.6. Find a particular solution of $y'' + y = 4 \sin 2t$. The driving frequency is 2 and the natural frequency is 1 – explain why no resonance occurs and no extra t is needed, then solve.

Exercise 38.7. The forcing in $y'' - y = 4e^t$ matches a homogeneous solution ($r = 1$ is a root of $r^2 - 1 = 0$). Use the corrected trial $y_p = Ate^t$ to find a particular solution. This is the exponential analogue of resonance.

Exercise 38.8. Pure resonance. Solve $y'' + 9y = 6 \cos 3t$ with $y(0) = 0$, $y'(0) = 0$. Identify the growing-amplitude term and state the envelope within which the solution oscillates.

Exercise 38.9. Damped driven oscillator. For $y'' + 2y' + 2y = 10 \cos t$, find the steady-state (particular) solution and its amplitude. Which part of the full solution is the transient, and roughly how long until it is negligible?

Exercise 38.10. A spring-mass system has $m = 1$, spring constant $k = 4$, and damping b. (a) For which value of b is the system critically damped? (b) Sketch (qualitatively) the response to the initial data $y(0) = 1$, $y'(0) = 0$ for b slightly below, equal to, and slightly above that critical value, and explain the difference in words.

Exercise 38.11. Reduction to a system. Given $y'' + by' + cy = 0$, set $v = y'$ and write the equivalent pair of first-order equations for (y, v). Show that looking for solutions of the form $(y, v) = \mathbf{u}\, e^{rt}$ recovers exactly the characteristic equation $r^2 + br + c = 0$. (This is the bridge to the next chapter.)

Exercise 38.12. Conceptual. Explain, without solving any equation, why a second-order linear ODE needs exactly two initial conditions while a first-order one needs only one. Connect your answer to the dimension of the homogeneous solution space and to the physical idea of a system's "state."

Chapter 39

Systems of Differential Equations and Beyond

In the previous chapter, we wrestled with second-order differential equations like $y'' + py' + qy = 0$, watching a single mass on a spring trade position for velocity and settle or oscillate according to one equation for one variable. Up to now, differential equations have described a solitary quantity changing in time: a population, a temperature, the charge on a capacitor, the angle of a swinging pendulum. One unknown function, one equation. Most real systems, however, involve several quantities changing together. Foxes and rabbits eat and are eaten; their fortunes are locked together, and neither population curve makes sense without the other. Two masses joined by springs trade energy back and forth. Three chemical species react, each feeding on and feeding the next. In every one of these settings we have not one unknown function but several, and the rate of change of each depends on *all* of them at once. We need a *system* of differential equations.

Here two main threads come together. On one side is everything we learned about derivatives, exponentials, and the scalar ODE $y' = ky$ whose solution is e^{kt}. On the other side is linear algebra – vectors, matrices, and above all **eigenvalues and eigenvectors**. An eigenvector is a special direction that a matrix merely stretches without rotating; the eigenvalue is that stretch factor. The astonishing payoff is this: a whole system of coupled linear equations, no matter how tangled it looks, can be *uncoupled* by choosing the right coordinates, and in those coordinates each piece is just $y' = \lambda y$ again. The eigenvectors are the right coordinates. The eigenvalues are the growth rates. Solving a linear system generalizes the scalar equation $y' = ky$ to matrix form.

We will build the machinery, draw the pictures that make it intuitive – the *phase portraits* that turn a system into a geometric vector field – classify when equilibria attract and when they repel, and then push at the edge of the linear world to glimpse what happens when systems go nonlinear: limit cycles, sensitive dependence, chaos. We end by pointing down the roads that leave this book and head into the rest of mathematics: partial differential equations, numerical methods, dynamical systems, and the foundational appendix that undergirds them all.

39.1 What a System Is, and Why You Already Have One

A **first-order system** of differential equations is a collection of equations, one for the derivative of each unknown function, where each right-hand side may depend on all the unknowns (and possibly on time):

$$\begin{aligned} x_1'(t) &= f_1(t, x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n), \\ x_2'(t) &= f_2(t, x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n), \\ &\vdots \\ x_n'(t) &= f_n(t, x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n). \end{aligned}$$

The word *first-order* means only first derivatives appear. The word *system* means the equations are bound together – you cannot solve one without the others, because each f_i depends on every x_j.

It is enormously clarifying to bundle the unknowns into a single vector-valued function

$$\mathbf{x}(t) = \big(x_1(t), x_2(t), \dots, x_n(t)\big),$$

and the right-hand sides into a single vector field $\mathbf{F}(t, \mathbf{x}) = (f_1, \dots, f_n)$. Then the entire system collapses to one clean line that looks exactly like the scalar case:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{x}'(t) = \mathbf{F}\big(t, \mathbf{x}(t)\big).}$$

Vector notation here expresses a geometric point of view. A single number moving on a line obeyed $x' = f(x)$. A single *point* moving through n-dimensional space obeys $\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{F}(\mathbf{x})$. The state of the whole world is one point; the differential equation tells that point, at every moment, which direction and how fast to move.

Intuition

Picture the unknowns as the coordinates of a single dot living in a space called **phase space**. For the fox–rabbit problem that space is a plane: the horizontal axis is the rabbit population, the vertical axis the fox population. The current state of the ecosystem is *one dot* in that plane. The system of ODEs is a rule that, at every dot, plants a little arrow telling the dot where to go next. The whole job of solving the system is to follow the arrows – to let the dot drift – and watch the curve it traces. That curve is the history of the ecosystem.

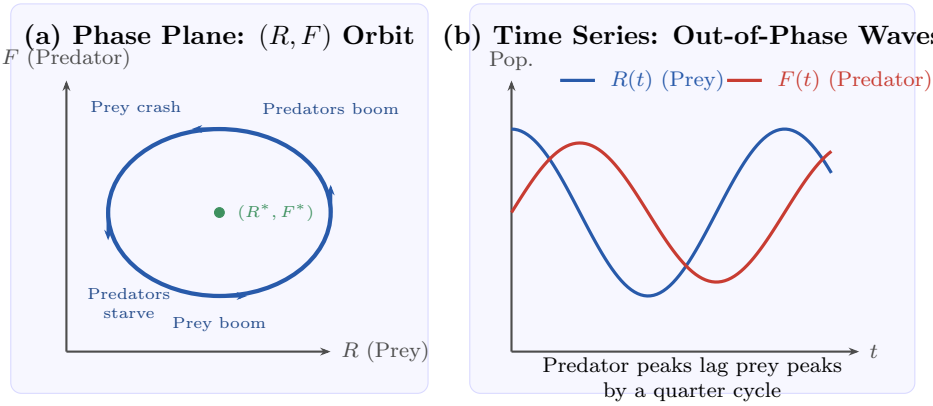


Figure 39.1: The predator–prey system in phase space and in time. (a) In phase space, the ecosystem state (R, F) traverses a closed orbit counterclockwise: abundant prey feed predators, predator overpopulation crashes the prey, food scarcity starves predators, allowing prey to recover. (b) Plotted against time, both populations oscillate periodically with identical period, with predator peaks chronically lagging behind prey peaks.

39.1.1 A first concrete example

Here is a small but real system. Let $x(t)$ and $y(t)$ be two quantities obeying

$$x' = \quad x + 2y, \qquad y' = 3x + 2y.$$

Notice the coupling: x' depends on y, and y' depends on x. You cannot integrate the first equation by itself because the $2y$ on its right is an unknown function you have not found yet. The equations are coupled; solving them requires methods that decouple the variables.

What is really happening

Notice the difference between writing the system down and solving it. The differential equations tell you the instantaneous velocity (x', y') at each point (x, y), whereas a solution gives an explicit formula $(x(t), y(t))$ telling you where the state is at any time t without having to trace the step-by-step path in between.

39.2 Reducing Higher-Order Equations to First-Order Systems

The previous chapter studied second-order equations like $y'' + py' + qy = 0$, and every higher-order ODE can be rewritten as a first-order system. This is one of the most useful structural facts in all of differential equations, and it is direct once you see it.

Take the second-order equation

$$y'' = -y$$

– the equation of simple harmonic motion, whose solutions you know are sines and cosines. Introduce a *second unknown* equal to the velocity:

$$x_1 = y, \qquad x_2 = y'.$$

Now ask for the derivatives of these two new unknowns. The first is immediate: $x_1' = y' = x_2$. The second uses the original equation: $x_2' = y'' = -y = -x_1$. So the single second-order equation becomes the first-order system

$$x_1' = x_2, \qquad x_2' = -x_1.$$

We have not changed the physics one bit; we have only renamed "position" and "velocity" as two coordinates and written down how each one changes. The trick generalizes word for word.

Why the technique works

Why does this always work? An nth-order equation $y^{(n)} = G(t, y, y', \dots, y^{(n-1)})$ determines the highest derivative from all the lower ones. So if we name the lower derivatives as new variables

$$x_1 = y, \quad x_2 = y', \quad x_3 = y'', \quad \dots, \quad x_n = y^{(n-1)},$$

then each variable's derivative is simply the *next* variable in the list ($x_1' = x_2$, $x_2' = x_3$, and so on) until the very last, whose derivative is the only place the original equation does any work: $x_n' = G(t, x_1, \dots, x_n)$. The cascade $x_i' = x_{i+1}$ is pure bookkeeping; the genuine content of the equation lives entirely in the final slot. That is why second-order, third-order, and millionth-order equations all reduce to first-order systems: differentiation just shifts you one notch up a ladder, and the equation tells you what happens when you fall off the top.

Why this matters

This reduction is why we can afford to spend the whole chapter on first-order systems and lose nothing. A numerical solver written for $\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{F}(\mathbf{x})$ can integrate the orbit of a planet (second order), the vibration of a bridge (fourth order), or the firing of a neuron (a tangle of several equations) without modification. That is why almost all general theorems and numerical algorithms in dynamics are written once, for first-order systems $\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{F}(\mathbf{x})$.

Example 39.1 (Damped oscillator as a system)**.** The equation $y'' + 2y' + 5y = 0$ models a mass on a spring with friction. Set $x_1 = y$, $x_2 = y'$. Then $x_1' = x_2$, and from the equation $y'' = -2y' - 5y$, so $x_2' = -5x_1 - 2x_2$. In matrix form,

$$\begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \end{pmatrix}' = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -5 & -2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The matrix that appears is called the **companion matrix** of the equation – a standard matrix that translates a single higher-order ODE into a first-order system by shifting variables along the upper off-diagonal and placing the original equation's coefficients in the bottom row. We will solve systems of exactly this shape in a moment; the bottom row is literally the coefficients of the original ODE, sign-flipped.

Walking question

Pause and think: Suppose you have the third-order equation $y''' - y = 0$. If you set $x_1 = y$, $x_2 = y'$, and $x_3 = y''$, what does the 3×3 companion matrix look like? The first row gives $x_1' = x_2$, so $(0, 1, 0)$; the second gives $x_2' = x_3$, so $(0, 0, 1)$; and the bottom row reads the ODE itself, $x_3' = y''' = y = x_1$, giving $(1, 0, 0)$. Each row shifts one notch to the right until the bottom row loops back.

39.3 The Matrix Form $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$

From here on we focus on **linear** systems with constant coefficients, because they are the ones we can solve completely and because everything we learn about them governs the local behavior of nonlinear systems too (Section 39.7). A linear constant-coefficient system in two unknowns looks like

$$u_1' = au_1 + bu_2,$$
$$u_2' = cu_1 + du_2,$$

and packs neatly into the single matrix equation

$$\boxed{\mathbf{u}' = A\,\mathbf{u}, \qquad \mathbf{u} = \begin{pmatrix} u_1 \\ u_2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}.}$$

Here $\mathbf{u}'$ means "differentiate each component": $\mathbf{u}' = (u_1', u_2')$. The whole system is now a single object: a matrix A acting on a moving vector.

Consider the scalar case as an analogy. If $\mathbf{u}$ has just one component, A is just a number λ, and the equation is $u' = \lambda u$, whose solution we have known since the chapter on exponentials:

$$u(t) = u(0)\, e^{\lambda t}.$$

The strategy for solving linear systems extends the exponential trial solution: we test whether the matrix equation admits solutions of the form $\mathbf{u}(t) = e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}$ for a constant vector $\mathbf{v}$ and scalar rate λ. Let us test that hypothesis.

Walking question

Suppose that $\mathbf{u}(t) = e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}$ where $\mathbf{v}$ is a constant nonzero vector. Differentiate the left side: since $\mathbf{v}$ is constant, $\mathbf{u}'(t) = \lambda e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}$. Now compute the right side: $A\mathbf{u}(t) = A(e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}) = e^{\lambda t}(A\mathbf{v})$. For these to be equal for all t, cancel the never-zero scalar $e^{\lambda t}$ and you are left with

$$A\mathbf{v} = \lambda\mathbf{v}.$$

That is the eigenvalue equation. The requirement that $e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}$ solve the differential equation is precisely the condition that $\mathbf{v}$ be an eigenvector of A with eigenvalue λ. The differential equation is converted directly into a problem of linear algebra.

Connection

This is the hinge between this book and its companion, *Linear Algebra From the Ground Up*. There, an eigenvector $\mathbf{v}$ of A is defined as a special direction that A merely *stretches* rather than rotates: $A\mathbf{v} = \lambda\mathbf{v}$, with the stretch factor λ the eigenvalue. That definition can feel abstract when you first meet it – why should anyone care about directions a matrix only stretches? Here is the answer, arriving from the calculus side: those are precisely the directions in which a linear system of ODEs behaves like a single scalar exponential. If you have not yet met eigenvalues, the chapters "Eigenvalues and Eigenvectors" and "Diagonalization" in the companion volume develop $\det(A - \lambda I) = 0$ and the solving of $(A - \lambda I)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ from scratch; we will use those tools freely below and recall just enough to stay self-contained.

39.3.1 Recipe: eigenvalues and eigenvectors

For a 2×2 matrix $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, the eigenvalues are the roots λ of the **characteristic equation** – the polynomial equation that ensures $(A - \lambda I)$ is singular, so it can squash nonzero vectors into the zero vector:

$$\det(A - \lambda I) = 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \lambda^2 - \underbrace{(a+d)}_{\text{trace } \tau}\lambda + \underbrace{(ad-bc)}_{\det \Delta} = 0.$$

Here the **trace** $\tau = a + d$ is the sum of the main diagonal entries, and the **determinant** $\Delta = ad - bc$ measures how the matrix scales areas. Using the quadratic formula, the eigenvalues are $\lambda = \frac{1}{2}\left(\tau \pm \sqrt{\tau^2 - 4\Delta}\right)$. For each eigenvalue λ, the eigenvectors are the nonzero solutions $\mathbf{v}$ of the system $(A - \lambda I)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$. Once we have a pair of eigenvalue–eigenvector couples $(\lambda_1, \mathbf{v}_1)$ and $(\lambda_2, \mathbf{v}_2)$, each gives a solution $e^{\lambda_i t}\mathbf{v}_i$, and – because the system is linear – *any combination of solutions is again a solution.*

Theorem 39.1 (General solution by eigen-decomposition)**.** *Suppose the $n \times n$ matrix A has n linearly independent eigenvectors $\mathbf{v}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{v}_n$ with eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$. Then* every *solution of $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ has the form*

$$\mathbf{u}(t) = c_1 e^{\lambda_1 t}\mathbf{v}_1 + c_2 e^{\lambda_2 t}\mathbf{v}_2 + \cdots + c_n e^{\lambda_n t}\mathbf{v}_n,$$

with constants $c_1, \ldots, c_n$ fixed by the initial condition $\mathbf{u}(0)$.

Why the technique works

Why does the combination sweep up *every* solution, not just some? Two reasons, both worth holding onto. First, *superposition*: if $\mathbf{p}$ and $\mathbf{q}$ each solve $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$, then so does $c_1\mathbf{p} + c_2\mathbf{q}$, because differentiation and the matrix A are both linear – $(c_1\mathbf{p} + c_2\mathbf{q})' = c_1\mathbf{p}' + c_2\mathbf{q}' = c_1 A\mathbf{p} + c_2 A\mathbf{q} = A(c_1\mathbf{p} + c_2\mathbf{q})$. So the listed combinations really are solutions. Second, *counting*: the existence-and-uniqueness theorem for linear systems says a solution is pinned down completely by its value at one instant, $\mathbf{u}(0) \in \mathbb{R}^n$ – that is n numbers of freedom, no more. Our family has exactly n free constants $c_1, \ldots, c_n$, and because the $\mathbf{v}_i$ are independent, choosing them can hit *any* starting vector $\mathbf{u}(0) = \sum c_i \mathbf{v}_i$. Because the eigenvectors span $\mathbb{R}^n$, this family satisfies arbitrary initial conditions $\mathbf{u}(0)$, and by the uniqueness theorem it contains every solution.

What is really happening

The eigenvectors do something decisive: they *uncouple* the system. Write the starting state in the eigenvector basis, $\mathbf{u}(0) = \sum c_i \mathbf{v}_i$. In those coordinates the matrix A stops mixing the components – along each eigen-direction it acts as pure multiplication by λ_i. So in the right coordinates, the tangled system $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ falls apart into n *independent* copies of the scalar equation $z_i' = \lambda_i z_i$, each solved by $z_i(t) = c_i e^{\lambda_i t}$. The coupling we fought in Section 39.1 was an illusion of bad coordinates. Eigenvectors are the good coordinates.

Walking question

Pause and think: Look at the general solution $\mathbf{u}(t) = c_1 e^{\lambda_1 t}\mathbf{v}_1 + c_2 e^{\lambda_2 t}\mathbf{v}_2$. Suppose $\lambda_1 = -1$ and $\lambda_2 = -4$. As $t \to \infty$, both terms decay to zero. But which direction does the trajectory hug as it glides into the origin? The term e^{-4t} decays four times faster than e^{-t}. Long after e^{-4t} has vanished into negligible fractions, the slower e^{-t} term is still present, so every typical trajectory flattens out and enters the origin tangent to the slower eigen-direction $\mathbf{v}_1$.

39.4 A Fully Worked 2×2 System

Let us solve the system from Section 39.1 completely, step by step.

$$\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}, \qquad A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Step 1 – eigenvalues. The trace is $\tau = 1 + 2 = 3$ and the determinant is $\Delta = (1)(2) - (2)(3) = 2 - 6 = -4$. The characteristic equation is

$$\lambda^2 - 3\lambda - 4 = 0 \implies (\lambda - 4)(\lambda + 1) = 0,$$

so $\lambda_1 = 4$ and $\lambda_2 = -1$. Two real eigenvalues of opposite sign – already this tells us (Section 39.5) that the origin will be a *saddle*.

Step 2 – eigenvector for $\lambda_1 = 4$. Solve $(A - 4I)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$:

$$A - 4I = \begin{pmatrix} 1-4 & 2 \\ 3 & 2-4 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -3 & 2 \\ 3 & -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The top row says $-3v_1 + 2v_2 = 0$, i.e. $v_2 = \tfrac{3}{2}v_1$. Choosing $v_1 = 2$ to clear the fraction gives $\mathbf{v}_1 = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 2 \\ 3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. (The bottom row $3v_1 - 2v_2 = 0$ is the same equation – it must be, because $A - 4I$ is singular; that redundancy is the eigenvalue working as designed.)

Step 3 – eigenvector for $\lambda_2 = -1$. Solve $(A + I)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$:

$$A + I = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 2 \\ 3 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad 2v_1 + 2v_2 = 0 \implies v_2 = -v_1.$$

Choosing $v_1 = 1$ gives $\mathbf{v}_2 = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$.

Step 4 – assemble. By Theorem 39.1,

$$\mathbf{u}(t) = c_1\, e^{4t} \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ 3 \end{pmatrix} + c_2\, e^{-t} \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Step 5 – fit an initial condition. Suppose $\mathbf{u}(0) = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. At $t = 0$ the exponentials are 1, so we need

$$c_1 \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ 3 \end{pmatrix} + c_2 \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix} \implies \begin{cases} 2c_1 + c_2 = 3, \\ 3c_1 - c_2 = 2. \end{cases}$$

Adding the two equations: $5c_1 = 5$, so $c_1 = 1$, and then $c_2 = 3 - 2 = 1$. The trajectory through $(3, 2)$ is

$$\mathbf{u}(t) = e^{4t} \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ 3 \end{pmatrix} + e^{-t} \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Intuition

Read the answer like a story of two tendencies. The e^{4t} piece grows explosively and points along $\mathbf{v}_1 = (2, 3)$: this is the *unstable* direction, the one the system is fleeing toward. The e^{-t} piece decays and points along $\mathbf{v}_2 = (1, -1)$: the *stable* direction, the one the system is collapsing

onto. Almost immediately the decaying term becomes negligible and the trajectory becomes nearly parallel to $(2, 3)$, hurtling outward. The two eigenvectors act as skewed coordinate axes for the flow: trajectories come in alongside the stable axis $(1, -1)$ and bend away to leave alongside the unstable axis $(2, 3)$.

Common trap

A frequent slip: writing $\mathbf{u}(t) = e^{\lambda_1 t}\mathbf{v}_1 + e^{\lambda_2 t}\mathbf{v}_2$ *without* the constants c_1, c_2, then being unable to match the initial condition. The constants are essential; they allow you to adjust the solution at the correct starting point. With two eigen-solutions you have two dials, exactly enough to hit any point in the plane. Drop them and you can describe only one special trajectory out of the infinitely many.

39.5 Phase Portraits: Drawing the Flow

Formulas give exact coordinates, but a picture shows the whole family of solutions at once. The **phase portrait** of a planar system is the (u_1, u_2) plane decorated with the arrows of the vector field $A\mathbf{u}$ and a representative sample of solution curves – the *trajectories* – threading through them. Reading a phase portrait is reading the destiny of every possible initial state at a single glance.

Here is the saddle we just solved. The two eigen-directions are drawn as bold lines; trajectories race away along the unstable direction $(2, 3)$ and are funneled in along the stable direction $(1, -1)$, sweeping out hyperbola-like curves between them.

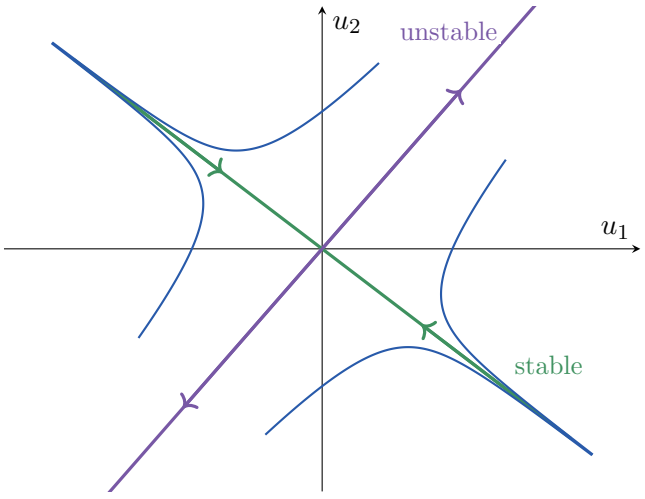


Figure 39.2: Phase portrait of the saddle $\mathbf{u}' = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 \end{smallmatrix}\right)\mathbf{u}$. Eigenvalues 4 and -1. Purple: the unstable eigen-direction $(2, 3)$; green: the stable eigen-direction $(1, -1)$. Trajectories flow out along purple and in along green.

39.5.1 The classification: trace and determinant decide everything

The qualitative shape of a planar phase portrait depends only on the two eigenvalues of A, and those depend only on the trace $\tau = a + d$ and determinant $\Delta = ad - bc$. Here is the full classification.

- **Two real eigenvalues, same sign.** If both are negative, every trajectory decays to the origin: a stable **node** (a sink), drawn in Figure 39.5. If both positive, everything flees outward: an unstable node (a source). The slower eigen-direction dominates the shape near the origin.

- **Two real eigenvalues, opposite signs.** A **saddle**, as in Figure 39.2. The origin attracts along one eigen-direction and repels along the other. Always unstable: almost every trajectory eventually leaves.

- **Complex eigenvalues $\lambda = \alpha \pm i\beta$, $\beta \neq 0$.** The solutions involve $e^{\alpha t}(\cos \beta t, \sin \beta t)$ – rotation (from the cos, sin) times scaling (from $e^{\alpha t}$). If $\alpha < 0$, trajectories spiral inward: a stable **spiral**. If $\alpha > 0$, an unstable spiral. If $\alpha = 0$ exactly, they neither grow nor shrink but circle forever: a **center**, a ring of closed orbits.

Why the technique works

Where do the rotation and the spiral come from, and how does a complex eigenvector give a real trajectory? Take $\lambda = \alpha + i\beta$ with $\beta \neq 0$, and split its eigenvector into real and imaginary parts, $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{a} + i\mathbf{b}$ with $\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}$ real. Euler's formula $e^{i\beta t} = \cos \beta t + i \sin \beta t$ expands the complex solution:

$$e^{\alpha t}(\cos \beta t + i \sin \beta t)(\mathbf{a} + i\mathbf{b}) = e^{\alpha t}(\cos \beta t\, \mathbf{a} - \sin \beta t\, \mathbf{b}) + i\, e^{\alpha t}(\sin \beta t\, \mathbf{a} + \cos \beta t\, \mathbf{b}).$$

Because A is real, the real part and the imaginary part each solve $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ on their own (the same argument as for second-order equations in Chapter 38), giving two independent *real* solutions. Read the structure: $e^{\alpha t}$ scales the size, while $\cos \beta t$ and $\sin \beta t$ turn the state around in the plane spanned by $\mathbf{a}$ and $\mathbf{b}$. That is why an undamped spring ($\alpha = 0$, eigenvalues $\pm i\omega$) orbits forever in a center, while a damped spring ($\alpha < 0$) spirals into rest.

The whole classification fits on one diagram in the (τ, Δ) plane. The parabola $\tau^2 = 4\Delta$ is the boundary where the eigenvalues switch from real to complex.

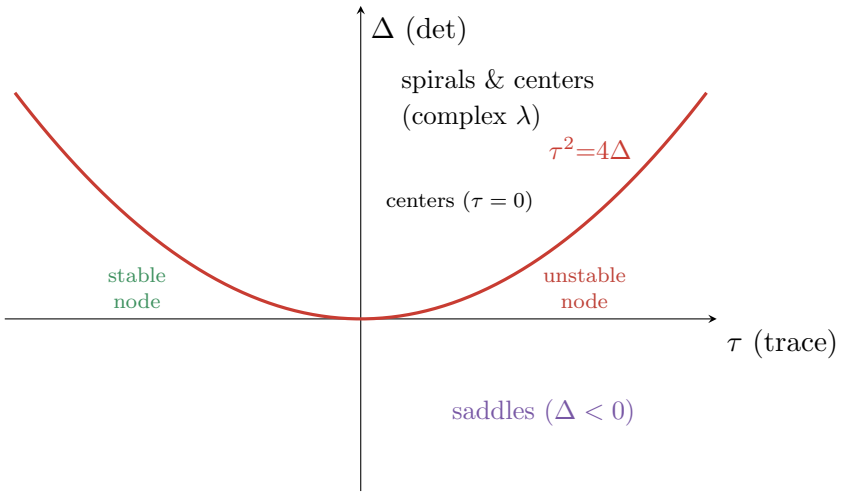


Figure 39.3: The trace–determinant plane. Below the horizontal axis ($\Delta < 0$): saddles. Above it and below the red parabola: real eigenvalues, hence nodes (stable on the left where $\tau < 0$, unstable on the right). Above the parabola: complex eigenvalues, hence spirals (stable for $\tau < 0$, centers on the line $\tau = 0$, unstable for $\tau > 0$).

Why this matters

Marvel at the economy. Two numbers – the trace and determinant of a 2×2 matrix – predict the entire qualitative fate of an infinite family of trajectories. You need not solve anything to know whether a bridge will settle or shake apart, whether a population will reach equilibrium or oscillate, whether a control system is stable. You compute τ and Δ and read off the answer from one picture. This is the gift of the eigenvalue viewpoint: it converts *dynamics* (hard, time-dependent) into *algebra* (two numbers on a chart).

Walking question

Pause and think: Suppose you compute the determinant of a 2×2 system matrix and get $\Delta = -6$. Can the origin ever be a stable equilibrium? Can it be a spiral? No: the determinant is the product of the eigenvalues, $\Delta = \lambda_1 \lambda_2$. If $\Delta < 0$, the eigenvalues cannot be complex conjugates, because $(\alpha + i\beta)(\alpha - i\beta) = \alpha^2 + \beta^2 \geq 0$. So the eigenvalues must be real with opposite signs: one positive, one negative. Trajectories always move outward along the positive eigen-direction, making the origin an unstable saddle every time.

39.5.2 A spiral, drawn

For concreteness, take $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} -0.3 & -1 \\ 1 & -0.3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. Here $\tau = -0.6$ and $\Delta = 0.09 + 1 = 1.09$, so $\lambda = \frac{1}{2}\left(-0.6 \pm \sqrt{0.36 - 4.36}\right) = -0.3 \pm i$: complex with negative real part, a stable spiral. For $\lambda = -0.3 + i$, the first row of $(A - \lambda I)\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{0}$ reads $-iv_1 - v_2 = 0$, so $\mathbf{v} = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 \\ -i \end{smallmatrix}\right) = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right) + i\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 \\ -1 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. The real and imaginary parts of $e^{-0.3t}(\cos t + i \sin t)\mathbf{v}$ are the two real solutions $e^{-0.3t}\left(\begin{smallmatrix} \cos t \\ \sin t \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ and $e^{-0.3t}\left(\begin{smallmatrix} \sin t \\ -\cos t \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. Every trajectory winds counterclockwise and decays inward to the origin.

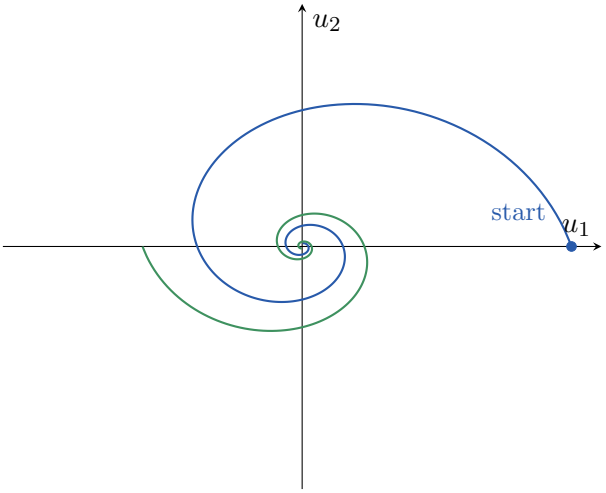


Figure 39.4: A stable spiral: $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} -0.3 & -1 \\ 1 & -0.3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, eigenvalues $-0.3 \pm i$. Rotation comes from the imaginary part $\pm i$; the inward decay comes from the real part -0.3. Two trajectories shown.

39.5.3 A stable node, drawn

For contrast, take the diagonal matrix $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, with eigenvalues -1 and -3 and eigenvectors along the two axes. Both eigenvalues are negative, so every trajectory decays to the origin – a stable node. Because the u_2 component dies three times faster (e^{-3t} versus e^{-t}), trajectories flatten toward the slow axis u_1 as they approach the origin, and that slow direction sets the shape you see near the origin.

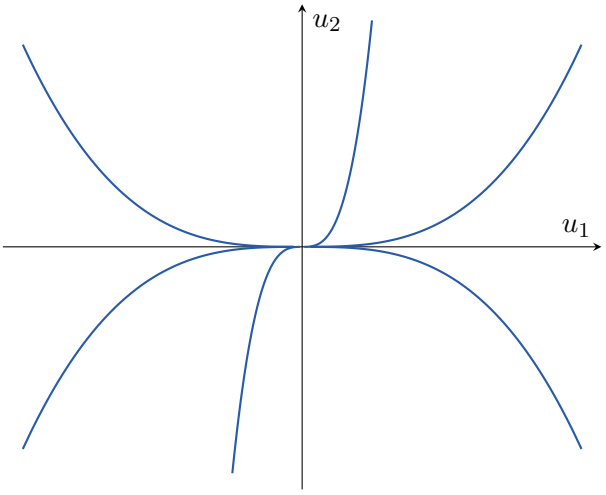


Figure 39.5: A stable node: $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, eigenvalues -1 and -3. Every trajectory decays to the origin. The faster-dying u_2 direction flattens each curve onto the slow u_1 axis before it arrives, so the node is "combed" along u_1.

39.6 Stability: When Does the System Settle?

A point $\mathbf{u}^*$ where $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{u}^*) = \mathbf{0}$ is an **equilibrium** – plant the state dot there and it never moves, because its velocity is zero. For the linear system $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ the origin is always an equilibrium (and the only one, if A is invertible). A fundamental practical question in engineering is: if the system is slightly perturbed from equilibrium, does it return, or does it diverge?

The eigenvalues answer it cleanly. A solution component behaves like $e^{\lambda t}$, which shrinks if the real part of λ is negative and grows if it is positive. Hence:

Theorem 39.2 (Linear stability)**.** *For $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$, the origin is*

- ***asymptotically stable*** *(every trajectory $\to \mathbf{0}$) if and only if* every *eigenvalue of A has negative real part;*
- ***unstable*** *if some eigenvalue has positive real part;*
- ***marginally stable*** *(trajectories stay bounded but need not decay) when no eigenvalue has positive real part and those on the imaginary axis are not repeated, e.g. a center with $\lambda = \pm i\beta$, $\beta \neq 0$. (A repeated eigenvalue on the axis can cause slow growth: $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ has the solution $(t, 1)$.)*

Intuition

The principle is direct: *the system is stable exactly when every growth rate is a decay rate.* One single eigenvalue poking into the right half of the complex plane – one direction in which a perturbation grows – is enough to doom stability, because a real trajectory generically has a nonzero component along every eigen-direction, and the growing one eventually swamps the rest. Stability is unanimity: *all* must decay.

Application

Flight stability and eigenvalue analysis. An aircraft in steady flight is an equilibrium of a system of differential equations governing its pitch, roll, and yaw. Engineers compute the eigenvalues of the linearized dynamics. If all have negative real part, a gust that tips the plane decays away and the plane self-corrects – the *phugoid* mode, a slow, lightly damped oscillation (a stable spiral), is something you can sometimes feel as a gentle porpoising. If an eigenvalue creeps into the right half-plane, the aircraft is unstable and needs a control system (itself adding feedback terms to A, shifting the eigenvalues leftward) to fly at all. Modern fighter jets are deliberately built unstable for agility and are flyable only because a computer moves the eigenvalues thousands of times a second. "Pole placement," as engineers call it, is a core tool of control engineering.

History

The geometric and stability theory of differential equations was forged in the late nineteenth century when classical analytical methods proved insufficient for complex systems. For two hundred years after Newton, mathematicians sought exact algebraic formulas for every moving system. They solved the two-body problem (a single planet orbiting the Sun) with clean Keplerian ellipses, but the three-body problem (the Sun, Earth, and Moon tugging on one

another) defeated every attempt. At the same time, the Industrial Revolution produced high-speed steam engines whose mechanical regulators (governors) suffered from violent, destructive oscillations called "hunting" – machines that shook themselves apart because their feedback loops overcorrected.

Armed only with paper-and-pencil algebra, linear approximations, and perturbation series that often quietly diverged, mathematicians were forced to invent new tools. James Clerk Maxwell opened stability theory in 1868 with "On Governors," analyzing when linear feedback stabilizes an engine. Edward Routh (1876) and Adolf Hurwitz (1895) devised algebraic recipes to test whether all roots of a polynomial have negative real parts without calculating them. In 1892, the Russian mathematician Aleksandr Lyapunov published *The General Problem of the Stability of Motion*, introducing what we now call Lyapunov functions: generalized energy-like functions that prove a system settles back to rest without needing explicit solutions.

A major conceptual development arrived with Henri Poincaré. In 1889, King Oscar II of Sweden sponsored an international prize to determine whether the solar system is stable. Poincaré submitted a memoir claiming a proof and won the gold medal. But while the paper was being typeset for the journal *Acta Mathematica*, the young editor Edvard Phragmén spotted an unexplained gap. Investigating it, Poincaré discovered to his horror that his proof had collapsed: trajectories did not glide smoothly along regular surfaces but crossed each other in an infinite, self-intersecting tangle. Poincaré paid, out of his own pocket, more than the prize was worth to recall and destroy the printed copies of the journal, rewrote the memoir, and in doing so discovered what we now call deterministic chaos.

Poincaré abandoned the hunt for closed-form formulas and founded the modern qualitative theory of dynamical systems: plotting trajectories directly in phase space, classifying equilibria, and tracking geometric flows. Yet the field remains alive with unsolved mysteries. The second half of Hilbert's 16th Problem, posed in 1900, asks for the maximum number and possible relative arrangements of limit cycles (isolated periodic orbits) for polynomial systems $x' = P(x, y)$, $y' = Q(x, y)$. Even for quadratic polynomials (degree two), it remains completely unsolved today.

39.7 A Glimpse Beyond the Linear World

Everything so far rested on linearity – the right-hand side was $A\mathbf{u}$, a matrix times the state. Real systems are usually *nonlinear*: the right-hand side bends. Foxes eating rabbits, the swing of a pendulum at large angles, the weather. We cannot solve these in closed form. But two ideas carry an astonishing distance.

39.7.1 Linearization: zoom in and the curve looks straight

Near an equilibrium $\mathbf{u}^*$, expand the vector field in a Taylor series (the multivariable kind from the partial-derivatives chapters). The constant term vanishes because $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{u}^*) = \mathbf{0}$, and to first order

$$\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{u}^* + \mathbf{h}) \approx J\,\mathbf{h}, \qquad J = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial u_1} & \frac{\partial F_1}{\partial u_2} \\ \frac{\partial F_2}{\partial u_1} & \frac{\partial F_2}{\partial u_2} \end{pmatrix}_{\mathbf{u}^*},$$

where J is the **Jacobian matrix** – a grid of all first partial derivatives that acts as the multivariable best linear approximation, the higher-dimensional version of the single derivative $f'(x)$. So *near an*

equilibrium, a nonlinear system looks like the linear system $\mathbf{h}' = J\mathbf{h}$, and the eigenvalues of J classify the equilibrium just as before.

Why the technique works

This is the deepest reason the linear theory was worth all our effort. A nonlinear vector field, viewed under a strong enough microscope centered on an equilibrium, is indistinguishable from its linearization – exactly as a smooth curve, magnified near a point, becomes its tangent line. The Hartman–Grobman theorem makes this precise: provided no eigenvalue of J sits on the imaginary axis, the nonlinear phase portrait near the equilibrium is a gently warped copy of the linear one. Saddles stay saddles, sinks stay sinks, spirals stay spirals. The whole trace–determinant classification governs nonlinear systems too – locally. Calculus's founding move, "replace the curve by its tangent," returns one last time, now in the shape of replacing a vector field by its Jacobian.

Example 39.2 (The pendulum)**.** The undamped pendulum $\theta'' = -\sin\theta$ becomes the system $x_1' = x_2$, $x_2' = -\sin x_1$ (with $x_1 = \theta$ the angle and $x_2 = \theta'$ the angular velocity). Its Jacobian is $J = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -\cos x_1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. At the bottom-hanging rest state $x_1 = 0$: $J = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, eigenvalues $\pm i$ – a *center*, the pendulum swinging back and forth forever without friction. At the inverted balance point $x_1 = \pi$: $J = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, eigenvalues ± 1 – a *saddle*, unstable, exactly matching the physical fact that balancing a pendulum upright is hopeless: the tiniest nudge runs away along the unstable eigen-direction.

Linearization tells us what happens near each equilibrium, but look at Figure 39.6 to see how the whole space weaves together. The motion is governed by total mechanical energy $E = \frac{1}{2}(\theta')^2 - \cos\theta$. At low energy ($E < 1$), the pendulum is trapped in the potential well, tracing closed blue loops around the center $(0, 0)$ in periodic oscillations. At high energy ($E > 1$), the pendulum has enough momentum to crest the top, whirling endlessly in wavy purple tracks that never reverse direction.

Dividing these two behaviors is a razor-thin boundary curve called the **separatrix** (from the Latin for "divider"), shown in red. The separatrix runs directly between the inverted saddles $(\pm\pi, 0)$ with energy $E = 1$, obeying $\theta' = \pm 2\cos(\theta/2)$. A trajectory launched precisely on the separatrix would coast upward, slowing exponentially and taking an infinite amount of time to come to rest balanced vertically on top.

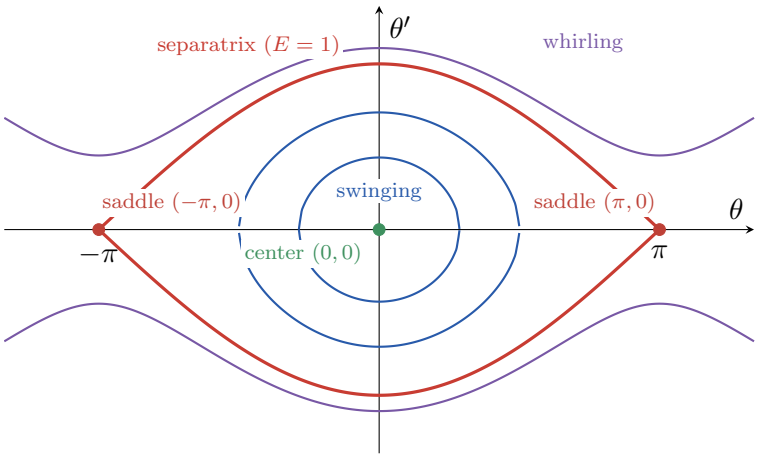


Figure 39.6: Phase portrait of the nonlinear pendulum $\theta'' = -\sin\theta$. Green dot: the stable hanging rest state $(0, 0)$, surrounded by closed blue orbits (periodic swinging). Red dots: unstable inverted balance points $(\pm\pi, 0)$ acting as saddles. The red separatrix divides swinging back and forth from continuous purple whirling over the top.

Walking question

Pause and think: At the bottom rest point $\theta = 0$, the undamped pendulum has eigenvalues $\pm i$ (a center). In a real room with friction, how do the eigenvalues change, and what happens to the phase portrait? Air resistance introduces a velocity drag term $-b\theta'$, which adds $-b$ to the trace. For light damping $(0 < b < 2)$ the eigenvalues become $-b/2 \pm i\sqrt{1 - b^2/4}$, shifting their real part into negative territory. The concentric closed orbits become inward spirals: every swinging pendulum eventually winds down and comes to rest at the bottom.

39.7.2 What linearization cannot see: limit cycles and chaos

Linearization approximates a nonlinear system locally by its tangent dynamics. Globally, nonlinear systems exhibit behaviors that do not appear in linear systems.

A **limit cycle** is an isolated closed loop that nearby trajectories spiral *onto* – a self-sustaining oscillation with its own preferred amplitude, like a heartbeat or the buzz of a violin string. The Van der Pol oscillator $x'' - \mu(1 - x^2)x' + x = 0$ is the classic example; no combination of eigenvectors can produce it, because a linear center has a whole continuum of orbits with no preferred size, while a limit cycle picks out exactly one.

And in three or more dimensions, nonlinear systems can be **chaotic**: trajectories that never repeat, never settle, and depend so sensitively on their starting point that two neighboring states diverge exponentially. The most famous is the Lorenz system,

$$x' = \sigma(y - x), \qquad y' = x(\rho - z) - y, \qquad z' = xy - \beta z,$$

which Edward Lorenz extracted in 1963 from a simplified model of atmospheric convection. Its trajectories are forever drawn toward a geometric object called an **attractor** – a shape in phase space that pulls in all nearby trajectories and traps them, yet on which they wander forever without repeating or crossing. This is the celebrated *Lorenz attractor*, looping around two swirling lobes in an order no formula predicts.

Application

The butterfly effect and the limits of forecasting. Lorenz discovered chaos by accident. Rerunning a weather simulation on his 1960s computer, he typed in a midstream value rounded to three decimals (0.506) instead of the full six the machine stored (0.506127), expecting the exact same forecast. Within simulated weeks the two runs had diverged completely, with nothing in common. That tiny rounding error, amplified by the system's exponential sensitivity, rewrote the future. A 1972 lecture by Lorenz gave the lesson its name, the **butterfly effect**: a butterfly flapping its wings in Brazil might set off a tornado in Texas – not because the flap carries immense energy, but because the atmosphere continually magnifies microscopic differences. Long-range weather prediction is therefore severely constrained in practice, no matter how powerful the computer or how dense the weather sensors.

Why this matters

The Lorenz system separates *determinism* from *predictability*. Nothing in the equations is random: each initial point determines a single, unique trajectory for all time. Yet because nearby trajectories separate exponentially fast, any tiny measurement uncertainty in the starting state grows until it covers the whole attractor. Exact laws do not guarantee long-range forecasts when initial measurements have finite precision.

39.8 Where to Go Next

This chapter sits at the frontier of what a first calculus book can cover. Three roads lead onward, and you are now equipped to walk all of them.

Partial differential equations. Every system here had a single independent variable, time, so the unknowns were functions of t alone – *ordinary* differential equations. But heat spreads through a *rod*, varying in both position and time; a drumhead vibrates across a *surface*; a quantum wavefunction fills *space*. These obey **partial** differential equations, where the unknown depends on several variables and *partial* derivatives appear – the heat equation $\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = k\,\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2}$, the wave equation, Laplace's equation, the Schrödinger equation. The partial derivatives of the multivariable chapters and the series of the Taylor chapters (Fourier series, their cousin) are exactly the tools that crack them open.

Numerical methods. Almost no differential equation arising in practice can be solved by a formula. We solve them by *marching*: from the state now, the equation gives the velocity now, so we step a tiny Δt forward and repeat. The crudest version is Euler's method, $\mathbf{u}_{n+1} = \mathbf{u}_n + \Delta t\,\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{u}_n)$; the standard tool is the fourth-order Runge–Kutta method, which samples the slope four times per step to cancel error. Every weather forecast, climate model, spacecraft trajectory, and animated-film cloth simulation is a differential equation being marched forward by a computer.

Dynamical systems. The phase-portrait, stability, and chaos ideas we touched are the doorway to a vast modern field – bifurcations (where an equilibrium suddenly changes character as a parameter crosses a threshold), strange attractors, ergodic theory, and the geometry of flows.

Connection

Notice how completely linear algebra and calculus have fused by the end of this book. We began with the slope of one curve; we end with the eigenvalues of a matrix dictating the fate of a whole flowing space. The two subjects are not neighbors but the same subject seen from two sides: calculus is linear algebra done to functions and rates, linear algebra is the skeleton calculus hangs on. If this chapter sent you hunting through the companion *Linear Algebra From the Ground Up* for eigenvalues, diagonalization, and the matrix exponential e^{At} (which packages *all* solutions of $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ into a single object $\mathbf{u}(t) = e^{At}\mathbf{u}(0)$), then the two books have done together what neither could alone.

Pause

Looking back at the progression, we expressed coupled equations in matrix form $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ and tested $e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}$, leading directly to the eigenvalue problem $A\mathbf{v} = \lambda\mathbf{v}$ whose eigenvectors decouple the system into scalar components. Next, we drew the flow as a phase portrait, classified it by trace and determinant, and read stability from the signs of the eigenvalue real parts. Finally, we saw how Jacobians linearize nonlinear systems locally before global phenomena such as limit cycles and chaos take over.

Where to go next in this volume. Two appendices close the book. The first reviews the algebraic identities, inequalities, absolute-value geometry, functions, and proof techniques (direct proof, contradiction, and induction) used throughout the text. The second develops the completeness of the real numbers – the least-upper-bound axiom that underpins every existence theorem in calculus.

39.9 Exercises

Exercise 39.1 (Reduce to a system)**.** Convert each higher-order equation to a first-order system $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$ (or $\mathbf{x}' = \mathbf{F}(\mathbf{x})$ if nonlinear), naming your new variables explicitly. (a) $y'' - 3y' + 2y = 0$. (b) $y''' = y$. (c) $y'' + \sin y = 0$. For (a), write down the companion matrix and state its trace and determinant.

Exercise 39.2 (Eigen-solve a system)**.** For $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, find the eigenvalues and eigenvectors, write the general solution of $\mathbf{u}' = A\mathbf{u}$, and find the particular solution with $\mathbf{u}(0) = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 \\ 3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. Classify the origin.

Exercise 39.3 (A saddle)**.** The matrix $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ has eigenvalues 4 and -2. Find the eigenvectors and sketch the phase portrait by hand, marking the stable and unstable directions and the flow along each.

Exercise 39.4 (Complex eigenvalues)**.** For $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & -2 \\ 2 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, show the eigenvalues are $\pm 2i$. What kind of equilibrium is the origin? Without solving, describe the shape of every trajectory. Then verify that $u_1 = \cos 2t$, $u_2 = \sin 2t$ is a solution.

Exercise 39.5 (Trace–determinant reading)**.** For each matrix, compute τ and Δ and classify the origin (stable/unstable node, saddle, stable/unstable spiral, or center) *without* finding the eigenvectors. (a) $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. (b) $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} -1 & 4 \\ -1 & -1 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. (c) $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. (d) $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -4 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$.

Exercise 39.6 (Stability hinges on a parameter)**.** Consider $A = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} -1 & 1 \\ -1 & k \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ with k a real parameter. Compute the trace and determinant, and find the range of k for which the origin is asymptotically stable. What happens at the value of k where stability is lost?

Exercise 39.7 (Damped oscillator, both ways)**.** Return to $y'' + 2y' + 5y = 0$ from Example 39.1. (a) Find the eigenvalues of the companion matrix. (b) Confirm they are complex with negative real part, and say what kind of equilibrium and what physical behavior this predicts. (c) Relate the real and imaginary parts of the eigenvalues to the decay rate and oscillation frequency of the solution.

Exercise 39.8 (Linearize a nonlinear system)**.** The system $x' = x(3 - x - y)$, $y' = y(2 - x)$ models two competing species. (a) Find all equilibria (there are three, including one in the interior with both populations positive). (b) Compute the Jacobian J at the interior equilibrium. (c) Find its eigenvalues and classify that equilibrium. Is coexistence stable?

Exercise 39.9 (Pendulum equilibria)**.** Using Example 39.2, add light damping: $x_1' = x_2$, $x_2' = -\sin x_1 - 0.2\, x_2$. Recompute the Jacobian at the hanging rest state $(0, 0)$. How do its eigenvalues differ from the undamped case, and what does the change predict about the pendulum's motion?

Exercise 39.10 (Conceptual: why eigenvectors?)**.** In your own words, explain why guessing a solution of the form $\mathbf{u}(t) = e^{\lambda t}\mathbf{v}$ forces $\mathbf{v}$ to be an eigenvector of A. Then explain why a 2×2 system with two independent eigenvectors has *exactly* the right number of free constants to match any initial condition.

Exercise 39.11 (A taste of chaos, by hand)**.** You cannot solve the Lorenz system, but you can march it. With $\sigma = 10$, $\rho = 28$, $\beta = 8/3$, and step $\Delta t = 0.01$, do *three* Euler steps starting from $(x, y, z) = (1, 1, 1)$, reporting all coordinates each step. Then repeat from $(1.001, 1, 1)$. Comment on how the two runs compare after three steps – and explain why, after a few thousand steps, they would have nothing in common.

Part IX

Mathematical Background

Chapter 40

Appendix: Algebra, Functions, and Proof

Calculus does not begin from nothing. Every limit, derivative, and integral in this book leans on a quieter layer underneath: the algebra of rearranging expressions, the laws of exponents, inequalities and absolute values, durable facts about functions, and the habit of proving that a step is true. This appendix gathers these fundamentals in one place — the reference to return to whenever a calculation in the main text seems puzzling.

The spirit here is the same as the rest of the book. We will not just list rules. We will ask *why* each rule holds, draw the picture that makes it obvious, and point out the traps where good students reliably slip. By the end you should feel that none of this is arbitrary: the exponent laws are forced on us once we decide what a^n should mean; the rules for inequalities follow from one plain fact about the number line; and a proof is an explanation that happens to be airtight.

Focus

Three things to carry away from this appendix:

1. Algebraic identities (factoring, exponent laws, the binomial pattern) are not arbitrary formulas to memorize — each is forced by a single defining idea, and once you see the idea you can reconstruct the rule.
2. Inequalities and absolute values are the native language of calculus (limits, error bounds, convergence). The one rule everyone forgets — multiplying by a negative flips the sign — has a clean reason.
3. A proof is an explanation with no gaps. Direct proof, proof by contradiction, and induction are three reliable shapes that explanation can take.

40.1 Numbers, and the Ground We Stand On

Before algebra there are the numbers algebra rearranges. We use a nested tower of number systems, each built to fix a shortcoming of the last:

$$\mathbb{N} \subset \mathbb{Z} \subset \mathbb{Q} \subset \mathbb{R} \subset \mathbb{C}.$$

The naturals $\mathbb{N} = \{1, 2, 3, \ldots\}$ count discrete items. The integers $\mathbb{Z} = \{\ldots, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, \ldots\}$ add the ability to subtract freely. The rationals $\mathbb{Q}$ — ratios p/q of integers with $q \neq 0$ — add the ability to divide. The reals $\mathbb{R}$ fill in the gaps between rationals so that the number line has no holes (a number like $\sqrt{2}$ or π lives here but not in $\mathbb{Q}$). The complex numbers $\mathbb{C}$ add a square root of -1. Calculus lives almost entirely in $\mathbb{R}$, and the "no holes" property of $\mathbb{R}$ — its *completeness* (the guarantee that the number line has no missing gaps or punctures, so every sequence of numbers squeezing closer together actually lands on an existing real number) — is what makes limits behave; that deeper story has its own dedicated appendix.

History

The language of algebra, number systems, and formal proof was not handed down fully formed; it was hammered out across two millennia of mathematical confusion, philosophical resistance, and hard-fought breakthroughs.

Ancient and medieval mathematicians worked without modern symbolic notation. In the third century CE, the Greek mathematician Diophantus of Alexandria solved algebraic equations using words and abbreviations, but he dismissed an equation like $4x + 20 = 4$ as "absurd" because it demanded a negative answer. Around 825 CE, the Persian scholar Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarizmi wrote *al-Kitab al-mukhtasar fi hisab al-jabr wa'l-muqabala* ("The Compendious Book on Calculation by Restoration and Balancing"). The word *al-jabr* (restoration, meaning moving a subtracted quantity to the opposite side of an equation to make it positive) gave us our word *algebra*. Al-Khwarizmi and his contemporaries solved quadratics by literal geometric cut-and-paste dissections of physical squares, but they avoided negative quantities entirely because a square cannot have a negative side length.

For centuries, negative numbers remained mathematical outcasts. As late as the seventeenth century, René Descartes termed negative polynomial roots "false roots" (*racines fausses*), and Blaise Pascal dismissed subtracting 4 from 0, arguing that "nothing can be less than nothing" in nature. It was not until John Wallis popularized the geometric number line in 1685 — interpreting positive and negative numbers as directed steps right and left from an origin — that negative quantities gained an intuitive home.

Meanwhile, the transition from words to symbols sparked its own revolution. In 1591, François Viète introduced the decisive convention of using letters for both unknowns and known parameters, transforming algebra from a catalog of rhetorical recipes into a universal symbolic language. But this newfound symbolic power outpaced its logical foundations. During the early development of calculus, mathematicians manipulated infinitesimals, cancelled vanishing factors, and summed divergent series purely formally, prompting Bishop George Berkeley in *The Analyst* (1734) to criticize dividing by increments $\mathrm{d}x \neq 0$ that were subsequently discarded as zero. Manipulating formulas without clear definitions frequently led to contradictions, such as bogus derivations that $1 = 2$ or that $1 - 1 + 1 - 1 + \cdots = 1/2$.

The crisis forced a nineteenth-century reckoning. Augustin-Louis Cauchy, Karl Weierstrass, and Richard Dedekind dismantled the vague geometric intuitions of calculus and rebuilt the subject on an explicit framework of inequalities, real-number completeness, and rigorous deductive proof. Mathematical induction, pioneered by Pascal and formalized by Giuseppe Peano, gave mathematicians an unbreakable chain of logic to tame infinity. Together, symbolic algebra and deductive proof gave modern science a precise language for deriving and checking predictions about planetary orbits, quantum wavefunctions, and fluid dynamics.

Yet the boundary between symbolic manipulation and truth remains an active frontier. In 1931, Kurt Gödel proved his revolutionary incompleteness theorems (showing that any con-

sistent, mechanically checkable system of axioms strong enough for basic arithmetic contains true statements that cannot be proved using the system's own rules). In our own time, the quest for absolute certainty has entered the digital age: automated theorem provers (software systems like Lean and Coq that verify proofs step by step down to fundamental logical axioms) are actively re-checking major mathematical libraries, while central questions like the Birch and Swinnerton-Dyer conjecture remain open.

Intuition

Picture the real line as an infinitely long, perfectly smooth ruler. Every point on it is a real number, and every real number sits at exactly one point. The rationals are dense — between any two of them there is another — yet they leave gaps you cannot see but can prove are there. The reals are what you get when you plug every gap. Most of calculus is the art of saying precise things about points sitting infinitely close together on this ruler.

The arithmetic of $\mathbb{R}$ obeys a short list of field axioms — the ground rules governing how numbers add and multiply. Addition and multiplication are commutative and associative with identities 0 and 1, every number has an additive inverse $-a$ (canceling it to zero), and every nonzero number has a multiplicative inverse $1/a$ (scaling it to one). Connecting the two operations, multiplication distributes over addition:

$$a(b+c) = ab + ac.$$

That last law, the *distributive law*, is the single most overworked fact in all of algebra. Expanding brackets, factoring, multiplying polynomials, the binomial theorem — all of it is the distributive law applied again and again.

What is really happening

When you "expand $3(x+2)$ to get $3x+6$" and when you "factor $3x+6$ back to $3(x+2)$" you are doing the exact same equation read in two directions: $a(b+c) = ab+ac$. Expanding goes left to right; factoring goes right to left. This is why factoring feels harder — running a rule *backwards* means searching for the inputs that would have produced what you see, and search is always harder than evaluation.

40.2 Algebraic Manipulation: Expanding and Factoring

40.2.1 Multiplying out

To multiply two sums, distribute every term of the first across every term of the second. For two binomials this is the familiar pattern (sometimes taught as "FOIL," though the name hides the principle):

$$(a+b)(c+d) = ac + ad + bc + bd.$$

Each term on the right is one term from the first factor times one term from the second; we collect every such pairing. There is nothing special about two terms. $(a+b)(c+d+e)$ produces six products, one for each (left term, right term) pair.

The identities worth knowing cold are the ones that appear constantly in calculus, especially when rationalizing or simplifying difference quotients:

$$(a+b)^2 = a^2 + 2ab + b^2, \tag{40.1}$$
$$(a-b)^2 = a^2 - 2ab + b^2, \tag{40.2}$$
$$(a+b)(a-b) = a^2 - b^2, \tag{40.3}$$
$$(a+b)^3 = a^3 + 3a^2b + 3ab^2 + b^3. \tag{40.4}$$

The difference of squares (40.3) is especially useful: it is the basis for multiplying by a conjugate, which you meet the very first time you compute a limit like $\lim_{x\to 0}(\sqrt{x+1}-1)/x$.

Why the technique works

Why is $(a+b)^2 = a^2 + 2ab + b^2$ and *not* $a^2 + b^2$? Because squaring a sum is not the same as summing the squares — the cross terms are real. Run the distributive law all the way out:

$$(a+b)^2 = (a+b)(a+b) = a\cdot a + a\cdot b + b\cdot a + b\cdot b = a^2 + 2ab + b^2.$$

The middle $2ab$ is the two "mixed" pairings ab and ba. Forgetting it is probably the single most common algebra error in all of calculus, and the picture below shows exactly what it is.

The cross term is not abstract. It is literally the two rectangles you get when you enlarge a square.

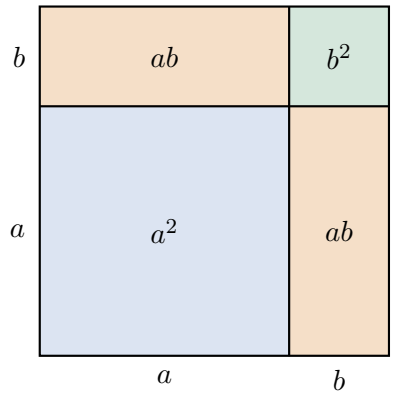


Figure 40.1: The square on side $a+b$ has area $(a+b)^2$. Cut it into four pieces: the a-square, the b-square, and *two* $a\times b$ rectangles. That is why $(a+b)^2 = a^2+2ab+b^2$ — the $2ab$ is the two orange rectangles, the part people forget.

40.2.2 Factoring: running the machine backwards

Factoring rewrites a sum as a product. It matters because a product is zero exactly when one of its factors is zero (the *zero-product property*), which is how we solve equations, and because a factored expression often lets a troublesome common factor cancel — the heart of computing limits of the indeterminate form $0/0$.

The basic moves, in rough order of how often you need them:

(1) Pull out a common factor.

$$6x^3 - 9x^2 = 3x^2(2x - 3).$$

Look for the largest factor shared by every term and lift it out front.

(2) Difference of squares.

$$x^2 - 25 = (x - 5)(x + 5), \qquad x^4 - 1 = (x^2 - 1)(x^2 + 1) = (x - 1)(x + 1)(x^2 + 1).$$

(3) Quadratic trinomials. To factor $x^2 + bx + c$, find two numbers that *multiply to* c *and add to* b. For $x^2 + 7x + 12$ we want a pair with product 12 and sum 7: that is 3 and 4, so

$$x^2 + 7x + 12 = (x + 3)(x + 4).$$

(4) Sum and difference of cubes.

$$a^3 - b^3 = (a - b)(a^2 + ab + b^2), \qquad a^3 + b^3 = (a + b)(a^2 - ab + b^2).$$

Common trap

There is no real factoring of a *sum* of squares: $a^2 + b^2$ does not factor over the reals (you need complex numbers). Students who just factored $a^2 - b^2$ often write $a^2 + b^2 = (a + b)(a - b)$ out of momentum — but expanding that gives $a^2 - b^2$, the wrong sign. The difference factors; the sum does not.

Example 40.1 (Factoring to resolve a 0/0 limit)**.** Consider $\dfrac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3}$ as $x \to 3$. Plugging in $x = 3$ gives 0/0, which says nothing yet. Factor the top as a difference of squares:

$$\frac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3} = \frac{(x - 3)(x + 3)}{x - 3} = x + 3 \quad (x \neq 3).$$

The offending factor $x - 3$ cancels, and the simplified expression $x + 3$ tends to 6 as $x \to 3$. The 0/0 indeterminacy came from a single shared factor $(x - 3)$, which factoring exposed and cancelled.

Common trap

The danger of formal cancellation without domain vigilance. Algebraic formulas manipulate symbols blindly unless you track domain restrictions. Consider the famous bogus "proof" that $1 = 2$: Start with $a = b$. Multiply by a to get $a^2 = ab$. Subtract b^2 from both sides: $a^2 - b^2 = ab - b^2$. Factor both sides: $(a - b)(a + b) = b(a - b)$. Now cancel the common factor $(a - b)$: $a + b = b$. Since $a = b$, this says $2b = b$, so dividing by b gives $2 = 1$.
Where did the reasoning derail? At the cancellation step: because $a = b$, the factor $a - b$ is identically 0. Dividing both sides by zero destroyed the equation. In calculus, when we write $\lim_{x\to 3} \frac{x^2-9}{x-3} = \lim_{x\to 3}(x + 3)$, the cancellation is valid precisely because the limit process considers values of x arbitrarily close to 3, but *never* $x = 3$. Hence $x - 3 \neq 0$ throughout the approach.

Walking question

Try factoring $2x^2 + x - 6$. (Hint: look for two numbers multiplying to $2 \cdot (-6) = -12$ and adding to 1; they are 4 and -3. Split the middle term: $2x^2+4x-3x-6 = 2x(x+2)-3(x+2) = (2x-3)(x+2)$.) The technique of "splitting the middle term" turns a hard trinomial into two easy common-factor pulls.

40.2.3 The quadratic formula, and completing the square

Not every quadratic factors with nice integers. For *any* quadratic $ax^2 + bx + c = 0$ with $a \neq 0$, the solutions are

$$x = \frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a}.$$

This is not handed down from the sky — it comes from *completing the square*, a technique worth seeing in full because the same maneuver reappears in integration (trig substitution) and in finding vertices of parabolas.

Why the technique works

Start from $ax^2 + bx + c = 0$. Divide by a and move the constant:

$$x^2 + \tfrac{b}{a}x = -\tfrac{c}{a}.$$

The left side is *almost* a perfect square. The square $(x + \frac{b}{2a})^2$ expands to $x^2 + \frac{b}{a}x + \frac{b^2}{4a^2}$, so add $\frac{b^2}{4a^2}$ to both sides to complete it:

$$\left(x + \tfrac{b}{2a}\right)^2 = \frac{b^2}{4a^2} - \frac{c}{a} = \frac{b^2 - 4ac}{4a^2}.$$

Now take square roots (the square root of the denominator gives $\sqrt{4a^2} = 2|a|$, and absorbing the absolute value into the $\pm$ leaves the familiar $2a$) and solve for x:

$$x + \frac{b}{2a} = \pm\frac{\sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a} \implies x = \frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a}.$$

The quadratic formula is just completing the square done once, symbolically, so you never have to repeat the algebra by hand.

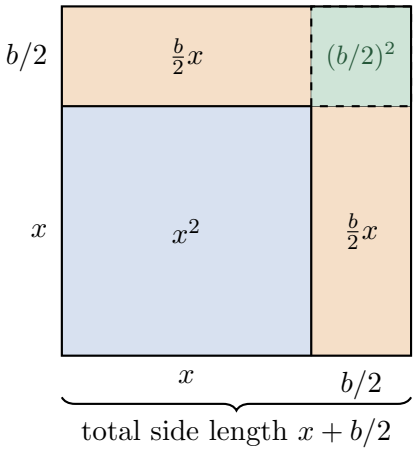


Figure 40.2: Completing the square seen as physical geometry. To make x^2+bx into a perfect square, divide the rectangular area bx into two equal strips of width $b/2$ and place them along the right and top edges of the $x \times x$ square. The resulting L-shape is missing only the small top-right corner of area $(b/2)^2$ (green, dashed). Adding this missing piece completes a perfect square of total side $x + b/2$ and area $(x + b/2)^2$.

Connection

The technique of completing the square is literally geometric. Four thousand years ago, Babylonian scribes solved quadratic problems by cutting and rearranging physical areas. When al-Khwarizmi solved $x^2 + 10x = 39$ in 825 CE, he drew a square of side x and two rectangles of width 5, placed them along the sides of the square, and noted that the entire shape was short of a full square by a small corner of area $5^2 = 25$. Adding 25 to both sides completed the square: $(x + 5)^2 = 39 + 25 = 64$, immediately yielding $x + 5 = 8$, so $x = 3$. Figure 40.2 shows this exact cut-and-paste maneuver.

The quantity $b^2 - 4ac$ under the root is the *discriminant* (the quantity that discriminates, or distinguishes, among the different types of solutions). If it is positive there are two distinct real roots; if zero, one repeated real root; if negative, no real roots (the parabola never touches the x-axis) and the solutions are a pair of complex conjugates.

40.3 Exponents and Their Laws

40.3.1 Where the laws come from

For a positive integer n, a^n means "multiply a by itself n times." From this single definition every exponent law follows by counting factors. Take $a^m \cdot a^n$: that is m copies of a times n copies of a, which is $m + n$ copies. Hence

$$a^m \cdot a^n = a^{m+n}.$$

There is nothing to memorize; you are just counting how many a's stand in the line. The same counting gives the rest:

$$a^m \cdot a^n = a^{m+n}, \qquad \frac{a^m}{a^n} = a^{m-n}, \tag{40.5}$$

$$(a^m)^n = a^{mn}, \qquad (ab)^n = a^n b^n, \tag{40.6}$$

$$\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)^n = \frac{a^n}{b^n}. \tag{40.7}$$

What is really happening

Every exponent law stems from the fundamental identity $a^{m+n} = a^m a^n$, which reflects how exponentiation turns addition (in the exponent) into multiplication (of the values). $(a^m)^n = a^{mn}$ is repeated addition of exponents: n copies of m. This addition-becomes-multiplication structure is exactly what makes the exponential function e^x so central in calculus — it is the function that converts the additive world of inputs into the multiplicative world of outputs, and, up to a constant multiple, it is the only function that is its own derivative.

40.3.2 Extending to zero, negatives, and fractions

The definition "multiply a by itself n times" only makes sense for positive integer n. So what could a^0, a^{-3}, or $a^{1/2}$ possibly mean? One principle settles all three cases at once: *we extend the definition in the only way that keeps the law $a^m a^n = a^{m+n}$ true.* The laws are not re-proved for the new cases; they are the very thing we insist on preserving, and that insistence forces a unique answer.

Zero exponent. We need $a^0 \cdot a^n = a^{0+n} = a^n$. Dividing by a^n (for $a \neq 0$) forces

$$a^0 = 1.$$

Negative exponent. We need $a^{-n} \cdot a^n = a^0 = 1$, so a^{-n} must be the reciprocal:

$$a^{-n} = \frac{1}{a^n}.$$

Fractional exponent. Take $a > 0$ and a positive integer n. We need $\left(a^{1/n}\right)^n = a^{(1/n)\cdot n} = a^1 = a$, so $a^{1/n}$ must be the positive number whose nth power is a — the nth root:

$$a^{1/n} = \sqrt[n]{a}, \qquad a^{m/n} = \left(\sqrt[n]{a}\right)^m = \sqrt[n]{a^m} \qquad (a > 0).$$

The restriction $a > 0$ matters. For $a < 0$ an even root is not a real number, and the exponent laws break: $\left((-1)^2\right)^{1/2} = 1$, while $(-1)^{2\cdot\frac{1}{2}} = -1$.

Why the technique works

This move is worth dwelling on, because mathematics repeats it constantly. The expression $a^{1/2}$ has *no* prior meaning — you cannot multiply a by itself "half a time." We *define* it. But we do not define it by whim: we choose the one value that lets the exponent law survive. That demand pins it down uniquely to $\sqrt{a}$. Mathematics grows by exactly this method: take a rule that holds in a small world, then extend the world in whatever way keeps the rule intact. The

same logic later defines a^x for irrational x, $0! = 1$, and $e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta$.

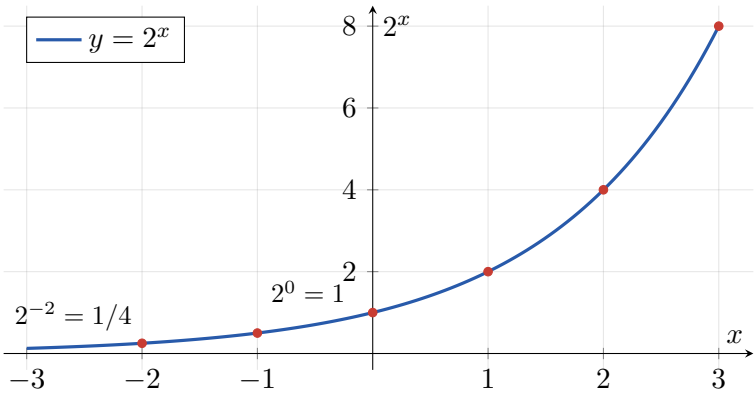


Figure 40.3: The exponential 2^x knits the integer powers (red dots) into a smooth curve. Negative exponents give reciprocals ($2^{-2} = \frac{1}{4}$), the zero exponent gives 1, and fractional exponents fill in everything between. The values for non-integer x are precisely the ones that keep $2^{m+n} = 2^m 2^n$ holding for all real m, n.

Common trap

The exponent laws govern *products with a shared base*, not sums and not mixed bases. All of the following are wrong:

$$a^m + a^n \neq a^{m+n}, \qquad (a+b)^n \neq a^n + b^n, \qquad \sqrt{a^2+b^2} \neq a + b.$$

The last is the same error as the missing cross term in $(a+b)^2$. There is no law that simplifies $a^m + a^n$ in general — the laws live on the multiplicative side only. Whenever you are tempted to "distribute" an exponent across a sum, stop: exponents distribute over products, never over sums.

Pause

Pause and think: Why is $(-2)^4 = 16$, but $-2^4 = -16$? By standard order of operations, exponentiation binds tighter than negation. In $(-2)^4$, the parentheses bundle the negative sign into the base: $(-2)(-2)(-2)(-2) = +16$. In -2^4, the power $2^4 = 16$ is computed first, and the minus sign is placed out front, giving -16. A missing set of parentheses in a derivative computation is one of the most common ways to accidentally flip a sign and derail an entire solution.

40.4 Inequalities

Equations ask *where* two things are equal; inequalities ask *which is bigger*. Calculus runs on inequalities far more than on equations: the definition of a limit is an inequality ($|f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$), comparison tests for series are inequalities, error bounds are inequalities. So fluency here pays off everywhere.

The order relation $<$ on $\mathbb{R}$ obeys a handful of rules. Most are unsurprising, but one is the famous trap.

Focus

Rules for inequalities. For real numbers,

- **Add anything:** if $a < b$ then $a + c < b + c$ (for any c).
- **Multiply by a positive:** if $a < b$ and $c > 0$ then $ac < bc$.
- **Multiply by a negative — FLIP:** if $a < b$ and $c < 0$ then $ac > bc$.
- **Transitivity:** if $a < b$ and $b < c$ then $a < c$.
- **Reciprocal of positives flips:** if $0 < a < b$ then $\frac{1}{a} > \frac{1}{b}$.

Why the technique works

Why does multiplying by a negative *flip* the inequality? Picture the number line. The statement $a < b$ means a sits to the left of b. Multiplying every number by -1 is a *reflection of the line through* 0: left and right swap. So whatever was on the left (a) lands on the right, and the order reverses. More algebraically: $a < b$ means $b - a > 0$, i.e. $b - a$ is positive. Multiply a positive number by a negative c and you get a negative: $c(b - a) < 0$, that is $cb - ca < 0$, i.e. $cb < ca$, i.e. $ca > cb$. The flip is forced.

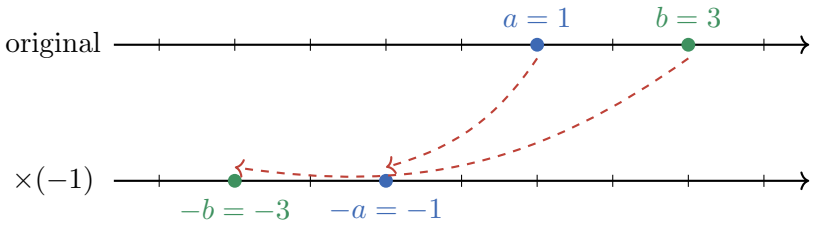


Figure 40.4: Multiplying by -1 reflects the line through 0. The blue point $a = 1$ was left of the green $b = 3$; after reflection $-a = -1$ is to the *right* of $-b = -3$. The order has flipped: $1 < 3$ but $-1 > -3$.

Common trap

The flip rule is the most common source of wrong inequality answers. When you divide both sides of $-2x < 6$ by -2, you must reverse: $x > -3$, *not* $x < -3$. A safe habit: never multiply or divide an inequality by a quantity whose sign you do not know. If you must divide by something like $x - 1$, split into cases $x > 1$ and $x < 1$ and handle each separately.

Example 40.2 (Solving a rational inequality the safe way)**.** Solve $\dfrac{x+1}{x-2} \geq 0$. Do *not* cross-multiply — you do not know the sign of $x - 2$. Instead find where each factor is zero or undefined: the numerator vanishes at $x = -1$, the denominator at $x = 2$ (where the expression is undefined). These split the line into three regions. Test one point in each:

region	$x < -1$	$-1 < x < 2$	$x > 2$
sign of $\frac{x+1}{x-2}$	$(-)/(-) = +$	$(+)/(-) = -$	$(+)/(+) = +$

So the expression is ≥ 0 on $x \leq -1$ and $x > 2$ (including $x = -1$ where it equals 0, excluding $x = 2$ where it is undefined). The solution is $(-\infty, -1] \cup (2, \infty)$.

The whole method is a *sign chart*: mark the points where the expression is zero or undefined, then record the sign in each gap. Figure 40.5 shows it at a glance.

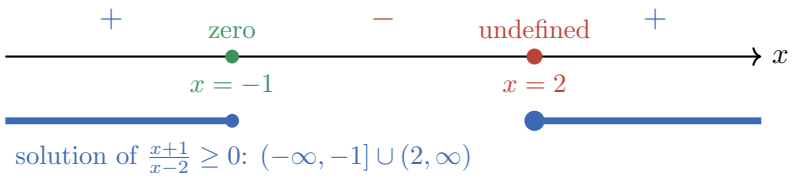


Figure 40.5: Sign chart for $\frac{x+1}{x-2}$. The two critical points — the zero at $x = -1$ (filled, included) and the undefined point at $x = 2$ (open, excluded) — cut the line into three regions. One test point per region fixes the sign there. The heavy blue segments below the axis are the solution set, where the fraction is ≥ 0.

40.5 Absolute Value: Distance Made Algebraic

The absolute value $|x|$ is defined by cases,

$$|x| = \begin{cases} x, & x \geq 0, \\ -x, & x < 0, \end{cases}$$

but the case split hides the real idea, which is geometric:

Intuition

$|x|$ is the *distance from x to 0* on the number line, and more generally $|x - a|$ is the *distance between x and a*. The two cases just say "distance is never negative; if the number is already to the right of 0 its distance is itself, and if it is to the left we negate to make it positive." Read every absolute value as a distance and most manipulations become obvious.

This distance reading immediately explains how absolute-value inequalities unfold:

$$|x - a| < r \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad a - r < x < a + r,$$

"x is within r of a," an *interval* centered at a with radius r. And the opposite,

$$|x - a| > r \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad x < a - r \ \text{ or } \ x > a + r,$$

"x is farther than r from a," the *outside* of that interval.

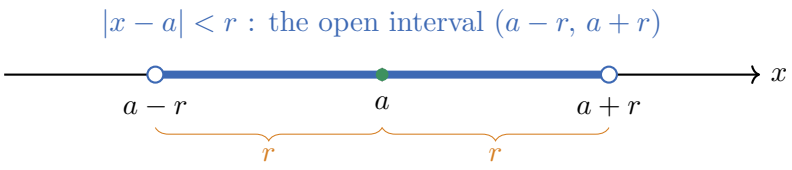


Figure 40.6: $|x - a| < r$ reads as "x is within distance r of a," so the solution set is the open interval $(a - r, a + r)$ — a fixed center a with a radius r in each direction. This exact picture is the geometry behind the ε–δ definition of a limit.

Connection

This inequality structure defines a limit in calculus. The statement $\lim_{x\to a} f(x) = L$ unpacks to: for every tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a $\delta > 0$ so that $|x - a| < \delta$ forces $|f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$. Both halves are absolute-value inequalities, i.e. "within distance" statements: *whenever x is within δ of a, $f(x)$ is within ε of L.* Figure 40.6 is, quite literally, the inner machinery of the central definition of calculus.

Pause

Pause and think: If an error tolerance is written as $|x - 5| < 0.02$, what is the nominal target value, and what is the allowable range for x? The nominal target is the center $a = 5$, and the maximum allowable error is the radius $r = 0.02$. The allowable range is the open interval $(5 - 0.02,\ 5 + 0.02) = (4.98,\ 5.02)$. Reading $|x - a| < r$ as "the distance from x to a is less than r" lets you write down intervals instantly on the number line without fumbling through formal case splits.

Two algebraic properties of the absolute value are used constantly throughout analysis.

Focus

Useful identities.

$$|xy| = |x|\,|y|, \qquad |x|^2 = x^2, \qquad \sqrt{x^2} = |x|.$$

The triangle inequality. For all real (indeed all complex) x, y,

$$|x + y| \le |x| + |y|.$$

The triangle inequality turns up more than any other inequality in analysis. Its name comes from the picture in the plane: the straight side of a triangle is no longer than the sum of the other two sides. On the line it says that walking from 0 to x and then on to $x+y$ is never shorter than walking straight from 0 to $x + y$.

Why the technique works

Here is a clean proof of the triangle inequality. For any real t, $-|t| \le t \le |t|$ (a number lies between $\pm$ its size). Apply this to x and to y and add:

$$-|x| \le x \le |x|, \qquad -|y| \le y \le |y|$$

add the left and right ends:

$$-(|x| + |y|) \le x + y \le |x| + |y|.$$

A statement of the form $-c \le s \le c$ (with $c \ge 0$) is exactly $|s| \le c$. With $s = x + y$ and $c = |x| + |y|$ this reads $|x + y| \le |x| + |y|$. Done. The whole proof is the single observation that every number is sandwiched by $\pm$ its absolute value.

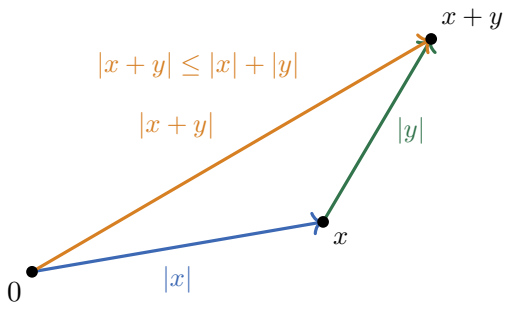


Figure 40.7: Geometry of the triangle inequality: the straight-line displacement $|x + y|$ from the origin to $x + y$ is never longer than the detour $|x| + |y|$ visiting x along the way. Equality holds if and only if x and y point in the exact same direction.

40.6 Functions: The Facts Calculus Leans On

Functions get a full chapter early in the book; here we collect, for reference, the handful of facts the later chapters use without re-deriving.

A function $f\colon D \to \mathbb{R}$ assigns to each input x in its domain D *exactly one* output $f(x)$. The "exactly one" is the defining demand — it is what the *vertical line test* checks on a graph: a curve is the graph of a function precisely when no vertical line meets it twice (which would mean a single input generates multiple outputs).

Composition. $(g \circ f)(x) = g(f(x))$: do f first, then feed the result to g. Order matters; $g \circ f$ and $f \circ g$ are usually completely different functions. The chain rule is the derivative of a composition, so composition is not a curiosity — it is half of differential calculus.

Inverse functions. f^{-1} undoes f: $f^{-1}(f(x)) = x$ and $f(f^{-1}(y)) = y$. An inverse exists exactly when f is *one-to-one* (each output comes from only one input), which the *horizontal line test* checks (verifying that no horizontal line meets the graph twice, which would mean two different inputs collide on the same output). The graph of f^{-1} is the graph of f reflected across the diagonal line $y = x$, because inverting swaps the roles of input and output, i.e. swaps the coordinates $(x, y) \mapsto (y, x)$.

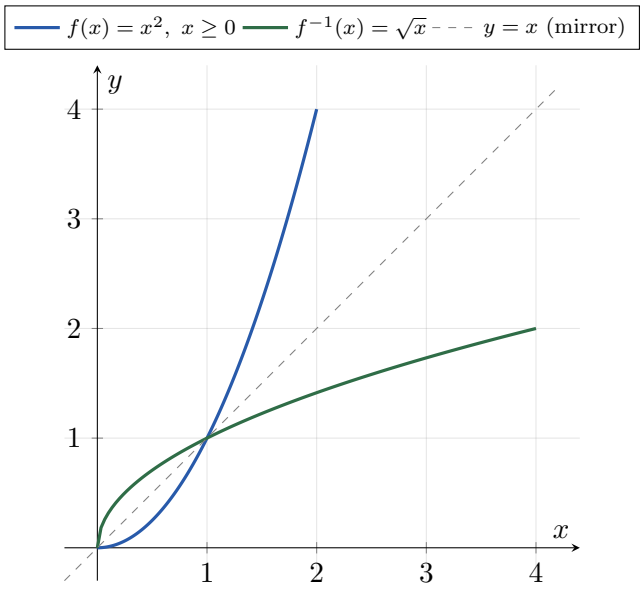


Figure 40.8: A function and its inverse are mirror images across the line $y = x$. Here $f(x) = x^2$ (restricted to $x \geq 0$ so it is one-to-one) and $f^{-1}(x) = \sqrt{x}$. Reflecting across $y = x$ swaps the x- and y-axes, which is exactly the algebra of solving $y = x^2$ for x.

Even and odd symmetry. f is *even* if $f(-x) = f(x)$ (graph symmetric across the y-axis, like x^2 or $\cos x$); *odd* if $f(-x) = -f(x)$ (graph symmetric through the origin, like x^3 or $\sin x$). These symmetries cut work in half: the integral of an odd function over a symmetric interval $[-a, a]$ is automatically 0.

Monotonicity. f is *increasing* if $x_1 < x_2 \Rightarrow f(x_1) < f(x_2)$, decreasing if the inequality reverses. A strictly monotonic function is automatically one-to-one, hence invertible. The derivative's sign detects monotonicity — this is the bridge from calculus back to this algebraic notion.

Common trap

f^{-1} means the *inverse function*, not the reciprocal. $\sin^{-1} x$ is the inverse sine (arcsine), not $1/\sin x$. The reciprocal is written $(\sin x)^{-1}$ or $1/\sin x = \csc x$. The clash of notation is unfortunate but standard; context and a sharp eye are your defense.

40.7 What a Proof Is, and Three Reliable Shapes

A theorem is a true statement; a proof is the evidence that compels belief. But "evidence" in mathematics is stricter than anywhere else: a proof is a chain of steps, each following from the previous by pure logic or from facts already granted, leaving *no* gap a skeptic could pry open. Checking a million cases is not a proof if there is a million-and-first. The reward for this strictness is total certainty: a theorem, once proved, is true forever and everywhere its hypotheses hold.

Why this matters

Why insist on proof when testing examples and spotting patterns works so often? Because a pattern can hold for dozens of cases and still fail. Consider $f(n) = n^2 + n + 41$. For $n = 0, 1, 2, \ldots, 39$ every value is prime — forty cases in a row, overwhelming "evidence." But $f(40) = 40^2 + 40 + 41 = 41^2$ is not prime. Forty confirmations could not save a false conjecture; one proof would have settled it either way. Calculus is built on infinitely many cases (every x, every ε), so we *cannot* check them one by one. Proof is the only tool that establishes a statement across infinitely many cases at once.

We will meet three shapes of proof again and again. Each is a strategy for getting from hypotheses to conclusion.

40.7.1 Direct proof

The most natural shape: assume the hypothesis, and march forward by valid steps until you reach the conclusion. Most "if P then Q" theorems are proved this way — start from P, deduce, arrive at Q.

Example 40.3 (A direct proof)**.** *Claim: the sum of two even integers is even.* An even integer is one of the form $2k$ for some integer k (that is the definition we work from). So let the two even integers be $m = 2j$ and $n = 2k$. Then

$$m + n = 2j + 2k = 2(j + k).$$

Since $j + k$ is an integer, $m + n$ has the form $2 \times$ (integer), which is exactly the definition of even. Therefore $m + n$ is even. □

Notice the rhythm: unfold the definitions of the hypotheses, do careful algebra, re-fold into the definition of the conclusion. This is the standard structure of a direct proof.

40.7.2 Proof by contradiction

Sometimes the conclusion is awkward to reach head-on, but its *negation* is straightforward to analyze. So we assume the opposite of what we want, follow the consequences, and reach a contradiction. Since valid reasoning from a true premise can never produce a falsehood, our starting assumption (the negation) must have been false — so the original claim is true.

Connection

The proof that $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational is one of the earliest landmarks in deductive mathematics, dating to the Pythagoreans in the fifth century BCE and recorded in Euclid's *Elements* (c. 300 BCE). The Pythagoreans held that the geometric world was governed strictly by whole numbers and their ratios. The discovery that the diagonal of a unit square could not be represented as any ratio of whole numbers — that it was *incommensurable* (having no shared unit of measure with the side) — came as a major surprise to ancient mathematics. Legend holds that the discovery was kept secret under penalty of death. Proof by contradiction compelled mathematicians to accept an unexpected truth that could never be reached by direct measurement.

Example 40.4 ($\sqrt{2}$ is irrational — proof by contradiction)**.** *Suppose, for contradiction, that* $\sqrt{2}$ *is rational.* Then we can write $\sqrt{2} = p/q$ as a fraction in *lowest terms* — meaning p and q share no common factor (any common factor could be cancelled first). Square both sides:

$$2 = \frac{p^2}{q^2} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad p^2 = 2q^2.$$

So p^2 is even, which forces p itself to be even (if p were odd, say $p = 2k+1$, then $p^2 = (2k+1)^2 = 4k^2 + 4k + 1 = 2(2k^2 + 2k) + 1$, which is odd). Write $p = 2r$. Substituting,

$$(2r)^2 = 2q^2 \implies 4r^2 = 2q^2 \implies q^2 = 2r^2.$$

Now q^2 is even, so q is even too. But then p and q are *both* even — they share the common factor 2 — contradicting our choice of a fraction in lowest terms. The contradiction means our supposition was impossible: $\sqrt{2}$ cannot be written as such a fraction. Hence $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational. □

What is really happening

Why were we allowed to assume lowest terms? Because cancelling common factors makes the positive denominator strictly smaller, and positive integers cannot shrink forever: every nonempty subset of $\mathbb{N}$ contains a least element (the *well-ordering principle*). So among all fractions equal to p/q there is one with the smallest denominator, and it must be in lowest terms. The same principle is the foundation of mathematical induction, which comes next.

40.7.3 Proof by induction

Induction proves a statement $P(n)$ for *every* natural number n at once, even though there are infinitely many. The image to hold is a line of dominoes.

Intuition

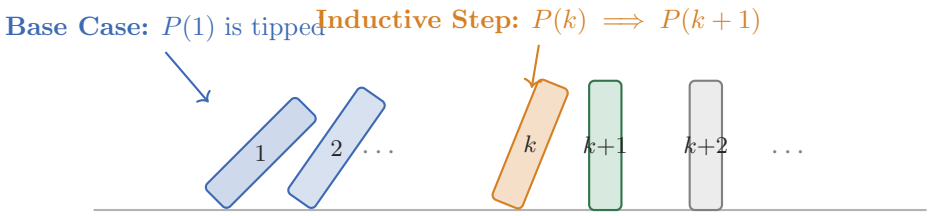
Imagine infinitely many dominoes standing in a row, one for each $n = 1, 2, 3, \ldots$. You want to know they all fall. You do not push each one — there are infinitely many. Instead you check two things: (1) the **first** domino falls, and (2) **each** domino, if it falls, knocks over the next. Granted those two facts, every domino must fall: the first falls by (1), which by (2) topples the second, which topples the third, forever. Induction is exactly this.

Focus

Principle of mathematical induction. To prove $P(n)$ holds for all integers $n \geq 1$, prove two things:

- **Base case:** $P(1)$ is true. (The first domino falls.)
- **Inductive step:** for every k, *if* $P(k)$ is true *then* $P(k+1)$ is true. (Each domino topples the next.)

The assumption "$P(k)$ is true" inside the step is called the *inductive hypothesis*. You are allowed to assume it precisely because you are about to show it would force the next case.



If the first falls, and each falling domino strikes its neighbor, the entire infinite chain must fall.

Figure 40.9: The domino model of mathematical induction. Establishing $P(1)$ guarantees the chain reaction starts. Establishing $P(k) \implies P(k+1)$ ensures the impulse propagates from each tile to the next. Together, they establish the result for all integers $n \geq 1$.

Example 40.5 (Sum of the first n integers)**.** *Claim:* for every $n \geq 1$,

$$1 + 2 + 3 + \cdots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}.$$

Base case ($n = 1$). The left side is just 1; the right side is $\frac{1 \cdot 2}{2} = 1$. They agree, so $P(1)$ holds.

Inductive step. Assume the formula holds for $n = k$ (the inductive hypothesis):

$$1 + 2 + \cdots + k = \frac{k(k+1)}{2}.$$

We must show it then holds for $n = k + 1$. Add $(k + 1)$ to both sides:

$$1 + 2 + \cdots + k + (k+1) = \frac{k(k+1)}{2} + (k+1).$$

Factor $(k + 1)$ out of the right-hand side:

$$\frac{k(k+1)}{2} + (k+1) = (k+1)\left(\frac{k}{2} + 1\right) = (k+1) \cdot \frac{k+2}{2} = \frac{(k+1)(k+2)}{2}.$$

That last expression is exactly the original formula with n replaced by $k + 1$. So $P(k) \Rightarrow P(k+1)$. By induction the formula holds for all $n \geq 1$. $\square$

Why the technique works

A famous story has the young Carl Friedrich Gauss, assigned by his schoolmaster to sum the integers from 1 through 100, producing the answer 5050 almost instantly. His insight was to pair the numbers from opposite ends:

$$1 + 100 = 101, \quad 2 + 99 = 101, \quad 3 + 98 = 101, \quad \ldots, \quad 50 + 51 = 101.$$

There are 50 such pairs, each totaling 101, giving $50 \times 101 = 5050$. For any positive integer n, write the sum forward and backward:

$$\begin{aligned} S &= 1 \quad + 2 \qquad + \cdots \quad + n \\ S &= n \quad + (n-1) \quad + \cdots \quad + 1 \end{aligned}$$

Adding the two lines produces n columns, every one summing to $n+1$. Therefore $2S = n(n+1)$, so $S = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$. It is healthy to know a result two ways: induction certifies that it holds without

exception; Gauss's pairing explains *why* the formula takes that shape.

Common trap

Induction without a base case proves nothing. "If $P(k)$ then $P(k+1)$" alone is a chain of dominoes that nobody pushed — the implications can all be valid while the statement is false for every n. Always nail down the base case. Conversely, a base case with a broken inductive step (a gap where $P(k)$ does not actually force $P(k+1)$) is equally worthless: one fallen domino, then nothing.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose someone claims: "For all integers $n \geq 1$, $n = n + 10$." They demonstrate that *if* $k = k + 10$, then adding 1 to both sides yields $k + 1 = (k + 1) + 10$, so the inductive step holds. Why is the claim false? The inductive step is a valid conditional statement ("if true for k, then true for $k + 1$"), but the base case $P(1)$ is $1 = 11$, which is flatly false. The dominoes are spaced to knock each other over, but the first domino was never tipped. An inductive argument without a verified base case proves nothing.

Connection

Induction is not confined to "sum" formulas. It underlies the power rule $\frac{d}{dx}x^n = nx^{n-1}$ for positive integer n (prove it for $n = 1$, then use the product rule to climb from x^k to x^{k+1}), the binomial theorem, and the convergence arguments behind Taylor series. Whenever a statement is indexed by a whole number and each case rests on the one before, induction is the tool. It is the discrete cousin of the "accumulate one step at a time" idea that integration makes continuous.

40.8 The Binomial Theorem: Algebra and Counting Together

One identity deserves a section of its own because it threads through the entire book — it appears in the power rule's derivation, in Taylor's theorem, and in the definition of e. It answers: what is $(a + b)^n$ expanded?

We already know $(a+b)^2 = a^2 + 2ab + b^2$ and $(a+b)^3 = a^3 + 3a^2b + 3ab^2 + b^3$. The coefficients $1, 2, 1$ and $1, 3, 3, 1$ are the rows of *Pascal's triangle*, where each entry is the sum of the two above it:

$$\begin{array}{ccccccc} & & & 1 & & & \\ & & 1 & & 1 & & \\ & 1 & & 2 & & 1 & \\ 1 & & 3 & & 3 & & 1 \\ 1 & & 4 & & 6 & & 4 & & 1 \end{array}$$

Theorem 40.1 (Binomial theorem)**.** *For any nonnegative integer n,*

$$(a+b)^n = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \binom{n}{k} a^{n-k} b^k, \qquad \binom{n}{k} = \frac{n!}{k!\,(n-k)!}.$$

What is really happening

Where do the coefficients $\binom{n}{k}$ come from? Expanding $(a+b)^n = (a+b)(a+b)\cdots(a+b)$ (n factors) means choosing, from each factor, either the a or the b, then multiplying the choices. A term $a^{n-k}b^k$ arises every time we pick b from exactly k of the n factors. The number of ways to choose which k factors contribute a b is $\binom{n}{k}$ — "n choose k." So the binomial theorem expresses a *combinatorial* fact algebraically: the coefficient is the count of ways a given mix of a's and b's can occur. This is why probability and algebra share the same triangle.

Example 40.6 (Why it matters for the power rule)**.** The derivative of x^n from the limit definition needs $(x+h)^n$. The binomial theorem gives

$$(x+h)^n = x^n + nx^{n-1}h + \binom{n}{2}x^{n-2}h^2 + \cdots + h^n.$$

Subtract x^n and divide by h:

$$\frac{(x+h)^n - x^n}{h} = nx^{n-1} + \binom{n}{2}x^{n-2}h + \cdots + h^{n-1}.$$

Every term after the first carries at least one factor of h, so as $h \to 0$ they all vanish, leaving

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x^n) = nx^{n-1}.$$

The binomial theorem isolated the one term that survives the limit. The power rule arises directly from the linear term in the binomial expansion.

40.9 Putting It Together: A Worked Gauntlet

To see these tools cooperate, run one expression through several of them.

Example 40.7 (Simplify a difference quotient)**.** Simplify $\dfrac{1}{h}\left(\dfrac{1}{x+h} - \dfrac{1}{x}\right)$ and find its limit as $h \to 0$ — this is the derivative of $1/x$ from scratch.

Step 1: combine the inner fractions over the common denominator $x(x+h)$:

$$\frac{1}{x+h} - \frac{1}{x} = \frac{x-(x+h)}{x(x+h)} = \frac{-h}{x(x+h)}.$$

Step 2: divide by h (multiply by $1/h$); the h's cancel, the move that makes the limit tractable:

$$\frac{1}{h}\cdot\frac{-h}{x(x+h)} = \frac{-1}{x(x+h)}.$$

Step 3: take the limit $h \to 0$. Now the expression is continuous at $h = 0$, so just substitute:

$$\lim_{h\to 0}\frac{-1}{x(x+h)} = \frac{-1}{x\cdot x} = -\frac{1}{x^2}.$$

So $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(1/x) = -1/x^2$. Every step was pure appendix material — common denominators, sign care, cancellation — yet the result is a genuine calculus fact.

Work it yourself

Run the same gauntlet on $\dfrac{\sqrt{x+h}-\sqrt{x}}{h}$. The right tool is the conjugate: multiply top and bottom by $\sqrt{x+h}+\sqrt{x}$ and use the difference of squares (40.3) to turn the top into $(x+h)-x=h$, which cancels the h below. You should land on $\dfrac{1}{2\sqrt{x}}$ in the limit — the derivative of $\sqrt{x}$. Notice the same three-step procedure: rewrite, cancel the h, substitute.

40.10 The Scope and Limits of Finite Algebra

Every algebraic identity and proof archetype in this appendix was designed to turn intuitive steps into an airtight, repeatable discipline. Factoring identities, difference-of-squares conjugates, and rational expressions allow us to dissect difference quotients $\frac{f(x+h)-f(x)}{h}$ and cleanly isolate and cancel the vanishing factor h before passing to the limit. Extending integer exponents to negative, zero, and rational powers systematically brings reciprocal functions and roots into the single power rule $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x)^r = rx^{r-1}$. Meanwhile, inequalities and absolute values provide an algebraic formulation of geometric tolerances: stating that $|x-a|<\delta$ forces $|f(x)-L|<\varepsilon$ translates proximity into the precise criteria of limits, while induction and contradiction let us verify claims across infinitely many cases at once.

Yet for all its versatility, elementary algebra possesses a fundamental boundary: *algebra is strictly finite and rational*. Addition, multiplication, factoring, and polynomial expansions are finite operations. If our universe of numbers is restricted to the rationals $\mathbb{Q}$, every field axiom and algebraic identity in this appendix holds without flaw, yet calculus completely collapses.

The rational line is perforated with gaps. As Euclid's contradiction proof established, $\sqrt{2}$ is not rational. An increasing sequence of rationals like $1, 1.4, 1.41, 1.414, \ldots$ has terms squeezing closer together, yet it possesses no landing point in $\mathbb{Q}$. On a rational domain, the Intermediate Value Theorem fails: the curve $f(x)=x^2-2$ crosses from $f(1)=-1$ to $f(2)=2$ without ever hitting zero, because the point $\sqrt{2}$ where $x^2-2=0$ does not exist in $\mathbb{Q}$. Continuous bounded functions on closed rational intervals can fail to attain maximum values because the supremum (least upper bound) is not rational.

Connection

To turn symbolic algebra into a rigorous foundation for calculus, we must move beyond finite operations into *order completeness*. This brings us to the next chapter, *Appendix: The Real Numbers and Completeness*. There we explore how Dedekind cuts and Cauchy sequences complete the rational line $\mathbb{Q}$, establishing the Least Upper Bound Property that guarantees every bounded monotone sequence converges, every continuous curve crossing zero strikes the axis, and every definite integral represents a genuine, well-defined real number.

Exercises

Exercise 40.1. Factor completely over the reals: (a) $x^3 - 4x$; (b) $x^4 - 16$; (c) $x^2 - 6x + 9$; (d) $8x^3 - 27$.
For each, state how you recognized the pattern (common factor, difference of squares, perfect square, difference of cubes).

Exercise 40.2. Simplify to a single power (no negative or fractional exponents in the final answer where avoidable): (a) $\dfrac{a^5 a^{-2}}{a^{-4}}$; (b) $\left(8x^6\right)^{1/3}$; (c) $\dfrac{(2x^2)^3}{4x^4}$; (d) $\dfrac{x^{1/2}\,x^{1/3}}{x^{-1/6}}$. Explain at each step which exponent law you are invoking.

Exercise 40.3. Solve $2x^2 - 4x - 3 = 0$ two ways: once with the quadratic formula, and once by completing the square. Confirm the answers agree, and state the discriminant and what it tells you about the roots.

Exercise 40.4. Solve each inequality, writing the answer in interval notation, and say where (if anywhere) the "flip" rule was needed: (a) $3 - 2x \le 11$; (b) $\dfrac{x-1}{x+2} \le 0$; (c) $x^2 < 5x - 6$.

Exercise 40.5. Rewrite each as an interval or union of intervals on the number line, and sketch it: (a) $|x - 3| < 2$; (b) $|2x + 1| \ge 5$; (c) $|x| = |x - 4|$ (interpret this one as "equidistant from 0 and 4" before computing).

Exercise 40.6. Use the triangle inequality to prove the *reverse triangle inequality* $\big|\,|x|-|y|\,\big| \le |x-y|$. (Hint: write $x = (x - y) + y$ and apply $|x + y| \le |x| + |y|$ to get $|x| \le |x - y| + |y|$; rearrange, then do the same with the roles of x and y swapped.)

Exercise 40.7. Let $f(x) = \dfrac{2x-1}{x+3}$. (a) Find f^{-1} by solving $y = f(x)$ for x. (b) Verify $f(f^{-1}(y)) = y$. (c) State the domain of f and the domain of f^{-1}, and explain why they are what they are.

Exercise 40.8. Give a direct proof that the product of two odd integers is odd. (Start from the definition: an odd integer has the form $2k + 1$.)

Exercise 40.9. Prove by contradiction that $\sqrt{3}$ is irrational. Identify the one place where the argument differs from the $\sqrt{2}$ proof of Example 40.4 (hint: you will use that "$3 \mid p^2 \Rightarrow 3 \mid p$," which deserves a sentence of justification).

Exercise 40.10. Prove by induction that for all $n \ge 1$,

$$1^2 + 2^2 + 3^2 + \cdots + n^2 = \frac{n(n+1)(2n+1)}{6}.$$

Be explicit about your base case, your inductive hypothesis, and the algebra that turns the $n = k$ formula into the $n = k + 1$ formula.

Exercise 40.11. Prove by induction that $2^n > n$ for every integer $n \ge 1$. (This is an *inequality* induction; in the step, add to or multiply the inductive hypothesis to reach the $k + 1$ case.)

Exercise 40.12. Use the binomial theorem (Theorem 40.1) to expand $(1 + x)^4$, and verify your coefficients against the corresponding row of Pascal's triangle. Then use the same expansion to write down the first three terms of the difference quotient $\big((1 + h)^4 - 1\big)/h$ and read off the derivative of x^4 at $x = 1$.

Chapter 41

Appendix: The Real Numbers and Completeness

Every theorem in this book that begins with the statement "there exists" — a limit exists, a continuous function attains a maximum, a curve crosses zero, a bounded monotone sequence converges — rests on the structure of the real numbers. Without the completeness of the real number line, these existence theorems fail, and key parts of calculus break down.

In the previous appendix, we traced the number systems from $\mathbb{N}$ to $\mathbb{C}$, noting that the passage from fractions to the reals eliminates gaps in the line. Throughout calculus, we relied on this property when defining limits, proving that continuous curves cross zero, and optimizing functions. This appendix examines that foundation directly: *what are the real numbers, and what makes the real line complete?* We routinely draw the number line as an unbroken continuum. But why should it have no gaps? The rationals — fractions p/q — already appear to fill the line densely: between any two of them sits another. Yet the rational numbers contain genuine gaps, and one of those gaps sits exactly where $\sqrt{2}$ should be.

The property that resolves these gaps is the **completeness axiom**, also called the least-upper-bound property. It provides the foundation for the Intermediate Value Theorem, the Extreme Value Theorem, the convergence of monotone sequences, the existence of the Riemann integral, and the definition of limits. What follows is the development of this property and its consequences throughout analysis.

41.1 A gap in the rationals

Start with the picture, where the trouble first becomes visible. Draw the rational points on a line. Between 0 and 1 you can mark $\frac{1}{2}$, and then $\frac{1}{3}, \frac{2}{3}$, and $\frac{1}{4}, \frac{3}{4}$, and on and on. The marks pile up so thickly that no matter how powerful a magnifying glass you bring, you will always find infinitely many rationals in any window, however small.

Intuition

The rationals are **dense**: between any two distinct rationals $a < b$ lies another rational, for example their average $\frac{a+b}{2}$. Repeat the averaging and you get infinitely many. Visually, the rational marks leave no *visible* space anywhere on the line. It is enormously tempting to conclude that they leave no space at all — that the rationals already *are* the continuous line. This is the trap. Density is not the same as having no holes. A fine sieve has wire near every point and is still full of holes.

To pinpoint a concrete gap, return to the diagonal of a unit square from Example 40.4. By the Pythagorean theorem, a square one unit on a side has a diagonal of length d with $d^2 = 1^2 + 1^2 = 2$, a definite length you can construct with straightedge and compass. We repeat the proof that no fraction has this length, so that this appendix stands on its own.

Theorem 41.1 (Irrationality of $\sqrt{2}$)**.** *There is no rational number r with $r^2 = 2$.*

Proof. Suppose, for contradiction, that such a rational exists. Write it in lowest terms as $r = p/q$, where p and q are integers with no common factor (we can always cancel until this holds). Then

$$\frac{p^2}{q^2} = 2 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad p^2 = 2q^2.$$

The right-hand side is even, so p^2 is even. But the square of an odd number is odd (an odd number is $2k+1$, and $(2k+1)^2 = 4k^2+4k+1$ is odd), so p itself must be even. Write $p = 2m$. Substituting,

$$(2m)^2 = 2q^2 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad 4m^2 = 2q^2 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad q^2 = 2m^2.$$

Now the same argument applies to q: q^2 is even, so q is even. But then p and q are *both* even — they share the factor 2 — contradicting our assumption that the fraction was in lowest terms. The assumption was impossible. Hence no rational squares to 2. □

Connection

As the previous appendix noted, the Pythagorean discovery that a square's diagonal is *incommensurable* with its side forced a split at the heart of Greek mathematics. Greek geometers responded by treating continuous magnitudes (lengths, areas) separately from whole-number arithmetic, most famously in Eudoxus's theory of proportions recorded in Book V of Euclid's *Elements*. Reuniting geometry with a single gap-free system of numbers took more than two millennia and was not completed until the 1870s, with the work of Dedekind and Cantor discussed in the history box in Section 41.3.

So there is a definite, constructible geometric point — the length $\sqrt{2}$, roughly $1.41421356\ldots$ — that no fraction reaches. The rationals, dense as they are, leave a gap at that position. By scaling and translating, similar gaps appear everywhere along the line. The rational line is dense, yet incomplete.

What is really happening

Here is the precise structure of the gap, which the completeness axiom will address. Consider the two sets of rationals

$$A = \{x \in \mathbb{Q} : x > 0 \text{ and } x^2 < 2\}, \qquad B = \{x \in \mathbb{Q} : x > 0 \text{ and } x^2 > 2\}.$$

Every positive rational lands in exactly one of A or B (none has square equal to 2, by Theorem 41.1). Every element of A is less than every element of B. The set A has no *largest* member: given any $x \in A$, we can always nudge it up to a larger rational whose square is still below 2. The set B has no *smallest* member: any $x \in B$ can be nudged down slightly and stay above $\sqrt{2}$. So the rational line partitions into a left set with no maximum and a right set with no minimum, with *no rational number sitting between them.* This partition of the ordered numbers into two complementary sets is what Richard Dedekind called a **cut** (Figure 41.1). In $\mathbb{R}$, there is always a number located at such a boundary; in $\mathbb{Q}$, there is sometimes none. That distinction is completeness.

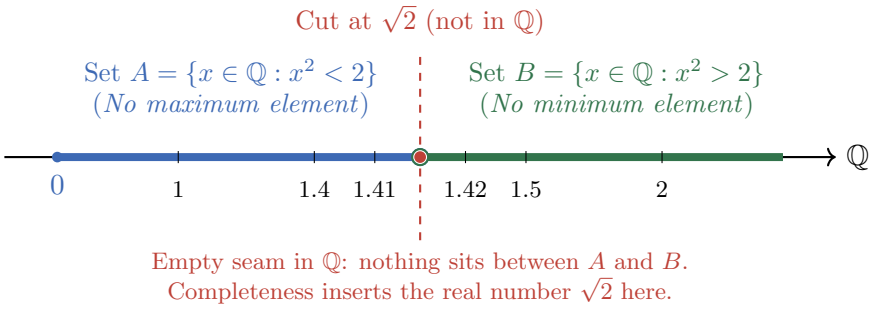


Figure 41.1: A Dedekind cut dividing the rational numbers at $\sqrt{2}$. Set A contains all positive rationals with $x^2 < 2$ (blue); set B contains all positive rationals with $x^2 > 2$ (green). Because $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational, set A has no largest element and set B has no smallest element. The seam between them is completely empty in $\mathbb{Q}$. Dedekind's breakthrough was defining the real number $\sqrt{2}$ to *be* this partition.

Squeezing the hole between fractions

We can watch the hole numerically. Build two sequences of rationals, one climbing toward $\sqrt{2}$ from below and one descending toward it from above, by choosing more and more decimal digits:

n	below: a_n	above: b_n
1	1.4	1.5
2	1.41	1.42
3	1.414	1.415
4	1.4142	1.4143
5	1.41421	1.41422

Each a_n is a rational with $a_n^2 < 2$ and each b_n is a rational with $b_n^2 > 2$, and the gap $b_n - a_n = 10^{-n}$ shrinks to zero. The two sequences close in on a single location on the line — you can pin it to within any tolerance you like — and yet *that location is occupied by no rational at all.* The fractions march right up to the edge of a point that, in their world, simply is not there.

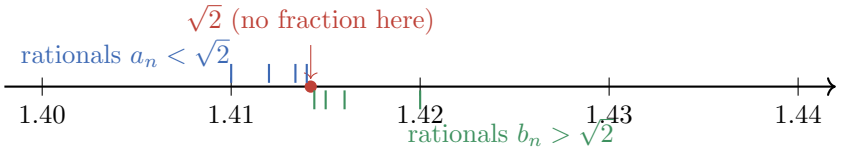


Figure 41.2: Rationals from the left (a_n, blue) and from the right (b_n, green) close in on the location of $\sqrt{2}$. The gap $b_n - a_n = 10^{-n}$ shrinks to zero, pinning a single point — but in the rational line that point is a hole. Completeness is the axiom that puts a real number there.

Why the technique works

Why does a missing point matter when rationals suffice for any physical measurement? Because calculus relies on general theorems guaranteeing that limits exist before we can compute them in closed form. The rational sequence $1.4, 1.41, 1.414, \ldots$ is strictly increasing and bounded above by 2, yet in $\mathbb{Q}$ it has no limit at all. To guarantee that bounded monotone sequences and Cauchy sequences actually converge, the number system cannot have missing targets.

41.2 Upper bounds, suprema, and the language of ceilings

To state the axiom that fixes everything, we first need vocabulary for "the place a set is heading toward from above." This is the notion of a *least upper bound*, and it deserves to be built slowly: it is subtle, and it underlies everything that follows.

Definition 41.1 (Bounded above; upper bound)**.** Let S be a nonempty set of real numbers. A number M is an **upper bound** for S if $x \le M$ for every $x \in S$. If S has at least one upper bound, we say S is **bounded above**. *Lower bound* and **bounded below** are defined the same way with the inequality reversed.

An upper bound is a ceiling: a number that no element of S exceeds. A set can have many ceilings. The interval $S = (0, 1)$ has 1 as a ceiling, but also 2, also 17.5, also a billion. Ceilings come in a whole upward family; once one number is a ceiling, so is every number above it.

The interesting ceiling is the *lowest* one — the tightest, the one that hugs the set from above with no slack.

Definition 41.2 (Supremum / least upper bound)**.** A number L is the **supremum** (or **least upper bound**) of a nonempty set S, written $L = \sup S$, if both:

1. L is an upper bound for S (nothing in S exceeds L), and
2. L is the *least* such bound: if M is any upper bound for S, then $L \le M$.

The mirror notion, the **infimum** or greatest lower bound, is written $\inf S$. It is the highest possible floor that stays beneath every point in the set.

Intuition

Think of lowering a ceiling slowly toward a crowd of people. You keep lowering until, just before it would touch someone's head, you stop. That stopping height is the supremum: the lowest you can put the ceiling while still clearing everyone. Two cases can happen at the moment you stop. In the first case, the ceiling rests directly on the tallest person's head, so the supremum belongs to the set and is a *maximum*. In the second case, there is no single tallest person, only an unending sequence of ever-taller people approaching the ceiling from below; here the supremum is their limiting height and belongs to no individual. The supremum captures *both* cases in one word, which is exactly why it is more powerful than "maximum."

The second case is the one to internalize, because it is the reason the supremum was invented. Consider the open interval $S = (0,1) = \{x : 0 < x < 1\}$. There is no largest element: whatever $x < 1$ you name, the number $\frac{x+1}{2}$ is larger and still below 1. So S has no maximum. But it plainly has a least upper bound: $\sup S = 1$. The number 1 is an upper bound, and nothing smaller can be, because any $M < 1$ is itself beaten by an element of S (the point $\frac{M+1}{2}$ lies in S and exceeds M). The supremum exists even though the maximum does not.

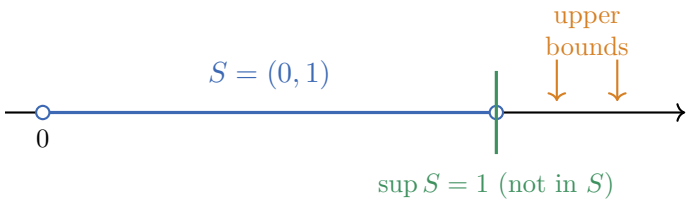


Figure 41.3: The open interval $(0,1)$ has no largest element — the right endpoint is missing (hollow circle) — yet it has a least upper bound, $\sup S = 1$. The orange arrows mark some of the upper bounds; the supremum is the leftmost of them, sitting exactly at the missing edge.

Focus

A clean way to test a candidate L for being $\sup S$ uses two complementary promises, and you will use this constantly in proofs:

1. **Ceiling:** $x \le L$ for all $x \in S$. (Nothing pokes above L.)
2. **Tightness:** for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is some $x \in S$ with $x > L - \varepsilon$. (You cannot lower the ceiling by any amount ε, however tiny, without cutting into the set.)

The second promise is the operational heart of the supremum. It says: elements of S come *arbitrarily close* to L from below. Whenever you see "sup" in a proof, reach for this ε-characterization — it converts the abstract "least upper bound" into a concrete sequence of elements creeping up to L, which is something you can compute with.

Pause

Pause and think: Consider the sequence set $S = \{2 - \frac{1}{n} : n \in \mathbb{N}\} = \{1, \frac{3}{2}, \frac{5}{3}, \frac{7}{4}, \ldots\}$. What is $\inf S$, and is it attained? What is $\sup S$, and is it attained? *(Check: The smallest term is the first one, so* $\inf S = 1$*, which is attained. As* n *grows, the terms climb toward* 2 *but never reach it. Lowering the ceiling to* $2 - \varepsilon$ *always leaves terms* $2 - 1/n$ *above it once* $n > 1/\varepsilon$*, so* $\sup S = 2$*, which is not attained.)*

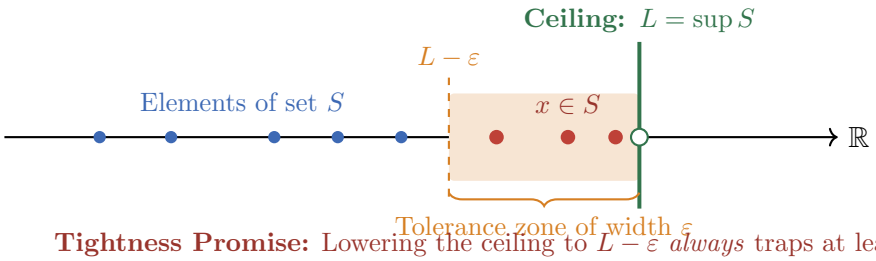


Figure 41.4: The ε-characterization of the supremum. $L = \sup S$ acts as an impassable ceiling for S. Tightness asserts that no matter how tiny the tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$ is, lowering the ceiling to $L - \varepsilon$ breaches the set: there must exist an element $x \in S$ inside the orange corridor $(L - \varepsilon, L]$.

Common trap

Do not confuse the supremum with the maximum, and do not assume the supremum belongs to the set. For $(0, 1)$, the supremum is 1 but $1 \notin (0, 1)$. For $[0, 1]$, the supremum is 1 and $1 \in [0, 1]$, so here it is also the maximum. A maximum is a supremum that happens to be attained; a supremum need not be attained. The reverse trap also bites: a set can have a supremum without a maximum, but it can never have a maximum without that maximum being the supremum. "Max exists" is the strong statement; "sup exists" is the one the axiom will guarantee.

41.3 The completeness axiom

We have seen exactly what goes wrong in $\mathbb{Q}$: the set $A = \{x \in \mathbb{Q} : x > 0,\ x^2 < 2\}$ is bounded above (by 2, say) but has no least upper bound *inside* $\mathbb{Q}$ — its only conceivable least upper bound is $\sqrt{2}$, which $\mathbb{Q}$ does not contain. The seam between A and the larger rationals is empty. The real numbers are, by definition, the system in which this never happens.

Focus

The Completeness Axiom (least-upper-bound property). *Every nonempty set of real numbers that is bounded above has a least upper bound in* $\mathbb{R}$. In symbols: if $S \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ is nonempty and bounded above, then $\sup S$ exists and is a real number.

That is the entire axiom. It does not mention $\sqrt{2}$, limits, or continuity; it speaks only of sets and upper bounds. Yet it is the defining property that distinguishes $\mathbb{R}$ from $\mathbb{Q}$, and it underlies every existence theorem in calculus.

What is really happening

What does the axiom mean geometrically? It asserts that **the real line has no gaps**. Recall the cut from Section 41.1: a left subset A with no maximum facing a right subset with no minimum, and no rational number between them. Completeness ensures that this cannot happen in $\mathbb{R}$. If S is bounded above, the upper bounds of S form a set to the right, and the elements of S lie to the left; completeness requires that the boundary between elements of S

and upper bounds of S is *an actual real number*, $\sup S$. Every cut determines a unique real number. This is why the real line forms an unbroken continuum: completeness is the precise mathematical formulation of that property.

Remark 41.1. By symmetry (replace S with $-S = \{-x : x \in S\}$ and flip every inequality), the axiom has a twin: *every nonempty set bounded below has a greatest lower bound,* $\inf S$, in $\mathbb{R}$. Suprema and infima always exist for bounded sets. You only ever need to prove the version you find convenient; the other follows for free by reflection.

History

Why is completeness an *axiom* and not a theorem? Because whether you take it as an axiom or prove it as a theorem depends on where you choose to start.

The trouble began with the Pythagorean discovery of incommensurable lengths (Section 41.1). For two thousand years afterward, geometry had to stand in for numbers because arithmetic had no language for irrational quantities. When Newton and Leibniz invented calculus in the late seventeenth century, they relied on geometric intuition of continuous curves, fluent quantities, and infinitesimals without any formal arithmetic definition of the continuum. In 1821, Augustin-Louis Cauchy published his *Cours d'Analyse*, attempting to place calculus on a solid foundation of limits. Yet Cauchy tacitly assumed without proof that whenever the terms of a sequence crowd closer and closer to one another (what we now call a **Cauchy sequence**), they must inevitably converge to an actual number.

The crisis came to a head in the autumn of 1858. Richard Dedekind, then preparing lecture notes on differential calculus at Zurich Polytechnic, was horrified to realize that he had no rigorous way to prove that an increasing bounded sequence has a limit without appealing to the physical, geometric drawing of a line. But using geometry to justify arithmetic is circular: analytic geometry uses coordinate pairs $(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ to define the line in the first place. Arithmetic had to stand on its own feet. Armed with only the rational numbers $\mathbb{Q}$ and basic set operations, mathematicians set out to construct the continuum from scratch.

In the 1870s, four mathematicians independently succeeded: Richard Dedekind, Georg Cantor, Charles Méray, and Karl Weierstrass. Dedekind (published in 1872 in *Stetigkeit und irrationale Zahlen*) defined a real number to be a "cut"—a partition of $\mathbb{Q}$ into a lower set and an upper set, placing an actual number into every empty seam. Cantor instead defined a real number as an equivalence class of Cauchy sequences of rationals, treating sequences that close in on the same spot as the same number. If you define the reals by Dedekind cuts or Cauchy sequences, the least-upper-bound property becomes a provable theorem. If you start with $\mathbb{R}$ as an ordered field, you take it as an axiom.

Yet this breakthrough sparked ferocious controversy. Leopold Kronecker, a strict finitary constructivist—one who believed that mathematical objects exist only if they can be calculated in a finite number of algorithmic steps—waged an intellectual war against Cantor and Dedekind. Kronecker famously proclaimed: *"Die ganzen Zahlen hat der liebe Gott gemacht, alles andere ist Menschenwerk"* ("God made the integers, all else is the work of man"). Kronecker argued that an irrational number like $\sqrt{2}$ has no legitimate existence unless accompanied by a finite algorithm to compute it, rejected completed infinities, and attempted to suppress Cantor's work.

History confirmed the value of Dedekind and Cantor's work: without their rigorous model of the continuum, modern analysis, topology, and differential equations could not have developed their current foundations. Yet foundational questions remain active. The philosophical

debate between classical mathematics (which accepts non-constructive existence by completeness) and constructive mathematics (which requires explicit algorithms) continues in logic and theoretical computer science. In addition, Cantor's discovery that the reals are uncountably infinite led to the **Continuum Hypothesis** — the question of whether there exists an infinite set strictly larger than $\mathbb{N}$ but strictly smaller than $\mathbb{R}$. Kurt Gödel (1940) showed that the standard axioms of set theory (ZFC) cannot disprove it, and Paul Cohen (1963) showed that they cannot prove it either: the question is undecidable within ZFC.

Completeness builds $\sqrt{2}$

To see how the axiom operates, we use it to prove the existence of $\sqrt{2}$.

Theorem 41.2 (Existence of square roots)**.** *There is a positive real number L with $L^2 = 2$.*

Proof sketch. Let $S = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x > 0 \text{ and } x^2 < 2\}$. The set is nonempty (it contains 1, since $1^2 = 1 < 2$) and bounded above (by 2, since any $x > 2$ has $x^2 > 4 > 2$ and so cannot be in S). By the completeness axiom, $L = \sup S$ exists as a real number. We claim $L^2 = 2$.

Suppose instead $L^2 < 2$. Then L is too small to be the ceiling: we can nudge it up and stay inside S. Concretely, for small $h > 0$,

$$(L + h)^2 = L^2 + 2Lh + h^2 \leq L^2 + (2L + 1)h \quad (\text{taking } h \leq 1),$$

and choosing h small enough that $(2L + 1)h < 2 - L^2$ makes $(L + h)^2 < 2$, so $L + h \in S$ — but $L + h > L$ contradicts L being an *upper* bound.

Suppose instead $L^2 > 2$. Then L is too big to be the *least* ceiling: we can shave it down and still have a ceiling. For small $h > 0$ (taking $h < L$ so $L - h > 0$),

$$(L - h)^2 = L^2 - 2Lh + h^2 > L^2 - 2Lh,$$

and choosing h small enough that $2Lh < L^2 - 2$ ensures $(L - h)^2 > 2$. For any $x \in S$, we have $x^2 < 2 < (L - h)^2$. Because both x and $L - h$ are positive, this implies $x < L - h$. Thus $L - h$ is an upper bound for S — but $L - h < L$ contradicts L being the *least* upper bound.

Both inequalities are impossible, so $L^2 = 2$. The completeness axiom has produced the number the rationals were missing. □

Why this matters

The proof above illustrates the power of the completeness axiom. We did not construct $\sqrt{2}$ digit by digit. Instead, we defined a set — the positive numbers whose square is less than 2 — and the axiom guaranteed that its least upper bound exists in $\mathbb{R}$, with that bound satisfying $L^2 = 2$. The supremum provides a general existence principle: for any nonempty bounded set, an exact supremum is guaranteed. Most existence theorems in calculus follow this pattern. By defining appropriate sets — points where a function is negative, function values on a closed interval, or partial sums of a series — completeness guarantees the existence of the critical value: the crossing point, the maximum, the limit, or the integral.

Pause

Pause and think: Does the set of all negative real numbers $S = (-\infty, 0) = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x < 0\}$ have a supremum? Is it bounded above? Does the completeness axiom apply? *(Check: Any number ≥ 0 is an upper bound, so S is bounded above, and S is nonempty. Completeness guarantees that* $\sup S$ *exists. The least upper bound is* $\sup S = 0$*, which is not in S.)*

41.4 Why calculus needs completeness

Four fundamental theorems in calculus follow directly from the completeness axiom. We prove the first two in full and outline the others, showing how completeness supplies the required existence guarantees in each case.

Monotone sequences converge

Theorem 41.3 (Monotone Convergence Theorem)**.** *A sequence (a_n) that is increasing ($a_1 \leq a_2 \leq a_3 \leq \cdots$) and bounded above converges to a real limit. In fact $a_n \to \sup\{a_n : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$.*

Proof. Let $S = \{a_n : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$, the set of values the sequence takes. It is nonempty and bounded above by hypothesis, so by completeness $L = \sup S$ exists. We show $a_n \to L$.

Fix any tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$. By the tightness property of the supremum (Section 41.2), $L - \varepsilon$ is not an upper bound, so some term a_N satisfies $a_N > L - \varepsilon$. Because the sequence is increasing, every later term is at least as large: for all $n \geq N$,

$$L - \varepsilon < a_N \leq a_n \leq L < L + \varepsilon,$$

the last inequality because L is an upper bound for all the a_n. Hence $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$ for all $n \geq N$. Since ε was arbitrary, $a_n \to L$ (Figure 41.5). □

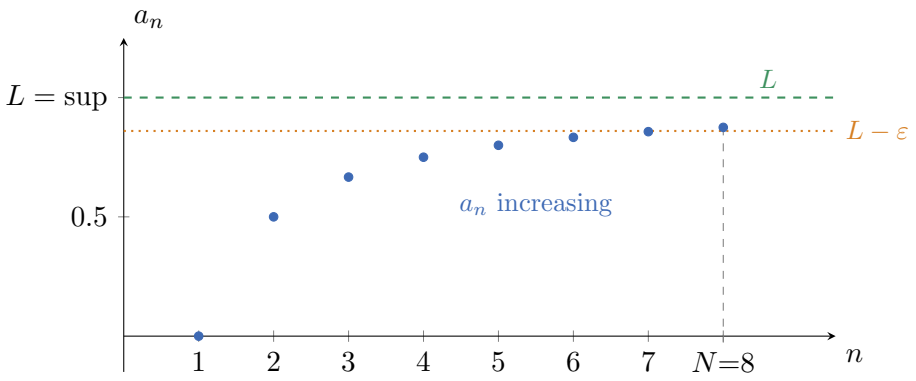


Figure 41.5: Monotone Convergence in one picture. An increasing sequence a_n (blue dots) that is bounded above presses upward against its supremum L (green dashed ceiling). For any tolerance ε, tightness of the supremum forces some term a_N above the line $L - \varepsilon$ (orange dotted); from that index on, every term is trapped in the strip $(L - \varepsilon, L]$, so $a_n \to L$.

Connection

This is the theorem that establishes convergence for the sequence $1.4, 1.41, 1.414, \ldots$ from Section 41.1. It is increasing and bounded above by 2, so by Monotone Convergence it converges, and its limit is $\sqrt{2}$ as established in Theorem 41.2. Decimal expansions rely fundamentally on this theorem: the digits $3.14159\ldots$ define an increasing, bounded sequence of rationals, and completeness guarantees that this sequence converges to a well-defined real number π. Without completeness, infinite decimal expansions would not be guaranteed to represent real numbers.

The Intermediate Value Theorem

Theorem 41.4 (Intermediate Value Theorem)**.** *If f is continuous on $[a, b]$ and $f(a) < 0 < f(b)$, then there is a point $c \in (a, b)$ with $f(c) = 0$.*

Proof via completeness. Consider the set of inputs on which f is still negative:

$$S = \{x \in [a, b] : f(x) < 0\}.$$

The set is nonempty ($a \in S$, since $f(a) < 0$) and bounded above (by b). By the completeness axiom, $c = \sup S$ exists as a real number, and $a \le c \le b$. In fact c lies strictly inside (a, b). Since $f(a) < 0$, continuity keeps f negative on some interval $[a, a + \delta_a)$, so $a + \delta_a/2 \in S$ and $c > a$. Since $f(b) > 0$, continuity keeps f positive on some interval $(b - \delta_b, b]$, so every element of S is at most $b - \delta_b$, and $c \le b - \delta_b < b$. We claim $f(c) = 0$, and we rule out both strict inequalities using continuity at c.

If $f(c) < 0$: take $\varepsilon = -f(c)/2 > 0$. By continuity there is a $\delta > 0$, which we may take small enough that $(c-\delta, c+\delta) \subset (a, b)$, with $|f(x)-f(c)| < \varepsilon$ on that interval. There $f(x) < f(c)+\varepsilon = f(c)/2 < 0$. In particular $c + \delta/2$ lies in $[a, b]$ and $f(c + \delta/2) < 0$, so $c + \delta/2 \in S$. But $c + \delta/2 > c$, contradicting the fact that c is an upper bound for S.

If $f(c) > 0$: take $\varepsilon = f(c)/2 > 0$ and, as before, a $\delta > 0$ with $(c-\delta, c+\delta) \subset (a, b)$ and $|f(x)-f(c)| < \varepsilon$ there. Then $f(x) > f(c) - \varepsilon = f(c)/2 > 0$ on that interval, so no point of $(c - \delta, c]$ belongs to S. Because c bounds S from above, every element $x \in S$ must satisfy $x \le c - \delta$. Thus $c - \delta$ is an upper bound for S. But $c - \delta < c$, contradicting the fact that c is the *least* upper bound.

Both inequalities fail, so $f(c) = 0$. The crossing point is the supremum of the "still negative" set. □

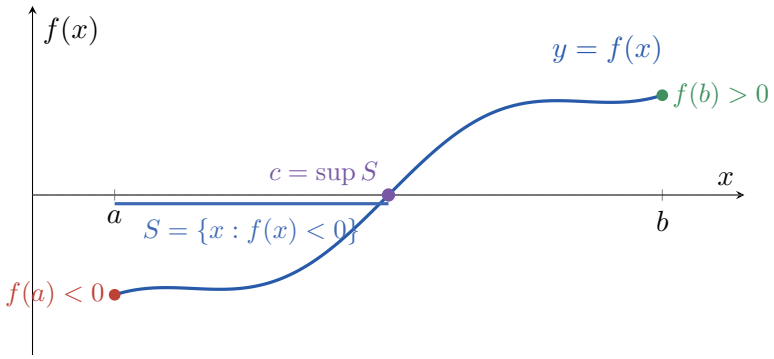


Figure 41.6: The Intermediate Value Theorem as a supremum. The curve starts below the axis and ends above it. The set S where f is still negative (blue segment) is bounded above; completeness guarantees $c = \sup S$ exists, and continuity forces $f(c) = 0$ — the curve must cross exactly at the edge of S.

Why the technique works

Why does the IVT *require* completeness and not just continuity? Because the very same continuous formula can have a crossing or not, depending only on whether the line has a hole there. Take $f(x) = x^2 - 2$ on $[0, 2]$. It is continuous, $f(0) = -2 < 0$, and $f(2) = 2 > 0$. As a function of *real* inputs it crosses zero at $x = \sqrt{2}$. But as a function of *rational* inputs — exactly the same formula, restricted to $\mathbb{Q}$ — it never equals zero, because $\sqrt{2} \notin \mathbb{Q}$. The function jumps from negative to positive *without ever passing through zero*, because the zero is in a hole. Continuity is satisfied either way; what changes the conclusion is whether the underlying number system has the point $\sqrt{2}$. The IVT is false over $\mathbb{Q}$ and true over $\mathbb{R}$, and the only difference between $\mathbb{Q}$ and $\mathbb{R}$ is completeness. So completeness is not a technicality behind the IVT — it *is* the IVT.

The Extreme Value Theorem

Theorem 41.5 (Extreme Value Theorem, sketch)**.** *A function continuous on a closed bounded interval $[a, b]$ attains a maximum and a minimum value on $[a, b]$.*

The proof proceeds in two steps, using completeness in each. First, we show that a continuous function on $[a, b]$ is *bounded*. If it were unbounded, there would exist inputs x_n with $f(x_n) \to \infty$, and completeness (via the Bolzano–Weierstrass theorem, below) yields a convergent subsequence whose limit produces a contradiction with continuity. Second, knowing the range $\{f(x) : x \in [a, b]\}$ is bounded above, completeness guarantees that $M = \sup\{f(x) : x \in [a, b]\}$ exists in $\mathbb{R}$, and a similar subsequence argument produces a point $c \in [a, b]$ with $f(c) = M$. The maximum *value* is a supremum (which always exists by completeness); continuity on a *closed* interval ensures that this supremum is *attained*. Drop completeness and the bound M might not exist; drop closedness and the supremum might not be attained, exactly as $\sup(0, 1) = 1$ is never reached inside $(0, 1)$.

This theorem provides the foundation for the Mean Value Theorem in Chapter 15. The proof of the Mean Value Theorem relies on Rolle's Theorem, which requires the function to attain an interior extremum. Without the Extreme Value Theorem, Rolle's Theorem cannot be applied; without completeness, the Extreme Value Theorem does not hold. Order completeness is thus the fundamental

property supporting the Mean Value Theorem.

Theorem 41.6 (Bolzano–Weierstrass, sketch)**.** *Every bounded sequence of real numbers has a convergent subsequence.*

The idea is a binary hunt. Enclose the bounded sequence in an interval $[A_0, B_0]$. Cut it in half; at least one half contains infinitely many terms of the sequence — keep that half and call it $[A_1, B_1]$. Halve again, keep an infinite half, and repeat forever. The left endpoints $A_0 \le A_1 \le A_2 \le \cdots$ form an increasing bounded sequence, so by Monotone Convergence (Theorem 41.3, itself completeness) they converge to a point ℓ; the interval lengths halve to zero, so the right endpoints converge to the same ℓ. Picking one sequence term from each nested interval yields a subsequence trapped in intervals shrinking to ℓ, hence converging to ℓ. The nested intervals close on a single point precisely *because the line has no holes* for them to close on emptily — completeness again.

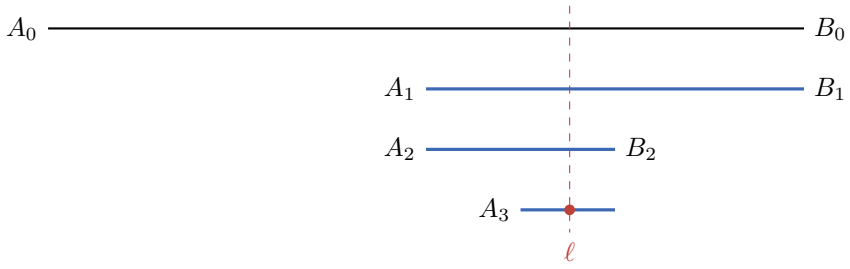


Figure 41.7: Bolzano–Weierstrass by repeated halving. Each interval keeps a half containing infinitely many sequence terms; the nested intervals shrink to a single point ℓ (dashed line), which exists because completeness leaves no empty seam for them to collapse into. A subsequence trapped in these intervals converges to ℓ.

The integral exists

When we built the definite integral in Chapter 20 as a limit of Riemann sums, we quietly used completeness twice. For any partition $P = \{a = x_0 < x_1 < \cdots < x_n = b\}$, the **lower Darboux sum** $L(f,P) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \inf_{[x_{i-1},x_i]} f \cdot \Delta x_i$ under-estimates the area, and the **upper Darboux sum** $U(f,P) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \sup_{[x_{i-1},x_i]} f \cdot \Delta x_i$ over-estimates it.

Every lower sum is bounded above by every upper sum. Therefore, the set of all possible lower sums $\{L(f,P) : P \text{ a partition}\}$ is nonempty and bounded above; completeness hands us its supremum, the **lower integral** I_*. Symmetrically, the upper sums form a set bounded below; completeness hands us its infimum, the **upper integral** I^*.

A bounded function is *Riemann integrable* precisely when these two numbers meet: $I_* = I^*$. For every continuous function on $[a,b]$, refining the partitions forces the gap $U(f,P) - L(f,P)$ to zero, pinching the lower and upper integrals together (Figure 41.8). The common real value is the definite integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,dx$. Without completeness, the set of lower sums would climb toward an empty hole, and the area under the curve would have no real number to equal.

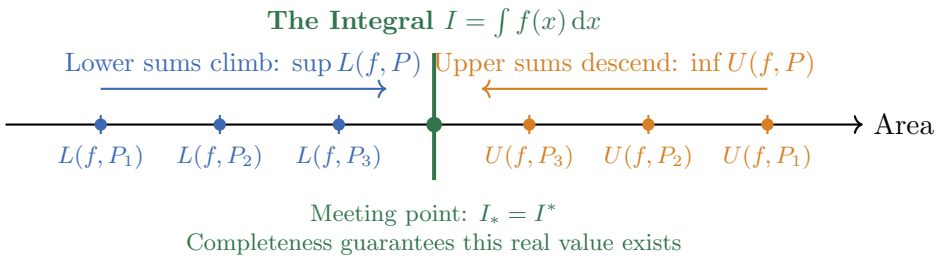


Figure 41.8: Darboux integration via completeness. Every lower sum $L(f,P)$ (blue) underestimates the area; every upper sum $U(f,P)$ (orange) overestimates it. As partitions refine, the lower sums climb toward their supremum and the upper sums descend toward their infimum. For a continuous function, these two values squeeze together to a single point. Completeness ensures that this meeting point is an actual real number: the definite integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,dx$.

Why this matters

Notice the common structure across all four theorems. The limit of a monotone sequence is a supremum, the crossing point of a continuous curve is a supremum, and the maximum of a continuous function is an attained supremum. Likewise, the area under a curve is the common value where a supremum of lower sums meets an infimum of upper sums. Each result applies the same completeness property to a different mathematical setting. The completeness axiom provides the unified foundation for analysis: every existence theorem for limits, derivatives, and integrals relies on this single property of the real numbers.

41.5 The Archimedean property: no infinities hiding

Completeness implies another property that is used in nearly every ε-argument: the real numbers contain no infinitely large elements or positive infinitesimals.

Theorem 41.7 (Archimedean property)**.** *For any real number x, there is a natural number n with $n > x$. Equivalently, for any $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a natural number n with $\frac{1}{n} < \varepsilon$.*

Proof. Suppose not: suppose some real x exceeds every natural number, so $\mathbb{N}$ is bounded above by x. Then by completeness $\mathbb{N}$ has a least upper bound $L = \sup \mathbb{N}$. Since L is the *least* upper bound, $L-1$ is not an upper bound, so some natural number n satisfies $n > L-1$. But then $n+1 > L$, and $n+1$ is also a natural number — contradicting L being an upper bound for $\mathbb{N}$. So no real number exceeds all naturals.

For the second form, given $\varepsilon > 0$ apply the first part to $x = 1/\varepsilon$ to get $n > 1/\varepsilon$, whence $1/n < \varepsilon$. □

What is really happening

The Archimedean property guarantees that $\frac{1}{n}$ can be made smaller than any given positive tolerance ε — an essential step in ε–δ arguments. It rules out any positive real number that is strictly smaller than every $\frac{1}{n}$ (an infinitesimal), because such a number would force $\mathbb{N}$ to be bounded. In this way, completeness ensures that $\mathbb{R}$ contains no infinitely large elements or

positive infinitesimals. (Mathematicians *can* construct non-Archimedean ordered fields with genuine infinitesimals, such as the hyperreals in nonstandard analysis, but they do not satisfy the completeness axiom.) When we write "for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists N," we rely on the Archimedean property, which itself derives from completeness.

Pause

Pause and think: Suppose someone claims to have found a positive real number $c > 0$ that is strictly smaller than $\frac{1}{n}$ for every single natural number $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Why does the Archimedean property immediately contradict this? *(Check: Apply Theorem 41.7 to the real number $x = 1/c$. There must exist some $n \in \mathbb{N}$ with $n > 1/c$, which rearranges to $\frac{1}{n} < c$, immediately disproving the claim that c is smaller than all fractions $\frac{1}{n}$.)*

Connection

The Archimedean property also explains why the rationals, holes and all, still manage to be *dense* in the reals: between any two reals $a < b$ there is a rational. Choose n with $\frac{1}{n} < b - a$ (Archimedean), so the rationals $\frac{k}{n}$ are spaced more finely than the gap $b - a$; one of them must land inside (a, b). So every real number, $\sqrt{2}$ and π included, has rationals arbitrarily close to it on both sides. The irrationals fill the holes, and the rationals crowd right up against every one of them. This is the precise sense in which the decimal expansions of $\sqrt{2}$ and π approximate them: rational truncations creeping arbitrarily close to a real destination that completeness guarantees is there.

41.6 A worked tour of suprema and infima

Abstract definitions calcify unless you compute with them. Here are four sets; for each we find sup and inf and decide whether they are attained. Work each one yourself before reading the resolution.

Example 41.1 (A set with inf attained, sup not)**.** Let $S = \{1 - \frac{1}{n} : n \in \mathbb{N}\} = \{0,\ \frac{1}{2},\ \frac{2}{3},\ \frac{3}{4},\ \ldots\}$.

Infimum. The smallest term is the first one, $1 - \frac{1}{1} = 0$. Every term is ≥ 0, and 0 is in S, so $\inf S = 0$ and it *is attained* (it is the minimum).

Supremum. The terms climb: $0, 0.5, 0.667, 0.75, 0.8, \ldots$, always below 1 since $\frac{1}{n} > 0$, yet creeping toward 1 as n grows (Archimedean: $\frac{1}{n} \to 0$). So 1 is an upper bound, and it is the least one — for any $\varepsilon > 0$, picking $n > \frac{1}{\varepsilon}$ gives a term $1 - \frac{1}{n} > 1 - \varepsilon$, so no smaller ceiling works. Thus $\sup S = 1$, and it is *not attained*: no term equals 1. Here is the open-interval phenomenon again, now in a sequence.

Example 41.2 (Sup of a set defined by an inequality)**.** Let $S = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 < 5\}$. This is the open interval $(-\sqrt{5}, \sqrt{5})$. It is bounded above by $\sqrt{5} \approx 2.236$, and $\sup S = \sqrt{5}$ (not attained, since $(\sqrt{5})^2 = 5 \not< 5$). Symmetrically $\inf S = -\sqrt{5}$ (not attained). The supremum $\sqrt{5}$ is itself an irrational number whose existence comes from completeness — the same move as Theorem 41.2 — so this innocuous-looking set has a supremum that does not exist at all in $\mathbb{Q}$.

Example 41.3 (Attained extremes with unattained limit points)**.** Let $S = \{(-1)^n \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right) : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$. The even terms are $1 + \frac{1}{n}$ (just above 1, decreasing toward 1): $\frac{3}{2}, \frac{5}{4}, \frac{7}{6}, \ldots$ The odd terms are $-(1 + \frac{1}{n})$ (just below -1, increasing toward -1): $-2, -\frac{4}{3}, -\frac{6}{5}, \ldots$

Supremum. The largest single term is the first even one, $n = 2$: $1 + \frac{1}{2} = \frac{3}{2}$. All later even terms are smaller, all odd terms are negative. So $\sup S = \frac{3}{2}$, *attained.*

Infimum. The smallest single term is the first odd one, $n = 1$: -2. So $\inf S = -2$, *attained.* Both extremes here happen to be reached; the limit points ± 1 that the sequence clusters around are *not* the sup or inf — a useful reminder that "where a sequence accumulates" and "its supremum" are different questions.

Example 41.4 (An unbounded set has no supremum)**.** Let $S = \{n - \frac{1}{n} : n \in \mathbb{N}\} = \{0, \frac{3}{2}, \frac{8}{3}, \frac{15}{4}, \ldots\}$. The terms grow without bound (by the Archimedean property, $n - \frac{1}{n}$ exceeds any fixed number once n is large). So S is *not bounded above* and has *no supremum* — the completeness axiom never applies, since its hypothesis "bounded above" fails. Its infimum is $\inf S = 0$, attained at $n = 1$. The lesson: completeness guarantees a supremum *only for bounded sets*; the hypothesis is not decorative.

Work it yourself

Try these before peeking at the answers in your head. For each set, find sup and inf, and say whether each is attained.

1. $S = \{\frac{n}{n+1} : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$. *(Answer:* $\inf = \frac{1}{2}$ *attained;* $\sup = 1$ *not attained.)*
2. $S = \{x \in \mathbb{Q} : x^3 < 7\}$. *(Answer:* $\sup = \sqrt[3]{7}$*, irrational, not attained; no inf, unbounded below.)*
3. $S = \{(-1)^n + \frac{1}{n} : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$. *(Answer:* $\sup = \frac{3}{2}$ *at* $n = 2$*, attained;* $\inf = -1$*, the limit of odd terms,* not *attained.)*

Notice how often the supremum is the place the set is *heading* rather than a place it *reaches.* That gap between heading-toward and reaching is the entire reason limits — and completeness — exist.

Application

Numerical root-finding relies on this exact principle to compute $\sqrt{2}$. A numerical root-finder never produces $\sqrt{2}$ exactly — it produces a *bounded sequence* of rational approximations, monotone from the second term on, and trusts completeness to guarantee a real destination. Newton's method (Exercise 41.7) generates $1, 1.5, 1.41\overline{6}, 1.41421\ldots$, each a rational, each closer; the *number* $\sqrt{2}$ is the limit these approximations define. Every time your calculator displays 1.41421356, it is showing you a truncation of a real number whose *existence* is underwritten by the completeness axiom. Floating-point arithmetic lives entirely among rationals; the meaning of its answers lives in $\mathbb{R}$.

41.7 The shape of the whole idea

The logical skeleton is more memorable than any single proof, so gather the thread.

Walking question

Walk the chain of dependence out loud:

1. The rationals are dense but *holey*: $\sqrt{2}$ names a real length that no fraction reaches

(Theorem 41.1).

2. A holey number system breaks limits: a bounded increasing sequence can head toward a destination the system does not contain.
3. The cure is one axiom: *every nonempty set bounded above has a least upper bound* (Section 41.3). This declares the line hole-free.
4. From that one axiom flow all the existence theorems: square roots (Theorem 41.2), monotone convergence (Theorem 41.3), the IVT (Theorem 41.4), the EVT (Theorem 41.5), Bolzano–Weierstrass (Theorem 41.6), the Archimedean property (Theorem 41.7), and the existence of the integral.

Every "there exists" in this book traces back, through this chain, to step 3.

Why this matters

Notice the historical reversal in how modern analysis is organized. Calculus came first, and the rigorous construction of $\mathbb{R}$ came two centuries later — engineered specifically so that bounded monotone sequences and continuous curves crossing zero would never fail for lack of points. When you open an analysis textbook, the completeness axiom appears on page one as an abstract rule about sets and ceilings, when historically it was reverse-engineered to make the theorems of calculus hold.

41.8 The Continuum: Triumphs, Costs, and the Horizon Ahead

Completeness provides the rigorous foundation for calculus. By ensuring the absence of gaps in the real line, the Least Upper Bound Property guarantees a limit for every bounded monotone or Cauchy process. In $\mathbb{Q}$, a Cauchy sequence can fail to converge because its apparent limit (such as $\sqrt{2}$ or π) is absent from $\mathbb{Q}$. Completeness guarantees that every Cauchy sequence of real numbers converges to an element of $\mathbb{R}$, making $\mathbb{R}$ a **complete metric space**.

The Intermediate Value Theorem, the Extreme Value Theorem, the Monotone Convergence Theorem, and the Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem are not isolated results; each of them is a direct consequence of order completeness. The definite integral $\int_a^b f(x)\,\mathrm{d}x$ likewise relies on completeness: Riemann's construction requires the supremum of lower sums to equal the infimum of upper sums, and completeness guarantees that these bounding numbers exist. The foundational issue identified by the Pythagoreans—that geometric lengths cannot all be expressed as rational ratios—is fully resolved: geometric continuity and numerical arithmetic are unified.

Yet completeness carries philosophical and computational consequences. The completeness axiom is non-constructive: it proves that $\sup S$ exists, but it gives no mechanical formula to generate its digits. As Alan Turing proved in 1936, the vast majority of real numbers are uncomputable—no finite algorithm running indefinitely can compute their successive decimals. In addition, Georg Cantor's diagonal argument revealed that $\mathbb{R}$ is **uncountably infinite** — an infinity so large that its points cannot be arranged into a numbered sequence $1, 2, 3, \ldots$. This led mathematics to foundational questions such as the Continuum Hypothesis (see the history box in Section 41.3). Finally, while completeness provides integrals for continuous functions, Riemann integration cannot integrate pointwise limits of discontinuous functions, an obstacle that led Henri Lebesgue in 1902 to introduce

measure theory — a general theory for assigning measure to sets by partitioning the range rather than the domain.

Connection

Calculus is the gateway to the rest of modern pure mathematics. With the real continuum and the calculus of one and several variables firmly in hand, three natural pathways open immediately ahead:

1. **Linear Algebra From the Ground Up (Book 3):** In multivariable calculus (Chapters 32 and 33) we saw that derivatives of multivariable maps are linear transformations represented by Jacobian matrices. Linear algebra develops vector spaces, matrix factorizations, eigenvalues, and orthogonal projections in full generality, elevating the local linear approximations of calculus into a universal language for physics, optimization, and high-dimensional geometry.
2. **Probability and Statistics From the Ground Up (Book 4):** Continuous probability density functions, the Gaussian distribution $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}}e^{-x^2/2}$, joint distributions, and the Central Limit Theorem build directly on the improper integrals, multiple integrals, and sequence limits established across this book.
3. **Real Analysis and Measure Theory:** To push beyond Riemann's integral and complete function spaces into the **Hilbert space** L^2 (a space where functions are treated like infinite-dimensional vectors with well-defined lengths and angles), pure mathematics turns to Lebesgue integration, topology, and functional analysis—the mathematical language of modern quantum mechanics and signal analysis.

41.9 Exercises

Exercise 41.1. (Mental check: finite sets.) Let $S = \{x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_k\}$ be any finite, nonempty set of real numbers. Explain why $\sup S$ must not only exist, but must always be *attained* (meaning $\sup S = \max S$). Contrast this with infinite sets such as $(0, 1)$ or $\{1 - 1/n : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$, where the supremum is never reached by any element of the set.

Exercise 41.2. Adapt the proof of Theorem 41.1 to show $\sqrt{3}$ is irrational. (Hint: you need the fact that if $3 \mid p^2$ then $3 \mid p$. Show this by checking the remainder of p modulo 3.) Then explain where the analogous argument *breaks down* for $\sqrt{4}$, and why it must, since $\sqrt{4} = 2$ is rational.

Exercise 41.3. For each set, find sup and inf and state whether each is attained.

(a) $\{2 + \frac{(-1)^n}{n} : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$, (b) $(-3, 5]$, (c) $\{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 - x < 0\}$, (d) $\{\frac{1}{n} + \frac{1}{m} : n, m \in \mathbb{N}\}$.

Exercise 41.4. Use the ε-characterization of the supremum (Section 41.2) to prove the following: if S is nonempty and bounded above with $L = \sup S$, then there is a sequence (x_n) of elements of S with $x_n \to L$. (Hint: for each n, apply tightness with $\varepsilon = 1/n$.)

Exercise 41.5. Let A and B be nonempty sets bounded above, and define $A + B = \{a + b : a \in A,\ b \in B\}$. Prove that $\sup(A + B) = \sup A + \sup B$. (Show $\leq$ using that $\sup A, \sup B$ are upper bounds, and $\geq$ using the ε-tightness of each, taking $\varepsilon/2$ for each set.)

Exercise 41.6. Define $f : \mathbb{Q} \to \mathbb{Q}$ by $f(x) = x^2 - 2$. Verify that f is continuous, $f(1) < 0$, and $f(2) > 0$, yet f has no zero in $\mathbb{Q}$. Explain in one or two sentences exactly which hypothesis of the

Intermediate Value Theorem (Theorem 41.4) is unavailable here, and connect your answer to the completeness axiom.

Exercise 41.7. Define a sequence by $a_1 = 1$ and $a_{n+1} = \frac{1}{2}\left(a_n + \frac{2}{a_n}\right)$ (this is Newton's method applied to $x^2 - 2 = 0$). Compute a_1, a_2, a_3, a_4 as fractions and as decimals. Argue that for $n \geq 2$ the sequence is decreasing and bounded below by $\sqrt{2}$, hence convergent by the Monotone Convergence Theorem (Theorem 41.3), and show its limit L must satisfy $L = \frac{1}{2}(L + \frac{2}{L})$, so $L^2 = 2$. You have just built $\sqrt{2}$ from rationals using completeness.

Exercise 41.8. Use the Archimedean property (Theorem 41.7) to prove that $\inf\{\frac{1}{n} : n \in \mathbb{N}\} = 0$. Be explicit about both promises an infimum must satisfy: that 0 is a lower bound, and that no positive number is a lower bound.

Exercise 41.9. (Nested intervals.) Suppose $[a_1, b_1] \supseteq [a_2, b_2] \supseteq \cdots$ is a shrinking chain of closed intervals with lengths $b_n - a_n \to 0$. Use the completeness axiom directly (consider $\sup\{a_n : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$) to prove there is exactly one real number belonging to *all* the intervals. Then explain why this fails over $\mathbb{Q}$ by exhibiting a nested chain of rational intervals whose only common point would be $\sqrt{2}$.

Exercise 41.10. Prove that between any two real numbers $a < b$ there is an irrational number. (Hint: between $a - \sqrt{2}$ and $b - \sqrt{2}$ there is a rational r by density; consider $r + \sqrt{2}$.) Combined with the density of the rationals, conclude that both the rationals and the irrationals are dense in $\mathbb{R}$ — every interval, however tiny, contains infinitely many of each.

Exercise 41.11. (The Cauchy criterion.) A sequence (x_n) is called a *Cauchy sequence* if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists an integer N such that $|x_n - x_m| < \varepsilon$ whenever $n, m \geq N$.

1. Prove that every Cauchy sequence is bounded. (Hint: take $\varepsilon = 1$, find the corresponding index N, and enclose all terms inside the bounds formed by the finite set $\{x_1, \ldots, x_{N-1}\}$ and the interval $(x_N - 1, x_N + 1)$.)
2. Use the Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem (Theorem 41.6) to extract a convergent subsequence $x_{n_k} \to L$, and prove that the full sequence (x_n) converges to L.

This establishes the *Cauchy criterion*: in $\mathbb{R}$, a sequence converges if and only if its terms crowd arbitrarily close together.